



μῆνιν ἄειδε, θεά, Πηληϊάδεω Ἀχιλῆος

Sing, goddess, the wrath of Peleus' son Achilles

# HOMER'S ILIAD

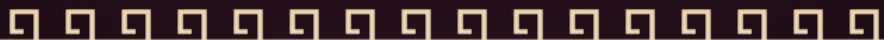
ΙΛΙΑΣ

LINE FOR LINE TRANSLATION BY FABLE 5



TRANSLATED BY  
CLAUDE

*24 books · 15,687 lines rendered from the Greek*



# The Iliad

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# The Iliad

*a line-for-line translation*

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FROM THE GREEK OF

Homer

TRANSLATED BY

Claude (Fable 5)

EDITED AND PRODUCED BY

Chris Duffy



μῆνιν ἄειδε θεὰ Πηληϊάδεω  
Ἀχιλῆος

*Sing, goddess, the wrath of Peleus' son  
Achilles*

# General Introduction

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## I. THE POEM

The Iliad is not the story of the Trojan War. The war is ten years long; the poem covers fifty-one days of it, and of those days all but a handful pass in a line or two of summary. There is no Judgment of Paris in it (one glancing mention, in its last book, which ancient critics wanted to cut), no abduction of Helen, no sacrifice of Iphigenia, no wooden horse, no fall of the city. The poem assumes you know all that the way you know the weather. What it

narrates is announced in its first word —  
mēnis, wrath: the wrath of Achilles, from  
the afternoon it is kindled by one man's  
arithmetic of honor to the night, some  
seven weeks later, when it has burned all  
the way through him and gone out, and he  
gives a dead body back to an old man and  
agrees that they should both eat dinner.

Between those two points the poem's  
architecture is exact. A king confiscates  
the prize of his best fighter, and the fighter  
withdraws — not merely from battle but  
from the whole system of honor-for-  
service that the prize embodied; his own  
goddess mother carries his grievance to  
Zeus, and heaven agrees to make the army  
lose until it learns what he was worth.

That is Book 1. The debt comes due  
through the poem's long middle: the army

is beaten back onto its ships, the king offers restitution and is refused — Achilles, given the chance to end his wrath on magnificent terms, discovers instead that he can imagine leaving the war altogether — and the fire reaches the first ship. Then the poem turns its screw: Achilles will not fight, but he lends his armor and his dearest companion, and Patroclus dies in his place, wearing his bronze, at the hands of Hector. From that point the wrath changes object. What was aimed at Agamemnon is aimed at Hector; what was a strike becomes a hunt; and the man who would not fight for honor now fights past every limit — against rivers, against decency, against the plain fact of his own oncoming death, which he knows in detail and accepts out loud. He kills Hector,

defiles the body, and cannot stop; his grief will not close. It closes only in Book 24, when the gods intervene not with force but with a visit: Priam, Hector's father, crosses the plain at night, kneels to the man who killed his son, and kisses his hands. The two of them weep — each for his own dead — and then, because the poem is wiser than any of its readers, they look at each other and marvel, and eat, and sleep. The Iliad ends with a burial and a shared meal among enemies. The city will still fall; everyone in the poem knows it; the poem does not need to show it.

The subject underneath the subject is mortality. Achilles is the one figure in the poem who gets to choose — a long obscure life or a short one with unwithering fame — and the poem's cruelty and its honesty

is that it lets him make the choice twice: once in the abstract, in Book 9, when he threatens to sail home and calls the choice itself into question (“The portion is equal for the man who hangs back and the man who fights hard”); and once for real, in Book 18, over Patroclus’s body, with nothing abstract left anywhere. Around that single free choice the poem arranges hundreds of unfree ones — minor men, each given a name and a father and a home and a widow at the moment of death, each “broken” in the poem’s flat carpenter’s verb — and one great counter-figure: Hector, who has no choice at all, who fights because a city and a wife and an infant son stand behind him, and who is the only person in the poem we watch being loved. The Iliad’s sympathy does not

follow its politics. It is a Greek poem in which the most humane scenes belong to Troy — Helen on the wall, Hector's helmet frightening his baby, Andromache running for the ramparts "like a madwoman" — and its final line of praise is for the man its hero killed.

Above the men sit the gods, and the poem uses them with a double-entry bookkeeping that no later theology has ever forgiven it for. The gods are the audience of the war and its meddlers; they feel real grief — Zeus rains blood for Sarpedon, and says of mortals, in the poem's shortest theology, "they matter to me, even as they perish" — but they cannot die, and so nothing for them is ever finally at stake. The poem knows exactly what that means: when gods fight gods, in

Book 21, it is comedy, boxed ears and a laughing father; when men fight men it is everything. Mortality is not the men's handicap. It is their seriousness. The gods watch the war the way we read the poem — with passionate partisanship and perfect safety — and the discomfort of that resemblance is intended.

## **II. THE ART OF REPETITION**

The Iliad comes out of a tradition of oral composition in performance, and its style is built from repeated elements: fixed epithets (“swift-footed Achilles,” “Hector of the flashing helmet”), whole recurring lines (“Then in answer spoke to him...”), repeated blocks (a message delivered in the same words it was given), and type-



scenes (arming, sacrifice, supplication) whose skeletons recur with controlled variation. For a nineteenth- or twentieth-century aesthetic trained to prize variety, this was an embarrassment to be smoothed away; translators varied the epithets and paraphrased the repeated speeches so the poem would read like a novel. This translation takes the opposite view, and it is the single decision from which most of its other decisions follow: the repetition is the art. A formula, once fixed, recurs in these pages verbatim. When the Greek repeats a whole line, the English repeats its own line, word for word; when a messenger relays a speech, the relay repeats the original exactly as far as the Greek does, shifting person only where the Greek shifts person.

The reason is not fidelity for its own sake. Repetition is how this poem thinks. When five different men — Odysseus, Menelaus, Agenor, Hector, Achilles — stand alone at their five separate crossroads and ask the same line, “But why does my own heart argue these things with me?”, the line is the point: the poem is showing you that the solitary man debating flight is a single recurring human situation, and the fifth occurrence carries the weight of the other four. When Achilles taunts a Trojan with “Unhappy are the fathers whose sons face my fury!” he is repeating, word for word, what Diomedes said in Book 6 — a line the audience has heard before in a scene that ended, unforgettably, in guest-friendship instead of killing; this time no one exchanges armor. When the narrator says

of Patroclus's arming what he will say of Achilles' arming three books later, the identity of the lines is a fuse burning between the two scenes. Vary the wording and all of this disappears — the echoes, the ironies, the sense that the poem's world runs on recurrences the characters cannot see. Keep it, and English readers can hear, for once, the machine turning.

The bookkeeping this requires is heavy, and it is done in the open: every fixed rendering is logged in a register (translation/CONVENTIONS.md) that binds all later books; the first English wording of a repeated line is binding on every recurrence; conformance is checked mechanically, and the whole translation was audited after completion, book by book against the Greek, precisely to hunt

down places where two occurrences of one Greek line had drifted apart in English.

Where the register deliberately merges two Greek terms under one English word, or splits one Greek word by context, the merge is documented. The same register conventions are shared, where the poems share formulas, with a companion *Odyssey* built on the same principles.

### **III. THE GREEK TEXT**

The translation follows the Oxford text of Monro and Allen, in the public-domain digitization that prints the poem at 15,693 lines, and it follows it line for line: English line 200 of a book renders Greek line 200, so that any line here can be laid beside its original — or against any commentary

keyed to the standard numeration — without arithmetic. Six lines of that numeration (the block 9.458-461, and the single lines 11.543 and 14.269) are absent from the transmitted source text this project prints; they are not silently patched. The gaps are marked where they fall, and the missing lines — where antiquity preserves them, as Plutarch preserves the four suppressed lines of Phoenix's confession — are translated in the notes.

Ancient scholarship is part of this poem's transmission, and the edition keeps it visible. Lines athetized by the Alexandrian critics — marked as spurious by Zenodotus, Aristophanes, or Aristarchus — are translated wherever the printed text prints them, and the athetesis is recorded

in a note, never acted on: so the divine singer stays in the dance on the Shield, the Pelian ash stays in the arming of Book 19, and the Judgment of Paris stays in Book 24 over Aristarchus's objection. Where the printed text itself makes an editorial choice against the manuscript majority, the note says so — most famously at 1.350, where this text's "boundless sea" displaces the vulgate's "wine-dark." And where a rejected ancient variant is too interesting to lose, the notes keep it: Zenodotus's text in which the corpses of the opening lines become a "feast" for the birds; his Book 19, which could not bear a seated Agamemnon and made him stand; the reading known to Strabo at 20.307 in which the rule of Aeneas's line is over "all," not over the Trojans — the variant Rome preferred, for

obvious reasons. The apparatus of an ancient poem is not scaffolding to be struck; it is the record of twenty-five centuries of readers arguing about the same lines, and this translation was made in their company.

## **IV. THE ENGLISH LINE**

The verse is plain, dignified, modern English free verse — no meter, no rhyme — held to a loose five-to-six-beat line that runs to a median of thirteen syllables, with better than nine lines in ten falling between nine and sixteen. That is not an imitation of the hexameter; English cannot sustain one for 15,000 lines without stilts. It is a discipline with a different purpose: since the translation is line-for-line, the

English line must do neither more nor less work than the Greek line it faces. It cannot pad, because the next Greek line is already waiting; it cannot sprawl, because it has to keep step for twenty-four books. What the line-for-line rule buys is worth its cost: the poem's pacing survives — the single-line death sentences land as single lines, the enjambments break where Homer broke them, the long speeches are exactly as long as Homer made them — and every sentence of the English is checkable against its original by anyone with a parallel text and a dictionary.

The diction aims at the register the Greek actually has: formal but not antique, plain but not flat. Homer's language was never anyone's daily speech — it is a poetic amalgam full of frozen archaisms — but it



is rapid, direct, and unembarrassed, and the worst betrayal of it is fustian. A few English choices carry particular weight and are worth declaring at the door. The theme word *mēnis* is “wrath” throughout, never “rage” or “anger” — a grudge with divine standing, not a mood. *Timē* is always “honor”; *geras* always “prize,” the concrete awarded object in which honor is embodied — the quarrel of Book 1 is unintelligible unless those two words stay rigid. *Atē* is “blindness” (capitalized when she walks as a goddess): the god-sent delusion Agamemnon pleads in his apology, “the eldest daughter of Zeus, who blinds all men.” The enslaved of the poem are called slaves. Where the Greek says *dmōs* or *dmōē* this translation does not say “servant” or “maid,” because the

difference between a servant and a slave is the difference Briseis and Andromache spend the poem on the wrong side of, and a translation that softens the word has taken a side. And the small change of the formulas is kept literal where literalness still works: words are winged; dawn is rosy-fingered and saffron-robed; men glare darkly before they speak; the day of death is “the pitiless day.”

Proper names use the familiar Latinized forms — Achilles, Ajax, Hecuba, Clytemnestra — on the principle that this poem belongs to readers, not to systems of transliteration; the register keeps the inventory, down to the diaeresis in Eëtion.

## **V. THIS EDITION**

Each of the twenty-four books is presented the same way: a one-sentence epigraph; a translator's commentary — an essay on what the book is and does, where its difficulties lie, and what this translation did about them; the verse itself, numbered to the Greek; and endnotes, marked in the text by bracketed numbers that restart with each book. The notes carry four kinds of freight: textual matters (atheteses, variants, disputed lines); formulas, flagged at their first occurrence in the whole poem and then trusted to the reader's ear; realia — who this minor king is, where that river runs, why a boar's-tusk helmet matters; and the occasional confession, where the English had to choose one horn of an ambiguity and the note preserves the other. A project file of disputed lines and a

full formula register sit beside the translation for anyone who wants the workshop as well as the work. After completion, every book was re-read entire against the Greek, line against line, and the handful of places where the translation had drifted from its own rules were repaired; the record of that audit, too, is preserved.

A reader who wants a map before setting out can hold the poem's twenty-four books in one hand. Book 1: the quarrel, the plague, and Thetis's bargain with Zeus. Book 2: the testing of the army and the great catalogue of ships. Books 3-7: the war seen whole, as if for the first time — the duel of Paris and Menelaus, Helen naming the kings from the wall, the truce broken, Diomedes' rampage among gods and men,

and, at the center, Hector in Troy with Hecuba, Helen, and Andromache — the poem's one visit inside the doomed city at peace. Book 8: Zeus bans the gods from the field and tilts the day to Troy. Book 9: the embassy — Agamemnon's gifts, and Achilles' refusal, the greatest speech in the poem. Book 10: the night raid. Books 11-15: the long third day of battle — the captains wounded one by one, the wall breached, Hera seducing Zeus on Ida, the tide turned twice, until Hector's hand is on the first ship. Book 16: Patroclus, in Achilles' armor, saves the ships, kills Sarpedon, and dies under the walls. Book 17: the fight over his body. Book 18: the news; Achilles' choice; Thetis; the making of the Shield, on which Hephaestus forges the whole living world the poem otherwise excludes. Book 19: the

wrath against Agamemnon renounced;  
Blindness anatomized; the horse Xanthus  
prophesies. Books 20-21: Achilles returned  
— against Aeneas, against everyone,  
against the river itself, with the gods  
loosed into the battle and finally laughing  
in each other's faces. Book 22: Hector alone  
before the gates; the chase; the death;  
Andromache at the loom. Book 23: the  
funeral of Patroclus and the games — the  
poem already practicing peace. Book 24:  
the gods' verdict, Priam's night journey,  
the ransom of Hector, and the twelve days  
of truce in which the poem, having begun  
with two men quarreling over what a life is  
worth, ends with two enemies agreeing on  
what a death is owed.

Read it aloud where you can. The poem  
was made for the ear, and its repetitions —

the epithets that toll like bells, the lines  
that return in new mouths, the pitiless day  
arriving on schedule — were composed to  
be heard coming. This translation has tried  
to keep every one of them audible.

# A Note on the Text

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The Greek is the Oxford Classical Text of Monro and Allen (3rd edition, 1920). The English translation is original to this project; each of its 15,687 lines is keyed one-to-one to its Greek line, and the printed text is followed throughout — including three passages the printed Greek lacks (9.458–461, 11.543, 14.269), which are marked in place rather than supplied.

Each book closes with its endnotes: a raised numeral in the text marks a note; tap it to jump there, and tap the return arrow (↵) to come back to your place in the verse. The translator's notes on the



several books are collected at the back, one tap from each book's opening.

Monro and Allen's 1920 text is in the public domain. Polytonic Greek is set in Gentium Plus (SIL Open Font License).

# Book 1

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*The wrath: the quarrel over Briseis, the plague,  
and Thetis's bargain with Zeus.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 Sing, goddess, the wrath<sup>1</sup> of Peleus' son  
Achilles,  
2 ruinous wrath, that laid griefs beyond  
counting on the Achaeans  
3 and hurled down to Hades many strong  
souls<sup>2</sup>  
4 of heroes, and made the men  
themselves prey for dogs  
5 and every bird — and the will of Zeus  
moved toward fulfillment —<sup>3</sup>  
6 from the moment those two first stood

apart in strife,

7 Atreus' son, lord of men<sup>4</sup>, and brilliant Achilles.

8 Which of the gods, then, set the two of them fighting?

9 The son of Leto and Zeus. Angered at the king,

10 he sent an evil plague up through the army, and the people were perishing,

11 because Atreus' son had dishonored Chryses, his priest.

12 For Chryses had come to the Achaeans' swift ships

13 to free his daughter, bearing ransom past counting,

14 holding in his hands, on a golden staff, the wreaths<sup>5</sup>

15 of Apollo who strikes from afar<sup>6</sup>, and he begged all the Achaeans,

16 but the two sons of Atreus most of all,  
marshals of the people:  
17 “Sons of Atreus, and you other strong-  
greaved Achaeans7,  
18 may the gods who keep their homes on  
Olympus grant you  
19 to sack Priam’s city and come home  
safe;  
20 only set my dear child free, and accept  
this ransom,  
21 in awe of Zeus’s son, Apollo who strikes  
from afar.”  
22 Then all the other Achaeans shouted  
assent:  
23 respect the priest, take the shining  
ransom.  
24 But it did not please the heart of  
Atreus’ son Agamemnon;  
25 he sent him off harshly, and laid a hard

command on him:

26 “Old man, let me not find you by the  
hollow ships,

27 either lingering now or coming back  
again later,

28 or the god’s staff and wreath may be no  
help to you.

29 The girl I will not release. Sooner shall  
old age come upon her

30 in our house, in Argos, far from her  
fatherland,

31 walking to and fro at the loom and  
sharing my bed.8

32 Now go — do not provoke me — so you  
may get home the safer.”

33 So he spoke, and the old man was  
afraid and obeyed his word.

34 He went in silence along the shore of  
the loud-roaring sea9,

35 and then, walking far apart, the old  
man prayed long  
36 to lord Apollo, whom lovely-haired  
Leto bore:  
37 “Hear me, god of the silver bow, who  
stand guard over Chryse  
38 and holy Cilla, who rule Tenedos in  
strength —  
39 Smintheus!10 If ever I roofed a temple  
that pleased you,  
40 if ever I burned for you the fat-rich  
thighs  
41 of bulls and goats, grant me this wish:  
42 may the Danaans pay for my tears by  
your arrows.”  
43 So he spoke in prayer, and Phoebus  
Apollo heard him.  
44 Down from the peaks of Olympus he  
came, angry at heart,

45 with the bow on his shoulders and the  
covered quiver;  
46 the arrows clashed on the shoulders of  
the angry god  
47 as he moved, and he came on like  
nightfall.**11**  
48 Then he settled apart from the ships  
and let fly a shaft,  
49 and terrible was the clang of the silver  
bow.  
50 The mules he attacked first, and the  
quick-running dogs,  
51 but then he loosed his piercing arrows  
on the men themselves  
52 and struck; and the crowded pyres of  
the dead burned without ceasing.  
53 Nine days the god's shafts ranged  
through the army,  
54 and on the tenth Achilles called the

people to assembly —  
55 the goddess white-armed Hera<sup>12</sup> had  
put it in his mind,  
56 for she cared for the Danaans, seeing  
them die.  
57 So when they were gathered and  
assembled together,  
58 swift-footed Achilles<sup>13</sup> rose and spoke  
among them:  
59 “Son of Atreus, now I think we shall be  
beaten back off our course  
60 and go home again — if we escape  
death at all —  
61 if war and plague together are to break  
the Achaeans.  
62 Come, let us ask some seer or priest,  
63 or even a reader of dreams — for a  
dream too is from Zeus —<sup>14</sup>  
64 who might tell us why Phoebus Apollo



is so angry:

65 whether he faults a vow unpaid or a  
hecatomb<sup>15</sup>,

66 in hope he may accept the savor of  
lambs and unblemished goats

67 and choose to drive this ruin from us.”

68 So he spoke and sat down; and among  
them rose

69 Calchas, Thestor’s son, far the best of  
bird-readers,

70 who knew what is, what will be, and  
what was before,

71 and who had guided the Achaeans’  
ships to Ilion

72 by the seercraft Phoebus Apollo gave  
him.

73 With good will toward them he spoke  
and addressed them:

74 “Achilles, dear to Zeus, you command

me to explain

75 the wrath of Apollo, the lord who  
strikes from afar.

76 Then I will speak. But you consider, and  
swear to me

77 that you will readily defend me with  
word and hand;

78 for I think I shall anger a man who  
rules

79 all the Argives in his great power, a  
man the Achaeans obey.

80 A king is the stronger when he rages at  
a lesser man;

81 even if he swallows his anger for that  
one day,

82 still he keeps resentment afterward in  
his chest

83 until he brings it to completion. Say,  
then, if you will keep me safe.”

84 Answering him spoke swift-footed  
Achilles:  
85 “Take heart, and speak whatever god-  
sign you know.  
86 For by Apollo, dear to Zeus — the god  
to whom you pray, Calchas,  
87 when you reveal god-signs to the  
Danaans —  
88 no man, while I live and see light on  
this earth,  
89 shall lay heavy hands on you beside the  
hollow ships,  
90 no man of all the Danaans — not if you  
name Agamemnon,  
91 who now claims to be far the best of  
the Achaeans.”  
92 Then the blameless seer took heart and  
spoke:  
93 “He faults no vow unpaid, no

hecatomb,

94 but for the sake of his priest, whom  
Agamemnon dishonored —

95 he did not release his daughter, would  
not accept the ransom —

96 for that the far-striker has given griefs,  
and will give more.

97 He will not lift this shameful ruin from  
the Danaans<sup>16</sup>

98 until we give back to her dear father  
the bright-eyed girl,

99 unbought, unransomed, and lead a  
holy hecatomb

100 to Chryse. Then we might appease  
him and win him over.”

101 So he spoke and sat down; and among  
them rose

102 the hero, Atreus’ son, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon,

103 in anguish: his darkened heart was  
brimming full  
104 of fury, and his eyes were like blazing  
fire.  
105 Glaring evil first at Calchas, he spoke:  
106 “Seer of evils! Never yet have you  
spoken a word to my good;  
107 always it is dear to your heart to  
prophecy evils,  
108 and no good word have you ever  
spoken or brought to pass.  
109 And now you stand prophesying  
before the Danaans  
110 that this is why the far-striker makes  
their griefs —  
111 because I would not take the shining  
ransom  
112 for the girl Chryseis, since I greatly  
wish

113 to keep her at home. Indeed I prefer  
her to Clytemnestra,  
114 my wedded wife, since she is not her  
inferior  
115 in build or bearing, in mind or in any  
work of her hands.  
116 Even so I am willing to give her back, if  
that is better;  
117 I want the people safe, not perishing.  
118 But make ready a prize<sup>17</sup> for me at  
once, so that I alone  
119 of the Argives not go unprized — that  
would not be fitting;  
120 for you all see it: my prize goes  
elsewhere.”  
121 Then swift-footed brilliant Achilles  
answered him:  
122 “Most glorious son of Atreus, greediest  
of all men,

123 how shall the great-hearted Achaeans  
give you a prize?

124 We know of no common store laid up  
anywhere;

125 what we took when we sacked the  
cities has been shared out,

126 and it is wrong to make the people  
gather it back again.

127 No — give the girl up now, to the god;  
and we Achaeans

128 will pay you back three and four times  
over, if ever Zeus

129 grants us to sack the well-walled city  
of Troy.”

130 Answering him spoke the lord  
Agamemnon:

131 “Do not, brave as you are, godlike  
Achilles,

132 try to cheat me with cleverness; you

will not slip past me or persuade me.

133 Is this your wish — that you keep your  
own prize, while I

134 sit here without one, just because you  
tell me to give her back?

135 If the great-hearted Achaeans will give  
me a prize,

136 suiting it to my heart, so it be worth as  
much — well and good;

137 but if they will not give it, then I  
myself will come and take

138 your prize, or Ajax's, or Odysseus's —

139 seize it and carry it off. And the man I  
visit will be angry.

140 But all that we can think through  
later.

141 For now, come, let us drag a black ship  
down to the bright sea,

142 gather rowers enough, set a hecatomb



aboard,

143 and put fair-cheeked18 Chryseis  
herself

144 on deck. And one man of counsel shall  
be commander —

145 Ajax, or Idomeneus, or brilliant  
Odysseus,

146 or you, son of Peleus, most terrifying  
of all men,

147 to make sacrifice and appease for us  
the worker-from-afar.”

148 Glaring at him darkly, swift-footed  
Achilles spoke:

149 “You — wrapped in shamelessness,  
mind set on profit!

150 How shall any Achaean gladly obey  
your orders,

151 to go on a mission or to fight men in  
strength?

152 It was not for the sake of Trojan  
spearmen that I came  
153 to fight here: they have done nothing  
to me.  
154 They never drove off my cattle or my  
horses,  
155 never in deep-soiled Phthia, feeder of  
men,  
156 did they ruin my harvest — since  
much lies between us,  
157 shadowing mountains and the echoing  
sea.  
158 No: you, colossal in shamelessness,  
you we followed,  
159 to please you — winning honor for  
Menelaus and for you, dog-face<sup>19</sup>,  
160 from the Trojans. None of that do you  
look at or care for.  
161 And now you threaten to take my prize

from me yourself,

162 the prize I labored hard for, which the  
sons of the Achaeans gave me.

163 I never have a prize equal to yours,  
whenever the Achaeans

164 sack some well-settled Trojan town;

165 my hands carry the greater part of  
furious war,

166 yet when the division comes,

167 your prize is far the larger, and I go  
back to my ships

168 with something small and dear, when I  
have worn myself out fighting.

169 Now I am going to Phthia. It is far  
better

170 to go home with my beaked ships. I do  
not intend,

171 dishonored here, to go on piling up  
wealth and riches for you.”

172 Then answered him the lord of men  
Agamemnon:

173 “Run, then, if your heart is set on it. I  
am not begging you

174 to stay for my sake. Beside me are  
others

175 who will honor me — above all Zeus  
the counselor.

176 Of all the kings whom Zeus sustains,  
you are the most hateful to me:

177 strife is always dear to you, and wars,  
and battles.

178 If you are very strong, some god gave  
you that.

179 Go home with your ships and your  
companions,

180 be king over your Myrmidons. I take  
no account of you;

181 your rage does not move me. But here

is my threat:

182 since Phoebus Apollo takes Chryseis  
from me,

183 her I will send off with my ship and  
my companions —

184 but I will come myself to your hut and  
take fair-cheeked

185 Briseis, your own prize, so you may  
learn well

186 how much greater I am than you, and  
the next man too may shrink

187 from calling himself my equal and  
matching himself against me.”

188 So he spoke. And grief came over  
Peleus’ son; the heart

189 in his shaggy chest was split two ways:

190 whether to draw the sharp sword  
from beside his thigh,

191 scatter the men between, and kill the

son of Atreus,

192 or to check his anger and rein in his  
spirit.

193 While he was turning this over in  
mind and heart

194 and drawing the great sword from its  
sheath, Athena came

195 from the sky. White-armed Hera had  
sent her,

196 loving both men alike in her heart,  
and caring for both.

197 She stood behind him and caught  
Peleus' son by his tawny hair,

198 showing herself to him alone; of the  
others, no one saw her.

199 Achilles was startled. He turned, and  
at once he knew

200 Pallas Athena — the eyes shining  
terribly —

201 and speaking winged words20 he  
addressed her:

202 “Why have you come this time, child  
of aegis-bearing Zeus?21

203 To see the outrage of Agamemnon,  
Atreus’ son?

204 I will tell you this, and I think it will  
be accomplished:

205 by his own arrogance he may soon  
lose his life.”

206 Then the goddess grey-eyed Athena22  
answered him:

207 “I came from the sky to stop your fury  
— if you will listen —

208 and white-armed Hera sent me,

209 loving you both alike in her heart, and  
caring for both.

210 Come, leave off this strife; do not draw  
the sword.

211 With words, though — taunt him with  
what is coming, and it will come.

212 I tell you this outright, and it will be  
accomplished:

213 one day gifts three times as splendid  
will be laid before you

214 because of this outrage. Hold back,  
and obey us.”

215 Answering her spoke swift-footed  
Achilles:

216 “Goddess, a man must keep the word  
of you two,

217 however angry his heart. That way is  
better.

218 Whoever obeys the gods, him they  
hear indeed.”

219 He spoke, and checked his heavy hand  
on the silver hilt,

220 and back into the sheath he drove the



great sword; he did not disobey  
221 the word of Athena. And she was gone  
to Olympus,  
222 to the house of aegis-bearing Zeus,  
among the other gods.  
223 But Peleus' son once more with  
cutting words  
224 went at Atreus' son, and did not yet  
let go his anger:  
225 "Wine-sack! Dog's eyes and a deer's  
heart! 23  
226 Never once to arm yourself for battle  
with the people,  
227 never to go out in ambush with the  
best of the Achaeans —  
228 you have not the courage; that looks  
like death to you.  
229 Far better, no doubt, through the wide  
Achaean camp

230 to strip his gifts from any man who  
speaks against you —  
231 a king who devours his own people!  
Because you rule nobodies;  
232 otherwise, son of Atreus, this outrage  
would be your last.  
233 But I will say this to you, and swear a  
great oath on it:  
234 by this staff — which will never again  
put out leaves and branches  
235 once it has left its stump in the  
mountains,  
236 nor bloom again, since the bronze  
stripped it  
237 of leaf and bark; and now the sons of  
the Achaeans  
238 carry it in their palms when they give  
judgment, those who guard  
239 the ordinances that come from Zeus —

this will be a great oath:

240 some day a longing for Achilles will  
come upon the sons of the Achaeans,  
241 all of them together. And then, grieved  
as you are, you will have no power  
242 to help, when many at the hands of  
man-slaughtering Hector  
243 fall dying. And you will tear the heart  
inside you,  
244 raging that you paid no honor to the  
best of the Achaeans.”

245 So spoke Peleus’ son, and he dashed to  
the ground the staff  
246 studded with golden nails, and sat  
down himself,  
247 while Atreus’ son raged on the other  
side. Then Nestor  
248 sprang up, the sweet-speaking, the  
clear-voiced speaker of Pylos,

249 from whose tongue the voice ran  
sweeter than honey.

250 In his time two generations of mortal  
men

251 had already passed away, who once  
were born and raised with him

252 in sacred Pylos, and he was king  
among the third.

253 With good will toward them he spoke  
and addressed them:

254 “Shame! Great grief comes upon the  
Achaean land.

255 Priam would rejoice indeed, and  
Priam’s sons,

256 and the rest of the Trojans would be  
glad at heart,

257 if they learned all this about the two  
of you quarreling —

258 you who surpass the Danaans in

counsel, surpass them in fighting.

259 But listen to me: you are both younger  
than I am.

260 Once, long ago, I kept company with  
better men

261 even than you, and they never made  
light of me.

262 Such men I have not seen since, nor  
shall I see —

263 Peirithous, and Dryas shepherd of the  
people,

264 Caeneus, Exadius, godlike  
Polyphemus,

265 and Theseus, Aegeus' son, image of  
the immortals.24

266 Strongest they grew of all men reared  
on earth;

267 strongest they were, and with the  
strongest they fought,

268 the beasts that lair in the mountains,  
and destroyed them terribly.

269 With these men I kept company, come  
from Pylos,

270 far away, from a distant land; for they  
themselves called me.

271 And I fought as my own man, by  
myself. Against them no one

272 of mortals now upon the earth could  
fight.

273 And they listened to my counsels and  
obeyed my word.

274 So you two listen also, since listening  
is better.

275 You — do not, great man though you  
are, take the girl from him;

276 let her be, as the sons of the Achaeans  
first gave her to him, a prize.

277 And you, son of Peleus — do not

choose to strive with a king,  
278 force against force. A scepter-holding  
king, to whom Zeus has given  
279 glory, has no common share of honor.  
280 If you are the stronger, and a goddess  
mother bore you,  
281 still he is the greater, because he rules  
over more.  
282 Son of Atreus, check your fury. It is I  
who beg you:  
283 let go your anger against Achilles,  
who stands, for all the Achaeans,  
284 a great wall against the evil of war.”  
285 Answering him spoke the lord  
Agamemnon:  
286 “Yes, old man — all this you have said  
rightly and in due measure.  
287 But this man wants to be above all  
others:

288 to hold power over all, to be king over  
all,

289 to give orders to all — and there is  
one, I think, who will not obey.

290 If the gods who live forever made him  
a spearman,

291 do they therefore give him leave to  
hurl insults?”**25**

292 Breaking in on him, brilliant Achilles  
answered:

293 “Yes — for I would be called coward  
and nobody

294 if I give way to you in every matter,  
whatever you say.

295 Lay these commands on others; do not  
give orders

296 to me. I do not think I shall obey you  
any longer.

297 And I will tell you another thing — put



it away in your heart:

298 with my hands I will not fight over the  
girl,

299 not with you, not with any man; you  
gave her, and you have taken her away.

300 But of all else that is mine by my swift  
black ship,

301 you shall carry off nothing, taking it  
against my will.

302 Go on — try it, so these men too may  
know:

303 in a moment your dark blood will  
spurt around my spear.”

304 So the two of them, fighting it out  
with head-on words,

305 rose, and dissolved the assembly by  
the Achaean ships.

306 Peleus’ son went off to his huts and  
balanced ships

307 with Menoetius' son<sup>26</sup> and his  
companions.  
308 And Atreus' son had a swift ship  
dragged to the sea,  
309 chose twenty rowers for her, drove  
aboard a hecatomb  
310 for the god, and brought fair-cheeked  
Chryseis  
311 and set her aboard; and resourceful  
Odysseus<sup>27</sup> went as commander.  
312 So they embarked and sailed the  
watery ways.  
313 And Atreus' son commanded the  
people to purify themselves:  
314 they washed themselves clean, and  
cast the washings into the sea,  
315 and offered to Apollo perfect  
hecatombs  
316 of bulls and goats along the shore of

the barren sea<sup>28</sup>,

<sup>317</sup> and the savor rose to the sky, curling  
in the smoke.

<sup>318</sup> So the camp busied itself with this.

But Agamemnon

<sup>319</sup> did not let go the quarrel with which  
he had first threatened Achilles:

<sup>320</sup> he spoke to Talthybius and Eurybates,

<sup>321</sup> his two heralds and ready henchmen:

<sup>322</sup> “Go to the hut of Peleus’ son Achilles.

<sup>323</sup> Take fair-cheeked Briseis by the hand  
and bring her.

<sup>324</sup> And if he will not give her up, I will  
come with more men

<sup>325</sup> and take her myself — which will be  
the worse for him.”

<sup>326</sup> So he sent them off, and laid a hard  
command on them.

<sup>327</sup> Unwilling, the two went along the

shore of the barren sea

328 and came to the huts and ships of the  
Myrmidons.

329 They found him beside his hut and his  
black ship,

330 sitting; and Achilles took no joy in  
seeing them.

331 The two, in fear and awe of the king,

332 stood, and did not speak to him or  
question him.

333 But he understood in his heart, and  
spoke:

334 “Welcome, heralds, messengers of  
Zeus and of men.

335 Come near. You are not to blame in my  
eyes, but Agamemnon,

336 who sends you two for the girl Briseis.

337 Come, Patroclus, sprung from Zeus —  
bring out the girl

338 and give her to them to take. And let  
these two themselves be witnesses  
339 before the blessed gods and mortal  
men  
340 and before that hard king, if ever  
again  
341 there is need of me to beat back  
shameful ruin  
342 from the rest. Truly, he rages in a  
ruinous mind;  
343 he has no thought of seeing before  
and behind at once,  
344 how his Achaeans might fight safe  
beside the ships.”  
345 So he spoke, and Patroclus obeyed his  
dear companion:  
346 he led fair-cheeked Briseis out of the  
hut  
347 and gave her to be taken. And the two

went back along the Achaean ships,  
348 and the woman went with them,  
unwilling. Then Achilles,  
349 weeping, drew apart from his  
companions and sat down  
350 on the shore of the grey sea, looking  
out over the boundless deep29,  
351 and stretched out his hands and  
prayed hard to his dear mother:  
352 “Mother, since you bore me to a short  
life,  
353 honor at least the Olympian owed me,  
354 Zeus who thunders on high. Now he  
has honored me not even a little.  
355 The son of Atreus, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon,  
356 has dishonored me: he has taken and  
keeps my prize; he seized it himself.”

357 So he spoke, shedding tears, and his  
lady mother heard him,  
358 sitting in the depths of the sea beside  
her old father.  
359 Quickly she rose from the grey salt  
water like mist,  
360 and sat down before him as he wept,  
361 stroked him with her hand, and spoke  
a word, and named him:  
362 “Child, why do you weep? What grief  
has come to your heart?  
363 Speak out; hide nothing; let us both  
know.”  
364 Groaning heavily, swift-footed  
Achilles said:  
365 “You know. Why tell it all to one who  
knows?  
366 We went to Thebe, Eëtion’s holy  
city30,

367 and sacked it, and brought everything  
here;  
368 the sons of the Achaeans divided it  
fairly among themselves,  
369 and for Atreus' son they picked out  
fair-cheeked Chryseis.  
370 Then Chryses, priest of Apollo who  
strikes from afar,  
371 came to the swift ships of the bronze-  
shirted Achaeans  
372 to free his daughter, bearing ransom  
past counting,**31**  
373 holding in his hands, on a golden staff,  
the wreaths  
374 of Apollo who strikes from afar, and he  
begged all the Achaeans,  
375 but the two sons of Atreus most of all,  
marshals of the people.  
376 Then all the other Achaeans shouted



assent:

377 respect the priest, take the shining  
ransom.

378 But it did not please the heart of  
Atreus' son Agamemnon;

379 he sent him off harshly, and laid a  
hard command on him.

380 And the old man went back angry;  
and Apollo

381 heard his prayer, since he was very  
dear to him,

382 and loosed an evil shaft on the  
Argives. And now the people

383 were dying thick and fast, and the  
god's arrows ranged

384 everywhere through the wide  
Achaean camp. But a seer,

385 knowing well, declared to us the god-  
word of the far-striker.

386 At once I, first, urged appeasing the  
god;  
387 but rage took hold of Atreus' son, and  
standing up  
388 he made a threat — which now stands  
accomplished.  
389 The girl the bright-eyed Achaeans are  
sending on a swift ship  
390 to Chryse, with gifts for the lord;  
391 and the other — heralds have just now  
gone from my hut leading her,  
392 the daughter of Briseus, whom the  
sons of the Achaeans gave me.  
393 But you — if you have the power,  
defend your son.  
394 Go to Olympus and entreat Zeus, if  
ever  
395 you gladdened the heart of Zeus by  
word or deed.

396 For often in my father's halls I heard  
you<sup>32</sup>  
397 declare it proudly: that you alone  
among the immortals  
398 warded off shameful ruin from the  
son of Cronos, lord of the dark cloud,  
399 that time the other Olympians wanted  
to bind him —  
400 Hera and Poseidon and Pallas Athena.  
401 But you came, goddess, and set him  
free of his bonds,  
402 quickly calling to high Olympus the  
hundred-handed one  
403 whom the gods call Briareus, but all  
men  
404 Aegaeon<sup>33</sup> — for he in turn is  
stronger than his father —  
405 and he sat down beside the son of  
Cronos, glorying in his splendor,

406 and the blessed gods shrank in fear of  
him, and bound Zeus no more.  
407 Sit beside him and remind him of this;  
take his knees;  
408 see if he may be willing to help the  
Trojans  
409 and pen the Achaeans back among the  
ships' sterns and the sea,  
410 dying — so they may all have joy of  
their king,  
411 and even Atreus' son, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon, may know  
412 his blindness, that he paid no honor to  
the best of the Achaeans.”  
413 Then Thetis answered him, letting fall  
her tears:  
414 “Ah my child, why did I raise you, born  
to sorrow?  
415 If only you could sit by the ships

without tears, without pain,

416 since your portion is short — not long  
at all.

417 Now you are both quick-fated and  
wretched beyond all men;

418 so it was for an evil fate I bore you in  
our halls.

419 To tell your word to Zeus who delights  
in thunder

420 I myself will go to snow-capped  
Olympus; he may listen.

421 And you — sit now by your swift-  
faring ships,

422 keep your wrath against the  
Achaeans, and let war go entirely.

423 For Zeus went yesterday to Ocean, to  
the blameless Ethiopians<sup>34</sup>,

424 for a feast, and all the gods went with  
him.

425 On the twelfth day he will come back  
to Olympus,  
426 and then I will go to Zeus's house with  
its bronze floor,  
427 and clasp his knees, and I think I will  
persuade him.”  
428 So she spoke and went away, and left  
him there,  
429 the heart in him angry for the fair-  
belted woman  
430 they had taken from him by force,  
against his will. Meanwhile Odysseus  
431 came to Chryse leading the holy  
hecatomb.  
432 When they had come inside the deep  
harbor,  
433 they furled the sails and stowed them  
in the black ship,  
434 dropped the mast by the forestays

into its crutch,  
435 smartly, and rowed her to her  
mooring with the oars.  
436 They threw out the anchor-stones and  
made fast the stern lines,  
437 and stepped out themselves onto the  
surf-line of the sea,  
438 and out came the hecatomb for Apollo  
who strikes from afar,  
439 and out of the seagoing ship stepped  
Chryseis.  
440 Then resourceful Odysseus led her to  
the altar  
441 and put her in her dear father's arms,  
and said:  
442 "Chryses, the lord of men  
Agamemnon sent me  
443 to bring you your child, and to offer a  
holy hecatomb

444 to Phoebus for the Danaans, that we  
may appease the lord  
445 who has now sent the Argives griefs  
and groaning.”  
446 So he spoke and put her in his arms,  
and the old man received  
447 his dear child, rejoicing. Then quickly  
they set up  
448 the holy hecatomb for the god in  
order around the well-built altar,  
449 washed their hands, and took up the  
barley-grains.  
450 And Chryses lifted his hands and  
prayed aloud for them:  
451 “Hear me, god of the silver bow, who  
stand guard over Chryse  
452 and holy Cilla, who rule Tenedos in  
strength.  
453 Once before you heard me when I



prayed:

454 you honored me, and struck the  
Achaean army hard.

455 So now again fulfill this wish of mine:

456 now beat the shameful ruin back from  
the Danaans.”

457 So he spoke in prayer, and Phoebus  
Apollo heard him.

458 And when they had prayed and  
thrown the barley-grains,35

459 they first drew back the victims’  
heads, cut their throats, and flayed them,

460 carved out the thigh-pieces and  
wrapped them in fat,

461 making a double fold, and laid raw  
flesh upon them.

462 The old man burned them on split  
wood, and over them poured

463 gleaming wine; beside him young men

held five-pronged forks.

464 When the thighs were burned and  
they had tasted the inner parts,

465 they cut up the rest and threaded it  
on spits,

466 roasted it with care, and drew it all  
off.

467 Then when they had finished the  
work and made the meal ready,

468 they feasted, and no heart lacked a  
fair share of the feast.

469 And when they had put away desire  
for eating and drinking,

470 the young men filled the mixing-  
bowls brim-high with drink

471 and served all, pouring first drops in  
each cup for the god.

472 So all day long they sought the god's  
grace with song,

473 the young men of the Achaeans  
singing the beautiful paeon,  
474 hymning the worker-from-afar; and  
he listened, and his heart was glad.  
475 And when the sun went down and  
darkness came on,  
476 they lay down to sleep by the ship's  
stern-cables;  
477 and when early-born rosy-fingered  
Dawn<sup>36</sup> appeared,  
478 then they put to sea for the wide  
Achaean camp,  
479 and Apollo the worker-from-afar sent  
them a following wind.  
480 They stepped the mast and spread the  
white sails,  
481 and the wind filled the belly of the  
sail, and around the cutwater  
482 the surging wave sang loud as the ship

went on,

483 and she ran down the waves, making  
her way.

484 And when they came to the wide  
Achaean camp,

485 they hauled the black ship up on the  
mainland,

486 high on the sand, and set the long  
props under her,

487 and scattered among the huts and  
ships.

488 But he raged on, sitting by his swift-  
faring ships,37

489 the Zeus-sprung son of Peleus, swift-  
footed Achilles.

490 He never went now to the assembly  
where men win glory,

491 never to war, but wasted his own heart  
away

492 staying there, longing for the war-cry  
and for battle.

493 But when the twelfth dawn from that  
day came,

494 then the gods who live forever went  
to Olympus

495 all together, Zeus leading. And Thetis  
did not forget the charge

496 of her son: she rose from the swell of  
the sea

497 and in the early mist went up to the  
great sky and Olympus.

498 She found the wide-seeing son of  
Cronos sitting apart from the others

499 on the topmost peak of many-ridged  
Olympus.

500 She sat down before him, and took his  
knees**38**

501 with her left hand, and with her right

taking him under the chin,  
502 she spoke in supplication to lord Zeus,  
son of Cronos:  
503 “Father Zeus, if ever among the  
immortals I helped you  
504 by word or deed, grant me this wish:  
505 honor my son, who is doomed to the  
swiftest death of all —  
506 and now the lord of men Agamemnon  
507 has dishonored him: he has taken and  
keeps his prize; he seized it himself.  
508 But honor him, Olympian Zeus of the  
counsels:  
509 give power to the Trojans until the  
Achaeans  
510 pay my son his due and magnify him  
with honor.”  
511 So she spoke. And Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer39 said nothing;

512 he sat silent a long time. And Thetis,  
as she had clasped his knees,  
513 so she held on, clinging close, and  
asked a second time:  
514 “Promise me truly now, and bow your  
head,  
515 or refuse — you have nothing to fear —  
so I may know well  
516 how far I am the most dishonored  
goddess of all.”  
517 Greatly troubled, Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer answered her:  
518 “A sorry business — you will set me at  
feud  
519 with Hera, when she provokes me with  
her taunting words.  
520 Even as it is she is forever at me  
among the immortal gods,  
521 saying I help the Trojans in battle.

522 Go now, go back, before Hera sees  
anything;  
523 these things will be my care, until I  
accomplish them.  
524 Look — I will bow my head to you, so  
you may believe:  
525 that, from me, is the greatest pledge  
among the immortals;  
526 for nothing of mine can be taken back,  
nothing proves false,  
527 nothing goes unfulfilled, once I bow  
my head to it.”  
528 The son of Cronos spoke, and nodded  
with his dark brows,  
529 and the ambrosial hair rolled forward  
from the lord’s  
530 immortal head; and he shook great  
Olympus.



531 So the two took counsel and parted.  
She  
532 leapt into the deep sea from shining  
Olympus,  
533 and Zeus went to his own house. And  
the gods all rose  
534 from their seats before their father;  
not one dared  
535 stay seated as he came, but all stood  
up to meet him.  
536 So he sat down there on his throne.  
But Hera  
537 had seen, and was not fooled: silver-  
footed Thetis<sup>40</sup>,  
538 daughter of the old man of the sea,  
had counseled with him.  
539 At once she spoke to Zeus, son of  
Cronos, with cutting words:  
540 “Which of the gods this time,

schemer, has been counseling with you?

541 It is always dear to you to be apart  
from me,

542 deciding things in secret. Never yet  
have you brought yourself

543 to tell me openly a word of what you  
intend.”

544 Then the father of men and gods  
answered her:

545 “Hera, do not hope to know all my  
words:

546 they would be hard for you, wife  
though you are.

547 Whatever is fitting to hear, no one,  
god or man,

548 shall know before you;

549 but what I choose to think apart from  
the gods,

550 do not pry into all that, or question me.”

551 Then the ox-eyed lady Hera<sup>41</sup> answered him:

552 “Most dread son of Cronos, what a word you have spoken!

553 Before now I have hardly asked or pried;

554 quite at your ease you decide whatever you wish.

555 But now I am terribly afraid at heart that she has won you over —

556 silver-footed Thetis, daughter of the old man of the sea.

557 In the early mist she sat beside you and took your knees,

558 and I think you bowed your head to her, a firm pledge to honor

559 Achilles, and to destroy many beside  
the Achaean ships.”

560 Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer:

561 “Strange one — always suspecting; I  
can never escape you.

562 Yet you will have no power to do  
anything about it, only sit

563 further from my heart — and that will  
be the colder for you.

564 If this is as you say, then it must be my  
pleasure.

565 Sit down and be silent, and obey my  
word,

566 or all the gods on Olympus may be no  
help to you

567 when I come nearer and lay my  
irresistible hands on you.”

568 So he spoke, and the ox-eyed lady  
Hera was afraid,  
569 and sat down in silence, bending her  
own heart.  
570 And through the house of Zeus the  
heavenly gods were troubled.  
571 Then Hephaestus, famed for craft,  
began to speak among them,  
572 bringing comfort to his dear mother,  
white-armed Hera:  
573 “A sorry business this will be, not to be  
borne,  
574 if you two quarrel this way over  
mortals  
575 and drive brawling through the gods.  
There will be no pleasure  
576 in the good feast, when the worse side  
wins.  
577 I advise my mother — though she

understands it herself —

578 to bring comfort to our dear father  
Zeus, so that the father

579 not scold again and throw our feast  
into confusion.

580 For if the Olympian, lord of lightning,  
chooses

581 to blast us from our seats — well, he is  
far the strongest.

582 No — touch him with soft words,

583 and at once the Olympian will be  
gracious to us.”

584 So he spoke, and springing up he set  
the two-handled cup

585 in his dear mother’s hand, and said to  
her:

586 “Bear up, my mother, and endure it,  
grieved though you are,

587 or I may see you beaten before my

eyes,

588 dear as you are — and then, for all my  
grief, I will have no power

589 to help. The Olympian is a hard one to  
stand against.

590 Once before, when I was straining to  
defend you,42

591 he caught me by the foot and flung me  
from the threshold of heaven:

592 all day I fell, and with the setting sun

593 I dropped on Lemnos, and there was  
little breath left in me;

594 there the Sintian men took me up,  
quickly, where I had fallen.”

595 So he spoke, and the goddess white-  
armed Hera smiled,

596 and smiling took the cup from her  
son’s hand.

597 Then, moving to the right, he poured

for all the other gods,  
598 drawing sweet nectar from the mixing  
bowl,  
599 and unquenchable laughter rose  
among the blessed gods  
600 as they watched Hephaestus bustling  
through the halls.  
601 So all day long until the sun went  
down  
602 they feasted, and no heart lacked a  
fair share of the feast,  
603 nor of the beautiful lyre that Apollo  
held,  
604 nor of the Muses, who sang in answer  
with lovely voice.  
605 But when the bright light of the sun  
had set,  
606 they went each to his own house to lie  
down,



607 where for each of them the famed  
crook-footed god,  
608 Hephaestus, had built a house with  
cunning skill.  
609 And Zeus the Olympian, lord of  
lightning, went to his own bed,  
610 where he always lay when sweet sleep  
came upon him;  
611 there he climbed and slept, with Hera  
of the golden throne beside him.

## Notes

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### NOTES

1. (1.1) “wrath” (μῆνιν) — the poem’s first word and announced theme. Rendered “wrath” rather than “rage” or “anger”: *mēnis* is a sustained, quasi-divine grudge (elsewhere used almost solely of gods), not a flash of temper, and “wrath” carries that weight. See the commentary above. ↩

2. (1.3) “souls” (ψυχάς) — Apollonius Rhodius is reported to have read κεφαλάς, “heads” (apparatus/book\_01.txt, Line 3). The vulgate “souls” is kept; “hurled heads to Hades” would make the bodies-for-dogs of the next lines redundant. ↩
3. (1.4-5) Zenodotus athetized both lines (apparatus, Line 4-5: ath. Zen); separately his text is reported (via Athenaeus) to have read δαῖτα, making the corpses “a feast” for the birds (disputed\_lines.md #1). Translated from the vulgate (πᾶσι, “every bird”), keeping the grim literal image over the sardonic “banquet”; see commentary. ↩
4. (1.7) “lord of men” (ἄναξ ἀνδρῶν) — Agamemnon’s fixed title epithet, always so rendered. Likewise δῖος (“heavenly, radiant”) is always “brilliant” — of Achilles and Odysseus here, of many heroes later. Epithet conventions are noted at first occurrence only; the full list lives in translation/CONVENTIONS.md. ↩
5. (1.14-15) The wreaths (στέμματα) are the god’s woolen fillets, carried on the priest’s golden staff: portable proof of sacred office. Chryses arrives simultaneously as suppliant and as Apollo’s

representative, so Agamemnon's threat in 26-32 is sacrilege, not mere rudeness. ↩

6. (1.14) “who strikes from afar” (ἐκηβόλος) — first of Apollo's archer epithets, a family rendered consistently: ἐκηβόλος/ἐκατηβόλος and ἐκατηβελέτης “who strikes from afar,” ἔκατος “the far-striker,” ἐκάεργος “the worker-from-afar.” ↩
7. (1.17) “strong-greaved Achaeans” (ἑϋκνήμιδες Ἀχαιοί) — stock epithet of the army (greaves: bronze shin-guards). Note also that “Achaeans,” “Danaans,” and “Argives” all name the same Greek host interchangeably, as meter requires; the translation keeps whichever the Greek uses. ↩
8. (1.29-31) Aristarchus athetized these three lines (apparatus, Line 29-31: ath. Ar.) — ancient critics found Agamemnon's leering detail unbecoming. Kept, following the printed text; the coarseness is dramatically apt at this first display of his character. ↩
9. (1.34) “loud-roaring sea” (πολυφλοίσβοιο θαλάσσης) — famous onomatopoeic formula for the surf-line, rendered thus wherever it recurs. ↩

10. (1.39) “Smintheus” — obscure cult title of Apollo, in antiquity connected with σμίνθος “mouse”; a mouse-god (whether as sender or averter of vermin and pestilence) suits the plague-god invoked here. Left untranslated, as a cult name. ↩
11. (1.46-47) Zenodotus athetized these two lines (apparatus, Line 46-47: ath. Zen) — the clashing arrows and “he came on like nightfall.” Kept; the simile is among the most admired in the poem. ↩
12. (1.55) “white-armed Hera” (λευκώλενος Ἥρη) — her fixed epithet; white forearms as a mark of female beauty (elite women stayed unsunburned). ↩
13. (1.58) “swift-footed Achilles” — his defining epithet. The Greek alternates πόδας ὠκύς (“swift as to his feet”) and ποδάρκης (“foot-strong”) by metrical convenience; both are rendered “swift-footed” rather than inventing a distinction English cannot hear. ↩
14. (1.63) “for a dream too is from Zeus” — athetized by Zenodotus (apparatus, Line 63: ath. Zen). Kept; the parenthetical justification is characteristic of Achilles’ earnest style here. ↩

15. (1.65) “hecatomb” (ἑκατόμβη) — literally “a hundred oxen,” in practice any large-scale public sacrifice (the one at 458 ff. is of bulls and goats, far fewer than a hundred). Kept as the standard English term. ↩
16. (1.97) For this line Zenodotus’ text read instead “until he holds back the plague’s heavy hands from the Danaans” (apparatus, Line 97). The vulgate, printed here, makes Apollo the subject throughout; the sense is not materially changed. ↩
17. (1.118-120) “prize” (γέρας) — the concrete share of spoils publicly awarded as the embodiment of a warrior’s honor (τιμή). Chryseis and Briseis are both gera. The entire quarrel runs on this institution: to lose one’s geras by force is to be publicly declared worthless, which is why Achilles calls the seizure “dishonoring” (ἀτιμάζειν). “Prize” is kept rigidly for γέρας throughout the translation. ↩
18. (1.143) “fair-cheeked” (καλλιπάρηος) — stock beauty epithet, used in this book of both Chryseis and Briseis; always so rendered. ↩
19. (1.159) “dog-face” (κυνῶπα) — in Homeric invective the dog is the type of shamelessness (scavenging, fawning, no sense of decency), not of loyalty; hence also “dog’s eyes” in Achilles’ next speech (225). The

insults are translated literally to keep their animal force. ↩

20. (1.201) “winged words” (ἔπεα πτερόεντα) — formula for direct speech launched at an addressee, probably from the image of a feathered arrow flying straight to its mark; always so rendered. ↩

21. (1.202) “aegis-bearing Zeus” (αἰγίοχος) — the aegis is Zeus’s terror-inducing goat-skin storm-shield, wielded also by Athena; his commonest fixed epithet. ↩

22. (1.206) “grey-eyed Athena” (γλαυκῶπις Ἀθήνη) — γλαυκῶπις may mean “gleaming-eyed” or “grey/silvery-eyed,” and was anciently connected with γλαύξ “owl,” her bird. “Grey-eyed” is adopted as the conventional English; the gleam, not the hue, is what the scenes exploit (cf. 200, “the eyes shining terribly”). ↩

23. (1.225-233) Zenodotus athetized this entire opening of Achilles’ tirade through the beginning of the oath (apparatus, Line 225-233: ath. Zen) — presumably as unworthy abuse. Kept: the escalation from insult to formal oath-on-the-staff is the dramatic hinge of the assembly. ↩

24. (1.265) The Theseus line is absent from most manuscripts and is identical to Hesiod, *Shield* 182; it is almost certainly a later insertion here (apparatus, Line 265: om. vulg.). Retained, bracketed by no marks, since the printed text keeps it — but it is the weakest line of the catalogue. The “beasts that lair in the mountains” (268, φῆρες) are the centaurs: Nestor is recalling the Lapith-centaur war. ↩
25. (1.291) “give him leave to hurl insults” — the verb προθέουσιν is an old crux: taken here (with the project treebank) as from προτίθημι, “do they set it before him / license him?”; others derive it from προθέω, “do his insults run out ahead?” The sarcastic sense — prowess is god-given, abuse is not — is the same either way. ↩
26. (1.307) “Menoetius’ son” — Patroclus, here making his first, silent appearance in the poem; he is named at 337. ↩
27. (1.311) “resourceful Odysseus” (πολύμητις) — “of much cunning intelligence (mētis)”; his fixed epithet, always so rendered. ↩
28. (1.316) “barren sea” (ἄτρυγέτοιο) — formulaic sea-epithet of uncertain sense, traditionally

“unharvested/yielding no crop”; “barren” is adopted as the convention. ↩

29. (1.350) “the boundless deep” — the printed text follows Aristarchus’ reading ἀπείρονα (“boundless”); nearly all manuscripts have οἶνοπα, the famous “wine-dark sea” (apparatus, Line 350). Readers expecting “wine-dark” here are remembering the manuscript vulgate. Translated as printed, with real regret. ↩
30. (1.366) Thebe — a town of the Troad ruled by Eëtion, father of Hector’s wife Andromache. Achilles sacked it; Chryseis was captured there (visiting, evidently, since her home is Chryse). The raid resurfaces in Book 6 as the source of Andromache’s griefs. ↩
31. (1.372-379) These eight lines repeat 12-16 and 22-25 verbatim — normal epic technique when a character retells events — and Aristarchus athetized the repetition here (apparatus, Line 372-379: ath. hic Ar.). Kept, and translated in identical words, since verbatim recurrence is a deliberate feature of the style. ↩
32. (1.396-406) Zenodotus athetized the whole Briareus digression (apparatus, Line 396-406: ath. Zen) — the only surviving mention of this failed divine coup



against Zeus. At 400 his text also named “Phoebus Apollo” among the conspirators instead of “Pallas Athena” (apparatus, Line 400). Kept as printed: the story is doing real work, reminding Zeus (through Thetis) of a concrete debt. ↩

33. (1.403-404) A rare glimpse of double naming: gods say “Briareus,” men say “Aegaeon.” The hundred-handed giant is elsewhere a son of Uranus; “stronger than his father” here more likely points to a tradition making him Poseidon’s son. Zenodotus’ text expanded the line with a verse on his strength (apparatus, Line 404). ↩

34. (1.423-425) The gods’ twelve-day absence feasting with the “blameless Ethiopians” at the world-encircling stream of Ocean is a standard epic device for clearing the divine stage. “For a feast” follows Aristarchus’ reading κατὰ δαῖτα (apparatus, Line 424). ↩

35. (1.458-466) The standard Homeric sacrifice, described with ritual precision: barley thrown, head drawn back, throat cut; thigh-bones wrapped in a double fold of fat with raw strips laid on top are the god’s portion, burned with wine poured over; the innards (σπλάγχνα) are tasted first by the participants, then

the rest is spitted and roasted for the shared feast.  
The gods receive smoke and savor; the people,  
dinner. ↩

36. (1.477) “early-born rosy-fingered Dawn”  
(ῥοδοδάκτυλος Ἥως) — the most famous of all  
Homeric formulas, marking daybreak; always so  
rendered. ↩
37. (1.488-492) Zenodotus athetized these five lines on  
Achilles wasting his heart in idleness (apparatus,  
Line 488-492: ath. Zen.). Kept: they are the essential  
bridge from quarrel to consequence, holding  
Achilles motionless while the plot moves to  
Olympus. ↩
38. (1.500-501) Thetis performs the full ritual of  
supplication: crouch before the person, clasp the  
knees with one hand, reach for the chin with the  
other. A completed supplication put the supplicated  
under strong obligation — hence Zeus’s trapped  
silence at 511-512. ↩
39. (1.511) “Zeus the cloud-gatherer” (νεφεληγερέτα  
Ζεὺς) — his fixed weather-god epithet, always so  
rendered. ↩

40. (1.538) “silver-footed Thetis” (ἀργυρόπεζα) — her fixed epithet. The “old man of the sea” is Nereus, her father, never named in the Iliad but always so designated. ↩
41. (1.551) “ox-eyed lady Hera” (βοῶπις πότνια Ἥρη) — her second fixed epithet: large, dark, liquid eyes as an archaic mark of majesty and beauty, possibly a fossil of older theriomorphic cult. Rendered literally. ↩
42. (1.590-594) Hephaestus’ fall: Zeus once hurled him from Olympus for siding with Hera; he fell a whole day, landed on Lemnos, and was tended by the Sintians, the island’s non-Greek early inhabitants. Lemnos was the chief historical center of Hephaestus’ cult. (Book 18 has a different, incompatible fall-story — thrown by Hera at birth; the poem tolerates both.) ↩

# Book 2

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*The lying Dream, the testing of the army,  
Thersites beaten — and the Catalogue of Ships.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 The other gods, and men who fight from chariots,
- 2 slept the whole night through; but sweet sleep did not hold Zeus.
- 3 He was turning over in his mind how he might honor
- 4 Achilles, and destroy many beside the Achaeon ships.
- 5 And this plan seemed to his heart the best:
- 6 to send baneful Dream to Atreus' son

Agamemnon.<sup>1</sup>

7 And speaking winged words he  
addressed him:

8 “Up, go, baneful Dream, to the  
Achaeans’ swift ships.

9 Come to the hut of Agamemnon, Atreus’  
son,

10 and tell him everything exactly as I  
charge you.

11 Bid him arm the long-haired Achaeans<sup>2</sup>

12 in full force: for now he might take the  
wide-wayed city

13 of the Trojans. The immortals who keep  
their homes on Olympus

14 are no longer divided; Hera has bent  
them all

15 by her begging, and sorrows are  
fastened on the Trojans.”

16 So he spoke, and Dream went when he

had heard the word.

17 Swiftly he came to the Achaeans' swift  
ships

18 and went to Atreus' son Agamemnon.  
He found him

19 sleeping in his hut, ambrosial slumber  
poured around him.

20 He stood above his head in the likeness  
of Neleus' son

21 Nestor, whom Agamemnon honored  
most of the elders;

22 in his likeness the divine Dream spoke:

23 "You sleep, son of war-minded Atreus,  
breaker of horses.3

24 A man of counsel should not sleep the  
whole night through,

25 a man to whom peoples are entrusted,  
who has so much to care for.

26 Now hear me quickly: I am a messenger

of Zeus,  
27 who far away cares greatly for you, and  
pities you.  
28 He bids you arm the long-haired  
Achaeans  
29 in full force: for now you might take  
the wide-wayed city  
30 of the Trojans. The immortals who  
keep their homes on Olympus  
31 are no longer divided; Hera has bent  
them all  
32 by her begging, and sorrows are  
fastened on the Trojans  
33 from Zeus. Keep this in your mind, and  
let no forgetting  
34 take you, when honey-hearted sleep  
lets you go.”  
35 So he spoke and went away, and left  
him there

36 believing in his heart things that were  
not to be:

37 he thought he would take Priam's city  
on that very day —

38 the fool: he did not know what work  
Zeus was planning,

39 who meant to lay yet more griefs and  
groans

40 on Trojans and Danaans alike through  
the strong encounters of war.

41 He woke from sleep, the divine voice  
drifting around him,

42 and sat upright, and pulled on his soft  
tunic,

43 fine and new-made, and threw his  
great cloak around him,

44 and beneath his shining feet he bound  
fair sandals,

45 and slung about his shoulders the



silver-studded sword,  
46 and took up the ancestral scepter,  
imperishable forever,  
47 and with it went down along the ships  
of the bronze-shirted Achaeans.  
48 Now the goddess Dawn went up to high  
Olympus,  
49 announcing light to Zeus and the  
immortals;  
50 and he ordered the clear-voiced  
heralds  
51 to summon the long-haired Achaeans  
to assembly.  
52 They made the summons, and the men  
gathered quickly.  
53 But first he seated a council of great-  
hearted elders  
54 beside the ship of Nestor, the Pylos-  
born king,

55 and calling them together he framed  
his shrewd plan:

56 “Hear me, friends. A divine Dream  
came to me in sleep

57 through the ambrosial night, and in  
face, in build, in bearing

58 it was most like brilliant Nestor.

59 It stood above my head, and it said to  
me:

60 ‘You sleep, son of war-minded Atreus,  
breaker of horses.4

61 A man of counsel should not sleep the  
whole night through,

62 a man to whom peoples are entrusted,  
who has so much to care for.

63 Now hear me quickly: I am a messenger  
of Zeus,

64 who far away cares greatly for you, and  
pities you.

65 He bids you arm the long-haired  
Achaean  
66 in full force: for now you might take  
the wide-wayed city  
67 of the Trojans. The immortals who  
keep their homes on Olympus  
68 are no longer divided; Hera has bent  
them all  
69 by her begging, and sorrows are  
fastened on the Trojans  
70 from Zeus. Keep this in your mind.' So  
the Dream spoke  
71 and flew away, and sweet sleep released  
me.  
72 Come then — let us see if we can arm  
the sons of the Achaeans.  
73 But first I will test them with words, as  
is the custom,<sup>5</sup>  
74 and order them to flee with the many-

benched ships;

75 and you, from your places, one here,  
one there, hold them back with words.”

76 So he spoke and sat down; and among  
them rose

77 Nestor, who was king of sandy Pylos.

78 With good will toward them he spoke  
and addressed them:

79 “Friends, leaders and lords of the  
Argives,

80 if any other Achaean had told us this  
dream,

81 we would call it a lie and turn our backs  
on it;

82 but the man who saw it claims to be far  
the best of the Achaeans.

83 Come then — let us see if we can arm  
the sons of the Achaeans.”

84 So he spoke, and led the way out of the

council,  
85 and the scepter-holding kings rose and  
obeyed  
86 the shepherd of the people; and the  
troops came streaming.  
87 As when the tribes of thronging bees  
come out  
88 of some hollow rock, always arriving  
anew,  
89 and fly in clusters over the flowers of  
spring,  
90 and some swarm thick this way, and  
some that way —  
91 so the many tribes of men from the  
ships and huts  
92 marched in companies along the deep  
beach  
93 to the assembly; and among them  
Rumor blazed like fire,

94 Zeus's messenger, driving them on; and  
they kept gathering.

95 The assembly was in turmoil, and the  
earth groaned beneath

96 as the troops sat down, and there was  
uproar. Nine heralds,

97 shouting, tried to hold them back — to  
stop the clamor

98 and make them listen to the Zeus-  
nurtured kings.

99 With effort the people were seated,  
held in their places,

100 and left off shouting. Then the lord  
Agamemnon stood up,

101 holding the scepter Hephaestus had  
labored to make.<sup>6</sup>

102 Hephaestus gave it to lord Zeus, son of  
Cronos;

103 then Zeus gave it to the guide, the

slayer of Argus;

104 lord Hermes gave it to Pelops, driver  
of horses;

105 Pelops in turn gave it to Atreus,  
shepherd of the people;

106 Atreus, dying, left it to Thyestes rich  
in flocks;

107 and Thyestes in turn left it to  
Agamemnon to carry,

108 to be lord over many islands and all of  
Argos.

109 Leaning on it, he spoke his words to  
the Argives:

110 “Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of  
Ares,

111 Zeus, Cronos’ great son, has bound me  
fast in heavy blindness —7

112 the hard god: he promised me once, he  
bowed his head,

113 that I should sack well-walled Iliion  
before returning;  
114 now he has planned a cruel deceit, and  
orders me  
115 back to Argos in disgrace, with half my  
people lost.  
116 Such, it seems, must be the pleasure of  
overmastering Zeus,  
117 who has undone the crowns of many  
cities  
118 and will undo more yet: his power is  
the greatest.  
119 This is a shameful thing even for men  
to come to hear of,  
120 that so fine an Achaeian host, so great,  
121 fought a fruitless war and battled  
122 fewer men, with no end yet in sight.  
123 For if we wished — Achaeians and  
Trojans both —



124 to swear a solemn truce and count  
ourselves,  
125 the Trojans mustering all who have  
their hearths in the city,  
126 and we Achaeans forming up in tens,  
127 and each ten chose one Trojan man to  
pour its wine,  
128 many tens would go without a wine-  
pourer.  
129 By so much, I tell you, the sons of the  
Achaeans outnumber  
130 the Trojans who live in the city. But  
there are allies,  
131 spear-wielding men from many cities,  
132 who beat me far off my course and  
will not let me  
133 sack Ilion's well-settled citadel, for all  
my wanting it.  
134 Nine years of great Zeus have gone

already,  
135 and now the ships' timbers are rotten,  
the rigging loosed,  
136 and our wives, no doubt, and our little  
children  
137 sit in our halls waiting; while the work  
138 for which we came here stands as  
undone as ever.  
139 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:  
140 let us flee with the ships to our dear  
fatherland.  
141 We shall not take wide-wayed Troy  
now.”  
142 So he spoke, and stirred the heart in  
the breast  
143 of everyone in the crowd who had not  
heard the council.  
144 The assembly moved like the long  
waves of the sea,

145 the Icarian deep, when East Wind and  
South Wind together  
146 rouse them, rushing down from the  
clouds of father Zeus;  
147 or as when the West Wind comes and  
moves deep grain,  
148 driving hard, and the field bows its  
ears —  
149 so all that assembly was moved. With a  
roar  
150 they rushed for the ships, and under  
their feet the dust  
151 rose and hung; and they shouted to  
one another  
152 to lay hold of the ships and drag them  
to the bright sea,  
153 and they cleared out the launching-  
channels; the cry went up to the sky  
154 as they strained for home; and they

pulled the props from under the hulls.

155 Then a homecoming beyond fate  
would have come to the Argives,

156 if Hera had not spoken a word to  
Athena:

157 “Shame! Unwearied one, child of  
aegis-bearing Zeus —8

158 is it like this, homeward, to their dear  
fatherland,

159 that the Argives are to flee over the  
broad back of the sea,

160 and leave to Priam and the Trojans  
their boast —

161 Argive Helen, for whose sake so many  
Achaeans

162 have perished at Troy, far from their  
dear fatherland?

163 Go now through the host of the  
bronze-shirted Achaeans;

164 with your gentle words hold back  
every man;  
165 do not let them drag the balanced  
ships down to the sea.”  
166 So she spoke, and the goddess grey-  
eyed Athena did not disobey.  
167 Down from the peaks of Olympus she  
went darting  
168 and swiftly came to the Achaeans’  
swift ships.  
169 There she found Odysseus, the equal  
of Zeus in counsel,<sup>9</sup>  
170 standing still: he had not laid a hand  
on his black  
171 well-benched ship, for grief had  
reached his heart and spirit.  
172 Standing close, grey-eyed Athena  
spoke to him:  
173 “Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus

of many devices,**10**

**174** is it like this, homeward, to your dear  
fatherland,

**175** that you will all flee, tumbling into the  
many-benched ships,

**176** and leave to Priam and the Trojans  
their boast —

**177** Argive Helen, for whose sake so many  
Achaean

**178** have perished at Troy, far from their  
dear fatherland?

**179** Go now through the host of the  
Achaean; hold back no longer;

**180** with your gentle words hold back  
every man;

**181** do not let them drag the balanced  
ships down to the sea.”

**182** So she spoke, and he knew the voice of  
the goddess speaking.

183 He set off at a run, and threw off his  
cloak — the herald  
184 Eurybates of Ithaca, who attended  
him, picked it up —  
185 and coming face to face with  
Agamemnon, Atreus' son,  
186 he took from him the ancestral  
scepter, imperishable forever,  
187 and with it went along the ships of the  
bronze-shirted Achaeans.  
188 Whenever he met a king, or a man of  
note,  
189 he would stand beside him and hold  
him back with gentle words:  
190 “Friend, it is not right to threaten you  
like a coward;  
191 but sit down yourself, and seat the rest  
of your people.  
192 You do not yet clearly know the mind

of Atreus' son:

193 now he is testing, and soon he will  
bear down on the sons of the Achaeans.11

194 Did we not all hear in council what he  
said?

195 May he not in anger do some harm to  
the sons of the Achaeans.

196 Great is the anger of Zeus-nurtured  
kings;

197 their honor is from Zeus, and Zeus the  
counselor loves them.”

198 But whatever man of the people he  
saw, and found him shouting,

199 him he would drive with the scepter  
and berate aloud:

200 “Fool — sit still and listen to what  
others tell you,

201 your betters. You are unwarlike and  
without strength,



202 never counted, whether in battle or in council.

203 We cannot all be kings here, we Achaeans.

204 The rule of many is no good thing: let there be one ruler,<sup>12</sup>

205 one king, to whom the son of crooked-counseled Cronos gave

206 the scepter and the ordinances, to do the ruling for his people.”

207 So, masterfully, he went through the army setting it in order; and they

208 came streaming back to the assembly from the ships and huts

209 with a roar, as when a wave of the loud-roaring sea

210 thunders on a great beach, and the deep crashes in answer.

211 Then the others sat down and were

held in their places —

212 all but Thersites, alone, still brawling  
on, unmeasured in speech, 13

213 whose mind was full of words,  
disorderly and many,

214 to quarrel with kings — recklessly, in  
no kind of order,

215 but with whatever looked likely to  
raise a laugh

216 among the Argives. And he was the  
ugliest man who came under Ilion:

217 bandy-legged, lame in one foot, his  
two shoulders

218 hunched and drawn in over his chest;  
and above them

219 a head that came to a point, with  
sparse stubble growing on it.

220 He was hatefulest of all to Achilles  
and Odysseus,

221 for those two he was forever reviling.  
But now it was brilliant Agamemnon  
222 he went at, shrieking shrill abuse; the  
Achaeans  
223 were furious at him, and indignation  
rose in every heart.  
224 Bawling loudly, he berated  
Agamemnon:  
225 “Son of Atreus, what are you  
complaining of now? What more do you  
want?  
226 Your huts are full of bronze; there are  
many women  
227 in your huts, choice ones, whom we  
Achaeans  
228 give you first of all whenever we take  
a town.  
229 Or do you still lack gold as well, that  
some son

230 of the horse-taming Trojans will bring  
out of Ilion as ransom  
231 for a son that I bound and led away —  
I, or another Achaean?  
232 Or a young woman, to lie with in love,  
233 one you keep apart for yourself? It is  
not right  
234 for the commander to march the sons  
of the Achaeans into misery.  
235 Soft things! Vile disgraces! Achaean  
women — Achaean men no longer!  
236 Let us go home, home with the ships,  
and leave this man  
237 here in Troy to digest his prizes, so he  
may learn  
238 whether we others are any help to  
him or not —  
239 he who even now dishonored Achilles,  
a man

240 far better than himself: he has taken  
and keeps his prize; he seized it himself.  
241 But there is no anger in Achilles'  
heart; he lets it go.  
242 Otherwise, son of Atreus, this outrage  
would be your last."  
243 So he spoke, reviling Agamemnon,  
shepherd of the people —  
244 Thersites. But quickly brilliant  
Odysseus was at his side,  
245 and glaring at him darkly he lashed  
him with hard words:  
246 "Thersites — endless babble, clear-  
voiced speaker though you are:  
247 stop; do not stand up alone to quarrel  
with kings.  
248 I say there is no viler mortal than you  
249 of all who came under Ilion with the  
sons of Atreus.

250 So you had better not take kings into  
your mouth when you hold forth,  
251 hurling insults at them, with one eye  
on the voyage home.  
252 We do not even know clearly yet how  
these things will end —  
253 whether we sons of the Achaeans  
come home well or badly.  
254 So now you sit here reviling  
Agamemnon, Atreus' son,  
255 shepherd of the people, because the  
Danaan heroes  
256 give him so much. You speak in  
mockery.  
257 But I tell you this outright, and it will  
be accomplished:  
258 if I find you playing the fool again as  
you are now,  
259 then may Odysseus' head no longer sit

on his shoulders,  
260 may I no longer be called the father of  
Telemachus,  
261 if I do not seize you and strip you of  
your own clothes,  
262 the cloak and the tunic that cover  
your shame,  
263 and send you off to the swift ships in  
tears,  
264 whipped out of the assembly with  
strokes of disgrace.”  
265 So he spoke, and with the scepter he  
struck his back  
266 and shoulders. Thersites doubled up,  
and a fat tear fell from him,  
267 and a bloody welt rose up out of his  
back  
268 under the golden scepter. He sat  
down, terrified,

269 and hurting, with a helpless look, he  
wiped away the tear.

270 And the men, vexed at heart though  
they were, laughed at him sweetly,

271 and thus one would say, with a glance  
at his neighbor:

272 “Well now! Odysseus has done ten  
thousand good things,

273 leading in good counsel, marshaling  
war;

274 but this is the best thing he has done  
among the Argives:

275 he has shut this word-slinging insulter  
out of our debates.

276 That proud heart of his will not send  
him back again

277 to rail at kings with words of abuse.”

278 So spoke the multitude. Then the  
sacker of cities, Odysseus,



279 stood up with the scepter, and beside  
him grey-eyed Athena,  
280 in the likeness of a herald, called the  
host to silence,  
281 so that near and far the sons of the  
Achaeans  
282 might hear his word alike, and take in  
his counsel.  
283 With good will toward them he spoke  
and addressed them:  
284 “Son of Atreus — now, lord, the  
Achaeans mean  
285 to make you the most despised of  
mortal men,  
286 and they will not fulfill the promise  
they undertook  
287 while still on the way here from  
horse-pasturing Argos:  
288 that you should sack well-walled Ilion

before returning.

289 Like little children or widowed women  
290 they wail to one another about going  
home.

291 And truly, there is toil here to send a  
man home disheartened:

292 a man kept even one month from his  
wife

293 frets by his many-benched ship when  
the winter gales

294 and the rising sea shut him in;

295 and for us this is the ninth year,  
circling round,

296 that we have stayed here. So I cannot  
blame the Achaeans

297 for fretting beside the beaked ships.

But even so —

298 it is shameful to wait so long and then  
come home empty.

299 Bear up, friends, and stay a while  
longer, till we learn  
300 whether Calchas prophesies truly or  
not.  
301 For this we know well in our hearts,  
and you are all  
302 witnesses — all whom the fates of  
death have not carried off:  
303 only yesterday, it seems, when the  
Achaean ships were gathering  
304 at Aulis, bearing evils for Priam and  
the Trojans,  
305 and we, around a spring, at the holy  
altars,  
306 were offering the immortals perfect  
hecatombs  
307 under a beautiful plane tree, where  
the bright water ran:  
308 there a great sign appeared. A

serpent, its back blood-dark,  
309 terrible, which the Olympian himself  
had sent into the light,  
310 darted from under the altar and made  
for the plane tree.  
311 There were nestling sparrows there,  
baby chicks,  
312 on the topmost branch, cowering  
under the leaves —  
313 eight of them, and the mother who  
hatched them made nine.  
314 There he devoured them, cheeping  
piteously,  
315 while the mother fluttered around,  
crying for her dear chicks;  
316 and coiling up he caught her by the  
wing as she shrieked about him.  
317 But when he had eaten the sparrow's  
children and the bird herself,

318 the god who had shown him made  
him a sign conspicuous:14  
319 the son of crooked-counseled Cronos  
turned him to stone,  
320 and we stood there marveling at what  
had happened.  
321 So then: since this dread portent  
entered the gods' hecatombs,  
322 Calchas straightway spoke in  
prophecy:  
323 'Why have you fallen silent, long-  
haired Achaeans?  
324 For us Zeus the counselor has shown  
this great sign,  
325 late, late of fulfillment, whose fame  
will never perish.  
326 As this serpent ate the sparrow's  
children and the bird herself —  
327 eight, and the mother who hatched

them made nine —

328 so shall we make war here for as many  
years,

329 and in the tenth we shall take the  
wide-wayed city.’

330 That is how he spoke; and now it is all  
being fulfilled.

331 Come then, stay, all of you, strong-  
greaved Achaeans,

332 right here, until we take the great city  
of Priam.”

333 So he spoke, and the Argives roared  
aloud — and around them the ships

334 echoed terribly under the shouting of  
the Achaeans —

335 in praise of the word of godlike  
Odysseus.

336 And among them spoke the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor:15

337 “Shame! You hold assembly like little  
boys,  
338 infants with no interest in deeds of  
war.  
339 Where then will our compacts go, and  
our oaths?  
340 Into the fire, then, with every counsel  
and plan of men,  
341 the unmixed libations, the right hands  
we trusted!  
342 We are battling with words, and  
nothing else; a remedy  
343 we cannot find, for all our long time  
here.  
344 Son of Atreus — hold your counsel  
unshaken, as before,  
345 and lead the Argives through the  
strong encounters;  
346 and let them rot, the one or two of the

Achaeans

347 who take counsel apart — they will  
accomplish nothing —

348 all for going back to Argos before we  
know

349 whether the promise of aegis-bearing  
Zeus is a lie or not.

350 For I say the overmastering son of  
Cronos bowed his head

351 on that day when the Argives went  
aboard their swift-faring ships

352 bearing slaughter and doom for the  
Trojans:

353 lightening on the right, showing signs  
of good omen.

354 Therefore let no man press to be gone  
homeward

355 before he has lain beside the wife of  
some Trojan,



356 and avenged the struggles and groans  
of Helen.16

357 But if any man is wildly set on going  
home,

358 let him just lay a hand on his black  
well-benched ship,

359 and before all others he will meet his  
death and doom.

360 And you, lord — take good counsel  
yourself, and listen to another;

361 not to be tossed aside is the word I  
speak:

362 divide the men by tribes and by clans,  
Agamemnon,

363 so clan may stand by clan, and tribe  
by tribe.

364 If you do this, and the Achaeans obey,

365 you will know then which of your  
leaders is a coward, and which of your

men,

366 and which is brave: for they will be  
fighting among their own.

367 And you will know whether it is by the  
gods' will you fail to take the city,

368 or by men's cowardice and folly in  
war."

369 Answering him spoke the lord  
Agamemnon:

370 "Once again, old man, you outdo the  
sons of the Achaeans in speech.

371 O father Zeus, Athena, Apollo —

372 if I had ten such counselors among the  
Achaeans,

373 then the city of lord Priam would soon  
bow its head,

374 taken and sacked beneath our hands.

375 But instead aegis-bearing Zeus,  
Cronos' son, gives me griefs,

376 throwing me into fruitless quarrels  
and feuds.

377 I and Achilles fought over a girl

378 with head-on words — and it was I  
who began the anger.

379 If ever we take counsel as one, then no  
longer

380 will there be any putting off of evil for  
the Trojans, not for a moment.

381 Now go to your meal, so we may join  
battle.

382 Let every man sharpen his spear well,  
and set his shield right,

383 let him give his swift-footed horses  
their feed,

384 let him look over his chariot on every  
side, and put his mind on war,

385 so that all day long we may measure  
ourselves in hateful battle.

386 For there will be no pause, not the  
least,  
387 until night comes on and parts the  
fury of men.  
388 The strap of the body-covering shield  
will be sweated through  
389 on many a chest, and the hand will  
ache around the spear,  
390 and many a horse will sweat, straining  
at the polished chariot.  
391 And whomever I see minded to hang  
back from the fighting,  
392 lingering by the beaked ships — for  
him there will be  
393 no hope after that of escaping the  
dogs and the birds.”  
394 So he spoke, and the Argives roared  
aloud, like a wave  
395 against a high headland when the

South Wind comes and drives it  
396 on a jutting cliff — the waves never  
leave it,  
397 whatever wind is blowing, whether  
they rise this side or that.  
398 They stood up and scattered, hurrying  
to the ships,  
399 and made their fires smoke among the  
huts, and took their meal.  
400 And each man sacrificed to one of the  
gods who are forever,  
401 praying to escape death and the grind  
of Ares.  
402 But Agamemnon, lord of men,  
slaughtered an ox,  
403 fat, five years old, to the  
overmastering son of Cronos,  
404 and called the elders, the chief men of  
all the Achaeans:

405 Nestor first of all, and lord Idomeneus,  
406 then the two Ajaxes and Tydeus' son,  
407 and sixth Odysseus, the equal of Zeus  
in counsel.

408 And Menelaus, good at the war-cry,  
came unbidden,<sup>17</sup>

409 for he knew in his heart how his  
brother labored.

410 They stood around the ox and took up  
the barley-grains,

411 and praying among them the lord  
Agamemnon spoke:

412 “Zeus, most glorious, greatest, lord of  
the dark cloud, dwelling in the sky:

413 let not the sun go down, nor the  
darkness come,

414 until I have thrown down Priam's hall  
headlong,

415 blackened with smoke, and burned its

doors with hostile fire,  
416 and slashed the tunic on Hector's  
chest to rags  
417 with the bronze; and around him may  
his companions, many of them,  
418 fall face-down in the dust and bite the  
earth."  
419 So he spoke; but the son of Cronos  
would not yet grant it.  
420 He accepted the offering — and piled  
up joyless toil.  
421 Then, when they had prayed and  
thrown the barley-grains,  
422 they first drew back the victims'  
heads, cut their throats, and flayed them,  
423 carved out the thigh-pieces and  
wrapped them in fat,  
424 making a double fold, and laid raw  
flesh upon them;

425 these they burned on dry leafless  
billets,  
426 and spitted the inner parts and held  
them over the flame of Hephaestus.  
427 When the thighs were burned and  
they had tasted the inner parts,  
428 they cut up the rest and threaded it  
on spits,  
429 roasted it with care, and drew it all  
off.  
430 Then when they had finished the  
work and made the meal ready,  
431 they feasted, and no heart lacked a fair  
share of the feast.  
432 And when they had put away desire  
for eating and drinking,  
433 the Gerenian horseman Nestor began  
to speak among them:  
434 “Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of



men Agamemnon,  
435 let us sit talking here no longer, nor  
delay  
436 any further the work the god is  
putting in our hands.  
437 Come: let the heralds of the bronze-  
shirted Achaeans  
438 make their cry and gather the host  
along the ships,  
439 and let us go down together, as we are,  
through the wide Achaean camp,  
440 to waken sharp Ares the sooner.”  
441 So he spoke, and the lord of men  
Agamemnon did not disobey.  
442 At once he ordered the clear-voiced  
heralds  
443 to summon the long-haired Achaeans  
to battle;  
444 they made the summons, and the men

gathered quickly.

445 The Zeus-nurtured kings around  
Atreus' son

446 hurried about marshaling them, and  
among them grey-eyed Athena,

447 holding the aegis — precious, unaging,  
immortal, **18**

448 from which a hundred tassels of pure  
gold float free,

449 all finely woven, each worth a  
hundred oxen.

450 With it she flashed through the  
Achaean host,

451 driving them on; and in each man's  
heart she roused strength

452 to war and fight without ceasing.

453 And at once war became sweeter to  
them than going home

454 in the hollow ships to their dear

fatherland.

455 As an annihilating fire blazes up  
through a boundless forest

456 on the peaks of a mountain, and the  
glare shows from far away,

457 so, as they marched, from the  
tremendous bronze

458 a gleam went flashing through the  
upper air to the sky.

459 And as the many tribes of winged  
birds —

460 geese, or cranes, or long-necked  
swans —

461 on the Asian meadow around the  
streams of Caystrius

462 fly this way and that, glorying in their  
wings,

463 settling with cries, always advancing,  
and the meadow rings —

464 so their many tribes from the ships  
and huts  
465 poured out onto the Scamandrian  
plain, and beneath them the ground  
466 thundered terribly under the feet of  
men and horses.  
467 They stood in the flowering  
Scamandrian meadow,  
468 tens of thousands, as many as the  
leaves and flowers in their season.  
469 As the many tribes of thronging flies  
470 that swarm through a herdsman's  
steading  
471 in the season of spring, when milk  
wets the pails,  
472 so many were the long-haired  
Achaeans who stood in the plain  
473 facing the Trojans, mad to break them.  
474 And as goatherds easily sort out

475 their wide-wandering flocks of goats  
when they mingle at pasture,  
476 so the leaders sorted the men this way  
and that  
477 to go into battle, and among them the  
lord Agamemnon:  
478 in eyes and head like Zeus who  
delights in thunder,  
479 in girdle like Ares, in chest like  
Poseidon.  
480 As a bull stands out far the finest of all  
in the herd,  
481 conspicuous among the gathering  
cattle,  
482 such did Zeus make Atreus' son on  
that day,  
483 conspicuous among many,  
preeminent among heroes.

484 Tell me now, Muses, who keep your  
homes on Olympus —19  
485 for you are goddesses, you are  
present, you know all things,  
486 while we hear only the report and  
know nothing —  
487 who were the leaders and lords of the  
Danaans.  
488 The multitude I could not tell nor  
name,  
489 not if I had ten tongues and ten  
mouths,  
490 a voice unbreakable, and a heart of  
bronze within me,  
491 unless the Olympian Muses, daughters  
of aegis-bearing  
492 Zeus, remembered for me all who  
came under Ilion.

493 But the captains of the ships I will tell,  
and all the ships.

494 Of the Boeotians, Peneleos and Leïtus  
were leaders,20

495 with Arcesilaus and Prothoenor and  
Clonius:

496 they who dwelt in Hyria and rocky  
Aulis,

497 in Schoenus and Scolus and Eteonus of  
the many ridges,

498 Thespeia, Graea, and spacious  
Mycalessus;

499 who dwelt around Harma and  
Eilesium and Erythrae;

500 who held Eleon and Hyle and Peteon,

501 Ocalea and Medeon, that well-built  
citadel,

502 Copae, Eutresis, and Thisbe of the  
many doves;

503 who held Coroneia and grassy  
Haliartus;  
504 who held Plataea; who dwelt in Glisas;  
505 who held Hypothebae, that well-built  
citadel,  
506 and holy Onchestus, Poseidon's  
shining grove;  
507 who held Arne rich in grapes, and  
Mideia,  
508 sacred Nisa, and Anthedon at the  
land's edge:  
509 of these came fifty ships, and in each  
one  
510 a hundred and twenty young men of  
the Boeotians.  
511 And those who lived in Aspledon and  
Minyan Orchomenus  
512 were led by Ascalaphus and Ialmenus,  
sons of Ares,



513 whom Astyoche bore in the house of  
Actor, Azeus' son —  
514 a modest maiden: she went up to her  
upper chamber,  
515 and mighty Ares lay with her in secret.  
516 With them thirty hollow ships sailed  
in order.  
517 And the Phocians were led by Schedius  
and Epistrophus,  
518 sons of great-hearted Iphitus,  
Naubolus' son:  
519 they who held Cyparissus and rocky  
Pytho,  
520 holy Crisa and Daulis and Panopeus;  
521 who dwelt around Anemorea and  
Hyampolis;  
522 who lived along the brilliant river  
Cephisus;  
523 who held Lilaea at the springs of

Cephisus.

524 With them followed forty black ships.

525 Their leaders were busy ranging the  
Phocian ranks,

526 and they armed close beside the  
Boeotians, on the left.

527 Of the Locrians, swift Ajax led, Oïleus'  
son —

528 the lesser Ajax, in no way so big as  
Telamonian Ajax

529 but far smaller: a little man, in a linen  
corslet,<sup>21</sup>

530 but with the spear he surpassed all  
Hellenes and Achaeans:

531 they who dwelt in Cynus and Opoeis  
and Calliarus,

532 Bessa and Scarphe and lovely Augeae,

533 Tarphe and Thronium, around the  
streams of Boagrius.

534 With him followed forty black ships  
535 of the Locrians who live across from  
holy Euboea.  
536 And the Abantes, breathing fury, who  
held Euboea —  
537 Chalcis and Eretria and Histiaea rich  
in grapes,  
538 Cerinthus by the sea and the steep  
citadel of Dios;  
539 who held Carystus; who dwelt in Styra  
—  
540 these were led by Elephenor, scion of  
Ares,  
541 Chalcodon's son, chief of the great-  
hearted Abantes.  
542 With him followed the swift Abantes,  
hair grown long behind,  
543 spearmen eager with outstretched  
ash-wood spears

544 to tear the cuirasses on the chests of  
their enemies.  
545 With him followed forty black ships.  
546 And those who held Athens, that well-  
built citadel,  
547 the district of great-hearted  
Erechtheus, whom once Athena<sup>22</sup>  
548 raised, Zeus's daughter — the grain-  
giving earth had borne him —  
549 and settled in Athens, in her own rich  
temple,  
550 where the young men of the  
Athenians seek his favor  
551 with bulls and rams as the years come  
round —  
552 these were led by Menestheus, son of  
Peteos.  
553 No man on the face of the earth was  
his equal

554 at marshaling horses and shield-  
bearing men;  
555 Nestor alone rivaled him, for he was  
older.  
556 With him followed fifty black ships.  
557 And Ajax led twelve ships from  
Salamis,<sup>23</sup>  
558 and brought them and set them where  
the Athenian ranks stood.  
559 And those who held Argos and walled  
Tiryns,  
560 Hermione and Asine that lie on the  
deep gulf,  
561 Troezen, Eïones, and vine-clad  
Epidaurus,  
562 and the young Achaean men who held  
Aegina and Mases —  
563 these were led by Diomedes, good at  
the war-cry,

564 and Sthenelus, dear son of famed  
Capaneus;  
565 and with them went a third, Euryalus,  
a godlike man,  
566 son of lord Mecisteus, Talaus' son;  
567 but the leader of them all was  
Diomedes, good at the war-cry.  
568 With them followed eighty black  
ships.  
569 And those who held Mycenae, that  
well-built citadel,  
570 and wealthy Corinth and well-built  
Cleonae;  
571 who dwelt in Orneiae and lovely  
Araethyrea  
572 and Sicyon, where Adrastus first was  
king;  
573 who held Hyperesia and steep  
Gonoessa

574 and Pellene; who dwelt around  
Aegium  
575 and through all Aegialus and around  
broad Helice —  
576 of their hundred ships the leader was  
the lord Agamemnon,  
577 Atreus' son. With him followed by far  
the most  
578 and the best troops; and he among  
them, clad in gleaming bronze,  
579 glorying, stood out preeminent among  
all the heroes,  
580 because he was the best, and led by  
far the most men.  
581 And those who held hollow  
Lacedaemon full of ravines,  
582 Pharos and Sparta and Messae of the  
many doves;  
583 who dwelt in Myrsinae and lovely

Augeae;

584 who held Amyclae and Helos, the  
citadel by the sea;

585 who held Laas and dwelt around  
Oetylus —

586 these his brother led, Menelaus, good  
at the war-cry,

587 with sixty ships; and they armed  
apart.

588 He himself moved among them,  
trusting his own eagerness,

589 urging them to war; and beyond all  
others his heart was set

590 on avenging the struggles and groans  
of Helen.

591 And those who dwelt in Pylos and  
lovely Arene,

592 Thryon, the ford of Alpheius, and  
well-built Aepy;



593 who lived in Cyparisseis and  
Amphigeneia,  
594 Pteleos and Helos and Dorium —  
where the Muses<sup>24</sup>  
595 met Thamyris the Thracian and ended  
his singing,  
596 as he came from Oechalia, from  
Eurytus the Oechalian:  
597 for he had vowed in his boasting that  
he would win, even if  
598 the Muses themselves should sing, the  
daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus;  
599 and in their anger they maimed him:  
they took away  
600 his wondrous song and made him  
forget his harping —  
601 these were led by the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor.  
602 With him ninety hollow ships sailed in

order.

603 And those who held Arcadia under the  
steep mountain of Cyllene,

604 beside the tomb of Aepytus, where  
men fight hand to hand;

605 who dwelt in Pheneos and  
Orchomenus rich in flocks,

606 Rhipe and Stratie and windswept  
Enispe;

607 who held Tegea and lovely Mantinea;

608 who held Stymphelus and dwelt in  
Parrhasia —

609 these were led by Ancaeus's son, the  
lord Agapenor,

610 with sixty ships, and in each ship  
many

611 Arcadian men went aboard, skilled  
fighters.

612 For the lord of men Agamemnon

himself had given them

613 the well-benched ships to cross the  
wine-dark sea —

614 Atreus' son — since the works of the  
sea were no concern of theirs.

615 And those who dwelt in Buprasium  
and brilliant Elis,

616 all that Hyrmine and Myrsinus at the  
land's edge

617 and the Olenian rock and Alesium  
enclose between them —

618 of these there were four leaders, and  
ten swift ships

619 followed each man, with many  
Epeians aboard.

620 Two of them, Amphimachus and  
Thalpius, led —

621 sons, one of Cteatus, one of Eurytus, of  
Actor's line;

622 of the third company strong Diores  
was leader, Amarynceus' son;  
623 and of the fourth godlike Polyxeinus  
was leader,  
624 son of lord Agasthenes, Augeias' son.  
625 And those from Dulichium and the  
holy Echinae,  
626 the islands that lie across the sea  
facing Elis —  
627 these were led by Meges, the equal of  
Ares,  
628 Phyleus' son, whom the horseman  
Phyleus dear to Zeus begot —  
629 who once, angered at his father, had  
moved away to Dulichium.  
630 With him followed forty black ships.  
631 And Odysseus led the great-hearted  
Cephalenians,  
632 who held Ithaca and Neriton with

quivering leaves;

633 who dwelt in Crocyleia and rugged  
Aegilips;

634 who held Zacynthus; who dwelt  
around Samos;

635 who held the mainland and dwelt on  
the facing shores —

636 these Odysseus led, the equal of Zeus  
in counsel,

637 and with him followed twelve ships  
with cheeks of vermillion.25

638 And the Aetolians were led by Thoas,  
Andraemon's son:

639 they who dwelt in Pleuron and Olenus  
and Pylene,

640 Chalcis by the shore and rocky  
Calydon.

641 For the sons of great-hearted Oeneus  
were no more,

642 and he himself was no more, and fair-  
haired Meleager was dead;  
643 so on Thoas the whole rule of the  
Aetolians had been laid.  
644 With him followed forty black ships.  
645 Of the Cretans, Idomeneus, famed  
with the spear, was leader:  
646 they who held Cnossos and walled  
Gortyn,  
647 Lyctus and Miletus and chalk-white  
Lycastus,  
648 Phaestus and Rhytium, fine cities to  
live in,  
649 and the others who dwelt through  
hundred-citied Crete.  
650 Of these Idomeneus, famed with the  
spear, was leader,  
651 with Meriones, the equal of Enyalius,  
slayer of men.

652 With them followed eighty black  
ships.  
653 And Tlepolemus, Heracles' son, tall  
and strong,  
654 led nine ships from Rhodes, of the  
lordly Rhodians,  
655 who dwelt through Rhodes in three  
divisions:  
656 Lindus, Ialysus, and chalk-white  
Cameirus.  
657 Their leader was Tlepolemus, famed  
with the spear,  
658 whom Astyocheia bore to the might of  
Heracles —  
659 he brought her out of Ephyra, from  
the river Selleïs,  
660 after sacking many towns of Zeus-  
nurtured fighting men.  
661 Now when Tlepolemus was grown in

the well-built hall,  
662 he killed, on the instant, his own  
father's dear uncle,  
663 Licymnius, scion of Ares, already  
growing old;  
664 and quickly he built ships, gathered a  
great following,  
665 and fled away over the sea, for the  
others threatened him —  
666 the sons and the grandsons of the  
might of Heracles.  
667 He came at last to Rhodes, a wanderer,  
a man of sorrows;  
668 and there they settled in three parts,  
tribe by tribe, and were loved  
669 by Zeus, who is king over gods and  
men,  
670 and the son of Cronos poured  
wondrous wealth upon them.



671 And Nireus led three balanced ships  
from Syme —26

672 Nireus, son of Aglaïa and lord  
Charopus;

673 Nireus, the most beautiful man who  
came under Ilion

674 of all the Danaans, after the blameless  
son of Peleus.

675 But he was a slight man, and few  
people followed him.

676 And those who held Nisyrus and  
Crapathus and Casus,

677 and Cos, city of Eurypylus, and the  
Calydnae islands —

678 these were led by Pheidippus and  
Antiphus,

679 two sons of lord Thessalus, Heracles’  
son.

680 With them thirty hollow ships sailed

in order.

681 Now all those who dwelt in Pelasgian  
Argos,

682 who lived in Alos and Alope and  
Trachis;

683 who held Phthia and Hellas of the  
beautiful women —

684 and they were called Myrmidons, and  
Hellenes, and Achaeans —

685 of their fifty ships Achilles was  
captain.

686 But they had no thought of grim-  
voiced war;27

687 there was no one to lead them into  
the ranks.

688 For swift-footed brilliant Achilles lay  
among the ships,

689 in wrath over the girl, Briseis of the  
lovely hair,

690 whom he had taken out of Lyrnessus  
with great toil,  
691 when he sacked Lyrnessus and the  
walls of Thebe  
692 and cut down Mynes and Epistrophus,  
the spear-mad  
693 sons of lord Euenus, Selepius' son.  
694 Grieving for her he lay there; but he  
was soon to rise.  
695 And those who held Phylace and  
flowering Pyrasus,  
696 Demeter's precinct, and Iton, mother  
of flocks,  
697 Antron by the sea, and Pteleos deep in  
meadow-grass —  
698 these warlike Protesilaus had led  
699 while he lived; but by then the black  
earth held him under.  
700 His wife, cheeks torn with mourning,

was left behind in Phylace,  
701 his house but half-built: a Dardanian  
man had killed him28  
702 as he leapt from his ship, far the first  
of the Achaeans.  
703 Yet the men were not leaderless,  
though they longed for their leader:  
704 Podarces, scion of Ares, set them in  
order,  
705 son of Iphiclus rich in flocks, Phylacus'  
son,  
706 own brother of great-hearted  
Protesilaus,  
707 the younger-born; the elder and the  
better man  
708 was the hero Protesilaus the warlike.  
So the people  
709 lacked no leader, though they longed  
for the brave man gone.

710 With him followed forty black ships.  
711 And those who dwelt in Pherae beside  
Lake Boebeïs,  
712 in Boebe and Glaphyrae and well-built  
Iolcus —  
713 these Admetus' dear son led with  
eleven ships:  
714 Eumelus, whom Alcestis bore to  
Admetus —  
715 brilliant among women, loveliest of  
the daughters of Pelias.  
716 And those who dwelt in Methone and  
Thaumacia;  
717 who held Meliboea and rugged Olizon  
—  
718 these Philoctetes led, the master  
bowman, 29  
719 with seven ships; and in each one fifty  
rowers

720 had come aboard, all skilled bowmen,  
strong fighters.  
721 But he lay on an island, suffering hard  
pains,  
722 on sacred Lemnos, where the sons of  
the Achaeans had left him  
723 tormented by the evil wound of the  
murderous water-snake.  
724 There he lay grieving. But soon the  
Argives by their ships  
725 were to remember lord Philoctetes.  
726 Yet the men were not leaderless,  
though they longed for their leader:  
727 Medon set them in order, Oïleus'  
bastard son,  
728 whom Rhene bore to Oïleus, sacker of  
cities.  
729 And those who held Tricca and  
terraced Ithome;

730 who held Oechalia, city of Eurytus the  
Oechalian —

731 these were led by the two sons of  
Asclepius,

732 the good healers Podaleirius and  
Machaon.

733 With them thirty hollow ships sailed  
in order.

734 And those who held Ormenion and the  
spring Hypereia;

735 who held Asterium and the white  
peaks of Titanus —

736 these Eurypylus led, Euaemon's  
shining son.

737 With him followed forty black ships.

738 And those who held Argissa; who  
dwelt in Gyrtone,

739 Orthe and Elone and the white city  
Oloosson —

740 these were led by Polypoetes,  
steadfast in battle,  
741 son of Peirithous, whom immortal  
Zeus begot;  
742 famed Hippodameia bore him to  
Peirithous  
743 on the day he took vengeance on the  
shaggy beast-men  
744 and drove them out of Pelion, and  
pushed them to the Aethices.  
745 Not alone: with him was Leonteus,  
scion of Ares,  
746 son of high-hearted Coronus, Caeneus'  
son.  
747 With them followed forty black ships.  
748 And Gouneus led two and twenty  
ships from Cyphus,  
749 and with him followed the Enienes  
and the battle-steadfast Peraebians,



750 who set their homes around wintry  
Dodona;  
751 who worked the fields around lovely  
Titaessus,  
752 the river that pours his fair-flowing  
water into Peneius —  
753 yet he does not mingle with the silver  
eddies of Peneius,  
754 but flows along on top of him like oil:  
755 for he is a branch broken off the water  
of Styx, the dread oath.  
756 And the Magnetes were led by  
Prothoos, Tenthredon's son:  
757 they who dwelt around Peneius and  
Pelion  
758 of the quivering leaves. Swift Prothoos  
was their leader,  
759 and with him followed forty black  
ships.

760 These, then, were the leaders and  
lords of the Danaans.  
761 Now which was far the best of them —  
tell me, Muse —  
762 of the men, and of the horses, that  
followed the sons of Atreus?  
763 Best by far of the horses were the  
mares of Pheres' line,  
764 which Eumelus drove: swift-footed as  
birds,  
765 matched in coat and matched in years,  
their backs as level as a plumb-line.  
766 Apollo of the silver bow had raised  
them in Pereia,  
767 both of them mares, carrying with  
them the panic of war.  
768 And of the men, far the best was  
Telamonian Ajax —  
769 while Achilles kept his wrath: for he

was mightiest by far,  
770 he, and the horses that carried the  
blameless son of Peleus.  
771 But he lay among his beaked seagoing  
ships,  
772 nursing his rage at Agamemnon,  
shepherd of the people,  
773 Atreus' son; and his men along the  
surf-line of the sea  
774 amused themselves throwing the  
discus and the hunting-spear,  
775 and shooting with bows; and the  
horses, each beside its chariot,  
776 stood cropping lotus and marsh-  
grown parsley,  
777 while the chariots lay well covered in  
the huts  
778 of their lords; and the men, longing  
for their leader dear to Ares,

779 drifted here and there through the  
camp, and did not fight.  
780 On the others came, as if all the land  
were swept with fire;  
781 and the earth groaned beneath them,  
as under Zeus who delights in thunder  
782 in his anger, when he lashes the earth  
around Typhoeus<sup>30</sup>  
783 among the Arimi, where they say  
Typhoeus has his bed:  
784 so the earth groaned greatly under  
their feet  
785 as they came on; and very swiftly they  
crossed the plain.  
786 And to the Trojans went wind-footed  
swift Iris, a messenger<sup>31</sup>  
787 from aegis-bearing Zeus, with a  
grievous message.  
788 They were holding assembly at

Priam's doors,

789 all gathered together, the young men  
and the old.

790 Standing close, swift-footed Iris spoke  
to them,

791 likening her voice to Priam's son  
Polites,

792 who sat as lookout of the Trojans,  
trusting the speed of his feet,

793 on the very top of the tomb of old  
Aesyetes,

794 watching for when the Achaeans  
should rush out from their ships;

795 in his likeness swift-footed Iris spoke:

796 "Old man, endless talk is always dear  
to you,

797 as once it was in peacetime; but  
relentless war is upon us.

798 Truly I have gone into very many

battles of men,

799 but never yet have I seen such a host,  
so great:

800 for like the leaves, like the sands, in  
their multitude

801 they are coming over the plain to fight  
for the city.

802 Hector, you above all I charge to do  
this:

803 there are many allies through Priam's  
great city,

804 and tongue differs from tongue  
among men of scattered lands.

805 Let each man give the word to those  
he rules;

806 let him marshal his own townsmen,  
and lead them out."

807 So she spoke, and Hector did not fail  
to know the goddess's voice.

808 At once he dissolved the assembly,  
and they rushed to arms.

809 All the gates were flung open, and the  
host streamed out,

810 foot-soldiers and horsemen; and a  
great din arose.

811 There is a steep mound out before the  
city,

812 apart in the plain, with open ground  
on every side;

813 men call it Batieia,

814 but the immortals call it the tomb of  
Myrine, light of step.<sup>32</sup>

815 There the Trojans and their allies  
formed their divisions.

816 The Trojans were led by great Hector  
of the flashing helmet,<sup>33</sup>

817 Priam's son; with him by far the most  
and the best

818 troops armed themselves, eager with  
their spears.

819 The Dardanians were led by the good  
son of Anchises,

820 Aeneas, whom brilliant Aphrodite  
bore to Anchises

821 on the spurs of Ida, a goddess bedded  
with a mortal.

822 Not alone: with him were Antenor's  
two sons,

823 Archelochus and Acamas, skilled in all  
fighting.

824 And those who dwelt in Zeleia under  
the lowest foot of Ida,

825 men of wealth, who drink the dark  
water of Aesepus,

826 Trojans — these were led by Lycaon's  
shining son,

827 Pandarus, to whom Apollo himself



gave the bow.

828 And those who held Adresteia and the  
district of Apaesus;

829 who held Pityeia and the steep mount  
of Tereia —

830 these were led by Adrestus and  
Amphius of the linen corslet,

831 two sons of Merops of Percote, who  
beyond all men

832 knew the seer's art, and would not let  
his sons

833 go to man-destroying war; but the two  
would not

834 obey him: the fates of black death  
were leading them on.

835 And those who dwelt around Percote  
and Practius;

836 who held Sestus and Abydos and  
brilliant Arisbe —

837 these were led by Hyrtacus' son Asius,  
marshal of men —

838 Asius, Hyrtacus' son, whom horses  
carried from Arisbe,

839 tall and fire-colored, from the river  
Selleïs.

840 And Hippothous led the tribes of the  
Pelasgian spearmen,

841 those who dwelt in deep-soiled Larisa;

842 these were led by Hippothous and  
Pylaeus, scion of Ares,

843 two sons of Pelasgian Lethus,  
Teutamus' son.

844 And the Thracians were led by  
Acamas and the hero Peiroos —

845 all those the strong-flowing  
Hellespont encloses.

846 And Euphemus was captain of the  
Ciconian spearmen,

847 son of Zeus-nurtured Troezenus, Ceas'  
son.  
848 And Pyraechmes led the Paeonians of  
the curved bows,  
849 from far away, from Amydon, from the  
wide-flowing Axius —  
850 Axius, whose water spreads fairest  
over the earth.  
851 And the Paphlagonians were led by  
Pylaemenes of the shaggy heart,  
852 from the Eneti, where the breed of  
wild mules is born:  
853 they who held Cytorus and dwelt  
around Sesamus,  
854 whose famed homes stood around the  
river Parthenius,  
855 Cromna and Aegialus and the heights  
of Erythini.  
856 And the Halizones were led by Odius

and Epistrophus,

857 from far away, from Alybe, where  
silver has its birthplace.

858 And the Mysians were led by Chromis,  
and Ennomus the bird-reader —

859 but his birds did not save him from  
black doom:

860 he was broken under the hands of the  
swift-footed son of Aeacus<sup>34</sup>

861 in the river, where Achilles cut down  
Trojans and others with them.

862 And Phorcys led the Phrygians, with  
godlike Ascanius,

863 from far Ascania; and they were eager  
to fight in the press of battle.

864 And the Maeonians were led by  
Mesthles and Antiphus,

865 the two sons of Talaemenes, whom  
the Gygaean lake bore;

866 they led the Maeonians, born under  
Tmolus.

867 And Nastes was captain of the Carians  
of barbarous speech,35

868 who held Miletus and the mountain of  
Phthires, dense with leaves,

869 the streams of Maeander and the  
steep peaks of Mycale;

870 these were led by Amphimachus and  
Nastes —

871 Nastes and Amphimachus, the shining  
children of Nomion.

872 And one of them went to war decked  
in gold, like a girl —

873 the fool: it did not ward off wretched  
destruction from him;

874 he was broken under the hands of the  
swift-footed son of Aeacus

875 in the river, and war-minded Achilles

carried off the gold.

876 And Sarpedon led the Lycians, with  
blameless Glaucus,

877 from far Lycia, from the eddying  
Xanthus.

## Notes

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### NOTES

1. (2.6) “baneful Dream” (οὔλον ὄνειρον) — Dream is a personified agent here, capitalized accordingly. That Zeus sends a deliberately lying dream scandalized ancient readers (Plato cites this passage disapprovingly, Republic 383a); the poem itself is unembarrassed — the deception is the mechanism of Zeus’s promise to Thetis. ↩
2. (2.11) “long-haired Achaeans” (κάρη κομόωντες Ἀχαιοί) — stock epithet of the army, literally “letting the hair grow long on the head”; always so rendered. ↩

3. (2.23) “breaker of horses” (ἵπποδάμιοι) — here of Atreus; later in the poem it is the standing epithet of the Trojans and of Hector (“horse-taming Trojans,” 230). Rendered “breaker(s) of horses” for individuals, “horse-taming” for the people. ↩
4. (2.60-70) The Dream repeats Zeus’s instructions verbatim, and Agamemnon repeats them verbatim again to the council — standard epic messenger technique. Zenodotus’ text drastically condensed such repetitions (apparatus, Line 60-70), and he omitted 157-168 below (Hera’s speech restated by Athena) entirely, replacing it with a single line (apparatus, Line 156, 157-168). The vulgate keeps the full repetitions; so does this translation, in identical English each time. ↩
5. (2.73) “I will test them with words, as is the custom” (ἥ θέμις ἐστί) — the “testing” (peira) is one of the poem’s strangest plot devices: no custom of testing armies is otherwise known, and the plan nearly destroys the expedition. The phrase may mean only “as is my right.” Translated neutrally; the narrative logic is left as the poem leaves it — precarious. ↩
6. (2.101-108) The scepter’s pedigree — Hephaestus, Zeus, Hermes, Pelops, Atreus, Thyestes, Agamemnon — is

a title-deed in miniature: Agamemnon's authority is literally handed down from Zeus. "The slayer of Argus" (ἀργεϊφόντης) is Hermes' fixed epithet, of disputed meaning ("Argus-slayer" is the traditional reading and is kept); "the guide" (διάκτορος) is his companion title. ↩

7. (2.111-118) Zenodotus athetized this opening of the speech (apparatus). Lines 111-118 recur nearly verbatim at 9.18-25, where Agamemnon speaks them in earnest; here they are play-acted despair. Note the vocabulary: Zeus "bound me in heavy blindness" (ἄτη) — the same word Achilles used of him at 1.412, and Agamemnon concedes at 378 that "it was I who began the anger." ↩
8. (2.157) "Unwearied one" (Ἀτρυτώνη) — obscure cult title of Athena, traditionally derived from "not to be worn down"; rendered by that traditional sense. ↩
9. (2.169) "the equal of Zeus in counsel" (Διὶ μῆτιν ἀτάλαντον) — Odysseus' loftiest epithet, crediting him with mētis, the cunning practical intelligence that is also Zeus's; always so rendered. ↩
10. (2.173) "Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices" (διογενὲς Λαερτιάδη πολυμήχαν' Ὀδυσσεῦ) — the full-line address formula used for Odysseus



throughout both epics; πολυμήχανος (“of many devices”) is kept distinct from πολύμητις (“resourceful”). ↩

11. (2.193-197) Aristarchus athetized these five lines, and they are independently absent from Xenophon’s quotation of the passage (*Memorabilia* 1.2.56) — two converging hints they may not be original (apparatus, Line 193-197; *disputed\_lines.md* #3). Without them, Odysseus’ speech to the kings loses its “he is only testing” explanation. Translated as printed; the two-tier treatment of kings and commoners on either side of this line is in any case secure. One crux inside the passage: 194 is printed here as a rhetorical question (“Did we not all hear in council what he said?” — so Lattimore), but Kirk reads it as a statement — “in council we did NOT all hear what he said” — which better explains why the man addressed needs Odysseus’s telling. The question-rendering stands; the alternative is recorded. ↩
12. (2.204) “The rule of many is no good thing; let there be one ruler” (οὐκ ἀγαθὸν πολυκοιρανίῃ· εἷς κοίρανος ἔστω) — the most quoted political sentence in Homer (Aristotle cites it in the *Metaphysics* in

defense of monarchy). In context it is crowd-control rhetoric, not constitutional theory. ↩

13. (2.212-219) Thersites is the only common soldier in the Iliad who is named, described, and given a speech — and the description is a catalogue of deformities, the epic’s physiognomic shorthand for baseness (contrast every hero’s beauty). His name suggests θέρσος, “audacity.” Zenodotus athetized 220-223 (apparatus). Notice that his complaints against Agamemnon are substantively Achilles’ complaints from Book 1, voiced one rung down the social ladder — and answered with a beating the assembly applauds. ↩
14. (2.318-319) “made him a sign conspicuous” — the vulgate reads ἀρίζηλον (“very plain to see”): the petrified serpent becomes a lasting marker of the portent. An ancient variant read ἀίζηλον (“unseen”): the god made the serpent vanish. Aristarchus athetized 319 (the petrification line) outright (apparatus, Line 318, 319). Translated from the printed text: conspicuous, then turned to stone. ↩
15. (2.336) “the Gerenian horseman Nestor” (Γερήνιος ἱππότα Νέστωρ) — his fixed title henceforth; “Gerenian” was obscure already in antiquity (usually

connected with Gerenia in Messenia, where Nestor was said to have been raised). Always so rendered. ↩

16. (2.356) “the struggles and groans of Helen” (Ἑλένης ὁρμήματά τε στοναχάς τε) — ambiguous since antiquity: either Helen’s own strivings and griefs (a Helen carried off unwilling), or the struggles and groans fought and suffered over her. The English keeps the genitive’s ambiguity. The line recurs at 590 of Menelaus. ↩
17. (2.408) “good at the war-cry” (βοὴν ἀγαθός) — fixed epithet of Menelaus and Diomedes: the carrying battlefield voice as a command skill. Always so rendered. Menelaus coming “unbidden” to his brother’s feast was proverbial in antiquity. ↩
18. (2.447-449) The aegis (see Book 1, note [21]) here gets its fullest description: a hundred all-gold tassels, “each worth a hundred oxen” (ἑκατόμβοιος) — value is reckoned in cattle, the Homeric world’s standard of price; there is no money in the poem. ↩
19. (2.484-493) The poet’s second and most elaborate invocation of the Muses, marking the Catalogue as a feat of memory beyond unaided human power (“ten tongues, ten mouths”). The Muses know because

they are present and see; the poet otherwise has only kleos — “the report” — at second hand. ↩

20. (2.494-759) The Catalogue of Ships: 29 Achaean contingents, some 190 place names, 1,186 ships by the traditional count. It has been argued since antiquity to reflect an originally separate composition (its geography fits mainland Greece of an earlier era better than the poem’s own dramatic situation — Boeotia leads, plausibly from the muster at Aulis), and several manuscripts omit the whole span (apparatus, Line 494-877: om.; disputed\_lines.md #2). Translated as fully integral, in the same line-for-line verse as the narrative; see commentary. ↩
21. (2.528-530) The disambiguation of the two Ajaxes. Zenodotus athetized 528 and Aristarchus 529-530 (apparatus) — the “linen corslet” (λινόθώραξ) bothered critics, linen being light armor at odds with heroic bronze. Kept: the lesser Ajax’s smallness and spear-skill are both plot-relevant later. ↩
22. (2.546-551) Erechtheus, the primeval Athenian king, is “borne by the grain-giving earth” and raised by Athena in her own temple — the earliest statement of the Athenian autochthony myth, and one of the

very few references to hero-cult practice (annual bull and ram offerings) in the Iliad. ↩

23. (2.557-558) The most notorious couplet in the poem. Aristarchus athetized 558, and ancient tradition (Strabo 9.1.10, Diogenes Laertius 1.48) reports that Solon or Pisistratus inserted it to support Athens's claim to Salamis against Megara — the Megarians circulated a rival version continuing Ajax's line with Megarian towns instead (quoted in the apparatus at Line 557-558). Whether or not the accusation is true, Ajax — the war's second-best fighter — receives a strikingly minimal two-line entry. Translated as printed, with the controversy recorded here (disputed\_lines.md #2a). ↩
24. (2.594-600) Thamyras the Thracian bard boasted he could outsing the Muses; they "maimed" him (πηρόν — later tradition specifies blinding, but the word is unspecific), stripped his song, and made him forget his lyre-craft. A dark in-poem parable of song as the Muses' revocable gift, placed pointedly just after the poet's own humble invocation of them. ↩
25. (2.637) "ships with cheeks of vermillion" (μυλοπάρηοι) — Odysseus' ships have bows painted

with red ochre; the word transfers the “cheek” of the human face-epithets to the ship’s prow. ↩

26. (2.671-675) The Nireus entry: his name opens three consecutive lines (anaphora unique in the Catalogue) — beautiful, well-born, and militarily negligible. Zenodotus athetized 673-675 and omitted 674 (apparatus). The rhetorical polish of the entry made it famous; it is kept at full strength. ↩
27. (2.686-694) Zenodotus athetized this Achilles-paragraph (apparatus, Line 686-694). It is the Catalogue’s load-bearing link to the poem’s plot: the fifty ships are mustered, and their leader lies apart “in wrath over the girl” — with the quiet promise “but he was soon to rise.” ↩
28. (2.698-702) Protesilaus, “far the first of the Achaeans” ashore, killed as he leapt from his ship (an oracle had promised death to the first to land — the poem alludes without telling). His “house but half-built” (δόμος ἡμιτελής) is ambiguous: an unfinished hall, or a marriage cut off half-made; the wife with torn cheeks favors hearing both. ↩
29. (2.716-725) Philoctetes, master of Heracles’ bow, abandoned on Lemnos with the festering water-snake wound. “Soon the Argives were to remember”

him: prophecy held that Troy could not fall without the bow — the story of Sophocles' Philoctetes. One of the Catalogue's several forward windows beyond the Iliad's own frame. ↩

30. (2.782-783) Typhoeus, the monstrous challenger of Zeus, lies lashed by his thunderbolts “among the Arimi” (location already disputed in antiquity — Cilicia, Lydia, and volcanic Ischia were all proposed). The marching army makes the earth groan like Zeus's cosmic punishment: the grandest of the muster-similes. ↩
31. (2.786) “wind-footed swift Iris” (ποδῆνεμος ὤκέα Ἴρις) — the rainbow goddess as messenger of Zeus; her fixed epithet, always so rendered. ↩
32. (2.813-814) Men call the mound Batieia; the gods call it “the tomb of Myrine” (an Amazon, in later tradition). Second instance of divine-versus-human double naming (cf. Briareus/Aegaeon, Book 1 note [33]) — the gods' name preserves the older, true history of the landmark. ↩
33. (2.816) “Hector of the flashing helmet” (κορυθαίολος Ἑκτωρ) — his defining epithet, first appearance in the poem; literally “with glancing/shimmering helm.” Always so rendered. ↩

34. (2.860-861) Aristarchus athetized these lines (and obelized the parallel pair at 874-875): they anticipate, in the future tense of the narrator, Achilles' massacre in the river Scamander — which belongs to Book 21 — and ancient critics disliked the Catalogue “spoiling” it. Kept: the Trojan catalogue's habit of glancing at its captains' deaths is part of its elegiac texture. ↩

35. (2.867) “Carians of barbarous speech” (βαρβαροφώνων) — the first occurrence in Greek literature of any “barbar-” word. Not yet the later blanket term “barbarian”: in the whole poem only the Carians get this label, and the Trojans themselves speak with the Achaeans unhindered. Rendered “of barbarous speech” to keep the word's echoic, language-centered sense. ↩



# Book 3

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*The duel for Helen: Paris against Menelaus, the  
view from the wall, and Aphrodite's rescue.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 Now when they were marshaled, each  
company with its leaders,
- 2 the Trojans came on with clamor and a  
cry, like birds —
- 3 like the clamor of cranes that rises  
against the sky,
- 4 when they flee the winter and the  
measureless rain
- 5 and fly clamoring toward the streams of  
Ocean,
- 6 bearing slaughter and doom to the

Pygmy men,<sup>1</sup>

<sup>7</sup> and out of the morning air they carry  
their evil strife —

<sup>8</sup> but the Achaeans came on in silence,  
breathing fury,

<sup>9</sup> hearts set on standing by one another.

<sup>10</sup> As when the South Wind pours mist on  
the peaks of a mountain,

<sup>11</sup> no friend to shepherds, better than  
night to the thief,

<sup>12</sup> and a man sees only as far as a stone's  
throw —

<sup>13</sup> so the dust rose swirling under their  
feet

<sup>14</sup> as they came on; and very swiftly they  
crossed the plain.

<sup>15</sup> And when they were close, advancing  
on one another,

<sup>16</sup> godlike Alexandros stood out as the

Trojans' champion,<sup>2</sup>  
<sup>17</sup> with a leopard skin on his shoulders,  
and curved bow  
<sup>18</sup> and sword; and shaking two spears  
headed with bronze<sup>3</sup>  
<sup>19</sup> he challenged all the best of the  
Argives  
<sup>20</sup> to fight him man to man in dread  
combat.  
<sup>21</sup> But when Menelaus dear to Ares caught  
sight of him<sup>4</sup>  
<sup>22</sup> coming out in front of the throng with  
long strides,  
<sup>23</sup> then like a lion delighted to light on a  
great carcass,  
<sup>24</sup> finding a horned stag or a wild goat  
<sup>25</sup> when he is starving — he devours it  
greedily even though  
<sup>26</sup> the swift dogs and the sturdy young

hunters are driving at him —

27 so Menelaus was delighted to see  
godlike Alexandros

28 with his own eyes; for he thought to  
make the offender pay.

29 At once he leapt from his chariot to the  
ground in his armor.

30 But when godlike Alexandros saw him

31 appear among the front fighters, his  
heart was struck cold,

32 and he shrank back into the crowd of  
his companions, dodging death.

33 As a man who has seen a snake in a  
mountain glen

34 starts back and away, and trembling  
seizes his limbs,

35 and he retreats, and pallor takes his  
cheeks,

36 so back into the throng of the proud

Trojans

37 slipped godlike Alexandros, in dread of  
Atreus' son.

38 And Hector saw him, and raked him  
with shaming words:

39 "Paris — evil Paris — beauty and  
nothing more, woman-mad, seducer:

40 I wish you had never been born, or had  
died unmarried.

41 That is what I would wish, and it would  
be far better

42 than to have you a disgrace like this, a  
thing others look at sideways.

43 How the long-haired Achaeans must be  
cackling —

44 they thought a prince was champion  
because a fine

45 look is on him; but there is no strength  
in his heart, no fight.

46 Were you really such a man when in  
the seagoing ships  
47 you sailed the deep with your trusted  
companions gathered,  
48 and mixed with strangers, and carried  
off a beautiful woman  
49 from a far land, a bride of spearmen —  
50 a great grief to your father, to the city,  
and to all the people,  
51 a joy to our enemies, a hanging of your  
own head?  
52 And will you not stand up to Menelaus  
dear to Ares?  
53 You would find out what kind of man it  
is whose wife in her bloom you keep.  
54 The lyre would be no help to you then,  
nor the gifts of Aphrodite,  
55 that hair and that fine look, when you  
went down in the dust.

56 The Trojans are cowards indeed —  
otherwise long since  
57 you would have put on a shirt of stone  
for all the evil you have done.”<sup>5</sup>  
58 And godlike Alexandros answered him:  
59 “Hector, you rake me justly, not more  
than justly.  
60 Your heart is always unwearying, like  
an axe  
61 driven through timber by a man’s  
swing when he skillfully  
62 cuts out a ship-beam, and the iron  
strengthens his stroke:  
63 so unshaken is the spirit in your chest.  
64 But do not throw in my face the lovely  
gifts of golden Aphrodite.  
65 Not to be flung away are the gods’  
glorious gifts —  
66 whatever they themselves give; no man

could take them by choosing.

67 Now, if you want me to fight and do  
battle:

68 make the other Trojans sit down, and  
all the Achaeans,

69 and put me in the middle with  
Menelaus dear to Ares

70 to fight for Helen and all her  
possessions.

71 Whichever of us wins and proves the  
stronger,

72 let him take all the wealth, and the  
woman, and lead them home;

73 and the rest of you, cutting friendship  
and sworn oaths,

74 may you live on in deep-soiled Troy,  
and they return

75 to horse-pasturing Argos and Achaea of  
the beautiful women.”



76 So he spoke, and Hector rejoiced  
greatly to hear the word,  
77 and he went into the middle and held  
back the Trojan lines  
78 gripping his spear by the middle; and  
they all sat down.  
79 But the long-haired Achaeans kept  
shooting at him,  
80 aiming with arrows and casting stones,  
81 until the lord of men Agamemnon  
called out loud and long:  
82 “Hold, Argives! Do not shoot, young  
men of the Achaeans!  
83 Hector of the flashing helmet stands  
ready to say something.”  
84 So he spoke, and they held from  
fighting and fell silent,  
85 quickly. And Hector spoke between the  
two armies:

86 “Hear from me, Trojans and strong-  
greaved Achaeans,  
87 the word of Alexandros, for whose sake  
this quarrel rose.  
88 He bids the other Trojans and all the  
Achaeans  
89 lay down their fine armor on the earth  
that feeds so many,  
90 while he in the middle, with Menelaus  
dear to Ares,  
91 fights alone for Helen and all her  
possessions.  
92 Whichever of them wins and proves  
the stronger,  
93 let him take all the wealth, and the  
woman, and lead them home;  
94 and the rest of us — let us cut  
friendship and sworn oaths.”  
95 So he spoke, and they all went still in

silence.

96 And among them spoke Menelaus,  
good at the war-cry:

97 “Hear me now also. The pain of this  
comes closest

98 to my heart; and I intend that they part  
at last,

99 Argives and Trojans, since you have  
suffered many evils

100 for the sake of my quarrel, and  
Alexandros who began it.

101 For whichever of the two of us death  
and fate are prepared,

102 let him die; and the rest of you part,  
and quickly.

103 Bring two lambs — one white ram, one  
black ewe,

104 for Earth and Sun; and we will bring  
another, for Zeus.<sup>6</sup>

105 And lead down the strength of Priam,  
so he may cut the oaths  
106 himself, since his sons are overbearing  
and not to be trusted —  
107 that no one by transgression may do  
violence to the oaths of Zeus.  
108 The minds of younger men are always  
blowing in the wind;  
109 but where an old man is present, he  
looks before and behind  
110 at once, how the best may come of it  
for both sides.”<sup>7</sup>  
111 So he spoke, and Achaeans and Trojans  
rejoiced,  
112 hoping to be done with the misery of  
war.  
113 They reined the chariots back into the  
lines, and stepped down,  
114 and stripped off their armor and laid it

on the ground

115 close together — there was little field  
between the armies.

116 And Hector sent two heralds to the  
city

117 quickly, to fetch the lambs and to  
summon Priam;

118 and the lord Agamemnon sent  
Talthybius off

119 to the hollow ships, and ordered him  
to bring

120 a lamb; and he did not disobey  
brilliant Agamemnon.

121 Now Iris went as messenger to white-  
armed Helen,

122 in the likeness of her sister-in-law, the  
wife of Antenor's son —

123 the one Antenor's son the lord  
Helicaon had married,

124 Laodice, loveliest of the daughters of  
Priam.  
125 She found her in the hall: she was  
weaving a great web,  
126 a double cloak of purple,<sup>8</sup> and working  
into it the many struggles  
127 of the horse-taming Trojans and  
bronze-shirted Achaeans,  
128 which for her sake they suffered at the  
hands of Ares.  
129 Standing close, swift-footed Iris spoke:  
130 “Come here, dear bride, to see  
wonderful doings  
131 of the horse-taming Trojans and  
bronze-shirted Achaeans.  
132 They who before this carried tearful  
war at each other  
133 in the plain, ravenous for deadly battle

—

134 now they sit in silence, and the war  
has stopped;  
135 they lean on their shields, and the  
long spears are stuck in the earth.  
136 But Alexandros and Menelaus dear to  
Ares  
137 will fight for you with their long  
spears;  
138 and you will be called the dear wife of  
the man who wins.”  
139 So speaking, the goddess put sweet  
longing into her heart  
140 for her first husband, and her city, and  
her father and mother.  
141 At once she veiled herself in shining  
white linen  
142 and went out of her chamber, letting  
fall a soft tear —  
143 not alone: two handmaids followed

with her,

144 Aethra, Pittheus' daughter,<sup>9</sup> and ox-eyed Clymene.

145 And quickly they came to where the Scaean Gates stood.<sup>10</sup>

146 Now those around Priam — Panthous and Thymoetes,

147 Lampus and Clytius and Hicetaon, scion of Ares,

148 and Ucalegon and Antenor, wise men both —

149 sat as elders of the people at the Scaean Gates,

150 finished with war now because of age, but speakers

151 of quality, like cicadas that in the woods

152 perch on a tree and send out their lily-thin voice:<sup>11</sup>



153 such were the leaders of the Trojans  
sitting on the tower.  
154 And when they saw Helen coming up  
onto the tower,  
155 softly they spoke winged words to one  
another:  
156 “No shame that Trojans and strong-  
greaved Achaeans  
157 have suffered pain so long for a  
woman like this one.  
158 She is terribly like the immortal  
goddesses to look at.  
159 But even so — such as she is, let her go  
home in the ships,  
160 and not be left here, a grief to us and  
our children after.”  
161 So they spoke; but Priam called Helen  
to him: 12  
162 “Come here, dear child, and sit in

front of me,

163 to see your first husband and your kin  
and your friends —

164 you are not to blame in my eyes: the  
gods are to blame,

165 who set upon me this tearful war with  
the Achaeans —

166 and to tell me the name of that  
gigantic man there,

167 who that Achaean is, so tall and  
strong.

168 There are others taller by a head,  
indeed;

169 but a man so beautiful I have never yet  
seen with my eyes,

170 nor so majestic. He looks like a king.”

171 And Helen answered him, brilliant  
among women:

172 “You are dear to me, dear father-in-

law, and dread to me too.

173 How I wish vile death had pleased me  
on the day I followed

174 your son here, leaving my bridal  
chamber and my kinsmen

175 and my own dear daughter and the  
sweet company of girls my age.

176 But that was not to be; and so I waste  
away with weeping.

177 But I will tell you what you ask me and  
inquire.

178 That man is Atreus' son, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon,

179 both things at once: a good king and a  
strong spearman.

180 And he was brother-in-law — to me,  
dog-face that I am<sup>13</sup> — if that ever was.”

181 So she spoke, and the old man  
marveled at him, and said:

182 “Fortunate son of Atreus, child of  
destiny, blessed of fortune —  
183 how many young Achaean men are  
subject to you!  
184 Once I went into Phrygia of the vines,  
185 and there I saw Phrygian men in their  
multitudes, with their glancing horses,  
186 the hosts of Otreus and godlike  
Mygdon,  
187 encamped then along the banks of  
Sangarius;  
188 for I too, as an ally, was counted  
among them  
189 on the day the Amazons came, the  
match of men.<sup>14</sup>  
190 But even they were not so many as the  
bright-eyed Achaeans.”  
191 Second, the old man saw Odysseus,  
and asked:

192 “Come, tell me of this one too, dear  
child — who he is.  
193 Shorter by a head than Agamemnon,  
Atreus’ son,  
194 but broader in the shoulders and chest  
to look at.  
195 His armor lies on the earth that feeds  
so many,  
196 and he himself ranges the ranks of  
men like a bellwether ram —  
197 yes, I liken him to a thick-fleeced ram  
198 that moves through a great flock of  
white ewes.”  
199 And Helen, sprung of Zeus, answered  
him:  
200 “That is Laertes’ son, resourceful  
Odysseus,  
201 raised in the land of Ithaca — rocky as  
it is —

202 a man who knows every kind of trick  
and close-woven plan.”

203 And wise Antenor said to her in  
answer:

204 “Lady, that word of yours is exactly  
true.

205 For brilliant Odysseus came here once  
before,

206 on an embassy about you, 15 with  
Menelaus dear to Ares;

207 and I was their host: I welcomed them  
in my halls,

208 and learned the build of both, and  
their close-woven plans.

209 Now when they mixed with the  
assembled Trojans,

210 standing, Menelaus overtopped him  
with his broad shoulders,

211 but with both seated, Odysseus was

the more majestic.

212 And when they wove their words and  
their plans before us all,

213 Menelaus, certainly, spoke fluently —

214 few words, but very clear: he was no  
man of many words,

215 no Rambler — though he was in fact  
the younger.

216 But whenever resourceful Odysseus  
rose to speak,

217 he would just stand there, eyes fixed  
down on the ground,

218 not moving the scepter backward or  
forward

219 but holding it stiff, like a man who  
knows nothing;

220 you would have called him some  
sulking churl, a plain fool.

221 But when he let the great voice out of

his chest,

222 and the words came like snowflakes in  
winter,

223 then no other mortal could rival  
Odysseus.

224 Then we did not marvel so much at  
how Odysseus looked.”

225 Third, the old man saw Ajax, and  
asked:

226 “And who is that other Achaean man,  
tall and strong,

227 towering over the Argives in head and  
broad shoulders?”

228 And Helen of the trailing robe  
answered, brilliant among women:

229 “That is gigantic Ajax, wall of the  
Achaeans.

230 And on the other side Idomeneus  
stands among the Cretans



231 like a god, and the Cretan captains are  
gathered around him.

232 Often Menelaus dear to Ares was his  
host

233 in our house, whenever he came from  
Crete.

234 And now I see all the other bright-  
eyed Achaeans,

235 whom I could well recognize and  
name their names;

236 but two marshals of the people I  
cannot see —

237 Castor breaker of horses and  
Polydeuces the great boxer,

238 my own brothers, whom one mother  
bore with me.

239 Either they did not follow from lovely  
Lacedaemon,

240 or they followed here in the seagoing

ships

241 but now are not willing to enter the  
battle of men,

242 fearing the shame and the many  
reproaches that are mine.”

243 So she spoke. But the life-giving earth  
already held them under, 16

244 there in Lacedaemon, in their dear  
fatherland.

245 Now the heralds were carrying  
through the city the gods’ oath-offerings,  
246 two lambs, and wine that gladdens the  
heart, fruit of the field,

247 in a goatskin bag; and the herald  
Idaeus carried

248 a gleaming mixing-bowl and cups of  
gold;

249 and he stood beside the old king and  
roused him:

250 “Rise, son of Laomedon. The chief  
men are calling —  
251 of the horse-taming Trojans and the  
bronze-shirted Achaeans —  
252 for you to come down to the plain, to  
cut the sworn oaths.  
253 For Alexandros and Menelaus dear to  
Ares  
254 will fight with their long spears for  
the woman;  
255 and woman and wealth shall go with  
the winner,  
256 while the rest, cutting friendship and  
sworn oaths,  
257 we should live on in deep-soiled Troy,  
and they return  
258 to horse-pasturing Argos and Achaea  
of the beautiful women.”  
259 So he spoke, and the old man

shuddered; but he told his companions  
260 to yoke the horses, and they promptly  
obeyed.

261 Priam mounted and drew the reins  
back taut,

262 and beside him Antenor mounted the  
beautiful chariot,

263 and through the Scaean Gates they  
drove the swift horses toward the plain.

264 And when they had come among the  
Trojans and Achaeans,

265 they stepped from the chariot onto  
the earth that feeds so many

266 and walked into the space between  
Trojans and Achaeans.

267 At once the lord of men Agamemnon  
rose,

268 and resourceful Odysseus rose; and  
the proud heralds

269 brought together the gods' oath-  
offerings, and in the bowl  
270 mixed the wine, and poured water  
over the kings' hands.  
271 And Atreus' son drew with his hand  
the knife  
272 that always hung beside the great  
sheath of his sword,  
273 and cut hairs from the lambs' heads;  
and then  
274 the heralds gave them out to the chief  
men of the Trojans and Achaeans.  
275 And Atreus' son prayed aloud among  
them, lifting his hands:  
276 "Father Zeus, ruling from Ida, most  
glorious, greatest;  
277 and Sun, who see all things and hear  
all things;  
278 and Rivers, and Earth, and you two

below who punish

279 the dead, whoever has sworn a false  
oath:17

280 be witnesses; guard the sworn oaths.

281 If Alexandros kills Menelaus,

282 let him keep Helen and all her  
possessions,

283 and we will go home in the seagoing  
ships;

284 but if tawny-haired Menelaus kills  
Alexandros,

285 then the Trojans are to give back  
Helen and all her possessions,

286 and pay the Argives whatever  
recompense is fitting,

287 such as will be remembered among  
men still to come.

288 And if Priam and Priam's sons refuse

289 to pay me that recompense when

Alexandros has fallen,  
290 then I will fight on for the payment  
owed,  
291 staying right here, until I reach the  
end of the war.”  
292 He spoke, and cut the lambs’ throats  
with the pitiless bronze,  
293 and laid them down on the ground  
gasping,  
294 the life going out of them: the bronze  
had taken their strength.  
295 Then drawing wine from the bowl into  
the cups  
296 they poured it out, and prayed to the  
gods who are forever;  
297 and thus would one of the Achaeans  
and Trojans say:  
298 “Zeus most glorious, greatest, and you  
other immortal gods:

299 whichever side first does harm against  
the oaths,  
300 may their brains run on the ground as  
this wine runs,  
301 theirs and their children's, and their  
wives be subdued to other men.”<sup>18</sup>  
302 So they spoke; but the son of Cronos  
would not yet bring it to pass.<sup>19</sup>  
303 And Priam, Dardanus' descendant,  
spoke his word among them:  
304 “Hear from me, Trojans and strong-  
greaved Achaeans.  
305 I am going back to windswept Ilion,  
306 since I cannot yet bear to watch with  
my own eyes  
307 my dear son fighting Menelaus dear to  
Ares.  
308 Zeus, I suppose, knows — and the  
other immortal gods —



309 for which of the two the end of death  
is fated.”

310 He spoke — a man like a god — and set  
the lambs in the chariot,  
311 and mounted himself, and drew the  
reins back taut,  
312 and beside him Antenor mounted the  
beautiful chariot;  
313 and back again to Ilion the two  
returned.

314 Then Hector, Priam’s son, and brilliant  
Odysseus  
315 first measured out the ground, and  
then  
316 took lots and shook them in a bronze-  
fitted helmet,  
317 for which of the two should cast his  
bronze spear first.

318 And the hosts prayed, and lifted their

hands to the gods,

319 and thus would one of the Achaeans  
and Trojans say:

320 “Father Zeus, ruling from Ida, most  
glorious, greatest:

321 whichever of the two brought these  
troubles on both peoples,

322 grant that he go down, dead, into the  
house of Hades,

323 and that friendship and sworn oaths  
be ours.”

324 So they spoke; and great Hector of the  
flashing helmet shook the lots,

325 looking away behind him; and Paris’s  
lot leapt quickly out.

326 Then the men sat down in ranks,  
where each man’s

327 high-stepping horses and patterned  
armor lay.

328 And he girded the fine armor about  
his shoulders —20  
329 brilliant Alexandros, husband of  
lovely-haired Helen.  
330 First he set the greaves along his  
shins,  
331 beautiful ones, fitted with silver ankle-  
guards;  
332 next he girt about his chest the corslet  
333 of his brother Lycaon — and it fitted  
him;  
334 and about his shoulders he slung the  
silver-studded sword,  
335 a sword of bronze, and then the  
shield, great and heavy;  
336 and on his strong head he set the well-  
made helmet  
337 with its horsehair crest — and terribly  
the plume nodded above him —

338 and took up a stout spear, fitted to his grip.

339 And in the same way warlike  
Menelaus put on his gear.

340 And when they had armed on either  
side of the throng,

341 they strode into the space between  
Trojans and Achaeans,

342 glaring terribly; and amazement held  
the watchers,

343 the horse-taming Trojans and the  
strong-greaved Achaeans.

344 They took their stand near each other  
on the measured ground,

345 shaking their spears, in fury at one  
another.

346 Alexandros first hurled his long-  
shadowed spear<sup>21</sup>

347 and struck the shield of Atreus' son,

balanced every way;  
348 but the bronze did not break through:  
its point was bent back  
349 in the strong shield. Second, Atreus'  
son Menelaus  
350 rose with his bronze, with a prayer to  
father Zeus:  
351 "Zeus, lord: grant me to punish the  
man who wronged me first —  
352 brilliant Alexandros — and break him  
under my hands,  
353 so that many a man may shudder,  
even among men yet to be born,  
354 at doing evil to a host who has offered  
him friendship."  
355 He spoke, and balancing his long-  
shadowed spear he hurled it  
356 and struck the shield of Priam's son,  
balanced every way.

357 Through the shining shield the heavy  
spear went,  
358 and through the richly worked corslet  
it drove;  
359 and straight on beside his flank the  
spear sheared through  
360 the tunic — but he had swerved aside,  
and dodged black doom.  
361 Then Atreus' son drew the silver-  
studded sword,  
362 rose up, and struck the ridge of his  
helmet; but around it  
363 the sword shattered in three and four  
pieces, and fell from his hand.  
364 And Atreus' son groaned, looking into  
the wide sky:  
365 "Father Zeus, no other god is more  
destroying than you!  
366 I thought I had made Alexandros pay

for his wickedness,

367 and now the sword is broken in my  
hands, and the spear

368 flew from my grip for nothing, and I  
have not hit him.”

369 He spoke — and springing on him he  
seized the horsehair helmet

370 and swung round and dragged him  
toward the strong-greaved Achaeans;

371 and the richly stitched strap was  
strangling the soft throat under it,

372 the chin-strap drawn tight beneath  
his jaw.

373 And now he would have dragged him  
off and won glory past telling,

374 had not Aphrodite, Zeus’s daughter,  
seen it sharply:

375 she broke the strap — leather of an ox  
felled by force —

376 and the helmet came away empty in  
his heavy hand.  
377 The hero sent it spinning away toward  
the strong-greaved Achaeans  
378 with a whirl, and his trusted  
companions gathered it up;  
379 and back again he sprang, raging to  
kill  
380 with his bronze spear. But Aphrodite  
snatched Paris away —  
381 easily, as a god can — and hid him in  
thick mist,  
382 and set him down in his fragrant,  
scented chamber.  
383 Then she went herself to summon  
Helen; she found her  
384 on the high tower, with the women of  
Troy thick around her.  
385 With her hand she plucked at her



nectar-sweet robe and shook it,  
386 and spoke to her in the likeness of an  
old woman,  
387 a wool-comber of long ago, who used  
to work fine wool  
388 for her when she lived in  
Lacedaemon, and whom she dearly loved;  
389 in her likeness brilliant Aphrodite  
spoke:  
390 “Come here. Alexandros calls you  
home.  
391 There he is, in the bedchamber, on the  
turned bed,  
392 gleaming in his beauty and his  
clothes. You would not say  
393 he had come from single combat —  
rather that he was going  
394 to a dance, or sitting down just now  
come from dancing.”

395 So she spoke, and stirred the heart in  
Helen's breast;  
396 and when she noticed the surpassing  
beauty of the goddess's throat  
397 and the breasts of desire and the  
flashing eyes,  
398 awe took her, 22 and she spoke a word,  
and named her:  
399 "Strange goddess — why are you so  
set on cheating me like this?  
400 Will you carry me somewhere still  
farther on, to one of the fine  
401 cities of Phrygia or lovely Maeonia,  
402 if some mortal man is dear to you  
there too?  
403 Is it because Menelaus has beaten  
brilliant Alexandros  
404 and wants to lead hateful me home  
again —

405 is that why you stand beside me now,  
weaving your tricks?  
406 Go sit beside him yourself. Renounce  
the paths of the gods;  
407 never again turn your feet back to  
Olympus,  
408 but fret over him forever, and guard  
him,  
409 until he makes you his wife — or else  
his slave.  
410 I will not go to him — that would be a  
thing for anger —  
411 to serve that man's bed. The women of  
Troy  
412 would all mock me afterward; and I  
have griefs past counting in my heart.”  
413 And in anger brilliant Aphrodite  
answered her:  
414 “Do not provoke me, hard woman — or

I may quit you in my anger  
415 and hate you as extravagantly as I now  
love you,  
416 and devise bitter hatreds between  
both sides,  
417 Trojans and Danaans alike — and you  
would perish miserably.”  
418 So she spoke, and Helen sprung of  
Zeus was afraid,  
419 and she went in silence, wrapped in  
her shining white robe,  
420 unnoticed by all the Trojan women;  
and the goddess led.  
421 When they came to the beautiful  
house of Alexandros,  
422 the handmaids turned quickly to their  
work,  
423 and she went to the high-roofed  
bedchamber, brilliant among women.

424 And laughter-loving Aphrodite<sup>23</sup> took  
a chair for her —  
425 a goddess! — carried it, and set it  
facing Alexandros;<sup>24</sup>  
426 there Helen sat, daughter of aegis-  
bearing Zeus,  
427 her eyes turned away, and she lashed  
her husband with her word:  
428 “You came back from the fight. How I  
wish you had died there,  
429 broken by the strong man who was  
my first husband.  
430 You used to boast, before, that you  
were the better man —  
431 stronger than Menelaus dear to Ares  
in force and hand and spear.  
432 Go on then, challenge Menelaus dear  
to Ares  
433 to fight you again face to face. — But

no; I myself

434 advise you to stop: do not fight tawny-  
haired Menelaus

435 man against man, do not battle him,

436 like a fool — or you may soon go down  
under his spear.”<sup>25</sup>

437 And Paris answered her with his word:

438 “Woman, do not lash my heart with  
hard reproaches.

439 This time Menelaus has won — with  
Athena’s help;

440 another time it will be I. There are  
gods on our side too.

441 Come, let us take our joy in love, in  
bed together.

442 Never has desire so wrapped itself  
around my heart —

443 not even when I first carried you off  
from lovely Lacedaemon

444 and sailed away in the seagoing ships,  
445 and on the island of Kranae<sup>26</sup> mixed  
with you in love and bed —  
446 as I love you now, and sweet longing  
takes hold of me.”  
447 He spoke, and led the way to bed; and  
his wife followed.  
448 So the two lay together on the corded  
bed.  
449 But Atreus’ son ranged through the  
throng like a wild beast,  
450 hunting for a glimpse of godlike  
Alexandros.  
451 And no one of the Trojans or their  
famed allies  
452 could show Alexandros to Menelaus  
dear to Ares;  
453 not out of friendship, surely, would  
they have hidden him, had anyone seen

him:

454 for he was hated by them all like black death.

455 And among them spoke the lord of men Agamemnon:

456 “Hear me, Trojans and Dardanians and allies.

457 Victory clearly belongs to Menelaus dear to Ares.

458 Give up, then, Argive Helen and the possessions with her,

459 and pay whatever recompense is fitting,

460 such as will be remembered among men still to come.”

461 So spoke Atreus’ son, and the rest of the Achaeans gave assent.

## Notes



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## NOTES

1. (3.3-7) The cranes migrating to Ocean's stream to war on the Pygmy men — the oldest surviving reference to the Pygmy legend. The simile's real work is the contrast it frames: the Trojans advance with clamor like birds, the Achaeans in disciplined silence (8-9) — a recurring characterization of the two armies. ↩
2. (3.16) "Alexandros" — the poem's usual name for Paris (Πάρις appears only occasionally, e.g. 325, 437). The translation reproduces whichever name the Greek uses in each line rather than normalizing. Hector's opening insult at 39, Δύσπαρι ("Dys-Paris," ill-Paris), is rendered "Paris — evil Paris." ↩
3. (3.18-20) A rare case of overlapping athetesis by both major Alexandrian editors: Zenodotus rejected 18-20, Aristarchus separately 19-20 (apparatus). The bother was partly Paris's arsenal — leopard skin, bow, sword, and two spears is theatrical overload. Kept: the over-dressed entrance is exactly in character. ↩
4. (3.21) "dear to Ares" (ἀρηΐφιλος) — Menelaus's standing epithet in this book; his other is "tawny-haired" (ξανθός, 284). Both always so rendered. ↩

5. (3.57) “a shirt of stone” (λάϊνον χιτῶνα) — i.e. death by public stoning, the community’s punishment for the offense Paris committed; the idiom is kept literal. ↩
6. (3.103-104) The victims are matched to the oath-witnesses: a white ram for the Sun, a black ewe for Earth, a third lamb from the Achaeans for Zeus. Priam must swear in person because oaths bind the swearer alone — and his sons are “not to be trusted” (106): the war began with Paris violating a solemn bond. ↩
7. (3.108-110) Aristarchus athetized these three generalizing lines on young men’s flightiness (apparatus, Line 108-110). Kept; the sententiousness suits Menelaus’s careful legalism in this speech. ↩
8. (3.125-128) Helen weaving the battles “which for her sake they suffered” — the poem’s most self-referential image: she is weaving the subject-matter of the Iliad while living inside it. The Alexandrian editors read “a double cloak of purple” (πορφυρέην, as printed); most manuscripts have “shimmering” (μαρμαρέην) — the apparatus records the split (Line 126). ↩
9. (3.144) Aethra, Pittheus’ daughter, is in myth the mother of Theseus, made Helen’s slave when the

Dioscuri sacked Athens's territory to recover the girl Theseus had abducted — a story alien to Homer, and ancient critics condemned the line as an Athenian interpolation (Aristarchus athetized it; apparatus, Line 144). Translated as printed; the name is either a fossil of that lost epic tradition or a coincidence ancient readers over-read. ↩

10. (3.145) The Scaean Gates: Troy's main gate facing the plain and the battlefield, the fixed stage-set for departures and watching in this poem (and, in tradition beyond it, the place of Achilles' death). ↩
11. (3.151-152) The old counselors chirp like cicadas with their "lily- thin voice" (ὄπα λειριόεσσαν — literally "lily-like," delicate as a petal): age has left them song without strength. One of the poem's most admired domestic similes. ↩
12. (3.161-244) The teichoscopia ("viewing from the wall"): Priam, in the war's tenth year, asks Helen to identify Agamemnon, Odysseus, and Ajax as though the enemy were new to him. Critics ancient and modern have noted the impossibility; dramatically it is the audience's own introduction to the Achaean captains, staged through the eyes of the two people most implicated in the war. ↩

13. (3.180) “dog-face that I am” (κυνώπιδος) — Helen turns on herself the poem’s harshest shame-insult (cf. Achilles to Agamemnon, Book 1 note [19]). Her self-lacerations (“hateful me,” 404; cf. 173-176) are unique in the poem and are rendered at full strength. ↩
14. (3.189) The Amazons, “the match of men” (ἀντιάνειραι) — one of only two Iliad references to them (cf. 6.186); Priam fought against them on the Sangarius in his youth. In post-Homeric epic they come to Troy as allies — here they are still simply a memory of a hard war. ↩
15. (3.205-224) Antenor recalls the pre-war embassy: Odysseus and Menelaus came to Troy to demand Helen back before hostilities — a tradition the Iliad otherwise passes over. His sketch of Odysseus’s oratory (the stiff stance, eyes down, then words “like snowflakes in winter”) became the classical archetype of deceptive-looking eloquence. ↩
16. (3.243-244) The famous ironic close of the teichoscopia: Helen scans the plain for her brothers Castor and Polydeuces, imagining them ashamed of her — “but the life-giving earth already held them under.” The narrator states their death with the

epithet *φυσίζοος* (“life-giving”) set against the grave: kept in its full contradiction. Homer knows nothing (or says nothing) of their later shared immortality. ↩

17. (3.276-279) The oath-witnesses: Zeus of Ida, the all-seeing Sun, the Rivers and Earth, “and you two below who punish the dead” — probably Hades and Persephone (some ancients understood the Erinyes). Perjury is the one sin explicitly punished after death in the *Iliad*. ↩

18. (3.298-301) The curse enacts itself in the ritual: as the wine is poured out, so may the perjurers’ brains pour on the ground. “Their wives be subdued to other men” completes the symmetry — the war is, precisely, about a wife taken by another man. ↩

19. (3.302) A Ptolemaic papyrus preserves four extra lines here — Zeus thundering in answer and planning woes for both sides — absent from the medieval manuscripts (apparatus, Line 302; cf. *disputed\_lines.md* #14 on Ptolemaic “plus verses”). A live specimen of how fluid the text still was before the Alexandrian standardization. The vulgate’s laconic “the son of Cronos would not yet

bring it to pass” is translated; the papyrus expansion is recorded here. ↩

20. (3.328-338) The poem’s first full arming type-scene, in the fixed order that recurs whenever a hero arms: greaves, corslet, sword, shield, helmet, spear(s). Later arming scenes (Agamemnon in Book 11, Patroclus in 16, Achilles in 19) elaborate the same skeleton; it will not be re-footnoted. Zenodotus athetized 334-335 (apparatus). Paris borrows his brother Lycaon’s corslet — the bowman owns none. ↩

21. (3.346) “long-shadowed spear” (δολιχόσκιον ἔγχος) — the fixed epithet of the thrown spear, always so rendered. ↩

22. (3.396-418) Aristarchus athetized this whole exchange (apparatus, Line 396-418) — Helen seeing through the disguise, defying the goddess to her face (“Go sit beside him yourself... his wife — or else his slave”), and Aphrodite’s naked threat. No other mortal in the Iliad speaks to a god like this; the scene lays bare what Aphrodite’s “gifts” cost the one who receives them. Kept entire. ↩

23. (3.424) “laughter-loving Aphrodite” (φιλομειδής Ἀφροδίτη) — her fixed epithet, always so rendered.



24. (3.424-425) A goddess carrying a chair for a mortal woman — service so startling the translation lets the narrator's shock show ("a goddess!" renders the emphatic θεά). Zenodotus rewrote 423-426 into a single innocuous line, "and she herself went and sat opposite lord Alexandros" (apparatus, Line 423-426) — flattening exactly the scandal that gives the gesture its force: Aphrodite is herself procuring, and stoops to it. ↩
25. (3.428-436) Helen's greeting to the rescued Paris — a death-wish, a taunt, and a mid-sentence collapse from "challenge him again" to "no — you would die." Aristarchus athetized 432-436 (apparatus). Kept: the broken movement of the speech is the psychology. ↩
26. (3.445) Kranae ("Rocky Isle") — the island where Paris and Helen first slept together on the flight from Sparta; possibly a proper name, possibly just "a rocky island." Ancient guesses ranged from Cythera to an islet off the Laconian coast later renamed Helene. ↩

# Book 4

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*The truce broken: Pandarus's arrow, the review of the troops, and the first battle of the poem.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 Now the gods, seated beside Zeus, were  
holding assembly
- 2 on the golden floor, and among them  
the lady Hebe
- 3 poured nectar; and they with golden  
cups
- 4 pledged one another, looking out at the  
city of the Trojans.
- 5 And at once the son of Cronos set about  
provoking Hera
- 6 with needling words, speaking sidelong:



7 “Two of the goddesses are helpers of  
Menelaus —  
8 Hera of Argos and Athena of  
Alalcomenae —  
9 and yet the two of them sit apart,  
looking on,  
10 taking their pleasure; while laughter-  
loving Aphrodite  
11 is forever at that other’s side, and keeps  
the fates of death from him:  
12 just now she saved him when he  
thought to die.  
13 Still — victory belongs to Menelaus  
dear to Ares.  
14 So let us consider how these things  
shall be:  
15 whether we shall stir up evil war again  
and the dread din  
16 of battle, or cast friendship between

the two sides.

17 If somehow this should be welcome and  
sweet to all,

18 then let the city of lord Priam stay a  
place men live in,

19 and let Menelaus take Argive Helen  
home again.”

20 So he spoke, and they murmured at it,  
Athena and Hera,

21 who sat side by side plotting evils for  
the Trojans.

22 Athena, to be sure, stayed silent and  
said nothing,

23 sulking at father Zeus, wild anger  
gripping her;

24 but Hera’s breast could not contain her  
anger, and she spoke:

25 “Most dread son of Cronos, what a  
word you have spoken!

26 How can you wish to make my labor  
vain and unaccomplished —  
27 the sweat I sweated in my toil, my  
horses worn out  
28 gathering the host, to bring evils on  
Priam and his sons?  
29 Do it. But we other gods do not all  
approve it.”  
30 Greatly troubled, Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer answered her:  
31 “Possessed one — what great evils do  
Priam and Priam’s sons  
32 do you, that you rage without respite  
33 to sack the well-built citadel of Ilion?  
34 If you could go in through the gates  
and the long walls  
35 and eat Priam raw, and Priam’s sons,<sup>2</sup>  
36 and the other Trojans too — then you  
might cure your anger.

37 Do as you please. Only let not this  
quarrel  
38 become in time a great strife between  
you and me.  
39 And I will tell you another thing — put  
it away in your heart:  
40 whenever I in my turn am bent on  
sacking a city,  
41 and choose one where men dear to you  
were born,  
42 do not try to delay my anger, but let  
me be:  
43 for I too have given you this willingly —  
with unwilling heart.  
44 Of all the cities under the sun and the  
starry sky  
45 that men who dwell on the earth  
inhabit,  
46 holy Ilion was most honored in my

heart,

47 and Priam, and the people of Priam of  
the good ash spear.

48 Never did my altar lack its fair share of  
the feast,

49 the libation and the savor: for that is  
the honor-portion we gods have.”

50 Then the ox-eyed lady Hera answered  
him:

51 “Three cities there are far dearest of all  
to me:

52 Argos, and Sparta, and wide-wayed  
Mycenae.

53 Sack these, whenever they grow  
hateful to your heart;

54 I do not stand in front of them; I do not  
grudge them to you.

55 For even if I did begrudge them, and  
refused you their sacking,

56 my grudging would accomplish  
nothing: you are far the stronger.<sup>3</sup>  
57 But my labor too must not be made  
unaccomplished.  
58 I also am a god; my birth is from the  
same stock as yours;  
59 crooked-counseled Cronos begot me,  
eldest of his daughters —  
60 eldest doubly: by birth, and because I  
am called  
61 your wife, and you are king among all  
the immortals.  
62 Come — in this let us yield to one  
another,  
63 I to you and you to me, and the other  
immortal gods  
64 will follow. Quickly now: order Athena  
65 to go down into the dread din of  
Trojans and Achaeans

66 and contrive that the Trojans be the  
first to do harm,  
67 against the oaths, to the Achaeans now  
in their glory.”  
68 So she spoke, and the father of men  
and gods did not disobey:  
69 at once he addressed Athena with  
winged words:  
70 “Go with all speed to the armies, to the  
Trojans and Achaeans,  
71 and contrive that the Trojans be the  
first to do harm,  
72 against the oaths, to the Achaeans now  
in their glory.”  
73 So speaking, he stirred Athena, already  
eager;  
74 and down from the peaks of Olympus  
she went darting.  
75 As the son of crooked-counseled

Cronos sends a star,  
76 a portent to sailors or to the wide host  
of an army,  
77 blazing, and sparks stream from it in  
multitudes —  
78 in such a likeness Pallas Athena darted  
to earth  
79 and leapt down into the middle; and  
amazement held the watchers,  
80 the horse-taming Trojans and the  
strong-greaved Achaeans;  
81 and thus one would say, with a glance  
at his neighbor:  
82 “Either evil war and the dread din of  
battle  
83 are coming again — or Zeus is setting  
friendship  
84 between the two sides, Zeus, the  
dispenser of war to men.”



85 So one of the Achaeans and Trojans  
would say.

86 And she, in the likeness of a man, went  
down into the Trojan throng —

87 of Laodocus, Antenor's son, a strong  
spearman —

88 searching for godlike Pandarus, if she  
might find him.

89 She found Lycaon's son, blameless and  
strong,

90 standing; and around him the strong  
ranks of shield-bearing

91 men who had followed him from the  
streams of Aesepus.

92 Standing close, she spoke winged  
words to him:

93 “Would you let me persuade you, war-  
minded son of Lycaon?

94 Would you dare send a swift arrow at

Menelaus,

95 and win favor and glory in the eyes of  
all the Trojans —

96 of prince Alexandros most of all?

97 From him first of anyone you would  
carry off shining gifts,

98 if he should see Menelaus, Atreus'  
warlike son,

99 brought down by your shaft and set on  
the grievous pyre.

100 Come then — shoot an arrow at  
glorious Menelaus,

101 and vow to Apollo the Lycian-born,  
famed for the bow,<sup>4</sup>

102 to offer a splendid hecatomb of  
firstborn lambs

103 when you come home to the town of  
holy Zeleia.”

104 So spoke Athena, and persuaded the

fool's heart.

105 At once he uncased his polished bow,  
made from the horn<sup>5</sup>

106 of a leaping wild ibex which he  
himself had once shot

107 under the chest as it stepped out from  
a rock — lying

108 in wait in a blind, he struck it in the  
chest,

109 and it fell back flat on the rock. From  
its head the horns

110 had grown sixteen palms; and the  
craftsman, the horn-polisher,

111 fitted them together, smoothed all  
smooth, and set on a tip of gold.

112 This bow he strung, bending it well,  
and laid it down

113 propped against the ground; and his  
good companions held their shields before

him,

114 so the warlike sons of the Achaeans  
should not spring up

115 before Menelaus, Atreus' warlike son,  
was hit.

116 Then he stripped the lid from his  
quiver and took out an arrow,

117 never yet shot, winged, a base of black  
pains;<sup>6</sup>

118 and quickly he set the bitter shaft in  
order on the string,

119 and vowed to Apollo the Lycian-born,  
famed for the bow,

120 to offer a splendid hecatomb of  
firstborn lambs

121 when he came home to the town of  
holy Zeleia.

122 Gripping together the notched butt  
and the string of ox-sinew, he drew:

123 the string he brought to his breast,  
and to the bow the iron head.<sup>7</sup>  
124 And when he had strained the great  
bow into a circle,  
125 the horn sang, the string cried aloud,  
and the arrow leapt,  
126 sharp-pointed, raging to fly on into  
the crowd.  
127 But the blessed immortal gods did not  
forget you,  
128 Menelaus — first among them Zeus's  
daughter, the driver of the spoil,  
129 who stood before you and warded off  
the piercing shaft.  
130 She brushed it back from the skin just  
so far as a mother  
131 brushes a fly from her child when he  
lies in sweet sleep,  
132 and steered it herself to where the

golden buckles<sup>8</sup>

<sup>133</sup> of the war-belt met and the corslet lay  
doubled.

<sup>134</sup> Into the fastened war-belt fell the  
bitter arrow:

<sup>135</sup> through the wrought belt it was  
driven,

<sup>136</sup> through the richly worked corslet it  
pressed on,

<sup>137</sup> and through the waist-guard he wore  
to shield his flesh, a fence against javelins

—

<sup>138</sup> that guarded him best, yet it passed  
through even this;

<sup>139</sup> and the arrow grazed the outermost  
skin of the man,

<sup>140</sup> and at once dark-clouded blood ran  
down from the wound.

<sup>141</sup> As when some woman of Maeonia or

Caria stains<sup>9</sup>

<sup>142</sup> ivory with crimson, to be a cheek-  
piece for horses;

<sup>143</sup> it lies in a treasure-room, and many  
horsemen

<sup>144</sup> have prayed to carry it; but it lies  
there, a king's treasure,

<sup>145</sup> both ornament for the horse and glory  
for the driver:

<sup>146</sup> so, Menelaus, your shapely thighs  
were stained

<sup>147</sup> with blood, your shins, and your fine  
ankles beneath.

<sup>148</sup> Then the lord of men Agamemnon  
shuddered

<sup>149</sup> as he saw the black blood running  
down from the wound,

<sup>150</sup> and Menelaus dear to Ares shuddered  
himself;

151 but when he saw the binding-cord and  
the barbs still outside the flesh,  
152 the spirit was gathered back into his  
breast.  
153 But groaning heavily, the lord  
Agamemnon spoke among them,  
154 holding Menelaus by the hand, and  
the companions groaned with him:  
155 “Dear brother, it was your death I was  
cutting in those oaths, 10  
156 setting you out alone before the  
Achaeans to fight the Trojans —  
157 now the Trojans have shot you down  
and trampled the sworn oaths.  
158 Yet not in vain are the oath, the blood  
of lambs,  
159 the unmixed libations, the right hands  
we trusted.  
160 For if the Olympian has not fulfilled it



at once,  
161 he fulfills it late — and men pay  
greatly for it,  
162 with their own heads, and their wives,  
and their children.  
163 For this I know well in my mind and  
heart:  
164 the day will come when holy Ilion  
shall perish,  
165 and Priam, and the people of Priam of  
the good ash spear,  
166 and Zeus the son of Cronos, high-  
throned, dwelling in the sky,  
167 will himself shake his dark aegis over  
them all  
168 in anger at this deceit. These things  
will not go unaccomplished.  
169 But my grief for you will be terrible, O  
Menelaus,

170 if you die and fill up your portion of  
life.

171 I would go back to thirsty Argos in  
utter disgrace,

172 for the Achaeans would think at once  
of their fatherland,

173 and we would leave to Priam and the  
Trojans their boast —

174 Argive Helen; and the field would rot  
your bones

175 as you lay in Troy, the work  
unaccomplished.

176 And thus some overweening Trojan  
will say,

177 leaping on the tomb of glorious  
Menelaus:

178 ‘May Agamemnon bring his anger to  
this end in every case —

179 as now he led an Achaean army here

for nothing,

180 and has gone off home to his dear  
fatherland

181 with empty ships, and left good  
Menelaus behind.'

182 So some day one of them will say.  
Then let the wide earth gape for me."

183 But tawny-haired Menelaus spoke to  
reassure him:

184 "Take heart; do not frighten the  
Achaean host at all.

185 The sharp shaft is not fixed in a mortal  
place: before that

186 my glittering war-belt saved me, and  
beneath it

187 the loin-guard, and the waist-guard  
bronze-smiths labored on."

188 Answering him spoke the lord  
Agamemnon:

189 “May it be so indeed, dear Menelaus.  
190 But a healer will probe the wound and  
lay on it  
191 drugs to stop the black pains.”  
192 He spoke, and addressed Talthybius  
the godlike herald:  
193 “Talthybius — as quick as you can, call  
Machaon here,  
194 the man who is son of Asclepius the  
blameless healer,<sup>11</sup>  
195 to see Menelaus, Atreus’ warlike  
son,<sup>12</sup>  
196 whom someone skilled in the bow has  
shot with an arrow,  
197 some Trojan or Lycian: glory for him,  
grief for us.”  
198 So he spoke, and the herald heard and  
did not disobey.  
199 He went through the host of the

bronze-shirted Achaeans

200 peering for the hero Machaon; and he  
saw him

201 standing, with the strong ranks of  
shield-bearing men

202 around him, who had followed him  
from horse-pasturing Tricca.

203 Standing close, he spoke winged  
words:

204 “Rise, son of Asclepius. The lord  
Agamemnon calls,

205 to see Menelaus, the warlike captain  
of the Achaeans,

206 whom someone skilled in the bow has  
shot with an arrow,

207 some Trojan or Lycian: glory for him,  
grief for us.”

208 So he spoke, and stirred the heart in  
his breast,

209 and they went through the crowd,  
through the wide Achaean camp.  
210 And when they came where tawny-  
haired Menelaus  
211 was wounded — and around him all  
the best men were gathered  
212 in a circle, and he, a man like a god,  
stood among them —  
213 at once Machaon drew the arrow from  
the fastened belt;  
214 and as it was drawn out, the sharp  
barbs broke backward.  
215 Then he loosed the glittering war-belt,  
and beneath it  
216 the loin-guard, and the waist-guard  
bronze-smiths labored on.  
217 And when he saw the wound where  
the bitter arrow had struck,  
218 he sucked out the blood, and skillfully

sprinkled on it

219 soothing drugs, which Chiron once  
gave his father out of friendship.

220 While they were busy about  
Menelaus, good at the war-cry,

221 the ranks of the shield-bearing  
Trojans came on;

222 and the Achaeans put on their armor  
again, and remembered their fighting.

223 Then you would not have seen  
brilliant Agamemnon drowsing,13

224 or cowering, or unwilling to fight,

225 but hurrying hard toward the battle  
where men win glory.

226 He left his horses and his chariot  
patterned with bronze —

227 his aide kept them snorting off to the  
side,

228 Eurymedon, son of Ptolemaeus,

Peiraeus' son,

229 with strict orders to keep them close  
at hand for the moment

230 weariness should take his limbs,  
commanding through so many —

231 and on foot he ranged the ranks of  
men.

232 Whomever of the Danaans of swift  
colts he saw pressing on,

233 he would stand beside them and  
hearten them with his words:

234 “Argives, do not let go your rushing  
courage now!

235 Father Zeus will be no helper to liars:

236 those who were first to do harm  
against the oaths —

237 vultures will eat their tender flesh,

238 and we will carry off their dear wives  
and little children



239 in our ships, when we take their  
citadel.”

240 But whomever he saw hanging back  
from hateful war,  
241 those he would rake with angry words:  
242 “Argives — loud boasters — disgraces!  
Have you no shame?<sup>14</sup>

243 Why do you stand stunned like this,  
like fawns  
244 that have run themselves tired over a  
wide plain  
245 and stand still, with no courage left in  
their hearts —  
246 so you stand stunned, and do not  
fight.

247 Are you waiting for the Trojans to  
come right up to where the ships  
248 with their fine sterns are drawn up on  
the shore of the grey sea,

249 to find out whether the son of Cronos  
will hold his hand over you?”

250 So, commanding, he ranged through  
the ranks of men,

251 and came to the Cretans, moving  
through the crowd of fighters.

252 They were arming around war-  
minded Idomeneus:

253 Idomeneus among the front-fighters,  
like a wild boar in courage,

254 while Meriones hurried on the  
rearmost companies.

255 Seeing them the lord of men  
Agamemnon rejoiced,

256 and at once he spoke to Idomeneus  
with honeyed words:

257 “Idomeneus, I honor you beyond all  
the Danaans of swift colts,

258 in war and in every other work,

259 and at the feast, when the chief men  
of the Argives

260 mix the elders' gleaming wine in the  
bowl.

261 For even if the other long-haired  
Achaeans

262 drink their allotted share, your cup  
stands always

263 full, as mine does, to drink whenever  
the heart bids.

264 Rouse yourself for battle, and be the  
man you claim of old to be."

265 And Idomeneus, captain of the  
Cretans, answered him:

266 "Son of Atreus, I will be a trusty  
companion to you

267 indeed, as I first promised and bowed  
my head;

268 go and rouse the other long-haired

Achaeans,

269 so we may fight at once — since the  
Trojans have poured away

270 the oaths. Death and sorrows  
hereafter will be theirs,

271 since they were first to do harm  
against the oaths.”

272 So he spoke, and Atreus’ son passed  
on, glad at heart,

273 and came to the two Ajaxes, moving  
through the crowd of fighters;

274 they were arming for war, and a cloud  
of foot-soldiers followed them.

275 As when from a lookout a goatherd  
sees a cloud

276 coming over the deep before the drive  
of the West Wind:

277 from far off, blacker than pitch it  
shows,

278 moving over the deep, and it brings a  
great storm with it;  
279 he shivers at the sight, and drives his  
flocks into a cave:  
280 such, beside the two Ajaxes, moved  
the close-packed companies  
281 of Zeus-nurtured fighting men, dark  
masses,  
282 into destroying war, bristling with  
shields and spears.  
283 Seeing them too the lord Agamemnon  
rejoiced,  
284 and speaking winged words he  
addressed them:  
285 “Ajaxes, leaders of the bronze-shirted  
Argives —  
286 to you two I give no orders: it would  
not be right to push you;  
287 you yourselves drive your people hard

to fight in strength.

288 O father Zeus, Athena, Apollo —

289 if such a spirit were in every breast,

290 then the city of lord Priam would  
soon bow its head,

291 taken and sacked beneath our hands.”

292 So speaking he left them there and  
went to the others.

293 There he came on Nestor, the clear-  
voiced speaker of Pylos,

294 arraying his companions and driving  
them to fight,

295 around tall Pelagon, and Alastor, and  
Chromius,

296 and the lord Haemon, and Bias,  
shepherd of the people.

297 The charioteers he arrayed in front  
with horses and cars,<sup>15</sup>

298 the foot-soldiers behind, many and

brave,

299 to be a wall of war; the shirkers he  
drove into the middle,

300 so that even the unwilling man would  
have to fight.

301 To the charioteers he gave his orders  
first: he bade them

302 hold their horses in hand and not  
tangle in the crowd:

303 “Let no man, trusting his  
horsemanship and his manhood,

304 burn to fight the Trojans alone out in  
front of the rest,

305 and let no man fall back — you will be  
the weaker for it.

306 But the man who from his own car  
can reach an enemy’s,

307 let him thrust with the spear: it is far  
better so.

308 This was the mind the men before us  
had when they sacked  
309 cities and walls, keeping this thought  
and spirit in their breasts.”  
310 So the old man drove them on, wise in  
war long since.  
311 Seeing him too the lord Agamemnon  
rejoiced,  
312 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:  
313 “Old man — would that, as the spirit is  
in your own breast,  
314 so your knees kept pace, and your  
strength stood firm.  
315 But age wears you, age that comes to  
all. If only  
316 some other man had your years, and  
you were among the young.”  
317 Then answered him the Gerenian



horseman Nestor:

318 “Son of Atreus, I too could dearly wish  
to be

319 the man I was when I cut down  
brilliant Ereuthalion.

320 But the gods never give men  
everything at once:16

321 if I was young then, now old age  
comes with me.

322 Even so I will be among the  
charioteers, and command them

323 with counsel and with words: that is  
the honor-portion of the old.

324 The spears the younger men will  
wield, who were born

325 after me and trust in their strength.”

326 So he spoke, and Atreus’ son passed  
on, glad at heart.

327 He found Menestheus, driver of

horses, son of Peteos,  
328 standing; and around him the  
Athenians, masters of the war-cry;  
329 and close by stood resourceful  
Odysseus,  
330 and beside him the ranks of  
Cephalenians, no weaklings,  
331 stood; for their people had not yet  
heard the war-cry,  
332 since the companies of horse-taming  
Trojans and Achaeans  
333 had only just begun to move; and they  
stood waiting  
334 for another Achaean column to come  
on,  
335 charge the Trojans, and begin the war.  
336 Seeing them, the lord of men  
Agamemnon raked them,  
337 and speaking winged words he

addressed them:

338 “You — son of Peteos, that Zeus-  
nurtured king;

339 and you, master of evil tricks, greedy-  
hearted:

340 why do you stand apart cowering, and  
wait for others?

341 It is for you two to stand among the  
first

342 and take your share of scorching  
battle face on;

343 for you are first to hear of my feast

344 whenever we Achaeans set out a feast  
for the elders.

345 There it pleases you to eat the roasted  
meat and drink

346 the cups of honey-sweet wine as long  
as you wish;

347 but now you would gladly watch even

if ten columns of Achaeans

348 fought with the pitiless bronze out in  
front of you.”

349 Glaring at him darkly, resourceful  
Odysseus answered:

350 “Son of Atreus — what a word has  
escaped the fence of your teeth!17

351 How can you say I hang back from  
fighting, whenever we Achaeans

352 wake sharp war on the horse-taming  
Trojans?

353 You will see — if you wish to, and if it  
matters to you —

354 the dear father of Telemachus mixing  
with the front-fighters

355 of the horse-taming Trojans. What  
you say is empty wind.”

356 And the lord Agamemnon answered  
him, smiling,

357 when he saw his anger, and took back  
his word:  
358 “Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus  
of many devices,  
359 I neither scold you beyond measure  
nor give you orders.  
360 I know the heart in your breast  
361 knows gentle counsels: you think what  
I think.  
362 Come — we will make this good later,  
if any harsh thing  
363 has been said now; may the gods make  
it all come to nothing.”  
364 So speaking he left them there and  
went to the others.  
365 He found Tydeus’ son, high-hearted  
Diomedes,  
366 standing among the horses and the  
bolted chariots,

367 and beside him stood Sthenelus,  
Capaneus' son.  
368 Seeing him too the lord Agamemnon  
raked him,  
369 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:  
370 "Ah me — son of war-minded Tydeus,  
breaker of horses:18  
371 why do you cower? Why do you eye  
the causeways of battle?  
372 It was not Tydeus' way to cower like  
this,  
373 but to fight the enemy far ahead of his  
own companions —  
374 so said those who watched him at his  
work; I myself  
375 never met him, never saw him; but  
they say he was beyond all others.  
376 Once, indeed, he came to Mycenae —

no war in it —

377 a guest, with godlike Polyneices,  
raising troops:

378 they were then marching on the holy  
walls of Thebes,

379 and they begged us hard to give them  
famed allies;

380 and our people were willing, and  
approved what they asked,

381 but Zeus turned them back with  
unfavorable signs.

382 So they went on their way, and when  
they were well along the road

383 and came to the Asopus, deep in  
rushes, bedded in grass,

384 the Achaeans sent Tydeus forward  
with a message.

385 He went, and found the Cadmeans in  
their numbers

386 feasting through the house of the  
might of Eteocles.  
387 There, stranger though he was, the  
horseman Tydeus  
388 was not afraid, alone among so many  
Cadmeans:  
389 he challenged them to contests, and  
won every one  
390 with ease — such a helper to him was  
Athena.  
391 But the Cadmeans, goaders of horses,  
were angered,  
392 and as he rode back they set a close-  
packed ambush,  
393 fifty young men, with two leaders:  
394 Maeon, Haemon's son, a match for the  
immortals,  
395 and Autophonus' son, Polyphontes  
steadfast in battle.



396 On these too Tydeus let loose an  
unseemly fate:  
397 he killed them all, and sent one man  
alone home —  
398 Maeon he sent off, obeying the gods’  
portents.  
399 Such a man was Tydeus the Aetolian.  
But the son  
400 he fathered is worse than he in battle  
— better in the assembly.”  
401 So he spoke, and strong Diomedes said  
nothing at all,  
402 humbled by the reverend king’s  
rebuke.  
403 But the son of glorious Capaneus  
answered him:  
404 “Son of Atreus, do not lie when you  
know how to speak the truth.<sup>19</sup>  
405 We claim to be far better men than

our fathers:

406 we took the seat of seven-gated  
Thebes,

407 though we led a smaller host beneath  
a stronger wall,

408 because we trusted the gods' portents  
and the help of Zeus;

409 they perished by their own  
recklessness.

410 So never set our fathers in honor  
equal to ours."

411 Glaring at him darkly, strong Diomedes  
answered:

412 "Old friend — sit quiet, and listen to  
my word.20

413 I hold nothing against Agamemnon,  
shepherd of the people,

414 for driving the strong-greaved  
Achaean to fight:

415 the glory will follow him if the  
Achaean  
416 cut down the Trojans and take holy  
Ilion —  
417 and his the great grief if the Achaeans  
are cut down.  
418 Come — let the two of us also  
remember our rushing courage.”  
419 He spoke, and leapt from the chariot  
to the ground in his armor,  
420 and the bronze rang terribly on the  
chest of the lord  
421 as he sprang: fear would have seized  
even a stone-hearted man.  
422 As when on a booming beach the swell  
of the sea  
423 rises, wave on wave, under the West  
Wind’s driving:  
424 out on the deep it first rears its crest,

and then

425 breaking on the land it thunders  
aloud, and around the headlands

426 it arches and comes to a peak and  
spits out the salt foam:

427 so wave on wave the companies of the  
Danaans moved

428 without pause into war; and each  
captain called commands

429 to his own; and the rest went silently  
— you would not think

430 so great a host was following with  
voices in their chests —

431 in silence, fearing their commanders;  
and on all of them

432 the patterned armor shone as they  
marched in order.

433 But the Trojans — as ewes past  
counting stand in the fold

434 of a man of much substance while  
their white milk is drawn,  
435 bleating without cease because they  
hear the voices of their lambs:  
436 so the clamor of the Trojans rose  
through the wide army;  
437 for their speech was not one, their cry  
not a single tongue,  
438 but language mixed with language,  
men called from many lands.  
439 These Ares drove on, and those grey-  
eyed Athena,  
440 and Terror, and Panic, and Strife  
insatiably raging,<sup>21</sup>  
441 sister and companion of man-  
slaughtering Ares —  
442 she who rears her crest small at first,  
but soon  
443 props her head against heaven while

she walks the earth.

444 She then cast common hatred into  
their midst,

445 moving through the crowd, swelling  
the groaning of men.

446 And when they had come together  
into one place,

447 they dashed together shields, and  
spears, and the fury of men

448 armored in bronze; the bossed shields  
449 pressed hard on one another, and a  
great din arose.

450 There rose together the groaning and  
the boasting of men

451 killing and killed, and the earth ran  
with blood.

452 As when winter torrents pouring  
down the mountains

453 hurl together their weight of water at

a meeting of glens

454 out of great springs, deep in a hollow  
ravine,

455 and far off in the mountains a  
shepherd hears the thunder of it:

456 such was the roar and the toil of them  
as they came together.

457 First Antilochus took a Trojan  
armored fighter, 22

458 a brave man among the front-fighters,  
Echepolus, Thalysias' son:

459 he struck him first on the ridge of his  
horsehair helmet,

460 and the bronze point fixed in his  
forehead and drove

461 inside the bone; and darkness covered  
his eyes,

462 and he crashed like a tower in the  
strong encounter.

463 As he fell, the lord Elephenor took  
him by the feet —  
464 Chalcodon's son, chief of the great-  
hearted Abantes —  
465 and dragged him out from under the  
missiles, straining to strip  
466 his armor with all speed. But his effort  
was short-lived:  
467 great-hearted Agenor saw him  
dragging the corpse,  
468 and where his side showed from  
under the shield as he bent,  
469 he stabbed him with the bronze-  
pointed spear, and unstrung his limbs.  
470 So the spirit left him; and over his  
body the work  
471 of Trojans and Achaeans grew grim:  
like wolves  
472 they leapt at one another, and man



tore at man.

473 Then Telamonian Ajax struck  
Anthemion's son,<sup>23</sup>

474 the young man Simoeisios in his  
bloom, whom once his mother

475 bore beside the banks of Simois,  
coming down

476 from Ida, where she had followed her  
parents to see the flocks:

477 for that they called him Simoeisios.

But to his dear parents

478 he never paid back the cost of his  
rearing; his life was short,

479 broken under the spear of great-  
hearted Ajax.

480 For as he came on in the front, Ajax  
struck him in the chest

481 by the right nipple, and straight  
through his shoulder

482 the bronze spear came; and he fell to  
the ground in the dust  
483 like a poplar that has grown up in the  
wet meadow  
484 of a great marsh — smooth, with the  
branches growing  
485 at its very top — and a chariot-maker  
with the bright iron  
486 fells it, to bend a wheel-rim for a  
beautiful car,  
487 and it lies there seasoning along the  
river bank:  
488 such was Anthemion's son Simoeisios,  
whom Ajax  
489 the Zeus-sprung killed. And at him  
Antiphos of the glancing corslet,  
490 Priam's son, cast his sharp spear  
through the crowd:  
491 he missed him, but struck Leucus,

Odysseus' brave companion,  
492 in the groin as he dragged the corpse  
to the other side,  
493 and he collapsed over it, and the body  
fell from his hand.  
494 For his killing Odysseus was enraged  
to the heart,  
495 and he strode through the front-  
fighters helmed in flashing bronze,  
496 and came up very close and cast his  
shining spear,  
497 glancing all around him; and the  
Trojans shrank back  
498 from the man as he cast. He did not  
send the shaft in vain,  
499 but struck Democoon, Priam's bastard  
son,  
500 who had come from Abydos, from the  
fast mares:

501 him Odysseus, enraged for his  
companion, struck with the spear  
502 in the temple, and out through the  
other temple passed  
503 the bronze point; and darkness  
covered his eyes,  
504 and he fell with a thud, and his armor  
clattered upon him.  
505 Then the front-fighters gave ground,  
and glorious Hector too;  
506 and the Argives shouted aloud and  
dragged away the corpses  
507 and pressed far forward. But Apollo  
took offense,  
508 looking down from Pergamos, and  
called aloud to the Trojans:  
509 “Rouse yourselves, horse-taming  
Trojans! Do not yield the fight  
510 to the Argives: their flesh is not stone,

not iron,

511 to hold off the flesh-cutting bronze  
when they are hit.

512 And Achilles, son of lovely-haired  
Thetis, is not

513 fighting: by the ships he digests his  
heart-paining anger.”

514 So spoke the dread god from the city.  
And the Achaeans

515 were urged on by Zeus’s daughter,  
most glorious Tritogeneia, 24

516 moving through the crowd wherever  
she saw them slacken.

517 Then fate shackled Diores,  
Amarynceus’ son:

518 he was struck by a jagged stone beside  
the ankle,

519 in his right shin, and the thrower was  
the captain of the Thracians,

520 Peiroos, Imbrasus' son, who had come  
from Aenus.  
521 Both tendons and the bones the  
shameless stone  
522 crushed utterly; and he fell back in the  
dust,  
523 stretching out both hands to his dear  
companions,  
524 gasping out his life; and the man who  
hit him ran up,  
525 Peiroos, and stabbed him with the  
spear beside the navel; and all  
526 his bowels poured out on the ground,  
and darkness covered his eyes.  
527 But as Peiroos sprang back, Thoas the  
Aetolian struck him  
528 with a spear in the chest above the  
nipple, and the bronze fixed in his lung;  
529 and Thoas came up close, wrenched

the heavy spear

530 out of his chest, and drew his sharp  
sword,

531 and struck him full in the belly, and  
took his life.

532 But he did not strip his armor: his  
companions stood round him,

533 the Thracians with their hair in  
topknots, long spears in their hands,

534 who, big and strong and proud as he  
was,

535 thrust him back from them; and he  
gave ground, staggering.

536 So the two lay stretched in the dust  
beside each other,

537 captains, one of the Thracians, one of  
the bronze-shirted

538 Epeians; and around them many  
others were killed.

539 Then no man could have come and  
made light of the work —25  
540 no man still unhit, unstabbed by the  
sharp bronze,  
541 who whirled through the middle of it,  
with Pallas Athena leading him  
542 by the hand and turning aside the  
rush of missiles:  
543 for many Trojans and Achaeans on  
that day  
544 were stretched face-down in the dust  
beside one another.

## Notes

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### NOTES

1. (4.8) “Hera of Argos and Athena of Alalcomenae” —  
cult titles tying each goddess to a major sanctuary  
(the Argive Heraion; Alalcomenae in Boeotia). Zeus



needles them by their official addresses, like reading their titles off a temple inscription. ↩

2. (4.34-36) “eat Priam raw” — the extremity of hatred in the poem’s idiom; the image recurs at its darkest moments (Achilles to Hector, 22.346-347; Hecuba on Achilles, 24.212). Here it is Zeus’s sardonic measure of Hera’s appetite. ↩
3. (4.51-56) Hera offers Zeus her own three dearest cities — Argos, Sparta, Mycenae, the great centers of her cult — to destroy at his pleasure, as the price of Troy. Aristarchus athetized 55-56 (apparatus, Line 55-56: ath. Ar), where she concedes that resistance would be futile anyway. The bargain frames the war’s resumption as a cold divine transaction; note Zeus’s matching concession at 43, “willingly — with unwilling heart” (ἐκὼν ἀέκοντί γε θυμῷ), the poem’s most compressed oxymoron. ↩
4. (4.101) “Apollo the Lycian-born” (Λυκηγενής) — disputed already in antiquity: “born in Lycia” (Pandarus’s men are Lycians of the Troad) or “wolf-born” (λύκος). The traditional rendering is kept. This is the same Pandarus whose bow “Apollo himself gave” (2.827) — the god of archery presides,

with grim irony, over the poem's most disastrous bowshot. ↩

5. (4.105-111) The bow: horns of a wild ibex Pandarus shot himself, sixteen palms (about four feet) of horn, joined and gold-tipped by a craftsman. The loving technical excursus at the moment of treachery is a signature Homeric effect — the made thing described while its use damns its user. ↩
6. (4.117) Aristarchus athetized this line (“never yet shot, winged, a base of black pains”), as he did 140 and 149 in the same scene (apparatus) — ornamental lines the tradition found dispensable. All are kept as printed. ↩
7. (4.123) “to the bow the iron head” — one of the poem's rare iron weapons: arms in the Iliad are bronze, and iron appears mainly as raw wealth or for tools (the chariot-maker's axe at 485). The arrowhead here and the mace of Areithous (7.141) are the notable exceptions — often taken as glimpses of the poet's own later age. ↩
8. (4.132-138) The arrow passes through three layers: the ζωστήρ (“war-belt,” the outer clasped belt), the doubled corslet, and the μίτρη (“waist-guard,” a bronze-faced apron beneath). These renderings are

fixed for the rest of the translation; the ζῶμα (“loin-guard”) appears at 187. ↩

9. (4.141-147) The ivory simile: a Maeonian or Carian craftswoman staining ivory crimson for a horse’s cheek-piece — a treasure “many horsemen prayed to carry.” Blood on Menelaus’s thighs becomes luxury inlay: the poem’s first great aestheticizing of a wound, and a deliberate shock after the fly-brushing tenderness of 130-131. ↩
10. (4.155) “it was your death I was cutting in those oaths” — the oath-cutting idiom (see Book 3 commentary) turned bitter: Agamemnon hears the ritual he performed as a throat-cutting of his own brother. ↩
11. (4.194, 219) Asclepius is in Homer a mortal hero-physician, taught by Chiron the centaur (the wise counter-image of the beast-men of 1.268) — not yet the god of healing of later cult. His sons Machaon and Podaleirius lead a contingent (2.731-732); Machaon’s treatment — extraction, sucking the wound, herbal dressings — is the poem’s standard battlefield medicine. ↩
12. (4.195-197) These lines recur verbatim at 205-207 when Talthibius delivers the message. Aristarchus

athetized the first occurrence (apparatus, Line 195-197: ath. hic Ar. (= 205-207)) — a doctrinaire application of his dislike of repetition; the messenger-repetition is normal epic technique (cf. Book 2, note [4]). Both passages are translated, identically. ↩

13. (4.223-421) The epipōlēsis (“review”): Agamemnon on foot down the line, praising Idomeneus, the Ajaxes, and Nestor, insulting Menestheus, Odysseus, and Diomedes. The scene is a portrait gallery — and a study of Agamemnon’s leadership, whose goads are as ill-judged as his flatteries are smooth. ↩
14. (4.242) “loud boasters” (ἰόμῳποι) — obscure insult, already opaque in antiquity: perhaps “braggarts with arrows” (fighting from range, not in the line), perhaps just “loudmouths.” The translation keeps the taunt and this note keeps the doubt. ↩
15. (4.297-309) Nestor’s tactics — chariots massed in front, infantry behind, shirkers penned in the middle, with a doctrine of chariot- line fighting “the men before us” used — describe a kind of massed chariot warfare that the poem’s actual battles never show (Homeric chariots are battle-taxis). Either a memory of older warfare or the old man’s

idealization of it; the poem lets Nestor be the keeper of both. ↩

16. (4.320) “the gods never give men everything at once” — athetized by Aristarchus (apparatus; cf. the similar 13.729). Ereuthalion (319) is the club-wielding champion Nestor killed in his youth — the full story is saved for 7.136-156. ↩
17. (4.350) “what a word has escaped the fence of your teeth” (ἔρκος ὀδόντων) — the fixed formula for speech that should have been kept in; always so rendered. ↩
18. (4.370-400) Agamemnon’s Tydeus-tale reaches back to the Theban war: Tydeus and Polyneices recruiting at Mycenae, the embassy to Thebes, the athletic challenges, the fifty-man ambush he wiped out. This is the Iliad’s fullest window on the Theban saga — the great rival epic cycle — deployed, characteristically, as a father held up against a son. “The might of Eteocles” (386) is the same periphrasis pattern as “the might of Heracles” (2.658). ↩
19. (4.404-410) Sthenelus’s retort: the Epigoni — the sons of the Seven — actually took Thebes, which their fathers failed to do and died trying, “by their own recklessness” (ἄτασθαλίῃσιν, the Odyssey’s opening

moral keyword). Aristarchus athetized 407-409 (apparatus, Line 407-409: ath. Ar). Kept: the exchange sets up Diomedes' pointed contrast. ↩

20. (4.412) "Old friend" (τέττα) — an affectionate, untranslatable address found only here. Diomedes silences Sthenelus and absorbs the insult out of respect for the king's office — restraint he will pointedly recall when he answers Agamemnon back at 9.32-49. The moment defines him: youngest of the great captains and the most self-governed. ↩
21. (4.440-443) Terror (Δεῖμος), Panic (Φόβος), and Strife (Ἐρις) — war's demons personified; Strife "small at first" but growing to prop her head on heaven is the ancestor of Virgil's Fama. Her epithet "insatiable" earns itself over the next twenty books. ↩
22. (4.457-462) The first death of the Iliad: Antilochus (Nestor's son) kills Echeolus. The kill establishes the death-formulas this translation keeps fixed from here on: "darkness covered his eyes," "he fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him," "unstrung his limbs," "his spirit left him." Their unvarying recurrence is the poem's own drumbeat and is preserved, never elegantly varied. ↩

23. (4.473-489) Simoeisios: named for the river Simois where his mother bore him, killed in his first bloom, who “never paid back the cost of his rearing” (θρέπτρα — the son’s debt of care to his parents), falling like a poplar cut down to be a chariot’s wheel-rim. The first full pathos-vignette of the battle books: an entire peacetime life conjured at the instant of its ending, the template for the poem’s way of killing men. ↩
24. (4.515) “Tritogeneia” — ancient title of Athena, of unknown meaning even to the ancients (connected variously with lake Tritonis, the river Triton, or “third-born”). Left as a name, like Atrytone (2.157).  
↩
25. (4.539-544) The book closes with an imagined observer led through the carnage by Athena, untouched and turning missiles aside — only under those impossible conditions could a man “make light of the work.” The narrator’s device measures the day: many Trojans and Achaeans “stretched face-down in the dust beside one another.” ↩

# Book 5

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*The aristeia of Diomedes: gods bleed —  
Aphrodite, then Ares himself, wounded by a  
mortal's spear.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 Then it was that Pallas Athena gave  
Tydeus' son<sup>1</sup>
- 2 Diomedes fury and daring, so that he  
might stand out
- 3 among all the Argives and win himself  
high fame.
- 4 She kindled unwearying fire from his  
helmet and shield,
- 5 like the star of late summer that beyond  
all others



6 blazes bright when it rises bathed in  
Ocean:  
7 such was the fire she kindled from his  
head and shoulders,  
8 and she drove him into the middle,  
where the press was thickest.  
9 There was among the Trojans one Dares,  
wealthy, blameless,  
10 a priest of Hephaestus; and he had two  
sons,  
11 Phegeus and Idaeus, skilled in all  
fighting.  
12 These two broke from the line and  
charged him head on,  
13 the two of them from their car, he on  
foot from the ground.  
14 And when they were close, advancing  
on one another,  
15 Phegeus first hurled his long-shadowed

spear:

16 over Tydeus' son's left shoulder the  
spear-point

17 passed, and did not hit him. Second,  
Tydeus' son

18 rose with his bronze; and not in vain  
did the shaft escape his hand:

19 he struck his chest between the  
nipples, and thrust him from the car.

20 Idaeus sprang away, leaving the  
beautiful chariot;

21 he did not dare stand over his slain  
brother —

22 nor would he himself have escaped  
black doom either,

23 but Hephaestus snatched him out and  
saved him, wrapped in night,

24 so that his old priest should not be  
wholly broken with grief.

25 And the son of great-hearted Tydeus  
drove off the horses  
26 and gave them to his companions to  
lead down to the hollow ships.  
27 Now when the great-hearted Trojans  
saw the two sons of Dares,  
28 one fleeing, one killed beside his  
chariot,  
29 the hearts of all were shaken. And  
grey-eyed Athena  
30 took rushing Ares by the hand and  
spoke to him:  
31 “Ares, Ares, bane of mortals, blood-  
stained stormer of walls —3  
32 shall we not leave the Trojans and  
Achaeans  
33 to fight it out, and let father Zeus give  
glory where he will,  
34 while we two withdraw, and keep clear

of the wrath of Zeus?”

35 So speaking she led rushing Ares out of  
the battle,

36 and sat him down on the high bank of  
Scamander.

37 Then the Danaans bent the Trojans  
back; and each of the captains

38 took his man. First the lord of men  
Agamemnon

39 threw great Odios, captain of the  
Halizones, from his chariot:

40 as he turned, first of all, the spear fixed  
in his back

41 between the shoulders and drove  
through his chest;

42 he fell with a thud, and his armor  
clattered upon him.

43 And Idomeneus cut down Phaestus, son  
of Maeonian Borus,

44 who had come from deep-soiled Tarne:  
45 him Idomeneus famed with the spear,  
just as he mounted  
46 behind his horses, stabbed with the  
long spear through the right shoulder;  
47 he crashed from the car, and hateful  
darkness seized him.  
48 And Idomeneus' aides stripped him of  
his armor.  
49 And Scamandrius, son of Strophius, the  
keen hunter,  
50 fell to Atreus' son Menelaus and his  
sharp spear —  
51 a fine huntsman: Artemis herself had  
taught him  
52 to bring down all the wild things the  
mountain forest breeds.  
53 But Artemis who showers arrows was  
no help to him then,<sup>4</sup>

54 nor the long shots in which he once  
excelled;  
55 Atreus' son Menelaus, famed with the  
spear,  
56 stabbed him with the spear in the back  
as he fled before him,  
57 between the shoulders, and drove it  
through his chest;  
58 he crashed face-down, and his armor  
clattered upon him.  
59 And Meriones cut down Phereclus, son  
of Tecton,  
60 Harmon's son, whose hands knew how  
to fashion  
61 all cunning work, for Pallas Athena  
loved him beyond all men;  
62 he was the one who had built for  
Alexandros the balanced ships  
63 that began the evil — a curse to all the

## Trojans<sup>5</sup>

<sup>64</sup> and to himself, since he knew nothing  
of the gods' decrees.

<sup>65</sup> Him Meriones, when he caught him in  
the chase,

<sup>66</sup> struck in the right buttock, and the  
point passed under the bone

<sup>67</sup> straight through into the bladder;

<sup>68</sup> he dropped to his knees with a scream,  
and death enfolded him.

<sup>69</sup> And Meges killed Pedaeus, Antenor's  
son —

<sup>70</sup> bastard-born, but brilliant Theano had  
reared him<sup>6</sup>

<sup>71</sup> with care, like her own dear children, to  
please her husband.

<sup>72</sup> Phyleus' son, famed with the spear,  
came in close

<sup>73</sup> and struck him with the sharp spear in

the tendon of the head;  
74 straight on through the teeth the  
bronze cut under his tongue,  
75 and he crashed in the dust, his teeth  
clenched on cold bronze.  
76 And Eurypylus, Euaemon's son, killed  
brilliant Hypsenor,  
77 son of high-hearted Dolopion, who was  
made  
78 Scamander's priest, and was honored  
by his people like a god:  
79 him Eurypylus, Euaemon's shining son,  
80 running him down as he fled before  
him, struck on the shoulder  
81 with a sweep of his sword, and sheared  
away his heavy arm;  
82 the bloody arm fell in the field; and  
over his eyes



83 came purple death, and fate the  
overpowering.<sup>7</sup>

84 So they labored in the strong  
encounter.

85 But Tydeus' son — you could not have  
told which side he fought on,

86 whether he ran with the Trojans or the  
Achaeans:

87 for he stormed across the plain like a  
river in flood,

88 a winter torrent that scatters the dikes  
in its rushing;

89 the close-built dikes cannot contain it,  
90 nor the walls of the fruitful orchards  
hold it,

91 when it comes suddenly, swollen with  
the rain of Zeus,

92 and everywhere the fine works of  
strong men crash before it:

93 so before Tydeus' son the packed  
companies of the Trojans  
94 were driven, and for all their numbers  
they could not stand him.  
95 But when Lycaon's shining son caught  
sight of him  
96 storming across the plain, driving the  
companies before him,  
97 quickly he bent his curved bow at  
Tydeus' son  
98 and shot him as he charged, striking  
the right shoulder  
99 at the plate of the corslet; the bitter  
arrow flew through  
100 and held straight on, and the corslet  
was spattered with blood.  
101 Over him Lycaon's shining son  
shouted aloud:  
102 "Rouse yourselves, great-hearted

Trojans, goaders of horses!

103 The best of the Achaeans is hit; and I  
say he will not

104 long stand up under the strong shaft  
— if truly it was

105 the lord Apollo, Zeus's son, who sped  
me here from Lycia.”

106 So he spoke in his boasting. But the  
swift shaft did not break him:

107 he drew back and stood before his  
horses and chariot

108 and spoke to Sthenelus, Capaneus'  
son:

109 “Up, good son of Capaneus — get  
down from the chariot,

110 and pull this bitter arrow out of my  
shoulder.”

111 So he spoke, and Sthenelus leapt from  
the car to the ground

112 and stood beside him and drew the  
swift shaft clean through the shoulder,  
113 and the blood came spurting up  
through the supple tunic.  
114 Then Diomedes, good at the war-cry,  
prayed aloud:  
115 “Hear me, child of aegis-bearing Zeus,  
Unwearied one!  
116 If ever with kind intent you stood by  
my father  
117 in the heat of war, now befriend me in  
turn, Athena:  
118 grant me to kill this man — let him  
come in range of my spear —  
119 who shot me before I saw him and now  
boasts of it, and says  
120 I shall not long look on the bright  
light of the sun.”  
121 So he spoke in prayer, and Pallas

Athena heard him.

122 She made his limbs light, the feet and  
the hands above them,

123 and standing close she spoke winged  
words:

124 “Take heart now, Diomedes, and fight  
the Trojans:

125 for into your chest I have put your  
father’s fury,

126 the fearless fury the shield-shaking  
horseman Tydeus had;

127 and I have taken from your eyes the  
mist that was on them before,<sup>8</sup>

128 so that you may know clearly god and  
man alike.

129 Therefore, if some god comes here to  
test you,

130 do not fight face to face with any  
immortal —

131 any of the others; but if Aphrodite,  
Zeus's daughter,  
132 comes into the fighting, wound her  
with the sharp bronze.”  
133 So speaking, grey-eyed Athena went  
her way,  
134 and Tydeus' son went back and mixed  
with the front-fighters;  
135 and eager as his heart had been before  
to fight the Trojans,  
136 now fury three times as great took  
hold of him — like a lion  
137 that a shepherd in the field, guarding  
his woolly sheep,  
138 has grazed as it leapt the fold-wall,  
and not brought down:  
139 he has only roused its strength; and  
after that, no help —  
140 he slips in among the folds, and the

flock panics, abandoned;

141 the sheep are heaped in piles on one  
another,

142 while the lion in its fury leaps the  
deep fold's wall again:

143 so in his fury strong Diomedes mixed  
with the Trojans.

144 There he took Astynous, and  
Hypeiron, shepherd of the people:

145 one he struck above the nipple with  
the bronze-pointed spear;

146 the other he hit with the great sword  
on the collarbone

147 by the shoulder, and sheared the  
shoulder from the neck and back.

148 These he left, and went after Abas and  
Polyidus,

149 sons of Eurydamas, the old reader of  
dreams;

150 but the old man read no dreams for  
them at their going —9  
151 strong Diomedes killed them both.  
152 Then he went after Xanthus and  
Thoon, sons of Phaenops,  
153 both late-born and beloved; and their  
father was worn with hard age,  
154 and had fathered no other son to leave  
over his possessions.  
155 There Diomedes killed them, and took  
the dear life  
156 of both, and left the father  
lamentation and bitter cares:  
157 he never welcomed them home alive  
from the fighting,  
158 and kinsmen of the widowed house  
divided the estate.  
159 Then he took two sons of Priam,  
Dardanus' descendant,



160 Echemmon and Chromius, both in one  
chariot.

161 As a lion leaps in among cattle and  
snaps the neck

162 of a heifer or a cow as they graze the  
woodland,

163 so the son of Tydeus forced them both  
from their horses,

164 hard against their will, and stripped  
their armor;

165 and the horses he gave his  
companions to drive to the ships.

166 Now Aeneas saw him tearing the ranks  
of men apart,

167 and went off through the fighting and  
the clatter of spears

168 searching for godlike Pandarus, if he  
might find him.

169 He found Lycaon's son, blameless and

strong,

170 and stood before him and spoke a  
word to his face:

171 “Pandarus, where are your bow, and  
your winged arrows,

172 and your fame? No man here rivals  
you in it,

173 and no man in Lycia claims to be  
better than you.

174 Come — lift your hands to Zeus, and  
loose a shaft at this man,

175 whoever he is, who is master here,  
who has done the Trojans

176 so much evil already, and unstrung the  
knees of many good men —

177 unless he is some god enraged at the  
Trojans,

178 angry over sacrifices; and a god’s  
wrath is a heavy thing.”

179 Then answered him Lycaon's shining  
son:

180 "Aeneas, counselor of the bronze-  
shirted Trojans,

181 in everything I liken him to the war-  
minded son of Tydeus:

182 I know him by his shield and his  
crested helmet's eye-slits,

183 and by the look of his horses. Yet I  
cannot say for sure he is not a god.

184 But if he is the man I think, the war-  
minded son of Tydeus,

185 then not without a god does he rage  
like this: one of the immortals

186 stands close by him, shoulders  
wrapped in cloud,

187 who turned aside my swift shaft even  
as it reached him.

188 For I have already loosed a shaft at

him, and I hit him

189 in the right shoulder, straight through  
the plate of the corslet;

190 I said to myself I had hurled him down  
to Aïdoneus —

191 and yet I did not break him. Some god  
is angry.

192 And horses I have none, no chariot I  
might mount —

193 though somewhere in Lycaon's halls  
stand eleven chariots,10

194 beautiful, new-built, fresh from the  
maker, with cloths

195 spread over them; and beside each a  
yoked pair of horses

196 stands, champing white barley and  
spelt.

197 Endlessly, as I was leaving, the old  
spearman Lycaon

198 charged me in our well-built house:  
199 he told me to mount horse and chariot  
200 and lead the Trojans in the strong  
encounters.  
201 But I would not listen — it would have  
been far better —  
202 sparing the horses, for fear that in the  
crush of men  
203 they would go short of fodder, they  
who were used to eating their fill.  
204 So I left them, and came on foot to  
Ilion,  
205 trusting my bow — and it was to do  
me no good.  
206 Already I have shot at two of their  
best,  
207 Tydeus' son and Atreus' son, and out  
of both  
208 I drew real blood with my hits — and

only roused them the more.

209 It was a bad fate that made me take  
my curved bow from its peg

210 that day when I led my Trojans to  
lovely Ilion,

211 doing a favor for brilliant Hector.

212 If ever I come home, and set eyes on

213 my fatherland and my wife and my  
great high-roofed house,

214 let some stranger strike my head off  
then and there

215 if I do not break this bow with my  
hands and throw it

216 into the blazing fire. It follows me  
around like wind.”

217 Then Aeneas, captain of the Trojans,  
answered him:

218 “No more of that kind of talk. Nothing  
will change

219 until we two go against this man with  
horses  
220 and chariot and try him in his armor,  
face to face.  
221 Come, get up into my car, and see  
222 what the horses of Tros are like, how  
they know their plain —  
223 how to wheel fast this way and that, in  
pursuit or flight.  
224 They will carry the two of us safe to  
the city, if once again  
225 Zeus hands the glory to Diomedes,  
Tydeus' son.  
226 Come then, take the whip and the  
glossy reins,  
227 and I will dismount to do the fighting;  
or you  
228 face the man yourself, and I will look  
after the horses.”

229 Then answered him Lycaon's shining  
son:

230 "Aeneas, keep the reins yourself, and  
your own two horses.

231 Better they pull the curved car under  
the driver they know,

232 if we should have to run from the son  
of Tydeus.

233 I would not have them take fright and  
stand useless, balking,

234 unwilling to carry us out of the  
fighting, missing your voice,

235 while the son of great-hearted Tydeus  
springs on us

236 and kills the two of us and drives off  
the single-hoofed horses.

237 You drive your own chariot and your  
own horses,

238 and I will take him, when he comes



on, with the sharp spear.”

239 So the two spoke, and mounting the  
patterned chariot

240 they drove the swift horses hard at  
Tydeus’ son.

241 And Sthenelus saw them, Capaneus’  
shining son,

242 and quickly he spoke winged words to  
Tydeus’ son:

243 “Diomedes, Tydeus’ son, delight of my  
heart,

244 I see two strong men bent on fighting  
you,

245 men of measureless power: one the  
master bowman

246 Pandarus — and he claims to be  
Lycaon’s son;

247 the other Aeneas, who claims  
blameless Anchises

248 for father — and his mother is  
Aphrodite.

249 Come, let us give ground on the  
chariot. Stop raging<sup>11</sup>

250 through the front-fighters like this, or  
you may lose your dear life.”

251 Glaring at him darkly, strong  
Diomedes answered:

252 “No talk of flight: I do not think you  
will persuade me.

253 It is not in my blood to dodge a fight

254 or cower down. My fury is still steady  
in me.

255 I balk at mounting the chariot: no —  
just as I am

256 I will go to meet them. Pallas Athena  
forbids me to tremble.

257 As for those two, their swift horses  
will not carry both

258 back out of range of us — even if one  
gets away.

259 And I will tell you another thing — put  
it away in your heart:

260 if Athena of the many counsels grants  
me the glory

261 to kill them both, then you check our  
own swift horses

262 here, and stretch the reins tight to the  
chariot rail,

263 and remember to make a dash for  
Aeneas' horses,

264 and drive them out of the Trojan lines  
to the strong-greaved Achaeans.

265 For they are of that stock which wide-  
seeing Zeus gave Tros<sup>12</sup>

266 in payment for his son Ganymede —  
the best

267 of all horses under the dawn and the

sun;

268 and from that stock the lord of men  
Anchises stole a breed,

269 putting his mares to them without  
Laomedon's knowledge.

270 From these a line of six was born him  
in his halls:

271 four he kept himself and reared at the  
manger,

272 and these two he gave to Aeneas,  
machines of rout.

273 If we could take those two, we would  
win high fame."

274 So the two of them spoke such things  
to one another,

275 and the other two came quickly on,  
driving the swift horses.

276 First Lycaon's shining son called out  
to him:

277 “Hard-hearted, war-minded son of  
proud Tydeus —  
278 so my swift shaft did not break you,  
my bitter arrow.  
279 Now I will try with the spear, and see  
if I hit.”  
280 He spoke, and balancing his long-  
shadowed spear he hurled it  
281 and struck the shield of Tydeus’ son:  
straight through it  
282 the bronze point flew and pressed on  
to the corslet.  
283 Over him Lycaon’s shining son  
shouted aloud:  
284 “You are hit clean through the flank! I  
do not think  
285 you will hold up long now. You have  
given me great glory!”  
286 Unshaken, strong Diomedes answered

him:

287 “A miss, not a hit! But you two, I think,  
will not

288 be done before one or the other of  
you falls

289 and gluts with his blood Ares, the  
fighter under the ox-hide shield.”

290 So speaking he hurled; and Athena  
steered the shaft

291 to the nose beside the eye, and it  
passed the white teeth.

292 The unwearying bronze cut off his  
tongue at the root13

293 and the point came out under the  
base of the chin;

294 he crashed from the car, and his  
armor clattered upon him,

295 glancing-bright, shimmering; and the  
swift-footed horses

396 shied aside; and there his life and  
strength were unstrung.  
397 Then Aeneas sprang down with shield  
and long spear,  
398 fearing the Achaeans might somehow  
drag the corpse away.  
399 He strode around it like a lion sure of  
its strength,  
300 holding before him his spear and the  
shield balanced every way,  
301 set on killing whoever came against  
him,  
302 crying terribly. But Tydeus' son  
caught up a boulder  
303 in his hand — a great feat: two men  
could not carry it,<sup>14</sup>  
304 such as mortals are now; but he  
swung it easily, even alone,  
305 and struck Aeneas with it on the hip,

where the thigh

306 turns in the hip-socket — the cup, as  
men call it:

307 he crushed the cup, and tore both  
tendons through,

308 and the jagged stone stripped the skin  
away. The hero

309 dropped to his knees and stayed  
there, propping himself

310 with one thick hand on the earth; and  
black night covered his eyes.

311 And now the lord of men Aeneas  
would have perished,

312 if Zeus's daughter Aphrodite had not  
been quick to see —

313 his mother, who conceived him to  
Anchises herding cattle.

314 She poured her white arms around her  
dear son,



315 and spread before him a fold of her  
shining robe  
316 to be a screen against missiles, for fear  
some Danaan of the swift colts  
317 might drive bronze into his chest and  
take his life.  
318 So she began to carry her dear son out  
of the fighting.  
319 But the son of Capaneus did not forget  
the orders  
320 that Diomedes, good at the war-cry,  
had laid on him:  
321 he checked their own single-hoofed  
horses  
322 clear of the tumult, stretching the  
reins tight to the rail,  
323 made his dash for the lovely-maned  
horses of Aeneas,  
324 and drove them out of the Trojan lines

to the strong-greaved Achaeans,  
325 and gave them to Deipylus, his dear  
companion, whom he honored  
326 beyond all his agemates because their  
minds ran together,  
327 to drive to the hollow ships. Then the  
hero  
328 mounted his own car and took the  
glossy reins  
329 and drove his strong-hoofed horses  
hard after Tydeus' son,  
330 eagerly. But Diomedes had gone after  
Cypris with the pitiless bronze, 15  
331 knowing her for a god without war-  
strength — none  
332 of those goddesses who lord it in the  
wars of men,  
333 no Athena, no Enyo, sacker of cities.  
334 And when he caught her, chasing

through the thick of the crowd,  
335 the son of great-hearted Tydeus  
lunged  
336 and leaping in stabbed with the sharp  
spear the tip  
337 of her soft hand; and the spear pierced  
the skin straight through  
338 the ambrosial robe the Graces  
themselves had made her,  
339 above the base of the palm. And the  
immortal blood of the goddess ran —  
340 ichor, such as runs in the veins of the  
blessed gods:16  
341 for they eat no bread, they drink no  
gleaming wine,  
342 and so they are bloodless, and are  
called deathless ones.  
343 She gave a great shriek, and flung her  
son from her —

344 and Phoebus Apollo caught him up in  
his arms

345 and hid him in a blue-dark cloud, for  
fear some Danaan of the swift colts

346 might drive bronze into his chest and  
take his life.

347 And over her Diomedes, good at the  
war-cry, shouted aloud:

348 “Give way, daughter of Zeus, from war  
and fighting!

349 Is it not enough that you cozen  
strengthless women?

350 If you must haunt the war, then I  
think

351 war will make you shudder after this,  
even at the rumor of it.”

352 So he spoke; and she went off dazed,  
in terrible pain;

353 and wind-footed Iris took her and led

her out of the crowd

354 crushed with agony, her lovely skin  
darkening.

355 She found rushing Ares seated on the  
battle's left,

356 his spear leaning on a cloud-bank, and  
his swift horses.

357 Dropping to her knees before her dear  
brother

358 she begged and begged him for the  
golden-fronted horses:

359 "Dear brother, take me in — give me  
your horses,

360 so I may reach Olympus, where the  
immortals have their seat.

361 The wound is too much for me — a  
mortal man struck me:

362 Tydeus' son, who would fight father  
Zeus himself now."

363 So she spoke, and Ares gave her the  
golden-fronted horses,  
364 and she climbed into the chariot, her  
dear heart aching,  
365 and Iris climbed in beside her and  
took the reins in her hands  
366 and whipped the horses on; and the  
two flew, nothing loath.  
367 Quickly they came to the gods' seat,  
steep Olympus,  
368 and there swift wind-footed Iris  
halted the horses,  
369 loosed them from the car, and threw  
them ambrosial fodder;  
370 and brilliant Aphrodite fell on the  
knees of Dione,<sup>17</sup>  
371 her mother; and Dione gathered her  
daughter in her arms  
372 and stroked her with her hand, and

spoke a word, and named her:

373 “Who has done this to you, dear child  
— which of the sons of Heaven —

374 so wantonly, as though you had been  
caught doing wrong in the open?”

375 Then answered her laughter-loving  
Aphrodite:

376 “Tydeus’ son wounded me, high-  
hearted Diomedes,

377 because I was carrying my dear son  
out of the fighting —

378 Aeneas, who is far the dearest of all  
things to me.

379 This is no longer the dread din of  
Trojans and Achaeans:

380 now the Danaans are fighting even  
with the immortals.”

381 Then answered her Dione, brilliant  
among goddesses:

382 “Bear up, my child, and endure it,  
grieved though you are.18  
383 Many of us who keep our homes on  
Olympus have endured  
384 things from men, in the hard griefs we  
lay on one another.  
385 Ares endured it, when Otus and strong  
Ephialtes,  
386 the sons of Aloeus, bound him in  
strong bonds:  
387 thirteen months he lay bound in a  
bronze jar,  
388 and Ares the insatiate of war might  
have perished there,  
389 if their stepmother, beautiful  
Eëriboea,  
390 had not brought word to Hermes; and  
Hermes stole Ares out,  
391 worn down already, for the hard bonds



were breaking him.

392 Hera endured it, when the strong son  
of Amphytryon

393 struck her in the right breast with a  
three-barbed arrow;

394 then pain took hold of her too, past all  
comfort.

395 Hades the gigantic endured a swift  
arrow with the rest,

396 when the same man, the son of aegis-  
bearing Zeus,

397 shot him at Pylos among the dead, and  
gave him over to pain:

398 he went to the house of Zeus and high  
Olympus

399 aching at heart, skewered with agony;  
the arrow

400 was driven deep in his massive  
shoulder, and it wore his spirit.

401 Paiëon sprinkled pain-killing drugs  
upon the wound  
402 and healed him: for he was not of  
mortal make.  
403 The hard man, the violent-worker! —  
he cared nothing what outrage he did,  
404 who vexed with his arrows the gods  
who hold Olympus.  
405 And this one — grey-eyed Athena set  
him on you.  
406 The fool: the son of Tydeus does not  
know in his heart  
407 that the man who fights the  
immortals does not live long;  
408 his children do not climb to his knees  
and call him papa<sup>19</sup>  
409 when he comes home from war and  
the dread fighting.  
410 So now let Tydeus' son, for all his

strength,

411 look to it, or a better fighter than you  
may face him,

412 and Aegialeia, Adrastus' watchful-  
minded daughter,

413 wake her whole house from sleep with  
her wailing,

414 mourning the wedded husband of her  
youth, the best of the Achaeans —

415 the strong wife of Diomedes, breaker  
of horses.”

416 She spoke, and with both hands wiped  
the ichor from the arm;

417 the arm was made whole, and the  
heavy pains were eased.

418 But Athena and Hera, looking on,

419 began to provoke Zeus, son of Cronos,  
with needling words;

420 and the goddess grey-eyed Athena led

the talk:

421 “Father Zeus, will you be angry at all  
with me for what I say?

422 It must be that Cypris was coaxing  
some Achaean woman

423 to run off with the Trojans she now so  
wonderfully loves,

424 and stroking that soft-robed Achaean  
woman’s gown,

425 she scratched her slender hand on a  
golden brooch-pin.”

426 So she spoke, and the father of men  
and gods smiled,

427 and he called golden Aphrodite to him  
and said:

428 “Not to you, my child, are given the  
works of war.20

429 No — you attend to the lovely works  
of marriage;

430 all this shall be the business of quick  
Ares and Athena.”

431 So they spoke such things to one  
another.

432 But Diomedes, good at the war-cry,  
sprang at Aeneas,

433 though he well knew Apollo himself  
held his arms above him;

434 he did not stand in awe even of the  
great god, but pressed on,

435 always straining to kill Aeneas and  
strip his famed armor.

436 Three times he sprang at him, raging  
to kill,

437 and three times Apollo beat back his  
shining shield;

438 but when for the fourth time he came  
on like more than man,<sup>21</sup>

439 Apollo the worker-from-afar called

out with a terrible cry:

440 “Think, son of Tydeus — and fall back.

Do not try to think

441 thoughts equal to the gods: never of  
one kind

442 are the race of immortal gods and of  
men who walk the earth.”

443 So he spoke, and Tydeus’ son gave  
back a little way,

444 shunning the wrath of Apollo who  
strikes from afar.

445 And Apollo set Aeneas down apart  
from the crowd

446 in holy Pergamos, where his own  
temple stood;

447 and Leto and Artemis who showers  
arrows

448 healed him in the great inner shrine,  
and made him glorious.

449 But Apollo of the silver bow made a  
phantom,<sup>22</sup>  
450 the very likeness of Aeneas, armor  
and all,  
451 and around the phantom the Trojans  
and brilliant Achaeans  
452 hacked at one another's chests, at the  
round  
453 ox-hide shields and the light fringed  
bucklers.  
454 Then Phoebus Apollo spoke to rushing  
Ares:  
455 "Ares, Ares, bane of mortals, blood-  
stained stormer of walls —  
456 will you not go in and drag this man  
out of the fighting,  
457 this son of Tydeus, who would fight  
father Zeus himself now?  
458 First he wounded Cypris, close in, on

the hand at the wrist;

459 then he charged at me myself, like  
more than man.”

460 So speaking, he sat down on the  
height of Pergamos,

461 and baneful Ares went in among the  
Trojan ranks and roused them,

462 in the likeness of Acamas, swift  
captain of the Thracians,

463 and called to the Zeus-nurtured sons  
of Priam:

464 “You sons of Priam, the king whom  
Zeus sustains,

465 how long will you let your people be  
killed by the Achaeans?

466 Until they are fighting around the  
well-built gates?

467 A man is down whom we honored like  
brilliant Hector —



468 Aeneas, son of great-hearted  
Anchises.

469 Come, let us save our brave  
companion from the tumult!”

470 So speaking he stirred the fury and  
heart of every man.

471 And then Sarpedon raked brilliant  
Hector hard:23

472 “Hector, where has that fury gone that  
you had before?

473 You used to say, I think, that you  
would hold the city without armies,

474 without allies — alone, with your  
sisters’ husbands and your brothers.

475 I cannot see one of them now, cannot  
pick one out:

476 they cower like dogs around a lion.

477 It is we who do the fighting — we,  
your mere allies.

478 I am an ally myself, and I came from  
very far:  
479 far away is Lycia, on the eddying  
Xanthus,  
480 where I left my dear wife and my little  
son,  
481 and great wealth besides, which every  
have-not covets.  
482 Even so I drive my Lycians on, and I  
am eager myself  
483 to fight my man — though there is  
nothing of mine here  
484 for the Achaeans to carry off or drive  
away.  
485 And you just stand there — you do not  
even order  
486 the rest of your people to hold and  
defend their wives.  
487 Take care, or like men caught in the

meshes of an all-catching net

488 you become the prey and spoil of your  
enemies —

489 and they will sack your well-peopled  
city soon.

490 All this should be your care, night and  
day:

491 to beg the captains of your far-famed  
allies

492 to hold on without flinching — and to  
put away hard reproach.”

493 So spoke Sarpedon, and the word bit  
Hector to the heart.

494 At once he leapt in his armor from the  
chariot to the ground,

495 and shaking his two sharp spears went  
everywhere through the army,

496 driving men to fight, and woke the  
dread din of battle.

497 And the Trojans wheeled about and  
stood to face the Achaeans;  
498 and the Argives, massed close,  
awaited them and did not run.  
499 As the wind carries chaff across the  
sacred threshing-floors  
500 when men are winnowing, and tawny-  
haired Demeter  
501 in the driving wind divides the grain  
from the husks,  
502 and the chaff-heaps whiten: so the  
Achaeans then  
503 turned white from above with dust,  
which through their ranks  
504 the horses' hooves beat up to the all-  
bronze sky  
505 as the fighting rejoined; and the  
drivers wheeled them round.  
506 Straight on they carried the fury of

their hands; and rushing Ares  
507 drew night over the battle to help the  
Trojans,  
508 ranging everywhere — carrying out  
the charge  
509 of Phoebus Apollo of the golden  
sword, who had bidden him  
510 wake the Trojans' spirit when he saw  
Pallas Athena  
511 leaving the field: for she was the  
Danaans' helper.  
512 And Apollo himself sent Aeneas out  
from the rich inner shrine  
513 and put fury into the chest of the  
shepherd of the people.  
514 Aeneas took his place among his  
companions; and they rejoiced  
515 to see him come to them alive and  
unhurt

516 and full of brave fury. But they asked  
him nothing:  
517 the other toil would not let them —  
the toil the god of the silver bow  
518 was waking, and Ares bane of mortals,  
and Strife insatiably raging.  
519 And on the other side the two Ajaxes  
and Odysseus and Diomedes  
520 drove the Danaans on to fight; and  
they of themselves  
521 feared neither the Trojans' force nor  
their charges,  
522 but stood fast, like the clouds the son  
of Cronos  
523 halts in windless weather on the  
mountain-tops,  
524 motionless, while the fury of the  
North Wind sleeps, and the other  
525 hard-blowing winds, whose shrill

blasts

526 scatter the shadowing clouds  
whenever they rise:

527 so the Danaans stood the Trojans,  
steady, unfleeing.

528 And Atreus' son ranged through the  
crowd, commanding everywhere:

529 "Friends — be men! Take hold of a  
fighting heart;

530 feel shame before each other in the  
strong encounters.

531 Where men feel shame, more are  
saved than slain;24

532 where they run, no fame rises, and no  
strength."

533 He spoke, and hurled his spear quick,  
and struck a front-rank man,

534 Deicoon, Pergasus' son, companion of  
great-hearted

535 Aeneas — a man the Trojans honored  
like Priam's own children,  
536 for he was quick to fight among the  
foremost.  
537 The lord Agamemnon struck his shield  
with the spear,  
538 and the shield did not stop it: the  
bronze passed clean through  
539 and drove through the war-belt into  
the lower belly;  
540 he fell with a thud, and his armor  
clattered upon him.  
541 Then Aeneas took two of the Danaans'  
best men,  
542 the sons of Diocles, Crethon and  
Orsilochus,  
543 whose father lived in well-built  
Pherae,  
544 rich in substance; his line was from



the river

545 Alpheius, which flows wide through  
the Pylians' land,

546 and the river begot Ortilochus, lord  
over many men,25

547 and Ortilochus fathered great-hearted  
Diocles,

548 and of Diocles were born twin sons,

549 Crethon and Orsilochus, skilled in all  
fighting.

550 These two in their first manhood, on  
the black ships,

551 followed with the Argives to Ilion of  
the fine colts,

552 winning recompense for the sons of  
Atreus, Agamemnon

553 and Menelaus; and there the end of  
death enfolded them both.

554 Like two lions reared by their mother

555 on the mountain peaks, in the thickets  
of deep forest,  
556 that harry the cattle and the fat sheep  
557 and lay waste the steadings of men,  
until they too  
558 are killed at men's hands by the sharp  
bronze:  
559 such were these two, broken under  
the hands of Aeneas,  
560 and they fell like tall fir trees.  
561 And as they fell, Menelaus dear to Ares  
pitied them,  
562 and strode through the front-fighters  
helmed in flashing bronze,  
563 shaking his spear; and Ares whetted  
his fury,  
564 with this thought: that he should go  
down under Aeneas' hands.  
565 But Antilochus saw him, great-hearted

Nestor's son,  
566 and strode through the front-fighters;  
for he feared for the shepherd of the  
people,  
567 lest he suffer harm and cheat them of  
all their labor.  
568 The two were holding out their hands  
and sharp spears  
569 face to face, raging to fight,  
570 when Antilochus came and stood close  
by the shepherd of the people;  
571 and Aeneas did not stand his ground,  
quick fighter though he was,  
572 when he saw two men holding the line  
side by side.  
573 And when they had dragged the  
corpses back to the Achaean host,  
574 they laid the poor pair in their  
companions' arms,

575 and turned themselves, and fought on  
among the foremost.

576 There the two of them took  
Pylaemenes, the equal of Ares, 26

577 captain of the great-hearted  
Paphlagonian shieldmen:

578 him Atreus' son Menelaus, famed with  
the spear,

579 stabbed with the spear as he stood,  
striking through the collarbone;

580 and Antilochus struck Mydon, his  
driver and aide,

581 Atymnius' brave son, just as he  
wheeled the single-hoofed horses —

582 caught his elbow square with a  
boulder; and out of his hands

583 the reins, white with ivory, dropped in  
the dust.

584 Antilochus sprang in and drove his

sword through his temple,  
585 and gasping he pitched from the well-  
made chariot  
586 headfirst in the dust, on his crown  
and shoulders.  
587 A long moment he stood there planted  
— he had struck deep sand —  
588 till his own horses knocked him flat in  
the dust  
589 as Antilochus whipped them, and  
drove them to the Achaean camp.  
590 But Hector marked them across the  
ranks, and charged them  
591 shouting; and with him followed the  
strong companies  
592 of the Trojans; and Ares led them, and  
the lady Enyo —27  
593 she bringing Tumult with her, the  
shameless spirit of carnage,

594 while Ares handled a gigantic spear in  
his fists  
595 and ranged now in front of Hector,  
now behind him.  
596 And seeing him Diomedes, good at the  
war-cry, shuddered.  
597 As a man crossing a great plain stops  
helpless  
598 at a quick-running river flowing down  
to the sea,  
599 sees it seething with foam, and starts  
back and away:  
600 so Tydeus' son now gave ground, and  
said to his people:  
601 "Friends — no wonder we marvel at  
brilliant Hector  
602 as spearman and daring fighter:  
603 beside him always stands some god  
who beats ruin away.

604 There — Ares stands by him now, in  
the likeness of a mortal man.  
605 Keep your faces to the Trojans, and  
give ground  
606 backward; do not rage to fight force  
against force with gods.”  
607 So he spoke; and the Trojans came on  
very close.  
608 There Hector killed two men skilled in  
fighting,  
609 Menesthes and Anchialus, both in one  
chariot.  
610 And as they fell, great Telamonian  
Ajax pitied them,  
611 and came up close and made his stand,  
and cast his shining spear  
612 and struck Amphius, Selagus’ son, who  
in Paesus  
613 lived rich in substance, rich in

grainland; but fate

614 led him to fight as ally for Priam and  
his sons.

615 Telamonian Ajax struck him in the  
war-belt:

616 the long-shadowed spear fixed in the  
lower belly,

617 and he fell with a thud. And glorious  
Ajax ran in

618 to strip his armor; but the Trojans  
rained down spears on him,

619 sharp, glittering; and his shield took  
many.

620 He set his heel on the corpse and  
pulled out

621 his bronze spear; but the rest of the  
fine armor he could not

622 lift from the shoulders: the missiles  
pressed him too hard.



623 And he feared the strong ring of the  
proud Trojans,  
624 who stood over him many and brave  
with spears set,  
625 who, big and strong and proud as he  
was,  
626 thrust him back from them; and he  
gave ground, staggering.  
627 So they labored in the strong  
encounter.  
628 And Tlepolemus, Heracles' son, tall  
and brave,  
629 was driven against godlike Sarpedon  
by fate the overpowering.  
630 And when they were close, advancing  
on one another —  
631 the son and the grandson of Zeus the  
cloud-gatherer —  
632 Tlepolemus spoke to him first:

633 “Sarpedon, counselor of the Lycians —  
what forces you  
634 to cower here, a man who knows  
nothing of battle?  
635 They lie when they call you the son of  
aegis-bearing  
636 Zeus: you fall far short of those men  
637 who were born of Zeus in the  
generations before us —  
638 what they say the might of Heracles  
was,  
639 my own father, bold-hearted, lion-  
spirited!  
640 He came here once for the horses of  
Laomedon, 28  
641 with only six ships and fewer men,  
642 and sacked the city of Ilion, and  
widowed her streets.  
643 But your heart is a coward’s, and your

people are dying away.

644 I do not think you will be any bulwark  
to the Trojans

645 for having come from Lycia — no, not  
if you are very strong —

646 but broken by me you will pass the  
gates of Hades.”

647 Then Sarpedon, captain of the  
Lycians, answered him:

648 “Tlepolemus — yes, that man  
destroyed holy Ilion

649 through the folly of one proud man,  
Laomedon,

650 who paid his good service with a hard  
word

651 and refused the horses he had come so  
far for.

652 But for you, I say your portion here  
from me is slaughter

653 and black doom: broken under my  
spear you will give  
654 the glory to me, and your life to Hades  
of the famed colts.”  
655 So spoke Sarpedon; and Tlepolemus  
lifted his ash spear,  
656 and the two long spears sprang from  
their hands  
657 in the same instant. Sarpedon struck  
him full in the neck,  
658 and the point passed through,  
bringing anguish;  
659 and murky night covered his eyes.  
660 And Tlepolemus’s long spear had  
struck the left thigh:  
661 the point tore through, raging,  
662 and grazed the bone — but his father  
still ward off ruin.  
663 Then his brilliant companions bore

godlike Sarpedon

664 out of the fighting; and the long spear  
dragging from his thigh

665 weighed on him; no one noticed it, no  
one thought

666 in their haste to draw the ash spear  
from his thigh

667 so he might stand: such toil they had  
in tending him.

668 And on the other side the strong-  
greaved Achaeans bore

669 Tlepolemus out of the fighting.  
Brilliant Odysseus marked it,

670 his enduring heart holding, and his  
spirit blazed up;

671 and he weighed it then in his mind  
and heart,

672 whether to press on after the son of  
loud-thundering Zeus

673 or take the lives of more of the Lycian  
rank and file.

674 But it was not fated for great-hearted  
Odysseus

675 to kill the strong son of Zeus with the  
sharp bronze;

676 so Athena turned his fury against the  
mass of the Lycians.

677 There he took Coeranus, and Alastor,  
and Chromius,

678 Alcandrus and Halius and Noëmon  
and Prytanis;

679 and brilliant Odysseus would have  
killed still more Lycians,

680 if great Hector of the flashing helmet  
had not been quick to see.

681 He strode through the front-fighters  
helmed in flashing bronze,

682 bringing terror to the Danaans; and

Sarpedon, Zeus's son,  
683 rejoiced at his coming, and spoke a  
piteous word:  
684 "Son of Priam — do not leave me lying  
here  
685 a prize for the Danaans. Stand over  
me! Afterward, if it must be,  
686 let life leave me in your city — since it  
was not to be  
687 that I should come home to my own  
dear fatherland  
688 and gladden my dear wife and my  
little son."  
689 So he spoke; and Hector of the  
flashing helmet answered him nothing,  
690 but swept past, straining to thrust the  
Argives back  
691 with all speed, and take the lives of  
many.

692 Then his brilliant companions laid  
godlike Sarpedon  
693 under a beautiful oak of aegis-bearing  
Zeus,  
694 and strong Pelagon, who was his dear  
companion,  
695 pushed the ash spear out through his  
thigh;  
696 and his spirit left him, and a mist  
poured down over his eyes.  
697 Then he breathed again: the breath of  
the North Wind29  
698 blowing round him brought back to  
life the spirit he had gasped away.  
699 Meanwhile the Argives, under Ares  
and bronze-helmed Hector,  
700 neither turned and ran for the black  
ships  
701 nor stood up to them in fight, but



always backward

702 they gave ground, once they learned  
Ares was with the Trojans.

703 Whom first, whom last did they strip  
of his arms,30

704 Hector, Priam's son, and brazen Ares?

705 Godlike Teuthras first, and Orestes,  
driver of horses,

706 and Trechus the Aetolian spearman,  
and Oenomaus,

707 and Helenus, Oenops' son, and  
Oresbius of the glancing waist-guard,

708 who lived in Hyle, hoarding his wealth  
with care,

709 on the shore of the Cephisian lake;  
and near him other

710 Boeotians lived, and held a rich  
district of land.

711 Now when the goddess white-armed  
Hera marked the two of them  
712 killing Argives in the strong  
encounter,  
713 at once she spoke winged words to  
Athena:  
714 “Shame! Unwearied one, child of  
aegis-bearing Zeus —  
715 empty, then, was the word we pledged  
to Menelaus,  
716 that he should sack well-walled Ilion  
before returning,  
717 if we let baneful Ares rage on like this.  
718 Come — let the two of us also  
remember our rushing courage.”  
719 So she spoke, and the goddess grey-  
eyed Athena did not disobey.  
720 Hera went to and fro harnessing the  
golden-fronted horses —

721 Hera, eldest goddess, daughter of great  
Cronos;  
722 and Hebe quickly set on the chariot  
the curved wheels,31  
723 bronze, eight-spoked, at the two ends  
of the iron axle.  
724 Their fellow is imperishable gold, and  
over it  
725 bronze tires are fitted, a wonder to  
see;  
726 the naves that circle at either side are  
silver,  
727 and the car is slung on plaited straps  
of gold  
728 and silver, with a double rail running  
round it.  
729 From it the pole ran out, of silver; and  
on its end  
730 she bound the beautiful golden yoke,

and cast on it

731 the beautiful golden breast-straps; and  
under the yoke Hera

732 led the swift-footed horses, hungry  
for strife and the war-cry.

733 And Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing  
Zeus,

734 let fall her soft robe on her father's  
floor,32

735 the many-colored robe she herself had  
made and worked with her hands,

736 and put on the tunic of Zeus the  
cloud-gatherer,

737 and armed herself in his gear for  
tearful war.

738 Around her shoulders she cast the  
tasseled aegis,33

739 terrible, crowned on every side with  
Rout;

740 on it is Strife, on it Valor, on it blood-  
chilling Pursuit,  
741 and on it the Gorgon's head, the dread  
monster's,  
742 dreadful and grim, the portent of  
aegis-bearing Zeus.  
743 On her head she set the golden  
helmet, double-ridged,  
744 four-bossed, fitted with the fighting  
men of a hundred cities.  
745 Into the flaming chariot she stepped,  
and gripped the spear —  
746 heavy, huge, compact — with which  
she breaks the ranks of men,  
747 of heroes, when she of the mighty  
father is angered with them.  
748 And Hera swiftly touched the horses  
with the whip;  
749 and self-moved the gates of heaven

groaned open, kept by the Seasons,<sup>34</sup>  
<sup>750</sup> to whom great heaven and Olympus  
are entrusted,  
<sup>751</sup> to roll the thick cloud aside, or set it  
back.  
<sup>752</sup> There, straight through, they held the  
goaded horses;  
<sup>753</sup> and they found the son of Cronos  
sitting apart from the other gods  
<sup>754</sup> on the topmost peak of many-ridged  
Olympus.  
<sup>755</sup> There the goddess white-armed Hera  
halted the horses  
<sup>756</sup> and questioned Zeus most high, the  
son of Cronos:  
<sup>757</sup> “Father Zeus, have you no anger at  
Ares for these brute works —  
<sup>758</sup> how great a host of the Achaeans he  
has destroyed, and what men,

759 recklessly, in no kind of order? It is  
grief to me; and meanwhile  
760 at their ease Cypris and Apollo of the  
silver bow  
761 enjoy it, having let loose this madman  
who knows no law.  
762 Father Zeus — will you be angry at all  
with me if I  
763 strike Ares a bitter blow and chase  
him out of the fighting?”  
764 Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer:  
765 “Go to it: set the driver of the spoil on  
him — Athena,  
766 who beyond all others is used to  
bringing him hard pain.”  
767 So he spoke, and the goddess white-  
armed Hera did not disobey.  
768 She whipped the horses on; and the

two flew, nothing loath,  
769 between the earth and the starry sky.  
770 As far as a man can see into the haze  
with his eyes,35  
771 sitting on a lookout, gazing over the  
wine-dark sea,  
772 so far at a single bound spring the  
gods' high-neighing horses.  
773 And when they came to Troy and the  
two flowing rivers,  
774 where Simois and Scamander join  
their streams,  
775 there the goddess white-armed Hera  
halted the horses,  
776 loosed them from the car, and poured  
thick mist around them;  
777 and Simois made ambrosia spring up  
for them to graze.  
778 And the two went with steps like shy



doves' in their gait,  
779 hot to bring help to the Argive men.  
780 And when they came to where the  
most and the best of them  
781 stood packed around the might of  
Diomedes, breaker of horses,  
782 like lions that eat flesh raw  
783 or wild boars, whose strength does  
not give out,  
784 there the goddess white-armed Hera  
stood and shouted,  
785 in the likeness of great-hearted  
Stentor of the bronze voice,<sup>36</sup>  
786 whose shout was as loud as fifty other  
men's:  
787 "Shame, Argives! Vile disgraces —  
admired only for your looks!  
788 While brilliant Achilles still came out  
to war,<sup>37</sup>

789 the Trojans never ventured past the  
Dardanian gates:  
790 they feared his massive spear too  
much.  
791 Now they fight far from the city, at the  
hollow ships.”  
792 So speaking she stirred the fury and  
heart of every man.  
793 And the goddess grey-eyed Athena  
sprang to Tydeus’ son.  
794 She found that lord beside his horses  
and chariot,  
795 cooling the wound Pandarus’s arrow  
had made.  
796 For the sweat was wearing him under  
the broad strap  
797 of his round shield — it wore him, and  
his arm was tired;  
798 he was lifting the strap and wiping off

the dark-clouded blood.

799 The goddess laid her hand on his  
horses' yoke and spoke:

800 "Little like himself, the son Tydeus  
got!<sup>38</sup>

801 Tydeus was a small man in build — but  
a fighter.

802 Even that time I would not let him  
fight

803 or flash to the front — when he came  
apart from the Achaeans

804 as a messenger to Thebes, among the  
Cadmeans in their numbers,

805 and I told him to feast in their halls at  
his ease —

806 even then, keeping that strong heart  
of his, as always,

807 he challenged the young Cadmean  
men, and won everything

808 with ease: such a helper was I to him.

809 And you — here I stand beside you,  
and guard you,

810 and bid you with good will: fight the  
Trojans!

811 But either the weariness of many  
charges has soaked your limbs,

812 or some spiritless fear is holding you.  
Then you are no

813 son of Tydeus, the war-minded son of  
Oeneus' line."

814 Answering her spoke strong  
Diomedes:

815 "I know you, goddess, daughter of  
aegis-bearing Zeus;

816 so I will tell you my word freely, and  
hide nothing.

817 No spiritless fear is holding me, no  
hanging back:

818 I am still keeping the commands you  
laid on me yourself.

819 You would not let me fight face to face  
with the blessed gods —

820 the others; but if Aphrodite, Zeus's  
daughter,

821 came into the fighting, her I might  
wound with the sharp bronze.

822 That is why I now give ground myself,  
and why I ordered

823 all the other Argives to fall in here  
around me:

824 for I know it is Ares who is lording it  
over the battle.”

825 Then answered him the goddess grey-  
eyed Athena:

826 “Diomedes, Tydeus' son, delight of my  
heart —

827 no: fear neither Ares for that, nor any

other

828 of the immortals: such a helper am I  
to you.

829 Come — at Ares first! Drive the single-  
hoofed horses at him

830 and strike him at close quarters. No  
awe of rushing Ares —

831 that raving thing, that made evil, that  
turncoat,

832 who just now stood promising me and  
Hera to his face

833 that he would fight the Trojans and  
help the Argives —

834 and now he runs with the Trojans,  
and has forgotten all of it.”

835 So speaking she pushed Sthenelus  
back off the chariot,

836 hauling him with her hand — and he  
leapt down smartly —

837 and the goddess mounted the car  
beside brilliant Diomedes,  
838 blazing for the fight; and the  
beechwood axle groaned aloud39  
839 under the weight: it carried a dread  
goddess, and the best of men.  
840 Pallas Athena took up the whip and  
the reins,  
841 and at Ares first she drove the single-  
hoofed horses.  
842 He was in the act of stripping gigantic  
Periphas,  
843 far the best of the Aetolians, Ochesius'  
shining son —  
844 blood-stained Ares was stripping him.  
And Athena  
845 put on the helmet of Hades, so that  
massive Ares should not see her.40  
846 But when Ares, bane of mortals, saw

brilliant Diomedes,  
847 he let gigantic Periphas lie where he  
was,  
848 there where he had first killed him  
and taken his life,  
849 and made straight for Diomedes,  
breaker of horses.  
850 And when they were close, advancing  
on one another,  
851 Ares lunged first, over the yoke and  
the horses' reins,  
852 with his bronze spear, raging to take  
his life;  
853 but the goddess grey-eyed Athena  
caught it in her hand  
854 and thrust it up over the car to spend  
itself on air.  
855 Second, Diomedes, good at the war-  
cry, drove in



856 with his bronze spear; and Pallas  
Athena rammed it home  
857 into the lowest belly, where the waist-  
guard girded him:  
858 there he stabbed and struck, and tore  
the fair flesh open,  
859 and wrenched the spear out again.  
And brazen Ares bellowed  
860 as loud as nine thousand men, or ten  
thousand,41  
861 cry out in war when they join the  
strife of the war-god.  
862 And trembling took hold of Achaeans  
and Trojans alike  
863 in their fear: so loud was the bellow of  
Ares insatiate of war.  
864 As dark air shows out of clouds  
865 when after heat a foul stormwind  
rises,

866 so brazen Ares showed to Diomedes,  
Tydeus' son,  
867 as he went up with the clouds into the  
wide sky.  
868 Swiftly he came to the gods' seat,  
steep Olympus,  
869 and sat down beside Zeus, son of  
Cronos, aching at heart,  
870 and showed the immortal blood  
running down from the wound,  
871 and whimpering he spoke winged  
words:  
872 "Father Zeus, have you no anger,  
seeing these brute works?  
873 Always we gods endure the most  
shuddering pains  
874 by one another's devices, when we  
bring favor to men.  
875 And with you we are all at war: for you

fathered the mad,

876 accursed girl whose mind is forever  
on lawless deeds.

877 All the other gods on Olympus

878 obey you; each one of us is subject to  
you;

879 but her you never check by word or  
deed —

880 you let her run, because you bore this  
destroying child yourself.

881 Now she has set the son of Tydeus,  
overweening Diomedes,

882 raging against the immortal gods.

883 First he wounded Cypris, close in, on  
the hand at the wrist;

884 then he charged at me — at me! — like  
more than man.

885 My quick feet carried me out of it;  
otherwise I should long

886 be suffering agonies there among the  
ghastly heaps of dead,  
887 or living strengthless from the strokes  
of the bronze.”  
888 Glaring at him darkly, Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer answered:  
889 “Do not sit beside me and whimper,  
turncoat.<sup>42</sup>  
890 Most hateful to me are you of all the  
gods who hold Olympus:  
891 strife is always dear to you, and wars,  
and battles.  
892 You have your mother Hera’s temper  
— unbearable,  
893 past yielding; I can scarcely break her  
with words;  
894 and so I think it is by her promptings  
you suffer this.  
895 Still, I will not bear to see you long in

pain:

896 you are of my stock; your mother bore  
you to me.

897 But had you been born so destroying  
from any other god,

898 long since you would have lain lower  
than the sons of Uranus.”

899 So he spoke, and told Paiëon to heal  
him;

900 and Paiëon sprinkled pain-killing  
drugs upon the wound

901 and healed him: for he was not of  
mortal make.

902 As when fig-juice thickens the white  
milk at a stir,<sup>43</sup>

903 liquid before, and it curdles fast as a  
man turns it,

904 so quickly he healed rushing Ares.

905 And Hebe bathed him and dressed

him in graceful clothing,

906 and he sat down beside Zeus, son of  
Cronos, exulting in his glory.

907 And the two came back to the house  
of great Zeus —

908 Hera of Argos and Athena of  
Alalcomenae —

909 having stopped the bane of mortals  
from his slaughter of men.

## Notes

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### NOTES

1. (5.1-8) The poem's first *aristeia* — a single hero's sustained blaze of supremacy — opens with literal blaze: Athena kindles fire from Diomedes' armor, like "the star of late summer" (Sirius, whose rising brings fever-heat; the same star will light Achilles in Book 22). The scene-type recurs for Agamemnon

(11), Patroclus (16), and Achilles (19-22); it will not be re-footnoted. ↩

2. (5.9-24) The book's first vignette is a priest's sons — and Hephaestus saves the survivor “so that his old priest should not be wholly broken with grief.” A god honoring his priest's grief is the Chryses situation of Book 1 in miniature, here granted mercy. ↩
3. (5.31) “Ares, Ares, bane of mortals, blood-stained stormer of walls” (Ἄρες Ἄρες βροτολοιγὲ μαιφόνε τευχέσιπλῆτα) — the famous triple invocation; repeated verbatim by Apollo at 455. The epithets are now fixed: βροτολοιγός “bane of mortals,” μαιφόνος “blood-stained,” θοῦρος “rushing,” χάλκεος “brazen.” ↩
4. (5.51-54) “Artemis herself had taught him... But Artemis was no help to him then” — the recurring pathos-pattern of the divine gift that fails its owner at the killing moment (cf. the seer's sons at 148-151, whose father “read no dreams for them at their going”). ↩
5. (5.59-64) Phereclus, the shipwright who built Paris's ships “that began the evil” (ἀρχεκάκους) — the craftsman of the war's first cause, loved by Athena, killed in her war. His genealogy is a craft-pedigree:

son of Tecton (“Carpenter”), Harmon’s son (“Joiner”). Aristarchus athetized 64 (apparatus). ↩

6. (5.69-71) Theano — Antenor’s wife and (in Book 6) priestess of Athena in Troy — reared her husband’s bastard “like her own dear children, to please her husband”: a one-line window into the social workings of concubinage and legitimacy in the poem’s households. ↩
7. (5.82-83) “over his eyes closed purple death, and fate the overpowering” — the grandest of the death-formulas, reserved for moments of special weight; πορφύρεος is the dark surge-color of a swelling sea. Fixed rendering hereafter. ↩
8. (5.127-132) Athena lifts the mist so Diomedes can tell god from man, and issues the standing order that structures the whole book: fight no immortal — except Aphrodite. His exact obedience (he yields to Apollo at 443, cites the order verbatim at 815-824) is what marks his god-fighting as sanctioned service rather than hybris — until she herself revokes the order at 825-834. ↩
9. (5.148-151) Eurydamas “read no dreams for them at their going” — the dream-interpreter who could not



(or did not) read his own sons' deaths; the same irony as note [4], sharpened to a profession. ↩

10. (5.192-216) Pandarus's self-revelation: eleven new chariots at home under dust-cloths, the father's advice refused, the horses spared their fodder — thrift and half-measures, ending in the bowman's curse on his own bow. The poem gives the truce-breaker of Book 4 a small-souled domestic interior just before killing him. ↩
11. (5.249-250) Zenodotus athetized Sthenelus's counsel of retreat (apparatus, Line 249-250: ath. Zen.) — perhaps as unworthy of a hero. Kept: the exchange sets up Diomedes' refusal ("It is not in my blood," 253) and the horse-raid plan. ↩
12. (5.265-272) The horses of Tros: Zeus's compensation to the mortal father for carrying off Ganymede — the poem's matter-of-fact note that gods pay for what they take. Anchises' stealth breeding from Laomedon's stock supplies Aeneas's team; their theft at 323-327 re-enacts the pedigree. ↩
13. (5.290-296) Athena steers the spear through Pandarus's mouth, severing "his tongue at the root": the oath-breaker and boaster of Book 4 is killed

through the organ of his boasting. The poem does not say “poetic justice”; it merely aims the spear. ↩

14. (5.302-304) “two men could not carry it, such as mortals are now” (οἷοι νῦν βροτοί εἰσι) — first occurrence of the diminished-present formula: the narrator measures his heroes against his own lesser age. It recurs at 12.383, 12.449, 20.287. ↩
15. (5.330) “Cypris” (Κύπρις) — Aphrodite’s cult-name from Cyprus, used in the Iliad only in this book (330, 422, 458, 760, 883). Kept as the name wherever the Greek uses it. ↩
16. (5.339-342) Ichor: the poem invents divine hematology on the spot — gods bleed a different fluid because “they eat no bread, they drink no gleaming wine.” Wounded, a god is proved bloodless and deathless at once; the theology is delivered as physiology. ↩
17. (5.370-371) Dione — Aphrodite’s mother here, otherwise almost absent from Greek epic; in Hesiod Aphrodite is born of the sea-foam from Uranus’s severed flesh, motherless. The Iliad’s genealogy makes her a daughter of Zeus with a mother whose name is the feminine of Zeus (Diōnē ~ Dios). At Dodona, Dione was worshipped as Zeus’s consort. ↩

18. (5.382-404) Dione's consolation-catalogue — mortals have wounded gods before: Ares chained thirteen months in a bronze jar by the giant twins Otus and Ephialtes; Hera shot in the breast and Hades shot "at Pylos among the dead" by Heracles. These are shards of older, wilder myth preserved nowhere else; "at Pylos" was already disputed in antiquity (the town? or "at the gate" — πύλῳ — of the dead?). Paiëon, the gods' own healer (distinct from Apollo in this poem), closes the paradigm — and will be needed again at 899. Consolation-by-precedent ("others have endured; endure") is the poem's standard comfort, used on gods exactly as on men. ↩
19. (5.406-415) Dione's veiled prophecy: the god-fighter "does not live long; his children do not climb to his knees and call him papa" — with Diomedes' wife Aegialeia imagined waking the house with her mourning. The Iliad lets the warning hang unfulfilled (Diomedes survives the poem); later tradition made Aegialeia faithless on his return — a grim afterlife for Aphrodite's grudge that the poem does not know or does not say. ↩
20. (5.428-430) "Not to you, my child, are given the works of war" — Zeus's gentle, smiling demarcation of

spheres; among the most quoted lines of the poem in antiquity (Cicero renders it in Latin, *apparatus at* Line 428). The smile, and the fact that it is Aphrodite's only wound in the poem, keep the scene comedy. ↩

21. (5.436-442) Three times he charged — the fourth time “like more than man” (δαίμονι ἴσος) — and the god's warning: “never of one kind / are the race of immortal gods and of men who walk the earth.” The poem's theology in a couplet, and the planting of its most fateful rhythm: the same three-then-fourth pattern, with the same phrase, will kill Patroclus at the hands of this same god (16.702-711, 784-793). ↩
22. (5.449-453) The *eidōlon*: Apollo fashions a phantom Aeneas, and both armies fight over an image while the man heals in the temple. The poem's first phantom — a device more at home in the *Odyssey* and in later Helen-legend — dropped here without comment. ↩
23. (5.471-492) Sarpedon's rebuke of Hector: the great statement of the ally's claim — “It is we who do the fighting — we, your mere allies,” from a man with nothing at stake here, whose wife and little son wait in Lycia. It is the seed of his famous speech on why

kings must fight (12.310-328), and the wife and son return in his death-scene (16.431-461). First full appearance of the poem's noblest Trojan-side figure.



24. (5.529-532) “Where men feel shame, more are saved than slain” — Agamemnon’s couplet on αἰδώς, the battlefield ethic of mutual shame that holds lines together; quoted and reused throughout antiquity as the classic statement of shame-culture soldiering (it recurs at 15.561-564). ↩
25. (5.541-549) The twins Crethon and Orsilochus, with the river Alpheius three generations back — note the grandfather Ortilochus and grandson Orsilochus: the printed text itself varies the name’s spelling across one genealogy (Zenodotus regularized both to Ortilochus; apparatus, Lines 542-549). Translated as printed, variation and all. ↩
26. (5.576-579) Pylaemenes, the Paphlagonian captain, is killed here by Menelaus — and at 13.658-659 he will walk, alive and weeping, behind his own son’s corpse: the most famous continuity slip in the Iliad, noticed since antiquity (“even Homer nods” is Horace’s phrase for it). The translation of course leaves both passages as they stand. ↩

27. (5.592-593) Enyo, war-goddess (“sacker of cities,” 333), leading with Ares and carrying Tumult (Κυδοιμός), “the shameless spirit of carnage” — the war-demons of 4.440-443 gaining a new member. Personifications capitalized, per convention. ↩
28. (5.638-651) Heracles’ sack of Troy, one generation before this war: Laomedon (Priam’s father) promised divine horses for the rescue of his daughter Hesione and cheated the hero of his wage; six ships sufficed. The story — Troy already once destroyed for a Laomedon’s bad faith — shadows the present war with precedent; the poem glances at it again at 7.452-453 and 21.441-457. ↩
29. (5.696-698) Sarpedon’s swoon: “his spirit left him... then he breathed again” — ψυχή here is literally breath, gasped out and blown back by the North Wind. The physiology of the Homeric soul, caught in the act of almost leaving. ↩
30. (5.703-704) “Whom first, whom last did they strip of his arms...?” — the narrator’s roll-call question, first occurrence; a formula for the turning tide, reused at 8.273, 11.299, 16.692 (there addressed, devastatingly, to Patroclus himself). ↩

31. (5.722-732) Hebe assembles the chariot of the gods — eight-spoked bronze wheels on an iron axle, gold felloes, bronze tires, silver naves and pole — the poem's most loving machine-description, in present tenses, as of divine property that simply is. Hebe ("Youth"), cupbearer of Book 4, here shows a mechanic's hands; at 905 she bathes Ares. The Seasons (749) mind the gates. ↩
32. (5.734-735) Athena "let fall her soft robe on her father's floor, the many-colored robe she herself had made" — the goddess of weaving strips her own handiwork to put on her father's tunic for war. Zenodotus athetized the couplet (apparatus, Line 734-735); kept — the gesture is the whole meaning. ↩
33. (5.738-744) The aegis unfurled — its fullest description: crowned with Rout, set with Strife, Valor, blood-chilling Pursuit, and the Gorgon's head, "the portent of aegis-bearing Zeus" (cf. 2.447-449 for its golden tassels). The golden helmet "fitted with the fighting men of a hundred cities" (744) was obscure already in antiquity — big enough for the armies of a hundred cities, or adorned with them in relief; the translation keeps the strangeness. ↩

34. (5.749-751) The gates of heaven, “self-moved,” groan open — kept by the Seasons (Ἵραι), doorkeepers whose “gate” is the thick cloud they roll aside or set back. Sky-weather as divine architecture. ↩
35. (5.770-772) The horizon-leap: as far as a watchman on a headland can see into the haze over the wine-dark sea, so far the divine horses clear at a single bound. Longinus quotes the lines (On the Sublime 9.5) as the measure of Homeric grandeur — “the universe is not big enough for their second stride”; the apparatus records the citation at Line 772. ↩
36. (5.785-786) Stentor of the bronze voice, “as loud as fifty other men” — the origin of “stentorian.” Only here in the poem; ancient scholars knew further verses about him (apparatus at 2.609 mentions them): a famous figure of whom the Iliad keeps only the shout. ↩
37. (5.788-791) Hera’s taunt measures the plot: while Achilles fought, the Trojans never left their gates; now they fight at the ships. The absent hero is the book’s invisible unit of measure — the same arithmetic Achilles himself will state at 9.352-355. (Echo note.) ↩



38. (5.800-813) Athena retells the Tydeus embassy — the same story Agamemnon told at 4.370-400 as a goad, now told by the goddess who was there (“such a helper was I to him”), with the detail that she had forbidden Tydeus to fight and been disobeyed with impunity. The father’s licensed recklessness frames the son’s licensed obedience: Diomedes’ defense (818-824) is that he was following her orders exactly. (Echo note.) ↩
39. (5.838-839) “the beechwood axle groaned aloud under the weight: it carried a dread goddess, and the best of men.” Aristarchus athetized the couplet (apparatus, Line 838-839) — divine weight straining mortal carpentry was evidently too physical for him. Kept: it is the book’s theology of embodied gods in one image. ↩
40. (5.844-845) The helmet of Hades — the cap of invisibility (Hades’ name was heard as “the Unseen One”): Athena puts it on so that Ares cannot see her, god blinding god. Only here in Homer; later myth gives it to Perseus. ↩
41. (5.859-863) The wounded Ares bellows “as loud as nine thousand men, or ten thousand... in war” — the war-god’s pain measured in the units of his own

element. Both armies tremble at a sound they cannot place. ↩

42. (5.888-898) Zeus to Ares: “Most hateful to me are you of all the gods who hold Olympus: strife is always dear to you, and wars, and battles” — repeating verbatim Agamemnon’s words to Achilles at 1.176-177. The poem’s supreme father passes on a mortal king’s rebuke, god-scale: the quarrel of Book 1 was a theomachy in miniature, and this theomachy is a family quarrel. “Turncoat” (ἄλλοπρόσαλλος, 831, 889) — Ares’ new epithet, “the one who leaps to either side.” And the threat: born of any other god, Ares would lie “lower than the sons of Uranus” — beneath the imprisoned Titans, in the pit below Tartarus. (Echo note.) ↩

43. (5.899-906) Paiëon heals the war-god, and the simile is from the dairy: as fig-juice curdles milk, the wound knits — the homeliest image in the poem laid against divine flesh. Hebe bathes him, and he sits by Zeus “exulting in his glory” — a line repeated from 1.405 (of Briareus), and athetized here by Aristarchus for that reason (apparatus, Line 906). The unrepentant swagger of the freshly healed is, either way, perfect Ares. ↩

# Book 6

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*Hector in Troy: Glaucus and Diomedes trade armor on the field; Hector and Andromache at the Scaean Gates.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 So the dread din of Trojans and  
Achaean was left to itself;
- 2 and this way and that the battle swayed  
across the plain
- 3 as they aimed their bronze-pointed  
spears at one another,
- 4 midway between the streams of Simois  
and Xanthus.
- 5 Ajax first, Telamon's son, wall of the  
Achaean,

6 broke a Trojan company and made light  
for his companions,  
7 striking the man who was best among  
the Thracians,  
8 Acamas, Eussorus' son, tall and brave.  
9 He struck him first on the ridge of his  
horsehair helmet,  
10 and the bronze point fixed in his  
forehead and drove  
11 inside the bone; and darkness covered  
his eyes.  
12 And Diomedes, good at the war-cry,  
killed Axylus,  
13 Teuthras' son, who lived in well-built  
Arisbe,  
14 a man rich in substance, and a friend to  
all mankind:1  
15 living in his house by the road, he  
welcomed all comers.

16 But not one of them stood before him  
then to beat off wretched destruction,  
17 meeting the enemy for him; Diomedes  
took the life of both,  
18 the man himself and his aide Calesius,  
who was then  
19 his charioteer; and the two of them  
went under the earth.  
20 And Euryalus killed Dresus and  
Opheltius,  
21 and went after Aesepus and Pedasus,  
whom once the water-nymph  
22 Abarbarea bore to blameless Bucolion.  
23 Bucolion was proud Laomedon's son,<sup>2</sup>  
24 eldest born, though his mother bore  
him in darkness:  
25 shepherding his flocks he lay with the  
nymph in love,  
26 and she conceived, and bore him twin

sons —

27 and Mecisteus' son unstrung the  
strength and the shining limbs

28 of both, and stripped the armor from  
their shoulders.

29 And Polypoetes steadfast in battle  
killed Astyalus;

30 and Odysseus cut down Pidytes of  
Percote

31 with his bronze spear, and Teucer  
brilliant Aretaon.

32 Antilochus, Nestor's son, took Ablerus  
with his shining spear,

33 and the lord of men Agamemnon took  
Elatius,

34 who lived by the banks of fair-flowing  
Satnioeis

35 in steep Pedasus. And the hero Leïtus  
caught Phylacus

36 as he ran; and Eurypylus cut down  
Melanthius.

37 Then Menelaus, good at the war-cry,  
took Adrestus

38 alive: for his two horses, bolting across  
the plain,

39 fouled in a tamarisk branch, snapped  
the curved chariot

40 at the pole's tip, and themselves ran on  
41 toward the city, where the rest were  
bolting in panic,

42 while he rolled from the car beside the  
wheel,

43 face-down in the dust on his mouth.  
And beside him stood

44 Atreus' son Menelaus, holding his long-  
shadowed spear.

45 Then Adrestus clasped his knees and  
begged him:

46 “Take me alive, son of Atreus — and  
take a worthy ransom.  
47 Many treasures lie stored in my rich  
father’s house,  
48 bronze, and gold, and iron worked with  
much labor:  
49 out of these my father would gladden  
you with ransom past counting  
50 if he learned I was alive by the ships of  
the Achaeans.”  
51 So he spoke, and was moving the heart  
in his chest;  
52 and soon he would have given him to  
his aide to lead down  
53 to the Achaeans’ swift ships. But  
Agamemnon  
54 came running to meet him, and cried  
out his word:  
55 “Soft-hearted Menelaus! Why do you



care so tenderly

56 for men? Were such fine things done in  
your house

57 by Trojans? Let not one of them escape  
sheer destruction

58 and our hands — not even the boy his  
mother carries

59 in her womb, not even he: let all of  
them together

60 perish out of Ilion, unmourned, and  
leave no trace.”

61 So speaking the hero turned his  
brother’s mind,

62 for his urging was of things due; and  
Menelaus pushed<sup>3</sup>

63 the hero Adrestus back with his hand,  
and the lord Agamemnon

64 stabbed him in the flank; he doubled  
over, and Atreus’ son

65 set a heel on his chest and pulled out  
the ash spear.

66 Then Nestor called to the Argives with  
a far-carrying shout:

67 “Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of  
Ares —

68 let no man now hang back for spoils,  
69 to reach the ships carrying the biggest  
load:

70 let us kill men. Afterward, at your ease,  
71 you will strip the corpses dead across  
the plain.”

72 So speaking he stirred the fury and  
heart of every man.

73 Then once more the Trojans, under the  
Achaeans dear to Ares,

74 would have climbed back into Ilion,  
broken by their own cowardice,

75 had not Helenus, Priam’s son, far the

best of bird-readers,<sup>4</sup>

<sup>76</sup> come and stood by Aeneas and Hector:

<sup>77</sup> “Aeneas and Hector — since on you two  
above all rests

<sup>78</sup> the labor of the Trojans and Lycians,  
because for every venture

<sup>79</sup> you are the best men, for fighting and  
for counsel:

<sup>80</sup> make your stand here; go everywhere  
and hold the army

<sup>81</sup> before the gates, before they run and  
fall

<sup>82</sup> into their women’s arms, and become a  
joy to our enemies.

<sup>83</sup> Then, when you have set all the  
companies moving,

<sup>84</sup> we will hold here and fight the  
Danaans,

<sup>85</sup> hard-pressed though we are: necessity

drives.

86 But you, Hector — go to the city, and  
speak there

87 to your mother and mine: let her  
gather the older women

88 at grey-eyed Athena's temple on the  
city's height,

89 and open with her key the doors of the  
holy house,

90 and the robe that seems to her the  
loveliest and amplest

91 in the hall, and far the dearest to  
herself,

92 let her lay it on the knees of lovely-  
haired Athena,5

93 and vow to sacrifice to her in the  
temple twelve heifers,

94 yearlings, never goaded, if she will pity

95 the town, and the Trojans' wives, and

their little children —

96 if she will hold back Tydeus' son from  
holy Ilion,

97 that wild spearman, that strong  
machine of rout,

98 who I say has proved the strongest of  
the Achaeans.

99 Not even Achilles, that leader of men,  
ever made us fear so,

100 who they say was born of a goddess;  
but this man

101 rages beyond measure, and no one can  
match his fury.”

102 So he spoke, and Hector did not  
disobey his brother.

103 At once he leapt in his armor from the  
chariot to the ground,

104 and shaking his two sharp spears went  
everywhere through the army,

105 driving men to fight, and woke the  
dread din of battle.

106 And they wheeled about and stood to  
face the Achaeans;

107 and the Argives gave ground and left  
off their killing:

108 they thought some immortal had  
come down from the starry sky

109 to stand by the Trojans, so suddenly  
they wheeled.

110 And Hector called to the Trojans with  
a far-carrying shout:

111 “High-hearted Trojans, and you far-  
famed allies —

112 be men, my friends; remember your  
rushing courage,

113 while I go up to Ilion and tell

114 the elders of the council and our wives

115 to pray to the divine ones, and vow

them hecatombs.”

116 So speaking Hector of the flashing  
helmet went;

117 and against his ankles and his neck the  
black oxhide beat,

118 the rim that ran outermost on his  
bossed shield.

119 Now Glaucus, Hippolochus’ son, and  
Tydeus’ son<sup>6</sup>

120 came together in the space between,  
raging to fight.

121 And when they were close, advancing  
on one another,

122 Diomedes, good at the war-cry, spoke  
to him first:

123 “Who are you, brave friend, of mortal  
men?

124 I have never seen you in the battle  
where men win glory

125 before this; yet now you have come  
out far in front of all

126 in your daring, to stand my long-  
shadowed spear.

127 Unhappy are the fathers whose sons  
face my fury!

128 But if you are some immortal come  
down from the sky —

129 I will not fight with heavenly gods.

130 No — even Dryas' son, strong  
Lycurgus,<sup>7</sup>

131 did not live long, who strove with  
heavenly gods:

132 he once chased the nurses of raving  
Dionysus

133 down the holy mountain of Nysa; and  
all together

134 they flung their sacred wands to the  
ground, as man-slaughtering



135 Lycurgus beat them with an ox-goad;  
and Dionysus in terror  
136 dived under the salt sea's wave, and  
Thetis took him,  
137 frightened, to her bosom: for a strong  
trembling held him  
138 at the man's shouting. But the gods  
who live at ease were angered  
139 at Lycurgus, and Cronos' son struck  
him blind; nor did he  
140 live long after, hated by all the  
immortal gods.  
141 I would not choose to fight the blessed  
gods.  
142 But if you are a mortal, one of those  
who eat the fruit of the field,  
143 come closer — and come the sooner to  
the borders of destruction."  
144 Then Hippolochus' shining son

addressed him:

145 “Great-hearted son of Tydeus — why  
ask my lineage?

146 As the generation of leaves, so is the  
generation of men.8

147 The wind pours some leaves to the  
ground, and others the forest

148 grows in their fullness when the  
season of spring comes on:

149 so with the generations of men — one  
grows, one dies away.

150 But if you wish to hear even this, and  
to know

151 my lineage — many men know it  
already:

152 there is a city, Ephyra, in a fold of  
horse-pasturing Argos,

153 and there lived Sisyphus, craftiest of  
men —9

154 Sisyphus, Aeolus' son; and he fathered  
a son, Glaucus,  
155 and Glaucus fathered blameless  
Bellerophon.  
156 To him the gods gave beauty and  
lovely manhood;  
157 but Proetus plotted evil against him in  
his heart,  
158 and drove him out of the land of the  
Argives — being far  
159 the stronger: for Zeus had bowed them  
under his scepter.  
160 For Proetus' wife, brilliant Anteia, was  
mad  
161 to lie with him in secret love; but she  
could not  
162 move right-minded, war-minded  
Bellerophon.  
163 So she lied to King Proetus:

164 'Die yourself, Proetus — or kill  
Bellerophon,  
165 who wanted to lie with me in love, and  
I unwilling.'  
166 So she spoke, and anger took hold of  
the king at what he heard.  
167 He shrank from killing him — his heart  
stood in awe of that —  
168 but he sent him to Lycia, and gave him  
baneful signs,  
169 scratching in a folded tablet many life-  
destroying marks,<sup>10</sup>  
170 and told him to show it to his wife's  
father: that he might perish.  
171 So he went to Lycia, under the gods'  
blameless escort.  
172 And when he came to Lycia and the  
flowing Xanthus,  
173 the lord of wide Lycia honored him

with a ready heart:

174 nine days he feasted him, and  
slaughtered nine oxen.

175 But when the tenth rosy-fingered  
Dawn appeared,

176 then he questioned him, and asked to  
see the token,

177 whatever it was he brought from his  
son-in-law Proetus.

178 And when he had received his son-in-  
law's evil token,

179 first he ordered him to kill the raging  
Chimaera —

180 a thing of divine stock, not of men:

181 in front a lion, behind a serpent, in the  
middle a she-goat,

182 breathing out the terrible fury of  
blazing fire.<sup>11</sup>

183 And he killed her, trusting the

portents of the gods.

184 Second, he fought the far-famed  
Solymi:

185 the hardest battle of men, he said, he  
ever entered.

186 Third, he cut down the Amazons, the  
match of men.

187 And as he came back the king wove  
him another close-set trap:

188 choosing the best men out of wide  
Lycia

189 he set an ambush; and they never  
came home again —

190 blameless Bellerophon killed them all.

191 But when the king came to know he  
was the brave son of a god,

192 he kept him there, and gave him his  
daughter,

193 and gave him half of all his kingly

honor;

194 and the Lycians cut him a precinct  
beyond all others,

195 fine land for orchard and plowland, to  
enjoy.

196 And she bore three children to war-  
minded Bellerophon:

197 Isander, and Hippolochus, and  
Laodameia.

198 By Laodameia Zeus the counselor lay,

199 and she bore godlike Sarpedon of the  
bronze helmet.

200 But when even Bellerophon came to  
be hated by all the gods,

201 he wandered alone across the Aleian  
plain,

202 eating out his heart, shunning the  
trodden paths of men;**12**

203 and his son Isander was killed by Ares

insatiate of war

204 as he fought the far-famed Solymi;

205 and his daughter — Artemis of the  
golden reins killed her in anger.

206 But Hippolochus fathered me: from  
him I claim my birth.

207 He sent me to Troy, and he charged  
me strictly

208 always to be the best, and to hold my  
head above all others,

209 and not to shame the stock of my  
fathers, who were far the best

210 in Ephyra, and in wide Lycia.

211 Of this lineage and this blood I claim to  
be.”

212 So he spoke; and Diomedes, good at  
the war-cry, rejoiced.

213 He planted his spear in the earth that  
feeds so many



214 and spoke with honeyed words to the  
shepherd of the people:  
215 “Why — then you are my guest-friend  
from our fathers’ time!13  
216 For brilliant Oeneus once entertained  
blameless  
217 Bellerophon in his halls, and kept him  
twenty days;  
218 and they gave one another fine gifts of  
friendship:  
219 Oeneus gave a war-belt bright with  
crimson,  
220 and Bellerophon a golden two-  
handled cup —  
221 I left it in my house when I came away.  
222 Tydeus I do not remember: I was still  
small  
223 when he left me, that time the  
Achaean host perished at Thebes.

224 So now I am your dear guest-friend in  
the heart of Argos,  
225 and you are mine in Lycia, whenever I  
come to that country.  
226 Let us keep clear of each other's  
spears, even in the crush:  
227 there are Trojans enough for me, and  
famed allies,  
228 to kill whomever a god delivers and  
my feet overtake,  
229 and Achaeans enough for you, to cut  
down whom you can.  
230 And let us exchange armor with each  
other, so that these men too  
231 may know we claim to be guest-  
friends from our fathers' time."  
232 So the two spoke, and leapt down  
from their chariots  
233 and took each other's hands and

pledged their faith.

234 And then Zeus, Cronos' son, took  
Glaucus's wits away:

235 he exchanged with Tydeus' son  
Diomedes armor

236 of gold for bronze — a hundred oxen's  
worth for nine.14

237 Now when Hector came to the Scaean  
Gates and the oak,15

238 the Trojans' wives and daughters  
came running around him,

239 asking after sons and brothers and  
kinsmen

240 and husbands. And he told them to  
pray to the gods,

241 all of them, one after another: griefs  
hung over many.

242 But when he came to Priam's  
beautiful palace,

243 built with polished colonnades — and  
in it  
244 were fifty chambers of polished  
stone,16  
245 built close by one another, where the  
sons  
246 of Priam slept beside their wedded  
wives,  
247 and for the daughters, opposite,  
within the court,  
248 were twelve roofed chambers of  
polished stone,  
249 built close by one another, where the  
sons-in-law  
250 of Priam slept beside their honored  
wives —  
251 there his gentle-giving mother came  
to meet him,  
252 leading in Laodice, loveliest of her

daughters;

253 and she clung to his hand, and spoke a  
word, and named him:

254 “Child, why have you left the bold  
fighting and come here?

255 Surely they are wearing you down —  
those cursed sons

256 of the Achaeans, fighting around the  
town — and your heart sent you

257 here, to lift your hands to Zeus from  
the city’s height.

258 But wait while I bring you honey-  
sweet wine,

259 to pour first to father Zeus and the  
other immortals,

260 and then to do yourself good, if you  
will drink.

261 Wine greatly swells the strength of a  
wearied man —

262 and you are wearied with defending  
your kinsmen.”

263 Then great Hector of the flashing  
helmet answered her:

264 “Bring me no wine, honey-hearted  
lady mother,

265 or you may unstring my limbs and I  
forget my courage.

266 And I shrink from pouring gleaming  
wine to Zeus<sup>17</sup>

267 with unwashed hands: a man  
spattered with blood and filth

268 cannot pray to the son of Cronos, lord  
of the dark cloud.

269 No — you go to the temple of Athena,  
driver of the spoil,

270 with burnt offerings, when you have  
gathered the older women,

271 and the robe that is loveliest and

amplest

272 in the hall, and far the dearest to  
yourself,

273 lay it on the knees of lovely-haired  
Athena,

274 and vow to sacrifice to her in the  
temple twelve heifers,

275 yearlings, never goaded, if she will  
pity

276 the town, and the Trojans' wives, and  
their little children —

277 if she will hold back Tydeus' son from  
holy Ilion,

278 that wild spearman, that strong  
machine of rout.

279 So go to the temple of Athena, driver  
of the spoil;

280 and I will go after Paris, to summon  
him,

281 if he is willing to hear me speak. May  
the earth gape for him  
282 where he stands! The Olympian  
reared him as a great affliction  
283 to the Trojans, and to great-hearted  
Priam, and Priam's sons.  
284 If I could see that man gone down into  
Hades' house,  
285 I could say my heart had forgotten its  
joyless misery.”  
286 So he spoke; and she went to the hall  
and called  
287 her handmaids, and they gathered the  
older women through the city.  
288 She herself went down to the fragrant  
storeroom  
289 where her robes were kept, the richly  
patterned work of women  
290 of Sidon, whom godlike Alexandros



himself<sup>18</sup>

<sup>291</sup> brought from Sidon, sailing the wide  
sea,

<sup>292</sup> on that voyage on which he carried  
home high-born Helen.

<sup>293</sup> Of these Hecuba took one to carry as  
gift to Athena,

<sup>294</sup> the one that was loveliest in its  
patterning, and amplest,

<sup>295</sup> and it shone like a star; it lay beneath  
all the others.

<sup>296</sup> Then she set out, and the many older  
women hurried after.

<sup>297</sup> And when they came to Athena's  
temple on the city's height,

<sup>298</sup> fair-cheeked Theano opened the  
doors for them,

<sup>299</sup> Cisseus' daughter, wife of Antenor,  
breaker of horses,

300 whom the Trojans had made priestess  
of Athena.19

301 With a wailing cry they all lifted their  
hands to Athena;

302 and fair-cheeked Theano took the  
robe

303 and laid it on the knees of lovely-  
haired Athena,

304 and vowing she prayed to the  
daughter of great Zeus:

305 “Lady Athena, guardian of the city,  
brilliant among goddesses:

306 break now the spear of Diomedes, and  
grant

307 that the man himself fall on his face  
before the Scaean Gates,

308 and we will sacrifice to you at once,  
here in the temple,

309 twelve heifers, yearlings, never

goaded, if you will pity

310 the town, and the Trojans' wives, and  
their little children."

311 So she spoke, vowing. But Pallas  
Athena turned her head away.20

312 So they were praying to the daughter  
of great Zeus;

313 and Hector had gone to the house of  
Alexandros,

314 the beautiful house he had built  
himself with the men

315 who were then the best builders in  
deep-soiled Troy:

316 they had made him a chamber and a  
hall and a courtyard

317 close by Priam and Hector, on the  
city's height.

318 There Hector entered, dear to Zeus,  
and in his hand

319 he held a spear eleven cubits long; and  
before him the bronze  
320 point of the shaft shone, and a ring of  
gold ran round it.  
321 He found Paris in the chamber busy  
with his beautiful armor,  
322 the shield and the corslet, and  
handling his curved bow;  
323 and Argive Helen sat among her slave-  
women, 21  
324 directing her handmaids in their  
famous work.  
325 And seeing him Hector raked him  
with shaming words:  
326 “Strange man — it is not decent to  
nurse this anger in your heart.  
327 The people are dying around the city  
and the steep wall  
328 as they fight; and it is for your sake

that the war-cry and the war  
329 burn around this town. You would  
quarrel yourself  
330 with any man you saw hanging back  
from hateful war.  
331 Up — before the town is warmed by  
the enemy's fire!"  
332 And godlike Alexandros answered  
him:  
333 "Hector, you rake me justly, not more  
than justly;  
334 so I will tell you — and you mark me,  
and hear me out.  
335 It was not so much anger at the  
Trojans, or resentment,  
336 that kept me sitting in my chamber: I  
wanted to give in to grief.  
337 But just now my wife, coaxing me  
with soft words,

338 urged me back to the war; and it  
seems even to me  
339 that it will be better so. Victory shifts  
from man to man.  
340 Come then, wait while I put on the  
gear of Ares —  
341 or go, and I will follow: I think I shall  
overtake you.”  
342 So he spoke; and Hector of the  
flashing helmet answered him nothing.  
343 But Helen spoke to Hector with  
honeyed words:  
344 “Brother — brother of me, the dog,  
the evil-scheming horror:22  
345 how I wish that on the day my mother  
first bore me  
346 some foul storm of wind had carried  
me off  
347 to a mountain, or into the wave of the

loud-roaring sea,

348 where the wave would have swept me  
away before all this was done.

349 But since the gods ordained these  
evils so,

350 then I wish I had been wife to a better  
man,

351 one who felt the world's anger and the  
long reproaches of men.

352 But this one — his wits are not steady  
now, and never

353 will be; and I think he will reap the  
harvest of it.

354 But come in now, brother, and sit on  
this chair,

355 since the labor rings your heart above  
all others' —

356 for the sake of me, the dog, and for  
Alexandros's blindness:

357 on whom Zeus has set an evil doom, so  
that hereafter

358 we may be subjects of song for men  
still to come.”**23**

359 Then great Hector of the flashing  
helmet answered her:

360 “Do not seat me, Helen, though you  
love me. You will not persuade me.

361 Already my heart is driving me to  
stand by

362 the Trojans, who feel their great  
longing for me gone.

363 No — you rouse this man, and let him  
hurry himself,

364 so he may catch me still inside the  
city.

365 For I am going home first, to see

366 my household, and my dear wife, and  
my little son:



367 I do not know if I shall come back to  
them again,  
368 or whether the gods will break me  
now under Achaean hands.”  
369 So speaking Hector of the flashing  
helmet went.  
370 And quickly he came to his well-  
settled house —  
371 but he did not find white-armed  
Andromache in the hall:  
372 she had gone with the child and one  
fair-robed handmaid  
373 and stood on the tower, weeping and  
mourning.  
374 When Hector did not find his  
blameless wife within,  
375 he stopped on the threshold and  
spoke among the slave-women:  
376 “Come, slave-women, tell me the truth

of it:

377 where has white-armed Andromache  
gone from the hall?

378 To one of my sisters, or my brothers'  
fair-robed wives?

379 Or out to Athena's temple, where the  
other

380 lovely-braided women of Troy are  
appeasing the dread goddess?"

381 And the busy housekeeper answered  
him:

382 "Hector — since you order me strictly  
to tell the truth:

383 not to one of your sisters, nor your  
brothers' fair-robed wives,

384 nor out to Athena's temple, where the  
other

385 lovely-braided women of Troy are  
appeasing the dread goddess —

386 she went up on the great tower of  
Ilion, because she heard  
387 the Trojans were worn down, and the  
Achaeans' power was great.  
388 She has gone hurrying to the wall  
389 like a woman gone mad; and the nurse  
carries the child beside her.”  
390 So the housekeeper spoke; and Hector  
sped from the house  
391 back the same way, down the well-  
built streets.  
392 When, crossing the great city, he  
reached the gates —  
393 the Scaean Gates, by which he meant  
to go out on the plain —  
394 there his richly dowered wife came  
running to meet him,  
395 Andromache, daughter of great-  
hearted Eëtion —

396 Eëtion, who lived under wooded  
Placus,  
397 in Thebe-under-Placus, lord over the  
Cilician men:  
398 his daughter was wife to Hector of the  
bronze helmet.  
399 She met him there, and with her came  
the handmaid  
400 holding the child at her breast, all  
baby-thoughts still, a little one,  
401 the beloved son of Hector, like a  
beautiful star:  
402 Hector called him Scamandrius, but  
the others  
403 Astyanax — for Hector alone was the  
saving of Ilion.24  
404 He looked at his boy and smiled in  
silence;  
405 but Andromache came and stood close

beside him, weeping,  
406 and she clung to his hand, and spoke a  
word, and named him:  
407 “Strange man — your own fury will  
destroy you. And you have no pity  
408 for your son, a little child, or for  
doomed me, who soon  
409 shall be your widow: for soon the  
Achaeans will kill you,  
410 falling on you all together. And for me  
it would be better,  
411 losing you, to go under the earth:  
there will be no other  
412 comfort ever again, once you have met  
your doom —  
413 only griefs. And I have no father, no  
lady mother.  
414 My father — brilliant Achilles killed  
him,

415 the day he sacked the well-settled city  
of the Cilicians,  
416 Thebe of the high gates. He killed  
Eëtion —  
417 but he did not strip him: his heart  
stood in awe of that.<sup>25</sup>  
418 He burned his body in the wrought  
armor  
419 and heaped a grave-mound over him;  
and around it the mountain nymphs,  
420 daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus,  
planted elm trees.  
421 And my seven brothers in our halls —  
422 all of them went to Hades' house in a  
single day:  
423 swift-footed brilliant Achilles killed  
them all  
424 among their rolling-gaited cattle and  
their white sheep.

425 And my mother, who was queen under  
wooded Placus —  
426 he brought her here with the rest of  
the plunder,  
427 but set her free again, taking ransom  
past counting,  
428 and in her father's halls Artemis who  
showers arrows struck her down.  
429 Hector — so you are my father, and  
my lady mother,  
430 and my brother; and you are my  
strong young husband.26  
431 Come, take pity now, and stay here on  
the tower:  
432 do not make your child an orphan and  
your wife a widow.  
433 And station the army by the wild fig  
tree, where the city  
434 is easiest to scale, and the wall lies

open to assault.<sup>27</sup>

<sup>435</sup> Three times their best men have come  
there and tried it,

<sup>436</sup> the two Ajaxes and famous Idomeneus  
together,

<sup>437</sup> and the sons of Atreus, and Tydeus'  
powerful son —

<sup>438</sup> whether someone skilled in god-signs  
told them of it,

<sup>439</sup> or their own hearts drive and  
command them to it.”

<sup>440</sup> Then great Hector of the flashing  
helmet answered her:

<sup>441</sup> “All this is my care too, wife. But I  
would stand

<sup>442</sup> in terrible shame before the Trojans,  
and the Trojan women

<sup>443</sup> with their trailing gowns, if like a  
coward I skulked apart from the war;



444 and my own heart will not let me. I  
have learned to be brave  
445 always, and to fight among the  
foremost Trojans,  
446 winning great fame for my father, and  
for myself.  
447 For this I know well in my mind and  
heart:  
448 the day will come when holy Ilion  
shall perish,<sup>28</sup>  
449 and Priam, and the people of Priam of  
the good ash spear.  
450 But it is not the Trojans' coming grief  
that so much moves me —  
451 not Hecuba's own, not lord Priam's,  
452 not my brothers', who many and  
brave  
453 may fall in the dust under enemy  
hands —

454 as yours: when some bronze-shirted  
Achaean  
455 leads you away in tears, and takes  
your day of freedom;  
456 and in Argos you would weave at  
another woman's loom,  
457 and carry water from the spring  
Messeis or Hypereia,  
458 hating it, every step — and hard  
necessity on you;  
459 and someone will say, seeing you  
letting fall your tears:  
460 'This is the wife of Hector, who was  
best in battle  
461 of all the horse-taming Trojans, when  
they fought around Ilion.'  
462 So someone will say; and for you it  
will be fresh grief,  
463 for want of such a man to beat off the

day of slavery.<sup>29</sup>

464 But may the heaped earth cover me,  
dead,

465 before I hear your cry and see you  
dragged away.”

466 So speaking, glorious Hector reached  
out for his boy —

467 and the child shrank back, crying,  
against the breast

468 of his fair-belted nurse, terrified at  
the sight of his own father,

469 frightened by the bronze and the  
horsehair crest,

470 seeing it nod terribly from the  
helmet’s top.

471 And his dear father laughed aloud, and  
his lady mother;<sup>30</sup>

472 at once glorious Hector took the  
helmet from his head

473 and laid it, all shining, on the ground.  
474 Then he kissed his dear son, and  
swung him in his arms,  
475 and spoke in prayer to Zeus and the  
other gods:  
476 “Zeus, and you other gods: grant that  
this boy,  
477 my son, may become, as I am,  
preeminent among the Trojans,  
478 as strong and brave as I; and rule Ilion  
in strength;  
479 and may men someday say he is far  
better than his father  
480 as he comes home from war. May he  
carry back the bloody spoils  
481 of the enemy he has killed, and his  
mother’s heart be glad.”<sup>31</sup>  
482 So speaking he laid his son in the  
arms

483 of his dear wife; and she took him to  
her fragrant breast,  
484 laughing through her tears. And her  
husband saw, and pitied her,  
485 and stroked her with his hand, and  
spoke a word, and named her:  
486 “Strange woman — do not grieve too  
much for me in your heart.  
487 No man will hurl me to Hades beyond  
my portion;  
488 but his fate, I say, no man has ever  
escaped,  
489 coward or brave man, once he has  
been born.**32**  
490 Go home now, and set your own work  
in order —  
491 the loom and the distaff — and tell  
your handmaids  
492 to go about their work. War shall be

men's concern —

493 all men's, and mine above all, of all  
who were born in Ilion.”**33**

494 So speaking, glorious Hector took up  
the helmet

495 with its horsehair crest; and his dear  
wife went home,

496 turning back again and again, letting  
the full tears fall.

497 And quickly she came to the well-  
settled house

498 of man-slaughtering Hector, and  
found inside her many

499 handmaids; and in all of them she  
stirred lament.

500 So they mourned Hector, still alive, in  
his own house:

501 for they said he would never again  
come back

502 out of the war, escaping the fury and  
the hands of the Achaeans.34

503 Nor did Paris linger long in his high  
house:

504 when he had put on his famed armor,  
patterned with bronze,

505 he ran through the city, sure of his  
quick feet.

506 As when a stalled horse, corn-fed at  
the manger,

507 breaks his tether and gallops  
drumming across the plain,

508 used to bathing in the fair-flowing  
river,

509 glorying: he holds his head high, and  
the mane

510 streams along his shoulders; sure of  
his own splendor,

511 his knees carry him lightly to the

haunts and pastures of horses:35

512 so Paris, Priam's son, came striding  
down from the height

513 of Pergamos, blazing in his armor like  
the beaming sun,

514 laughing aloud, and his quick feet  
carried him. And at once

515 he came on brilliant Hector, his  
brother, just turning away

516 from the place where he had talked  
with his wife.

517 Godlike Alexandros spoke to him first:

518 "Elder brother — surely I have held  
you back in your hurry,

519 lingering so long; I did not come  
promptly, as you asked.36"

520 Answering him spoke Hector of the  
flashing helmet:

521 "Strange man — no fair-minded man



could disparage

522 your work in battle: you have your  
courage.

523 But you hang back by choice; you will  
not try. And my heart

524 aches in me when I hear your shame  
on Trojan lips —

525 the men who bear this long labor for  
your sake.

526 But let us go. We will make all this  
good later, if ever Zeus

527 grants us to set out for the heavenly  
gods who are forever

528 the mixing-bowl of freedom in our  
halls,

529 when we have driven the strong-  
greaved Achaeans out of Troy.”

## Notes

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## NOTES

1. (6.12-19) Axylus of Arisbe, “a friend to all mankind,” who kept open house by the road — and not one guest stood by him at his death. The hospitality-vignette inverted: *xenia* builds a network of obligation, and the poem records the one moment it cannot pay out. ↩
2. (6.21-28) Bucolion, Laomedon’s eldest son “borne in darkness” (σκότιον — illegitimate), and the water-nymph Abarbarea: a shepherd’s love-story compressed into five lines so that its twin sons can die in two. Nymph-brides on Mount Ida are a recurring Trojan genealogy (cf. Aeneas’s own conception, 2.820-821). ↩
3. (6.45-65) The Adrestus scene: a ransom-supplication (the standard battlefield transaction, cf. 1.12-13) refused in the war’s most chilling terms — “not even the boy his mother carries in her womb.” The narrator’s comment, αἵσιμα παρειπών, is rendered at face value (“for his urging was of things due”) and has been disputed since antiquity: does the poet endorse the atrocity as just payment for Paris’s crime, or does αἵσιμα mean only “words of destiny”?

The translation does not soften it; the dispute lives here. ↩

4. (6.76) Helenus, Priam's son, "far the best of bird-readers" — the Trojan counterpart of Calchas (1.69, same formula); distinct from the Helenus killed at 5.707. ↩
5. (6.90-97) The peplos-offering: a woven robe laid on the knees of the seated cult-statue, with a vow of twelve unworked heifers — the fullest description of civic ritual supplication in the poem. The instruction is relayed verbatim three times (Helenus 90-97, Hector 269-278, performed 293-310), per messenger convention; the English repeats identically. ↩
6. (6.119-236) The Glaucus-Diomedes encounter. Aristonicus reports that some ancient critics transposed the whole episode elsewhere in the poem (apparatus, Line 119-236) — it sits oddly in mid-battle, two enemies talking genealogy at leisure. Kept, of course, where the tradition kept it: its meditation on lineage, mortality, and obligation is the hinge between the battlefield and Troy's interiors. ↩
7. (6.130-140) Lycurgus who chased Dionysus's nurses with an ox-goad — the Iliad's only Dionysus

narrative (the god is strikingly marginal in Homer), told as a cautionary paradigm against god-fighting. Thetis's sea-rescue of the terrified child is her third such rescue in the poem's memory (Zeus at 1.396-406, Hephaestus at 18.398). ↩

8. (6.146-149) "As the generation of leaves, so is the generation of men" — the most famous simile in the poem, and the classic statement of its view of mortality; quoted, imitated, and answered from Mimnermus to the present. Glaucus's point is scornful — why ask lineage? — and he then gives sixty lines of it: the tension is the speech. ↩
9. (6.152-155) Sisyphus "craftiest of men" — here simply a clever Corinthian ancestor; the Iliad knows nothing (or says nothing) of the underworld stone, which appears first in Odyssey 11. ↩
10. (6.160-170) Proetus's wife Anteia and the lethal letter: the oldest Greek instance of the "Potiphar's wife" motif — and the "baneful signs... scratched in a folded tablet" are the only reference to writing in all of Homer. Whether the poet imagined true script or ominous symbols was already debated in antiquity; the translation keeps the vagueness ("marks"). ↩

11. (6.179-186) Bellerophon's labors: the Chimaera (lion-serpent-goat, fire-breathing — the poem's canonical description), the Solymi, the Amazons "the match of men" (cf. 3.189). Pegasus is conspicuously absent: Homer's Bellerophon does his killing without the winged horse of later art. ↩
12. (6.200-205) Bellerophon's end: "hated by all the gods," wandering the Aleian plain ("the Plain of Wandering" — the name puns on his roaming), "eating out his heart" — the poem's image of a man dropped by fortune, cause unstated. His son falls to Ares, his daughter to Artemis: in Homeric idiom, sudden death of a man is Ares' or Apollo's arrow, of a woman Artemis's (cf. 6.428). ↩
13. (6.215-231) The discovery: Diomedes' grandfather hosted Glaucus's grandfather for twenty days, therefore the grandsons may not fight — guest-friendship binds across generations and across the war itself. They will kill other men's guest-friends all afternoon; the institution is particular, not humanitarian. The gift-list (war-belt for cup) is a miniature of the economy. ↩
14. (6.234-236) "Zeus took Glaucus's wits away": gold armor for bronze, "a hundred oxen's worth for nine"

— proverbial by Plato’s time for a bad bargain. The narrator’s only intrusion into the scene, and a famously debated one: divine folly, or the reckless magnificence that is exactly what Glaucus’s speech about glory demanded? ↩

15. (6.237) “the Scaean Gates and the oak” — the oak of Zeus (cf. 5.693), a fixed landmark of the battlefield’s edge; some manuscripts read “tower” for “oak” (apparatus, Line 237). ↩
16. (6.242-250) Priam’s palace: fifty chambers for sons, twelve for daughters and sons-in-law — dynastic architecture, the physical form of Priam’s abundance that the war is grinding away (cf. his own count of lost sons at 24.493-498). ↩
17. (6.264-268) Hector’s double scruple — wine would slacken him; blood-spattered hands cannot pour to Zeus: battlefield piety in its exact ritual grammar (cf. the hand-washing at 1.449, 3.270). ↩
18. (6.289-295) The Sidonian robes: Phoenician luxury goods brought home by Paris “on that voyage on which he carried home high-born Helen” — the abduction had a shopping itinerary. The offering to Athena is thus chosen from the very cargo of the crime. ↩

19. (6.298-300) Theano (cf. 5.70) as priestess of Athena “whom the Trojans had made” so — a civic appointment, the only such notice in Homer, and evidence that Athena has an established cult inside the city she is destroying. ↪
20. (6.311) “But Pallas Athena turned her head away.” Aristarchus athetized the line (apparatus); it is the bleakest single verse in the poem — the exact ritual performed exactly, and refused in four words. Kept, emphatically: without it the whole peplos sequence loses its point. ↪
21. (6.323-324, 375-376) First occurrences of δμωαί, rendered “slave-women” per the project’s adopted policy (never “servants” or “maids”); ἀμφίπολος remains “handmaid,” ταμίη “housekeeper,” τιθήνη “nurse.” The household vocabulary matters in this book above all: its climax turns on Andromache’s foreseen “day of slavery” (463). ↪
22. (6.344-356) Helen to Hector: “me, the dog, the evil-scheming horror” — her third self-directed dog-insult (3.180, 3.404’s “hateful me”); no one in the poem abuses Helen except Helen. At 356 the printed text has “Alexandros’s blindness” (ἄτης) — Zenodotus read ἀρχῆς, “Alexandros who began it”

(apparatus; cf. 3.100). The ἄτη-reading ties Paris to the poem's key word for ruinous delusion. ↩

23. (6.357-358) “so that hereafter we may be subjects of song for men still to come” — the poem explaining its own existence through Helen's mouth: their suffering is Zeus's device for making poetry. Cf. Alcinous's version of the same thought at *Odyssey* 8.579. ↩
24. (6.402-403) The child's two names: Hector calls him Scamandrius (after the river), the city calls him Astyanax — “lord of the city” — “for Hector alone was the saving of Ilion.” The people's name for the son is their thanks to the father; its bitter payoff comes at 22.506-507. Third instance of the double-naming motif (cf. 1.403-404, 2.813-814), here mortal/civic rather than divine/human. ↩
25. (6.414-428) Andromache's family history is Achilles' work in its entirety: father killed (but honored — burned in his armor, mound heaped, elms planted by nymphs: even his enemies' awe, *σεβάσσατο*), seven brothers in one day, mother ransomed then dead. The raid on Thebe is the poem's economic backstory (Chryseis was taken there, 1.366-369; Briseis's city Lyrnessus fell in the same campaign, 2.690-691).



When Achilles and Andromache's griefs finally meet, in Book 24, they will already share every dead person in them. ↩

26. (6.429-430) "you are my father, and my lady mother, and my brother; and you are my strong young husband" — arithmetic of the preceding catalogue: everything the war has taken, refigured in the one person it is about to take. ↩
27. (6.433-439) Andromache's tactical advice — mass the army at the wild fig tree where the wall is scalable and thrice-probed. Aristarchus athetized the lines (apparatus, Line 433-439), on the ancient view that military counsel was unfitting in her mouth. Kept: the poem's women know exactly how Troy falls; the fig tree recurs as a tactical landmark at 11.167 and 22.145. ↩
28. (6.447-449) "the day will come when holy Ilion shall perish, and Priam, and the people of Priam of the good ash spear" — verbatim the lines Agamemnon spoke at 4.163-165. There they were a threat sworn in anger; here Hector speaks them as settled knowledge, and fights on anyway. The reuse is the measure of the man. (Echo note; English repeated word for word.) ↩

29. (6.454-465) The enslaved future, imagined by the husband: the loom of another woman, the water of Messeis or Hypereia, the stranger's comment on her tears. "Day of freedom" / "day of slavery" (ἐλεύθερον ἡμᾶρ / δούλιον ἡμᾶρ) — the Homeric idiom that makes a condition a date. Hector's wish to be dead first will be granted exactly. ↩
30. (6.466-474) The helmet scene: the baby screaming at the nodding crest, and both parents laughing — the poem's only moment of family comedy, set precisely between prophecy and farewell. The flashing-helmet epithet the poem has attached to Hector some forty times becomes, for four lines, a thing his son cannot recognize him through. ↩
31. (6.476-481) Hector's prayer: "may men someday say he is far better than his father... and his mother's heart be glad." The tradition beyond the poem answers with the child thrown from the walls; the Iliad says nothing of it, and the silence is part of the effect. Even within the prayer, joy is measured in "bloody spoils." ↩
32. (6.486-489) "his fate, I say, no man has ever escaped, coward or brave man, once he has been born" — the consolation of shared mortality, Hector's plainest

theology; the same thought Achilles will offer Priam in Book 24 at far greater length. ↩

33. (6.490-493) “the loom and the distaff... War shall be men’s concern” — the fixed formula dividing the spheres (Hector will be echoed nearly verbatim by Telemachus, with “speech” for “war,” at Odyssey 1.356-359). Coming directly after note [27]’s athetized tactics, the line enacts the boundary the critics wanted enforced. ↩
34. (6.500-502) “So they mourned Hector, still alive, in his own house” — the lament raised before the death; the poem lets the funeral of Book 24 begin here, eighteen books early. ↩
35. (6.506-511) The stalled horse: Paris released, glorying, mane streaming — repeated verbatim at 15.263-268, where it describes Hector returning to battle; the same simile serving vanity there and heroism here is a masterclass in how formulas mean by placement. English fixed for the recurrence. ↩
36. (6.519) The OCT punctuates Paris’s close as a question — “and did I not come in due time, as you bade?” — a touch of fishing for reassurance. Printed here as a flat admission (a reading with editorial standing),

which suits Hector's mollified reply; the crux is recorded. ↩

# Book 7

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*The duel of Hector and Ajax, the burial truce,  
and the building of the Achaean wall.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 So speaking, glorious Hector swept out  
through the gates,
- 2 and with him went Alexandros his  
brother; and in their hearts
- 3 both were raging for war and for battle.
- 4 As a god gives to longing sailors
- 5 a following wind, when they have worn  
themselves out at the polished
- 6 pine oars, driving the sea, and their  
limbs are unstrung with weariness:
- 7 so those two appeared to the longing

Trojans.

8 Then each took his man: Paris the son of  
lord Areithous,

9 Menesthius, who had his home in Arne  
— whom the club-man<sup>1</sup>

10 Areithous fathered with ox-eyed  
Phylomedusa;

11 and Hector hit Eioneus with his sharp  
spear

12 in the neck, under the fine bronze  
helmet-rim, and unstrung his limbs.

13 And Glaucus, Hippolochus' son, captain  
of the Lycian men,

14 hit Iphinous, Dexias' son, with his spear  
in the strong encounter

15 as he leapt up behind his fast mares,

16 in the shoulder; he dropped from the  
car to the ground, and his limbs were  
unstrung.

17 Now when the goddess grey-eyed  
Athena marked them  
18 killing Argives in the strong encounter,  
19 down from the peaks of Olympus she  
went darting  
20 to holy Ilion; and Apollo rose to meet  
her,  
21 looking out from Pergamos, wanting  
victory for the Trojans;  
22 and the two of them met each other  
beside the oak.  
23 Lord Apollo, Zeus's son, spoke to her  
first:  
24 "Why so eager, this time, daughter of  
great Zeus?  
25 Why come from Olympus? What great  
passion sent you?  
26 Is it to give the Danaans victory that  
turns the battle's tide?

27 You have no pity, none, for the Trojans  
as they die.

28 But if you would let me persuade you,  
it would be far better:

29 let us stop the war and the fighting

30 for today. Later they will fight again,  
until they find

31 the appointed end of Iliion — since it is  
so dear to the hearts

32 of you immortal goddesses to sack this  
city.”

33 Then the goddess grey-eyed Athena  
answered him:

34 “So be it, worker-from-afar. With that  
very thought

35 I came from Olympus among the  
Trojans and Achaeans.

36 Come then — how do you mean to stop  
the men’s fighting?”



37 And lord Apollo, Zeus's son, answered  
her:  
38 "Let us rouse the strong fury of Hector,  
breaker of horses,  
39 to see if he will challenge some one of  
the Danaans  
40 to fight him man to man in dread  
combat,  
41 and the bronze-greaved Achaeans,  
stung to honor,  
42 will send out one man alone to fight  
brilliant Hector."  
43 So he spoke, and the goddess grey-eyed  
Athena did not disobey.  
44 And Helenus, Priam's dear son, put  
together in his heart  
45 their counsel — the plan that had  
pleased the plotting gods;  
46 and he came and stood by Hector and

spoke his word:

47 “Hector, son of Priam, the equal of Zeus  
in counsel,

48 would you let me persuade you? I am  
your brother.

49 Make the other Trojans sit down, and  
all the Achaeans,

50 and yourself challenge whoever is best  
of the Achaeans

51 to fight you man to man in dread  
combat.

52 It is not yet your fate to die and meet  
your doom:

53 so I heard it in the voice of the gods  
who are forever.”<sup>2</sup>

54 So he spoke, and Hector rejoiced  
greatly to hear the word,

55 and he went into the middle and held  
back the Trojan lines,

56 gripping his spear by the middle; and  
they all sat down,  
57 and Agamemnon seated the strong-  
greaved Achaeans.  
58 And Athena and Apollo of the silver  
bow,  
59 in the likeness of vulture birds, settled  
60 on the tall oak of father Zeus who  
bears the aegis,<sup>3</sup>  
61 delighting in the men; and the ranks of  
them sat close,  
62 bristling with shields and helmets and  
spears.  
63 As a shiver from the West Wind spreads  
down over the deep  
64 when the wind first rises, and the sea  
darkens beneath it,  
65 such were the ranks of the Achaeans  
and Trojans sitting

66 in the plain. And Hector spoke between  
the two armies:

67 “Hear from me, Trojans and strong-  
greaved Achaeans,

68 so I may say what the heart in my chest  
commands me.

69 Our sworn oaths — the high-throned  
son of Cronos did not seal them,

70 but plans evil for both sides, and marks  
it out,

71 until either you take fair-towered Troy

72 or are broken yourselves beside your  
seagoing ships.

73 Among you are the chief men of all the  
Achaeans:

74 of these, let the man whose heart bids  
him fight me

75 come out here now, before you all, to  
champion you against brilliant Hector.

76 And this is my word — let Zeus be our  
witness to it:  
77 if that man takes my life with the long-  
edged bronze,  
78 let him strip my armor and carry it to  
the hollow ships,  
79 but give my body back to my home, so  
that in death  
80 the Trojans and the Trojans' wives may  
give me my due of fire.  
81 But if I take him, and Apollo gives me  
the glory,  
82 I will strip his armor and carry it to  
holy Ilion  
83 and hang it before the temple of Apollo  
the far-striker;  
84 but the corpse I will give back to the  
well-benched ships,  
85 so the long-haired Achaeans may give

him burial

86 and heap him a mound beside the wide  
Hellespont.

87 And someday a man will say, even  
among men born late,

88 sailing his many-benched ship over the  
wine-dark sea:

89 ‘This is the mound of a man who died  
long ago,

90 whom once, fighting his best, glorious  
Hector killed.’

91 So someone will say; and my fame will  
never perish.”<sup>4</sup>

92 So he spoke, and they all went still in  
silence:

93 ashamed to refuse, and afraid to  
accept.

94 At long last Menelaus stood up and  
spoke among them,

- 95 raking them with his scorn, groaning  
deep at heart:
- 96 “Ah me — you threateners! Women of  
Achaëa, men of Achaëa no longer!5
- 97 Surely this disgrace will be grim  
beyond grimness
- 98 if no Danaan now goes out to meet  
Hector.
- 99 May every one of you turn to water and  
earth,
- 100 sitting there where you sit, heartless,  
fameless.
- 101 Against this man I will arm myself; the  
ends of victory
- 102 are held above us, in the hands of the  
immortal gods.”
- 103 So speaking he began to put on his  
beautiful armor.
- 104 And then, Menelaus, the end of your

life would have shown

105 at Hector's hands, since he was far the  
stronger,

106 had not the kings of the Achaeans  
sprung up and caught you —

107 and Atreus' son himself, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon,

108 took him by the right hand, and spoke  
a word, and named him:

109 "You are raving, Zeus-nurtured  
Menelaus — and this raving

110 is not required of you. Hold back,  
though it stings,

111 and do not, for pride's sake, fight a  
better man than you,

112 Hector, Priam's son — a man the  
others shudder at.

113 Even Achilles, in the battle where men  
win glory,



114 shivered to meet this man — and he is  
far better than you.<sup>6</sup>

115 Go now and sit among the company of  
your companions;

116 the Achaeans will put up another  
champion against this one.

117 Fearless though he is, and never sated  
with the grind of battle,

118 I say he will be glad to bend his knee  
in rest, if he escapes

119 out of the fury of war and the dread  
combat.”

120 So speaking the hero turned his  
brother’s mind,

121 for his urging was of things due; and  
he obeyed. Then his aides,<sup>7</sup>

122 rejoicing, lifted the armor from his  
shoulders;

123 and Nestor stood up among the

Argives and spoke:

124 “Shame! Great grief comes upon the  
Achaean land.

125 How the old horseman Peleus would  
groan aloud,<sup>8</sup>

126 the good counselor of the Myrmidons,  
their speaker —

127 who once in his own house delighted  
in questioning me

128 for the lineage and the birth of every  
man of the Argives.

129 If he heard of them now, cowering,  
every one, before Hector,

130 he would lift his dear hands to the  
immortals, over and over,

131 praying his spirit down out of his body  
into Hades’ house.

132 O father Zeus, Athena, Apollo —

133 would I were young, as when by quick-

running Celadon

134 the Pylians and the spear-mad  
Arcadians met and fought

135 by the walls of Pheia, around the  
streams of Iardanus.

136 Their champion stood forth:  
Ereuthalion, a man like a god,<sup>9</sup>

137 wearing on his shoulders the armor of  
lord Areithous —

138 brilliant Areithous, whom men called  
by his surname

139 Club-man — the men, and the fair-  
belted women —

140 because he fought with no bow, no  
long spear:

141 with a club of iron he smashed the  
companies apart.

142 Lycurgus killed him — by craft, not  
force at all —

143 in a narrow lane, where the iron club  
was no use  
144 to ward destruction off: Lycurgus was  
in first,  
145 pinned him through the middle with  
his spear, and he crashed back on the  
earth;  
146 and he stripped the armor brazen Ares  
had given him.  
147 That armor he wore himself, after, in  
the grind of Ares;  
148 and when Lycurgus was growing old  
in his halls  
149 he gave it to Ereuthalion, his dear  
aide, to wear —  
150 and wearing it, Ereuthalion challenged  
all our best.  
151 They trembled, they were terrified; no  
man dared.

152 But my much-enduring heart drove  
me on  
153 to fight him with its daring — and I  
was youngest-born of all —  
154 and I fought him, and Athena gave me  
my glory.  
155 The tallest and the strongest man I  
ever killed:  
156 a great sprawl of him lay there, this  
way and that.  
157 Would that I were young like that, my  
strength still steady!  
158 Hector of the flashing helmet would  
soon have his fight.  
159 But you — you who are the chief men  
of all the Achaeans —  
160 not even you are heartily eager to go  
and face Hector.”  
161 So the old man raked them; and nine

men in all stood up.<sup>10</sup>

<sup>162</sup> First by far to rise was the lord of men  
Agamemnon;

<sup>163</sup> after him rose Tydeus' son, strong  
Diomedes;

<sup>164</sup> after them the two Ajaxes, clothed in  
rushing courage;

<sup>165</sup> after them Idomeneus, and  
Idomeneus' comrade

<sup>166</sup> Meriones, the equal of Enyalios, slayer  
of men;

<sup>167</sup> after them Eurypylus, Euaemon's  
shining son;

<sup>168</sup> and up rose Thoas, Andraemon's son,  
and brilliant Odysseus:

<sup>169</sup> all these were willing to fight brilliant  
Hector.

<sup>170</sup> And among them spoke the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor:

171 “Shake now the lots, all of you, for the  
man who draws it:  
172 he is the one who will profit the  
strong-greaved Achaeans,  
173 and he will profit his own heart too, if  
he escapes  
174 out of the fury of war and the dread  
combat.”  
175 So he spoke, and each man marked his  
lot  
176 and they threw them into the helmet  
of Atreus’ son Agamemnon;  
177 and the armies prayed, and lifted their  
hands to the gods,  
178 and thus would one say, looking into  
the wide sky:  
179 “Father Zeus, let it be Ajax, or Tydeus’  
son,  
180 or the king himself of Mycenae rich in

gold.”

181 So they spoke; and the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor shook,

182 and out of the helmet leapt the lot  
they had wished for —

183 Ajax’s. And a herald carried it  
everywhere through the crowd,

184 showing it left to right to all the chief  
men of the Achaeans;

185 and each, not knowing the mark,  
denied it was his.

186 But when, carrying it everywhere  
through the crowd, he came

187 to the man who had marked it and  
thrown it in the helmet — glorious Ajax —

188 Ajax held out his hand, and the herald  
stood by him and dropped it in,

189 and he knew his lot’s mark at a glance,  
and rejoiced at heart.11



190 He threw it to the ground beside his  
foot, and called out:  
191 “Friends — the lot is mine! And I am  
glad  
192 with my whole heart, for I think I shall  
beat brilliant Hector.  
193 Come then: while I put on my battle  
armor,  
194 you pray to lord Zeus, the son of  
Cronos —  
195 in silence, to yourselves, so the  
Trojans do not hear —  
196 or aloud, for that matter, since we fear  
no man in any case.**12**  
197 For no man by force, by his will  
against my will, shall drive me off,  
198 nor by know-how either; I hope I was  
not born in Salamis  
199 and raised there to be such a know-

nothing as that.”

200 So he spoke, and they prayed to lord  
Zeus, son of Cronos,

201 and thus would one say, looking into  
the wide sky:

202 “Father Zeus, ruling from Ida, most  
glorious, greatest:

203 grant Ajax the victory and the  
winning of shining glory;

204 but if you love Hector too, and care  
for him,

205 then give to both of them equal  
strength and glory.”

206 So they spoke; and Ajax armed  
himself in gleaming bronze.

207 And when he had put all his armor  
about his body,

208 he charged out, huge as Ares comes  
on

209 when he goes to war among men  
whom the son of Cronos  
210 has thrown together to fight in the  
fury of heart-devouring strife.  
211 Such was gigantic Ajax as he rose, wall  
of the Achaeans,  
212 smiling with his grim face; and  
beneath him his feet  
213 went in long strides, and he shook his  
long-shadowed spear.  
214 And the Argives rejoiced to look at  
him,  
215 but a dread trembling came into the  
limbs of every Trojan,  
216 and Hector's own heart hammered in  
his chest;  
217 but there was no way now to shrink  
back or retreat  
218 into the crowd of his people: he had

made the challenge.

219 Ajax came near, carrying his shield  
like a tower,

220 bronze, of seven oxhides, which  
Tychius labored to make,13

221 far the best of leather-cutters, whose  
home was in Hyle:

222 he made him the glancing shield of  
seven hides

223 from well-fed bulls, and hammered on  
an eighth layer of bronze.

224 Carrying it before his chest,  
Telamonian Ajax

225 stood close in front of Hector, and  
spoke to him in threat:

226 “Hector, now you will learn, plainly,  
man to man,

227 what sort of chief men the Danaans  
have among them

228 even after Achilles, breaker of men,  
the lion-heart.14

229 He lies among his beaked seagoing  
ships,

230 nursing his rage at Agamemnon,  
shepherd of the people;

231 but we are such as can stand up  
against you —

232 and there are many of us. Begin the  
fight.”

233 Then great Hector of the flashing  
helmet answered him:

234 “Ajax, Zeus-sprung son of Telamon,  
marshal of the people:

235 do not test me like some feeble boy

236 or a woman, who does not know the  
works of war.

237 I know battles; I know the killings of  
men.

238 I know how to swing my dried oxhide  
to the right,  
239 I know how to swing it left — that, to  
me, is shieldcraft that lasts;  
240 I know how to charge into the tumult  
of fast mares;  
241 and I know, at close quarters, the  
dance of hostile Ares.**15**  
242 But I have no wish to hit a man of  
your size  
243 by stealth, watching my moment:  
openly, if I can.”  
244 He spoke, and balancing his long-  
shadowed spear he hurled it,  
245 and struck the terrible sevenhide  
shield of Ajax  
246 on the outermost bronze, the eighth  
layer upon it:  
247 through six folds the unwearying

bronze went shearing,  
248 and in the seventh hide it held.  
Second in turn,  
249 Zeus-sprung Ajax hurled his long-  
shadowed spear  
250 and struck the shield of Priam's son,  
balanced every way.16  
251 Through the shining shield the heavy  
spear went,  
252 and through the richly worked corslet  
it drove;  
253 and straight on beside his flank the  
spear sheared through  
254 the tunic — but he had swerved aside,  
and dodged black doom.  
255 Then the two of them, pulling out the  
long spears with their hands,  
256 fell on each other like lions that eat  
flesh raw

257 or wild boars, whose strength does not  
give out.17

258 Priam's son stabbed the shield full in  
the middle with his spear,

259 but the bronze did not break through:  
its point was bent back.

260 And Ajax, leaping in, pierced the  
shield: straight through

261 the spear went, and staggered him in  
his fury;

262 it came cutting in a graze at his neck,  
and the black blood welled up.

263 But even so Hector of the flashing  
helmet did not leave the fight:

264 he gave ground, and seized in his thick  
hand a stone

265 lying in the plain, black and rough and  
huge;

266 with it he struck the terrible



sevenhide shield of Ajax

267 full on the central boss, and the  
bronze rang out around.

268 Then Ajax in turn lifted a far greater  
stone,

269 whirled, and threw it, putting  
measureless force behind it,

270 and broke the shield inward with the  
millstone rock

271 and hurt his knees under him; and he  
was stretched on his back,

272 pinned to the shield. But Apollo  
straightened him at once.18

273 And now they would have been  
stabbing hand to hand with swords,

274 had not the heralds, messengers of  
Zeus and of men,

275 come between — one from the  
Trojans, one from the bronze-shirted

276 Achaeans: Talthybius and Idaeus, wise  
men both.

277 They held their staffs between the  
two; and the herald Idaeus,

278 whose mind was full of wise counsel,  
spoke his word:

279 “Fight no more, dear sons; battle no  
longer.

280 Zeus the cloud-gatherer loves you  
both alike,

281 and both of you are spearmen: that we  
all know.

282 And night is coming on. It is good to  
yield to night as well.”<sup>19</sup>

283 Answering him spoke Telamonian  
Ajax:

284 “Idaeus, tell Hector to say those  
things:

285 it was he who challenged all our best

men to the fight.

286 Let him lead; and I will follow  
whatever he does.”

287 Then great Hector of the flashing  
helmet answered him:

288 “Ajax — since a god has given you  
stature and strength

289 and good sense, and with the spear  
you are strongest of the Achaeans,

290 let us stop our fighting and our  
combat

291 for today. Later we will fight again,  
until the god

292 decides between us, and hands victory  
to one side or the other.

293 And night is coming on. It is good to  
yield to night as well —

294 so you may gladden all the Achaeans  
by the ships,

295 your kinsmen above all, and the  
companions who are yours;  
296 and I, through the great city of lord  
Priam,  
297 will gladden the Trojans and the  
Trojan women with their trailing gowns,  
298 who will go into the gods' assembly-  
place with prayers for me.  
299 Come — let us give each other  
glorious gifts,  
300 so that Achaeans and Trojans alike  
will say:  
301 ‘The two of them fought in heart-  
devouring strife,  
302 and parted again joined together in  
friendship.’”  
303 So speaking, he gave him his silver-  
studded sword,  
304 bringing it with its sheath and its

well-cut baldric;

305 and Ajax gave his war-belt, bright  
with crimson.20

306 So the two parted: one went to the  
Achaean host,

307 the other to the crowd of the Trojans.  
And they rejoiced

308 to see him come to them alive and  
unhurt,

309 escaped from the fury of Ajax and his  
untouchable hands,

310 and led him to the city, scarcely  
believing him safe.

311 And on the other side the strong-  
greaved Achaeans led Ajax,

312 glad in his victory, to brilliant  
Agamemnon.

313 And when they were gathered in the  
huts of Atreus' son,

314 the lord of men Agamemnon  
slaughtered an ox for them,  
315 a male of five years, to the  
overmastering son of Cronos.  
316 They flayed it and dressed it, and cut it  
all apart,  
317 and deftly chopped it small and  
threaded it on spits,  
318 roasted it with care, and drew it all off.  
319 Then when they had finished the work  
and made the meal ready,  
320 they feasted, and no heart lacked a  
fair share of the feast;  
321 and Ajax was honored with the long  
cuts of the chine<sup>21</sup>  
322 by the hero, Atreus' son, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon.  
323 And when they had put away desire  
for eating and drinking,

324 the old man first of all began to weave  
his counsel —

325 Nestor, whose plan had shown itself  
best before as well.

326 With good will toward them he spoke  
and addressed them:

327 “Son of Atreus, and you other chief  
men of all the Achaeans:

328 many of the long-haired Achaeans are  
dead,

329 whose dark blood sharp Ares has  
scattered now

330 along fair-flowing Scamander, and  
their souls have gone down to Hades.

331 Therefore with dawn have the  
Achaeans stop the fighting;

332 and let us gather and wheel the  
corpses back here

333 with oxen and mules, and burn them

334 a little off from the ships, so each man  
may carry the bones  
335 home to the children, when we return  
to our fatherland.22  
336 And around the pyre let us heap a  
single mound, drawn up  
337 from the plain, one mound for all  
alike; and against it build  
338 with all speed high towers, a shelter  
for the ships and ourselves.  
339 And in them let us make close-fitted  
gates,  
340 so that a road for chariots runs  
through;  
341 and outside, close by, let us dig a deep  
ditch  
342 to circle it, and hold off chariots and  
men,  
343 so the war of the proud Trojans never



breaks over us.”

344 So he spoke, and all the kings  
approved.

345 Now the Trojans held assembly on the  
height of Ilion,

346 a dread assembly, all in tumult, at  
Priam’s doors;

347 and among them wise Antenor began  
to speak:

348 “Hear from me, Trojans and  
Dardanians and allies,

349 so I may say what the heart in my  
chest commands me.

350 Come now: Argive Helen and her  
possessions with her

351 let us give to the sons of Atreus to lead  
away. Now it is with sworn

352 oaths made false that we fight; and so  
I have no hope

353 that anything will end well for us,  
unless we do this.”**23**

354 So he spoke and sat down; and among  
them rose

355 brilliant Alexandros, husband of  
lovely-haired Helen,

356 who spoke to him in answer with  
winged words:

357 “Antenor, this talk of yours pleases me  
no longer;

358 you know how to think another word,  
better than this one.

359 But if you truly say this thing in  
earnest,

360 then the gods themselves have  
destroyed your wits.

361 And I will speak out among the horse-  
taming Trojans:

362 I say it straight out — the woman I will

not give back.

363 But the goods, all I brought from  
Argos to our house —

364 all these I am willing to give, and to  
add more of my own.”

365 So he spoke and sat down; and among  
them rose

366 Priam, Dardanus’ descendant, the  
equal of the gods in counsel.

367 With good will toward them he spoke  
and addressed them:

368 “Hear from me, Trojans and  
Dardanians and allies,

369 so I may say what the heart in my  
chest commands me.

370 Now take your supper through the  
city, as before,

371 and remember the watch, and stay  
awake, every man.

372 At dawn let Idæus go to the hollow  
ships  
373 to tell the sons of Atreus, Agamemnon  
and Menelaus,  
374 the word of Alexandros, for whose  
sake this quarrel rose;  
375 and to say this shrewd word too:  
whether they are willing  
376 to rest from the harsh-crying war  
until we burn  
377 the dead. Later we will fight again,  
until the god  
378 decides between us, and hands victory  
to one side or the other.”  
379 So he spoke, and they listened well to  
him and obeyed;  
380 and they took their supper through  
the army, in their companies.  
381 At dawn Idæus went to the hollow

ships,

382 and found the Danaans, squires of  
Ares, in assembly

383 by the stern of Agamemnon's ship;  
and among them,

384 standing in the middle, the far-calling  
herald spoke:

385 "Son of Atreus, and you other chief  
men of all the Achaeans:

386 Priam and the other proud Trojans  
command me

387 to tell you — if it should be welcome  
and sweet to you —

388 the word of Alexandros, for whose  
sake this quarrel rose.

389 The goods that Alexandros brought to  
Troy in his hollow

390 ships — how he should have perished  
first! —

391 all these he is willing to give, and to  
add more of his own.

392 But the wedded wife of glorious  
Menelaus

393 he says he will not give — though the  
Trojans, I tell you, command it.

394 And they told me to say this too:  
whether you are willing

395 to rest from the harsh-crying war  
until we burn

396 the dead. Later we will fight again,  
until the god

397 decides between us, and hands victory  
to one side or the other.”

398 So he spoke, and they all went still in  
silence.

399 At long last Diomedes, good at the  
war-cry, spoke:

400 “Let no man now accept the goods of

Alexandros —

401 nor Helen either. It is known, even to a  
plain fool,

402 that the cables of destruction are  
fastened on the Trojans already.”<sup>24</sup>

403 So he spoke, and all the sons of the  
Achaeans shouted,

404 marveling at the word of Diomedes,  
breaker of horses;

405 and then the lord Agamemnon spoke  
to Idaeus:

406 “Idaeus — you hear the word of the  
Achaeans yourself,

407 how they give you their answer. And it  
pleases me so.

408 But as for the dead — I do not grudge  
their burning.

409 There is no stinting toward the bodies  
of the dead:

410 once they are gone, be quick with the  
fire's appeasement.  
411 And let Zeus the loud-thunderer,  
Hera's lord, witness the oaths."  
412 So speaking he lifted up the scepter to  
all the gods,  
413 and Idaeus went back toward holy  
Ilion.  
414 The Trojans and Dardanians were  
sitting in assembly,  
415 all gathered together, waiting for the  
moment  
416 Idaeus should come; and he came, and  
delivered his message,  
417 standing in the middle. Then they  
made ready with all speed,  
418 in two parties: one to bring the  
corpses, one to fetch wood;  
419 and the Argives on their side, from the



well-benched ships,  
420 hurried too — some to bring the  
corpses, others to fetch wood.  
421 The sun was just striking the fields  
with its first light,  
422 climbing into the sky out of the deep,  
soft-flowing  
423 stream of Ocean, when the two sides  
met each other.  
424 Then it was hard to know each man  
again;  
425 but washing off the clotted gore with  
water,  
426 and letting warm tears fall, they lifted  
them onto the wagons.  
427 But great Priam would not let them  
wail; so in silence25  
428 they heaped the corpses on the pyre,  
grieving at heart,

429 and when they had burned them in  
the fire, went to holy Ilion.  
430 And just so, on the other side, the  
strong-greaved Achaeans  
431 heaped the corpses on the pyre,  
grieving at heart,  
432 and when they had burned them in  
the fire, went to the hollow ships.  
433 And when it was not yet dawn, but the  
night still half-light,<sup>26</sup>  
434 then a picked company of Achaeans  
woke around the pyre,  
435 and they heaped around it a single  
mound, drawn up  
436 from the plain, one mound for all  
alike; and against it they built  
437 a wall with high towers, a shelter for  
the ships and themselves.  
438 And in them they set close-fitted

gates,

439 so that a road for chariots ran  
through;

440 and outside they dug a deep ditch  
hard against it,

441 wide and great, and planted a row of  
stakes within it.

442 So the long-haired Achaeans labored;  
443 and the gods, sitting beside Zeus the  
lord of lightning,

444 watched the great work of the bronze-  
shirted Achaeans.

445 And Poseidon the earth-shaker began  
to speak among them:

446 “Father Zeus, is there a mortal left on  
the boundless earth

447 who will still tell the immortals his  
mind and purpose?

448 Do you not see? The long-haired

Achaean

- 449 have built themselves a wall to  
landward of the ships, and driven  
450 a ditch around it — and gave the gods  
no glorious hecatombs!
- 451 The fame of this will spread as far as  
the dawn-light scatters,  
452 and men will forget that wall which I  
and Phoebus Apollo  
453 built for the hero Laomedon, laboring  
hard.”
- 454 Deeply troubled, Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer answered him:
- 455 “Shame, wide-ruling earth-shaker —  
what a thing to say!
- 456 Some other god might tremble at this  
thought,  
457 one far feebler than you in hand and  
fury:

458 your fame will spread as far as the  
dawn-light scatters.  
459 Come now: when the long-haired  
Achaeans are gone  
460 again with their ships to their dear  
fatherland,  
461 break the wall up, sweep it all into the  
sea,  
462 and hide the wide beach over again  
with sand,  
463 so the great wall of the Achaeans may  
be effaced.”**27**  
464 So they spoke such things to one  
another;  
465 and the sun went down, and the  
Achaeans’ work was finished,  
466 and they slaughtered oxen through  
the huts, and took their supper.  
467 And ships had come in from Lemnos,

carrying wine,  
468 many of them, sent out by Jason's son  
Euneus,  
469 whom Hypsipyle bore to Jason,  
shepherd of the people.  
470 Separately, for the sons of Atreus,  
Agamemnon and Menelaus,  
471 Jason's son had given a thousand  
measures of wine to carry.  
472 From these ships the long-haired  
Achaeans bought their wine,  
473 some with bronze, and some with  
gleaming iron,  
474 some with hides, and some with the  
live cattle themselves,  
475 and some with slaves; and they set the  
rich feast going.28  
476 All night long the long-haired  
Achaeans

477 feasted, and the Trojans through the  
city, and their allies;  
478 and all night long Zeus the counselor  
devised evil against them,  
479 thundering terribly. And green fear  
took hold of them:29  
480 they poured the wine from their cups  
onto the ground, and no man  
481 dared drink before he poured to the  
overmastering son of Cronos.  
482 Then they lay down, and took the gift  
of sleep.

## Notes

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### NOTES

1. (7.8-10) Paris kills Menesthius, son of Areithous “the club-man” — the very Areithous whose story Nestor will tell in full at 136-149: the son dies at the book’s

door, the father's legend follows. A plant-and-payoff inside a single book. ↪

2. (7.44-53) Helenus “put together in his heart” the gods’ private plan — how the seer overheard a conversation between Apollo and Athena was already a problem for ancient critics; Aristarchus athetized 53 (“so I heard it in the voice of the gods”), the line that makes the eavesdropping explicit (apparatus, Line 53). Kept: seercraft as reception of divine speech is exactly Helenus’s office (6.76). ↪
3. (7.58-61) Athena and Apollo settle on the oak of Zeus “in the likeness of vulture birds, delighting in the men” — the gods as spectators, perched carrion-fashion above the duel they arranged. The poem’s frankest image of the divine audience. ↪
4. (7.76-91) Hector’s terms and the mound-speech: armor to the victor, the corpse home for its “due of fire” — and then the imagined sailor of a later age reading the tomb by the Hellespont. The poem’s clearest statement of the kleos-economy, spoken from the winner’s side of an imagined victory: even the man Hector kills is conscripted into Hector’s undying fame. (The Iliad’s audience knew such mounds on that shore.) ↪



5. (7.96) “Women of Achaea, men of Achaea no longer” — Menelaus borrows Thersites’ taunt verbatim (2.235): the loudmouth’s insult has become respectable under shame’s pressure. (Echo note; English repeats 2.235’s rendering.) ↩
6. (7.113-114) “Even Achilles... shivered to meet this man.” The absent hero as unit of measure again (cf. 2.768-770, 5.788-791) — here bent into hyperbole: nothing in the poem shows Achilles fearing Hector, and Book 22 will show the reverse. Agamemnon’s flattery of Hector serves his need to stop his brother. ↩
7. (7.120-121) αἵσιμα παρειπών — “his urging was of things due” — the same narratorial formula that follows Agamemnon’s atrocity-counsel at 6.62. Here the counsel is unimpeachable (saving Menelaus from a fatal mismatch), which weighs on the Book 6 dispute: the formula commends the persuasion’s aptness, not its morality. ↩
8. (7.124-131) Nestor conjures Peleus at home — the old man who once joyfully catalogued the Argives’ lineages, now imagined praying for death at news of their shame. First full sounding of the Peleus-motif: the father at home as the war’s moral audience

(Odysseus will weaponize the same figure to Achilles at 9.252-259). ↩

9. (7.132-156) The Ereuthalion story, promised at 4.319 and delivered here: Areithous the Club-man with his iron club (iron again the marked exception, cf. 4.123), killed by craft in a lane too narrow to swing in; the armor's passage from Ares' gift to Lycurgus to Ereuthalion; and young Nestor, "youngest-born of all," taking down the giant. This Lycurgus is an Arcadian mortal — not the Thracian god-fighter of 6.130-140 who shares the name. ↩
10. (7.161-169) The nine volunteers — the poem's explicit roster of the best available Achaeans with Achilles out: both Atreidae, Diomedes, both Ajaxes, Idomeneus, Meriones, Eurypylus, Thoas, Odysseus. The lot-prayer at 179-180 then ranks the top three in the army's own eyes: Ajax, Diomedes, Agamemnon. ↩
11. (7.175-189) The lot-procedure: each man scratches his mark (σῆμα) on his token; the herald carries the leaping lot around until its owner recognizes it. Like the "baneful signs" of 6.168, marks that identify without being read as language — the poem's world writes tokens, not texts. ↩

12. (7.195-199) Ajax's instructions — pray silently so the Trojans don't hear, "or aloud, for that matter, since we fear no man" — athetized by Zenodotus, Aristophanes, and Aristarchus all three (apparatus, Line 195-199). The swagger is pure Ajax; kept. ↩
13. (7.219-223) The tower shield: seven oxhides and an eighth face of bronze, made by Tychius of Hyle, "far the best of leather-cutters" — the craftsman-vignette again (cf. Phereclus, 5.59-64). Ajax's body-length shield is older military technology than the round shields elsewhere in the poem — a fossil the tradition preserved with the hero it belonged to. ↩
14. (7.226-232) "even after Achilles, breaker of men, the lion-heart" — Ajax concedes the ranking in the act of boasting; the poem's second-best hero is the one who says "second" out loud (cf. 2.768-769). ↩
15. (7.237-241) Hector's credo: shield-work right and left, the charge, and "at close quarters, the dance of hostile Ares" — war as a craft with figures and steps (μέλπεσθαι, properly of dance and song). The self-description of a man who has made himself skilled at what he tells Andromache he has "learned" to do (6.444-445). ↩

16. (7.244-254) The spear-exchange replays the Paris-Menelaus duel verbatim: 250-254 = 3.355-360, and the English here repeats the Book 3 rendering word for word. The rematch of Book 3 with the war's real principals is scored on the same notes — except that this time both men are too good for the first exchange to decide anything. ↩
17. (7.255-257) The lions-and-boars simile — athetized by Zenodotus (apparatus, Line 255-257); nearly the same pair as 5.782-783. Kept, as the moment the formal duel becomes simply combat. ↩
18. (7.268-272) The stones: Hector's blow rings the bronze; Ajax's millstone rock breaks the shield inward and folds Hector's knees — "but Apollo straightened him at once." The god's whole intervention in five words; without it the duel (and the poem) ends here. ↩
19. (7.279-282) The heralds part them with staffs, and Idaeus — the Trojan herald of 3.248 — gives the evening its proverb: "It is good to yield to night as well." Night as the arbiter both armies obey; Hector repeats the line back with full agreement (293). ↩
20. (7.287-305) The gift-exchange: Hector's silver-studded sword for Ajax's crimson war-belt, "so that Achaeans

and Trojans alike will say... they parted again joined together in friendship.” Tradition made both gifts fatal: Ajax falls on Hector’s sword (Sophocles’ Ajax), and Hector’s corpse is dragged by Ajax’s belt — “the gifts of enemies are no gifts.” The poem itself says nothing; the exchange is left shining. (Aristarchus athetized 295, the “kinsmen and companions” line, within Hector’s speech.) ↩

21. (7.321-322) The chine — the unbroken length of the back-cut — is the portion of honor, awarded to Ajax by Agamemnon: the feast as scoreboard (cf. Idomeneus’s ever-full cup, 4.257-263). ↩
22. (7.327-343) Nestor’s double proposal: burn the dead, and build the wall. Aristarchus athetized 334-335 — carrying the bones “home to the children” reflects classical Athenian practice (the state funeral), not Homeric cremation-and-mound, and the couplet has long been suspected as an Athenian interpolation (apparatus, Line 334-335). The wall itself is the poem’s new stage-set: Books 8-15 will be fought around it. ↩
23. (7.345-353) Antenor moves to give Helen back — the appeasement party in Troy made explicit (he hosted the pre-war embassy, 3.205-224; later tradition

spared his house at the sack for it). Aristarchus  
athetized 353. Paris's counter-offer — goods yes,  
“the woman I will not give back” — and Priam's  
meek relay of it complete the pattern: Troy's  
assembly knows the right answer and cannot act on  
it. ↩

24. (7.399-402) Diomedes' refusal: take neither the goods  
“nor Helen either — the cables of destruction are  
fastened on the Trojans already.” The rope-image  
answers Menelaus's “ends of victory... held above”  
(101-102): the gods hold the rope-ends of outcomes.  
The young man silent under rebuke in Book 4 now  
answers embassies for the army, with the crowd  
shouting assent — the arc runs straight on to 9.32-  
49. (Echo note.) ↩

25. (7.421-432) The shared field at dawn: both sides  
washing the clotted blood from the dead they  
cannot recognize, “letting warm tears fall” — and  
Priam forbidding lament, as the Achaeans mourn  
unforbidden. The armies' identical griefs are given  
identical lines (428-429 = 431-432, Ilion for the  
ships); the translation keeps the symmetry exact. ↩

26. (7.433-441) “not yet dawn, but the night still half-  
light” (ἀμφιλύκη νύξ — only here in Homer): in the

grey hour, the Achaeans raise one mound “for all alike” (ἄκριτον — undivided, no man singled) — the common grave of a common army, in contrast to every individual mound the poem imagines (cf. 86-91). ↩

27. (7.443-464) The gods audit the wall: Poseidon’s professional jealousy (he and Apollo built Laomedon’s wall — the last time Troy’s ruler cheated them, 21.441-457), the missing hecatombs, and Zeus’s remedy: erase it when the war ends, sea and sand over everything. Zenodotus, Aristophanes, and Aristarchus athetized the whole exchange (apparatus, Line 443-464); Aristotle admired it as the poet “effacing” his own invention — the poem arranges in advance why no trace of its greatest earthwork survives on the real coast (the demolition comes at 12.13-33). ↩

28. (7.467-475) The wine-fleet from Lemnos, sent by Euneus, son of Jason and Hypsipyle — the poem’s one glance at the Argonaut generation, now middle-aged commerce. The market-list prices the camp’s economy: bronze, iron, hides, live cattle — “and some with slaves” (ἄνδραπόδεσσι, the only occurrence of the classical word for chattel-slaves in

Homer; all three Alexandrians athetized the line, partly for that anachronism). Rendered “slaves” under the project’s policy: the traffic the poem’s captives fear is here, briefly, a line-item. ↩

29. (7.478-482) The book closes on the uneasy feast: Zeus thundering all night “devising evil,” green fear (χλωρὸν δέος — the fixed color of dread) on both armies, and no man drinking undedicated wine. After a day of institutions — duel, truce, wall, market — the last word is the god’s weather, and it is against them. ↩



# Book 8

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*Zeus bans the gods from the battle; the golden scales tip against the Achaeans; the Trojans camp on the plain under a thousand watchfires.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 Dawn in her saffron robe was spreading over all the earth<sup>1</sup>
- 2 when Zeus who delights in thunder made an assembly of the gods
- 3 on the topmost peak of many-ridged Olympus;
- 4 and he spoke to them himself, and all the gods gave ear:
- 5 “Hear me, all you gods and all you goddesses,

- 6 so I may say what the heart in my chest  
commands me.
- 7 Let no female god attempt — and no  
male either —
- 8 to cut across this word of mine: all of  
you together
- 9 assent to it, so I may bring these things  
quickly to their end.
- 10 Whomever I mark trying, apart from  
the gods, by his own choice,
- 11 to go and help either Trojans or  
Danaans,
- 12 struck out of all order he shall come  
back to Olympus —
- 13 or I will take and hurl him into misty  
Tartarus,
- 14 far down, where the deepest pit yawns  
under the earth,
- 15 where the gates are iron and the

threshold bronze,

16 as far beneath Hades as heaven is above  
the earth:2

17 then he will know how far I am  
strongest of all gods.

18 Or come, try it, gods — so all of you  
may know:

19 hang a golden cord down out of heaven

20 and lay hold of it, all you gods and all  
you goddesses:

21 you could not drag out of heaven down  
to the plain

22 Zeus the counselor most high — not if  
you wore yourselves out.

23 But whenever I chose to pull in earnest,

24 I would haul you up, and the earth and  
the sea with you;

25 then I would bind the cord around a  
horn of Olympus,

26 and the whole of it would hang in the air.

27 By so much am I beyond gods, and beyond men.”<sup>3</sup>

28 So he spoke, and they all went still in silence,

29 marveling at his word: he had spoken with great power.

30 At long last the goddess grey-eyed Athena spoke:

31 “Father of us all, son of Cronos, highest of the mighty:

32 well do we know your strength is not to be bent;

33 but even so we grieve for the Danaan spearmen

34 who will fill up an evil doom and perish.

35 Yes: we will hold back from the war, as

you command;

36 but we will put counsel into the  
Argives — such as will help them —  
37 so they do not all perish under your  
anger.”

38 Smiling, Zeus the cloud-gatherer  
answered her:

39 “Take heart, Tritogeneia, dear child: I  
do not speak

40 with a set purpose; and toward you I  
mean to be gentle.”<sup>4</sup>

41 So speaking he yoked beneath his car  
the bronze-hoofed horses,

42 swift-flying, with manes streaming  
gold,

43 and clothed himself in gold, and took  
the whip,

44 gold, well-wrought, and mounted the  
chariot,

45 and whipped the horses on; and the  
two flew, nothing loath,  
46 between the earth and the starry sky.  
47 He came to Ida of the many springs,  
mother of wild things,  
48 to Gargaron, where his precinct is, and  
his smoking altar.<sup>5</sup>  
49 There the father of men and gods  
halted his horses,  
50 loosed them from the car, and poured  
thick mist around them;  
51 and he sat on the peaks, exulting in his  
glory,  
52 looking out at the Trojans' city and the  
ships of the Achaeans.  
53 Now the long-haired Achaeans took  
their meal  
54 quickly through the huts, and armed  
themselves straight after;

55 and the Trojans on their side armed  
through the city,  
56 fewer — yet even so they were mad to  
join battle,  
57 under hard necessity, for their children  
and their wives.  
58 All the gates were flung open, and the  
host streamed out,  
59 foot-soldiers and horsemen; and a  
great din arose.  
60 And when they had come together into  
one place,  
61 they dashed together shields, and  
spears, and the fury of men  
62 armored in bronze; the bossed shields  
63 pressed hard on one another, and a  
great din arose.  
64 There rose together the groaning and  
the boasting of men

65 killing and killed, and the earth ran  
with blood.

66 So long as it was morning, and the  
sacred day still growing,

67 so long the missiles of both sides struck  
home, and the people fell.

68 But when the Sun bestrode the middle  
of heaven,

69 then the father stretched out his  
golden scales,

70 and set in them two fates of death that  
lays men low,

71 one for the horse-taming Trojans, one  
for the bronze-shirted Achaeans,

72 and took the middle and pulled; and  
the Achaeans' day of doom sank.<sup>6</sup>

73 The Achaeans' fates settled down on  
the earth

74 that feeds so many, and the Trojans'



rose toward the wide sky.

75 And he thundered aloud from Ida, and  
sent a blazing

76 flash among the Achaean host; and  
they saw it

77 and were stunned, and green fear took  
hold of them all.

78 Then neither Idomeneus dared stand,  
nor Agamemnon,

79 nor the two Ajaxes hold their ground,  
squires of Ares:

80 Nestor alone stayed, the Gerenian,  
warden of the Achaeans —

81 in no way willing: his horse was failing,  
shot by an arrow

82 from brilliant Alexandros, lovely-  
haired Helen's husband,

83 on the very crown of the head, where a  
horse's first hairs

84 grow on the skull — the deadliest spot  
of all.

85 It reared in agony as the shaft went  
into the brain,

86 and threw the team into chaos,  
writhing around the bronze.

87 And while the old man leapt with his  
sword to cut away

88 the trace-horse, Hector's swift horses  
came on

89 through the rout, carrying their bold  
driver —

90 Hector. And there the old man would  
have lost his life,

91 had not Diomedes, good at the war-cry,  
been quick to see.

92 He shouted terribly, calling Odysseus  
on:

93 “Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus

of many devices —

94 where are you running, your back  
turned, like a coward in the crowd?

95 Take care no one plants a spear in that  
back as you flee!

96 Stand, till we beat this wild man off the  
old one.”

97 So he spoke; and much-enduring  
brilliant Odysseus did not hear,<sup>7</sup>

98 but swept on past, toward the hollow  
ships of the Achaeans.

99 Then Tydeus’ son, alone as he was,  
mixed with the front-fighters

100 and made his stand before the horses  
of the old man, Neleus’ son,

101 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:

102 “Old man, the young fighters are  
wearing you hard;

103 your force is unstrung, and hard old  
age attends you;  
104 your aide is feeble now, and your  
horses slow.  
105 Come, get up into my car, and see  
106 what the horses of Tros are like, how  
they know their plain —8  
107 how to wheel fast this way and that, in  
pursuit or flight.  
108 I took the pair from Aeneas — those  
two machines of rout.  
109 Let our aides look after yours; these  
two  
110 we will drive straight at the horse-  
taming Trojans, so that even Hector  
111 may know whether my spear too rages  
in my hands.”  
112 So he spoke, and the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor did not disobey.

113 Then their two aides looked after  
Nestor's mares,  
114 strong Sthenelus, and Eurymedon the  
kindly;  
115 and the two of them mounted  
Diomedes' chariot.  
116 Nestor took the glossy reins into his  
hands  
117 and whipped the horses; and quickly  
they closed with Hector.  
118 Straight at him, as he charged, the son  
of Tydeus cast:  
119 him he missed — but his driver and  
aide,  
120 Eniopeus, son of high-hearted  
Thebaeus,  
121 he struck in the chest by the nipple as  
he held the reins.  
122 He crashed from the car, and the

swift-footed horses

123 shied back; and there his life and  
strength were unstrung.

124 And terrible grief closed over Hector's  
heart for his driver;

125 but he left him lying there, though  
grieving for his companion,

126 and went after a bold driver in his  
place; nor did his horses

127 lack a master long: for soon he found

128 bold Archeptolemus, Iphitus' son, and  
set him up

129 behind the swift horses, and gave the  
reins into his hands.

130 And now there would have been ruin,  
deeds beyond remedy,

131 and they would have been penned in  
Ilion like lambs,

132 had not the father of men and gods

been quick to see.

133 Thundering terribly he let fly a white-hot bolt

134 and dashed it to the ground before the horses of Diomedes;

135 and a terrible flame rose up of burning sulphur,

136 and the two horses, terrified, cowered under the car.

137 The glossy reins slipped out of Nestor's hands,

138 and he was afraid at heart, and said to Diomedes:

139 "Tydeus' son — come, turn the single-hoofed horses to flight.

140 Do you not see? Victory out of Zeus does not go with you.

141 Today it is that man Zeus, Cronos' son, hands the glory —

142 today; later, if he chooses, he will give  
it

143 to us in turn. No man can fend off the  
purpose of Zeus,

144 not even the strongest: for he is  
stronger by far.”<sup>9</sup>

145 Then answered him Diomedes, good at  
the war-cry:

146 “Yes, old man — all this you have said  
rightly and in due measure.

147 But this bitter grief comes over my  
heart and spirit:

148 Hector one day will say, speaking  
among the Trojans:

149 ‘Tydeus’ son ran before me to his  
ships.’

150 So he will boast one day. Then let the  
wide earth gape for me.”

151 Then answered him the Gerenian



horseman Nestor:

152 “Ah me, war-minded Tydeus’ son —  
what a thing to say.

153 Even if Hector calls you coward and  
weakling,

154 the Trojans will never believe him, nor  
the Dardanians,

155 nor the wives of the great-hearted  
Trojan shieldmen

156 whose husbands in their strength you  
tumbled in the dust.”

157 So speaking he turned the single-  
hoofed horses to flight

158 back through the rout; and the Trojans  
and Hector after them

159 with unearthly clamor poured their  
groaning missiles.

160 And over him great Hector of the  
flashing helmet shouted:

161 “Tydeus’ son — the Danaans of swift  
colts honored you  
162 beyond all others, with the seat, the  
meats, the full cups.  
163 Now they will dishonor you: you were  
a woman after all.  
164 Away with you, painted doll! Never,  
with me not yielding,  
165 shall you scale our towers, never carry  
off our women  
166 in your ships: before that, I will deal  
you your doom.”**10**  
167 So he spoke; and Tydeus’ son was torn  
two ways,  
168 whether to wheel the horses and fight  
him face to face.  
169 Three times he pondered it in mind  
and heart,  
170 and three times from the mountains of

Ida Zeus the counselor thundered,  
171 giving his sign to the Trojans: victory  
that turns the battle's tide.<sup>11</sup>  
172 And Hector called to the Trojans with  
a far-carrying shout:  
173 "Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians  
who fight at close quarters —  
174 be men, my friends; remember your  
rushing courage.  
175 I know that the son of Cronos has  
bowed his head and promised me  
176 victory and great glory — and grief for  
the Danaans.  
177 The fools! — contriving those walls of  
theirs,  
178 feeble things, not worth a thought:  
they will not hold my fury,  
179 and our horses will lightly leap the  
ditch they dug.

180 But when I have come among their  
hollow ships,  
181 then let there be some memory of  
burning fire,  
182 so I may fire the ships and kill the men  
themselves —  
183 the Argives by their ships, dazed in  
the smoke.”  
184 So speaking he called to his horses,  
and named them:  
185 “Xanthus, and you, Podargus, and  
Aethon, and brilliant Lampus:12  
186 now pay me back your keep — all the  
care and plenty  
187 of Andromache, great-hearted Eëtion’s  
daughter,  
188 who set the honey-hearted wheat  
before you first,  
189 and mixed wine for you to drink when

your hearts commanded —

190 before me, and I claim to be her strong  
young husband.13

191 After them now, at full stretch, so we  
may take

192 the shield of Nestor, whose fame now  
reaches heaven —

193 solid gold, they say, the cross-rods and  
the shield itself —

194 and off the shoulders of Diomedes,  
breaker of horses,

195 the wrought corslet Hephaestus  
labored to make.14

196 Could we take those two things, I  
should hope to put the Achaeans

197 aboard their swift ships this very  
night.”

198 So he spoke in his vaunting; and the  
lady Hera was outraged:

199 she shook on her throne and made  
high Olympus tremble,  
200 and spoke straight out to the great  
god Poseidon:  
201 “Shame, wide-ruling earth-shaker —  
not even you,  
202 in your own chest, grieve for the  
Danaans as they die.  
203 Yet to you, to Helice and Aegae, they  
bring gifts up, 15  
204 many and pleasing; then wish them  
victory now.  
205 If only we chose — all of us who stand  
by the Danaans —  
206 to thrust the Trojans back and hold  
off wide-seeing Zeus,  
207 he could sit there and sulk, alone on  
Ida.”  
208 Deeply troubled, the lord earth-

shaker answered her:

209 “Hera, reckless of tongue — what a  
word you have spoken!

210 I would not choose to have the rest of  
us fight

211 Zeus, Cronos’ son: for he is stronger by  
far.”

212 So they spoke such things to one  
another;

213 and all the space the ditch walled off  
between wall and ships

214 filled with a crush of horses and  
shield-bearing men

215 penned in: and the penner was Hector,  
Priam’s son,

216 the equal of quick Ares, now that Zeus  
gave him glory.

217 And he would have burned the  
balanced ships with blazing fire,

218 had not the lady Hera put it in  
Agamemnon's mind  
219 to bestir himself and rouse the  
Achaean, quickly.  
220 He went his way along the huts and  
ships of the Achaeans  
221 holding a great purple cloak in his  
heavy hand,  
222 and stood on Odysseus's black ship,  
huge of hull,  
223 which lay midmost, so a shout could  
carry to both ends,  
224 both to the huts of Ajax, Telamon's  
son,  
225 and to Achilles' — for they had drawn  
their balanced ships up  
226 at the ends, trusting their courage and  
the strength of their hands.16  
227 There he called to the Danaans,



piercing-clear:

228 “Shame, Argives! Vile disgraces —  
admired only for your looks!

229 Where have the boasts gone, when we  
said we were the best —

230 the boasts you made on Lemnos, all  
empty wind,17

231 eating your fill of the flesh of straight-  
horned oxen,

232 drinking the bowls brimmed over  
with wine:

233 that each of you would stand against a  
hundred Trojans

234 in battle — two hundred! Now we are  
not worth one:

235 Hector, who soon will fire the ships  
with blazing flame.

236 Father Zeus — was there ever another  
great king

237 you blinded with blindness like this,  
and stripped of his great glory?  
238 And yet I say I never passed one  
beautiful altar of yours  
239 on my luckless way here in my many-  
benched ship:  
240 on every one I burned the fat and the  
thighs of oxen,  
241 in my longing to sack well-walled  
Troy.  
242 But Zeus — grant me at least this wish:  
243 let these men at least escape and get  
away;  
244 do not let the Achaeans be broken by  
the Trojans so.”  
245 So he spoke; and the father pitied his  
weeping,  
246 and nodded: the host should be saved,  
and not perish.

247 At once he sent an eagle — surest of  
omens among birds —  
248 holding a fawn in its talons, young of  
a running deer;  
249 beside the beautiful altar of Zeus it  
dropped the fawn,  
250 where the Achaeans made offering to  
Zeus of All Voices.<sup>18</sup>  
251 And when they saw that the bird had  
come from Zeus,  
252 they leapt the more on the Trojans,  
and remembered their fighting.  
253 Then no Danaan there, many as they  
were, could boast  
254 he was before Tydeus' son in holding  
his swift horses,  
255 driving them across the ditch, and  
fighting face to face:  
256 far the first, he took a Trojan armored

fighter,

257 Agelaus, Phradmon's son, just  
wheeling his horses to flight:

258 as he turned, the spear fixed in his  
back

259 between the shoulders and drove  
through his chest;

260 he crashed from the car, and his  
armor clattered upon him.

261 After him came the sons of Atreus,  
Agamemnon and Menelaus;

262 after them the two Ajaxes, clothed in  
rushing courage;

263 after them Idomeneus, and  
Idomeneus' comrade

264 Meriones, the equal of Enyalius, slayer  
of men;

265 after them Eurypylus, Euaemon's  
shining son;

266 and ninth came Teucer, bending his  
back-sprung bow,  
267 and took his stand under the shield of  
Ajax, Telamon's son.  
268 Ajax would edge the shield aside; and  
the hero,  
269 when he had scanned his man and  
shot into the crowd  
270 and hit him — the man dropped  
where he stood and lost his life —  
271 then back he would slip, like a child to  
his mother,**19**  
272 to Ajax; and Ajax hid him with the  
shining shield.  
273 Whom first of the Trojans did  
blameless Teucer take?  
274 Orsilochous first, and Ormenus, and  
Ophelestes,  
275 Daetor and Chromius and godlike

Lycophontes,

276 and Amopaon, Polyaeon's son, and  
Melanippus —

277 all these, one on another, he brought  
down to the earth that feeds so many.

278 And seeing him the lord of men  
Agamemnon rejoiced

279 as he wrecked the Trojan companies  
from his strong bow;

280 and he came and stood beside him  
and spoke his word:

281 "Teucer, dear heart, Telamon's son,  
marshal of the people:

282 keep shooting like that — and be a  
light to the Danaans,

283 and to your father Telamon, who  
reared you when you were little

284 and cared for you in his own house,  
bastard though you were:

285 set him in the way of glory, far off as  
he is.

286 And I will tell you outright, and it will  
be accomplished:

287 if aegis-bearing Zeus and Athena  
grant me

288 to sack the well-built citadel of Ilion,

289 first after myself I will set a prize of  
honor in your hands —

290 a tripod, or a pair of horses with their  
chariot,

291 or a woman, to climb into one bed  
with you.”

292 Answering him spoke blameless  
Teucer:

293 “Most glorious son of Atreus — why  
urge me on when I am

294 eager myself? So far as the strength is  
in me

295 I do not stop: from the hour we  
pushed them back toward Ilion,  
296 from then I have watched with my  
bow, and killed my men.  
297 Eight long-barbed arrows I have  
loosed by now,  
298 and all of them fixed in the flesh of  
quick young fighters;  
299 but this mad dog I cannot hit.”  
300 He spoke, and shot another arrow  
from the string  
301 straight at Hector, his heart aching to  
hit him:  
302 him he missed — but blameless  
Gorgythion,  
303 Priam’s brave son, he struck in the  
chest with the arrow —  
304 the son his wedded mother bore,  
brought from Aesyme,



305 beautiful Castianeira, in body like the  
goddesses.

306 And as a poppy in a garden lets its  
head fall sideways,

307 heavy with its own seed and the rains  
of spring,

308 so his head bowed to one side under  
the weight of the helmet.<sup>20</sup>

309 And Teucer shot another arrow from  
the string

310 straight at Hector, his heart aching to  
hit him;

311 but this one too he missed — Apollo  
brushed it wide —

312 and struck bold Archeptolemus,  
Hector's driver,

313 as he swept into battle, in the chest by  
the nipple.

314 He crashed from the car, and the

swift-footed horses

315 shied back; and there his life and  
strength were unstrung.

316 And terrible grief closed over Hector's  
heart for his driver;

317 but he left him lying there, though  
grieving for his companion,

318 and called to his brother Cebriones,  
who was near,

319 to take the horses' reins; and he heard,  
and did not disobey.

320 Hector himself leapt down from the  
shining chariot

321 with a terrible cry, and caught up a  
boulder in his hand,

322 and went straight for Teucer, his heart  
driving him to strike.

323 Teucer had drawn a bitter arrow from  
the quiver

324 and laid it on the string; and just as he  
drew, Hector  
325 of the flashing helmet struck him with  
the jagged stone  
326 beside the shoulder, where the  
collarbone parts the neck  
327 and chest, the deadliest spot of all, as  
he aimed at him,  
328 and snapped the bowstring; his hand  
went numb at the wrist;  
329 he dropped to his knees and stayed,  
and the bow fell from his hand.  
330 But Ajax did not neglect his fallen  
brother:  
331 running, he stood over him and  
covered him with the shield.  
332 Then two loyal companions stooped  
beneath him,  
333 Mecisteus, Echius' son, and brilliant

Alastor,

334 and carried him, groaning heavily, to  
the hollow ships.

335 And once more the Olympian woke  
fury in the Trojans,

336 and they pushed the Achaeans  
straight on the deep ditch;

337 and Hector went among the first,  
glorying in his strength.

338 As when a hound with quick feet  
presses a wild boar

339 or a lion from behind, snapping at  
flank

340 and buttock, and watches for the  
moment it turns,

341 so Hector pressed the long-haired  
Achaeans,

342 killing always the hindmost as they  
fled.

343 But when they had crossed the stakes  
and the ditch, running,  
344 and many were broken under Trojan  
hands,  
345 they halted and held their ground  
beside the ships,  
346 calling to one another, and lifting  
their hands  
347 to all the gods, each man prayed  
aloud;  
348 and Hector wheeled his lovely-maned  
horses this way and that,  
349 with the eyes of the Gorgon, or of Ares  
bane of mortals.**21**  
350 And seeing them the goddess white-  
armed Hera pitied them,  
351 and quickly spoke winged words to  
Athena:  
352 “Shame — child of aegis-bearing Zeus!

Shall the two of us

353 no longer care for the Danaans dying,  
even at the last?

354 They will fill up an evil doom and  
perish

355 under one man's onset — this Hector,  
Priam's son,

356 raging now past all bearing; and great  
evil he has done already.”

357 Then the goddess grey-eyed Athena  
answered her:

358 “That man might well have lost his  
fury and his life,

359 broken at Argive hands, dead in his  
own fatherland —

360 but my father rages with no good  
mind:

361 the hard god, forever the sinner,  
thwarter of my purposes.

362 He remembers nothing of all the  
times I saved his son  
363 worn to breaking under Eurystheus's  
labors:  
364 he would cry up to heaven, and Zeus  
would send me  
365 down out of heaven to stand by him  
and help.  
366 If my crafty mind had only known all  
this  
367 that time Eurystheus sent him down  
to the house of Hades the gate-closer,  
368 to bring out of Erebus the hound of  
hateful Hades —  
369 he would not have escaped the sheer  
waters of the Styx.<sup>22</sup>  
370 But now Zeus loathes me, and works  
out the plans of Thetis,  
371 who kissed his knees, and took his

chin in her hand,  
372 begging him to give honor to Achilles,  
sacker of cities.  
373 The day will come when he calls me  
his dear grey-eyes again.  
374 But you — harness the single-hoofed  
horses for the two of us,  
375 while I go down into the house of  
aegis-bearing Zeus  
376 and arm myself in gear for war — so I  
may see  
377 whether Priam's son, Hector of the  
flashing helmet,  
378 will be glad when the two of us appear  
on the causeways of battle —  
379 or whether some Trojan too will glut  
the dogs and the birds  
380 with his fat and his flesh, fallen beside  
the ships of the Achaeans.”



381 So she spoke, and the goddess white-  
armed Hera did not disobey.  
382 Hera went to and fro harnessing the  
golden-fronted horses —  
383 Hera, eldest goddess, daughter of  
great Cronos;  
384 and Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing  
Zeus,  
385 let fall her soft robe on her father's  
floor,  
386 the many-colored robe she herself  
had made and worked with her hands,  
387 and put on the tunic of Zeus the  
cloud-gatherer, 23  
388 and armed herself in his gear for  
tearful war.  
389 Into the flaming chariot she stepped,  
and gripped the spear —  
390 heavy, huge, compact — with which

she breaks the ranks of men,  
391 of heroes, when she of the mighty  
father is angered with them.  
392 And Hera swiftly touched the horses  
with the whip;  
393 and self-moved the gates of heaven  
groaned open, kept by the Seasons,  
394 to whom great heaven and Olympus  
are entrusted,  
395 to roll the thick cloud aside, or set it  
back.  
396 There, straight through, they held the  
goaded horses.  
397 But father Zeus, when he saw it from  
Ida, was terribly angered,  
398 and sent Iris of the golden wings to  
bear his message:  
399 “Up, go, swift Iris: turn them back; do  
not let them

400 come against me. It will be no fair  
meeting if we join in war.  
401 For I say this outright, and it will be  
accomplished:  
402 I will lame their swift horses under  
the chariot,  
403 hurl the two of them from the car, and  
smash the chariot;  
404 and not in ten circling years will they  
be healed  
405 of the wounds the thunderbolt tears  
— so grey-eyes may learn  
406 what it is to fight against her own  
father.  
407 With Hera I am not so indignant, not  
so angry:  
408 it has always been her way to cross  
whatever I say.”  
409 So he spoke; and storm-footed Iris

rose to bear the message,

410 and went from the mountains of Ida to  
high Olympus.

411 At the very gates of many-folded  
Olympus

412 she met them and held them, and told  
them the word of Zeus:

413 “Where are you two rushing? What is  
this madness raging in your hearts?

414 The son of Cronos forbids you to stand  
by the Argives.

415 For thus the son of Cronos threatens —  
and he will do it:

416 to lame your swift horses under the  
chariot,

417 hurl the two of you from the car, and  
smash the chariot;

418 and not in ten circling years will you  
be healed

419 of the wounds the thunderbolt tears —  
so you may learn,

420 grey-eyes, what it is to fight against  
your own father.

421 With Hera he is not so indignant, not  
so angry:

422 it has always been her way to cross  
whatever he says.

423 But you — appalling; you shameless  
dog — if you truly

424 dare to lift your gigantic spear against  
Zeus.”**24**

425 So speaking, swift-footed Iris went her  
way;

426 and Hera spoke her word to Athena:

427 “Shame — child of aegis-bearing Zeus:  
I say no longer

428 can the two of us make war on Zeus  
for the sake of mortals.

429 Of them, let one man perish, and  
another live,  
430 as it may fall; and let him, pondering  
his own purposes,  
431 judge between Trojans and Danaans,  
as is fitting.”<sup>25</sup>  
432 So speaking she turned the single-  
hoofed horses back.  
433 The Seasons unyoked their lovely-  
maned horses for them,  
434 and tethered them at the ambrosial  
mangers,  
435 and leaned the chariot against the  
shining inner wall;  
436 and the goddesses sat down on golden  
chairs  
437 among the other gods, their dear  
hearts sorrowing.  
438 And father Zeus drove his strong-

wheeled chariot and horses

439 from Ida to Olympus, and came to the  
sessions of the gods.

440 For him the famed earth-shaker  
unyoked the horses

441 and set the car on its stand, and  
spread a cloth across it;

442 and wide-seeing Zeus himself sat  
down on his golden throne,

443 and great Olympus shook beneath his  
feet.

444 Apart from Zeus, and alone, sat  
Athena and Hera,

445 and did not speak to him or question  
him;

446 but he understood in his heart, and  
spoke:

447 “Why so stricken, Athena and Hera?

448 Surely you are not worn out with

battle where men win glory —  
449 with killing Trojans, against whom  
you have set your dread hatred!  
450 Come what may — such is my fury, so  
untouchable my hands —  
451 all the gods there are on Olympus  
could not turn me.  
452 As for you two: trembling took your  
shining limbs  
453 before you ever saw the war, and war's  
grim works.  
454 For I will say this outright — and it  
would have been accomplished:  
455 struck by my thunderbolt, you two  
would never have come back  
456 on your own chariot to Olympus,  
where the immortals have their seat.”  
457 So he spoke, and they murmured at it,  
Athena and Hera,



458 who sat side by side plotting evils for  
the Trojans.

459 Athena, to be sure, stayed silent and  
said nothing,

460 sulking at father Zeus, wild anger  
gripping her;

461 but Hera's breast could not contain  
her anger, and she spoke:

462 "Most dread son of Cronos, what a  
word you have spoken!

463 Well do we know your strength is  
nothing feeble;

464 but even so we grieve for the Danaan  
spearmen

465 who will fill up an evil doom and  
perish.

466 Yes: we will hold back from the war, if  
you command;

467 but we will put counsel into the

Argives — such as will help them —

468 so they do not all perish under your  
anger.”

469 Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer:

470 “At dawn you will see him — if you  
have the heart for it,

471 ox-eyed lady Hera — the  
overmastering son of Cronos

472 wrecking still more of the great host  
of Argive spearmen.

473 For massive Hector will not stop from  
the fighting

474 until the swift-footed son of Peleus  
rises beside the ships,

475 on that day when they fight at the  
ships’ sterns,

476 in the narrowest, most terrible press,  
over Patroclus fallen.26

477 So it is decreed by heaven. And for  
your anger

478 I care nothing — not if you go to the  
nethermost limits

479 of earth and sea, where Iapetus and  
Cronos

480 sit, and take no joy in the rays of  
Hyperion the Sun,

481 nor in any wind, and deep Tartarus is  
all around them:

482 not if you reach that place in your  
wandering do I care

483 for your sulking — since there is  
nothing more dog-like than you.”<sup>27</sup>

484 So he spoke; and white-armed Hera  
answered him nothing.

485 And the bright light of the sun fell  
into Ocean,

486 drawing black night across the grain-

giving earth.

487 To the Trojans the light sank  
unwelcome; but to the Achaeans

488 dark night came welcome — thrice  
prayed for — very welcome.

489 Now glorious Hector made an  
assembly of the Trojans,

490 leading them apart from the ships, by  
the eddying river,

491 in a clear space, where ground showed  
empty of the dead.28

492 Stepping from their chariots to the  
earth they listened to the word

493 that Hector spoke, dear to Zeus. In his  
hand

494 he held a spear eleven cubits long; and  
before him the bronze

495 point of the shaft shone, and a ring of  
gold ran round it.

496 Leaning on this, he spoke his words to  
the Trojans:

497 “Hear from me, Trojans and  
Dardanians and allies.

498 Just now I said that I should destroy  
the ships and all

499 the Achaeans, and go back again to  
windy Ilion;

500 but darkness came too soon. That,  
above all, has saved

501 the Argives now, and the ships at the  
surf-line of the sea.

502 So then: for now, let us yield to black  
night

503 and make our supper ready. The  
lovely-maned horses —

504 loose them from under the cars, and  
throw fodder beside them;

505 and bring oxen from the city, and fat

sheep,  
506 quickly; get honey-hearted wine, and  
bread  
507 from your halls; and gather plenty of  
wood besides,  
508 so that all night long, till early-born  
Dawn,  
509 we may burn fires in plenty, and the  
glare go up to heaven —  
510 lest even by night the long-haired  
Achaeans  
511 make a run for home over the broad  
back of the sea.  
512 Not at their ease, at least! — not  
unbloodied shall they board:  
513 let many a one of them have a shaft to  
digest at home,  
514 struck by an arrow or a sharp spear  
515 as he leaps for his ship — so that

others too may shudder

516 to bring tearful war on the horse-  
taming Trojans.

517 And let heralds dear to Zeus announce  
through the city

518 that boys in first youth and grey-  
templed old men

519 are to post themselves around the  
town on the god-built towers;

520 and the women, every one of them,  
each in her hall,

521 to burn a great fire; and let the watch  
be kept unbroken,

522 lest a raiding party enter the town  
while the army is away.

523 So let it be, great-hearted Trojans, as I  
say it:

524 let the word that serves this night  
stand as spoken,

525 and the word for dawn I will speak  
among the horse-taming Trojans  
tomorrow.

526 I hope — with prayer to Zeus and the  
other gods —

527 to drive out of here those dogs whom  
the death-fates carry,29

528 whom the fates carried to us on their  
black ships.

529 So: through the night we will guard  
ourselves,

530 and early, toward dawn, armed in our  
gear,

531 we will waken sharp Ares beside the  
hollow ships.

532 I will know whether Tydeus' son,  
strong Diomedes,

533 will thrust me from the ships back on  
their wall — or whether I



534 will break him with the bronze and  
carry off his bloody spoils.  
535 Tomorrow he will find out his own  
worth — whether he can stand  
536 my spear as it comes on. No: among  
the first, I think,  
537 he will lie speared, and many  
companions around him,  
538 as the sun climbs tomorrow. Would  
that I were as surely  
539 deathless and ageless for all my days,  
540 and honored as Athena and Apollo are  
honored,  
541 as surely as this day now brings evil to  
the Argives!”**30**  
542 So Hector spoke; and the Trojans  
roared applause.  
543 They loosed their sweating horses  
from under the yoke

544 and tethered them with straps, each  
by his own chariot;  
545 and they brought oxen from the city,  
and fat sheep,  
546 quickly; got honey-hearted wine, and  
bread  
547 from their halls; and gathered plenty  
of wood besides;  
548 and they offered to the immortals  
perfect hecatombs.  
549 The winds carried the savor from the  
plain into the sky —  
550 sweet savor; but the blessed gods took  
no share of it;  
551 they would not: for holy Ilion was  
hated in their hearts, 31  
552 and Priam, and the people of Priam of  
the good ash spear.  
553 But they, high in their hopes, on the

causeways of battle

554 sat all night long, and their fires  
burned in multitudes.

555 As when in the sky the stars around  
the shining moon

556 appear in all their glory, when the air  
falls windless,

557 and all the lookout-peaks show clear,  
and the jutting headlands,

558 and the glens; and from heaven the  
measureless air breaks open,

559 and every star is seen; and the  
shepherd's heart is glad:32

560 so many, between the ships and the  
streams of Xanthus,

561 shone the fires the Trojans burned  
before Ilion.

562 A thousand fires burned in the plain,  
and beside each one

563 sat fifty men in the glare of the  
blazing fire.

564 And the horses, champing white  
barley and spelt,

565 stood beside the chariots, and waited  
for fair-throned Dawn.

## Notes

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### NOTES

1. (8.1) “Dawn in her saffron robe” (κροκόπεπλος) — a new dawn-formula for the register, distinct from “early-born rosy-fingered Dawn” (1.477); the book will close with a third, “fair-throned Dawn” (565). ↩
2. (8.13-16) Tartarus mapped: iron gates, bronze threshold, “as far beneath Hades as heaven is above the earth” — the cosmos as three equal stories, with the threat calibrated to the architecture. ↩
3. (8.18-27) The golden cord: all gods and goddesses on one end, Zeus on the other — and he would reel in

“the earth and the sea with you,” and hang the whole from a horn of Olympus. Zenodotus athetized 25-26 and Aristarchus condemned the sequel (apparatus, Lines 25-26, 28-34). Later antiquity allegorized the cord endlessly (the sun, the chain of being); in context it is a weight-boast, and the whole book is its demonstration. ↩

4. (8.38-40) Zeus smiles: “I do not speak with a set purpose; toward you I mean to be gentle.” Aristarchus athetized (= 22.183-184, where the lines recur). The wink complicates the ban — how seriously Zeus means his own decree is exactly what Books 8-15 keep testing. ↩
5. (8.47-48) Gargaron, Ida’s peak, “where his precinct is, and his smoking altar” — Zeus takes his seat above the battle at one of his own cult-sites: spectator’s box and shrine in one. ↩
6. (8.69-74) The golden scales: two “fates of death” weighed, and the Achaeans’ day of doom sinks. Aristarchus athetized 73-74 (apparatus). Zeus weighs but does not choose — the gesture that poses, without solving, the poem’s deepest question about Zeus and fate; it returns, for two men instead of two armies, at 22.209-213. ↩

7. (8.90-98) Odysseus, called by name to stand for old Nestor, “did not hear” (οὐδ’ ἑσάκουσε) — or did not heed? The Greek permits both, and ancient readers already argued; the poem moves on without comment, and Diomedes goes back alone. First Iliad occurrence of the Odysseus’s great epithet “much-enduring brilliant Odysseus” — in the poem’s least flattering moment for him. ↩
8. (8.105-108) Diomedes’ offer repeats his own words about the horses of Tros (5.221-223, verbatim in Greek and in this translation) — the captured team already a talking point. (Echo note.) ↩
9. (8.139-144) Nestor’s counsel of retreat: “No man can fend off the purpose of Zeus.” The old man articulates the book’s rule — divine favor is temporal (“today... later”) — and Diomedes’ agonized compliance (146-150 reuse the formulas of 1.286 and 4.182) marks the limit of even the best mortal’s aristeia. ↩
10. (8.161-166) Hector’s taunt — “you were a woman after all. Away with you, painted doll!” (κακὴ γλῆνη, a glass-eyed puppet or doll). Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized 164-166, and Zenodotus’s text read “I will deal you your death” (πότημον ἐφήσω) for

“deal you your doom” (δαίμονα δώσω) at 166 — the entry for this book in `disputed_lines.md` (#4). Kept: the gendered insult answers 163’s “you were a woman,” and Diomedes’ three-fold hesitation at 167-169 shows it landed. ↩

11. (8.169-171) “Three times he pondered... and three times Zeus thundered” — the three-then-fourth pattern (5.436-438) with the fourth beat removed: against Zeus there is no fourth try, only the sign obeyed. ↩
12. (8.185) Hector names four horses — Xanthus, Podargus, Aethon, Lampus — but a Homeric chariot is drawn by two, and Aristarchus athetized the line as un-Homeric (apparatus). This Xanthus is not Achilles’ immortal horse (19.400) nor the river; the poem’s names circulate. ↩
13. (8.186-190) Andromache fed the horses “before me” — wheat, and wine mixed in — the domestic tenderness of Book 6 recruited into Hector’s war-speech (Aristarchus athetized 189). The detail is the marriage in one image; that it surfaces as an argument to horses is Hector all over. ↩
14. (8.191-195) The fabulous targets: Nestor’s shield of solid gold “whose fame now reaches heaven,”

Diomedes' corslet forged by Hephaestus — neither is mentioned anywhere else in the poem. Rumor-armor, conjured by desire at the moment of imagined victory. ↩

15. (8.203) Helice and Aegae — Poseidon's great cult-seats on the Achaean gulf; Hera's argument is a priest's ledger: they pay you; act accordingly. ↩

16. (8.220-226) The camp's geography, stated plainly: Odysseus's ship at the midpoint, where a shout reaches both ends; Ajax and Achilles holding the exposed extremities, "trusting their courage and the strength of their hands." The arrangement (repeated at 11.5-9) is the war's org-chart in ship-positions — and explains why Hector's assault will fall where it falls. ↩

17. (8.228-235) "the boasts you made on Lemnos" — the wine-stop of the outbound voyage (the same Lemnos whose wine-fleet supplied the camp at 7.467-475): each man good for a hundred Trojans, two hundred. Agamemnon's rebuke opens with the same "Shame, Argives!" line as Hera's at 5.787 — the army's leaders now sound like its goddess. ↩

18. (8.247-252) The eagle drops the fawn beside the altar of "Zeus of All Voices" (Πανομφαῖος — source of



every omen): a sign delivered to the address of signs. Zeus grants the prayer's minimum — the host will not perish — while the day's verdict stands. ↩

19. (8.266-334) Teucer's aristeia: shooting from under Ajax's shield and slipping back "like a child to his mother" — the bastard brother (Agamemnon says the word, 284, in praise) whose skill is framed by dependency; his reward-list runs tripod, horses, "or a woman"; and his day ends with Hector's stone to the collarbone — "the deadliest spot" (326-327, the same anatomical formula as the horse's crown at 83-84). ↩

20. (8.302-308) Gorgythion: the son of a mother "beautiful as the goddesses," and the poppy heavy with seed and spring rain — the poem's most famous image of a death, a garden conscripted to carry a battlefield. Virgil took it for Euryalus (Aeneid 9.435-437). The vignette-technique of 4.473-489 perfected in three lines. ↩

21. (8.348-349) Hector wheeling "with the eyes of the Gorgon, or of Ares bane of mortals" — the Gorgon-face from Athena's own aegis (5.741) lent to the poem's most human warrior at his most daemonic.

The book's Hector is glory running ahead of its limit.



22. (8.362-369) Athena's grievance: she was Zeus's instrument for saving Heracles through Eurystheus's labors — including the descent “to bring out of Erebus the hound of hateful Hades”: Cerberus, present but unnamed, as at *Odyssey* 11.623. Her wish that he had drowned in Styx is savage even by Olympian standards (Zenodotus omitted, Aristarchus athetized 371-372, the Thetis-supplication reprise). ↩

23. (8.384-391) Athena's arming repeats 5.733-747 in abridged form — the robe she made herself falling on her father's floor — and Zenodotus/Aristophanes/Aristarchus objected here too (apparatus, Line 385-387). The English repeats the Book 5 rendering verbatim, per the repetition policy. ↩

24. (8.397-424) The Iris relay: Zeus's threat — lamed horses, smashed chariot, thunderbolt wounds that “not in ten circling years” will heal — delivered word for word, with the messenger's licensed shift of person... and then one line of Iris's own: “you shameless dog” (423, κύον ἄδεός). Aristarchus

athetized 420-424; but the herald who adds venom the principal never spoke is a precise, humanized touch. Dogs are this book's insult-currency (299, 423, 483, 527). ↩

25. (8.427-431) Hera's retreat: "let one man perish, and another live, as it may fall." The coldest couplet in the poem's divine politics — the goddess of the Achaean cause, rebuffed once, reverting to actuarial indifference. It is the exact opposite of the poem's own attention, which never lets a death be "as it may fall." ↩

26. (8.470-477) The Patroclus prophecy: Hector will not stop "until the swift-footed son of Peleus rises beside the ships, on that day when they fight at the ships' sterns... over Patroclus fallen. So it is decreed" (θέσφατον). The poem's plot through Book 18, announced by Zeus as settled fact — the first time Patroclus's death is spoken. Suspense in Homer is never whether, only how and at what cost. ↩

27. (8.478-483) "where Iapetus and Cronos sit" — the imprisoned Titans, sunless and windless in deep Tartarus (cf. 5.898, Zeus's threat to Ares; and 14.279). Zeus's rhetoric to his wife reaches for the family's

oldest violence — and ends on “nothing more dog-like than you.” ↩

28. (8.489-491) The Trojan assembly “in a clear space, where ground showed empty of the dead” — the plain is now so strewn that open ground needs remarking. Hector’s eleven-cubit spear repeats 6.318-320 verbatim (English likewise): the domestic Hector of Book 6 and the field-marshal of Book 8 carry the same spear. ↩
29. (8.526-528) “those dogs whom the death-fates carry, whom the fates carried here on their black ships” — κῆρες as both escort and doom: the Achaeans came shipped by their own deaths. Hector’s grimmest wordplay. ↩
30. (8.538-541) “Would that I were as surely deathless and ageless for all my days... as surely as this day brings evil to the Argives”: the adynaton-wish at the peak of Hector’s confidence. Zenodotus omitted 535-537 and Aristarchus flagged 538-541 with critical points (apparatus) — ancient discomfort at Hector wishing himself Athena’s and Apollo’s equal. Kept: the wish measures exactly how far Zeus’s one day of favor has carried him; its cadence returns, desperate, at 22.304-305. ↩

31. (8.548-552) The Trojans sacrifice perfect hecatombs — “but the blessed gods took no share of it; they would not: for holy Ilion was hated in their hearts.” Ritual perfectly performed and refused (cf. 6.311): between Athena’s turned head and this rejected savor, Troy’s fate is already liturgically sealed. ↩
32. (8.555-565) The watchfires: stars around the moon in windless air, every peak and headland clear, “and the shepherd’s heart is glad” — the observer’s joy that Zenodotus deleted (apparatus, Line 557-558) and that makes the simile: dread from the Achaean wall is wonder from the hills. A thousand fires, fifty men to each; and the last word of this most martial book belongs to horses champing barley, “waiting for fair-throned Dawn.” ↩

# Book 9

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*The Embassy to Achilles: Agamemnon's gifts,  
three speeches, and three refusals — each  
smaller than the last.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 So the Trojans kept their watches. But  
the Achaeans  
2 were held by unearthly Panic, the  
companion of icy Rout,<sup>1</sup>  
3 and all their best were stricken with  
grief past bearing.  
4 As two winds stir up the sea where the  
fish swarm,  
5 the North Wind and the West Wind,  
blowing out of Thrace,

6 arriving suddenly: and all at once the  
dark wave  
7 crests, and heaps the seaweed out along  
the tide-line:  
8 so the heart was torn in the chests of  
the Achaeans.  
9 And Atreus' son, stricken to the heart  
with great grief,  
10 went to and fro, bidding the clear-  
voiced heralds  
11 summon every man by name to  
assembly,  
12 but not to shout; and he himself  
worked among the first.  
13 So they sat in assembly, dejected; and  
Agamemnon  
14 stood up, letting fall tears like a spring  
of dark water<sup>2</sup>  
15 that pours its black stream down a

goat-proof cliff.

16 So, groaning heavily, he spoke his words to the Argives:

17 “Friends, leaders and lords of the Argives,

18 Zeus, Cronos’ great son, has bound me fast in heavy blindness —3

19 the hard god: he promised me once, he bowed his head,

20 that I should sack well-walled Ilion before returning;

21 now he has planned a cruel deceit, and orders me

22 back to Argos in disgrace, with half my people lost.

23 Such, it seems, must be the pleasure of overmastering Zeus,

24 who has undone the crowns of many cities



- 25 and will undo more yet: his power is  
the greatest.
- 26 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:  
27 let us flee with the ships to our dear  
fatherland.
- 28 We shall not take wide-wayed Troy  
now.”
- 29 So he spoke, and they all went still in  
silence.
- 30 A long while the sons of the Achaeans  
sat mute, dejected;
- 31 and at long last Diomedes, good at the  
war-cry, spoke:
- 32 “Son of Atreus, it is you I will fight first  
— your folly —4
- 33 where it is right, lord: in assembly. And  
do not be angered.
- 34 My courage you insulted once before  
the Danaans:

35 you called me unwarlike, without  
strength. And all this  
36 the Argives know, the young men and  
the old.  
37 To you the son of crooked-counseled  
Cronos gave by halves:  
38 with the scepter he gave you honor  
beyond all men,  
39 but courage he did not give you — and  
that is the greatest power.  
40 Strange man — do you really suppose  
the sons of the Achaeans  
41 are as unwarlike and strengthless as  
you say?  
42 If your own heart is set on going home,  
43 go: the way lies open, and your ships  
stand by the sea,  
44 the great fleet that followed you from  
Mycenae.

45 But the other long-haired Achaeans  
will stay  
46 until we sack Troy. And if they too —  
47 well, let them flee with their ships to  
their dear fatherland;  
48 the two of us, Sthenelus and I, will  
fight on until we find  
49 the appointed end of Ilion: for we came  
here with the god.”  
50 So he spoke, and all the sons of the  
Achaeans shouted,  
51 marveling at the word of Diomedes,  
breaker of horses.  
52 And the horseman Nestor stood up and  
spoke among them:  
53 “Tydeus’ son, in war you are strong  
beyond others,  
54 and in counsel you are best of all your  
age-mates.

55 Not a man of all the Achaeans will fault  
your word  
56 or speak against it. But you have not  
reached the end of words.  
57 You are young indeed — you could be  
my own son,  
58 the latest-born; and yet you speak good  
sense  
59 to the kings of the Argives, for you  
have spoken rightly.  
60 Come then, I — who claim to be older  
than you —  
61 will speak out and go through  
everything; and no one  
62 will slight my word, not even the lord  
Agamemnon.  
63 Clanless, lawless, hearthless: that is the  
man<sup>5</sup>  
64 who is in love with war among his own

people — the horror of it.

65 But for now, let us yield to black night

66 and make our supper ready. Let the  
sentries

67 post themselves along the dug ditch  
outside the wall —

68 that is my charge to the young men.  
And then,

69 son of Atreus, you lead: for you are  
most the king.

70 Give the elders a feast: it becomes you;  
it is no disgrace.6

71 Your huts are full of wine, which the  
Achaeans' ships

72 bring over the wide sea from Thrace  
daily;

73 all hosting is yours to give: you are king  
over many.

74 With many gathered, you will heed the

man who counsels

75 the best counsel; and sorely do all the  
Achaean need

76 good counsel and shrewd — with the  
enemy this close to the ships,

77 burning their fires past counting. Who  
could rejoice at that?

78 This night will break the army, or will  
save it.”

79 So he spoke, and they listened well to  
him and obeyed.

80 Out went the sentries in their armor,  
mustered

81 around Nestor’s son Thrasymedes,  
shepherd of the people,

82 around Ascalaphus and Ialmenus, sons  
of Ares,

83 around Meriones, and Aphareus, and  
Deïpyrus,

84 and around Creon's son, brilliant  
Lycomedes.

85 Seven were the captains of the sentries,  
and with each went

86 a hundred young men carrying their  
long spears;

87 and they went and took post between  
the ditch and wall,

88 and there lit fires, and each man set  
about his supper.

89 And Atreus' son led the gathered elders  
of the Achaeans

90 to his hut, and set before them a feast  
to fill the heart;

91 and they put out their hands to the  
good things lying ready.

92 And when they had put away desire for  
eating and drinking,

93 the old man first of all began to weave

his counsel —

94 Nestor, whose plan had shown itself  
best before as well.

95 With good will toward them he spoke  
and addressed them:

96 “Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of  
men Agamemnon,

97 with you I will end, and with you begin:  
because you are

98 lord of many peoples, and Zeus has put  
into your hands<sup>7</sup>

99 the scepter and the ordinances, to take  
counsel for them.

100 Therefore you above all must speak a  
word and listen,

101 and act for another too, whenever his  
heart bids a man

102 speak for the good: whatever he  
begins will hang on you.



103 And I will say how it seems to me to be  
best.

104 No other man will think a better  
thought than this —

105 the thought I think, and thought long  
since and still,

106 from that day, Zeus-born, when you  
went and took the girl

107 Briseis out of the hut of Achilles in his  
anger —

108 in no way by our judgment. I myself

109 argued long against it; but you,  
yielding

110 to your great-hearted spirit,  
dishonored the best of men,

111 a man the immortals honor: for you  
took and keep his prize.

112 Even now — even late — let us  
consider how to make amends

113 and win him over with soothing gifts  
and with honeyed words.”

114 Then answered him the lord of men  
Agamemnon:

115 “Old man, that was no false telling of  
my blindness.8

116 Blinded I was — I do not deny it  
myself. Worth many

117 hosts of men is the man whom Zeus  
loves in his heart:

118 as now he has honored this man, and  
broken the Achaean host.

119 But since I was blinded, and followed  
my wretched heart,

120 I am willing to make amends, and to  
give ransom past counting.

121 Before you all I will name the glorious  
gifts:9

122 seven tripods untouched by fire, ten

talents of gold,  
123 twenty gleaming cauldrons, and  
twelve horses,  
124 strong-built, prize-winners, who have  
taken races with their speed.  
125 No man who owned all they have won  
for me  
126 would be poor in goods, or lacking in  
precious gold —  
127 all the prizes those single-hoofed  
horses have carried home.  
128 And I will give seven women skilled in  
blameless work,  
129 women of Lesbos — the ones I chose  
when he himself  
130 took well-built Lesbos, who in beauty  
outdid the tribes of women.  
131 These I will give; and among them will  
be the one I took away:

132 the daughter of Briseus. And I will  
swear the great oath besides:  
133 I never went up into her bed, I never  
lay with her,10  
134 as is the way of human kind, of men  
and women.  
135 All this shall be his at once. And if  
hereafter  
136 the gods grant us to sack the great city  
of Priam,  
137 let him heap his ship with gold and  
bronze  
138 when he comes in, when we Achaeans  
divide the spoil,  
139 and let him choose out twenty Trojan  
women for himself,  
140 the loveliest there are after Argive  
Helen.  
141 And if we come home to Achaean

Argos, udder of the plowland,  
142 he can be my son-in-law: I will honor  
him the equal of Orestes,  
143 my late-born boy, reared in high  
plenty.  
144 I have three daughters in my strong-  
built hall,  
145 Chrysothemis, Laodice, and  
Iphianassa:11  
146 of these let him lead the one he  
chooses, without bride-price,  
147 to the house of Peleus; and I will add  
wedding-gifts  
148 in plenty — more than any man yet  
gave with his daughter.  
149 And I will give him seven well-peopled  
citadels:  
150 Cardamyle, and Enope, and grassy  
Hire,

151 sacred Pherae, and Antheia of the deep  
meadows,  
152 beautiful Aipeia, and Pedasus of the  
vines —12  
153 all near the sea, on the edge of sandy  
Pylos,  
154 and in them live men rich in flocks  
and rich in cattle,  
155 who will honor him like a god with  
their gifts  
156 and render him, under his scepter,  
their shining dues.  
157 All this I will accomplish for him, if he  
leaves off his anger.  
158 Let him be broken. Hades is the one  
unappeasable,13  
159 the untamable — and for that, of all  
gods, mortals hate him most.  
160 And let him yield place to me, by as

much as I am more kingly,

161 by as much as I claim to be the elder-born.”

162 Then answered him the Gerenian horseman Nestor:

163 “Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men Agamemnon,

164 the gifts you offer lord Achilles now — no man could scorn them.

165 Come then, let us send chosen men, to go

166 with all speed to the hut of Peleus’ son Achilles —

167 or come: those my eye falls on, let them consent.

168 Phoenix first, dear to Zeus — let him lead;<sup>14</sup>

169 and then great Ajax, and brilliant Odysseus;

170 and of the heralds, Odius and  
Eurybates go with them.  
171 Now bring water for our hands, and  
call the holy silence,  
172 that we may pray to Zeus, Cronos' son,  
for his pity."  
173 So he spoke, and the word he spoke  
was pleasing to them all.  
174 At once the heralds poured water over  
their hands,  
175 the young men filled the mixing-bowls  
brim-high with drink  
176 and served all, pouring first drops in  
each cup for the god;  
177 and when they had poured, and drunk  
what their hearts would,  
178 they set out from the hut of Atreus'  
son Agamemnon.  
179 And the Gerenian horseman Nestor



charged them well,  
180 with a look at each in turn, at  
Odysseus above all:  
181 try hard to win over the blameless son  
of Peleus.  
182 So the two of them went along the  
shore of the loud-roaring sea, 15  
183 praying hard to the holder and shaker  
of the earth  
184 that they might easily bend the great  
mind of Aeacus' grandson;  
185 and the two came to the huts and the  
ships of the Myrmidons.  
186 They found him delighting his heart  
with the clear-toned lyre,  
187 beautiful, richly worked, with a  
crossbar of silver on it,  
188 which he had taken from the spoils  
when he wrecked Eëtion's city:

189 with this he was pleasuring his heart,  
and singing the fames of men.16

190 And Patroclus alone sat facing him, in  
silence,

191 waiting for Aeacus' grandson to leave  
off singing.

192 So the two of them came forward,  
brilliant Odysseus leading,

193 and stood before him; and Achilles  
sprang up amazed,

194 lyre still in hand, leaving the seat  
where he had sat;

195 and Patroclus likewise rose when he  
saw the men.

196 And greeting the two of them, swift-  
footed Achilles said:

197 "Welcome! Truly dear men have come  
— the need must be great —

198 you who even in my anger are dearest

to me of the Achaeans.”**17**

**199** So speaking, brilliant Achilles led  
them forward

**200** and seated them on chairs with  
coverings of purple,

**201** and quickly said to Patroclus, who  
stood near:

**202** “Set out a bigger mixing-bowl, son of  
Menoetius;

**203** mix the wine stronger; and make  
ready a cup for each man:**18**

**204** for the men beneath my roof are the  
men I love best.”

**205** So he spoke, and Patroclus obeyed his  
dear companion.

**206** He threw down a great chopping-  
block in the light of the fire

**207** and laid on it the chine of a sheep and  
of a fat goat,

208 and the back of a great hog, rich with  
lard.  
209 Automedon held them for him, and  
brilliant Achilles carved,  
210 and sliced the meat with skill, and  
threaded it on spits;  
211 and the son of Menoetius, a man like a  
god, built up the fire.  
212 And when the fire had burned down  
and the flame died,  
213 he leveled the embers and stretched  
the spits above them,  
214 and sprinkled the holy salt, resting the  
spits on their stones.  
215 And when he had roasted it all and  
heaped it on platters,  
216 Patroclus took bread and set it out on  
the table  
217 in beautiful baskets, and Achilles

served the meat.

218 He himself sat down facing godlike  
Odysseus

219 against the far wall, and told his  
companion Patroclus

220 to sacrifice to the gods; and he threw  
the offerings in the fire.

221 And they put out their hands to the  
good things lying ready.

222 And when they had put away desire  
for eating and drinking,

223 Ajax nodded to Phoenix. But brilliant  
Odysseus caught it,

224 and filling a cup with wine he pledged  
Achilles:

225 “Your health, Achilles! Of the fair-  
shared feast we have no lack,

226 whether in the hut of Agamemnon,  
Atreus’ son,

227 or here and now: plenty to fill the  
heart  
228 is set before us. But the works of the  
lovely feast are not  
229 our business now. We are looking at  
grief too great, Zeus-nurtured;  
230 we are afraid. It stands in doubt  
whether we save  
231 the well-benched ships or lose them —  
unless you clothe yourself in valor.  
232 For close to the ships and the wall  
they have made their camp,  
233 the high-hearted Trojans and their  
far-famed allies,  
234 with fires past counting through their  
host; and they say  
235 nothing will hold them now from  
falling on the black ships.  
236 And Zeus, Cronos' son, shows them

signs on the right,  
237 flashing his lightning; and Hector,  
glorying in his strength,  
238 rages terribly, trusting in Zeus, and  
gives way to nothing,  
239 neither man nor god: the strong  
madness has entered him.  
240 He prays for the brilliant Dawn to  
show herself quickly,  
241 for he vows he will hew off the ships'  
stern-horns,  
242 burn the hulls themselves with  
ravaging fire, and cut down  
243 the Achaeans beside them, dazed in  
the smoke.  
244 This is the fear my heart dreads  
terribly — that the gods  
245 may make his threats good, and it  
prove our portion

246 to die at Troy, far from horse-  
pasturing Argos.  
247 Up, then! — if you mean, even at this  
late hour, to save  
248 the wearied sons of the Achaeans  
from the Trojan onslaught.  
249 It will be your own grief later; and  
there is no finding  
250 a cure for harm once done. Far sooner,  
then:  
251 think how to ward the evil day from  
the Danaans.  
252 Dear friend — surely your father  
Peleus charged you19  
253 the day he sent you out of Phthia to  
Agamemnon:  
254 ‘My child, the victory Athena and  
Hera  
255 will give, if they choose; but the great-



hearted spirit —

256 rein that in in your own chest.

Friendliness is better.

257 Break off strife, the deviser of evil, so  
the Argives

258 may honor you the more, the young  
men and the old.’

259 So the old man charged you; and you  
forget. Yet even now

260 stop; let go the anger that grieves the  
heart. Agamemnon

261 offers you worthy gifts, if you leave off  
your anger.

262 Come, listen to me, and I will count  
out for you

263 all the gifts Agamemnon promised in  
his huts:20

264 seven tripods untouched by fire, ten  
talents of gold,

265 twenty gleaming cauldrons, and  
twelve horses,  
266 strong-built, prize-winners, who have  
taken races with their speed.  
267 No man who owned all they have won  
268 would be poor in goods, or lacking in  
precious gold —  
269 all the prizes Agamemnon's horses  
have carried home.  
270 And he will give seven women skilled  
in blameless work,  
271 women of Lesbos — the ones he chose  
when you yourself  
272 took well-built Lesbos, who in beauty  
outdid the tribes of women.  
273 These he will give; and among them  
will be the one he took away:  
274 the daughter of Briseus. And he will  
swear the great oath besides:

275 he never went up into her bed, he  
never lay with her,  
276 as is the way, lord, of men and women.  
277 All this shall be yours at once. And if  
hereafter  
278 the gods grant us to sack the great city  
of Priam,  
279 you may heap your ship with gold and  
bronze  
280 when you come in, when we Achaeans  
divide the spoil,  
281 and choose out twenty Trojan women  
for yourself,  
282 the loveliest there are after Argive  
Helen.  
283 And if we come home to Achaean  
Argos, udder of the plowland,  
284 you can be his son-in-law: he will  
honor you the equal of Orestes,

285 his late-born boy, reared in high  
plenty.  
286 He has three daughters in his strong-  
built hall,  
287 Chrysothemis, Laodice, and  
Iphianassa:  
288 of these you may lead the one you  
choose, without bride-price,  
289 to the house of Peleus; and he will add  
wedding-gifts  
290 in plenty — more than any man yet  
gave with his daughter.  
291 And he will give you seven well-  
peopled citadels:  
292 Cardamyle, and Enope, and grassy  
Hire,  
293 sacred Pherae, and Antheia of the  
deep meadows,  
294 beautiful Aipeia, and Pedasus of the

vines —

295 all near the sea, on the edge of sandy  
Pylos,

296 and in them live men rich in flocks  
and rich in cattle,

297 who will honor you like a god with  
their gifts

298 and render you, under your scepter,  
their shining dues.

299 All this he will accomplish for you, if  
you leave off your anger.

300 But if Atreus' son is grown too hateful  
to your heart,

301 he and his gifts together — then pity  
all the rest,

302 the Achaeans of every rank, worn  
down through the camp, who will honor  
you

303 like a god. Truly, you would win great

glory in their eyes:

304 for now you might take Hector's very  
self — he would come

305 in close to you in his deadly madness,  
since he says no man

306 is his equal of all the Danaans the  
ships brought here.”

307 Answering him spoke swift-footed  
Achilles:

308 “Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus  
of many devices:

309 I must speak my word to you outright,  
without mercy —

310 exactly as I think it, and as it will be  
accomplished —

311 so you will not sit by me and coo at  
me, one after another.

312 For hateful to me as the gates of Hades  
is the man<sup>21</sup>

313 who hides one thing in his mind and  
says another.

314 So I will speak it as it seems to me  
best.

315 Neither Atreus' son Agamemnon will  
persuade me, I think,

316 nor the other Danaans — since there  
was no thanks, it seems,

317 for battling the enemy without  
respite, forever.

318 The portion is equal for the man who  
hangs back and the man who fights  
hard;22

319 in one honor stand the coward and the  
brave;

320 death comes alike to the do-nothing  
and the man of many deeds.

321 And nothing is laid up for me because  
I suffered

322 the pains of it, forever staking my life  
in the fighting.

323 As a bird carries to her unfledged  
chicks<sup>23</sup>

324 every morsel she takes, and it goes  
hard with herself,

325 so I have lain awake through many an  
unsleeping night

326 and fought through bloody days of  
battle,

327 contending with men for the sake of  
their women.

328 Twelve cities of men I have sacked  
from my ships,<sup>24</sup>

329 and eleven by land, I tell you, across  
deep-soiled Troy:

330 from all of them I took out treasure,  
much and good,

331 and brought it all and gave it to



Agamemnon,

332 Atreus' son — who waited behind by  
the swift ships,

333 took it in, doled out a little, and kept  
the most.

334 What he gave the chief men and the  
kings as prizes

335 stands untouched with them; from me  
alone of the Achaeans

336 he took — and he keeps my bed-dear  
wife. Let him lie beside her<sup>25</sup>

337 and take his pleasure! But why must  
the Argives make war

338 on the Trojans? Why did Atreus' son  
gather an army

339 and lead it here? Was it not for lovely-  
haired Helen?

340 Are the sons of Atreus alone among  
mortal men

341 the ones who love their wives? — since  
any man who is good  
342 and sensible loves his own and cares  
for her,  
343 as I loved that one from my heart,  
spear-won though she was.  
344 Now, since he took my prize out of my  
hands and cheated me,  
345 let him not try me: I know him too  
well. He will not persuade me.  
346 No, Odysseus — with you and the  
other kings  
347 let him think how to beat the enemy  
fire from the ships.  
348 Truly he has labored greatly with me  
gone:  
349 he has even built a wall, and driven a  
ditch along it,  
350 wide and great, and planted stakes

within it —

351 and even so he cannot hold the  
strength of man-slaughtering

352 Hector! While I was fighting among  
the Achaeans,

353 Hector had no wish to raise battle  
away from his wall;

354 he came only as far as the Scaean  
Gates and the oak.26

355 There once he stood up to me alone —  
and barely escaped my charge.

356 But now, since I have no wish to fight  
brilliant Hector,

357 tomorrow I will sacrifice to Zeus and  
all the gods,

358 load my ships well, and drag them  
down to the sea —

359 and you will see, if you care to, if such  
things interest you,

360 my ships at earliest light sailing the  
Hellespont  
361 where the fish swarm, and in them  
men rowing with a will;  
362 and if the famed earth-shaker grants  
fair passage,  
363 on the third day I should reach deep-  
soiled Phthia.  
364 I have great possessions there, left  
when I made my luckless  
365 journey here; and more from here —  
gold, red bronze,  
366 fair-belted women, grey iron — I will  
carry home,  
367 all that fell to me by lot. But my prize  
— the man who gave it,  
368 the lord Agamemnon, Atreus' son, in  
his insolence  
369 took it back. Tell him all of it, just as I

charge you,

370 openly — so the other Achaeans too  
may be angry,

371 if he hopes to cheat some other  
Danaan yet,

372 clothed as he always is in  
shamelessness. And yet —

373 dog though he is — he would not dare  
look me in the face.

374 I will not join him in counsel, and not  
in action:

375 he cheated me outright, he wronged  
me. Never again

376 will he trick me with words. Once is  
enough. Let him go

377 to ruin at his ease: Zeus the counselor  
has taken his wits.

378 His gifts are hateful to me; I count him  
at a hair's worth.27

379 Not if he gave me ten times as much,  
and twenty times,  
380 all he has now and more from  
elsewhere besides;  
381 not all the revenue of Orchomenus, or  
of Thebes —  
382 Egyptian Thebes, where the houses  
hold the greatest treasures,  
383 the city of a hundred gates, and  
through each gate  
384 two hundred men drive out with  
horses and chariots;  
385 not if he gave me gifts as many as the  
sand and dust —  
386 not even so would Agamemnon  
persuade my heart  
387 until he has paid me back all the  
outrage that galls it.  
388 And the daughter of Agamemnon,

Atreus' son — I will not

389 marry her: not if she rivaled golden  
Aphrodite in beauty

390 and matched the works of grey-eyed  
Athena.

391 Not even so will I marry her. Let him  
choose another Achaean,

392 one who suits him — someone more  
kingly than I.

393 For if the gods preserve me, and I  
come home,

394 Peleus himself will find me a wife.28

395 There are Achaean girls enough  
through Hellas and through Phthia,

396 daughters of chieftains, men who  
guard their citadels:

397 of these I will make whichever one I  
choose my own dear wife.

398 There — that is where my proud heart

kept urging me:

399 to take a wedded wife, a fitting bride,  
400 and enjoy the possessions old Peleus  
won.

401 For not worth my life is all they say  
was stored<sup>29</sup>

402 in Ilion, that well-peopled citadel,  
403 before, in peacetime, before the sons  
of the Achaeans came —

404 nor all the stone threshold of the  
Archer holds within it,

405 Phoebus Apollo's, in rocky Pytho.

406 Cattle can be lifted, and fat sheep;

407 tripods can be won, and the tawny  
heads of horses:

408 but a man's life cannot be lifted back,  
cannot be caught,

409 once it has crossed the fence of his  
teeth.



410 For my mother tells me — Thetis, the  
goddess of the silver feet —30  
411 that two fates carry me toward the end  
of death:  
412 if I stay here and fight around the  
Trojans' city,  
413 my homecoming is lost — but my fame  
will be imperishable;  
414 and if I come home to my dear  
fatherland,  
415 my noble fame is lost — but my life  
will be long,  
416 and the end of death will not be quick  
to find me.  
417 And to the rest of you I would give this  
counsel:  
418 sail home — since you will never now  
reach the end  
419 of steep Ilion: wide-seeing Zeus has

held

420 his hand over her, and her people  
have taken heart.

421 So go; and carry my message to the  
chief men

422 of the Achaeans — that is the honor-  
portion of the old —

423 so they may devise in their minds  
some better plan

424 to save the ships, and the Achaean  
host

425 beside the hollow ships: since this one  
— this they thought of —

426 will not serve, while my anger stands.  
But Phoenix —

427 let him stay and sleep here with us,

428 so he may follow in my ships to our  
dear fatherland

429 tomorrow, if he wishes. I will not take

him by force.”

430 So he spoke, and they all went still in  
silence,

431 marveling at his word: he had refused  
with great power.

432 At long last the old horseman Phoenix  
spoke,<sup>31</sup>

433 bursting into tears, in terrible fear for  
the ships:

434 “If it is homecoming you now ponder,  
shining Achilles,

435 and you will not lift ruinous fire from  
the swift ships

436 at all, because anger has fallen on  
your heart —

437 how then could I be left here without  
you, dear child,

438 alone? It was to you the old horseman  
Peleus sent me

439 the day he sent you out of Phthia to  
Agamemnon,  
440 a child still, knowing nothing yet of  
leveling war,  
441 nothing of assemblies, where men  
become preeminent.  
442 For that he sent me: to teach you all  
these things —  
443 to be a speaker of words, and a doer of  
deeds.  
444 After all that, dear child, I would not  
choose to be left  
445 without you — no, not if a god himself  
should promise  
446 to scrape old age from me and set me  
young again,  
447 as I was when I first left Hellas of the  
beautiful women,  
448 fleeing a quarrel with my father,

Amyntor, Ormenus' son.**32**

**449** He was enraged with me over his  
lovely-haired concubine:

**450** he loved her, and dishonored his own  
wife,

**451** my mother; and my mother begged  
me endlessly by my knees

**452** to lie with the concubine first, so she  
would loathe the old man.

**453** I obeyed her, and did it. And my  
father, guessing at once,

**454** cursed me long and hard, and called  
up the hateful Erinyes:

**455** that never should a dear son born of  
me

**456** be set upon his knees. And the gods  
fulfilled his curses —

**457** Zeus of the world below, and dread  
Persephone.

*[Lines 458-461 are absent from the printed text; see note 32.]*

462 Then the heart in my chest could no  
longer be held at all

463 to linger in the halls of my angry  
father.

464 Kinsmen and cousins in plenty,  
gathered around me,

465 held me there in the halls with their  
begging:

466 many a fat sheep and rolling-gaited  
crook-horned ox

467 they slaughtered; many a hog rich in  
lard

468 was stretched to singe across the  
flame of Hephaestus,

469 and much of the old man's wine was  
drunk from the jars.

470 Nine nights together they kept their  
watch around me;

471 they took the guard in turns, and the  
fires never died —  
472 one under the colonnade of the  
strong-fenced court,  
473 one in the porch, before my  
bedchamber doors.  
474 But when the tenth dark night came  
on me,  
475 then I burst the close-fitted doors of  
my chamber  
476 and got out, and vaulted the courtyard  
fence  
477 lightly, unseen by the watchmen and  
the slave-women.  
478 Then I fled far away through Hellas of  
the wide spaces  
479 and came to deep-soiled Phthia,  
mother of flocks,  
480 to lord Peleus. And he received me

with a ready heart,  
481 and loved me as a father loves his son,  
482 his only son, late-born, heir to great  
possessions;  
483 and he made me rich, and gave me a  
numerous people:  
484 I lived at the edge of Phthia, ruling the  
Dolopes.  
485 And I made you what you are, Achilles  
like the gods,33  
486 loving you from my heart: you would  
not go with another  
487 to the feast, or eat in the halls,  
488 until I had sat you on my knees and  
cut  
489 the first bit of meat for you, and held  
the wine to your lips.  
490 Many a time you soaked the tunic on  
my chest,



491 spitting up wine in your troublesome  
babyhood.  
492 So I suffered much for you, and toiled  
much,  
493 minding always that the gods would  
bring no child of mine  
494 to birth; no — I made you my child,  
godlike Achilles,  
495 so that someday you might ward  
unseemly ruin from me.  
496 Achilles — break your great spirit. It  
does not become you  
497 to keep a pitiless heart. Even the gods  
themselves can bend,  
498 and theirs is the greater excellence,  
honor, and strength:  
499 with burnt offerings and gentle vows,  
500 with libation and savor, men turn  
even them

501 by their prayers, when a man has  
transgressed and gone wrong.

502 For Prayers, too, are daughters of  
great Zeus —34

503 lame, and wrinkled, and eyes turned  
aside,

504 who make it their care to follow after  
Blindness.

505 But Blindness is strong and sound of  
foot, and far outruns them

506 all, and gets in first over all the earth

507 tripping mankind; and they come  
healing after.

508 Now the man who respects the  
daughters of Zeus when they approach,

509 him they greatly bless, and hear him  
when he prays;

510 but when a man denies them and  
stiffly refuses,

511 they go to Zeus, Cronos' son, and pray  
512 that Blindness go with that man, till  
he trips, and pays in full.  
513 So you too, Achilles — grant the  
daughters of Zeus  
514 their due of honor, which bends the  
will of others, and good men too.  
515 If Atreus' son were not bringing gifts,  
and naming more  
516 to come — if he raged on furiously still  
—  
517 I would not be the one to tell you:  
throw your wrath away  
518 and defend the Argives, however  
much they need it.  
519 But now he gives much at once, and  
has promised more hereafter,  
520 and has sent out the best men to  
entreat you,

521 chosen through the Achaean host, the  
men who are dearest  
522 to you yourself of the Argives. Do not  
shame their words  
523 or their coming; till now, no one could  
blame your anger.  
524 So it was with the men before us too  
— the fames we hear of,  
525 heroes of old, when furious anger  
came on one of them:  
526 they could be won by gifts, and won  
over by words.  
527 I remember this deed of old — no new  
thing —  
528 how it was; and I will tell it among  
you, friends, all of you.  
529 The Curetes were fighting, and the  
battle-biding Aetolians, 35  
530 around the city of Calydon, and killing

one another —

531 the Aetolians in defense of lovely  
Calydon,

532 the Curetes raging to sack it in war.

533 For golden-throned Artemis had  
raised that evil among them,

534 in anger that Oeneus brought no  
harvest-offering

535 from his orchard slope: the other gods  
feasted on hecatombs,

536 and to her alone, great Zeus's  
daughter, he offered nothing —

537 he forgot, or he did not think of it: a  
great blindness of heart.

538 Enraged, the child of Zeus who  
showers arrows

539 roused against him a wild boar, white-  
tusked ravager,

540 who did great damage, haunting

Oeneus' orchard land,  
541 tearing up tall trees and hurling them  
to the ground,  
542 roots and all, apple-blossom and all.  
543 Him the son of Oeneus killed —  
Meleager —  
544 when he had gathered huntsmen out  
of many cities,  
545 and hounds: for the boar was not  
brought down by few men,  
546 so huge he was; and he set many on  
the pyre of grief.  
547 But around the carcass the goddess  
raised a great clamor and battle-cry,  
548 over the boar's head and the bristling  
hide,  
549 between the Curetes and the great-  
hearted Aetolians.  
550 Now as long as Meleager dear to Ares

fought,

551 so long it went hard with the Curetes;  
they could not

552 hold their ground outside the wall,  
though they were many.

553 But when anger entered Meleager —  
anger that swells

554 in the chests of others too, even the  
close-thinking —

555 enraged at his own mother Althaea, he  
lay idle

556 beside his wedded wife, beautiful  
Cleopatra,

557 daughter of Marpessa of the beautiful  
ankles, Euenus' child,

558 and of Idas, strongest of men on the  
earth

559 in his time — who even lifted his bow  
against the lord

560 Phoebus Apollo, for the sake of his  
lovely-ankled bride.  
561 Her, in those days, in their halls her  
father and lady mother  
562 called by the name Alcyone — halcyon  
— because  
563 her own mother, with the mourning  
halcyon's fate upon her,  
564 wept when Phoebus Apollo the  
worker-from-afar snatched her away.  
565 By her Meleager lay, digesting his  
heart-paining anger,  
566 enraged at his mother's curses: for she  
prayed the gods  
567 against him, in her grief for a  
brother's killing —  
568 over and over she beat the earth that  
feeds so many with her hands,  
569 calling on Hades and dread



Persephone,  
570 crouched on her knees, her bosom wet  
with tears,  
571 to give her son death; and out of  
Erebus an Erinys  
572 who walks in mist heard her, with her  
unappeasable heart.  
573 Soon the din of the enemy rose  
around the gates, the thud  
574 of towers battered; and the Aetolian  
elders begged him,  
575 sending the gods' chosen priests:  
576 come out and defend us — and they  
promised a great gift:  
577 where the plain of lovely Calydon was  
fattest,  
578 there they bade him choose a  
beautiful precinct,  
579 fifty fields broad, half of it vineyard,

580 half open plowland, cut from the  
plain.  
581 And the old horseman Oeneus begged  
him over and over,  
582 standing at the threshold of his high-  
roofed chamber,  
583 shaking the bolted doors, entreating  
his son;  
584 over and over his sisters and his lady  
mother  
585 begged him — he refused the more —  
and his companions,  
586 the truest and dearest of them all:  
587 but not even so could they move the  
heart in his chest —  
588 until the chamber itself was under  
thick bombardment, and the Curetes  
589 were scaling the towers and firing the  
great city.

590 Then at last his fair-belted wife  
begged Meleager,  
591 wailing, and counted out for him all  
592 the griefs that come to people whose  
city is taken:  
593 the men killed, the town burned down  
to ash,  
594 the children led away by strangers,  
and the deep-belted women.  
595 And his heart was stirred as he heard  
those terrible things:  
596 he went out, and clothed his body in  
shining armor.  
597 So he beat the evil day back from the  
Aetolians,  
598 yielding to his own heart. And they no  
longer made good  
599 the gifts, the many gracious gifts; yet  
he ward off the evil all the same.

600 But you — do not think that way in  
your heart; do not let a god  
601 turn you that way, dear boy. It would  
be worse  
602 to defend the ships already burning.  
While there are gifts,  
603 come: the Achaeans will honor you  
like a god.  
604 But if without gifts you enter man-  
destroying war,  
605 you will not be honored the same,  
though you beat the war away.”  
606 Answering him spoke swift-footed  
Achilles:  
607 “Phoenix, old father, aged one, Zeus-  
nurtured: I have no need36  
608 of that honor. I judge that I am  
honored by the portion of Zeus,  
609 which will keep me here by the

beaked ships as long as breath

610 stays in my chest and my knees have  
their spring.

611 And I will tell you another thing — put  
it away in your heart:

612 do not blur my heart with weeping  
and grieving

613 to gratify the hero son of Atreus. You  
must not

614 love him, or my love for you may turn  
to hatred.

615 It is right for you to wound the man  
who wounds me.

616 Be king equally with me; take half my  
honor.

617 These men will carry the message; you  
stay here and sleep

618 in a soft bed; and with the showing of  
Dawn

619 we will decide whether to go to our  
own country, or to stay.”

620 He spoke, and with his brows signed  
silently to Patroclus

621 to spread a thick bed for Phoenix, so  
the others

622 might think the sooner of leaving the  
hut. And Ajax,

623 Telamon’s godlike son, spoke his word  
among them:

624 “Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus  
of many devices —37

625 let us go. I do not think the end of this  
errand

626 will be reached by this road. We must  
report the word,

627 unwelcome as it is, to the Danaans  
with all speed —

628 they sit waiting for it now. But

Achilles

629 has made the great-hearted spirit in  
his chest a savage thing —

630 the hard man! — and cares nothing  
for the love of his companions,

631 the love we honored him with by the  
ships beyond all others.

632 Pitiless! And yet a man accepts blood-  
price

633 even from his brother's killer, even for  
his own dead son;

634 and the killer stays in his own  
country, having paid the great price,

635 and the kinsman's heart and proud  
spirit are held in check

636 once he has taken the price. But you —  
the gods have set

637 in your chest an anger unending, and  
evil, over a girl —

638 one girl! — while we now offer you  
seven, far the best,  
639 and much else besides. Put a gracious  
spirit in you;  
640 respect your own roof: we are under  
it,  
641 out of the whole Danaan host; and  
beyond all others we have longed  
642 to be nearest to you and dearest of all  
the Achaeans.”  
643 Answering him spoke swift-footed  
Achilles:  
644 “Ajax, Zeus-sprung son of Telamon,  
marshal of the people:  
645 everything you have said is very  
nearly after my own heart.  
646 But my heart swells with rage  
whenever I remember  
647 those things — how Atreus’ son



treated me like dirt among the Argives,<sup>38</sup>

<sup>648</sup> as if I were some vagrant without  
honor.

<sup>649</sup> But you two go, and carry back my  
message:

<sup>650</sup> I will not think of bloody war again

<sup>651</sup> until brilliant Hector, war-minded  
Priam's son,

<sup>652</sup> comes killing Argives right up to the  
huts and ships

<sup>653</sup> of the Myrmidons, and blackens the  
ships with fire.

<sup>654</sup> At my hut, though — at my black ship  
— I think

<sup>655</sup> Hector will be stopped, for all his  
hunger for battle.”

<sup>656</sup> So he spoke; and each of them took a  
two-handled cup,

<sup>657</sup> poured the libation, and went back

along the ships, Odysseus leading.

658 And Patroclus told his companions  
and the slave-women

659 to spread a thick bed for Phoenix with  
all speed;

660 and they obeyed, and spread the bed  
as he commanded —

661 fleeces, a rug, and a fine flare of linen.

662 There the old man lay down, and  
waited for brilliant Dawn.

663 And Achilles slept in the innermost  
corner of the strong-built hut,

664 and beside him lay a woman he had  
brought from Lesbos:39

665 Phorbas's daughter, fair-cheeked  
Diomedes.

666 And Patroclus lay down on the other  
side, and by him too

667 lay fair-belted Iphis, whom brilliant

Achilles gave him

668 when he took steep Scyros, Enyeus'  
citadel.

669 Now when the envoys were back in  
the huts of Atreus' son,

670 the sons of the Achaeans, springing up  
on every side,

671 pledged them with golden cups, and  
pressed their questions;

672 and the lord of men Agamemnon  
asked first:

673 "Come, tell me, Odysseus of the many  
tales, great glory of the Achaeans:

674 is he willing to beat the enemy fire  
from the ships,

675 or did he refuse — does anger still  
hold that great-hearted spirit?"

676 Then answered him much-enduring  
brilliant Odysseus:

677 “Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of  
men Agamemnon:  
678 that man has no will to quench his  
anger — he is filled  
679 fuller yet with fury; he refuses you,  
and your gifts.  
680 He bids you take counsel yourself,  
among the Argives,  
681 how you may save the ships and the  
Achaean host;  
682 and he himself threatens, with the  
showing of Dawn,**40**  
683 to drag his well-benched, well-curved  
ships to the sea.  
684 And he said he would counsel the  
others too  
685 to sail for home — since you will never  
now reach the end  
686 of steep Ilion: wide-seeing Zeus has

held

687 his hand over her, and her people  
have taken heart.

688 So he spoke. And here are these to  
confirm it, who went with me:

689 Ajax, and the two heralds, wise men  
both.

690 But old Phoenix has laid himself down  
there — as Achilles bade —

691 so he may follow in the ships to his  
dear fatherland

692 tomorrow, if he wishes; he will not  
take him by force.”

693 So he spoke, and they all went still in  
silence,

694 marveling at his word: he had spoken  
with great power.

695 A long while the sons of the Achaeans  
sat mute, dejected;

696 and at long last Diomedes, good at the  
war-cry, spoke:

697 “Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of  
men Agamemnon:41

698 would you had never begged the  
blameless son of Peleus,

699 offering gifts past counting. He is  
proud at the best of times,

700 and now you have driven him deeper  
into pride by far.

701 No — let us leave him be: whether he  
goes

702 or stays; he will fight again whenever

703 the heart in his chest commands him,  
and the god rouses him.

704 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:

705 sleep now, when you have taken your  
hearts’ content

706 of bread and wine — for in them are

fury and valor;  
707 and when the beautiful rosy-fingered  
Dawn appears,  
708 marshal the men and the horses  
quickly before the ships,  
709 urging them on — and fight yourself  
among the first.”  
710 So he spoke, and all the kings  
approved,  
711 marveling at the word of Diomedes,  
breaker of horses.  
712 Then they poured libation, and went  
each man to his hut,  
713 and there they lay down, and took the  
gift of sleep.

## Notes

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NOTES

1. (9.1-8) Panic (Φύζα) “companion of icy Rout” — the war-demons of 4.440 gain another member; and the two-winds simile makes the army’s heart a sea worked by opposed gales: the book’s whole subject — a mind torn two ways — announced in weather. ↩
2. (9.14-15) Agamemnon weeps “like a spring of dark water” pouring down a cliff — the exact simile that will describe Patroclus weeping for the dying Achaeans at 16.3-4. The poem opens its two great turning-points, the embassy and the Patrocleia, with the same tears. (Echo note; English will repeat verbatim there.) ↩
3. (9.17-28) Agamemnon repeats his own test-speech of 2.110-118 and 139-141 word for word (the English repeats the Book 2 rendering) — but this time he means it. The counterfeit despair of Book 2 has become real, and no Odysseus rises to stop the flight: only Diomedes. ↩
4. (9.32-49) Diomedes’ answer — the payoff planted at 4.401-402, where he took Agamemnon’s insult in silence “where it is right” now claims the assembly’s license: “it is you I will fight first — your folly.” The scepter/courage antithesis (37-39) dismantles



Agamemnon's authority with surgical courtesy.  
Aristarchus athetized 44. ↩

5. (9.63-64) "Clanless, lawless, hearthless is the man who is in love with war among his own people" — Nestor's anathema on civil strife, the most quoted political sentence in the poem after 2.204; the triple alpha-privative (ἀφρήτωρ ἀθέμιτος ἀέστιος) strips the stasis-lover of every circle of belonging. ↩
6. (9.70-72) Wine-ships from Thrace "daily" — with 7.467-475 (Lemnos), the poem's second glimpse of the supply-economy behind the war. ↩
7. (9.97-99) "Zeus has put into your hands the scepter and the ordinances" — Odysseus's crowd-control theology of 2.205-206, now recited to the king as obligation rather than of him as privilege: with the scepter comes the duty to listen. ↩
8. (9.115-120) "Blinded I was — I do not deny it" (ἄσάμην): Agamemnon at last speaks the ἄτη-word of 1.412 and 2.111 in the first person. A line quoted by Athenaeus adds after 119: "or maddened with wine, or the gods themselves harmed me" (apparatus, Line 119) — an ancient plus-verse softening the confession that the vulgate leaves

bare. His fullest self-exculpation waits for 19.86-138.



9. (9.121-157) The catalogue of gifts: seven tripods, ten talents, twenty cauldrons, twelve racehorses, seven women of Lesbos, Briseis with an oath, and on the far side of victory a ship's hold of treasure, twenty Trojan women, a royal marriage "without bride-price" (146 — the suitor's payment waived and reversed: Agamemnon dowers the groom), and seven cities. It is a king's ransom — and every item denominates honor in exactly the currency Achilles is about to declare bankrupt. ↩
10. (9.132-134) The oath that he never touched Briseis — offered unprompted, and revealing what the quarrel's language of "prizes" had buried: that this is also about a woman's bed, and that Agamemnon knows it. He will swear it publicly at 19.258-265. ↩
11. (9.144-145) Chrysothemis, Laodice, Iphianassa: no Electra, and an Iphianassa alive and marriageable in the war's tenth year — the Iliad appears not to know (or pointedly ignores) the sacrifice of Iphigenia at Aulis. The tragedians' house of Atreus is not yet this poem's. ↩

12. (9.149-156) The seven cities stand on the Messenian coast, “on the edge of sandy Pylos” — inside Nestor’s sphere, not Agamemnon’s: ancient critics already asked by what right he gives them away. Royal gift-geography is aspirational; the point is the scale. ↩
13. (9.158-161) The poison pill: “Let him be broken (δμηθήτω)... and let him yield place to me, by as much as I am more kingly.” The gift-list ends by re-enacting the original offense — the gifts are to purchase not reconciliation but submission. Odysseus will cut these lines in the retelling (note [20]). ↩
14. (9.168-170) The envoys: Phoenix — Achilles’ own tutor, somehow present in Agamemnon’s council — to lead; then Ajax and Odysseus, with two heralds (this Odys is not the Halizone captain of 2.856). The oddity of Phoenix’s presence and the dual verbs that follow (note [15]) have fed two centuries of analysis about whether his role was a later expansion. The poem’s own logic is plain: it sends Achilles’ three loves — his teacher, his bluntest peer, and the army’s best voice. ↩
15. (9.182-198) The famous duals (disputed\_lines.md #5): “the two of them went... the two came... greeting the

two of them” — the Greek uses strict dual verbs for a party of three envoys plus two heralds. Ancient solutions (Aristarchus: the duals cover only the two principals; others: Phoenix went ahead) and modern ones (an older two-man embassy, with Phoenix stitched in later; or the heralds as the pair) all leave a seam showing. The translation renders every dual visibly as “the two,” per project policy, so the crux is present in English rather than smoothed away. ↩

16. (9.186-191) Achilles singing “the fames of men” (κλέα ἄνδρῶν) to a lyre taken at the sack of Eëtion’s Thebe — Andromache’s city (6.414-428). The poem’s only scene of epic performed shows its greatest hero as the singer, and his instrument as spoil of the very raid whose griefs thread the poem; while Patroclus waits, silent, for his turn in the song. What Achilles sings, he is choosing between at 410-416. ↩

17. (9.197-198, 202-220) “You who even in my anger are dearest to me” — the greeting concedes at once what the answers will struggle to unsay. The hosting is done by the heroes’ own hands (Patroclus mixing “stronger” wine, Achilles carving) — the full feast type-scene performed personally: the quarrel is with one man, not with fellowship. ↩

18. — merged into [17]. ↩
19. (9.252-259) Odysseus quotes Peleus's parting advice verbatim — "rein in the great-hearted spirit... break off strife" — the absent-father motif (cf. 7.124-128) turned into an instrument of persuasion. Whether Odysseus actually heard it (he was there, 11.765-790 implies) or reconstructs what fathers say, it is the speech's shrewdest stroke — and its failure measures how far Achilles now stands from Phthia's ethics. ↩
20. (9.264-299) The relay: Odysseus repeats the catalogue word for word (the English repeats it too, person-shifted, per policy) — and stops at 299. The poison lines (158-161, "let him yield to me...") are silently omitted, and in their place he pivots to pity for the army and the bait of Hector's nearness (300-306). The poem's masterclass in diplomatic editing: fidelity as technique, suppression as tact. Achilles' "hateful as the gates of Hades" answer suggests he smells the redaction anyway. ↩
21. (9.308-314) "Hateful to me as the gates of Hades is the man who hides one thing in his mind and says another" (disputed\_lines.md #6): the referent is contested — a warning aimed at Odysseus the professional speaker standing before him, or at the

absent Agamemnon, the actual hider-and-sayer of the quarrel? The translation keeps the generalizing third person that lets both targets stand. Plato quotes the passage (Hippias Minor 365a) in just this connection — Achilles the plain speaker against Odysseus the polytropic. ↩

22. (9.318-321) “The portion is equal for the man who hangs back and the man who fights hard; in one honor stand the coward and the brave; death comes alike...” — the sentence that unmakes the poem’s social contract. If *timē* no longer tracks merit, the whole exchange-economy of prizes, and the war built on it, loses its reason. This is the radical center of the book: not a bigger price demanded, but the currency refused. ↩
23. (9.323-327) Achilles as mother-bird, carrying every morsel to unfledged chicks “and it goes hard with herself” — the fighter’s self-image as feeder and nurturer, gender-crossed; the tenderest simile any warrior applies to himself in the poem. ↩
24. (9.328-336) Twelve cities by sea, eleven by land: the sack-list that stocked the poem’s backstory (Thebe, Lyrnessus, Lesbos, Scyros...) — all carried to Agamemnon, “who waited behind by the swift

ships.” The distribution-economy described from the point of view of its producer. ↩

25. (9.336-343) “He keeps my bed-dear wife (ἄλοχον θυμαρέα)... as I loved that one from my heart, spear-won though she was.” Achilles calls Briseis by the word for wedded wife, and answers the whole war’s premise with a question — “are the sons of Atreus alone among mortal men the ones who love their wives?” The captive “prize” of Book 1 is re-described as a loved woman; Briseis’s own voice, confirming, comes at 19.287-300. ↩

26. (9.354-355) “only as far as the Scaean Gates and the oak” — the landmark of 7.22 and 6.237; Achilles’ memory of a Hector who would not fight in the open is the exact inverse of the Hector of Book 8, and both are true in their seasons of divine favor. ↩

27. (9.378-387) “I count him at a hair’s worth” (ἐν καρὸς αἴσῃ) — and the great refusal-crescendo: ten times, twenty times the gifts; the wealth of Orchomenus; “Egyptian Thebes, the city of a hundred gates” (the Iliad’s only mention of Egypt); gifts like sand and dust. Not until “he has paid me back all the outrage” — a price no catalogue can denominate. ↩

28. (9.388-400) The marriage refused: “Peleus himself will find me a wife.” Against Agamemnon’s dynastic offer Achilles sets an ordinary happiness — a local bride, his father’s goods — spoken by the one man in the poem who knows (410-416) he will never have it. ↩
29. (9.401-409) “Not worth my life (ψυχῆς ἀντάξιον)”: cattle can be raided, tripods won, “but a man’s life cannot be lifted back... once it has crossed the fence of his teeth.” The formula for guarded speech (4.350) turned into the body’s last gate — words return, breath does not. This is the poem’s deepest sentence against its own heroic premise, and the Odyssey’s Achilles in the underworld will say it again in other words. ↩
30. (9.410-416) The two fates: stay and win “imperishable fame” (κλέος ἄφθιτον — the oldest phrase of Indo-European praise-poetry, cognate formulas in the Vedas), or go home to long, fameless life. Only Achilles receives destiny as a menu; and the poem that preserves his fame is itself the content of the first option — the choice is between existing in epic and existing. Zenodotus omitted and Aristarchus athetized 416. ↩



31. (9.432-445) Phoenix: guardian of Achilles' boyhood, teacher of the heroic double curriculum — "a speaker of words, and a doer of deeds" (443) — the poem's one-line definition of the complete man, spoken by the man who taught it to its greatest exemplar. ↩
32. (9.447-461) Phoenix's own story: his father's concubine, his mother's plea, the old man's curse of childlessness sworn to the Erinyes and ratified by "Zeus of the world below" (Hades) "and dread Persephone." At this point the vulgate — and this project's Greek text — omits four lines (458-461), and the numbering jumps: preserved only by Plutarch (How to Study Poetry 26f), they read, in translation: "Then I planned in my heart to cut him down with the sharp bronze; but some immortal checked my anger, putting in my heart the people's talk and the many reproaches of men, that I might not be called a father-killer among the Achaeans." Aristarchus athetized them for their shocking content (disputed\_lines.md #7), and the printed tradition dropped them so thoroughly that editors since Wolf (1785) have had to reinsert them from Plutarch (apparatus, Line 457). The translation reproduces the transmitted gap; the suppressed confession —

Phoenix nearly a parricide, saved by fear of what men would say — is the darkest mirror the poem holds up to anger mastered. ↩

33. (9.485-495) Phoenix nursing the baby Achilles — cutting his meat, holding the wine, the tunic soaked “in your troublesome babyhood”: the war’s most terrifying fighter recalled as a spitting infant, by the childless man who made him his child. The plea’s authority is this memory, and its failure is measured by it. ↩
34. (9.502-514) The Litai — the Prayers: daughters of Zeus, “lame, and wrinkled, and eyes turned aside,” limping forever after swift, strong Blindness (Ἄρτη) to heal what she wrecks; scorn them, and they ask Zeus to send Atē against the scorner. The poem’s only sustained allegory, and its moral crux: within the fiction, Achilles’ refusal of these suppliants files the request that his own ruin follow — as it does, through Patroclus. The ἄρτη-thread (1.412, 2.111, 9.115, 19.91-136 where Agamemnon tells Atē’s own myth) runs straight through this passage. ↩
35. (9.524-599) The Meleager paradigm — the poem in miniature, told to its own hero: Artemis slighted (the same forgotten-sacrifice motif, with the ἄρτη-verb at

537), the boar, the wrath, the hero idle beside his wife while his city burns; the ladder of suppliants — priests and elders with a gift of land, father at the threshold, sisters, mother, dearest companions — all refused; then the wife, Cleopatra, with her catalogue of a sacked city's griefs; he yields, fights, saves them — “and they no longer made good the gifts.” Every rung maps onto Achilles' own night (elders-with-gifts = Odysseus; father-figure = Phoenix; companions = Ajax), and the poem's audience can finish the map: the beloved whose plea will finally move Achilles is the one sitting silent in this very hut — and Meleager's wife bears the name Cleopatra, “famed of her fathers,” Patroclus's name with its elements reversed. The onomastic mirror was noticed in antiquity and remains the most elegant argument in Homer. (The Marpessa-Idas digression, 557-564 — a mortal who drew his bow on Apollo for love, and a wife nicknamed Halcyon for her mother's mourning — folds yet another tale of defiance and grief inside the paradigm.) Phoenix's warning lands askew: Meleager's lesson as told is “yield before it is too late for gifts,” but its buried lesson is “the wife's plea — the Cleopatra — comes last, and works.” Book 16 is that plea. ↩

36. (9.606-619) To Phoenix, the first softening: “I am honored by the portion of Zeus” (the replacement for the army’s failed *timē*); “be king equally with me; take half my honor”; and the schedule slips — from “tomorrow I sail” (357-363) to “at dawn we will decide whether to go or stay.” ἄττα, “old father” — the nursery word — enters the register in the same breath as the threat to hate whomever Phoenix loves. ↩
37. (9.624-642) Ajax, to Odysseus, about Achilles, in front of him — the bluntest speech in the poem: a man takes blood-price (ποινὴ) even for a murdered brother or son, and the killer walks his own country; Achilles is implacable “over a girl — one girl! — while we offer seven.” The argument from composition for homicide is the strongest yet — it names the going rate for the unpayable — and its miss is the most revealing: the wrong is no longer priced in girls at all. Then the master-stroke of the plain man: “respect your own roof: we are under it” — the *xenia*-claim, which is the one Achilles grants. ↩
38. (9.643-655) The third answer, to Ajax: “everything you have said is very nearly after my own heart” — and

the line that started it all restated raw: he treated me “as if I were some vagrant without honor (ἀτίμητον μετανάστην).” Then the third position: not sailing, not deciding at dawn, but — I fight when Hector reaches the ships of the Myrmidons. Refusal has become a timetable; the plot of Books 11-16 is Achilles’ own sentence coming true at his hut, where Hector is indeed stopped — by Patroclus’s death. ↩

39. (9.658-668) The beds: Phoenix’s made by the slave-women; Achilles with Diomedes of Lesbos, Patroclus with Iphigenia, taken at Scyros — the sack-list of 328-329 embodied in the hut’s sleeping arrangements; each concubine a city. The embassy departs one man lighter: Phoenix stays, the first crack in Achilles’ isolation. ↩

40. (9.673-692) The report: to “Odysseus of the many tales” (πολύαινος — new epithet, register), Odysseus repeats Achilles’ first answer verbatim (682-687 = 417-420, English likewise) — and reports nothing of the second or third: not “at dawn we decide,” not “when Hector reaches my ships.” The editor of the offer (note [20]) now edits the refusal, presenting the council with the starkest version — whether as

rigor, or despair, or policy is the reader's to judge.  
Aristarchus athetized 688-692, Zenodotus 692. ↩

41. (9.693-709) Diomedes closes the book he opened:  
“would you had never begged him... he will fight  
again whenever the heart in his chest commands  
him, and the god rouses him” — the truest prophecy  
in the book, and the completion of the arc from the  
silent young man of 4.401 to the voice the kings  
applaud into the night. Eat, sleep, fight at dawn: the  
war goes on without its best man, which is exactly  
what Books 10-15 now show. ↩

# Book 10

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*The Doloneia: both armies send spies into the same night — Dolon dies talking, and Odysseus and Diomedes come home laughing, with the horses of Rhesus.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 The other captains of all the Achaeans  
by the ships<sup>1</sup>
- 2 slept the whole night through, mastered  
by soft sleep;<sup>2</sup>
- 3 but not Atreus' son Agamemnon,  
shepherd of the people —
- 4 sweet sleep did not hold him, his mind  
churning many things.
- 5 As when the husband of lovely-haired

Hera flashes lightning,  
6 working a huge rain beyond all telling,  
or hail,  
7 or a snowstorm, when snow powders  
over the plowlands,  
8 or somewhere the great mouth of bitter  
war,<sup>3</sup>  
9 so thick and fast came the groans of  
Agamemnon in his chest,  
10 from the bottom of his heart; and his  
mind shook within him.  
11 Whenever he looked out toward the  
Trojan plain,  
12 he marveled at the many fires burning  
before Ilion,  
13 at the voice of flutes and pipes, and the  
din of men;<sup>4</sup>  
14 but whenever he looked at the ships  
and the Achaean host,



15 he tore the hair from his head out by  
the roots  
16 before Zeus on high, and his glorious  
heart groaned greatly.  
17 And this to his mind seemed the best  
counsel:  
18 to go first of all men to Nestor, Neleus'  
son,  
19 and see whether with him he might  
build some blameless plan  
20 that would prove a warder-off of evil  
for all the Danaans.  
21 He rose upright, and put his tunic on  
about his chest,  
22 and beneath his shining feet he bound  
fair sandals,  
23 and after that wrapped round him the  
blood-red hide of a lion,  
24 fiery, huge, reaching his feet; and he

took up a spear.

25 In the same way trembling held  
Menelaus; on his eyelids

26 either, sleep would not settle: for fear  
something befall

27 the Argives, who for his sake across so  
much water

28 had come to Troy, nursing their  
audacious war.

29 First he covered his broad back with  
the skin of a leopard,<sup>5</sup>

30 dappled; and then he lifted a rimmed  
helmet of bronze

31 and set it on his head, and took a spear  
in his thick hand.

32 Then he went to rouse his brother, who  
ruled with might

33 over all the Argives, honored by the  
people like a god.

34 He found him putting his fine armor  
about his shoulders  
35 by the stern of his ship; and his coming  
was welcome to him.  
36 Menelaus, good at the war-cry, spoke to  
him first:  
37 “Elder brother, why arm yourself so? Is  
it to rouse  
38 some companion to spy upon the  
Trojans? I am afraid,  
39 badly afraid, that no one will undertake  
that work for you —  
40 to go out alone against the enemy men,  
and scout them,  
41 through the ambrosial night. It will  
need a very bold heart.”  
42 Answering him spoke the lord  
Agamemnon:  
43 “There is need of counsel, Zeus-

nurtured Menelaus, for me  
44 and for you — cunning counsel, that  
will protect and save  
45 the Argives and the ships; for the mind  
of Zeus has turned:  
46 his heart is set now rather on Hector's  
sacrifices.  
47 For never have I seen, nor heard a man  
tell of it,  
48 one man contriving so much havoc in  
one day  
49 as Hector, dear to Zeus, has done  
against the sons of the Achaeans,  
50 unaided — no dear son of a goddess or  
a god.  
51 He has done deeds that I tell you will be  
the Argives' concern  
52 long and lastingly — such evils he has  
devised against the Achaeans.<sup>6</sup>

- 53 But go now, run beside the ships, and  
call
- 54 Ajax and Idomeneus; and I will go to  
brilliant Nestor
- 55 and urge him to rise — to see if he is  
willing
- 56 to go to the sacred company of the  
guards, and give the orders.
- 57 They would obey him soonest, for his  
own son
- 58 is a commander of the guards, with  
Idomeneus' aide
- 59 Meriones; to them above all others we  
gave the charge.”
- 60 Then answered him Menelaus, good at  
the war-cry:
- 61 “How do you mean this word of  
command you give me?
- 62 Do I stay there with them, waiting until

you come,

63 or run after you again, once I have delivered your orders?”

64 Then the lord of men Agamemnon answered him:

65 “Stay there, so that we do not miss one another

66 as we come and go; there are many paths through the camp.

67 Call out, wherever you go, and bid them stay awake,

68 naming each man from his father, by his lineage,7

69 giving every man his honor. Do not be lofty in spirit;

70 no, let us do the labor ourselves, we too. This must be

71 the heavy misery Zeus laid on us at our very birth.”

72 So speaking, he sent his brother off  
with clear instructions,  
73 and set out himself for Nestor,  
shepherd of the people.  
74 He found him beside his hut and his  
black ship,  
75 in a soft bed; beside him lay his  
intricate gear —  
76 a shield, and two spears, and a shining  
helmet;  
77 beside him lay the glittering war-belt  
the old man girded on  
78 whenever he armed himself for man-  
destroying war  
79 and led out his people; he made no  
concession to grim old age.  
80 He raised himself up on his elbow,  
lifted his head,  
81 and spoke to Atreus' son, questioning

him with a word:

82 “Who are you, walking alone through  
the camp among the ships

83 in the murky night, when other  
mortals are sleeping?

84 Seeking one of your mules, or one of  
your companions?8

85 Speak — do not come at me silent.  
What is your need?”

86 Then answered him the lord of men  
Agamemnon:

87 “Nestor, Neleus’ son, great glory of the  
Achaeans,

88 you will know Atreus’ son Agamemnon  
— the man whom Zeus

89 beyond all men has plunged into toils  
without end, while breath

90 stays in my chest and my knees have  
their spring.



- 91 I wander so because sweet sleep will  
not settle on my eyes;
- 92 the war is my care, and the sufferings  
of the Achaeans.
- 93 I fear terribly for the Danaans. My  
heart is not
- 94 steady; I am storm-tossed; the heart  
leaps out of my chest,
- 95 and my shining limbs tremble beneath  
me.
- 96 But if you will bestir yourself — since  
sleep has not come to you either —
- 97 come, let us go down to the guards, and  
look:
- 98 for fear that, sodden with weariness  
and with sleep,
- 99 they have dropped off, and forgotten  
the watch entirely.
- 100 Enemy men are camped close by, and

we know nothing:

101 they might even be minded to fight us  
in the night.”

102 Then answered him the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor:

103 “Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of  
men Agamemnon,

104 surely not all of Hector’s designs will  
Zeus the counselor

105 accomplish for him — all he now  
hopes. I think instead

106 he will sweat under troubles even  
more than ours, if once Achilles

107 turns his own heart back from its  
galling anger.

108 And I will follow you, gladly. But let us  
wake others as well:

109 Tydeus’ son, famed with the spear,  
and Odysseus,

110 and swift Ajax, and the stout son of  
Phyleus.<sup>9</sup>

111 And if someone would also go and  
summon the rest —

112 godlike Ajax, and the lord Idomeneus,  
113 whose ships are the farthest off of all,  
nowhere near us.

114 But Menelaus — dear though he is to  
me, and respected —

115 I will fault him, though you may resent  
me; I will not hide it:<sup>10</sup>

116 he sleeps, and has left the labor to you  
alone.

117 Now is when he should be laboring  
among all the captains,

118 pleading with them; the need that has  
come will not be borne.”

119 Then the lord of men Agamemnon  
answered him:

120 “Old man, another day I would even  
bid you blame him;  
121 he does often hang back, and is  
unwilling to labor —  
122 not that he yields to sloth or  
thoughtlessness of mind,  
123 but he looks to me, and waits for my  
lead.  
124 This time he woke well before me, and  
came and stood over me,  
125 and I sent him ahead to summon the  
very men you ask for.  
126 Let us go: we shall overtake them  
before the gates,  
127 among the guards; for that is where I  
told them to gather.”  
128 Then answered him the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor:  
129 “Then no man of the Argives will

resent him

130 or disobey, when he stirs a man on  
and gives commands.”

131 So speaking, he put his tunic on about  
his chest,

132 and beneath his shining feet he bound  
fair sandals,

133 and pinned about himself a purple-red  
cloak,

134 double-folded, full-falling, thick with a  
nap of wool.

135 And he took up a stout spear, edged  
with sharp bronze,

136 and went along the ships of the  
bronze-shirted Achaeans.

137 First it was Odysseus, the equal of Zeus  
in counsel,

138 that the Gerenian horseman Nestor  
woke from sleep,

139 calling out; and the voice came quickly  
about his senses,  
140 and he came out of the hut, and spoke  
to them a word:  
141 “Why do you wander alone like this by  
the ships, through the camp,  
142 in the ambrosial night — what need is  
so great upon you?”  
143 Then answered him the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor:  
144 “Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus  
of many devices,  
145 do not be angry: such grief has  
overmastered the Achaeans.  
146 Come with us, so we may wake the  
next man too, one fit  
147 to take counsel together, whether to  
run or fight.”  
148 So he spoke; and resourceful Odysseus,

going into the hut,

149 put his figured shield about his  
shoulders, and went with them.

150 They went on to Tydeus' son  
Diomedes, and came upon him

151 outside his hut with his weapons; and  
around him his companions

152 slept with their shields beneath their  
heads; their spears

153 stood driven upright on their butt-  
spikes, and far off the bronze

154 flashed like the lightning of father  
Zeus. The hero himself

155 slept, the hide of a field-ox spread  
underneath him

156 and a bright carpet stretched beneath  
his head.

157 The Gerenian horseman Nestor stood  
by him and woke him,

158 stirring him with a kick of his heel,  
and scolded him to his face:  
159 “Wake, son of Tydeus! Why doze away  
the whole night’s sleep?<sup>11</sup>  
160 Do you not hear how the Trojans, on  
the swell of the plain,  
161 sit close to the ships, and only a little  
ground still holds them off?”  
162 So he spoke; and Diomedes started  
sharply out of sleep,  
163 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:  
164 “You are a hard one, old man. You  
never cease from labor.  
165 Are there not other, younger sons of  
the Achaeans,  
166 who might go round and wake each of  
the kings in turn,  
167 walking everywhere? You are



impossible, old man.”

168 Then answered him the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor:

169 “Yes, friend — all this you have said  
rightly and in due measure.

170 I have blameless sons of my own, and I  
have people,

171 plenty of them; one of these might go  
around and call.

172 But a very great need has  
overmastered the Achaeans:

173 now for all of us it stands upon the  
razor’s edge —12

174 either grim destruction for the  
Achaeans, or life.

175 Go then and rouse swift Ajax and the  
son of Phyleus —

176 you are the younger — if you have pity  
on me.”

177 So he spoke; and round his shoulders  
he wrapped the hide of a lion,  
178 fiery, huge, reaching his feet; and he  
took up a spear.  
179 And the hero went, woke those men,  
and brought them from their places.  
180 And when they came among the  
assembled guards,  
181 they did not find the leaders of the  
watch asleep:  
182 all of them sat wide awake with their  
weapons.  
183 As dogs around sheep in a fold keep  
painful watch,  
184 hearing a hard-hearted beast that  
through the timber  
185 comes down among the mountains,  
and much clamor rises  
186 about it from men and dogs, and their

sleep is destroyed,

187 so sweet sleep was destroyed from  
their eyelids

188 as they kept watch through the evil  
night; toward the plain

189 they were turned always, listening for  
the Trojans coming.

190 The old man rejoiced to see them, and  
heartened them with a word,

191 and speaking winged words he  
addressed them:

192 “Keep your watch like that, dear  
children. Let no one

193 be taken by sleep — or we become a  
joy to our enemies.”

194 So speaking he swept on across the  
ditch; and with him followed

195 the kings of the Argives, all who had  
been summoned to council.

196 With them went Meriones and  
Nestor's shining son,  
197 for the kings themselves had called  
them in to share the counsels.  
198 They crossed the deep-dug ditch and  
seated themselves  
199 in a clear space, where ground showed  
empty of the dead<sup>13</sup>  
200 who had fallen — there where massive  
Hector had turned back  
201 from destroying Argives, when night  
closed in around them.  
202 There they sat down and declared  
their words to one another,  
203 and the Gerenian horseman Nestor  
began to speak among them:  
204 "Friends, will no man put trust  
enough in his own  
205 daring heart to go out among the

great-hearted

206 Trojans? He might catch some  
straggler at the enemy's edge,

207 or he might even gather some rumor  
among the Trojans —

208 what they are counseling among  
themselves — whether they mean

209 to stay where they are by the ships,  
far away, or will withdraw

210 back to the city, since they have  
beaten down the Achaeans.

211 All that he might learn, and come back  
to us again

212 unharmed; and great would his fame  
be under heaven

213 among all men, and a noble gift will be  
his:

214 for as many of the best men as  
command the ships,

215 of all of those, each single one will  
give him a black ewe,

216 a female with lamb at teat — no  
possession like it —14

217 and he will always be included at  
feasts and banquets.”

218 So he spoke, and they all went still in  
silence.

219 And among them spoke Diomedes,  
good at the war-cry:

220 “Nestor, my own heart and my proud  
spirit urge me

221 to enter the camp of the enemy men  
who lie

222 close by — the Trojans. But if some  
other man went with me,

223 there would be more comfort in it,  
and more boldness too.

224 When two go together, one marks

before the other<sup>15</sup>

<sup>225</sup> where the advantage lies. A man alone  
may see it,

<sup>226</sup> but his wit is slower, and his cunning  
thin.”

<sup>227</sup> So he spoke; and many were willing to  
follow Diomedes.

<sup>228</sup> The two Ajaxes were willing, those  
squires of Ares;

<sup>229</sup> Meriones was willing; most willing,  
Nestor’s son;

<sup>230</sup> willing was Atreus’ son Menelaus,  
famed with the spear;

<sup>231</sup> and willing was hardy Odysseus to slip  
into the throng

<sup>232</sup> of the Trojans — the heart in his chest  
was always daring.

<sup>233</sup> And among them spoke the lord of  
men Agamemnon:

234 “Diomedes, Tydeus’ son, delight of my  
heart,  
235 the companion — you shall choose  
him yourself, whichever you want,  
236 the best of those who offer  
themselves; many are eager.  
237 Do not, from deference in your heart,  
leave the better man  
238 behind, and take the worse to go with  
you,  
239 yielding to respect, eyeing birth — not  
even if he is the more kingly.”  
240 So he spoke, and was afraid for tawny-  
haired Menelaus.16  
241 And among them spoke again  
Diomedes, good at the war-cry:  
242 “If you truly bid me choose my  
companion myself,  
243 how then could I forget godlike



Odysseus,

244 whose heart is forward and whose  
spirit proud

245 in every kind of labor — and Pallas  
Athena loves him.

246 With him following me, even out of  
blazing fire

247 the two of us would come home; he  
knows beyond all how to think.”

248 Then answered him much-enduring  
brilliant Odysseus:

249 “Tydeus’ son, neither praise me  
overmuch nor blame me;

250 these are things known to the Argives  
you say them among.

251 Come, let us go. The night is far spent,  
and dawn is near;

252 the stars have moved far on; and more  
of the night has passed

253 than two of its parts, and only the  
third part is left.”17

254 So the two spoke, and got themselves  
into their fearsome gear.

255 Thrasymedes, steadfast in battle, gave  
Tydeus’ son

256 a two-edged sword — for his own was  
left by his ship —

257 and a shield; and about his head he set  
a helmet

258 of bull’s hide, ridgeless, crestless —  
the kind men call

259 a skull-cap, and it guards the heads of  
strong young men.18

260 And Meriones gave Odysseus a bow  
and a quiver

261 and a sword; and about his head he set  
a helmet

262 made of leather; and inside it was

strung taut

263 with many thongs; and outside the  
white teeth

264 of a shining-tusked boar were set  
close along it, this way and that,

265 well and with skill; and in the middle a  
cap of felt was fitted.

266 This helmet Autolycus once stole out  
of Eleon19

267 from Amyntor, Ormenus' son,  
breaking into his close-built house;

268 he gave it at Scandeia to Amphidamas  
of Cythera;

269 Amphidamas gave it to Molus, to be  
his guest-gift,

270 and Molus gave it to his son Meriones  
to wear;

271 and now it was set round the head of  
Odysseus, and covered it.

272 And when the two had got themselves  
into their fearsome gear,  
273 they set out, and left all the best men  
there in their places.  
274 And close by their road Pallas Athena  
sent them  
275 a heron on the right; their eyes could  
not see it20  
276 through the murky night, but they  
heard it cry aloud.  
277 Odysseus rejoiced at the bird-sign, and  
prayed to Athena:  
278 “Hear me, child of aegis-bearing Zeus  
— you who always  
279 stand beside me in every labor, and I  
do not  
280 escape your eye when I move: now  
again love me best, Athena,  
281 and grant that we come back with

glory to the ships,

282 having done a great deed, one that  
will be the Trojans' concern."

283 And second in turn prayed Diomedes,  
good at the war-cry:

284 "Hear me now also, child of Zeus,  
Unwearied one.

285 Go with me as once you went with my  
father, brilliant Tydeus,21

286 into Thebes, when he went before the  
Achaeans as their envoy.

287 He left the bronze-shirted Achaeans  
there at the Asopus,

288 and himself carried a honeyed word  
to the Cadmeans

289 there; but on the way back he devised  
deeds of sheer havoc

290 with you, brilliant goddess, when you  
stood by him in your kindness.

291 So now again be willing to stand by  
me, and guard me.

292 And I in return will sacrifice to you a  
yearling heifer,  
293 broad-browed, unbroken, that no man  
has yet led under the yoke:  
294 that I will sacrifice to you, and  
sheathe her horns in gold.”<sup>22</sup>

295 So they spoke in prayer, and Pallas  
Athena heard them.

296 And when they had prayed to the  
daughter of great Zeus,  
297 they went on their way like two lions  
through the black night,  
298 through the slaughter, through the  
corpses, through the gear and the black  
blood.<sup>23</sup>

299 Nor did Hector allow the proud  
Trojans to sleep

300 either; he called together all their  
best men,  
301 all who were leaders and lords of the  
Trojans;  
302 and calling them together he framed  
his shrewd plan:  
303 “Who will undertake a work for me  
and bring it through  
304 to the end, for a great gift? The wage  
will be enough:  
305 I will give a chariot and two strong-  
necked horses,  
306 the finest that there are beside the  
swift ships of the Achaeans,  
307 to the man who dares — and he will  
win glory for himself —  
308 to go close to the swift-faring ships,  
and find out  
309 whether the swift ships are guarded

as before,

310 or whether by now, beaten down  
under our hands,

311 they are planning flight among  
themselves, and have no wish

312 to keep watch through the night,  
sodden with brutal weariness.”

313 So he spoke, and they all went still in  
silence.

314 Now there was among the Trojans one  
Dolon, the son of Eumedes24

315 the sacred herald — rich in gold and  
rich in bronze —

316 who was ugly to look at, but swift-  
footed;

317 and he was an only son among five  
sisters.

318 He then spoke his word to the Trojans  
and Hector:



319 “Hector, my own heart and my proud  
spirit urge me<sup>25</sup>  
320 to go close to the swift-faring ships,  
and find out.  
321 Come then, lift up your scepter to me,  
and swear  
322 that you will give the horses, and the  
chariot intricate with bronze,  
323 that carry the blameless son of Peleus;  
324 and I will not be a vain scout for you,  
nor fall short of your thought.  
325 For I will go straight on through the  
camp until I come  
326 to Agamemnon’s ship, where no doubt  
their best men  
327 are taking counsel together, whether  
to run or fight.”  
328 So he spoke; and Hector took the  
scepter in his hand, and swore:

329 “Let Zeus himself now witness it, the  
loud-thunderer, Hera’s lord:  
330 no other man of the Trojans shall  
mount behind those horses;  
331 you and none other, I declare, shall  
glory in them forever.”  
332 So he spoke, and swore it falsely —  
and set the man on fire.  
333 At once he slung his curved bow over  
his shoulders,  
334 and over it put on the hide of a grey  
wolf,  
335 and on his head a ferret-skin cap; and  
he took a sharp javelin, 26  
336 and set out from the camp toward the  
ships — nor was he ever  
337 to come back from the ships and carry  
his word to Hector.  
338 But when he had left the crowds of

horses and men behind,  
339 he went up the road, all eagerness;  
and Zeus-sprung Odysseus  
340 marked him coming on, and said to  
Diomedes:  
341 “Diomedes, here is some man coming  
out of the camp;  
342 I cannot tell if he means to spy upon  
our ships  
343 or to strip one of the corpses of the  
dead.  
344 Let us let him pass us by on the plain  
345 a little first; then rushing after we can  
take him  
346 quickly. And if he outruns the two of  
us on foot,  
347 keep crowding him always toward the  
ships, away from the camp,  
348 lunging with your spear, so he cannot

slip off to the town.”

349 So the two spoke, and they lay down  
off the road

350 among the corpses; and in his folly he  
ran quickly past.

351 But when he was as far away as mules  
plow in one stretch —27

352 for mules are better beasts than oxen  
353 at dragging the jointed plow through  
deep fallow land —

354 the two ran after him; and he stopped  
still at the sound of feet,

355 for he hoped in his heart they were  
companions coming

356 from the Trojans to turn him back,  
Hector recalling him.

357 But when they were a spear-throw off,  
or even less,

358 he knew them for enemy men, and

moved his nimble knees

359 in flight; and they leapt quickly into  
the chase.

360 As when two jag-toothed hounds that  
know the hunt

361 press hard on a fawn or a hare,  
unrelenting, always,

362 through wooded country, and it runs  
crying before them,

363 so Tydeus' son and Odysseus, sacker of  
cities,

364 cut him off from his people and  
chased him, unrelenting, always.

365 But when he was on the point of  
mixing with the guards

366 in his flight toward the ships, then  
Athena put fury

367 into Tydeus' son, so that no bronze-  
shirted Achaeon

368 might boast that he struck first, with  
Diomedes coming second.

369 Rushing at him with the spear, strong  
Diomedes spoke:

370 “Stand — or I reach you with the  
spear; and I tell you,

371 you will not long escape sheer  
destruction from my hand.”

372 He spoke, and let the spear fly — and  
missed the man on purpose:28

373 over his right shoulder the point of  
the polished spear

374 stuck fast in the earth. Dolon stood  
still, terrified,

375 stammering — through his mouth  
came the chatter of his teeth —

376 green with fear. Panting, the two  
caught up with him

377 and seized his hands; and he burst into

tears and said:

378 “Take me alive, and I will ransom  
myself: at home there lies

379 bronze, and gold, and iron worked  
with much labor;

380 out of these my father would gladden  
you with ransom past counting

381 if he learned I was alive by the ships of  
the Achaeans.”

382 Answering him spoke resourceful  
Odysseus:

383 “Take heart; and let death be no  
concern of your mind.29

384 But come, tell me this, and recount it  
truly:

385 where are you going alone to the  
ships, away from the camp,

386 in the murky night, when other  
mortals are sleeping?

387 To strip one of the corpses of the  
dead?

388 Or did Hector send you out to spy on  
everything

389 at the hollow ships? Or did your own  
heart drive you?”

390 Then Dolon answered him, his limbs  
trembling under him:

391 “With many blindnesses Hector led  
my mind astray:30

392 the whole-hoofed horses of the  
illustrious son of Peleus

393 he promised on his nod to give, and  
the chariot intricate with bronze,

394 and told me to go on through the  
swift black night,

395 and get close to the enemy men, and  
find out

396 whether the swift ships are guarded



as before,

397 or whether by now, beaten down  
under our hands,

398 they are planning flight among  
themselves, and have no wish

399 to keep watch through the night,  
sodden with brutal weariness.”31

400 And resourceful Odysseus answered  
him, smiling:

401 “Great gifts indeed those were your  
heart was set on —

402 the horses of the war-minded son of  
Aeacus. They are hard

403 for mortal men to break or to drive,

404 for any man but Achilles, whom an  
immortal mother bore.

405 But come, tell me this, and recount it  
truly:

406 where, when you came here, did you

leave Hector, shepherd of the people?

407 Where does his warlike gear lie?

Where are his horses?

408 And the other Trojans — how are  
their watches and sleeping-places?

409 What are they counseling among  
themselves — whether they mean

410 to stay where they are by the ships,  
far away, or will withdraw

411 back to the city, since they have beaten  
down the Achaeans?”

412 Then answered him Dolon, Eumedes’  
son:

413 “Well then, I will recount all this to  
you very truly.

414 Hector, with all those men who are  
counselors,

415 is taking counsel by the tomb of  
godlike Ilus,32

416 apart from the din. But the watches  
you ask about, hero —  
417 no picked guard protects the camp,  
and none keeps watch.  
418 As for the Trojans' watch-fires: the  
men under necessity,  
419 they stay awake beside them, and call  
to one another  
420 to keep the watch. But the allies,  
called from many lands,  
421 are sleeping; they leave the watching  
to the Trojans,  
422 for their own children and wives do  
not lie near them.”  
423 Answering him spoke resourceful  
Odysseus:  
424 “Now how is it — do they sleep  
mingled with the horse-taming  
425 Trojans, or apart? Tell me plainly, so I

may know.”

426 Then answered him Dolon, Eumedes’  
son:

427 “Well then, I will recount this too to  
you very truly.

428 Toward the sea lie the Carians and the  
Paeonians of the curved bows,33

429 the Leleges and the Caucones and the  
brilliant Pelasgians;

430 toward Thymbre fell the lot of the  
Lycians and the lordly Mysians

431 and horse-fighting Phrygians, and  
Maeonians, men who fight from chariots.

432 But why do you question me through  
all this, point by point?

433 If you two are bent on slipping into  
the Trojans’ throng,

434 here, apart, are the Thracians, new-  
come, outermost of all,

435 and among them their king Rhesus,  
son of Eïoneus.  
436 His horses are the finest I have ever  
seen, and the biggest:  
437 whiter than snow, and like the winds  
in running.  
438 His chariot is finely worked with gold  
and silver,  
439 and the armor he came in is golden,  
gigantic, a wonder<sup>34</sup>  
440 to look at — armor that suits, not  
mortal men  
441 to carry, but the deathless gods.  
442 But now, take me with you to the  
swift-faring ships,  
443 or bind me with a pitiless bond and  
leave me here,  
444 until you two have gone and made  
your trial of me,

445 whether I have spoken to you justly, or  
not.”

446 Glaring at him darkly, strong  
Diomedes spoke:

447 “Do not put escape into your heart,  
Dolon,

448 good though your news is, now you  
have come into our hands.

449 For if we free you now for ransom, or  
let you go,

450 surely later you will come again to the  
swift ships of the Achaeans,

451 either spying once more, or fighting  
us face to face;

452 but if, beaten down under my hands,  
you lose your life,

453 never again will you be a plague upon  
the Argives.”

454 He spoke; and the man was reaching

for his chin with his broad hand,  
455 meaning to plead — but the other  
drove at the middle of his neck,  
456 springing with the sword, and sheared  
through both the tendons;  
457 and the head of the still-speaking man  
was mingled with the dust.35  
458 From him they took the cap of ferret  
skin,  
459 the grey wolf's hide, the back-bent  
bow, and the long spear;  
460 and these to Athena of the Spoils  
brilliant Odysseus36  
461 held up high in his hand, and praying  
spoke a word:  
462 “Rejoice in these, goddess. To you first  
of all the immortals  
463 on Olympus we will give your share.  
But once again

464 send us on, to the Thracian men's  
horses and sleeping-places."  
465 So he spoke, and lifted the spoils high  
away from himself  
466 and set them on a tamarisk; and he set  
a mark plain to see,  
467 pulling together reeds and the  
tamarisk's flourishing boughs,  
468 so they would not miss it, coming  
back through the swift black night.  
469 The two went forward, through the  
gear and the black blood,  
470 and quickly, pressing on, they reached  
the company of Thracian men.  
471 They were sleeping, sodden with  
weariness, and their fine gear  
472 lay by them on the ground, all in good  
order,  
473 in three rows; and beside each man his



yoke-pair of horses.

474 Rhesus slept in the middle, and beside  
him his swift horses

475 were tethered by the reins to the  
chariot's outer rail.

476 Odysseus saw him first, and pointed  
him out to Diomedes:

477 "That is the man, Diomedes; and those  
are the horses

478 that Dolon marked out for us — the  
man we killed.

479 Come then, show your great strength.  
You have no business

480 standing idle in your armor. Untie the  
horses —

481 or else you kill the men, and the  
horses will be my care."

482 So he spoke; and grey-eyed Athena  
breathed fury into him.

483 He killed, wheeling on every side, and  
a hideous groaning rose  
484 from men struck by the sword; and  
the earth reddened with blood.  
485 As a lion coming upon flocks without  
their herdsman,  
486 on goats or on sheep, springs in with  
evil purpose,  
487 so Tydeus' son moved up and down  
among the Thracian men  
488 until he had killed twelve. And  
resourceful Odysseus —  
489 whomever Tydeus' son struck with  
the sword, standing above him,  
490 him Odysseus would seize by the foot  
from behind and drag aside,  
491 with this thought in his mind: that the  
fair-maned horses  
492 might pass through easily, and not

shiver in their hearts

493 at stepping on dead men — being still  
unused to them.

494 But when Tydeus' son came upon the  
king,

495 he was the thirteenth he robbed of his  
honey-sweet life,

496 gasping hard: for an evil dream stood  
at his head

497 that night — the son of Oeneus' son —  
by the cunning of Athena.37

498 All that time hardy Odysseus was  
untying the whole-hoofed horses;

499 he bound them together with reins  
and drove them from the crowd,

500 beating them with his bow, because  
he had not thought38

501 to take up in his hands the shining  
whip from the intricate chariot;

502 then he gave a whistle, his signal to  
brilliant Diomedes.

503 But Diomedes waited, weighing what  
boldest thing he might do:

504 whether to seize the chariot where  
the intricate gear lay

505 and drag it out by the pole, or heave it  
high and carry it,

506 or take away the life of still more  
Thracians.

507 While he was turning this over in his  
mind, Athena

508 came near and stood, and spoke to  
brilliant Diomedes:

509 “Think of your return now, son of  
great-hearted Tydeus,<sup>39</sup>

510 back to the hollow ships — or you may  
go back to them running,

511 and some other god may waken the

Trojans too.”

512 So she spoke; and he knew the voice of  
the goddess speaking,

513 and swiftly mounted a horse; and  
Odysseus struck the pair

514 with his bow, and they flew toward the  
swift ships of the Achaeans.

515 But Apollo of the silver bow kept no  
blind man’s watch40

516 when he saw Athena attending on  
Tydeus’ son:

517 angry with her, he sank into the great  
throng of Trojans

518 and woke a counselor of the  
Thracians, Hippocoon,

519 Rhesus’ noble kinsman. And he leapt  
up out of sleep,

520 and when he saw the place empty  
where the swift horses had stood,

521 and the men gasping amid the grim  
slaughter,  
522 he groaned aloud, and called out the  
name of his dear companion.  
523 And a clamor rose from the Trojans,  
and measureless uproar,  
524 as they rushed together; they gazed at  
the deeds of havoc —  
525 all that the men had done before  
going to the hollow ships.  
526 And when the two came where they  
had killed Hector's scout,  
527 there Odysseus, dear to Zeus, held in  
the swift horses,  
528 and Tydeus' son leapt down, and put  
the bloody spoils  
529 into Odysseus' hands, and mounted up  
again;  
530 and he whipped the horses on, and

the two flew, nothing loath,  
531 toward the hollow ships; for that way  
was dear to their hearts.  
532 Nestor was the first to hear the  
drumming of hooves, and spoke:  
533 “Friends, leaders and lords of the  
Argives,  
534 shall I be wrong, or right, in what I  
say? My heart commands it.41  
535 The drumming of swift-footed horses  
strikes about my ears.  
536 If only it were Odysseus and strong  
Diomedes  
537 driving whole-hoofed horses here, so  
quickly, out of the Trojans!  
538 But terribly I fear in my heart that  
they have come to harm —  
539 the best of the Argives — in the uproar  
of the Trojans.”

540 The whole word was not yet spoken  
when they came themselves,  
541 and stepped down to the ground; and  
the others, rejoicing,  
542 welcomed them with clasped right  
hands and honeyed words.  
543 And first to question them was the  
Gerenian horseman Nestor:  
544 “Come, tell me, Odysseus of the many  
tales, great glory of the Achaeans:  
545 how did you two take these horses? By  
slipping into the throng  
546 of the Trojans? Or did some god meet  
you, and give them?  
547 They are terribly like the rays of the  
sun.  
548 Always I mix with the Trojans; I say I  
am no lingerer  
549 beside the ships, old warrior though I



am;

550 but never yet have I seen such horses,  
or dreamed of them.

551 No — I think some god must have met  
you and given them,

552 for Zeus the cloud-gatherer loves the  
two of you,

553 and the daughter of aegis-bearing  
Zeus, grey-eyed Athena.”

554 Answering him spoke resourceful  
Odysseus:

555 “Nestor, Neleus’ son, great glory of the  
Achaeans,

556 easily could a god, if he wished, give  
better horses

557 even than these, since the gods are far  
mightier.

558 But these horses you ask about, old  
man, are newly come —

559 Thracians; their lord — brave  
Diomedes killed him,  
560 and beside him twelve companions,  
all their best men.  
561 The thirteenth was a scout we took  
near the ships, 42  
562 a man sent out to be a spy upon our  
army  
563 by Hector and the rest of the  
illustrious Trojans.”  
564 So speaking, he drove the whole-  
hoofed horses across the ditch,  
565 laughing aloud; and the other  
Achaeans followed, rejoicing.  
566 And when they reached the well-built  
hut of Tydeus’ son,  
567 they tied up the horses with well-cut  
thongs  
568 at the horse-manger, where the

horses of Diomedes

569 stood, swift-footed, eating their  
honey-sweet grain.

570 And on his ship's stern Odysseus laid  
the bloody spoils

571 of Dolon, till they could make the  
offering ready for Athena.

572 And the men themselves waded into  
the sea, and washed away

573 the heavy sweat from their shins and  
necks and thighs.

574 And when the waves of the sea had  
washed the heavy sweat

575 from their skin, and the dear heart in  
them was cooled,

576 they stepped into polished bathing-  
tubs and bathed.43

577 And when the two had bathed and  
rubbed themselves sleek with oil,

578 they sat down to their meal, and from  
a brimming mixing-bowl  
579 they drew honey-sweet wine and  
poured it out to Athena.

## Notes

### NOTES

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#### NOTES

1. (10.1) The Doloneia is the only book of the Iliad whose place in the poem was disputed in antiquity as a whole (curated dispute #8). A scholion preserved in the T manuscript reports: “they say that this rhapsody was arranged separately by Homer and was not counted part of the Iliad, but was placed into the poem by Pisistratus.” Aristarchus treated the book as genuine; modern critics have gone both ways, Analysts excising it, defenders reading it as an old ambush-theme (the *lochos*) integral to the tradition. The internal evidence is genuinely double-

edged — see the commentary above and notes [39] and [43]. The apparatus for this book records only line-level variants; the whole-book question lives in the testimonia. ↩

2. (10.1-2) The opening repeats the shape of Book 2's opening, in our same words ("slept the whole night through"; 2.1-2). The reversal is exact: there all slept but Zeus, who lay awake devising the Achaeans' ruin through a false dream; here all sleep but Agamemnon, who lies awake suffering that ruin — and the night will end with a true nightmare standing over a sleeper's head (note [37]). ↩
3. (10.5-8) Zeus's lightning as the portent of prodigious rain, hail, snow, "or somewhere the great mouth of bitter war": πευκεδανοῖο (8), a rare word cognate with pine-pitch bitterness, occurs only here in Homer. Agamemnon's groans come as thick as the flashes. ↩
4. (10.11-13) The many fires are the ones Hector lit at the end of Book 8 (8.553-565): Book 10, like Book 9 (9.77), opens inside the tableau Book 8 left burning. The "flutes and pipes" are the only battlefield music in the Iliad — the sound of an army sure of tomorrow —

heard otherwise only in the city at peace on the Shield (18.495). ↩

5. (10.29) Night gear. This book replaces the formal bronze arming scene with skins: Agamemnon's lion (23-24), Menelaus's leopard and plain bronze cap, Diomedes' lion (177-178), Dolon's wolf-hide and ferret cap (334-335), and the two spies' leather helmets (257-265). Animal dress belongs to the night-world of the ambush, where the day-world's flashing crests would kill their wearer; the poet has an exact costume-vocabulary for it, most of it appearing nowhere else. ↩
6. (10.51-52) Athetized by Aristophanes of Byzantium and Aristarchus — the hyperbole (one day's work to be the Argives' concern "long and lastingly") judged un-Homeric. ↩
7. (10.68) "naming each man from his father, by his lineage" — courtesy as night-discipline: a voice in the dark must honor to be trusted. With it goes Agamemnon's "let us do the labor ourselves... Zeus laid this heavy misery on us at our very birth" (70-71); the night-book consistently shows the commanders' fear and drudgery that the day-books dress in ceremony. ↩

8. (10.84) Athetized by Aristarchus, presumably for the mules: Nestor's guess that a man groping through the camp at midnight is after a strayed mule struck ancient taste as beneath the epic. It is also the poem's one quartermaster's-eye view of its own camp. ↩
9. (10.110) "swift Ajax" is the Locrian, Oïleus' son (2.527); "the stout son of Phyleus" is Meges (2.627). The greater Ajax is the "godlike Ajax" of 112, paired as usual with Idomeneus. ↩
10. (10.114-125) Nestor's rebuke of the sleeping Menelaus, and Agamemnon's careful defense — he often hangs back, "not that he yields to sloth... but he looks to me, and waits for my lead" — reverse the Book 1 Agamemnon, who could not take one word of blame. The night steadies him; his fairest self appears at his least kingly hour. ↩
11. (10.158-159) Nestor wakes Diomedes "with a kick of his heel" — the poem's only comic reveille, answered by the sleeper's growl that the old man is "impossible." After 159 some ancient texts carried an extra line preserved only by Diogenes Laertius (6.53), who has Diogenes the Cynic quote it while prodding

a sleeping man: “lest someone plant a spear in your back while you sleep.” It is not in the printed text. ↩

12. (10.173-174) “it stands upon the razor’s edge” — ἐπὶ ξυροῦ ἴσταται ἀκμῆς: the earliest surviving occurrence of the idiom English still uses, taken up by Theognis, Sophocles, and Herodotus (6.11). ↩
13. (10.199-201) The Achaean council convenes beyond the ditch “in a clear space, where ground showed empty of the dead” — line 199 repeats 8.491 (our wording kept), where Hector held his night assembly by the river on the same terms. Each army deliberates sitting in the other’s killing-ground; the mirrored councils organize the whole book (note [25]). ↩
14. (10.212-217) The scout’s reward: fame “under heaven,” plus a black ewe with her lamb from every captain, and a standing place at the feasts. Livestock and a seat at table — the modest, concrete economy of the night-book, set against Book 9’s seven tripods, twenty cauldrons, and seven cities. ↩
15. (10.224-226) “When two go together, one marks before the other / where the advantage lies” — proverbial already in antiquity: Plato has Socrates quote it on the way to the banquet (Symposium



174d) and again at Protagoras 348d. The couplet is the book's thesis; the Iliad's only two-man aristeia follows from it. ↩

16. (10.240) Omitted by Zenodotus, athetized by Aristarchus: the narrator's aside that Agamemnon "was afraid for tawny-haired Menelaus." The aside decodes 237-239 — "do not leave the better man behind... not even if he is the more kingly" is a king's coded plea that his brother not be chosen; the critics apparently preferred the code left unbroken. ↩
17. (10.252-253) Odysseus tells time by the stars — the working star-clock of a night operation. Line 253 was athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus over the arithmetic: if "more of the night has passed than two of its parts," then less than a third should remain — yet Odysseus allows "the third part." The Greek is loose the way spoken time-reckoning is loose ("it's past two in the morning; we have till first light"), and the ancient fussing over it is a small monument of pedantry. ↩
18. (10.257-259) The *κατὰ τρυξ*, "skull-cap": a plain bull's-hide helmet, "ridgeless, crestless," glossed in-line by the poet as if his audience needed the word explained — it occurs nowhere else in Greek

literature. Night war strips off whatever catches light. ↩

19. (10.261-271) The boar's-tusk helmet is a genuine Bronze Age object: rows of sliced boar-tusk plates over felt and leather, known from Mycenaean excavation and art, and centuries obsolete by any plausible date of the poem's composition — the pedigree the poet gives it (stolen by Autolycus, passed via Amphidamas of Cythera to Molus to Meriones) is epic's own memory of the object's antiquity. Two ironies ride with it. Autolycus is Odysseus's maternal grandfather (Od. 19.394-466): the master-thief's loot ends the night on his own grandson's head. And its original owner, "Amyntor, Ormenus' son" of Eleon, is Phoenix's father (9.448) — the house Phoenix fled in Book 9 is burgled again, as it were, in Book 10's props. ↩
20. (10.274-276) A heron on the right hand is a favorable sign; in the dark the omen is heard, not seen. The entire daylight apparatus of the poem — arming, augury, even prayer-answer — is systematically converted to the ear in this book (cf. the hooves at 532-535, the whistle at 502). ↩

21. (10.285-290) Tydeus at Thebes for the fourth time in the poem (4.372-398; 5.800-808; cf. 23.679-680): the friendly embassy, the “honeyed word,” and on the road home the ambush of fifty men that he destroyed — “deeds of sheer havoc.” Diomedes has been measured against his father since Book 4; only here, on a night ambush, does the paternal precedent exactly fit the son’s occasion. ↩
22. (10.292-294) The vow of the unbroken heifer with gilded horns recurs nearly verbatim in the *Odyssey* (3.382-384) — vowed there too by a Nestor, and fulfilled at 3.430-438, where a goldsmith actually sheathes the horns in gold leaf: the fullest “receipt” for any Homeric vow, and a famous cross-epic pair with this passage. ↩
23. (10.297-298) The epigraph lines. “Through the slaughter, through the corpses” (ἄμ φόνον, ἄν νέκυας) is the literal ground of the whole night-walk — repeated when they go forward again at 469. The two lions become two hounds on a hare (360-362) and a lion among unshepherded flocks (485-486): the book’s men are beasts of prey throughout, and the skins they wear (note [5]) say so. ↩

24. (10.314-317) Dolon: the name is transparently “Sneak” (from δόλος, “trick”). A rich herald’s son, “ugly to look at, but swift-footed” — the poet lends him Achilles’ own epithet — and an only son among five sisters: a portrait, unique in the poem, of the spoiled volunteer. He will demand Achilles’ horses as his wage (321-323) and be run down on foot. ↩
25. (10.319-332) Dolon’s speech opens word for word as Diomedes’ did (220): “my own heart and my proud spirit urge me...” — twinned volunteer-scenes, one issuing in the choice of Odysseus, the other in an empty oath. Hector swears by the scepter that “no other man of the Trojans shall mount behind those horses,” and the narrator files his verdict flat: “he swore it falsely” — not because Hector meant to cheat, but because the oath was never his to keep. Coveting the immortal horses of Achilles is this book’s measure of delusion (cf. note [30]; at 17.75-78 Hector himself is warned off them). ↩
26. (10.334-335) The grey wolf’s hide and the ferret-skin cap (κτιδέη, marten or weasel): the spy dressed as a small night predator — the bottom rung of the book’s ladder of skins (note [5]). Attic vase-painters

loved the costume; several show Dolon on all fours in the wolf-suit. ↩

27. (10.351-353) Distance measured by plowing: “as far as mules plow in one stretch” is the οὔρον, the length of furrow a team draws before turning. The homely aside — mules out-pull oxen in deep fallow — arrives at the moment of highest suspense; the epic measures its night-chase by a farmer’s daylight (cf. the fence-post interval of 23.431-432). ↩

28. (10.372-376) The spear “missed the man on purpose” — thrown to stop, not kill: they need him talking. Dolon’s terror is clinically itemized: rooted feet, stammer, teeth chattering audibly, “green with fear” — our fixed color of fear (7.479), here soaked into the man himself. ↩

29. (10.383) “Take heart; and let death be no concern of your mind” — literally true (his death is already decided, so no longer worth minding) and utterly false as the comfort it pretends to be. The interrogation that follows is the poem’s only one: two rounds, each opened with the courteous fixed line “But come, tell me this, and recount it truly” (384 = 405), each answered “Well then, I will recount... very truly” (413, 427) — the formulas of

guest-conversation conducted over a man already dead. ↩

30. (10.391) “With many blindnesses Hector led my mind astray” — ἄτησι, the register’s “blindness” (1.412): the god-sent delusion by which Agamemnon will explain the whole war in Book 19, here claimed by a small man about a promise of horses. Everyone in this poem accounts for ruin the same way; the poet lets the excuse shrink to the size of its owner. ↩
31. (10.397-399, 409-411) Both passages were athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus. Dolon reports Hector’s briefing in Hector’s very words (396-399 = 309-312 — kept verbatim in our English, “our hands” and all), and Odysseus’s question repeats Nestor’s proposal (409-411 = 208-210, flagged in the scholia as a wrongful repeat). The critics disliked the mechanical reuse; but verbatim relay is exactly how a chain of command speaks, and the poem’s economy of repeated blocks is nowhere more functional than in a spy’s debriefing. ↩
32. (10.415) The tomb of Ilus, eponym and founder of Ilion, is the plain’s standing landmark (11.166, 371-372; 24.349): Hector holds his war-council at the

ancestor's grave, as the Achaeans hold theirs among the fresh dead (note [13]). ↩

33. (10.428-431) A miniature order of battle, complement to the Trojan Catalogue (2.816-877): the same allied peoples, now laid out by billet rather than muster — Carians, Paeonians, Leleges, Caucones, Pelasgians toward the sea; Lycians, Mysians, Phrygians, Maeonians toward Thymbre. The Thracians of Rhesus stand in no catalogue: “new-come, outermost of all” — arrived, and doomed, within the one night. ↩

34. (10.435-441) Rhesus: horses “whiter than snow, and like the winds in running,” a gold-and-silver chariot, and golden armor fit for “the deathless gods.” Later tradition — the scholia, Virgil (*Aeneid* 1.469-473), and the Rhesus transmitted under Euripides’ name — knew an oracle that Troy could never fall once Rhesus and his horses had grazed Trojan pasture and drunk of Scamander, making the raid a preemption of fate. Our text knows nothing of it: here the splendor simply dwarfs its owner’s one-night part, and the armor “for the deathless gods” lies on the ground at 504 while the gods’ own agent decides against taking it. ↩

35. (10.454-457) Dolon's hand is out for the suppliant's touch of the chin (the gesture of 1.501) when the sword falls: supplication not refused, as Agamemnon refused Adrestus (6.55-65), but forestalled — a beat crueler. "And the head of the still-speaking man was mingled with the dust" (457): Aristotle quotes the line in earnest (Parts of Animals 673a), discussing whether severed heads can speak. The grammar performs the horror: the man is still a speaking subject in mid-construction as his head meets the ground. ↩
36. (10.460-466) "Athena of the Spoils" (ληϊτις) — an epithet found only here. The trophies are hung on a tamarisk and flagged with reeds and boughs for the return leg: fieldcraft doubling as votive religion, an altar-less offering to match the unseen omen of note [20]. The dedication is completed at 570-571 and the libation of 578-579. ↩
37. (10.496-497) Rhesus dies "gasping hard: for an evil dream stood at his head / that night — the son of Oeneus' son — by the cunning of Athena." The nightmare stands at the sleeper's head in the regular posture of Homeric dreams (2.20, 23.68) — and the dream is Diomedes himself, Oeneus' grandson, sword



in hand: dream and killer are one figure, the boldest compression in the book, closing the frame the false dream of Book 2 opened (note [2]). Zenodotus and Aristophanes omitted 497 and Aristarchus athetized it — flattening the vision back into ordinary death; the printed text keeps it. ↩

38. (10.498-502) Odysseus improvises: the whip is still lying in the chariot, so he beats the horses with his bow, and signals with a whistle — the only whistle in Homer. Someone did not think of everything: the small unheroic realism the day-books never allow. ↩
39. (10.509-513) “Think of your return” — νόστου δὴ μνησῶναι: the Odyssey’s theme-word sounded by Athena in the Iliad, to the other poem’s kind of hero on the other poem’s kind of errand; a centerpiece of the book’s Odyssean coloring (see commentary). And they escape riding bareback — nearly the only riding of horses in the Iliad (elsewhere a simile, 15.679-684) — because the chariot stayed with the dead. ↩
40. (10.515) “kept no blind man’s watch” — ἀλαοσκοπή, fixed here at its first occurrence; it recurs of Poseidon at 13.10 and 14.135. Zenodotus read the phrase as two words with a different sense; the printed text follows Aristarchus. ↩

41. (10.534) “shall I be wrong, or right, in what I say? My heart commands it” — literally “shall I lie, or speak true?”: Nestor’s strange scruple, omitted by Zenodotus here, recurs in Helen’s mouth at *Odyssey* 4.140. It is the night-book’s epistemology in one line: hooves heard in the dark must be guessed at aloud before they can be greeted. ↩
42. (10.561-565) Odysseus’s tally makes Dolon “the thirteenth” — answering Rhesus, the thirteenth Thracian (495): each side’s night closes its account in the same figure, and Odysseus books his interrogation-kill as a line-item. Then he drives the ditch “laughing aloud” (565) — no other killing in the *Iliad* ends in laughter; the book’s moral register, and part of what has always made readers uneasy in it, is in that word. ↩
43. (10.572-579) The close: a wade in the sea, then “polished bathing-tubs” — ἀσάμινθοι, only here in the *Iliad* against nine occurrences in the *Odyssey* — oil, a meal, and honey-sweet wine poured to Athena. An *Odyssean* hospitality-sequence grafted onto the war-camp, and a chief exhibit in the authenticity dossier (note [1]); it is also precisely what the poem’s one successful night requires — the blood of 483-484

washed off before rosy-fingered dawn, eight lines into Book 11, restores the rules of the day. In 579 Aristarchus read “drew” (ἀφυσσόμενοι); the vulgate carried a variant of the same sense. ↩

# Book 11

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*The long day begins: Agamemnon's morning of glory, the captains carried off wounded one by one, and Nestor plants the plan that will kill Patroclus.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 Dawn rose from her bed beside illustrious Tithonus<sup>1</sup>
- 2 to bring light to the immortals and to mortal men;
- 3 and Zeus sent Strife down to the swift ships of the Achaeans,
- 4 the grim goddess, holding a portent of war in her hands.
- 5 She stood on Odysseus's black ship, huge

of hull,

6 which lay midmost, so a shout could  
carry to both ends,

7 both to the huts of Ajax, Telamon's son,  
8 and to Achilles' — for they had drawn  
their balanced ships up

9 at the ends, trusting their courage and  
the strength of their hands.

10 Standing there the goddess screamed,  
great and terrible,

11 a high shriek; and into each Achaean's  
heart she threw

12 great strength, to war and fight  
without ceasing.

13 And at once war became sweeter to  
them than going home<sup>2</sup>

14 in the hollow ships to their dear  
fatherland.

15 And Atreus' son shouted aloud,

commanding the Argives

16 to gird themselves; and he himself put  
on the flashing bronze.

17 First he set the greaves along his shins,

18 fine greaves, fitted with silver ankle-  
pieces;

19 second, he put the corslet about his  
chest,

20 the one that Cinyras once gave him as a  
guest-gift:3

21 for the great report had reached him in  
Cyprus — the Achaeans

22 were about to sail up in their ships for  
Troy —

23 and so he gave it to him, a favor for the  
king.

24 On it there were ten bands of dark blue  
enamel,4

25 and twelve of gold, and twenty of tin;

26 and serpents of blue enamel reached  
up toward the neck,  
27 three on either side, like the rainbows  
the son of Cronos  
28 sets in a cloud, a portent for mortal  
men.  
29 Around his shoulders he threw his  
sword: on it the studs  
30 glittered gold, and the scabbard about  
it  
31 was silver, fitted with golden straps.  
32 And he took up his man-covering, rich-  
worked, rushing shield,  
33 a fine shield: around it ran ten circles  
of bronze,  
34 and on it were twenty bosses of tin,  
35 white, and in the center one of dark  
blue enamel;  
36 and crowning it was the Gorgon, grim

of face,

37 glaring terribly, and around her Terror  
and Panic.<sup>5</sup>

38 The shield-strap was of silver, and  
along it

39 writhed a serpent of blue enamel, with  
three heads

40 twisting every way, grown from a  
single neck.

41 On his head he set his helmet, double-  
ridged, four-bossed,

42 horsehair-crested; the plume nodded  
terribly above him.

43 And he took two stout spears, headed  
with bronze,

44 sharp ones; and far off into heaven the  
bronze

45 flashed from them; and Athena and  
Hera thundered over him,



46 doing honor to the king of Mycenae  
rich in gold.6  
47 Then each man gave his charioteer the  
order  
48 to hold the horses in good order there  
at the ditch,  
49 while they themselves, on foot, armed  
in their gear,  
50 swept forward; and quenchless rose the  
shouting before dawn.  
51 They formed at the ditch well ahead of  
the charioteers,  
52 who followed a little behind. And an  
evil tumult  
53 the son of Cronos stirred among them,  
and down from on high he sent  
54 dews dripping with blood out of the  
upper air, because he was about7  
55 to hurl down to Hades many strong

heads.

56 The Trojans on the other side, on the  
swell of the plain,

57 gathered around great Hector and  
blameless Polydamas

58 and Aeneas, honored like a god among  
Trojans by the people,

59 and Antenor's three sons — Polybus,  
and brilliant Agenor,

60 and young Acamas, the image of the  
immortals.

61 Hector among the foremost carried his  
shield, balanced every way.

62 As out of clouds a baleful star shows  
clear,<sup>8</sup>

63 all shining, and then sinks again into  
the shadowed clouds,

64 so Hector would appear now among  
the foremost,

65 now in the rearmost ranks, giving  
commands; and all in bronze  
66 he flashed like the lightning of father  
Zeus who bears the aegis.  
67 And as reapers, facing one another  
down the rows,<sup>9</sup>  
68 drive their swathes through a rich  
man's field  
69 of wheat or barley, and the handfuls  
fall thick and fast,  
70 so Trojans and Achaeans, springing at  
one another,  
71 cut men down, and neither side  
thought of ruinous flight.  
72 The battle held their heads level; and  
they raged  
73 like wolves. And Strife of the many  
groans rejoiced to see it,  
74 for she alone of the gods was with

them as they fought;

75 the other gods were not there, but at  
their ease

76 they sat in their own halls, where for  
each of them

77 a fair house was built along the folds of  
Olympus.

78 And all were blaming the son of  
Cronos, lord of the dark cloud,10

79 because his will was to hand the glory  
to the Trojans.

80 The father took no thought of them.  
Withdrawn apart,

81 he sat away from the others, exulting  
in his glory,

82 looking out at the city of the Trojans  
and the ships of the Achaeans,

83 at the flash of bronze, at the killers and  
the killed.

84 So long as it was morning, and the  
sacred day still growing,<sup>11</sup>  
85 so long the missiles of both sides struck  
home, and the people fell.  
86 But at the hour a woodcutter makes his  
meal ready  
87 in the mountain glens, when his arms  
have had their fill  
88 of felling the tall trees, and weariness  
comes on his heart,  
89 and desire for sweet food takes hold of  
his mind,  
90 at that hour the Danaans by their  
courage broke the battle-lines,  
91 calling to their companions down the  
ranks. And Agamemnon  
92 charged first, and killed a man: Bienor,  
shepherd of the people —  
93 the man himself, then his companion

Oïleus, lasher of horses,  
94 who had leapt down from the chariot  
and stood to face him;  
95 and as he came straight on, he stabbed  
him with the sharp spear  
96 in the forehead; the helmet's heavy  
bronze rim did not stop it —  
97 through rim and bone it went, and the  
brain  
98 was all spattered inside it. He broke  
him in mid-charge.  
99 And the lord of men Agamemnon left  
them there,  
100 their chests gleaming bare, when he  
had stripped their tunics,  
101 and went on to kill Isus and Antiphus,  
102 two sons of Priam, bastard and true-  
born both,  
103 riding one chariot: the bastard held

the reins,

104 and famed Antiphus stood beside him  
to fight. Achilles

105 once bound these two with willow  
shoots, in the spurs of Ida,

106 taking them as they watched their  
sheep, and freed them for ransom.12

107 But now the son of Atreus, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon,

108 struck one with the spear in the chest  
above the nipple,

109 and struck Antiphus by the ear with  
the sword, and threw him from the  
chariot.

110 Hurrying, he stripped their fine armor  
from them —

111 knowing them: for he had seen them  
once before by the swift ships,

112 when swift-footed Achilles brought

them down from Ida.

113 As a lion easily crushes the helpless  
young

114 of a swift deer, seizing them in his  
strong teeth,

115 having come to their bed, and takes  
their soft life away,

116 and the mother, even if she chances to  
be very near, can do

117 nothing to help them, for terrible  
trembling comes on her too,

118 and swiftly she darts away through the  
thick brush and the timber,

119 sweating, at speed, before the assault  
of the mighty beast —

120 so no one of the Trojans could ward  
destruction

121 from those two; they themselves were  
fleeing before the Argives.



122 Next Peisander and Hippolochus,  
staunch in the fight,  
123 sons of war-minded Antimachus — the  
man who, above all,  
124 taking Alexandros's gold, his glittering  
gifts,  
125 opposed giving Helen back to tawny-  
haired Menelaus —  
126 his two sons the lord Agamemnon  
caught,  
127 both in one chariot, trying to hold  
their swift horses,  
128 for the shining reins had slipped out  
of their hands  
129 and the pair had panicked. Like a lion  
the son of Atreus  
130 rose to meet them; and from the  
chariot the two begged him:  
131 "Take us alive, son of Atreus — and

take a worthy ransom.

132 Many treasures lie stored in the house  
of Antimachus,

133 bronze, and gold, and iron worked  
with much labor:

134 out of these our father would gladden  
you with ransom past counting

135 if he learned we were alive by the  
ships of the Achaeans.”

136 So the two of them, weeping,  
addressed the king

137 with honeyed words; but the voice  
they heard was unhoneeyed:13

138 “If you two are truly sons of war-  
minded Antimachus,

139 who once in the Trojan assembly  
urged that Menelaus,

140 come as an envoy with godlike  
Odysseus,

141 be killed on the spot and not released  
back to the Achaeans —  
142 now you will pay for your father's foul  
outrage.”  
143 He spoke, and thrust Peisander from  
the chariot to the ground,  
144 striking him with the spear in the  
chest; he crashed on his back in the dust.  
145 Hippolochus leapt away; and him he  
killed on the ground,  
146 shearing his hands off with the sword,  
and striking off his neck,  
147 and sent him rolling like a stone  
through the crowd.  
148 He left them; and where the thickest  
battle-lines were driven,  
149 there he charged in, and with him  
other strong-greaved Achaeans.  
150 Foot-soldiers killed foot-soldiers,

forced into flight,  
151 and horsemen horsemen — from  
under them rose the dust  
152 out of the plain, stirred by the  
thundering feet of horses —  
153 dealing death with the bronze. And  
the lord Agamemnon,  
154 killing always, followed, calling on the  
Argives.  
155 As when annihilating fire falls on  
unthinned timber,  
156 and the whirling wind carries it  
everywhere, and the thickets  
157 fall root and all under the fire's  
assault,  
158 so under Atreus' son Agamemnon fell  
the heads  
159 of Trojans in flight; and many strong-  
necked horses

160 rattled empty chariots down the  
causeways of the battlefield,  
161 missing their blameless charioteers —  
who lay on the earth,  
162 far dearer now to the vultures than to  
their wives.**14**  
163 But Hector — Zeus drew him out of  
the missiles and the dust,  
164 out of the man-slaughter, out of the  
blood and the tumult,  
165 while Atreus' son followed on, hot,  
calling to the Danaans.  
166 Past the tomb of ancient Ilus,  
Dardanus' descendant,**15**  
167 across the middle of the plain, past the  
fig tree they streamed,  
168 straining for the city; and always  
Atreus' son followed  
169 screaming, his invincible hands

spattered with gore.

170 But when they came to the Scaean  
Gates and the oak tree,

171 there at last they halted, and stood  
waiting for one another.

172 Others were still in full flight across  
the plain, like cattle

173 a lion has set running, coming on  
them in the milking-dark of night —16

174 all of them; but to one of them sheer  
destruction appears:

175 her neck he breaks first, seizing it in  
his strong teeth,

176 and then he gulps down the blood and  
all the inward parts;

177 so Atreus' son, the lord Agamemnon,  
pressed them,

178 killing always the hindmost man; and  
they fled before him.

179 Many fell from their chariots on their  
faces, or on their backs,  
180 under Atreus' son's hands, for he  
raged with the spear before all.17  
181 But when he was on the point of  
coming up under the city  
182 and the steep wall, then the father of  
men and gods  
183 came down from heaven and took his  
seat on the peaks  
184 of Ida of the many springs; and he  
held the lightning in his hands.  
185 And he sent Iris of the golden wings to  
carry his word:  
186 "Up, go, swift Iris; tell this word to  
Hector.  
187 So long as he sees Agamemnon,  
shepherd of the people,  
188 raging among the front-fighters,

cutting down the ranks of men,  
189 so long let him give ground, and  
command the rest of the army  
190 to fight the enemy through the strong  
encounter.  
191 But when, struck by a spear or hit by  
an arrow,  
192 Agamemnon leaps to his horses, then I  
will hand him the power  
193 to kill, until he reaches the well-  
benched ships  
194 and the sun goes down and the sacred  
darkness comes on.”18  
195 So he spoke, and wind-footed swift Iris  
did not disobey,  
196 and went down from the hills of Ida to  
holy Ilion.  
197 She found the son of war-minded  
Priam, brilliant Hector,



198 standing among his horses and his  
bolted chariot;  
199 and standing close, swift-footed Iris  
spoke to him:  
200 “Hector, son of Priam, the equal of  
Zeus in counsel,  
201 Zeus the father has sent me out to tell  
you this.  
202 So long as you see Agamemnon,  
shepherd of the people,  
203 raging among the front-fighters,  
cutting down the ranks of men,  
204 so long yield from the fighting, and  
command the rest of the army  
205 to fight the enemy through the strong  
encounter.  
206 But when, struck by a spear or hit by  
an arrow,  
207 Agamemnon leaps to his horses, then

Zeus will hand you the power

208 to kill, until you reach the well-  
benched ships

209 and the sun goes down and the sacred  
darkness comes on.”

210 So speaking, swift-footed Iris went her  
way,

211 and Hector with his weapons leapt  
from the chariot to the ground,

212 and shaking his sharp spears went  
everywhere through the army,

213 stirring them to fight; and he woke the  
dread din of battle.

214 They wheeled about and stood to face  
the Achaeans,

215 and the Argives on their side  
strengthened their battle-lines.

216 The battle was set, and they stood face  
to face; and Agamemnon

217 charged first, determined to fight far  
ahead of all.

218 Tell me now, Muses, who keep your  
homes on Olympus —19

219 who was the first to come against  
Agamemnon,

220 either of the Trojans themselves or of  
their famed allies?

221 Iphidamas, Antenor's son, a good man  
and a big one,

222 who was reared in Thrace of the deep  
soil, mother of flocks.

223 Cisses raised him in his house when  
he was little,

224 his mother's father, who begot fair-  
cheeked Theano;

225 and when he reached the measure of  
glorious youth,

226 Cisses tried to keep him there, and

offered him his daughter.

227 But newly wed, out of the bridal  
chamber he went chasing the report  
228 of the Achaeans, with twelve beaked  
ships that followed him.

229 The balanced ships he left behind at  
Percote,

230 and came on foot the rest of the way  
to Ilion;

231 and now he came against Atreus' son  
Agamemnon.

232 And when they were close, advancing  
on one another,

233 Atreus' son missed his cast; the spear  
was turned aside;

234 but Iphidamas stabbed at the belt,  
below the corslet,

235 and leaned into the thrust, trusting  
his heavy hand.

236 He did not pierce the glittering war-  
belt: long before that,  
237 meeting the silver, the point bent back  
like lead.  
238 And wide-ruling Agamemnon caught  
the shaft in his hand  
239 and dragged it toward him, furious as  
a lion, and out of his grip  
240 wrenched it; and he struck his neck  
with the sword, and unstrung his limbs.  
241 So he fell there, and slept a sleep of  
bronze,<sup>20</sup>  
242 pitiable man — far from his wedded  
bride, helping his townsmen,  
243 far from the wife he had seen no joy  
of, though he gave much for her:  
244 first he gave a hundred cattle, then  
promised a thousand  
245 goats and sheep together, out of his

numberless flocks.

246 But now Agamemnon, Atreus' son,  
stripped him bare

247 and carried his fine armor away  
through the crowd of the Achaeans.

248 But when Coon saw him — a man  
conspicuous among men,

249 Antenor's eldest-born — strong grief  
came down

250 over his eyes for his fallen brother.

251 He took his stand aside with his spear,  
unseen by brilliant Agamemnon,

252 and stabbed him mid-forearm, below  
the elbow;

253 and the point of the shining spear  
drove clean through.

254 Then the lord of men Agamemnon  
shuddered —

255 but even so he did not leave off from

battle and war:

256 he sprang at Coon, gripping his wind-toughened spear.

257 Coon was dragging Iphidamas, his brother by one father,

258 hurrying, holding his foot, calling to all the best men;

259 but as he dragged him through the crowd, under his bossed shield

260 Agamemnon thrust with the bronze-shod shaft, and unstrung his limbs,

261 and stepped up close and cut his head off, over Iphidamas.21

262 There the sons of Antenor, at the hands of the king, Atreus' son,

263 filled up their measure of doom and went down into the house of Hades.

264 But he kept ranging down the ranks of the other men

265 with spear and sword and with great  
stones,  
266 so long as the blood still welled warm  
from his wound.  
267 But when the wound began to dry, and  
the blood stopped,  
268 sharp pains came sinking into the  
strength of Atreus' son.  
269 As when the sharp shaft of labor  
seizes a woman in her pangs, 22  
270 the piercing shaft the Eileithyiai of  
hard labor send,  
271 Hera's daughters, keepers of the bitter  
pangs,  
272 so sharp pains sank into the strength  
of Atreus' son.  
273 He sprang into the chariot and told his  
charioteer  
274 to drive to the hollow ships; for his



heart was heavy.

275 And he cried a piercing cry, to carry to  
the Danaans:

276 “Friends, leaders and lords of the  
Argives,

277 yours be the task now: keep from the  
seafaring ships

278 the grim din of battle, since Zeus the  
counselor has not

279 allowed me to war with the Trojans all  
day long.”

280 So he spoke; and the charioteer  
whipped the fair-maned horses

281 toward the hollow ships, and the two  
flew, nothing loath;

282 their chests were white with foam,  
dusted beneath with dust,

283 as they carried the worn king out of  
the fighting.

284 And when Hector saw Agamemnon  
going off,  
285 he called to Trojans and Lycians with  
a great shout:  
286 “Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians  
who fight at close quarters —  
287 be men, my friends; remember your  
rushing courage.  
288 Their best man is gone, and Zeus the  
son of Cronos has given  
289 great glory to me. Drive your whole-  
hoofed horses straight  
290 at the powerful Danaans, and win the  
higher glory.”  
291 So speaking he stirred the fury and  
the heart of every man.  
292 As when some hunter sets his white-  
toothed hounds  
293 on a wild boar or a lion,

294 so on the Achaeans Hector, Priam's  
son, the equal  
295 of Ares bane of mortals, set the great-  
hearted Trojans.  
296 He himself strode among the  
foremost, thinking great things,  
297 and fell upon the battle like a howling  
squall  
298 that leaps down and lashes the violet-  
colored sea.  
299 Whom first, whom last did he strip of  
his arms, 23  
300 Hector, Priam's son, when Zeus gave  
him the glory?  
301 Asaeus first, and Autonous, and  
Opites,  
302 and Dolops, Clytius' son, and  
Opheltius, and Agelaus,  
303 and Aesymnus, and Orus, and

Hipponous staunch in the fight.

304 These leaders of the Danaans he took,  
and after them

305 the multitude — as when the West  
Wind batters the clouds

306 of the white South Wind, striking with  
deep squall,

307 and the swollen wave rolls huge, and  
the spray

308 is scattered high under the wandering  
wind's blast,

309 so thick and fast were the heads of the  
army beaten down by Hector.

310 And now there would have been ruin,  
deeds beyond remedy,24

311 and the Achaeans in flight would have  
flung themselves on their ships,

312 had not Odysseus called to Tydeus' son  
Diomedes:

313 “Tydeus’ son, what has come over us?  
We have forgotten our rushing courage.  
314 Come here, old friend; stand beside  
me. It will be disgrace  
315 if Hector of the flashing helmet takes  
the ships.”  
316 Answering him spoke strong  
Diomedes:  
317 “I will stand, certainly, and I will  
endure it; but small  
318 will be our profit, since Zeus the  
cloud-gatherer  
319 would rather hand the power to the  
Trojans than to us.”  
320 He spoke, and thrust Thymbraeus  
from his chariot to the ground,  
321 striking him with the spear by the left  
nipple; and Odysseus  
322 killed Molion, the godlike aide of that

same lord.

323 They left them there, done with  
fighting for good,

324 and the two went through the crowd  
wreaking havoc, as when two boars

325 fall on the hunting hounds, thinking  
great things;

326 so, turning back, they cut down  
Trojans; and the Achaeans

327 gladly caught their breath in their  
flight from brilliant Hector.

328 Then they took a chariot and two  
men, the best of their district,

329 two sons of Merops of Percote, who  
beyond all men

330 knew the seer's art, and would not let  
his sons

331 go to man-destroying war; but the two  
would not

332 obey him: the fates of black death  
were leading them on.  
333 Tydeus' son Diomedes, famed with the  
spear,  
334 robbed them of life and breath and  
took their glorious armor;  
335 and Odysseus killed Hippodamus and  
Hypeirochus.  
336 Then the son of Cronos stretched the  
battle level between them,  
337 looking down from Ida; and they went  
on killing one another.  
338 Tydeus' son wounded the hero  
Agastrophus with his spear,  
339 Paeon's son, at the hip-joint; his  
horses were not  
340 near for escape — great was the  
blindness of his heart:  
341 his aide was holding them apart, while

he on foot

342 raged through the front-fighters, until  
he lost his own life.

343 But Hector marked them sharply  
down the ranks, and rushed at them

344 shouting; and with him followed the  
Trojan battle-lines.

345 Diomedes, good at the war-cry,  
shuddered to see him,

346 and quickly spoke to Odysseus, who  
was near:

347 “Here it comes rolling at the two of us,  
this plague — massive Hector.

348 Come, let us stand and beat him off,  
holding our ground.”

349 He spoke, and balanced his long-  
shadowed spear and hurled it,

350 and hit — he did not miss — aiming at  
the head,



351 at the helmet's crown; but bronze was  
turned by bronze  
352 and never reached the fair skin: the  
helmet stopped it,  
353 three-layered, socket-eyed, which  
Phoebus Apollo gave him.<sup>26</sup>  
354 And Hector ran back an immense way,  
and merged with the crowd,  
355 dropped to his knees and stayed there,  
propping himself  
356 with one thick hand on the earth; and  
black night covered his eyes.  
357 But while Tydeus' son went after his  
spear's cast,  
358 far through the front-fighters, where  
he saw it strike the earth,  
359 Hector caught his breath again, and  
springing back into his chariot  
360 drove out into the mass of men, and

dodged black doom.

361 Rushing after with his spear, strong  
Diomedes called:

362 “Dog! Again you have run out from  
under death — and yet the evil<sup>27</sup>

363 came close. Now once more Phoebus  
Apollo has pulled you out —

364 to him you must pray whenever you  
go into the thud of javelins.

365 I will finish you yet, meeting you later,

366 if any god anywhere stands helper to  
me too.

367 For now I will go after the others,  
whoever I can catch.”

368 He spoke, and set to stripping Paeon’s  
spear-famed son.

369 But Alexandros, the husband of  
lovely-haired Helen,

370 drew his bow against Tydeus’ son,

shepherd of the people,  
371 leaning against the pillar on the man-  
made mound,  
372 the tomb of Ilus, Dardanus' son, elder  
of the people of old.  
373 Diomedes was lifting the corslet of  
powerful Agastrophus  
374 from his chest, all glittering, and the  
shield from his shoulders,  
375 and the heavy helmet — and Paris  
drew back the grip of his bow  
376 and shot; and the shaft did not leave  
his hand in vain:  
377 he hit the flat of the right foot, and  
the arrow, clean through,  
378 fixed in the earth. And laughing very  
sweetly  
379 Paris leapt up out of his hiding-place,  
and spoke in triumph:28

380 “You are hit! The arrow did not fly in  
vain. If only  
381 I had struck deep in the groin and  
taken your life!  
382 Then the Trojans could have breathed  
again after their misery —  
383 they who shudder at you as bleating  
goats at a lion.”  
384 Unshaken, strong Diomedes answered  
him:  
385 “Bowman, foul-mouth, glorious with  
your curls, ogler of girls —29  
386 if you made trial of me face to face, in  
armor,  
387 your bow would not help you, and  
your showers of arrows;  
388 as it is you have scratched the flat of  
my foot, and boast of it.  
389 I care no more than if a woman had

hit me, or a witless child;

390 blunt is the dart of a worthless man, a  
nobody.

391 From me it is otherwise: even if it only  
grazes,

392 the point is sharp, and makes its man  
a corpse on the instant.

393 His wife's cheeks are torn on both  
sides in mourning,

394 his children are fatherless; and he,  
reddening the earth with his blood,

395 rots, and there are more birds than  
women about him."

396 So he spoke; and Odysseus, famed  
with the spear, came near

397 and stood in front of him; and sitting  
behind, Diomedes drew

398 the swift arrow out of his foot; and  
hard pain went through his flesh.

399 He sprang into the chariot and told  
his charioteer  
400 to drive to the hollow ships; for his  
heart was heavy.  
401 Now Odysseus, famed with the spear,  
was left alone: not one  
402 of the Argives stayed by him, for fear  
had seized them all.  
403 Troubled, he spoke to his own great-  
hearted spirit:  
404 “Ah me, what happens to me now?  
Great evil if I run,  
405 fearing their numbers; but grimmer  
still if I am taken  
406 alone — and the son of Cronos has set  
the rest of the Danaans running.  
407 But why does my own heart argue  
these things with me?  
408 For I know that cowards walk away

from the war,  
409 but whoever would be best in battle,  
his duty is  
410 to stand his ground with strength,  
whether he is hit or hits another.”<sup>30</sup>  
411 While he was turning this over in mind  
and heart,  
412 the ranks of the Trojan shield-men  
came on  
413 and penned him in their midst —  
setting their own plague among them.  
414 As when hounds and young men in  
their vigor rush  
415 a boar on every side, and he comes out  
of the deep thicket  
416 whetting the white tusk in his curved  
jaws,  
417 and they charge in around him, and  
from under comes the noise

418 of gnashing tusks; but they stand up  
to him, terrible as he is —  
419 so then around Odysseus, dear to Zeus,  
the Trojans  
420 rushed. And he first wounded  
blameless Deïopites  
421 above the shoulder, leaping in with his  
sharp spear;  
422 and after that he stripped the life  
from Thoon and Ennomus,  
423 and next Chersidamas, as he sprang  
down from his chariot,  
424 he stabbed with the spear below the  
bossed shield  
425 in the navel; and he fell in the dust  
and clutched the earth with his palm.  
426 These he left, and wounded with the  
spear Charops, Hippasus' son,  
427 own brother of wealthy Socus;



428 and Socus came to his rescue, a man  
like a god,  
429 and came up very close and spoke his  
word to him:  
430 “Odysseus of the many tales, insatiate  
of tricks and of labor,<sup>31</sup>  
431 today you will either boast over both  
of Hippasus’ sons —  
432 such a pair of men! — for killing them  
and stripping their armor,  
433 or struck under my spear you will lose  
your life.”  
434 So speaking, he struck the shield  
balanced every way:  
435 through the shining shield the heavy  
spear went,  
436 and through the richly worked corslet  
it drove,  
437 and tore all the flesh clean from his

ribs; but Pallas Athena

438 did not let it reach the man's inward  
parts.

439 Odysseus knew the point had not  
come home to a mortal spot,

440 and drawing back he spoke his word  
to Socus:

441 "Poor wretch — sheer destruction has  
surely caught you now.

442 True: you have stopped my fighting  
against the Trojans;

443 but I say that death and black doom  
will be yours

444 here, on this day; broken under my  
spear you will give

445 the triumph to me, and your soul to  
Hades of the famed colts."

446 He spoke; and Socus had turned and  
was moving into flight,

447 and square in his back as he turned he  
fixed the spear  
448 between the shoulders, and drove it  
through the chest.  
449 He fell with a thud; and brilliant  
Odysseus exulted over him:  
450 “Socus, son of war-minded Hippasus,  
breaker of horses:  
451 death’s end was too quick for you —  
you did not slip it.  
452 Poor wretch! Your father and your  
lady mother will not32  
453 close your eyes in death; the flesh-  
eating birds  
454 will pull at you long before, their  
wings beating thick about you.  
455 But me, when I die, the brilliant  
Achaeans will bury with honors.”  
456 So speaking, he dragged the massive

spear of war-minded Socus

457 out of his flesh and out of his bossed  
shield;

458 and when it was wrenched free the  
blood sprang up, and his heart sank.

459 And the great-hearted Trojans, when  
they saw Odysseus's blood,

460 called to one another through the  
crowd, and all made for him.

461 He gave ground backward, and  
shouted to his companions.

462 Three times he shouted, as loud as a  
man's head can hold,

463 and three times Menelaus, dear to  
Ares, heard him crying,

464 and quickly spoke to Ajax, who was  
near:

465 "Ajax, Zeus-sprung son of Telamon,  
marshal of the people,

466 the cry of patient-hearted Odysseus  
rings around me,  
467 and it sounds as though the Trojans  
had cut him off alone  
468 in the strong encounter and were  
forcing him under.  
469 Come, let us go through the crowd;  
better to defend him.  
470 I fear he may suffer something, alone  
among the Trojans,  
471 brave as he is, and a great longing  
come to the Danaans.”  
472 So speaking he led the way, and the  
other followed, a man like a god.  
473 They found Odysseus, dear to Zeus;  
and around him  
474 the Trojans pressed, like tawny jackals  
in the mountains  
475 around an antlered stag that is

wounded — a man has hit it  
476 with an arrow from the bowstring,  
and it escaped him, running  
477 on its feet, while the blood ran warm  
and its knees still lifted;  
478 but when at last the swift arrow has  
beaten it down,  
479 the flesh-eating jackals tear it apart in  
the mountains,  
480 in a shadowy grove; but then some  
god leads in a ravening  
481 lion, and the jackals scatter in terror,  
and he does the tearing —33  
482 so then around war-minded Odysseus  
of the subtle wiles  
483 the Trojans pressed, many and stout,  
while the hero  
484 lunging with his spear held off the  
pitiless day.

485 And Ajax came up close, carrying his  
shield like a tower,  
486 and stood beside him; and the Trojans  
broke, every man a different way.  
487 Then warlike Menelaus led Odysseus  
out of the crowd,  
488 holding him by the hand, till his aide  
drove the horses close.  
489 And Ajax, springing on the Trojans,  
killed Doryclus,  
490 Priam's bastard son, and then  
wounded Pandocus,  
491 and wounded Lysander, and Pyrasus,  
and Pylartes.  
492 As when a river in flood comes down  
onto the plain,  
493 a winter torrent off the mountains,  
driven by the rain of Zeus,  
494 and carries with it many dry oaks and

many pines,  
495 and flings much wrack and driftwood  
into the sea,  
496 so glorious Ajax swept the plain then,  
harrying it,  
497 slaughtering horses and men. And  
Hector knew nothing of it,  
498 for he was fighting at the far left of  
the whole battle  
499 by the banks of the river Scamander,  
where beyond all places  
500 the heads of men were falling, and the  
quenchless roar had risen,  
501 around great Nestor and warlike  
Idomeneus.  
502 Among these Hector moved, wreaking  
deeds of havoc  
503 with spear and horsemanship,  
wrecking the young men's battle-lines.



504 Yet even so the brilliant Achaeans  
would not have given way  
505 from his path, had not Alexandros, the  
husband of lovely-haired Helen,  
506 stopped Machaon, shepherd of the  
people, in mid-valor,  
507 hitting his right shoulder with a  
three-barbed arrow.  
508 Then the Achaeans, breathing fury,  
feared for him,  
509 that the enemy might take him as the  
fighting tilted;  
510 and at once Idomeneus spoke to  
brilliant Nestor:  
511 “Nestor, Neleus’ son, great glory of the  
Achaeans,  
512 up, mount your chariot; let Machaon  
mount beside you;  
513 and drive your whole-hoofed horses to

the ships with all speed.

514 For a healer is a man worth many  
other men together,

515 at cutting out arrows and sprinkling  
gentle drugs.”<sup>34</sup>

516 So he spoke, and the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor did not disobey.

517 At once he mounted his chariot, and  
beside him Machaon

518 mounted, the son of Asclepius the  
blameless healer;

519 and he whipped the horses on, and the  
two flew, nothing loath,

520 toward the hollow ships; for that way  
was dear to their hearts.

521 But Cebriones, standing beside Hector,  
saw

522 the Trojans being driven, and spoke  
his word to him:

523 “Hector, the two of us are engaged  
with the Danaans here  
524 at the outermost edge of the harsh-  
sounding war, while the other  
525 Trojans are driven in confusion,  
horses and men together.  
526 Telamonian Ajax is driving them — I  
know him well,  
527 for the broad shield is around his  
shoulders. Come,  
528 let us steer our horses and chariot  
there, where beyond all  
529 horsemen and foot-soldiers, hurling  
their evil strife at one another,  
530 are killing each other, and the  
quenchless roar has risen.”  
531 So speaking, he lashed the fair-maned  
horses on  
532 with the whistling whip; and feeling

the stroke

533 they carried the swift chariot lightly  
among Trojans and Achaeans,

534 trampling corpses and shields; with  
blood the axle

535 beneath was all spattered, and the  
rails that ran round the car,

536 struck by the drops thrown up from  
the horses' hooves

537 and from the wheel-rims. And Hector  
strained to plunge into the crowd

538 of men and break it, leaping in; and an  
evil tumult

539 he hurled among the Danaans, and  
gave the spear little rest.

540 But he kept ranging down the ranks of  
the other men

541 with spear and sword and with great  
stones —

542 yet he shunned the fight with Ajax,  
Telamon's son.

*[Line 543 is absent from the printed text; see note 35.]*

544 But father Zeus, high-throned, stirred  
fear in Ajax:35

545 he stood dazed, and slung the  
sevenfold-oxhide shield behind him,

546 and trembled, glancing round at the  
crowd like a wild beast,

547 turning this way and that, slowly  
changing knee for knee.

548 As a fiery lion from a yard of cattle

549 is driven off by dogs and countrymen,

550 who will not let him take the fat of the  
herd,

551 watching all night long; and he,  
craving the meat,

552 charges in but gets nowhere, for

javelins thick and fast  
553 fly out to meet him from daring  
hands,  
554 and burning brands besides, and he  
flinches at those for all his fury,  
555 and at dawn he goes off apart, sullen  
at heart;  
556 so Ajax then, sullen at heart, fell back  
from the Trojans,  
557 much against his will; for he feared for  
the Achaeans' ships.  
558 As when a donkey going past a  
cornfield masters the boys who drive him,  
559 a slow one, on whose ribs many sticks  
have been broken,  
560 and he gets in and crops the deep  
grain, while the boys  
561 beat him with sticks — but their  
strength is a child's strength —

562 and only just drive him out when he  
has eaten his fill,  
563 so then great Ajax, Telamon's son, was  
harried  
564 by the high-hearted Trojans and their  
allies called from many lands,  
565 stabbing the middle of his shield with  
pikes, following him always.<sup>36</sup>  
566 And Ajax would now remember his  
rushing courage,  
567 wheeling round again to hold back the  
battle-lines  
568 of the horse-taming Trojans; and now  
again turn to flee.  
569 But he barred them all from the path  
to the swift ships,  
570 standing alone between Trojans and  
Achaeans,  
571 raging. And the spears from daring

hands

572 stuck fast, some in his great shield,  
driving forward,

573 and many midway, before they could  
reach the white flesh,

574 stood planted in the earth, still  
hungry to glut themselves on it.

575 But when Euaemon's shining son  
Eurypylus

576 saw him under the pressure of the  
thick missiles,

577 he came and stood beside him and cast  
with his shining spear,

578 and hit Apisaon, Phausius' son,  
shepherd of the people,

579 in the liver below the midriff, and  
unstrung his knees on the instant.

580 And Eurypylus sprang on him to strip  
the armor from his shoulders.



581 But when godlike Alexandros saw him  
582 stripping the armor of Apisaon, at  
once he drew  
583 his bow at Eurypylus, and hit him  
with an arrow  
584 in the right thigh; the reed shaft  
snapped, and the thigh grew heavy.  
585 Back into the band of his companions  
he shrank, dodging doom,  
586 and cried a piercing cry, to carry to  
the Danaans:  
587 “Friends, leaders and lords of the  
Argives,  
588 turn and stand, and beat off the  
pitiless day  
589 from Ajax, who is under pressure of  
missiles: I do not think  
590 he will escape out of the harsh-  
sounding war. Come, stand

591 face to face around great Ajax,  
Telamon's son."  
592 So spoke the wounded Eurypylus; and  
they stood  
593 close beside him, shields leaned  
against their shoulders,  
594 spears held high; and Ajax came to  
meet them,  
595 and turned and stood, when he  
reached the band of his companions.  
596 So they fought on, like blazing fire;  
597 and the mares of Neleus, sweating,  
carried Nestor  
598 out of the battle, bringing Machaon  
too, shepherd of the people.  
599 And swift-footed brilliant Achilles saw  
him, and marked him;  
600 for he stood on the stern of his ship,  
huge of hull,

601 gazing at the sheer toil and the tearful  
rout.

602 At once he spoke to his companion  
Patroclus,

603 calling from beside the ship; and he  
heard it in the hut

604 and came out, the equal of Ares — and  
that was the beginning of his evil.37

605 Menoetius's stout son spoke to him  
first:

606 "Why do you call me, Achilles? What  
need have you of me?"

607 Answering him spoke swift-footed  
Achilles:

608 "Brilliant son of Menoetius, delight of  
my heart,

609 now I think the Achaeans will soon  
stand about my knees

610 begging; for the need that has come

will not be borne.

611 But go now, Patroclus dear to Zeus,  
and ask Nestor

612 who this wounded man is he brings  
out of the fighting.

613 From behind, he looks in every way  
like Machaon,

614 Asclepius' son — but I did not see the  
man's eyes,

615 for the horses shot past me, straining  
forward.”

616 So he spoke, and Patroclus obeyed his  
dear companion,

617 and set off running along the huts and  
ships of the Achaeans.

618 Now when the others reached the hut  
of Neleus' son,

619 they stepped down onto the earth that  
feeds so many,

620 and Eurymedon, the old man's aide,  
loosed the horses  
621 from the chariot; and the two men  
cooled the sweat from their tunics,  
622 standing in the breeze by the shore of  
the sea; and then  
623 they went into the hut and sat down  
on the couches.  
624 And lovely-braided Hecamede made  
them a posset —  
625 the woman the old man took out of  
Tenedos, when Achilles sacked it,  
626 daughter of great-hearted Arsinous;  
the Achaeans  
627 had picked her out for him, because in  
counsel he was best of all.  
628 First she drew up before the two of  
them a table,  
629 fair, blue-enameled at the feet, well

polished, and on it  
630 a bronze basket, and an onion beside  
it, relish for the drink,  
631 and pale honey, and beside it the meal  
of sacred barley,  
632 and a magnificent cup, which the old  
man had brought from home,  
633 studded with golden nails. Four  
handles  
634 it had, and about each one a pair of  
golden doves  
635 was feeding, and beneath it were two  
supports.  
636 Another man could barely have  
shifted it from the table  
637 when it was full; but Nestor, the old  
man, raised it without strain.38  
638 In it the woman like the goddesses  
mixed them the posset

639 with Pramnian wine, and over it  
grated goat's-milk cheese  
640 with a bronze grater, and sprinkled  
white barley on top,  
641 and invited them to drink, when she  
had made the posset ready.<sup>39</sup>  
642 And when the two had drunk, and put  
away their parching thirst,  
643 they took their pleasure in talk, telling  
tales to one another;  
644 and Patroclus stood at the door, a man  
like a god.  
645 Seeing him, the old man rose from his  
shining chair,  
646 took him by the hand, led him in, and  
pressed him to be seated.  
647 But Patroclus, from where he stood,  
declined, and spoke a word:  
648 "No seat for me, aged sir, Zeus-

nurtured; you will not persuade me.

649 To be respected — and feared — is the  
man who sent me, to learn

650 who this man is you bring in  
wounded. But I myself

651 can see; I recognize Machaon,  
shepherd of the people.

652 Now I will go back with the word, a  
messenger to Achilles.

653 And you know well, aged sir, Zeus-  
nurtured, what kind of man

654 he is — a terrible man. He would  
quickly blame even the blameless.”40

655 Then answered him the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor:

656 “Why is Achilles so full of pity now for  
the sons of the Achaeans,

657 for all who have been hit by missiles?  
He knows nothing



658 of the grief that has risen through the  
army: the best men  
659 lie by the ships, hit from afar or  
stabbed close.  
660 Hit is Tydeus' son, strong Diomedes;  
661 stabbed is Odysseus, famed with the  
spear; and Agamemnon;  
662 and hit too is Eurypylus, by an arrow  
in the thigh;  
663 and this man here is another, whom I  
have just brought  
664 out of the fighting, hit by an arrow  
from the bowstring. But Achilles,  
665 brave as he is, has no care for the  
Danaans and no pity.  
666 Is he waiting until the swift ships by  
the sea,  
667 against the will of the Argives, are  
warm with consuming fire,

668 and we ourselves are killed one after  
another? For my strength  
669 is not what once it was in my supple  
limbs.  
670 Would that I were young like that, my  
strength still steady,  
671 as when the quarrel arose between us  
and the Eleians  
672 over a cattle-raid, when I killed  
Itymoneus,  
673 Hypeirochus' brave son, who lived in  
Elis,  
674 as I drove off our reprisal. Defending  
his cattle  
675 he was hit among the foremost by a  
javelin from my hand,  
676 and fell; and his country people  
scattered in terror.  
677 And we drove together plunder out of

that plain past counting:

678 fifty herds of cattle, as many flocks of  
sheep,

679 as many droves of pigs, as many wide-  
ranging herds of goats,

680 and a hundred and fifty tawny horses,

681 all mares, and many with foals  
beneath them.

682 All these we drove at night into  
Neleian Pylos,

683 into the town; and Neleus was glad at  
heart

684 that so much had fallen to me, going  
young to war.

685 And with the showing of dawn the  
heralds cried aloud

686 for all to come who were owed a debt  
in brilliant Elis;

687 and the leading men of the Pylians

gathered together

688 and divided it up — for the Epeians  
owed a debt to many,

689 few and battered as we were in Pylos:

690 for the might of Heracles had come  
and battered us

691 in the years before, and all our best  
men had been killed.

692 Twelve sons of blameless Neleus we  
had been,

693 and of these I alone was left; the  
others had all perished.

694 Puffed up over all this, the bronze-  
shirted Epeians

695 treated us with outrage, and devised  
their reckless works.

696 And the old man chose out for himself  
a herd of cattle

697 and a great flock of sheep — three

hundred, with their herdsmen —  
698 for a great debt was owed to him in  
brilliant Elis:  
699 four prize-winning horses, chariot  
and all,  
700 come to the games to compete — for a  
tripod they were  
701 to race — and Augeias, lord of men,  
kept them  
702 there, and sent their driver home  
grieving for his horses.  
703 Angered by all this, words and deeds  
alike, the old man  
704 chose out a mass past telling; and the  
rest he gave to the people  
705 to divide, so no man might go cheated  
of his fair share.  
706 So we were settling each matter, and  
around the town

707 were offering sacrifice to the gods;  
and on the third day they came,  
708 all of them at once, men in numbers  
and whole-hoofed horses,  
709 in full force; and with them the two  
Moliones armed,  
710 boys still, not yet well skilled in  
rushing courage.  
711 There is a city, Thryoessa, a steep hill  
712 far off on the Alpheiuss, at the edge of  
sandy Pylos:  
713 this they besieged, furious to raze it to  
the ground.  
714 But when they had crossed the whole  
plain, Athena  
715 came running to us by night, a  
messenger from Olympus,  
716 crying "To arms!" — and no unwilling  
army did she gather

717 in Pylos: men hot to fight. But Neleus  
would not  
718 let me arm myself, and hid my horses,  
719 for he said I did not yet know the  
works of war.  
720 Even so I stood out among our own  
horsemen,  
721 on foot as I was, since Athena led the  
quarrel so.  
722 There is a river, Minyeïus, that falls  
into the sea  
723 near Arene, where we waited for the  
brilliant Dawn,  
724 we horsemen of the Pylians, while the  
streams of foot-soldiers flowed in.  
725 From there in full force, armed in our  
gear,  
726 we came by midday to the sacred  
stream of Alpheius.

727 There we sacrificed fine victims to  
Zeus the almighty,  
728 a bull to Alpheius, a bull to Poseidon,  
729 and to grey-eyed Athena a cow of the  
herd,  
730 and then took supper through the  
camp by companies,  
731 and lay down to sleep, each man in his  
armor,  
732 along the streams of the river. And the  
great-hearted Epeians  
733 stood round the city, furious to raze it  
to the ground;  
734 but before that could be, a great work  
of Ares showed before them:  
735 for when the blazing sun stood clear  
above the earth,  
736 we joined battle, praying to Zeus and  
Athena.



737 And when the fight between Pylians  
and Epeians began,  
738 I was first to kill a man — and I took  
his whole-hoofed horses —  
739 Mulius the spearman. He was Augeias'  
son-in-law,  
740 husband of his eldest daughter,  
tawny-haired Agamede,  
741 who knew as many drugs as the wide  
earth grows.  
742 As he came on I hit him with the  
bronze-headed spear,  
743 and he crashed in the dust; and I,  
springing into his chariot,  
744 took my stand among the front-  
fighters. And the great-hearted Epeians  
745 fled in terror every man a different  
way, when they saw the man fallen  
746 who led their horsemen, who was

their best in battle.

747 And I charged in on them like a black  
squall,

748 and took fifty chariots, and around  
each one two men

749 caught the earth in their teeth, broken  
under my spear.

750 And now I would have cut down the  
two Moliones, Actor's line,

751 had not their father, the wide-ruling  
earth-shaker,

752 saved them out of the war, wrapping  
them in thick mist.

753 Then Zeus handed great power to the  
Pylions:

754 for we followed them across the wide  
plain,

755 killing the men and gathering up their  
fine armor,

756 until we drove our horses to  
Buprasion rich in wheat  
757 and the Olenian rock, and where the  
hill is called  
758 the hill of Alesion; from there Athena  
turned our army back.  
759 There I killed the last man and left  
him. And the Achaeans  
760 steered their swift horses back from  
Buprasion to Pylos,  
761 and all gave glory among gods to Zeus,  
and among men to Nestor.  
762 Such was I among men — if ever I was.  
But Achilles<sup>41</sup>  
763 will have the profit of his valor alone.  
And yet I think  
764 he will weep for it bitterly, when the  
army has perished.  
765 Dear boy, this was surely what

Menoetius charged you

766 on that day when he sent you out of  
Phthia to Agamemnon.

767 The two of us were inside — I and  
brilliant Odysseus —

768 and heard it all in the halls,  
everything he charged you.

769 We had come to the well-built house  
of Peleus,

770 gathering the army through Achaea  
that feeds so many,

771 and there inside we found the hero  
Menoetius,

772 and you, and Achilles beside you. The  
old horseman Peleus

773 was burning the fat thigh-pieces of an  
ox to Zeus who delights in thunder,

774 in the enclosure of the court; and he  
held a golden cup,

775 pouring the fire-bright wine over the  
burning offerings.

776 The two of you were busy with the  
ox's flesh; and we two

777 stood in the doorway. Achilles sprang  
up amazed,

778 took us by the hand, led us in, and  
pressed us to be seated,

779 and set out a guest-meal well, all that  
is due to guests.

780 And when we had taken our pleasure  
of eating and drinking,

781 I began the talk, and urged the two of  
you to follow us;

782 and you were both entirely willing,  
and both fathers charged you well.

783 Old Peleus charged his son Achilles

784 always to be the best, and to hold his  
head above all others;

785 and to you Menoetius, Actor's son,  
gave this charge:  
786 'My child, in birth Achilles is above  
you,  
787 but you are the elder — though in  
strength he is far the better.  
788 Speak to him a close-packed word;  
advise him well;  
789 give him direction: he will listen — for  
his own good.'**42**  
790 So the old man charged you — and  
you have forgotten. Yet even now  
791 you might say all this to war-minded  
Achilles, and he might listen.  
792 Who knows whether, with a god's  
help, you might stir his heart  
793 by your persuading? The persuasion  
of a companion is a good thing.  
794 But if in his heart he is dodging some

prophecy,  
795 something his lady mother has told  
him from Zeus,  
796 then let him send you out at least, and  
let the rest of the army  
797 of Myrmidons follow, and you may be  
a light to the Danaans;  
798 and let him give you his fine armor to  
carry into the war,  
799 so that the Trojans may take you for  
him, and hold back  
800 from the fighting, and the warlike  
sons of the Achaeans catch their breath,  
801 worn as they are; for the breathing-  
spaces of war are few.  
802 Fresh men, with one shout, could  
easily push men weary  
803 of battle back on the city, away from  
the ships and the huts.”43

804 So he spoke, and stirred the heart in  
Patroclus's chest,  
805 and he set off running along the ships  
to Achilles, son of Aeacus.  
806 But when in his running Patroclus  
came to the ships  
807 of godlike Odysseus, where the  
assembly and the judgment-ground  
808 lay, and where the altars of the gods  
were built,  
809 there wounded Eurypylus met him,  
810 Euaemon's Zeus-sprung son, hit in the  
thigh by the arrow,  
811 limping out of the battle; the sweat  
ran streaming down  
812 his shoulders and his head, and from  
the grievous wound  
813 the black blood trickled; but his mind  
held firm.



814 Seeing him, Menoetius's stout son  
pitied him,  
815 and in sorrow he spoke winged words:  
816 "Poor wretches, leaders and lords of  
the Danaans!  
817 So it was your fate, far from your  
friends and your fatherland,  
818 to glut the quick dogs of Troy with  
your white fat.  
819 But come, tell me this, Zeus-nurtured  
Eurypylus, hero:  
820 will the Achaeans somehow still hold  
gigantic Hector,  
821 or will they perish now, broken under  
his spear?"  
822 And wounded Eurypylus answered  
him face to face:  
823 "No longer, Zeus-sprung Patroclus,  
will there be any bulwark

824 of the Achaeans; they will fall upon  
the black ships.

825 For all the men who before were our  
best

826 lie by the ships, hit from afar or  
stabbed close

827 at Trojan hands; and the enemy's  
strength rises and rises.

828 But save me now — take me to my  
black ship,

829 and cut the arrow out of my thigh,  
and wash the black blood

830 from it with warm water, and sprinkle  
on the wound the gentle drugs,

831 the good ones they say you have  
learned of from Achilles,

832 whom Chiron taught, the most  
righteous of the Centaurs.

833 For the healers, Podaleirius and

Machaon —

834 one, I think, lies wounded in the huts,  
835 himself in need of a blameless healer,  
836 and the other waits on the plain for  
the sharp war-god of the Trojans.”

837 Then Menoetius’s stout son answered  
him:

838 “How can these things be? What are  
we to do, Eurypylus, hero?

839 I am on my way to tell war-minded  
Achilles the word

840 that Nestor, the Gerenian, warden of  
the Achaeans, charged me with;

841 but even so I will not abandon you in  
your suffering.”

842 He spoke, and gripping him under the  
chest led the shepherd of the people

843 to his hut; and his aide, seeing them,  
spread down oxhides.

844 There Patroclus laid him at full  
length, and with a knife cut  
845 the sharp, biting arrow out of his  
thigh, and washed the black blood  
846 from it with warm water, and cast on  
a bitter root,  
847 rubbing it between his hands, a pain-  
killer, which stayed  
848 all his pains; and the wound began to  
dry, and the blood stopped.44

## Notes

### NOTES

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#### NOTES

1. (11.1-2) Dawn rises “from her bed beside illustrious Tithonus” — the same couplet opens *Odyssey* 5, a famous cross-epic doublet. Tithonus is the Trojan

prince (brother of Priam, 20.237) whom Dawn carried off as her consort; the story of his withering immortality is later. A new dawn-formula for the register, distinct from “early-born rosy-fingered Dawn”: this is the dawn of the poem’s longest day, which will not set until 18.239-242. ↩

2. (11.3-14) Strife (Eris) opens the day as Dream opened Book 2 — Zeus’s emissary to a sleeping army. Lines 5-9 repeat the camp geometry of 8.222-226 in our same words: Odysseus’s ship lies at the midpoint of the beached fleet, Ajax and Achilles hold the exposed ends. And 13-14 repeat 2.453-454 (“war became sweeter to them than going home...” — there the effect of Odysseus and Athena rallying a mob that had run for the ships; here the work of a shrieking goddess. Ancient critics (Zenodotus omitted, Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized) judged the couplet wrongly repeated here; the poet’s point may be exactly the repetition: what rhetoric did in Book 2, mere *din* does now. ↩

3. (11.20-23) Cinyras, legendary king of Cyprus — the island’s only appearance in the Iliad. He hears the “great report” (κλέος) of the coming war and buys his distance from it with a corslet: a guest-gift as

diplomatic exemption. Later tradition made him promise fifty ships and send one real ship and forty-nine clay models; the poem knows only the elegant bribe. ↩

4. (11.24-28) κύαρος, rendered “blue enamel,” is dark-blue glass paste or niello inlay — a genuine Bronze Age luxury technique (the inlaid daggers of Mycenae). Serpents “like rainbows” that Zeus “sets in a cloud, a portent for mortal men”: the rainbow as omen of war or storm (17.547-549), armor that carries the day’s weather on the king’s chest. ↩
5. (11.36-37) The Gorgon between Terror and Panic (Deimos and Phobos, capitalized personifications since 4.440): the shield’s face is the face of battle itself — cf. the aegis at 5.739-742, which carries the same company. ↩
6. (11.45-46) Athena and Hera thunder in honor of “the king of Mycenae rich in gold” — a unique gesture: thunder is Zeus’s instrument, but the arming of the paramount king draws a salute from the two pro-Achaean goddesses. The aristeia of Agamemnon is thus formally announced; it will last some two hundred lines. ↩

7. (11.52-55) Zeus rains dew dripping with blood — the sky itself hemorrhaging before the killing (again at 16.459, for Sarpedon, where the drops are explicitly tears). Line 55 reads “many strong heads” where the proem (1.3) has “many strong souls”; ancient copies show the variant ψυχάς here too — the echo of the poem’s opening is audible either way. ↩
8. (11.62-66) Hector as the “baleful star” (οὔλιος ἀστήρ) that shows and hides among clouds: the star similes track him and Achilles across the poem until Achilles becomes the Dog Star itself at 22.26-31 — “brightest of all, but an evil sign.” ↩
9. (11.67-73) The reapers: two lines of harvesters facing each other, driving swathes toward the middle of a rich man’s field — armies as farmhands, the plain as harvest. “The battle held their heads level” (72): the fighting itself is the subject, holding the two lines like a beam of scales (cf. Zeus’s actual scales, 8.69). Then the wolves; and Strife alone of the gods present, rejoicing — the day’s one spectator-deity on the field, while Zeus watches from Ida “exulting in his glory.” ↩
10. (11.78-83) The gods sit at home blaming Zeus; he ignores them. Zenodotus omitted the passage and

Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized it, apparently as inconsistent with the gods' oath-bound quiescence of Book 8. But the tableau — all heaven sulking in its fine houses while one god watches the killing with pleasure — is the day's theology in miniature. ↩

11. (11.84-91) The register morning-line (fixed at 8.66-67) is followed by the poem's homeliest time-stamp: the hour when the woodcutter, arms weary, makes his midday meal. Homer's clock runs on labor, not hours — dawn, the woodcutter's dinner, the unyoking of oxen (16.779). At that hour the line breaks, and the *aristeia* proper begins. ↩
12. (11.101-112) Isus and Antiphus: Achilles once caught these same two on Ida, bound them with willow shoots, and released them for ransom — pastoral war, an economy of capture and return. Agamemnon recognizes them and kills them: the third ransom-refusal of the poem (6.45-65 *Adrestus*; 10.378-457 *Dolon*) and the mark of what the war has become since Achilles left it. ↩
13. (11.122-147) Peisander and Hippolochus: their father Antimachus took Paris's gold to block the return of Helen, and proposed murdering the ambassador



Menelaus (the embassy of 3.205-224). Agamemnon's sentence — “now you will pay for your father's foul outrage” — is justice as inherited debt, and the execution (hands sheared off, head struck off, the trunk sent “rolling like a stone”) is the poem's most clinical mutilation. The frame is a bitter pun kept from the Greek: they beg “with honeyed words” (μειλίχοις) and hear a voice “unhoneyed” (ἄμειλικτον). Compare 21.98-135, where Achilles will answer a suppliant's plea with the same adjective and worse. ↩

14. (11.159-162) The empty chariots rattling down the causeways, their drivers “far dearer now to the vultures than to their wives” — the aristeia's cost stated in one hexameter of domestic arithmetic. It prepares the Iphidamas vignette (note [20]). ↩
15. (11.166-168) The rout streams past the tomb of Ilus and the wild fig tree: the plain's fixed survey-marks (the tomb: 10.415, and again 11.371; the fig tree: 6.433, 22.145). Landmarks let the audience feel the front move — from mid-plain to the Scaean Gates and the oak, and back again within the book. ↩
16. (11.172-178) “in the milking-dark of night” (νυκτὸς ἀμολγῶ) — an already-obscure formula (recurring

15.324, 22.28, 22.317) connected by the ancients with milking-time; the lion who scatters the whole herd but eviscerates one cow is Agamemnon exactly: the multitude flees, the hindmost dies. ↩

17. (11.179-180) Omitted by Zenodotus, athetized by Aristarchus (179-180) and Aristophanes (180): the couplet generalizing the slaughter (“many fell from their chariots...”) judged a weak doublet of what precedes. ↩
18. (11.185-194) Zeus’s message is the day’s script, delivered in advance: Agamemnon’s wounding as the trigger-clause, Hector’s power to run “until he reaches the ships and the sun goes down and the sacred darkness comes on.” Everything from here to 18.242 executes this sentence. Iris relays it with the change the grammar demands and nothing more (202-209 = 187-194) — divine messages are verbatim or they are nothing (cf. 2.23-33). ↩
19. (11.218-220) The Muse-invocation repeats 2.484 in our fixed line — full formality for a single duel: Iphidamas is granted a catalogue-style entrance, which is his funeral honor too (the other invocations: 2.484, 14.508, 16.112). ↩

20. (11.221-247) Iphidamas of Thrace: raised by his grandfather Cisses, married to his young aunt (Theano's sister — the poet does not pause over it), he left the bridal chamber for the war and “slept a sleep of bronze” — χάλκεον ὕπνον, the poem's hardest metal laid over its softest noun. The bride-price arithmetic — a hundred cattle down, a thousand head promised — turns the obituary into a ledger: everything paid, nothing enjoyed. This is the Iliad's marriage-economics of death at its most explicit, and the template for Protesilaus (2.700-702) and for Othryoneus later (13.363-382). ↩
21. (11.248-263) Coon wounds Agamemnon and dies trying to drag his brother's body clear; Agamemnon beheads him over the corpse — the two sons of Antenor “filled up their measure of doom” in one another's arms. Antenor, the Trojan advocate of returning Helen (7.347-353), loses two sons in this book to the king Helen was taken from; the poet says nothing, and the silence does the work. ↩
22. (11.269-272) The wounded king's pain is a woman's labor: the sharp shaft the Eileithyiai send, “Hera's daughters, keepers of the bitter pangs.” The inversion is deliberate and unique — the most

masculine act in the heroic economy, the aristeia, ends in the most feminine of agonies; war-wound and birth-pang are the poem's two involuntary cries. The Eileithyiai (birth-goddesses) enter the register here; one returns at 16.187, 19.103. ↩

23. (11.299-300) The narrator's roll-call question, fixed at 5.703: here it marks the transfer of the aristeia — the same frame that measured Hector-and-Ares now measures Hector alone, with "when Zeus gave him the glory" as the ominous answer-clause. ↩

24. (11.310-319) The register despair-line (8.130) sounds again, and Diomedes' answer to Odysseus is the day's arithmetic at its most honest: I will stand, "but small will be our profit," since Zeus wills it otherwise. Piety and futility in one breath — the last speech of Diomedes' fighting day. ↩

25. (11.328-334) The two sons of Merops of Percote fall to Diomedes: lines 329-332 repeat their Catalogue entry (2.831-834) almost verbatim, our wording kept. The Catalogue planted the seer-father who foresaw and forbade and was not obeyed; Book 11 harvests it. Compare 5.148-151 (the sons of the dream-reader).  
↩

26. (11.349-356) Diomedes' cast rings off the helmet  
"which Phoebus Apollo gave him" — divine  
equipment as plot-armor — yet Hector goes down;  
355-356 repeat 5.309-310 (Aeneas's swoon), our  
words kept, and the ancients athetized the repeat  
here. Hector's day of guaranteed glory (192-194)  
nearly ends at its opening: the promise covered the  
outcome, not the pain. ↩
27. (11.362-367) "Dog! Again you have run out from under  
death..." — this six-line taunt returns, word for  
word, in Achilles' mouth at 20.449-454. Diomedes has  
been the poem's stand-in Achilles all through the  
middle books; here he even pre-speaks him. Reuse  
the English verbatim there. ↩
28. (11.369-379) Paris shoots from the tomb of Ilus,  
leaning on the ancestor's grave-pillar — the city's  
founder as cover for the city's most criticized fighter  
— and comes up "laughing very sweetly." Three  
captains leave the field by his arrows in this book  
(Diomedes, Machaon, Eurypylus): the day of the bow.  
↩
29. (11.385-395) "Bowman, foul-mouth, glorious with  
your curls, ogler of girls" — the concentrated  
contempt-vocabulary of the spear-ethos. "Glorious

with your curls” renders κέρρα ἀγλαέ, an old crux: “horn” was read by some ancients as the horn bow, by others as a horn-shaped lovelock (the reading our translation follows; the apparatus records the living dispute). Diomedes’ disdain — “I care no more than if a woman had hit me, or a witless child” — is the poem’s fullest statement of the bow’s dishonor; yet the arrow-graze sends him from the field for the rest of the epic’s fighting, and an arrow of Paris will one day kill Achilles (19.416-417, 22.359-360). The taunt loses the war. ↩

30. (11.401-410) Odysseus alone: the poem’s first full deliberative soliloquy (“Troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit” — a frame that will recur for Menelaus, Agenor, Hector). The deliberation runs the heroic code to its bare axiom: “cowards walk away; whoever would be best must stand, hit or hitting.” Hector’s fatal monologue at 22.99-130 is this scene’s dark twin — there the same logic will forbid the retreat that would have saved him. ↩
31. (11.428-433) Socus — the only man in the poem to wound Odysseus — addresses him with a new-minted title: “Odysseus of the many tales, insatiate

of tricks and of labor.” Even his enemies speak his epithets; the compliment is the challenge. ↩

**32.** (11.450-455) Odysseus over Socus: your parents will not close your eyes; the birds will have you; “but me, when I die, the brilliant Achaeans will bury with honors.” The grimmest speech Odysseus makes in the Iliad — burial as the last competitive good, boasted over a corpse (Plutarch quotes the lines in his Consolation). It is the exact inverse of the poem’s ending, where the enemy dead is given back for burial. ↩

**33.** (11.473-484) The triple simile: jackals round the arrowed stag — until “some god leads in” a lion who scatters them and eats. Ajax arrives as the lion; the rescued Odysseus, uncomfortably, occupies the stag’s place, and the “rescue” is another predation. In 480 Zenodotus read “hollow” for “shadowy” grove, and some copies inserted a line naming the shield of Tychius (= 7.220) after 485 — the apparatus notes both; the printed text keeps neither. ↩

**34.** (11.514-515) “A healer is a man worth many other men together” — proverbial ever after; the specifying line 515 (“at cutting out arrows and sprinkling gentle drugs”) was omitted by Zenodotus

and athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus as a prosaic gloss. Homeric medicine is exactly these two skills — extraction and pharmacy — practiced by warriors: Machaon and Podaleirius are fighting doctors, and when both are down the craft passes to laymen taught by laymen (830-832: Patroclus, taught by Achilles, taught by Chiron). ↩

35. (11.543) Our printed Greek text genuinely lacks line 543 (the numbering jumps 542 to 544): the line was absent from the medieval manuscripts and is known because Aristotle quotes it, discussing righteous indignation (Rhetoric 1387a; cf. Plutarch's citations of the passage): "for Zeus would be indignant with him, whenever he fought a better man" — Ajax retreating not from Hector but from theology. Editors since Wolf print it in brackets; our source omits it as the OCT records, and the translation reproduces the gap. With 9.458-461, this is the second transmission-wound this project keeps visible. ↩

36. (11.544-565) The double simile of Ajax's retreat: first the lion driven all night from the cattle-yard by dogs, javelins, and firebrands, going off "sullen at heart" at dawn; then, without pause, the donkey —



slow, stick-broken, cropping the deep grain while boys beat him, leaving only when he is full. The lion was athetized by Zenodotus (548-557), and ancient taste flinched at the donkey; but the pair is the whole portrait: nobility from inside Ajax's chest, comedy from outside — the strongest man in the army backing away at his own pace, the only donkey in Homer, and one of the great tonal risks in epic. ↩

37. (11.596-604) The hinge of the Iliad. Achilles, “gazing at the sheer toil and the tearful rout” from his stern — spectator by choice — sees Nestor pass with a wounded man and calls out Patroclus, who comes out “the equal of Ares — and that was the beginning of his evil” (ἐκμολεν ἴσος Ἄρηϊ, κακοῦ δ’ ἄρα οἱ πέλεν ἀρχή). The narrator breaks his own reticence to mark the moment: a door opens, and the poem names it fate. Achilles’ stated hope — “now I think the Achaeans will soon stand about my knees begging” — shows the wrath still fed by the sight; his curiosity about one wounded man is what kills his friend. ↩

38. (11.632-637) The cup of Nestor: golden studs, four handles, doves feeding at each — and the poet’s tape-measure detail that another man could barely

lift it full, “but Nestor, the old man, raised it without strain.” On a clay cup from Pithekoussai (Ischia), c. 730-720 BC, someone scratched three lines: “I am the cup of Nestor, good to drink from; whoever drinks from me, straightway desire of fair-crowned Aphrodite will seize.” It is among the oldest surviving Greek writing — and it is a joke that only works on an audience that already knew this passage: the earliest external witness to the Iliad in circulation. Scholars have matched the described cup to Mycenaean finds (the gold “dove cup” from Shaft Grave IV); the poem’s furniture is centuries older than the poem. ↩

39. (11.624-641) Hecamede — Nestor’s prize-woman from Tenedos, sacked by Achilles (every comfort in this hut traces back to the man refusing to fight) — mixes the *κυκεών*, “posset”: Pramnian wine, grated goat’s-milk cheese, white barley, with honey and onion as relish alongside. Plato quotes the recipe (Ion 538c) — and elsewhere (Republic 405e-406a) makes it a scandal of Homeric medicine that a wine posset is served to wounded men; Machaon, shot through the shoulder, drinks it. The same drink, drugged, is Circe’s instrument in Odyssey 10 — the ordinary hospitality this scene shows straight. ↩

40. (11.654) “a terrible man. He would quickly blame even the blameless” — Patroclus on Achilles, the poem’s most intimate character-note: fear inside love. Plutarch quotes the line (How to Tell a Flatterer). Patroclus will say the harder version to Achilles’ face at 16.29-35 (“your parent was the grey sea and the cliffs”). ↩
41. (11.656-762) Nestor’s Pylian epic, his longest memory: the cattle-raid against Elis, the debt-division at dawn, Heracles’ devastation of Pylos (eleven brothers dead), the Moliones saved by their father Poseidon, and Nestor’s first aristeia — fifty chariots taken, “two men around each.” Its function is paradigm: the young Nestor fought although Neleus forbade him and hid his horses; Achilles, with every power to fight, withholds. (One line of the tale, 699, is flagged in the scholia as suspected spurious.) The close is the old man’s whole tragedy in seven words: “Such was I among men — if ever I was” (εἴ ποτ’ ἔον γε) — glory so far off that its owner half-doubts it happened. ↩
42. (11.765-790) The send-off at Peleus’s house: the embassy of recruitment, the sacrifice in the courtyard, young Achilles leaping up to seat the

guests — the poem’s one glimpse of its hero at home, in a scene of pure *xenia*. Peleus’s charge repeats 6.208 word for word in Greek and in our English — “always to be the best, and to hold one’s head above all others” — the aristocratic imperative issued identically to Glaucus and to Achilles; and against it Menoetius sets the other ethic: you are lesser-born and weaker, but older — advise him. Patroclus’s whole life is in that division of labor. Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized 767-785 (the reminiscence’s core!) as inconsistent in its geography; the vulgate kept it, and so does the printed text. ↩

43. (11.794-803) The fatal plan, invented by Nestor: if a prophecy holds Achilles back, “let him send you out at least... and let him give you his fine armor to carry into the war, so that the Trojans may take you for him.” Patroclus will repeat these lines to Achilles nearly verbatim at 16.36-45 — reuse this English there. Ancient critics chipped at the passage from both ends (794-795 athetized by Zenodotus; 802-803 by Aristarchus, as lifted from 16.44-45 — where they stand in Patroclus’s mouth). “You may be a light to the Danaans”: the image is of the beacon-fire — and what the disguise actually buys is Patroclus’s death,

Hector's brief triumph, and Achilles' return. The oldest man in the army, meaning pure good, sets the poem's catastrophe in motion in ten lines. ↩

44. (11.804-848) The delay that structures the middle of the poem: Patroclus, running back with Nestor's words in him, is stopped at the assembly-ground by wounded Eurypylus, pities him, and stays — “even so I will not abandon you in your suffering.” He cuts out the arrow, washes the wound, crushes the bitter root: the healer's craft learned from Achilles, learned from Chiron “the most righteous of the Centaurs” — the gentlest genealogy in the poem, running through its two great killers. Patroclus will still be in this hut at 15.390-404, and what finally moves him is watching the wall fail. The book's last clause — “and the wound began to dry, and the blood stopped” — repeats 267 exactly: Agamemnon's wound opened the day's subtraction, Eurypylus's closes the book; between the two dryings, the poem has chosen its victim. ↩

# Book 12

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*The battle at the wall: the Trojans storm it on foot, Sarpedon states the heroic contract, Hector overrules the omen, and the gate goes down.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 So in the huts Menoetius's stout son
- 2 was healing wounded Eurypylus. But the others fought on,1
- 3 Argives and Trojans in their masses; nor was the ditch
- 4 to hold much longer, nor the wide wall above it
- 5 the Danaans built to shield the ships — they drove the ditch

6 around it, but gave the gods no glorious  
hecatombs —  
7 so that it might guard for them the swift  
ships and the great  
8 plunder within. It was built against the  
will of the gods,  
9 the immortals; and so it stood firm for  
no long time.  
10 So long as Hector was alive, and  
Achilles in his wrath,  
11 and the city of lord Priam unsacked,  
12 so long the great wall of the Achaeans  
too stood firm.  
13 But when all the best of the Trojans had  
died,  
14 and of the Argives many were broken,  
though some were left,  
15 and Priam's city was sacked in the  
tenth year,

16 and the Argives had gone in their ships  
to their dear fatherland,  
17 then at last Poseidon and Apollo took  
counsel  
18 to wash the wall away, turning against  
it the fury of rivers,  
19 all that flow from the mountains of Ida  
down to the sea:  
20 Rhesus and Heptaporus, Caresus and  
Rhodius,  
21 Granicus and Aesepus, and brilliant  
Scamander,  
22 and Simois, where so many oxhide  
shields and helmets  
23 had fallen in the dust, and the race of  
half-god men:  
24 the mouths of all these Phoebus Apollo  
turned together,  
25 and nine days hurled their flood



against the wall; and Zeus rained  
26 without ceasing, to drown the wall in  
sea the sooner.  
27 And the earth-shaker himself, trident  
in hand,  
28 led them, and sent out on the waves all  
the foundations  
29 of beams and stones the Achaeans had  
laid with labor,  
30 and made all smooth along the strong-  
flowing Hellespont,  
31 and covered the great beach over again  
with sand,  
32 the wall washed away; and he turned  
the rivers back to run  
33 in their channels, where before they  
had poured their fair streams.<sup>2</sup>  
34 So Poseidon and Apollo were to dispose  
of it

35 hereafter. But now battle and clamor  
blazed  
36 around the well-built wall, and the  
beams of the towers rang  
37 under the blows. The Argives, broken  
under the whip of Zeus,  
38 were penned by the hollow ships and  
held there,  
39 dreading Hector, the strong machine of  
rout;  
40 while he, as before, fought on like a  
whirlwind.  
41 As when among hounds and hunting  
men  
42 a boar or lion wheels, glorying in his  
strength,  
43 and they form themselves into a tower-  
line  
44 and stand to face him, hurling from

their hands

45 spearheads thick and fast; but his  
glorious heart

46 knows no fear and no flight — and his  
courage kills him —3

47 and again and again he wheels, testing  
the ranks of men,

48 and wherever he charges, there the  
ranks of men give way:

49 so Hector went through the crowd and  
begged his companions,

50 urging them to cross the ditch. But his  
swift-footed horses

51 did not dare it; loudly they neighed,  
standing

52 at the very lip, for the wide ditch  
frightened them off —

53 not easy to leap from close up, nor to  
drive across,

54 for overhanging banks stood all around  
it  
55 on both sides, and above it was fitted  
with pointed  
56 stakes, planted by the sons of the  
Achaeans,  
57 close-set and great, a defense against  
enemy men.  
58 A horse straining at a well-wheeled  
chariot could not easily  
59 get in; but the foot-soldiers were mad  
to try it.  
60 Then Polydamas came and stood by  
daring Hector:  
61 “Hector, and you other leaders of  
Trojans and allies,  
62 it is folly to drive our swift horses  
across the ditch.  
63 It is very hard to cross: sharp stakes

64 stand in it, and right up against them is  
the Achaeans' wall.

65 There is no way down there, no way to  
fight

66 for men in chariots: the space is  
narrow, and I think we would be hurt.

67 For if Zeus who thunders on high, with  
evil in mind,

68 is wiping out the Achaeans utterly,  
eager to help the Trojans,

69 then I too would wish it done this very  
instant —

70 the Achaeans perishing here, nameless,  
far from Argos.

71 But if they turn on us, and we are  
driven back

72 from the ships, and get ourselves  
tangled in the dug ditch,

73 then not even a messenger, I think, will

make it back

74 to the city, once the Achaeans have  
wheeled on us.

75 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:

76 let the aides hold the horses at the  
ditch,

77 while we ourselves, on foot, armed in  
our gear,

78 follow Hector in one mass; and the  
Achaeans

79 will not hold, if the cables of  
destruction are fastened on them.”

80 So spoke Polydamas, and the prudent  
word pleased Hector,<sup>4</sup>

81 and at once he leapt with his weapons  
from the chariot to the ground.

82 Nor did the other Trojans stay massed  
on their chariots:

83 they all sprang down, when they saw

brilliant Hector do it.

84 Then each man gave his charioteer the  
order

85 to hold the horses in good order there  
at the ditch;

86 and they divided, formed themselves  
in companies,

87 and marshaled in five bodies they  
followed their leaders.

88 Those who went with Hector and  
blameless Polydamas

89 were the most and the best, and were  
most determined

90 to break the wall and fight beside the  
hollow ships;

91 and Cebriones followed as third man —  
by the chariot

92 Hector had left another man, a lesser  
one than Cebriones.

93 The second body Paris led, with  
Alcathous and Agenor;  
94 the third, Helenus and godlike  
Deiphobus,  
95 two sons of Priam; the third with them  
was the hero Asius —  
96 Asius, Hyrtacus' son, whom horses  
carried from Arisbe,<sup>5</sup>  
97 tall and fire-colored, from the river  
Selleïs.  
98 The fourth was led by Anchises' brave  
son  
99 Aeneas, and with him Antenor's two  
sons,  
100 Archelochus and Acamas, well skilled  
in all fighting.  
101 And Sarpedon led the far-famed allies,  
102 choosing to himself Glaucus and  
warlike Asteropaeus,



103 for they seemed to him beyond  
dispute the best  
104 of the rest after himself — he stood  
out even among all.<sup>6</sup>  
105 And when they had locked shields of  
worked oxhide together,  
106 they went straight for the Danaans,  
hot with eagerness, certain  
107 the Achaeans would hold no longer,  
but fall upon the black ships.  
108 Then the other Trojans and their far-  
famed allies  
109 obeyed the counsel of blameless  
Polydamas;  
110 but Asius, Hyrtacus' son, marshal of  
men, refused  
111 to leave his horses there with his  
charioteer-aide:  
112 with horses and all he drove at the

swift ships —

113 the fool: he was not to dodge the evil  
death-spirits

114 and come home again, exulting in  
horses and chariot,

115 back from the ships to windy Ilion.

116 Before that, fate of the hateful name  
closed round him

117 through the spear of Idomeneus,  
Deucalion's illustrious son.<sup>7</sup>

118 For he steered left of the ships, where  
the Achaeans

119 came back out of the plain with horses  
and chariots;

120 there he drove his horses and car, and  
at the gates

121 he found the doors not shut, the long  
bar not in place:

122 men were holding them thrown open,

hoping to save

123 any companion in flight from the  
battle, and bring him to the ships.

124 Straight for that point, deliberate, he  
held his horses, and his men

125 followed, screaming sharply, certain  
the Achaeans

126 would hold no longer, but fall upon  
the black ships —

127 the fools: at the gates they found two  
men of the bravest,

128 high-hearted sons of Lapith spearmen,

129 one the son of Peirithous, strong  
Polypoetes,

130 the other Leonteus, the equal of Ares  
bane of mortals.

131 These two, in front of the high gates,

132 stood like high-crowned oaks in the  
mountains

133 that abide the wind and rain through  
all their days,  
134 fast-fixed by their great roots running  
deep —  
135 so the two of them, trusting their  
hands and their strength,  
136 abode the coming of great Asius, and  
did not run.  
137 But the Trojans, holding their dried-  
oxhide shields high,  
138 came straight for the well-built wall  
with a great war-shout  
139 around lord Asius, and Iamenus, and  
Orestes,  
140 and Asius's son Adamas, and Thoon,  
and Oenomaus.  
141 And for a while the two, staying inside,  
were urging  
142 the strong-greaved Achaeans to

defend the ships;  
143 but when they saw the Trojans  
storming at the wall,  
144 and shouting and panic broke out  
among the Danaans,  
145 the two burst out and fought in front  
of the gates  
146 like a pair of wild boars in the  
mountains  
147 that stand the oncoming rabble of  
men and dogs,  
148 and charging slantwise shatter the  
timber around them,  
149 shearing it off at the root, and from  
under comes the noise  
150 of gnashing tusks, until a man's cast  
takes their life:  
151 so the shining bronze on their chests  
rang under the blows

152 struck face to face; for they fought  
hard indeed,  
153 trusting the troops above them and  
their own strength.<sup>8</sup>  
154 For the men above hurled stones from  
the well-built towers,  
155 defending themselves, their huts,  
156 and the swift-faring ships. Like  
snowflakes the stones fell earthward,  
157 flakes a blustering wind, driving the  
shadowed clouds,  
158 pours thick and fast on the earth that  
feeds so many:  
159 so the missiles streamed from their  
hands, from Achaeans  
160 and Trojans alike; and helmets and  
bossed shields  
161 rang harsh and dry, pounded with  
millstone rocks.

162 Then Asius, Hyrtacus' son, groaned  
aloud and struck  
163 both his thighs, and spoke in outrage:  
164 "Father Zeus, so even you, it turns out,  
are an utter  
165 lover of lies! I did not think the  
Achaean heroes  
166 would stand our fury and our  
invincible hands —  
167 and they, like wasps of the nimble  
waist, or bees  
168 that make their homes beside a rocky  
road  
169 and will not abandon their hollow  
house, but stay  
170 and fight off the raiding men for their  
children's sake,  
171 so these men will not give back from  
the gates, two though they are,

172 until they kill or are taken.”<sup>9</sup>  
173 So he spoke, but speaking did not  
persuade the mind of Zeus:  
174 his heart willed the glory for Hector.  
175 And others fought the fight at other  
gates —  
176 hard for me to tell it all through, as  
though I were a god:<sup>10</sup>  
177 for everywhere around the wall a  
prodigious fire had risen,  
178 a fire of stone; and the Argives,  
grieved to the heart,  
179 fought on for the ships by necessity;  
and the gods were downcast,  
180 all of them who were the Danaans’  
helpers in the fighting.  
181 And the Lapiths clashed into war and  
combat.  
182 There the son of Peirithous, strong



Polypoetes,

183 hit Damasus with the spear through  
the bronze-cheeked helmet:

184 the bronze helmet did not hold;  
straight on through

185 the bronze point broke the bone, and  
the brain

186 was all spattered inside it. He broke  
him in mid-charge.

187 And after him he stripped the life  
from Pylon and Ormenus.

188 And Leonteus, scion of Ares, hit  
Antimachus's son

189 Hippomachus with the spear, catching  
him at the war-belt;

190 then drawing his sharp sword out of  
its sheath

191 he sprang through the crowd and  
struck Antiphates first,

192 close-in, hand to hand; he crashed on  
his back on the ground;  
193 and after him Menon, and Iamenus,  
and Orestes —  
194 all these, one on another, he brought  
down to the earth that feeds so many.  
195 While they were stripping the  
glittering armor from these,  
196 the young men who followed  
Polydamas and Hector,  
197 who were the most and the best, and  
were most determined  
198 to break the wall and set fire to the  
ships,  
199 still stood at the ditch's edge and were  
divided in mind:  
200 for a bird had come upon them as  
they strained to cross:  
201 an eagle, flying high, herding the

army to the left,  
202 carrying in its talons a monstrous  
blood-red snake,  
203 alive, still writhing — and it had not  
forgotten its war-craft,  
204 for it struck the bird that held it, on  
the chest beside the neck,  
205 coiling itself backward; and the eagle  
flung it from him earthward,  
206 stung with the pain, and let it fall in  
the middle of the crowd,  
207 and with a scream flew off down the  
gusts of the wind.  
208 And the Trojans shuddered when they  
saw the writhing snake  
209 lying in their midst: a portent of  
aegis-bearing Zeus.<sup>11</sup>  
210 Then Polydamas came and stood by  
daring Hector:

211 “Hector, always somehow you rebuke  
me in the assemblies  
212 though I counsel well — since it is  
never fitting, it seems,  
213 for a man of the people to speak  
against you, in council  
214 or ever in war, but always to swell  
your power.  
215 Yet now once more I will say what  
seems to me best.  
216 Let us not go forward to fight the  
Danaans for the ships.  
217 For this, I think, is how it will end — if  
truly  
218 this bird came for the Trojans as they  
strained to cross:  
219 an eagle, flying high, herding the  
army to the left,  
220 carrying in its talons a monstrous

blood-red snake,  
221 alive — and it dropped it before it  
reached its own nest,  
222 and never finished carrying it home to  
give its young.  
223 So we: even if we break the gates and  
the wall  
224 of the Achaeans by main strength, and  
the Achaeans give way,  
225 we will come back from the ships in  
no good order by the same road;  
226 for we will leave many Trojans  
behind, whom the Achaeans  
227 will cut down with the bronze,  
defending their ships.  
228 So a reader of gods' signs would  
interpret, one whose heart  
229 truly knew the portents, and the  
people would believe him."

230 Glaring at him darkly, Hector of the  
flashing helmet answered:  
231 “Polydamas, this talk of yours pleases  
me no longer;  
232 you know how to think another word,  
better than this one.  
233 But if you truly say this thing in  
earnest,  
234 then the gods themselves have  
destroyed your wits —  
235 you who tell me to forget the counsels  
of loud-thundering  
236 Zeus, which he himself promised me,  
and bowed his head;  
237 you who tell me to put my faith in  
birds  
238 with wings outstretched. I take no  
thought of them, no care  
239 whether they go to the right, toward

the dawn and the sun,  
240 or to the left, toward the misty dark.  
241 Let us put our faith in the counsel of  
great Zeus,  
242 who is king over all mortals and  
immortals.  
243 One bird-sign is best: to fight for your  
fatherland.12  
244 Why are you so afraid of war and  
combat?  
245 For even if the rest of us are killed to a  
man  
246 beside the Argive ships, you need not  
fear to perish:  
247 your heart is not battle-staunch, not a  
fighter's heart.  
248 But if you hang back from the  
fighting, or talk any other man  
249 around with your words and turn him

away from war,  
250 struck down at once under my spear  
you will lose your life.”  
251 So speaking he led the way, and they  
followed him  
252 with a prodigious roar; and Zeus who  
delights in thunder  
253 roused out of the mountains of Ida a  
squall of wind  
254 that carried the dust straight at the  
ships; and it bewitched  
255 the mind of the Achaeans, and handed  
glory to the Trojans and Hector.**13**  
256 Trusting his portents, then, and their  
own strength,  
257 they set to trying to break the great  
wall of the Achaeans.  
258 They dragged at the towers’ galleries,  
pulled down the breastworks,



259 and levered up the jutting buttress-  
piles the Achaeans  
260 had set first in the earth to shore the  
towers:14  
261 these they tried to pull out, hoping to  
break the wall  
262 of the Achaeans. But the Danaans did  
not yet yield the path:  
263 they fenced the breastworks with  
oxhide shields  
264 and from behind them hurled at the  
enemy coming under the wall.  
265 And the two Ajaxes, marshaling on the  
towers,  
266 ranged everywhere, urging on the  
fury of the Achaeans;  
267 one man with honeyed words, another  
with hard ones  
268 they would lash, whomever they saw

hanging wholly back from the fight:  
269 “Friends — you who are excellent  
among the Argives, you who are middling,  
270 you who are lesser — since men are in  
no way all equal  
271 in war — now there is work for every  
man of you,15  
272 and you know it yourselves. Let no  
one turn back  
273 toward the ships now he has heard the  
man who drives you;  
274 press forward instead, and call each  
other on,  
275 in hope that Olympian Zeus, lord of  
lightning, may grant us  
276 to beat back the assault and drive our  
enemies to their city.”  
277 So the two, shouting ahead, stirred up  
the Achaeans’ battle.

278 And as flakes of snow fall thick and  
fast on a winter's day,  
279 when Zeus the counselor has bestirred  
himself to snow  
280 on mankind, and shows them what  
his missiles are,  
281 and lulling the winds he pours it down  
steadily, until he has covered  
282 the peaks of the high mountains, and  
the jutting headlands,  
283 and the clover meadows, and men's  
rich worked fields;  
284 and it is poured out over the harbors  
and shores of the grey sea,  
285 and only the wave, breaking on it,  
keeps it off; but all things else  
286 are wrapped from above, when the  
storm of Zeus drives down upon it:16  
287 so from both sides their stones flew

thick and fast,

288 some onto the Trojans, some from  
Trojans onto Achaeans,

289 as they pelted each other; and over  
the whole wall the din rose.

290 Yet not even then would the Trojans  
and glorious Hector

291 have broken the gates of the wall and  
the long bar,

292 had not Zeus the counselor roused his  
own son Sarpedon

293 against the Argives, like a lion on  
twist-horned cattle.17

294 At once he held before him his shield,  
balanced every way,

295 fair, of hammered bronze, which the  
smith had hammered out,

296 stitching inside it oxhides thick and  
close

297 with golden rods running unbroken  
round the rim.18

298 Holding this before him, shaking his  
two spears,

299 he went his way like a mountain-bred  
lion who has long

300 gone hungry for meat, and his proud  
spirit drives him

301 to make trial of the flocks, to go even  
into the close-built fold;

302 and even if he finds the herdsmen  
there beside them,

303 watching over the sheep with dogs  
and spears,

304 he will not be driven from the  
steading without his try:

305 either he leaps in and seizes one, or  
himself

306 is hit among the foremost by a javelin

from a quick hand:

307 so then his spirit drove godlike  
Sarpedon

308 to rush the wall and break through  
the breastworks.

309 And at once he spoke to Glaucus,  
Hippolochus's son:

310 "Glaucus, why is it that we two are  
honored beyond all

311 with the seat of honor, and the cuts of  
meat, and full cups,

312 in Lycia, and all men look on us like  
gods,

313 and we are granted a great estate on  
the banks of Xanthus,

314 fine land, orchard and wheat-bearing  
plowland?

315 For that, it is our duty now to stand  
among the first

316 of the Lycians, and to meet the blaze  
of battle,  
317 so that many a Lycian in his close  
armor may say:  
318 'No, they are not inglorious, these  
kings of ours  
319 who rule in Lycia, who eat the fat  
sheep  
320 and drink the choice honey-sweet  
wine: their strength too  
321 is noble, since they fight among the  
first of the Lycians.'  
322 Old friend, if the two of us could  
escape this war  
323 and live forever, ageless and immortal,  
324 I would not fight among the foremost  
myself,  
325 nor would I send you into the battle  
where men win glory.

326 But now — since the death-spirits  
stand over us  
327 in their thousands, and no mortal can  
flee them or slip past —  
328 let us go: we will give the triumph to  
some man, or he to us.”<sup>19</sup>  
329 So he spoke; and Glaucus did not turn  
away or disobey,  
330 and the two went straight on, leading  
the great Lycian nation.  
331 And Menestheus, Peteos’ son,  
shuddered to see them,  
332 for it was toward his tower they came,  
carrying ruin.  
333 He peered along the Achaean wall,  
hoping to see  
334 some captain who would ward off  
harm from his companions,  
335 and made out the two Ajaxes, never



sated with war,  
336 standing there, and Teucer, just come  
from his hut,  
337 close by; but there was no way to  
shout and be heard,  
338 so great was the din — the clamor  
went up to heaven —  
339 of battered shields and horsehair-  
crested helmets  
340 and of the gates: for all had been shut,  
and the Trojans  
341 stood against them, trying to break  
them by force and get in.  
342 At once he sent the herald Thootes to  
Ajax:  
343 “Go, brilliant Thootes — run, and call  
Ajax;  
344 or rather both of them; that would be  
best of all,

345 since sheer destruction will soon be  
upon us here.

346 The leaders of the Lycians bear down  
so — men who have always  
347 come storming into the strong  
encounters.

348 But if toil and struggle have risen for  
them there as well,  
349 then at least let stout Telamonian  
Ajax come alone,  
350 and let Teucer follow with him, who  
knows the bow well.”20

351 So he spoke; and the herald heard, and  
did not disobey,  
352 and set off running along the wall of  
the bronze-shirted Achaeans,  
353 and came and stood by the Ajaxes, and  
spoke at once:  
354 “You two Ajaxes, leaders of the

bronze-shirted Argives:

355 the dear son of Zeus-nurtured Peteos  
bids you

356 come there, to share the toil at least a  
little while —

357 or rather both of you; that would be  
best of all,

358 since sheer destruction will soon be  
upon them there.

359 The leaders of the Lycians bear down  
so — men who have always

360 come storming into the strong  
encounters.

361 But if here too war and struggle have  
risen,

362 then at least let stout Telamonian  
Ajax come alone,

363 and let Teucer follow with him, who  
knows the bow well.”

364 So he spoke, and great Telamonian  
Ajax did not disobey.

365 At once he spoke winged words to  
Oïleus' son:21

366 "Ajax — you and strong Lycomedes  
stay here,

367 stand fast, and urge the Danaans to  
fight their hardest.

368 I will go over there and take my share  
of the fighting,

369 and come back quickly, when I have  
given them good defense."

370 So speaking, Telamonian Ajax went  
off,

371 and with him went Teucer, his brother  
by one father,

372 and with them Pandion carried  
Teucer's curved bow.

373 And when they reached the tower of

great-hearted Menestheus,  
374 passing inside the wall — they came to  
men hard pressed,  
375 for up onto the breastworks like a  
dark squall  
376 came the powerful leaders and lords  
of the Lycians;  
377 and they clashed together in combat,  
and the war-cry rose.  
378 Telamonian Ajax was first to kill his  
man:  
379 great-hearted Epicles, Sarpedon's  
companion,  
380 striking him with a jagged block of  
marble that lay  
381 inside the wall, huge, topmost by the  
breastwork. Not easily  
382 could a man hold it in both hands, not  
in his youth's best,

383 such as mortals are now; but he  
heaved it high and threw it,<sup>22</sup>  
384 and crushed the four-bossed helmet,  
and smashed the bones  
385 of the head all in together; and like a  
diver  
386 he dropped from the high tower, and  
the life left his bones.  
387 And Teucer hit Glaucus, Hippolochus's  
strong son,  
388 with an arrow as he came storming up  
the high wall,  
389 just where he saw the arm bared, and  
stopped his fighting.  
390 He sprang back down from the wall,  
keeping hidden, so that no Achaean  
391 might see that he was hit and glory  
over him with words.<sup>23</sup>  
392 And grief came over Sarpedon at

Glaucus's going,  
393 the moment he knew it; but he did not  
forget his war-craft:  
394 he caught Alcmaon, Thestor's son,  
with a lunge of the spear  
395 and stabbed, then wrenched the spear  
out; and the man, following the spear,  
396 fell on his face, and his armor,  
intricate with bronze, clashed about him.  
397 And Sarpedon, gripping the  
breastwork with his massive hands,  
398 pulled — and the whole length of it  
followed; and above,  
399 the wall was laid naked; and he had  
made a road for many.**24**  
400 Ajax and Teucer answered him  
together: Teucer's arrow  
401 struck the shining strap that held the  
man-covering shield

402 about his chest; but Zeus beat the  
death-spirits away  
403 from his son — he was not to be  
broken by the ships' sterns —25  
404 and Ajax, leaping in, stabbed at the  
shield; the spear  
405 did not drive through, but staggered  
him in mid-fury.  
406 He gave back a little space from the  
breastwork, but wholly  
407 he did not yield, for his heart still  
hoped to seize glory.  
408 Wheeling round, he called to the  
godlike Lycians:  
409 "Lycians, why do you slacken your  
rushing courage so?  
410 It is hard for me, powerful as I am,  
411 to break through alone and make a  
path to the ships.



412 Follow me in! More hands make better  
work.”**26**

413 So he spoke; and they, in dread of their  
king’s rebuke,

414 pressed on harder around their  
counselor-king.

415 And the Argives on the other side  
strengthened their battle-lines

416 inside the wall; and the work before  
them showed very great:

417 for neither could the powerful Lycians  
break the wall

418 of the Danaans and make a path to the  
ships,

419 nor could the Danaan spearmen ever  
push back

420 the Lycians from the wall, once they  
had come close against it.

421 But as two men quarrel over

boundary-stones,  
422 measuring-rods in hand, in a common  
field,  
423 who in a little strip of ground contend  
over the fair share:27  
424 so the breastworks held them apart;  
and over them  
425 they hacked at one another, at the  
 chests, at the oxhide  
426 shields, round and well-made, and the  
 fluttering bucklers.  
427 Many were wounded in the flesh by  
 the pitiless bronze,  
428 whenever a man turned and his back  
 was left bare  
429 in the fighting, and many straight  
 through the shield itself.  
430 Everywhere the towers and  
 breastworks were spattered

431 with the blood of men, from both  
sides, Trojan and Achaean.  
432 But even so they could not turn the  
Achaeans to flight:  
433 the lines held — as an honest working  
woman holds the scales,  
434 who with the weight in one pan and  
the wool in the other  
435 draws them level, to win a pitiful wage  
for her children:28  
436 so their battle and their war were  
drawn level and taut,  
437 until the moment Zeus handed the  
higher glory to Hector,  
438 Priam's son, who was first to leap  
inside the wall of the Achaeans.  
439 He cried a piercing cry, to carry to the  
Trojans:  
440 "Rise up, horse-taming Trojans! Break

the wall

441 of the Argives, and hurl prodigious fire  
among the ships!”

442 So he spoke, spurring them on; and  
every ear heard him,

443 and they charged the wall in one  
mass; and then they

444 began mounting the galleries,  
sharpened spears in hand,

445 while Hector snatched up a stone and  
carried it — it stood

446 before the gates, thick at the base and  
sharp

447 on top; the two best men of a district  
could not easily

448 lever it off the ground and onto a  
wagon,

449 such as mortals are now; but he swung  
it easily, even alone, 29

450 for the son of crooked-counseled  
Cronos made it light for him.  
451 As when a shepherd carries the fleece  
of a ram  
452 easily in one hand, and its weight is  
little burden,  
453 so Hector lifted the stone and carried  
it straight  
454 at the doors that guarded the close  
and strong-fitted gates,  
455 double doors, high, with two crossed  
bars  
456 inside to hold them, fastened with a  
single bolt.  
457 He came and stood very close, and  
planted himself, and struck them  
458 full in the middle, legs braced wide, to  
give the blow its force,  
459 and broke both hinges away; and the

stone fell inside

460 by its own weight; and the gates  
groaned loud on either side; the bars  
461 did not hold, and the doors were burst  
apart this way and that

462 under the rush of the stone. And  
glorious Hector leapt in,

463 in his face the very likeness of swift  
night; and he blazed in the bronze

464 that terribly clothed his body, and in  
his hands he held

465 two spears. No one who met him  
could have held him back —

466 none but the gods — when he leapt  
the gates; and his eyes flared with fire.

467 Wheeling in the crowd, he called out  
to the Trojans

468 to climb over the wall; and they  
obeyed his urging:

469 at once some were climbing over the  
wall, while others poured  
470 through the built gates themselves;  
and the Danaans fled  
471 among the hollow ships; and the din  
rose unabating.30

## Notes

### NOTES

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#### NOTES

1. (12.1-2) The book opens by holding the camera on Patroclus, still in the hut healing Eurypylus — where 11.848 left him, and where he stays until 15.390-404. The whole battle at the wall is thus bracketed inside Patroclus's delayed errand: the poem keeps its catastrophe waiting in a doorway. ↩
2. (12.3-35) Unique in Homer: the narrator leaves the story's time entirely to relate the wall's future

annihilation — after the sack, Poseidon and Apollo turn the eight rivers of Ida against it for nine days, Zeus rains, the trident-bearer levers out the foundations and re-beds the beach in sand. The passage explains to the poet’s own audience why no trace of so great a work survived to be visited: epic erasing its own footprint (already at 7.443-464 Poseidon complained the wall would out-fame the one he built for Laomedon; Zeus there licensed this very deletion). Line 23 contains the poem’s only “race of half-god men” (ἡμιθέων γένος ἀνδρῶν): elsewhere the heroes are simply men; only here, looking back from the audience’s diminished present, does the narrator name the gulf. Aristotle admired the maneuver (Strabo 13.1.36 preserves the remark): “the poet who made the wall also made it disappear.” ↩

3. (12.41-48) The boar-or-lion at bay, wheeling on the closing ring: “his glorious heart knows no fear and no flight — and his courage kills him” (ἀγηνορίῃ δέ μιν ἔκτα, 46). The aside is proverb-grade and is the book’s thesis about Hector — spoken inside a simile about him, six books before 22.99-130 proves it. ↩



4. (12.60-80) Polydamas's first counsel, accepted. He appears here for the first time speaking (named 11.57): born the same night as Hector (18.251), the poem's designated counter-voice — his four speeches (here; 211; 13.726; 18.254) run accepted, rejected, accepted, rejected, and the last rejection kills Hector's army. The pattern begins with success: chariots left at the ditch, the wall attacked on foot. ↩
5. (12.96-97) Asius's entry repeats his Catalogue lines (2.838-839) verbatim — our wording kept: the muster-roll recalled at the moment the muster begins to die (cf. the Merops sons, 11.329). ↩
6. (12.87-104) The five battalions — the Trojan order of battle, with two debuts that matter: Alcaethous (dead at 13.427-444) and Asteropaeus the Paeonian, "warlike," chosen by Sarpedon as third — the man whose duel with Achilles in the river (21.139-204) will be the last full combat before Hector's. Sarpedon "stood out even among all": the poem promotes him steadily toward Book 16. ↩
7. (12.108-117) Asius refuses the plan — "the fool" (νήπιος), and the narrator files the death-notice in advance, naming the killer: Idomeneus, at 13.384-

393. The prolepsis-with-obituary is the poem's standard seal on disobedience (2.38, 16.46, 20.466); "fate of the hateful name" (μοῖρα δυσώνυμος) belongs to the small class of fate-phrases where the word itself winces. ↩

8. (12.127-153) The Lapith aristeia: Polypoetes and Leonteus keep their Catalogue credentials (2.740-746). The similes stack — oaks with roots running deep (131-134), then wild boars shattering the brush (146-150). The apparatus preserves Hephaestion's observation that 131-140 and 141-153 read like alternative versions of the same scene, only one of which was meant to stand — a rare window onto the poem's own workshop; the printed text, and this translation, keep both. ↩

9. (12.162-172) Asius's outrage: "Father Zeus, so even you, it turns out, are an utter lover of lies!" (φιλοψευδής — nowhere else does a mortal call Zeus a liar to his face). The wasps- and-bees simile he builds — nest defenders who "will not abandon their hollow house... for their children's sake" — is finer than he knows: he has conceded that the two Lapiths are the ones fighting for something. The narrator's dry

audit follows: Zeus was not persuaded; the glory was Hector's. ↩

10. (12.175-181) “hard for me to tell it all through, as though I were a god” — the narrator’s only confession of overload in the *Iliad*, athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus and omitted by Zenodotus, perhaps precisely because it lets the human singer show through the Muse’s voice. The “prodigious fire... of stone” (θεσπιδαῆς πῦρ λάϊνον) is a famous compression: the stone barrage burns like fire along the whole wall — the enjambed adjective detonates the metaphor. ↩
11. (12.200-209) The omen: an eagle on the left with a great snake in its talons; the snake, “not forgetting its war-craft,” strikes the eagle’s chest, is dropped in the crowd, and the eagle screams away empty. Polydamas will read it exactly (218-227): you may take the prey, but you will not carry it home. The scene is the poem’s fullest bird-sign, and the interpretation is never refuted — only overruled. ↩
12. (12.230-250) Hector’s answer, culminating in the most quoted hexameter of the *Iliad*: “One bird-sign is best: to fight for your fatherland” (243). Cited from classical Athens onward as the motto of patriotic

defense — and in context it is a king dismissing accurate intelligence on the strength of a private promise from Zeus (236) that expires at sundown (11.192-194, which Hector was not told). The rhetoric is immortal; the generalship is the disaster Polydamas predicted, and both men will say so later — Polydamas at 18.254-283, Hector to himself at 22.99-107. The closing threat (248-250) to kill any Trojan who hangs back completes the inversion: the omen-scene ends with the patriot promising to spear his own men. ↩

13. (12.251-255) Zeus's dust-squall off Ida "bewitched the mind of the Achaeans": the day's tilt made weather. *θέλγε* — the verb of enchantment (Circe's verb in the *Odyssey*) — for what a dust storm does to a defending army's judgment. ↩
14. (12.258-264) Siege engineering, precisely itemized: the galleries (*κρόσσαι*), the breastworks, the jutting buttress- piles set as footings for the towers — pulled, pried, and levered by hand. The *Iliad*'s only sustained description of fortification assault, and the vocabulary is a hapax-cluster to match the singular event. ↩

15. (12.265-276) The Ajaxes' exhortation sorts the army into "excellent... middling... lesser — since men are in no way all equal in war — now there is work for every man": the clearest statement in Homer of the mass army's ethic, where even the worse man's labor counts — a note closer to the hoplite line than to the duel of champions, and fittingly spoken by the defensive hero par excellence. ↩
16. (12.278-289) The great snow simile: Zeus "shows them what his missiles are," lulls the winds, and covers peaks, headlands, clover meadows, "men's rich worked fields," harbors and shores — only the breaking wave keeps it off. The barrage of stones is rendered as the silencing of the whole worked world under steady snow: din translated into hush, war into weather, and for four lines the poem simply looks at peace. Among the most admired similes in ancient and modern criticism alike. ↩
17. (12.290-293) "Yet not even then would the Trojans... have broken the gates, had not Zeus roused his own son Sarpedon": the breach requires a demigod, and the poet says so in the counterfactual frame he reserves for real turning-points. The lion simile that follows (299-306) is the poem's fullest: the hungry

lion who will either seize his prey or “himself be hit among the foremost” — the exact two outcomes Sarpedon offers Glaucus at 328. ↩

18. (12.294-297) Sarpedon’s shield, described from the smith’s bench: hammered bronze face, oxhides stitched inside with golden rods running full circle. The poem’s craftsmanship- passages dignify what is about to be risked; compare the cup of Nestor (11.632-637) and Hector’s stone below. ↩
19. (12.310-328) The Sarpedon speech — the classic statement of the heroic contract, in two movements. First, honor as obligation: the seat, the cuts, the full cups, the riverside estate — all are wages, and the Lycian in the ranks must be able to say his kings earn them (“not inglorious... their strength too is noble”). Second, the deeper clause (322-328): if escaping this battle meant being “ageless and immortal forever,” fighting would be senseless — I would neither fight nor send you; it is because death comes anyway, in ten thousand forms no mortal dodges, that courage is rational: “let us go: we will give the triumph to some man, or he to us.” Mortality is not the objection to heroism but its premise. This is the contract Achilles has just

repudiated in Book 9 (life outweighs all Troy's wealth, 9.401-409), and the poem has placed its finest defense in the mouth of the man Zeus's own son — whom Zeus will watch die in Book 16, weeping blood-rain. Quoted and imitated from antiquity forward; the whole aristocratic ethics of the West descends through these nineteen lines. ↩

20. (12.331-363) The Menestheus episode: the Athenian captain — praised in the Catalogue as a marshal, silent ever since — peers for help and sends Thootes. The herald delivers the message nearly word for word (354-363 = 343-350 with only the deixis shifted: “here” to “there”), our wording kept: messenger-fidelity as verbal discipline. Ancient critics athetized the Teucer line in both copies (350 = 363) as needless; it is the request's whole point — the bowman is wanted against Sarpedon. ↩

21. (12.365) “Oïleus' son” — the lesser Ajax. Zenodotus read a different form of the patronymic here (Ἰλιάδην), and — a marvel of textual history — his reading appears on a vase of the sixth century BC (published J.H.S. 1898): a pre- Alexandrian variant caught in paint before any surviving manuscript. The printed text follows Aristarchus. ↩

22. (12.378-386) Epicles goes down under the jagged marble block — “not easily could a man hold it in both hands... such as mortals are now” (the fixed diminished-present formula, 5.304) — and falls “like a diver... from the high tower.” The diver- image for a death-plunge recurs at 16.742 (Cebriones, with Patroclus’s terrible joke about oysters): grace at the instant of obliteration. ↩
23. (12.387-391) Teucer’s arrow finds Glaucus’s bared arm, and Glaucus drops back off the wall hiding the wound, “so that no Achaean might see that he was hit and glory over him.” The concealment is heroic bookkeeping — deny the enemy the boast — and the wound is a plot-load: at 16.508-531 it is this arm Glaucus begs Apollo to heal so he can defend Sarpedon’s corpse. ↩
24. (12.397-399) Sarpedon pulls down the breastwork with his bare hands: “the wall was laid naked; and he had made a road for many.” He does not enter — that honor is reserved (note [30]); he opens. Made a road for many: the plain half-line has the whole tragedy of Book 16 folded in it — the road is for Hector, and for Patroclus coming the other way. ↩



25. (12.400-403) Teucer's arrow finds only the shield-strap: "Zeus beat the death-spirits away from his son — he was not to be broken by the ships' sterns." Not saved: rescheduled. The clause quietly fixes the terms of 16.433-461, where Zeus will weigh saving him and be talked out of it by Hera. Every rescue in this poem is a date moved. ↩
26. (12.409-412) After the grandest speech in the book, Sarpedon's working voice: I cannot break through alone — "Follow me in! More hands make better work." The proverb (πλεόνων δέ τι ἔργον ἄμεινον) is the plain-prose twin of Diomedes' "when two go together" (10.224-226): heroism, at the wall as in the night, is cooperative labor. ↩
27. (12.421-426) The deadlock as a boundary dispute: two men with measuring-rods in a common field, quarreling "in a little strip of ground over the fair share." The war for Troy reduced to village litigation over inches — and with the surveyor's precision comes the bitter joke: this, too, is a war about property. The breastwork is the boundary-stone; the poem's great space annihilates to a farmer's furrow. ↩

28. (12.432-436) The second scales of the poem: not Zeus's golden balance (8.69) but a wage-worker's — "an honest working woman" (γυνὴ χερνῆτις ἀληθής) holding weight against wool, drawing them level "to win a pitiful wage for her children." The adjective ἀληθής — "true, honest" — is given to the poorest person in the Iliad, and the whole stalemated battle hangs from her steady hand. The pathos is in the economics: she balances so carefully because the wage is pitiful and the children are hers. No simile in the poem reaches further down the social order, or carries more weight per line. ↩

29. (12.445-450) Hector's stone: thick-butted, sharp-topped — a natural battering ram — "the two best men of a district could not easily lever it off the ground and onto a wagon, such as mortals are now; but he swung it easily even alone." The diminished-present formula again (its second use in the book, the fifth in the poem), and then the theological asterisk: "the son of crooked-counseled Cronos made it light for him." Line 450 was omitted by Zenodotus and athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus — deleting the asterisk credits Hector; keeping it credits Zeus; the printed text keeps it, and the

shepherd- and-fleece simile (451-452) plays the weight both ways. ↩

30. (12.457-471) The breach, in carpenter's detail: double doors, two crossed bars, one bolt; the stance ("legs braced wide, to give the blow its force"), both hinges sheared, the stone falling inside "by its own weight," the gates bellowing. Then the poem's great darkness-image: Hector leaps in "in his face the very likeness of swift night" — νυκτὶ θοῇ ἀτάλαντος — man as nightfall, the bronze blazing about the dark (Zenodotus read "wrapped in night," and the vulgate's phrase has passed into proverb as "sudden night"). "No one who met him could have held him back — none but the gods... and his eyes flared with fire." The book ends at the exact instant of penetration — Trojans over the wall and through the gates, Danaans in rout among the ships — the only book of the poem that closes inside an unresolved catastrophe: the door broken, and everything still to lose. ↩

# Book 13

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*Poseidon's defiance: Zeus looks away, the sea-god slips into the battle in disguise, and the line holds — shield on shield, man on man.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 Now Zeus, when he had brought the  
Trojans and Hector to the ships,
- 2 left them beside them, to bear the toil  
and the misery
- 3 without respite; and he himself turned  
his shining eyes
- 4 away, gazing far off at the land of the  
horse-herding Thracians,
- 5 and the close-fighting Mysians, and the  
proud Mare-milkers

6 who drink the milk, and the Abioi, most  
righteous of men.<sup>1</sup>

7 To Troy he no longer turned his shining  
eyes at all,

8 for he did not expect in his heart that  
any immortal

9 would come to stand by either Trojans  
or Danaans.

10 But the lord earth-shaker kept no blind  
man's watch:

11 he sat marveling at the war and the  
fighting,

12 high on the topmost peak of wooded  
Samos,

13 Thracian Samos; for from there all Ida  
showed clear,

14 and Priam's city showed clear, and the  
ships of the Achaeans.

15 There he sat, come up out of the sea,

and he pitied the Achaeans

16 broken under the Trojans; and against  
Zeus his anger was strong.

17 At once he came down from the rugged  
mountain,

18 striding fast on his feet; and the tall  
hills trembled, and the timber,

19 under the immortal feet of Poseidon as  
he went.<sup>2</sup>

20 Three strides he made, and with the  
fourth he reached his goal,

21 Aegae, where his famous house in the  
depths of the water,

22 golden, glittering, is built for him,  
imperishable forever.

23 There he came, and yoked beneath his  
chariot the bronze-hoofed horses,

24 swift-flying, with manes streaming  
gold,

25 and clothed himself in gold, and took  
the whip,  
26 gold, well-wrought, and mounted the  
chariot,  
27 and drove out over the waves. And the  
sea-beasts gamboled beneath him,  
28 coming from every hollow, and did not  
fail to know their lord;  
29 and the sea in its joy stood apart; and  
the horses flew on  
30 lightly, and the bronze axle beneath  
was not even wetted;<sup>3</sup>  
31 and the bounding horses carried him  
toward the ships of the Achaeans.  
32 There is a broad cave in the depths of  
the deep water,  
33 midway between Tenedos and rugged  
Imbros:  
34 there Poseidon the earth-shaker stayed

his horses,  
35 loosing them from the chariot, and  
threw down ambrosial fodder  
36 for them to eat; and around their feet  
he cast golden hobbles,  
37 unbreakable, not to be undone, so they  
would stay there unmoved  
38 for their lord's return; and he went to  
the army of the Achaeans.  
39 And the Trojans, massed like flame or  
like a stormwind,  
40 followed Hector, Priam's son, in  
insatiable fury,  
41 roaring, crying as one; and they hoped  
to take the ships  
42 of the Achaeans, and kill all their best  
men beside them.  
43 But Poseidon, holder of the earth, the  
earth-shaker,



44 come up out of the deep water, was  
rousing the Argives,  
45 likened to Calchas in body and tireless  
voice.  
46 First he spoke to the two Ajaxes, eager  
as they already were:  
47 “You two Ajaxes — you will save the  
army of the Achaeans  
48 if you remember your courage, and no  
shiver of panic.  
49 Elsewhere I do not fear the invincible  
hands  
50 of the Trojans who have climbed our  
great wall in a mass:  
51 the strong-greaved Achaeans will hold  
all of them.  
52 But here I fear most terribly that we  
suffer something —  
53 here where that rabid one leads them,

like a flame,

54 Hector, who claims to be a son of  
mighty Zeus.

55 May some god put it into the hearts of  
you two

56 to stand hard yourselves, and to  
command the others:

57 then you might beat him back from the  
swift-faring ships

58 for all his fury, even if the Olympian  
himself is driving him.”

59 He spoke, and the holder of the earth,  
the earth-shaker,

60 striking both of them with his staff,  
filled them with strong fury,

61 and made their limbs light, their feet  
and their hands above.

62 And he himself rose to fly like a swift-  
winged hawk

63 that lifts from a sheer towering rock-  
face

64 and swoops to chase some other bird  
across the plain:

65 so Poseidon the earth-shaker darted  
away from them.

66 Of the two, swift Ajax, Oileus' son,  
knew him first,

67 and at once he spoke to Ajax,  
Telamon's son:

68 "Ajax — since some one of the gods  
who hold Olympus,

69 likened to the seer, tells us to fight  
beside the ships —

70 and that is not Calchas, the reader of  
gods' bird-signs:

71 the trace of his feet and legs from  
behind, as he went off,

72 I knew it easily — the gods are easy to

know —4

73 now the heart in my own chest, for its  
part,

74 is set far more on warring and fighting,

75 and my feet beneath are hungry for it,  
and my hands above.”

76 Answering him spoke Telamonian Ajax:

77 “So with me: my invincible hands  
about the spear

78 are hungry, and my fury has risen, and  
beneath me both

79 my feet are driving; and I long — even  
alone —

80 to fight Hector, Priam’s son, in his  
insatiable fury.”

81 So the two of them spoke to one  
another,

82 in the joy of battle-craving the god had  
cast into their hearts;

83 and meanwhile the holder of the earth  
roused the Achaeans behind them,  
84 who were cooling their hearts back by  
the swift ships.  
85 Their limbs were unstrung with  
grievous weariness,  
86 and grief was rising in their hearts as  
they watched  
87 the Trojans, who had climbed the great  
wall in a mass:  
88 looking at them, they let the tears spill  
under their brows,  
89 for they did not think they would  
escape the evil. But the earth-shaker,  
90 passing easily among them, stirred the  
strong battle-lines.  
91 To Teucer first he came, and Leïtus,  
commanding,  
92 and the hero Peneleos, and Thoas, and

Deïpyrus,

93 and Meriones and Antilochus, masters  
of the war-shout;

94 urging these on, he spoke winged  
words:

95 “Shame, Argives — young men! It was  
you I trusted:

96 fight, and you will save our ships.

97 But if you slacken from the misery of  
this war,

98 now dawns the day we are broken  
under the Trojans.

99 Shame! — a great marvel is this I see  
with my eyes,

100 a terrible thing I never once said  
would come to pass:

101 the Trojans advancing on our ships —  
the Trojans, who before

102 were like skittering deer, which

through the timber,  
103 feed for jackals and leopards and  
wolves,  
104 wander witless and weaponless, with  
no fight in them:  
105 so before now the Trojans would not  
stand against  
106 the fury and the hands of the  
Achaeans — not for a moment.  
107 Now, far from their city, they are  
fighting at the hollow ships,  
108 through a leader's failing and the  
slackness of the army,  
109 who quarrel with him, and will not  
defend  
110 the swift-faring ships, but are killed  
among them.  
111 Yet even if the truth is that the man  
wholly to blame

112 is the hero, Atreus' son, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon,  
113 because he dishonored the swift-  
footed son of Peleus,  
114 we, for our part, have no leave to  
slacken from the war.  
115 No: let us heal it, quickly. The minds of  
good men can be healed.<sup>5</sup>  
116 It is no longer honorable, this  
slackening of your rushing courage,  
117 you who are all of you the best men in  
the army. I would not  
118 quarrel with any man who hung back  
from the fighting  
119 because he was worthless; but with  
you my heart is angry to the core.  
120 Soft men! Soon you will make some  
greater evil yet  
121 by this hanging back. Let each of you



put in his heart

122 shame, and the fear of blame: a great  
struggle has risen.

123 Hector is fighting at the ships now,  
good at the war-cry,

124 in his power, and he has broken the  
gates and the long bar.”

125 So the holder of the earth,  
commanding, roused the Achaeans.

126 And around the two Ajaxes the battle-  
lines took their stand,

127 strong lines: Ares himself could not  
have come and faulted them,

128 nor Athena, driver of armies. For the  
chosen best

129 stood and awaited the Trojans and  
brilliant Hector,

130 locking spear on spear, shield on  
layered shield:

131 buckler pressed on buckler, helmet on  
helmet, man on man,  
132 and the horsehair crests on the bright  
ridges touched  
133 as they nodded, so close they stood to  
one another;<sup>6</sup>  
134 and the spears, shaken in daring  
hands,  
135 crossed over one another; and their  
minds were set straight ahead, hot to fight.  
136 The Trojans struck first, massed;  
Hector led them,  
137 straining straight on, like a boulder off  
a cliff-face  
138 that a river swollen with winter  
shoves down the ledge,  
139 breaking with prodigious rain the  
shameless rock's moorings;  
140 bounding high it flies, and the timber

crashes

141 under it; and it runs on unswerving,  
steady, until it reaches

142 the level plain — and there it rolls no  
more, for all its rush:7

143 so Hector for a while threatened to  
sweep clean to the sea,

144 clean through the huts and ships of  
the Achaeans,

145 killing; but when he ran against those  
close-set battle-lines,

146 he stopped, jammed hard against  
them. And the sons of the Achaeans facing  
him,

147 stabbing with swords and double-  
curved spears,

148 thrust him away from them; and he  
shuddered and gave ground.

149 He cried a piercing cry, to carry to the

Trojans:

150 “Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians  
who fight at close quarters —

151 stand by me! Not for long will the  
Achaeans hold me,

152 not though they have built themselves  
into a tower,

153 no — I think they will give way under  
my spear, if truly

154 the best of gods drove me on, the  
loud-thunderer, Hera’s lord.”

155 So speaking he stirred the fury and the  
heart of every man.

156 And Deiphobus strode among them  
thinking great things,

157 Priam’s son, holding before him his  
shield, balanced every way,

158 stepping light on his feet, advancing  
under the shield’s cover.

159 And Meriones aimed at him with his  
shining spear  
160 and threw, and did not miss, striking  
the shield, balanced every way,  
161 the bull's-hide shield — but drove  
nowhere through it: well before that  
162 the long spear snapped at the socket.  
And Deiphobus  
163 held the bull's-hide shield away from  
him, and his heart feared  
164 the spear of war-minded Meriones;  
but that hero  
165 drew back into the band of his  
companions, angry to the bone  
166 both ways — for the lost victory, and  
the spear he had shattered —  
167 and set off along the huts and ships of  
the Achaeans  
168 to fetch a long spear that was left him

in his hut.

169 The others fought on, and the  
quenchless roar rose.

170 Teucer, Telamon's son, was first to kill  
his man,

171 the spearman Imbrius, son of Mentor  
rich in horses.

172 He lived in Pedaeum, before the sons  
of the Achaeans came,

173 and had for wife a bastard daughter of  
Priam, Medesicaste;

174 but when the double-ended ships of  
the Danaans came,

175 he came back to Ilion, and stood out  
among the Trojans,

176 and lived with Priam, who honored  
him like his own children.

177 Him the son of Telamon stabbed under  
the ear with the long spear,

178 and wrenched the spear out; and he  
fell like an ash tree  
179 that on the crest of a mountain seen  
clear from every side  
180 is cut down by the bronze, and brings  
its soft leaves to the ground:  
181 so he fell, and his armor, intricate with  
bronze, clashed about him.  
182 And Teucer rushed in, hot to strip the  
armor off him;  
183 but as he rushed, Hector cast at him  
with his shining spear.  
184 He saw it coming and dodged the  
bronze spear —  
185 barely; and Hector struck  
Amphimachus, son of Cteatus  
186 of Actor's line, with the spear in the  
chest as he came into the battle:  
187 he fell with a thud, and his armor

clattered upon him.

188 And Hector rushed in to tear the  
helmet, close-fitted

189 at the temples, from the head of great-  
hearted Amphinachus;

190 but as he rushed, Ajax lunged at him  
with the shining spear —

191 yet nowhere reached the flesh, for all  
of him was sheathed

192 in terrible bronze. He stabbed the boss  
of the shield instead

193 and shoved him back with great  
strength; and Hector gave ground

194 behind the two corpses, and the  
Achaeans dragged them clear.

195 Amphinachus, then, Stichius and  
brilliant Menestheus,

196 captains of the Athenians, carried  
back among the Achaean host;



197 and Imbrius the two Ajaxes, hot with  
rushing courage,  
198 as two lions snatch a goat from under  
the guard  
199 of sharp-toothed dogs and carry it  
through the thick brush,  
200 holding it high above the ground in  
their jaws:  
201 so the two Ajaxes, helmed for war,  
holding him high,  
202 stripped his armor; and the head from  
the soft neck  
203 Oïleus' son cut off, in wrath for  
Amphimachus,  
204 and swung and sent it rolling like a  
ball through the crowd;  
205 and it fell in the dust in front of  
Hector's feet.<sup>8</sup>  
206 And then it was that Poseidon was

angered to the heart,  
207 his grandson fallen in the dread  
combat,<sup>9</sup>  
208 and he set off along the huts and ships  
of the Achaeans  
209 to rouse the Danaans; and he was  
building sorrows for the Trojans.  
210 And Idomeneus, famed with the spear,  
met him  
211 coming from a companion who had  
just come out of the fighting,  
212 cut behind the knee by the sharp  
bronze.  
213 His comrades carried him in; and  
Idomeneus, giving the healers  
214 their orders, was going to his hut, for  
he still longed  
215 to face the war. And the lord earth-  
shaker spoke to him,

216 likening his voice to Thoas,  
Andraemon's son,  
217 who in all Pleuron and steep Calydon  
218 ruled the Aetolians, honored like a god  
by the people:  
219 "Idomeneus, counselor of the Cretans,  
where have they gone,  
220 the threats the sons of the Achaeans  
threatened against the Trojans?"  
221 And Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans,  
answered him:  
222 "Thoas, no man is at fault now — not  
so far  
223 as I can tell; for all of us know how to  
fight.  
224 No one is gripped by bloodless fear, no  
one yields  
225 to shirking and ducks out of this evil  
war. No — this, it seems,

226 must be the pleasure of the  
overmastering son of Cronos:  
227 that the Achaeans perish here,  
nameless, far from Argos.  
228 But Thoas — you were always staunch  
before,  
229 and you rouse any other man you see  
slackening:  
230 so do not leave off now. Call to every  
man.”  
231 Then answered him Poseidon the  
earth-shaker:  
232 “Idomeneus, may the man never come  
home  
233 from Troy — may he be sport for dogs  
on this ground —  
234 who on this day chooses to slacken  
from the fighting.  
235 Come then, take up your weapons and

come out with me. We must

236 press this together, and see if the two  
of us can be of use.

237 Even sorry men, combined, come to  
some courage —10

238 and the two of us would know how to  
fight even the best.”

239 So speaking, the god went back into  
the toil of men;

240 and Idomeneus, when he reached his  
well-built hut,

241 put his fine armor about his body,  
caught up two spears,

242 and went his way like the lightning-  
bolt the son of Cronos

243 takes in his hand and brandishes from  
glittering Olympus,

244 showing a sign to mortals, and its  
flashes blaze far:

245 so the bronze blazed on his chest as he  
ran.

246 And Meriones, his brave aide, met him  
247 while he was still near the hut — he  
was going to fetch

248 a bronze spear — and the strength of  
Idomeneus spoke to him:

249 “Meriones, Molus’s son, swift-footed,  
dearest of my companions,11

250 why have you come, leaving the war  
and the combat?

251 Are you hit somewhere — is an  
arrowhead wearing you down?

252 Or do you come after me with some  
message? I myself

253 have no wish to sit in the huts, but to  
fight.”

254 And level-headed Meriones answered  
him:

255 “Idomeneus, counselor of the bronze-  
shirted Cretans,

256 I come to fetch a spear, if one is left

257 in your huts; the one I carried before,  
we shattered it —

258 I struck the shield of Deiphobus in his  
arrogance.”

259 And Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans,  
answered him:

260 “Spears — if you want them you will  
find one, and twenty,

261 standing in my hut against the bright  
entrance-wall:

262 Trojan spears, which I strip from the  
men I kill. I hold<sup>12</sup>

263 it is not my way to fight standing far  
from enemy men;

264 and so I have spears, and bossed  
shields,

265 and helmets, and corslets shining  
bright.”

266 And level-headed Meriones answered  
him:

267 “I too, by my hut and my black ship,  
have plenty

268 of Trojan spoils — but they are not  
close by for the taking.

269 For I say I am no more forgetful of  
courage than you:

270 I take my stand among the first in the  
battle where men win glory

271 whenever the strife of war has risen.

272 Some other of the bronze-shirted  
Achaeans might miss

273 my fighting; but you — you are the  
one who knows it, I think.”

274 And Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans,  
answered him:



275 “I know your worth, and what kind of  
man you are. Why recite it?  
276 If now beside the ships all our best  
were being counted  
277 for an ambush — where the worth of  
men shows clearest,  
278 where the coward and the brave man  
stand revealed:  
279 the coward’s color changes to one  
thing and another,  
280 and the spirit in his chest cannot hold  
him steady in his seat,  
281 but he shifts his crouch, sits back from  
foot to foot,  
282 and the heart in his ribs hammers  
hugely  
283 as he imagines the death-spirits, and  
his teeth chatter aloud;  
284 but the brave man’s color never

changes, and no fear in him

285 is too great, once he has settled into  
the ambush of men,

286 and he prays to be mixed at once in  
the misery of battle —

287 there, no man could fault your fury or  
your hands.

288 For even if you were hit in the work,  
or struck close in,

289 the missile would not fall on the nape  
of your neck, or your back:

290 it would meet your chest or your belly

291 as you pressed forward into the front-  
fighters' trysting-place.<sup>13</sup>

292 But come, no more standing here  
talking of this

293 like children — someone might scoff  
beyond all measure.

294 Go to the hut, and choose yourself a

massive spear.”

295 So he spoke; and Meriones, the equal  
of swift Ares,

296 quickly took up a bronze spear from  
the hut

297 and went after Idomeneus, his whole  
mind on war.

298 As Ares, bane of mortals, goes out to  
war,

299 and with him follows Panic, his dear  
son, strong and fearless,

300 who sends even the patient-hearted  
warrior running;

301 the two of them arm out of Thrace  
against the Ephyri

302 or the great-hearted Phlegyes — and  
they do not hear<sup>14</sup>

303 both sides’ prayers, but hand the  
glory to one:

304 such were Meriones and Idomeneus,  
leaders of men,  
305 as they went into the war, helmed in  
blazing bronze.  
306 And Meriones spoke to him first with  
his word:  
307 “Son of Deucalion, where are you  
eager to enter the crowd?  
308 On the right of the whole army, or  
through the middle,  
309 or on the left? For nowhere else, I  
think, do the long-haired  
310 Achaeans so fail of hands in the  
fighting.”  
311 And Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans,  
answered him:  
312 “In the center ships there are others  
to hold the defense,  
313 the two Ajaxes, and Teucer, who is

best of the Achaeans

314 in bowmanship, and good too in the  
standing fight:

315 they will drive him to sickness of it,  
however hot for battle —

316 Hector, Priam's son — however strong  
he is.

317 It will be steep going for him, blaze as  
he may to fight:

318 against their conquering fury and  
invincible hands

319 he will not fire the ships — unless the  
son of Cronos in person

320 hurls a burning brand onto the swift  
ships.

321 To no man would he yield, great  
Telamonian Ajax —

322 to no man who is mortal and eats the  
grain of Demeter,

323 who can be broken by bronze or by  
great hurled stones.  
324 Not even to Achilles, breaker of men,  
would he give way —  
325 in the standing fight; in speed of foot  
there is no contesting him.  
326 So take us leftward of the army, and  
quickly: we will see  
327 whether we give the triumph to some  
man, or he to us.”  
328 So he spoke; and Meriones, the equal  
of swift Ares,  
329 led on, until they came to the army  
where he had bidden.  
330 And when they saw Idomeneus,  
strong as a flame,  
331 him and his aide, in their intricate  
war-gear,  
332 they called to one another through

the crowd and made for him,  
333 and their struggle joined, one mass,  
by the sterns of the ships.  
334 As when squalls come racing under  
shrill winds  
335 on a day when the dust lies thickest  
on the roads,  
336 and all together they raise up a great  
cloud of dust:  
337 so their battle came together in one  
mass, and they were hot  
338 in their hearts to slaughter each other  
in the crowd with the sharp bronze.  
339 And the man-destroying battle  
bristled with the long  
340 flesh-cutting spears they gripped; and  
eyes were blinded  
341 by the flare of bronze off glittering  
helmets

342 and fresh-burnished corslets and  
shining shields  
343 as they came on in one mass. It would  
be a hard-hearted man  
344 who could rejoice at the sight of that  
toil, and not be grieved.<sup>15</sup>  
345 And the two strong sons of Cronos,  
divided in purpose,  
346 were building grim sorrows for the  
fighting men.  
347 Zeus willed the victory for the Trojans  
and Hector,  
348 glorifying swift-footed Achilles; yet he  
had no wish  
349 for the Achaean army to perish wholly  
before Ilium —  
350 he was glorifying Thetis, and her  
strong-hearted son.  
351 But Poseidon had come among the



Argives and was stirring them,  
352 slipped up in secret from the grey salt  
water; for it galled him  
353 to see them broken by Trojans, and  
against Zeus his anger was strong.  
354 Both, to be sure, were of one stock and  
one parentage,  
355 but Zeus was elder-born, and he knew  
more.  
356 For that reason Poseidon shunned  
defending them openly,  
357 and in secret, always, roused them  
down the army, likened to a man.  
358 So the two of them knotted the cord  
of strong strife  
359 and leveling war, and drew it taut over  
both sides —  
360 a cord unbreakable, not to be untied;  
and it unstrung the knees of many.<sup>16</sup>

361 Then — though his hair was half-grey  
— Idomeneus,  
362 calling on the Danaans, leapt on the  
Trojans and drove panic among them.  
363 For he killed Othryoneus, in the town  
from Cabetes —  
364 lately come, chasing the report of the  
war,  
365 and he had asked for the loveliest of  
Priam's daughters,  
366 Cassandra, without bride-gifts —  
promising a great work instead:  
367 to drive the sons of the Achaeans out  
of Troy against their will.  
368 And old Priam had promised her, had  
bowed his head:  
369 give her he would; and Othryoneus  
fought trusting the promises.  
370 Idomeneus aimed at him with his

shining spear

371 and threw, and hit him in mid-stride;  
the corslet of bronze

372 he wore did not hold: the spear fixed  
in his belly's middle.

373 He fell with a thud; and Idomeneus  
exulted, calling:

374 "Othryoneus — I congratulate you  
beyond all living men

375 if you are really going to accomplish  
all you promised

376 Priam, Dardanus' heir! He promised  
you his daughter.

377 Look — we too could promise you as  
much, and keep it:

378 we would give you the loveliest of the  
daughters of Atreus' son,

379 bringing her out of Argos for you to  
marry, if you will join us

380 and sack the well-peopled city of  
Ilion.

381 Come along: let us settle the marriage  
at the seafaring ships —

382 you will find we are not hard men  
over bride-terms.”<sup>17</sup>

383 So speaking the hero Idomeneus  
dragged him by the foot

384 through the strong encounter. But  
Asius came to avenge him,

385 on foot before his horses; the aide  
who drove them

386 kept them breathing at his shoulders  
always. And his heart was hot

387 to hit Idomeneus; but the other was  
quicker, and struck him with the spear

388 in the throat under the chin, and  
drove the bronze clean through.

389 He fell as an oak falls, or a white

poplar,

390 or a towering pine, that carpenters up  
in the mountains

391 cut down with fresh-whetted axes to  
be a ship's timber:18

392 so he lay stretched out before his  
horses and chariot,

393 bellowing, clawing at the blood-  
soaked dust.

394 And the charioteer was struck out of  
the wits he had:

395 he did not dare wheel the horses  
round and slip

396 out of the enemy's hands; and  
Antilochus, staunch in the fight,

397 caught him with the spear mid-body;  
the corslet of bronze

398 he wore did not hold: the spear fixed  
in his belly's middle,

399 and he fell gasping out of the well-  
built chariot.  
400 And the horses Antilochus, great-  
hearted Nestor's son,  
401 drove off from the Trojans to the  
strong-greaved Achaeans.  
402 Then Deiphobus came up very close to  
Idomeneus,  
403 grieving for Asius, and cast with his  
shining spear.  
404 But Idomeneus saw it coming and  
dodged the bronze spear:  
405 he hid himself behind his shield,  
balanced every way,  
406 the shield he carried, built of oxhides  
and gleaming bronze  
407 rounded on the wheel, fitted with two  
cross-rods:  
408 under it he gathered himself whole,

and the bronze spear flew over  
409 and the shield rang dry and harsh as  
the spear grazed  
410 across it. Yet Deiphobus's heavy hand  
had not thrown in vain:  
411 he hit Hypsenor, Hippasus's son,  
shepherd of the people,  
412 in the liver below the midriff, and  
unstrung his knees on the instant.  
413 And Deiphobus vaunted terribly over  
him, crying far:  
414 "Not unavenged, after all, lies Asius!  
No — I say  
415 that even going down to Hades, the  
strong closer of the gate,  
416 he will be glad at heart: I have given  
him an escort for the road."<sup>19</sup>  
417 So he spoke, and grief came over the  
Argives at his vaunting,

418 and most of all he stirred the heart of  
war-minded Antilochus;  
419 yet grieved as he was, he did not  
forget his companion:  
420 running, he stood over him and  
covered him with the shield,  
421 and two loyal companions stooped  
beneath him,  
422 Mecisteus, Echius' son, and brilliant  
Alastor,  
423 and carried him, groaning heavily, to  
the hollow ships.  
424 And Idomeneus did not slacken his  
great fury: he strained  
425 always either to wrap some Trojan in  
blinding night  
426 or to fall himself with a crash,  
warding ruin from the Achaeans.  
427 Then the dear son of Zeus-nurtured



Aesyetes,  
428 the hero Alcathous — he was  
Anchises' son-in-law,  
429 married to the eldest of his daughters,  
Hippodameia,  
430 whom her father and her lady mother  
loved with all their hearts  
431 at home; for she outshone all the girls  
of her age  
432 in beauty and in handiwork and in  
wit, and for that  
433 the best man in the breadth of Troy  
had married her —  
434 him, then, Poseidon broke under  
Idomeneus's hand:  
435 he charmed his shining eyes and  
shackled his glorious limbs, 20  
436 so that he could neither run back nor  
swerve aside,

437 but stood unmoving, like a grave-  
pillar or a tree  
438 in high leaf, while the hero  
Idomeneus stabbed him with the spear  
439 mid-chest, and burst the bronze tunic  
around it,  
440 the tunic that till then had kept ruin  
from his flesh:  
441 it screamed dry and harsh as it tore  
around the spear.  
442 He fell with a thud, the spear stuck  
fast in his heart,  
443 and the heart, still beating, shook  
even the butt-end  
444 of the spear, quivering — until at last  
massive Ares stilled its fury.  
445 And Idomeneus vaunted terribly over  
him, crying far:  
446 “Deiphobus! Shall we call it a fair

reckoning now —

447 three men killed for one? — since it  
was you who boasted.

448 Strange man: come stand against me  
yourself, face to face,

449 and learn what son of Zeus's line has  
come here:

450 Zeus first begot Minos, warden of  
Crete;

451 and Minos got a son, blameless  
Deucalion;

452 and Deucalion fathered me, lord over  
many men

453 in wide Crete; and now the ships have  
carried me here,

454 an evil to you, and your father, and  
the rest of the Trojans.”**21**

455 So he spoke; and Deiphobus was torn  
two ways —

456 whether to fall back and take as  
companion some one  
457 of the great-hearted Trojans, or to try  
it alone.  
458 And as he weighed it, this seemed to  
him the better course:  
459 to go for Aeneas. He found him  
standing rearmost  
460 of the crowd; for he was forever  
furious at brilliant Priam,  
461 because, brave among men as he was,  
Priam gave him no honor.22  
462 Standing close, he spoke winged  
words to him:  
463 “Aeneas, counselor of the Trojans,  
now the great need is on you  
464 to stand for your sister’s husband — if  
kinship’s grief can reach you.  
465 Come, let us fight for Alcathous, who

long ago,

466 as your sister's husband, reared you in  
his house when you were little;

467 and Idomeneus, famed with the spear,  
has stripped him."

468 So he spoke, and stirred the heart in  
Aeneas's chest,

469 and he went after Idomeneus, his  
whole mind on war.

470 But no panic took hold of Idomeneus,  
as though he were some pampered boy:

471 he stood his ground, like a boar in the  
mountains sure of his strength,

472 who abides the great oncoming rabble  
of men

473 in a lonely place, and the ridge of his  
back bristles up,

474 and his eyes shine with fire, and he  
whets his tusks,

475 hot to beat off the dogs and the men:  
476 so Idomeneus, famed with the spear,  
stood fast and did not yield  
477 to Aeneas coming swift to the rescue.  
But he called his companions,  
478 looking to Ascalaphus and Aphareus  
and Deïpyrus  
479 and Meriones and Antilochus, masters  
of the war-shout;  
480 urging these on, he spoke winged  
words:  
481 “Here, friends — I am alone: defend  
me! I dread him terribly,  
482 swift-footed Aeneas, who is coming at  
me —  
483 who is very strong in battle at killing  
men,  
484 and has the flower of youth besides,  
which is the greatest power.

485 If we were of one age, with the heart I  
carry now,  
486 quickly would he carry off great  
power — or I would.”  
487 So he spoke; and all of them, one spirit  
in their chests,  
488 took their stand close by him, shields  
leaned against their shoulders.  
489 And Aeneas on the other side called to  
his companions,  
490 looking to Deiphobus and Paris and  
brilliant Agenor,  
491 fellow-leaders of the Trojans with  
him; and after them  
492 the troops followed, as flocks follow  
the bell-ram  
493 down from the pasture to drink — and  
the shepherd’s heart is glad:23  
494 so the heart in Aeneas’s chest rejoiced

495 when he saw the mass of troops  
following his own lead.  
496 And around Alcatous they went at  
each other, close in,  
497 with their long pikes; and the bronze  
about their chests  
498 rang terribly as they aimed at one  
another  
499 through the crowd. And two men of  
war beyond the others,  
500 Aeneas and Idomeneus, the equals of  
Ares,  
501 strained to hew each other's flesh  
with the pitiless bronze.  
502 Aeneas first cast at Idomeneus;  
503 but he saw it coming and dodged the  
bronze spear,  
504 and the point of Aeneas's spear went  
quivering



505 into the earth, hurled in vain from his  
massive hand.

506 But Idomeneus struck Oenomaus mid-  
belly,

507 and burst the plate of his corslet, and  
the bronze

508 spilled his bowels through; and falling  
in the dust he clutched the earth in his  
palm.

509 And Idomeneus wrenched the long-  
shadowed spear out

510 of the corpse, but could not strip the  
rest of the fine armor

511 from his shoulders: the missiles  
pressed him too hard.

512 For the joints of his feet no longer held  
firm in the charge —

513 no spring left, either to follow his own  
cast or to dodge another's.

514 So in the standing fight he still fended  
off the pitiless day,  
515 but in retreat his feet could no longer  
carry him quick out of the battle.  
516 And as he was stepping slowly back,  
Deiphobus cast at him  
517 with his shining spear — for the  
grudge he held him was relentless, always.  
518 But this time too he missed; and the  
spear hit Ascalaphus,  
519 the son of Enyalios; through the  
shoulder the massive spear  
520 drove; and falling in the dust he  
clutched the earth in his palm.  
521 But loud-roaring massive Ares knew  
nothing of it yet —  
522 that his son had fallen in the strong  
encounter —  
523 for he sat on the peak of Olympus,

under the golden clouds,  
524 penned there by the designs of Zeus,  
where the other  
525 immortal gods sat too, barred from  
the war.24  
526 And around Ascalaphus they went at  
each other close in:  
527 Deiphobus tore the shining helmet  
from Ascalaphus,  
528 but Meriones, the equal of swift Ares,  
leaping in,  
529 stabbed his upper arm with the spear,  
and out of his hand  
530 the socketed helmet fell ringing to the  
ground.  
531 And Meriones, springing in again like  
a vulture,  
532 wrenched the massive spear out of his  
upper arm

533 and drew back into the band of his  
companions. And Polites,  
534 Deiphobus's own brother, throwing  
his arms around his waist,  
535 led him out of the harsh-sounding  
war, until they reached  
536 his swift horses, which stood behind  
the battle and the fighting  
537 with their charioteer and the intricate  
chariot;  
538 these carried him toward the city,  
groaning heavily,  
539 worn; and the blood ran down from  
the fresh wound on his arm.  
540 The others fought on, and the  
quenchless roar rose.  
541 There Aeneas sprang on Aphareus,  
Caletor's son,  
542 and struck his throat — it was turned

toward him — with the sharp spear;  
543 his head dropped to one side, and  
shield and helmet  
544 crumpled down on him, and death  
that breaks the spirit poured round him.  
545 And Antilochus, watching Thoon as he  
turned around,  
546 leapt in and stabbed him, and severed  
the whole vein  
547 that runs up the length of the back to  
reach the neck:  
548 the whole of it he severed, and the  
man dropped on his back in the dust,  
549 stretching both hands out toward his  
dear companions.  
550 And Antilochus sprang on him and set  
to stripping the armor  
551 from his shoulders, watching all  
round; for the Trojans, ringing him,

552 stabbed at his broad glittering shield  
from this side and that, yet could not  
553 get through to graze the soft flesh  
behind it with the pitiless bronze —  
554 the flesh of Antilochus; for Poseidon  
the earth-shaker  
555 guarded Nestor's son on every side,  
even amid the thick missiles.  
556 For never was he out of reach of  
enemies; he wheeled  
557 among them; and his spear was never  
held still, but always  
558 shaken, quivering; and his aim was set  
in his mind  
559 either to cast at someone, or to charge  
in close.  
560 But as he aimed through the crowd he  
did not go unseen  
561 by Adamas, Asius's son, who leapt in

close and stabbed

562 the middle of his shield with the sharp  
bronze; but the blue-maned

563 Poseidon made the point strengthless,  
grudging him that life.25

564 And half of it stuck there, like a fire-  
hardened stake,

565 in the shield of Antilochus, and half  
lay on the ground;

566 and Adamas drew back into the band  
of his companions, dodging doom.

567 But Meriones, following as he went,  
threw the spear

568 and hit him between the genitals and  
the navel — there

569 where the war-god comes most  
grievous to wretched mortals.

570 There the spear stuck fast; and  
doubled over the shaft

571 he writhed, as a bull writhes that  
herdsmen in the mountains  
572 have bound with willow-ropes and  
drag along unwilling:  
573 so, stabbed, he writhed a little while —  
not long —  
574 until the hero Meriones came close  
and wrenched  
575 the spear out of his flesh; and  
darkness covered his eyes.  
576 And Helenus struck Deïpyrus close in,  
on the temple,  
577 with a great Thracian sword, and  
sheared the helmet away;  
578 it was knocked spinning to the  
ground, and some Achaean  
579 picked it up as it rolled between the  
fighters' feet;  
580 and gloomy night came down and



covered his eyes.

581 Then grief seized Atreus' son,

Menelaus good at the war-cry,

582 and he strode out threatening against  
the hero, lord Helenus,

583 shaking his sharp spear; and Helenus  
drew back the grip of his bow.

584 So the two came on together, the one  
hot to cast

585 the sharp-pointed spear, the other the  
arrow off the string.

586 Priam's son struck him first, with the  
arrow, on the chest,

587 on the corslet's plate — and the bitter  
arrow sprang off.

588 As off a broad winnowing-shovel, on a  
great threshing-floor,

589 the dark-skinned beans or the  
chickpeas jump

590 under the shrill wind and the  
winnower's swing,  
591 so from the corslet of glorious  
Menelaus  
592 the bitter arrow glanced far off,  
turned hard away.<sup>26</sup>  
593 But Atreus' son, Menelaus good at the  
war-cry, struck  
594 the hand in which he held the  
polished bow: and into the bow  
595 the bronze spear drove, clean through  
the hand.  
596 He drew back into the band of his  
companions, dodging doom,  
597 his hand hanging slack at his side,  
dragging the ash spear.  
598 Great-hearted Agenor drew it out of  
the hand,  
599 and bound the hand itself in a sling of

twisted

600 sheep's wool, which his aide carried  
for the shepherd of the people.27

601 Then Peisander came straight at  
glorious Menelaus —

602 but an evil fate was leading him  
toward death's end:

603 toward you, Menelaus, to be broken in  
the dread combat.

604 And when they were close, advancing  
on one another,

605 Atreus' son missed his cast; the spear  
was turned aside;

606 and Peisander stabbed at the shield of  
glorious Menelaus

607 but could not drive the bronze on  
through:

608 the broad shield held it, and the spear  
snapped

609 at the socket. Yet he rejoiced in his  
heart, and hoped for victory.  
610 But Atreus' son, drawing his silver-  
studded sword,  
611 sprang at Peisander; and he, from  
under his shield, pulled out  
612 a fine axe of good bronze on a haft of  
olive-wood,  
613 long and well-polished; and in the  
same instant they reached each other.  
614 Peisander chopped at the ridge of the  
horsehair-crested helmet  
615 at its very peak, under the plume;  
Menelaus caught him coming on  
616 at the forehead, above the base of the  
nose: the bones cracked loud,  
617 and his eyes, all blood, dropped in the  
dust by his feet,  
618 and he doubled over and fell. And

setting a heel on his chest

619 Menelaus stripped his armor, and  
spoke in triumph over him:

620 “This is how you will leave the ships  
of the swift-colted Danaans —

621 you Trojans past all pride, never sated  
with the terrible war-shout —

622 nor short of any other outrage and  
disgrace,

623 like the outrage you did to me, you  
foul dogs, with never a fear

624 in your hearts for the harsh wrath of  
loud-thundering Zeus

625 of Guest-right, who one day will  
destroy your steep city.

626 You who went off — wantonly —  
carrying away my wedded wife

627 and much of my wealth, when it was  
she who had made you welcome;

628 and now you rage to hurl annihilating  
fire  
629 on the seafaring ships, and to kill the  
Achaean heroes.  
630 But you will be stopped, somewhere,  
war-hungry as you are.  
631 O father Zeus — they say you stand  
above all others  
632 in wisdom, men and gods alike; yet all  
this comes from you:  
633 what favor you are showing to men of  
violence —  
634 these Trojans, whose fury is forever  
reckless, who cannot  
635 get their fill of the din of leveling war!  
636 Of all things there is satiety — of  
sleep, of love,  
637 of sweet song and of blameless  
dancing;

638 a man would sooner pray to take his  
fill of these  
639 than of war. But the Trojans are never  
sated with battle.”28  
640 So speaking, blameless Menelaus  
stripped the bloody armor  
641 from the body and gave it to his  
companions,  
642 and went back himself again and  
mixed with the front-fighters.  
643 There the son of king Pylaemenes  
leapt out at him,  
644 Harpalion, who had followed his dear  
father to fight  
645 at Troy, and never came home again  
to his fatherland.  
646 He stabbed the middle of Atreus’ son’s  
shield with his spear,  
647 close in, but could not drive the

bronze on through,  
648 and drew back into the band of his  
companions, dodging doom,  
649 glancing on every side, lest flesh of his  
meet bronze.  
650 But Meriones, as he retreated, shot a  
bronze-tipped arrow  
651 and hit him in the right buttock; and  
the arrow  
652 passed under the bone, straight on,  
into the bladder.  
653 Sinking down on the spot, in the arms  
of his dear companions,  
654 breathing out his life, he lay stretched  
on the ground  
655 like a worm; and the dark blood ran  
out and soaked the earth.<sup>29</sup>  
656 Around him the great-hearted  
Paphlagonians busied themselves:



657 they lifted him into a chariot and  
drove him toward holy Ilion,  
658 grieving; and among them went his  
father, shedding tears;  
659 and there was no blood-price for his  
son who was dead.  
660 Now at his killing the heart of Paris  
was angered exceedingly,  
661 for he had been his guest-friend  
among the many Paphlagonians;  
662 and angered for him, he let fly a  
bronze-tipped arrow.  
663 There was one Euchenor, the son of  
the seer Polyidus,  
664 a rich man and a brave one, whose  
house was in Corinth,  
665 who had boarded his ship knowing  
well his deadly fate:  
666 for the good old man Polyidus had

told him, often,  
667 that he would waste to death of a  
grievous sickness at home,  
668 or go down under Trojan hands  
among the ships of the Achaeans;  
669 and so he shunned two things at once:  
the heavy fine  
670 of the Achaeans, and the loathsome  
sickness, that his heart might feel no  
pain.**30**  
671 Him Paris struck below the jaw, under  
the ear; and quickly the spirit  
672 went out of his limbs, and the hateful  
darkness took him.  
673 So they fought on, like blazing fire;  
674 and Hector, dear to Zeus, had not  
heard, and did not know at all  
675 that on the left of the ships his people  
were being cut down

676 by the Argives — and soon the  
triumph would have belonged  
677 to the Achaeans: such was the holder  
of the earth, the earth-shaker,  
678 driving the Argives on, and defending  
them besides with his strength.  
679 But Hector held where first he had  
leapt the gates and the wall,  
680 breaking the close-set battle-lines of  
Danaan shield-men,  
681 there where the ships of Ajax and  
Protesilaus  
682 were drawn up on the beach of the  
grey sea, and above them  
683 the wall was built at its lowest — there  
where beyond all places  
684 the men themselves and their horses  
were fiercest in the fight.  
685 There the Boeotians, and the Ionians

with their trailing tunics,<sup>31</sup>  
<sup>686</sup> the Locrians, and the Phthians, and  
the shining Epeians  
<sup>687</sup> held him off the ships as he charged  
hard, but had not strength  
<sup>688</sup> to thrust him back away from them —  
brilliant Hector like a flame —  
<sup>689</sup> the picked men of the Athenians  
among them; and their leader  
<sup>690</sup> was Menestheus, Peteos' son, and  
with him followed  
<sup>691</sup> Pheidas and Stichius and brave Bias;  
and the Epeians' leaders  
<sup>692</sup> were Meges, Phyleus' son, and  
Amphion and Dracius,  
<sup>693</sup> and before the Phthians, Medon, and  
Podarces steadfast in battle.  
<sup>694</sup> Now the one — Medon — was a  
bastard son of godlike Oïleus

695 and brother of Ajax; but he lived in  
Phylace,  
696 far from his own fatherland, having  
killed a man,  
697 a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis,  
wife of Oïleus;<sup>32</sup>  
698 and the other was a son of Iphiclus,  
Phylacus's line.  
699 These, armed in the front of the great-  
hearted Phthians,  
700 fought in defense of the ships beside  
the Boeotians;  
701 and Ajax, the swift son of Oïleus,  
would no longer  
702 stand apart from Ajax, Telamon's son  
— not by a step:  
703 but as in fallow land two wine-dark  
oxen strain  
704 at the jointed plow with one and the

same heart, and around  
705 the roots of their horns the sweat  
wells up in streams,  
706 and only the polished yoke holds the  
two apart  
707 as they drive down the furrow, and the  
plow cuts to the field's edge:  
708 so the two of them took their stand,  
shoulder to shoulder.33  
709 But the son of Telamon had troops  
with him, many and brave,  
710 companions who took his shield from  
him  
711 whenever weariness and sweat came  
over his knees;  
712 while no Locrians followed the great-  
hearted son of Oïleus:  
713 their hearts had no stomach for the  
standing fight,

714 for they had no bronze helmets, thick  
with horsehair,  
715 no round shields and no ash spears:  
716 it was trusting in their bows, and in  
the twisted wool  
717 of sheep, that they had followed him  
to Ilion; and with these,  
718 shooting thick and fast, they broke the  
Trojan battle-lines.  
719 So then: the ones in front, in their  
intricate war-gear,  
720 fought the Trojans and Hector of the  
bronze helmet,  
721 while the others shot from behind,  
unseen; and the Trojans  
722 lost all memory of the joy of battle:  
the arrows drove them into rout.<sup>34</sup>  
723 And then, in misery, back from the  
ships and the huts

724 the Trojans would have retreated to  
windy Ilion,  
725 had not Polydamas come and stood by  
daring Hector:  
726 “Hector, there is no dealing with you:  
no man’s persuasion moves you.  
727 Because a god gave you the works of  
war beyond others,  
728 you insist on knowing counsel, too,  
better than others;  
729 but you cannot possibly take all things  
to yourself at once.  
730 To one man the god has given the  
works of war,  
731 to another the dance, to another the  
lyre and song,  
732 and in another’s chest wide-seeing  
Zeus sets a mind  
733 of worth, and many men get profit of



it,

734 and it saves many, and he who has it  
knows it best of all.35

735 But I will say it as it seems to me to be  
best.

736 Everywhere around you the garland of  
war is blazing;

737 and the great-hearted Trojans, now  
they have crossed the wall,

738 are some of them standing back with  
their arms, and some fighting,

739 fewer against more, scattered along  
the ships.

740 Fall back, then, and summon all our  
best men here;

741 and then we could weigh the whole  
counsel together —

742 whether to fall on the many-benched  
ships, if the god

743 is willing to hand us the power, or  
whether after all  
744 to come away from the ships unhurt.  
For I, for one, fear  
745 the Achaeans may pay us back  
yesterday's debt in full:  
746 a man waits by the ships insatiate of  
war,  
747 and I think he will hold back from the  
fighting no longer.”  
748 So spoke Polydamas, and the prudent  
word pleased Hector,  
749 and at once he leapt with his weapons  
from the chariot to the ground,  
750 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:  
751 “Polydamas — you hold all our best  
men here,  
752 I will go over there and take my share

of the fighting,

753 and come back quickly, when I have  
given them their orders.”

754 He spoke, and set off — like a snow-  
shining mountain —36

755 screaming, and flew through the  
Trojans and the allies.

756 And they all surged toward Panthous’s  
son, gracious Polydamas,

757 when they heard the voice of Hector.

758 But he went ranging through the  
front-fighters, searching

759 for Deiphobus, and the strength of  
lord Helenus,

760 and Adamas, Asius’s son, and Asius,  
Hyrtacus’s son —

761 if he might find them anywhere. He  
found them

762 not unhurt, not unruined: some by the

sterns

763 of the Achaean ships lay dead at  
Argive hands,

764 and some were inside the wall with  
wounds from far or near.

765 But one he found quickly, on the left  
of the tearful battle:

766 brilliant Alexandros, the husband of  
lovely-haired Helen,

767 heartening his companions and  
urging them to fight.

768 Standing close, he raked him with  
shaming words:

769 “Paris — evil Paris — beauty and  
nothing more, woman-mad, seducer:37

770 where is Deiphobus, and the strength  
of lord Helenus,

771 and Adamas, Asius’s son, and Asius,  
Hyrtacus’s son?

772 And where is Othryoneus? Now all of  
steep Ilion  
773 is ruined, top to bottom. Now your  
own sheer destruction is sure.”  
774 Then godlike Alexandros answered  
him:  
775 “Hector — since your heart is set on  
blaming the blameless,  
776 some other day, perhaps, I may hang  
back from the fighting;  
777 but not now: my mother did not bear  
me wholly a coward.  
778 From the moment you woke the battle  
of our companions at the ships,  
779 from then we have stood our ground  
here, engaging the Danaans  
780 without respite. The companions you  
ask after are dead —  
781 except Deiphobus and the strength of

lord Helenus:

782 those two have gone off, each  
wounded in the hand

783 by long spears; the son of Cronos kept  
death from them.

784 Now lead on, wherever your heart and  
spirit command,

785 and we will follow you, and gladly; nor  
do I think

786 you will find us short of courage, so  
far as the strength is in us.

787 Beyond his strength no man can fight,  
however hot he burns.”

788 So speaking the hero turned his  
brother’s mind.

789 They set off for where the battle and  
struggle burned thickest,

790 around Cebriones, and blameless  
Polydamas,

791 and Phalces, and Orthaeus, and  
godlike Polyphetes,  
792 and Palmys, and Ascanius and Morys,  
sons of Hippotion,  
793 who had come in relief out of deep-  
soiled Ascania  
794 the dawn before; and now Zeus drove  
them to fight.  
795 And they came on like a squall of  
punishing winds  
796 that under the thunder of father Zeus  
drives at the plain  
797 and with a prodigious roar meets the  
sea, and the countless  
798 seething waves of the loud-roaring  
water  
799 arch up, white-crested, some in front,  
and others behind them:  
800 so the Trojans, closed up, some in

front, and others behind them,  
801 glittering in bronze, came on behind  
their leaders.  
802 And Hector led them, the equal of  
Ares bane of mortals,  
803 Priam's son; before him he held his  
shield, balanced every way,  
804 thick with hides, with heavy bronze  
hammered over it,  
805 and about his temples the shining  
helmet shook.  
806 Everywhere he probed the battle-  
lines, advancing,  
807 trying whether they might give before  
him as he came under shield-cover;  
808 but he could not confound the heart  
in the Achaeans' chests.  
809 And Ajax, striding long, was first to  
challenge him:



810 “Possessed one — come closer! Why  
try to frighten Argives  
811 with mere noise? We are not  
unschooled in battle;  
812 it is the evil whip of Zeus that has  
broken us Achaeans.  
813 I suppose your heart hopes to strip the  
ships clean —  
814 well, we too have hands, quick hands,  
to hold them.  
815 Long before that, mark me, your own  
well-peopled city  
816 will be taken under our hands, and  
sacked.  
817 And for you yourself, I say the hour is  
near when, running,  
818 you will pray to father Zeus and the  
other immortals  
819 to make your fair-maned horses

swifter than falcons

820 as they carry you to the city, raising  
the dust of the plain.”

821 And as he spoke, a bird flew by on the  
right hand,

822 an eagle, flying high; and the Achaean  
army shouted at it,

823 heartened by the sign. But glorious  
Hector answered:

824 “Ajax, you blundering ox of a braggart  
— what a thing to say!

825 I wish I were as surely, all my days, the  
son

826 of aegis-bearing Zeus, and the lady  
Hera had borne me,

827 and I were honored as Athena and  
Apollo are honored,

828 as surely as this day now brings evil to  
the Argives —

829 all of them; and you will be killed  
among them, if you dare  
830 stand against my long spear, which  
will tear open  
831 your lily-soft skin; and you will glut  
the dogs and birds of Troy<sup>38</sup>  
832 with your fat and your flesh, fallen  
beside the ships of the Achaeans.”  
833 So speaking he led the way, and they  
followed him  
834 with a prodigious roar, and the army  
screamed behind him.  
835 And the Argives on the other side  
raised their cry, and did not forget  
836 their courage, but stood fast against  
the best of the Trojans coming on;  
837 and the clamor of both reached the  
ether and the radiance of Zeus.<sup>39</sup>

# Notes

## NOTES

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### NOTES

1. (13.1-9) Zeus, sure of his arrangements, turns his shining eyes away from the war — north, to the horse-herding Thracians, the close-fighting Mysians, and then clean off the map of the war: the Hippemolgoi, “Mare-milkers who drink the milk,” and the Abioi, “most righteous of men.” The lines are the most famous ethnographic glance in Homer — steppe pastoralists (later identified with Scythians; Ammianus Marcellinus was still quoting the verse in the fourth century AD) whose remoteness from the war is precisely their righteousness. Zeus rests his eyes on the people who own least and quarrel least — and his inattention is the hinge of the plot: no god, he thinks, will dare (7-9). One will. ↩
2. (13.17-22) Poseidon’s descent: “the tall hills trembled, and the timber, under the immortal feet of Poseidon as he went. Three strides he made, and with the

fourth he reached his goal.” Longinus quotes the passage in *On the Sublime* (9.8) as an instance of the divine measured by cosmic stride. Aegae, his golden house under the water, was paired with Helice at 8.203; Samothrace (“Thracian Samos”), the north-Aegean peak, really does command a sight-line over Imbros to the Troad — the poet’s geography of watching is checkable, and correct. ↩

3. (13.23-31) The ride: gold horses, gold whip, gold armor — and then the great verse of the animal world’s homage: “the sea-beasts gamboled beneath him, coming from every hollow, and did not fail to know their lord; and the sea in its joy stood apart.” The wave makes way; the axle stays dry. After eleven books of the sea as grey backdrop for grief, one god’s commute turns it joyful — the *Iliad*’s single moment of happy nature. ↩

4. (13.66-75) The lesser Ajax detects the god from the way he moves: “the trace of his feet and legs from behind, as he went off, I knew it easily — the gods are easy to know” (ἀρίγνωτοι δὲ θεοί περ). Divine disguise deceives the face-to-face view only; gait betrays godhead. The other symptom is inward: both

Ajaxes' hands and feet go "hungry" for battle — possession described from inside the possessed. ↩

5. (13.95-124) Poseidon's rebuke, pivoting on the poem's political nerve: even if Agamemnon is "wholly to blame... because he dishonored the swift-footed son of Peleus, we, for our part, have no leave to slacken" — and then the great clause: "let us heal it, quickly. The minds of good men can be healed" (ἄκεσταί τοι φρένες ἐσθλῶν, 115). The god concedes the grievance and dissolves its authority in nine words — the whole ethics of the quarrel-plot, and the sentence Achilles will not hear until Book 19. ↩
6. (13.126-135) The locked phalanx: "buckler pressed on buckler, helmet on helmet, man on man, and the horsehair crests on the bright ridges touched as they nodded." The lines (131-133) recur at 16.215-217 when the Myrmidons form up — reuse this English there. Whatever the date of hoplite tactics, this is the sensation of close order: equipment touching equipment before any enemy is met. ↩
7. (13.136-146) Hector as the boulder: torn loose by a river in flood, bounding, the woods crashing beneath it — "until it reaches the level plain, and there it rolls no more, for all its rush." The simile carries its

own prophecy: the stone's momentum is the cliff's gift, not the stone's, and the plain is waiting. Hector jams against the close-set lines within five lines of it.



8. (13.170-205) Imbrius, the son-in-law from Pedaeum who came back to Troy when the war began and was honored by Priam “like his own children” — another of the poem’s in-law obituaries (cf. Iphidamas, Othryoneus, Alcatous: Troy’s defense is a web of marriages). He falls like an ash on a mountain crest cut down by bronze. Then the book’s most brutal image: the lesser Ajax cuts the head from the corpse “in wrath for Amphinomachos” and bowls it through the crowd “like a ball,” to stop in the dust at Hector’s feet. Wrath answered with sport: the small Ajax’s savagery is a fixed trait (cf. 23.473-498, and his end in the *Odyssey*), and the head at Hector’s feet is a delivery with an address on it. ↩

9. (13.206-209) Amphinomachos was Cteatus’s son — a grandson of the Moliones pair whom Poseidon fathered and once rescued from Nestor (11.750-752). So the god’s rage here is family grief: the *Iliad*’s gods enter its casualty-lists two generations removed, and

Poseidon's next intervention (note [25]) is likewise a grandfather's grudge. ↩

10. (13.232-238) Poseidon-as-Thoas: on the day's deserter, "may he be sport for dogs"; then the recruiting proverb — "Even sorry men, combined, come to some courage — and the two of us would know how to fight even the best." The arithmetic of the wall (12.412) again: courage as a sum, spoken by a god enlisting one tired middle-aged king. ↩
11. (13.249) "Meriones, Molus's son": Molus received the boar's- tusk helmet in its pedigree (10.269-270) — the same household's war-gear economy continues here, an entire scene about where spears come from. Idomeneus and Meriones bicker with perfect courtesy — the older man teasing, the younger standing on his record — before the god-stirred battle lets either spend it. ↩
12. (13.260-294) The armory speech: twenty Trojan spears against the bright wall of the hut, "which I strip from the men I kill," because Idomeneus does "not fight standing far from enemy men." Then the great set-piece (275-286): the ambush as the assay of worth — the coward's color running, his crouch shifting from foot to foot, the heart hammering on



the ribs, the teeth chattering aloud; the brave man's color "never changes," and his one prayer is to be mixed in the fighting at once. It is the poem's fullest psychology of fear, set not in the charge but in the waiting — and given to the oldest front-fighter in the army. ↩

13. (13.291) "the front-fighters' trysting-place" — ὀαριστύς, the word for lovers' intimate talk (cf. 22.127-128, where Hector uses it of a boy and girl whispering), applied to the range where chests meet spears. The battlefield as terrible intimacy: one of the boldest single words in the Iliad. ↩
14. (13.298-305) Ares and Panic (Phobos, his son, the capitalized personification of 4.440) arming out of Thrace against the Ephyri or Phlegyes — gods who "do not hear both sides' prayers, but hand the glory to one." War-god theology in miniature; and an uneasy simile to hang on Idomeneus and Meriones, since Ares at this hour is penned on Olympus, deaf to everything — not even hearing of his own son's death (note [24]). ↩
15. (13.339-344) The battle "bristled" (ἔφριξεν) with flesh-cutting spears — the field itself gets gooseflesh; eyes are blinded by bronze glare. Then

the narrator's aside: "It would be a hard-hearted man who could rejoice at the sight of that toil, and not be grieved." As at 12.176 and 4.539-542, the poem turns to check the audience's pleasure — the singer measuring the distance between glory sung and toil seen. ↩

16. (13.345-360) The theological knot of the middle Iliad: Zeus wills Trojan victory (to glorify Thetis and her son), yet not Achaean annihilation; Poseidon works the other side "in secret... likened to a man" — because "both were of one stock and one parentage, but Zeus was elder-born, and he knew more." Primogeniture as cosmology (restated by force in 15.165-167, and contested at 15.185-199). And so the two sons of Cronos "knotted the cord of strong strife and leveling war, and drew it taut over both sides — a cord unbreakable, not to be untied; and it unstrung the knees of many": the tug-of-war image of battle (cf. 7.102, 11.336) tied to its grimmest clause — the knot the gods cannot break is loosed instead in men's knees. Aristarchus athetized 350 (the Thetis line) as needless; the printed text keeps it. ↩
17. (13.363-382) Othryoneus, war-bridegroom: he bid for Cassandra — her first appearance in the poem,

“loveliest of Priam’s daughters,” with no word of prophecy, which is post-Homeric — “without bride-gifts,” offering instead the war itself as bride-price. Idomeneus kills him mid-stride and conducts the poem’s cruelest wedding-negotiation over the body: we’ll give you Agamemnon’s loveliest daughter “if you will join us and sack the well-peopled city of Ilion. Come along: let us settle the marriage at the seafaring ships — you will find we are not hard men over bride-terms.” The marriage-economics of death (Iphidamas, 11.241-245) turned entirely to mockery: the dead man dragged by the foot toward his “wedding.” ↩

18. (13.389-393) Asius falls “as an oak falls, or a white poplar, or a towering pine, that carpenters up in the mountains cut down with fresh-whetted axes to be a ship’s timber” — paying the death-notice filed at 12.116-117, killed by the very man it named. The simile recurs verbatim at 16.482-484 for Sarpedon — reuse this English there. Man as felled timber “to be a ship’s timber”: the war’s dead as material for the very machines that brought the war. ↩

19. (13.402-416) Deiphobus’s vaunt for Hypsenor: Asius shall not lie unavenged — “even going down to

Hades, the strong closer of the gate, he will be glad at heart: I have given him an escort for the road.” The dead man as travel-arrangement; the poem’s bookkeeping of vengeance (ποινή) spoken as courtesy. (In fact Hypsenor’s death-wound is described and mourned — but the poet never says he died; ancient critics worried the point.) ↩

20. (13.424-444) Alcaethous: the poem’s most terrible intervention. Poseidon “charmed his shining eyes and shackled his glorious limbs” — the god holds the man still, “like a grave-pillar or a tree in high leaf,” while Idomeneus spears him through the chest. The bridegroom-obituary again (Hippodameia, who outshone her age-mates “in beauty and in handiwork and in wit”); the grave-stele simile stands the man’s own monument up in advance; and the heart, still beating, shakes the butt-end of the spear — the most clinically horrifying detail in the poem. A god fighting for the Achaeans does this: the poem does not flinch, and does not comment. ↩

21. (13.446-454) Idomeneus’s ledger (“three for one”) and pedigree: Zeus - Minos “warden of Crete” - Deucalion - Idomeneus. The Cretan king’s genealogy is the shortest distance in the poem between Zeus and a

living fighter — three generations — and he ends it flatly: the ships have carried me here, “an evil to you, and your father, and the rest of the Trojans.” ↩

22. (13.459-461) Aeneas found sulking, “rearmost of the crowd, for he was forever furious at brilliant Priam, because, brave among men as he was, Priam gave him no honor.” The Achilles-pattern in Trojan miniature: worth unhonored by the king, service withheld. The grievance (never elsewhere explained) belongs to the junior branch of the royal house — cf. 20.178-183, where Achilles taunts him with hoping to inherit Priam’s rank, and 20.302-308, where Poseidon prophesies that his line, not Priam’s, will rule the Trojans hereafter. ↩

23. (13.489-495) Aeneas’s men follow “as flocks follow the bell-ram down from the pasture to drink — and the shepherd’s heart is glad”: war-following rendered as the tamest scene the poem knows, with the commander’s joy set inside the shepherd’s. The gentlest simile in a savage book. ↩

24. (13.518-525) Deiphobus’s cast kills Ascalaphus, “son of Enyalios” (Ares’ son by the Catalogue, 2.512) — “but loud-roaring massive Ares knew nothing of it yet... he sat on the peak of Olympus, under the golden

clouds, penned there by the designs of Zeus.” A father’s ignorance held in suspension across two books: at 15.110-142 Ares learns, arms for revenge against Zeus’s edict, and must be forced down by Athena. The quiet lines here are the fuse. ↩

25. (13.554-575) Poseidon shields Antilochus (Nestor’s son — the god’s affection for the house of Neleus again) and makes Adamas’s spear-point “strengthless... grudging him that life.” Adamas dies under Meriones’ throw “between the genitals and the navel — there where the war-god comes most grievous to wretched mortals” — the poem’s plainest statement about wounds and pain — writhing “as a bull writhes that herdsmen in the mountains have bound with willow-ropes and drag along unwilling.” The pastoral world keeps arriving as the measure of agony. ↩
26. (13.586-592) Helenus’s arrow springs off Menelaus’s corslet “as off a broad winnowing-shovel, on a great threshing-floor, the dark-skinned beans or the chickpeas jump under the shrill wind and the winnower’s swing.” Harvest again — the missile as chaff-work; the deadly and the domestic in one bounce. The duel itself is asymmetric: spear against bow, and the spear pins the bow-hand to the bow. ↩

27. (13.598-600) The wounded hand is bound “in a sling of twisted sheep’s wool” — the σφενδόνη, the Iliad’s only named sling, here as bandage; at 716 the same twisted wool arms the Locrians as a weapon. One humble implement, both uses, thirty lines apart: the poem’s quartermaster memory at work. ↩
28. (13.620-639) Menelaus over Peisander (killed in the poem’s one axe-against-sword exchange, his eyes dropped bloody in the dust): the wronged husband’s theology. The Trojans are indicted under “the harsh wrath of loud-thundering Zeus of Guest-right” (Ζηνὸς ξεινίου... μῆνιν — the poem’s theme-word “wrath” given to Zeus as protector of hospitality, the war’s whole legal basis in one phrase); then the strange, wonderful complaint: “Of all things there is satiety — of sleep, of love, of sweet song and of blameless dancing; a man would sooner pray to take his fill of these than of war. But the Trojans are never sated with battle.” The catalogue of things men can have enough of is the poem’s shyest confession of what peace is for. Ancient critics athetized here (637); readers have loved the passage in exact proportion. ↩

29. (13.643-659) Harpalion dies “like a worm... stretched on the ground” — the poem’s smallest death-simile, for a boy who followed his father to war. And then the famous impossibility: “among them went his father, shedding tears” — his father is Pylaemenes, killed by Menelaus at 5.576-579 in our own text.

Ancient critics athetized 658-659 to heal the contradiction; moderns treat it as the clearest seam of oral composition — the poet reaching for the pathos-formula (a father behind a bier) without an audit of Book 5. The translation keeps the printed text and the wound. The closing line — “and there was no blood-price for his son who was dead” — prices the loss in the currency the poem uses everywhere (cf. 9.632-636, 18.498). ↩

30. (13.663-672) Euchenor of Corinth, the seer’s son, who sailed “knowing well his deadly fate”: his father had told him he would die of sickness at home or under Trojan hands at the ships. He chose the spear — “and so he shunned two things at once: the heavy fine of the Achaeans, and the loathsome sickness.” The precise double of Achilles’ two fates (9.410- 416) at commoner’s scale — and with the poem’s driest touch, the war-death is also a tax dodge: the θωή, the fine levied on draft-evaders, listed in one breath



with mortal disease. He is killed by Paris, absent-mindedly, in someone else's revenge. ↩

31. (13.685-700) The defense roster: Boeotians, Locrians, Phthians, Epeians, picked Athenians — and “the Ionians with their trailing tunics” (ἰάονες ἐλκεχίτωνες), the name's only occurrence in Homer, applied to Athenian-led troops: a single audible seam between the poem's world and the poet's own Ionian one. ↩
32. (13.694-697) Medon, bastard son of Oïleus, exiled from his fatherland “having killed a man, a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis”: the homicide-exile is epic's standard hard-luck biography (cf. Patroclus, 23.85-88). These four lines recur verbatim at 15.333-336, where Medon dies — the poem files a man's whole story twice, once at his post and once at his death. Reuse this English there. ↩
33. (13.701-708) The two Ajaxes as “two wine-dark oxen” (βόε οἴνορε — the sea's own color-word given to plow-beasts) straining at one plow, sweat welling at the roots of their horns, the polished yoke alone holding them apart: the poem's great image of joint labor — heroic partnership rendered as agriculture, down the furrow to the field's edge. ↩

34. (13.712-722) The Locrian way of war: no helmets, no shields, no ash spears — bows and wool slings, shooting “from behind, unseen,” while the armored line fights in front. Combined arms, and the breaking of the Trojan rush credited to the missile troops the heroic code barely deigns to see (cf. 11.385-390): the poem knows exactly what wins battles, and says so here without editorializing. ↩
35. (13.726-747) Polydamas’s third counsel — accepted, like the first: the famous division of gifts. “To one man the god has given the works of war, to another the dance, to another the lyre and song, and in another’s chest wide-seeing Zeus sets a mind of worth... But you cannot possibly take all things to yourself at once.” (Line 731 — dance and song — was omitted by Aristarchus; Zenodotus kept it, Lucian quoted it, and the printed text prints it.) The tactical advice — regroup, count heads, decide — carries a shadow-clause: “a man waits by the ships insatiate of war,” the book’s only reference to Achilles as a standing threat, from the man who is always right. ↩
36. (13.754) Hector sets off “like a snow-shining mountain” — ὄρεϊ νιφόεντι ἐοικώς: a man like a

mountain, and a moving one; ancient and modern readers have puzzled at it (a mass of glittering bronze? a peak walking?). It is the largest thing Hector is ever compared to, on the day his rush crests. ↩

37. (13.769) “Paris — evil Paris — beauty and nothing more, woman-mad, seducer”: Hector’s rebuke repeats 3.39 word for word, our English kept. There it opened the poem’s first duel, here its last day of Trojan victory — and Paris’s answer this time is measured, brave, and just (“your heart is set on blaming the blameless” — the very phrase Patroclus used of Achilles, 11.654), ending on the proverb “Beyond his strength no man can fight, however hot he burns.” The poem allows Paris his best moment exactly where Hector repeats his worst line. ↩

38. (13.809-832) The exchange before the charge: Ajax’s taunt promises Hector a prayer for horses “swifter than falcons,” and the eagle confirms it on the right; Hector’s reply is the strangest oath-wish in the poem — “I wish I were as surely, all my days, the son of aegis-bearing Zeus... as this day is bringing evil on the Argives”: certainty of today traded against an impossible divinity, from the man who cannot know

his warrant expires at sundown. His threat gives Ajax “lily- soft skin” (χρόα λειριόεντα) — the flower-word for the flesh of the enemy’s biggest man; and “you blundering ox of a braggart” (βουγάϊε) is one of the poem’s rare pure insults, coarse as a barnyard. ↩

39. (13.837) The last line: “and the clamor of both reached the ether and the radiance of Zeus.” The book that began with Zeus turning his shining eyes away ends with the battle arriving at him as sound — αἰθέρα καὶ Διὸς αὐγὰς, the noise climbing into the very brightness he looked away with. The ring closes: he will look back down at 15.4, and the correction will be immediate and total. ↩

# Book 14

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*The Deception of Zeus: Hera borrows the girdle of Aphrodite, buys Sleep with a Grace, and Zeus sleeps on Gargaron while the sea-god turns the battle.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 But the war-cry did not escape Nestor,  
drinking though he was:1
- 2 he spoke winged words to Asclepius'  
son:
- 3 "Consider, brilliant Machaon, how these  
things will go:
- 4 the cry of the strong young men is  
louder by the ships.
- 5 You sit here now and drink the fire-

bright wine

6 until lovely-braided Hecamede has  
heated

7 a warm bath, and washed away the  
clotted blood;

8 I will go out to a lookout point and  
quickly learn the truth.”

9 So speaking he took up the well-made  
shield of his son,

10 horse-taming Thrasymedes, that lay in  
the hut

11 all glittering with bronze — the son had  
his father’s shield —

12 and took up a stout spear, edged with  
sharp bronze,

13 and stood outside the hut, and at once  
saw ugly work:

14 his own men being driven, and the  
high-hearted Trojans

15 hounding them from behind; and the  
Achaean's wall was down.

16 As when the great open sea darkens  
with soundless swell,<sup>2</sup>

17 boding the quick paths of the shrill  
winds —

18 only boding: it neither rolls forward  
nor to either side,

19 until some deciding blast comes down  
from Zeus:

20 so the old man weighed it, his heart  
torn two ways —

21 to go into the crowd of the swift-colted  
Danaans,

22 or after Atreus' son Agamemnon,  
shepherd of the people.

23 And as he weighed it, this seemed to  
him the better course:

24 to go to Atreus' son. Meanwhile the

others went on killing  
25 one another as they fought; and the  
unwearying bronze rang  
26 about their bodies, stabbed with  
swords and double-curved spears.  
27 And the Zeus-nurtured kings fell in  
with Nestor,  
28 coming up from the ships — all who  
had been hit by the bronze,  
29 Tydeus' son, and Odysseus, and Atreus'  
son Agamemnon.<sup>3</sup>  
30 For their ships were drawn up far away  
from the fighting  
31 on the beach of the grey sea: those had  
been hauled first,  
32 up toward the plain, and the wall was  
built by the sterns.  
33 For the beach, wide as it was, could not  
hold all



34 the ships, and the armies were  
cramped for room;  
35 so they had drawn them up in tiers,  
and filled the whole  
36 long mouth of the shore, all the  
headlands penned between.  
37 So the kings, wanting to see the battle  
and the war-cry,  
38 came up together leaning on their  
spears; and the heart  
39 in each man's chest was grieved. And  
the old man met them,  
40 Nestor — and the heart in the  
Achaean's chests went cold.  
41 And the lord Agamemnon called to him  
and spoke:  
42 “Nestor, Neleus' son, great glory of the  
Achaean,  
43 why have you left the man-destroying

war and come here?

44 I fear massive Hector may make good  
the word he spoke

45 when he threatened us once,  
haranguing the Trojans:

46 that he would not go back from the  
ships to Ilion

47 until he had burned the ships with fire  
and killed the men.

48 So that man talked; and now it is all  
coming to pass.

49 Shame! — surely the other strong-  
greaved Achaeans too

50 are storing anger against me in their  
hearts, like Achilles,

51 and have no will to fight by the sterns  
of the ships.”

52 Then answered him the Gerenian  
horseman Nestor:

53 “Yes — all this stands accomplished  
before us, and not even  
54 Zeus who thunders on high could build  
it otherwise now.  
55 For the wall is down — the wall we  
trusted  
56 to be an unbreakable shield for the  
ships and for ourselves;  
57 and the enemy at the swift ships keep  
up their relentless  
58 battle without pause. You could no  
longer tell, however hard  
59 you studied it, from which side the  
Achaeans are being driven:  
60 so mixed is the killing; and the clamor  
goes up to heaven.  
61 Let us take thought how these things  
will go —  
62 if thought can do anything. But I do

not counsel

63 that we enter the fighting: a wounded  
man cannot fight.”

64 Then the lord of men Agamemnon  
answered him:

65 “Nestor — since they are fighting by  
the sterns of the ships,

66 and the built wall was no use, nor the  
ditch,

67 though the Danaans suffered so much  
for it, and hoped in their hearts

68 it would be an unbreakable shield for  
the ships and for ourselves —

69 Such, it seems, must be the pleasure of  
overmastering Zeus:

70 that the Achaeans perish here,  
nameless, far from Argos.

71 I knew it when he defended the  
Danaans with a will,

72 and I know it now, when he glorifies  
our enemies  
73 like the blessed gods, and has bound  
our fury and our hands.  
74 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:  
75 the ships that are drawn up nearest the  
sea —  
76 let us drag them down and haul them  
all to the bright water,  
77 and moor them riding high at anchor-  
stones, until  
78 the deathless night comes — if even by  
night the Trojans  
79 will hold off from war; and then we  
might haul down every ship.  
80 There is no shame in fleeing ruin, not  
even by night.  
81 Better a man who flees and escapes the  
evil than one who is caught.”

82 Glaring at him darkly, resourceful  
Odysseus answered:  
83 “Son of Atreus — what a word has  
escaped the fence of your teeth!<sup>4</sup>  
84 Ruinous man! I wish you commanded  
some other army,  
85 a shabby one — not that you were lord  
over us, for whom Zeus  
86 has given it, from youth right down to  
old age,  
87 to wind the skein of hard wars, till we  
perish every one.  
88 Is this how you long to leave the wide-  
wayed city  
89 of the Trojans, for which we have  
suffered so much misery?  
90 Silence! — before some other Achaean  
hears this word,  
91 which no man should so much as bring

through his mouth,  
92 no man whose heart knows how to  
speak what is fitting,  
93 no sceptered king whom armies obey  
—  
94 armies as many as the Argives you rule.  
95 This time I scorn your judgment  
outright — such a thing to say!  
96 You tell us, with the war standing  
joined and the shouting up,  
97 to haul the well-benched ships to the  
sea, so that the Trojans  
98 can have still more of their prayers,  
winning as they already are,  
99 and sheer destruction tip its beam onto  
us. For the Achaeans  
100 will not hold their battle while the  
ships are dragged seaward:  
101 they will look back over their

shoulders and drop out of the fighting.

102 Then, marshal of the people, your  
counsel will have wrecked us.”

103 Then the lord of men Agamemnon  
answered him:

104 “Odysseus — you have caught me  
hard, straight to the heart,

105 with that grim rebuke. I do not order  
the sons of the Achaeans

106 to haul the well-benched ships to the  
sea against their will.

107 Now let there be a man with better  
counsel than mine —

108 young or old — and I would welcome  
him gladly.”

109 And among them spoke Diomedes,  
good at the war-cry:

110 “The man is here — we need not  
search for long — if you are willing



111 to listen, and each of you does not  
bristle with resentment  
112 because by birth I am the youngest  
among you.  
113 I too claim my descent from a noble  
father,  
114 Tydeus, whom the heaped earth  
covers now at Thebes.<sup>5</sup>  
115 For to Porthus three blameless sons  
were born,  
116 and they lived in Pleuron and steep  
Calydon:  
117 Agrius, and Melas, and the third was  
the horseman Oeneus,  
118 my father's father — in valor the best  
of them.  
119 Oeneus stayed there; but my father  
settled at Argos,  
120 a wanderer: so, I suppose, Zeus and

the other gods willed it.

121 He married a daughter of Adrastus,  
and lived in a house

122 rich in substance: he had wheat-  
bearing fields enough,

123 and many orchards of trees stood  
round about,

124 and he had flocks in plenty; and he  
surpassed all the Achaeans

125 with the spear. You will have heard all  
this — that it is true.

126 So you cannot say my stock is base and  
cowardly

127 and dishonor the word I speak, if I  
speak it well.

128 Come: let us go to the battle, wounded  
as we are. We must.

129 There, let us hold ourselves out of the  
combat,

130 beyond spear-cast, lest anyone take  
wound upon wound;  
131 but the others we will drive in and  
send to it — those who before,  
132 indulging their tempers, have stood  
apart and would not fight.”  
133 So he spoke; and they heard him well,  
and obeyed,  
134 and set off; and the lord of men  
Agamemnon led them.  
135 But the famed earth-shaker kept no  
blind man’s watch:  
136 he came after them in the likeness of  
an old man, 6  
137 and took the right hand of  
Agamemnon, Atreus’ son,  
138 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:  
139 “Son of Atreus — now, I think, Achilles’

ruinous heart

140 is rejoicing in his chest, watching the  
slaughter

141 and the rout of the Achaeans; for there  
is no sense in him, none.

142 Well — let him perish just so; may a  
god strike him lame.

143 But with you the blessed gods are not  
yet wholly angry:

144 the day is coming, I think, when the  
leaders and lords of the Trojans

145 will raise the dust of the wide plain,  
and you yourself will watch them

146 running for the city, away from the  
ships and the huts.”

147 So speaking he gave a great shout, and  
swept off across the plain.

148 as loud as nine thousand men, or ten  
thousand,

149 cry out in war when they join the  
strife of the war-god,  
150 so great was the voice the lord earth-  
shaker sent  
151 out of his chest; and into each  
Achaean's heart he threw  
152 great strength, to war and fight  
without ceasing.<sup>7</sup>  
153 Now Hera of the golden throne looked  
out and saw them,  
154 standing on her peak of Olympus; and  
at once she knew  
155 her own brother — her husband's  
brother too — bustling  
156 through the battle where men win  
glory, and her heart was glad;  
157 and she saw Zeus, seated on the  
topmost peak  
158 of Ida of the many springs, and he was

hateful to her heart.

159 Then ox-eyed lady Hera fell to  
pondering

160 how she might trick the mind of aegis-  
bearing Zeus;<sup>8</sup>

161 and this to her mind seemed the best  
counsel:

162 to array herself with care and go to  
Ida —

163 in hope that he might desire to lie in  
love

164 against her body, and she might pour a  
sleep, harmless and warm,

165 over his eyelids and over his close  
counsels.

166 She went to her chamber, which her  
dear son Hephaestus

167 had built her, fitting the close doors to  
their posts

168 with a secret bolt no other god could  
open.

169 There she went in, and closed the  
shining doors.

170 With ambrosia first she washed from  
her desirable body

171 every stain, and anointed herself with  
rich oil,

172 ambrosial, soft, and scented for her  
especially:

173 if it were so much as stirred in the  
bronze-floored house of Zeus,

174 its breath reached earth and heaven  
alike.

175 With this she anointed her fair body,  
and combed her hair,

176 and with her own hands plaited the  
shining braids,

177 beautiful, ambrosial, streaming from

her immortal head.

178 And she put on the ambrosial robe  
that Athena

179 had smoothed and worked for her, and  
set with many figures,

180 and pinned it across her breast with  
brooches of gold.

181 She belted it with a girdle hung with a  
hundred tassels,

182 and in her pierced earlobes she hung  
the earrings,

183 three-dropped, mulberry-dark; and  
great grace shone from her.

184 And over all, brilliant among  
goddesses, she veiled herself

185 in a headdress lovely and new, white  
as the sun,

186 and beneath her shining feet she  
bound fair sandals.9



187 And when she had set all this  
adornment about her body,  
188 she went from the chamber, and  
calling Aphrodite  
189 apart from the other gods she spoke  
her word:  
190 “Would you do something for me, dear  
child, if I ask it?  
191 Or will you refuse me, holding it  
against me in your heart  
192 that I defend the Danaans, and you the  
Trojans?”  
193 Then Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus,  
answered her:  
194 “Hera, eldest goddess, daughter of  
great Cronos,  
195 say what is in your mind. My heart  
bids me do it,  
196 if do it I can — if it is a thing that can

be done.”

197 And with guile in her heart the lady  
Hera answered:

198 “Give me now love, and desire — the  
power with which

199 you master all the immortals, and  
mortal men.

200 For I am going to the ends of the  
generous earth, to see

201 Oceanus, the begetting of the gods,  
and mother Tethys,

202 who reared me well in their own halls  
and cherished me,

203 taking me from Rhea, when wide-  
seeing Zeus put Cronos

204 down beneath the earth and the  
barren sea.

205 I go to see them, and to loose their  
endless quarrel:

206 for a long time now they have held  
apart from one another,  
207 from bed and from love, since anger  
fell upon their hearts.  
208 If with words I could persuade those  
two dear hearts,  
209 and bring them back to their bed, to  
be joined in love,  
210 forever I would be called dear to them,  
and revered.”  
211 Then laughter-loving Aphrodite  
answered her:  
212 “It cannot be, and it would not be  
right, to refuse your word:  
213 you sleep in the arms of Zeus, and  
Zeus is highest.”  
214 She spoke, and loosed from her breast  
the pierced band,  
215 embroidered, where all her

enchantments lie worked:

216 in it is love, in it desire, in it the  
trysting-talk —

217 persuasion, that steals the wits even of  
the close-thinkers.10

218 She put it in her hands, and spoke a  
word, and named her:

219 “There: take this band and put it away  
in the fold

220 of your breast — embroidered:  
everything is worked into it. And I tell you

221 you will not come back  
unaccomplished, whatever your heart  
intends.”

222 So she spoke; and ox-eyed lady Hera  
smiled,

223 and smiling put it away in the fold of  
her breast.

224 Then Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus,

went to the house,  
225 and Hera in one spring left the peak of  
Olympus,  
226 and touching down on Pieria and  
lovely Emathia<sup>11</sup>  
227 swept over the snowy mountains of  
the horse-herding  
228 Thracians, over their topmost  
summits, nor grazed the ground with her  
feet;  
229 from Athos she stepped out over the  
heaving sea  
230 and came to Lemnos, city of godlike  
Thoas.  
231 There she met Sleep, the brother of  
Death,<sup>12</sup>  
232 and clung to his hand, and spoke a  
word, and named him:  
233 “Sleep, lord of all gods and of all men

—

234 as once before you heard my word, so  
now again

235 obey me; and I will owe you thanks all  
my days.

236 Put Zeus's shining eyes to sleep for me  
beneath his brows,

237 the moment I have lain beside him in  
love.

238 And I will give you gifts: a fair throne,  
imperishable forever,

239 golden, which my own son  
Hephaestus the crook-footed

240 will make with all his craft; and under  
it he will set a footstool

241 where you can rest your shining feet  
at the feast."

242 And answering her spoke sweet Sleep:

243 "Hera, eldest goddess, daughter of

great Cronos,  
244 any other of the gods, the everlasting-born,  
245 I would easily put under — even the streams of the river  
246 Oceanus, who is the begetting of them all;  
247 but Zeus, the son of Cronos — I would not come near him,  
248 much less put him to sleep, unless he himself commanded.  
249 For once before now a command of yours taught me my lesson,  
250 the day when that high-hearted son of Zeus  
251 sailed from Ilion, having sacked the Trojans' city.  
252 I laid the mind of aegis-bearing Zeus asleep,

253 poured sweet about him; and you  
devised evils in your heart,  
254 rousing the blasts of punishing winds  
over the sea,  
255 and carried Heracles away to well-  
peopled Cos,  
256 far from all his friends. And Zeus,  
waking, was furious,  
257 hurling gods this way and that  
through the house; and me above all  
258 he hunted, and would have flung me  
from the sky into the sea, gone forever,  
259 had Night not saved me — Night,  
subduer of gods and men.  
260 To her I came running; and he  
checked himself, for all his anger:  
261 he stood in awe of doing what swift  
Night would hate.  
262 And now you ask me to do this other



impossible thing.”

263 Then ox-eyed lady Hera answered  
him:

264 “Sleep, why do you brood on such  
things in your heart?

265 Do you think wide-seeing Zeus will  
rage for the Trojans

266 as he raged that time over Heracles,  
his own son?

267 Come — I will give you one of the  
younger Graces:

268 marry her, and let her be called your  
wife.”

*[Line 269 is absent from the printed text; see note 13.]*

270 So she spoke; and Sleep was delighted,  
and answered her:13

271 “Swear to me now by the inviolable  
water of Styx —

272 lay one hand on the earth that feeds  
so many,  
273 and the other on the shining sea, so  
that all may be  
274 witnesses between us, the gods below  
with Cronos —  
275 that you will truly give me one of the  
younger Graces:  
276 Pasithea, whom I myself have longed  
for all my days.”  
277 So he spoke, and the goddess white-  
armed Hera did not refuse:  
278 she swore as he commanded, and  
named all the gods  
279 under Tartarus, who are called the  
Titans.  
280 And when she had sworn and brought  
the oath to completion,  
281 the two of them left the towns of

Lemnos and Imbros,  
282 clothed in mist, and made their road  
swiftly.  
283 They came to Ida of the many springs,  
mother of wild things,  
284 to Lecton, where they first left the  
sea; and over dry land  
285 they went, and the treetops shook  
beneath their feet.  
286 There Sleep halted, before the eyes of  
Zeus could see him,  
287 climbing into a towering fir, the tallest  
288 then grown on Ida, that reached  
through the mist to the upper air.  
289 There he perched, hidden close in the  
fir boughs,  
290 in the likeness of the clear-voiced  
mountain bird  
291 the gods call chalkis, and men call

kymindis.**14**

**292** But Hera went quickly on up to  
Gargaron peak

**293** on lofty Ida; and Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer saw her.

**294** And the moment he saw her, desire  
wrapped his close mind round,

**295** as on the day they first mingled in  
love,

**296** going to the bed again and again  
behind their dear parents' backs.**15**

**297** He stood before her, and spoke a word,  
and named her:

**298** "Hera — where are you rushing, that  
you come down from Olympus

**299** like this — with no horses near, no  
chariot to mount?"

**300** And with guile in her heart the lady  
Hera answered:

301 “I am going to the ends of the  
generous earth, to see  
302 Oceanus, the begetting of the gods,  
and mother Tethys,  
303 who reared me well in their own halls  
and cherished me;  
304 I go to see them, and to loose their  
endless quarrel:  
305 for a long time now they have held  
apart from one another,  
306 from bed and from love, since anger  
fell upon their hearts.  
307 My horses stand at the foot of Ida of  
the many springs,  
308 ready to carry me over dry land and  
water both.  
309 It is on your account I have come  
down from Olympus now —  
310 so that you would not be angry with

me afterward, if I went

311 in silence to the house of deep-flowing  
Oceanus.”

312 Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-  
gatherer:

313 “Hera — you can set out for there later  
just as well.

314 Come, let the two of us go to bed, and  
turn to love.

315 For never has desire for goddess or for  
woman

316 so flooded and mastered the heart  
inside my chest —

317 not when I loved Ixion’s wife, 16

318 who bore Peirithous, the equal of the  
gods in counsel;

319 nor Danaë of the lovely ankles,  
Acrisius’ daughter,

320 who bore Perseus, most admired of all

men;

321 nor the daughter of far-famed  
Phoenix,

322 who bore me Minos and godlike  
Rhadamanthys;

323 nor Semele, nor Alcmene in Thebes —  
324 and she bore Heracles, my strong-  
hearted son,

325 while Semele bore Dionysus, a joy to  
mortals;

326 nor when I loved the lady Demeter of  
the lovely braids,

327 nor glorious Leto — no, nor you  
yourself:

328 none as I love you now, and sweet  
desire takes hold of me.”

329 And with guile in her heart the lady  
Hera answered:

330 “Most dread son of Cronos, what a

word you have spoken!**17**

**331** If now you long to lie down in love

**332** on the peaks of Ida, where everything  
stands open to view —

**333** how would it be if some one of the  
everlasting gods

**334** saw us asleep, and going among all the  
gods

**335** told them? I could not rise from that  
bed and simply

**336** walk home to your house; it would be  
a scandal.

**337** But if you will — if that is truly your  
heart's pleasure —

**338** you have a chamber, which your dear  
son Hephaestus

**339** built you, fitting the close doors to  
their posts:

**340** let us go and lie there, since the bed is



your desire.”

341 Answering her spoke Zeus the cloud-gatherer:

342 “Hera, have no fear that any god or man

343 will see: such a cloud will I wrap around us,

344 a golden one. Not even Helios could spy us through it,

345 and his light is the sharpest sight there is.”

346 He spoke, and the son of Cronos caught his wife in his arms;

347 and beneath them the bright earth put out fresh grass,

348 and dewy lotus, and crocus, and hyacinth,

349 thick and soft, that held them up off the ground.

350 In that they lay together, and drew  
over them a cloud,  
351 fair and golden; and glittering dew-  
drops fell away from it.**18**  
352 So the father slept, unmoving, on  
Gargaron peak,  
353 broken by sleep and love, his wife in  
his arms;  
354 and sweet Sleep set off at a run for the  
ships of the Achaeans  
355 to bring the word to the holder of the  
earth, the earth-shaker.  
356 Standing close, he spoke winged  
words to him:  
357 “Now, Poseidon, help the Danaans  
with a will,**19**  
358 and hand them the glory — at least a  
little while, while Zeus  
359 still sleeps; for I have wrapped him in

a soft daze,

360 and Hera has tricked him into bed,  
into love.”

361 So speaking he went off toward the  
famed tribes of men;

362 and Poseidon, stirred still more to  
defend the Danaans,

363 sprang far out among the foremost at  
once, and called:

364 “Argives! Are we to concede the  
victory again to Hector,

365 Priam’s son — let him take the ships  
and win the glory?

366 That is his own claim and his boast,  
because Achilles

367 sits by the hollow ships with anger in  
his heart.

368 But Achilles will not be missed so very  
much

369 if the rest of us rouse ourselves to  
defend each other.

370 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:  
371 let us dress ourselves in the biggest  
and best shields  
372 in the army, and hide our heads in  
helmets  
373 blazing all over, and take the longest  
spears in our hands,  
374 and go. And I will lead; and I say  
Hector, Priam's son,  
375 will not stand us, however hot he  
burns.

376 And whatever staunch fighter has a  
small shield at his shoulder,  
377 let him give it to a worse man, and get  
into a bigger.”<sup>20</sup>  
378 So he spoke; and they heard him well,  
and obeyed.

379 And the kings themselves, wounded as  
they were, marshaled them —  
380 Tydeus' son, and Odysseus, and  
Atreus' son Agamemnon —  
381 and going down the whole line they  
made the exchange of war-gear:  
382 the good man got into good armor,  
and gave the worse to the worse.  
383 And when they had clothed their  
bodies in the flashing bronze  
384 they set out; and Poseidon the earth-  
shaker led them,  
385 holding in his heavy hand a terrible  
thin-edged sword  
386 like a lightning-flash — a thing no  
man may meet  
387 in the grim combat: dread holds men  
back from it.**21**  
388 And on the other side glorious Hector

marshaled the Trojans.

389 Then it was that they stretched the  
most terrible strife of war,

390 blue-maned Poseidon and glorious  
Hector,

391 one defending the Trojans, the other  
the Argives;

392 and the sea washed up to the huts and  
ships

393 of the Argives, and the armies met  
with a great war-shout.

394 Not so loud does the sea's wave roar  
against the land,22

395 driven up out of open water by the  
hard North Wind;

396 not so loud the bellow of blazing fire

397 in mountain glens, when it rises to  
burn the timber;

398 not so loud the wind through the

high-crowned oaks —  
399 the wind at its loudest, when its rage  
is up and roaring —  
400 as the voice of Trojans and Achaeans  
then,  
401 crying terror, when they sprang upon  
each other.  
402 At Ajax first glorious Hector cast  
403 his spear, as Ajax stood turned full  
toward him, and did not miss:  
404 he hit where the two straps lay  
stretched across the chest,  
405 one for the shield, one for the silver-  
studded sword;  
406 the two of them saved the soft flesh.  
And Hector was angered  
407 that his swift missile had flown from  
his hand in vain,  
408 and drew back into the band of his

companions, dodging doom.

409 But as he went back, great Telamonian  
Ajax

410 took up a stone — one of the many  
that rolled there

411 under the fighters' feet, props for the  
swift ships —

412 and struck his chest, over the shield-  
rim, close to the neck,

413 and set him spinning like a top with  
the blow: he reeled full circle.23

414 As when an oak goes down under the  
stroke of father Zeus,

415 torn out by the roots, and the terrible  
smell of sulphur

416 rises off it, and courage fails whoever  
sees it

417 from close by — for hard is the bolt of  
great Zeus:



418 so Hector's fury dropped in an instant  
to the dust.

419 His hand let go the spear, and shield  
and helmet

420 crumpled down on him, and his  
armor, intricate with bronze, clashed  
about him.

421 With a great shout the sons of the  
Achaeans ran in,

422 hoping to drag him off, and hurled  
their spears

423 thick and fast; but no one could  
wound the shepherd of the people

424 with thrust or throw: before that, the  
best men ringed him round —

425 Polydamas, and Aeneas, and brilliant  
Agenor,

426 and Sarpedon, leader of the Lycians,  
and blameless Glaucus;

427 and of the rest not one neglected him,  
but they held  
428 their round shields before him. And  
his companions  
429 lifted him in their arms and carried  
him out of the toil,  
430 until they reached his swift horses,  
which stood behind  
431 the battle and the fighting with their  
charioteer and the intricate chariot;  
432 these carried him toward the city,  
groaning heavily.  
433 But when they came to the ford of the  
fair-flowing river, 24  
434 eddying Xanthus, whom immortal  
Zeus begot,  
435 there they laid him from the chariot  
onto the ground, and poured  
436 water over him; and he got his breath,

and looked up with his eyes,  
437 and sitting on his knees he vomited  
dark blood;  
438 then sank back again to the ground,  
and both his eyes  
439 were covered in black night: the blow  
still broke his spirit.  
440 And the Argives, when they saw  
Hector going off,  
441 leapt at the Trojans all the harder, and  
remembered their war-craft.  
442 There first of all the swift Ajax, Oïleus'  
son,  
443 sprang in and wounded Satnius with  
his sharp-pointed spear —  
444 Enops's son, whom the blameless  
naiad nymph bore  
445 to Enops as he herded by the banks of  
Satnioeis.25

446 Oïleus' spear-famed son came close  
and stabbed him

447 in the flank; he tumbled backward,  
and around him

448 Trojans and Danaans joined the  
strong encounter.

449 Polydamas the spear-shaker came to  
avenge him,

450 Panthous's son, and hit Prothoenor,  
Areïlycus's son,

451 in the right shoulder; through the  
shoulder the massive spear

452 drove; and falling in the dust he  
clutched the earth in his palm.

453 And Polydamas vaunted terribly over  
him, crying far:

454 "There — again! From the massive  
hand of the great-hearted

455 son of Panthous the javelin did not

leap in vain:

456 one of the Argives caught it in his  
flesh; and I think

457 he will lean on it for a staff as he walks  
down into Hades.”<sup>26</sup>

458 So he spoke, and grief came over the  
Argives at his vaunting,

459 and most of all he stirred the heart of  
war-minded Ajax,

460 Telamon’s son — for the man fell  
closest to him.

461 Quickly he cast at the other with his  
shining spear as he drew back.

462 Polydamas himself escaped black  
doom,

463 springing aside; but Antenor’s son  
Archelochus

464 caught it — for the gods had  
counseled his destruction.

465 It struck him where head and neck  
join,  
466 at the topmost bone of the spine, and  
sheared both tendons through;  
467 and his head and mouth and nostrils  
hit the ground  
468 long before his shins and knees, as he  
fell.<sup>27</sup>  
469 And Ajax in his turn called out to  
blameless Polydamas:  
470 “Think it over, Polydamas, and tell me  
truly:  
471 is this man not a worthy exchange for  
Prothoenor  
472 dead? He seems to me no base man, of  
no base line:  
473 a brother of horse-taming Antenor,  
474 or a son — the family look sits close  
upon him.”

475 He spoke knowing it well; and grief  
seized the Trojans' hearts.

476 Then Acamas, standing over his  
brother, wounded with the spear

477 Promachus the Boeotian, who was  
hauling the body by the feet.

478 And Acamas vaunted terribly over  
him, crying far:

479 "Argives — arrow-braggarts — never  
sated with threats!**28**

480 Not for us alone, I promise you, the  
toil

481 and the misery: you too will be killed  
like this, in your turn.

482 Look how your Promachus sleeps,  
beaten down

483 by my spear — so my brother's blood-  
price should not go

484 long unpaid. That is why a man prays

for a kinsman

485 left in his halls: to ward off ruin for  
him.”

486 So he spoke, and grief came over the  
Argives at his vaunting,

487 and most of all he stirred the heart of  
war-minded Peneleos.

488 He went for Acamas; and Acamas did  
not stand the charge

489 of lord Peneleos; and Peneleos  
wounded Ilioneus,

490 son of Phorbas rich in flocks, whom  
Hermes loved

491 beyond all the Trojans, and gave him  
wealth;

492 and to him his mother had borne one  
only son, Ilioneus.

493 Him he stabbed beneath the brow, at  
the roots of the eye,



494 and pushed the eyeball out; straight  
through the eye  
495 and through the nape the spear drove,  
and he sank down,  
496 stretching out both his hands. And  
Peneleos, drawing  
497 his sharp sword, hewed through the  
middle of the neck, and struck  
498 to the ground head and helmet  
together; and the massive spear  
499 still stood in the eye; and holding it up  
like a poppy-head<sup>29</sup>  
500 he displayed it to the Trojans, and  
spoke in triumph:  
501 “Trojans — take a message for me to  
the dear father  
502 and the mother of illustrious Ilioneus:  
let them wail in their halls.  
503 For neither will the wife of

Promachus, Alegenor's son,  
504 rejoice to meet her dear husband  
coming home, that day  
505 when we young men of the Achaeans  
sail back from Troy.”  
506 So he spoke; and trembling took the  
limbs of every one of them,30  
507 and each man looked about him for  
escape from sheer destruction.  
508 Tell me now, Muses, who keep your  
homes on Olympus —31  
509 who was first of the Achaeans to lift  
the bloody spoils  
510 of men, once the famed earth-shaker  
had tilted the battle?  
511 Ajax first, Telamon's son, wounded  
Hyrtius,  
512 Gyrtius' son, leader of the strong-  
hearted Mysians;

513 and Antilochus stripped the life from  
Phalces and Mermerus;

514 and Meriones killed Morys and  
Hippotion,

515 and Teucer brought down Prothoon  
and Periphetes;

516 and Atreus' son next wounded  
Hyperenor, shepherd of the people,

517 in the flank, and the bronze drank his  
bowels through,

518 tearing in; and his soul through the  
stabbed wound

519 came hurrying out, and darkness  
covered his eyes.

520 But the most were killed by the swift  
Ajax, Oïleus' son:

521 for there was no one like him for  
speed of foot in the chase

522 when men broke and ran, when Zeus  
drove the panic in them.32

## Notes

### NOTES

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#### NOTES

1. (14.1-8) The book opens on the smallest possible hinge: Nestor, still in the hut of Book 11, hears the noise change pitch — “drinking though he was” — sets down the cup, borrows his son’s shield (the son has his father’s: the family’s gear swapped down the generations), and steps outside into the catastrophe. Machaon is left with the wine and the promised bath: the wounded man’s war is a warm tub. ↩
2. (14.16-22) The old man’s indecision as ground-swell: the open sea darkening “with soundless swell, boding the quick paths of the shrill winds — only boding: it neither rolls forward nor to either side, until some deciding blast comes down from Zeus.” Deliberation rendered as weather that has not

chosen; among the subtlest interior similes in the poem — the mind as sea before the decision that will move it, and the decision, as always, filed under Zeus. ↩

3. (14.27-40) The council of the wounded: Diomedes, Odysseus, Agamemnon, “leaning on their spears,” come up merely to watch — the poem’s commanders reduced to spectators with walking-sticks. The parenthesis on the camp’s terraced ship-rows (30-36) is the Iliad’s clearest picture of its own stage-set: the beach too small for the fleet, the ships in tiers filling “the whole long mouth of the shore.” ↩

4. (14.82-102) Agamemnon’s third flight-proposal (cf. 2.139, 9.26) — this time under fire, ships to be dragged seaward mid-battle — meets the poem’s fiercest rebuke, reusing 4.349-350 verbatim: “what a word has escaped the fence of your teeth!” Odysseus’s indictment is total: the wish for “some other army, a shabby one”; the credo of the war-generation (“for whom Zeus has given it, from youth right down to old age, to wind the skein of hard wars, till we perish every one” — war as spun wool, the life-thread and the war-thread one); the flat imperative “Silence!” (σίγα); and the tactical point

that settles it — armies do not fight while their transport is leaving. Agamemnon's answer is the best thing he does in the poem: "you have caught me hard... Now let there be a man with better counsel than mine — young or old — and I would welcome him gladly." ↩

5. (14.109-132) Diomedes claims the floor by genealogy — Portheus, Agrius, Melas, Oeneus; Tydeus the wanderer who married Adrastus's daughter and lies "under the heaped earth at Thebes" — the poem's fullest version of his family tree, deployed for the right to advise elders. The advice itself is modest and correct: go down, stay out of range, and shame the shirkers in. The youngest speaks last and best (cf. 9.31-49). ↩

6. (14.135-152) Poseidon as anonymous old man, taking Agamemnon by the right hand: the gesture of pledge. His curse on Achilles — "let him perish just so; may a god strike him lame" — is the harshest thing said of Achilles in the poem, and it is said by a god fighting for Achilles' own side. (Zenodotus's text added a line making the disguise Phoenix — tidier and much less interesting.) Then the shout of "nine thousand men, or ten thousand": divine

encouragement measured in decibels, repeating the strength-verse used of Strife at 11.11-12. ↩

7. (14.148-152) See above — the shout-lines close with the same formula that opened Book 11's Strife-scene: the gods' rallying voices are interchangeable parts, and the poem knows it. ↩
8. (14.153-165) The plan, stated with the poem's usual candor about Hera: she saw her brother-in-law working "and her heart was glad"; she saw her husband "and he was hateful to her heart." The deception is her own invention from desire's raw materials: body, sleep, and the borrowed girdle. The Dios Apatē is the one stretch of the Iliad where the plot of Zeus is successfully counter-plotted — by his wife, with comedy's weapons. ↩
9. (14.166-186) The toilette is built exactly like an arming scene — the sequence of items (wash, anoint, robe, girdle, earrings, veil, sandals) laid out with the same formulaic machinery as greaves-corslet-sword-shield-helmet-spear (cf. 3.330-338), ending in the same clause that ends armings. Hera arms for bed. Every item has its maker or provenance (the chamber and bolt by Hephaestus, the robe worked by Athena) — divine materiel, like Agamemnon's

corslet or Achilles' spear. The scent of the oil reaching earth and heaven; the veil "white as the sun"; the earrings "three-dropped, mulberry-dark": the poem's richest inventory of female adornment.



10. (14.187-223) The lie to Aphrodite runs on real cosmology: Oceanus "the begetting of the gods" and mother Tethys — an alternative theogony in which the world-river, not Cronos or Zeus, is origin (Sleep repeats it at 246: "the begetting of them all"; ancient readers from Plato and Crates on treated these lines as Homer's cosmological fragment). The *kestos himas* — the "pierced, embroidered band" — carries the poem's finest abstraction-list: "in it is love, in it desire, in it the trysting-talk — persuasion, that steals the wits even of the close-thinkers" (ὀαριστύς again — the intimacy-word the poem put on the front line at 13.291; here in its home register). Aristotle quotes the couplet in the *Nicomachean Ethics* (1149b) on the coercive power of desire. Aphrodite's consent-line — "you sleep in the arms of Zeus, and Zeus is highest" (213) — was *athetized* in antiquity; it is also, dramatically, the girdle working before it is even lent: persuasion stealing the wits of the goddess of persuasion. ↩



11. (14.225-230) The flight-path: Olympus - Pieria - Emathia - the Thracian snow-mountains - Athos - Lemnos, feet never touching ground. Divine travel in the Iliad is always mapped (cf. 13.20-33): the geography is real and sequential, a northern-Aegean arc drawn at a goddess's speed. ↩
12. (14.231-262) Sleep, "brother of Death" (the pairing returns with terrible weight at 16.672, carrying Sarpedon home). His refusal recalls the poem's deepest backstory: after Heracles sacked Troy, Hera used Sleep against Zeus and blew the hero to Cos; Zeus woke "hurling gods this way and that through the house," and Sleep survived only by running to Night, "subduer of gods and men" — "he checked himself: he stood in awe of doing what swift Night would hate." The one being before whom Zeus restrains himself is primordial darkness; the theology is older than Olympus, glimpsed once, through a frightened minor god's memory. Note too the escalation of fees: golden throne and footstool (furniture, the standard divine honorarium) refused; a Grace accepted — Sleep bargains like a craftsman who knows his labor's worth. ↩

13. (14.267-276) Our printed Greek lacks line 269 —  
“Pasithea, for whom you long always, all your days”  
— the naming of the offered Grace inside Hera’s  
speech; the line stands in only part of the  
manuscript tradition (an addition in several copies,  
as the apparatus records), and the numbering here  
jumps 268 to 270. Nothing is lost but an anticipation:  
Sleep himself names Pasithea at 276, with the  
longing-clause intact. This is the third genuine  
transmission-gap this translation reproduces (9.458-  
461; 11.543). The oath Sleep demands is the great  
one: by Styx, one hand on the earth, one on the  
shining sea, “so that all may be witnesses between  
us, the gods below with Cronos” — the defeated  
elder gods, “under Tartarus, who are called the  
Titans” (279), summoned as notaries: the old world-  
order exists, in the *Iliad*, to witness contracts. ↩
14. (14.283-291) Landfall at Lecton, “and the treetops  
shook beneath their feet”; then Sleep in the tallest  
fir on Ida, “in the likeness of the clear-voiced  
mountain bird the gods call chalkis, and men call  
kymindis.” The double-name motif  
(Briareus/Aegaeon 1.403, Batieia/Myrine 2.813) —  
the universe bilingual, and the poet claiming the  
gods’ dictionary — here attached to a real bird (likely

a hawk-owl) waiting in a tree to watch a seduction.



15. (14.292-296) Zeus sees her, “and the moment he saw her, desire wrapped his close mind round, as on the day they first mingled in love, going to the bed again and again behind their dear parents’ backs.” The marriage’s beginning as adolescent secrecy — brother and sister evading Cronos and Rhea — is the poem’s one glimpse of the primal domestic scene, and it makes the seduction work: what Hera has staged is his memory of their youth. ↩
16. (14.313-328) The Leporello-catalogue: seven loves — Ixion’s wife (mother of Peirithous), Danaë (Perseus), Europa the daughter of Phoenix (Minos and Rhadamanthys), Semele (Dionysus, “a joy to mortals” — his only Iliadic mention as Zeus’s son), Alcmena (Heracles), Demeter, Leto — each with issue noted, ending “no, nor you yourself: none as I love you now.” As courtship, an itemized list of adulteries addressed to one’s wife is catastrophically tactless; as enchantment- symptom it is exact — the girdle’s power made audible as babble. Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized all twelve lines as unseemly;

antiquity laughed and kept them; so does the printed text. ↩

17. (14.330-340) Hera's answer opens with the register's fixed outrage-line ("Most dread son of Cronos, what a word you have spoken!" = 1.552) — deployed now in mock-modesty: what if some god saw us and told? The counter-offer (Hephaestus's chamber with the secret bolt) is a trap avoided by Zeus's own escalation: the golden cloud. ↩

18. (14.346-353) The hieros gamos: "beneath them the bright earth put out fresh grass, and dewy lotus, and crocus, and hyacinth, thick and soft, that held them up off the ground." Earth flowering under the union of Sky-god and his queen — a fossil of fertility-religion set blooming in the middle of the war-poem; the golden cloud rains glittering dew. Then the plainest possible clause: "So the father slept." The plot of the Iliad from 8.473 onward hangs suspended inside a nap. ↩

19. (14.354-360) Sleep reports to Poseidon in person — "I have wrapped him in a soft daze" — divine conspiracy with courier service. The alliance of Sleep and the sea-god frees the battle for exactly one Achaean surge, on borrowed time. ↩

20. (14.364-382) Poseidon's tactical speech, with its remarkable order: swap armor by capability — “whatever staunch fighter has a small shield at his shoulder, let him give it to a worse man, and get into a bigger... the good man got into good armor, and gave the worse to the worse.” Ancient critics athetized (376-377); soldiers will recognize the first recorded redistribution of kit by fighting value, ordered by a god and executed by three wounded kings. ↩
21. (14.384-387) Poseidon leads with “a terrible thin-edged sword like a lightning-flash — a thing no man may meet in the grim combat: dread holds men back from it.” The god's blade is not said to kill anyone: its work is categorical, a boundary (θέμις) — mortals simply may not engage it. ↩
22. (14.389-401) The triple negative simile: not the sea's wave under the North Wind, not fire in the mountain glens, not the wind in the high oaks roars so loud as the two armies' voice. The poem's own sound-engineering: three natural crescendos stacked and overtopped — and all three (wave, fire, wind) are the similes this battle has been using for its charges, now outshouted by the real thing. ↩

23. (14.402-420) The duel of the day: Hector's spear defeated by the crossing-point of two straps — the war of equipment again — and Ajax's answer with one of the ship-props: the stone "set him spinning like a top." Then the great oak simile: struck by the bolt of Zeus, torn out by the roots, "and the terrible smell of sulphur rises off it, and courage fails whoever sees it from close by." The lightning-smell is the most sensorily exact divine detail in the poem — and its theology cuts: Hector, whose whole warrant is Zeus's bolt, falls like a tree struck by it, while Zeus sleeps. ↩
24. (14.433-439) The retreat to "the ford of the fair-flowing river, eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot" — the line- pair that will open Book 21, laid down here; the river-god's paternity registered in passing. Hector's revival is clinical concussion: water poured over him, breath recovered, "sitting on his knees he vomited dark blood," relapse, "black night" again. He is out of the poem until 15.239 — and it takes Apollo, on Zeus's woken orders, to put him back. ↩
25. (14.442-448) Satnius, son of Enops and "the blameless naiad nymph" who bore him "as Enops herded by

the banks of Satnioeis”: a river-bank begetting, a boy named for the river, killed in the mud of a different one. The smallest pastoral obituary in the poem. ↩

26. (14.449-457) Polydamas’s vaunt: the spear in Prothoenor’s shoulder becomes “a staff... as he walks down into Hades” — death as an old man’s stroll, cane provided by the killer. The counselor’s wit is colder than the warriors’. The vaunt- chain that follows (458 = 486: “grief came over the Argives / Trojans at his vaunting”) is built as strict alternation — grief answering grief, kill for kill, four boasts in sequence: the poem’s mechanics of escalation laid bare. ↩

27. (14.463-474) Archelochus, taking the spear meant for Polydamas “for the gods had counseled his destruction”: struck at the join of head and neck, “and his head and mouth and nostrils hit the ground long before his shins and knees.” Ajax’s forensic vaunt — no base man, “a brother of horse- taming Antenor, or a son — the family look sits close upon him” — identifies the corpse by resemblance: kinship legible in a dead face, the poem’s grimmest use of family likeness. ↩

28. (14.476-485) Acamas over Promachus: “arrow-braggarts” for the Argives; then the blood-price logic said straight — “so my brother’s blood-price (ποινή) should not go long unpaid. That is why a man prays for a kinsman left in his halls: to ward off ruin for him.” The economy of vengeance (cf. 13.659, where Harpalion’s death has no ποινή) stated as household prudence: brothers are insurance. ↩
29. (14.489-505) Ilioneus: only son of Hermes-loved, flock-rich Phorbas — the eye put out at its roots, the spear through eye and nape, the head severed and lifted, spear and all, “like a poppy-head” (κώδεια, the seed-capsule). At 8.306-308 a dying boy’s head drooped “as a poppy in a garden... heavy with seed and the rains of spring”; here the poppy returns as a thing brandished. Peneleos completes it with the poem’s cruelest message home: tell his father and mother “to wail in their halls” — and Promachus’s wife will not rejoice either, when the young men sail home. The taunt’s real addressees are the two houses where the news will arrive; the Iliad’s wars are always fought, at last, in the rooms of the parents and the wives. ↩



30. (14.506-507) After the poppy-head, no answering vaunt: “trembling took the limbs of every one of them, and each man looked about him for escape.” The chain of reciprocal boasts (note [26]) ends because one image exceeded the genre. Even this poem’s warriors have a limit, and Peneleos found it. ↩
31. (14.508-510) The fixed Muse-invocation (= 2.484, 11.218) for the rout’s tally — “who was first of the Achaeans to lift the bloody spoils of men” (ἀνδράγρια, “man-spoils,” a word that occurs nowhere else): full epic formality summoned for a plunder-list, as the tide turns on Poseidon’s tilt. ↩
32. (14.511-522) The tally: Hyrtius, Phalces, Mermerus, Morys, Hippotion, Prothoon, Periphetes — and Hyperenor, whose death at Menelaus’s hands is recalled with strange precision at 17.24-28 (there with an insult-backstory the narrative here lacks; the poem’s ledgers do not always reconcile). The last word goes to the lesser Ajax: “there was no one like him for speed of foot in the chase when men broke and ran” — the book’s closing epitaph is for a sprinter of the pursuit, the specialist of the broken field: the Deception of Zeus ends with the poem’s

ugliest hero doing the one thing he does best, to  
men who can no longer fight back. ↩

# Book 15

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*Zeus wakes: the plan of the whole poem is spoken aloud, Apollo kicks down the wall like a child's sand, and Hector's hand closes on the stern of Protesilaus's ship.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 But when in their flight they had  
crossed the stakes and the ditch,
- 2 and many were broken under Danaan  
hands,
- 3 they halted and held their ground  
beside the chariots,
- 4 green with fear, panic-driven. And Zeus  
woke
- 5 on the peaks of Ida beside Hera of the

golden throne,  
6 and started up, and stood, and saw  
Trojans and Achaeans —  
7 the ones being driven, the others  
driving them on  
8 from behind, the Argives, and among  
them lord Poseidon;  
9 and he saw Hector lying on the plain,  
his companions  
10 sitting around him, and he laboring for  
breath, his wits astray,  
11 vomiting blood — for not the feeblest of  
the Achaeans had hit him.<sup>1</sup>  
12 Seeing him, the father of men and gods  
felt pity,  
13 and glaring darkly, terribly, he spoke  
his word to Hera:  
14 “Past all handling, Hera — this evil  
craft, this trick of yours

- 15 has stopped brilliant Hector from the  
fight, and routed his army.
- 16 I wonder whether you may not be the  
first to reap the fruit
- 17 of your grievous plot-weaving, when I  
flog you with lashes.
- 18 Do you not remember hanging from on  
high, when from your feet<sup>2</sup>
- 19 I slung two anvils, and threw about  
your wrists a band
- 20 of gold, unbreakable? In the clear air  
and the clouds
- 21 you hung; and the gods raged up and  
down high Olympus
- 22 but could not come and free you:  
whomever I caught
- 23 I seized and hurled from the threshold,  
till he struck
- 24 the earth with little life in him. Even so

my heart would not  
25 let go its relentless pain for godlike  
Heracles,  
26 whom you, suborning the storm-blasts  
with the North Wind's help,  
27 sent driving over the barren sea,  
plotting evils,  
28 and carried away at last to well-  
peopled Cos.  
29 I rescued him from there, and brought  
him back again  
30 to horse-pasturing Argos, after all his  
labors.  
31 I remind you of this so you will drop  
your deceits — so you will see  
32 whether the love-making helps you,  
and the bed  
33 you came from among the gods and lay  
in, and tricked me.”

34 So he spoke; and ox-eyed lady Hera  
shuddered,  
35 and speaking winged words she  
addressed him:  
36 “Let Earth be my witness now, and  
wide Heaven above,<sup>3</sup>  
37 and the down-flowing water of Styx —  
the greatest oath  
38 and the most terrible for the blessed  
gods —  
39 and your own sacred head, and the bed  
of the two of us,  
40 our bridal bed — a thing I would never  
swear by falsely:  
41 it is not by any will of mine that  
Poseidon the earth-shaker  
42 harms the Trojans and Hector and  
gives help to the others.  
43 It is his own heart, I suppose, that

drives and commands him:

44 he saw the Achaeans worn down at the  
ships and pitied them.

45 Why — I would as soon give him my  
counsel

46 to walk the road you lead us, lord of the  
dark cloud.”

47 So she spoke; and the father of men  
and gods smiled,

48 and answering her he spoke winged  
words:

49 “If from now on, then, ox-eyed lady  
Hera,

50 you would sit among the immortals  
thinking with my mind,

51 Poseidon, however much his will runs  
otherwise,

52 would soon enough bend his thought  
to your heart and mine.



53 But if you are speaking truly now, and  
without evasion,  
54 go to the tribes of the gods, and call for  
me  
55 Iris to come here, and Apollo famed for  
the bow:  
56 she to go to the army of bronze-shirted  
Achaeans<sup>4</sup>  
57 and tell lord Poseidon to leave the war  
58 and come to his own house; and  
Phoebus Apollo  
59 to rouse Hector into the fighting and  
breathe fury into him  
60 again, and make him forget the pains  
that now  
61 wear down his wits; and to turn the  
Achaeans back  
62 again, driving strengthless panic into  
them,

63 till in their flight they fall among the  
many-benched ships  
64 of Achilles, Peleus' son. And he will  
send out his companion  
65 Patroclus; and glorious Hector will kill  
him with the spear  
66 before Ilion, after he has cut down  
many strong young men —  
67 and among them my own son, brilliant  
Sarpedon.  
68 And in anger for him brilliant Achilles  
will kill Hector.  
69 From that hour on I will make the tide  
run back  
70 from the ships, steadily, without pause,  
until the Achaeans  
71 take steep Ilion through the counsels of  
Athena.  
72 Before that I do not cease my anger,

and no other

73 immortal will I allow to defend the  
Danaans here,

74 not before the desire of Peleus' son is  
accomplished

75 as I promised him at the first, and  
bowed my head to it,

76 on the day the goddess Thetis clasped  
my knees,

77 begging me to honor Achilles, sacker of  
cities."

78 So he spoke, and the goddess white-  
armed Hera did not disobey,

79 and went from the mountains of Ida to  
high Olympus.

80 As when the mind of a man darts, who  
has traveled<sup>5</sup>

81 over much country, and thinks in his  
quick wits

82 “would I were here, or there,” and  
wishes himself many places,  
83 so swiftly, straining, flew the lady Hera;  
84 and she came to steep Olympus, and  
found the immortal gods  
85 assembled in the house of Zeus. And  
when they saw her  
86 they all sprang up and pledged her  
with their cups.  
87 The others she let be; but from fair-  
cheeked Themis  
88 she took the cup, for Themis came  
running first to meet her,  
89 and speaking winged words addressed  
her:  
90 “Hera, why have you come? You look  
like one struck senseless.  
91 Cronos’s son has frightened you badly  
— your own husband.”

92 Then answered her the goddess white-  
armed Hera:

93 “Do not ask me that, goddess Themis.  
You yourself know

94 what kind of heart is his — how  
arrogant, how unbending.

95 Lead the gods to the fair-shared feast  
in the house,

96 and you will hear with all the  
immortals together

97 what evil works Zeus is announcing. I  
do not think

98 every heart will be pleased alike,  
mortal or god,

99 however cheerfully some may be  
feasting still.”

100 So the lady Hera spoke, and took her  
seat;

101 and the gods were troubled through

the house of Zeus. And she laughed  
102 with her lips; but the forehead above  
her dark brows  
103 did not warm; and she spoke among  
them all, vexed:6  
104 “Fools — who rage against Zeus with  
no more sense than children!  
105 Do we still mean to march up close  
and stop him,  
106 by word or by force? He sits apart and  
takes no thought,  
107 no notice; for he says that among the  
immortal gods  
108 in power and might he is beyond  
dispute the first.  
109 So — swallow whatever evil he sends  
each one of you.  
110 Already now, I think, calamity is built  
for Ares:

111 his son has perished in the fighting —  
the dearest of men to him —  
112 Ascalaphus, whom massive Ares calls  
his own.”  
113 So she spoke; and Ares struck his  
sturdy thighs  
114 with his flat hands, and cried out in  
grief:  
115 “Do not blame me now, you who keep  
the halls of Olympus,<sup>7</sup>  
116 if I go down to the ships of the  
Achaeans to avenge  
117 the killing of my son — even if my fate  
is to be struck  
118 by Zeus’s bolt, and lie with the corpses  
in the blood and the dust.”  
119 So he spoke, and ordered Terror and  
Panic to yoke  
120 his horses; and he himself got into his

blazing armor.

121 And then a greater and more grievous  
anger and wrath

122 would have been wrought by Zeus  
against the immortals,

123 had not Athena, in terror for all the  
gods,

124 sprung through the doorway, leaving  
the chair where she sat.

125 She tore the helmet from his head, the  
shield from his shoulders,

126 and took the bronze spear out of his  
heavy hand

127 and set it up; and she lashed rushing  
Ares with words:

128 “Madman! Wits gone — you are  
destroyed! So you do have ears

129 for hearing — but your mind is  
perished, and your shame.



130 Do you not hear what the goddess  
white-armed Hera says,  
131 come straight now from Olympian  
Zeus?  
132 Or do you want to fill your own cup of  
evils and come back  
133 to Olympus by compulsion, grieving as  
you go,  
134 and plant a great calamity for all the  
rest of us?  
135 For he will leave the high-hearted  
Trojans and the Achaeans  
136 on the instant, and come to Olympus  
to set us tumbling,  
137 and he will seize us each in turn, guilty  
or not.  
138 So drop your anger now for your son.  
Better men  
139 than he by strength of hands have

been killed before this,  
140 or will be killed hereafter. It is a hard  
thing  
141 to rescue the line and offspring of  
every man.”  
142 So speaking she seated rushing Ares  
on his chair.  
143 And Hera called Apollo outside the  
house,  
144 and Iris, who runs messages for the  
immortal gods,  
145 and speaking winged words she  
addressed them:  
146 “Zeus commands you both to come to  
Ida with all speed;  
147 and when you have come, and looked  
on the face of Zeus,  
148 do whatever he urges and commands.”  
149 So speaking the lady Hera went back

in

150 and sat on her chair; and the two  
sprang up and flew.

151 They came to Ida of the many springs,  
mother of wild things,

152 and found the wide-seeing son of  
Cronos seated on Gargaron

153 peak; and a fragrant cloud was  
wreathed about him.

154 The two of them came before Zeus the  
cloud-gatherer

155 and stood; and seeing them his heart  
was not angered,

156 because they had obeyed his dear  
wife's words so quickly.

157 To Iris first he spoke winged words:

158 "Up, go, swift Iris; to lord Poseidon

159 carry all this word, and be no false  
messenger.

160 Command him to leave the battle and  
the war  
161 and go to the tribes of the gods, or into  
the bright sea.  
162 And if he will not obey my words, but  
makes light of them,  
163 let him consider then in his mind and  
heart  
164 whether, strong as he is, he can dare  
to stand my coming —  
165 since I say my strength is far greater  
than his,  
166 and my birth is elder; yet his heart  
does not shrink  
167 from calling himself my equal —  
whom the others dread.”  
168 So he spoke, and wind-footed swift Iris  
did not disobey,  
169 and went down from the mountains of

Ida to holy Ilion.

170 As when out of the clouds the snow  
flies, or the hail,

171 cold under the blast of the sky-born  
North Wind,

172 so swiftly, straining, flew swift Iris,

173 and standing close she spoke to the  
famed earth-shaker:

174 “A message for you, holder of the  
earth, blue-maned one:

175 I have come here carrying it from  
aegis-bearing Zeus.

176 He commands you to leave the battle  
and the war

177 and go to the tribes of the gods, or into  
the bright sea.

178 And if you will not obey his words, but  
make light of them,

179 he threatens to come here himself and

fight you

180 strength against strength; and he  
warns you to keep out

181 from under his hands, since he says  
his strength is far greater

182 than yours, and his birth is elder; yet  
your heart does not shrink

183 from calling yourself his equal —  
whom the others dread.”

184 Then, deeply angered, the famed  
earth-shaker answered her:

185 “Shame on him! Great as he is, this is  
arrogance —8

186 to hold me back by force, against my  
will, who am his equal in honor.

187 Three brothers are we, whom Rhea  
bore to Cronos:

188 Zeus, and I, and Hades third, who is  
king of those below.

189 All was divided three ways; each got  
his share of honor:  
190 I drew the grey sea to live in forever  
191 when the lots were shaken; and Hades  
drew the misty dark,  
192 and Zeus drew the wide heaven, in the  
clear air and the clouds;  
193 but the earth is common to all three  
still, and high Olympus.  
194 So I will not walk by the mind of Zeus.  
Let him stay  
195 quiet in his third portion, strong as he  
is;  
196 and let him not try to frighten me  
with his hands as though I were  
197 some coward. Better he keep his  
blustering words  
198 to scold the daughters and the sons he  
fathered himself,

199 who will have to listen to whatever he  
commands.”

200 Then answered him wind-footed swift  
Iris:

201 “Is this really the word, holder of the  
earth, blue-maned one,

202 that I am to carry to Zeus — this hard,  
unbending word?

203 Or will you turn a little? The hearts of  
the great can turn.9

204 You know how the Erinyes always side  
with the elder-born.”

205 Then Poseidon the earth-shaker  
answered her:

206 “Iris, goddess — that word of yours  
was rightly spoken:

207 it is a fine thing when a messenger  
knows what is fitting.

208 But this comes as bitter grief to my



heart and spirit —

209 when he chooses to rail with angry  
words at one

210 allotted an equal share, doomed to the  
same portion.

211 Still — for now I will yield, indignant  
though I am.

212 But I will tell you this, and it is a threat  
from my heart:10

213 if in spite of me, and Athena driver of  
the spoil,

214 and Hera, and Hermes, and lord  
Hephaestus,

215 he spares steep Ilion — if he refuses

216 to sack it and to hand great power to  
the Argives —

217 let him know this: between us two the  
anger will have no healing.”

218 So speaking the earth-shaker left the

Achaean army

219 and went into the sea and sank; and  
the Achaean heroes missed him.

220 Then Zeus the cloud-gatherer spoke  
to Apollo:

221 “Go now, dear Phoebus, to Hector of  
the bronze helmet.

222 For by this time the holder of the  
earth, the earth-shaker,

223 has gone into the bright sea, dodging  
our sheer anger —

224 otherwise even the others would have  
heard of our fight,

225 the gods who are down below,  
gathered around Cronos.

226 But this is far better, for me and for  
himself:

227 that he yielded, for all his indignation,  
before my hands —

228 since not without sweat would the  
business have been settled.

229 Now: take up in your hands the  
tasseled aegis<sup>11</sup>

230 and shake it hard over the Achaean  
heroes, to rout them.

231 And for yourself, far-striker: let  
glorious Hector be your care.

232 Wake the great fury in him, until the  
Achaeans

233 come in their flight to the ships and  
the Hellespont.

234 From there I myself will devise the  
word and the work

235 by which the Achaeans may catch  
their breath again from toil.”

236 So he spoke, and Apollo did not  
disobey his father,

237 but went down from the mountains of

Ida like a hawk,  
238 the swift dove-killer, fastest of flying  
things.  
239 He found the son of war-minded  
Priam, brilliant Hector,  
240 sitting up — no longer lying down: he  
had just gathered his spirit,  
241 knowing the companions around him;  
and the gasping and the sweat  
242 had ceased, for the mind of aegis-  
bearing Zeus was waking him.  
243 And standing close, the worker-from-  
afar, Apollo, spoke to him:  
244 “Hector, son of Priam — why do you  
sit apart from the others,  
245 with so little strength in you? Has  
some trouble found you?”  
246 And with the little strength he had,  
Hector of the flashing helmet answered:12

247 “Which of the gods are you, kindest  
one, who ask me face to face?  
248 Have you not heard? By the sterns of  
the Achaeian ships,  
249 as I killed his companions, Ajax good  
at the war-cry  
250 struck me on the chest with a stone,  
and stopped my rushing courage.  
251 Indeed I thought that on this day I  
would look on the dead  
252 and the house of Hades: I was  
breathing out my own dear life.”  
253 Then lord Apollo the worker-from-  
afar answered him:  
254 “Take heart: such a helper has the son  
of Cronos  
255 sent down from Ida to stand beside  
you and defend you —  
256 Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword: I

who before now

257 have guarded you, yourself and your  
steep citadel alike.

258 Up now: command your many  
charioteers

259 to drive their swift horses at the  
hollow ships;

260 and I will go before them and smooth  
the whole road

261 for the horses, and turn the Achaean  
heroes back.”

262 So speaking he breathed great fury  
into the shepherd of the people.

263 As when a stalled horse, corn-fed at  
the manger,13

264 breaks his tether and gallops  
drumming across the plain,

265 used to bathing in the fair-flowing  
river,

266 glorying: he holds his head high, and  
the mane  
267 streams along his shoulders; sure of  
his own splendor,  
268 his knees carry him lightly to the  
haunts and pastures of horses:  
269 so Hector plied his feet and knees,  
quick and light,  
270 urging on his horsemen, now he had  
heard the god's voice.  
271 And the others — as when dogs and  
countrymen  
272 chase an antlered stag or a wild goat,  
273 and a sheer rock-face or a shadowy  
wood  
274 saves it, since it was not their portion  
to catch it,  
275 and then, drawn by their clamor, a  
bearded lion

276 shows himself in the way, and turns  
them all back for all their fury:  
277 so for a while the Danaans followed  
close, in a mass,  
278 stabbing with swords and double-  
curved spears;  
279 but when they saw Hector ranging  
down the ranks of men,  
280 they were afraid, and every man's  
heart dropped to his feet.  
281 Then Thoas spoke among them,  
Andraemon's son,<sup>14</sup>  
282 far the best of the Aetolians — skilled  
with the javelin,  
283 brave in the standing fight; and in  
assembly few Achaeans  
284 could beat him, when the young men  
contended in debate.  
285 With good will toward them he spoke



and addressed them:

286 “Shame! — a great marvel is this I see  
with my eyes:

287 how he has risen again, escaped the  
death-spirits —

288 Hector! The heart in each of us hoped  
hard enough

289 that he had died under the hands of  
Ajax, Telamon’s son.

290 But some one of the gods has rescued  
and saved him again —

291 Hector, who has unstrung the knees of  
many Danaans,

292 as he will now too, I think: for not  
without loud-thundering Zeus

293 does he stand there in the front rank,  
blazing like this.

294 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:

295 Let us order the multitude back to the

ships;

296 and we ourselves, all who claim to be  
best in the army,

297 let us stand, and see if we can blunt  
him first, meeting him

298 with spears held high. For all his fury,  
I think

299 his heart will fear to sink into the  
crowd of the Danaans.”

300 So he spoke; and they heard him well,  
and obeyed.

301 Those around Ajax and lord  
Idomeneus,

302 and Teucer, and Meriones, and Meges  
the equal of Ares,

303 called up the best men and formed for  
battle,

304 facing Hector and the Trojans; and  
behind them

305 the multitude went back to the ships  
of the Achaeans.

306 The Trojans struck first, massed;  
Hector led them

307 with long strides; and in front of him  
went Phoebus Apollo,

308 his shoulders wrapped in cloud,  
holding the rushing aegis,

309 terrible, shag-fringed, dazzling —  
which the smith

310 Hephaestus gave to Zeus, to carry for  
the routing of men;15

311 holding this in his hands he led the  
army.

312 And the Argives stood to meet them,  
close-massed, and the war-cry

313 rose shrill from both sides; from the  
bowstrings the arrows

314 leapt; and many spears from daring

hands

315 fixed themselves in the flesh of quick  
young fighters,

316 and many midway, before they could  
reach the white flesh,

317 stood planted in the earth, still hungry  
to glut themselves on it.

318 So long as Phoebus Apollo held the  
aegis unmoving,

319 so long the missiles of both sides  
struck home, and the people fell;

320 but when he looked the swift-colted  
Danaans full in the face

321 and shook it, and himself gave a great  
shout, then the heart

322 in their chests he bewitched, and they  
forgot their rushing courage.

323 And as two wild beasts stampede a  
herd of cattle

324 or a great flock of sheep in the  
milking-dark of night,  
325 coming suddenly, when the herdsman  
is not by,  
326 so the Achaeans panicked,  
strengthless: for Apollo drove  
327 the panic into them, and handed glory  
to the Trojans and Hector.  
328 Then man killed man, as the battle  
scattered.  
329 Hector cut down Stichius and  
Arcesilaus, 16  
330 the one a leader of the bronze-shirted  
Boeotians,  
331 the other the trusted companion of  
great-hearted Menestheus;  
332 and Aeneas stripped the life from  
Medon and Iasus.  
333 Now the one — Medon — was a

bastard son of godlike Oïleus  
334 and brother of Ajax; but he lived in  
Phylace,  
335 far from his own fatherland, having  
killed a man,  
336 a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis,  
wife of Oïleus;  
337 and Iasus was set a captain of the  
Athenians,  
338 and was called the son of Sphelus,  
Boucolus's son.  
339 And Polydamas killed Mecisteus, and  
Polites Echius,  
340 in the first onset, and brilliant Agenor  
killed Clonius;  
341 and Paris hit Deiochus at the base of  
the shoulder, from behind,  
342 as he fled through the front-fighters,  
and drove the bronze clean through.

343 While they were stripping the armor  
from these, the Achaeans,  
344 tangled in the dug ditch and the  
stakes,  
345 were fleeing this way and that, and  
diving behind the wall by necessity.  
346 And Hector called to the Trojans with  
a great shout:  
347 “Straight for the ships — and leave the  
bloody spoils!**17**  
348 Whomever I see hanging back, away  
from the ships,  
349 I will plan his death on the spot; and  
no brothers of his,  
350 no sisters, will give his dead body its  
portion of fire:  
351 the dogs will drag him before our city.”  
352 So speaking, with a full swing of the  
whip he drove his horses on,

353 calling to the Trojans down the ranks;  
and all of them with him,  
354 shouting as one, steered the chariot-  
pulling horses  
355 with a prodigious roar. And in front of  
them Phoebus Apollo,  
356 kicking down the banks of the deep  
ditch with his feet,  
357 easily, tumbled them into the middle,  
and bridged a causeway  
358 long and wide — about as wide as a  
spear-cast  
359 carries, when a man is trying his  
strength.  
360 Down this they poured, rank after  
rank, and before them Apollo  
361 held the aegis beyond all price; and he  
kicked down the wall  
362 of the Achaeans — easily — as when a



boy by the sea<sup>18</sup>

<sup>363</sup> heaps sand into shapes in his childish  
play,

<sup>364</sup> and then, still playing, scatters them  
again with his feet and hands:

<sup>365</sup> so you, archer Phoebus, poured into  
ruin the long

<sup>366</sup> labor and misery of the Argives, and  
drove the panic through them.

<sup>367</sup> So they halted and held their ground  
beside the ships,

<sup>368</sup> calling to one another, and lifting  
their hands

<sup>369</sup> to all the gods, each man prayed  
aloud;

<sup>370</sup> and Nestor above all, the Gerenian,  
warden of the Achaeans,

<sup>371</sup> prayed, stretching his arms toward the  
starry heaven:

372 “Father Zeus — if ever anyone in  
wheat-rich Argos, 19  
373 burning to you the fat thighs of ox or  
sheep,  
374 prayed for his homecoming, and you  
promised it with a nod:  
375 remember it, Olympian; ward off the  
pitiless day,  
376 and do not let the Achaeans be broken  
so by the Trojans.”  
377 So he spoke in prayer; and Zeus the  
counselor thundered loud,  
378 hearing the prayers of the old man,  
Neleus’ son.  
379 But the Trojans, when they heard the  
thunder of aegis-bearing Zeus,  
380 leapt at the Argives all the harder, and  
remembered their war-craft.  
381 As a great wave of the wide-wayed

sea<sup>20</sup>

<sup>382</sup> comes down over a ship's bulwarks,  
when the strength of the wind

<sup>383</sup> drives it high — for that above all  
makes the waves grow:

<sup>384</sup> so the Trojans with a great cry came  
down over the wall,

<sup>385</sup> and driving their horses in they  
fought at the sterns,

<sup>386</sup> hand to hand with double-curved  
spears — they from their chariots,

<sup>387</sup> and the Achaeans high up, from the  
decks of their black ships,

<sup>388</sup> with the long pikes that lay aboard for  
sea-fighting,

<sup>389</sup> jointed and socketed, their heads  
clothed in bronze.

<sup>390</sup> Now Patroclus, so long as the  
Achaeans and Trojans

391 fought for the wall, outside the swift  
ships,  
392 sat in the hut of gracious Eurypylus  
393 and delighted him with talk, and on  
his grievous wound  
394 sprinkled the remedies against the  
black pains.  
395 But when he saw the Trojans storming  
over the wall,  
396 and the Danaans' shouting and panic  
broke out,  
397 he groaned aloud, and struck both his  
thighs  
398 with his flat hands, and cried out in  
grief:  
399 "Eurypylus — I can stay with you here  
no longer,<sup>21</sup>  
400 much as you need me: a great struggle  
has risen.

401 Let your aide look after you now; I  
myself  
402 will hurry to Achilles, to rouse him to  
fight.  
403 Who knows whether, with a god's  
help, I might stir his heart  
404 by my persuading? The persuasion of  
a companion is a good thing."  
405 And even as he spoke his feet were  
carrying him. Meanwhile the Achaeans  
406 stood fast against the Trojan advance,  
yet could not  
407 push them from the ships, though  
they were fewer;  
408 nor could the Trojans ever break the  
Danaans' lines  
409 and force their way in among the huts  
and the ships.  
410 But as a chalk-line trues a ship-timber

straight<sup>22</sup>

<sup>411</sup> in the hands of a skilled carpenter,  
who knows

<sup>412</sup> his whole craft well by the promptings  
of Athena,

<sup>413</sup> so their battle and their war were  
drawn even and taut.

<sup>414</sup> And others fought their fight at other  
ships,

<sup>415</sup> but Hector made straight for glorious  
Ajax.

<sup>416</sup> The two of them labored over a single  
ship, and neither

<sup>417</sup> could win: Hector could not drive Ajax  
off and fire the ship,

<sup>418</sup> nor Ajax push Hector back — since a  
god had brought him.

<sup>419</sup> Then shining Ajax hit Caletor, Clytius's  
son,<sup>23</sup>

420 with the spear in the chest as he  
carried fire toward the ship:  
421 he fell with a thud, and the brand  
dropped from his hand.  
422 And Hector, when he saw with his  
own eyes his cousin  
423 fallen in the dust before the black  
ship,  
424 called to the Trojans and Lycians with  
a great shout:  
425 “Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians  
who fight at close quarters —  
426 do not give back from the battle in  
this narrow place:  
427 save the son of Clytius, or the  
Achaeans will strip  
428 his armor, fallen where the ships  
stand gathered.”  
429 So speaking he cast at Ajax with his

shining spear.

430 Him he missed; but Lycophron,  
Mastor's son,

431 Ajax's henchman from Cythera, who  
lived with him —

432 for he had killed a man in most holy  
Cythera —

433 him he struck on the head above the  
ear with the sharp bronze

434 as he stood beside Ajax; and backward  
in the dust

435 he dropped from the ship's stern to  
the ground, and his limbs were unstrung.

436 And Ajax shuddered, and spoke to his  
brother:

437 "Teucer, old friend — our trusted  
companion is killed,

438 Mastor's son, the man from Cythera  
we honored



439 in our halls like our own dear parents.  
440 Great-hearted Hector has killed him.  
Where now are your arrows  
441 of quick death, and the bow that  
Phoebus Apollo gave you?”  
442 So he spoke; and Teucer understood,  
and came running to stand  
443 beside him, his back-bent bow in his  
hand  
444 and the arrow-holding quiver; and  
fast he loosed his shafts at the Trojans.  
445 And he hit Cleitus, the shining son of  
Peisenor,  
446 companion of Polydamas, Panthous’s  
illustrious son,  
447 with the reins in his hands, laboring  
with his horses;  
448 for he held them where the most  
battle-lines were driven

449 in confusion, doing a favor to Hector  
and the Trojans. But swiftly  
450 the evil came on him that no one  
could hold off, wish it as they might:  
451 for the arrow of many groans dropped  
into the back of his neck,  
452 and he crashed from the chariot, and  
the horses shied back,  
453 rattling the empty car. And lord  
Polydamas saw it  
454 at once, and was first to come and  
stand at the horses' heads.  
455 He gave them to Astynous, Protiaon's  
son,  
456 with many orders to hold them close  
and keep them  
457 in his eye; and himself went back and  
mixed with the front-fighters.  
458 And Teucer was drawing another

arrow, for Hector

459 of the bronze helmet — and would  
have stopped the battle

460 at the ships of the Achaeans, had he  
hit him mid-triumph

461 and torn out his life. But he did not  
slip the close mind of Zeus,

462 who was guarding Hector, and robbed  
Teucer, Telamon's son, of his triumph:24

463 the well-twisted string on the  
blameless bow —

464 Zeus broke it as he drew; and the  
bronze-weighted arrow

465 swerved wide and away, and the bow  
dropped from his hand.

466 And Teucer shuddered, and spoke to  
his brother:

467 “Look — how utterly some power is  
shearing off the plans

468 of our fighting! It has struck the bow  
from my hand  
469 and snapped the fresh-twisted string I  
bound on it  
470 this very morning, to bear the arrows  
springing thick and fast.”  
471 Then great Telamonian Ajax answered  
him:  
472 “Old friend — then let the bow and the  
showering arrows  
473 lie, since a god has spited the Danaans  
and wrecked them.  
474 Take a long spear in your hands and a  
shield on your shoulder  
475 and fight the Trojans yourself, and  
drive on the rest of the army.  
476 If they take us, at least let it cost them  
labor —  
477 the well-benched ships. Let us

remember our war-craft.”

478 So he spoke; and Teucer set the bow  
away in the huts,

479 and about his shoulders he slung a  
shield of four hides,

480 and on his powerful head he set a  
well-made helmet,

481 horsehair-crested; the plume nodded  
terribly above it;

482 and he took up a stout spear, edged  
with sharp bronze,

483 and set off at a run, and quickly stood  
by Ajax.

484 And Hector, when he saw Teucer’s  
shots crippled,

485 called to the Trojans and Lycians with  
a great shout:

486 “Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians  
who fight at close quarters —

487 be men, my friends; remember your  
rushing courage  
488 here along the hollow ships: for I have  
seen with my own eyes  
489 the shots of their best man crippled  
by Zeus.  
490 Easily known among men is the  
strength of Zeus —25  
491 both those to whom he hands the  
higher glory  
492 and those he wears down and will not  
defend:  
493 so now he wears down the Argives'  
fury, and helps us.  
494 Fight at the ships in one mass! And  
whichever of you,  
495 hit from afar or stabbed close, meets  
his death and his doom —  
496 let him die. It is no dishonor for him

to die

497 defending his fatherland: his wife is  
safe after him, and his children,

498 his house and his portion of land  
unharméd, if the Achaeans

499 go away in their ships to their dear  
fatherland.”

500 So speaking he stirred the fury and  
the heart of every man.

501 And Ajax on the other side called to  
his companions:

502 “Shame, Argives! Now it is certain:  
either we perish<sup>26</sup>

503 or we are saved, and beat the ruin  
back from the ships.

504 Do you hope, if Hector of the flashing  
helmet takes the ships,

505 that each of you will walk home on  
foot to his fatherland?

506 Do you not hear him driving his whole  
army —

507 Hector, who is raging now to burn the  
ships?

508 It is not to a dance he is inviting them:  
he invites them to fight.

509 For us there is no plan, no better  
thought than this:

510 to bring our hands and fury against  
them, body to body.

511 Better once for all to seize our death or  
our life

512 than be squeezed slowly dry in the  
dread combat,

513 here by the ships, uselessly, under  
worse men than ourselves.”

514 So speaking he stirred the fury and the  
heart of every man.

515 Then Hector cut down Schedius,



Perimedes' son,  
516 a captain of the Phocians; and Ajax cut  
down Laodamas,  
517 a leader of the foot-soldiers, Antenor's  
shining son;  
518 and Polydamas stripped the life from  
Otus of Cyllene,  
519 companion of Phyleus' son, a captain  
of the great-hearted Epeians.  
520 Meges saw it and sprang at him; but  
Polydamas swerved  
521 from under, and Meges missed him —  
for Apollo  
522 would not let Panthous's son be  
broken among the front-fighters —  
523 but he stabbed Croesmus full in the  
chest with the spear:  
524 he fell with a thud, and Meges set to  
stripping the armor from his shoulders.

525 But meanwhile Dolops sprang on him,  
a master of the spear,  
526 Lampus's son — the strongest son that  
Lampus fathered,  
527 Laomedon's own son, well skilled in  
rushing courage —  
528 who stabbed the middle of Phyleus'  
son's shield with his spear<sup>27</sup>  
529 at close range; but the thick corslet  
saved him,  
530 the corslet he wore, close-fitted with  
its plates: the one Phyleus  
531 brought home once out of Ephyra,  
from the river Selleïs.  
532 A guest-friend gave it to him —  
Euphetes, lord of men —  
533 to carry into war, a defense against  
enemy men;  
534 and now it kept destruction from the

flesh of his son.

535 Then Meges stabbed with his sharp-  
pointed spear at the topmost  
536 ridge of Dolops's bronze helmet, thick  
with horsehair,  
537 and sheared the horsehair plume  
clean off; and the whole of it  
538 fell in the dust, fresh-shining with its  
scarlet dye.

539 While Meges held his ground and  
fought him, still hoping for victory,  
540 warlike Menelaus came to his rescue:  
541 he took his stand aside with his spear,  
unseen, and hit his shoulder  
542 from behind; and the point, raging,  
drove through his chest  
543 and out, straining onward; and he  
crumpled down on his face.  
544 The two of them moved in to strip the

bronze armor

545 from his shoulders; but Hector called  
on his kinsmen,

546 all of them; and first he rebuked  
Hicetaon's son,

547 strong Melanippus. He had herded his  
shambling cattle28

548 in Percote a while, with the enemy far  
away;

549 but when the double-ended ships of  
the Danaans came,

550 he came back to Ilion, and stood out  
among the Trojans,

551 and lived with Priam, who honored  
him like his own children.

552 Him Hector rebuked, and spoke a  
word, and named him:

553 "Is this how we slacken, Melanippus?  
Is your own heart

554 not turned at all — for your cousin  
killed?

555 Do you not see how they swarm over  
Dolops's armor?

556 Follow me. No longer can we stand off  
and fight

557 the Argives at a distance: now we kill  
them, or they pull down

558 steep Ilion from its height and cut her  
citizens down.”

559 So speaking he led the way, and the  
other followed, a man like a god.

560 And great Telamonian Ajax roused the  
Argives:

561 “Friends — be men! Set shame in your  
hearts,

562 and feel shame before each other in  
the strong encounters.

563 Where men feel shame, more are

saved than slain;<sup>29</sup>

<sup>564</sup> where they run, no fame rises, and no strength.”

<sup>565</sup> So he spoke; and they themselves were furious to beat the enemy off,

<sup>566</sup> and took his word to heart, and fenced the ships

<sup>567</sup> in a hedge of bronze; and Zeus drove the Trojans on against them.

<sup>568</sup> And Menelaus, good at the war-cry, urged Antilochus:

<sup>569</sup> “Antilochus — no other Achaean is younger than you,

<sup>570</sup> none faster on his feet or braver in the fighting:

<sup>571</sup> might you not spring out and hit some man of the Trojans?”

<sup>572</sup> So speaking he hurried back; but he had stirred him,

573 and out from the front-fighters he  
sprang, and cast his shining spear,  
574 glancing all round him; and the  
Trojans shrank away  
575 from the man as he threw. And his  
shot did not go in vain:  
576 Hicetaon's high-hearted son,  
Melanippus,  
577 coming into the battle, he hit in the  
chest by the nipple:  
578 he fell with a thud, and darkness  
covered his eyes.  
579 And Antilochus sprang on him as a  
hound springs on a fawn  
580 that is hit — the hunter's shot caught  
it leaping  
581 out of its bed, and unstrung its limbs  
beneath it:  
582 so on you, Melanippus, staunch

Antilochus sprang,  
583 to strip your armor. But he was not  
unseen by brilliant Hector,  
584 who came running through the  
combat to face him;  
585 and Antilochus did not stand him,  
quick fighter though he was,  
586 but fled, like a wild beast that has  
done some mischief —30  
587 that has killed a dog, or a herdsman  
with his cattle,  
588 and runs before the crowd of men can  
gather:  
589 so Nestor's son ran; and after him the  
Trojans and Hector  
590 with a prodigious roar poured their  
missiles of groaning;  
591 and he turned and stood, when he  
reached the band of his companions.



592 And now the Trojans, like flesh-eating  
lions,  
593 stormed at the ships, accomplishing  
the commands of Zeus,  
594 who woke the great fury in them  
always, and bewitched the heart  
595 of the Argives, and stole their  
triumph, and drove the others on.  
596 For his heart willed the glory for  
Hector,  
597 Priam's son, so he might hurl on the  
beaked ships  
598 the prodigious, unwearying fire, and  
bring to pass  
599 the whole extraordinary prayer of  
Thetis. For Zeus the counselor  
600 waited for one thing: to see with his  
own eyes  
601 the flare of a single burning ship.

From that moment on

602 he would make the Trojans' tide run  
back

603 from the ships, and hand the glory to  
the Danaans.

604 With this in mind he woke against the  
hollow ships

605 Hector, Priam's son — already burning  
hot himself.

606 He raged like Ares the spear-shaker,  
or as annihilating fire

607 rages in the mountains, in the thickets  
of a deep wood;

608 the foam stood at his mouth, and his  
two eyes

609 blazed under his grim brows, and  
around his temples the helmet

610 shook terribly as Hector fought. For  
out of the upper air

611 Zeus himself was his defender — Zeus  
who honored  
612 and glorified him, one man among  
many; for he was to be31  
613 short-lived: already Pallas Athena was  
speeding  
614 his death-day on, under the strength  
of Peleus' son.  
615 And he strained to break the ranks of  
men, probing them  
616 wherever he saw the thickest crowd  
and the best armor;  
617 but he could not break them for all his  
blazing:  
618 they held, locked like a tower — like a  
rock-face,  
619 sheer and huge, hard by the grey salt  
water,  
620 that abides the quick paths of the

shrill winds

621 and the swollen waves belching  
against it:

622 so the Danaans stood the Trojans,  
steady, and did not run.

623 But he, glittering with fire on every  
side, leapt on the mass,

624 and fell on them as a wave falls on a  
swift ship,

625 wind-fed, ravening, out of the clouds:  
and the whole ship

626 is buried in spray, and the terrible  
blast of the wind

627 roars in the sail, and the sailors  
tremble at heart,

628 terrified: for they are carried only just  
out from under death:

629 so the heart was torn in the chest of  
every Achaean.

630 And he came on like a murderous lion  
on cattle<sup>32</sup>

631 grazing in their thousands in the  
water-meadow of a great marsh,

632 and among them a herdsman not yet  
sure of his skill

633 to fight a beast off from the carcass of  
a twist-horned cow:

634 he keeps pace always with the first  
ranks or the last,

635 but the lion leaps on the middle and  
devours a cow,

636 and all the rest stampede: so then the  
Achaeans

637 fled unearthly before Hector and  
father Zeus,

638 all of them — though he killed one  
man only: Periphetes of Mycenae,

639 the dear son of Copreus, who used to

carry the messages

640 of king Eurystheus to the might of  
Heracles.

641 Of that far worse father was born a  
better son

642 in every virtue — in speed of foot and  
in fighting,

643 and in mind among the first of the  
Mycenaeans;

644 and it was he, then, who handed  
Hector the higher glory.

645 For turning back, he tripped against  
the rim of his shield —

646 the shield he carried himself, reaching  
his feet, a tower against javelins;

647 tangled in it he tumbled backward,  
and the helmet

648 clanged terribly about his temples as  
he fell.

649 And Hector saw it sharply, and ran to  
stand beside him,  
650 and fixed the spear in his chest, and  
killed him close by  
651 his own dear companions; and they  
could not help him, though grieving:  
652 they were themselves too much afraid  
of brilliant Hector.  
653 Now they had come inside the ships,  
and around them stood  
654 the ends of the ships drawn up in the  
first line; and the Trojans poured in.  
655 And the Argives gave back from the  
first line of ships  
656 by necessity, but held their ground  
right there among the huts,  
657 massed together, not scattering  
through the camp: shame held them,  
658 and fear; and they called to one

another without ceasing.

659 And Nestor above all, the Gerenian,  
warden of the Achaeans,

660 begged each man by his parents,  
clasping their knees with his words:

661 “Friends — be men! Set in your hearts  
the shame<sup>33</sup>

662 of what other men will say; and  
remember, each of you,

663 your children and your wives, your  
property and your parents —

664 you whose parents live, and you  
whose parents are dead:

665 for their sake, absent though they are,  
I clasp your knees here:

666 stand strong — and do not turn  
yourselves to panic.”

667 So speaking he stirred the fury and  
the heart of every man.



668 And from their eyes Athena thrust  
away the prodigious  
669 cloud of mist; and light came hard and  
clear on both sides,  
670 toward the ships and toward the  
leveling war alike.  
671 And they made out Hector, good at the  
war-cry, and his companions,  
672 both those who stood behind and  
were not fighting  
673 and those who fought the battle along  
the swift ships.  
674 Nor did it please the heart of great-  
hearted Ajax any longer  
675 to stand where the other sons of the  
Achaeans stood back:  
676 he went striding along the decks of  
the ships,  
677 wielding in his hands a great jointed

pike for sea-fighting,  
678 twenty-two cubits long, socketed with  
rings.  
679 And as a man well skilled in trick-  
riding,<sup>34</sup>  
680 who has yoked together four horses  
picked from many  
681 and comes sweeping in from the plain  
toward the great city  
682 along the public road — and many  
marvel at him,  
683 men and women both — while he,  
steady, sure, and always  
684 leaping, changes from horse to horse  
as they fly along:  
685 so Ajax went striding deck to deck  
across the swift ships  
686 with long steps, and his voice went up  
to the very sky

687 as with terrible shouts, always, he  
called on the Danaans  
688 to defend the ships and the huts. Nor  
did Hector  
689 stay back in the crowd of close-  
armored Trojans:  
690 but as a fiery eagle drops on a nation  
of winged birds  
691 feeding by a river's edge —  
692 geese, or cranes, or long-necked  
swans —  
693 so Hector went straight at a dark-  
prowed ship,  
694 charging it head-on; and from behind  
Zeus thrust him  
695 onward with his very great hand, and  
drove the army with him.  
696 And again the fighting sharpened by  
the ships.

697 You would say they met each other in  
the war unworn  
698 and unbroken, so furiously they  
fought;  
699 and this was the thinking of the  
fighters: the Achaeans  
700 said they would not escape the evil,  
but must perish;  
701 and the heart in every Trojan's chest  
was hoping  
702 to fire the ships and cut down the  
Achaean heroes.  
703 With these thoughts they stood  
against each other;  
704 and Hector laid his hand on the stern  
of a seagoing ship —35  
705 a fair ship, quick on the salt water,  
that had carried Protesilaus  
706 to Troy, and never carried him home

again to his fatherland.

707 Around that ship Achaeans and  
Trojans

708 cut each other down hand to hand; no  
longer at a distance

709 did they stand the volleys of arrows  
and of javelins,

710 but standing close, one heart in all of  
them,

711 they fought with sharpened axes and  
with hatchets

712 and with great swords and double-  
curved spears;

713 and many fine blades, dark-bound at  
the hilt,

714 fell to the ground, some from the  
hands, some from the shoulders

715 of the fighting men; and the black  
earth ran blood.

716 And Hector, once he had seized the  
stern-horn, would not let go:  
717 gripping it in his hands, he called to  
the Trojans:  
718 “Bring fire! And all together raise the  
war-cry!  
719 Now Zeus has given us a day worth all  
the rest:  
720 to take the ships — the ships that  
came here against the gods’ will  
721 and made us so much misery —  
through the cowardice of the elders,  
722 who, when I wanted to fight at the  
ships’ sterns,  
723 held me back myself, and kept the  
army in.  
724 But if wide-seeing Zeus was damaging  
our wits then,  
725 now he himself is driving and

commanding us.”

726 So he spoke; and they leapt at the  
Argives all the harder,

727 and Ajax could hold no longer: the  
missiles pressed him too hard.

728 He gave back a little, thinking now to  
die,

729 onto the seven-foot bridge-plank, and  
left the deck of the balanced ship.

730 There he stood watchful; and always  
with his spear

731 he beat the Trojans off the ships —  
whoever carried the unwearying fire —

732 and always with terrible shouts he  
called on the Danaans:

733 “Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of  
Ares — **36**

734 be men, my friends; remember your  
rushing courage.

735 Do we imagine there are allies at our  
backs?

736 Some stronger wall, to ward the ruin  
off our men?

737 There is no city near us fitted with  
towers

738 where we might make defense, and a  
people to turn the scale.

739 No: we sit in the plain of the close-  
armored Trojans,

740 pinned against the sea, far from our  
fatherland.

741 Our light of safety is in our hands —  
not in any gentleness of war.”

742 He spoke, and pressed on furious with  
his sharp-pointed spear.

743 And whoever of the Trojans came  
driving at the hollow ships

744 with blazing fire, to please Hector at



his urging,

745 Ajax stood waiting and stabbed him  
with the long spear:

746 twelve men he wounded close-in  
before the ships.

## Notes

### NOTES

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### NOTES

1. (15.4-11) Zeus wakes to the whole tableau at once: the rout, Poseidon among the Argives, and Hector “laboring for breath, his wits astray, vomiting blood — for not the feeblest of the Achaeans had hit him.” The litotes is the poem’s dry salute to Ajax; the concussion is continuous from 14.433-439. What wakes is not just the god but the plot. ↩
2. (15.18-33) The punishment of Hera: hung from heaven in a golden unbreakable band, “and from your feet I slung two anvils” — the gods raging up and down

Olympus, unable to free her, and any who tried “I seized and hurled from the threshold, till he struck the earth with little life in him.” The cosmic-discipline memory (cf. Hephaestus’s version, 1.590-594) is deployed as marital threat; and the occasion was the same Heracles-storm that Sleep remembered at 14.249-261 — the poem’s back-story is consistent across books, and both tellings exist to make one point: this has happened before, and she did it anyway. ↩

3. (15.36-46) Hera’s oath — the fullest in the poem: Earth, wide Heaven, the down-flowing water of Styx (“the greatest oath and the most terrible for the blessed gods”), “and your own sacred head, and the bed of the two of us, our bridal bed.” And it is a lawyer’s oath: every word true — Poseidon did act of his own heart (13.15-16 confirms it) — and the seduction, the girdle, and Sleep’s errand to Poseidon (14.354-360) nowhere within its terms. She swears by the very bed she used. Zeus smiles (47): readers have argued ever since about how much of that smile is belief. ↩
4. (15.49-77) The plan of the poem, spoken by its administrator: Hector to drive the Achaeans on the ships of Achilles; “and he will send out his

companion Patroclus; and glorious Hector will kill him with the spear... and among them my own son, brilliant Sarpedon. And in anger for him brilliant Achilles will kill Hector” — then the reversed tide “until the Achaeans take steep Ilium through the counsels of Athena.” Sixty lines of Iliad and the fall of Troy, dictated in advance and pinned to the Book 1 promise (“on the day the goddess Thetis clasped my knees”). Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized 56-77 and Zenodotus omitted 64-77 — prophecy so total seemed to them to deflate the tale. It does the opposite: from here on, suspense is replaced by witness. Zeus names his own son among the costs with zero comment; Book 16 will prize that silence.



5. (15.80-83) Hera travels at the speed of homesick thought: “as when the mind of a man darts, who has traveled over much country, and thinks in his quick wits ‘would I were here, or there’” — the mind’s instant travel as the fastest thing the poet knows (cf. Odyssey 7.36, ships “swift as wing or thought”). Cognition itself becomes the vehicle of a god. ↩
6. (15.101-103) Hera’s laugh: “she laughed with her lips; but the forehead above her dark brows did not

warm.” The poem’s greatest piece of face-writing — the smile as mask worn over rage, observed with a portraitist’s exactness three thousand years before the psychology had a vocabulary. ↩

7. (15.110-142) The Ascalaphus fuse (13.518-525)  
detonates: Hera lights it deliberately, naming the death to wound Zeus through Ares. Ares’ reply is the book’s darkest heroism — “do not blame me... even if my fate is to be struck by Zeus’s bolt, and lie with the corpses in the blood and the dust”: the war-god volunteering for mortality’s posture. Athena disarms him physically — helmet, shield, spear — and delivers the poem’s mortality-policy in the flattest possible terms: “Better men than he... have been killed before this, or will be killed hereafter. It is a hard thing to rescue the line and offspring of every man.” A god may not grieve past policy; men, the poem knows, do nothing else. ↩

8. (15.185-199) Poseidon’s cosmology: three brothers, three lots — “I drew the grey sea to live in forever when the lots were shaken; and Hades drew the misty dark, and Zeus drew the wide heaven... but the earth is common to all three still, and high Olympus.” Sovereignty by sortition, not

primogeniture — the constitutional counter-claim to Zeus’s “elder-born and stronger” (165-166). The tripartite division by lot has close Near Eastern kin (the Akkadian Atrahasis opens with Anu, Enlil, and Enki dividing sky, earth, and waters); here it surfaces once, in anger, and nowhere else in Homer. “Let him stay quiet in his third portion”: for one speech, the Iliad’s monarchy of heaven is a contested federation.



9. (15.200-211) Iris earns her wage: “Is this really the word... Or will you turn a little? The hearts of the great can turn. You know how the Erinyes always side with the elder-born.” The messenger exceeds her brief with a diplomat’s question and a theological reminder — the Furies as enforcers of birth-order — and Poseidon’s capitulation praises the craft itself: “it is a fine thing when a messenger knows what is fitting.” The scene is the poem’s tribute to its own couriers. ↩
10. (15.212-217) The yielding god’s condition: if Zeus spares Ilion against the will of Poseidon, Athena, Hera, Hermes, and Hephaestus, “between us two the anger will have no healing.” Athetized in antiquity, but load-bearing: the fall of Troy is established as an

inter-divine settlement no single god — not even Zeus — can cheaply revoke (cf. 4.30-49, where Zeus traded away his own three cities). ↩

11. (15.229-230, 308-311) The aegis passes to Apollo: made by the smith Hephaestus for Zeus “to carry for the routing of men” — the one artifact in the poem whose function is pure panic. Apollo carries it unshaken at first (318-320: stalemate), then shakes it and shouts — and the balance-clause the poem used for whole mornings of battle (“the missiles of both sides struck home, and the people fell”) snaps in a single line. ↩

12. (15.244-262) Hector’s revival: he answers the unrecognized god with the accurate history of his own concussion, believing he was bound that day for “the dead and the house of Hades”; Apollo answers with his full title — “Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword: I who before now have guarded you, yourself and your steep citadel alike” (the helmet of 11.353; the walls he built, 7.452-453; 21.446-447). The god who will one day stand off and let him die (22.213) introduces himself as his oldest bodyguard. ↩

13. (15.263-270) The stalled-horse simile, repeated verbatim from 6.506-511 — our English kept, as the

Greek is kept (ancient critics athetized the repeat here). In Book 6 it carried Paris, glittering and trivial, down from Pergamos; here it carries Hector back from the edge of death. Same gallop, same streaming mane, opposite gravities: the formula system's boldest double exposure, and the poem trusts its audience to hold both. ↩

14. (15.281-300) Thoas of Aetolia, given a rare résumé — best with the javelin, brave standing, “and in assembly few Achaeans could beat him, when the young men contended in debate”: the full heroic curriculum (deeds and words, 9.443) in a supporting player. His plan — multitude back, champions stand — is the professional's answer to a revenant: you cannot outfight a portent, but you can blunt it. ↩
15. (15.318-327) The physics of the aegis: held still, nothing; shaken, with the god's shout laid over it, it “bewitched” (θέλγε) the heart — the enchantment-verb again (12.255, Circe's verb). Panic in Homer is not an emotion but a possession, and the stampede simile that follows (two beasts, the herdsman absent, “in the milking-dark of night”) makes the Achaeans the cattle of a masterless field. ↩

16. (15.328-345) The counter-rout's ledger, paying debts across three books: Stichius (13.691) and Arcesilaus (2.495) fall to Hector; Aeneas kills Iasus and Medon — whose biography (334-337) repeats 13.694-697 verbatim, our English kept: the homicide-exile's story told once at his post and once at his death, as the register promised. Mecisteus, who carried the wounded off the field at 8.333 and 13.422, is carried off himself; Clonius (2.495) and Deiochus complete the roll. The poem audits its minor lives with the same care as its princes. ↩
17. (15.346-352) Hector's field-order crosses the poem's deepest line: the man who hangs back "I will plan his death on the spot; and no brothers of his, no sisters, will give his dead body its portion of fire: the dogs will drag him before our city." Denial of burial as military discipline, threatened by Hector against his own — the exact fate Achilles will attempt on Hector's corpse, and the theme of the poem's whole last movement. The words are spoken at his triumph's crest; the poem never forgets them. ↩
18. (15.355-366) Apollo bridges the ditch with a kick and levels the wall — the wall of Books 7-12, the wall that cost the dead their monument-fires — "as when a



boy by the sea heaps sand into shapes in his childish play, and then, still playing, scatters them again with his feet and hands.” And the narrator turns, for once, to face the god directly: “so you, archer Phoebus, poured into ruin the long labor and misery of the Argives.” The apostrophe (elsewhere reserved for Menelaus and Patroclus, figures of pathos) here carries something close to reproach: the distance between divine play and human toil has never been measured more exactly, in either direction. What Books 12-13 fought for line by line, a god undoes as recreation. ↩

19. (15.372-380) Nestor’s prayer — the old contract-form: “if ever anyone in wheat-rich Argos... prayed for his homecoming, and you promised it with a nod: remember it.” Zeus thunders — hearing him, the poet says plainly. And the Trojans, hearing the same thunder, take it for their own sign and charge harder. One peal, two readings, both catastrophic in different keys: the poem’s most economical lesson in omens. ↩
20. (15.381-390) The wave-over-the-bulwarks simile lands the Trojans inside the ships’ line, and the fighting goes naval: they from chariots, the Achaeans from

the decks “with the long pikes that lay aboard for sea-fighting, jointed and socketed, their heads clothed in bronze” — the ναύμαχα ξυστά, boarding weapons stowed since the landing ten years ago, at last taken down. The war has come full circle to the gear of its arrival. ↩

21. (15.390-405) The Patroclus thread, resumed from 11.848: he is still in Eurypylus’s hut, “delighting him with talk” and dressing the wound — the poem’s gentlest man at his gentlest — when the wall’s fall ends the interlude. His exit couplet repeats Nestor’s own persuasion-lines (11.792-793) in the first person, our English kept: “Who knows whether, with a god’s help, I might stir his heart by my persuading?” He leaves to fetch Achilles and will return only inside the plan of Zeus (note [4]). “Even as he spoke his feet were carrying him”: the poem’s quietest sentence of doom. ↩

22. (15.410-414) The carpenter’s chalk-line: battle-equilibrium as a timber trued straight “in the hands of a skilled carpenter, who knows his whole craft well by the promptings of Athena.” The deadlock similes have run from farmers’ scales (12.433) to

boundary stones (12.421) to this: war measured, again, by the honest work it interrupts. ↩

23. (15.419-441) Caletor, Hector's cousin, falls with the fire-brand still in his hand; and Hector's answering cast kills Lycophron of Cythera — Ajax's henchman, a homicide-exile "we honored in our halls like our own dear parents." The third such exile in three books (Medon, note [16]; Patroclus himself, 23.85-88); the heroic household absorbs killers as kin, and they die defending the men who took them in. ↩

24. (15.458-478) Teucer's bowstring, "fresh-twisted... bound on this very morning," snaps in the draw — Zeus, guarding Hector, disarms the one man whose shot could end the day. Teucer reads it exactly ("some power is shearing off the plans of our fighting"); Ajax's answer is the poem's practical theology: "let the bow and the showering arrows lie, since a god has spited the Danaans... Take a long spear." No lament, no inquiry: identify the interference, change weapons, keep fighting. Between them the brothers state the whole range of sane response to an intervening god. ↩

25. (15.486-499) Hector's great exhortation. First the sign read right for once ("I have seen with my own eyes

the shots of their best man crippled by Zeus — easily known among men is the strength of Zeus”); then the lines Lycurgus read out to an Athenian jury in 330 BC (Against Leocrates 103), prosecuting a man who fled the city after Chaeronea: “whichever of you... meets his death and his doom — let him die. It is no dishonor for him to die defending his fatherland: his wife is safe after him, and his children, his house and his portion of land unharmed.” The patriot-death ethic of 12.243 completed with its economic clause — what the dying man’s death purchases, itemized. That the poem gives this creed to Hector, whose wife will not be safe, whose child will not live, whose city burns in every listener’s knowledge, is the deepest irony the Iliad ever builds into a speech; and it was still doing civic work in a law-court three centuries later. ↩

26. (15.502-514) Ajax’s counter-speech strips the same choice of all its consolations: “either we perish or we are saved”; the savage joke (“It is not to a dance he is inviting them”); and the preference — “Better once for all to seize our death or our life than be squeezed slowly dry... under worse men than ourselves.” Where Hector offers death a meaning, Ajax offers only the arithmetic of now or slowly: the defender’s

creed, with no city behind it (completed at 733-742, note [36]). ↩

27. (15.525-539) Dolops, son of Lampus — grandson of Laomedon: even the Trojan royal cousins now feed the ships' battle. His death turns on heirloom armor: the corslet Phyleus brought out of Ephyra, guest-gift of Euphetes, "and now it kept destruction from the flesh of his son" — a cuirass with a passport, protecting the second generation (cf. the boar's-tusk helmet, 10.261-271). The plume Meges shears falls "fresh- shining with its scarlet dye" — the ornament dies first; then Menelaus, "unseen," finishes the man from behind. ↩

28. (15.547-559) Melanippus of Percote: the cattle-herding cousin who came back when the ships came — lines 550-551 repeat the Imbrius formula (13.175-176) verbatim, our English kept: the poem has a fixed biography for Troy's returned provincials, honored "like his own children" by Priam and spent like coin by Hector, whose rebuke ends on the naked alternative: "now we kill them, or they pull down steep Ilion from its height and cut her citizens down." ↩

29. (15.561-565) Ajax's shame-couplet repeats 5.531-532 (our English kept): "Where men feel shame, more are saved than slain; where they run, no fame rises, and no strength." Once Agamemnon's marshaling wisdom, now the last doctrine of a shrinking perimeter — αἰδώς as the army's remaining wall. ↩
30. (15.579-591) Antilochus springs like a hound on a shot fawn, then flees Hector "like a wild beast that has done some mischief — that has killed a dog, or a herdsman with his cattle, and runs before the crowd of men can gather." The guilty-animal simile is unique — predation with a conscience attached — and it fits the poem's tenderest young fighter: Antilochus kills, knows the price of the field instantly, and is standing again the moment he reaches his friends. ↩
31. (15.592-615) The narrator's double disclosure. Zeus drives everything toward one image: "to see with his own eyes the flare of a single burning ship" — Thetis's "extraordinary prayer" made a visual trigger; from that flare the tide reverses. Then over Hector — foam at his mouth, eyes blazing under grim brows — the lines Zenodotus cut and Aristarchus athetized: Zeus honored him "for he was

to be short-lived: already Pallas Athena was speeding his death-day on, under the strength of Peleus' son." Glory as hospice-gift: every act of Hector's greatest hour is performed inside a sentence that has already ended him. The ancients found the disclosure intolerable; it is the poem's whole method — nothing is suspenseful, everything is witnessed. ↩

32. (15.630-652) The lion takes one cow from the middle of thousands: Periphetes of Mycenae — son of Copeus ("Dung-man"), Eurystheus's herald to Heracles, "of that far worse father was born a better son in every virtue." The Heracles-cycle surfaces as family shame redeemed one generation on — and then the poem's most pitilessly ordinary death: he trips backward over his own shield-rim, "the shield he carried himself, reaching his feet, a tower against javelins," and Hector spears him where he lies tangled in his own protection. The best equipment in the panic is the thing that kills him; his friends watch, too afraid to help. ↩

33. (15.653-667) The last line before the huts. Nestor "begged each man by his parents, clasping their knees with his words" — supplication conducted by

proxy, at range: “remember, each of you, your children and your wives, your property and your parents — you whose parents live, and you whose parents are dead: for their sake, absent though they are, I clasp your knees here.” The absent invoked as the army’s true country (Ajax will say the country itself is absent, note [36]); and Athena lifts the mist so that they can at least see the enemy that is upon them — the poem’s recurring mercy of light (17.646-647). ↩

34. (15.674-688) Ajax’s pike-walk: deck to deck with the twenty- two-cubit boarding pike, “as a man well skilled in trick- riding... yoked together four horses... steady, sure, and always leaping, changes from horse to horse as they fly along.” The one extended image of equestrian spectacle in the poem — public road, admiring crowd, the city ahead — laid over a man hopping burning-threatened hulls with a siege-pole: peacetime’s showman as war’s last acrobat. ↩
35. (15.704-726) Hector’s hand closes on the stern of the ship “that had carried Protesilaus to Troy, and never carried him home again”: the war’s first casualty (2.698-702) supplying the altar for its crisis — the fleet’s mortality concentrated in one hull. Hector’s



speech from the stern-horn rewrites his own history — the elders’ “cowardice” held him back (it was Polydamas’s prudence, and his own obedience) — and then produces the poem’s most convenient theology: “if wide-seeing Zeus was damaging our wits then, now he himself is driving and commanding us.” Both clauses are true; neither means what he thinks. The day Zeus gave him is real, and expires at sundown (11.192-194); “bring fire!” is the exact fulfillment, and the exact limit, of his warrant. ↩

36. (15.727-746) The last stand, measured in carpentry: Ajax gives back from the deck to “the seven-foot bridge-plank” — θρήνυς ἑπταπόδης, the cross-bench of a beached hull as the war’s entire remaining ground. His speech is the reply to Hector’s fatherland-creed (note [25]) from men who have none in reach: “Do we imagine there are allies at our backs? Some stronger wall?... There is no city near us fitted with towers ... We sit in the plain of the close-armored Trojans, pinned against the sea, far from our fatherland. Our light of safety is in our hands — not in any gentleness of war.” τὼ ἐν χερσὶ φῶως: salvation as a thing held, like a spear. Then the book’s last sentence does the accounting its hero

would approve: “twelve men he wounded close-in  
before the ships.” No simile, no god, no glory-word  
— a count. The fire is one torch away, and Book 16  
opens with Patroclus weeping in front of Achilles. ↩

# Book 16

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*The Patrocleia: Patroclus goes out in Achilles' armor, quenches the fire, kills Sarpedon — and dies at the wall, struck by a god, a boy, and Hector, in that order.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 So they fought on around the well-benched ship;
- 2 and Patroclus stood beside Achilles, shepherd of the people,
- 3 letting fall hot tears like a spring of dark water<sup>1</sup>
- 4 that pours its black stream down a goat-proof cliff.
- 5 And swift-footed brilliant Achilles saw

him, and pitied him,

6 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:

7 “Why are you in tears, Patroclus — like a  
little girl

8 running at her mother’s side, begging to  
be carried,

9 clutching her skirt, dragging at her  
hurrying steps,

10 and looking up at her in tears until she  
lifts her:

11 that is you, Patroclus — spilling soft  
tears just so.

12 Have you some news for the  
Myrmidons, or for me myself?

13 Some message out of Phthia that you  
alone have heard?

14 They say Menoetius, Actor’s son, is still  
living,

15 and Peleus, Aeacus' son, lives among  
his Myrmidons —  
16 the two whose deaths would grieve us  
most of all.  
17 Or are you mourning for the Argives,  
watching them perish  
18 by the hollow ships for their own high-  
handedness?  
19 Speak out: hide nothing. Then we will  
both know.”  
20 Then, groaning heavily, you answered,  
Patroclus, horseman:  
21 “Achilles, son of Peleus, far greatest of  
the Achaeans,  
22 do not be angry: such grief has  
overmastered the Achaeans.  
23 For all the men who before were our  
best  
24 lie by the ships, hit from afar or

stabbed close.

25 Hit is Tydeus' son, strong Diomedes;

26 stabbed is Odysseus, famed with the  
spear; and Agamemnon;

27 and hit too is Eurypylus, by an arrow in  
the thigh.

28 Around these men the healers with  
their many drugs

29 are busy, tending their wounds. But  
you, Achilles — there is no dealing with  
you.

30 May such anger never take me as this  
anger you nurse,

31 cursed in your valor! What good will  
any late-born man get of you?

32 if you will not beat back shameful ruin  
from the Argives?

33 Pitiless man: the horseman Peleus was  
no father of yours,

34 nor Thetis your mother — the grey sea  
bore you,  
35 and the sheer cliffs, so unbending is the  
mind in you.  
36 But if in your heart you are dodging  
some prophecy,<sup>4</sup>  
37 something your lady mother has told  
you from Zeus,  
38 then send me out at least, and let the  
rest of the army  
39 of Myrmidons follow, and I may be a  
light to the Danaans;  
40 and give me your own armor to buckle  
on my shoulders,  
41 so that the Trojans may take me for  
you, and hold back  
42 from the fighting, and the warlike sons  
of the Achaeans catch their breath,  
43 worn as they are; for the breathing-

spaces of war are few.

44 Fresh men, with one shout, could easily  
push men weary

45 of battle back on the city, away from  
the ships and the huts.”

46 So he spoke, begging — the great fool:  
it was his own

47 death and evil doom he was begging  
for.

48 And deeply troubled, swift-footed  
Achilles answered him:

49 “Ah, Zeus-sprung Patroclus — what a  
thing you have said.

50 I care for no prophecy, none that I  
know of,

51 nor has my lady mother told me  
anything from Zeus.

52 But this bitter grief keeps coming at my  
heart and spirit:5



53 when a man is minded to rob his own  
equal  
54 and take his prize back, just because he  
outranks him in power.  
55 That is my bitter grief; I have suffered  
it to the heart.  
56 The girl the sons of the Achaeans  
picked out as my prize —  
57 won with my own spear when I sacked  
her walled city —  
58 her the lord Agamemnon took back out  
of my hands,  
59 Atreus' son, as if I were some vagrant  
without honor.  
60 But we will let that be — a thing done  
and past. It seems there was  
61 no way, after all, to be angry in my  
heart forever;  
62 and yet I said I would not lay my wrath

aside

63 until the moment the war-shout and  
the fighting reached

64 my own ships. So: you put my famous  
armor on your shoulders,

65 and lead the war-loving Myrmidons  
into the fight,

66 since the dark cloud of Trojans has  
closed hard

67 around the ships, and the Argives are  
penned against

68 the surf-line of the sea, and hold only a  
little strip

69 of ground; and the whole city of the  
Trojans has come out

70 emboldened — because they do not see  
the face of my helmet

71 blazing near them. Soon enough they  
would be running

72 and choking the gullies with their dead,  
if the lord Agamemnon  
73 knew how to deal kindly with me.  
Instead they besiege the camp.  
74 For no spear rages in the hands of  
Diomedes,  
75 Tydeus' son, to beat destruction off the  
Danaans;  
76 and I have not yet heard the voice of  
Atreus' son  
77 shouting from his hated head. It is  
man-slaughtering Hector's  
78 voice that breaks around them, calling  
the Trojans on; and they  
79 hold the whole plain with their war-  
cry, beating the Achaeans in battle.  
80 Even so, Patroclus — beat the ruin off  
the ships:  
81 fall on them with all your power, or

they will burn

82 the ships with blazing fire and take  
away our own dear homecoming.

83 But obey me — here is the whole end of  
my word, laid in your mind —

84 so that you may win me great honor  
and glory<sup>6</sup>

85 in the eyes of all the Danaans, and they  
send back

86 the beautiful girl, and bring shining  
gifts besides:

87 once you have driven them from the  
ships, come back. And if

88 the loud-thunderer, Hera's lord, grants  
you your hour of glory,

89 do not go lusting after battle apart  
from me

90 against the war-loving Trojans — you  
will strip my honor thinner;

91 and do not, exulting in the war and the  
slaughter,  
92 killing Trojans, lead the way to Ilion:  
93 one of the everlasting gods from  
Olympus may step in —  
94 the worker-from-afar, Apollo, loves  
them dearly.  
95 Turn back, once you have set the light  
of safety in the ships,  
96 and leave the rest to cut each other  
down across the plain.  
97 For — O father Zeus, Athena, Apollo —  
would<sup>7</sup>  
98 that not one Trojan might escape  
death, of all there are,  
99 and not one Argive; and that we two  
alone might slip destruction,  
100 so that alone we might undo Troy's  
holy coronal of towers.”

101 So the two of them spoke such things  
to one another.

102 But Ajax could hold no longer: the  
missiles pressed him too hard.<sup>8</sup>

103 The mind of Zeus was breaking him,  
and the proud Trojans

104 with their throwing; and the bright  
helmet at his temples

105 rang terribly under the blows — struck  
and struck again

106 on its well-made cheek-pieces; and his  
left shoulder ached,

107 steady so long under the glittering  
shield; yet they could not

108 shake him loose for all the missiles  
they leaned against him.

109 And always he labored, gasping hard,  
the sweat streaming

110 down from every limb of him, and he

could nowhere

111 catch his breath: everywhere evil was  
propped on evil.

112 Tell me now, Muses, who keep your  
homes on Olympus —9

113 how the fire first fell on the ships of  
the Achaeans.

114 Hector, coming close, struck the ash  
spear of Ajax

115 with his great sword, behind the point  
at the socket,

116 and sheared it clean off; and  
Telamonian Ajax

117 brandished a docked shaft, useless in  
his hand, while far away

118 the bronze point rang on the ground  
where it fell.

119 And Ajax knew in his blameless heart,  
and shuddered at it:

120 the work of gods — that Zeus who  
thunders on high was shearing off  
121 all the plans of his fighting, and willed  
victory to the Trojans.  
122 He drew back out of range. And onto  
the swift ship they hurled  
123 unwearying fire; and the quenchless  
flame poured over it at once.  
124 So the fire wrapped the stern of the  
ship. And Achilles  
125 struck both his thighs and spoke to  
Patroclus:  
126 “Up, Zeus-sprung Patroclus, master of  
horses!  
127 I see the rush of consuming fire at the  
ships.  
128 Before they take them, and there is no  
escaping left —  
129 get into the armor, quick, and I will



gather the men.”

130 So he spoke; and Patroclus armed  
himself in the flashing bronze.10

131 First he set the greaves along his shins,  
132 fine greaves, fitted with silver ankle-  
pieces;

133 second, he put the corslet about his  
chest,

134 the intricate, star-bright corslet of the  
swift-footed son of Aeacus.

135 Around his shoulders he threw the  
sword, silver-studded,

136 bronze; and after that the shield, great  
and heavy;

137 and on his powerful head he set the  
well-made helmet,

138 horsehair-crested; the plume nodded  
terribly above it.

139 And he took two stout spears, fitted to

his grip —

140 only the spear he did not take of  
Aeacus' blameless son:

141 heavy, huge, compact — no other of  
the Achaeans

142 could swing it; Achilles alone knew  
how to swing it —

143 the Pelian ash that Chiron gave his  
dear father

144 from the peak of Pelion, to be death  
for heroes.

145 The horses he told Automedon to  
yoke, and quickly —

146 the man he honored most after  
Achilles breaker of men,

147 and trustiest at his post to await the  
shout of battle.

148 So Automedon led the swift horses  
under the yoke,

149 Xanthus and Balius, the pair who flew  
with the winds:11  
150 the harpy Podarge conceived them by  
the West Wind  
151 as she grazed in a meadow beside the  
stream of Ocean.  
152 And in the side-traces he put  
blameless Pedasus,  
153 whom Achilles brought home when he  
took Eëtion's city:  
154 a horse who, mortal as he was, kept  
pace with immortal horses.  
155 And Achilles went down the huts and  
armed the Myrmidons,  
156 all of them, in their war-gear. And  
they, like wolves12  
157 that eat flesh raw, hearts full of  
unspeakable courage,  
158 who have brought down a great

antlered stag in the mountains

159 and tear it, and every muzzle among  
them is red with blood;

160 and in a pack they go to a spring of  
dark water

161 to lap with their thin tongues the  
black surface-water,

162 belching up clotted gore; and the  
heart in their chests

163 is fearless still, though every belly is  
stretched:

164 such were the leaders and lords of the  
Myrmidons

165 streaming round the brave aide of the  
swift-footed son of Aeacus;

166 and among them stood Achilles the  
warlike,

167 urging on the horses and the shield-  
bearing men.

168 Fifty were the swift ships that  
Achilles, 13  
169 dear to Zeus, led to Troy, and in each  
one  
170 fifty men, companions at the oar-  
benches;  
171 and he made five men leaders, and  
trusted them  
172 to command, while he himself in his  
great power was king.  
173 One line was led by Menesthius of the  
glittering corslet,  
174 the son of Spercheius, the sky-fed  
river:  
175 Peleus' daughter bore him, beautiful  
Polydora,  
176 a woman bedded with a god, to tireless  
Spercheius —  
177 though in name to Borus, Perieres'

son, who wed her

178 openly before men, and gave bride-  
gifts past counting.

179 The second was led by warlike  
Eudorus, born

180 out of wedlock: Polymele, beautiful in  
the dance,

181 bore him — Phylas's daughter. Strong  
Hermes, the slayer of Argus,

182 fell in love with her, his eyes catching  
her among the singers

183 in the dancing-choir of Artemis of the  
golden distaff, the huntress-crier;

184 and straightway he climbed to her  
upper room and lay with her

185 in secret — Hermes the gracious — and  
she gave him a shining son,

186 Eudorus, quick beyond all men to run,  
and a fighter.

187 And when Eileithyia of hard labor had  
brought him  
188 out into the light, and he had seen the  
rays of the sun,  
189 the strong might of Echeclus, Actor's  
son,  
190 led her home to his house, once he  
had given countless bride-gifts;  
191 and old Phylas reared the boy well,  
and cherished him,  
192 wrapping him round with love, as  
though he were his own son.  
193 The third was led by warlike  
Peisander,  
194 Maemalus's son, who outshone all the  
Myrmidons  
195 in spear-fighting, after Peleus' son's  
own companion.  
196 The fourth the old horseman Phoenix

led;

197 the fifth, Alcimedon, Laerces'  
blameless son.

198 Now when Achilles had set them all  
with their leaders,

199 duly marshaled, he laid this hard word  
upon them:14

200 “Myrmidons — let no man forget for  
me the threats

201 you made beside the swift ships  
against the Trojans

202 all through my wrath, when every one  
of you accused me:

203 ‘Cruel son of Peleus — your mother  
reared you on bile!

204 Pitiless — holding your companions  
by the ships against their will!

205 Let us at least sail home again in our  
seagoing ships,



206 since this ruinous anger has fallen on  
your heart.’

207 So you would gather and mutter at  
me. Now here it is —

208 the great work of battle you were  
lusting for, in plain sight.

209 Now let each man fight the Trojans  
with a stout heart.”

210 So speaking he stirred the fury and  
the heart of every man,

211 and the ranks locked tighter, once they  
heard their king.

212 As when a man fits close the stones of  
a high house’s wall, **15**

213 building against the strength of the  
winds,

214 so close were fitted the helmets and  
the bossed shields:

215 buckler pressed on buckler, helmet on

helmet, man on man,  
216 and the horsehair crests on the bright  
ridges touched  
217 as they nodded, so close they stood to  
one another.  
218 And in front of them all two men  
armed themselves,  
219 Patroclus and Automedon, of one  
mind between them:  
220 to fight in the forefront of the  
Myrmidons. But Achilles  
221 went into his hut, and lifted the lid of  
a chest,  
222 beautiful, intricate, that silver-footed  
Thetis<sup>16</sup>  
223 had put aboard his ship to carry, filled  
with tunics  
224 and wind-proof cloaks and thick-piled  
rugs.

225 And in it lay a wrought cup: no other  
man  
226 drank the fire-bright wine from it, and  
to no god  
227 did he pour from it, except to Zeus the  
father.  
228 This he took from the chest and  
cleansed with sulphur  
229 first, then washed it in fair streams of  
water,  
230 and washed his own hands, and drew  
off the fire-bright wine.  
231 Then he prayed, standing in the  
middle of the yard, and poured the wine  
232 looking up into heaven; and Zeus who  
delights in thunder marked him well:  
233 “Zeus — lord — Dodonaean —  
Pelagian — dweller far off,<sup>17</sup>  
234 ruling over wintry Dodona; and

around you the Selloi

235 live, your interpreters, men of  
unwashed feet, who sleep on the ground.

236 Once before, when I prayed, you heard  
my word:

237 you did me honor, and struck the  
Achaean army hard.

238 So now again accomplish this desire  
for me.

239 I myself will stay in the gathering-  
place of the ships,

240 but I am sending out my companion,  
with many Myrmidons,

241 to fight. Send glory out with him,  
wide-seeing Zeus,

242 and make the heart bold in his chest,  
so that even Hector

243 may learn whether our aide knows  
how to make war

244 alone — or whether his hands rage  
invincible only  
245 when I myself go into the grind of the  
war-god.  
246 But when he has driven the fighting  
and the war-cry from the ships,  
247 then let him come back to me at the  
swift ships unhurt,  
248 with all his armor, and his close-  
fighting companions.”  
249 So he spoke in prayer, and Zeus the  
counselor heard him;  
250 and the father granted him one thing,  
and refused the other:18  
251 that Patroclus should push the war  
and battle back from the ships  
252 he granted; and refused that he come  
back safe out of the fighting.  
253 So Achilles, having poured and prayed

to Zeus the father,  
254 went into his hut again and laid the  
cup in the chest,  
255 and came out and stood before the  
hut; for his heart still longed  
256 to watch the dread struggle of Trojans  
and Achaeans.  
257 And they, armed all together with  
great-hearted Patroclus,  
258 marched until they charged the  
Trojans, thinking great things.  
259 At once they came pouring out like  
roadside wasps19  
260 that boys are forever provoking,  
forever tormenting —  
261 wasps with their nests along the road  
— as boys will,  
262 the little fools: they make a common  
evil for many.

263 If some traveling man going by then  
stirs the wasps  
264 without meaning it, out they come  
with fearless hearts,  
265 every one flying at him, defending  
their young:  
266 with their heart and courage the  
Myrmidons then  
267 came pouring from the ships; and the  
quenchless roar rose.  
268 And Patroclus called to his  
companions with a great shout:  
269 “Myrmidons, companions of Achilles,  
Peleus’ son —  
270 be men, my friends; remember your  
rushing courage;  
271 so we may honor Peleus’ son, who is  
far the best  
272 of the Argives by the ships — he, and

his close-fighting aides —

273 and so that Atreus' son, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon,

274 may know his blindness: that he  
honored not at all the best of the  
Achaeans.”20

275 So speaking he stirred the fury and  
the heart of every man,

276 and they fell on the Trojans in one  
mass; and around them the ships

277 echoed terribly under the shouting of  
the Achaeans.

278 But the Trojans, when they saw the  
stout son of Menoetius,

279 himself and his aide beside him,  
blazing in their armor,

280 the heart was shaken in all of them,  
and the battle-lines wavered:

281 they thought the swift-footed son of



Peleus by the ships

282 had thrown away his wrath and taken  
back friendship;

283 and each man looked about him for  
escape from sheer destruction.

284 Then Patroclus first cast with his  
shining spear,

285 straight into the middle, where the  
most men were driven

286 in confusion around the stern of the  
ship of great-hearted

287 Protesilaus, and he struck Pyraechmes  
— who led the Paeonians, 21

288 who fight from chariots, out of  
Amydon, from the wide-flowing Axius —

289 in the right shoulder; and he went  
down on his back in the dust

290 with a groan, and around him his  
companions panicked,

291 the Paeonians: for Patroclus had  
driven the panic among them all,  
292 killing their leader, who was their best  
in battle.  
293 He drove them from the ships, and  
quenched the blazing fire;  
294 and the ship was left there, half-  
burnt. And the Trojans fled  
295 with an unearthly din, and the  
Danaans poured after them  
296 along the hollow ships; and the roar  
rose unabating.  
297 As when from the high crest of a great  
mountain  
298 Zeus who gathers the lightning moves  
a close-packed cloud,  
299 and all the lookout-peaks show clear,  
and the jutting headlands,  
300 and the glens; and from heaven the

measureless air breaks open:

301 so the Danaans, having thrust the  
enemy fire from the ships,

302 caught their breath a little. But there  
was no pause in the war:

303 for the Trojans, before the Achaeans  
dear to Ares, were not yet

304 turned in headlong flight away from  
the black ships —

305 they still stood facing them, giving  
ground from the ships only by need.

306 Then man killed man, as the battle  
scattered,

307 among the leaders. First the stout son  
of Menoetius

308 hit Areilycus in the thigh, just as he  
turned,

309 with his sharp-pointed spear, and  
drove the bronze clean through;

310 the spear shattered the bone, and he  
came down on his face  
311 to the ground. Then warlike Menelaus  
wounded Thoas  
312 where the chest showed bare beside  
the shield, and unstrung his limbs.  
313 And Phyleus' son, watching Amphiclus  
as he charged in,  
314 was quicker: he lunged and hit the top  
of his leg,  
315 where a man's muscle is thickest, and  
around the spear-point  
316 the sinews were torn through; and  
darkness covered his eyes.  
317 And of Nestor's sons, one — Antilochus  
— stabbed Atymnius  
318 with his sharp spear, and drove the  
bronze point through his flank;  
319 he fell forward. But Maris, close in,

rushed Antilochus

320 with his spear, in fury for his brother,

321 standing in front of the corpse; but

godlike Thrasymedes

322 was quicker: he lunged before he

could stab — and did not miss —

323 straight at the shoulder; and the

spear-point tore the arm's base

324 away from the muscles, and cracked

the bone clean through:

325 he fell with a thud, and darkness

covered his eyes.

326 So those two, beaten down by two

brothers,

327 went to Erebus — the brave

companions of Sarpedon,

328 spearmen sons of Amisodarus, the

man who reared

329 the raging Chimaera, an evil to many

men.**22**

**330** And Ajax, Oïleus' son, sprang on  
Cleobulus

**331** and took him alive, tangled in the  
crush; but there and then

**332** he unstrung his strength, driving the  
hilted sword through his neck:

**333** the whole blade ran hot with blood,  
and down over his eyes

**334** came purple death, and fate the  
overpowering.

**335** Peneleos and Lycon ran together: with  
their spears

**336** they had missed each other, both casts  
thrown in vain,

**337** so they ran together again with  
swords. There Lycon

**338** hacked at the ridge of the horsehair-  
crested helmet,

339 and the sword shattered at the hilt;  
but Peneleos struck  
340 his neck below the ear, and the whole  
blade sank in,  
341 and only skin held: the head lolled  
sideways, and his limbs were unstrung.  
342 And Meriones, overtaking Acamas on  
quick feet,  
343 stabbed his right shoulder as he was  
mounting his chariot;  
344 he crashed from the car, and mist  
poured down over his eyes.  
345 And Idomeneus stabbed Erymas in the  
mouth  
346 with the pitiless bronze: the bronze  
spear passed straight through,  
347 up under the brain, and split the  
white bones;  
348 his teeth were shaken out, and both

his eyes

349 filled up with blood; and blood  
through his open mouth

350 and through his nostrils he blew as he  
gaped; and death's black cloud wrapped  
round him.

351 These, then, were the Danaan leaders,  
and each killed his man.

352 As ravaging wolves fall on lambs or on  
kids,

353 snatching them out from the flocks,  
when in the mountains

354 a shepherd's carelessness has let them  
scatter — the wolves see,

355 and swiftly seize the young whose  
hearts have no courage:

356 so the Danaans fell on the Trojans;  
and the Trojans remembered

357 the harsh clamor of rout, and forgot



their rushing courage.

358 And the great Ajax strained forever to  
cast his spear

359 at Hector of the bronze helmet; but  
Hector, in his war-craft,

360 his broad shoulders covered by the  
bull's-hide shield,

361 watched the whistle of arrows and the  
thud of javelins.

362 Truly he knew the tide of the battle  
had turned;

363 but even so he stood, and tried to save  
his loyal companions.

364 As when a cloud comes from Olympus  
into heaven<sup>23</sup>

365 out of the clear upper air, when Zeus  
stretches the squall,

366 so the shouting and the rout came  
from the ships;

367 and in no good order they crossed  
back. Hector's own swift horses  
368 carried him off, armor and all; and he  
left the Trojan army  
369 penned against their will by the dug  
ditch;  
370 and in the ditch many swift chariot-  
teams  
371 snapped the pole at the tip and  
abandoned their lords' cars.  
372 But Patroclus followed, calling hard to  
the Danaans,  
373 with evil intent for the Trojans; and  
they in their shrieking rout  
374 choked every path, once their lines  
were cut; and high up the dust-squall  
375 scattered under the clouds, and the  
whole-hoofed horses strained  
376 back toward the city, away from the

ships and the huts.

377 And wherever Patroclus saw the most  
men driven in confusion,

378 there he steered with a shout; and  
men kept falling under his axles

379 face-first from their chariots, and the  
cars went clattering over.

380 Straight across the ditch the swift  
horses leapt —

381 the immortal horses the gods gave  
Peleus as shining gifts —

382 straining onward; and his heart cried  
out for Hector,

383 hot to strike him; but Hector's swift  
horses carried him away.

384 And as the whole black earth is  
weighed down under a storm

385 on a day of harvest-season, when Zeus  
pours down

386 his most violent water, when in rage  
he turns bitter  
387 against men who by force render  
crooked judgments in the assembly  
388 and drive justice out, careless of the  
gods' vengeance:  
389 all their rivers rise in flood as they  
run,  
390 and the torrents cut the hillsides into  
gullies,  
391 and down to the darkening sea they  
roar headlong  
392 from the mountains, groaning huge,  
and the works of men are diminished:  
393 so huge was the groaning of the  
Trojan mares as they ran.  
394 And Patroclus, when he had cut off  
the front battle-lines,  
395 turned and penned them back against

the ships, and would not let them  
396 climb to the city for all their straining,  
but in the space between  
397 the ships and the river and the high  
wall  
398 he swept and killed, and exacted the  
blood-price for many.24  
399 There first he hit Pronous with his  
shining spear  
400 where the chest showed bare beside  
the shield, and unstrung his limbs:  
401 he fell with a thud. Then Thestor,  
Enops's son —  
402 his second rush — Thestor, who sat  
hunched  
403 in his polished chariot, struck out of  
his wits, the reins  
404 slipped from his hands: Patroclus  
came close and stabbed him

405 through the right jaw, and drove the  
spear on through his teeth,  
406 and hauled him by the spear-shaft  
over the chariot-rail — as a man  
407 sitting on a jutting rock hauls a sacred  
fish  
408 out of the sea with his line and his  
glittering bronze:  
409 so he hauled him gaping from the  
chariot on the shining spear  
410 and tumbled him down on his face;  
and the life left him as he fell.  
411 Then Erylaus, running in — he struck  
him with a stone  
412 full mid-skull, and the whole head  
split in two  
413 inside the heavy helmet; and he  
dropped face-first  
414 to the ground, and death that breaks

the spirit poured round him.

415 Then one upon another — Erymas and  
Amphoterus and Epaltes,

416 Tlepolemus Damastor's son, and  
Echius and Pyris,

417 Ipheus and Euippus and Polymelus,  
Argeas' son —

418 he brought them all, in heaps, to the  
earth that feeds so many.

419 But Sarpedon, when he saw his  
companions of the unbelted tunics<sup>25</sup>

420 broken under the hands of Patroclus,  
Menoetius's son,

421 called out, rebuking the godlike  
Lycians:

422 “Shame, Lycians! Where are you  
running? Now be quick — against him.

423 I will meet this man myself, and learn

424 who it is that conquers here — who

has worked the Trojans

425 so much evil already, and unstrung  
the knees of many good men.”

426 He spoke, and leapt with his weapons  
from the chariot to the ground;

427 and Patroclus on the other side, seeing  
him, sprang from his car.

428 And they — like hook-clawed, crook-  
beaked vultures

429 screaming great cries on a high rock-  
face as they fight —

430 so they rushed screaming at one  
another.

431 And the son of crooked-counseled  
Cronos saw them, and pitied,

432 and spoke to Hera, his sister and his  
wife:

433 “Ah me — my Sarpedon, dearest to me  
of men,



434 is fated to be broken under Patroclus,  
Menoetius's son.  
435 And my heart is divided as I ponder it:  
436 whether to snatch him living out of  
the tearful battle  
437 and set him down in the rich country  
of Lycia,  
438 or to break him now under the hands  
of Menoetius's son."  
439 Then ox-eyed lady Hera answered  
him:  
440 "Most dread son of Cronos, what a  
word you have spoken!  
441 A man — a mortal, long since doomed  
to his fate —  
442 and you mean to release him back out  
of harsh-sounding death?  
443 Do it. But we other gods will not all  
approve you.

444 And I will tell you another thing — lay  
it away in your mind:  
445 if you send Sarpedon living to his own  
house,  
446 consider: some other god may  
likewise choose  
447 to send his dear son out of the strong  
encounter —  
448 for many sons of the immortals fight  
around Priam's great city,  
449 and you will set loose terrible  
resentment among their fathers.  
450 But if he is dear to you — if your heart  
grieves for him —  
451 then let him be broken in the strong  
encounter  
452 under the hands of Patroclus,  
Menoetius's son;  
453 but when his soul and his life have left

him,  
454 send Death to carry him, and painless  
Sleep,  
455 until they come to the country of wide  
Lycia;  
456 and there his brothers and kinsmen  
will give him burial  
457 with a tomb and a grave-stone: for  
that is the honor-right of the dead.”  
458 So she spoke, and the father of men  
and gods did not refuse her;  
459 but he rained down drops of blood  
upon the earth,  
460 honoring his dear son, whom  
Patroclus was about  
461 to destroy in deep-soiled Troy, far  
from his fatherland.  
462 And when they were close, advancing  
on one another,

463 Patroclus struck far-famed  
Thrasymelus,  
464 the brave aide of lord Sarpedon,  
465 in the lower belly, and unstrung his  
limbs.  
466 And Sarpedon, casting second, missed  
his man  
467 with the shining spear, but wounded  
the horse Pedasus<sup>26</sup>  
468 in the right shoulder; and he  
screamed away his life,  
469 and went down crying in the dust, and  
his spirit flew from him.  
470 The two yoke-horses reared apart, the  
yoke creaked,  
471 and the reins fouled over them, with  
the trace-horse lying in the dust.  
472 But spear-famed Automedon found  
the remedy:

473 drawing the thin-edged sword from  
his massive thigh,  
474 he sprang and cut away the trace-  
horse, and did not fumble;  
475 the pair righted themselves and  
pulled taut in the harness;  
476 and the two men came together again  
in heart-devouring strife.  
477 Then Sarpedon missed again with his  
shining spear:  
478 over Patroclus's left shoulder the  
point of the spear  
479 passed, and did not strike him. But  
Patroclus in his turn  
480 rose with the bronze; and his shot did  
not go in vain from his hand,  
481 but struck where the beating heart is  
closed in the midriff.  
482 He fell as an oak falls, or a white

poplar,<sup>27</sup>

<sup>483</sup> or a towering pine, that carpenters up  
in the mountains

<sup>484</sup> cut down with fresh-whetted axes to  
be a ship's timber:

<sup>485</sup> so he lay stretched out before his  
horses and chariot,

<sup>486</sup> bellowing, clawing at the blood-  
soaked dust.

<sup>487</sup> As a lion kills a bull, coming in among  
the herd —

<sup>488</sup> a fiery, great-hearted bull among the  
shambling cattle —

<sup>489</sup> and it perishes groaning under the  
lion's jaws:

<sup>490</sup> so under Patroclus the leader of the  
Lycian shield-men

<sup>491</sup> raged as he was killed; and he called  
his dear companion by name:

492 “Glaucus, old friend — fighter among  
men — now above all

493 you must be a spearman and a daring  
man of war;

494 now let evil battle be your desire, if  
you are quick at all.

495 First go everywhere and rouse the  
leaders of the Lycians

496 to fight for Sarpedon’s body;

497 and then fight for me yourself with  
the bronze.

498 For I will be your shame and your  
hanging head

499 all your days, forever after, if the  
Achaeans

500 strip my armor here where I fell in  
the gathering-place of the ships.

501 Hold on with all your strength, and  
drive on the whole army.”

502 As he was speaking so, the end that is  
death covered him —  
503 his eyes and his nostrils. And  
Patroclus, setting his heel on his chest,  
504 drew the spear out of his flesh, and  
the midriff followed it:  
505 he pulled out his life and the spear-  
point together.28  
506 And the Myrmidons held the snorting  
horses there,  
507 plunging to bolt, now they had left  
their masters' chariot.  
508 But on Glaucus came terrible grief at  
the sound of that voice,  
509 and his heart was churned, that he  
could not help him.  
510 He gripped his own arm and pressed it  
hard, for the wound  
511 wore at him — the wound Teucer's



arrow had dealt him as he stormed  
512 the high wall, beating harm away from  
his companions.  
513 And he spoke in prayer to Apollo who  
strikes from afar:29  
514 “Hear me, lord — you who are  
somewhere in the rich country of Lycia  
515 or here in Troy: you have power  
everywhere to hear  
516 a man in grief, as grief has come on  
me now.  
517 For I have this powerful wound; my  
arm is pierced  
518 with sharp pains through and  
through, and the blood  
519 will not dry; my shoulder is heavy  
under it;  
520 I cannot hold my spear steady, cannot  
go

521 and fight the enemy. And the best of  
men has perished —  
522 Sarpedon, son of Zeus; and Zeus does  
not defend even his own child.  
523 But you, lord — heal me this powerful  
wound;  
524 lull the pains, and give me strength, so  
I may call  
525 my Lycian companions and drive  
them to the fighting,  
526 and fight myself for the body of the  
dead man.”  
527 So he spoke in prayer, and Phoebus  
Apollo heard him.  
528 At once he stilled the pains, and on  
the grievous wound  
529 he dried the dark blood, and threw  
strength into his heart.  
530 And Glaucus knew it in his heart, and

was glad

531 that the great god had heard his  
prayer so quickly.

532 First he went everywhere and roused  
the leaders of the Lycians

533 to fight for Sarpedon's body;

534 then he went with long strides after  
the Trojans —

535 after Polydamas, Panthous's son, and  
brilliant Agenor,

536 and after Aeneas, and Hector of the  
bronze helmet;

537 and standing close he spoke winged  
words:

538 "Hector — now you have wholly  
forgotten your allies,30

539 who for your sake, far from their  
friends and their fatherland,

540 breathe out their lives; and you will

not help them.

541 Sarpedon lies dead — the leader of the  
Lycian shield-men,

542 who kept Lycia safe by his judgments  
and his strength:

543 brazen Ares has broken him on  
Patroclus's spear.

544 Friends, stand by him! Feel the  
outrage in your hearts,

545 or the Myrmidons will strip his armor  
and defile his body,

546 in anger for all the Danaans we have  
killed,

547 the men our spears cut down beside  
the swift ships.”

548 So he spoke; and grief seized the  
Trojans, head to foot,

549 unbearable, not to be borne down —  
for he was a stay of their city,

550 foreigner though he was: many men  
had followed him,  
551 and he himself was their best in battle.  
552 They went straight for the Danaans,  
hot; and Hector led them,  
553 angered for Sarpedon. But the  
Achaean were driven on  
554 by the shaggy heart of Patroclus,  
Menoetius's son:  
555 he spoke first to the two Ajaxes, eager  
as they already were:  
556 "You two Ajaxes — now let your  
pleasure be defense,  
557 the men you were among men before  
— or braver.  
558 The man lies dead who first leapt  
inside the wall of the Achaeans:  
559 Sarpedon. If only we could take him  
and defile him,

560 and strip the armor from his  
shoulders, and break  
561 some companion of his defending him,  
with the pitiless bronze.”  
562 So he spoke; and they themselves  
were furious to beat the enemy off.  
563 And when on both sides they had  
strengthened their battle-lines,  
564 Trojans and Lycians, Myrmidons and  
Achaeans,  
565 they clashed together to fight around  
the dead man’s body  
566 with a terrible war-shout; and the  
men’s armor rang loud.  
567 And Zeus stretched a deadly night  
over the strong encounter, 31  
568 so that around his dear son the deadly  
toil of battle might be waged.  
569 And the Trojans at first pushed back

the bright-eyed Achaeans,  
570 for a man was hit who was by no  
means the worst of the Myrmidons:  
571 brilliant Epeigeus, son of great-  
hearted Agacles,32  
572 who was king once in well-peopled  
Budeum —  
573 before: but having killed a noble  
cousin,  
574 he came a suppliant to Peleus and  
silver-footed Thetis,  
575 and they sent him to follow Achilles,  
breaker of men,  
576 to Ilion of the fine colts, to fight the  
Trojans.  
577 He was laying hold of the corpse when  
glorious Hector  
578 struck him with a stone full on the  
head; and the whole head split in two

579 inside the heavy helmet; and he  
dropped face-first  
580 over the dead man, and death that  
breaks the spirit poured round him.  
581 And grief came over Patroclus for his  
fallen companion,  
582 and he swept straight through the  
front-fighters like a swift hawk  
583 that sends the daws and starlings  
scattering:  
584 straight so, Patroclus, master of  
horses, you swept  
585 at the Lycians and Trojans, with anger  
in your heart for your companion.  
586 And he struck Sthenelaus,  
Ithaemenes' dear son,  
587 on the neck with a stone, and tore the  
tendons from it;  
588 and the front-fighters gave ground,



and glorious Hector.

589 As far as the carry of a long throwing-  
spear

590 a man sends flying, testing his  
strength in the games

591 or in war, against enemies who break  
the spirit:

592 so far the Trojans gave, and the  
Achaeans pushed them.

593 Then Glaucus first, the leader of the  
Lycian shield-men,

594 turned, and killed great-hearted  
Bathycles,

595 the dear son of Chalcon, whose home  
was in Hellas —

596 a man who stood out among the  
Myrmidons for riches and wealth:

597 him Glaucus stabbed full in the chest  
with his spear,

598 wheeling suddenly, just as the man's  
pursuit had caught him.  
599 He fell with a thud; and close grief  
took the Achaeans,  
600 so good a man went down; and the  
Trojans rejoiced greatly,  
601 and came and stood in a mass around  
him. But the Achaeans  
602 did not forget their courage: they  
carried their fury straight at them.  
603 Then Meriones took a Trojan fighter,  
helmed in bronze —  
604 Laogonus, daring son of Onetor, who  
was priest  
605 of Idaean Zeus, and honored like a god  
by the people:  
606 he struck him below the jaw, under  
the ear; and quickly the spirit  
607 went out of his limbs, and the hateful

darkness took him.

608 And Aeneas let fly his bronze spear at  
Meriones,

609 hoping to catch him as he came on  
under his shield;

610 but he saw it coming and dodged the  
bronze spear,

611 ducking forward; and behind him the  
long spear

612 stuck fast in the ground, and the butt-  
end stood quivering;

613 and there at last massive Ares stilled  
its fury —

614 and the point of Aeneas's spear went  
quivering

615 into the earth, hurled in vain from his  
massive hand.

616 And Aeneas was angered at heart, and  
called out:

617 “Meriones — dancer though you are,  
my spear<sup>33</sup>  
618 would have stopped your dancing for  
good, if I had only hit you.”  
619 And spear-famed Meriones answered  
him:  
620 “Aeneas — strong as you are, it is hard  
for you  
621 to quench the fury of every man who  
stands  
622 against you in defense. You too were  
made mortal.  
623 And if I hit you square in the middle  
with the sharp bronze,  
624 strong as you are, and sure of your  
hands, you would quickly  
625 give the triumph to me, and your soul  
to Hades of the famed colts.”  
626 So he spoke; and the stout son of

Menoetius rebuked him:

627 “Meriones — you are a brave man:  
why speechify?

628 Old friend, the Trojans will not back  
away from the corpse

629 for insults. The earth will hold down  
some of them first.

630 In hands lies the outcome of war; of  
words, in council.

631 So there is no need to pile up speech,  
but to fight.”

632 So speaking he led the way, and the  
other followed, a man like a god.

633 And from them — as the din of  
woodcutting men rises

634 in the mountain glens, and the sound  
carries far:

635 so from the wide-wayed earth their  
pounding rose,

636 of bronze and leather and well-made  
oxhide shields,  
637 stabbed at with swords and double-  
curved spears.  
638 And by now not even a discerning  
man could have known  
639 brilliant Sarpedon, wrapped from his  
head clean down  
640 to the soles of his feet in missiles and  
blood and dust.34  
641 And they crowded round the corpse  
always — as flies  
642 in a farmstead buzz about the  
brimming milk-pails  
643 in the season of spring, when the milk  
wets the vessels:  
644 so they crowded round the corpse.  
And Zeus never once  
645 turned his shining eyes away from the

strong encounter,

646 but gazed down at them always, and  
pondered in his heart,

647 brooding long over the killing of  
Patroclus:35

648 whether now, in the strong encounter,  
over godlike

649 Sarpedon, glorious Hector should cut  
him down

650 with the bronze, and strip the armor  
from his shoulders —

651 or whether he should swell the sheer  
toil for still more men.

652 And as he pondered, this seemed to  
him the better course:

653 that the brave aide of Achilles, Peleus'  
son,

654 should drive the Trojans and Hector of  
the bronze helmet

655 back toward the city once more, and  
take the life from many.  
656 And in Hector first he put a  
strengthless heart:  
657 he climbed into his chariot and turned  
to flee, and called  
658 the other Trojans to fly; for he knew  
the sacred scales of Zeus.  
659 Then not even the powerful Lycians  
stood, but panicked  
660 all of them, when they saw their king  
struck through the heart,  
661 lying under the pile of dead — for  
many had fallen  
662 over him, once the son of Cronos  
stretched the strife taut.  
663 And the Achaeans stripped the armor  
from Sarpedon's shoulders,  
664 bronze and glittering; and the stout



son of Menoetius

665 gave it to his companions to carry to  
the hollow ships.

666 And then Zeus the cloud-gatherer  
spoke to Apollo:36

667 “Up now, dear Phoebus: go cleanse  
Sarpedon of the dark

668 clotted blood, out of the range of the  
missiles, and carry him

669 far away, and wash him in the running  
river,

670 and anoint him with ambrosia, and  
put immortal clothing round him;

671 and send him to be carried by swift  
escorts,

672 the twin brothers Sleep and Death,  
who quickly

673 will set him down in the rich country  
of wide Lycia.

674 There his brothers and kinsmen will  
give him burial  
675 with a tomb and a grave-stone: for  
that is the honor-right of the dead.”  
676 So he spoke, and Apollo did not  
disobey his father,  
677 but went down from the mountains of  
Ida into the dread din,  
678 and at once lifted brilliant Sarpedon  
out of the missiles,  
679 and carried him far away, and washed  
him in the running river,  
680 and anointed him with ambrosia, and  
put immortal clothing round him;  
681 and he sent him to be carried by swift  
escorts,  
682 the twin brothers Sleep and Death,  
who quickly  
683 set him down in the rich country of

wide Lycia.

684 But Patroclus, calling to his horses  
and Automedon, 37

685 went after the Trojans and Lycians —  
and was greatly blinded,

686 the fool: had he kept the word of  
Peleus' son,

687 he would have escaped the evil doom  
of black death.

688 But always the mind of Zeus is  
stronger than men's:

689 he sends even the brave man running,  
and strips away victory

690 easily — and then again himself drives  
a man to fight;

691 and it was he who now put the fury in  
Patroclus's chest.

692 Then whom first, whom last did you  
strip of his arms,

693 Patroclus, when the gods were calling  
you deathward?  
694 Adrestus first, and Autonus, and  
Echeclus,  
695 and Perimus, Megas's son, and Epistor,  
and Melanippus,  
696 and after them Elasmus, and Mulus,  
and Pylartes:  
697 these he took; and the rest were each  
man minded to run.  
698 And then the sons of the Achaeans  
would have taken high-gated Troy  
699 by the hands of Patroclus — such was  
his raging spear-charge —  
700 had not Phoebus Apollo taken his  
stand on the well-built tower,  
701 with deadly thoughts for him, siding  
with the Trojans.  
702 Three times Patroclus set his foot on

the angle of the high wall,  
703 and three times Apollo slapped him  
back and away,  
704 thrusting at the shining shield with  
his immortal hands.  
705 But when for the fourth time he came  
on like more than man,  
706 the god shouted terribly, and spoke  
winged words:  
707 “Back, Zeus-sprung Patroclus! It is not  
your portion  
708 that the proud Trojans’ city fall to  
your spear —  
709 no, nor to Achilles’, who is a far better  
man than you.”  
710 So he spoke; and Patroclus gave back a  
long way,  
711 dodging the wrath of Apollo who  
strikes from afar.

712 But Hector held his whole-hoofed  
horses at the Scaean Gates,  
713 divided: whether to drive back into  
the confusion and fight,  
714 or shout for the army to gather inside  
the wall.  
715 And as he pondered, Phoebus Apollo  
came and stood by him<sup>38</sup>  
716 in the likeness of a man young and  
strong,  
717 Asius — the uncle of horse-taming  
Hector,  
718 own brother of Hecuba, and son of  
Dymas,  
719 who lived in Phrygia on the streams of  
Sangarius;  
720 in his likeness Apollo, son of Zeus,  
spoke to him:  
721 “Hector, why have you dropped out of

the fighting? It is not right.

722 Would that I were as much stronger  
than you as I am weaker:

723 then you would soon and bitterly  
regret this skulking from the war.

724 Come — drive your strong-hoofed  
horses at Patroclus,

725 and you may take him yet, and Apollo  
hand you the glory.”

726 So speaking, the god went back into  
the toil of men;

727 and glorious Hector ordered war-  
minded Cebriones

728 to lash the horses into the battle. And  
Apollo

729 sank into the crowd, and hurled an  
evil rout

730 among the Argives, and handed glory  
to the Trojans and Hector.

731 And Hector let the other Danaans be —  
killed none of them —  
732 but drove his strong-hoofed horses  
straight at Patroclus;  
733 and Patroclus, facing him, sprang  
from his chariot to the ground  
734 with his spear in his left hand; and in  
the other he caught up a stone,  
735 jagged marble, glittering — his hand  
just closed around it —  
736 and planted himself and hurled it, not  
shrinking long from the man;  
737 and his missile was not wasted: he  
struck Hector's charioteer —39  
738 Cebriones, a bastard son of far-famed  
Priam —  
739 with the reins in his hands, full on the  
forehead with the sharp stone.  
740 The stone crushed both brows



together; the bone did not hold;  
741 and his eyes dropped to the ground in  
the dust  
742 there at his feet; and like a diver he  
plunged  
743 from the well-wrought chariot, and  
the life left his bones.  
744 And mocking him you spoke,  
Patroclus, horseman:  
745 “Well, well — how nimble the man is!  
What easy tumbling!  
746 If ever he found himself on the fish-  
teeming sea,  
747 this man could feed a whole crew,  
diving for oysters,  
748 leaping overboard even in rough  
weather —  
749 as easily as he tumbles now from his  
chariot onto the plain.

750 So: there are acrobats among the  
Trojans too.”

751 So speaking he went for the hero  
Cebriones

752 with the spring of a lion who, ravaging  
the farmsteads,

753 has been struck in the chest — and his  
own courage kills him:

754 so, Patroclus, you leapt on Cebriones,  
blazing.

755 And Hector on the other side sprang  
from his chariot to the ground;

756 and the two fought over Cebriones like  
two lions

757 that on a mountain’s peaks, over a  
slain hind,

758 both of them hungry, fight with  
towering hearts:

759 so over Cebriones the two masters of

the war-shout,  
760 Patroclus, Menoetius's son, and  
glorious Hector,  
761 strained to hew each other's flesh with  
the pitiless bronze.  
762 Hector had him by the head, and  
would not let go;  
763 Patroclus, opposite, held a foot; and  
around them the rest,  
764 Trojans and Danaans, joined the  
strong encounter.  
765 As the East Wind and the South  
contend with one another40  
766 in the mountain glens, to shake the  
deep timber —  
767 oak and ash and smooth-barked  
cornel-tree,  
768 that hurl their long slim branches  
each against each

769 with a prodigious noise, and the crash  
of them breaking:

770 so Trojans and Achaeans, springing at  
one another,

771 cut men down, and neither side  
thought of ruinous flight.

772 And around Cebriones many sharp  
spears stood fixed,

773 and winged arrows leaping from the  
bowstrings,

774 and many great stones battered  
against the shields

775 of the men fighting round him. And he  
in the whirl of dust

776 lay mighty in his mightiness, his  
horsemanship all forgotten.

777 So long as the sun bestrode the middle  
heaven,**41**

778 so long the missiles of both sides

struck home, and the people fell;  
779 but when the sun turned toward the  
unyoking of oxen,  
780 then, beyond their portion, the  
Achaeans proved the stronger.  
781 They dragged the hero Cebriones out  
of the missiles,  
782 out of the Trojans' clamor, and  
stripped the armor from his shoulders;  
783 and Patroclus, with evil intent for the  
Trojans, charged them.  
784 Three times he charged then, the  
equal of swift Ares,  
785 screaming terribly, and three times he  
killed nine men.  
786 But when for the fourth time he came  
on like more than man —  
787 then, Patroclus, the end of your life  
showed clear:

788 for Phoebus met you in the strong  
encounter,  
789 terrible. And Patroclus did not see him  
coming through the confusion,  
790 for he came against him wrapped in  
thick mist,  
791 and stood behind him, and struck his  
back and broad shoulders  
792 with the flat of his hand; and his eyes  
spun.  
793 And Phoebus Apollo knocked the  
helmet from his head:42  
794 it rolled ringing away beneath the  
horses' hooves,  
795 the socketed helmet, and the plumes  
were fouled  
796 with blood and dust. Before this it was  
not lawful  
797 for that horsehair-crested helmet to

be fouled with dust:

798 it guarded the head and the gracious  
brow of a godlike

799 man, Achilles. But then Zeus gave it to  
Hector

800 to wear on his own head; and his  
destruction was near him.

801 And the long-shadowed spear was  
shattered whole in his hands,

802 heavy, huge, compact, helmeted in  
bronze; and from his shoulders

803 the fringed shield with its baldric  
dropped to the ground;

804 and the lord Apollo, son of Zeus,  
loosed the corslet off him.

805 Blindness took his mind; his shining  
limbs were unstrung;

806 he stood dazed. And from behind, at  
close range, a Dardanian

807 struck him with a sharp spear  
between the shoulders:  
808 Euphorbus, Panthous's son, who  
outshone all men of his age<sup>43</sup>  
809 at the spear, at horsemanship, and in  
the race on foot;  
810 indeed he had already brought down  
twenty men from their horses,  
811 though he came the first time with his  
chariot, still learning war.  
812 He it was who first sent a missile into  
you, Patroclus, horseman,  
813 and did not break you; and he ran back  
and merged with the crowd,  
814 snatching the ash spear out of the  
wound — he did not stand  
815 against Patroclus, even unarmed as he  
was, in the combat.  
816 And Patroclus, broken by the god's



blow and the spear,  
817 drew back into the band of his  
companions, dodging doom.  
818 But Hector, when he saw great-  
hearted Patroclus  
819 drawing back, wounded by the sharp  
bronze,  
820 came close on him through the ranks,  
and stabbed with his spear  
821 into the pit of his belly, and drove the  
bronze clean through:  
822 he fell with a thud, and hugely  
grieved the Achaean army.  
823 As a lion overpowers a tireless boar in  
combat44  
824 when the two fight, towering-hearted,  
on a mountain's peaks  
825 over a little spring, both set on  
drinking,

826 and the lion by main strength breaks  
the boar as he gasps:  
827 so the son of Menoetius, killer of  
many, was robbed  
828 of his life at close quarters by Hector,  
Priam's son, with the spear;  
829 and vaunting over him Hector spoke  
winged words:  
830 "Patroclus — no doubt you said you  
would raze our city,  
831 and take from the women of Troy the  
day of freedom,  
832 and carry them off in your ships to  
your dear fatherland —  
833 fool! Before them the swift horses of  
Hector  
834 stride full-stretch to the fighting; and  
I with my spear  
835 am chosen out among the war-loving

Trojans, I who beat off

836 the day of necessity for them. But you  
— the vultures will eat you here.

837 Poor wretch: not even Achilles, brave  
as he is, was any use to you,

838 who stayed behind, I suppose, and  
gave you strict orders as you left:

839 ‘Do not come back to me, Patroclus,  
master of horses,

840 back to the hollow ships, before you  
have torn the bloody

841 tunic around the chest of man-  
slaughtering Hector.’

842 So he must have talked to you — and  
persuaded your witless heart.”

843 And with the little strength left you,  
you answered, Patroclus, horseman:

844 “Boast your fill now, Hector. Yours is  
the victory —45

845 given by Zeus, the son of Cronos, and  
by Apollo: they broke me  
846 easily; for they themselves took the  
armor from my shoulders.  
847 Twenty men like you could have come  
against me,  
848 and all of them would have died here,  
broken under my spear.  
849 No — deadly fate has killed me, and  
Leto's son,  
850 and of men, Euphorbus. You are only  
the third at my stripping.  
851 And I will tell you another thing — lay  
it away in your mind:  
852 you yourself have no long life left.  
Already  
853 death stands close beside you, and  
fate the overpowering:  
854 you will be broken under the hands of

Achilles, Aeacus' blameless son."

855 Even as he spoke, the end that is death  
covered him;

856 and his soul, flying from his limbs,  
went down to the house of Hades,

857 wailing its fate, leaving its manhood  
and its youth.

858 And glorious Hector spoke to him —  
though he was dead:

859 "Patroclus — why prophesy my sheer  
destruction?

860 Who knows whether Achilles, the son  
of lovely-haired Thetis,

861 may not be hit first by my spear, and  
lose his own life?"

862 So speaking, he set his heel on him  
and drew the bronze spear

863 out of the wound, and shoved him  
backward off the spear.

864 And at once he went with the spear  
after Automedon,  
865 the godlike aide of the swift-footed  
son of Aeacus —  
866 hot to strike him; but the swift horses  
carried him away,  
867 the immortal horses the gods gave  
Peleus as shining gifts.

## Notes

### NOTES

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#### NOTES

1. (16.2-11) Patroclus's tears reuse Agamemnon's simile from 9.14-15, our English kept — "like a spring of dark water that pours its black stream down a goat-proof cliff": the general wept so for his army's ruin; the friend weeps so for the same army now. Achilles answers with the poem's tenderest teasing: the little

girl running at her mother's skirt, begging to be carried — mockery whose every detail is affection, and whose image (the child who will not be put down until she is lifted) is exactly what Patroclus is about to ask for and receive. ↩

2. (16.20) “you answered, Patroclus, horseman” — the narrator's apostrophe, used of Patroclus eight times in this book (20, 584-587, 693-695, 744-746, 754-756, 787-789, 812-814, 843-845) — far more than anyone else receives in the whole poem (elsewhere chiefly Menelaus). The grammar itself breaks neutrality: the singer cannot keep the third person for this man. Antiquity already read the device as pathos; nothing else in the Iliad marks a character as loved by the poem itself. ↩

3. (16.29-35) “you and your cursed valor” — αἰναπέτη, a word invented for this line (excellence-in-disaster, valor that curses); then the great disowning: “the horseman Peleus was no father of yours, nor Thetis your mother — the grey sea bore you, and the sheer cliffs.” The gentlest man in the poem delivers its harshest genealogy (he had feared to hear a smaller version at 11.654); Patroclus's twin charges — pitiless (νηλεές) and unbending (ἀπηνής) — are the exact

vocabulary the poem will need again for Achilles in Book 24. ↩

4. (16.36-47) The plan repeats Nestor's lines (11.794-803) nearly verbatim, our English kept — the fatal scheme now carried by its victim, in the first person ("send me out... give me your own armor"). The narrator's seal, before Achilles can answer: "So he spoke, begging — the great fool (μέγα νήπιος): it was his own death and evil doom he was begging for." The poem's strongest use of its fool-formula: not blindness to a detail, but a prayer with its object inverted. ↩
5. (16.49-63) Achilles denies the prophecy excuse — no oracle, nothing from his mother (though 9.410-416 told us of the two fates; the poem lets the contradiction stand as suppression rather than ignorance) — and restates the grievance in the quarrel's oldest words: the prize taken back "as though I were some vagrant without rights" (ἀτίμητον μετανάστην, the phrase of 9.648). Then the concession that has already expired: "I said I would not lay my wrath aside until the war-shout reached my own ships" — it has; the fire is minutes away. ↩



6. (16.64-96) The conditions. Drive them from the ships; win me honor so they return the girl “and bring shining gifts besides” (the Book 9 offer, still wanted — the wrath’s economy intact); and then the double interdiction: come back; do not lead toward Ilion, “one of the everlasting gods may step in — the worker-from-afar, Apollo, loves them dearly.” Achilles speaks his friend’s actual death as a hypothesis, naming the god. Zenodotus compressed 93-96 into a single line (“lest Hector of the flashing helmet catch you stripped bare”) — tidier, and deaf to the point: the danger Achilles fears is not a man.



7. (16.97-100) The prayer that ends the speech: may every Trojan die, and every Argive, “and that we two alone might slip destruction, so that alone we might undo Troy’s holy coronal of towers.” Zenodotus and Aristarchus athetized the lines (Aristarchus noting that Zenodotus “suspected” them — ancient readers already heard how much the wish contains). It is the wrath’s logical terminus: the army abolished, the war reduced to the two of them — spoken to the man whose death will prove they were never separable from the rest. ↩

8. (16.102-111) Ajax's last stand at the ship, told in pure physiology: the helmet ringing "struck and struck again," the left shoulder aching under the shield, the gasping, the sweat that "could nowhere catch its breath" — and the summary line ancient critics loved to quote: "everywhere evil was propped on evil" (κακὸν κακῷ ἐστήρικτο). The bravest man in the army is described entirely from inside his fatigue. ↩
9. (16.112-124) The fixed Muse-invocation (= 2.484) — summoned not for a catalogue but for a single fact: "how the fire first fell on the ships." This is the flare Zeus has waited for since 15.599-600. Hector shears the head off Ajax's ash spear — the docked shaft brandished "useless in his hand" — and Ajax reads the theology correctly and withdraws; the flame pours over Protesilaus's ship (the war's first casualty again, 15.705); and Achilles, watching, sees exactly what Zeus sees, and slaps his thighs: "Up, Zeus-sprung Patroclus!" One ship burns for one book: the pivot's mechanism, precise as a clock. ↩
10. (16.131-145) The arming — the register's standard sequence (greaves, corslet, sword, shield, helmet, spears) with one exception the poem underlines:

“only the spear he did not take of Aeacus’ blameless son... the Pelian ash that Chiron gave his dear father from the peak of Pelion, to be death for heroes.” No other Achaean can even swing it. Zenodotus omitted the lines; they are the scene’s whole meaning: the disguise is complete except for the one thing that is Achilles — and the poem measures Patroclus by the weapon he cannot lift, exactly as it will measure Hector by the armor he cannot fill. ↩

11. (16.145-155) The team: Xanthus and Balius, foaled by the harpy Podarge to the West Wind in the meadow by Ocean — wind-grandsons; and in the side-traces “blameless Pedasus,” the war-prize from Eëtion’s city, “who, mortal as he was, kept pace with immortal horses.” The poem builds the team as it built the expedition: an immortal pair with one mortal running beside them, keeping up. The trace-horse’s death (467-471) is the book’s first fatality among Achilles’ own. ↩
12. (16.156-164) The Myrmidon wolf simile — the pack at its most physical in Homer: raw flesh, muzzles red, “belching up clotted gore,” the thin tongues lapping black spring-water, bellies stretched and hearts still fearless. The dark spring of Patroclus’s tears (3-4)

returns as the wolves' watering hole: the book's imagery runs on dark water. ↩

13. (16.168-198) The Catalogue of Myrmidons: fifty ships, fifty men each, five battalions — a miniature of Book 2, complete with erotic biographies. Menesthius, son of the river Spercheius by Peleus's daughter Polydora ("though in name" a mortal's son — the double-paternity formula); and Eudorus, the παρθένιος, born of Hermes' love for Polymele, seen dancing in Artemis's choir — seduction, secret bed, bride-price, grandfather's rearing: a complete romance in twelve lines. Phoenix (Book 9's tutor) commands the fourth battalion; Alcimedon (who will matter at 17.466ff) the fifth. The muster the wrath had parked since Book 2 stands up again. ↩

14. (16.200-210) Achilles quotes his own army's grumbling back at them — "Cruel son of Peleus — your mother reared you on bile... Let us at least sail home" — the only place we hear the Myrmidons' opinion of the wrath, and it matches Patroclus's ("pitiless," "cruel"). Achilles repeats it without rebuttal and points them at the work: the speech of a commander who knows exactly what has been said of him and considers the account now settled. ↩

15. (16.212-218) The wall-builder simile (close-set stones against the wind) introduces the phalanx lines repeated from 13.131-133, our English kept: “buckler pressed on buckler, helmet on helmet, man on man.” There the formation was defensive despair; here it is an offensive spring compressed — the same order, opposite potential energy. ↩
16. (16.220-233) The cup: from the chest Thetis packed — the poem’s one glimpse of a mother provisioning her son for war (tunics, wind-proof cloaks, rugs) — a cup reserved for one man and one god: “no other man drank from it, and to no god did he pour from it, except to Zeus the father.” Sulphur, clean water, washed hands: the private liturgy of a prince who deals with heaven bilaterally. No other hero in the poem has a personal cult protocol. ↩
17. (16.233-248) The Dodona prayer: “Zeus — lord — Dodonaean — Pelasgian — dweller far off” — the oldest oracle in Greece (Herodotus agrees), with its astonishing priesthood: “the Selloi, your interpreters, men of unwashed feet, who sleep on the ground” — holiness as permanent contact with the earth (ancient scholars debated Selloi/Helloi, whence “Hellenes”). Achilles prays past every

Olympian courtesy to something older and darker than Olympus, in the correct contract-form (“Once before, when I prayed, you heard my word”) — the Book 1 plague answered him; now he asks the second favor: glory for Patroclus, and his safe return “with all his armor, and his close-fighting companions.” ↩

18. (16.249-253) “And the father granted him one thing, and refused the other.” The poem’s most economical sentence of doom: prayer processed as paperwork, one clause approved, one denied, no notification issued. Achilles will stand at his hut believing both clauses filed. ↩
19. (16.259-267) The wasp simile — with the poet’s editorial inside it: boys provoke the roadside nest “as boys will, the little fools: they make a common evil for many.” The second child-image of the day’s fighting (the sand-castle god, 15.362); this one indicts the war itself — someone poked the nest, and the passer-by gets stung. The Myrmidons (“ant-men” by folk-etymology) fight under insect colors: wasps, then flies (641-644). ↩
20. (16.269-283) Patroclus’s field-speech turns the private grievance public: fight “so that Atreus’ son... may

know his blindness (ἄτην), that he honored not at all the best of the Achaeans” — the register’s ἄτη, deployed by the wrath’s gentlest partisan. And the disguise works precisely once, in the aggregate: the Trojans do not identify the man; they identify the armor and infer the reconciliation — “each man looked about him for escape from sheer destruction.” The armor is the argument. ↩

21. (16.287-305) Pyraechmes of the Paeonians — mustered at 2.848 with the same river-formula (“out of Amydon, from the wide- flowing Axios”) — is the first kill, and the tactical one: the fire is quenched, “and the ship was left there, half- burnt” (ἡμιδαής, a word occurring nowhere else — the poem coins a term for its own precise scorch-line). The clearing simile that follows — Zeus moving one cloud off a peak, “and the prodigious upper air breaks open from heaven” — measures the relief exactly: light, but “no pause in the war.” ↩

22. (16.317-330) The sons of Nestor kill the sons of Amisodarus — “the man who reared the raging Chimaera”: the monster of Bellerophon’s tale (6.179-183) resurfaces as someone’s livestock, one genealogical step from the battlefield. The paired-

brothers kill (Antilochus and Thrasymedes against Atymnius and Maris) is the book's small mirror of its great theme: companionship as a fighting unit. ↩

23. (16.364-394) The rout at the ditch — Hector's horses carry him clear while the army snaps its chariot-poles behind him — rises into the great storm simile of divine justice: Zeus's worst autumn deluge falls "when in rage he turns bitter against men who by force render crooked judgments in the assembly and drive justice out, careless of the gods' vengeance." Nowhere else does the Iliad's Zeus mind human justice at all — this is the Zeus of Hesiod's Works and Days, surfacing for nine lines to make the routed army's panic a moral weather. That the flood "diminishes the works of men" while the crooked judges sit indoors is the simile's quiet sting. ↩
24. (16.399-419) The angler: Thestor, huddled witless in his chariot, is hooked through the jaw and hauled "gaping" over the rail "as a man sitting on a jutting rock hauls a sacred fish out of the sea with his line and his glittering bronze." The most horrifying transformation in the poem's killing-repertoire — a man landed as a catch — done with a fisherman's leisure. ("Sacred fish": ancient guesses ranged from



a species to a fish grown temple-fat; the adjective's unplaceability is half its power.) Then the nine-name sweep, "in heaps, to the earth that feeds so many." ↩

25. (16.419-461) Sarpedon sees his "companions of the unbelted tunics" (the Lycians' native dress, without the Greek war- belt) going down, and the poem mounts its highest scene: Zeus asks Hera whether he may save his son. Her answer is the constitution of the poem's universe: "Do it. But we other gods will not all approve... many sons of the immortals are fighting around the great city of Priam" — fate as the equality of bereavement; if one father cheats, all may. The compromise she offers becomes the poem's tenderest machinery: Death and painless Sleep to carry him home, "with a tomb and a grave-stone: for that is the honor-right of the dead" (τὸ γὰρ γέρας ἐστὶ θανόντων — γέρας, the quarrel's own word for honor's portion, given its final meaning). Zeus consents and "rained down drops of blood upon the earth, honoring his dear son": the sky's grief, the blood-dew of 11.53 made personal. Zenodotus struck the entire dialogue out (432-458) — deleting the theology of the poem to spare Zeus the tears. ↩

26. (16.462-477) The duel's first exchange kills an aide and a horse: Sarpedon's miss finds Pedasus, and the mortal trace- horse "screamed away his life" — the poem's only equine casualty, and the death that previews everything: the mortal yoked beside immortals dies; the immortal pair tangle and rear; and it takes Automedon's sword — cutting the dead weight loose — to right the team. The allegory is left entirely to the reader. ↩
27. (16.477-507) Sarpedon falls with the shipwright simile repeated from 13.389-391 (our English kept) — Asius's death- tree now felling the man whose Book 12 speech justified every death in the poem — and then the bellowing bull under the lion. His dying speech is not of Lycia, wife, or son, but of the body and the shame-economy: "I will be your disgrace and your hanging head all your days... if the Achaeans strip my armor here." Patroclus's extraction of the spear is the grimmest anatomical clause in Homer: "he pulled out his life and the spear-point together" — the midriff following the bronze, soul and weapon in one motion. ↩
28. (16.508-533) Glaucus's prayer pays off the wound Teucer dealt him at 12.387-391 (concealed then;

crippling now) and briefly indicts heaven itself: “the best of men has perished — Sarpedon, son of Zeus; and Zeus does not defend even his own child.” Apollo — hearer “everywhere” of “a man in grief” — stills the pain and dries the blood: the god acting in his oldest capacity, healer, minutes before he acts in his darkest. ↩

29. (16.538-553) Glaucus’s rebuke of Hector states the allied grievance (men dying “far from their friends and their fatherland” for a city not theirs) and the city’s debt: Sarpedon “kept Lycia safe by his judgments and his strength” — δίκησι, the justice-word, in the obituary of the man the justice-storm (385-393) did not protect. The Trojan grief- line is the poem’s tribute to the foreigner: “he was a stay of their city, foreigner though he was.” ↩
30. (16.567-570) Zeus stretches “a deadly night over the strong encounter, so that around his dear son the deadly toil of battle might be waged” — darkness as paternal mourning-veil, the counterpart of the blood-rain: the god cannot save him, so he dims the lights over the body. ↩
31. (16.570-582) — see note [32]. ↩

32. (16.570-607) The battle over the body opens with Epeigeus: once a king in Budeum, then a cousin-killer, then a suppliant of Peleus and Thetis, then Achilles' man, now dead across Sarpedon's corpse — the third homicide-exile biography in four books (Medon, Lycophron), and the closest to Patroclus's own (23.85-90). The Myrmidon court at Phthia absorbs killers and re-employs them; the poem keeps burying them in order. Bathycles (richest of the Myrmidons) and Laogonus (priest of Idaean Zeus) follow — wealth and priesthood, the two exemptions that never exempt. ↩
33. (16.617-633) The dancer taunt: Aeneas mocks Meriones' dodge as Cretan dancing (Crete's dancers were proverbial); Meriones answers with mortality-arithmetic; and Patroclus's rebuke closes the exchange with the poem's own poetics of action: "In hands lies the outcome of war; of words, in council. So there is no need to pile up speech, but to fight." The gentlest speaker in the epic states the genre's law — battle is not a debate — and the poem, which loves its taunts, lets him. ↩
34. (16.633-646) The signature of this battle: Sarpedon's body made anonymous — "not even a discerning

man could have known brilliant Sarpedon, wrapped from his head clean down to the soles of his feet in missiles and blood and dust” — while around it the armies cluster “as flies in a farmstead buzz about the brimming milk-pails in the season of spring.” Homer dares the smallest, homeliest life against the largest death: spring, milk, plenty — and men as flies. The corpse the flies swarm cannot be told from the field it lies on; Apollo’s bath (note [36]) exists to reverse exactly this. ↩

35. (16.644-660) Zeus’s gaze never leaves the fight, “brooding long over the killing of Patroclus: whether now... or whether he should swell the sheer toil for still more men.” The decision — more — is mercy indistinguishable from sentence: the extra hour of glory is granted the way the prayer was half-granted (note [18]). Hector’s panic is knowledge: “he knew the sacred scales of Zeus” — the balance of 8.69 and 22.209 felt from inside, tipping. ↩
36. (16.666-683) The funeral of Sarpedon: Apollo lifts him from the missiles, washes him in the running river, anoints him with ambrosia, wraps him in immortal clothes, and gives him to “the twin brothers Sleep and Death” for the journey home to Lycia — Zeus’s

orders repeated in execution almost word for word, as the poem's rituals must be. Zenodotus athetized the whole passage; against him stand the gentlest lines any death receives in the Iliad — and the scene's afterlife: on the Euphronios krater (Athens, c. 515 BC), winged Sleep and Death lift the bleeding Sarpedon while Hermes watches — the single most famous painted image of the Iliad in ancient art. The promise of 14.231 ("Sleep, the brother of Death") completes itself: the pair Hera bribed with a Grace now carry her rival's son to burial. What the honor-right of the dead looks like, the poem shows once, here, done by gods. ↩

37. (16.684-711) The turn: "the fool (νήπιος): had he kept the word of Peleus' son, he would have escaped the evil doom of black death. But always the mind of Zeus is stronger than men's." The apostrophized roll-call follows ("whom first, whom last did you strip of his arms, Patroclus, when the gods were calling you deathward?" — the fixed register question turned, for the first time, on the poem's beloved), then the thrice-and-fourth at the wall's very angle — Apollo slapping the shield back with immortal hands — and the warning that grades all mortals in one line: not your portion, "no, nor

Achilles', who is a far better man than you."

Patroclus backs off "dodging the wrath of Apollo" —  
μῆνιν, the poem's title- word, now the god's. ↩

38. (16.712-726) Apollo as Asius — Hecuba's brother, the third bearer of the name (the doomed captain of Book 12-13; the disguise of Book 10's era) — turns Hector around with a taunt at his skulking. The god who has just saved the wall now aims its defender at Patroclus: the same power working both sides of the same death. ↩

39. (16.726-752) Cebriones: the stone crushes both brows, "and his eyes dropped to the ground in the dust there at his feet; and like a diver he plunged" — the diver of 12.385 (our phrase kept), now with the eyes watching from the ground. Patroclus's mock-eulogy — the oyster-diver who "could feed a whole crew... even in rough weather... there are acrobats among the Trojans too" — is the war's blackest comedy, and its placement is the point: the poem's kindest man, one god-blow from death, is granted the gallows-wit of the doomed. He has become, for thirty lines, Achilles. ↩

40. (16.756-778) Over the body: Hector by the head, Patroclus by the foot — the tug-of-war of the whole

poem in one grip — while East and South Wind thrash the mountain timber overhead. And beneath it, the line that outlives the battle: Cebriones “in the whirl of dust lay mighty in his mightiness, his horsemanship all forgotten” (κεῖτο μέγας μεγαλωστί, λελασμένος ἵπποσυνάων). The Odyssey will use the verse of Achilles himself (24.39-40): the poem’s ultimate epitaph, first spent on a charioteer.



41. (16.777-790) The clock: sun at mid-heaven, stalemate; sun at “the unyoking of oxen,” and the Achaeans prevail “beyond their portion” (ὕπὲρ αἴσαν — the day’s ration of fate overdrawn). Thrice nine men fall; the fourth rush comes “like more than man” (δαίμονι ἴσος — the register phrase, twice in this book); “then, Patroclus, the end of your life showed clear.” The formula-system itself has been counting: three-and-the-fourth is the poem’s rhythm of trespass (5.436-439, 16.702-705), and the fourth time always finds the god. ↩
42. (16.790-807) The un-arming. Apollo, wrapped in mist, strikes the flat-handed blow — the only time a god personally strikes a mortal dead-on in the poem — and then dismantles the arming scene of 131-139 in



reverse: helmet rolling under the hooves (“Before this it was not lawful for that horsehair-crested helmet to be fouled with dust: it guarded the head and the gracious brow of a godlike man, Achilles. But then Zeus gave it to Hector to wear on his own head; and his destruction was near him” — the armor-transfer chain announced with its invoice attached); the spear shattered — the one he could carry; the shield down; “and the lord Apollo, son of Zeus, loosed the corslet off him.” A god undresses the man for death. ἄτη — blindness — takes his wits; he stands dazed, naked in the crowd: the poem’s most terrifying image of what it is to lose divine favor — not to be struck, but to be unwrapped. ↩

43. (16.806-817) Euphorbus: the beautiful new fighter — best of his age with spear, horse, and foot, twenty men down in his first campaign, “still learning war” — spears the dazed man from behind and runs, “and did not stand against Patroclus, even unarmed as he was.” He will die for it at 17.9-60, where his blood wets hair “like the Graces’.” Fame followed him strangely: Pythagoras claimed Euphorbus’s soul as a former life of his own, and proved it (the story goes) by recognizing the shield Menelaus took, hung in

Hera's temple — the poem's minor duelist became antiquity's test-case for transmigration. ↩

44. (16.818-844) Hector, third, into the belly. His vaunt invents a quotation — Achilles supposedly ordering Patroclus not to return “before you have torn the bloody tunic around the chest of man-slaughtering Hector... So he must have talked to you” — the exact inversion of the truth we heard (87-96: come back; avoid the wall; fear Apollo). Hector's tragedy is compressed into his reconstruction of an order that was its opposite: he cannot imagine the restraint that was Achilles' actual love, and so misreads the man he must soon face. ↩
45. (16.843-869) The dying prophecy: “You are only the third at my stripping” — the killers ranked (fate and Apollo; of men, Euphorbus; Hector last), the boast priced (“twenty men like you”), and then the forward sentence: “Already death stands close beside you... you will be broken under the hands of Achilles.” The soul-flight couplet — “his soul, flying from his limbs, went down to the house of Hades, wailing its fate, leaving its manhood and its youth” — recurs verbatim at 22.361-363 for Hector himself: reuse this English there; the two deaths are one

sentence spoken twice (Plutarch and Athenaeus were still quoting it). Hector answers the corpse — “Who knows whether Achilles... may not be hit first by my spear?” — hope addressed to a dead prophet; then the heel, the spear withdrawn, and the lunge for Automedon, foiled by the book’s last image: “the swift horses carried him away, the immortal horses the gods gave Peleus as shining gifts.” The gods’ wedding-present outruns the man wearing the gods’ other gift; Book 17 opens over the body. ↩

# Book 17

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*The fight over the body of Patroclus: Hector puts on the armor of Achilles, the immortal horses weep, and Ajax prays not for rescue but for light.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 Nor did it escape Atreus' son, Menelaus dear to Ares,
- 2 that Patroclus had been broken by Trojans in the combat.
- 3 He came through the front-fighters helmed in blazing bronze
- 4 and stood over the body — as a mother-cow, lowing,
- 5 stands over her first calf, who never

knew birth before:1

6 so tawny-haired Menelaus stood over  
Patroclus.

7 He held his spear before him, and his  
shield, balanced every way,

8 hot to kill whatever man might come  
against him.

9 Nor was Panthous's son of the good ash  
spear careless

10 of blameless Patroclus fallen: he came  
and stood

11 close by, and spoke to Menelaus dear to  
Ares:

12 "Son of Atreus — Zeus-nurtured  
Menelaus, marshal of the people —

13 give way: leave the body; let the bloody  
spoils be.

14 For no man of the Trojans or their  
famed allies

- 15 hit Patroclus with the spear in the  
strong encounter before me:2
- 16 so let me take my good fame among the  
Trojans,
- 17 or I will strike you and take your  
honey-sweet life.”
- 18 Then, deeply angered, tawny-haired  
Menelaus answered him:
- 19 “Father Zeus — how ugly a thing is  
arrogant boasting!
- 20 Not the leopard’s fury is so great, nor  
the lion’s,
- 21 nor the murderous wild boar’s — whose  
heart in his chest
- 22 is the biggest of all, glorying in his  
strength —
- 23 as the pride of the sons of Panthous  
with their good ash spears.
- 24 Yet the strength of Hyperenor, breaker

of horses, had no joy  
25 of his youth, when he mocked me and  
stood against me  
26 and called me the sorriest fighter of  
the Danaans:  
27 I say his own feet never carried him  
home  
28 to delight his dear wife and his devoted  
parents.  
29 Just so, I promise you, I will unstring  
your strength, if you stand  
30 against me. Go back into the crowd —  
that is my counsel —  
31 and do not stand against me, before  
some evil  
32 takes you. When the thing is done,  
even the fool learns.”  
33 So he spoke, and did not persuade him;  
and he answered:

34 “Now, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus, now  
you will pay in full<sup>3</sup>  
35 for my brother, whom you killed — and  
boast of it in speeches —  
36 whose wife you widowed in the depth  
of her new bridal chamber,  
37 who brought his parents cursed  
mourning and grief.  
38 I could be some stay of weeping for  
those unhappy two  
39 if I brought back your head and your  
armor  
40 and laid them in the hands of Panthous  
and brilliant Phrontis.  
41 But not for long shall the labor go  
untried between us,  
42 and unfought — whether it end in  
courage or in flight.”  
43 So speaking, he stabbed at the shield,



balanced every way;  
44 but the bronze did not break through:  
the point bent back  
45 in the strong shield. And second, with  
the bronze,  
46 rose Atreus' son Menelaus, with a  
prayer to Zeus the father:  
47 as Euphorbus drew back, he stabbed  
the base of his throat,  
48 and leaned into the thrust, trusting his  
heavy hand;  
49 and clean through the soft neck the  
point ran out.  
50 He fell with a thud, and his armor  
clattered upon him.  
51 His hair was soaked with blood — hair  
like the Graces',<sup>4</sup>  
52 and the braids pinched tight in gold  
and silver.

53 As a man rears a flourishing olive  
sapling  
54 in a lonely place, where water wells up  
in plenty —  
55 a fair shoot, and a thriving; and the  
breathing of every  
56 wind rocks it, and it breaks thick with  
white blossom;  
57 but suddenly a wind comes with a great  
squall  
58 and wrenches it out of its trench and  
lays it flat on the earth:  
59 such was Panthous's son of the good  
ash spear, Euphorbus,  
60 when Atreus' son Menelaus killed him,  
and set to stripping his armor.  
61 And as when some mountain-bred lion,  
sure of his strength,<sup>5</sup>  
62 snatches from a grazing herd the finest

heifer:

63 her neck he breaks first, seizing it in  
his strong teeth,

64 and then he gulps down the blood and  
all the inward parts,

65 rending her; and around him the dogs  
and the herdsmen

66 raise clamor upon clamor — from a  
distance: they have no will

67 to go against him, for green fear has  
hold of them:

68 so the heart in the chest of not one of  
them dared

69 to go against glorious Menelaus.

70 And now Atreus' son would easily have  
carried off the famed armor

71 of Panthous's son, had not Phoebus  
Apollo grudged it,

72 and roused Hector against him, the

equal of swift Ares,  
73 in the likeness of a man, Mentès, leader  
of the Cicones;  
74 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:  
75 “Hector — you are running now,  
chasing what cannot be caught:6  
76 the horses of the war-minded son of  
Aeacus. They are hard  
77 for mortal men to break or to drive,  
78 for any man but Achilles, whom an  
immortal mother bore.  
79 And meanwhile Menelaus, warlike son  
of Atreus,  
80 standing over Patroclus, has killed the  
best of the Trojans —  
81 Panthous’s son Euphorbus — and  
stopped his rushing courage.”  
82 So speaking, the god went back into

the toil of men;

83 and terrible grief packed Hector's  
darkened heart.

84 He peered along the ranks, and knew at  
once

85 the one man stripping the famed  
armor, the other lying

86 on the ground, the blood running from  
the open wound.

87 He came through the front-fighters  
helmed in blazing bronze,

88 screaming sharp, like the  
unquenchable flame

89 of Hephaestus. And his sharp cry did  
not escape Atreus' son;

90 troubled, he spoke to his own great-  
hearted spirit:

91 "Ah me — if I abandon the fine armor,

92 and Patroclus, who lies here for the

sake of my honor,

93 I fear any Danaan who sees it will call it  
my disgrace.

94 But if, in shame, I fight Hector and the  
Trojans

95 alone — I fear the many will surround  
me, one man:

96 Hector of the flashing helmet is leading  
all of them here.

97 But why does my own heart argue  
these things with me?

98 When a man wills, against the god's  
face, to fight a man

99 whom a god honors — a great woe rolls  
down on him quickly.

100 So no Danaan who sees me give way  
before Hector

101 will call it my disgrace: he fights out of  
heaven.

102 But if I could only hear Ajax of the  
great war-cry —  
103 the two of us together might go back  
and remember our war-craft,  
104 even against the god's face, and haul  
the body clear  
105 for Achilles, Peleus' son. Of evils, that  
would be best.”  
106 While he was turning this over in  
mind and heart,  
107 the Trojan battle-lines came on; and  
Hector led them.  
108 And he gave ground backward, and  
left the body,  
109 turning again and again — like a  
bearded lion  
110 that dogs and men drive off from the  
fold  
111 with spears and shouting: the brave

heart in his chest

112 goes stiff with the cold, and unwilling  
he leaves the yard:

113 so tawny-haired Menelaus went from  
Patroclus.

114 He turned and stood, when he reached  
the band of his companions,

115 peering everywhere for great Ajax,  
Telamon's son;

116 and he saw him quickly, on the far left  
of the whole battle,

117 heartening his companions and  
driving them to fight,

118 for Phoebus Apollo had thrown  
unearthly panic among them.

119 He set off at a run, and stood by him at  
once, and spoke:

120 "Ajax — this way, old friend! Let us  
hurry for dead Patroclus,



121 and see if we can bring the body at  
least to Achilles —

122 naked: for Hector of the flashing  
helmet has the armor.”

123 So he spoke, and stirred the heart in  
war-minded Ajax,

124 and he came through the front-  
fighters, and with him tawny-haired  
Menelaus.

125 Hector, when he had stripped  
Patroclus of the famed armor,

126 was dragging him, to shear the head  
from the shoulders with the sharp bronze

127 and haul the body off and give it to the  
dogs of Troy.

128 But Ajax came up close, carrying his  
shield like a tower,

129 and Hector drew back into the band of  
his companions

130 and sprang into his chariot; and he  
gave the fine armor  
131 to Trojans to carry to the city, to be his  
own great glory.  
132 And Ajax covered Menoetius's son  
with his broad shield  
133 and stood — as a lion stands over his  
young,<sup>9</sup>  
134 a lion leading his cubs, when hunting  
men come on him  
135 in the timber: he glories in his  
strength,  
136 and draws the whole scowl of his  
brows down over his eyes:  
137 so Ajax bestrode the hero Patroclus.  
138 And on the other side Atreus' son,  
Menelaus dear to Ares,  
139 stood fast, nursing great grief in his  
chest.

140 Then Glaucus, Hippolochus's son,  
leader of the Lycian men,  
141 glaring darkly at Hector, rebuked him  
with a hard word:  
142 "Hector — best of us all to look at: in  
battle you fall far short.**10**  
143 Fine fame indeed is yours — a  
runaway's.  
144 Consider now how you will save your  
town and citadel  
145 alone — you with the people born in  
Ilion;  
146 for no Lycian, at least, will go out to  
fight the Danaans  
147 for your city, since there was no  
thanks, it seems,  
148 for battling the enemy without  
respite, forever.  
149 How would you save a lesser man in

the press of war,  
150 hard-hearted one, when Sarpedon —  
your guest-friend and companion —  
151 you abandoned to the Argives, their  
prey and their prize:  
152 a man who served you greatly, your  
city and yourself,  
153 while he lived; and now you have not  
dared to keep the dogs from him.  
154 So now, if any Lycian man will obey  
me,  
155 we go home — and let sheer  
destruction show over Troy.  
156 For if the Trojans now had daring fury  
in them,  
157 unshaking — the kind that comes into  
men who for their fatherland  
158 take on the toil and the grinding of  
war against their enemies —

159 we would quickly haul Patroclus inside  
Ilion.

160 And if that man came to the great city  
of lord Priam,

161 dead — if we hauled him out of the  
fighting —

162 the Argives would quickly ransom  
back the fine armor

163 of Sarpedon, and we would bring the  
man himself into Ilion:

164 for the aide of such a man lies killed —  
far the best

165 of the Argives by the ships, he and his  
close-fighting aides.

166 But you had not the courage to stand  
against great-hearted

167 Ajax, eye to eye in the enemies'  
clamor,

168 and fight him straight — since he is a

better man than you.”

169 Glaring at him darkly, Hector of the  
flashing helmet answered:

170 “Glaucus — why does a man like you  
talk so overweening?<sup>11</sup>

171 Well now! And I always said you were  
first in judgment

172 of all who live in Lycia of the deep soil;

173 but now I scorn your wits outright —  
such a thing to say:

174 you say I did not stand against gigantic  
Ajax.

175 It is not battle I shudder at, nor the  
thunder of horses;

176 but always the mind of Zeus who bears  
the aegis is stronger:

177 he sends even the brave man running,  
and strips away victory

178 easily — and then again himself drives

a man to fight.

179 Come stand beside me, old friend —  
watch my work:

180 see whether all day long I prove the  
coward you call me,

181 or whether I stop many a Danaan too,  
however hot

182 his courage, from his defense of dead  
Patroclus.”

183 So speaking, he called to the Trojans  
with a great shout:

184 “Trojans and Lycians and Dardanians  
who fight at close quarters —

185 be men, my friends; remember your  
rushing courage,

186 while I put on the armor of blameless  
Achilles,

187 the fine armor I stripped from the  
strength of Patroclus when I killed him.”

188 So speaking, Hector of the flashing  
helmet went off  
189 out of the grim war; and running he  
overtook his companions,  
190 quickly, on swift feet, not yet far away  
—  
191 the men carrying toward the city the  
famed armor of Peleus' son.  
192 And standing apart from the battle of  
many tears, he changed his armor:12  
193 his own he gave to the war-loving  
Trojans to carry  
194 to holy Ilion; and he put on the  
immortal armor  
195 of Achilles, Peleus' son, which the  
heavenly gods  
196 had given his dear father; and the  
father, grown old, passed it  
197 to his son — but the son did not grow



old in his father's armor.

198 And when Zeus the cloud-gatherer  
saw him from afar

199 arming himself in the gear of the  
godlike son of Peleus,

200 he shook his head, and spoke to his  
own spirit:

201 "Ah, poor man — death is nowhere in  
your thoughts, 13

202 and it stands close beside you. You are  
putting on the immortal

203 armor of the best of men — a man the  
others shudder at.

204 His companion you have killed, who  
was gentle and strong,

205 and stripped the armor from his head  
and shoulders

206 not by right. Yet for now I will hand  
you great power —

207 as recompense for this: that never  
home out of the battle  
208 will you come, nor Andromache take  
from you the famous armor of Peleus' son."  
209 He spoke, and the son of Cronos  
bowed his head with his dark brows;  
210 and he fitted the armor to Hector's  
body, and Ares entered him,  
211 the terrible war-god, and his limbs  
were filled inside  
212 with courage and strength. He went  
out to the famed allies  
213 with a great shout, and showed  
himself before them all,  
214 blazing in the armor of the great-  
hearted son of Peleus.  
215 And going among them he stirred  
each man with his words —  
216 Mesthles and Glaucus and Medon and

Thersilochus,

217 Asteropaeus and Deisenor and

Hippothous,

218 Phorcys and Chromius and Ennomus

the bird-reader;

219 urging these on, he spoke winged  
words:

220 “Hear me, you numberless tribes of  
allies who dwell around us:14

221 it was not for a crowd’s sake — not  
because I lacked numbers —

222 that I gathered you here, each man  
from his own city,

223 but so that you would guard, with a  
will, the Trojans’ wives

224 and little children from the war-  
loving Achaeans.

225 With that in mind I wear down my  
own people

226 for gifts and provisions, to feed the  
courage in each of you.  
227 So now — let every man turn straight  
ahead, and die  
228 or live: that is the trysting-talk of war.  
229 And whoever hauls Patroclus, dead  
though he is,  
230 in among the horse-taming Trojans,  
and Ajax yields to him —  
231 half the spoils I will share out to that  
man, and half I keep  
232 myself; and his glory shall be as great  
as mine.”  
233 So he spoke; and they marched  
straight down on the Danaans, heavy,  
234 spears held high; and their hearts had  
great hope  
235 of hauling the body from under Ajax,  
Telamon’s son —

236 fools: over that body he was to rob  
many of life.15

237 And then Ajax spoke to Menelaus,  
good at the war-cry:

238 “Old friend — Zeus-nurtured  
Menelaus — I no longer count

239 on the two of us, even ourselves,  
coming home from this war.

240 It is not so much for the corpse of  
Patroclus I fear —

241 he will glut the dogs and birds of Troy  
soon enough —

242 as for my own head, that something  
may happen to it,

243 and yours: for Hector, that cloud of  
war, has covered

244 everything, and for us sheer  
destruction shows clear.

245 Come — call the best of the Danaans, if

any may hear.”

246 So he spoke, and Menelaus, good at  
the war-cry, did not disobey,

247 and cried a piercing cry, to carry to  
the Danaans:

248 “Friends — leaders and lords of the  
Argives —

249 you who beside the two Atreus’ sons,  
Agamemnon and Menelaus,

250 drink at the public cost, and each give  
orders

251 to your people — from Zeus come  
honor and glory.

252 It is hard for me to pick out each one

253 of the leaders — so great is the strife  
of war ablaze —

254 so let each man come uncalled, and  
feel the outrage in his heart

255 that Patroclus should be sport for the

dogs of Troy.”

256 So he spoke; and the swift Ajax,

Oïleus’ son, heard him sharp,

257 and came first to meet him, running  
through the combat,

258 and after him Idomeneus, and  
Idomeneus’s aide

259 Meriones, the equal of Enyalius, slayer  
of men.

260 But of the rest — who could speak  
their names out of his own mind,

261 all who came up behind and woke the  
Achaean battle?**16**

262 And the Trojans struck first, massed;  
Hector led them.

263 As when at the mouth of a sky-fed  
river

264 the great swell bellows against the  
current, and around it

265 the jutting shores boom, as the salt  
sea belches beyond them:  
266 with such a roar came the Trojans on.  
But the Achaeans  
267 stood fast around Menoetius's son,  
one heart in all of them,  
268 fenced with their bronze-faced  
shields. And over their bright  
269 helmets the son of Cronos poured  
thick mist, 17  
270 since never in the time before had he  
hated Menoetius's son,  
271 while he was alive and the aide of  
Aeacus' grandson;  
272 and he loathed that he become the  
prey of the dogs  
273 of Troy — and so he roused his  
companions to defend him.  
274 And at first the Trojans pushed back



the bright-eyed Achaeans:

275 they left the body and shrank away,  
and the high-hearted Trojans

276 took not one of them with their  
spears, for all their striving,

277 but set to hauling the corpse. Yet only  
a little while

278 were the Achaeans to hold off from it:  
they were rallied fast

279 by Ajax, who in build, and in what he  
wrought,

280 surpassed all the Danaans after the  
blameless son of Peleus.

281 He swept straight through the front-  
fighters, like a wild boar

282 in his strength, that up in the  
mountains scatters hounds

283 and strong young men with ease,  
wheeling through the glens:

284 so the son of illustrious Telamon,  
shining Ajax,  
285 swept in and easily scattered the  
Trojan battle-lines  
286 that had taken their stand over  
Patroclus, minded above all  
287 to haul him to their own city and win  
the glory.  
288 Now Hippothous, the shining son of  
Pelasgian Lethus, 18  
289 was dragging him by the foot through  
the strong encounter,  
290 a shield-strap bound around the  
ankle-tendons,  
291 doing a favor to Hector and the  
Trojans. But swiftly  
292 the evil came on him that no one  
could hold off, wish it as they might:  
293 the son of Telamon, springing at him

through the crowd,  
294 struck close-in, through the helmet's  
bronze cheek-pieces;  
295 and the horsehair-crested helmet split  
around the spear-point,  
296 struck by the great spear and the  
heavy hand,  
297 and the brain came running out of the  
wound along the socket,  
298 bloody; and there and then his  
strength was unstrung, and from his hands  
299 he let the foot of great-hearted  
Patroclus drop  
300 to lie on the ground; and he fell face-  
down on the corpse beside it,  
301 far from deep-soiled Larisa; nor did he  
repay  
302 his dear parents the price of his  
rearing: his life was short,

303 broken under the spear of great-  
hearted Ajax.  
304 And Hector in turn cast at Ajax with  
his shining spear;  
305 but he saw it coming and dodged the  
bronze spear —  
306 barely; and it struck Schedius, great-  
hearted Iphitus's son,  
307 far the best of the Phocians, whose  
home was in famed  
308 Panopeus, where he was king over  
many men:  
309 it struck him under the middle of the  
collarbone, and through it  
310 the bronze point drove, and came out  
at the base of the shoulder.  
311 He fell with a thud, and his armor  
clattered upon him.  
312 And Ajax struck war-minded Phorcys,

Phaenops's son,  
313 full in the belly as he bestrode  
Hippothous,  
314 and burst the plate of his corslet, and  
the bronze  
315 spilled his bowels through; and falling  
in the dust he clutched the earth in his  
palm.  
316 And the front-fighters gave ground,  
and glorious Hector;  
317 and the Argives shouted loud, and  
dragged away the corpses,  
318 Phorcys and Hippothous, and loosed  
the armor from their shoulders.  
319 And then once more the Trojans,  
before the Achaeans dear to Ares,  
320 would have climbed into Ilion, broken  
by their own weakness,  
321 and the Argives would have won glory

even beyond the portion of Zeus<sup>19</sup>

<sup>322</sup> by their own power and strength —  
had not Apollo himself

<sup>323</sup> stirred up Aeneas, in the likeness of  
the herald

<sup>324</sup> Periphas, Epytus's son, who at his old  
father's side

<sup>325</sup> had grown grey in his heraldry, his  
heart a well of kindly counsel;

<sup>326</sup> in his likeness Apollo, son of Zeus,  
spoke to him:

<sup>327</sup> "Aeneas — how could you and yours  
hold steep Ilion

<sup>328</sup> even against a god? — as I have seen  
other men do,

<sup>329</sup> trusting their power and strength,  
their manhood

<sup>330</sup> and their own numbers, though their  
people were too few.

331 But Zeus wills the victory to us, far  
rather  
332 than to the Danaans — and you flinch  
unspeakably, and will not fight.”  
333 So he spoke; and Aeneas knew Apollo  
who strikes from afar,  
334 looking him in the face, and called  
aloud to Hector:  
335 “Hector — and you other leaders of  
Trojans and allies —  
336 this now is disgrace: to climb back  
into Ilion  
337 before the Achaeans dear to Ares,  
broken by our own weakness.  
338 No — for a god has just now stood  
beside me and said  
339 Zeus, highest deviser of battle, is still  
our helper.  
340 So let us go straight for the Danaans,

and not let them

341 bring dead Patroclus to their ships at  
their ease.”

342 So he spoke, and sprang far out  
beyond the front-fighters, and stood;

343 and they wheeled about, and stood to  
face the Achaeans.

344 Then Aeneas wounded Leiocritus with  
his spear,

345 the son of Arisbas, brave companion  
of Lycomedes;

346 and as he fell, Lycomedes dear to Ares  
pitied him,

347 and came and stood very close, and  
cast with his shining spear,

348 and struck Apisaon, Hippasus’s son,  
shepherd of the people,

349 in the liver below the midriff, and  
unstrung his knees on the instant —



350 the man who had come out of deep-  
soiled Paeonia,  
351 and was their best in battle after  
Asteropaeus.  
352 And as he fell, warlike Asteropaeus  
pitied him,  
353 and he too drove forward, willing to  
fight the Danaans;  
354 but there was no way any longer:  
fenced with shields on every side  
355 they stood around Patroclus, spears  
held out before them.  
356 For Ajax ranged among them all with  
strict command:20  
357 no man to give back a step from the  
body,  
358 no man to fight out in front of the  
other Achaeans,  
359 but to stand close over him, and fight

hand to hand.

360 So gigantic Ajax commanded; and the  
earth grew soaked

361 with purple blood, and they fell in  
heaps together,

362 dead men of the Trojans and their  
overmastering allies

363 and Danaans too — for not without  
blood did these defend —

364 but far fewer of them perished: they  
remembered always

365 to ward sheer ruin from one another  
in the crowd.

366 So they fought on, like fire; nor would  
you have said21

367 the sun was safe in the sky, or the  
moon:

368 for they were held in mist, all the best  
men in the battle

369 who stood around the dead son of  
Menoetius.  
370 But the other Trojans and strong-  
greaved Achaeans  
371 fought at their ease under clear air:  
the piercing light  
372 of the sun lay spread, and no cloud  
showed over all  
373 the earth or the mountains; and they  
fought in pauses,  
374 keeping well apart, dodging each  
other's  
375 missiles of groaning. But those in the  
middle suffered  
376 in the mist and the war, worn down by  
the pitiless bronze —  
377 all who were the best. And two men  
had not yet heard —  
378 two famous men, Thrasymedes and

Antilochus —

379 that blameless Patroclus was dead:

they thought him

380 living still, fighting Trojans in the  
front of the crowd;

381 and watching against the death and  
rout of their companions

382 they fought apart, since Nestor had so  
ordered them,

383 when he drove them to the war from  
the black ships.

384 But for the others, all day long the  
great struggle of grinding

385 strife stood taut: with the weariness  
and the sweat of it,

386 without respite, the knees and shins,  
the feet beneath,

387 the hands and eyes of every man were  
spattered

388 in the fight around the brave aide of  
the swift-footed son of Aeacus.  
389 As when a man gives his people the  
hide of a great bull22  
390 to stretch, soaked through with fat:  
391 they take it and stand in a circle and  
stretch it  
392 outward; and quickly the moisture  
goes, and the fat sinks in  
393 with so many pulling, and the whole  
hide is stretched taut through:  
394 so this way and that, in a little space,  
both sides hauled  
395 the corpse; and their hearts had great  
hope —  
396 the Trojans, of dragging him to Ilion;  
the Achaeans,  
397 to the hollow ships. And around him  
the brawl rose

398 savage: not Ares driver of armies, not  
Athena  
399 could have looked at it and scorned it,  
however great their anger:  
400 such was the evil toil of men and  
horses Zeus  
401 stretched taut over Patroclus on that  
day.  
402 And brilliant Achilles knew nothing at  
all, yet, of Patroclus dead:23  
403 for the battle was fought far from the  
swift ships,  
404 under the wall of the Trojans. So  
never in his heart  
405 did he think him dead — but living,  
pressed hard on the gates,  
406 and coming home again; since he  
never thought at all  
407 that Patroclus would sack the city

without him — nor with him:

408 for often he had learned as much  
from his mother, hearing her apart,  
409 when she brought him word of the  
purpose of great Zeus.

410 But now his mother told him nothing  
of the evil that had happened —

411 so great — that his far-dearest  
companion had perished.

412 And they around the corpse, holding  
their sharpened spears,

413 pressed close without respite, and  
killed each other;

414 and thus would one of the bronze-  
shirted Achaeans say:

415 “Friends — no glory for us in going  
back24

416 to the hollow ships. Sooner let the  
black earth gape

417 for all of us here. That would be better  
by far, at once,  
418 than to leave this man to the horse-  
taming Trojans  
419 to haul to their own city, and win the  
glory.”  
420 And thus in turn would one of the  
great-hearted Trojans say:  
421 “Friends — even if it is fate that we be  
broken beside this man,  
422 all of us alike, let no one yet give way  
from the war.”  
423 So a man would speak, and stir the  
fury of each.  
424 So they fought on; and the iron din  
went up  
425 through the barren air to the brazen  
sky.<sup>25</sup>  
426 But the horses of Aeacus’ grandson,



apart from the battle,<sup>26</sup>  
<sup>427</sup> were weeping, ever since they first  
had learned their charioteer  
<sup>428</sup> was fallen in the dust at the hands of  
man-slaughtering Hector.  
<sup>429</sup> Automedon, Diores' stout son, tried  
them —  
<sup>430</sup> lashing them again and again with the  
quick whip's stroke,  
<sup>431</sup> again and again with honeyed words,  
and again with curses:  
<sup>432</sup> but the pair would not go back to the  
ships and the broad Hellespont,  
<sup>433</sup> nor into the battle after the Achaeans.  
<sup>434</sup> As a grave-stone stands unmoving, set  
on the barrow  
<sup>435</sup> of a dead man or a woman,  
<sup>436</sup> so they stood, unstirring, with the  
beautiful chariot,

437 drooping their heads to the earth; and  
hot tears  
438 ran from their eyelids to the ground  
as they mourned  
439 in longing for their charioteer; and  
their rich manes were fouled,  
440 streaming down from the yoke-pad on  
both sides of the yoke.  
441 And seeing the two of them mourning,  
the son of Cronos pitied them,  
442 and he shook his head, and spoke to  
his own spirit:  
443 “Ah, poor pair — why did we give you  
to king Peleus, 27  
444 a mortal — you who are ageless and  
deathless?  
445 Was it so that you too might have  
sorrows among unhappy men?  
446 For there is nothing anywhere more

pitiful than man,  
447 of all things that breathe and creep  
upon the earth.  
448 But not on you, at least, and your  
intricate chariot  
449 shall Hector, Priam's son, ride. I will  
not allow it.  
450 Is it not enough that he has the armor,  
and vaunts in it — just so?  
451 Into your knees and into your hearts I  
will throw fury,  
452 so you may carry Automedon safe out  
of the war  
453 to the hollow ships. For I will still  
hand the enemy glory,  
454 to kill, until they reach the well-  
benched ships,  
455 and the sun goes down and the sacred  
darkness comes on.”

456 So speaking, he breathed brave fury  
into the horses;  
457 and the two of them, shaking the dust  
from their manes to the ground,  
458 swiftly carried the quick chariot  
among Trojans and Achaeans.  
459 And behind them Automedon fought,  
grieving for his companion, 28  
460 swooping with the horses like a  
vulture on geese:  
461 easily he would run back out of the  
Trojans' clamor,  
462 and easily charge in again, pressing  
through the thick crowd.  
463 But he took no men when he swept in  
pursuit:  
464 it was not possible, alone in the sacred  
chariot,  
465 to go at them with the spear and hold

the swift horses.

466 At last a companion saw him with his  
own eyes —

467 Alcimedon, the son of Laerces,  
Haemon's son;

468 he stood behind the chariot and spoke  
to Automedon:

469 "Automedon — which of the gods put  
this profitless plan

470 in your chest, and took your good wits  
from you?

471 — fighting the Trojans alone, in the  
front of the crowd,

472 while your companion lies killed, and  
Hector himself

473 glories with the armor of Aeacus'  
grandson on his own shoulders."

474 And Automedon, Diores' son,  
answered him:

475 “Alcimedon — what other Achaean is  
your equal  
476 at holding the fury of immortal horses  
in hand —  
477 except Patroclus, the equal of the gods  
in counsel,  
478 while he lived? Now death and fate  
have overtaken him.  
479 So: you take over the whip and the  
shining reins,  
480 and I will step down from the horses,  
and fight.”  
481 So he spoke; and Alcimedon, springing  
onto the rescue-chariot,  
482 quickly caught up the whip and reins  
in his hands,  
483 and Automedon leapt down. And  
glorious Hector saw it,  
484 and at once he spoke to Aeneas, who

was near:

485 “Aeneas — counselor of the bronze-  
shirted Trojans —

486 I see the two horses of the swift-  
footed son of Aeacus

487 come out into the battle with feeble  
charioteers.

488 I could hope to take them, if you in  
your heart

489 are willing; since if the two of us  
charged, they would not

490 dare stand against us face to face, and  
fight the war-god.”

491 So he spoke, and the brave son of  
Anchises did not disobey.

492 The two went straight on, their  
shoulders wrapped in oxhides

493 dry and stiff, with heavy bronze  
hammered over them;

494 and with them went Chromius, and  
godlike Aretus,  
495 the two together; and their hearts had  
great hope  
496 of killing the men, and driving off the  
strong-necked horses —  
497 fools: not without blood were they to  
come away  
498 again from Automedon. He, with a  
prayer to Zeus the father,  
499 was filled with courage and strength  
in his darkened heart;  
500 and at once he spoke to Alcimedon,  
his trusted companion:  
501 “Alcimedon — hold the horses not far  
off from me,  
502 but breathing right on my back. For I  
do not think  
503 Hector, Priam’s son, will be checked in



his fury

504 before he has mounted behind the  
fair-maned horses of Achilles —

505 with the two of us killed — and routed  
the ranks of the Argive

506 men; or else been taken himself  
among the first.

507 So speaking he called the two Ajaxes  
and Menelaus:

508 "You two Ajaxes, leaders of the  
Argives, and Menelaus —

509 leave the corpse to the best men you  
have, to stand

510 and bestride it and hold off the enemy  
ranks,

511 and from the two of us — living men —  
beat off the pitiless day.

512 For here they bear down hard through  
the war of tears,

513 Hector and Aeneas, the best men of  
the Trojans.

514 But these things lie on the knees of  
the gods:

515 I too will let fly — and all the rest will  
be Zeus's care."

516 He spoke, and balanced his long-  
shadowed spear and hurled it,

517 and struck the shield of Aretus,  
balanced every way;

518 and the shield did not hold the spear:  
the bronze drove clean through,

519 and through the war-belt it tore into  
the pit of his belly.

520 As when a strong-grown man with a  
sharp axe, 29

521 striking behind the horns of an ox of  
the field,

522 shears the tendon clean through, and

the ox springs forward and drops:

523 so Aretus sprang forward and fell on  
his back; and the spear,

524 quivering razor-sharp in his bowels,  
unstrung his limbs.

525 And Hector cast at Automedon with  
his shining spear;

526 but he saw it coming and dodged the  
bronze spear,

527 ducking forward; and behind him the  
long spear

528 stuck fast in the ground, and the butt-  
end stood quivering;

529 and there at last massive Ares stilled  
its fury.

530 And now they would have gone at  
each other with swords, close in,

531 had not the two Ajaxes parted them  
for all their heat,

532 coming through the crowd at their  
companion's call.

533 In dread of them the others drew back  
again —

534 Hector and Aeneas and godlike  
Chromius —

535 and left Aretus lying there, torn  
through the heart.

536 And Automedon, the equal of swift  
Ares,

537 stripped the armor, and spoke his  
triumph over him:

538 “Now I have eased my heart a little of  
its grief

539 for Menoetius's dead son — though  
the man I killed was worse.”

540 So speaking, he took up the bloody  
spoils and set them

541 in the chariot, and mounted, feet and

hands

542 all bloody, like a lion that has fed on a  
bull.

543 And back over Patroclus the strong  
encounter was stretched again,

544 grinding, of many tears; and Athena  
woke the struggle,

545 come down from heaven: for wide-  
seeing Zeus had sent her

546 to drive on the Danaans — for now his  
mind was turned.

547 As Zeus stretches a shimmering  
rainbow out of heaven30

548 for mortals to see, a portent either of  
war

549 or of a chill storm — the kind that  
stops men's work

550 on the face of the earth, and troubles  
the flocks:

551 so she, wrapping herself in a  
shimmering cloud,  
552 sank into the Achaean host, and woke  
each man.  
553 First she spoke to Atreus' son, urging  
him on —  
554 strong Menelaus, for he was nearest  
her —  
555 likened to Phoenix in body and  
tireless voice:  
556 “Yours will be the hanging head,  
Menelaus, yours the disgrace,  
557 if under the wall of the Trojans the  
running dogs  
558 drag the trusted companion of  
illustrious Achilles.  
559 Hold on with all your strength, and  
drive on the whole army.”  
560 Then answered her Menelaus, good at

the war-cry:

561 “Phoenix — old father, elder born long  
ago — if only Athena

562 would give me strength, and hold off  
the rush of missiles!

563 Then I would be willing indeed to  
stand and defend

564 Patroclus: for his death has touched  
me to the heart.

565 But Hector has the terrible fury of fire,  
and will not stop

566 cutting men down with the bronze;  
for Zeus hands him the glory.”

567 So he spoke; and the goddess grey-  
eyed Athena was glad

568 that he had prayed to her first of all  
the gods.

569 She put strength into his shoulders  
and his knees,

570 and set in his chest the boldness of the  
fly,**31**

571 which — beaten off again and again  
from a man's skin —

572 persists in biting; and human blood is  
sweet to it:

573 with boldness like that she filled his  
darkened heart,

574 and he strode over Patroclus and cast  
with his shining spear.

575 Now there was among the Trojans one  
Podes, Eëtion's son,**32**

576 a rich man and a brave one; and  
Hector honored him

577 above the people, for he was his dear  
companion at the feast.

578 Him tawny-haired Menelaus struck on  
the war-belt

579 as he sprang away in flight, and drove



the bronze clean through:

580 he fell with a thud; and Atreus' son  
Menelaus

581 dragged the corpse away from the  
Trojans into the band of his companions.

582 But Apollo came and stood by Hector,  
and stirred him,

583 in the likeness of Phaenops, Asius's  
son, who of all

584 his guest-friends was dearest to him,  
with his house at Abydos;

585 in his likeness Apollo the worker-  
from-afar spoke to him:

586 "Hector — what other Achaean will  
fear you now?

587 Look how you flinched from  
Menelaus, who before this

588 was a soft spearman — and now he is  
gone, alone, lifting

589 the corpse away from under the  
Trojans: he has killed your trusted  
590 companion, brave among the front-  
fighters — Podes, Eëtion's son.”  
591 So he spoke; and the black cloud of  
grief wrapped Hector round,  
592 and he came through the front-  
fighters helmed in blazing bronze.  
593 And then the son of Cronos took up  
the tasseled aegis,**33**  
594 glittering, and hid Ida under clouds,  
595 and lightened and thundered hugely,  
and shook it,  
596 and gave victory to the Trojans, and  
routed the Achaeans.  
597 First to lead the rout was Peneleos the  
Boeotian:**34**  
598 turned forever toward the enemy, he  
was hit in the shoulder,

599 a grazing hit on the crest of it; but the  
spear-point of Polydamas  
600 scored clean to the bone — for he had  
come close when he threw.  
601 Then Hector wounded Leïtus, close in,  
on the wrist —  
602 the son of great-hearted Alectryon —  
and stopped his fighting;  
603 he shrank back, glancing round, for  
his heart no longer hoped  
604 to hold a spear steady in hand and  
fight the Trojans.  
605 And as Hector chased Leïtus,  
Idomeneus  
606 struck him on the corslet, on the  
chest beside the nipple;  
607 but the long spear snapped at the  
socket, and the Trojans  
608 shouted. And Hector cast at

Idomeneus, Deucalion's son,  
609 standing in his chariot; and missed  
him by a little,  
610 but struck the aide and charioteer of  
Meriones,  
611 Coeranus, who had followed him from  
well-founded Lyctus.  
612 (Idomeneus had come on foot at first,  
leaving the double-ended  
613 ships, and would have handed the  
Trojans a great triumph  
614 had not Coeranus driven up fast with  
the swift horses:  
615 to him he came as light, and beat off  
the pitiless day —  
616 and lost his own life under man-  
slaughtering Hector.)  
617 Him Hector struck below the jaw,  
under the ear, and the spear-butt

618 dashed his teeth out at the roots, and  
cut the tongue through the middle:  
619 he crashed from the chariot, and  
poured the reins to the ground.  
620 And Meriones stooped and gathered  
them up off the plain  
621 in his own hands, and called to  
Idomeneus:  
622 “Lay on the whip now, till you come to  
the swift ships!  
623 You see it yourself: the power is no  
longer with the Achaeans.”  
624 So he spoke; and Idomeneus whipped  
the fair-maned horses  
625 back to the hollow ships; for fear had  
fallen on his heart.  
626 Nor did great-hearted Ajax fail to see  
it, and Menelaus —  
627 that Zeus was giving the Trojans the

tide-turning victory;

628 and great Telamonian Ajax began to  
speak among them:

629 “Shame! By now even a man who was  
a great fool35

630 could see that father Zeus himself is  
helping the Trojans.

631 Every missile of theirs strikes home,  
whoever lets fly,

632 coward or brave man: Zeus guides  
them all alike;

633 and ours drop to the ground, every  
one, spent for nothing.

634 Come then — let us ourselves think  
out the best plan,

635 both how to haul the corpse away, and  
how we ourselves

636 may come home to be a joy to our  
dear companions,

637 who look this way, grieving, and say  
that no longer  
638 can the fury of man-slaughtering  
Hector and his invincible  
639 hands be held — that he will fall on  
the black ships.  
640 And would there were some  
companion to carry word quickly  
641 to Peleus' son; for I do not think he  
has even heard  
642 the wretched news — that his dear  
companion has perished.  
643 But nowhere can I see such a man  
among the Achaeans:  
644 they are held in the mist, themselves  
and their horses alike.  
645 Father Zeus — deliver the sons of the  
Achaeans out of the mist;  
646 make clear sky; grant our eyes to see;

647 and in the light — kill us, since that is  
now your pleasure.”  
648 So he spoke; and the father pitied him  
as he wept, 36  
649 and at once he scattered the mist and  
thrust the fog away,  
650 and the sun blazed out, and the whole  
battle came clear.  
651 And then Ajax spoke to Menelaus,  
good at the war-cry:  
652 “Look about you now, Zeus-nurtured  
Menelaus — see if you can  
653 sight Antilochus alive, great-hearted  
Nestor’s son,  
654 and send him running to war-minded  
Achilles  
655 with word that his far-dearest  
companion has perished.”  
656 So he spoke, and Menelaus, good at



the war-cry, did not disobey,  
657 and set out — like a lion from a  
farmstead37  
658 that has grown weary at last of  
provoking the dogs and the men,  
659 who will not let him take the fat of the  
herd,  
660 watching all night long; and he,  
craving the meat,  
661 charges in but gets nowhere, for  
javelins thick and fast  
662 fly out to meet him from daring  
hands,  
663 and burning brands besides, and he  
flinches at those for all his fury,  
664 and at dawn he goes off apart, sullen  
at heart:  
665 so from Patroclus went Menelaus,  
good at the war-cry,

666 much against his will; for he feared  
the Achaeans  
667 in the grim rout would leave him, prey  
for the enemy;  
668 and long he charged Meriones and the  
two Ajaxes:  
669 “You two Ajaxes, leaders of the  
Argives, and Meriones —  
670 now let each man remember the  
gentleness  
671 of poor Patroclus: to every one of us  
he knew how  
672 to be kind, while he lived. Now death  
and fate have overtaken him.”  
673 So speaking, tawny-haired Menelaus  
went off,  
674 glancing on every side, like an eagle —  
the bird  
675 men say has the sharpest sight of all

things under heaven:

676 high as he rides, the swift-footed hare  
does not escape him

677 crouched under a leafy bush, but  
down upon it

678 he swoops, and seizes it fast, and takes  
its life:

679 so then, Zeus-nurtured Menelaus,  
your shining eyes

680 went ranging everywhere across the  
crowd of your companions,

681 hunting Nestor's son, if you might see  
him still alive.

682 And he saw him quickly, on the far left  
of the whole battle,

683 heartening his companions and  
driving them to fight;

684 and standing close, tawny-haired  
Menelaus spoke:

685 “Antilochus — come here, Zeus-  
nurtured; hear  
686 the wretched news — the thing that  
should never have happened.  
687 Already, I think, you see it with your  
own eyes  
688 and know it: a god is rolling calamity  
on the Danaans,  
689 and victory is the Trojans’. And killed  
is the best of the Achaeans —  
690 Patroclus; and a great longing is built  
for the Danaans.  
691 Run to the ships of the Achaeans,  
quick, and tell  
692 Achilles — he may yet bring the body  
safe to his ship,  
693 naked: for Hector of the flashing  
helmet has the armor.”  
694 So he spoke; and Antilochus heard the

word with horror.**38**

**695** For a long time speechlessness held  
him: his eyes

**696** filled with tears, and his strong voice  
was checked.

**697** Yet not even so did he neglect  
Menelaus's charge:

**698** he set off at a run, and gave his armor  
to his blameless companion

**699** Laodocus, who wheeled the whole-  
hoofed horses close beside him.

**700** And his feet carried him weeping out  
of the battle,

**701** bearing the evil word to Achilles,  
Peleus' son.

**702** And your heart, Zeus-nurtured  
Menelaus, had no will**39**

**703** to defend the worn companions there  
where Antilochus

704 had left them, and great longing was  
built for the Pylians;  
705 but he sent them brilliant  
Thrasymedes,  
706 and himself went back again to  
bestride the hero Patroclus;  
707 and running he stood beside the two  
Ajaxes, and spoke at once:  
708 “That man I have sent off to the swift  
ships,  
709 to go to Achilles of the swift feet. But I  
do not think  
710 Achilles will come now, however great  
his anger at brilliant Hector:  
711 there is no way he could fight the  
Trojans naked.  
712 So let us ourselves think out the best  
plan,  
713 both how to haul the corpse away, and

how we ourselves

714 may escape death and doom out of the  
Trojans' clamor."

715 Then great Telamonian Ajax answered  
him:

716 "All you have said is right and true,  
far-famed Menelaus.

717 You and Meriones — stoop down,  
quickly, get under him,

718 lift the corpse and carry him out of  
the toil. And behind you

719 we two will fight the Trojans and  
brilliant Hector,

720 one heart in us as we share one name,  
we two who before now

721 have stood the sharp war-god side by  
side, together."

722 So he spoke; and they took the corpse  
up off the ground in their arms,

723 high and mightily; and behind them  
the Trojan army  
724 screamed, when they saw the  
Achaeans lifting the body,  
725 and charged like hounds that spring  
on a wounded boar<sup>40</sup>  
726 ahead of the young hunters:  
727 for a while they race in, furious to tear  
him —  
728 but when he wheels among them, sure  
of his strength,  
729 back they shrink, and scatter in terror  
this way and that:  
730 so the Trojans for a while kept up the  
chase in a mass,  
731 stabbing with swords and double-  
curved spears;  
732 but whenever the two Ajaxes turned  
about and stood



733 against them, their color changed, and  
not one dared  
734 dart forward and fight for the corpse.  
735 So the two of them, straining, carried  
the body out of the battle  
736 toward the hollow ships; and the war  
stretched taut behind them,  
737 savage as fire that leaps on a city of  
men,  
738 rising suddenly, and blazes, and the  
houses crumble  
739 in the great glare, and the wind's  
strength roars across it:  
740 so the relentless din of horses and of  
spearmen  
741 came on behind them as they went.  
742 And they — like mules who have  
thrown their great strength into the work,  
743 dragging down from the mountain

along a rugged track

744 a roof-beam or a huge ship-timber,  
and inside them the heart

745 is worn with weariness and sweat  
together as they strain:

746 so the two of them, straining, carried  
the body. And behind them

747 the two Ajaxes held the enemy — as a  
wooded ridge

748 holds back water, a ridge lying clean  
across a plain,

749 which checks even the punishing  
currents of powerful rivers,

750 and at once turns the flood of them all  
to wander

751 loose across the lowland; and all their  
strength cannot break it:

752 so the two Ajaxes, behind, kept  
fending off the battle

753 of the Trojans. But they followed hard,  
and two above all,

754 Aeneas, Anchises' son, and glorious  
Hector.

755 And as a cloud of starlings goes, or of  
jackdaws,41

756 shrieking ruin, when they see coming  
at them

757 a falcon, that carries death to small  
birds:

758 so before Aeneas and Hector the  
young Achaeans men

759 went shrieking ruin, and forgot their  
war-craft.

760 And much fine armor fell around and  
about the ditch

761 as the Danaans fled; and there was no  
pause in the war.

# Notes

## NOTES

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1. (17.1-6) Menelaus over the body “as a mother-cow, lowing, stands over her first calf, who never knew birth before” (πρωτοτόκος κινυρή — the lowing of a first-time mother). The poem opens its longest battle with its most maternal image: the corpse-defense that will consume the book is presented first not as war but as instinct — and given to Menelaus, the poem’s specialist in loyal, unglamorous care. ↩
2. (17.9-32) Euphorbus claims the spoils by right of first blood (his dart at 16.806-815); Menelaus’s answer settles the Hyperenor account opened at 14.516 — with details the earlier narrative never gave (the mockery, “sorriest fighter of the Danaans”): the poem’s ledgers, as at 17.24-28, remember more than they recorded. His closing proverb — “When the thing is done, even the fool learns” (ῥεχθὲν δέ τε

νήπιος ἔγνων) — became Greek proverbial stock permanently. ↩

3. (17.33-42) Euphorbus's revenge-speech is a family portrait: the brother's widow "in the depth of her new bridal chamber," the parents' "cursed mourning," and the imagined homecoming — your head and armor "in the hands of Panthous and brilliant Phrontis." He is the third Panthoid the war has engaged (Polydamas, Hyperenor); by naming his own parents he writes the address on his own death-notice. ↩

4. (17.43-60) The kill and the double image. First the hair: "soaked with blood — hair like the Graces", and the braids pinched tight in gold and silver" — the poem's dandy-warrior, beautiful even in the detail of his hair-clasps. Then the olive sapling: reared by hand in a lonely place by welling water, rocked by every breathing of wind, white with blossom — torn out by one squall and laid flat. The most tender death-simile in the Iliad, spent on a minor Trojan — and made immortal twice over: Porphyry's *Life of Pythagoras* quotes the passage because Pythagoras claimed to have been Euphorbus (16.[43]); the sage's

remembered death arrived pre-fitted with the loveliest lines in Homer. ↩

5. (17.61-69) The lion takes the finest heifer: lines 63-64 repeat 11.175-176 verbatim (our English kept) — the neck broken first, the blood and inward parts gulped down — while dogs and herdsman clamor “from a distance,” held by green fear. Menelaus, so often the poem’s second-rank fighter, is for once the beast nobody dares approach. ↩
6. (17.70-105) Apollo-as-Mentes turns Hector back with the horses-taunt that reuses Dolon’s dream (10.402-404, our English kept): the unattainable team as the measure of Trojan overreach, third time offered, never possessed. Menelaus’s soliloquy that follows is the poem’s clearest statement of the shame-calculus (fixed frame lines kept: “Troubled, he spoke...”; “But why does my own heart argue...”): abandoning the body is disgrace, fighting a god-backed man is doom — “When a man wills, against the god’s face, to fight a man whom a god honors, a great woe rolls down on him quickly” — and the resolution is neither: withdraw, find Ajax, return. Prudence with a plan is not cowardice; the poem lets the calculation stand unmocked. ↩

7. (17.109-113) The reluctant lion — driven from the fold, “the brave heart in his chest goes stiff with the cold” — the first of the book’s two borrowings from Ajax’s great retreat- simile family of Book 11 (see note [35] for the second): the poem now clothes Menelaus in the images it minted for its strongest defender. ↩
8. (17.125-127) Hector’s intention, stated flat: to shear the head from the shoulders and give the trunk “to the dogs of Troy.” The corpse-outrage theme crosses a line no one has yet crossed in act — and it is Hector, the poem’s most humane warrior, who first conceives it. Books 22-24 will weigh everything that follows against these three lines. ↩
9. (17.132-139) Ajax over the corpse as a lion over his cubs, the whole scowl of his brows drawn down over his eyes — guardianship again (note [1]), now paternal; and Menelaus beside him “nursing great grief.” The two images of the book’s opening — mother-cow and lion-father — bracket the dead man like parents. ↩
10. (17.140-168) Glaucus’s rebuke — the harshest any ally gives Hector — climaxes in the book’s most startling proposal: haul Patroclus into Ilion and trade him — “the Argives would quickly ransom back the fine

armor of Sarpedon, and we would bring the man himself into Ilion.” Corpse for corpse, gear for gear: the dead as exchangeable stores of value. The poem’s whole final movement (Hector’s body ransomed for weighed gold) is glimpsed here first as an ally’s grievance; and the grievance itself — “there was never any thanks” — is the mercenary’s ledger Hector must answer with his own accounting at 220-232. ↩

11. (17.169-182) Hector’s answer reuses the theology of 16.688-692 (our English kept): “always the mind of Zeus... is stronger: he sends even the brave man running... and then again himself drives a man to fight.” True doctrine — and, as ever with Hector, deployed exactly where it excuses him. The challenge (“stand beside me, old friend — watch my work”) converts the quarrel into witness. ↩
12. (17.183-197) The changing of the armor, staged “apart from the battle of many tears” like a rite: his own gear sent into Ilion, the immortal gear put on — and the poem recites its provenance as elegy: gods to Peleus; Peleus, “grown old,” to his son; “but the son did not grow old in his father’s armor.” The line every reader remembers: the armor’s history is a



history of interrupted inheritance, and Hector is now inside it. ↩

13. (17.198-214) Zeus's head-shake over Hector is the poem's theology of recompense at its most precise: the armor taken "not by right" (οὐ κατὰ κόσμον); the grant of "great power" made explicitly τῶν ποινῆν — as blood-price, compensation paid in advance for the death already decreed: "never home out of the battle will you come, for Andromache to take from you the famous armor of Peleus' son." Andromache, who begged him to fight from the wall (6.431), enters the sentence as the person who will not perform the homecoming ritual. Then the uncanny grace-note: the armor fits — Zeus himself "fitted the armor to Hector's body, and Ares entered him." The gift, the doom, and the ecstasy are one act.



14. (17.215-232) Hector's speech to the allies is the epic's frankest look at coalition warfare: "it was not for a crowd's sake I gathered you... I wear down my own people for gifts and provisions, to feed the courage in each of you" — the war economy Glaucus invoked (147-148) conceded in full. Then the third and strangest use of the intimacy-word: die or live —

“that is the trysting-talk of war” (πολέμου ὀαριστύς; 13.291, 14.216). And the bounty: half-shares with Hector for whoever drags Patroclus in — glory made divisible and priced. ↩

15. (17.233-261, 260-261) The advance is stamped “fools” (over that body Ajax “was to rob many of life”); Ajax’s grim realism (“It is not so much for the corpse I fear... as for my own head”); Menelaus’s call to the leaders “who drink at the public cost” — rank invoked through its perquisites; and then the narrator’s own confession, athetized by Zenodotus: “But of the rest — who could speak their names out of his own mind...?” The inverted Muse-invocation: where 2.484 called on the goddesses because memory fails, here the singer simply shows the failure. The ancients heard a lapse; it reads as the book’s honesty about crowds. ↩

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17. (17.262-273) Zeus pours mist over the body’s defenders with the poem’s most carefully argued motive: “never in the time before had he hated Menoetius’s son, while he was alive... and he loathed that he become the prey of the dogs of Troy.” The god who engineered the death (16.644-655) now spends the day protecting the corpse: the two attitudes are not reconciled — they are both true, and the poem leaves them side by side. ↩

18. (17.274-318) The first full swing of the tug: Hippothous drags the body by a shield-strap bound round the ankle- tendons — the technical, butcher’s detail — and dies across it, “far from deep-soiled Larisa; nor did he repay his dear parents the price of his rearing” (θρέπτρα — child-care as a debt the dead leave unpaid; cf. 4.477-478). Schedius the Phocian falls to Hector — the death our register logged when his namesake died at 15.515: the poem keeps both

Schedii and spends them in different books. The exchange ends with the Argives dragging away not Patroclus but the Trojan dead: every body on this field is now cargo. ↩

19. (17.319-334) The counterfactual — Troy broken “even beyond the portion of Zeus” (ὕπερ Διὸς αἴσαν) by mortal strength alone — is the strongest such clause in the poem: fate has slack in it, and only Apollo’s intervention takes it up. The god borrows the shape of Periphas the herald, “grown grey in his heraldry” beside old Epytus — the poem’s tenderness for professions again — and Aeneas knows him at once (“looking him in the face”): the recognition granted to the pious Aeneas and almost no one else. ↩

20. (17.356-365) Ajax’s field-order is the tactical heart of the book: no retreat from the body, no heroics out in front, “stand close over him, and fight hand to hand.” The result the poet audits precisely: the ground purple, dead on both sides — “but far fewer of them perished: they remembered always to ward sheer ruin from one another in the crowd.” The phalanx-discipline of Books 13 and 16 has become doctrine, stated and costed: cohesion is casualty-arithmetic. ↩

21. (17.366-383) The doubled sky: over Patroclus, mist and night — “you would not have said the sun was safe, or the moon”; everywhere else “the piercing light of the sun lay spread, and no cloud showed over all the earth or the mountains,” where men fight “in pauses, keeping well apart.” A private midnight for the best, sunshine for the rest — the poem’s most surreal battlefield image, ending on the two who fight in the light and do not know (Thrasymedes and Antilochus): light as ignorance, darkness as the place where the truth is. ↩
22. (17.384-401) The tanning simile: the great bull’s hide, soaked in fat, stretched in a circle by many hands “until the moisture goes and the fat sinks in... and the whole hide is stretched taut through” — the day’s whole war compressed into a work-yard: the corpse pulled “this way and that, in a little space,” by professionals, patiently. Even Ares and Athena “could not have scorned” the toil — the gods invoked as connoisseurs of labor. Nothing in the poem is grimmer than the craftsmanship of this comparison. ↩
23. (17.401-411) And Achilles does not know. The passage Zenodotus cut (404-425 in his edition): Thetis

“often” told him the purpose of Zeus, “but now his mother told him nothing of the evil that had happened.” Inside it, the strangest clause in the poem’s plotting: Achilles never hoped Patroclus would sack the city “without him — nor with him”: he has carried his mother’s prophecies far enough to know Troy is not theirs to take together. The ignorance is thus doubly cruel: he knows the large doom and not the small one that is running toward him on Antilochus’s feet. ↩

24. (17.412-425) The paired anonymous vows (τις-speeches): the Achaean — “Sooner let the black earth gape for all of us here”; the Trojan — “even if it is fate that we be broken beside this man, all of us alike, let no one yet give way.” The two armies, nameless, say the same sentence from opposite sides. ↩
25. (17.424-425) “the iron din went up through the barren air to the brazen sky” — iron, bronze, and the barren middle air (ἀτρυγέτος, the sea’s own epithet lent to the ether): the war as metallurgy filling the whole space between earth and heaven. ↩
26. (17.426-440) The weeping horses. Immortal Xanthus and Balius stand apart from the battle “as a grave-

stone stands unmoving, set on the barrow of a dead man or a woman” — creatures of wind become their charioteer’s own monument — heads to the earth, “hot tears” running, “their rich manes fouled, streaming down from the yoke-pad.” Automedon tries whip, honey, and curses; grief does not answer to any of the three. It is the poem’s only animal mourning, and among its greatest inventions: sorrow without speech, loyalty without hope, in bodies that cannot die. ↩

27. (17.441-455) Zeus’s pity — the sentence at the poem’s center of gravity: “why did we give you to king Peleus, a mortal — you who are ageless and deathless? Was it so that you too might have sorrows among unhappy men? For there is nothing anywhere more pitiful than man, of all things that breathe and creep upon the earth.” The god who runs the war states its final metaphysics: mortality itself, not any battle, is the pity of it; the immortal horses’ one flaw is contact with us. Then the practical rider: Hector shall not have them (“Is it not enough that he has the armor...?”), and the sunset clause of the day repeated word for word from 11.193-194 — the doom still running on schedule beneath the compassion. ↩

28. (17.456-542) The Automedon sequence: the charioteer fights “like a vulture among geese,” is talked into sense by Alcimedon (the Myrmidon fifth-captain of 16.197), and the two-man crew re-forms — driver breathing on his back — against Hector, Aeneas, Chromius, and Aretus. Aretus takes the spear “as when a strong-grown man with a sharp axe, striking behind the horns of an ox of the field, shears the tendon clean through, and the ox springs forward and drops” — the sacrificial slaughter-stroke on the battlefield. And Automedon’s vaunt is the book’s grief-economy in one line: “Now I have eased my heart a little of its grief... though the man I killed was worse.” Vengeance as approximate payment; the ledger never balances, and he says so. ↩

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30. (17.543-552) Athena comes down wrapped in "a shimmering cloud" like the rainbow Zeus stretches "for mortals to see, a portent either of war or of a chill storm that stops men's work on the face of the earth, and troubles the flocks." The rainbow as omen (11.27-28 made it armor- decoration) — beauty that means interruption: war for men, weather for the sheep, the two disasters given equal standing in the farmer's sky. ↩

31. (17.553-573) Athena-as-Phoenix, and the fly. She fills Menelaus "with the boldness of the fly, which — beaten off again and again from a man's skin — persists in biting; and human blood is sweet to it." The smallest courage-simile in epic and the most audacious: persistence stripped of all dignity and honored anyway — appetite as valor. Plutarch and Galen both quote it; no other poet would have dared attach it to a king at the moment a goddess strengthens him. ↩

32. (17.575-591) Podes, Eëtion's son — “his dear companion at the feast” (εἰλαπιναστής): Hector's table-intimate, rich and brave, killed in flight by the man Apollo then calls “before this a soft spearman” (μαλθακὸς αἰχμητής). The grief-cloud that wraps Hector is personal — the war has finally reached his own mess-table. The name Eëtion tolls again (Andromache's father, 6.396; Pedasus's city, 16.153): everything Hector loves seems to descend from men of that name. ↩
33. (17.593-596) Zeus ends the argument by hand: the tasseled aegis taken up, Ida hidden in cloud, lightning, thunder, the shake — “and gave victory to the Trojans, and routed the Achaeans.” The instrument Apollo borrowed at 15.229 is back with its owner; four verbs, and the day tilts. ↩
34. (17.597-625) The rout ledger: Peneleos and Leïtus wounded (the two Boeotian catalogue-leaders of 2.494 subtracted in two lines); Idomeneus's spear snapping on Hector's corslet; and Coeranus of Lyctus, who dies taking the cast meant for his king — “to him he came as light, and beat off the pitiless day — and lost his own life”: the poem's formula of salvation (φάος, light) priced at one charioteer.

Meriones stooping to gather the fallen reins off the plain while the world collapses is the kind of detail this poet never omits: someone must always pick up the reins. ↩

35. (17.626-647) Ajax's prayer. First the observation ("even a man who was a great fool could see that father Zeus himself is helping the Trojans — every missile of theirs strikes home... and ours drop to the ground, every one"), then the double need (save the body; send word to Achilles), and then the request that Longinus (On the Sublime 9.10) set above nearly everything in literature: "Father Zeus — deliver the sons of the Achaeans out of the mist; make clear sky; grant our eyes to see; and in the light — kill us, since that is now your pleasure" (ἐν δὲ φάει καὶ ὄλεσσον). He does not pray to live; he prays to see. The demand is worthy of the fighter the poem has built across seventeen books: no complaint, no bargain — visibility, and then whatever Zeus likes. ↩

36. (17.648-650) "And the father pitied him as he wept" — the tears are Ajax's (the strongest man in the army weeping inside his prayer, a detail easy to miss and impossible to forget), and Zeus's answer is instant and exact: mist scattered, fog thrust away, "the sun

blazed out, and the whole battle came clear.” He grants the seeing. The killing he keeps on its schedule. ↩

37. (17.651-701) The message chain. Menelaus leaves the body “much against his will,” in the reluctant-lion simile repeated from 11.550-555 (our English kept — the simile that carried Ajax’s retreat now carries Menelaus’s errand); his charge to the defenders is the dead man’s true eulogy: “let each man remember the gentleness of poor Patroclus: to every one of us he knew how to be kind, while he lived.” Then the eagle-eye search, and the delivery to Antilochus — who answers with the poem’s most complete silence: “For a long time speechlessness held him: his eyes filled with tears, and his strong voice was checked.” He hands his armor to Laodocus and runs weeping — the fastest of the young Achaeans carrying the heaviest sentence in the poem, unarmed, “bearing the evil word.” Book 18 opens on his arrival. ↩

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39. (17.702-721) Menelaus returns — the apostrophe turned on him twice in fifty lines (679, 702): the book's faithful laborer earns the second person too. Ajax's plan divides the last work: Menelaus and Meriones to carry, the two Ajaxes — "one heart in us as we share one name" — to hold the rear: the pun on Αἴαντες as a fighting unit, two men conjugated as a dual. ↩
40. (17.722-753) The carry: the body hoisted "high and mightily"; the boar wheeling on the hounds; the fire engulfing a city ("the houses crumble in the great

glare”); and then the pair of similes that turn rescue into labor and landscape — the mules dragging beam or ship-timber “down from the mountain along a rugged track... the heart worn with weariness and sweat”; the Ajaxes as “a wooded ridge... lying clean across a plain,” damming the flood of powerful rivers and turning it loose over the lowland. Men as terrain: the defensive fighter’s apotheosis is to become geography. ↩

41. (17.755-761) The end: starlings and jackdaws  
“shrieking ruin” before the falcon — the young Achaeans in flight before Aeneas and Hector — “and much fine armor fell around and about the ditch as the Danaans fled; and there was no pause in the war.” The book that fought all day for one man’s body closes with armor strewn like litter and the fighting unpaused: no cadence, no rest — because the poem’s next sound is Antilochus’s voice in Achilles’ hearing, and nothing in the war will ever be the same after it. ↩

# Book 18

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*The news reaches Achilles: the scream, the  
choice of death — and on the anvil of  
Hephaestus a whole world of peace, hammered  
onto the shield he will carry to kill Hector.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 So they fought on, like blazing fire;
- 2 and Antilochus came to Achilles, a swift-footed messenger.
- 3 He found him in front of his ships with their upright horns,
- 4 brooding in his heart on what was already done;
- 5 and troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit:

6 “Ah me — why are the long-haired  
Achaean again<sup>1</sup>  
7 being driven in rout across the plain,  
back on the ships?  
8 Let the gods not now accomplish the  
evil griefs of my heart,  
9 as my mother once set out for me  
plainly, and told me  
10 that the best of the Myrmidons, while I  
still lived,  
11 would leave the light of the sun at  
Trojan hands.  
12 Surely he is dead already — Menoetius’s  
stout son.  
13 Stubborn man! I ordered him: beat off  
the enemy fire,  
14 then back to the ships — do not fight  
Hector strength to strength.”  
15 While he was turning this over in mind



and heart,

16 the son of illustrious Nestor came up  
close to him,

17 shedding hot tears, and spoke the  
grievous message:

18 “Ah me, son of war-minded Peleus — it  
is very hard news<sup>2</sup>

19 you must hear now: a thing that should  
never have happened.

20 Patroclus lies dead. They are fighting  
over the body —

21 naked: for Hector of the flashing  
helmet has the armor.”

22 So he spoke; and the black cloud of  
grief covered Achilles.

23 With both hands he took up the sooty  
dust<sup>3</sup>

24 and poured it down over his head, and  
defiled his gracious face;

25 and on his nectar-fragrant tunic the  
black ash settled.

26 And he himself, in the dust, lay  
stretched out —

27 mighty in his mightiness — with his  
own hands he tore and fouled his hair.

28 And the slave-women Achilles and  
Patroclus had won as plunder

29 shrieked aloud in the grief of their  
hearts, and ran

30 out of the doors around war-minded  
Achilles, and all of them

31 beat their breasts with their hands, and  
the limbs of each went slack.

32 And Antilochus on the other side  
mourned, shedding tears,

33 holding the hands of Achilles as his  
glorious heart groaned —

34 for he feared he might cut his own

throat with the iron.

35 Then he cried out, terribly; and his lady  
mother heard him

36 where she sat in the depths of the sea  
beside her aged father,

37 and wailed in answer; and the  
goddesses gathered around her,

38 all the Nereids who were in the depths  
of the sea.

39 There were Glauce and Thaleia and  
Cymodoce,<sup>4</sup>

40 Nesaea and Speio and Thoë and ox-  
eyed Halië,

41 Cymothoë and Actaea and Limnoreia

42 and Melite and Iaera and Amphithoë  
and Agave,

43 Doto and Proto and Pherousa and  
Dynamene,

44 Dexamene and Amphinome and

Callianeira,

45 Doris and Panope and far-famed  
Galateia,

46 Nemertes and Apseudes and  
Callianassa;

47 and there were Clymene and Ianeira  
and Ianassa,

48 Maera and Oreithyia and lovely-  
braided Amatheia,

49 and the other Nereids who were in the  
depths of the sea.

50 The silver-shining cave was filled with  
them; and all together

51 they beat their breasts, and Thetis led  
the lament:

52 “Hear me, sister Nereids, so that all of  
you

53 may know well, hearing it, what griefs  
are in my heart.

54 Ah me, unhappy! Ah me — mother of  
the best of men, and cursed in it!5  
55 For I bore a son, blameless and  
powerful,  
56 first among heroes; and he shot up like  
a sapling.  
57 I reared him like a young tree on the  
orchard's slope  
58 and sent him out with the beaked ships  
to Ilion  
59 to fight the Trojans; and I shall never  
receive him again,  
60 never coming home again to the house  
of Peleus.  
61 And while he still lives, and looks on  
the light of the sun,  
62 he grieves; and I can do nothing to help  
him, though I go to him.  
63 But go I will, to see my dear child, and

to hear

64 what grief has come to him as he waits  
out of the fighting.”

65 So speaking she left the cave; and they  
went with her,

66 weeping; and around them the wave of  
the sea

67 broke apart. And when they came to  
deep-soiled Troy

68 they stepped up onto the beach, one  
after another, where the ships

69 of the Myrmidons were drawn up close  
around swift Achilles.

70 And his lady mother came and stood by  
him as he groaned heavily,6

71 and with a sharp wail she took her son’s  
head in her arms,

72 and mourning him she spoke winged  
words:

73 “Child, why do you weep? What grief  
has come to your heart?

74 Speak out; hide nothing. All of it has  
been accomplished

75 by Zeus, exactly as you prayed with  
lifted hands:

76 that the sons of the Achaeans be  
penned against the sterns,

77 in desperate need of you, and suffer  
shameful things.”

78 Then, groaning heavily, swift-footed  
Achilles answered her:

79 “Mother — yes: the Olympian has  
accomplished all of it.<sup>7</sup>

80 But what pleasure is it to me, when my  
dear companion has perished —

81 Patroclus — whom I honored beyond all  
companions,

82 equal to my own head? I have lost him;

and the armor

83 Hector has stripped from his kill — the  
gigantic armor, a wonder

84 to see, beautiful: the shining gifts the  
gods gave Peleus

85 on the day they threw you into the bed  
of a mortal man.

86 If only you had stayed there among the  
immortal women of the sea,

87 and Peleus had brought home a mortal  
wife!

88 But now — so that for you too there  
might be grief past measure

89 for a child destroyed, whom you will  
never receive again,

90 never coming home — since my own  
heart forbids me

91 to live on and remain among men,  
unless Hector



92 first, beaten under my spear, loses his  
life

93 and pays for making Patroclus,  
Menoetius's son, his spoil."

94 Then Thetis answered him, shedding  
tears:

95 "Quick-fated then you shall be, child,  
by what you say:

96 for straight after Hector your own  
doom stands ready."

97 Then, deeply troubled, swift-footed  
Achilles answered her:

98 "Then let me die at once, since I was  
not to help<sup>8</sup>

99 my companion at his killing. Far from  
his fatherland

100 he perished, and had need of me to be  
his warder-off of ruin.

101 Now — since I shall not come home to

my dear fatherland,  
102 since I proved no light of safety to  
Patroclus, nor to my other  
103 companions, all the many broken by  
brilliant Hector,  
104 but sit here by the ships, a useless  
weight on the plowland —  
105 I, who am such as no other of the  
bronze-shirted Achaeans  
106 in war, though in assembly there are  
others better —  
107 may strife perish from among gods  
and men,9  
108 and anger, that drives even the  
prudent man to harshness:  
109 sweeter by far than honey dripping  
down,  
110 it swells like smoke in the chests of  
men —

- 111 as the lord of men Agamemnon  
angered me now.
- 112 But we will let that be — a thing done  
and past, for all our grief,  
113 beating down the heart in our chests  
because we must.
- 114 Now I will go, to find the killer of the  
dear head —
- 115 Hector. My own death-spirit I will  
accept whenever
- 116 Zeus wills to accomplish it, and the  
other immortal gods.
- 117 For not even the might of Heracles  
escaped his doom —
- 118 and he was dearest of all to lord Zeus,  
Cronos's son —
- 119 but fate broke him, and the grinding  
anger of Hera.
- 120 So I too, if a like fate is built for me,

121 shall lie still when I die. But now let  
me win great fame:  
122 let me drive some deep-girdled  
woman of Troy  
123 or Dardania to wipe with both her  
hands the tears  
124 from her soft cheeks, sobbing without  
pause,  
125 and let them know how long I have  
been out of the war.  
126 Do not hold me from the fighting,  
though you love me. You will not persuade  
me.”  
127 Then answered him the goddess,  
silver-footed Thetis:  
128 “Yes, child — all this is true. It is no  
bad thing  
129 to beat sheer destruction away from  
worn companions.

130 But your fine armor is held among the  
Trojans,  
131 the glittering bronze; and Hector of  
the flashing helmet  
132 glories in it on his own shoulders. Yet I  
promise you  
133 he will not glory in it long: his killing  
is close to him.  
134 So do not go down into the grind of  
the war-god yet —  
135 not before your own eyes see me come  
back here.  
136 At dawn I will return, with the rising  
of the sun,  
137 bringing fine armor from the lord  
Hephaestus.”  
138 So speaking she turned away from her  
son,  
139 and turning spoke to her sisters of the

sea:

140 “Sink now, all of you, into the broad  
fold of the sea,  
141 to see the old man of the sea and our  
father’s house,  
142 and tell him everything. I go to high  
Olympus,  
143 to Hephaestus famed for craft, to see if  
he is willing  
144 to give my son famed armor, shining  
bright.”  
145 So she spoke; and they sank at once  
beneath the wave of the sea,  
146 and the goddess, silver-footed Thetis,  
went on  
147 to Olympus, to bring famed armor to  
her dear son.  
148 So her feet carried her toward  
Olympus. And the Achaeans,

149 fleeing with unearthly clamor before  
man-slaughtering Hector,  
150 came to the ships and the Hellespont;  
151 nor could the strong-greaved  
Achaean drag the corpse  
152 of Patroclus, Achilles' aide, out of the  
missiles:  
153 for the army overtook it again, and the  
horses,  
154 and Hector, Priam's son, like flame in  
his fury.  
155 Three times glorious Hector seized  
him from behind by the feet,  
156 straining to drag him off, calling loud  
on the Trojans;  
157 and three times the two Ajaxes,  
clothed in rushing courage,  
158 beat him back from the corpse. But he,  
steady, sure of his strength,

159 now charged into the crush, and now  
again  
160 stood and shouted his great shout; and  
he gave back not one step.  
161 As shepherds in the field can in no way  
drive  
162 a fire-colored lion from a carcass,  
when his hunger is huge,  
163 so the two Ajaxes, helmed for war,  
could not  
164 frighten Hector, Priam's son, away  
from the corpse.  
165 And now he would have dragged it off,  
and won unspeakable glory,  
166 had not wind-footed swift Iris come  
running<sup>10</sup>  
167 from Olympus with a message for  
Peleus' son — to arm —  
168 in secret from Zeus and the other



gods: for Hera sent her.

169 And standing close she spoke winged  
words:

170 “Rise, son of Peleus — most terrifying  
of all men!

171 Defend Patroclus, for whose sake the  
dread struggle

172 stands before the ships. They are  
killing one another —

173 the one side fighting for the dead  
man’s body,

174 the other, the Trojans, storming to  
drag him off

175 to windy Ilion; and glorious Hector  
above all

176 is wild to haul him away: his heart is  
set on cutting

177 the head from the soft neck, and fixing  
it on the palisade.

178 Up — lie there no longer! Let awe  
come into your heart  
179 that Patroclus should be sport for the  
dogs of Troy.  
180 Yours is the disgrace, if the corpse  
comes back defiled.”  
181 Then answered her swift-footed  
brilliant Achilles:  
182 “Goddess Iris — which of the gods sent  
you to me with this message?”  
183 Then answered him wind-footed swift  
Iris:  
184 “Hera sent me, the honored wife of  
Zeus;  
185 and the high-throned son of Cronos  
does not know it, nor any other  
186 of the immortals who live on snow-  
capped Olympus.”  
187 Answering her spoke swift-footed

Achilles:

188 “And how am I to go into the grind?

They have my armor —

189 those men; and my dear mother

forbade me to arm

190 before my own eyes see her come back  
here:

191 she promised to bring fine armor from  
Hephaestus.

192 I know no other man whose famed  
gear I could put on —

193 unless it were the shield of Ajax,  
Telamon’s son;

194 and he himself, I trust, is out among  
the front-fighters,

195 wreaking havoc with his spear for  
dead Patroclus.”

196 Then answered him wind-footed swift  
Iris:

197 “We know it well — yes, they hold your  
famed armor.

198 But go to the ditch, just as you are,  
and show yourself to the Trojans:

199 in dread of you the Trojans may hold  
back

200 from the fighting, and the warlike  
sons of the Achaeans catch their breath,

201 worn as they are; for the breathing-  
spaces of war are few.”

202 So speaking, swift-footed Iris went her  
way;

203 and Achilles, dear to Zeus, rose up.  
And around

204 his powerful shoulders Athena threw  
the tasseled aegis,

205 and around his head the brilliant  
goddess set a crown

206 of golden cloud, and out of it lit a

flame, blazing bright.**11**

**207** As when smoke rises from a city into  
the upper air,

**208** far off, from an island that enemies  
have surrounded,

**209** where all day long the men are put to  
the test of hateful war

**210** from their own city walls; and then,  
with the setting sun,

**211** beacon-fires blaze up one after  
another, and the glare

**212** shoots high for the neighboring  
islanders to see,

**213** in hope that they may come with  
ships as warders-off of ruin:

**214** so from the head of Achilles the light  
went up to the upper air.

**215** He went from the wall and stood at  
the ditch; nor did he mix

216 with the Achaeans, for he heeded his  
mother's strict command.  
217 There he stood, and shouted; and  
apart, Pallas Athena  
218 gave voice; and among the Trojans he  
stirred unspeakable tumult.  
219 As piercing-clear as the voice of the  
trumpet, when it screams  
220 around a city ringed by life-breaking  
enemies,  
221 so piercing-clear then was the voice of  
Aeacus' grandson.  
222 And when they heard the brazen voice  
of Aeacus' grandson,  
223 the heart in every man was shaken;  
and the fair-maned horses  
224 wheeled the chariots backward: they  
smelled sorrows coming.  
225 And the charioteers were struck out of

their wits, seeing

226 the unwearying fire, terrible, over the  
head

227 of great-hearted Peleus' son: grey-  
eyed Athena made it blaze.

228 Three times over the ditch brilliant  
Achilles gave his great shout,

229 and three times the Trojans and their  
famed allies were thrown into confusion;

230 and there and then twelve of their  
best men perished

231 on their own chariots and their own  
spears. And the Achaeans,

232 glad at heart, drew Patroclus out from  
under the missiles

233 and laid him on a bier; and his dear  
companions stood around him

234 mourning; and among them followed  
swift-footed Achilles,

235 shedding hot tears, when he saw his  
trusted companion  
236 lying on the litter, torn by the sharp  
bronze —12  
237 the man he had sent out with horses  
and chariot  
238 into the war, and never received again  
at his homecoming.  
239 And the ox-eyed lady Hera sent the  
unwearied Sun,13  
240 much against his will, into the  
streams of Ocean;  
241 and the Sun set, and the brilliant  
Achaeans rested  
242 from the strong struggle and the  
leveling war.  
243 And the Trojans on the other side,  
back from the strong encounter,  
244 loosed their swift horses from under



the chariots

245 and gathered in assembly before they  
thought of supper.

246 The assembly was held standing: no  
man dared<sup>14</sup>

247 sit, for trembling held them all —  
because Achilles

248 had appeared, who had long stayed  
out of the grievous fighting.

249 Among them the level-headed  
Polydamas began to speak,

250 Panthous's son: he alone looked  
before and behind.

251 He was Hector's companion, born in  
the one night with him;

252 but one was far the better in words,  
the other with the spear.

253 With good will toward them he spoke  
and addressed them:

254 “Weigh both sides well, my friends.  
For my part I command us:  
255 go to the city now — do not wait for  
the brilliant dawn  
256 on the plain beside the ships. We are  
far from our wall.  
257 So long as that man raged against  
brilliant Agamemnon,  
258 so long the Achaeans were easier men  
to fight —  
259 I too was glad to camp beside their  
swift ships,  
260 hoping we should take the double-  
ended vessels.  
261 But now I dread the swift-footed son  
of Peleus, terribly.  
262 So violent is that man’s heart, he will  
not be willing  
263 to stay on the plain, where Trojans

and Achaeans

264 share between them the middle  
ground and the fury of the war-god:

265 it is for our city he will fight, and for  
our women.

266 Let us go to the town. Trust me: for so  
it will be.

267 For now, the ambrosial night has  
stopped the swift-footed

268 son of Peleus; but if he finds us here  
tomorrow

269 when he comes out armed, then a  
man will know him

270 well enough: gladly will he reach holy  
Ilion,

271 whoever escapes; and dogs and  
vultures will eat many

272 of the Trojans. May such a tale stay far  
from my hearing!

273 But if we do as I say — though it  
grieves us —  
274 tonight we keep our force in the  
meeting-place, and the city  
275 is guarded by its towers and high  
gates and the tall  
276 polished doors, fitted close, bolted  
fast, that shut them;  
277 and early, toward dawn, armed in our  
gear,  
278 we take our stand along the towers.  
The worse for him then,  
279 if he wants to come from the ships  
and fight us for the wall:  
280 back to the ships he must go, when he  
has worn out his strong-necked  
281 horses with every kind of running,  
driving them under the town.  
282 Inside it his heart will not let him

charge;

283 never will he sack it: sooner the  
running dogs will eat him.”

284 Glaring at him darkly, Hector of the  
flashing helmet answered:15

285 “Polydamas, this talk of yours pleases  
me no longer —

286 you who command us to run back and  
be penned in the city.

287 Have you not all had your fill of being  
cooped inside those towers?

288 In the days before, all mortal men  
would tell of

289 Priam’s city as rich in gold, rich in  
bronze;

290 but now the fine heirlooms are gone  
out of our houses:

291 sold off, our treasures have long since  
passed to Phrygia

292 and lovely Maeonia, since great Zeus  
turned his wrath on us.

293 And now — now, when the son of  
crooked-counseled Cronos has granted me  
294 to win glory at the ships, and pen the  
Achaean against the sea —

295 fool, do not lay such counsels open  
before the people!

296 No Trojan will obey you: I will not  
allow it.

297 Come then — as I say it, let us all obey:

298 Take your supper now, through the  
army, by companies;

299 remember the watch; and let every  
man stay wakeful.

300 And any Trojan whose goods torment  
him beyond measure —

301 let him gather and give it to the  
people to consume in common:

302 better any of ours enjoy them than  
the Achaeans.

303 and early, toward dawn, armed in our  
gear,

304 we will waken sharp Ares beside the  
hollow ships.

305 If it is true that brilliant Achilles has  
risen by the ships,

306 the worse for him, if that is what he  
wants. I at least

307 will not run from him out of the  
harsh-sounding war: I will stand

308 against him, face to face — whether  
he carries off the great triumph,

309 or I carry it. Enyalios is impartial: he  
kills the would-be killer.”

310 So Hector spoke; and the Trojans  
roared applause —16

311 the fools: for Pallas Athena had taken

their wits from them.

312 To Hector they gave their praise,  
whose counsels were ruinous;

313 to Polydamas no man's, who had  
devised the good counsel.

314 Then they took their supper through  
the army. But the Achaeans

315 all night long mourned Patroclus with  
wails and groans;

316 and Peleus' son led the thick lament  
among them, 17

317 laying his man-slaughtering hands on  
his companion's chest,

318 groaning again and again — like a  
bearded lion

319 whose cubs a deer-hunter has  
snatched away

320 out of the thick wood; and he comes  
back too late, and grieves,



321 and goes down glen after glen tracking  
the man's footprints,  
322 hunting him out — for bitter anger  
takes hold of him:  
323 so, groaning heavily, Achilles spoke  
among the Myrmidons:  
324 “Shame! It was an empty word I let  
fall on that day  
325 when I reassured the hero Menoetius  
in his halls:  
326 I said I would bring back his far-famed  
son to Opoeis  
327 with his share of the spoils, when he  
had sacked Ilion.  
328 But Zeus does not accomplish all the  
designs of men:  
329 for the two of us are fated to redden  
the same earth  
330 here in Troy — since I too will not

come home

331 to be received in his halls by the old  
horseman Peleus,

332 nor by Thetis my mother: the earth  
will hold me here.

333 But now, Patroclus, since I go under  
the earth after you,

334 I will not give you burial before I bring  
here

335 the armor and the head of Hector,  
your great-hearted killer;

336 and before your pyre I will cut the  
throats of twelve

337 shining children of the Trojans, in my  
rage at your slaying.

338 Until then, you shall lie just so by the  
beaked ships,

339 and around you the deep-girdled  
women of Troy and Dardania

340 shall mourn you night and day,  
shedding tears —  
341 the women we two labored to win, by  
strength and the long spear,  
342 sacking the rich cities of mortal men.”  
343 So speaking, brilliant Achilles ordered  
his companions  
344 to set a great tripod over the fire, so  
that with all speed  
345 they might wash the clotted blood  
from Patroclus.  
346 And they set the bath-water tripod on  
the blazing fire  
347 and poured the water in, and took  
wood and lit it beneath;  
348 and the fire wrapped the tripod’s  
belly, and the water warmed.  
349 And when the water boiled in the  
glittering bronze,

350 they washed him then, and anointed  
him richly with oil,  
351 and filled his wounds with unguent  
nine years old;  
352 and laying him on the bier they  
covered him with soft linen  
353 from head to foot, and over that a  
white cloak.  
354 Then all night long, around swift-  
footed Achilles,  
355 the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus  
with wails and groans.  
356 And Zeus spoke to Hera, his sister and  
his wife:18  
357 “So you have managed it after all, ox-  
eyed lady Hera —  
358 you have roused swift-footed Achilles.  
Truly they must be  
359 your own children, these long-haired

Achaeans — born from you!”

360 Then ox-eyed lady Hera answered  
him:

361 “Most dread son of Cronos, what a  
word you have spoken!

362 Even a man, I suppose, will do what he  
can for a man,

363 though he is mortal, and knows no  
such counsels as ours.

364 How then should I — who claim to be  
the best of goddesses,

365 doubly: by birth, and because I am  
called your wife,

366 and you are king over all the  
immortals —

367 how should I not stitch evils for the  
Trojans in my anger?”

368 So the two of them spoke such things  
to one another.

369 And silver-footed Thetis came to the  
house of Hephaestus, 19  
370 imperishable, starry, shining out  
among the immortals'  
371 houses, built of bronze — the crook-  
footed god had made it himself.  
372 She found him sweating, wheeling  
about his bellows,  
373 hard at his hurry: for he was forging  
tripods, twenty  
374 in all, to stand around the wall of his  
well-built hall,  
375 and under the base of each he had set  
golden wheels,  
376 so that self-moved they might enter  
the assembly of the gods  
377 and come home to his house again — a  
wonder to see.  
378 So much was finished; but the

intricate handles were not yet  
379 fitted on: these he was preparing, and  
hammering their rivets.  
380 While he labored at this with his  
knowing craft,  
381 the goddess, silver-footed Thetis,  
came near him;  
382 and Charis of the shining veil saw her  
and came forward —20  
383 the beautiful Charis, whom the famed  
crook-footed god had married —  
384 and clung to her hand, and spoke a  
word, and named her:  
385 “Thetis of the trailing robe — why  
have you come to our house,  
386 honored guest and dear? Before now  
you have not come often.  
387 Come further in with me, and let me  
set the guest-fare before you.”

388 So speaking, the brilliant goddess led  
her forward,  
389 and seated her on a chair, silver-  
studded,  
390 beautiful, intricate, with a footstool  
under her feet;  
391 and she called to Hephaestus famed  
for craft, and said:  
392 “Hephaestus — come out here: Thetis  
has need of you.”  
393 And the famed crook-footed god  
answered her:  
394 “Then a dread goddess is inside my  
house — one I revere:  
395 she saved me when the pain came  
over me after my great fall,  
396 by the will of my own bitch-faced  
mother, who wanted  
397 to hide me away for being lame. My



heart would have suffered then,  
398 had not Eurynome and Thetis caught  
me to their laps —  
399 Eurynome, daughter of back-flowing  
Ocean.  
400 Nine years I forged intricate things  
beside them —  
401 brooches, and curved spiral-bracelets,  
and rosette-cups, and necklaces —  
402 there in the hollow cave; and around  
us the stream of Ocean  
403 ran on forever, murmuring with foam.  
And no one knew —  
404 not one of the gods, not one of mortal  
men:  
405 only Thetis knew, and Eurynome —  
the two who saved me.  
406 Now she has come to our house; and  
so I am bound

407 to pay fair-braided Thetis the whole  
ransom of my life.  
408 Set out the fine guest-fare before her  
now,  
409 while I put away my bellows and all  
my tools.”  
410 He spoke, and heaved his monstrous  
bulk up from the anvil-block,21  
411 limping; and beneath him his slender  
legs moved quickly.  
412 He set the bellows away from the fire,  
and gathered  
413 all the tools of his labor into a silver  
chest;  
414 and with a sponge he wiped his face  
and both his hands,  
415 his massive neck and his shaggy chest,  
416 and put on a tunic, and took up a thick  
staff, and came out

417 limping; and there moved quickly,  
supporting their lord,  
418 attendants made of gold, in the  
likeness of living girls:  
419 in them is mind, in their breasts, and  
voice,  
420 and strength; and they know  
handiwork from the immortal gods.  
421 These moved bustling at their lord's  
side; and he, laboring on  
422 to where Thetis was, sat down on a  
shining chair,  
423 and clung to her hand, and spoke a  
word, and named her:  
424 "Thetis of the trailing robe — why  
have you come to our house,  
425 honored guest and dear? Before now  
you have not come often.  
426 Say what is in your mind. My heart

bids me do it,

427 if do it I can — if it is a thing that can  
be done.”

428 Then Thetis answered him, shedding  
tears:22

429 “Hephaestus — is there any goddess,  
of all on Olympus,

430 who has endured so many bitter griefs  
in her heart,

431 as many as the sorrows Zeus, Cronos’s  
son, has given me beyond all?

432 Out of all the sisters of the sea he  
broke me to a man,

433 to Peleus, Aeacus’ son; and I endured a  
man’s bed,

434 much against my will. That man lies in  
his halls now

435 worn out with wretched old age. But  
there is more for me:

436 he gave me a son to bear and to rear,  
437 first among heroes; and he shot up  
like a sapling.

438 I reared him like a young tree on the  
orchard's slope

439 and sent him out with the beaked  
ships to Ilion

440 to fight the Trojans; and I shall never  
receive him again,

441 never coming home again to the  
house of Peleus.

442 And while he still lives, and looks on  
the light of the sun,

443 he grieves; and I can do nothing to  
help him, though I go to him.

444 The girl the sons of the Achaeans  
picked out as his prize —

445 her the lord Agamemnon took back  
out of his hands;

446 and grieving for her he was eating his  
own heart out. Then the Trojans  
447 penned the Achaeans against the  
sterns, and would not let them  
448 come out; and the elders of the  
Argives begged him,  
449 naming over the many glorious gifts.  
450 He refused, then, to beat off the ruin  
himself;  
451 but he put his own armor on Patroclus  
452 and sent him into the war, and a great  
force with him.  
453 All day they fought around the Scaean  
Gates,  
454 and would have sacked the city that  
same day — had not Apollo  
455 killed the stout son of Menoetius in  
the front ranks,  
456 Patroclus who had wrought so much

harm, and handed the glory to Hector.

457 So now I come to your knees: will you  
give my son —

458 quick-fated as he is — a shield and a  
helmet,

459 and fine greaves fitted with ankle-  
pieces,

460 and a corslet? What he had, his  
trusted companion lost

461 when the Trojans broke him; and my  
son lies on the ground, eating his heart  
out.”

462 Then the famed crook-footed god  
answered her:23

463 “Take heart. Do not let these things  
trouble your mind.

464 Would that I could hide him away  
from harsh-sounding death

465 as surely — when the terrible doom

comes for him —

466 as fine armor shall be his: armor such  
that any man

467 of the many who see it hereafter will  
marvel.”

468 So speaking he left her there and went  
to his bellows,

469 and turned them toward the fire and  
bade them work.

470 And the bellows — twenty in all —  
blew on the crucibles,24

471 sending out their blast at every  
strength:

472 now to serve him pressing hard, and  
now the opposite,

473 however Hephaestus willed it and the  
work required.

474 And he threw unwearying bronze on  
the fire, and tin,



475 and precious gold, and silver; and next  
he set  
476 the great anvil on the anvil-block, and  
took up in one hand  
477 the massive hammer, and in the other  
took the tongs.  
478 And he made first of all a shield, great  
and heavy,  
479 working the whole of it with cunning;  
and around it he threw a rim,  
480 bright, triple, glittering; and from it a  
silver strap.  
481 Five were the layers of the shield  
itself; and on its face  
482 he wrought many intricate things  
with his knowing craft.  
483 On it he made the earth, and the  
heaven, and the sea,<sup>25</sup>  
484 the unwearied sun and the moon at

her full,

485 and on it all the constellations with  
which heaven is crowned —

486 the Pleiades and the Hyades, and the  
strength of Orion,

487 and the Bear, which men also call by  
the name of the Wagon,

488 who turns in her own place, keeping  
watch on Orion,

489 and alone has no share in the baths of  
Ocean.

490 And on it he made two cities of mortal  
men, 26

491 beautiful. In the one there were  
weddings and feasts:

492 brides were being led from their  
chambers under blazing torches

493 up through the town, and loud rose  
the wedding-song;

494 and young men whirled in the dance,  
and among them  
495 flutes and lyres kept up their cry; and  
the women,  
496 standing each at her door, looked on  
and marveled.  
497 And the people were gathered in the  
meeting-place, where a quarrel  
498 had risen: two men quarreling over  
the blood-price  
499 of a man who was killed. The one  
claimed he had paid all,  
500 declaring it to the people; the other  
refused to take anything;  
501 and both were eager to take an end of  
it before an arbiter.  
502 And the people cheered for both,  
supporters of either side,  
503 and the heralds held the crowd in

check; and the elders

504 sat on polished stones in the sacred  
circle,

505 the scepters of the clear-voiced  
heralds in their hands;

506 with these they rose, and gave  
judgment each in turn.

507 And in the middle lay two talents of  
gold,

508 to be given to the one who spoke the  
straightest judgment.

509 But around the other city two armies  
of fighting men were lying<sup>27</sup>

510 blazing in their armor; and their  
counsel was divided —

511 whether to sack it outright, or to  
divide in two

512 all the wealth the lovely town held  
inside it.

513 But the besieged were not yielding:  
they had armed in secret for an ambush.  
514 Their dear wives and little children  
stood on the wall  
515 and guarded it, with the men whom  
old age held;  
516 and the rest went out. And Ares led  
them, and Pallas Athena,  
517 both of gold, and golden the clothes  
they wore,  
518 beautiful and great in their armor —  
like the gods they were,  
519 conspicuous on every side; and the  
people under them were smaller.  
520 And when they came to the place that  
suited their ambush,  
521 by a river, where there was a watering-  
place for all the herds,  
522 there they settled themselves,

wrapped in blazing bronze.

523 And two scouts sat apart from the  
army,

524 waiting to sight the sheep and the  
twist-horned cattle.

525 And these came on soon, and two  
herdsmen followed with them,

526 delighting in their pipes: the trap they  
never guessed.

527 And the men in ambush saw them and  
ran out, and swiftly

528 cut off the herds of cattle and the fine  
flocks

529 of white-shining sheep, and killed the  
herdsmen over them.

530 But the besiegers, when they heard  
the great noise among the cattle

531 from where they sat before the  
assembly-ground, mounted at once

532 behind their high-stepping horses and  
came on fast, and reached them.

533 And they formed up and fought their  
battle on the river-banks,

534 striking one another with the bronze-  
fitted spears.

535 And Strife was joining the crowd, and  
Tumult, and deadly Fate,

536 holding one man fresh-wounded and  
alive, another

537 unwounded, another dead, dragging  
him by the feet through the fighting;

538 and the cloak on her shoulders was  
red with the blood of men.

539 They closed and fought like living  
mortals,

540 and dragged away each other's dead.

541 And on it he set a fallow field, soft,  
rich plowland,28

542 wide, thrice-turned; and on it many  
plowmen  
543 wheeled their teams and drove them  
this way and that;  
544 and whenever they turned and came  
to the field's edge,  
545 a man would come and put in their  
hands a cup  
546 of honey-sweet wine; and they would  
turn back down the furrows,  
547 straining to reach the deep fallow's  
edge again.  
548 And the field grew black behind them,  
like earth the plow has turned,  
549 though it was made of gold: that was  
the very wonder of the work.  
550 And on it he set a king's estate, where  
laborers29  
551 were reaping, with sharp sickles in



their hands.

552 Some handfuls were falling to the  
ground in rows along the swath,

553 and others the sheaf-binders were  
tying with twisted straw:

554 three binders stood at their work, and  
behind them

555 boys gathered the handfuls and  
carried them in their arms,

556 keeping them supplied without pause.  
And the king among them,

557 in silence, staff in hand, stood at the  
swath, glad at heart.

558 And heralds apart, beneath an oak,  
were laying out the feast,

559 dressing the great ox they had  
slaughtered; and the women

560 sprinkled the meal with white barley  
in plenty, for the laborers' dinner.

561 And on it he set a vineyard, heavy-  
laden with grape-clusters,30  
562 beautiful, golden: the grapes along it  
were black,  
563 and it stood staked from end to end on  
silver poles.  
564 And around it he drove a ditch of blue  
enamel, and about that a fence  
565 of tin; and one single path led in,  
566 by which the carriers passed  
whenever they gathered the vintage.  
567 And girls and young men, hearts light  
as children's,  
568 carried the honey-sweet fruit in  
woven baskets;  
569 and in the middle of them a boy with  
a clear-toned lyre  
570 played longingly, and sang the  
beautiful Linos-song

571 in his delicate voice; and they,  
stamping in time,  
572 followed with song and cries, skipping  
on their feet.  
573 And on it he made a herd of straight-  
horned cattle:31  
574 the cows were wrought of gold and of  
tin,  
575 and streamed lowing from the  
farmyard toward their pasture  
576 beside a murmuring river, beside the  
waving reeds.  
577 And golden herdsmen walked along  
with the cattle,  
578 four of them, and nine quick-footed  
dogs came after.  
579 But two terrible lions, in among the  
leading cattle,  
580 had hold of a bellowing bull; and he,

roaring loud,

581 was dragged away; and the dogs and  
the young men went after him.

582 The two lions, ripping open the great  
bull's hide,

583 were gulping the entrails and the  
black blood; and the herdsmen

584 urged their swift dogs in vain, setting  
them on:

585 the dogs kept shying back from  
sinking teeth in the lions,

586 but stood in close and barked, and  
leapt away.

587 And on it the famed crook-footed god  
made a pasture<sup>32</sup>

588 in a beautiful glen, a great pasture of  
white-shining sheep,

589 with steadings and roofed huts and  
pens.

590 And on it the famed crook-footed god  
wrought a dancing floor,<sup>33</sup>  
591 like the one that Daedalus once  
fashioned  
592 in wide Knossos for lovely-haired  
Ariadne.  
593 There young men and girls whose  
bride-price is many oxen  
594 were dancing, holding one another's  
hands at the wrist.  
595 The girls wore fine linen, and the  
young men tunics  
596 well-woven, glistening softly with oil;  
597 and the girls wore beautiful garlands,  
and the young men carried  
598 golden daggers hanging from silver  
belts.  
599 And now they would run on skillful  
feet,

600 lightly, easily — as when a potter,  
seated, tries  
601 the wheel fitted to his hands, to see if  
it will spin —  
602 and now again they would run in lines  
toward one another.  
603 And a great crowd stood around the  
lovely dance,  
604 delighting; and among them a divine  
singer made music,  
605 playing the lyre; and two acrobats,  
leading the measure,  
606 whirled through the middle of them.  
607 And on it he set the great strength of  
the river Ocean,<sup>34</sup>  
608 along the outermost rim of the  
strong-built shield.  
609 And when he had made the shield,  
great and heavy,<sup>35</sup>

610 he made him a corslet brighter than  
the blaze of fire,  
611 and he made him a heavy helmet,  
fitted to his temples,  
612 beautiful, intricate, and set upon it a  
crest of gold,  
613 and he made him greaves of pliant tin.  
614 And when the famed crook-footed god  
had labored out all the armor,  
615 he took it up and laid it before the  
mother of Achilles;  
616 and she like a hawk plunged down  
from snow-capped Olympus,  
617 carrying the glittering armor from  
Hephaestus.

## Notes

NOTES

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## NOTES

1. (18.1-14) Achilles reads the rout before the message arrives, through a prophecy remembered: “the best of the Myrmidons, while I still lived, would leave the light of the sun.” His mother’s oracles (cf. 17.408-411) work in him as dread; the fixed soliloquy frame (“troubled, he spoke...”) carries the poem’s most fearful private arithmetic. His last clause before the news is a rebuke to the dead man — “I ordered him: beat off the fire, then back” — the conditions of 16.87-96, recited by the man who set them, to no one. ↩
2. (18.15-21) The delivery: four lines, weeping, with the fixed formula shared by Menelaus’s instructions (17.685-693) — “Patroclus lies dead... naked: for Hector of the flashing helmet has the armor” (the line reused verbatim). Nothing softened, nothing arranged: the worst news in the poem is also its shortest speech. ↩
3. (18.22-35) The unmaking: the black cloud; both hands pouring soot over the head; the “nectar-fragrant tunic” fouled with ash; and the fallen line — “in the dust he lay stretched out, mighty in his mightiness”



— the epitaph of Cebriones (16.776, register kept), now describing a living man performing his own burial. The slave-women’s shrieking (δμῳαί, the register’s word) makes the hut a house of mourning; and Antilochus holds Achilles’ hands “for fear he might cut his own throat with the iron” — Aristarchus’s reading, and the Iliad’s only suicide watch: the poem considers, for one line, that its hero might end it here. Then the scream that a goddess hears through the sea. ↩

4. (18.35-49) The Nereid catalogue: thirty-three names of the sea’s daughters, athetized by Zenodotus and Aristarchus and omitted in the Argolic edition — and kept here, because the list is the point: an entire society of the sea rises keening. The names are transparent sea-poetry — Glaucē (Grey-green), Cymodoce and Cymothoë (Wave-gatherer, Wave-swift), Nemertes and Apseudes (Truthful and Unlying), Pherousa and Dynamene (Carrier and Capable), Galateia of the milk-white calm — Hesiod’s Theogony shares many. Grief summons the whole element: when Achilles screams, the Mediterranean answers by name. ↩

5. (18.50-64) Thetis leads the lament (ἐξῆρχε γόοιο — the ritual term for the chief mourner) for a son not yet dead, and coins for herself the poem's most desolate word: δυσαριστοτόκεια — “unhappy in the best of sons”: mother of the best, and cursed by the superlative itself. The sapling lines — “he shot up like a sapling; I reared him like a young tree on the orchard's slope” — recur verbatim in her petition to Hephaestus (437-443): a mother's lament already hardened into liturgy. ↩
6. (18.65-77) The Nereids beach at Troy; Thetis “took her son's head in her arms” — the position of the chief mourner at a corpse's head (cf. 24.724): she mourns him alive, enacting the funeral she will not attend. Her comfort is the poem's bitterest arithmetic: all this “has been accomplished by Zeus, exactly as you prayed” — the Book 1 petition returned with interest. ↩
7. (18.78-93) Achilles' answer: the prayer granted, “but what pleasure is it to me?” Patroclus “equal to my own head” — self and friend one body — and the armor's loss traced to its origin: the gods' wedding-gift “on the day they threw you into the bed of a mortal man.” The logic runs backward from grief to

his own conception: better his mother had stayed in the sea, better he had never been. Then the vow that closes the argument of the whole poem's first movement: no life "unless Hector first, beaten under my spear, loses his life." ↩

8. (18.94-116) The choice. Thetis: "Quick-fated then you shall be, child" (ὠκύμορος — her word for him since 1.417); "straight after Hector your own doom stands ready." Achilles: "Then let me die at once (αὐτίκα τεθναίην), since I was not to help my companion at his killing." Plato set this exchange at the center of the *Apology* (28c-d): Socrates, refusing to abandon his post for fear of death, cites Achilles despising danger "when the alternative was to live a coward who does not avenge his friends" — the pagan scripture of principled dying, quoted by philosophy at its own martyrdom. (Aeschines quoted the neighboring lines in court in 345 BC, reading the friendship as love — the ancient debate about what Patroclus was to Achilles begins in the orators.) The self-portrait that follows is pitiless: "a useless weight on the plowland" — the best of the Achaeans as unharvested ground. ↩

9. (18.107-126) The wish against strife: “may strife perish from among gods and men, and anger, that drives even the prudent man to harshness: sweeter by far than honey dripping down, it swells like smoke in the chests of men.” The wrath of the poem’s first word is renounced by its owner in its most quoted self-description — anger as honey and smoke, pleasure and suffocation in one body. Then the turn: “done is done”; death accepted “whenever Zeus wills”; the Heracles precedent (even Zeus’s dearest died); and the terrible new economy of fame — to make “some deep-girdled woman of Troy or Dardania wipe with both her hands the tears from her soft cheeks”: his glory henceforth denominated in enemy grief. Thetis does not argue; she schedules the armor. ↩
10. (18.148-202) Hera’s covert operation: Iris sent “in secret from Zeus,” finding Achilles weaponless — and Iris’s answer to “how am I to go?” is the poem’s discovery about presence: “go to the ditch, just as you are, and show yourself.” The reuse of 16.42-43 (our English kept: “catch their breath... for the breathing-spaces of war are few”) makes the point formally: what Patroclus’s borrowed armor did in Book 16, Achilles’ bare appearance will do now. The

disguise-plot ends: the man himself is the weapon.



11. (18.203-231) The epiphany at the ditch: aegis, golden cloud, and flame from the head — and the great simile turns the Achaean camp inside out: the light is like smoke and beacon-fires “from an island that enemies have surrounded... in hope that neighbors may come with ships as warders-off of ruin.” The besieged fleet’s distress-signal is Achilles himself: he is the rescue the beacons pray for. The trumpet simile (a city ringed by “life-breaking” enemies) keeps the siege inverted; Athena’s voice doubles his; and the toll is the poem’s most economical: twelve men dead “on their own chariots and their own spears” — killed by sound. He never crosses the ditch; his mother’s command holds even here. ↩
12. (18.232-239) The body received: Achilles walking behind the bier “shedding hot tears, when he saw his trusted companion lying on the litter, torn by the sharp bronze — the man he had sent out with horses and chariot into the war, and never received again at his homecoming.” The verb is Thetis’s (59, 89, 440): the failed reception, parent’s and friend’s, is now the poem’s defining gesture of loss. ↩

13. (18.239-242) Hera sends the unwearied Sun into Ocean “much against his will”: the goddess closes by force the day that began at 11.1 — the longest day in poetry, eight books long — and with it expires Hector’s warrant, which ran “until the sun goes down” (11.193-194). The astronomical order itself is bent to end a battle: nothing in the poem says more economically how much the gods now need Achilles on the field tomorrow. ↩
14. (18.243-284) The standing assembly (“no man dared sit”): fear given a posture. Polydamas — introduced with his full credentials: born the same night as Hector, “one far the better in words, the other with the spear,” the man who “alone looked before and behind” — gives the fourth and last of his counsels (12.61 accepted; 12.211 rejected; 13.726 accepted; now this): into the city tonight, fight from the towers at dawn. Every clause is correct, and the poem lets him paint the alternative exactly as Book 22 will stage it: the horses worn out “with every kind of running, driving them under the town... sooner the running dogs will eat him.” ↩
15. (18.285-310) Hector’s answer — the register’s darkly-glaring formula for the first time turned on his own

counselor since 12.230. Its center is the war's balance- sheet: Priam's city, once "rich in gold, rich in bronze," stripped — "sold off, our treasures have long since passed to Phrygia and lovely Maeonia" — ten years of attrition in four lines, the clearest economics in the poem. Then the fatal logic: Zeus has granted me glory at the ships — "I will not allow" retreat; and the creed: "I will stand against him, face to face — whether he carries off the great triumph, or I. Enyalios is impartial: he kills the would-be killer" (ξυνὸς Ἐνυάλιος — war the commons, shared ground where the hunter is hunted). Magnificent, and the exact miscalculation: the last time Hector trusted a grant of Zeus, it expired at sundown (note [13]). It has. ↩

16. (18.310-314) The narrator's civic verdict: the Trojans applaud — "the fools: for Pallas Athena had taken their wits from them. To Hector they gave their praise, whose counsels were ruinous; to Polydamas no man's, who had devised the good counsel." The poem's one explicit theory of collective political failure: the assembly's judgment itself god-damaged. Hector will remember this night with these very terms at 22.99-107 ("Polydamas will be first to heap reproach on me"); the applause the Trojans give

here is the shame that keeps him outside the wall to die. ↩

17. (18.314-355) The wake. Achilles leads the lament with “man-slaughtering hands” laid on his companion’s chest — the poem’s fixed epithet for Hector’s hands (ἀνδροφόνος) transferred once, here, to Achilles’ (ancient copies read it either way; the transfer is the point). The lion robbed of his cubs “goes down glen after glen tracking the man’s footprints... for bitter anger takes hold of him”: grief as pursuit — the simile knows revenge is a species of mourning. The speech makes the broken promise to Menoetius explicit (Opoeis, the share of spoils), accepts the shared grave (“the two of us are fated to redden the same earth here in Troy”), and then makes the poem’s darkest vow: Hector’s armor and head; “and before your pyre I will cut the throats of twelve shining children of the Trojans” — human sacrifice, promised in cold blood and later paid (21.27-32; 23.175-176). The poem neither softens nor condemns it; it sets it beside the tenderness of the washing — the boiled water, oil, nine-year unguent, soft linen, white cloak — one night containing both. ↩



18. (18.356-368) Zeus and Hera, dry as a domestic ledger:  
“So you have managed it... Truly they must be your own children, these long-haired Achaeans — born from you!” Her answer scales godhead by analogy from below: even a mortal man does what he can for a friend — how should the best of goddesses “not stitch evils for the Trojans in my anger?” (κακὰ ῥάψαι — mischief as needlework: the craft-verb of the book, on the eve of its greatest crafting.) An ancient critic (Zenodorus) condemned the exchange; it is the Olympian marriage in equilibrium — the quarrel of Books 1 and 15 subsided into married irony. ↩
19. (18.369-381) The house of Hephaestus, “imperishable, starry... he had made it himself” — and the first wonder: twenty tripods with golden wheels under their bases, “so that self-moved (αὐτόματοι) they might enter the assembly of the gods and come home to his house again.” The first self-propelled machines in literature, unfinished on the workbench — their intricate handles still to be riveted — when the biggest commission of the poem walks in. The god of craft is discovered mid-project, sweating: labor is labor even on Olympus. ↩

20. (18.382-409) Charis — “Grace of the shining veil” — is Hephaestus’s wife here (in the *Odyssey* it is Aphrodite: the poem marries the craftsman to the quality of his own work). Her hospitality frames the god’s great autobiography: thrown from heaven by “my own bitch-faced mother,” who wanted the lame child hidden; caught in the laps of Thetis and Eurynome; nine years in the sea-cave forging “brooches, and curved spiral-bracelets, and rosette-cups, and necklaces” while Ocean foamed around and no one knew. (At 1.590-594 he tells of a different fall — hurled by Zeus, landing on Lemnos: two falls, unreconciled; a god may have more than one myth.) The debt is named in the language of ransom: ζῶάγρια, “the whole ransom of my life” — the shield of Achilles will be forged as the repayment of a rescue, the poem’s economy of obligation reaching into heaven. ↩

21. (18.410-421) The god at rest: the “monstrous bulk” heaving up from the anvil-block, the sponge over face and hands and “shaggy chest” — divine labor with human sweat — and then the second wonder: “attendants made of gold, in the likeness of living girls: in them is mind, in their breasts, and voice, and strength; and they know handiwork from the

immortal gods.” Artificial intelligence, three millennia early: the lame god has built himself helpers with minds. The poem presents them without astonishment — in this house, the made and the living have equal standing. ↩

22. (18.428-461) Thetis’s petition: her own biography first — married off “out of all the sisters of the sea... and I endured a man’s bed, much against my will,” Peleus now “worn out with wretched old age” (the wedding the gods attended, reduced to a widowhood-in-waiting); the sapling lines repeated verbatim from her lament (note [5]); and then the entire Iliad summarized in thirteen lines — the prize taken, the wrath, the embassy’s gifts refused, the borrowed armor, Apollo’s kill, Hector’s glory — the poem retold inside the poem as one mother’s grievance (Aristarchus athetized the summary as needless; it is the story’s shape seen from the sea: this is what the epic looks like to a bereaved immortal). The request itself is a plain equipment-list: shield, helmet, greaves with ankle-pieces, corslet — for a son she names with her own epithet for him: “quick-fated.”



23. (18.462-467) Hephaestus's answer measures exactly what craft can and cannot do: "Would that I could hide him away from harsh-sounding death as surely... as fine armor shall be his." He can make anything except the one thing wanted. The armor is promised not as protection but as marvel — "any man of the many who see it hereafter will wonder" — art's honest offer: not to save, but to amaze. ↩
24. (18.468-482) The forge in motion: twenty bellows blowing "at every strength... however Hephaestus willed it and the work required" — automated, responsive tools; the four metals; anvil, hammer, tongs. The shield: five layers, triple shining rim, silver strap — and the maker's formula that will govern everything on it: "he wrought many intricate things with his knowing craft" (ἰδυίησι πραπίδεςσιν — with knowing wits: intelligence in the hands). ↩
25. (18.483-489) The cosmos first: earth, heaven, sea, sun, full moon, "all the constellations with which heaven is crowned" — Pleiades, Hyades, Orion's strength, and the Bear-also-called-Wagon "who turns in her own place, keeping watch on Orion, and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean": the circumpolar star that never sets, described with precise naked-eye

astronomy (the same lines steer Odysseus at Od. 5.272-275). The shield begins where Genesis begins; everything human on it will happen under this permanent sky. ↩

26. (18.490-508) The city at peace: weddings first — torchlit processions, the hymenaios, whirling dancers, “the women, standing each at her door, looked on and marveled” (the audience inside the artwork, marveling as we do). Then the trial: two men quarreling “over the blood-price of a man who was killed” — one claiming full payment made, one refusing to accept — both eager for an arbiter; the elders in the sacred circle with the heralds’ scepters, judging in turn; two talents of gold for “the straightest judgment.” The most-argued lines in Greek legal history (already in antiquity) — and, in this poem, the shield’s quiet answer to its bearer: in the city at peace, a killing becomes a procedure; ποινή can be paid, accepted, judged. Ajax said it to Achilles’ face (9.632-636): a man accepts the price even for a slain brother. Achilles carries into battle a picture of the settlement he refused — and will, in Book 24, at last enact. ↩

27. (18.509-540) The city at war fights this poem's own war in miniature: the divided counsel of the besiegers (sack, or take half the wealth — the very offer Hector floated at 22.111-121's rehearsal); the wall held by wives, children, and old men (Troy's exact demography, 8.518-522); the ambush at the watering-place; the herdsmen killed "delighting in their pipes: the trap they never guessed" (the shield's one unbearable clause — music as the last sound of the unsuspecting); and the river-bank battle joined by Strife, Tumult, and deadly Fate dragging a dead man by the feet, "and the cloak on her shoulders was red with the blood of men. They closed and fought like living mortals" — the highest compliment art pays itself in the poem: the made men fight like real ones. What Hephaestus forges here is the Iliad. ↩

28. (18.541-550) The plowing: thrice-turned fallow, the teams wheeling, and at every turn "a man would come and put in their hands a cup of honey-sweet wine" — labor's rhythm marked in refreshment. Then the master-stroke: "the field grew black behind them, and looked like earth that the plow has turned, though it was made of gold: that was the very wonder of the work." Gold made to look like soil

— the poem names realism itself as the miracle: not the precious material but its perfect surrender to truth. ↩

29. (18.551-561) The king's estate: reapers, binders, boys with armfuls, the slaughtered ox under the oak, women and barley — and at the center, the poem's image of right lordship: "the king among them, in silence, staff in hand, stood at the swath, glad at heart." A king whose joy is watching his people's work — the anti-Agamemnon: no prize taken, nothing seized; the staff (σκήπτρον, the quarrel's own prop in Book 1) held in stillness over harvest instead of strife. (Some ancient copies added a line naming the grain "Eleusinian Demeter's" — the apparatus records the pious insertion.) ↩
30. (18.562-573) The vineyard: gold vines, black grapes, silver poles, enamel ditch, tin fence, "and one single path led in" — the picture composed like the object it is. At its heart the poem's most haunting music: the boy with the clear lyre singing "the beautiful Linos-song in his delicate voice" while the pickers stamp and skip in time. The Linos-song was the ancient harvest-lament — grief for the dying year sung inside abundance (Herodotus 2.79 found its

double in Egypt) — so even the shield's happiest panel keeps one thread of mourning, in a boy's voice, at the vintage. ↩

31. (18.574-587) The cattle and the lions: the herd streaming out “beside a murmuring river, beside the waving reeds” — and then the shield's only irruption of the wild: two lions on the bellowing bull, “gulping the entrails and the black blood,” the dogs barking close and shying back. The countryside's one violence is the oldest kind — predation, not war: on the shield as in the poem's similes, the lion is what battle keeps trying to look like. ↩
32. (18.588-590) The sheep pasture: glen, steadings, huts, pens — three lines with no event at all: the shield's one panel of pure peace, and the shortest. ↩
33. (18.591-607) The dancing floor “like the one that Daedalus once fashioned in wide Knossos for lovely-haired Ariadne” — Homer's only Daedalus, invoked as the craftsman's own benchmark: Hephaestus outdoing the human master. Young men and much-wooed girls (“whose bride-price is many oxen”), hand on wrist; linen and oiled tunics; garlands, gold daggers on silver belts; and the wheeling runs compared to a potter testing his wheel — a craft



simile inside the craftwork, the second artisan invoked within the artifact. Then the line with the great textual history: “among them a divine singer made music, playing the lyre.” Aristarchus deleted the singer (Athenaeus 180-181 preserves the surgery), claiming the verse was imported from *Odyssey* 4.17-18 — but our printed text keeps him, and rightly: the shield’s final human figure is the poet, singing inside the world he is part of, while two acrobats lead the measure. The *Iliad*’s maker signs the work — inside it. ↩

34. (18.607-608) Ocean at the rim: the river that circles the world circles the shield — the cosmos of line 483 closed by its own boundary; the object is finished as the world is, edged with water. On this disk Achilles will carry the entire ordered world — seasons, courts, weddings, harvests, the dance — into a battle where he intends to die. ↩

35. (18.610-618) The rest, in one breath each: corslet “brighter than the blaze of fire,” helmet with golden crest, greaves of pliant tin; and the delivery — Thetis “like a hawk plunged down from snow-capped Olympus, carrying the glittering armor.” The book that began with a scream ends with a stoop of wings:

the mother diving seaward-fast out of heaven,  
bringing her quick-fated son the most beautiful  
object in literature, so that he can go and be killed in  
it gloriously. Book 19 opens with the armor laid  
down clashing before him. ↩

# Book 19

---

*The wrath is renounced from a seat; the blame  
is laid on a goddess; and the gifts nobody looks  
at are carried past a fasting man — who arms,  
mounts, and hears his own horse foretell his  
death.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 Dawn in her saffron robe rose up from  
the streams of Ocean<sup>1</sup>
- 2 to bring light to the immortals and to  
mortal men;
- 3 and she came to the ships carrying the  
god's gifts.
- 4 She found her dear son lying over  
Patroclus,

5 wailing his piercing grief; and around  
him his many companions  
6 mourned. The brilliant goddess stood  
among them,  
7 and clung to his hand, and spoke a word,  
and named him:  
8 “My child — we must let this man lie,  
for all our grief,<sup>2</sup>  
9 since by the will of the gods, first of all,  
he was broken.  
10 Now you: take from Hephaestus this  
famed armor,  
11 beautiful — such as no man has ever  
worn on his shoulders.”  
12 So speaking, the goddess laid the armor  
down<sup>3</sup>  
13 in front of Achilles; and all the intricate  
work clashed aloud.  
14 And trembling took all the Myrmidons:

not one dared

15 look at it straight on; they shrank away.

But Achilles —

16 the more he looked, the deeper the  
anger sank in him, and his eyes

17 blazed out terribly under their lids like  
flame-glare;

18 and he delighted, holding the god's  
shining gifts in his hands.

19 And when he had taken his joy of  
looking at the intricate work,

20 at once he spoke winged words to his  
mother:

21 “Mother, the god has given me arms:  
such work as is fitting<sup>4</sup>

22 for immortals — such as no mortal man  
could have made.

23 Now I will arm myself in them. But I  
am terribly

24 afraid that meanwhile, into the stout  
son of Menoetius,  
25 flies will enter by the bronze-cut  
wounds  
26 and breed worms in him, and defile the  
body —  
27 the life is slain out of it — and all the  
flesh will rot.”  
28 Then answered him the goddess,  
silver-footed Thetis:  
29 “Child, do not let these things trouble  
your mind.  
30 I will undertake to beat away those  
savage tribes,  
31 the flies, that feed on men killed in war.  
32 Even if he lies here till a year runs to its  
end,  
33 his flesh shall stay sound as it is — or  
better.

34 But you: call the Achaean heroes to  
assembly,  
35 renounce your wrath against  
Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,  
36 and then arm quickly for the war, and  
put on your valor.”  
37 So speaking, she sent daring strength  
into him;  
38 and into Patroclus, through the  
nostrils, she distilled  
39 ambrosia and red nectar, so his flesh  
might stay sound.  
40 And brilliant Achilles went along the  
beach of the sea<sup>5</sup>  
41 shouting his terrible shout, and roused  
the Achaean heroes.  
42 And even those who before had always  
stayed among the ships —  
43 the helmsmen, the men who kept the

steering-oars,

44 and the stewards who stayed aboard as  
dealers of bread —

45 even they went then to the assembly,  
because Achilles

46 had appeared, who had long stayed out  
of the grievous fighting.

47 And two came limping, the squires of  
Ares:

48 war-staunch Tydeus's son and brilliant  
Odysseus,

49 leaning on their spears, for they still  
carried grievous wounds;

50 and they went and sat down in the  
front of the assembly.

51 And last of all came the lord of men  
Agamemnon,

52 carrying his wound: for he too, in the  
strong encounter,



53 was stabbed by Coon, Antenor's son,  
with a bronze-fitted spear.

54 And when all the Achaeans were  
gathered together,

55 swift-footed Achilles rose up among  
them and spoke:

56 "Son of Atreus — was this, then, in any  
way the better for us both,<sup>6</sup>

57 for you and for me, when the two of us,  
grieved at heart,

58 raged in heart-devouring strife for the  
sake of a girl?

59 I wish Artemis had killed her with an  
arrow at the ships

60 on the day I chose her from the sack of  
Lyrnessus:

61 then not so many Achaeans would have  
bitten the boundless earth

62 under enemy hands, while I raged on

in my wrath.

63 For Hector and the Trojans, the gain.

The Achaeans, I think,

64 will long remember the strife of me  
and you.

65 But we will let that be — a thing done  
and past, for all our grief,7

66 beating down the heart in our chests  
because we must.

67 Now I end my anger. There is no need  
for me

68 to rage on, relentless, forever. Come  
then: quickly

69 drive the long-haired Achaeans into  
the war,

70 so that I can go out against the Trojans  
once again

71 and test them — whether they choose  
to spend the night by the ships.

72 Many a one of them, I think, will be  
glad to bend the knee,  
73 whoever escapes out of the deadly war  
from under our spear.”  
74 So he spoke; and the strong-greaved  
Achaeans rejoiced  
75 that the great-hearted son of Peleus  
renounced the wrath.  
76 And among them spoke also the lord of  
men Agamemnon —8  
77 from the place where he sat, not  
standing up in their midst:  
78 “Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of  
Ares:9  
79 when a man stands to speak, it is right  
to listen, and unseemly  
80 to break in on him: that is hard even  
for a practiced speaker.  
81 In a great uproar of men, how could

anyone hear

82 or speak? Even a clear-voiced speaker  
is defeated there.

83 To the son of Peleus I will declare  
myself. But the rest of you

84 Argives, mark it, and each man know  
my word well.

85 Often the Achaeans have said this thing  
against me,

86 and they would revile me for it. But I  
am not to blame:

87 Zeus is, and Fate, and the Erinyes who  
walks in mist,

88 who cast wild blindness into my mind  
in the assembly

89 on that day when I myself stripped  
Achilles of his prize.

90 But what could I do? A god carries all  
things to their end:

91 Blindness, the eldest daughter of Zeus,  
who blinds<sup>10</sup>  
92 all men — the deadly one. Her feet are  
soft: not on the ground  
93 does she walk, but over the heads of  
men  
94 she moves, damaging mankind; and  
one after another she snares.  
95 For once she blinded even Zeus — and  
he, they say, is best  
96 of men and gods alike; yet even Zeus  
97 Hera, female as she is, deceived with  
her scheming  
98 on the day when the might of Heracles  
was due to be born  
99 of Alcmene, inside fair-crowned  
Thebes.  
100 For Zeus spoke out in triumph among  
all the gods:

101 'Hear me, all you gods and all you  
goddesses,  
102 while I say what the heart in my chest  
commands me.  
103 Today Eileithyia of hard labor will  
bring  
104 into the light a man who shall rule all  
who dwell around him —  
105 of the race of men who are of my own  
blood.'  
106 And scheming lady Hera answered  
him:  
107 'You will prove a liar: you will set no  
fulfillment on your word.  
108 Come then, Olympian: swear me now  
a strong oath  
109 that he shall indeed be lord of all who  
dwell around him  
110 who on this day falls between the feet

of a woman,

111 of those men who are of the race of  
your blood.'

112 So she spoke; and Zeus saw none of her  
scheming,

113 but swore the great oath — and was  
blinded to his cost.

114 And Hera darted down, leaving the  
peak of Olympus,

115 and came quickly to Achaean Argos,  
where she knew

116 the sturdy wife of Sthenelus, Perseus's  
son.

117 She was pregnant with a dear son, and  
her seventh month was standing;

118 and Hera brought him out into the  
light before his month,

119 and stayed Alcmene's labor, and held  
back the Eileithyiai.

120 Then she herself brought the news,  
and said to Zeus, Cronos's son:  
121 'Father Zeus of the bright bolt — I will  
put a word in your mind.  
122 Already a fine man is born who shall  
rule the Argives:  
123 Eurystheus, son of Sthenelus,  
Perseus's son —  
124 your stock. It is no disgrace for him to  
rule the Argives.'  
125 So she spoke; and sharp grief struck  
him deep in his mind.  
126 And at once he seized Blindness by her  
shining-braided head,  
127 raging in his heart, and swore a strong  
oath  
128 that never again to Olympus and the  
starry heaven  
129 would she come back — Blindness,



who blinds all.

130 So speaking, he whirled her in his  
hand and flung her

131 out of the starry heaven; and soon she  
came to the works of men.

132 Over her he groaned forever,  
whenever he saw his dear son

133 doing shameful labor under  
Eurystheus's tasks.

134 So I too — when great Hector of the  
flashing helmet

135 kept slaughtering Argives at the sterns  
of the ships,

136 I could not forget the Blindness that  
first blinded me.

137 But since I was blinded, and Zeus took  
my wits away, 11

138 I am willing to make amends, and to  
give ransom past counting.

139 Up, then, into the war — and rouse the  
rest of the army.

140 The gifts: I am here to furnish all of  
them, as many

141 as brilliant Odysseus promised  
yesterday in your hut.

142 Or if you wish, hold back a while,  
pressed though you are for war,

143 and my attendants will fetch the gifts  
out of my ship

144 and bring them here — and you will  
see I give what contents your heart.”

145 Then in answer spoke to him swift-  
footed Achilles:

146 “Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of  
men Agamemnon:12

147 the gifts — furnish them if you wish, as  
is proper,

148 or keep them with you. But now let us

remember our war-craft,  
149 at once. There is no need to sit here  
bandying words,  
150 no need for delay: a great work is still  
undone —  
151 so that men may see Achilles once  
again among the front-fighters,  
152 wrecking the Trojan battalions with  
his bronze spear.  
153 So let each of you remember this, and  
fight your man.”  
154 Then in answer spoke to him  
resourceful Odysseus:  
155 “Not so — brave though you are,  
godlike Achilles.13  
156 Do not drive the sons of the Achaeans  
fasting toward Ilion  
157 to fight the Trojans, since the press of  
battle will not last

158 a short time only, once the phalanxes  
of men  
159 close with each other, and the god  
breathes fury into both.  
160 No — order the Achaeans by the swift  
ships to take  
161 bread and wine: for that is fury, and  
that is valor.  
162 No man will be able to fight the whole  
day through,  
163 to the setting of the sun, fasting from  
bread:  
164 for even if in his heart he is wild to  
make war,  
165 his limbs grow heavy on him  
unawares, and thirst  
166 and hunger overtake him, and his  
knees fail as he goes.  
167 But the man who has had his fill of

wine and food

168 and fights the enemy men the whole  
day long —

169 his heart in his chest is daring, and his  
limbs

170 do not tire before all break off from  
the war.

171 Come then: dismiss the army, and  
order the morning meal

172 made ready. And the gifts — let the  
lord of men Agamemnon

173 bring them into the middle of the  
assembly, so all the Achaeans

174 may see them with their eyes, and  
your heart be warmed.

175 And let him stand up among the  
Argives and swear you an oath

176 that he never went up into her bed, he  
never lay with her,

177 as is the way, lord, of men and women;  
178 and let the heart in your own chest be  
gracious.

179 And then let him appease you with a  
rich feast

180 in his hut, so you may lack nothing of  
your due.

181 And you, son of Atreus, will be more  
just toward another man

182 hereafter. There is no cause for  
indignation when a king

183 makes amends to a man, when he was  
first to turn harsh.”

184 Then answered him the lord of men  
Agamemnon:14

185 “I am glad, son of Laertes, to hear your  
speech:

186 you have gone through it all in due  
measure, point by point.

187 The oath — I am willing to swear it;  
my heart commands me;  
188 and I will not forswear myself before  
the god. But let Achilles  
189 wait here so long, pressed though he  
is for the war-god's work;  
190 and wait, all the rest of you, together,  
until the gifts  
191 come from my hut, and we cut the  
faithful oaths.  
192 And to you yourself, Odysseus, I give  
this charge and order:  
193 choose out the noblest young men of  
all the Achaeans  
194 and carry the gifts from my ship, all  
that yesterday  
195 we promised to give Achilles — and  
lead the women too.  
196 And let Talthybius, quickly, through

the broad Achaean camp,  
197 make ready a boar, to sacrifice to Zeus  
and to the Sun.”  
198 Then in answer spoke to him swift-  
footed Achilles:  
199 “Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of  
men Agamemnon:15  
200 some other time were better for  
busying yourselves with this —  
201 some pause in the fighting, whenever  
one may come,  
202 some hour when the fury is not so  
great in my chest.  
203 Now they lie torn — the men whom  
Hector, Priam’s son,  
204 broke, when Zeus was handing him  
the glory —  
205 and you two urge us to our food! For  
my part



206 I would command the sons of the  
Achaean to fight now,  
207 fasting, unfed, and at the setting of  
the sun  
208 make a great supper — once we have  
paid off the outrage.  
209 Before that, down my own throat, not  
a thing  
210 shall pass — no drink, no food — my  
companion being dead,  
211 who lies in my hut torn by the sharp  
bronze,  
212 turned toward the doorway, and  
around him our companions  
213 mourn. So those things have no place  
in my thoughts —  
214 but slaughter, and blood, and the hard  
groaning of men.”  
215 Then in answer spoke to him

resourceful Odysseus:

216 “Achilles, son of Peleus, far greatest of  
the Achaeans,16

217 you are stronger than I am, and  
mightier, not by a little,

218 with the spear; but in thought I would  
surpass you

219 by much, since I was born first and  
know more things.

220 So let your heart endure to hear my  
words.

221 Quickly men have their fill of battle —

222 that harvest where the bronze strews  
the most straw on the ground

223 and the crop is smallest, once Zeus  
tilts his scales —

224 Zeus, the dispenser of war to men.

225 With the belly the Achaeans cannot  
mourn a corpse:

226 too many men, one on another, day  
after day,  
227 are falling: when could anyone  
breathe from the labor?  
228 No — we must bury the man who dies,  
229 keeping a pitiless heart, weeping for  
one day;  
230 and all who are left alive from the  
hateful war  
231 must remember drink and food, so  
that all the more  
232 we may fight the enemy without  
pause, forever,  
233 our flesh clothed in unwearying  
bronze. And let no man  
234 hang back, waiting for a second  
summons to the army:  
235 this is the summons — and it will go  
hard with the man who is left

236 behind at the ships of the Argives. All  
in one body,  
237 let us wake the sharp war-god against  
the horse-taming Trojans.”  
238 He spoke, and took with him the sons  
of glorious Nestor,17  
239 and Meges, Phyleus’s son, and Thoas,  
and Meriones,  
240 and Lycomedes, Creon’s son, and  
Melanippus;  
241 and they went to the hut of  
Agamemnon, Atreus’s son.  
242 Then no sooner was the word said  
than the thing was done:  
243 seven tripods they carried out of the  
hut, as he had promised him,  
244 and twenty gleaming cauldrons, and  
twelve horses;  
245 and they led out at once the women

skilled in blameless work,  
246 seven, and the eighth was fair-  
cheeked Briseis.  
247 Then Odysseus weighed out ten full  
talents of gold  
248 and led the way; and the young  
Achaean men behind him carried the gifts.  
249 And they set them in the middle of  
the assembly; and Agamemnon18  
250 stood up. Talthybius, his voice like a  
god's,  
251 holding the boar in his hands, stood  
beside the shepherd of the people.  
252 And the son of Atreus drew out with  
his hands the knife  
253 that always hung beside the great  
scabbard of his sword,  
254 cut the first hairs from the boar, and  
lifting his hands

255 to Zeus he prayed. And all the Argives  
sat by in silence,  
256 in due order, listening to the king.  
257 And praying, he spoke, looking up into  
the wide heaven:  
258 “Let Zeus be witness first — highest of  
the gods, and best —  
259 and Earth, and the Sun, and the  
Erinyes, who under the earth  
260 exact payment from men, whoever  
swears a false oath:  
261 I never laid a hand on the girl Briseis,  
262 neither desiring her for my bed nor  
for anything else;  
263 untouched she has remained inside  
my huts.  
264 If any of this is falsely sworn, may the  
gods give me pains  
265 in plenty — all they give a man who

sins against them in his oath.”

266 He spoke, and cut the boar’s throat  
with the pitiless bronze.

267 And Talthybius whirled it and threw it  
into the great gulf

268 of the grey sea, food for fish. Then  
Achilles

269 rose up and spoke among the war-  
loving Argives:

270 “Father Zeus — great is the blindness  
you deal to men!**19**

271 Never otherwise would the son of  
Atreus have stirred

272 the heart in my chest so thoroughly,  
nor led the girl off

273 against my will, unbending. No: it was  
Zeus, somehow,

274 who willed that death should come to  
many Achaeans.

275 Now go to your meal, so we may join  
the war-god together.”  
276 So he spoke, and dissolved the  
assembly quickly.  
277 They scattered then, each man to his  
own ship;  
278 but the great-hearted Myrmidons  
busied themselves with the gifts  
279 and went carrying them to the ship of  
godlike Achilles.  
280 They laid them in the huts, and seated  
the women there,  
281 and proud attendants drove the  
horses to the herd.  
282 Then Briseis, like golden Aphrodite, 20  
283 when she saw Patroclus torn by the  
sharp bronze,  
284 flung herself on him with a piercing  
wail, and with her hands tore



285 her breasts and her soft throat and  
her beautiful face.  
286 And weeping, the woman like the  
goddesses said:  
287 “Patroclus — dearest of all to my  
unhappy heart —  
288 alive I left you when I went out of this  
hut;  
289 now I come back, leader of the people,  
and find you  
290 dead. So evil follows evil for me,  
always.  
291 The husband to whom my father and  
lady mother gave me  
292 I saw torn by the sharp bronze before  
our city,  
293 and my three brothers, whom one  
mother bore with me,  
294 beloved — all of them met their day of

destruction.

295 And you would not let me — not even  
when swift Achilles

296 killed my husband, and sacked the  
city of godlike Mynes —

297 you would not let me weep: you kept  
saying you would make me

298 the wedded wife of godlike Achilles,  
and take me in the ships

299 to Phthia, and hold my marriage-feast  
among the Myrmidons.

300 So I weep your death without ceasing.  
You were gentle, always.”

301 So she spoke, weeping; and the  
women wailed in answer —

302 for Patroclus in show; but each for her  
own sorrows.

303 And around Achilles the elders of the  
Achaeans gathered,21

304 begging him to eat; but he refused  
them, groaning:  
305 “I beg you — if any of my dear  
companions will hear me —  
306 do not bid me, before it is time, with  
food and drink  
307 to sate my own heart, since terrible  
grief has come to me.  
308 Until the sun goes down I will hold  
out, and endure regardless.”  
309 So speaking, he sent the other kings  
away,  
310 but the two sons of Atreus stayed, and  
brilliant Odysseus,  
311 and Nestor, and Idomeneus, and the  
old horseman Phoenix,  
312 trying to comfort his thick grief. But  
his heart would not  
313 be comforted, before he entered the

mouth of bloody war.

314 Remembering, he heaved a deep sigh,  
and spoke aloud:

315 “There was a time — unhappy man,  
dearest of my companions —22

316 when you yourself would set the  
savory meal before me in this hut,

317 quickly and deftly, whenever the  
Achaeans were rushing

318 to carry the war of many tears against  
the horse-taming Trojans.

319 Now you lie torn; and my heart goes

320 without taste of the drink and food  
that are here in plenty,

321 for want of you. Nothing worse could I  
suffer —

322 not even if I learned my father had  
died,

323 who now in Phthia, I suppose, is

letting soft tears fall

324 for lack of a son like me — while I, in a  
strange country,

325 fight the Trojans for blood-chilling  
Helen's sake —

326 or the death of my dear son, who is  
being reared for me on Scyros:

327 if he still lives somewhere — godlike  
Neoptolemus.

328 For until now the heart in my chest  
had hoped

329 that I alone would die far from horse-  
pasturing Argos,

330 here in Troy, and that you would come  
home to Phthia,

331 so you might take my child in the swift  
black ship

332 out of Scyros, and show him  
everything of mine —

333 my possessions, my slaves, my great  
high-roofed house.

334 For Peleus by now, I think, is either  
altogether

335 dead, or — barely living still — he  
grieves on

336 in hateful old age, forever waiting the  
bitter

337 news of me: when he shall hear that I  
am dead.”

338 So he spoke, weeping; and the elders  
groaned in answer,23

339 each remembering what he had left  
behind in his own halls.

340 And seeing them mourning, the son of  
Cronos pitied them,

341 and quickly he spoke winged words to  
Athena:

342 “My child, you have deserted your

man completely.

343 Is Achilles, then, no longer any care to  
your mind?

344 There he sits, in front of his ships with  
their upright horns,

345 mourning his dear companion. The  
others

346 have gone to their meal; he is fasting,  
and will not eat.

347 Go — distill nectar and lovely  
ambrosia

348 into his chest, so hunger does not  
reach him.”

349 So speaking, he urged on Athena,  
eager already;

350 and like a falcon, wide-winged and  
shrill-voiced,

351 she dropped from heaven through the  
upper air. And the Achaeans

352 were arming there and then  
throughout the camp. To Achilles  
353 she distilled nectar in his chest, and  
lovely  
354 ambrosia, so joyless hunger would not  
reach his knees;  
355 and she was gone, back to the close-  
built house of her mighty  
356 father. And they poured out away  
from the swift ships.  
357 As when thick snowflakes flutter down  
from Zeus, 24  
358 cold under the blast of Boreas born in  
the clear sky,  
359 so thick then the helmets, glittering  
bright,  
360 streamed out of the ships, and the  
bossed shields,  
361 the strong-plated corslets and the ash-



wood spears.

362 The gleam went up to heaven; and all  
the earth around laughed

363 at the lightning-flash of bronze; and a  
thunder rose from under

364 the feet of men. And in their midst  
brilliant Achilles armed.

365 His teeth ground loud against each  
other; and his two eyes<sup>25</sup>

366 blazed as if they were flame-glare; and  
into his heart

367 sank grief past bearing. Raging against  
the Trojans,

368 he put on the gifts of the god that  
Hephaestus had labored to forge.

369 First he set the greaves along his  
shins,

370 fine greaves, fitted with silver ankle-  
pieces;

371 second, he put the corslet about his  
chest;  
372 and around his shoulders he threw the  
sword, silver-studded,  
373 bronze; and after that the shield, great  
and heavy,  
374 he took up, and its light went out far,  
like the moon's.  
375 As when out at sea a light shows to  
sailors,  
376 the glare of a burning fire, that burns  
high in the mountains  
377 at a lonely steading — while the  
storm-winds carry them,  
378 unwilling, over the fish-filled sea away  
from their dear ones:  
379 so from Achilles' shield the light went  
up to the upper air,  
380 the beautiful, intricate shield. And

lifting the heavy helmet

381 he set it on his head; and it shone out  
like a star,

382 the horse-haired helmet; and around  
it shook the plumes

383 of gold that Hephaestus had set thick  
along the crest.

384 And brilliant Achilles tried himself in  
the armor,26

385 whether it fitted him, and his shining  
limbs ran free in it;

386 and it became like wings to him, and  
lifted the shepherd of the people.

387 And out of its case he drew his father's  
spear —

388 heavy, huge, compact — no other of  
the Achaeans

389 could swing it; Achilles alone knew  
how to swing it —

390 the Pelian ash that Chiron gave his  
dear father  
391 from the peak of Pelion, to be death  
for heroes.  
392 And Automedon and Alcimus tended  
the horses<sup>27</sup>  
393 and yoked them: they put the fine  
breast-straps on, cast the bits  
394 into their jaws, and drew the reins  
back tight  
395 to the jointed chariot. And taking up  
the shining whip,  
396 fitted to his hand, Automedon sprang  
up  
397 behind the horses; and behind him,  
armed, mounted Achilles,  
398 blazing in his gear like Hyperion the  
shining sun,  
399 and terribly he called to the horses of

his father:

400 “Xanthus and Balius, far-famed  
children of Podarge:

401 take thought, this time, to bring your  
charioteer back safe

402 into the crowd of the Danaans, when  
we have had our fill of war —

403 do not leave him there, like Patroclus,  
dead.”

404 Then from under the yoke the  
glancing-footed horse answered him —

405 Xanthus. He dropped his head,  
suddenly, and all his mane,

406 spilling from the yoke-pad by the  
yoke, came down and reached the ground;

407 and the goddess white-armed Hera  
gave him voice:

408 “This time, yes — we will bring you  
back safe, mighty Achilles.

409 But the day of your destruction is  
near. And it is not we  
410 who are to blame, but a great god, and  
strong Fate.  
411 It was not by our slowness, not by any  
sloth of ours,  
412 that the Trojans stripped the armor  
from Patroclus's shoulders:  
413 the best of the gods, whom lovely-  
haired Leto bore,  
414 killed him among the front-fighters,  
and gave the glory to Hector.  
415 We two could run with the very breath  
of the West Wind,  
416 which men say is the lightest thing  
that flies; but for you yourself  
417 it is fated to be broken by force — by a  
god, and by a man.”  
418 When he had spoken so, the Erinyes

stopped his voice.

419 Then, deeply troubled, swift-footed  
Achilles answered him:

420 “Xanthus, why prophesy my death?  
You need not.

421 I know it well myself: it is my portion  
to die here,

422 far from my dear father and my  
mother. Even so,

423 I will not stop before I have driven the  
Trojans to their fill of war.”

424 He spoke; and shouting he held his  
single-hoofed horses in the front rank.

## Notes

NOTES

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NOTES

1. (19.1-7) Dawn “in her saffron robe” (κροκόπεπλος, the register’s fixed rendering) rises from Ocean to light a day that will end with Hector dead; line 2 repeats 11.2 exactly (our English kept), binding this dawn to the one that opened the poem’s longest day. Thetis arrives to find her son not waiting for the armor but “lying over Patroclus” — the delivery of the most beautiful object in literature interrupts an embrace of a corpse. ↩
2. (19.8-11) Thetis’s consolation is the poem’s hardest kind: “we must let this man lie, for all our grief, since by the will of the gods, first of all, he was broken” — the same verb-frame Achilles used of the quarrel at 18.112. Grief is to be set down the way a settled thing is set down. Then the gift: armor “such as no man has ever worn on his shoulders” — literally true; it was forged for one wearing. ↩
3. (19.12-18) The armor “clashed aloud” (ἀνέβραχε) — its first act is a war-sound — and the Myrmidons cannot look at it: Hephaestus promised that “any man of the many who see it hereafter will marvel” (18.466-467), and the marvel arrives as terror. Only Achilles can face it, and the poem’s psychology is exact: “the more he looked, the deeper the anger sank in him.”



Beauty does not soothe him; it fuels him. His eyes blaze “like flame-glare” — the fire Athena lit over his head at the ditch (18.206-227) has moved inside. ↩

4. (19.21-39) Achilles’ first thought after accepting the arms is the flies. The realism is unblinking — “flies will enter by the bronze-cut wounds and breed worms... and all the flesh will rot” — and the divine answer matches it: ambrosia and red nectar distilled through the nostrils, the body kept “a year entire... sound as it is, or better.” Embalming, in the poem’s idiom: the gods’ food, which makes the immortals deathless, here holds one mortal body just short of decay. (Line 39’s placement was doubted by some ancient editors; a few copies added an extra line after 38 on Thetis’s departure — the apparatus records it.) ↩
5. (19.40-53) The muster of everyone: even the helmsmen and the ships’ bread-stewards — the poem’s only census of the noncombatants — come to see Achilles reappear. The wounded kings arrive as casualties of Book 11: Diomedes and Odysseus “leaning on their spears,” Agamemnon last, still carrying Coön’s spear-wound (11.251-253). The assembly that ends

the quarrel physically displays what the quarrel cost. ↩

6. (19.56-64) The renunciation begins with a wish that undoes the poem: better Artemis had shot Briseis “on the day I chose her from the sack of Lyrnessus” — the prize whose taking launched the wrath now wished dead by the man who fought for her honor... or rather for his. The accounting is pitiless: “For Hector and the Trojans, the gain.” Briseis herself will be standing in the assembly within two hundred lines; the poem lets the wish and the woman meet.



7. (19.65-75) The formal close of the wrath: 65-66 repeat 18.112-113 verbatim (our English kept) — the renunciation rehearsed to his mother now performed in public. The narrator seals it with the poem’s own thematic word: “the great-hearted son of Peleus renounced the wrath” (μῆνιν ἀπειπόντος) — the μῆνις of line 1.1, formally discharged. What replaces it is not peace: it is a purer anger with a different object. ↩

8. (19.76-77) The strangest stage-direction in the poem: Agamemnon speaks “from the place where he sat, not standing up in their midst.” Ancient editors were

so unsettled that Zenodotus's text (with the Massaliot and Chian editions) substituted a standing formula — "rising up among them spoke the wide-ruling Agamemnon" — and the Massaliot text added a line about him "groaning over his wound." The vulgate's seated king is better: whether he sits as an invalid, or to avoid the exposed stance of a formal orator (his next lines fret about hecklers), or because he cannot bring himself to perform deference standing, the poem's great authority-figure ends the quarrel without ever getting to his feet. ↩

9. (19.78-94) The apology that is not one. After a nervous exordium on heckling ("even a clear-voiced speaker is defeated"), the thesis: "I am not to blame: Zeus is, and Fate, and the Erinyes who walks in mist." The word rendered "blindness" is ἄτη — the divinely-sent infatuation that makes disaster feel reasonable. This register keeps "Blindness" from Phoenix's allegory (9.502-512), where she is "strong and sound of foot" and outruns the limping Prayers; here her feet are "soft: not on the ground does she walk, but over the heads of men." Two portraits, one goddess: fast as rumor, soft as a thought. Aristarchus athetized line 94 as an over-explaining tag. Line 77's opening ("when a man stands to speak...") was read

by some ancients as a rebuke of Achilles' brevity;  
more likely it is anxiety dressed as etiquette. ↩

10. (19.95-133) The parable of Ate: even Zeus was blinded — on the day of Heracles' birth, when Hera extracted the unguarded oath, held back the Eileithyiai to delay Alcmena, and rushed Eurystheus into the light at seven months: the poem's most consequential act of obstetric sabotage, making the strongest man ever born the servant of the weakest king. Zeus's response founds the theology Agamemnon needs: he threw Blindness out of heaven by her "shining-braided head" — so she now lives here, "among the works of men." Delusion is a permanent resident of earth by divine eviction: whatever we wreck, we wreck in her company. The self-serving use is patent — if Zeus could be blinded, the king's surrender of judgment is company for gods — and the poem neither endorses nor mocks it; it lets Achilles accept the same doctrine at 270-274. ↩

11. (19.134-144) The amends: 138 repeats 9.120 exactly ("I am willing to make amends, and to give ransom past counting") — Agamemnon's position has not moved one line in ten books; what has moved is everything around it. One ancient text (quoted by Athenaeus

from Dioscurides) added a line after 137: “either drunk with wine, or the gods themselves hurt me” — a plus-line that makes the king blame the cup as well as the goddess; the vulgate rightly refuses it. ↩

12. (19.145-153) Achilles’ answer prices the gifts at nothing: “furnish them if you wish, as is proper, or keep them with you.” The catalogue that Book 9 built across forty lines and Book 19 will parade through the assembly is waved off in a line and a half — the entire heroic economy of compensation dismissed by the man it was designed to persuade. What he wants now cannot be paid in tripods. ↩

13. (19.154-183) Odysseus’s first meal-speech, and a small masterpiece of practical authority: “bread and wine — for that is fury, and that is valor.” The physiology is exact (the limbs “grow heavy unawares”; the knees fail), and the procedure he lays out — gifts displayed in mid-assembly, the oath about Briseis’ bed sworn standing (176-177 reuse the wording of 9.133-134), the feast of appeasement, so Achilles “may lack nothing of your due” (δίκη — of justice) — is a complete protocol for ending a feud, *dikē* made procedural. His closing sentence dares what no one else has: “you, son of Atreus, will be more just

toward another man hereafter” — the king corrected to his face, inside a compliment. ↩

14. (19.184-197) Agamemnon accepts everything, gladly — the management of the reconciliation has passed entirely to Odysseus (“to you yourself I give this charge”). The king’s one initiative is liturgical: Talthibius and the boar for Zeus and the Sun. ↩
15. (19.198-214) Achilles’ refusal of food is the book’s center of gravity. His counter-proposal — fight fasting, feast at sundown “once we have paid off the outrage” — makes eating itself a thing that must be earned by vengeance; and the personal vow beneath it is absolute: “down my own throat, not a thing shall pass.” The speech ends on the book’s most famous line, the fast’s true diet: “but slaughter, and blood, and the hard groaning of men.” Grief has reorganized appetite itself. ↩
16. (19.215-237) Odysseus’s second speech is the Iliad’s ethics of endurance. The opening claim of eldership (216 = 16.21, our English kept — the vocative Patroclus once used to beg) licenses the great agricultural figure: battle as the harvest “where the bronze strews the most straw on the ground and the crop is smallest, once Zeus tilts his scales” —

maximum cutting, minimum grain; and  $224 = 4.84$ , “Zeus, the dispenser of war to men” (our English kept). Then the doctrine: “With the belly the Achaeans cannot mourn a corpse... we must bury the man who dies, keeping a pitiless heart, weeping for one day.” An army that loses men daily must ration grief like food — the survivor’s discipline stated once for the whole tradition. Achilles is not persuaded; he is overruled by everyone else’s hunger. ↩

17. (19.238-248) The gifts pass in review, matching the Book 9 pledge item for item (9.122-130, renderings kept): seven tripods, twenty cauldrons, twelve horses, seven women of Lesbos — “and the eighth was fair-cheeked Briseis.” The woman the poem began over enters as the last item in an inventory, between the women and the gold. Lycomedes and Melanippus and the young nobles carry the treasure; nobody in the text so much as looks at it. ↩

18. (19.249-268) The oath-rite, in exact ritual order: the herald holding the boar; the knife kept beside the sword’s scabbard (a sacrificial implement carried into battle); the first-cut hairs; the invocation of Zeus, Earth, Sun, and the Erinyes “who under the earth exact payment from men” — the oath-police of

the cosmos; the oath itself (“I never laid a hand on the girl Briseis” — confirming 9.133 was true when sworn); and the disposal: the boar whirled into the sea, “food for fish.” An oath-victim is not eaten — it has absorbed the conditional curse — so the carcass goes to the element that swallows everything. ↩

19. (19.270-275) Achilles’ response accepts Agamemnon’s theology wholesale: “Father Zeus — great is the blindness you deal to men!” — the wronged man agreeing that Zeus, not the king, “willed that death should come to many Achaeans.” The quarrel thus closes with both parties blaming heaven: a settlement, not a reckoning — and the poem quietly files it against Zeus’s own protest in the *Odyssey* (1.32-34) that mortals blame the gods for what their own recklessness earns. The last line is pure Achilles: dismissal, meal, war — “so we may join the war-god together.” ↩

20. (19.282-302) Briseis’s only speech in the poem — the prize speaks. Her lament gives her, at last, a biography: husband cut down before the city, three full brothers dead in one day, and the man who did it — Achilles — the man whose wife Patroclus promised she would become, “with the marriage-



feast among the Myrmidons.” Her grief for Patroclus is grief for the one person who converted her catastrophe into a future; “You were gentle, always” (μείλιχον αἰεὶ) is the poem’s whole portrait of the dead man in three words. Then the narrator’s terrible widening; the captive women wail with her “for Patroclus in show; but each for her own sorrows” — every slave in the camp mourning her own dead under cover of the master’s. Two lines that contain the entire suppressed grief of the war’s losers. ↩

21. (19.303-313) The comforters: both Atreidae, Odysseus, Nestor, Idomeneus, Phoenix — the embassy of Book 9 enlarged — around a man who again refuses what they offer; but where Book 9’s refusal was rage, this is grief with a deadline: “Until the sun goes down I will hold out.” He cannot be comforted “before he entered the mouth of bloody war” — battle as the only door out of mourning. ↩

22. (19.314-337) The lament for a lost future. It begins at the table — Patroclus remembered not in arms but serving dinner “quickly and deftly”: intimacy measured in housework — and opens into the poem’s geography of bereavement: Peleus in Phthia

weeping for a son who will not return, “while I, in a strange country, fight the Trojans for blood-chilling Helen’s sake”; and on Scyros the son, Neoptolemus, named only here in the Iliad — “if he still lives” — whom Patroclus was to fetch home and show “my possessions, my slaves, my great high-roofed house.” Aristophanes and Aristarchus athetized line 327 (the Neoptolemus line); it should stand: the dead man’s assignment was to be the bridge between Achilles’ father and Achilles’ son, and with him dies the family’s last connected future. Achilles imagined one exemption — “that I alone would die” — and Troy has refused even that. ↩

23. (19.338-356) Zeus’s pity and the strangest feeding in the poem: Athena, falcon-swift, distills nectar and ambrosia into the chest of a man who must not know he is being fed — the fast kept and the body sustained, both at once. The gods honor his vow by cheating it. The elders’ tears (“each remembering what he had left behind in his own halls”) make Achilles’ singular grief, for one moment, the army’s common one. ↩

24. (19.357-364) The arming of the host as weather: helmets thick as snowflakes “under the blast of

Boreas born in the clear sky” — cold light, innumerable, wind-driven — “and all the earth around laughed at the lightning-flash of bronze.” The laughing earth (γέλασσε... χθών) is the poem’s boldest pathetic figure: the world itself amused, or gleaming — the Greek means both — at what is coming. ↩

25. (19.365-383) The fourth and last full arming scene of the poem (Paris 3.330-338; Agamemnon 11.17-45; Patroclus 16.131-139; now this), each item in the canonical order — greaves, corslet, sword, shield, helmet — and everything scaled up: teeth grinding, eyes as flame-glare, the shield’s light “like the moon’s.” The great simile turns Book 18 inside out: there, beacon-fires promised rescue to a besieged island; here the mountain fire is seen by sailors “storm-driven, unwilling, over the fish-filled sea away from their dear ones” — light as pure distance, home visible and unreachable. It is the truest emblem in the poem of what Achilles’ return actually is: he shines, and he is not coming home. ↩

26. (19.384-391) The test: the armor fits so perfectly it “became like wings to him, and lifted the shepherd of the people” — Hephaestus’s craft answering the

body it was made for. Then the one weapon the god did not make: the Pelian ash of Chiron, which “no other of the Achaeans could swing” — 388-391 repeat 16.141-144 verbatim (our English kept), where Patroclus, taking everything else, left precisely this spear behind. Aristarchus athetized the lines here as an importation (“they were not even in the other editions”); kept, they complete the Book 16 figure: the borrowed armor is gone with the borrower, and what remains, inimitable, is the father’s spear — the one piece of Achilles no one else could carry. ↩

27. (19.392-424) The ending no other book has. Achilles charges his horses to bring their driver back — “do not leave him there, like Patroclus, dead” — and Xanthus answers: Hera gives him voice (line 407, athetized by Aristarchus), and the horse first bows till his mane pours from the yoke-pad to the ground: the animal’s grief-gesture the poem showed at 17.426-440, the weeping horses, now given language. His speech is exact prophecy: not our slowness but “the best of the gods” killed Patroclus; “we two could run with the very breath of the West Wind” — their sire (16.150) — “but for you yourself it is fated to be broken by force — by a god, and by a man” (Apollo and Paris, 22.359-360, though Aristarchus

athetized 416-417). Then “the Erinyes stopped his voice” — the same powers invoked at 259 as oath-police: guardians of the order of things, for whom a speaking horse is a breach to be closed. Achilles’ reply is the book in miniature: “I know it well myself.” Foreknowledge changes nothing; that is what makes him Achilles. The book ends with the shout and the horses held “in the front rank” — the wrath’s second life, pointed at Troy at last. ↩

# Book 20

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*Zeus opens the gates and the gods go down to  
war — then sit and watch, while Achilles begins  
the killing that will not stop until Hector:  
Aeneas saved for empire, Hector saved for Book  
22, and twelve men in a row not saved at all.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 So beside the beaked ships the Achaeans  
armed<sup>1</sup>
- 2 around you, son of Peleus — insatiate of  
battle! —
- 3 and the Trojans on their side, on the rise  
of the plain.
- 4 And Zeus commanded Themis to call the  
gods to assembly

5 from the crest of many-folded Olympus;  
and she went  
6 everywhere, and commanded them to  
come to the house of Zeus.  
7 Not one of the rivers was absent, except  
Ocean,  
8 nor one of the nymphs, who haunt the  
beautiful groves  
9 and the springs of rivers and the grassy  
water-meadows.  
10 And coming to the house of Zeus the  
cloud-gatherer  
11 they sat down in the polished  
colonnades that Hephaestus  
12 had built for father Zeus with his  
knowing craft.  
13 So they gathered inside Zeus's house.  
Nor did the earth-shaker<sup>2</sup>  
14 ignore the goddess's call: he came out

of the sea among them,

15 and sat in their midst, and asked what Zeus intended:

16 “Why, lord of the bright bolt, have you called the gods to assembly?

17 Are you deliberating something for the Trojans and Achaeans?

18 For now, at closest grip, their battle and war are blazing.”

19 Then in answer spoke to him cloud-gatherer Zeus:

20 “You know, earth-shaker, the counsel in my chest,

21 the reason I gathered you: they matter to me, even as they perish.

22 Yet I — I will stay here in a fold of Olympus,

23 sitting where I can watch and delight my mind. But the rest of you:



24 go now, till you come among the  
Trojans and Achaeans,  
25 and help both sides, as the mind of  
each of you inclines.  
26 For if Achilles fights the Trojans alone,  
27 not even briefly will they hold the  
swift-footed son of Peleus.  
28 Even before, they trembled just to look  
at him;  
29 now, with his heart raging terribly for  
his companion,  
30 I fear he may storm the wall itself,  
ahead of what is fated.”  
31 So spoke the son of Cronos, and woke  
unrelenting war.  
32 And the gods went to the war, their  
hearts divided:3  
33 Hera to the gathering-place of the  
ships, with Pallas Athena

34 and Poseidon who holds the earth, and  
the courier  
35 Hermes, unmatched in the shrewdness  
of his mind;  
36 and with them went Hephaestus,  
glorying in his strength,  
37 limping, and beneath him his slender  
legs moved quickly.  
38 To the Trojans went Ares of the  
flashing helmet, and with him  
39 Phoebus of the unshorn hair, and  
Artemis who showers arrows,  
40 and Leto, and Xanthus, and laughter-  
loving Aphrodite.  
41 Now as long as the gods stayed apart  
from mortal men,<sup>4</sup>  
42 the Achaeans triumphed greatly,  
because Achilles  
43 had appeared, who had long stayed out

of the grievous fighting,  
44 and terrible trembling came up in the  
limbs of every Trojan,  
45 in dread, when they saw the swift-  
footed son of Peleus  
46 blazing in his armor, the equal of Ares,  
bane of mortals.  
47 But when the Olympians came down  
into the crowd of men,  
48 up rose strong Strife, driver of armies,  
and Athena shouted,  
49 now standing at the dug ditch outside  
the wall,  
50 now on the thundering headlands  
crying her great cry;  
51 and Ares on the other side, like a black  
stormwind,  
52 screamed his shrill commands to the  
Trojans from the citadel's height,

53 now running by Simoïs over  
Callicolone.

54 So the blessed gods, driving both sides  
on,5

55 clashed them together — and broke out  
their own heavy strife.

56 And terribly, from on high, the father  
of men and gods

57 thundered; and from below Poseidon  
shook

58 the boundless earth and the steep  
heads of the mountains.

59 All the roots of many-springed Ida  
were shaken,

60 and all her peaks, and the Trojans' city,  
and the Achaeans' ships.

61 And under the ground the lord of those  
below, Aïdoneus, took fright,

62 and in his fright leapt from his throne

and screamed — lest above him

63 Poseidon the earth-shaker crack the  
earth wide open

64 and his houses stand exposed to  
mortals and immortals —

65 terrible, mouldering houses, which the  
very gods abhor:

66 so great was the crash that rose as the  
gods came together in strife.

67 For there, facing the lord Poseidon,6

68 stood Phoebus Apollo with his winged  
arrows,

69 and against Enyalios the goddess grey-  
eyed Athena;

70 against Hera stood the clamorous  
goddess of the golden shafts,

71 Artemis who showers arrows, sister of  
the far-striker;

72 against Leto the strong courier Hermes;

73 and against Hephaestus the great deep-  
eddying river  
74 whom the gods call Xanthus, and men  
Scamander.  
75 So god went against god. But Achilles7  
76 longed above all to come through the  
crowd against Hector,  
77 Priam's son: with that man's blood  
beyond all others  
78 his heart commanded him to glut Ares,  
the fighter under the ox-hide shield.  
79 But Apollo, driver of armies, stirred  
Aeneas  
80 straight against the son of Peleus, and  
put strong fury in him.  
81 He made his voice like the voice of  
Lycaon, Priam's son;  
82 in his likeness spoke Apollo, son of  
Zeus:

83 “Aeneas, counselor of the Trojans —  
where are those threats  
84 you made to the kings of Troy over  
your wine,  
85 that you would fight Achilles, Peleus’s  
son, man to man?”  
86 Then in turn Aeneas answered him and  
said:  
87 “Son of Priam, why do you order me,  
against my own will,  
88 to stand and fight the overweening son  
of Peleus?  
89 It would not be the first time I stand  
against swift-footed  
90 Achilles: once before now he chased  
me with his spear  
91 off Ida, when he came down on our  
cattle  
92 and sacked Lyrnessus and Pedasus.

Zeus saved me,  
93 rousing my strength and my quick  
knees —  
94 else I had gone down under the hands  
of Achilles, and of Athena,  
95 who went before him setting the light  
of safety, and urged him on  
96 to slaughter Lelegians and Trojans with  
his bronze spear.  
97 That is why no man can fight Achilles  
face to face:  
98 always one of the gods is beside him,  
beating ruin away.  
99 And even without that, his weapon  
flies straight, and does not slacken  
100 till it has driven through human flesh.  
Yet if a god  
101 stretched the war's issue level, he  
would not beat me



102 so easily — not though he boasts that  
he is bronze all through.”

103 Then in turn the lord Apollo, son of  
Zeus, addressed him:9

104 “Hero — come then, you too: pray to  
the gods

105 who live forever. You also, men say,  
were born

106 of Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus; his  
mother is the lesser goddess:

107 yours is a child of Zeus; his, of the old  
man of the sea.

108 Carry your unwearying bronze  
straight at him. Do not let him

109 turn you back with contemptuous  
words and threats.”

110 So speaking he breathed great fury  
into the shepherd of the people,

111 and he went through the front-

fighters, helmed in gleaming bronze.

112 But the son of Anchises did not slip  
past white-armed Hera<sup>10</sup>

113 as he went through the press of men  
against the son of Peleus;

114 and she gathered the gods together  
and spoke among them:

115 “Consider, you two — Poseidon and  
Athena —

116 consider in your minds how these  
things are to go.

117 Here is Aeneas, marching helmed in  
gleaming bronze

118 against the son of Peleus — and  
Phoebus Apollo set him on.

119 Come then: either let us turn him back  
again

120 where he stands — or else let one of us

121 stand by Achilles too, and give him

great strength; let his heart  
122 lack nothing; let him know that they  
love him — the best  
123 of the immortals — and that windy  
nothings are the ones who till now  
124 have warded war and slaughter from  
the Trojans.  
125 We all came down from Olympus to  
take our part  
126 in this battle, so that among the  
Trojans he suffer nothing  
127 today. Later he will suffer whatever  
Fate  
128 spun for him with her thread at his  
birth, when his mother bore him.  
129 But if Achilles does not learn all this  
from a god's own voice,  
130 he will be afraid, when some god  
comes against him

131 face to face in the war. Gods seen in  
their true shapes are hard to bear.”

132 Then answered her Poseidon the  
earth-shaker:11

133 “Hera, do not rage beyond good sense.  
You need not.

134 I at least would not choose to drive the  
gods together

135 in strife — us against the others —  
since we are far the stronger.

136 No: let us go and sit down out of the  
path,

137 on a lookout place, and leave the war  
to men.

138 But if Ares begins the fighting, or  
Phoebus Apollo,

139 or if they hold Achilles back and will  
not let him fight,

140 then at once, on the spot, our own

quarrel with them rises —

141 total war; and very soon, I think, they  
will break it off

142 and go back to Olympus, to the  
company of the other gods,

143 beaten down under our hands by  
force.”

144 So speaking, the dark-haired god led  
the way<sup>12</sup>

145 to the heaped-up wall of godlike  
Heracles —

146 the high wall the Trojans and Pallas  
Athena

147 had built him, so he might escape the  
sea-monster and elude it

148 whenever it chased him from the  
beach onto the plain.

149 There Poseidon sat down, and the  
other gods,

150 and drew unbroken cloud around their  
shoulders;  
151 and the others sat over against them  
on the brows of Callicolone  
152 around you, archer Phoebus, and Ares  
sacker of cities.  
153 So on either side they sat deliberating  
154 their counsels; but both sides shrank  
from beginning  
155 the grinding war — and Zeus, seated  
on high, commanded it.  
156 And the whole plain was filled with  
them, and blazed with the bronze13  
157 of men and horses; and the earth rang  
under their feet  
158 as they rushed together. And two men,  
the best by far,  
159 came together in the middle ground,  
hot to fight:

160 Aeneas, Anchises' son, and brilliant  
Achilles.

161 Aeneas came out first, with a threat,  
tossing

162 his heavy helmet as he strode; his  
rushing shield

163 he held before his chest, and he shook  
his bronze spear.

164 And the son of Peleus rose from the  
other side to meet him like a lion,

165 a raider, whom men are wild to kill —

166 a whole district, gathered; and at first  
he comes on

167 heedless of them, but when one of the  
battle-quick young men

168 hits him with a spear, he crouches,  
jaws gaping, foam

169 gathering on his teeth, and the brave  
heart in him groans,

170 and with his tail he lashes his ribs and  
flanks  
171 on both sides, and whips himself on to  
fight,  
172 and glaring he drives straight in, to  
see whether he will kill  
173 some man, or die himself in the front  
of the crowd:  
174 so his fury and his proud heart drove  
Achilles  
175 to go against great-hearted Aeneas.  
176 And when they had come close,  
advancing on each other,  
177 the first to speak was swift-footed  
brilliant Achilles:  
178 “Aeneas — why have you come so far  
out of the crowd<sup>14</sup>  
179 to stand here? Does your heart  
command you to fight me



180 in hope of ruling the horse-taming  
Trojans  
181 with Priam's honor? Even if you killed  
me,  
182 Priam would not lay that prize in your  
hand:  
183 he has sons; and he is steady, not weak  
in the head.  
184 Or have the Trojans cut you a private  
estate, finest of all,  
185 fair land of orchard and plowland, to  
enjoy  
186 if you kill me? You will find that  
killing hard, I think.  
187 Once before now, I say, my spear has  
made you run.  
188 Do you not remember when you were  
alone with the cattle, and I  
189 chased you down the mountains of Ida

on my quick feet —

190 headlong? You did not turn to look  
back once as you ran.

191 From there you fled to Lyrnessus; and I  
wrecked it,

192 storming after you with Athena and  
father Zeus,

193 and took the women captive, their day  
of freedom gone —

194 though you Zeus rescued, and the  
other gods.

195 But now I think they will not save you,  
as in your heart

196 you reckon. No — go back into the  
crowd — that is my counsel —

197 and do not stand against me, before  
some evil

198 takes you. When the thing is done,  
even the fool learns.”

199 Then in turn Aeneas answered him  
and said:15

200 “Son of Peleus — do not hope to  
frighten me with words,

201 as if I were a silly child, since I too  
know well enough

202 how to sling insults, and how to speak  
outrage.

203 We know each other’s lineage, we  
know each other’s parents,

204 hearing the famous tales of mortal  
men —

205 though you have never set eyes on  
mine, nor I on yours.

206 They say you are the son of blameless  
Peleus,

207 and your mother Thetis of the lovely  
braids, the sea-born;

208 I claim to be the son of great-hearted

Anchises,

209 and my mother is Aphrodite.

210 Of those two houses, one pair will  
mourn their dear son

211 today: for I tell you, we two will not  
part from battle

212 and go our ways on the strength of  
silly words.

213 But if you care to learn this too, and  
know for certain

214 our lineage — and many men know it  
already:

215 Dardanus first was begotten by cloud-  
gatherer Zeus,

216 and he founded Dardania — for holy  
Ilion

217 was not yet built on the plain, a city of  
mortal men,

218 and they still lived on the lower slopes

of many-springed Ida.

219 And Dardanus in turn had a son,  
Erichthonius the king,

220 who became the richest of mortal  
men:

221 three thousand mares of his grazed  
the water-meadow,

222 mothers, delighting in their tender  
foals.

223 And Boreas desired them as they  
pastured,

224 and covered them in the likeness of a  
dark-maned stallion;

225 and they conceived, and bore twelve  
foals.

226 And these, when they frisked over the  
grain-giving plowland,

227 would run along the tips of the wheat-  
ears and never break them;

228 and when they frisked over the broad  
back of the sea,  
229 they would run along the crests of the  
breakers of the grey salt water.  
230 And Erichthonius fathered Tros, lord  
of the Trojans;  
231 and from Tros in turn three blameless  
sons were born:  
232 Ilus, and Assaracus, and godlike  
Ganymede,  
233 who was born the most beautiful of  
mortal men —  
234 and the gods caught him up to be the  
wine-pourer of Zeus,  
235 for his beauty's sake, so he might live  
among the immortals.  
236 And Ilus in turn had a son, blameless  
Laomedon;  
237 and Laomedon fathered Tithonus and

Priam

238 and Lampus and Clytius and Hicetaon,  
sprig of Ares;

239 and Assaracus, Capys — whose son  
was Anchises;

240 and Anchises fathered me, and Priam  
brilliant Hector.

241 That is the lineage and the blood I  
claim to come of.

242 As for worth — Zeus increases it in  
men and diminishes it

243 however he wills: for he is the  
strongest of all.

244 Come then, let us stand no longer  
talking of this like children,

245 here in the middle of the grind of  
battle.

246 There are insults enough for both of  
us to speak —

247 so many, a ship of a hundred benches  
could not carry the load.  
248 The tongue of mortals is a twisty  
thing; the words in it are many,  
249 of every kind; and the range of speech  
is wide, this way and that:  
250 whatever sort of word you speak, that  
is the sort you will hear.  
251 But what need have we two of strife  
and quarreling,  
252 wrangling face to face like women,  
253 who in the anger of some heart-  
devouring feud  
254 go out and wrangle with each other in  
the middle of the street,  
255 and much is true, and much is not: the  
anger orders that too.  
256 Words will not turn me back from the  
valor I burn with —



257 not before we have fought it out,  
bronze against bronze. Come then:  
258 let us taste one another with our  
bronze-fitted spears.”  
259 He spoke, and drove his heavy spear  
into the terrible, 16  
260 dreadful shield; and the great shield  
rang round the spear’s point.  
261 And the son of Peleus with his thick  
hand thrust the shield  
262 out from his body, afraid: he thought  
the long-shadowed spear  
263 of great-hearted Aeneas would drive  
clean through it —  
264 the fool: he did not consider in mind  
and heart  
265 that the glorious gifts of the gods do  
not lie down easily  
266 under mortal men, do not give way

before them.

267 So the heavy spear of war-minded  
Aeneas did not

268 break the shield: the gold held it, the  
god's gift.

269 Through two folds he did drive it; but  
three were still

270 left, since the crook-footed god had  
hammered five:

271 two of bronze, and inside them two of  
tin,

272 and one of gold — and in the gold the  
ash spear was held.

273 Second in turn Achilles let fly his  
long-shadowed spear<sup>17</sup>

274 and struck the balanced round shield  
of Aeneas

275 under the outermost rim, where the  
bronze ran thinnest

276 and the oxhide thinnest over it; and  
straight on through  
277 shot the Pelian ash, and the shield  
shrieked under it.  
278 And Aeneas crouched, and held the  
shield up and away,  
279 in dread; and the spear passed over his  
back and stood  
280 planted in the earth, still hungry,  
having torn through both circles  
281 of the man-covering shield. He had  
dodged the long spear;  
282 he stood, and grief past measure  
flooded down over his eyes,  
283 in terror at how close the point was  
planted. But Achilles  
284 drew his sharp sword and leapt on  
him, furious, **18**  
285 shouting his terrible shout. And

Aeneas caught up a stone in his hand —  
286 a great feat — which no two men  
could carry,  
287 such as mortals are now; but he swung  
it easily, even alone.  
288 And now Aeneas would have struck  
him with the rock as he charged,  
289 on helmet or shield, which had fended  
grim death from him,  
290 and the son of Peleus, closing, would  
have taken his life with the sword,  
291 had not Poseidon the earth-shaker  
seen it sharply.  
292 And at once he spoke among the  
immortal gods:19  
293 “Oh shame — my grief for great-  
hearted Aeneas,  
294 who will quickly go down to Hades,  
broken by the son of Peleus,

295 because he listened to the words of  
far-striker Apollo —  
296 the fool: Apollo will not help him  
against grim death.  
297 But why should this man, guiltless,  
suffer sorrows  
298 for no reason — for griefs that belong  
to others — he who always  
299 gives welcome gifts to the gods who  
hold the wide heaven?  
300 Come: let us ourselves lead him out  
from under death,  
301 for fear the son of Cronos too be  
angered, if Achilles  
302 cuts this man down. It is destined for  
him to escape,  
303 so that the race of Dardanus not  
perish seedless, blotted out —  
304 of Dardanus, whom the son of Cronos

loved beyond all the children  
305 born to him from mortal women.  
306 For the son of Cronos has come to  
hate the line of Priam;  
307 and now the might of Aeneas shall be  
king over the Trojans —  
308 and his children's children, who shall  
be born hereafter.”  
309 Then answered him the ox-eyed lady  
Hera:20  
310 “Earth-shaker, take counsel with your  
own mind  
311 about Aeneas: whether to pull him out,  
or let him  
312 be broken by Achilles, Peleus's son,  
brave as he is.  
313 We two have sworn oaths, many of  
them,  
314 before all the immortals — I and Pallas

Athena —

315 never to ward the evil day away from  
the Trojans,

316 not even when all Troy is burning in  
ravaging fire —

317 burning, and the warlike sons of the  
Achaeans light it.”

318 Now when Poseidon the earth-shaker  
heard that,21

319 he went up through the battle and the  
clatter of spears

320 and came where Aeneas was, and  
famed Achilles.

321 And at once he poured a mist over the  
eyes

322 of Achilles, Peleus’s son; and the ash  
spear, well-shod in bronze,

323 he drew out of the shield of great-  
hearted Aeneas

324 and laid it down in front of Achilles'  
feet;  
325 and Aeneas he swept off the ground  
and swung high in the air.  
326 Over many ranks of heroes, many  
ranks of horses,  
327 Aeneas vaulted, launched from the  
god's hand,  
328 and came down at the outermost edge  
of the surging battle,  
329 where the Caucones were arming  
themselves for war.  
330 And Poseidon the earth-shaker came  
up close beside him,  
331 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:  
332 "Aeneas, which of the gods commands  
you to such madness —  
333 fighting face to face with the



overweening son of Peleus,  
334 who is at once stronger than you and  
dearer to the immortals?  
335 No: draw back whenever you find  
yourself against him,  
336 or you will enter the house of Hades  
even beyond your portion.  
337 But when Achilles has met his death  
and doom,  
338 then take courage, and fight among  
the front-fighters:  
339 no other of the Achaeans will ever  
strip your armor.”  
340 So speaking he left him there, when  
he had told him everything,22  
341 and quickly scattered the unearthly  
mist from the eyes  
342 of Achilles; and he stared out hard  
with his eyes,

343 and troubled, he spoke to his own  
great-hearted spirit:  
344 “Shame! — a great marvel is this I see  
with my eyes:  
345 my spear lying on the ground, and no  
sight anywhere  
346 of the man I hurled it at, hot to kill  
him.  
347 So Aeneas really was dear to the  
immortal gods —  
348 and I thought his boasting empty  
wind.  
349 Let him go, and good riddance. He will  
find no heart  
350 to test me again — glad enough, this  
time, to escape death.  
351 Come then: I will call on the war-  
loving Danaans  
352 and go against the rest of the Trojans,

and test them.”

353 He spoke, and leapt along the ranks,  
and called to every man:23

354 “No longer stand off from the Trojans,  
brilliant Achaeans!

355 Come — man against man, and let  
each be hot to fight!

356 It is a hard thing for me, strong as I  
am,

357 to deal with so many men and fight  
them all:

358 not even Ares, immortal god though  
he is, not even Athena

359 could work the mouth of a battle-line  
so wide, and labor it through.

360 But whatever I can do with hands and  
feet

361 and strength, I promise I will not  
slacken — not one least bit:

362 straight through the line I will go; and  
no Trojan, I think,

363 will be glad who comes within reach  
of my spear.”

364 So he spoke, urging them on. And  
glorious Hector<sup>24</sup>

365 called to the Trojans, shouting; he said  
he would go against Achilles:

366 “High-hearted Trojans — do not fear  
the son of Peleus!

367 I too could fight the very immortals —  
with words;

368 with the spear it is harder, since they  
are far stronger.

369 Not even Achilles will bring all his  
words to fulfillment:

370 one part he will accomplish; the other  
he cuts short half-done.

371 I will go against him, though his hands

are like fire —

372 though his hands are like fire, and his  
fury like burning iron.”

373 So he spoke, urging them; and the  
Trojans raised their spears<sup>25</sup>

374 to face them; and fury met mingled  
fury, and the war-cry rose.

375 And then Phoebus Apollo stood beside  
Hector and said:

376 “Hector — do not fight Achilles out in  
front any longer.

377 Wait for him in the mass, out of the  
battle’s roar,

378 or he will hit you with a cast — or  
close, and cut you down with the sword.”

379 So he spoke; and Hector sank back  
into the crowd of men,

380 shaken, when he heard the voice of  
the god speaking.

381 But Achilles leapt in among the  
Trojans, his heart clothed in valor,26  
382 shouting his terrible shout. And first  
he killed Iphition,  
383 Otrynteus's stout son, a leader of  
many men,  
384 whom a naiad nymph bore to  
Otrynteus, sacker of cities,  
385 under snowy Tmolus, in the rich  
district of Hyde.  
386 As he came straight on, brilliant  
Achilles caught him with the spear  
387 full in the middle of the head; and the  
whole skull split in two,  
388 and he fell with a thud; and brilliant  
Achilles cried over him:  
389 "Lie there, son of Otrynteus — most  
terrifying of all men!  
390 Here is your death. Your birth was by

the Gygaean lake,  
391 where your father's estate lies, by fish-  
filled  
392 Hyllus and eddying Hermus.”  
393 So he cried in triumph; and darkness  
covered his eyes,  
394 and the wheel-rims of Achaean  
chariots tore him apart  
395 in the front of the struggle. And after  
him, Demoleon —27  
396 a stout warder-off of battle, Antenor's  
son —  
397 he stabbed in the temple, through the  
bronze-cheeked helmet.  
398 The bronze helmet did not hold it:  
straight through  
399 drove the point, hungry, and broke the  
bone; and the brain  
400 was all spattered inside it. He broke

him in mid-charge.

401 Then Hippodamas: as he sprang down  
from his horses

402 and fled before him, he stabbed him  
in the back with the spear;

403 and he gasped out his life, bellowing  
— as a bull

404 bellows when he is dragged for the  
Heliconian lord,

405 young men dragging him, and the  
earth-shaker delights in them:

406 so, as he bellowed, the proud life left  
his bones.

407 Then with his spear he went for  
godlike Polydorus, 28

408 Priam's son. His father had forbidden  
him to fight,

409 because among his children he was  
youngest-born



410 and dearest; and he beat them all at  
running.

411 And just then, in his boy's folly,  
showing off the speed of his feet,

412 he was darting through the front-  
fighters — till he lost his dear life.

413 As he flashed past, swift-footed  
brilliant Achilles hit him: the javelin

414 square in the back, where the golden  
clasps of his war-belt

415 fastened, and the corslet doubled over;

416 and the spear-point held straight on  
through, out beside the navel,

417 and he dropped to his knees with a  
scream, and a cloud of darkness

418 wrapped him round, and he clutched  
his bowels to him with his hands as he  
sank.

419 And when Hector saw his brother

Polydorus<sup>29</sup>

<sup>420</sup> clutching his bowels in his hands,  
sinking to the earth,

<sup>421</sup> a mist poured down over his eyes. He  
could no longer bear

<sup>422</sup> to range apart; he came out against  
Achilles,

<sup>423</sup> shaking his sharp spear, like a flame.  
And Achilles —

<sup>424</sup> the instant he saw him, he sprang,  
and spoke his word of triumph:

<sup>425</sup> “Near me — the man who beyond all  
others has stung my heart,

<sup>426</sup> who killed my honored companion!  
No longer now

<sup>427</sup> shall we cower from each other down  
the lanes of war.”

<sup>428</sup> He spoke, and glaring darkly he said  
to brilliant Hector:

429 “Come closer — and come the sooner  
to the borders of destruction.”

430 And unshaken, Hector of the flashing  
helmet answered him:

431 “Son of Peleus — do not hope to  
frighten me with words,

432 as if I were a silly child, since I too  
know well enough

433 how to sling insults, and how to speak  
outrage.

434 I know that you are brave, and that I  
am far weaker than you.

435 But these things lie on the knees of  
the gods:

436 whether I, the weaker man, may still  
take the life out of you

437 with a cast of my spear — since my  
weapon too has been sharp before now.”

438 He spoke, and poised and hurled his

spear; and Athena  
439 turned it back from glorious Achilles  
with a breath —  
440 the gentlest breathing; and it came  
back to brilliant Hector  
441 and fell there in front of his feet. And  
Achilles  
442 leapt on him, furious, wild to kill him,  
443 shouting his terrible shout. But Apollo  
snatched Hector away —  
444 easily, as a god does — and hid him in  
thick mist.  
445 Three times swift-footed brilliant  
Achilles charged  
446 with his bronze spear, and three times  
he struck the deep mist.  
447 But when for the fourth time he came  
on like more than man,  
448 with a terrible shout he spoke winged

words at him:

449 “Dog! Again you have run out from  
under death — and yet the evil

450 came close. Now once more Phoebus  
Apollo has pulled you out —

451 to him you must pray whenever you  
go into the thud of javelins.

452 I will finish you yet, meeting you later,  
453 if any god anywhere stands helper to  
me too.

454 For now I will go after the others,  
whoever I can catch.”

455 So speaking, he stabbed Dryops full in  
the neck with the javelin, 30

456 and he crashed down in front of his  
feet. He left him there,

457 and Demuchus, Philetor’s son, a good  
man and a big one,

458 he stopped with a spear-cast to the

knee; and then

459 he took his life away with a stroke of  
the great sword.

460 Then Laogonus and Dardanus, the two  
sons of Bias:

461 rushing both, he tumbled them from  
their horses to the ground,

462 one with a spear-throw, one with the  
sword at close quarters.

463 Then Tros, Alastor's son — who came  
at him to clasp his knees,

464 hoping he might spare him, take him  
and let him go alive,

465 might pity a man of his own age and  
not kill him —

466 the fool: he did not know there would  
be no persuading.

467 This was not a sweet-tempered man,  
not mild of mind,

468 but all raw fury. Tros reached with his  
hands for his knees,  
469 desperate to plead; and he stabbed  
him in the liver with the sword,  
470 and the liver slid out, and the black  
blood pouring from it  
471 filled the fold of his tunic; and  
darkness covered his eyes,  
472 and the life failed. And next, standing  
over Mulius, he drove  
473 the spear into his ear, and out through  
the other ear  
474 the bronze point passed. Then  
Agenor's son Echeclus:  
475 he struck him full mid-head with the  
hilted sword,  
476 and the whole blade ran hot with  
blood, and down over his eyes  
477 came purple death, and fate the

overpowering.

478 Then Deucalion: just where the  
tendons of the elbow

479 join, there he pierced him through the  
arm

480 with the bronze point; and he stood  
and waited, his arm hanging heavy,

481 looking at death before him; and with  
the sword Achilles struck his neck

482 and sent head and helmet flying far  
together; and the marrow

483 spurted up out of the spine, and the  
trunk lay stretched on the earth.

484 Then he went after the blameless son  
of Peiros —31

485 Rhigmus, who had come from deep-  
soiled Thrace:

486 him he hit square with the javelin,  
and the bronze stuck in his belly,



487 and he crashed from his chariot. And  
Areithous his aide,  
488 as he wheeled the horses around, he  
stabbed in the back  
489 with the sharp spear, and thrust him  
from the car; and the horses ran wild.  
490 As unearthly fire rages through the  
deep glens  
491 of a parched mountain, and the deep  
forest burns,  
492 and the wind, driving it everywhere,  
whirls the flame around:  
493 so everywhere he stormed with his  
spear, like more than man,  
494 harrying the men he killed; and the  
black earth ran with blood.  
495 And as when a man yokes broad-  
browed bull oxen  
496 to tread white barley on a well-built

threshing-floor,

497 and quickly the grain is husked under  
the feet of the bellowing oxen:

498 so under great-hearted Achilles the  
single-hoofed horses

499 trampled corpses and shields  
together; and with blood the axle

500 beneath was all spattered, and the  
rails that ran round the car,

501 struck by the drops thrown up from  
the horses' hooves

502 and from the wheel-rims. And on he  
pressed to win glory —

503 the son of Peleus — spattering his  
invincible hands with gore.

## Notes

NOTES

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## NOTES

1. (20.1-12) The opening apostrophe — “around you, son of Peleus” — puts the poet’s own voice in the second line: the book that begins Achilles’ aristeia begins by addressing him. Themis, Right herself, is the summoner (her one act in the poem), and the invitation-list is total: every river but Ocean (who anchors the world and cannot leave it), every nymph of grove and spring and meadow. The whole animate landscape is called in to watch what Achilles does to the plain it lives in. ↩
2. (20.13-30) Zeus’s convocation speech is the poem’s theology at its most compressed. Asked why he has called them, he answers: “they matter to me, even as they perish” (μέλουσί μοι ὀλλύμενοί περ) — care and destruction in one clause, the whole divine economy of the Iliad. He will watch from a fold of Olympus and “delight my mind” — the god as spectator at the theater he financed — but the license he gives the gods is practical: without divine interference on both sides, Achilles “may storm the wall itself, ahead of what is fated” (ὑπέρμορον). Fate in Homer is not self-enforcing: it can be jumped, and the gods are deployed here as its police. The Book 8 ban is

formally dissolved; the last movement of the poem runs with all gods on the field. ↩

3. (20.31-40) The order of battle: five gods to the ships (Hera, Athena, Poseidon, Hermes, Hephaestus), five to the Trojans (Ares, Apollo, Artemis, Leto, Xanthus the river, with Aphrodite). Ares arrives as “Ares of the flashing helmet” — Hector’s fixed epithet, lent to the war-god this once, as if the poem were already transferring Hector’s identity to the god he follows. Xanthus fights for the city through whose plain he flows — the enlistment Book 21 will take terribly seriously. ↩
4. (20.41-53) Before the gods engage: pure Achilles-effect — Achaeans exultant, “terrible trembling” in every Trojan limb. When they do engage, the poem gives us war-noise as divine antiphony: Athena shouting from the ditch and the headlands, Ares “like a black stormwind” screaming from the citadel and Callicolone — the battlefield turned into a theater with two crying gods for a chorus. ↩
5. (20.54-66) The cosmic quake. Zeus thunders above, Poseidon shakes “the boundless earth and the steep heads of the mountains,” Ida trembles root to peak — and below, the poem’s single glimpse into the

underworld from the inside: Aïdoneus leaping from his throne with a scream, terrified the crust will split “and his houses stand exposed to mortals and immortals — terrible, mouldering houses, which the very gods abhor.” Death’s kingdom described only by the horror of its possible exposure: the gods themselves cannot bear to look at what they consign men to. Longinus quoted these lines as the summit of the sublime. ↩

6. (20.67-74) The pairings — Poseidon/Apollo, Athena/Enyalios, Hera/Artemis, Hermes/Leto, Hephaestus/Xanthus — a formal duel-card that Book 21 will actually play out. The river is introduced with the poem’s fullest instance of divine double-naming: “whom the gods call Xanthus, and men Scamander” — the world has two vocabularies, and the poem knows both. ↩

7. (20.75-85) Apollo picks Aeneas as the delaying weapon and wears the voice of Lycaon, Priam’s son — a savage irony held in reserve: the real Lycaon will meet Achilles in Book 21 and become the poem’s great emblem of unsparable life. The taunt is perfectly aimed: dinner-table threats “over your wine” against the sober fact of Achilles. ↩

8. (20.86-102) Aeneas's answer is a veteran's risk-assessment: he has run from Achilles before, off Ida, in the raid that sacked Lyrnessus and Pedasus (the raid that took Briseis — the poem's pre-history everywhere this afternoon), and he names the real problem: "always one of the gods is beside him, beating ruin away." His conditional — with a level field, "he would not beat me so easily" — is exactly the proposition the duel will test and the gods will refuse to let conclude. ↩
9. (20.103-111) Apollo's counter is genealogical arithmetic: Aphrodite outranks Thetis ("yours is a child of Zeus; his, of the old man of the sea") — therefore fight. The syllogism is divine snobbery, and false as tactics: rank of mother decides nothing on the plain, as the shield of Hephaestus is about to demonstrate. But it works — on "the shepherd of the people," the poem's title for the responsible man goaded into an irresponsible duel. ↩
10. (20.112-131) Hera's alarm council. Her speech swings characteristically from tactics (turn Aeneas back) to prestige (let Achilles "know that they love him — the best of the immortals — and that windy nothings" defend Troy); lines 125-128, with their weaving Fate

(“whatever Fate spun for him with her thread at his birth”), were athetized by Aristarchus. Her closing maxim earns its place in the book of divine epiphanies: “Gods seen in their true shapes are hard to bear” (χαλεποὶ δὲ θεοὶ φαίνεσθαι ἐναργεῖς). ↩

11. (20.132-143) Poseidon’s restraint doctrine — “we are far the stronger” is his reason not to fight: overwhelming force can afford to sit down. “Leave the war to men” is the book’s quiet thesis: the gods’ battle is theater; the men’s is real. His trigger-conditions (if Ares or Apollo start, or if they hold Achilles back) keep the Theomachy loaded for Book 21. ↩
12. (20.144-155) The gods take their seats — on the wall of Heracles, the rampart Trojans and Athena built a generation ago so Heracles could escape the sea-monster sent against Laomedon’s Troy (the Hesione story, surfacing only here). The Greek gods watch this Trojan war from the fortification of the last one: Troy’s past salvation reused as the grandstand for its destruction. Both parties sit “deliberating” — and Zeus, alone, “seated on high, commanded” the war on: the only spectator who wants the show to start. ↩

13. (20.156-175) The champions meet, and Achilles gets the book's great lion simile — not a hunting lion but a hunted one: “a raider, whom men are wild to kill — a whole district, gathered,” heedless until wounded, then foaming, groaning, lashing his own ribs with his tail, “whipping himself on to fight,” driving in “to see whether he will kill some man, or die himself in the front of the crowd.” The simile makes self-destruction part of the charge: kill or die are equal outcomes inside it — which is, since Book 18, precisely Achilles' own arithmetic. ↩

14. (20.178-198) Achilles' taunt runs through every motive a rational Aeneas could have — the succession (“Priam would not lay that prize in your hand: he has sons; and he is steady”), the land-grant (the *temenos* of orchard and plowland) — Aristarchus athetized 180-186, but the political satire is sharp and early: the poem knows about princes who fight for estates. Then the memory: the cattle-raid chase down Ida, Lyrnessus wrecked, “the women captive, their day of freedom gone.” It ends with the registered proverb, reused verbatim from Menelaus at 17.30-32: “When the thing is done, even the fool learns.” ↩



15. (20.199-258) Aeneas's genealogy — the longest pedigree in the poem, and the poem's most self-aware speech about speech. The frame (200-202: "do not hope to frighten me with words, as if I were a silly child") will be repeated verbatim by Hector at 431-433 — the Trojan princes share a script against Achilles. Then the lineage: Dardanus, son of Zeus; Erichthonius, richest of men, whose three thousand mares bore to Boreas twelve foals that ran over wheat-ears without breaking them and along the crests of the breakers — the poem's most weightless image, horses of wind bred from the hill-pastures of Troy; Tros; Ganymede, "most beautiful of mortal men," taken up to pour Zeus's wine; then the split into the two houses — Ilus to Laomedon to Priam and Hector; Assaracus to Capys to Anchises to Aeneas. Two first-cousin lines, and the survival of one is being decided this hour. The coda is the poem's finest statement on language: "The tongue of mortals is a twisty thing... whatever sort of word you speak, that is the sort you will hear" — and the simile of the wrangling women in the street ("and much is true, and much is not: the anger orders that too"), athetized by Aristarchus (251-255), too

humanly observed to lose. Then, superbly: “let us taste one another with our bronze-fitted spears.” ↩

16. (20.259-272) The shield test. Aeneas’s spear beats two folds and stops in the gold — and the narrator scolds Achilles for flinching (“the fool: he did not consider... that the glorious gifts of the gods do not lie down easily under mortal men”): even its owner does not yet trust divine craft. The five layers (two bronze, two tin, one gold) troubled the ancients — if the gold is decorative surface, how does it stop a spear at the third layer? — and Aristarchus athetized 269-272; some ancient texts omitted them entirely. Kept here: the physics of a miraculous object need not audit. ↩

17. (20.273-283) Achilles’ cast: through both circles of the rim where bronze and hide run thinnest — the Pelian ash “shrieked” through and stood planted in the earth “still hungry” (ἰεμένη — straining onward). Aeneas crouched under his own shield with the spear quivering over his back: “grief past measure flooded down over his eyes, in terror at how close the point was planted.” Zenodotus’s text had a different pair of lines here; the vulgate’s

sequence — cast, crouch, the standing spear — is the most cinematic near-miss in the poem. ↩

18. (20.285-291) The stone “which no two men could carry, such as mortals are now” (the register’s fixed diminished- present formula, its fourth occurrence) — and the double counterfactual: rock against sword, both blows about to land, when Poseidon “saw it sharply.” The duel is frozen at its decisive instant and never resumed: the poem refuses to know who was better. ↩
19. (20.292-308) Poseidon’s rescue speech — a Greek god saving Troy’s prince — is the poem’s window onto a future beyond itself: Aeneas is “guiltless,” pious, and destined: “It is destined for him to escape, so that the race of Dardanus not perish seedless... and now the might of Aeneas shall be king over the Trojans — and his children’s children.” The Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite makes the same promise; Strabo knew a variant — “his race shall rule over all” (γένος πάντεσσιν ἀνάξει) — which Rome, tracing the Julii through Iulus to Aeneas, had every reason to prefer; the apparatus records it. Whatever its politics, the moment is structurally superb: in the middle of the

Iliad's terminal battle, the poem certifies that something Trojan survives everything. ↩

20. (20.309-317) Hera's consent is glacial: do as you like about Aeneas — “we two have sworn oaths, many of them... never to ward the evil day away from the Trojans, not even when all Troy is burning in ravening fire.” The burning-city clause, spoken as calmly as a contract term, is the coldest sentence any god utters in the poem. ↩
21. (20.318-339) The rescue itself: mist over Achilles' eyes, the spear laid back at his feet (a courtesy with an edge: nothing of yours is lost — except the kill), and Aeneas thrown over “many ranks of heroes, many ranks of horses” to the Caucones at the battle's rim. Poseidon's parting instructions are precise prophecy: avoid Achilles while he lives; after his death, “fight among the front-fighters: no other of the Achaeans will ever strip your armor.” Aeneas exits the poem's war carrying its only personal guarantee of survival. ↩
22. (20.340-352) Achilles' soliloquy over the vanished opponent gets his tone exactly: wonder for one breath (“a great marvel is this I see with my eyes”), then the shrug — “Let him go, and good riddance

(ἐππέτω). He will find no heart to test me again” — and back to work. The aristeia’s engine does not idle.



23. (20.353-363) The order of the day: “man against man.”

His self-estimate is the rarest thing in his mouth — a limit: not even Ares or Athena “could work the mouth of a battle-line so wide” (the battle imagined as a thing with jaws; cf. 19.313 “the mouth of bloody war”). What follows is the promise kept literally: “straight through the line I will go.” ↩

24. (20.364-372) Hector’s rally answers it with the poem’s

most honest command ever given to troops: “I too could fight the very immortals — with words; with the spear it is harder, since they are far stronger.” Then the great epanalepsis, the line that turns on its own hinge: “I will go against him, though his hands are like fire — though his hands are like fire, and his fury like burning iron.” The repetition is courage audibly talking itself past its own information. ↩

25. (20.373-380) Apollo’s counter-order — wait in the mass, “or he will hit you with a cast — or close, and cut you down with the sword” — names exactly the two deaths Hector risks; and Hector, who told the Trojans not to fear Achilles, obeys the god and sinks

back “shaken.” The gap between his speech and his obedience is the whole tragedy of Hector, one book early. ↩

26. (20.381-395) The aristeia’s first kill: Iphition, a nymph’s son from under snowy Tmolus, his skull split clean in two — and Achilles’ epitaph-taunt returns the man to his geography: “Here is your death. Your birth was by the Gygaean lake” — death here, birth there, the whole biography reduced to two map-points (the register’s “most terrifying of all men” — Iris’s address to Achilles at 18.170 — flung at a corpse). Then the poem lets the chariots shred him: no burial-notice, only wheel-rims. ↩

27. (20.395-406) Demoleon (temple, through the bronze-cheeked helmet, “the brain was all spattered inside it”) and Hippodamas, whose soul leaves him “bellowing — as a bull bellows when he is dragged for the Heliconian lord”: the sacrifice of bulls to Poseidon Heliconius at the Panionian festival, where a bellowing victim was a good omen — “and the earth-shaker delights in them.” A man’s death-cry heard by the poem as a pleasing sacrifice: the grimmest cult-note in the Iliad, and Poseidon is standing right there on the field. ↩

28. (20.407-418) Polydorus — Priam's youngest, forbidden the war "because among his children he was youngest-born and dearest," fastest of them all, killed "in his boy's folly, showing off the speed of his feet" as he darted through the front-fighters: struck where the war-belt's golden clasps meet, the point out beside the navel, kneeling with a scream, "and he clutched his bowels to him with his hands as he sank." The poem will reveal in Books 21-22 that he and Lycaon were Laothoe's sons — Priam mourns the pair at 22.46-48 — making Polydorus the first payment of a double debt this *aristeia* collects from one mother. ↩

29. (20.419-454) The premature Hector-duel. The sight of his brother's bowels brings Hector out against orders — the mist that "poured down over his eyes" is grief doing to him what gods do to the doomed — and the exchange is a dress rehearsal of Book 22: taunt ("Come closer — so you come the sooner to the borders of destruction"), Hector's reply reusing Aeneas's frame verbatim (431-433 = 200-202) but adding what Aeneas never said: "I know that you are brave, and that I am far weaker than you. But these things lie on the knees of the gods." Then Athena turns his spear back "with a breath — the gentlest

breathing” (the war decided by the smallest quantity of divine effort in the poem), Apollo snatches him into mist, and Achilles’ three charges and fourth “like more than man” (δαίμονι ἴσος) end in the shout that repeats 11.362-367 word for word — Diomedes’ very speech to the same rescued man: “Dog! Again you have run out from under death.” Two heroes, nine years apart in the poem’s afternoon, are given identical words against Hector’s charmed life — a repetition that makes Apollo’s protection feel like policy, and its expiry date (Book 22) feel like doom.



30. (20.455-483) The spree, each kill a different door out of life: Dryops (neck), Demuchus (knee, then sword), the sons of Bias tumbled from their chariot, Mulius (spear in one ear, point out the other), Echeclus (the whole sword-blade “grew hot with the blood” — the register’s “purple death” takes his eyes), Deucalion (arm pinned through the elbow-tendons; he “stood and waited, his arm hanging heavy, looking at death before him” — the poem’s stillest instant of doomed consciousness — then head and helmet flying, “and the marrow spurted up out of the spine”). At the center, Tros son of Alastor, who tries the war’s other exit: supplication, knees clasped, mercy of an age-



mate — “the fool: he did not know there would be no persuading. This was not a sweet-tempered man, not mild of mind.” The litotes is the aristeia’s moral thermometer: the man who once spared and ransomed captives (as Lycaon will remind him, 21.74-96) is not there to be reached. The liver slides out; the tunic fills with blood; the theme is set for Lycaon. ↩

31. (20.484-503) Rhigmus of Thrace and his driver Areithous close the count (a dozen named kills), and the book ends in two similes that refuse pathos: the fire-storm in the parched glens (“the wind, driving it everywhere, whirls the flame around”), and — harder — the threshing-floor: oxen treading barley, “and quickly the grain is husked under the feet of the bellowing oxen: so under great-hearted Achilles the single-hoofed horses trampled corpses and shields together.” Slaughter as agriculture, the dead as processed grain; the axle and chariot-rails “spattered” with the spray from hooves and wheel-rims. The last line hangs the whole book on its hero’s hands: “spattering his invincible hands with gore” — the hands Thetis called man-slaughtering (18.317), still reaching for glory, not yet for Hector.

There is no closural cadence: Book 21 continues the same hour at the river. ↩

# Book 21

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*Half the rout is driven into the river, and the  
river fights back: Lycaon's bared throat,  
Asteropaeus's two spears, Scamander rising  
against the man who has choked him with  
corpses — water against fire, gods against gods  
— until Troy's gates gape for the routed, and  
Apollo, wearing a man's face, runs Achilles out  
of the way.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1 But when they came to the ford of the fair-flowing river,<sup>1</sup>
- 2 eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot,
- 3 there he cut them in two: one half he

chased over the plain  
4 toward the city, where the Achaeans had  
fled in terror  
5 the day before, when glorious Hector  
raged —  
6 there they streamed in rout, and Hera  
spread deep mist  
7 in front of them, to hold them; and the  
other half  
8 were rolled into the deep-flowing,  
silver-eddy river.  
9 In they fell with a great crash, and the  
sheer current roared,  
10 and the banks rang loud around them;  
and shouting they  
11 swam this way and that, spun about in  
the eddies.  
12 As when locusts rise on the air before  
the rush of fire

13 and flee toward a river: the unwearying  
flame burns on,  
14 leaping up suddenly, and they cower  
down in the water:  
15 so before Achilles the sounding stream  
of Xanthus,  
16 the deep-eddying, was choked with  
horses and men together.  
17 And the Zeus-born one left his spear  
there on the bank,<sup>2</sup>  
18 leaned on the tamarisks, and leapt in  
like more than man,  
19 holding only his sword, with dark work  
in his heart,  
20 and struck on every side; and an ugly  
groaning rose  
21 from the men the blade hit, and the  
water reddened with blood.  
22 As before a huge-mawed dolphin the

other fish

23 flee and fill the inlets of a fair-  
anchoring harbor,

24 terrified — for he devours whatever he  
catches:

25 so the Trojans down the channels of  
the terrible river

26 cowered under the overhangs. And  
when his hands were weary of killing,

27 he picked twelve young men alive out  
of the river —

28 blood-price for the death of Patroclus,  
Menoetius's son.

29 He led them out dazed, like fawns,

30 and tied their hands behind them with  
the well-cut straps

31 they wore on their own supple tunics,

32 and gave them to his companions to  
lead down to the hollow ships.

33 Then back he sprang, wild to be killing.  
34 There he met a son of Priam,  
Dardanus's descendant,<sup>3</sup>  
35 running out of the river: Lycaon —  
whom he himself  
36 had taken once by night, and led away  
unwilling  
37 from his father's orchard: with the  
sharp bronze he was cutting  
38 young shoots from a wild fig, to be  
chariot-rails,  
39 when — evil unlooked-for — brilliant  
Achilles came on him.  
40 That time he shipped him to well-built  
Lemnos and sold him,  
41 and the son of Jason paid the price;  
42 from there a guest-friend ransomed  
him — he paid a fortune —  
43 Eëtion of Imbros, and sent him to

shining Arisbe;

44 and slipping away from there, he  
reached his father's house.

45 Eleven days he delighted his heart  
among his dear ones,

46 home from Lemnos; and on the twelfth  
the god threw him

47 once more into the hands of Achilles,  
who was to send him

48 down to the house of Hades — not  
willing to go.

49 Now when swift-footed brilliant  
Achilles saw him —4

50 naked, without helmet or shield, and  
no spear either:

51 he had thrown it all to the ground, for  
the sweat wore him down

52 as he ran from the river, and weariness  
broke his knees under him —



53 troubled, Achilles spoke to his own  
great-hearted spirit:  
54 “Shame! — a great marvel is this I see  
with my eyes:  
55 so the great-hearted Trojans I have  
killed  
56 will rise again out of the murky dark  
below,  
57 the way this man has come back,  
escaping the pitiless day —  
58 sold into holy Lemnos! And the deep of  
the grey sea  
59 did not hold him, which holds so many  
against their will.  
60 Well then: now he shall taste the point  
of our spear  
61 as well — so I may see in my mind, and  
learn for certain,  
62 whether he will come back equally

from down there, or be held  
63 by the life-giving earth, which holds  
down even the strong.”  
64 So he weighed it, and waited. And the  
man came near him, dazed,5  
65 desperate to touch his knees: for his  
heart’s whole wish  
66 was to escape from evil death and the  
black spirit of destruction.  
67 Brilliant Achilles lifted the long spear  
68 meaning to stab; but he ducked under  
and grasped his knees,  
69 crouching; and the spear passed over  
his back and stood in the earth,  
70 planted, still hungry for the flesh of a  
man.  
71 With one hand Lycaon held his knees  
and begged,  
72 and with the other gripped the sharp

spear, and would not let go,

73 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:

74 “By your knees, Achilles: respect me,  
and pity me.

75 I stand to you, Zeus-nurtured, as a  
suppliant with a claim:

76 it was at your table first that I ate the  
grain of Demeter,

77 on the day you took me in the well-  
built orchard,

78 and led me away, far from father and  
friends, and sold me

79 into holy Lemnos: I brought you the  
price of a hundred oxen.

80 I was freed for three times that; and  
this dawn

81 is my twelfth since I came back to Ilion

82 after much suffering. And now

murderous fate has put me  
83 in your hands again. I must be hateful  
to father Zeus,  
84 who gave me to you twice. To a short  
life my mother  
85 bore me — Laothoe, daughter of the old  
man Altes:  
86 Altes, who is lord of the war-loving  
Lelegians,  
87 holding steep Pedasus on the Satnioeis.  
88 Priam had his daughter — among his  
many wives;  
89 and of her we two were born, and you  
will butcher both.  
90 One you have broken already among  
the front-rank foot-fighters —  
91 godlike Polydorus, when you hit him  
with your sharp spear;  
92 and now, here, it will be evil for me: for

I do not hope

93 to escape your hands, since the god has  
driven me into them.

94 But I will say one thing more — take it  
into your heart:

95 do not kill me. I am not from the same  
womb as Hector,

96 who killed your companion, the gentle  
and the strong.”

97 So the shining son of Priam spoke to  
him,6

98 a speech of begging; but the voice he  
heard was without honey:

99 “Fool — offer me no ransom. Make me  
no speeches.

100 Before Patroclus met his day of  
destiny,

101 sparing Trojans was dearer to my  
heart:

102 many I took alive, and sold abroad.  
103 Now there is not one who escapes  
death — not one the god  
104 delivers into my hands in front of Ilion  
—  
105 not one of all the Trojans, and of  
Priam's sons beyond all.  
106 So, friend — you die too. Why lament  
it so?  
107 Patroclus died, and he was a far better  
man than you.  
108 And do you not see what I am — how  
beautiful, how big?  
109 My father is a noble man, a goddess  
was the mother who bore me:  
110 yet over me too stand death, and  
strong fate.  
111 There will be a dawn, or an evening, or  
a midday,

112 when someone takes my life too out of  
me in the fighting,  
113 whether he hits me with a spear or an  
arrow from the string.”  
114 So he spoke; and there the man’s knees  
went slack, and his own heart.<sup>7</sup>  
115 He let go of the spear, and sat back,  
spreading both hands  
116 wide. And Achilles drew his sharp  
sword  
117 and struck at the collarbone, beside  
the neck, and the whole  
118 two-edged blade went in; and face-  
down on the earth  
119 he lay stretched out, and the black  
blood ran, and soaked the ground.  
120 Achilles seized him by the foot and  
slung him into the river,  
121 and cried in triumph over him with

winged words:

122 “Lie there now among the fish: they  
will lick the blood

123 from your wound, uncaring. No  
mother will lay you out

124 on a bed and mourn you: eddying  
Scamander

125 will carry you into the broad gulf of  
the sea,

126 and many a fish, leaping along the  
wave, will dart up

127 under the black ripple to eat the white  
fat of Lycaon.

128 Perish, all of you — till we reach the  
city of holy Ilion,

129 you running, and I cutting you down  
from behind!

130 Not even the river will save you — the  
fair-flowing,



131 silver-eddy river you have honored  
so long with slaughtered bulls,  
132 drowning single-hoofed horses alive in  
his eddies.  
133 Even so you shall die evil deaths —  
every one — till all of you  
134 pay for the killing of Patroclus and the  
ruin of the Achaeans  
135 whom you cut down beside the swift  
ships when I was away.”  
136 So he spoke; and the river’s anger rose  
the higher in his heart,  
137 and he turned over in his mind how to  
stop brilliant Achilles  
138 in his work, and beat destruction away  
from the Trojans.  
139 Meanwhile the son of Peleus, with his  
long-shadowed spear,<sup>8</sup>  
140 sprang on Asteropaeus, wild to kill

him —

141 the son of Pelegon, whom wide-  
flowing Axius

142 begot on Periboea, eldest of the  
daughters

143 of Acessamenus: the deep-eddying  
river lay with her.

144 On him Achilles rushed; and he stood  
up out of the river

145 to face him, holding two spears; and  
Xanthus put fury

146 in his chest, in anger for the young  
men cut down in the fighting,

147 the ones Achilles was butchering down  
the stream without pity.

148 And when they had come close,  
advancing on each other,

149 the first to speak was swift-footed  
brilliant Achilles:

150 “Who are you — of what men — that  
you dare come against me?

151 Unhappy are the fathers whose sons  
face my fury!”

152 And the shining son of Pelegon  
answered him:

153 “Great-hearted son of Peleus, why ask  
my lineage?

154 I am from Paeonia of the deep soil — a  
far country —

155 leading the Paeonian men of the long  
lances; and this dawn

156 is my eleventh now, since I came to  
Ilion.

157 My line is from Axius, the wide-  
flowing —

158 Axius, who sends the most beautiful  
water over the earth;

159 he fathered Pelegon, famed with the

spear; and of Pelegon

160 they say I was born. Now let us fight,  
brilliant Achilles.”

161 So he spoke, threatening; and brilliant  
Achilles raised<sup>9</sup>

162 the Pelian ash. But the hero  
Asteropaeus threw

163 both spears at once — for he was a  
two-handed fighter.

164 With the one spear he hit the shield,  
but did not

165 break the shield: the gold held it, the  
god’s gift;

166 with the other he grazed the elbow of  
the right arm,

167 and the dark blood shot out; and the  
spear, passing over him,

168 stuck fast in the earth, still craving its  
fill of flesh.

169 Second in turn Achilles let fly his  
straight-flying ash  
170 at Asteropaeus, wild to kill him —  
171 and missed the man, and hit the high  
bank,  
172 and drove the ash spear half its length  
into the bank.  
173 Then the son of Peleus, drawing the  
sharp sword from his thigh,  
174 leapt on him, furious; and the man  
could not wrench  
175 Achilles' ash out of the bluff with his  
thick hand.  
176 Three times he shook it, straining to  
pull it free,  
177 and three times his strength gave out;  
the fourth time his heart wished  
178 to bend and snap the ash spear of  
Aeacus' grandson —

179 but before that Achilles closed, and  
took his life with the sword.  
180 He struck him in the belly beside the  
navel, and all  
181 his bowels gushed out on the ground;  
and darkness covered his eyes  
182 as he gasped. And Achilles, springing  
on his chest,  
183 stripped his armor, and spoke his  
word of triumph:  
184 “Lie there. It is a hard thing to strive  
with the children10  
185 of Cronos’s mighty son — even for one  
born of a river.  
186 You said your birth was from a wide-  
flowing river;  
187 I claim the lineage of great Zeus.  
188 The man who fathered me is lord of  
many Myrmidons —

189 Peleus, Aeacus' son; and Aeacus was  
from Zeus.

190 As Zeus is stronger than the rivers  
that run murmuring to the sea,

191 so the line of Zeus is made stronger  
than a river's.

192 Why — here is a great river at your  
side, if he can help

193 at all. But there is no fighting Zeus,  
Cronos's son:

194 not even Achelous the king is his  
equal,

195 not even the great strength of deep-  
flowing Ocean,

196 from whom all rivers flow and every  
sea,

197 and all the springs, and the deep wells:

198 even he fears the thunderbolt of great  
Zeus

199 and the terrible thunder, when it  
crashes out of heaven.”  
200 He spoke, and pulled the bronze spear  
out of the bluff,11  
201 and left the man there, where he had  
taken his dear life,  
202 lying in the sands; and the dark water  
lapped him.  
203 Around him the eels and the fish were  
busy,  
204 tearing at the fat of his kidneys,  
plucking it away.  
205 And Achilles went on after the  
chariot-fighting Paeonians,  
206 who were still running in terror along  
the eddying river,  
207 since they had seen their best man in  
the strong encounter  
208 broken by force under the hands and



sword of the son of Peleus.

209 There he took Thersilochus and  
Mydon and Astypylus

210 and Mnesus and Thrasius and Aenius  
and Ophelestes —

211 and now swift Achilles would have  
killed still more Paeonians,

212 had not the deep-eddying river called  
to him in anger,12

213 likened to a man, and sent his voice  
out of a deep eddy:

214 “O Achilles — beyond men you are  
strong, and beyond men you do

215 outrage — and always the gods  
themselves are your defenders.

216 If the son of Cronos has granted you to  
destroy all the Trojans,

217 at least drive them out of me and do  
your grim work on the plain:

218 my lovely streams are crammed full of  
corpses,

219 and I can no longer pour my current  
through to the bright sea,

220 choked with the dead — and you kill,  
and kill.

221 Come, let it be. Horror takes me,  
leader of the people.”

222 Then in answer spoke to him swift-  
footed Achilles:

223 “It shall be so, Scamander, nurtured of  
Zeus, as you command.

224 But the arrogant Trojans — I will not  
stop cutting them down

225 before I pen them in their city, and  
stand against Hector

226 face to face, whether he breaks me or  
I break him.”

227 So speaking he swept on the Trojans

like more than man.

228 And then the deep-eddying river  
called to Apollo:

229 “Shame, lord of the silver bow, child of  
Zeus — you have not

230 kept the counsels of Cronos’s son, who  
charged you strictly

231 to stand by the Trojans and defend  
them, until the late

232 evening-light comes down and  
shadows the deep-soiled plowland.”

233 He spoke; and spear-famed Achilles  
leapt from the bluff13

234 and sprang into mid-current. And the  
river rushed on him, surging

235 and swelling, and stirred all his  
streams into turmoil, and shoved

236 the many corpses that crowded him —  
Achilles’ killing —

237 out onto dry land, bellowing like a bull  
238 as he threw them; and the living he  
saved down his beautiful streams,  
239 hiding them in his eddies, deep and  
wide.  
240 And terrible around Achilles the  
churning water towered,  
241 and the current beat down on his  
shield and shoved him; nor could  
242 his feet find purchase. He grasped an  
elm with both hands —  
243 full-grown, majestic — and it tore out  
by the roots,  
244 brought the whole overhang down  
with it, dammed the beautiful  
245 streams with its dense branches, and  
bridged the river itself,  
246 falling in whole. And he sprang up out  
of the eddy

247 and set off flying across the plain on  
his quick feet —  
248 terrified. And the great god did not let  
up, but rose behind him,  
249 cresting black, to stop the labor of  
brilliant  
250 Achilles, and beat destruction away  
from the Trojans.  
251 And the son of Peleus bounded away a  
spear-cast's length,  
252 with the swoop of the black eagle, the  
hunter,  
253 strongest of winged things at once,  
and swiftest:  
254 like him he darted, and the bronze on  
his chest  
255 clashed terribly; and swerving out  
from under it  
256 he fled, and the river poured after

him, roaring hugely.

257 As when a ditch-tending man leads a  
stream of water<sup>14</sup>

258 from a dark spring down through his  
plantings and gardens,

259 mattock in hand, knocking the clogs  
from the channel,

260 and as it flows all the pebbles are  
rolled and tumbled

261 under it, and it runs murmuring  
quickly down

262 the sloping ground, and outruns the  
very man who guides it:

263 so the wave of the current forever  
caught Achilles,

264 fast as he was: gods are stronger than  
men.

265 And as often as swift-footed brilliant  
Achilles turned

266 to make a stand against it, and to  
learn whether all  
267 the immortals who hold the wide  
heaven were hunting him,  
268 so often the great wave of the sky-fed  
river  
269 battered down on his shoulders; and  
he sprang high with his feet,  
270 heartsick; and the river was breaking  
his knees from under him,  
271 raging slantwise beneath, eating the  
dust from under his feet.  
272 And the son of Peleus cried aloud,  
looking into the wide heaven:15  
273 “Father Zeus! — that no god  
undertakes to save me,  
274 pitiful as I am, from the river!  
Afterward let anything happen.  
275 No other of the sons of Heaven is so

much to blame

276 as my own mother, who beguiled me  
with lies:

277 she said I would die under the wall of  
the armored Trojans

278 by the swift arrows of Apollo.

279 I wish Hector had killed me — the best  
man reared here:

280 then a good man would have done the  
killing, and stripped a good man.

281 Now it is my portion to be caught by a  
wretched death,

282 hemmed in a great river, like a  
swineherd's boy

283 swept away by a gully he was crossing  
in a storm.”

284 So he spoke; and very quickly  
Poseidon and Athena

285 came and stood beside him, likened to



men in body,

286 and taking his hand in their hands  
they pledged him with words.

287 And Poseidon the earth-shaker began  
speaking among them:

288 “Son of Peleus — do not tremble so  
hard, do not be afraid.

289 Such are we two of the gods who  
stand your helpers —

290 Zeus approving — I and Pallas Athena.

291 It is not your portion to be broken by a  
river:

292 this one will soon give over — you will  
see it yourself.

293 And we will give you close counsel, if  
you will heed it:

294 do not rest your hands from the  
leveling war

295 before you pen the Trojan army inside

the famed walls

296 of Ilion — whoever escapes. And when  
you have taken Hector's life,

297 come back to the ships. We give you  
the glory to carry off."

298 The two of them, so speaking, went  
away to the immortals;16

299 and he went on — for the gods'  
command stirred him greatly —

300 into the plain. And the whole of it was  
filled with flood-water,

301 and much beautiful armor of young  
men killed in battle

302 floated there, and their bodies. His  
knees sprang high

303 as he rushed straight on against the  
current, nor could the river

304 hold him now, wide as it flowed:  
Athena put great strength in him.

305 But Scamander did not slacken his  
fury either — worse,  
306 his rage at Peleus's son grew; and he  
crested the wave of his current,  
307 lifting himself high, and shouted a call  
to Simoïs:  
308 “Dear brother — the strength of this  
man — let the two of us  
309 hold it together, since very soon he  
will sack the great city  
310 of lord Priam; and the Trojans will not  
stand in the chaos.  
311 Help me, and quickly: fill your streams  
with water  
312 from the springs, and rouse up every  
gully;  
313 raise a great wave, and stir a huge  
clamor  
314 of timbers and stones — so we stop the

wild man

315 who is winning now, and straining like  
the gods themselves.

316 For I say his strength will help him  
nothing, nor his beauty,

317 nor those beautiful arms, which deep  
beneath the mere

318 shall lie wrapped in slime — and the  
man himself

319 I will roll in sand, and pour around  
him shingle

320 past counting; and the Achaeans will  
not know where to gather

321 his bones, so deep in silt shall I bury  
him.

322 There his burial-mound will stand  
ready-made: he will need

323 no heaping of a tomb when the  
Achaeans bury him.”

324 He spoke, and surged at Achilles,  
churning, rearing high,  
325 seething with foam and blood and  
dead men.  
326 And the darkening wave of the sky-fed  
river  
327 towered above him, and began to drag  
the son of Peleus down.  
328 And Hera shrieked aloud, in terror for  
Achilles, 17  
329 lest the great deep-eddying river  
sweep him away,  
330 and at once she called to Hephaestus,  
her dear son:  
331 “Up, Crook-foot! Up, my child! — for it  
was against you  
332 we always reckoned eddying Xanthus  
matched in battle.  
333 Help him, and quickly: bring your

flames out in force.

334 And I will go rouse a hard storm out of  
the sea —

335 the West Wind and the white South  
Wind — to carry

336 the evil burning and set the Trojans’  
heads and armor alight.

337 You, along the banks of Xanthus, burn  
the trees,

338 and throw the fire into the river  
himself. And do not let him

339 turn you back at all with soft words or  
with threats;

340 do not slacken your fury — not until  
the moment

341 I shout and call to you: then hold the  
unwearying fire.”

342 So she spoke; and Hephaestus made  
ready unearthly fire.**18**

343 First the fire blazed on the plain, and  
burned  
344 the many corpses that crowded it —  
Achilles' killing;  
345 and the whole plain was dried, and  
the shining water stopped.  
346 As when in late summer the North  
Wind quickly dries  
347 a new-watered orchard, and the man  
who tends it is glad:  
348 so the whole plain was dried, and the  
fire consumed  
349 the corpses. Then he turned his all-  
shining flame on the river.  
350 The elms burned, and the willows, and  
the tamarisks;  
351 the lotus burned, and the rushes, and  
the galingale,  
352 which grew in abundance around the

river's beautiful streams;  
353 and the eels and the fish were in  
torment down the eddies,  
354 tumbling this way and that through  
the beautiful streams,  
355 worn down by the blast of resourceful  
Hephaestus.  
356 And the strong river burned, and  
spoke a word, and named him:19  
357 "Hephaestus! — no one of the gods  
can stand against you,  
358 and I will not fight you, flaming with  
fire as you are.  
359 Leave off the strife. As for the Trojans  
— let brilliant Achilles  
360 drive them out of their city this  
instant. What are strife and rescue to me?"  
361 He spoke, burning in the fire, and his  
beautiful streams were seething.



362 As a cauldron boils within, hurried by  
a great fire,  
363 melting down the lard of a fatted hog,  
364 bubbling up on every side, with dry  
split wood beneath it:  
365 so his beautiful streams blazed with  
the fire, and the water boiled,  
366 and would not flow onward, but stood  
checked: the breath  
367 of mighty, wise Hephaestus wore him  
down. And to Hera,  
368 begging hard, he spoke winged words:  
369 “Hera, why has your son fallen on my  
current, to torment it  
370 out of all others? Surely I am not so  
much to blame  
371 as all the rest of them — all the helpers  
of Troy.  
372 I will stop — I promise it — if you

command it;

373 but let him stop as well. And I will  
swear this oath besides:

374 never to ward the evil day away from  
the Trojans,

375 not even when all Troy is burning in  
ravaging fire —

376 burning, and the warlike sons of the  
Achaean light it.”

377 Now when the goddess white-armed  
Hera heard that,

378 at once she called to Hephaestus, her  
dear son:

379 “Hephaestus — hold, my glorious  
child. It is not seemly

380 to batter an immortal god this way for  
the sake of mortals.”

381 So she spoke; and Hephaestus  
quenched the unearthly fire,

382 and the wave ran back down the  
beautiful streams.  
383 And when the fury of Xanthus was  
beaten, those two20  
384 rested — for Hera held them back,  
angry as she was.  
385 But on the other gods fell strife, heavy  
and grinding,  
386 and the hearts in their chests blew  
two ways at once;  
387 and they fell together with a great  
crash, and the wide earth rang,  
388 and the great heaven trumpeted  
around them. And Zeus heard it,  
389 sitting on Olympus; and his own heart  
laughed  
390 for joy, when he saw the gods coming  
together in strife.  
391 Then they stood apart no longer. Ares

began it —**21**

**392** the shield-piercer: first he sprang at  
Athena,

**393** bronze spear in hand, and flung the  
word of insult:

**394** “Why, dog-fly — why do you drive the  
gods together in strife

**395** with your gale of daring, your great  
heart egging you on?

**396** Do you not remember when you set  
Diomedes, Tydeus’s son,

**397** on me to wound me — and took the  
spear yourself, in plain sight,

**398** and drove it straight at me, and tore  
my beautiful flesh?

**399** Now, I think, you will pay me for all  
you have done.”

**400** So speaking, he stabbed at the  
tasseled aegis —

401 the terrible aegis that not even Zeus's  
thunderbolt breaks:  
402 there blood-stained Ares stabbed her  
with his long spear.  
403 But she, giving ground, caught up a  
stone in her thick hand —  
404 a stone that lay on the plain, black,  
jagged, and huge,  
405 which men of former times had set to  
be a field's boundary-marker.  
406 With it she hit rushing Ares in the  
neck, and unstrung his limbs.  
407 Seven acres he covered, falling; and  
his hair was fouled with dust,  
408 and his armor clattered around him.  
And Pallas Athena laughed,  
409 and triumphing over him she spoke  
winged words:  
410 "Baby fool — you have never yet

reckoned how much stronger

411 I claim to be, that you match your fury  
against mine.

412 So pay in full your mother's curses —  
the Erinyes

413 she wishes on you in her anger,  
because you deserted

414 the Achaeans and defend the arrogant  
Trojans.”

415 So speaking, she turned her shining  
eyes away.

416 And Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus, took  
Ares by the hand<sup>22</sup>

417 and led him off, groaning thick and  
fast, barely gathering his spirit.

418 But when the goddess white-armed  
Hera noticed her,

419 at once she spoke winged words to  
Athena:

420 “Shame! Unwearied one, child of  
aegis-bearing Zeus —  
421 there goes the dog-fly again, leading  
Ares, bane of mortals,  
422 out of the deadly war through the  
chaos. After her!”  
423 So she spoke; and Athena sped after,  
glad at heart,  
424 and rushing on Aphrodite she struck  
her on the breast  
425 with her thick hand; and there her  
knees went slack, and her own heart.  
426 So the two of them lay on the earth  
that feeds many,  
427 and Athena, triumphing, spoke  
winged words:  
428 “Such may they all be now — all the  
helpers of the Trojans  
429 when they fight the armored Argives:

430 just so bold, and just so hardy, as  
Aphrodite  
431 coming to second Ares, and facing my  
fury.  
432 Then long ago we should have rested  
from the war,  
433 with the well-built citadel of Ilion  
sacked.”  
434 So she spoke; and the goddess white-  
armed Hera smiled.  
435 And the lord earth-shaker addressed  
Apollo:23  
436 “Phoebus — why do we two stand  
apart? It is not fitting,  
437 when the others have begun. The  
greater shame if we go back  
438 fightless to Olympus, to the bronze-  
floored house of Zeus.  
439 Begin: you are the younger born. It



would not be right

440 for me, since I was born first and  
know more things.

441 Baby fool — how mindless a heart you  
have! Do you not even

442 remember all we two suffered around  
Ilion,

443 alone of the gods, when we came from  
Zeus and drudged

444 a whole year for haughty Laomedon at  
a stated wage,

445 and he gave the orders, and we  
served?

446 I built the Trojans their wall around  
the city —

447 wide, and very beautiful, so the city  
might be unbreakable —

448 while you, Phoebus, herded the  
shambling twist-horned cattle

449 in the spurs of wooded, many-folded  
Ida.  
450 But when the glad seasons brought  
around the term  
451 of our hire, then he robbed us of all  
our wage by force —  
452 terrifying Laomedon — and sent us off  
with threats.  
453 He threatened to bind our feet, and  
our hands above them,  
454 and ship us for sale to far-off islands;  
455 and he vowed to lop the ears from  
both of us with bronze.  
456 So back we went, the two of us, with  
rancor in our hearts,  
457 in anger for the wage he promised and  
did not pay.  
458 And it is his people you now favor —  
instead of trying,

459 with us, to make the arrogant Trojans  
perish

460 root and branch, evilly, with their  
children and honored wives!”

461 Then in turn the lord Apollo, the  
worker-from-afar, answered him:24

462 “Earth-shaker — you would say I was  
unsound of mind

463 if I fought against you for the sake of  
mortals —

464 pitiful things, who like the leaves at  
one time

465 flourish in their blaze, eating the fruit  
of the plowland,

466 and at another wither heartless away.  
No — quickly,

467 let us rest from battle. Let them do  
their own fighting.”

468 So speaking he turned away: for he

shrank in awe

469 from trading blows with his father's  
brother.

470 But his sister rebuked him bitterly —  
the lady of wild beasts, 25

471 Artemis of the wilds — and flung the  
word of insult:

472 “So you run, worker-from-afar! — and  
hand Poseidon the whole

473 victory, and give him glory for  
nothing!

474 Baby fool — why do you carry that  
bow, useless as wind?

475 Never again let me hear you in our  
father's halls

476 boasting, as before among the  
immortal gods,

477 that you would fight Poseidon face to  
face.”

478 So she spoke; and Apollo the worker-  
from-afar answered nothing;  
479 but the honored wife of Zeus, in anger,  
480 reviled the shooter of arrows with  
words of insult:  
481 “And how is it you are eager,  
shameless bitch, to stand  
482 against me? I am a hard match for  
your fury,  
483 bow-carrier though you are — you  
whom Zeus made a lion  
484 to women, and gave you leave to kill  
whichever you choose.  
485 Better, surely, to slaughter beasts on  
the mountains,  
486 and wild deer, than to fight by force  
with your betters.  
487 But if you want a lesson in war — so  
you may know well

488 how much stronger I am, when you  
match your fury against mine —”  
489 She spoke, and with her left hand  
caught both the other’s hands  
490 at the wrist, and with her right  
stripped the bow from her shoulders,  
491 and with the bow itself, smiling, she  
boxed her about the ears  
492 as she twisted this way and that; and  
the swift arrows spilled out.  
493 And the goddess fled from under her,  
weeping, like a dove  
494 that flies from a hawk into a hollow  
rock,  
495 a cleft — for it was not her portion to  
be caught:  
496 so she fled weeping, and left her bow  
and arrows where they lay.  
497 And to Leto spoke the courier, the

slayer of Argus:**26**

**498** “Leto, I will not fight you — no: it is a  
hard thing

**499** to trade blows with the wives of  
cloud-gatherer Zeus.

**500** With all my heart’s goodwill: boast  
among the immortal gods

**501** that you overcame me with your  
strong force.”

**502** So he spoke; and Leto gathered up the  
curved bow

**503** and the arrows, fallen this way and  
that in the swirl of dust,

**504** and taking her daughter’s bow and  
arrows she went back.

**505** And the girl came to Olympus, to the  
bronze-floored house of Zeus,**27**

**506** and sat down weeping on her father’s  
knees,

507 the ambrosial robe trembling around  
her; and her father  
508 the son of Cronos drew her to him,  
and asked, laughing sweetly:  
509 “Who of the sons of Heaven, dear  
child, has treated you so —  
510 for nothing — as if you had been  
caught doing wrong in the open?”  
511 And the fair-crowned goddess of the  
clamorous hunt answered him:  
512 “Your wife battered me, father —  
white-armed Hera,  
513 from whom strife and quarrel cling to  
the immortals.”  
514 So the two of them spoke such things  
to one another.**28**  
515 And Phoebus Apollo went down into  
holy Ilion:  
516 for the wall of the well-built city was



on his mind —

517 lest the Danaans sack it that day,  
beyond its fate.

518 The other everlasting gods went to  
Olympus,

519 some in anger, and some in high  
triumph,

520 and sat down beside the father of the  
black cloud. But Achilles

521 went on killing the Trojans — the men  
and their single-hoofed horses.

522 As when smoke rises and reaches the  
wide heaven

523 from a burning city — the wrath of the  
gods has sent it up,

524 and it lays labor on all, and grief on  
many:

525 so Achilles laid labor and grief on the  
Trojans.

526 And old Priam stood on the god-built  
tower,  
527 and made out gigantic Achilles: and  
there before him  
528 the Trojans were being driven pell-  
mell in rout, and no defense  
529 was left. He cried out, and came down  
from the tower,  
530 to rouse the famed gate-keepers along  
the wall:  
531 “Hold the gates spread open in your  
hands, until the army  
532 comes into the city in its rout: for here  
is Achilles  
533 close by, driving them. Now, I think,  
comes disaster.  
534 But the moment they are gathered  
inside the wall and breathing,  
535 close the tight-fitted double doors

again:

536 I dread that ruinous man — that he  
may leap inside the wall.”

537 So he spoke; and they loosed the gates  
and thrust back the bars,

538 and the gates, spread wide, made a  
light of safety. And Apollo

539 sprang out to meet the rout, to beat  
destruction from the Trojans.

540 And they, straight for the city and the  
high wall,

541 parched with thirst and caked with  
dust, came fleeing

542 out of the plain; and he pressed hard  
behind them with the spear:

543 raging madness held his heart, and he  
strained for glory.

544 Then the sons of the Achaeans would  
have taken high-gated Troy,<sup>29</sup>

545 had not Phoebus Apollo stirred up  
brilliant Agenor —  
546 Antenor's son, a man blameless and  
strong.  
547 Into his heart he threw courage, and  
himself stood  
548 beside him, to beat away the heavy  
hands of death,  
549 leaning on the oak tree, wrapped in  
thick mist.  
550 Now when Agenor caught sight of  
Achilles, sacker of cities,  
551 he stood fast; but the heart in him  
churned dark as he waited,  
552 and troubled, he spoke to his own  
great-hearted spirit:  
553 "Ah me! If I run from strong Achilles  
554 the way the rest are driven, panicked,  
in rout —

555 he will catch me all the same, and  
butcher me for the coward I am.  
556 But if I leave these men to be driven  
before him —  
557 before Achilles, Peleus's son — and run  
on my own feet  
558 another way, off from the wall, toward  
the Ileian plain,  
559 until I reach the spurs of Ida and get  
into the brush —  
560 then at evening, when I have bathed  
in the river  
561 and cooled the sweat from me, I could  
come back to Ilion...  
562 But why does my own heart argue  
these things with me?  
563 What if he sees me swinging wide of  
the city toward the plain,  
564 and comes after at a sprint, and runs

me down on his quick feet?

565 Then there will be no more escaping  
death and the death-spirits:

566 he is too strong — strong beyond all  
mankind.

567 But what if, in front of the city, I stand  
and face him?

568 His flesh too, surely, can be cut by the  
sharp bronze;

569 in him is one life, no more; and  
mortal, men say

570 he is — though Zeus, Cronos's son,  
keeps handing him the glory."

571 So speaking, braced and gathered, he  
waited for Achilles, 30

572 and the brave heart in him strained  
toward war and battle.

573 As a leopard comes out of deep brush

574 to face the huntsman, and her heart

neither

575 fears nor thinks of flight when she  
hears the baying —

576 for even if he is quicker, and stabs or  
hits her with a cast,

577 still, run through on the very spear,  
she does not leave off

578 her valor, until she closes with him or  
goes down:

579 so the son of proud Antenor, brilliant  
Agenor,

580 refused to run before he had put  
Achilles to the test.

581 He held the balanced round shield out  
before him,

582 aimed at him with his spear, and  
shouted loud:

583 “No doubt you hoped in your heart,  
shining Achilles,

584 to sack the city of the proud Trojans  
this very day.  
585 Baby fool — there is grief yet to be  
suffered over her:  
586 inside her we are many, and men of  
valor,  
587 who will guard Ilion, standing in front  
of our dear parents  
588 and wives and sons. It is you who will  
meet your doom here —  
589 terrifying as you are, and so daring a  
fighter.”  
590 He spoke, and let the sharp javelin fly  
from his heavy hand,  
591 and hit him on the shin below the  
knee — no miss:  
592 and around it the greave of new-  
forged tin  
593 screamed terribly; and the bronze



sprang back

594 from where it struck, and did not pass:  
the god's gifts held it.

595 And the son of Peleus went for godlike  
Agenor

596 in his turn — but Apollo would not let  
him win the glory:

597 he snatched Agenor away, and hid him  
in thick mist,

598 and sent him quietly out of the war, to  
go his way.

599 Then by a trick he kept the son of  
Peleus from the army:**31**

600 likened in every point to Agenor  
himself, the worker-from-afar

601 stood before his feet — and Achilles  
ran hot after him.

602 And while he chased him across the  
wheat-bearing plain,

603 turning him along the deep-eddying  
river Scamander  
604 as he ran just a little ahead — for by  
that cunning Apollo  
605 kept him beguiled, always hoping to  
catch him on his quick feet —  
606 meanwhile the rest of the routed  
Trojans, in a mass,  
607 came glad to the city, and the town  
was filled with their crowding.  
608 Nor did they dare wait for one  
another any longer  
609 outside the city and the wall, to learn  
who had escaped  
610 and who had died in the fighting: in  
they poured, headlong,  
611 every man whose feet and knees could  
save him.

# Notes

## NOTES

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### NOTES

1. (21.1-16) The opening repeats 14.433-434 exactly (our English kept): “the ford of the fair-flowing river, eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot” — the crossing where the stunned Hector was laid and revived in Book 14. The river of Trojan refuge becomes the killing-pen: Achilles splits the rout, Hera walls one half behind mist, and the other half goes into the water. The locust simile knows what is coming three hundred lines early: men driven into a river by fire is precisely how the book will end for the river himself. ↩
2. (21.17-33) The spear left leaning on the tamarisks: sword work — butcher’s work — is what the moment wants. The dolphin simile makes the water itself predatory ground. Then the poem’s coldest logistics: twelve young men taken alive “blood-price for the death of Patroclus” — the vow of 18.336-337

collected on schedule, the victims led out “dazed, like fawns,” bound with the belts of their own tunics. They will be paid out at 23.175-176. Between vow and payment the poem never lets them speak. ↩

3. (21.34-48) Lycaon’s dossier — the fullest biography any minor victim receives, given precisely so we know the whole weight of what is about to be refused: the night raid, the fig-shoots cut for chariot-rails (a boy doing farm-work in an orchard war), the sale on Lemnos to Euneus son of Jason (the fleet’s wine-merchant, 7.467-469), the ransom by Eëtion of Imbros, Arisbe, the escape home. “Eleven days he delighted his heart among his dear ones; and on the twelfth the god threw him once more into the hands of Achilles.” The symmetry is exact and awful: eleven days of resurrection, and then the machinery resumes. ↩

4. (21.49-63) Achilles’ soliloquy over the unarmed man plays the return as ghost-story: “the great-hearted Trojans I have killed will rise again out of the murky dark.” The joke — spear as experiment: “so I may see... whether he will come back equally from down there” — is the aristeia’s humor: death-dealing grown so routine it wants variety. Under it, the

poem's physics: the sea did not hold him; "the life-giving earth... holds down even the strong" will. ↩

5. (21.64-96) The supplication tableau: one hand on the knees, one gripping the spear itself — clinging to the weapon to keep it out of his own body. Lycaon's claims are, in order: the suppliant-bond; table-fellowship ("at your table first I ate the grain of Demeter" — the captive fed by his captor becomes his guest); the ransom record (a hundred oxen paid, three hundred to free him); the fate-arithmetic of the twelfth dawn; and last, the desperate genealogical wedge — born of Laothoe, not Hecuba: "I am not from the same womb as Hector." He offers every category the heroic world honors. The answer voids the categories. ↩
6. (21.97-113) The refusal and the consolation, the poem's ethical summit. "Fool — offer me no ransom": the economy that ran Books 1-9 (and Lycaon's own first capture — "before Patroclus met his day of destiny, sparing Trojans was dearer to my heart") is formally closed. Then the turn from wrath to metaphysics — "So, friend, you die too" (ἀλλὰ φίλος θάνε καὶ σύ) — and the terms of the consolation: Patroclus was better, and died; "do you not see what I am — how

beautiful, how big?” — and I die too: “a dawn, or an evening, or a midday.” The killer comforts his victim with their equality before death, and means it; φίλος is not sarcasm but the only fellowship left to a man who has accepted his own sentence. No passage of the poem was more quoted in antiquity as the summary of the human condition. ↩

7. (21.114-135) Lycaon’s assent: knees slack, spear released, both hands spread — a posture between surrender and embrace — and the sword at the collarbone. Then the anti-funeral: slung into the river with a taunt that negates each rite in turn — no mother’s laying-out, no lament; instead fish licking the wound “uncaring” and darting up “under the black ripple to eat the white fat of Lycaon” (the body already imagined as carcass-meat). The closing insult is cultic: the river you honored “so long with slaughtered bulls, drowning single-hoofed horses alive in his eddies” (live-horse sacrifice to rivers is real archaic practice) will not save you. Aristophanes athetized 130-135 — and Didymus suspected Aristarchus agreed — but the lines are the hinge: this speech is what the river cannot forgive, and the next six hundred lines grow out of it. ↩

8. (21.136-160) Asteropaeus: grandson of the river Axius, eleven days at Troy (to Lycaon's twelve — the book counts its doomed newcomers), with Xanthus himself putting fury in his chest: the river's first counter-move is a champion of river-blood. The challenge-exchange is a diptych with Book 20's: where Aeneas gave sixteen generations, the Paeonian gives a river and a spear — "Axius, who sends the most beautiful water over the earth." ↩
9. (21.161-183) The double cast — "for he was a two-handed fighter" (περιδέξιος): one spear into the shield's gold, the other grazing Achilles' right elbow — the only blood Achilles sheds in the entire poem, and a river's grandson draws it. The duel then turns on the ash spear stuck in the bluff: three heaves, and on the fourth attempt — trying to snap the spear of Aeacus' grandson — the sword takes him. He dies at the belly like Polydorus, bowels on the ground, "gasping"; the register's darkness-formula closes his eyes. ↩
10. (21.184-199) The victory-boast is a theology lesson: "It is a hard thing to strive with the children of Cronos's mighty son — even for the son of a river." Zeus's line beats water's line; and the ladder runs up: "not even

Achelous the king is his equal, not even the great strength of deep-flowing Ocean, from whom all rivers flow and every sea, and all the springs, and the deep wells.” Zenodotus and Megaclides omitted line 195 (Pausanias saw such texts), which makes Achelous — not Ocean — the greatest of waters: the two readings preserve the oldest Greek dispute about the primal water. The vulgate keeps Ocean as source of all things and Achelous as king of rivers; this translation keeps the vulgate. ↩

11. (21.200-210) The corpse in the shallows: “around him the eels and the fish were busy, tearing at the fat of his kidneys” — Lycaon’s threatened fate enacted on the next body within eighty lines. Then seven Paeonians in a line — the plain catalogue-deaths that mark an aristeia running at full mechanical speed — until the river speaks. ↩

12. (21.211-232) The river’s protest is the book’s ecological center: “my lovely streams are crammed full of corpses, and I can no longer pour my current through to the bright sea... and you kill, and kill.” The god of the landscape pleads not for Troy but for his own nature — a river’s function is to flow, and slaughter has clogged it. Achilles’ answer grants the



venue-change and nothing else, and states the poem's remaining program in one line: "stand against Hector face to face, whether he breaks me or I break him." The river then rebukes Apollo with Zeus's sunset commission — the day-clause that has governed the poem since 11.194 — as if to say: someone must hold the line till dark, and the archer is idle. ↩

13. (21.233-271) The attack. The river fights as water fights: not blows but volume — the surge that shoves corpses ashore ("bellowing like a bull") while hiding the living in his eddies (the river as shepherd of his people, doing with water what Apollo does with mist); the wave on the shield; the uprooted elm that takes the whole bank with it and bridges the stream. Achilles — for the first time since Book 1 — runs. The eagle simile keeps his dignity ("strongest of winged things at once, and swiftest"); the irrigation simile takes it away magnificently: the cosmic terror measured by a gardener whose channel outruns him, mattock in hand — the most domestic image in the Iliad set against its most elemental combat, closed by the flattest of maxims: "gods are stronger than men." ↩

14. (21.272-283) The despair-prayer. Achilles wails (ᾤωξεν) — the verb of the wounded — that no god will save him, and that “my own mother beguiled me with lies”: the promised death “under the wall... by the swift arrows of Apollo” (exactly the death he will in fact receive, 22.359-360 — the complaint certifies the prophecy). The horror is genre-specific: to drown is to die without a victor, without a grave-mound, without kleos — “like a swineherd’s boy swept away by a gully he was crossing in a storm.” The greatest of heroes measures his death against the smallest imaginable one; Odysseus, drowning, makes the same calculation (Od. 5.306-312). ↩
15. (21.284-297) The rescue is pure dramaturgy: Poseidon and Athena “likened to men,” taking his hand — the pledge- gesture — and dictating the remainder of the epic: not fated to die by water; pen the Trojans; kill Hector; return to the ships; “we give you the glory to carry off.” (Seleucus athetized 290-292, and the Cretan edition omitted them.) The plot of Books 21-22 is handed over in a handclasp. ↩
16. (21.298-327) Scamander summons Simoïs — “dear brother” — for the war of the waters: springs opened, gullies roused, “a huge clamor of timbers

and stones.” The threat-speech is the book’s dark masterpiece: armor “deep beneath the mere... wrapped in slime,” the man rolled in sand under “shingle past counting,” and the perfect inversion of epic burial: “the Achaeans will not know where to gather his bones... There his burial-mound will stand ready-made: he will need no heaping of a tomb.” Book 23 will build Patroclus (and eventually Achilles) the greatest funeral in poetry; the river offers its exact negation — burial as disappearance, the tomb no one can find. For a hero, that is not death but erasure. ↩

17. (21.328-341) Hera’s counter-stroke calls the match-card of 20.73-74 by name: “it was against you we always reckoned eddying Xanthus matched in battle.” Her plan is a coordinated burn: Hephaestus on the trees and the river, herself rousing Zephyrus and the white South Wind from the sea to drive the flame onto the Trojans. Her warning — “do not let him turn you back at all with soft words or with threats” — repeats Apollo’s coaching of Aeneas (20.108-109): even gods need to be told not to listen.

↩

18. (21.342-355) Fire eats the book's own scenery. First the corpses — the dead of Achilles' killing get from Hephaestus the cremation the river denied them: the aristeia's litter burned off the plain. The drying simile answers the irrigation simile: there, water outran its gardener; here, the North Wind dries the new-watered orchard "and the man who tends it is glad." Then the riverside flora burns by name — elms, willows, tamarisks (where the spear leaned at line 18), lotus, rushes, galingale — and the eels and fish that ate Asteropaeus tumble in the boil. The book's justice is elemental and complete. ↩
19. (21.356-382) The surrender: "no one of the gods can stand against you... What are strife and rescue to me?" — the god of the landscape resigning the war effort mid-sentence. The cauldron simile is the poem at its most audaciously domestic: a god's agony rendered as kitchen-work, "melting down the lard of a fatted hog... with dry split wood beneath." And the oath he offers Hera is her own: 374-376 repeat, word for word, the Troy-burning clause she recited at 20.315-317 (renderings kept identical) — the river buys his life by swearing the destruction of the city he rose to save. Hera's stand-down order states the Theomachy's official rule — "not seemly to batter an

immortal god for the sake of mortals” — which every god then proceeds to break. ↩

20. (21.383-390) The gods fall on each other, “the wide earth rang, and the great heaven trumpeted” — and the audience is named: “Zeus heard, sitting on Olympus; and his own heart laughed for joy, when he saw the gods coming together in strife.” This is the show he commissioned at 20.23 (“where I can watch and delight my mind”), now delivered. The gods cannot die; therefore their war is comedy, and the poem plays it as such — the laughter of Zeus is the genre-marker for the next hundred lines, while beneath it the mortal war goes on being fatal. ↩

21. (21.391-415) Ares vs Athena, the grudge-match of Book 5: his “dog-fly” and the memory of Diomedes’ guided spear; her weapon a boundary-stone “which men of former times had set to be a field’s boundary-marker” — the goddess of civic order felling the war-god with the marker of agreed limits (what Ares tramples, in every sense). Seven acres of fallen god, dusty hair, a laugh, and the taunt: pay “your mother’s curses — the Erinyes she wishes on you” for changing sides. The register’s formulas —

“blood-stained Ares,” “unstrung his limbs” — do their fixed work. ↩

22. (21.416-434) Aphrodite leading Ares off by the hand is Book 5 again (she led him wounded then too), and Hera’s “there goes the dog-fly again” hands Athena her second knockdown: one blow to the breast, and the pair lie together “on the earth that feeds many.” Athena’s boast — had all Troy’s helpers been so brave, “long ago we should have rested from the war, with the well-built citadel of Ilion sacked” — is the counterfactual that exposes the whole Theomachy: divine partisanship is what keeps the war long. Hera smiles; the smile is the scene’s verdict. ↩

23. (21.435-460) The one serious challenge: Poseidon to Apollo, elder to younger (“Begin: you are the younger born” — dueling etiquette among immortals), grounded in the poem’s deepest Trojan backstory: the year of bonded labor under Laomedon, Poseidon building the wall “wide, and very beautiful, so the city might be unbreakable” (the very fortification this war beats against), Apollo herding cattle on Ida; the wage refused, the threats — binding, sale to far islands, ears lopped with bronze. Troy’s royal house cheated two gods and

threatened them with mutilation and slavery: the city's doom has a contract-law history, and Poseidon's indignation — "it is his people you now favor!" — is the poem's last rehearsal of it. ↩

24. (21.461-469) Apollo's refusal is the great verdict on mankind from above: fighting a fellow-god "for the sake of mortals — pitiful things, who like the leaves at one time flourish in their blaze, eating the fruit of the plowland, and at another wither heartless away." This is Glaucus's leaf-simile (6.146-149) — there, a man's hard-won consolation ("as the generation of leaves, so the generations of men"); here, a god's reason for indifference. The same image carries humility from below and contempt from above: no two lines in the poem measure the distance between gods and men more exactly. He turns away out of respect — for his uncle, not for us. (471 and 475-477 were athetized by Aristarchus.) ↩

25. (21.470-496) Artemis pays for her brother's prudence: her taunt ("why do you carry that bow, useless as wind?") draws Hera — and the queen of heaven disciplines the huntress like an unruly girl: wrists caught in one hand, the bow stripped and used to box her ears, "smiling" as she does it, the arrows

spilling. Hera's speech first defines her — "Zeus made you a lion to women, and gave you leave to kill whichever you choose" (Artemis as the sender of women's sudden deaths) — then demotes her: "better to slaughter beasts on the mountains than to fight by force with your betters." The dove-into-the-rock-cleft simile turns the archeress into her own quarry; the bow lies where it fell. ↩

26. (21.497-504) Hermes to Leto — the Theomachy's shortest match and its wittiest: an immediate, courteous forfeit ("it is a hard thing to trade blows with the wives of cloud-gatherer Zeus") with the winnings handed over in advance: "boast among the immortal gods that you overcame me with your strong force." Leto, unbloodied, gathers her daughter's scattered arrows — the one maternal gesture in a battle of gods. ↩

27. (21.505-513) The end of the divine war: Artemis in Zeus's lap, the ambrosial robe trembling, and the father "laughing sweetly" as he asks who hurt her "as if you had been caught doing wrong in the open." Her answer indicts the household: "Your wife battered me... from whom strife and quarrel cling to the immortals." The Theomachy that began with a



cosmic quake ends as a family scene in the living room — which is the poem’s point: for the deathless, war can only ever be domestic comedy. Below, meanwhile, it is Books 22-24. ↩

28. (21.514-543) Apollo alone stays at his post, entering Troy “lest the Danaans sack it that day, beyond its fate” — the god now guarding the same limit Zeus feared for at 20.30. The burning-city simile makes Achilles into the thing he is about to cause (“the wrath of the gods has sent it up” — he is that wrath); and Priam appears in his end-game role for the first time: the old man on the tower, ordering the gates held open in men’s hands until the rout is in, then barred — “I dread that ruinous man — that he may leap inside the wall.” The gates “spread wide, made a light of safety” (φάος — the register’s word for rescue): the same doors that will stand between Hector and his life in Book 22. ↩

29. (21.544-570) Agenor — one man, stiffened by Apollo, between Achilles and the open gates. His soliloquy in the registered frame (“troubled, he spoke to his own great-hearted spirit”) is the infantryman’s complete decision-tree: flight with the crowd (caught and butchered “for the coward I am”); solo flight to Ida’s

brush — with the poem's most humane detail, the fugitive's daydream of an evening bath in the river, "cooled the sweat from me" — rejected on pure footspeed-arithmetic; then the discovery on which the rest of the poem stands: "His flesh too, surely, can be cut by the sharp bronze; in him is one life, no more; and mortal, men say he is." Every man who chooses to stand against Achilles must first say this catechism; Hector will say it, and its refutations, at 22.99-130. ↩

30. (21.571-598) The leopard simile — she comes out of deep brush at the huntsman and "run through on the very spear, she does not leave off her valor, until she closes with him or goes down": doomed courage as the poem's highest animal image, spent here on a secondary hero to set the standard Hector will be measured against. Agenor's cast hits the shin — "the greave of new-forged tin screamed terribly" — and Hephaestus's armor turns its first blow in combat exactly where Hephaestus promised marvel rather than protection (18.466-467): it gives both. Apollo snatches Agenor into mist before the counterstroke — the third man so saved from Achilles in two books. ↩

31. (21.599-611) The decoy: Apollo “likened in every point to Agenor” runs, and the fastest man alive chases a god across the wheat-bearing plain, “always hoping to catch him on his quick feet” — Achilles’ one weapon against Hector, his speed, played against him to bleed the pursuit of its object. The trade is a city’s remnant for one man’s glory: while he chases nothing, Troy pours inside, “glad” — and the book’s last lines are the rout’s arithmetic, without a single name: no one dared wait “to learn who had escaped and who had died in the fighting: in they poured, headlong, every man whose feet and knees could save him.” One man is not inside. Book 22 opens with Hector standing in front of the gates. ↩

# Book 22

---

*One man is left outside the wall. His father begs  
from the tower, his mother bares her breast; he  
debates, runs, is run down past the washing-  
places of the old peace; the scales dip, Athena  
lies, the ash spear finds the throat above the  
stolen armor's collar — and a woman heating  
bath-water learns why the tower is wailing.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1** So, driven like fawns into the city, the  
Trojans**1**  
**2** dried their sweat, and drank, and slaked  
their thirst,  
**3** leaning on the beautiful battlements;  
and the Achaeans

4 came up close under the wall, shields  
tilted on shoulders.

5 But Hector — deadly fate shackled him  
where he stood,

6 in front of Ilion and the Scaean Gates.

7 And Phoebus Apollo called to the son of  
Peleus:

8 “Why, son of Peleus, do you chase me on  
your quick feet —

9 you a mortal, and I a deathless god? Not  
even yet

10 have you known me for a god: how  
unrelenting your fury is!

11 And the Trojans you routed — no  
thought for that labor now?

12 They are penned in the town, while you  
swerve away out here.

13 You cannot kill me: I am not a man  
marked out for death.”

14 Then, deeply troubled, swift-footed  
Achilles answered him:  
15 “You have robbed me, worker-from-  
afar — deadliest of all gods —  
16 turning me away from the wall. Many  
more of them  
17 would have bitten the earth before they  
got to Ilion!  
18 Now you have stolen great glory from  
me, and saved them  
19 cheaply: you had no vengeance to fear  
afterward.  
20 I would pay you back — I! — if only I  
had the power.”  
21 So speaking, he set off for the city,  
high-hearted,<sup>2</sup>  
22 stretched out like a prize-winning  
horse with his chariot,  
23 one that runs at full reach, easily, over

the plain:

24 so Achilles worked his feet and knees,  
and they were quick.

25 And it was old Priam whose eyes first  
made him out,

26 streaking across the plain, blazing like  
the star

27 that rises at harvest-time, and its rays  
shine clear

28 among many stars in the milking-dark  
of night —

29 the star men call by name the Dog of  
Orion.

30 Brightest of all it is; and it is made an  
evil sign,

31 and brings great fever down on  
wretched mortals:

32 so shone the bronze on his chest as he  
ran.

33 And the old man cried out, and beat his  
head with his hands,  
34 raising them high, and shouted down,  
crying aloud,  
35 begging his dear son. But he, before the  
gates,  
36 stood fast, hot beyond turning to fight  
Achilles;  
37 and the old man called to him  
piteously, hands outstretched:  
38 “Hector — do not wait for that man,  
dear child!  
39 Not alone, with no one by you — or you  
will meet your doom quickly,  
40 broken by the son of Peleus: for he is  
far the stronger.  
41 Merciless! I wish the gods loved him  
just as much  
42 as I do: quickly enough the dogs and



vultures would eat him

43 where he lay — and this terrible grief  
would leave my heart.

44 He has emptied me of many sons, and  
good ones,

45 killing them, or selling them off to far-  
lying islands.

46 Even now there are two — Lycaon and  
Polydorus —

47 whom I cannot see among the Trojans  
penned in the town,

48 the sons Laothoe bore me, a queen  
among women.

49 If they are alive somewhere in the  
camp, then we will

50 ransom them with bronze and gold: it  
is there, inside —

51 old Altes, the famous name, gave plenty  
with his daughter.

52 But if they are dead already, and in the  
house of Hades,  
53 that is grief to my heart and their  
mother's — we who bore them.  
54 To the rest of the people the grief will  
be briefer —  
55 so long as you do not die too, broken by  
Achilles.  
56 Come inside the wall, my child — so  
you may save  
57 the men and women of Troy; do not  
hand the great glory  
58 to the son of Peleus, and be stripped of  
your own dear life.  
59 And pity me — the wretch, the ill-fated,  
who can still feel —  
60 whom the father, Cronos's son, on the  
threshold of old age  
61 will wither out in hard fate, with my

eyes full of evils:

62 sons destroyed, daughters dragged  
away captive,

63 store-chambers ransacked, and little  
children

64 dashed against the ground in the  
terrible slaughter,

65 and my sons' wives dragged off under  
the deadly hands of Achaeans.

66 And me last of all — at my own front  
door the dogs

67 will tear me raw, when someone with  
the sharp bronze

68 has stabbed or speared the life out of  
my limbs —

69 the dogs I fed at my table, to keep my  
doors,

70 who will drink my blood, and sprawl,  
their hearts run mad,

71 in my own doorway. For a young man it  
is all seemly:  
72 killed in war, torn by the sharp bronze,  
73 to lie there — everything is beautiful on  
him, dead, whatever shows.  
74 But when the dogs defile the grey head  
and the grey beard  
75 and the naked shame of an old man  
slain,  
76 that is the most pitiful thing there is  
for wretched mortals.”  
77 So the old man spoke, and pulled at his  
grey hair with his hands,  
78 tearing it from his head; but he could  
not move the heart of Hector.  
79 And his mother in her turn wailed,  
letting her tears fall,<sup>4</sup>  
80 loosening the fold of her gown; with  
the other hand she held out her breast,

81 and letting her tears fall she spoke  
winged words:  
82 “Hector, my child — respect this. And  
pity me —  
83 me — if ever I gave you this breast, and  
it stilled your crying.  
84 Remember that, dear child. Fight that  
man of death  
85 from inside the wall — do not stand out  
there to meet him,  
86 merciless one! For if he kills you, I shall  
never  
87 mourn you laid on a bed, dear green  
shoot I bore —  
88 nor will your wife of the rich dowry —  
but far away from us both,  
89 by the ships of the Argives, the quick  
dogs will eat you.”  
90 So the two of them, weeping, called to

their dear son,  
91 begging over and over; but they could  
not move the heart of Hector.  
92 He stood fast, as gigantic Achilles came  
on nearer.  
93 And as a mountain snake at his hole  
waits for a man,5  
94 fed full of evil poisons, and the terrible  
anger has entered him,  
95 and he glares dreadfully, coiling around  
his hole:  
96 so Hector, holding his fury  
unquenchable, would not give way,  
97 his shining shield propped on the jut of  
the tower;  
98 and troubled, he spoke to his own  
great-hearted spirit:  
99 “Ah me! If I go inside the gates and the  
wall,6

- 100 Polydamas will be the first to lay  
reproach on me —
- 101 he who commanded me to lead the  
Trojans back to the city
- 102 on that ruinous night, when brilliant  
Achilles rose.
- 103 I would not listen. It would have been  
far better if I had.
- 104 Now — since I have destroyed the  
army by my own recklessness —
- 105 I am ashamed before the Trojan men  
and the trailing-robed
- 106 Trojan women: that some worse man  
than I may say:
- 107 ‘Hector trusted his own strength, and  
destroyed the army.’
- 108 So they will talk. And then it would be  
far better for me
- 109 to meet Achilles man to man, and kill

him, and come home —

110 or die at his hands myself, with honor,  
in front of the city.

111 Or what if — if I set down the bossed  
shield

112 and the heavy helmet, and lean the  
spear on the wall,

113 and go out, just myself, to meet  
blameless Achilles,

114 and promise him Helen, and all her  
treasure with her —

115 everything, all that Alexandros in his  
hollow ships

116 brought home to Troy, the beginning  
of the quarrel —

117 to give to the sons of Atreus to lead  
away; and for the Achaeans,

118 to divide with them everything else  
this city holds;



119 and after, I would take the elders' oath  
for the Trojans  
120 to hide nothing, but to split it all in  
two —  
121 all the wealth the lovely town keeps  
locked within it —  
122 but why does my own heart argue  
these things with me?  
123 I might come to him, suppliant — and  
he would show no pity,  
124 no respect at all: he would kill me  
naked as I stood,  
125 just like a woman, once I had put off  
my armor.  
126 There is no way now, from an oak or  
from a rock,  
127 to murmur with him softly — the way  
a girl and a young man,  
128 a girl and a young man, murmur softly

with each other.

129 Better to drive together in strife —  
and quickly.

130 Let us see to which of us the Olympian  
hands the triumph.”

131 So he weighed it, waiting. And Achilles  
came near him,7

132 the equal of Enyalios, the war-god of  
the flashing helm,

133 shaking the Pelian ash over his right  
shoulder,

134 terrible; and the bronze around him  
flashed with a light

135 like blazing fire, or the sun as it rises.

136 And trembling took Hector when he  
saw him. He could bear it8

137 no longer there: he left the gates  
behind, and ran in terror;

138 and the son of Peleus sprang after,

trusting his quick feet.

139 As a falcon in the mountains, lightest  
of winged things,

140 swoops easily after a trembling dove:

141 she flees away under him, and he close  
upon her, shrieking

142 sharp, lunges again and again, and his  
heart drives him to take her:

143 so Achilles flew straight for him, hot;  
and Hector fled

144 under the wall of the Trojans, working  
his knees fast.

145 Past the lookout-place, past the wind-  
blown wild fig,9

146 always out from under the wall, along  
the wagon-road

147 they sped; and they came to the two  
fair-flowing springs,

148 where the twin sources of eddying

Scamander leap up.

149 One flows with warm water, and steam  
all around it

150 rises off it, as if from a burning fire;

151 the other runs out even in summer as  
cold as hail

152 or freezing snow, or ice that forms  
from water.

153 And there beside them are the wide  
washing-troughs,

154 beautiful, of stone, where their  
glistening clothes

155 were washed by the Trojans' wives and  
their beautiful daughters —

156 in the old days, in peace: before the  
sons of the Achaeans came.

157 There the two of them ran past, one  
fleeing, one behind pursuing:

158 a brave man fled in front — but a far

better one pursued him —

159 fast: since it was no beast of sacrifice,  
no ox-hide,

160 they strove for — the prizes given for  
men's running:

161 they ran for the life of Hector, the  
tamer of horses.

162 As when prize-winning single-hoofed  
horses wheel round the turn-posts

163 at full gallop, and a great prize is set  
out —

164 a tripod, or a woman — in the games  
for a man who has died:

165 so the two of them whirled three  
times around Priam's city

166 on their quick feet. And all the gods  
looked on.

167 And the father of men and gods began  
speaking among them:10

168 “Shame — a man that I love, chased  
around the wall  
169 before my own eyes! My heart is  
grieving for Hector,  
170 who has burned the thigh-cuts of  
many oxen for me  
171 on the peaks of folded Ida, and other  
times again  
172 on the city’s height; and now brilliant  
Achilles  
173 hunts him on quick feet around the  
city of Priam.  
174 Come, gods — consider it, take  
counsel:  
175 shall we save him from death? Or now,  
at last,  
176 break him — brave though he is —  
under Achilles, Peleus’s son?”  
177 Then answered him the goddess grey-

eyed Athena:

178 “Father of the bright bolt, of the black  
cloud — what a word!

179 A man — a mortal, long since doomed  
to his fate —

180 and you mean to release him back out  
of harsh-sounding death?

181 Do it. But we other gods will not all  
approve you.”

182 Then in answer spoke to her cloud-  
gatherer Zeus:

183 “Take heart, Tritogeneia, dear child. I  
do not speak

184 in full earnest, and to you I mean to be  
kind.

185 Do as your purpose is. Hold back no  
longer.”

186 So speaking, he urged on Athena,  
eager already,

187 and she went darting down from the  
peaks of Olympus.

188 And swift Achilles pressed Hector  
without pause, driving him.11

189 As when a hound in the mountains  
starts the fawn of a deer

190 out of its bed, and courses it through  
glens and gorges;

191 and even if it goes to ground, cowering  
under a thicket,

192 the hound tracks it out, running  
steadily, till he finds it:

193 so Hector could not shake the swift-  
footed son of Peleus.

194 As often as he set himself to dash for  
the Dardanian gates,

195 to get in under the strong-built  
towers,

196 hoping the men above might defend



him with their missiles,  
197 so often Achilles headed him off and  
turned him back  
198 toward the plain, keeping himself  
always on the city side.  
199 And as in a dream a man cannot catch  
one who runs —  
200 the one cannot escape him, nor the  
other catch —  
201 so he could not run him down, nor the  
other get away.  
202 And how could Hector have slipped  
the death-spirits of death,  
203 had not Apollo — for the last and  
latest time — come near him,  
204 to rouse his strength in him, and his  
quick knees?  
205 And brilliant Achilles shook his head  
to the army: no —

206 he would not let them throw their  
bitter missiles at Hector,  
207 lest some thrower win the glory, and  
he come second.  
208 But when they came the fourth time  
round to the springs,<sup>12</sup>  
209 then it was that the father stretched  
out his golden scales,  
210 and set in them two death-spirits of  
death that lays men low —  
211 one for Achilles, one for Hector, tamer  
of horses —  
212 and grasping the middle he raised it.  
And Hector's day of doom  
213 sank down, and went to Hades; and  
Phoebus Apollo left him.  
214 And the goddess grey-eyed Athena  
came to the son of Peleus,<sup>13</sup>  
215 and standing close she spoke winged

words:

216 “Now at last, shining Achilles, dear to  
Zeus, I hope

217 the two of us bring the Achaeans great  
glory at the ships,

218 breaking Hector, however insatiable  
for battle.

219 Now there is no escaping us any  
longer — not for him,

220 not though Apollo the worker-from-  
afar should suffer agonies for it,

221 rolling and rolling at the feet of father  
Zeus of the aegis.

222 Now stop, and catch your breath. I will  
go

223 and win this man over to fight you  
face to face.”

224 So spoke Athena; and he obeyed, and  
rejoiced at heart,

225 and stood there, leaning on his  
bronze-bladed ash.

226 And she left him, and came up with  
brilliant Hector,

227 likened to Deiphobus in body and  
unwearying voice;

228 and standing close she spoke winged  
words:

229 “Old friend — how hard swift Achilles  
is pressing you,

230 hunting you on quick feet around the  
city of Priam!

231 Come — let us make our stand, and  
hold him off together.”

232 Then answered her great Hector of  
the flashing helmet:

233 “Deiphobus — you were always  
dearest to me before this

234 of all the brothers Hecuba and Priam

bore;

235 and now I mean to honor you in my  
heart still more,

236 who dared for my sake, when your  
eyes saw me,

237 to come outside the wall — while the  
others stay within.”

238 Then answered him the goddess grey-  
eyed Athena:

239 “Old friend — yes: father and lady  
mother begged me hard,

240 each in turn, clasping my knees, and  
my companions around them,

241 to stay inside — so hard they are all  
trembling.

242 But the heart in me was worn away  
with grieving.

243 Now — straight at him, and let us two  
fight; and no

244 sparing of spears: so we may learn  
whether Achilles  
245 kills us both and carries our bloody  
armor  
246 to the hollow ships — or is broken by  
your spear.”  
247 So spoke Athena, and led him on by  
her cunning.  
248 And when they had come close,  
advancing on each other,<sup>14</sup>  
249 the first to speak was great Hector of  
the flashing helmet:  
250 “No more running from you, son of  
Peleus — not now, as before,  
251 when I fled three times round the  
great city of Priam, and dared not  
252 stand to your coming. Now my heart  
has risen and set me  
253 to stand against you face to face. I will

kill, or be killed.

254 But come — let us swear here by the  
gods: for they

255 will be the best witnesses, and the  
guardians of covenants.

256 I will not defile you — not  
monstrously — if Zeus grants me

257 the endurance, and I take your life:

258 no, when I have stripped your famed  
armor, Achilles,

259 I will give your body back to the  
Achaeans. And you do the same.”

260 Then, glaring darkly, swift-footed  
Achilles answered him:15

261 “Hector — you past forgiving — talk to  
me of no covenants.

262 As between lions and men there are  
no faithful oaths,

263 and wolves and lambs do not carry

hearts in concord,  
264 but think evil against each other all  
the way through:  
265 so there is no way for me and you to  
be friends, and between us  
266 there will be no oaths — not before  
one or the other falls  
267 and gluts with his blood Ares, the  
fighter under the ox-hide shield.  
268 Remember every kind of valor you  
own: now above all hours  
269 you must be a spearman, and a daring  
fighter.  
270 There is no way out for you any  
longer: this instant Pallas Athena  
271 breaks you under my spear. Now, in  
one payment, you settle  
272 all my grief for my companions — the  
men you killed, raging with your spear.”



273 He spoke, and poised and hurled his  
long-shadowed spear.16

274 But shining Hector was watching it,  
and dodged:

275 he saw it coming and crouched, and  
the bronze spear flew over

276 and stuck in the earth. And Pallas  
Athena snatched it up

277 and gave it back to Achilles — hidden  
from Hector, shepherd of the people.

278 And Hector called across to the  
blameless son of Peleus:

279 “You missed! So after all, godlike  
Achilles, you never

280 learned my doom from Zeus — though  
you claimed to know it.

281 You are a glib one, a very thief with  
your words —

282 hoping I would forget my fury and

valor for fear of you.

283 You will plant no spear in my back as I  
run:

284 as I charge you straight on, drive it  
through my chest —

285 if the god has given you that. Now  
dodge my bronze

286 in your turn — and may you carry all  
of it away in your flesh!

287 The war would be lighter for the  
Trojans

288 with you destroyed. You are their  
greatest bane.”

289 He spoke, and poised and hurled his  
long-shadowed spear,

290 and hit the shield of the son of Peleus,  
mid-center — no miss —

291 but the spear glanced far off the  
shield. And Hector was angry

292 that the swift cast had left his hand  
for nothing,  
293 and stood there hanging his head: he  
had no second ash spear.  
294 He shouted then, calling to white-  
shielded Deiphobus —  
295 a long spear was what he asked — but  
Deiphobus was nowhere near him.  
296 And Hector understood inside  
himself, and said:17  
297 “So. The gods have called me  
deathward after all.  
298 I thought the hero Deiphobus stood  
beside me;  
299 but he is inside the wall, and Athena  
has tricked me.  
300 Now evil death is close to me — not  
far off now,  
301 and no way out. So this, long since,

was the true pleasure  
302 of Zeus, and of Zeus's son who strikes  
from afar, who before  
303 defended me gladly. And now fate  
overtakes me.  
304 Then let me not die without a fight,  
without glory —  
305 no: having done some great thing  
first, for men to come to hear of.”  
306 So speaking, he drew the sharp  
sword18  
307 that hung along his flank, heavy and  
huge,  
308 gathered himself, and swooped — like  
the high-flying eagle  
309 that drops to the plain through the  
lowering clouds  
310 to snatch a soft lamb or a cowering  
hare:

311 so Hector swooped, shaking his sharp  
sword.  
312 And Achilles charged to meet him, his  
heart crammed full  
313 of savage fury; over his chest he held  
the cover of his shield,  
314 beautiful, intricate; and he nodded  
with the shining helmet,  
315 four-horned; and around it tossed the  
beautiful plumes  
316 of gold that Hephaestus had set thick  
along the crest.  
317 And as a star moves among stars in the  
milking-dark of night —  
318 Hesperus, the most beautiful star that  
stands in heaven —  
319 so the light went from the keen point  
that Achilles  
320 balanced in his right hand, purposing

evil for brilliant Hector,

321 searching the beautiful flesh for where  
it would yield the most.

322 Now all the rest of his flesh the bronze  
armor held —19

323 the beautiful armor he stripped from  
the might of Patroclus, killed —

324 but there showed, where the  
collarbones part neck from shoulders,

325 the gullet — where the destruction of  
a life is quickest.

326 There, as he charged, brilliant Achilles  
drove with the spear,

327 and the point went through and out  
the soft neck —

328 yet the ash, heavy with bronze, did  
not sever the windpipe,

329 so that he could still speak, and trade  
words with him.

330 He crashed down in the dust; and  
brilliant Achilles cried in triumph:  
331 “Hector — no doubt you thought,  
while you stripped Patroclus,  
332 that you were safe; and I, far off — you  
gave me no thought.  
333 Fool: far from him, a helper — and a  
far greater one —  
334 was left behind at the hollow ships: I,  
335 who have unstrung your knees. You  
the dogs and the birds  
336 will drag and defile. Him the Achaeans  
will bury.”  
337 Then, his strength nearly gone, Hector  
of the flashing helmet:20  
338 “I beg you — by your life, by your  
knees, by your parents:  
339 do not let the dogs devour me by the  
ships of the Achaeans.

340 Take the bronze — take gold in plenty

—

341 the gifts my father and my lady  
mother will give you;

342 and give my body back to go home, so  
that the Trojans

343 and the Trojans' wives may grant me,  
dead, my portion of fire.”

344 Then, glaring darkly, swift-footed  
Achilles answered him:

345 “Dog. Do not beg me by knees, or by  
parents.

346 I only wish the fury and the heart in  
me would drive me

347 to hack away your flesh and eat it raw  
myself — for what you have done —

348 as surely as there is no man alive who  
will keep the dogs

349 from your head: not if they bring here



and weigh out

350 ransom ten times over — twenty times  
— and promise more;

351 not if Priam, Dardanus's descendant,  
bids them buy you

352 for your own weight in gold — not  
even so shall your lady mother

353 lay on a bed and mourn the son she  
bore.

354 No: the dogs and the birds will share  
you out — all of you."

355 Then, dying, Hector of the flashing  
helmet said to him:21

356 "I know you now — looking at you.  
There was never a chance

357 I would persuade you: the heart in  
your chest is iron.

358 Only take care, now, that I not become  
the gods' curse

359 upon you — on that day when Paris  
and Phoebus Apollo  
360 destroy you, brave as you are, at the  
Scaean Gates.”  
361 Even as he spoke, the end that is death  
covered him;  
362 and his soul, flying from his limbs,  
went down to the house of Hades,  
363 wailing its fate, leaving its manhood  
and its youth.  
364 And brilliant Achilles spoke to him —  
dead already:  
365 “Die. My own death-spirit I will accept  
whenever  
366 Zeus wills to accomplish it, and the  
other immortal gods.”  
367 He spoke, and pulled the bronze spear  
out of the corpse<sup>22</sup>  
368 and set it aside, and stripped the

bloody armor

369 from the shoulders. And the other  
sons of the Achaeans ran up around him,

370 and gazed at the stature and the  
marvelous beauty

371 of Hector; and not one man stood by  
him without a stab.

372 And thus would one of them say, with  
a glance at his neighbor:

373 “Well now — softer to the touch, this  
Hector, easier handling

374 than when he burned the ships with  
blazing fire!”

375 So a man would say — and step in  
close, and wound him.

376 Now when swift-footed brilliant  
Achilles had stripped him, 23

377 he stood among the Achaeans and  
spoke winged words:

378 “Friends — leaders and counselors of  
the Argives —  
379 since the gods have granted us the  
breaking of this man,  
380 who did more harm than all the rest  
together,  
381 come: let us circle the city under arms  
and probe it,  
382 and learn what mind the Trojans have  
in them now —  
383 whether they will abandon the high  
town, with this man fallen,  
384 or are set on holding it, though Hector  
is no more.  
385 But why does my own heart argue  
these things with me?  
386 By the ships lies a dead man —  
unwept, unburied —  
387 Patroclus. I will not forget him, not

while I

388 am among the living, and my own  
knees have their spring.

389 And if in the house of Hades men  
forget their dead,

390 even there I will remember my dear  
companion.

391 Now, singing the paeon, young men of  
the Achaeans,

392 let us go back to the hollow ships, and  
take this man.

393 We have won great glory: we have  
killed brilliant Hector —

394 the man the Trojans prayed to  
through their city, as to a god.”

395 He spoke; and he devised foul work  
against brilliant Hector.24

396 Behind both feet he pierced the  
tendons through,

397 from heel to ankle, and threaded  
straps of oxhide,  
398 and bound them to his chariot, and  
left the head to drag;  
399 and lifting the famed armor into the  
car, he mounted  
400 and lashed the horses on; and they  
flew, nothing loath.  
401 And the dust rose off the dragged  
man; and his dark hair  
402 spread wide around him; and in the  
dust lay all that head  
403 that was so beautiful before; but now  
Zeus gave him  
404 to his enemies, to be defiled in his  
own fatherland.  
405 So all his head was fouled with dust.  
And now his mother<sup>25</sup>  
406 tore her hair, and flung the shining

veil

407 far from her, and screamed aloud at  
the sight of her child;

408 and his dear father groaned piteously,  
and around them the people

409 were seized with screaming and with  
wailing through the city.

410 It was most like this — as if the whole  
of

411 beetling Ilion, top to bottom, were  
smouldering in fire.

412 The people could barely hold the old  
man, frantic

413 in his grief to go out by the Dardanian  
gates.

414 He begged them all, groveling in the  
dung,

415 calling on each man by his name:

416 “Let be, friends — for all your care of

me, let me alone

417 go out of the city and come to the  
ships of the Achaeans.

418 I will beg this man — this reckless  
doer of violence —

419 if somehow he may respect my years,  
and pity

420 old age. For he too has a father — such  
a one as I am:

421 Peleus, who begot him and reared him  
to be a bane

422 for the Trojans — and beyond all men  
he has laid grief on me:

423 so many of my sons he has killed in  
their green prime.

424 Yet for all of them I do not mourn so  
much — grieved as I am —

425 as for one, whose sharp loss will carry  
me down into Hades:



426 Hector. I wish he had died in my arms!

427 Then the two of us could have glutted  
ourselves with weeping and wailing —

428 the mother who bore him — born to  
sorrow — and I myself.”

429 So he spoke, weeping; and the citizens  
groaned in answer.

430 And among the women of Troy,  
Hecuba led the thick lament:26

431 “My child — I am destroyed. Why  
should I live now, in this horror,

432 with you dead? — you who were, night  
and day,

433 my boast through the city, and a  
blessing to all,

434 to the men and women of Troy  
through the town, who greeted you

435 like a god: for you were their great  
glory too,

436 while you lived. Now death and fate  
have overtaken you.”  
437 So she spoke, weeping. But the wife of  
Hector had not yet<sup>27</sup>  
438 heard anything: no true messenger  
had come to her  
439 to tell her that her husband stood  
alone outside the gates.  
440 She was weaving at her loom, deep in  
the high house,  
441 a double cloak, purple, sprinkling in  
flowers of many colors;  
442 and she had called through the house  
to her lovely-braided handmaids  
443 to set a great tripod over the fire, so  
there would be  
444 a warm bath for Hector, for his return  
out of the fighting.  
445 Poor innocent: she did not know that

far from all baths

446 grey-eyed Athena had broken him  
under the hands of Achilles.

447 Then she heard the shrieking and the  
wailing from the tower;

448 and her limbs whirled where she  
stood, and the shuttle fell out of her hand,

449 and she called again to her lovely-  
braided slave-women:

450 “Here — two of you, come with me. I  
must see what has happened.

451 I heard the voice of my honored  
mother-in-law, and in me

452 my own heart leaps to my mouth, and  
beneath me my knees

453 are frozen: something evil is close to  
the children of Priam.

454 May the word stay far from my ear! —  
but I am terribly

455 afraid that brilliant Achilles has cut off  
my bold Hector,  
456 alone, from the city, and driven him  
toward the plain,  
457 and has ended it — that grievous pride  
of his  
458 that always held him: he would never  
stay back in the crowd of men,  
459 but ran far out in front, yielding first  
place to no one.”  
460 So speaking she rushed through the  
hall like a madwoman,**28**  
461 her heart slamming; and her maids  
went with her.  
462 But when she reached the tower and  
the crowd of men,  
463 she stopped on the wall, staring — and  
saw him:  
464 dragged in front of the city, and the

quick horses

465 dragging him, uncaring, toward the  
hollow ships of the Achaeans.

466 Then black night came down and  
covered her eyes,

467 and she toppled backward, and gasped  
her spirit out.

468 And off her head she flung the shining  
head-dress —

469 the frontlet, and the cap, and the  
woven band,

470 and the veil that golden Aphrodite  
gave her

471 on the day Hector of the flashing  
helmet led her

472 out of Eëtion's house, when he had  
brought bride-gifts past counting.

473 Around her, thick, stood her  
husband's sisters and his brothers' wives,

474 and held her up among them, dazed to  
the point of death.

475 But when she caught her breath, and  
the spirit gathered again in her chest,<sup>29</sup>

476 with bursting sobs she spoke among  
the women of Troy:

477 “Hector — I am wretched. To one fate,  
then, we were born,

478 the two of us: you in Troy, in the  
house of Priam,

479 and I in Thebe, under wooded Placus,

480 in the house of Eëtion — who reared  
me when I was little,

481 the doomed man, the ill-doomed girl. I  
wish he had never begotten me.

482 Now you go down to the house of  
Hades under the hidden places

483 of the earth, and you leave me in  
hateful mourning,

484 a widow in your halls. And the boy is  
just a baby still,  
485 whom we bore, you and I — the two  
ill-fated. No help  
486 will you be to him, Hector — you are  
dead — nor he to you.  
487 For even if he escapes the Achaeans’  
war of many tears,30  
488 still there will be nothing for him ever  
after but labor  
489 and sorrows: other men will strip  
away his fields.  
490 The day of orphaning makes a child  
companionless:  
491 his head is bowed to everyone; his  
cheeks are wet with tears;  
492 and in his need the boy goes up to his  
father’s friends,  
493 tugging at one man’s cloak, another’s

tunic;

494 and of those who pity him, one holds  
out his cup — a moment:

495 he wets his lips; his palate he does not  
wet.

496 And a boy with both parents living  
beats him from the feast,

497 striking him with his fists, jeering at  
him with insults:

498 ‘Get out — just as you are! No father of  
yours dines with us.’

499 And in tears the boy goes up to his  
widowed mother —

500 Astyanax: who before, on his own  
father’s knees,

501 would eat only marrow and the rich  
fat of sheep;

502 and when sleep came over him, and  
he left off his child’s play,



503 he would slumber in a bed, in the  
arms of his nurse,  
504 in soft bedding, his heart brimful of  
good things.  
505 But now he will suffer and suffer,  
missing his dear father —  
506 Astyanax, ‘the lord of the city,’ as the  
Trojans call him  
507 by name: for you alone guarded their  
gates and their long walls.  
508 Now, by the beaked ships, far away  
from your parents,31  
509 the writhing worms will eat you,  
when the dogs have had  
510 their fill of you — naked: though here  
in your halls lies clothing,  
511 fine-woven and lovely, made by the  
hands of women.  
512 All of it — all — I will burn now in

blazing fire:

513 no use to you: you will not lie in it.

514 Let it be your glory in the eyes of the men and women of Troy.”

515 So she spoke, weeping; and the women wailed in answer.

## Notes

### NOTES

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### NOTES

1. (22.1-20) The frame: Troy drinking and drying its sweat on the battlements — safety made physical — while one man stands outside, “shackled” by fate (πέδησεν: the poem’s verb for the trap already sprung). Apollo’s revelation ends the decoy-chase of 21.599-611, and his taunt — “you cannot kill me: I am not a man marked out for death” — states the book’s whole geometry: gods are unkillable, so all the afternoon’s fury must land on the one man who is

not. Achilles' reply — "I would pay you back, if only I had the power" — is the closest any mortal in the poem comes to declaring war on heaven. ↩

2. (22.21-32) The Dog Star simile. Priam sees Achilles as Sirius — "brightest of all... and it is made an evil sign, and brings great fever down on wretched mortals": the most beautiful light in the sky, read as pestilence. It is the book's signature: brilliance and disaster in a single body, seen by an old man from a wall. (Achilles' own armor makes the same double sign at 134-135 — fire, or sunrise.) ↩

3. (22.38-76) Priam's plea moves from policy to the body. The center is Lycaon and Polydorus — "whom I cannot see among the Trojans penned in the town" — the audience knowing what the father does not: Book 20 and 21 have already answered him. The close is the most terrible passage spoken by any parent in the poem: the vision of his own scavenging — the table-dogs, "my door-keepers," drinking his blood at his own threshold — governed by the law he states with dreadful calm: on a young man killed in war "everything is beautiful, dead, whatever shows" (πάντα καλά); but dogs at the grey head and beard and "the naked shame of an old man slain — that is

the most pitiful thing there is for wretched mortals.”  
Tyrtaeus rebuilt the lines for Spartan war-song; here  
they are not exhortation but a father’s terror. ↩

4. (22.79-89) Hecuba’s argument is the breast itself —  
λαθικηδέα μαζόν, “the breast that stills care” —  
motherhood presented as evidence: “if ever I gave  
you this breast... remember that.” Both parents end  
at the same image (the dogs, the unmourned bed)  
because both know what corpse- treatment this war  
has come to; the poem has spent four books teaching  
it. ↩
5. (22.93-98) The snake simile: coiled at his hole, “fed full  
of evil poisons,” glaring — the only simile in the  
poem that makes a hero venomous. It renders  
exactly what shame has done to Hector: courage  
held not as flame (his usual fire-similes) but as toxin  
— swallowed anger waiting at a threshold it cannot  
abandon. ↩
6. (22.99-130) The soliloquy. Its logic deserves tracing: (1)  
Polydamas was right on the ruinous night (18.249-  
313 — “whose counsels were ruinous” said the  
narrator; Hector now says it of himself: “I have  
destroyed the army by my own recklessness”); (2)  
therefore the city’s eyes — down to “some worse

man than I” — are unbearable: shame (αἰδέομαι) holds him outside; (3) the fantasy of total surrender — Helen, her treasure, half the city’s wealth under oath — rehearsed in loving legal detail and cut off by the fixed register line (“but why does my own heart argue these things with me?” = 21.562): he would be killed “naked... just like a woman”; (4) the strangest and most human turn in the poem — “There is no way now, from an oak or from a rock, to murmur with him softly — the way a girl and a young man, a girl and a young man, murmur softly with each other.” The doubled phrase (the Greek repeats it too) is courtship remembered at the door of death: no more beginning-talk; only the ending. So: “Let us see to which of us the Olympian hands the triumph.” ↩

7. (22.131-135) Achilles arrives as the war-god (“the equal of Enyalios”), the Pelian ash over his shoulder, bronze like “blazing fire, or the sun as it rises” — the Dog Star of 26-31 come to ground-level. The poem has spent two similes making him light; the third thing light does, after shining and warming, is blind. ↩

8. (22.136-144) “And trembling took Hector... he left the gates behind, and ran.” The poem does not soften it:

the snake bolts from its hole; the best man of Troy, having chosen to stand through ninety lines of deliberation, is undone in one look. The falcon-and-dove simile gives the chase its physics (the shriek, the repeated lunges) and its verdict: from here to the springs Hector is prey. ↩

9. (22.145-166) The run past the landmarks — lookout, wild fig, wagon-road — to the double springs of Scamander (one steaming, one ice-cold) and the stone washing-troughs “where the Trojans’ wives and their beautiful daughters used to wash their glistening clothes — in the old days, in peace, before the sons of the Achaeans came.” No passage in Homer does more with less: the whole lost civilian world folded into laundry, set at the exact spot where its defender is being run down. Then the narrator’s cold accounting — “a brave man fled in front, but a far better one pursued” — and the great inversion of the games: they run as at funeral games, “a tripod, or a woman” for prize — “but they ran for the life of Hector, the tamer of horses.” (Some ancient copies added a plus- line at 158; the apparatus records it.) Book 23 will run real races, for real tripods, around this dead man’s pyre. ↩

10. (22.167-187) The divine council in miniature: Zeus's grief for a pious man ("who has burned the thigh-cuts of many oxen for me") and the proposal to save him — answered by Athena with the same three lines Hera used over Sarpedon (179-181 = 16.441-443, kept verbatim); a mortal "long since doomed" cannot be un-doomed without cosmic scandal; "Do it. But we other gods will not all approve you." The rescue-debate has become a form-letter, and both times the father yields — adding here, with terrible mildness, that he "does not speak in full earnest." Zeus's love is real; it is simply not the kind that saves. ↩

11. (22.188-207) Three similes of unclosable distance: the hound and the fawn (tracking "steadily, till he finds it"); Achilles heading Hector off from the Dardanian gates "keeping himself always on the city side" — the pursuit as sheep-dogging, the runner herded away from rescue; and the dream — "as in a dream a man cannot catch one who runs — the one cannot escape him, nor the other catch." Aristarchus athetized the dream-lines as undignified; they are the passage's genius — the one simile in Homer taken not from the world but from the experience of nightmare, where both runners labor and neither

moves. Achilles' head-shake to the army (no missiles — “lest some thrower win the glory, and he come second”) keeps the kill private: this death has an owner. ↩

12. (22.208-213) The scales. “Then the father stretched out his golden scales” — as at 8.69-74 for the armies, now for two men — “and Hector’s day of doom sank down, and went to Hades; and Phoebus Apollo left him.” Two clauses, no comment: the god who saved him at 20.443, who roused his knees at 22.204, departs like an advocate leaving a courtroom at verdict. Fate in the Iliad is exactly this scene: not a decree from above the gods, but the moment the gods stop arguing. ↩

13. (22.214-247) Athena’s masterpiece of cruelty. To Achilles she is plain (“Now stop, and catch your breath. I will go and win this man over”); to Hector she is Deiphobus — the dearest brother, “in body and unwearying voice” — with a fabricated biography of devotion (the parents’ clasped knees, “the heart in me was worn away with grieving”) engineered to convert the fugitive’s shame into hope. Hector’s answer — “I mean to honor you in my heart still more” — is the sound of a man being loved back into



a trap. The narrator closes the scene with the plainest possible verdict: “So spoke Athena, and led him on by her cunning” (κερδοσύνη). Nothing else any god does in the poem is this personal. ↩

14. (22.248-259) Hector’s compact: he has stopped running — “I will kill, or be killed” — and offers the war’s last treaty, with the gods as “witnesses and guardians of covenants”: the winner strips the armor and returns the body. It is the decent minimum of heroic war, the norm the whole Patroclus-sequence has been shredding; and he offers it to the one man in the poem for whom it is now unthinkable. ↩
15. (22.260-272) The refusal, in natural law: “As between lions and men there are no faithful oaths, and wolves and lambs do not carry hearts in concord... there will be no oaths — not before one or the other falls and gluts with his blood Ares, the fighter under the ox-hide shield” (the register’s phrase, 5.289 = 20.78 — now at its terminus). Achilles has left the covenant-species; he says so in genus terms. The taunt’s ledger — “in one payment, you settle all my grief” — makes Hector the invoice for every companion dead since Book 16. ↩

16. (22.273-295) The exchange of casts, rigged: Achilles misses — and Athena returns the spear “hidden from Hector, shepherd of the people” (the title never crueller than here, applied to the deceived). Hector’s speech at the false parity — “You missed!... You will plant no spear in my back as I run: drive it through my chest as I charge” — is magnificent precisely because it is obsolete: he thinks he is in a duel; he is in an execution with an intermission. His own cast hits mid-shield, true — against the shield of Hephaestus. Then: “he had no second ash spear,” and Deiphobus “was nowhere near him.” ↩

17. (22.296-305) The recognition. “So. The gods have called me deathward... Athena has tricked me. Now evil death is close to me — not far off now, and no way out.” Four lines from deception to acceptance, and then the sentence on which Hector’s whole meaning rests: “Then let me not die without a fight, without glory — no: having done some great thing first, for men to come to hear of” (ἔσσομένοισι πυθέσθαι — for those-to-be to learn). Cheated by heaven, out of weapons, out of brothers, he reorganizes in four heartbeats around the only future left: the story. It is the clearest statement in Greek of what heroism is for. ↩

18. (22.306-321) The last charge: Hector's eagle-stoop with the sword (the predator-simile returned to him for his final act — he dies attacking); Achilles' counter-charge behind the shield, the four-horned helmet, and Hesperus — “the most beautiful star that stands in heaven” — as the light of the spear-point “purposing evil.” The evening star: the day-clause of Zeus's plan, the sunset Hector was granted through, now rising as the gleam on the weapon that ends him. ↩
19. (22.322-330) The gap in the armor: Hector dies through Achilles' own stolen gear — “the beautiful armor he stripped from the might of Patroclus” — pierced at the one place it leaves open, the collarbones' notch, “the gullet — where the destruction of a life is quickest.” The borrowed-armor chain (16.793-804; Zeus's comment at 17.198-208) closes with precise irony: Patroclus's disguise becomes Hector's coffin, and its known gap the door. The spear spares the windpipe “so that he could still speak” — the poem granting itself the dying dialogue it needs, and saying so. ↩
20. (22.331-354) Triumph and plea. Achilles' first speech is the ledger (you thought you were safe; “I... have

unstrung your knees”), with the sentence-pair the whole corpse-war rests on: “You the dogs and the birds will drag and defile. Him the Achaeans will bury.” Hector, “his strength nearly gone,” begs by life, knees, parents — the full suppliant formula — for burial at any price; and the answer passes beyond the human: “I only wish the fury and the heart in me would drive me to hack away your flesh and eat it raw myself.” Not even Zeus’s scale of ransom — Hector’s weight in gold — would move him. The wish to eat the enemy is the *aristeia*’s terminal reading: Achilles has argued himself, by grief, to the edge of what the poem’s world can call a man. Book 24 exists because the poem cannot leave him there. ↩

21. (22.355-366) The dying prophecy and the double death. “I know you now... the heart in your chest is iron” — then the curse-warning: “that I not become the gods’ wrath (μήνιμα) upon you — on that day when Paris and Phoebus Apollo destroy you, brave as you are, at the Scaean Gates” — naming the god, the man, and the place (Xanthus’s “a god and a man,” 19.416-417, now specified; the gates are the very ones behind him). Then 361-363 repeat 16.855-857 verbatim, as the Greek repeats them — the soul-

flight couplet, “wailing its fate, leaving its manhood and its youth”: Patroclus and Hector go down through the same three lines, killer echoing killed. And Achilles answers the corpse with 18.115-116, kept verbatim: “Die. My own death-spirit I will accept whenever Zeus wills to accomplish it” — the acceptance he spoke to his mother, restated over the man whose death guarantees his own. ↩

22. (22.367-375) The stabbing-circle: the Achaeans running up to admire “the stature and the marvelous beauty of Hector — and not one man stood by him without a stab.” The anonymous soldier’s joke — “softer to the touch, this Hector, than when he burned the ships” (line 375 was athetized in antiquity) — is the war’s ugliest line, and true to armies: the terror of months paid out on a body that can no longer object. ↩

23. (22.376-394) Achilles’ speech breaks in half exactly where his mind does: strategy (probe the city — will it fall now?) collapsing mid-sentence into the register’s self-interruption (“But why does my own heart argue these things with me?” = 122 = 21.562 — the third use binds victor to victim: Hector’s phrase, in Achilles’ mouth, within four hundred lines). What

replaces strategy is Patroclus — “unwept, unbursed... And if in the house of Hades men forget their dead, even there I will remember my dear companion” — memory outlasting death itself. Then the paean-couplet (“we have killed brilliant Hector — the man the Trojans prayed to... as to a god”), athetized by Aristarchus, kept here: the poem needs the army’s song to set against what the next line does. ↩

24. (22.395-404) The outrage, in procedural detail: tendons pierced heel to ankle, oxhide straps, the head left to drag; the dust; “his dark hair spread wide around him; and in the dust lay all that head that was so beautiful before.” The narrator’s judgment is one clause wide and bottomless: “Zeus gave him to his enemies, to be defiled in his own fatherland” (ἐῖς ἐν πατρίδι γαίῃ) — the last three words doing what no exclamation could. ἀεικέα ἔργα, “foul work”: the poem names the deed and does not look away; its whole final book will be the undoing of these ten lines. ↩

25. (22.405-429) Troy’s grief begins with a simile of the end: the city’s wailing “most like this — as if the whole of beetling Ilion, top to bottom, were smouldering in fire.” Troy burns in the poem only

here — in a comparison: with Hector dead, the fall is now a fact of grammar, needing no narration. Priam in the dung, begging to go out to the ships, announces Book 24 entire: “I will beg this man... He too has a father — such a one as I am: Peleus.” The wish — “I wish he had died in my arms! Then the two of us could have glutted ourselves with weeping” — makes grief itself the feast (κορεσσάμεθα: the verb of eating one’s fill): the only satiety left to the old. ↩

26. (22.430-436) Hecuba’s lament is civic: Hector as “boast” and “blessing,” greeted “like a god” — the exact echo of the army’s paeon-line at 394, spoken now from the other wall: what the Achaeans sang as trophy, the mother sings as loss. Between the two uses, the poem holds its balance. ↩
27. (22.437-446) The most devastating dramatic irony in epic: Andromache “had not yet heard anything,” weaving flowers into a purple cloak — making beauty — and ordering the cauldron heated “for Hector, for his return out of the fighting. Poor innocent (νηπίη): she did not know that far from all baths grey-eyed Athena had broken him under the hands of Achilles.” The bath for the living that

becomes the bath for the dead (the washing of corpses) hovers unspoken; the narrator's νηπίη — the word for doomed unknowing children and soldiers all poem long — is spent here on its most undeserving bearer. ↩

28. (22.447-474) The recognition sequence, staged in the body before the mind: the shuttle drops; the heart “to my mouth”; knees frozen; her exact guess about his “grievous pride... he would never stay back in the crowd of men” (she knew him better than his own soliloquy did); the run “like a madwoman”; the sight from the wall — the horses dragging him “uncaring” (ἀκηδέστως — the word for funeral-neglect); night on her eyes. Then the fall’s one gesture: the head-dress flung off — frontlet, cap, woven band, “and the veil that golden Aphrodite gave her on the day Hector of the flashing helmet led her out of Eëtion’s house.” Widowhood performed as un-wedding: the marriage undone garment by garment in the sight of the city, at the news, before a word of lament is possible. ↩

29. (22.475-486) The lament’s opening: “To one fate, then, we were born, the two of us” — Troy and Thebe, Priam’s house and Eëtion’s, joined in a single doom



(her whole Book 6 biography compressed: the father who reared her “when I was little,” dead at Achilles’ hands with all her brothers — this is the second household Achilles has emptied for her). Its center is the child: “No help will you be to him, Hector — you are dead — nor he to you”: mutual uselessness as the measure of death, between father and infant son. ↩

30. (22.487-507) The orphan-passage, athetized by Aristarchus (487-499) as beneath the moment — kept here, because its smallness is the point. Andromache’s grief goes microscopically social: the seized fields; the bowed head and wet cheeks; the boy tugging at cloaks for charity; the friend’s cup lent “a moment: he wets his lips; his palate he does not wet” — the most exactly observed line about charity in ancient poetry; the beating at the feast (“No father of yours dines with us”). Against it, the pampered past — the marrow, the sheep’s fat, the nurse’s arms — and the name that has become a taunt: Astyanax, “lord of the city... for you alone guarded their gates and their long walls.” She is wrong about his future — the tradition kills him at the sack, thrown from these walls — and the poem lets her terrible modest fears stand as the mercy of not knowing worse. ↩

31. (22.508-515) The close: worms and dogs at the naked body “far away from your parents” — while at home the clothes lie “fine-woven and lovely, made by the hands of women.” Her one remaining act is the fire: to burn the unused garments — “no use to you: you will not lie in it — let it be your glory (κλέος) in the eyes of the men and women of Troy.” Kleos, the poem’s grand word — what Achilles traded his life for, what Hector died reorganizing himself around — is here a widow burning shirts: glory reduced to, and rescued as, a household rite performed in the absence of a body. “So she spoke, weeping; and the women wailed in answer” — the same close as Briseis’s lament (19.301-302, wording kept): the poem ends its greatest book on the sound it trusts most, the antiphony of grieving women — which is also how, two books from now, the whole Iliad will end. ↩

# Book 23

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*The ghost asks for burial and one last embrace;  
the pyre takes horses, dogs, and twelve men;  
and then — games: the army that has been  
killing for nine years spends a day competing  
for tripods and mares, quarreling justly,  
yielding handsomely, and laughing — while the  
man who arranged it all watches, having no  
future of his own.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1** So they mourned through the city. And the Achaeans,**1**
- 2** when they had come to the ships and the Hellespont,
- 3** scattered, each man to his own ship —

- 4 but Achilles would not let the  
Myrmidons scatter:
- 5 he spoke out among his war-loving  
companions:
- 6 “Myrmidons of the fast horses, my  
trusted companions,
- 7 let us not yet loose the single-hoofed  
horses from the cars:
- 8 with the very horses and chariots let us  
drive close
- 9 and mourn Patroclus: for that is the  
honor-right of the dead.
- 10 Then, when we have taken our fill of  
the deadly lament,
- 11 we will unyoke the horses, and all take  
supper here.”
- 12 So he spoke; and they wailed as one  
body, and Achilles led.
- 13 Three times around the corpse they

drove their well-maned horses,  
14 mourning; and among them Thetis  
stirred the desire of lament.  
15 The sands were wet, and the armor of  
the men was wet  
16 with tears: such a machine of rout they  
missed.  
17 And the son of Peleus led the thick  
lament among them,2  
18 laying his man-slaughtering hands on  
his companion's chest:  
19 "Rejoice, O Patroclus, even in the house  
of Hades:  
20 for now I am accomplishing all I  
promised you before —  
21 to drag Hector here and give him raw  
to the dogs,  
22 and before your pyre to cut the throats  
of twelve

23 shining children of the Trojans, in my  
rage at your slaying.”

24 He spoke, and devised foul work  
against brilliant Hector,

25 stretching him face-down in the dust  
beside the bier of Menoetius’s son.

26 And the men put off their armor, each  
his gear of glittering bronze,

27 and loosed their high-necked horses,  
and sat down beside the ship

28 of the swift-footed son of Aeacus, in  
their thousands;

29 and he set the funeral feast before  
them, to their hearts’ fill.

30 Many shining oxen bellowed around  
the iron

31 as their throats were cut, and many  
sheep and bleating goats;

32 and many white-tusked swine,

blooming with fat,  
33 were stretched to singe across the  
flame of Hephaestus;  
34 and everywhere around the corpse the  
blood ran in cupfuls.  
35 But the lord, the swift-footed son of  
Peleus —  
36 the kings of the Achaeans led him to  
brilliant Agamemnon,  
37 persuading him with effort, his heart  
still angry for his companion.  
38 And when they came in their going to  
Agamemnon's hut,  
39 at once they ordered the clear-voiced  
heralds  
40 to set a great tripod over the fire, in  
hope of persuading  
41 the son of Peleus to wash off the clotted  
gore.

42 But he refused them flatly, and swore  
an oath on it:  
43 “No — by Zeus, who is highest of the  
gods and best,  
44 it is not right that water come near this  
head  
45 before I lay Patroclus on the fire, and  
heap his mound,  
46 and cut my hair for him: since never a  
second time  
47 will such grief reach my heart, while I  
am among the living.  
48 For now — yes, let us yield to the  
hateful feast;  
49 and at dawn, lord of men Agamemnon,  
drive the men  
50 to bring in wood, and furnish all that is  
fitting  
51 for a dead man to have, going under the



murky dark,

52 so that untiring fire may burn him the  
sooner

53 out of our eyes, and the army turn back  
to its work.”

54 So he spoke; and they listened to him  
well, and obeyed.

55 Quickly, each company, they made the  
supper ready

56 and feasted; and no man’s appetite  
went short of the equal feast.

57 And when they had put away the desire  
for drink and food,

58 the rest went off to their rest, each  
man to his hut;

59 but the son of Peleus, on the shore of  
the loud-roaring sea,

60 lay groaning heavily, among his many  
Myrmidons,

61 in a clear space, where the waves  
washed up along the beach —  
62 until sleep took hold of him, loosening  
the cares of his heart,  
63 poured sweet around him: for his  
shining limbs were spent  
64 with chasing Hector toward windy  
Ilion.  
65 And there came to him the soul of  
unhappy Patroclus,<sup>4</sup>  
66 in everything like the man himself — in  
stature, and the beautiful  
67 eyes, and the voice; and the same  
clothes were on his body.  
68 He stood above his head, and spoke a  
word to him:  
69 “You sleep — and you have forgotten  
me, Achilles.  
70 You were never careless of me living —

only dead.

71 Bury me with all speed, and let me pass  
the gates of Hades.

72 The souls keep me at a distance — the  
images of the worn-out —

73 and they will not yet let me join them  
across the river:

74 I wander, just as I am, through the  
wide-gated house of Hades.

75 And give me your hand: I am weeping.  
Never again

76 shall I come back out of Hades, once  
you have given me my fire.

77 Never again in life shall we two sit  
apart

78 from our dear companions, making our  
plans. The hateful

79 death-spirit has gaped around me —  
the one allotted at my very birth.

80 And for you too the portion stands,  
Achilles like the gods:  
81 to die beneath the wall of the rich  
Trojans.  
82 And one thing more I will say, and  
charge you, if you will listen:  
83 do not lay my bones apart from yours,  
Achilles,  
84 but together — as we were raised  
together in your house,  
85 when Menoetius brought me, still a  
small boy,  
86 out of Opoeis to your country, for a  
grim killing:  
87 the day I killed the son of Amphidamas  
—  
88 a child's act; I did not mean it; I was  
angry over the dice.  
89 The horseman Peleus took me into his

house then,

90 and raised me with kindness, and  
named me your companion.

91 So let one vessel enfold the bones of us  
both —

92 the golden two-handled jar your lady  
mother gave you.”

93 Then in answer swift-footed Achilles  
spoke to him:5

94 “Why have you come to me here,  
beloved head,

95 and why do you charge me with all  
these things? For me,

96 I will accomplish everything, and bow  
to what you ask.

97 But stand nearer to me: even for a  
little, let us

98 put our arms around each other and  
take our fill of deadly lament.”

99 So speaking, he reached out with his  
own hands —  
100 and grasped nothing: the soul, like  
smoke, was gone  
101 under the earth, squeaking. And  
Achilles started up, astonished,  
102 and drove his hands together, and  
spoke the word of mourning:  
103 “Ah then — so there is, even in the  
house of Hades,  
104 a soul and an image — but the wits are  
not in it at all!  
105 All night long the soul of unhappy  
Patroclus  
106 stood over me, weeping and wailing,  
107 and charged me point by point — and  
it was marvelously like him.”  
108 So he spoke; and in them all he stirred  
the desire of lament;

109 and rosy-fingered Dawn shone out  
upon them still  
110 mourning around the pitiful corpse.  
And lord Agamemnon  
111 drove out the mules and men from  
every hut  
112 to bring in wood; and a good man  
oversaw them —  
113 Meriones, the aide of kind-hearted  
Idomeneus.  
114 They went out with woodcutters' axes  
in their hands  
115 and well-braided ropes; and the mules  
went on before them;  
116 and long they climbed — uphill,  
downhill, sidehill, slantwise.  
117 But when they came to the spurs of  
many-springed Ida,  
118 at once they set to felling the high-

crowned oaks

119 with the long-edged bronze, in haste;  
and with a great crashing

120 the trees came down. Then the  
Achaeans split them

121 and lashed them behind the mules;  
and these tore up the ground with their  
feet,

122 straining for the plain through the  
dense thickets.

123 And all the woodcutters carried logs:  
for so commanded

124 Meriones, the aide of kind-hearted  
Idomeneus.

125 They laid them down along the shore  
in rows, at the place

126 where Achilles planned the great  
mound for Patroclus — and for himself.<sup>6</sup>

127 And when they had laid down



measureless wood on every side,  
128 they sat where they were, all together,  
and waited. And Achilles  
129 at once commanded the war-loving  
Myrmidons  
130 to belt on their bronze, and each man  
yoke his horses;  
131 and they rose and got into their armor,  
132 and mounted their chariots, fighters  
and drivers both,  
133 the horsemen in front, and behind  
them followed a cloud of foot-soldiers,  
134 thousands; and in their midst his  
companions carried Patroclus,  
135 and they heaped the whole corpse  
with the locks of hair they cut  
136 and cast on him. And behind, brilliant  
Achilles held the head,  
137 grieving: a blameless companion he

was sending down to Hades.

138 And when they came to the place  
Achilles had appointed,

139 they set him down, and quickly piled  
the wood to his heart's fill.

140 Then swift-footed brilliant Achilles  
thought of one thing more:7

141 standing apart from the pyre, he cut  
the tawny lock

142 he had been growing long for the river  
Spercheius,

143 and troubled, he spoke, looking out on  
the wine-dark sea:

144 “Spercheius — for nothing did my  
father Peleus vow to you

145 that when I came home there, to my  
dear fatherland,

146 I would cut my hair for you, and offer  
a holy hecatomb,

147 and sacrifice fifty rams into your very  
sources,  
148 where your sacred plot and your  
smoking altar stand.  
149 So the old man vowed; and you did not  
accomplish his intent.  
150 Now — since I am not going home to  
my dear fatherland —  
151 let me give my hair to the hero  
Patroclus, to carry with him.”  
152 So speaking, he laid the hair in the  
hands of his dear  
153 companion; and in them all he stirred  
the desire of lament.  
154 And the light of the sun would have  
gone down on their mourning  
155 had not Achilles quickly stepped to  
Agamemnon’s side:  
156 “Son of Atreus — you are the man

whose word the army

157 most obeys. Of lament there can be fill  
enough.

158 Disperse them now from the pyre; tell  
them to make

159 their meal. We to whom the dead is  
nearest care

160 will labor at the rest; and let the  
leaders stay beside us.”

161 Now when the lord of men  
Agamemnon heard him,<sup>8</sup>

162 at once he dispersed the army among  
the balanced ships;

163 and the mourners of the closest care  
stayed there and heaped the wood,

164 and made a pyre a hundred feet this  
way and that,

165 and on the pyre’s height they laid the  
corpse, grieving at heart.

166 Many fat sheep and shambling twist-  
horned cattle  
167 they flayed and dressed before the  
pyre; and from them all  
168 great-hearted Achilles took the fat,  
and wrapped the corpse  
169 from head to foot, and heaped the  
flayed carcasses around him.  
170 And he set two-handled jars of honey  
and of oil  
171 leaning against the bier; and four  
strong-necked horses  
172 he flung on the pyre with violence,  
groaning aloud.  
173 Nine dogs the lord had, fed from his  
table;  
174 and of these he cut the throats of two,  
and flung them on;  
175 and twelve noble sons of the great-

hearted Trojans

176 he butchered with the bronze — and  
evil was the work his heart intended —

177 and into it all he threw the iron  
strength of fire, to feed.

178 Then he wailed aloud, and called his  
dear companion by name:

179 “Rejoice, O Patroclus, even in the  
house of Hades:

180 for now I am accomplishing all I  
promised you before.

181 Twelve noble sons of the great-  
hearted Trojans —

182 the fire is eating all of them with you.  
But Hector,

183 Priam’s son, I will not give to the fire  
to feed on — but to the dogs.”

184 So he spoke, threatening. But the dogs  
did not deal with Hector:

185 the daughter of Zeus, Aphrodite, kept  
the dogs from him  
186 by day and by night, and anointed him  
with oil of roses,  
187 ambrosial, so the dragging would not  
tear him;  
188 and Phoebus Apollo drew a dark-blue  
cloud  
189 down from heaven to the plain, and  
covered all the ground  
190 the corpse lay over, so the sun's  
strength would not  
191 wither the flesh too soon on his sinews  
and limbs.  
192 But the pyre of dead Patroclus would  
not kindle.<sup>9</sup>  
193 Then swift-footed brilliant Achilles  
thought of one thing more:  
194 standing apart from the pyre, he

prayed to the two winds,  
195 Boreas and Zephyrus, and promised  
them fine offerings;  
196 and pouring many libations from a  
golden cup he begged them  
197 to come, so the dead would blaze up in  
the fire  
198 with all speed, and the wood take  
flame. And quickly Iris,  
199 hearing his prayers, went messenger  
to the winds.  
200 They were all indoors at the house of  
gusting Zephyrus,  
201 feasting at a banquet, when Iris came  
running  
202 and stood on the stone threshold. And  
the moment their eyes saw her  
203 they all sprang up, and each one  
called her to himself.



204 But she refused to sit, and said her  
word:  
205 “No seat for me: I am away over the  
streams of Ocean  
206 to the Aethiopians’ land, where they  
are offering hecatombs  
207 to the immortals — so I too may share  
the feast.  
208 But Achilles is praying to Boreas and  
loud Zephyrus  
209 to come, and he promises you fine  
offerings,  
210 so you may rouse the pyre to burning,  
where lies  
211 Patroclus, whom all the Achaeans  
mourn aloud.”  
212 So speaking she went her way; and  
they rose up  
213 with an unearthly roar, driving the

clouds in rout before them.

214 Quickly they came to the sea, to blow  
across it, and the wave

215 swelled under their shrill blast; and  
they reached deep-soiled Troy

216 and fell upon the pyre; and the  
unearthly fire howled huge.

217 All night long together they beat the  
flame of the pyre,

218 blowing shrill; and all night long swift  
Achilles,

219 taking a two-handled cup from a  
golden bowl,

220 drew wine and poured it on the  
ground, and soaked the earth,

221 calling upon the soul of unhappy  
Patroclus.

222 As a father mourns, burning the bones  
of his son,

223 a bridegroom, whose death has  
grieved his unhappy parents:  
224 so Achilles mourned, burning the  
bones of his companion,  
225 dragging himself around the pyre,  
groaning without pause.  
226 At the hour the morning star goes  
forth to herald light over the earth,  
227 and behind it Dawn in her saffron robe  
spreads out across the sea,  
228 at that hour the pyre died down, and  
the flame was done.  
229 And the winds set out again, to go  
back home  
230 across the Thracian sea; and it  
groaned, seething with swell.  
231 And the son of Peleus turned a little  
from the burning-place  
232 and lay down, worn out; and sweet

sleep leapt upon him.

233 But the others gathered in a body  
around the son of Atreus,

234 and the noise and tramp of their  
coming woke him;

235 and he sat upright, and spoke his word  
to them:

236 “Son of Atreus, and you other chiefs of  
all the Achaeans:10

237 first quench the burning-place with  
glistening wine,

238 all of it, wherever the fire’s strength  
has reached. Then

239 let us gather the bones of Patroclus,  
Menoetius’s son,

240 telling them apart well — and they are  
easily known:

241 he lay in the middle of the pyre; the  
others burned apart,

242 at the edge, horses and men together.  
243 And let us lay his bones in a golden  
vessel, in a double  
244 fold of fat, until I myself am hidden in  
Hades.  
245 And no huge mound do I ask you to  
labor over —  
246 a seemly one, no more. Then  
afterward the Achaeans  
247 may build it wide and high — you who  
are left  
248 behind me in the many-benched  
ships.”  
249 So he spoke; and they obeyed the  
swift-footed son of Peleus.  
250 First they quenched the burning-place  
with glistening wine,  
251 far as the flame had gone, and the ash  
had settled deep;

252 and weeping, they gathered the white  
bones of their kindly companion  
253 into a golden vessel, in a double fold  
of fat,  
254 and laid it in the hut, and covered it  
with soft linen;  
255 and they drew the circle of the  
mound, and set its footing-stones  
256 around the pyre, and heaped the piled  
earth over it;  
257 and when they had heaped the  
mound, they turned to go. But Achilles  
258 held the army there, and sat them in a  
wide assembly,  
259 and out of the ships he brought his  
prizes: cauldrons and tripods,  
260 and horses and mules and strong  
heads of oxen,  
261 and deep-girdled women, and grey

iron.

262 For the swift charioteers first he set  
out shining prizes:11

263 a woman skilled in blameless work, to  
lead away,

264 and an eared tripod holding twenty-  
two measures —

265 these for the first man; and for the  
second he set a mare,

266 six years old, unbroken, carrying a  
mule foal;

267 and for the third he set down a  
cauldron untouched by fire,

268 a beautiful one, holding four  
measures, white as new;

269 and for the fourth he set out two  
talents of gold;

270 and for the fifth, a two-handled bowl  
untouched by flame.

271 Then he stood upright, and spoke his  
word among the Argives:  
272 “Son of Atreus, and you other strong-  
greaved Achaeans:12  
273 these prizes lie in the gathering,  
waiting for the charioteers.  
274 If we Achaeans were competing now  
for any other man,  
275 I would take the first prize myself, and  
carry it to my hut:  
276 you know how far my horses surpass  
all others in their worth —  
277 for they are immortal: Poseidon gave  
them  
278 to my father Peleus, and he passed  
them into my hands.  
279 But I will stay aside, I and my single-  
hoofed horses:  
280 such is the driver whose glory they



have lost —

281 the gentle one, who so many times  
poured smooth oil

282 down their manes, when he had  
washed them in shining water.

283 They stand and mourn him now; their  
manes trail

284 on the ground; they stand with grief  
in their hearts.

285 But the rest of you make ready  
through the army — whoever

286 of the Achaeans trusts his horses and  
his bolted car.”

287 So spoke the son of Peleus, and the  
swift charioteers gathered.13

288 Up first, far first, rose Eumelus, lord of  
men,

289 Admetus’s dear son, supreme in  
horsemanship;

290 and after him rose Tydeus's son,  
strong Diomedes,  
291 and led under the yoke the horses of  
Tros, which he once  
292 stripped from Aeneas — though  
Apollo saved the man himself;  
293 and after him rose Atreus's son, fair-  
haired Menelaus,  
294 the Zeus-born, and led beneath the  
yoke two swift horses —  
295 Aethe, Agamemnon's mare, and his  
own Podargus.  
296 Her Echepolus, Anchises' son, gave to  
Agamemnon  
297 as a gift, so he need not follow him to  
windy Ilion  
298 but stay at home and take his ease: for  
Zeus had given him  
299 great wealth, and he lived in Sicyon of

the wide dancing-floors.

300 Her Menelaus led beneath the yoke,  
athirst for the running.

301 And fourth, Antilochus made ready his  
well-maned horses —

302 the shining son of Nestor, the great-  
hearted lord,

303 Neleus's son; and horses bred in Pylos

304 drew his car, quick-footed. And his  
father, standing by him,

305 spoke good counsel to a son who knew  
it for himself:

306 “Antilochus — young as you are, Zeus  
and Poseidon

307 have loved you, and taught you  
horsemanship

308 of every kind. So there is no great  
need to teach you:

309 you know well how to wheel the

turning-post. But your horses

310 are the slowest in the running; so I  
expect a sorry business.

311 Their horses are faster — but the men  
themselves

312 do not know more of cunning than  
you do.

313 Come then, dear boy: lay up cunning  
in your heart,

314 cunning of every kind, so the prizes do  
not slip past you.

315 By cunning, far more than by force, is  
the woodcutter better;

316 by cunning the helmsman on the  
wine-dark sea

317 holds his swift ship on course when  
the winds are tearing at it;

318 by cunning charioteer outdoes  
charioteer.

319 One man, trusting in his horses and  
his car,  
320 swings wide, mindlessly, this way and  
that,  
321 and his horses wander down the  
course, and he cannot hold them.  
322 But the man who knows his  
advantages, driving lesser horses,  
323 keeps his eye on the post and turns it  
close, and never forgets  
324 how much rein of oxhide to give at the  
start —  
325 he holds his line securely, and watches  
the man in front.  
326 And the mark itself I will tell you —  
plain to see; you cannot miss it.  
327 A dry stump stands there, a fathom  
high above the ground,  
328 of oak or of pine, not rotted by the

rain,

329 and two white stones are set against  
it, one on either side,

330 at the joining of the track; and around  
it the racing-ground is smooth.

331 Either it is the grave-mark of a man  
dead long ago,

332 or it was set for a turning-post by men  
before our time;

333 and now swift-footed brilliant Achilles  
has made it the goal.

334 Drive your car and horses grazing  
hard against it,

335 and lean your own body, in the well-  
plaited chariot,

336 a little to their left; and the right-  
hand horse —

337 goad him and call to him, and give  
him rein from your hands.

338 And let your left-hand horse graze the  
post so close  
339 that the hub of the well-wrought  
wheel seems to touch  
340 its very edge — but take care not to  
catch the stone,  
341 or you will wound the horses and  
wreck the car:  
342 joy for the others, and reproach for  
you.  
343 Dear boy — keep your wits about you;  
be watchful.  
344 For if at the turn you slip past them in  
your pursuit,  
345 there is no man who will catch you  
with a lunge, or pass you —  
346 not though he drove brilliant Arion  
behind you,  
347 Adrastus's swift horse, whose line was

from the gods,  
348 or the horses of Laomedon, best of the  
breed reared here.”  
349 So speaking, Nestor Neleus’s son sat  
back down in his place,  
350 when he had told his son the  
essentials of each thing.  
351 And Meriones was the fifth to make  
ready his well-maned horses.14  
352 They mounted their chariots, and cast  
in their lots;  
353 and Achilles shook them, and out  
sprang the lot of Nestor’s son,  
354 Antilochus; and after him lord  
Eumelus drew;  
355 and after him Atreus’s son, spear-  
famed Menelaus;  
356 and after him Meriones drew his place  
to drive; and last of all



357 the son of Tydeus, far the best of  
them, drew his place to drive.  
358 They stood in line; and Achilles  
showed them the turn-post,  
359 far off on the level plain; and beside it  
he set an umpire,  
360 godlike Phoenix, his own father's  
follower,  
361 to keep the running in memory, and  
report the truth.  
362 Then all of them together raised the  
lash over their horses,  
363 and struck with the reins, and shouted  
them on with words,  
364 furiously; and they swept fast across  
the plain,  
365 away from the ships; and under their  
chests the dust  
366 hung, rising like a cloud or a

stormwind,

367 and their manes streamed back on the  
rush of the wind.

368 And the chariots now hugged the  
earth that feeds many,

369 now leapt bounding high in the air;  
and the drivers

370 stood in the cars, and each man's  
heart was pounding

371 in his hunger for victory; and each one  
called to his horses,

372 and they flew through the dust of the  
plain.

373 But when the swift horses were  
running the last of the course<sup>15</sup>

374 back toward the grey sea, then each  
man's worth

375 showed itself, and the pace stretched  
them flat out; and quickly

376 the swift-footed mares of Pheres'  
grandson shot ahead,  
377 and behind them the stallions of  
Diomedes, the horses of Tros,  
378 ran close — not far at all, but hard  
upon him:  
379 they seemed forever on the point of  
mounting his chariot,  
380 and their breath was hot on the back  
and broad shoulders  
381 of Eumelus: their heads were laid right  
on him as they flew.  
382 And now he would have passed him,  
or made it a dead heat,  
383 had not Phoebus Apollo been angry  
with Tydeus's son  
384 and dashed the shining whip out of  
his hands.  
385 Then the tears of rage sprang from his

eyes: he saw

386 the mares going better still — better  
and better —

387 while his own pair faltered, running  
without the goad.

388 But Apollo's cheating of the son of  
Tydeus did not

389 slip past Athena: she swept after the  
shepherd of the people,

390 gave him back his whip, and put fury  
in his horses;

391 and after Admetus's son she went in  
her anger

392 and shattered — a goddess — his  
horses' yoke; and his mares

393 ran out to either side of the road, and  
the pole slewed to the ground,

394 and he himself was tumbled out of the  
car beside the wheel,

395 and the skin was ripped from his  
elbows, his mouth, his nostrils,  
396 and his forehead bruised above the  
brows; and his eyes  
397 filled up with tears, and the strong  
voice stuck in his throat.  
398 And the son of Tydeus swung his  
single-hoofed horses past him,  
399 leaping far out in front of the rest: for  
Athena  
400 had put fury in his horses, and set the  
glory on him.  
401 And after him came Atreus's son, fair-  
haired Menelaus.  
402 But Antilochus called to his father's  
horses:16  
403 "Get in there, you two as well! Stretch  
out — as fast as you can!  
404 I am not telling you to race with those

in front —

405 the horses of war-minded Tydeus's  
son, to whom Athena

406 has just now given speed, and set the  
glory on their driver.

407 But catch the horses of Atreus's son —  
don't be left behind them! —

408 quickly — or Aethe will pour shame  
over the two of you:

409 a female! Why are you falling behind,  
my braves?

410 For I will tell you this, and it will be  
accomplished:

411 there will be no more care for you two  
at the hands of Nestor,

412 shepherd of the people — he will cut  
your throats on the spot

413 with the sharp bronze, if by your  
slacking we carry off the lesser prize.

414 After them! Press hard — fast as you  
can!

415 And I myself will devise it and manage  
it —

416 a way to slip past in the narrow of the  
road. It will not escape me.”

417 So he spoke; and in dread at their  
master’s rebuke

418 they ran the harder for a little while;  
and quickly then

419 Antilochus, staunch in battle, saw the  
narrows of the sunken road.

420 There was a break in the ground,  
where winter-gathered water

421 had torn away the track and hollowed  
the whole place deep;

422 there Menelaus held his line, shy of  
fouling wheels;

423 but Antilochus swerved his single-

hoofed horses and drove

424 outside the track, and pressed him  
hard, bearing in a little.

425 And the son of Atreus was afraid, and  
shouted to Antilochus:

426 “Antilochus — this is mad driving!  
Hold in your horses!

427 The road is narrow here — it widens  
soon for passing —

428 you’ll wreck the both of us, fouling my  
car!”

429 So he spoke; but Antilochus drove all  
the harder,

430 laying on the goad, like a man who  
had not heard.

431 As far as the swing of a discus flung  
from the shoulder,

432 hurled by a young man testing the  
strength of his youth,



433 so far they ran on together; and then  
the mares of Atreus's son  
434 dropped back: he slackened his  
driving by his own will,  
435 for fear the single-hoofed horses  
would collide in the road  
436 and overturn the well-plaited cars,  
and the men themselves  
437 go down in the dust for all their  
straining after victory.  
438 And fair-haired Menelaus called after  
him in rebuke:  
439 "Antilochus — no mortal man alive is  
more ruinous than you!  
440 Go, and be damned — we Achaeans  
were wrong to call you sane.  
441 But even so, you shall not carry off the  
prize without an oath."  
442 So he spoke, and called out to his

horses:

443 “Don’t hang back on me now, don’t  
stand there grieving!

444 Their feet and knees will tire before  
yours do:

445 the pair of them are past their youth.”

446 So he spoke; and in dread at their  
master’s rebuke

447 they ran the harder, and quickly  
closed the gap.

448 Meanwhile the Argives, sitting in the  
assembly, watched<sup>17</sup>

449 for the horses; and these came flying  
through the dust of the plain.

450 And the first to make them out was  
Idomeneus, leader of the Cretans:

451 for he sat outside the gathering,  
highest up, on a lookout;

452 and hearing the voice of a driver

shouting, far off as he was,  
453 he knew it; and he made out a horse,  
clear in the lead,  
454 chestnut over all the rest of him,  
except that on his forehead  
455 a white blaze was set, round as the full  
moon.  
456 And he stood upright, and spoke his  
word among the Argives:  
457 “Friends — leaders and counselors of  
the Argives —  
458 am I the only one who sees the horses,  
or do you see them too?  
459 Other horses seem to me to be in front  
now —  
460 another driver shows. The mares  
must have come to grief  
461 out on the plain — the ones that led  
on the way out:

462 I saw them rounding the turn-post  
first,  
463 and now I cannot see them anywhere,  
though my eyes  
464 go searching everywhere across the  
Trojan plain.  
465 Did the reins escape their driver, so he  
could not  
466 hold them well around the post, and  
failed to make the turn?  
467 He was thrown out there, I think, and  
the chariot wrecked,  
468 and the mares bolted off the course,  
their hearts gone wild.  
469 But stand up and look for yourselves: I  
cannot  
470 make it out for certain. The man in  
front seems to me  
471 to be Aetolian by birth — and a lord

among the Argives —

472 the son of horse-taming Tydeus,  
strong Diomedes.”

473 Then swift Ajax, Oileus’s son, rounded  
on him shamefully:

474 “Idomeneus — why this blather before  
the time? The mares

475 are far away still, sweeping the wide  
plain.

476 You are not so much the youngest  
among the Argives,

477 and the eyes in your head are not the  
sharpest lookers —

478 yet you are always blathering. There is  
no need for you

479 to blather here: better men than you  
are present.

480 The mares in front are the same that  
led before —

481 Eumelus's; and it is he who stands  
there holding the reins."  
482 And the leader of the Cretans  
answered him in anger:  
483 "Ajax — champion of insult, wit of  
straw — in all things else  
484 you are least of the Argives: your  
mind is a stubborn mind.  
485 Come then: let us wager a tripod or a  
cauldron,  
486 and let us both make Agamemnon,  
Atreus's son, our judge —  
487 whose mares are in front. You will  
learn as you pay."  
488 So he spoke; and at once swift Ajax,  
Oileus's son,  
489 rose up in anger to answer with hard  
words —  
490 and the quarrel between the two

would have gone further,  
491 had not Achilles himself stood up, and  
said his word:  
492 “No longer answer each other with  
hard words,  
493 Ajax — Idomeneus — with evil words:  
it is not seemly.  
494 You would be indignant at another  
man who acted so.  
495 Sit down in the gathering, and watch  
496 for the horses: they are straining for  
victory, and they  
497 will be here soon enough. Then each  
of you can know  
498 the Argive horses — who is behind,  
and who in front.”  
499 So he spoke — and the son of Tydeus  
came driving in nearly upon them, 18  
500 laying on the whip down from the

shoulder, stroke on stroke; and his horses  
501 lifted high, going fast, devouring the  
way.

502 And the spatters of dust rained  
without pause on the driver,

503 and the chariot, plated with gold and  
tin,

504 ran hard on the heels of the quick-  
footed horses — and behind them

505 the tires left hardly a trace of wheel-  
track

506 in the fine dust: the pair of them flew,  
straining.

507 He pulled up in the middle of the  
gathering, the sweat

508 streaming to the ground from his  
horses' necks and chests;

509 and he himself leapt to the ground  
from his shining car



510 and leaned the whip against the yoke.  
Nor did strong Sthenelus  
511 delay: he seized the prize at once,  
eagerly,  
512 and gave the woman to his high-  
hearted companions to lead,  
513 and the eared tripod to carry; and he  
loosed the horses from the yoke.  
514 Next after him Antilochus of Neleus's  
line drove in his horses —19  
515 by craft, not speed at all, he had  
slipped past Menelaus;  
516 yet even so Menelaus held his swift  
horses close behind.  
517 As far as a horse stands from the  
wheel, when he strains  
518 drawing his master over the plain with  
the chariot,  
519 and the tips of his tail-hairs brush

against the tire,  
520 for he runs close in front, and there is  
little space between  
521 as he sweeps the wide plain:  
522 so far was Menelaus behind blameless  
Antilochus —  
523 though at first he was left a discus-  
throw behind,  
524 he was catching him fast: the fine fury  
of Aethe,  
525 Agamemnon's lovely-maned mare,  
was rising still;  
526 and had the course run longer for the  
two of them,  
527 he would have passed him clean,  
beyond dispute.  
528 And Meriones, the good aide of  
Idomeneus,  
529 came in a spear-cast behind famed

Menelaus:

530 for his lovely-maned horses were the  
slowest of them all,

531 and he himself the least of them at  
driving in a race.

532 And Admetus's son came last of all the  
others,

533 dragging his beautiful chariot, driving  
his horses before him.

534 And swift-footed brilliant Achilles saw  
him, and pitied him, 20

535 and stood among the Argives and  
spoke winged words:

536 "Last comes the best man, driving his  
single-hoofed horses.

537 Come, let us give him a prize, as is  
fitting —

538 the second; and let the son of Tydeus  
carry off the first."

539 So he spoke; and they all approved  
what he commanded.

540 And now he would have given him the  
mare — for the Achaeans approved —

541 had not Antilochus, great-hearted  
Nestor's son,

542 stood up and answered Achilles,  
Peleus's son, with a claim of right:

543 "Achilles, I will be very angry with you  
if you accomplish

544 this word: for you mean to take away  
my prize,

545 weighing this — that his chariot came  
to grief, and his swift horses,

546 and he himself a good man. But he  
should have prayed

547 to the immortals: then he would not  
have come in last of all.

548 If you pity him, and he is dear to your

heart,

549 there is gold in plenty in your hut, and  
there is bronze,

550 and sheep and goats, and there are  
slave-women and single-hoofed horses:

551 take from those, and give him  
afterward an even greater prize —

552 or right now, this moment — and the  
Achaeans will applaud you.

553 But the mare I will not give up. For  
her, let any man

554 who wants her try me — hand to  
hand.”

555 So he spoke; and swift-footed brilliant  
Achilles smiled,

556 delighting in Antilochus, because he  
was his dear companion;

557 and in answer he spoke winged words  
to him:

558 “Antilochus — if you would have me  
give Eumelus  
559 some other thing from my stores, that  
too I will do.  
560 I will give him the corslet I stripped  
from Asteropaeus —  
561 bronze, with a casting of shining tin  
562 run round it. It will be worth much to  
him.”  
563 He spoke, and told Automedon, his  
dear companion,  
564 to bring it from the hut; and he went  
and brought it,  
565 and laid it in Eumelus’s hands; and he  
received it, rejoicing.  
566 Then Menelaus also rose among them,  
grieved at heart, 21  
567 angry past soothing at Antilochus.  
And the herald

568 put the staff into his hand, and called  
the Argives

569 to silence; and then that man like a  
god spoke out:

570 “Antilochus — you who had good  
sense before — what have you done?

571 You have shamed my skill and fouled  
my horses,

572 throwing your own in front, which  
were far the worse.

573 Come then, leaders and counselors of  
the Argives:

574 judge between the two of us — and no  
favor either way —

575 so no man of the bronze-shirted  
Achaean ever says:

576 ‘Menelaus beat Antilochus down with  
lies

577 and went off leading the mare — his

horses were far the worse,  
578 but he himself the greater in rank and  
power.’  
579 Or come — I will judge it myself; and I  
say no other  
580 Danaan will fault the judgment: it will  
be straight.  
581 Antilochus — come here, Zeus-  
nurtured, as the custom stands:  
582 stand in front of your horses and your  
chariot, take in your hand  
583 the slender whip you drove with,  
584 lay your hand on your horses, and  
swear by the earth-upholder,  
585 the earth-shaker, that you did not foul  
my car by deliberate craft.”  
586 Then in his turn sound-minded  
Antilochus answered him:  
587 “Bear with me now: I am far younger



588 than you, lord Menelaus — you are the  
elder, and the better man.

589 You know how a young man's  
trespasses come about:

590 his mind is the quicker, but his  
judgment thin.

591 So let your heart endure it. The mare I  
won —

592 I give her to you myself. And if you  
asked of me some greater thing

593 from my own stores besides, I would  
choose to give it to you

594 at once, this moment, Zeus-nurtured  
— rather than fall

595 out of your favor all my days, and be  
wrong before the gods.”

596 So spoke great-hearted Nestor's son,  
and led the mare

597 and put her into Menelaus's hands.

And that man's heart  
598 was warmed like the dew about the  
ears of ripening corn,  
599 when the fields are bristling: so,  
Menelaus,  
600 was the heart in your chest warmed  
within you.  
601 And he spoke to him in answer winged  
words:  
602 "Antilochus — now I will yield to you  
myself, out of my anger:  
603 for you were never scattered or light  
of mind before.  
604 This once, youth got the better of  
your judgment;  
605 the next time, take care not to  
outscheme your betters.  
606 No other man of the Achaeans would  
have soothed me quickly —

607 but you have suffered much, and  
labored much for my sake,  
608 you and your good father and your  
brother.  
609 So I will be persuaded by your plea;  
and the mare —  
610 mine though she is, I will give her to  
you — so these men too may know  
611 that my heart was never overbearing  
and unbending.”  
612 He spoke, and gave the mare to  
Noëmon, Antilochus’s  
613 companion, to lead away; and took for  
himself the shining cauldron.  
614 And Meriones took up the two talents  
of gold,  
615 fourth, as he had driven. But the fifth  
prize was left over —  
616 the two-handled bowl. Achilles gave it

to Nestor,

617 carrying it to him across the gathering  
of the Argives, and said:

618 “Here, old man. Let this be a treasure  
laid away for you,22

619 a memorial of the burial of Patroclus:  
for never again

620 will you see him among the Argives. I  
give you this prize

621 outright: for you will not box, and you  
will not wrestle,

622 nor enter for the javelins, nor race

623 on foot: the hard weight of age is on  
you now.”

624 So speaking, he laid it in his hands;  
and he received it, rejoicing,

625 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:

626 “Yes, child — all this you have said

aright.

627 My limbs are no longer sound, dear  
friend — my feet — nor do my arms

628 swing light from my shoulders on  
either side.

629 Would that I were young, and my  
strength as firm

630 as when the Epeians buried lord  
Amarynceus

631 at Buprasium, and his sons set out the  
king's prizes.

632 There no man proved my equal — not  
of the Epeians,

633 not of the Pylians themselves, not of  
the great-hearted Aetolians.

634 In boxing I beat Clytomedes, Enops's  
son;

635 at wrestling, Ancaeus of Pleuron, who  
stood up against me;

636 Iphiclus I outran on foot, good runner  
though he was;  
637 and with the spear I out-threw  
Phyleus and Polydorus.  
638 Only with the horses did the two sons  
of Actor pass me —  
639 crowding ahead by force of numbers,  
grudging me the victory,  
640 because the biggest prizes had been  
left for the horses.  
641 They were twins: one held the reins —  
held the reins  
642 for good and all — while the other laid  
on the whip.  
643 Such I was once. Now let younger men  
take on  
644 such labors: I must bow to grim old  
age —  
645 though in my day I shone among the

heroes.

646 But go: honor your companion too  
with funeral games.

647 This gift I receive gladly, and my heart  
rejoices

648 that you remember me always as your  
kindly friend, and never forget

649 the honor with which it is fitting I be  
honored among the Achaeans.

650 And may the gods, in return, grant  
you grace to your heart's fill."

651 So he spoke; and the son of Peleus  
went back through the great

652 crowd of Achaeans, when he had  
heard out all the praise of Neleus's son.

653 Then he set out the prizes for the  
punishing fist-fight:23

654 a hard-working mule he led out and  
tethered in the gathering,

655 six years old, unbroken — the hardest  
kind to break;

656 and for the beaten man he set a two-  
handled cup.

657 Then he stood upright, and spoke his  
word among the Argives:

658 “Son of Atreus, and you other strong-  
greaved Achaeans:

659 for these we summon two men — the  
best there are —

660 to put up their fists and trade blows.  
The man to whom Apollo

661 grants endurance, and all the  
Achaeans acknowledge it,

662 let him lead the hard-working mule  
away to his hut;

663 and the beaten man carries off the  
two-handled cup.”

664 So he spoke; and at once a man rose



up, huge and strong,  
665 skilled in fist-fighting — Epeius,  
Panopeus's son;  
666 and he laid a hand on the hard-  
working mule, and said:  
667 "Step up, whoever wants to carry off  
the two-handled cup:  
668 the mule — I say no other Achaean is  
taking her  
669 by winning with his fists. I claim to be  
the best.  
670 Is it not enough that I fall short in  
battle? There was never a way,  
671 it seems, for one man to be skilled in  
every work there is.  
672 For I tell you this, and it will be  
accomplished:  
673 I will split his skin clean open and  
stave his bones in.

674 Let his next of kin stand waiting here  
in a body  
675 to carry him out when my fists have  
finished him.”  
676 So he spoke; and they all fell silent,  
stilled.  
677 Euryalus alone stood up to face him, a  
man like a god,  
678 son of lord Mecisteus, Talaus’s son,  
679 who once came to Thebes for the  
burial of fallen  
680 Oedipus, and there beat all the sons of  
Cadmus.  
681 And Tydeus’s spear-famed son busied  
himself about him,  
682 cheering him with words, wanting the  
victory for him badly.  
683 First he threw down the girdle for  
him, and then

684 he gave him the well-cut thongs of a  
field-ranging ox.  
685 Girded, the two men strode into the  
middle of the gathering,  
686 and squaring up, both at once, with  
their heavy hands,  
687 they fell on each other, and their  
heavy fists mixed.  
688 Terrible was the grinding of jaws, and  
the sweat ran  
689 everywhere off their limbs. And  
brilliant Epeius rose to it:  
690 as the other glanced for an opening,  
he struck him on the cheek,  
691 and he could stand no longer: there  
his shining limbs went down.  
692 As under the North Wind's shiver a  
fish leaps up  
693 on the weed-strewn shallows, and the

black wave hides it again:

694 so he leapt at the blow. But great-  
hearted Epeius

695 took him in his hands and set him  
upright; and his own companions

696 crowded round and led him through  
the gathering, feet trailing,

697 spitting thick blood, his head lolling to  
one side;

698 and they sat him down among them,  
wits astray,

699 and went themselves and fetched the  
two-handled cup.

700 Then the son of Peleus set out at once,  
and showed the Danaans, 24

701 a third set of prizes, for the punishing  
wrestling:

702 for the winner a great tripod made to  
stand over fire —

703 the Achaeans among themselves  
priced it at twelve oxen —  
704 and for the beaten man he put a  
woman in their midst,  
705 skilled in many kinds of work; they  
priced her at four oxen.  
706 And he stood upright, and spoke his  
word among the Argives:  
707 “Up — you two who will make trial of  
this prize.”  
708 So he spoke; and then great  
Telamonian Ajax rose,  
709 and resourceful Odysseus stood up,  
the knower of advantages.  
710 Girded, the two men strode into the  
middle of the gathering  
711 and grappled each other arm on arm  
with their heavy hands,  
712 like the gable-rafters a famous builder

joins

713 in a high house, to baffle the strength  
of the winds.

714 Their backs creaked under the  
stubborn hauling

715 of bold hands; and the wet sweat ran  
down;

716 and welts thick and many along their  
ribs and shoulders

717 sprang up red with blood; and always  
they

718 strained for victory, and the wrought  
tripod;

719 and Odysseus could not trip him and  
bring him to the ground,

720 nor could Ajax — the strong build of  
Odysseus held.

721 But when they began to weary the  
strong-greaved Achaeans,

722 then great Telamonian Ajax said to  
him:

723 “Zeus-born son of Laertes, Odysseus of  
many devices:

724 lift me — or I lift you. And the rest will  
be Zeus’s business.”

725 So speaking he heaved him up. But  
Odysseus did not forget his craft:

726 he caught him with a kick behind the  
knee, and unstrung his limbs,

727 and threw him backward, and fell on  
his chest

728 himself. The watching army marveled  
at it.

729 Second, much-enduring brilliant  
Odysseus heaved in his turn,

730 and budged him a little off the ground  
— but could not lift him —

731 and hooked his knee inside; and both

went down together

732 close in each other's grip, and were  
fouled with dust.

733 And now they would have sprung up  
and wrestled a third fall,

734 had not Achilles himself risen, and  
held them back:

735 "Strain against each other no more.  
Do not wear yourselves out with pain.

736 Victory to you both. Take equal prizes  
737 and go — so the other Achaeans may  
compete."

738 So he spoke; and they listened to him  
well, and obeyed,

739 and wiped away the dust, and put  
their tunics on.

740 Then the son of Peleus set out at once  
the prizes for the foot-race:25

741 a mixing-bowl of silver, a worked



piece: six measures

742 it held, and in beauty it outdid all  
others on earth

743 by far, since craftsmen of Sidon, the  
cunning-handed, made it well,

744 and Phoenician men carried it over  
the misty sea,

745 set it up in harbor, and gave it as a gift  
to Thoas;

746 and Euneus, Jason's son, gave it as the  
price of Lycaon,

747 Priam's son, to the hero Patroclus.

748 This too Achilles set out as a prize for  
his companion —

749 for the man who should prove the  
lightest on his quick feet;

750 for the second again he set out an ox,  
big and heavy with fat;

751 and a half-talent of gold he set out for

the last.

752 And he stood upright, and spoke his  
word among the Argives:

753 “Up — you who will make trial of this  
prize.”

754 So he spoke; and at once swift Ajax  
rose, Oileus’s son,

755 and resourceful Odysseus stood up,  
and then Nestor’s son

756 Antilochus: for he beat all the young  
men at running.

757 They stood in line; and Achilles  
showed them the goal.

758 The course was stretched flat-out  
from the start; and quickly

759 the son of Oileus shot ahead; and  
brilliant Odysseus drove in

760 close behind — close as the weaving-  
rod to the breast

761 of a fair-girdled woman, when she  
pulls it deftly in her hands,  
762 drawing the spool out along the warp,  
and holds the rod  
763 near her breast: so close Odysseus ran,  
and behind him  
764 he struck the man's footprints with  
his feet before the dust could settle,  
765 and brilliant Odysseus poured his  
breath down on his head,  
766 running lightly on and on; and all the  
Achaeans roared  
767 for his straining after victory, and  
cheered him pressing on.  
768 But when they were running the last  
of the course, at once  
769 Odysseus prayed in his heart to grey-  
eyed Athena:  
770 "Hear me, goddess: come a good

helper to my feet!”

771 So he spoke, praying; and Pallas  
Athena heard him,

772 and made his limbs light — his feet,  
and his arms above them.

773 And when they were on the point of  
darting in for the prize,

774 then Ajax slipped at a dead run — for  
Athena tripped him —

775 just where the dung lay scattered from  
the slaughtered bellowing

776 oxen swift-footed Achilles had killed  
for Patroclus;

777 and his mouth and nostrils filled with  
ox-dung.

778 So much-enduring brilliant Odysseus  
took up the bowl,

779 having come in first; and shining Ajax  
took the ox.

780 And he stood there holding the horn  
of the field-ranging ox,  
781 spitting out dung, and spoke among  
the Argives:  
782 “Damn it all — the goddess hobbled  
my feet! — she who forever  
783 stands by Odysseus like a mother, and  
comes to help him.”  
784 So he spoke; and they all laughed at  
him sweetly.  
785 And Antilochus carried off the last  
prize  
786 smiling, and spoke his word among  
the Argives:  
787 “I tell you all what you know already,  
friends: the immortals  
788 honor the elder generation of men,  
now as always.  
789 For Ajax is only a little older than I am

—

790 but this one is of an earlier stock, of  
earlier men:

791 a green old age, they say, is his. And it  
is hard work

792 for any Achaean to race him — except  
Achilles.”

793 So he spoke, and gave glory to the  
swift-footed son of Peleus.

794 And Achilles answered him with his  
word, and said:

795 “Antilochus — your praise shall not be  
spoken for nothing:

796 I will add to your prize a half-talent of  
gold.”

797 So speaking, he laid it in his hands;  
and he received it, rejoicing.

798 Then the son of Peleus carried into  
the gathering and set down26

799 a long-shadowed spear, and a shield  
and helmet —  
800 the armor of Sarpedon, which  
Patroclus stripped from him.  
801 And he stood upright, and spoke his  
word among the Argives:  
802 “For these we summon two men — the  
best there are —  
803 to put on armor, take up the flesh-  
cutting bronze,  
804 and make trial of each other before  
the crowd.  
805 Whichever man first reaches the  
other’s fair flesh  
806 and touches the inward parts through  
armor and dark blood,  
807 to him I will give this sword with its  
silver studs —  
808 a beautiful Thracian blade I stripped

from Asteropaeus;

809 and the armor — let both men carry it  
off in common;

810 and we will set a good feast before  
them in the huts.”

811 So he spoke; and then great  
Telamonian Ajax rose,

812 and up rose the son of Tydeus, strong  
Diomedes.

813 And when they had armed themselves  
on opposite sides of the crowd,

814 the two came together in the middle,  
hot for combat,

815 glaring terribly; and awe held all the  
Achaeans.

816 And when they had come close,  
advancing on each other,

817 three times they lunged in, three  
times they charged to close quarters.



818 Then Ajax stabbed at the balanced  
round shield —  
819 but did not reach the flesh: the corslet  
inside it held.  
820 And the son of Tydeus, over the rim of  
the great shield,  
821 kept reaching for his neck with the  
point of the shining spear.  
822 And then, in fear for Ajax, the  
Achaeans  
823 called on them to stop, and take equal  
prizes.  
824 But to the son of Tydeus the hero gave  
the great sword,  
825 bearing it with its scabbard and well-  
cut baldric.  
826 Then the son of Peleus set out a lump  
of self-smelted iron<sup>27</sup>  
827 that the huge strength of Eëtion used

to throw;

828 but him swift-footed brilliant Achilles  
killed,

829 and carried the iron off in his ships  
with the rest of his goods.

830 And he stood upright, and spoke his  
word among the Argives:

831 “Up — you who will make trial of this  
prize.

832 Though his rich fields lie very far  
away,

833 the winner will have this to use for  
five revolving years:

834 not for want of iron will his shepherd  
or his plowman

835 go into town — this will supply them.”

836 So he spoke; and then war-staunch  
Polypoetes rose,

837 and the strong might of godlike

Leonteus rose,

838 and Ajax, Telamon's son, and brilliant  
Epeius.

839 They stood in order; and brilliant  
Epeius took the weight,

840 whirled, and let it fly; and all the  
Achaeans laughed at him.

841 Second in turn Leonteus, sprig of Ares,  
threw it;

842 and third, great Telamonian Ajax  
flung it

843 from his heavy hand, and passed the  
marks of all the others.

844 But when war-staunch Polypoetes  
took up the weight —

845 far as a herdsman sends his throwing-  
staff

846 spinning away through the herds of  
his cattle —

847 so far past the whole field he threw it;  
and the people shouted;  
848 and the companions of strong  
Polypoetes stood up  
849 and carried the king's prize away to  
the hollow ships.  
850 Then for the archers he set out the  
dark-blue iron:28  
851 ten double axes he laid down, and ten  
half-axes,  
852 and he set up the mast of a dark-  
prowed ship  
853 far off in the sands, and to it, by a thin  
cord,  
854 tied a trembling dove by the foot, and  
commanded them  
855 to shoot at her: "Whoever hits the  
trembling dove,  
856 let him take up all the double axes and

carry them home;

857 whoever hits the cord, and misses the  
bird —

858 he is the lesser man: let him carry off  
the half-axes.”

859 So he spoke; and then the strength of  
lord Teucer rose,

860 and up rose Meriones, the good aide  
of Idomeneus.

861 They took lots and shook them in a  
bronze helmet,

862 and Teucer drew first place; and at  
once he let fly

863 an arrow with all his force — but did  
not vow to the lord

864 a famous hecatomb of firstling lambs.

865 So he missed the bird — Apollo  
grudged him that —

866 but hit the cord beside her foot,

where the bird was tied,  
867 and the bitter arrow cut the cord  
clean through.  
868 She darted up toward heaven; and the  
cord fell slack  
869 toward the earth; and the Achaeans  
thundered.  
870 But Meriones, in one motion,  
snatched the bow  
871 out of his hand — an arrow he had  
held ready while the other aimed —  
872 and vowed at once to Apollo who  
strikes from afar  
873 a famous hecatomb of firstling lambs;  
874 and high under the clouds he saw the  
trembling dove:  
875 there, as she circled, he shot her  
under the wing, full through,  
876 and the shaft passed clean out, and

came back down to plant itself  
877 in the earth before Meriones's foot.  
And the bird  
878 settled on the mast of the dark-  
prowed ship,  
879 her neck drooped over, and the close-  
set wings went slack,  
880 and the life flew swift from her limbs,  
and she dropped far down  
881 from the mast; and the watching army  
marveled at it.  
882 And Meriones took up all ten double  
axes,  
883 and Teucer carried the half-axes to  
the hollow ships.  
884 Then, last, the son of Peleus carried  
into the gathering29  
885 a long-shadowed spear and an unfired  
cauldron worked with flowers,

886 worth an ox; and the javelin-throwers  
stood up:

887 up rose the son of Atreus, wide-ruling  
Agamemnon,

888 and up rose Meriones, the good aide  
of Idomeneus.

889 And among them spoke swift-footed  
brilliant Achilles:

890 “Son of Atreus — we know how far  
you surpass all others,

891 how much you are the best in power  
and in the throw:

892 take this prize with you to the hollow  
ships,

893 and let us give the spear to the hero  
Meriones —

894 if your own heart is willing: for that is  
what I urge.”

895 So he spoke; and the lord of men



Agamemnon did not refuse.

896 Achilles gave the bronze spear to  
Meriones; and the hero

897 handed his prize, the beautiful  
cauldron, to Talthybius the herald.

## Notes

### NOTES

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1. (23.1-16) The Myrmidons mourn mounted: three circuits of the body with horses and chariots — cavalry honors, the war-machine itself made to grieve — with Thetis stirring “the desire of lament” (γόου ἔμπερος: grief in Homer is an appetite, roused, fed, and satisfied). Achilles’ ruling is the book’s charter: “that is the dead man’s due” (γέρας θανόντων) — the prize of the dead, in the same word the living quarreled over in Book 1. ↩

2. (23.17-25) The vow reported to its beneficiary: 22-23 repeat the wording of 18.336-337 (register kept), and Hector is laid “face-down in the dust beside the bier” — the outrage arranged like a grave-good. The poem keeps Achilles’ promise-keeping and its horror in one frame: he is exact with the dead on both sides of hate. ↩
3. (23.26-58) The funeral feast — “everywhere around the corpse the blood ran in cupfuls” — and the refusal to wash: the fast of Book 19 (19.208-210, 305-308) still governs Achilles’ body; he yields to the “hateful feast” but swears off water “before I lay Patroclus on the fire.” His oath contains the book’s quiet self-knowledge: “never a second time will such grief reach my heart, while I am among the living” — true both ways, as he intends it and as the poem knows it: there is not much “while” left. ↩
4. (23.59-92) The ghost. Patroclus comes “in everything like the man himself” — stature, the beautiful eyes, the voice, even the clothes — and opens with the gentlest rebuke in epic: “You sleep — and you have forgotten me, Achilles.” His requests are a dead man’s administration: burial now, because the other souls bar him from crossing the river (the poem’s

one glimpse of the afterlife's waiting-room); the hand ("I am weeping"); and the shared urn — grounded in the biography only now revealed: Patroclus came to Peleus's house as a child-killer, a boy who slew the son of Amphidamas "angry over the dice — a child's act; I did not mean it." The gentlest man in the poem was a refugee from his own temper: gentleness, the lines quietly say, was something he built. Aristarchus athetized 92 (the golden amphora, "which your lady mother gave you" — Dionysus's gift to Thetis in the later tradition; Aeschines' text lacked it), but the request stands: one vessel, two friends, the arrangement the Odyssey (24.74) confirms was kept. ↪

5. (23.93-108) The failed embrace: Achilles reaches, "and grasped nothing: the soul, like smoke, was gone under the earth, squeaking." His waking cry is the plainest statement of Homeric eschatology: "so there is, even in the house of Hades, a soul and an image (ψυχὴ καὶ εἶδωλον) — but the wits (φρένες) are not in it at all." (Aristophanes athetized the line as too doctrinal; it is the shape of the whole scene.) The dead persist as form without force — enough to be loved, too little to be held: the exact measure of

what the living owe them, which is everything this book does. ↩

6. (23.109-140) The wood-train — Meriones's logistics, the mules, the felled oaks “with a great crashing” — ends at the shore where Achilles plans “the great mound for Patroclus — and for himself”: his own funeral entering the arrangements as a fact needing no comment. The army heaps the corpse with cut hair; Achilles carries the head — chief mourner's station, as Thetis held his (18.71). ↩
7. (23.141-154) The Spercheius lock: hair grown long for a homecoming vow — Peleus's fifty rams at the river's sources — cut now and given to the dead instead: “since I am not going home to my dear fatherland.” The vow of return is formally transferred to the grave; no line in the book cancels Achilles' future more quietly. He says it looking at the sea — the road home, declined. ↩
8. (23.161-192) The pyre, a hundred feet each way, and its freight: fat-wrapped corpse, honey and oil, four horses, two of the nine table-dogs — and the twelve Trojan youths of the vow, butchered with the narrator's own verdict attached: “and evil was the work his heart intended” (κακά δὲ φρεσὶ μήδετο

ἔργα). The poem does not flinch from human sacrifice and does not condone it: one clause of judgment, unique in the epic, set exactly here. And then, within eight lines, Book 24 quietly begins: Aphrodite keeping the dogs from Hector “by day and by night,” the oil of roses, Apollo’s sheltering cloud — the gods already voting against the rage they have stopped assisting. ↩

9. (23.193-232) The winds must be asked: Iris fetches Boreas and Zephyrus from a banquet (declining a seat — she is expected at the Aethiopians’: divine society continuing around the edges of grief), and they burn the pyre all night while Achilles pours wine and calls the soul. Over it, the poem’s most terrible simile of mourning: “As a father mourns, burning the bones of his son, a bridegroom” — the worst grief the Greek imagination could name, a child dead at the threshold of marriage — given to a friend for a friend, and doubled by the fact that the mourner’s own father will soon have precisely this grief and no body to burn. ↩
10. (23.236-257) The white bones “of their kindly companion” (ἐννέος — the dead man’s adjective) into the golden vessel “until I myself am hidden in

Hades”; the mound deliberately modest, “then afterward the Achaeans may build it wide and high — you who are left behind me”: Achilles designs his own tomb as an afterthought to his friend’s, assigning the enlargement to survivors he has already stopped counting himself among. The funeral is double throughout; only one of the dead is present. ↩

11. (23.257-271) The pivot of the book: “But Achilles held the army there” — grief converted, by decree, into games. The prize-list is the Iliad’s economy in miniature: women, tripods, mares, cauldrons, gold, iron — the same currencies men died over, now to be won by rule. ↩
12. (23.271-286) Achilles’ abdication: his immortal horses would win, so he withdraws — and the reason is their mourning: they stand with manes trailing the ground for “the gentle one” (ἡπίου), who washed them and oiled their manes. Patroclus’s epithet-world (kindly, gentle) persists in the memory of animals; the horses that wept at 17.426-440 are still in mourning, and their grief disqualifies the field’s best entry. ↩

13. (23.287-351) Nestor's sermon on μῆτις — “by cunning, far more than by force, is the woodcutter better; by cunning the helmsman... by cunning charioteer outdoes charioteer” — the poem's most explicit praise of intelligence over strength, delivered to a son whose horses are slowest. The turn-post itself is the book's emblem: “either it is the grave-mark of a man dead long ago, or it was set for a turning-post by men before our time; and now Achilles has made it the goal” — a monument whose meaning is already lost, reused as sport: what tombs become, in the long run the poem knows all about. The driving instructions (lean left, goad the right-hand horse, graze the post with the hub) are the oldest coaching manual in literature. ↩
14. (23.352-373) The start: lots drawn (Antilochus first — the inside track his tactics will need), Phoenix as umpire “to keep the running in memory and report the truth,” and the break — dust like cloud or stormwind, manes streaming, the cars now hugging earth, now airborne, “and each man's heart was pounding in his hunger for victory.” The poem's joy in speed, absent since the chariots ran for Hector's life, is given back clean. ↩

15. (23.373-402) The gods play the race as they played the war: Apollo dashes the whip from Diomedes (still angry from Book 5, perhaps — or just partisan); Athena returns it and breaks Eumelus's yoke — the best horseman skinned across mouth and elbows in the dust. Divine interference, which cost Patroclus his life and Hector his, here costs a man a mare and his skin: the same machinery at play-scale, safe at last. ↩
16. (23.402-447) Antilochus's foul: the speech to his horses (threatening them with Nestor's knife — charioteer's hyperbole; "Aethe will pour shame over you: a female!"), the sunken narrows, and the swerve that forces Menelaus to yield or wreck. The narrator is exact: Menelaus dropped back "by his own will," the prudence of the elder buying both men's safety — and his shout ("you shall not carry off the prize without an oath") files the case the assembly will hear. The young man drives "like a man who had not heard": Nestor's cunning-lecture, over-learned in one generation. ↩
17. (23.448-499) The spectators' quarrel — Idomeneus's sharp-eyed call (the chestnut with the moon-round blaze), Oilean Ajax's gratuitous insult, the proposed



wager with Agamemnon as judge — is Book 1 in a teacup: two proud men, a prize, an arbiter. And it is stopped by Achilles — “it is not seemly... You would be indignant at another man who acted so” — the poem’s original quarreler now its peacemaker, speaking to others the sentence nobody managed to speak to him. The reformation is complete and completely unremarked: the poem lets you notice it yourself. ↩

18. (23.499-514) Diomedes wins — whip-strokes “down from the shoulder,” the gold-and-tin car running the horses’ heels down, wheel-tracks barely printed in the fine dust (speed measured by what it fails to leave), and the cool gesture at the end: the whip leaned against the yoke. Sthenelus takes the woman and the tripod: Book 5’s team, intact, at play. ↩
19. (23.514-533) The placings, with the poem’s own verdict on Antilochus: “by craft, not speed at all” (κέρδειςιν, οὐ τι τάχει γε). The tail-hairs-brushing-the-tire figure measures Menelaus’s closing surge; Meriones a spear-cast back; and last, dragging his wreck, “the best man” — Eumelus, whose excellence the race no longer records, which is why the next scene has to. ↩

20. (23.534-566) Justice, round one: Achilles proposes second prize for Eumelus (pity ranking worth above result), and Antilochus objects on procedure — the mare is won; compensate from your own stores — with the challenge-tag of a man standing on right (“let any man who wants her try me — hand to hand”). And Achilles smiled — his only smile in the Iliad — “delighting in Antilochus, because he was his dear companion.” The word ἑταῖρος, freighted with all the book’s grief, spent here on the living: the smile is the poem’s first evidence that Achilles can still be reached. Eumelus gets Asteropaeus’s corslet; everyone is paid; nobody is wronged. ↩
21. (23.566-613) Justice, round two — the poem’s model trial. Menelaus rises “grieved at heart,” takes the herald’s staff (procedure!), and offers two courses: judgment by the leaders, “and no favor either way,” or — better — the self-executing oath: stand before your horses, whip in hand, touch the team, and swear by the earth-upholder, the earth-shaker, that the foul was not deliberate. Antilochus folds precisely at the oath — he will not perjure — with the young man’s confession for all time: “his mind is the quicker, but his judgment thin” — and hands over the mare with his whole inheritance in one

sentence rather than “be wrong before the gods.” And Menelaus melts — the dew-on-the- ripening-corn simile, the gentlest in the poem, for the untensing of an angry heart — and gives the mare back. Compare Book 1: a prize, a grievance, an assembly — and there, wrath; here, yielding met by yielding. This scene is the Iliad showing what the quarrel of Achilles and Agamemnon should have been. ↩

22. (23.615-652) Nestor’s prize for nothing: the leftover bowl, given “a memorial of the burial of Patroclus: for never again will you see him among the Argives.” The old man’s answer is his career in miniature — the games for Amarynceus at Buprasium, four victories named, and the one defeat: the Molione twins who beat him “by force of numbers... one held the reins — held the reins for good and all — while the other laid on the whip” (the doubled phrase is the Greek’s own, an old man’s groove in the telling). His thanks name the thing the whole book trades in: “my heart rejoices that you remember me always as your kindly friend” (ἐννέος — Patroclus’s word, 252). Honor, in the end, is being remembered kindly: the games’ true currency, and the poem’s. ↩

23. (23.653-700) The boxing; Epeius's magnificent boast with its disarming core — "Is it not enough that I fall short in battle? There was never a way for one man to be skilled in every work there is" — the most honest self-assessment in the epic (this is the man who will build the wooden horse; his skill was coming). Euryalus's pedigree is a funeral-games résumé — he won at the burial of "fallen Oedipus" at Thebes, the Iliad's only notice of Oedipus, dead at home and buried with games. One counter-punch ends it; the fish-leap simile under Boreas's shiver lands him; and Epeius "took him in his hands and set him upright" — courtesy inside violence, the book's whole ethic in one gesture. ↩

24. (23.700-740) The wrestling, with the poem's price-list attached: the tripod worth twelve oxen; the woman "skilled in many kinds of work," worth four. The Iliad states its world's arithmetic without comment, and no reader is meant to pass it in silence: this is the economy the whole war runs on. Ajax and Odysseus lock like "gable-rafters a famous builder joins"; two falls — Odysseus's knee-trick, then the failed lift and mutual tumble — and Achilles calls it: "Victory to you both." Force and cunning, the poem's two great modes, wrestle to a draw and are sent to dinner. ↩

25. (23.740-798) The foot-race, and the bowl with a biography: Sidonian work, Phoenician freight, guest-gift to Thoas, and then — the price of Lycaon, paid by Euneus to Patroclus. The object that once bought Lycaon's life (21.40-41) is now the prize at the funeral of the man it was paid to, raced for while Lycaon lies in the river. Objects in Homer remember what men would rather not. The race itself is the book's comedy: Odysseus running so close he treads Ajax's prints "before the dust could settle," breathing on his head (with the weaving-woman simile — the poem's most domestic measure of distance); the prayer; Athena's trip; Ajax face-down in the sacrificial ox-dung, spitting, with the complaint that convulses the army: "she stands by Odysseus like a mother!" — "and they all laughed at him sweetly" (ἡδύ). Laughter, which this poem has mostly given to gods and scorners, comes back to men, sweet, at a funeral. Antilochus's graceful last-place speech ("the immortals honor the elder generation... hard work to race him — except Achilles") wins a half-talent bonus for pure charm.



26. (23.798-826) The armed duel — for Sarpedon's armor, Patroclus's greatest spoil (16.663-665) — is the one

event that edges too close to the real thing: first blood “through armor and dark blood” for Asteropaeus’s Thracian sword. Ajax and Diomedes close “glaring terribly; and awe held all the Achaeans”; Diomedes keeps reaching over the shield-rim for the neck — the exact stroke that killed Hector — and the Achaeans, “in fear for Ajax,” stop it. Play that can kill is called before it does: the community knows where the line is now. (Aristophanes’ text varied the victory-terms; Aristarchus athetized 806 and 810; 824-825 were athetized too — antiquity was uneasy exactly where the game is uneasy.) ↩

27. (23.826-849) The weight-throw: the prize is the implement — Eëtion’s self-smelted iron lump, war-booty from Andromache’s father’s city, now five years’ supply for a winner’s shepherd and plowman: iron passing from a king’s sport through sack and spoil to farm-tools — the poem’s whole material history in one object. Polypoetes’s cast, measured by a herdsman’s throwing-staff “spinning away through the herds,” wins it for the ships. ↩

28. (23.850-883) The archery: a dove on a cord at the mast-head. Teucer shoots without vowing the

hecatomb — “Apollo grudged him that” — and cuts the cord; Meriones, arrow already in hand, vows, and takes the bird under the wing as she circles the clouds. Piety as marksmanship’s missing variable, scored like the contest it is; and the poem’s last death — after Hector, after the twelve — is a dove’s, drooping her neck on the mast “and the life flew swift from her limbs.” The Iliad’s killing ends in miniature, feathered, at a game. ↩

29. (23.884-897) The close: Agamemnon stands up for the javelin — and Achilles awards him the prize without a throw: “we know how far you surpass all others... take this prize” — with the spear to Meriones. The poem’s first quarrel was these two men over a prize; its last prize passes between them ungrudged, unthrown-for, by the loser of Book 1 now presiding in perfect courtesy. Agamemnon hands the cauldron to Talthibius — the herald who once came to Achilles’ hut to take Briseis (1.320-348) now receives, from Agamemnon’s own hands, a gift born of Achilles’ graciousness. The circle shuts without a word of comment: the games have done what nine years of war could not. All that remains is a corpse behind the hut, and a father across the plain — Book 24. ↩

# Book 24

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*The gods vote against the rage; a mother tells  
her son to eat, to sleep, to love; an old man  
kisses the hands that killed his sons — and the  
two of them weep, eat, and look at each other.  
The poem that began with the wrath ends with  
a burial done properly.*

[Translator's note →](#)

- 1** The gathering broke, and the people  
scattered, each man<sup>**1**</sup>
- 2** to his own swift ship. The rest turned  
their minds to supper
- 3** and to sweet sleep, and took their fill;  
but Achilles
- 4** wept, remembering his dear companion;



and sleep

5 that subdues all things would not take  
him: he turned this way and that,

6 aching for Patroclus — for his manhood  
and his brave strength,

7 and all he had wound through and  
suffered at his side,

8 threading the wars of men and the  
punishing waves.

9 Remembering these things he let the  
swollen tears fall,

10 lying now on his side, now again

11 on his back, now face-down; and then  
he would stand

12 straight up, and wander in circles,  
distraught, along the beach. Nor did dawn

13 ever slip past him, showing over the sea  
and the shores:

14 he would yoke his swift horses under

the chariot,  
15 and tie Hector behind the car, to drag  
him,  
16 and haul him three times round the  
tomb of Menoetius's dead son,  
17 then rest again in his hut, and leave  
him there,  
18 stretched face-down in the dust. But  
Apollo kept  
19 all disfigurement from the flesh,  
pitying the man  
20 even in death: he covered him round  
with the aegis,  
21 all golden, so the dragging would not  
tear him.  
22 So Achilles in his fury defiled brilliant  
Hector;<sup>2</sup>  
23 but the blessed gods, looking on, were  
moved to pity,

24 and kept urging the sharp-eyed slayer  
of Argus to steal him.  
25 That pleased all the others — but never  
Hera,  
26 nor Poseidon, nor the grey-eyed  
maiden:  
27 they held fast, as when it first began, to  
their hatred  
28 of holy Ilion, and Priam, and his people  
— for the blindness  
29 of Alexandros, who insulted the  
goddesses when they came  
30 to his sheep-fold, and praised the one  
who fed his grievous lust.  
31 But when the twelfth dawn rose from  
that day,<sup>3</sup>  
32 then Phoebus Apollo spoke among the  
immortals:  
33 “You are hard, you gods — you

destroyers! Did Hector never  
34 burn for you the thigh-cuts of oxen and  
unblemished goats?  
35 And now you cannot bring yourselves  
to save him — a corpse! —  
36 for his wife to look upon, and his  
mother, and his child,  
37 and his father Priam, and the people,  
who would quickly  
38 burn him in the fire and give him his  
portion of rites.  
39 No — it is ruinous Achilles you gods  
choose to help:  
40 a man with no fit wits in him, no  
purpose in his chest  
41 that will bend: his thoughts are savage,  
like a lion  
42 who yields to his own great strength  
and lordly heart

43 and goes at the flocks of men, to take  
his feast:  
44 so Achilles has destroyed pity; and  
there is no shame in him —  
45 shame, which harms men greatly, and  
profits them too.  
46 A man may lose someone even closer  
than a friend —  
47 a brother of one womb, or his own son  
—  
48 and yet, when he has wept and  
lamented, he lets go:  
49 for the Fates gave mankind an  
enduring heart.  
50 But this man — since he stripped great  
Hector of his dear life,  
51 he ties him behind his horses and drags  
him round the tomb  
52 of his dear companion. It is not the

finer thing, nor the better.

53 Let him take care we do not turn on  
him in anger, great as he is:

54 it is dumb earth he defiles in all his  
fury.”

55 And white-armed Hera, angered,  
answered him:4

56 “Even that word of yours might stand,  
lord of the silver bow,

57 if you gods will set Achilles and Hector  
at one price.

58 Hector is mortal, and was suckled at a  
woman’s breast;

59 but Achilles is the child of a goddess —  
one I myself

60 reared and cherished and gave to a  
man to be his wife —

61 to Peleus, dear beyond all men to the  
immortals.

62 All of you gods were at the wedding;  
and you among them  
63 sat at the feast with your lyre —  
companion of evils, faithless forever!”  
64 Then in answer spoke to her cloud-  
gatherer Zeus:  
65 “Hera — do not be wholly furious with  
the gods.  
66 Their honor shall not be one price. And  
yet Hector  
67 was dearest to the gods of all mortals in  
Ilion —  
68 so he was to me: he never failed in the  
gifts I love.  
69 Never did my altar lack its fair share of  
the feast,  
70 the libation and the savor: for that is  
the honor-portion we gods have.  
71 But the stealing — let it go. There is no

way to take

72 bold Hector unseen by Achilles: his  
mother

73 is beside him always, mingled with his  
nights and days.

74 No — let one of the gods call Thetis  
here to me,

75 so I can tell her a close-packed word:  
that Achilles

76 shall take gifts from Priam, and give  
Hector back.”

77 So he spoke; and storm-footed Iris rose  
to carry it,5

78 and midway between Samos and  
rugged Imbros

79 she plunged into the black sea; and the  
water groaned above her.

80 Down she shot to the bottom like the  
lead sinker



81 that rides the horn of a field-ox down  
the line  
82 and goes among the ravening fish,  
carrying death.  
83 She found Thetis in the hollow cave,  
and around her  
84 the other sea-goddesses sat gathered;  
and she in their midst  
85 was weeping the fate of her blameless  
son, who was to  
86 perish in deep-soiled Troy, far from his  
fatherland.  
87 And standing close, swift-footed Iris  
addressed her:  
88 “Rise, Thetis. Zeus of the imperishable  
counsels calls you.”  
89 Then answered her the goddess, silver-  
footed Thetis:  
90 “Why does the great god summon me?

I shrink from

91 mixing with the immortals: the griefs  
in my heart are past counting.

92 But I will go. Whatever word he speaks  
shall not be spoken in vain.”

93 So speaking, the brilliant goddess took  
up a veil —

94 a dark-blue one: there is no garment  
blackier.

95 And she set out, and wind-footed swift  
Iris led

96 before her; and around them the wave  
of the sea gave way.

97 They stepped out on the beach and  
darted up to heaven,

98 and found the wide-seeing son of  
Cronos, and around him

99 sat gathered all the other blessed gods  
who are forever.

100 And she sat down beside father Zeus  
— Athena yielded her place —  
101 and Hera put a beautiful golden cup in  
her hand  
102 and cheered her with words; and  
Thetis drank, and gave it back.  
103 And the father of men and gods began  
speaking among them:  
104 “You have come to Olympus, goddess  
Thetis, for all your sorrow,  
105 carrying unforgettable grief in your  
heart. I know it myself.  
106 Even so, I will tell you why I called you  
here.  
107 For nine days a quarrel has stood  
among the immortals  
108 over Hector’s body, and Achilles  
sacker of cities;  
109 they keep urging the sharp-eyed

slayer of Argus to steal him.

110 But I attach this glory to Achilles  
instead —

111 guarding your reverence and your love  
for the days to come.

112 Go quickly to the camp, and lay this  
charge on your son:

113 tell him the gods are indignant with  
him — and I beyond all

114 immortals am angered — because in  
his heart's madness

115 he holds Hector at the beaked ships,  
and has not released him:

116 so that, it may be, he will fear me, and  
give Hector back.

117 And I will send Iris to great-hearted  
Priam:

118 to ransom his dear son, going to the  
ships of the Achaeans,

119 bearing gifts to Achilles that will warm  
his heart.”

120 So he spoke; and the goddess, silver-  
footed Thetis, obeyed,<sup>6</sup>

121 and went darting down from the peaks  
of Olympus,

122 and came to her son’s hut. There she  
found him

123 groaning without pause; and around  
him his companions

124 were busy at speed, making the  
morning meal:

125 a great shaggy sheep lay slaughtered  
in the hut.

126 And she, his lady mother, sat down  
close beside him,

127 and stroked him with her hand, and  
spoke a word, and named him:

128 “My child — how long will you eat

your own heart out

129 with weeping and grieving,

remembering neither bread

130 nor bed? Yet it is good to lie with a

woman

131 in love. For you will not be with me

long: already

132 death stands close beside you, and fate

the overpowering.

133 Now listen quickly: I am a messenger

of Zeus to you.

134 He says the gods are indignant with

you — and he beyond all

135 immortals is angered — because in

your heart's madness

136 you hold Hector at the beaked ships,

and have not released him.

137 Come: give him up, and accept ransom

for the dead.”

138 Then in answer spoke to her swift-footed Achilles:  
139 “So be it. Whoever brings the ransom, let him take the body,  
140 if the Olympian himself, in earnest, commands it.”  
141 So the two of them, in the gathering-place of the ships,  
142 mother and son, spoke many winged words to each other.  
143 And the son of Cronos sent Iris down to holy Ilion:  
144 “Up, swift Iris: leave the seat of Olympus<sup>7</sup>  
145 and carry word to great-hearted Priam inside Ilion:  
146 to ransom his dear son, going to the ships of the Achaeans,  
147 bearing gifts to Achilles that will warm

his heart —

148 alone: let no other man of the Trojans  
go with him.

149 A herald may follow him, an elder one,  
to steer

150 the mules and the smooth-wheeled  
wagon, and to carry

151 back to the city the dead man brilliant  
Achilles killed.

152 And let no thought of death trouble  
his mind, no fear:

153 such an escort we will give him — the  
slayer of Argus,

154 who will lead him until his leading  
brings him to Achilles.

155 And when he has led him inside  
Achilles' hut,

156 that man will not kill him — he will  
hold all others back:



157 for he is not witless, not blind, not  
godless;  
158 he will spare a suppliant man, and  
treat him with all kindness.”  
159 So he spoke; and storm-footed Iris  
rose to carry it,  
160 and came to Priam’s house, and found  
there crying and mourning.  
161 The sons sat around their father inside  
the courtyard,  
162 soaking their clothes with tears; and  
in their midst the old man,  
163 wrapped tight in his mantle; and thick  
on the old man’s  
164 head and neck lay the dung  
165 he had gathered on himself with his  
own hands, rolling in it.  
166 And his daughters and his sons’ wives  
wailed through the house,

167 remembering the men — so many, and  
so brave —  
168 who lay dead at Argive hands, their  
lives destroyed.  
169 And the messenger of Zeus stood by  
Priam and spoke,  
170 in a small voice; and trembling took  
his limbs:  
171 “Take courage in your heart, Priam,  
Dardanus’s descendant. Do not fear.  
172 I do not come to you with my eye on  
evil,  
173 but meaning well. I am a messenger of  
Zeus to you,  
174 who far away cares for you greatly,  
and pities you.  
175 The Olympian commands you: ransom  
brilliant Hector,  
176 bearing gifts to Achilles that will warm

his heart —

177 alone: let no other man of the Trojans  
go with you.

178 A herald may follow you, an elder one,  
to steer

179 the mules and the smooth-wheeled  
wagon, and to carry

180 back to the city the dead man brilliant  
Achilles killed.

181 And let no thought of death trouble  
your mind, no fear:

182 such an escort will go with you — the  
slayer of Argus,

183 who will lead you until his leading  
brings you to Achilles.

184 And when he has led you inside  
Achilles' hut,

185 that man will not kill you — he will  
hold all others back:

186 for he is not witless, not blind, not  
godless;  
187 he will spare a suppliant man, and  
treat him with all kindness.”  
188 So speaking, swift-footed Iris went her  
way.<sup>8</sup>  
189 And Priam ordered his sons to make  
ready the smooth-wheeled  
190 mule-wagon, and to lash the wicker  
box upon it;  
191 and he himself went down to the  
vaulted store-room,  
192 cedar-beamed, high-roofed, that held  
his many treasures,  
193 and called his wife Hecuba, and said to  
her:  
194 “Lady — a messenger from Zeus has  
come to me from Olympus:  
195 I am to ransom our dear son, going to

the ships of the Achaeans,

196 bearing gifts to Achilles that will  
warm his heart.

197 So come, tell me: how does it seem to  
your mind?

198 For my own strength and heart are  
urging me terribly

199 to go there — to the ships, into the  
broad camp of the Achaeans.”

200 So he spoke; and the woman shrieked,  
and answered:

201 “Ah me — where have your wits gone,  
for which you once

202 were famous among strangers and the  
people you rule?

203 How can you want to go to the ships  
of the Achaeans — alone —

204 into the eyes of the man who has  
stripped your many

205 brave sons? Your heart must be iron.  
206 If he takes you — if he sets eyes on you  
—  
207 savage and faithless as that man is, he  
will not pity you,  
208 he will not respect you. No: let us  
weep for our son far off,  
209 sitting in the hall. So overpowering  
Fate  
210 spun for him with her thread at his  
very birth, when I bore him:  
211 to glut the running dogs, far from his  
own parents,  
212 beside a violent man — oh, that I could  
fasten on that man's  
213 liver, and eat it raw! Then there would  
be work paid back  
214 for my son — for it was no coward he  
killed:

215 a man who stood for the men of Troy  
and the deep-girdled women  
216 of Troy, with no thought of shelter,  
none of flight.”  
217 Then in turn the old man, godlike  
Priam, answered her:  
218 “I will go. Do not hold me back — and  
do not be  
219 a bird of evil omen in my own halls.  
You will not persuade me.  
220 If any other man on earth had  
ordered this —  
221 some seer reading the smoke, some  
priest —  
222 we would call it false, and keep our  
distance from it.  
223 But now — I heard the god myself; I  
looked her in the face —  
224 I go; and her word shall not be spoken

in vain. And if it is my portion

225 to die by the ships of the bronze-  
shirted Achaeans,

226 I choose it. Let Achilles kill me on the  
spot —

227 once I have taken my son in my arms,  
and put away my fill of weeping.”

228 He spoke, and lifted the beautiful lids  
of the chests,<sup>9</sup>

229 and out of them he took twelve  
magnificent robes,

230 twelve single-fold cloaks, and as many  
blankets,

231 as many white mantles, and as many  
tunics besides.

232 He weighed and carried out ten full  
talents of gold,

233 and two glittering tripods, and four  
cauldrons,



234 and a cup of great beauty, which the  
men of Thrace had given him  
235 when he went on embassy — a great  
treasure. Not even this  
236 did the old man spare in his halls: he  
wished with all his heart  
237 to ransom his dear son. And the  
Trojans — all of them —  
238 he drove from the colonnade, lashing  
them with words of shame:  
239 “Out, you disgraces! You objects of  
reproach! Have you no  
240 mourning of your own at home, that  
you come to torment me?  
241 Is it nothing to you that Zeus, Cronos’s  
son, has given me this grief —  
242 to lose my best son? You will learn it  
yourselves:  
243 you will be far easier now for the

Achaeans

244 to slaughter, with that man dead. But  
as for me —

245 before I see this city sacked and  
ravaged

246 with my own eyes, let me go down  
into the house of Hades.”

247 He spoke, and went at the men with  
his staff; and they fled out

248 before the old man’s fury. And he  
shouted at his own sons,

249 cursing Helenus and Paris and  
brilliant Agathon

250 and Pammon and Antiphonus and  
Polites of the war-cry

251 and Deiphobus and Hippothous and  
noble Dius —

252 nine sons; and the old man bellowed  
his orders at them:

253 “Move, you worthless children — my  
shames! I wish the whole pack of you  
254 had been killed at the swift ships  
instead of Hector.  
255 Ah, my evil fate! — I fathered the best  
sons  
256 in wide Troy, and I tell you not one of  
them is left:  
257 Mestor the godlike, and Troilus the  
chariot-fighter,  
258 and Hector, who was a god among  
men — he did not seem  
259 the son of a mortal man, but of a god.  
260 Ares destroyed them. And these —  
these disgraces — are all left me:  
261 liars, dancers, heroes of the beaten  
dance-floor,  
262 plunderers of their own people’s  
lambs and kids!

263 Will you not get a wagon ready for me  
— now —

264 and load all this on it, so we can be on  
our way?”

265 So he spoke; and dreading their  
father’s rebuke<sup>10</sup>

266 they brought out the smooth-wheeled  
mule-drawn wagon,

267 a beautiful one, fresh-built, and lashed  
the wicker box upon it;

268 and they took down from its peg the  
box-wood mule-yoke

269 with its knob, well fitted with guide-  
rings,

270 and brought out with the yoke its  
lashing, nine cubits long.

271 They set the yoke with care on the  
polished pole,

272 on the rest at the pole’s end, and

threw the ring on the peg,  
273 and lashed it three times each way  
round the knob, and then  
274 wound the rest down the pole and  
tucked the tongue beneath.  
275 Then they brought from the store-  
room and heaped on the polished wagon  
276 the ransom past counting for Hector's  
head,  
277 and yoked the strong-hoofed mules,  
trained to the harness,  
278 which once the Mysians gave to  
Priam, a shining gift;  
279 and for Priam they led beneath the  
yoke the horses  
280 the old man kept for himself, and fed  
at the polished manger.  
281 So the two of them, in the high house,  
were having their teams yoked —

282 the herald and Priam, with close-  
packed counsel in their minds —  
283 when Hecuba came up to them, her  
heart heavy,11  
284 carrying honey-hearted wine in her  
right hand  
285 in a golden cup, for them to pour  
before they went;  
286 and she stood before the horses, and  
spoke a word, and named him:  
287 “Here: pour to father Zeus, and pray  
to come home again  
288 out of the enemy’s hands — since your  
heart  
289 drives you to the ships, though I  
would not have it so.  
290 Pray, then, to the son of Cronos of the  
black cloud,  
291 the god of Ida, who looks down on all

the Troad,  
292 and ask for a bird of omen — the swift  
messenger  
293 that is dearest of birds to him, whose  
power is greatest —  
294 on the right, so that seeing it with  
your own eyes  
295 you may trust it, and go to the ships of  
the quick-horsed Danaans.  
296 But if wide-seeing Zeus will not give  
you his messenger,  
297 then I at least would not urge you on,  
or bid you  
298 go to the Argive ships, however hard  
you desire it.”  
299 Then in answer spoke to her godlike  
Priam:  
300 “Lady, I will not refuse what you ask.  
301 It is good to lift hands to Zeus, in hope

he will pity.”

302 He spoke, and the old man told the  
housekeeper to pour

303 clean water over his hands; and she  
stood by,

304 the serving-woman, with basin and  
pitcher in her hands.

305 He washed, and took the cup from his  
wife,

306 and standing in the middle of the  
court he prayed, and poured the wine,

307 looking up into heaven, and spoke  
aloud:

308 “Father Zeus, ruling from Ida, most  
glorious, greatest:

309 grant that I come to Achilles welcome,  
and pitied;

310 and send me a bird of omen — the  
swift messenger



311 that is dearest of birds to you, whose  
power is greatest —  
312 on the right, so that seeing it with my  
own eyes  
313 I may trust it, and go to the ships of  
the quick-horsed Danaans.”  
314 So he spoke, praying; and Zeus the  
counselor heard him,  
315 and at once sent an eagle, surest omen  
of flying things,  
316 the dark hunter, the one men call the  
dusky one.  
317 Wide as the door of some rich man’s  
high-roofed  
318 treasure-chamber stands, a door well  
fitted with bolts,  
319 so wide his wings spread out on either  
side. He appeared to them  
320 on the right, sweeping across the city;

and seeing him

321 they rejoiced, and the hearts in them  
all were warmed.

322 Then the old man in haste mounted  
his chariot<sup>12</sup>

323 and drove out of the gateway and the  
echoing colonnade.

324 In front the mules drew the four-  
wheeled wagon —

325 war-minded Idaeus drove them — and  
behind came the horses

326 the old man urged along with the  
whip

327 at a brisk pace through the city; and  
all his people followed,

328 mourning without end, as if he were  
going to his death.

329 And when they had come down from  
the city and reached the plain,

330 the others turned back for Ilion —  
331 the sons and the sons-in-law. But the  
two of them did not slip past  
332 wide-seeing Zeus as they came out on  
the plain: he saw, and pitied  
333 the old man, and quickly spoke to  
Hermes, his dear son:  
334 “Hermes — since to you, beyond all  
gods, it is dearest  
335 to be man’s companion, and you listen  
to whom you will,  
336 go now, and lead Priam to the hollow  
ships of the Achaeans  
337 so that no one sees him, no one marks  
him,  
338 of all the Danaans, before he reaches  
the son of Peleus.”  
339 So he spoke; and the courier, the  
slayer of Argus, obeyed.

340 At once he bound beneath his feet the  
beautiful sandals,  
341 ambrosial, golden, that carry him over  
the water  
342 and over the boundless land with the  
breath of the wind;  
343 and he took up the wand with which  
he charms men's eyes  
344 to sleep, whomever he wishes, and  
wakes the sleeping;  
345 with this in his hands the strong  
slayer of Argus flew,  
346 and quickly came to Troy and the  
Hellespont,  
347 and went on his way in the likeness of  
a princely youth  
348 with the first down on his lip — the  
age when youth has its highest grace.  
349 Now when the two had driven past

the great mound of Ilus,  
350 they halted the mules and horses at  
the river  
351 to drink; for dusk by now had come  
down over the earth.  
352 And the herald peered close, and  
made out Hermes  
353 near at hand, and spoke out to Priam:  
354 “Look sharp, Dardanus’s descendant!  
Here is work for a careful mind.  
355 I see a man; and I think we are about  
to be torn to pieces.  
356 Come — let us flee with the horses; or  
if not,  
357 clasp his knees and beg him — he  
might pity us.”  
358 So he spoke; and the old man’s mind  
was scattered, and he was terribly  
359 afraid, and the hair stood up on his

bent limbs,

360 and he froze, dazed. But the helper-  
god came close himself,

361 and took the old man's hand, and  
questioned him:

362 "Where, father, are you steering these  
horses and mules13

363 through the ambrosial night, when  
other mortals sleep?

364 Have you no fear of the Achaeans,  
breathing fury,

365 your enemies, pitiless, so near at  
hand?

366 If one of them saw you through the  
running black night

367 bringing so many treasures — what  
would your plan be then?

368 You are not young yourself, and this  
man with you is old —

369 no strength to fight off a man who  
starts a quarrel.

370 But I will do you no harm — no: I  
would defend you

371 against another. You are the image of  
my own dear father.”

372 Then in turn the old man, godlike  
Priam, answered him:

373 “It is all much as you say, dear child.

374 But some god, even now, has held his  
hand over me,

375 who sent a wayfarer like you to cross  
my path —

376 a good omen: such is your body and  
your beauty, a wonder,

377 and your mind is sound. Blessed are  
the parents you come of.”

378 Then in turn the courier, the slayer of  
Argus, addressed him:

379 “Yes, old man — all this you have said  
aright.  
380 But come, tell me this, and recount it  
truly:  
381 are you sending away a great treasure,  
and a fine one,  
382 to foreign men somewhere, so that  
much at least survives you?  
383 Or are you all abandoning holy Ilion  
now  
384 in fear — such a man has perished, the  
best among you,  
385 your son: who never hung back from  
battle with the Achaeans.”  
386 Then in turn the old man, godlike  
Priam, answered him:  
387 “Who are you, my brave one? Of what  
parents do you come,  
388 who speak so beautifully of my ill-



fated son's death?"

389 Then in turn the courier, the slayer of  
Argus, addressed him:

390 "You test me, old man — asking about  
brilliant Hector.

391 Him my own eyes have seen — and  
often — in the battle

392 where men win glory; and when he  
drove the Argives

393 onto their ships and kept killing,  
carving with the sharp bronze,

394 we stood and marveled at it: for  
Achilles,

395 in his anger at Atreus's son, would not  
let us fight.

396 I am his squire; one strong-built ship  
brought us both.

397 I am a Myrmidon by birth; my father  
is Polyctor —

398 a wealthy man, and old, just as you  
are:  
399 six sons he has, and I am his seventh;  
400 I shook lots with the others, and the  
lot fell to me to sail here.  
401 Now I have come to the plain from the  
ships: for at daybreak  
402 the bright-eyed Achaeans will set  
their battle around the city.  
403 They chafe at sitting idle, and the  
kings of the Achaeans  
404 cannot hold them back, so hot they  
are for war.”  
405 Then in turn the old man, godlike  
Priam, answered him:  
406 “If you are truly a squire of Achilles,  
Peleus’s son,  
407 come then — tell me the whole truth:  
408 is my son still by the ships? Or has

Achilles

409 cut him limb from limb by now, and  
thrown him to his dogs?”

410 Then in turn the courier, the slayer of  
Argus, addressed him:

411 “Old man — the dogs have not eaten  
him, nor the birds:

412 he lies there still, beside the ship of  
Achilles,

413 just as he was, among the huts. Twelve  
dawns now

414 he has lain there; and his flesh does  
not decay, and the worms

415 do not eat him — the worms that  
devour men killed in war.

416 It is true that around the tomb of his  
dear companion

417 Achilles drags him, careless, whenever  
bright dawn shows —

418 but he cannot disfigure him. You  
would marvel yourself, if you came,  
419 at how he lies there dewy-fresh, the  
blood all washed  
420 from him, no stain anywhere; and  
every wound has closed,  
421 every one that was struck — and many  
drove their bronze into him.  
422 Such is the care the blessed gods take  
for your son,  
423 a dead man though he is — because  
they loved him at heart.”  
424 So he spoke; and the old man rejoiced,  
and answered:  
425 “My child — how good a thing it is to  
give the immortals  
426 their due gifts! For my son — if ever  
he truly was —  
427 never forgot, in his halls, the gods

who hold Olympus;

428 and so they have remembered him,  
even in the portion of death.

429 But come — take from me this  
beautiful cup,

430 and guard my body, and escort me,  
with the gods,

431 until I come to the hut of Peleus's  
son.”

432 Then in turn the courier, the slayer of  
Argus, addressed him:

433 “You test me again, old man — the  
young man — but you will not persuade  
me,

434 asking me to take your gifts behind  
Achilles' back.

435 I fear that man; my heart shrinks with  
too much awe

436 to rob him — lest some evil find me

afterward.

437 But you — I would escort you with all  
care, even to famous Argos,

438 by swift ship or on foot beside you;

439 and no man would make light of your  
escort, or attack.”

440 He spoke, and the helper-god sprang  
up onto the chariot,<sup>14</sup>

441 and swiftly caught the whip and reins  
into his hands,

442 and breathed brave strength into the  
horses and the mules.

443 And when they came to the towers  
and the ditch of the ships,

444 the sentries were just busying  
themselves with supper;

445 and the courier, the slayer of Argus,  
poured sleep

446 over them all, and opened the gates at

once, and thrust back the bars,  
447 and led in Priam and the shining gifts  
on the wagon.  
448 And when they came to the hut of  
Peleus's son —  
449 the high hut the Myrmidons had built  
their lord,  
450 cutting beams of fir, and roofed it over  
451 with a shaggy thatch of reeds mown  
from the meadow,  
452 and around it made their lord a great  
courtyard  
453 with close-set stakes; and one single  
bar of fir  
454 held the door — a bolt three Achaeans  
would drive home  
455 and three would draw, of the others:  
three men  
456 to that great bolt, though Achilles

would ram it home alone —

457 then Hermes the helper opened it for  
the old man,

458 and brought in the famed gifts for the  
swift-footed son of Peleus,

459 and stepped down from the chariot to  
the ground, and said:

460 “Old man — I am an immortal god  
come down to you:

461 Hermes. My father sent me with you  
as your escort.

462 But now I will go back: I will not walk

463 into Achilles’ sight. It would stir  
indignation —

464 an immortal god openly entertained  
by mortals.

465 You go in; clasp the knees of Peleus’s  
son,

466 and beg him by his father, by his



mother of the lovely hair,

467 by his child — so you may stir the  
heart in him.”

468 So speaking, Hermes went his way to  
high Olympus;15

469 and Priam leapt from the chariot to  
the ground

470 and left Idaeus there to hold

471 the horses and mules; and the old man  
walked straight in,

472 to where Achilles, dear to Zeus, was  
sitting. Inside

473 he found him — his companions  
sitting apart; only two,

474 the hero Automedon and Alcimus,  
sprig of Ares,

475 were busy at his side; he had newly  
finished eating,

476 finished food and drink; the table still

stood by him.

477 Great Priam came in unseen by them  
all, and standing close,

478 he clasped Achilles' knees with his  
hands, and kissed his hands —

479 the terrible, man-slaughtering hands  
that had killed so many of his sons.

480 As when thick blindness takes a man,  
who in his own country

481 kills another, and comes among a  
different people,

482 to a rich man's house, and wonder  
holds all who see him:

483 so Achilles wondered, seeing godlike  
Priam;

484 and the others wondered too, and  
looked at one another.

485 And Priam, in supplication, spoke his  
word to him:16

486 “Remember your father, Achilles like  
the gods —  
487 a man of my years, on the ruinous  
threshold of old age.  
488 It may be that the men who live  
around him  
489 are grinding him down, and there is  
no one to beat off ruin and destruction.  
490 Yet he at least, hearing that you are  
alive,  
491 rejoices in his heart, and hopes  
through all his days  
492 to see his dear son coming home from  
Troy.  
493 But I am doomed to the last: I fathered  
the best sons  
494 in wide Troy, and I tell you not one of  
them is left.  
495 Fifty I had, when the sons of the

Achaeans came:

496 nineteen were mine from a single  
womb,

497 and the others women of the palace  
bore me.

498 Rushing Ares has unstrung the knees  
of most of them;

499 and the one who was left me, who  
guarded the city and the people —

500 him you killed, days ago, fighting for  
his fatherland:

501 Hector. For his sake I come now to the  
ships of the Achaeans

502 to ransom him from you; and I bring  
ransom past counting.

503 Respect the gods, Achilles, and pity  
me,

504 remembering your own father. And I  
am still more pitiable:

505 I have endured what no other mortal  
on earth has yet endured —  
506 to lift to my lips the hand of the man  
who killed my son.”  
507 So he spoke; and he stirred in Achilles  
the desire to weep for his father.<sup>17</sup>  
508 He took the old man’s hand, and  
gently pushed him back;  
509 and the two of them remembered: the  
one wept long and sore  
510 for man-slaughtering Hector, huddled  
at Achilles’ feet,  
511 and Achilles wept for his own father —  
and now again  
512 for Patroclus; and the sound of their  
mourning filled the house.  
513 But when brilliant Achilles had taken  
his fill of lament,  
514 and the longing for it had gone out of

his chest and limbs,  
515 he rose from his seat at once, and  
raised the old man up by the hand,  
516 pitying the grey head and the grey  
beard,  
517 and speaking winged words he  
addressed him:  
518 “Poor man. How much evil your heart  
has endured!18  
519 How could you bear to come to the  
ships of the Achaeans — alone —  
520 into the eyes of the man who has  
stripped your many  
521 brave sons? Your heart must be iron.  
522 Come, sit on this chair; and our griefs  
— we will let them  
523 lie quiet in our hearts, for all our  
sorrow.  
524 There is nothing to be gained from

chill lament.

525 For this is the way the gods have spun  
it for wretched mortals:

526 to live in grief. And they themselves  
are free of care.

527 Two jars stand on the floor of Zeus's  
hall,

528 full of the gifts he gives: one of evils,  
one of blessings.

529 The man to whom Zeus who delights  
in thunder gives a mixture,

530 meets now with evil, and now again  
with good;

531 but the man to whom he gives only  
from the jar of sorrows —

532 him he has made an outcast: ravening  
hunger drives him over the earth,

533 and he wanders honored neither by  
gods nor by mortals.

534 So it was with Peleus: the gods gave  
him shining gifts  
535 from his birth; he outshone all  
mankind  
536 in wealth and fortune, and was king of  
the Myrmidons,  
537 and mortal though he was, they made  
a goddess his wife.  
538 But even on him the god laid evil: no  
brood  
539 of ruling sons was born to him in his  
halls —  
540 one child he fathered, doomed out of  
season. And I give him  
541 no care in his old age: far from my  
fatherland  
542 I sit here in Troy, grieving you and  
your children.  
543 And you, old man — we hear you



prospered once:

544 all that Lesbos out to sea, the seat of  
Macar, bounds,

545 and Phrygia inland, and the boundless  
Hellespont —

546 over all these, old man, they say you  
were first in wealth and sons.

547 But since the gods of heaven brought  
this affliction on you,

548 there is nothing around your city now  
but battles and the killing of men.

549 Bear it. Do not mourn without respite  
in your heart.

550 You will accomplish nothing, grieving  
for your son;

551 you will not raise him up — sooner you  
will suffer some new evil.”

552 Then in turn the old man, godlike  
Priam, answered him:19

553 “Do not seat me on a chair, Zeus-  
nurtured — not while Hector  
554 lies in the huts uncared-for. Give him  
back  
555 quickly, so my eyes can see him; and  
accept the ransom —  
556 the great ransom we bring you. May  
you have joy of it, and come  
557 to your own fatherland — since you  
have let me,  
558 from the first, live on and look upon  
the light of the sun.”  
559 Then, glaring darkly, swift-footed  
Achilles answered him:  
560 “Do not provoke me now, old man. I  
mean myself  
561 to give Hector back to you: a  
messenger came to me from Zeus —  
562 my mother, who bore me, the

daughter of the old man of the sea.

563 And I know you too, Priam — do not  
think to hide it:

564 some god led you to the swift ships of  
the Achaeans.

565 No mortal would have dared come  
into the camp — not even

566 a man in his prime: he could not have  
slipped past the sentries,

567 nor easily levered back the bar of our  
doors.

568 So do not stir my heart further in its  
griefs,

569 or I may not spare even you, old man,  
inside my huts —

570 suppliant though you are — and may  
trespass against the commands of Zeus.”

571 So he spoke; and the old man was  
afraid, and obeyed.

572 And the son of Peleus sprang out the  
door of the house like a lion —20  
573 not alone: two of his aides went with  
him,  
574 the hero Automedon and Alcimus, the  
two Achilles  
575 honored most of his companions after  
dead Patroclus.  
576 They loosed the horses and mules  
from the yokes,  
577 and led in the old man's clear-voiced  
herald  
578 and sat him on a bench; and from the  
polished wagon  
579 they lifted down the ransom past  
counting for Hector's head.  
580 But they left two mantles and a fine-  
spun tunic,  
581 so he might wrap the body and give it

to be carried home.

582 And Achilles called out slave-women,  
and ordered them to wash him

583 and anoint him — but apart, moved  
away, so Priam would not see his son:

584 lest the grief in his heart not master  
his anger

585 at the sight of his child, and Achilles'  
own spirit be stirred,

586 and he kill him, and trespass against  
the commands of Zeus.

587 And when the slave-women had  
washed him and anointed him with oil,

588 and wrapped the beautiful mantle and  
the tunic around him,

589 Achilles himself lifted him and laid  
him on a bier,

590 and his companions with him raised it  
onto the polished wagon.

591 Then he groaned, and called his dear  
companion by name:  
592 “Do not be angry with me, Patroclus,  
if you learn —  
593 even in the house of Hades — that I  
released brilliant Hector  
594 to his dear father: the ransom he gave  
was not unworthy.  
595 And to you, in turn, I will give your  
share of it — all that is fitting.”  
596 He spoke, and went back into the hut,  
brilliant Achilles,  
597 and sat down on the richly-worked  
couch he had risen from,  
598 against the far wall, and spoke his  
word to Priam:  
599 “Your son is given back, old man, as  
you commanded:  
600 he lies on a bier. At the showing of

dawn

601 you will see him yourself, and take  
him. Now — let us remember supper.

602 For even lovely-haired Niobe  
remembered food,21

603 though twelve children perished in  
her halls —

604 six daughters, and six sons in the  
pride of their youth.

605 The sons Apollo killed with his silver  
bow,

606 in anger at Niobe; and Artemis who  
showers arrows killed the daughters —

607 because Niobe had matched herself  
with fair-cheeked Leto:

608 Leto, she said, bore two; she herself  
had borne many.

609 So those two, though they were only  
two, destroyed them all.

610 Nine days they lay in their blood, and  
there was no one  
611 to bury them: the son of Cronos had  
turned the people to stones.  
612 On the tenth day the gods of heaven  
buried them.  
613 And she remembered food, when she  
was worn out with weeping.  
614 And now, somewhere among the  
rocks, in the lonely mountains,  
615 on Sipylus, where they say the  
goddess nymphs  
616 have their beds — the nymphs who  
dance along the Achelous —  
617 there, stone though she is, she broods  
on the griefs the gods gave her.  
618 Come then, noble old man: let the two  
of us also remember  
619 food. Afterward you may weep for



your dear son again,

620 when you have brought him into  
Ilion. He will cost you many tears.”

621 He spoke, and swift Achilles sprang up  
and slaughtered<sup>22</sup>

622 a white-fleeced sheep; and his  
companions flayed and dressed it well

623 and duly, and cut it up with skill, and  
pierced it on the spits,

624 and roasted it with care, and drew off  
every portion.

625 And Automedon took bread and set it  
out along the table

626 in beautiful baskets; and Achilles  
portioned out the meat.

627 And they reached out their hands to  
the good things lying ready.

628 And when they had put away the  
desire for drink and food,

629 then Priam, Dardanus's descendant,  
marveled at Achilles —  
630 how big he was, how beautiful: like  
the gods to look upon;  
631 and Achilles marveled at Priam,  
Dardanus's descendant,  
632 looking at his fine face and listening  
to his words.  
633 And when they had taken their fill of  
looking at each other,  
634 the first to speak was the old man,  
godlike Priam:23  
635 "Give me a bed now quickly, Zeus-  
nurtured, so that we  
636 may lie down at last and take our fill  
of sweet sleep.  
637 For my eyes have never closed  
beneath their lids  
638 since my son lost his life under your

hands:

639 I have done nothing but groan, and  
brood on griefs past counting,

640 rolling in the dung in the yard where  
my cattle are penned.

641 Now at last I have tasted bread, and let  
the gleaming wine

642 down my throat. Before this I had  
touched nothing.”

643 He spoke; and Achilles ordered his  
companions and the slave-women

644 to set out beds under the porch, and  
to throw on them

645 fine purple rugs, and spread blankets  
over these,

646 and lay out fleecy cloaks on top for  
covering.

647 And the women went from the hall  
with torches in their hands,

648 and quickly and busily made up two  
beds.

649 And swift-footed Achilles said to him,  
with an edge in his voice:

650 “Sleep outside, dear old man — in case  
some Achaean

651 councilor comes here: they are forever  
sitting

652 at my side weaving plans, as is their  
custom.

653 If one of them saw you through the  
running black night,

654 he would tell it at once to  
Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,

655 and there would be delay in the  
release of the body.

656 But come, tell me this, and recount it  
truly:

657 how many days do you need for the

burial of brilliant Hector —

658 so I may wait that long myself, and  
hold back the army.”

659 Then in turn the old man, godlike  
Priam, answered him:24

660 “If you are truly willing that I give  
brilliant Hector burial,

661 then this, Achilles, is how you would  
do me kindness.

662 You know how we are penned in the  
city; and the wood

663 is far to bring from the mountain, and  
the Trojans are afraid.

664 Nine days we would mourn him in the  
halls;

665 on the tenth we would bury him, and  
the people feast;

666 on the eleventh we would raise the  
mound above him;

667 and on the twelfth we will fight again  
— if we must.”

668 Then in turn swift-footed brilliant  
Achilles addressed him:

669 “This too shall be as you command,  
old Priam:

670 I will hold off the war for the time you  
ask.”

671 So speaking, he took the old man’s  
right hand

672 at the wrist, so his heart should not be  
afraid.

673 So there in the fore-hall of the house  
they lay down,

674 the herald and Priam, with close-  
packed counsel in their minds;

675 but Achilles slept in the inner corner  
of his strong-built hut,

676 and fair-cheeked Briseis lay beside

him.

677 The other gods, and men who fight  
from chariots,25

678 slept the whole night through,  
subdued by soft sleep;

679 but sleep would not take Hermes the  
helper,

680 turning it over in his heart how he  
would bring king Priam

681 away from the ships unseen by the  
strong gate-keepers.

682 He stood above his head, and spoke a  
word to him:

683 “Old man — no evil worries you, to  
judge by how you sleep

684 among enemy men, because Achilles  
spared you.

685 You have ransomed your dear son  
now; you paid a great price.

686 But for you — alive — your sons left  
behind would pay  
687 three times as much again, if  
Agamemnon  
688 Atreus's son knew of you — if all the  
Achaeans knew.”  
689 So he spoke; and the old man was  
afraid, and woke the herald.  
690 And Hermes yoked the horses and the  
mules for them,  
691 and drove them quickly through the  
camp himself; and no one knew.  
692 But when they came to the ford of the  
fair-flowing river,  
693 eddying Xanthus, whom immortal  
Zeus begot,  
694 then Hermes went his way to high  
Olympus,  
695 and Dawn in her saffron robe was



spreading over all the earth,  
696 and they drove the horses toward the  
city with wailing  
697 and lamentation; and the mules  
carried the dead.  
698 Nor did any other know them, man or  
fair-girdled woman —26  
699 only Cassandra, like golden Aphrodite,  
700 who had climbed Pergamus, and saw  
her dear father  
701 standing in the chariot, and the  
herald, the city's crier,  
702 and saw him too — lying on the bier  
behind the mules —  
703 and shrieked, and cried out through  
the whole city:  
704 “Come, men of Troy, women of Troy:  
come and see Hector —  
705 if ever, while he lived, you rejoiced

when he came home

706 from battle: for he was a great joy to  
the city and all its people.”

707 So she spoke; and not one man was  
left in the city,

708 not one woman: on all of them came  
grief past bearing;

709 and close by the gates they met him  
bringing home the dead.

710 First of all his dear wife and his lady  
mother

711 tore their hair for him, rushing at the  
smooth-wheeled wagon,

712 touching his head; and the crowd  
stood around them, weeping.

713 And now the whole day long until the  
setting sun

714 they would have mourned Hector  
before the gates, pouring their tears,

715 had not the old man spoken to the  
people from his chariot:  
716 “Make way for the mules to pass.  
Afterward  
717 you may glut yourselves with weeping  
— when I have brought him home.”  
718 So he spoke; and they parted, and  
made way for the wagon.  
719 And when they had brought him into  
the famous house, they laid him  
720 on a corded bed, and set beside him  
singers,  
721 leaders of the dirge, who sang their  
mournful song —  
722 they chanted the dirge, and the  
women wailed in answer.  
723 And among them white-armed  
Andromache led the lament, 27  
724 holding in her hands the head of man-

slaughtering Hector:

725 “Husband — you were lost young out  
of life, and you leave me

726 a widow in your halls; and the boy is  
just a baby still,

727 whom we bore, you and I — the two  
ill-fated. And I think

728 he will not reach manhood: before  
that, this city

729 will be sacked from its height. For you  
have perished — you, its watcher,

730 who guarded it, and kept safe its  
honored wives and little children.

731 They will ride away soon in the hollow  
ships,

732 and I with them. And you, my child —  
you will follow me

733 where degrading labors wait for you,

734 drudging under a harsh master’s eye

— or some Achaean

735 will seize you by the arm and fling you  
from the wall — a wretched death —

736 in anger, because Hector killed his  
brother,

737 or his father, or his son: for very many  
Achaeans

738 bit the boundless earth in their teeth  
at Hector's hands.

739 Your father was not gentle in the sad  
fighting;

740 and so the people mourn him through  
the city,

741 and you have laid a cursed grief and  
mourning, Hector,

742 on your parents. And for me beyond  
all others the bitter

743 pain is left: you did not die in bed,  
reaching your arms to me,

744 you spoke no close last word that I  
might have  
745 remembered always, nights and days,  
with my tears falling.”  
746 So she spoke, weeping; and the  
women wailed in answer.  
747 And among them Hecuba in her turn  
led the thick lament:28  
748 “Hector — far dearest to my heart of  
all my children,  
749 dear to the gods you were while you  
lived with me,  
750 and they have cared for you even in  
the portion of death.  
751 My other sons — swift-footed Achilles  
would sell them,  
752 whichever ones he took, across the  
barren sea,  
753 into Samos, and Imbros, and Lemnos

of the smoke.

754 But you — when he had taken your life  
with the long-edged bronze,

755 he dragged you again and again  
around the tomb of his companion

756 Patroclus, whom you killed — though  
not even so did he raise him up.

757 And now you lie in my halls dewy-  
fresh, as if newly slain,

758 like one whom Apollo of the silver  
bow has visited

759 and killed with his gentle arrows.”

760 So she spoke, weeping, and roused the  
endless lament.

761 And third after them, Helen led the  
lament:29

762 “Hector — far dearest to my heart of  
all my husband’s brothers!

763 My husband is godlike Alexandros,

764 who brought me to Troy. I wish I had  
died before that day.

765 This is now the twentieth year for me  
766 since I came away from there and left  
my own country;

767 yet never once did I hear from you an  
evil word, or a slighting one.

768 No — if any other rebuked me in the  
halls,

769 a brother of my husband, or a sister,  
or a brother's fine-robed wife,

770 or my husband's mother — though his  
father was always gentle as my own —

771 you would turn them aside, you would  
restrain them,

772 with your gentle-mindedness and  
your gentle words.

773 And so I weep for you — and for  
myself, doomed as I am — grieving at



heart:

774 for there is no one else now in wide  
Troy

775 gentle to me, or kind: they all shudder  
at me.”

776 So she spoke, weeping; and the vast  
crowd groaned in answer.

777 And old Priam spoke his word among  
the people:30

778 “Bring wood now, Trojans, into the  
city; and have no fear

779 in your hearts of an Argive ambush:  
for Achilles,

780 sending me from the black ships, gave  
me his pledge

781 that he will do us no harm until the  
twelfth dawn comes.”

782 So he spoke; and they yoked oxen and  
mules to the wagons,

783 and quickly then they gathered before  
the city.

784 Nine days they hauled in wood past  
measuring;

785 and when the tenth dawn rose with its  
light for mortals,

786 then they carried out bold Hector,  
weeping,

787 and set the body on the height of the  
pyre, and threw on the fire.

788 And when young Dawn showed again,  
the rosy-fingered,

789 then the people gathered around  
glorious Hector's pyre.

790 And when they had assembled and  
were gathered together,

791 first they quenched the burning-place  
with glistening wine,

792 all of it, wherever the fire's strength

had reached; and then  
793 his brothers and companions gathered  
the white bones,  
794 mourning, and the swollen tears ran  
down their cheeks.  
795 And they took the bones and laid  
them in a golden box,  
796 wrapping them in soft purple robes,  
797 and quickly set it down in a hollow  
grave,  
798 and roofed it over with great stones  
set close together;  
799 and swiftly they heaped the mound —  
with watchers posted round on every side,  
800 lest the strong-greaved Achaeans  
should storm out before the time.  
801 And when they had heaped the  
mound they went back; and then,  
802 gathered together in due order, they

feasted a glorious feast

803 in the house of Priam, the king  
nurtured of Zeus.

804 So they busied themselves with the  
burial of Hector, the tamer of horses.

## Notes

### NOTES

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#### NOTES

1. (24.1-21) The book opens on the community dissolving back into ordinary life — supper, sweet sleep — and one man exempt: Achilles cycling through the postures of grief (side, back, face-down, up and pacing), unreached by “sleep that subdues all things.” The dawns are iterative — the Greek’s tenses make the dragging a routine: harness, drag three times round the tomb, rest, leave him face-down. And the routine accomplishes nothing: Apollo with the golden aegis keeps the flesh whole, “pitying the

man even in death.” Rage has become machinery — running, grinding, and feeding no one. That futility is the book’s premise. ↩

2. (24.22-30) The divine majority wants the corpse stolen; three gods refuse — Hera, Poseidon, Athena — because of the poem’s oldest wound: “the blindness of Alexandros, who insulted the goddesses when they came to his sheep-fold, and praised the one who fed his grievous lust.” This is the Iliad’s only mention of the Judgment of Paris, and Aristarchus athetized the passage — partly because the poem nowhere else knows the story, partly for the coarse word μαχλοσύνη (“lust”). Kept here: at the very end, the poem finally names the beginning — a beauty contest on a hillside as the seed of everything we have watched. ↩

3. (24.31-54) Apollo’s indictment is the poem’s ethical summit-speech: Achilles has “destroyed pity,” and lost aidōs — the shame-before-others “which harms men greatly, and profits them too”: the double-edged social emotion that the whole epic runs on, defined in one line. The lion comparison strips the aristeia of its glamour (savagery “at the flocks of men, to take his feast”); and the norm is stated with

terrible gentleness: a man may lose a brother or a son, “and yet, when he has wept and lamented, he lets go: for the Fates gave mankind an enduring heart” (τλητὸν γὰρ Μοῖραι θυμὸν θέσαν ἀνθρώποισιν) — endurance as the species-defining gift. The close is the book’s moral in five words: “it is dumb earth he defiles in all his fury” — the dead man is beyond harm; the harm is all the living man’s own. ↩

4. (24.55-76) Hera’s counter is pure rank (a breast-fed mortal cannot be priced with a goddess’s son — with her swipe at Apollo’s lyre-playing at the very wedding: “companion of evils, faithless forever”); and Zeus’s ruling splits the difference with statesman’s care: no equal honor — but Hector was “dearest to the gods of all mortals in Ilion” for the oldest reason in the poem’s theology, the unfailing altar. The theft is rejected on practical grounds (Thetis’s watch), but the true design appears in one phrase: “I attach this glory (κῦδος) to Achilles” — the return of the body is arranged not as defeat but as honor, mercy denominated in the only currency the recipient still values. ↩

5. (24.77-119) Iris's dive "like the lead sinker that rides the horn of a field-ox down the line" — the most homely simile ever given a goddess: heaven's messenger as fishing-tackle. Thetis's veil is the poem's blackest object ("there is no garment blacker"): she dresses for her son's death to attend a council about his mercy. On Olympus the courtesies are exact — Athena yields her place, Hera hands the cup — the divine family arranging itself gently around a bereaved mother whose bereavement has not yet happened. ↩
6. (24.120-142) Thetis delivers Zeus's rebuke and adds what no god scripted: "it is good to lie with a woman in love. For you will not be with me long..." (Aristarchus athetized 130-132 as indecorous; they are the scene's heart). A mother's last advice to a doomed son is bread, bed, and love — the whole mortal portion, urged because the portion is nearly spent. And Achilles' answer, after three books of iron: "So be it" (τῇδ' εἴη) — the wrath that filled an epic ends in two words of assent, the moment the demand comes from the one person he cannot refuse, carrying an honor he can accept. ↩

7. (24.143-187) Iris's commission to Priam repeats Zeus's wording verbatim (146-158 = 175-187, kept identical here): heaven's mercy delivered twice, unedited — the poem's formulaic economy made providential. The house she enters is a tableau of collective ruin: sons weeping in the courtyard, daughters and sons' wives wailing within, and the king wrapped in his mantle with dung on his head and neck, "gathered on himself with his own hands." The message lands on a man already performing his own burial. ↩
8. (24.188-228) The marriage scene: Priam tells Hecuba, and her answer is the poem's final maternal ferocity — the wish to "fasten on that man's liver, and eat it raw." The raw-eating triplet closes: Hera (4.35), Achilles (22.346), and now Hecuba — goddess of the winning side, killer, and grieving mother speaking one idiom; grief and hate converge in the same appetite. Priam's answer sets the book's terms: he has seen the god face to face; and if the price is death, "I choose it. Let Achilles kill me on the spot — once I have taken my son in my arms, and put away my fill of weeping." The embassy is a father's calculated exchange: his life, if need be, for one embrace. ↩



9. (24.229-264) The ransom counted out (the poem loves the inventory: robes, cloaks, blankets, mantles, tunics, twelve of each; ten talents; tripods, cauldrons, the Thracian cup “not even this did the old man spare”) — and then Priam’s rage: first at the Trojans (“Have you no mourning of your own at home?”), then the terrible roll- call of the nine surviving sons — “liars, dancers, heroes of the beaten dance-floor, plunderers of their own people’s lambs and kids” — against the dead: Mestor, Troilus, “and Hector, who was a god among men.” Grief in old men, the poem knows, comes out as fury at the living for not being the dead. (Among the cursed: Helenus, Paris, Deiphobus — the city’s remaining leadership, measured and found wanting by their father in public.) ↩
10. (24.265-282) The yoking, in loving procedural detail — the box-wood yoke, the knob, the guide-rings, the nine-cubit lashing wound three times each way. The poem slows to craftsman’s tempo exactly as it did for Hera’s chariot and Priam’s own libation to come: ritual care in the doing is how the Iliad marks an act as sacred. This wagon is an altar being assembled. ↩

11. (24.283-322) Hecuba's libation-counsel — having failed to stop him, she arms him with piety: pour to Zeus, ask for the eagle on the right; "but if wide-seeing Zeus will not give you his messenger, I at least would not urge you." The omen comes: the dusky hunter-eagle, wings as wide "as the door of some rich man's high-roofed treasure-chamber" — the simile drawn from precisely the world of stored wealth Priam has just emptied for the ransom. And the exit: all Troy follows the wagon "mourning without end, as if he were going to his death" — which is, as far as anyone knows, the truth. ↩
12. (24.322-362) Zeus's commission to Hermes defines the god: "to you, beyond all gods, it is dearest to be man's companion" (ἄνδρὶ ἐταίρισσαι) — the escort-god, the one Olympian whose office is company. He comes as a princely youth "with the first down on his lip — the age when youth has its highest grace," and the meeting at the ford by Ilus's tomb, at dusk, is built as pure terror first: the herald's whisper, the old man's hair standing on his bent limbs — before the god takes his hand. Every earlier night-crossing in this poem (Book 10) ended in blood; the poem uses that memory to make this one tremble. ↩

13. (24.362-440) The interrogation is Hermes at play — “You are the image of my own dear father”; the invented Myrmidon biography (seventh son of Polyctor, chosen by lot) — but its center is the report on the corpse: twelve days dead, dragged daily, and “his flesh does not decay... You would marvel yourself, if you came, at how he lies there dewy-fresh, the blood all washed from him, no stain anywhere; and every wound has closed... Such is the care the blessed gods take for your son, a dead man though he is — because they loved him at heart.” The kindest sentence in the Iliad, spoken by a disguised god to a father in the dark. Priam’s response makes it doctrine — “how good a thing it is to give the immortals their due gifts” — with the one heartbreaking parenthesis, “if ever he truly was” (εἴ ποτ’ ἔην γε): grief’s suspicion that the beloved might have been a dream. Hermes’ refusal of the cup — no gifts “behind Achilles’ back” — teaches with a light hand the order of things: even gods respect what is owed to Achilles; mercy must come from the man himself. ↩

14. (24.440-468) Into the camp: sleep poured on the sentries, the gates opened — and the poem pauses to build Achilles’ hut in full (fir beams, meadow-thatch,

the palisade court) for the sake of one detail: the fir-wood bar that “three Achaeans would drive home and three would draw... though Achilles would ram it home alone.” The door is a strength-gauge; Hermes opens it for an old man. His parting instructions are the supplication-manual: knees, and the names — father, mother, child. ↩

15. (24.469-485) The entrance. Priam walks in unseen (a god's last gift), and the recognition is staged in gestures before any word: knees clasped, and the kiss — “the terrible, man-slaughtering hands that had killed so many of his sons” (χεῖρας δεινὰς ἀνδροφόνους): the fixed epithet of Hector's hands, then Achilles', pressed now to a father's lips. Then the simile that turns the world over: as when a man who has killed someone in his own country arrives in exile at a rich man's hall, “and wonder holds all who see him” — the innocent suppliant king compared to a murderer, the killer cast as the startled host. The reversal is the scene's meaning: guilt and grief have changed places so many times in this poem that only an exchanged simile can measure the moment. “And the others wondered too, and looked at one another” — the poem's

people, like its audience, checking that everyone is seeing this. ↩

16. (24.486-507) The plea. “Remember your father” — the argument Hermes assigned and Priam perfects: Peleus, same age, same encircling enemies — but with hope, because his son lives; “But I am doomed to the last”: fifty sons, nineteen from one womb, and the guardian of all of them killed “days ago, fighting for his fatherland: Hector” — the name held back to the end of its clause. Then the two lines on which the Iliad closes its account of what humans can do: “I have endured what no other mortal on earth has yet endured — to lift to my lips the hand of the man who killed my son.” Endurance — Apollo’s *τλητὸν θυμόν* of line 49 — performed past its imaginable limit. ↩

17. (24.507-518) The weeping. Priam’s words stir in Achilles “the desire to weep for his father” — grief answering grief by way of substitution — and the poem’s quietest, deepest sentence: “the two of them remembered: the one wept long and sore for man-slaughtering Hector, huddled at Achilles’ feet, and Achilles wept for his own father — and now again for Patroclus; and the sound of their mourning filled the house.” Two men weeping for different dead in one

sound: shared mourning without shared objects — the only communion the Iliad believes in, and enough. When it is spent, Achilles lifts the old man up by the hand, “pitying the grey head and the grey beard” — the exact grey head and beard Priam foresaw defiled by his own dogs (22.74): the image returns, and is pitied instead. ↩

18. (24.518-553) The consolation of the jars. Achilles’ speech is the poem’s theology spoken by its protagonist: “this is the way the gods have spun it for wretched mortals: to live in grief. And they themselves are free of care.” Two jars on Zeus’s floor — evils and blessings — and only two possible mixtures: mixed, or purely evil. No mortal draws unmixed good; the best life alternates. The proofs are the two fathers in the room: Peleus — wealth, kingship, a goddess-wife — and one doomed son who gives him “no care in his old age”; Priam — wealth and sons from Lesbos to the Hellespont — and this. The counsel is Apollo’s from line 49, now spoken by the man it indicted: “Bear it... you will not raise him up.” Achilles has become the teacher of the endurance he could not practice; saying it to Priam is how he begins to practice it. ↩

19. (24.552-573) The flash of the old fire: Priam pushes — no chair while Hector lies uncared-for — and Achilles darkens: “Do not provoke me now, old man... or I may not spare even you... suppliant though you are, and may trespass against the commands of Zeus.” The rage is not cured; it is contained, and knows itself. That self- knowledge — Achilles managing his own danger like a man banking a fire — is what makes the mercy trustworthy: the poem does not sentimentalize its hero into safety; it shows him holding himself, barely and deliberately, on the right side of the line. “And the old man was afraid, and obeyed.” ↩

20. (24.574-597) The ransoming, managed with the same self- knowledge: the body washed and anointed away from Priam’s sight, “lest the grief in his heart not master his anger... and Achilles’ own spirit be stirred, and he kill him” — mercy engineering its own conditions. Then Achilles himself lifts Hector onto the bier: the hands that dragged him now carry him — the body given back by the same strength that destroyed it. And the apology to Patroclus, with its scrupulous accounting (“the ransom he gave was not unworthy — and I will give you your share”): even now, the dead friend is a partner whose

consent matters, and the transaction must be squared with the grave. ↩

21. (24.598-622) Niobe. The paradigm is chosen with terrifying precision: the mother of twelve dead children “remembered food” — therefore eat. Inside it, the poem’s darkest wonder-tale: nine days the children lay in blood “and there was no one to bury them: the son of Cronos had turned the people to stones. On the tenth day the gods of heaven buried them” — a world petrified by grief until heaven itself performs the funeral; and Niobe on Sipylus, “stone though she is, she broods on the griefs the gods gave her” (614-617 were athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus — the mourner turned mountain, weeping forever, kept here). Eating, in this logic, is not the end of grief but the body’s assent to go on being mortal: Niobe ate; Achilles ate (24.475-476; 19’s fast long broken); now Priam must. The shared meal is the sacrament of the enduring heart. ↩

22. (24.623-635) The meal and the gaze. Achilles slaughters, his companions dress, Automedon serves, Achilles portions — the host’s offices performed in full for the father of his enemy. And then the poem’s most humane astonishment: “Priam



marveled at Achilles — how big he was, how beautiful: like the gods to look upon; and Achilles marveled at Priam... And when they had taken their fill of looking at each other” (the verb of satiety the book has used for grief and food now given to sight). Two men who have destroyed each other’s lives sit and behold each other as marvels. It is the closest the Iliad comes to peace: not reconciliation, not forgiveness — just the full, mutual, unhurried sight of another human being. ↩

23. (24.636-660) Priam’s first sleep-request since his son died (“my eyes have never closed... I have done nothing but groan”), and his first food (“Before this I had touched nothing” — his fast ending in the same hut where Achilles’ ended). Achilles’ bed-arrangement comes “with an edge in his voice” (ἐπικερτομέων): sleep outside, lest a wandering Achaean councilor see you and Agamemnon “delay the release of the body” — the grim comedy of a mercy that must be hidden from its own army, and a last flick at the king he quarreled with. Then the question no one could have predicted in Book 22: “how many days do you need for the burial of brilliant Hector?” ↩

24. (24.661-678) The truce: nine days of mourning, the tenth for burial and the feast, the eleventh for the mound — “and on the twelfth we will fight again — if we must” (εἴ περ ἀνάγκη: the war resumed as necessity, not appetite; no one in this room wants it anymore). Achilles grants it with the book’s definitive gesture: he takes the old man’s right hand “at the wrist, so his heart should not be afraid” — the killer’s hand as guarantee of safety. And then, in one clause with no comment: “and fair-cheeked Briseis lay beside him.” The woman the wrath began over is home; Thetis’s counsel (130-132) is kept; the poem’s first quarrel closes in a domestic sentence. ↩
25. (24.679-695) Hermes’ midnight warning turns the ransom grammar around — “for you — alive — your sons left behind would pay three times as much”: Priam himself is the last treasure in the camp — and the departure crosses “the ford of the fair-flowing river, eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus begot”: the register’s line (14.433-434 = 21.1-2), at its third and last station. Hector was revived at this ford; the rout was split here; now his body crosses it homeward. Hermes leaves at the boundary; Dawn in her saffron robe spreads over the whole earth; the poem’s last day begins. ↩

26. (24.696-724) Cassandra — her only appearance in the poem's action, “like golden Aphrodite” — is Troy's watcher now (climbing Pergamus as Priam climbed the tower), and her cry is the city's whole relation to Hector in one sentence: “come and see Hector — if ever, while he lived, you rejoiced when he came home from battle.” The gate-scene reprises Book 22's discovery in the key of ritual — wife and mother first, hands on his head — and Priam's crowd-order (“you may glut yourselves with weeping — when I have brought him home”) is grief marshaled into procession. The bed, the singers, the antiphony: at last, the apparatus of proper mourning around the body that was promised to dogs. ↩

27. (24.725-749) Andromache's lament — holding “the head of man-slaughtering Hector in her hands”: the epithet of the killing hands (479, 509) given now to the head a widow cradles; the poem's fiercest word gentled by its final position. Her lament is all future tense: the child who “will not reach manhood,” the city sacked, the ships, the slavery — and the alternative she imagines for Astyanax, flung from the wall by an Achaean avenging what “Hector killed — his brother, or his father, or his son”: the fate the tradition indeed assigns him, spoken here as a

mother's reasoned dread. Her last grievance is the tenderest in the poem: "you did not die in bed, reaching your arms to me, you spoke no close last word that I might have remembered always" — not the death, but the missing goodbye. ↩

28. (24.750-763) Hecuba's lament is a theodicy: her sold sons (Samos, Imbros, "Lemnos of the smoke") against this one, killed, dragged — "though not even so did he raise him up" (the futility of the outrage stated by the victim's mother) — and yet lying "dewy-fresh, as if newly slain, like one whom Apollo of the silver bow has visited and killed with his gentle arrows." The gods' care, which Hermes reported to Priam in the dark, is now visible in Troy by torchlight: the body itself has become the proof that heaven loved him. ↩

29. (24.764-779) Helen's lament, third and last — the poem's final speech given to the woman the war was fought over. Twenty years from home, and her praise of Hector is the smallest and most exact in the three laments: "never once did I hear from you an evil word, or a slighting one" — and when others reviled her, "you would turn them aside... with your gentle-mindedness and your gentle words." She

mourns him as the last kindness in Troy — “there is no one else now in wide Troy gentle to me, or kind: they all shudder at me” — so that the poem’s cause weeps for the poem’s best man as her only friend. The crowd’s groan answers her: the city, for one moment, grieving with the woman it shudders at. ↩

30. (24.780-804) The ending: the truce honored (wood gathered nine days under Achilles’ pledge), the pyre, rosy-fingered Dawn, the wine-quench and white bones — the rites following, step for step, the liturgy of Patroclus’s funeral in Book 23: the two enemies buried by the same book of rites. The bones in the golden box, the soft purple robes, the hollow grave roofed with great stones, the mound raised quickly with watchers posted (grief efficient under threat — the war visible at the edges of the funeral), and the feast “in the house of Priam, the king nurtured of Zeus.” Then the last line: “So they busied themselves with the burial of Hector, the tamer of horses” — the poem of wrath ends with no death, no fall, no victory: with rites performed, a feast eaten, and a single dead man given his due — the γέρας θανόντων Achilles named at 23.9. Everything else — Achilles’ death, the horse, the sack, the fates Andromache numbered — stands just outside the

final line, known to every hearer and refused entry. (Antiquity's rhapsodes felt the door ajar: a variant continuation ran "So they busied themselves with the burial of Hector; and there came the Amazon, the daughter of great-hearted Ares..." — splicing the epic onward into the Aethiopsis. Our text ends where the poet ended: on the funeral, the feast, and the name of the man the city buried.) The Iliad begins with a father begging a king for his child and being refused; it ends with a father begging a king for his child and being answered. That is the distance the poem travels; the wrath of Achilles is the space between. ↩

# The Translator's Notes on the Books

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The note on each book, collected here so the poem itself reads clean. Each heading links back to its book; in the text, the line under every book's argument links here.

## Book 1

This translation aims at plain, dignified modern English free verse, kept line-for-line with the Greek of the Monro-Allen text (books/book\_01.txt) so that any English line can be checked against its original. It follows the printed text throughout, including passages that ancient critics athetized (marked as spurious but retained); atheteses are recorded in the notes, not acted on. Where the printed text itself embodies an editorial choice against the manuscript majority — most strikingly at 1.350, where it reads “boundless sea” where nearly all manuscripts have the famous “wine-dark sea” — the note says so.



The poem's first word, *mēnis*, is rendered "wrath" rather than "rage" or "anger": *mēnis* in Homer is not a mood but a durable, quasi-divine cosmic grudge, and English "wrath" carries the required archaic, more-than-human weight. The other load-bearing terms of the quarrel are kept consistent so their economy stays visible: *timē* is always "honor," *geras* always "prize" (the concrete, publicly awarded object in which honor is embodied — Chryseis, Briseis), and *atē* "blindness" (the god-sent ruin-bringing delusion Agamemnon will later plead). The quarrel of Book 1 is unintelligible unless the reader can see that Achilles' complaint is not about a woman but about the public arithmetic of honor; the vocabulary is kept rigid for that reason.

Recurring epithets are translated by fixed English equivalents (“swift-footed Achilles,” “white-armed Hera,” “the lord of men Agamemnon”), footnoted at first occurrence only, and logged in translation/CONVENTIONS.md as binding for later books. Fixity is deliberate: the epithets are load-bearing oral formulas, and varying them for elegance would erase exactly the texture that makes them Homeric. Proper names use familiar Latinized spellings (Achilles, Ajax, Clytemnestra), also logged there.

On the one Book 1 entry in disputed\_lines.md (1.4-5): Zenodotus athetized both lines, and his text is reported to have read *daita*, making the corpses a “feast” for the birds. The translation follows the vulgate (“prey for

dogs / and every bird”), keeping the grim literal image rather than the sardonic “banquet”; the opening sentence is already as harsh as English can decently make it, and the “feast” reading, though grotesquely apt, rests on a single reported reading of doubtful standing. See note [3]. One grammatical crux was settled by the project’s morphology files: at 1.291 the treebank parses *protheousin* as a form of *protithēmi* (“set forth, grant”), and the translation follows it (“do they therefore give him leave to hurl insults?”); the rival parse is recorded in note [25].

## Book 2

Book 2 falls into two very different halves — the night-intrigue, failed test, and Thersites scene (1-493), and then the Catalogue of Ships with its Trojan counterpart (494-877) — and the main book-wide decision here was how to handle the second half. The Catalogue has been suspected since antiquity's critics and modern Analysts alike of being an originally independent composition, and several manuscripts omit the span entirely (see note [20]). I have translated it as fully integral, and deliberately kept its litany register rather than flattening it into a gazetteer: one English line per Greek line as elsewhere, every place-epithet

translated (“Thisbe of the many doves,” “rocky Aulis”), leader-genealogies given their full ceremonial weight. The incantatory repetition of the ship-count refrains (“With him followed forty black ships”) is preserved exactly where the Greek repeats and varied only where the Greek varies. The little narrative windows that open out of the list — Thamyris maimed by the Muses, Protesilaus’ half-built house, Philoctetes on Lemnos, Nireus beautiful and negligible — are the Catalogue’s own pulse, and the notes flag them rather than the geography.

The other live decision was tonal: Odysseus’ two-tier crowd control (kings get “gentle words,” commoners get the scepter across the back). Aristarchus athetized 193-197, and the passage is

independently missing from Xenophon's quotation of the scene (note [11]); I translate as printed and let the class asymmetry stand at full strength, since Thersites' beating immediately afterward depends on it. Thersites himself I have kept rough — "endless babble," "word-slinging insulter" — because the poem's own verdict on him is rough; this is the one place in the Iliad where the army's laughter is turned on a named common soldier, and softening it misrepresents the scene.

Zenodotus is unusually active in this book: he condensed the Dream's triple-repeated message (notes [4]), athetized Agamemnon's atē-speech (11-118, note [7]), the Thersites portrait-lines, the Nireus anaphora (note [26]), and the Achilles-

passage inside the Catalogue (note [27]). As in Book 1, the translation follows the printed vulgate text throughout and records *atheteses* in the notes.

Two carried-over threads from Book 1 to watch: Agamemnon here blames his quarrel with Achilles on Zeus-sent *atē* (“blindness,” 111, and openly “it was I who began the anger,” 378) — the same vocabulary Achilles used of him at 1.412; and the Catalogue’s Achilles-paragraph (686-694) holds the plot’s tension in place mid-list. New recurring epithets are footnoted at first occurrence and logged in translation/CONVENTIONS.md; the famous crux at 318 (did the god make the serpent-portent “conspicuous” or “invisible”?) is note [14], and the Salamis

couplet with its ancient forgery accusation  
is note [23].



## Book 3

Book 3 reads like the war's first year transplanted into its tenth: a duel between the two men the whole war is about, a truce, and Helen naming the Achaean commanders for Priam as though he had never seen them in nine years of siege. Ancient and modern critics alike noticed the chronological strain; the poem plainly does not care, and the translation does not try to smooth it. What the book actually does is introduce the war's cause and cast in the most economical way possible, and it is built almost entirely out of formal, ceremonial speech — challenge, herald's summons, oath, prayer, curse. Those registers are rendered with deliberate

stiffness (the oath-language especially), because Book 9's embassy and later truce scenes will reuse them; the conventions are logged in translation/CONVENTIONS.md.

One idiom is kept literal as a matter of policy: ὄρκια τάμνειν, “to cut oaths” — from cutting the victims' throats — is translated “cut the sworn oaths” throughout, not softened to “swear a treaty.” The whole oath scene (hair distributed to the chief men, wine poured as the curse names the perjurers' spilled brains, the lambs' throats cut with the same knife) is a single ritual gesture, and the verb carries it.

Paris is called both Ἀλέξανδρος and Πάρις by the poem, with Ἀλέξανδρος predominating; the translation reproduces

whichever name the Greek uses in each line rather than normalizing to “Paris” (see note [2]). Helen’s voice is this book’s discovery: her self-lacerating “dog-face that I am” (note [13]), the elders’ hushed astonishment, and the confrontation in which she — alone of mortals in the Iliad — talks back to a god to her face and is crushed into obedience (notes [22]-[24]). Aristarchus athetized both that confrontation and her bitter speech to Paris; Zenodotus rewrote the line in which Aphrodite carries her a chair. The ancient editors were visibly uncomfortable with exactly the scenes a modern reader values most, and the notes record each intervention while the translation keeps the vulgate text intact.

The apparatus also preserves, at line 302, four “plus verses” found in a Ptolemaic papyrus but absent from the medieval manuscripts — a live specimen of the pre-Aristarchean fluidity of the text (note [19]).

## Book 4

Book 4 contains the poem's moral pivot — the gods deliberately engineer the breaking of a sworn truce — and its first battle. The divine council that opens the book is the darkest divine politics in the Iliad: Zeus proposes peace (perhaps in earnest, perhaps as bait), Hera offers him her own three dearest cities, Argos, Sparta, and Mycenae, to destroy at will in exchange for Troy's ruin, and Zeus concedes with the unforgettable “willingly — with unwilling heart.” Aristarchus athetized the sharpest couplet of Hera's speech (55-56; note [3]), but the transaction stands in the text: the war resumes because two gods trade cities like

counters. I have translated the scene coldly, without softening the horse-trading tone, because the Pandarus scene that follows — Athena talking a fool into perjury his whole people will pay for — is its direct execution.

This is also the book where the poem's combat idiom begins, and the conventions set here bind the remaining twenty books (all logged in translation/CONVENTIONS.md): death formulas rendered fixed and unvarying (“darkness covered his eyes”; “he fell with a thud, and his armor clattered upon him”; “unstrung his limbs”), wound anatomy kept clinically precise as the Greek keeps it, and the armor vocabulary settled (ζωστήρ “war-belt,” ζῶμα “loin-guard,” μίτρη “waist-guard”). The first man to die

in the Iliad is Echepolus at 457 (note [22]); the first extended pathos-vignette is Simoeisios at 473-489 (note [23]), the young man felled like a poplar cut for a chariot-wheel, who “never paid back the cost of his rearing” — the template for a hundred deaths to come.

Agamemnon’s inspection tour (the *epipōlēsis*, 223-421) is the book’s long character study: honeyed words for Idomeneus and the Ajaxes, wistful respect for Nestor, and gratuitous insults for Odysseus and Diomedes — both unearned, both answered in ways that define each man (Odysseus with hot dignity, Diomedes with a silence that will pay out in Book 9). The rebuke of Diomedes drags in the Theban saga (notes [18], [19]) — the Iliad’s fullest glance at the war of the previous

generation, and Sthenelus's retort ("we took seven-gated Thebes; our fathers died of their own recklessness") was athetized by Aristarchus, perhaps for its flat contradiction of Agamemnon's point.



## Book 5

Book 5 is the poem's first *aristeia* — the sustained blaze of a single hero — and its most theologically audacious book: a mortal wounds two gods, and the poem takes the wounds seriously enough to invent divine physiology for them (ichor, “for they eat no bread,” note [16]) and divine medicine (Paiëon and the rennet simile, notes [18], [43]). The structure is a standing order and its two-stage release: Athena's instruction at 127-132 — fight no god except Aphrodite — governs the first half; her revocation at 825-834 licenses the second. Diomedes is exactly as obedient as the order requires, which is what separates his god-fighting from *hybris*: when Apollo

warns him off with the poem's theology compressed into one couplet ("never of one kind / are the race of immortal gods and of men who walk the earth," 441-442, note [21]), he yields at the fourth rush. That three-times-then-the-fourth pattern is planted here for its terrible recurrences later in the poem.

The book's gods are physical to the point of comedy, and the translation does not tone it down: the chariot axle groans under Athena's weight (athetized by Aristarchus, note [39]), Ares bellows like ten thousand men and then whimpers to his father, and Zeus's rebuke of him (889-891) repeats verbatim the words Agamemnon flung at Achilles in Book 1 — "most hateful to me are you... strife is always dear to you, and wars, and battles"

— the poem’s own judgment on the war-god delivered in a mortal quarrel’s language (note [42]). Dione’s consolation of the wounded Aphrodite (382-404) reaches back to older, stranger myth — Ares thirteen months in a bronze jar, Hera and Hades shot by Heracles — and Dione herself, Aphrodite’s mother here, contradicts the Hesiodic foam-birth (note [17]).

Two continuity matters are recorded rather than smoothed: Pylaemenes, killed at 576, will reappear alive in Book 13 — the most famous authorial nod in the poem (note [26]) — and the Ortilochus/Orsilochus spellings at 542-549 follow the printed text’s own variation. New fixed epithets are registered for Ares (“bane of mortals,” “blood-stained,”

“rushing,” “brazen”) and for the book’s one-off divine names (Cypris, Enyo, Paiëon, the Seasons). The formula checker has been extended to cover the Ares set.

## Book 6

Book 6 is the poem's great turn inward: the battle continues offstage while Hector walks through his city — mother, brother, sister-in-law, wife, son — and every meeting is a farewell taken in advance. The book's engineering is visible and unbearable at once: Athena refuses Troy's prayer in a single line ("But Pallas Athena turned her head away," 311 — athetized by Aristarchus, kept here as the bleakest line in the poem), Hector answers Andromache's plea with the same verbatim prophecy Agamemnon spoke as a threat in Book 4 ("the day will come when holy Ilion shall perish," 448-449 — an echo the translation reproduces word for word),

and the household mourns Hector alive before he has died (500-502). Against all this the poem sets its one scene of family comedy — the baby screaming at his father’s helmet crest, and both parents laughing (466-474).

The Glaucus-Diomedes encounter (119-236) — which some ancient critics wanted to transpose elsewhere in the poem (note [6]) — carries the book’s other cargo: the generation-of-leaves simile, the Bellerophon story with the poem’s only reference to writing (the “baneful signs... in a folded tablet,” note [10]), and the guest-friendship that stops a duel and ends in the proverbial exchange of gold armor for bronze.

Two register events. First, the δμῶς policy adopted from the Odyssey project goes

live: δμῳαί is rendered “slave-women” at its first occurrences (6.323, 375-376, note [21]), with ἀμφίπολος “handmaid” and ταμίη “housekeeper” kept distinct — the vocabulary of the household the book itself is about, in the book where Hector imagines Andromache’s “day of slavery” (463). Second, Agamemnon’s atrocity-counsel at 55-60 (kill even the unborn) is followed by the narrator’s much-disputed half-line “for his urging was of things due” (αἴσιμα παρειπών) — translated at face value and flagged in note [3], where the interpretive dispute belongs.

## Book 7

Book 7 is the poem's book of institutions. Its duel replays Book 3 with the war's real fighters — and the poem says so in its own medium: the spear-exchange at 244-254 reuses the Paris-Menelaus lines of 3.355-360 verbatim, and this translation repeats its own Book 3 English word for word (note [16]). Around the duel stand the machinery of managed violence: the challenge with terms for the corpse, the marked lots, the heralds parting the fighters at dusk ("It is good to yield to night as well"), the exchange of gifts — Hector's sword and Ajax's belt, on which later tradition hung both their deaths (note [20]) — the burial truce, the diplomatic offer and its refusal,



and at last the wall and ditch that will be the stage-set of Books 8-15.

The wall carries the book's strangest scene: Poseidon's complaint that the Achaeans built it "and gave the gods no glorious hecatombs," and Zeus's answer licensing its future erasure — sweep it into the sea, hide the beach under sand again. All three Alexandrian critics athetized the exchange (443-464), and it is easy to see why it unsettled them: the poem pauses to arrange the demolition of its own scenery, as if to certify that no trace of the fiction will contradict the visible coastline (note [27]; the demolition is narrated at 12.13-33). Nestor's proposal that each man's bones be carried "home to the children" (334-335) was also athetized — the custom looks Athenian, not Homeric — and

Antenor's motion to hand Helen back completes the pattern of a book in which every institution for ending the war is tried and fails (notes [22], [23]).

Small register notes: αἵσιμα παρειπών, the disputed narratorial phrase from the Adrestus scene (6.62), recurs at 120-121 in a context where it is plainly benign — evidence worth weighing back into that dispute. Poseidon “the earth-shaker” enters the register, with “green fear,” the “bronze-greaved” hapax at 41, and the slave-trade line at 475 — the only occurrence of ἀνδράποδα in Homer, athetized by all three critics, and rendered “slaves” under the project’s policy (note [28]).

## Book 8

Book 8 exists to reverse the war's flow and set up everything that follows: Zeus takes the field-glass seat on Ida, forbids divine interference on pain of Tartarus, tips his golden scales, and by nightfall the Trojans — for the first time in ten years — are camped in the open plain. Ancient critics disliked the book intensely (its nickname was “the docked battle”), and the apparatus shows the highest athetesis-density of any book so far: the golden-cord boast, Zeus's smiling “I am not in earnest,” the four named horses, Andromache's fodder, the whole Iris relay, the Heracles digression, and even the shepherd's gladness in the watchfire simile all drew

critical daggers. This translation keeps the printed text entire and records each mark; what the critics read as padding largely reads now as the book's system: everything in it — the cord, the scales, the thunder repeated three times, the prophecy — performs Zeus's singular, uncontested weight.

Two disclosures anchor the book. At 475-478 Zeus names the plot of the rest of the poem: Hector will not stop “until the swift-footed son of Peleus rises beside the ships... over Patroclus fallen” — the first explicit statement of Patroclus's death, delivered as decree eight books before the event (note [26]). And at 161-166 stands the one passage flagged for this book in `disputed_lines.md`: Hector's taunt to Diomedes (“you were a woman after all...

painted doll”), athetized by Aristophanes and Aristarchus, with Zenodotus’s variant close (note [10]). The book ends on the poem’s most famous nocturne — the watchfires like stars around the moon, the shepherd glad at heart (a gladness Zenodotus deleted), a thousand fires, fifty men at each, and the horses waiting for Dawn (notes [30], [31]).

Repetition discipline mattered here: the Athena arming scene reuses Book 5’s lines and this translation’s Book 5 English verbatim; Iris relays Zeus’s threat word for word and adds one line of her own venom; and the Hera-Athena murmuring scene repeats 4.20-24 exactly. New register entries: saffron-robed Dawn, “much-enduring brilliant Odysseus” (first Iliad occurrence, in the awkward scene where

he fails to hear Diomedes — note [7]), the golden scales, and “fair-throned Dawn” closing the book.

## Book 9

Book 9 is the poem's hinge and its greatest sustained writing: the offer that should end the wrath, and the answer that reveals the wrath has outgrown its cause. The book's architecture is a series of descents. The gift-catalogue is spoken three times — by Agamemnon with its poison pill (“let him yield to me by as much as I am more kingly,” 158-161), by Odysseus verbatim but with the poison silently cut (note [20]), and back through Achilles' contempt. And Achilles' three answers step downward: to Odysseus, “tomorrow I sail”; to Phoenix, “at dawn we will decide”; to Ajax, “I fight when Hector reaches my own ships” — which is, of course, exactly what he will

do. Odysseus then reports only the first answer (note [41]), and Diomedes closes the book with the truest sentence in it: he will fight “whenever the heart in his chest commands him, and the god rouses him.” All three curated disputes for this book are handled in place. The dual verbs of 182-198 (disputed #5) are translated as duals — “the two of them went” — with the crux laid out in note [15]. The “gates of Hades” lines (312-313, disputed #6) and their contested referent are note [21]. And the famous four lines in which Phoenix contemplated killing his father (458-461, disputed #7) are physically absent from this project’s Greek text, as from the printed Monro-Allen vulgate — the numbering jumps 457 to 462 — athetized by Aristarchus for their content and



preserved only through Plutarch; the translation reproduces the gap, and note [32] supplies the missing lines so the reader loses nothing but the illusion that the text was ever whole.

Watch also: Achilles heard singing “the fames of men” — the poem’s only image of epic performed, by its own hero, on a lyre looted from Andromache’s city (note [16]); the demolition of the honor-economy at 318-321; the two fates and “imperishable fame” (410-416); the Litai allegory (note [34]); and the Meleager paradigm, at whose center sleeps a wife named Cleopatra — Patroclus’s name reversed — while Patroclus sits listening (note [35]). Register notes: 18-25 reuse the Book 2 English verbatim, now spoken in earnest; ἄττα “old father” joins the vocatives; δμῳαί “slave-

women” appears twice more under the policy.

## Book 10

Book 10 is the Iliad's night. Nothing in it happens by daylight rules: the arming is in animal skins, the omens are heard rather than seen, the fighting is throat-cutting among sleeping men, and the one killing that follows a supplication does not even wait for the suppliant to finish his sentence. It is also the only book of the Iliad whose right to be in the poem has been disputed since antiquity (curated dispute #8): a scholion reports that "this rhapsody was arranged separately by Homer and not counted part of the Iliad, but was placed into the poem by Pisistratus." Aristarchus kept it; Analysts have excised it; its defenders answer that

the ambush (the *lochos*) is an ancient heroic theme with its own conventions — leaders’ fear, borrowed gear, beast- skins, two-man teamwork — which this book executes with complete control, and that the poem’s long day of Books 11-18 needs precisely this restorative night between the Embassy’s failure and disaster. The internal evidence cuts both ways: the diction has an Odyssean cast (the bathing-tubs of 576 and the whistle of 502 occur nowhere else in the *Iliad*; Athena tells Diomedes to “think of your return”), and nothing in the book — Rhesus, his marvelous horses, Dolon’s intelligence — is ever mentioned again in the poem. Our policy is unchanged: the printed text is translated entire, and the argument lives in the notes ([1], [39], [43]).

What the book is, read on its own terms, is a study in symmetry. Two sleepless kings; two councils held in the dark, each seated in the other's killing-ground (note [13]); two spies sent out in the same hour with twinned volunteer-speeches (note [25]) — but one side sends its best two men for a black ewe apiece, and the other sends its worst man alone, for a promise of Achilles' horses that was never Hector's to give. The interrogation runs on the courteous formulas of guest- conversation with a corpse at the end of it (note [29]); the thirteenth Thracian killed matches the "thirteenth" scout in Odysseus's tally (note [42]); and the book ends with the poem's only laughter after killing and its only hot bath — the night washed off before rosy-

fingering dawn restores the day-world's rules.

Register notes: the boar's-tusk helmet pedigree returns the loot of Phoenix's father's house (note [19]); "when two go together" enters the proverb-stock (note [15]); ἀλαοσκοπιή "no blind man's watch" is fixed for Books 13-14; ἄτη "blindness" shrinks to fit Dolon (note [30]); and 10.199 reuses our 8.491 verbatim, as the Greek does.

## Book 11

Book 11 opens the longest day in poetry: the sun that rises from Tithonus's bed in line 1 will not set until 18.239-242, seven and a half books from now, and Zeus dictates the day's whole shape in advance in his message to Hector (185-194): let Agamemnon rage; when he is wounded and mounts his chariot, Hector's hour begins, and runs until he reaches the ships and the sun goes down. What follows is a day of subtraction. Agamemnon's *aristeia* — the poem's first sight of the commander actually pre-eminent in battle — burns hot and short, and then the captains are removed one by one: Agamemnon by Coon's spear, Diomedes and Eurypylus and

Machaon by Paris's arrows, Odysseus by Socus's thrust; by the book's end Ajax alone is left in the field, backing away like a beast, like a donkey — and the despised bow (note [29]) has done most of the day's work.

The book's second half changes register entirely, and is the hinge of the whole epic. Achilles, watching the rout from his stern for pleasure, sees Nestor carry a wounded man past and sends Patroclus to ask the name — and the poet stamps the errand at once: “he came out, the equal of Ares — and that was the beginning of his evil” (604). In Nestor's hut the plan is invented that Patroclus will repeat at the opening of Book 16: let Achilles send you out in his own armor (794-803, largely athetized in antiquity — see notes [42]-[43]). Nestor's



enormous Pylian reminiscence (656-762) earns its length as paradigm — the young Nestor fought although his father forbade him and hid his horses; Achilles, able, withholds — and closes on the saddest line the old man speaks: “Such was I among men — if ever I was.” Patroclus, running back, is detained by the wounded Eurypylus and stays to cut out the arrow: the book ends with the gentlest man in the poem healing one wound while his own death is being prepared, and its last clause repeats, word for word, the drying of Agamemnon’s wound at 267 — the day’s first casualty and its last, rhymed.

Our printed Greek genuinely lacks line 543 — the line Aristotle read, “for Zeus would be indignant with him, whenever he fought a better man” — and the translation

reproduces the gap (numbering jumps 542 to 544), with the line translated in note [35]. Register notes: the Muse-invocation reuses 2.484; 13-14 reuse 2.453-454 (athetized here as a wrongful repeat); 5-9 reuse the camp geometry of 8.222-226; Peleus's "always to be the best" repeats 6.208, our wording kept; and the cup of Nestor (632-637) meets the oldest joke in Greek epigraphy (note [38]).

## Book 12

The shortest book of the Iliad so far translated is also its most tightly built: a single military action — the storming of the Achaean wall — organized as a sequence of thresholds: ditch, gates, breastwork, bar; and at each threshold, a debate. Polydamas counsels leaving the chariots, and Hector accepts; Asius refuses, and the narrator files his death-notice in advance (note [7]); Polydamas reads the eagle-and-snake omen and counsels retreat, and Hector answers with the most quoted line of the poem — “One bird-sign is best: to fight for your fatherland” (243) — an answer that is magnificent, politically immortal, and wrong (note

[12]). The book's crown is Sarpedon's speech to Glaucus (310-328), the classic statement of why kings fight — honor received obliges honor paid, and since death comes anyway, the only choice left is the manner — the exact contract whose repudiation by Achilles in Book 9 the poem has already staged (note [19]).

The opening is unlike anything else in Homer: the narrator steps out of the story's time to tell how, after the war, Poseidon and Apollo turned eight rivers against the wall and erased it from the beach (3-35) — epic covering its own tracks, since no trace of the wall survived to be seen; the passage contains the poem's only "race of half-god men," the heroes seen for once from the far side of the gulf that separates them from the

audience (note [2]). Equally unusual is the narrator's cry of overload at 176 — "hard for me to tell it all through, as though I were a god" — which ancient critics athetized, perhaps for its very humanity (note [10]).

Throughout, the poet measures the widest war by the smallest peace: stones fall like snow muffling the works of men (note [16]); the deadlock is two farmers with measuring-rods disputing a boundary (note [27]); the balance of battle is an honest wool-worker's scale, held level "to win a pitiful wage for her children" (note [28]). Then Hector lifts the stone two men of today could not shift, breaks the double gate, and leaps through "in his face the very likeness of swift night" — and the book ends inside the breach, the Danaans

in rout among their ships, nothing  
resolved except the door.

Register notes: 12.96-97 reuse the Asius  
entry of the Catalogue (2.838-839)  
verbatim; the Lapiths keep their Book 2  
epithets; “such as mortals are now” recurs  
twice (383, 449) in its fixed form; and  
Menestheus’s message is relayed by the  
herald almost word for word (343-350 =  
354-363) — the verbatim discipline of  
messengers, kept.

## Book 13

Book 13 begins with a look and ends with a noise. Zeus, satisfied, turns his shining eyes away from Troy toward the far pastoral north — the mare-milkers and the Abioi, “most righteous of men” (note [1]) — certain no god will dare interfere; Poseidon, watching from the peak of Samothrace, comes down in four strides, and the whole book runs on his stolen presence: a god working the Achaean line in borrowed shapes and voices, “in secret, always, up and down the army” — because Zeus is elder-born and knows more (note [15]). The last line closes the frame: the clamor of both armies “reached the ether and the radiance of Zeus” — the battle he

refused to watch arrives as sound (note [37]).

Its centerpiece is the poem's one *aristeia* of a middle-aged man: Idomeneus of Crete, "half-grey," met coming back from a comrade's sickbed, talked into glory by a god, and given the book's most famous set-piece before he throws a spear — the anatomy of courage and cowardice in ambush, where the coward's color runs and his teeth chatter and the brave man's color never changes (note [12]). His kills are the book's plot: Othryoneus, who bid for Cassandra with a promise instead of gifts (note [16]); Asius, paying the death-notice filed in Book 12; and Alcathous, whom Poseidon freezes where he stands — the god holding the victim for the blow,



the most terrible divine intervention in the poem (note [19]).

Around the *aristeia* the book builds the day's resistance out of lists and low things: the locked phalanx where "shield pressed on shield, helmet on helmet, man on man" (note [6]); the defense roster with its Ionians (nowhere else in Homer) and its exiled homicide Medon; the Locrians who fight shoeless of honor, with bows and wool slings, unseen from behind (note [31]); beans jumping from a winnowing-shovel; oxen sweating at one plow; a roped bull; a worm. Where Book 12 measured war by peace, Book 13 arms peace and sends it back in. Two wounds are planted for later books: Ascalaphus lies dead and his father Ares, penned on Olympus by Zeus's command, does not know it (note [23]);

and Harpalion's father walks weeping behind the bier — Pylaemenes, whom the poem killed in Book 5: the most famous inconsistency in Homer, which ancient critics solved with an *athetesis* and this translation keeps in the open (note [27]).

Register notes: 13.769 reuses 3.39 ("Paris — evil Paris...") verbatim; 13.10 uses the fixed "kept no blind man's watch"; the phalanx lines are fixed for reuse at 16.215-217, the shipwright tree-fall for 16.482-484, and Medon's biography for 15.333-336.

## Book 14

The Dios Apatē — the Deception of Zeus — is the Iliad's great comic interlude, and its comedy is engineering: every scene is a tool fetched for the next. Hera sees Poseidon working the lines and Zeus sitting on Ida (153-158); what follows is a bathing and dressing scene built exactly like an arming scene (note [9]); a lie to Aphrodite that borrows the deep past — Oceanus “begetting of the gods” and mother Tethys quarreling — as cover story (note [10]); the loan of the keston, the embroidered band that holds “love, and desire, and the trysting-talk — persuasion, that steals the wits even of the close-thinkers,” a line Aristotle quoted (note

[10]); the recruitment of Sleep, who once before put Zeus under for Hera's sake and barely survived it — saved only by Night, “subduer of gods and men,” the one power Zeus fears to displease (note [12]); and the payment, negotiated upward from golden furniture to a Grace, sworn by Styx with one hand on the earth and one on the shining sea, the Titans under Tartarus called to witness (note [13]).

The seduction itself is the poem at its most audaciously funny — Zeus woos his wife with a catalogue of seven prior conquests, mothers and offspring itemized, ending “not even you yourself, as I love you now” (317-328; ancient critics athetized the whole list as indecorous, note [16]) — and then, without warning, at its most beautiful: the golden cloud, and the earth

flowering beneath them, “dewy lotus, and crocus, and hyacinth, thick and soft, that held them up off the ground” — the sacred marriage older than the comedy, glittering dew falling from the cloud (note [18]). Zeus sleeps; Sleep runs to Poseidon; and the last third of the book is the counterattack the nap purchases: the armor sorted by size to the men who can use it, Ajax’s boulder spinning Hector “like a top” and putting him, vomiting blood, out of the poem until Zeus wakes, and a chain of vaunts — grief answering grief — that ends with Ilioneus’s head raised on a spear “like a poppy-head,” the poem’s own earlier poppy (8.306) grown monstrous (note [29]).

Our printed Greek lacks line 269 — the naming of Pasithea in Hera’s offer, an addition in only part of the tradition; the

numbering jumps 268 to 270, the line is translated in note [13], and Sleep names her anyway at 276: the third transmission-gap this project reproduces (with 9.458-461 and 11.543). Register notes: 14.82-83 reuse 4.349-350 verbatim (“the fence of your teeth”); 14.508 reuses the fixed Muse-invocation; the ford-of-Xanthus formula (433-434) is laid down for reuse at 21.1-2.

## Book 15

Book 15 is the great correction. Zeus wakes on Gargaron, sees the rout and Hector vomiting blood, and in three moves restores the poem's direction: Hera is terrorized with the memory of her punishment — hung from heaven with anvils at her ankles (note [2]) — and swears the greatest oath in the poem, by Styx, his sacred head, and their bridal bed, a lawyer's truth that acquits her of Poseidon while saying nothing of the seduction (note [3]); Iris carries an ultimatum to Poseidon, who answers with the three-way division of the cosmos — sea, murk, and sky by lot, “earth and Olympus common to all” — and yields only to the argument of

the Erinyes who attend elder-born brothers (notes [8], [9]); and Apollo, given the aegis, revives Hector and levels the ditch and wall “as when a boy by the sea heaps sand in his childish play and then, still playing, scatters it with his feet and hands” — the most devastating image of divine ease in epic, delivered, uniquely, as an apostrophe to the god himself (note [18]).

At the center, before any of this, Zeus speaks the rest of the poem aloud (56-77, athetized in antiquity for that very completeness): Patroclus sent out, Sarpedon killed, Patroclus killed by Hector, Hector killed by Achilles, and after that the long Achaean tide “until they take steep Ilium through Athena’s counsels” — all of it suspended from the promise to Thetis in



Book 1 (note [4]). From here forward the audience watches men choose what it has heard decreed. The narrator twice does the same on his own account: Zeus waits “to see with his eyes the flare of a burning ship,” and Hector rages superb in his last full day of glory — “for he was to be short-lived: already Pallas Athena was speeding his death-day under the strength of Peleus’ son” (610-614, which Zenodotus cut; note [30]).

The fighting that fills the second half is the war at its narrowest: pikes on ship-decks, axes and swords at arm’s length, Ajax striding from deck to deck with a twenty-two-cubit boarding pike like a trick-rider leaping between four horses (note [34]). The paired exhortations are the book’s moral architecture: Hector’s “it is no

dishonor to die defending your fatherland  
— his wife is safe, his children after him”  
(494-499, quoted three centuries later by  
Lycurgus prosecuting an Athenian  
deserter, note [25]) against Ajax’s stripped-  
down answer to men who have no  
fatherland at their backs: “our light of  
safety is in our hands, not in any  
gentleness of war” (733-741, note [36]).  
Patroclus, mid-book, finally leaves  
Eurypylus’s hut quoting Nestor’s own hope  
back to himself — the fatal errand resumes  
(note [21]). The book ends with Hector’s  
hand on the stern-horn of the ship that  
carried the war’s first casualty, calling for  
fire, and Ajax on a seven-foot plank,  
counting his twelve.

Register notes: 15.263-268 reuse the  
stalled-horse simile of 6.506-511 verbatim,

as the Greek does; 15.333-336 reuse Medon's biography from 13.694-697, at his death; 15.550-551 reuse 13.175-176 (the returned-exile lines); 15.563-564 reuse 5.531-532; 15.403-404 reuse Nestor's persuasion-couplet from 11.792-793, now in Patroclus's own mouth.

## Book 16

Book 16 is the poem's pivot, and it knows it: the narrator turns eight times to address Patroclus by name — “you answered, Patroclus, horseman” — an intimacy of grammar shown to no one else in the Iliad (note [2]). Every promissory note the epic has issued since Book 9 is called in. The dark-spring tears reuse Agamemnon's simile from 9.14-15; Patroclus repeats Nestor's plan of 11.794-803 nearly word for word, and the narrator stamps it before Achilles can answer: “So he spoke, begging — the great fool: it was his own death and evil doom he was begging for” (46-47, note [4]). Achilles' consent comes wrapped in the conditions

that will be violated one by one — drive them from the ships, then come back; do not push on toward Ilion, “lest one of the everlasting gods step in: the worker-from-afar, Apollo, loves them” (93-94) — the death spoken as a warning by the man who will mourn it (note [6]). The Dodona prayer asks two things, and “the father granted one, and refused the other” (note [18]).

At the center, the poem’s theology pays its highest price. Zeus watches his son Sarpedon come against Patroclus and asks Hera whether he may save him; her answer — every god has sons in this war — holds the door of fate shut from inside, and the compromise is the poem’s most beautiful invention: Sleep and Death, the twin brothers, to carry the body home to Lycia for tomb and grave-stone, “for that is

the honor-right of the dead” (457, 675). Zeus consents and rains blood; Apollo washes the body in the river and hands it to the twins — the lines Zenodotus deleted and athetized, and the scene painted on the Euphronios krater three centuries later (notes [25], [35]). Between father and corpse the poem sets its most pitiless couplet: the extra hour of glory Zeus grants Patroclus is deliberated over his head like a sentence (note [34]).

The death itself is built as an un-arming: Apollo, hidden in mist, strikes the flat-handed blow, and the arming-scene of line 130 runs backwards — helmet rolling under the hooves (“before this it was not lawful for that helmet to be fouled with dust”), spear shattered, shield down, corslet loosed by the god’s own hands

(note [41]); then Euphorbus's dart from behind, and only third, Hector, into the belly. The dying prophecy counts the killers in order and adds Hector to the list of the dead (note [44]); the soul-flight lines — "wailing its fate, leaving manhood and youth" — are fixed here for their verbatim return at 22.361-363, where Hector will speak a dying prophecy of his own. The book ends with Hector answering a corpse and the immortal horses, "the gods' shining gifts to Peleus," carrying Automedon out of his reach.

Register notes: 16.3-4 = 9.14-15; 16.36-45 ≈ 11.794-803 (16.44-45 = 11.802-803 exactly); 16.112 reuses the fixed Muse-invocation; 16.215-217 = 13.131-133; 16.482-484 = 13.389-391; 16.742-743 reuses the diver of 12.385-386; the apostrophe roll-call line

(16.692-693) adapts the fixed “Whom first,  
whom last.”



## Book 17

Book 17 is the Iliad's longest tug-of-war: one dead man at the center, and the whole day's war reorganized around the question of who will hold him. The poem frames it in similes of guardianship and labor rather than glory — Menelaus over the body “as a mother- cow, lowing, stands over her first calf” (note [1]); the corpse dragged this way and that “as men stretch a great bull's hide soaked in fat,” the tanning-yard come to the battlefield (note [21]); the rescue at last like mules hauling a ship-timber down a rocky path, the two Ajaxes behind it like a wooded ridge damming a flood (note [37]). Against these stand the book's two heights of theology. Zeus watches Hector

put on the stripped armor of Achilles and shakes his head: the gear “not taken by right,” the power granted as ποινή — blood-price paid in glory to a man who will never come home from the battle, “nor will Andromache take from you the famous armor of Peleus’ son” (notes [12], [13]). And Zeus watches the immortal horses stand like a grave-stone, manes in the dust, weeping for their charioteer, and asks the poem’s deepest question of his own gift: why did we give you to a mortal, “you who are ageless and deathless? Was it so that you too might have sorrows among unhappy men? For there is nothing anywhere more pitiful than man, of all things that breathe and creep upon the earth” (notes [25], [26]).

The book's people are its second glory: Euphorbus dead with his Graces' hair in the blood and the olive-sapling simile that Pythagoras's biographers never stopped quoting (note [4]); Glaucus proposing to trade corpse for corpse, Patroclus for Sarpedon — bodies as the war's currency (note [10]); the anonymous soldiers' paired vows (note [23]); Antilochus struck speechless by the news he must carry (note [35]); and Ajax, in the god-sent mist, making the request Longinus judged the most sublime in literature — not life, but light: “and in the light — kill us, since that is now your pleasure” (note [33]).

Register notes: 17.63-64 reuse the lion lines of 11.175-176; 17.75-78 reuse the horses-of-Aeacus taunt of 10.402-404; 17.97 and 17.106 reuse the fixed soliloquy lines;

17.177-178 reuse 16.691-692; 17.454-455 reuse the sunset clause of 11.193-194; the reluctant lion of 17.657-664 reuses 11.550-555. Zenodotus's excision of 404-425 (Achilles' ignorance) and the athetized narrator's confession at 260-261 are noted in place.

## Book 18

Book 18 is built from three scenes of making and unmaking: a man unmade by four lines of news; a night of vows over a washed body; and a god at his anvil making a world. The unmaking first: Antilochus delivers the catastrophe in the poem's most economical sentence — “Patroclus lies dead... naked; and Hector of the flashing helmet has the armor” — and Achilles pours soot on his head and lies down in the dust “mighty in his mightiness,” the epitaph-line of Cebriones (16.776) settling on a living man, while Antilochus holds his hands “for fear he would cut his throat with the iron”: the Iliad's only suicide watch (notes [2], [3]).

Thetis rises with all the Nereids — the catalogue of sea-names the ancients athetized and this translation keeps (note [4]) — to mourn a son still alive; and in their exchange the poem reaches its hinge: “quick-fated then you shall be, child” — “Then let me die at once, since I could not defend my companion.” Plato put the exchange at the center of the *Apology*; Socrates chose his death by quoting this one (note [8]). With it comes the wrath’s own retraction: “may strife perish from among gods and men, and anger — sweeter far than dripping honey, it swells like smoke in men’s chests” (note [9]).

The middle movement belongs to voice and light: the unarmed Achilles at the ditch, flame streaming from his head like the beacon of a besieged island city — the

Achaeans' own situation made into his halo — killing twelve men with three shouts (note [11]); Hera forcing the sun into Ocean to end the longest day of the poem (note [13]); and, in the standing Trojan assembly, Polydamas's fourth and fatal counsel rejected — “Enyalios is impartial: he kills the would-be killer” — with the narrator's civic verdict on the applause (notes [14]-[16]).

Then the Shield (478-608), which Zenodotus athetized entire and which is the reason the book is immortal: the cosmos; the city at peace with its weddings and its trial — where the blood-price for a killed man is argued before elders, the very *ποινή* Achilles refused in Book 9, shown working (note [26]); the city at war fighting this poem's own battle in

miniature, Fate dragging the dead by the feet (note [27]); the plowland turning black behind the plow “though it was made of gold” (note [28]); the harvest, the vineyard with the boy singing the Linos-song, the lions on the bull, the dancing floor of Daedalus with its potter’s-wheel simile and — kept in our printed text against Aristarchus’s deletion — the divine singer himself, the poet inside his own artifact (note [33]); and Ocean round the rim. A world of peace is forged as the equipment of revenge: the poem’s whole argument, carried on one arm.

Register notes: 18.21 reuses 17.693; 18.200-201 reuse 16.42-43; Thetis’s sapling-lament (56-62) recurs verbatim at 437-443, both kept identical; “quick-fated” continues 1.417; the slave-women, the fixed soliloquy



frames, and the Book 1 “Most dread son of Cronos” line all recur in their registered forms.

## Book 19

Book 19 is called the Renunciation of the Wrath, and its business is to close the quarrel that opened the poem — which it does in the strangest scene of public reconciliation in literature. Achilles, who now wants only to kill, renounces the wrath in nine lines and wishes Briseis — the girl the quarrel was about — had died before it started (note [6]). Agamemnon answers seated, “not standing up in their midst” (the ancient editors were so unsettled that Zenodotus’s text made him stand; note [8]), and delivers not an apology but a theology: “I am not to blame: Zeus is, and Fate, and the Erinyes who walks in mist” — followed by the great parable of

Ate, Blindness, the soft-footed eldest daughter of Zeus who walks on the heads of men, and whom Zeus himself, blinded over the birth of Heracles, hurled from heaven by her shining braids (notes [9], [10]). Book 9's Blindness was "strong and sound of foot"; this register keeps the one English name so the two portraits can argue with each other. And Achilles accepts the theology — "Father Zeus, great is the blindness you deal to men!" — so the quarrel ends with both parties agreeing that nobody human did it (note [19]). The gifts so bitterly itemized in Book 9 are carried into the middle of the assembly, and the man they were meant to persuade tells Agamemnon to give them or keep them as he pleases.

The book's real argument is between grief and the belly. Odysseus — “I was born first and know more things” — insists twice that armies cannot mourn fasting: his harvest of bronze, “where the bronze strews the most straw on the ground and the crop is smallest,” and his terrible discipline: bury the dead “keeping a pitiless heart, weeping for one day” (note [16]). Achilles refuses — “slaughter, and blood, and the hard groaning of men” is the only food he wants (note [15]) — and has to be fed like a wick, drop by drop, with nectar by Athena. Between the two positions stands the book's finest scene: Briseis, restored at last and given her only speech in the poem, keening over Patroclus who had promised to make her Achilles' wedded wife — “You were gentle,

always” — while the narrator, in two lines as cold and true as anything in Homer, notes that the women wailed with her “for Patroclus in show; but each for her own sorrows” (note [20]).

Then the arming — snowfall of helmets, the earth laughing at the lightning of bronze, the shield’s light like a lonely mountain fire seen by sailors storm-driven away from their dear ones (the inverse of Book 18’s rescue-beacon; note [25]) — the Pelian ash only Achilles can swing (kept verbatim from Book 16, against Aristarchus; note [26]), and the ending no other book has: the war-horse Xanthus, given voice by Hera, bows his head till his mane pours to the ground and tells his master he will die — “by a god, and by a man” — before the Erinyes shut his mouth.

Achilles already knows. He says so, and drives.

Register notes: 19.2 = 11.2; 19.65-66 = 18.112-113; 19.78 = 2.110 (“squires of Ares”); 19.176-177 reuse the oath-wording of 9.133-134; 19.216 = 16.21; 19.224 = 4.84; 19.388-391 = 16.141-144; Ate is “Blindness” per 9.502-512; the gift-catalogue matches 9.122-130 item for item.

## Book 20

Book 20 begins the single continuous battle — one afternoon long, four books wide — that runs from here to Hector's death. It opens with the poem's fullest divine mobilization: Themis summons every god to assembly, rivers and nymphs included (only Ocean stays home), and Zeus, whose ban of Book 8 kept the gods in the stands, now reverses it: go down, help whichever side you love. His reasons are the poem's theology in two lines: "they matter to me, even as they perish" — and the fear that Achilles, unchecked, "may storm the wall itself, ahead of what is fated" (note [2]). Fate, it turns out, needs defending; that is what gods are for this

afternoon. The mobilization produces the Iliad's greatest seismic picture — Zeus thundering above, Poseidon shaking the mountain roots below, and Hades leaping from his throne with a scream, lest the crust crack open and his “terrible, mouldering houses, which the very gods abhor” stand naked to the daylight (note [5]) — and then, superbly, anticlimax: the gods pair off, look at one another, and sit down. The Theomachy is postponed to Book 21; what we get instead is men fighting under divine spectatorship. The core of the book is the duel that cannot happen: Achilles against Aeneas — pushed into the ring by Apollo wearing the voice of Lycaon (whose own meeting with Achilles, in Book 21, will be very different). Aeneas answers Achilles' magnificent



taunting with the longest genealogy in the poem: Dardanus to Erichthonius — whose three thousand mares bore to the North Wind foals that ran over wheat-ears without breaking them — to Tros, to Ganymede taken up for his beauty, down the twin branches to Hector and to himself (note [15]). It is a speech about why he cannot die here, and the poem agrees: when the boulder and the sword are about to decide it, Poseidon — a Greek partisan — saves Troy's enemy prince, because "it is destined for him to escape, so that the race of Dardanus not perish seedless": "the might of Aeneas shall be king over the Trojans — and his children's children" (note [19]). The apparatus records the variant Strabo knew, "his race shall rule over all" — the reading Rome preferred;

Virgil's epic grows out of this rescue. Hector too is saved — once by Apollo's word, once by Apollo's mist, after Athena turns his spear back with a breath — and Achilles' frustrated cry over him repeats, word for word, what Diomedes shouted at Hector in Book 11: "Dog! Again you have run out from under death" (note [29]). Everyone the gods do not save, dies. The book's last movement is the first panel of Achilles' *aristeia*, and this translation keeps its full brutality: Iphition's split skull and the chariots that shred him; Polydorus — Priam's youngest, forbidden the war, showing off his running — holding his own bowels; Tros of the refused supplication, "not a sweet-tempered man, not mild of mind" (the *litotes* that measures what Achilles has become; the theme will climax

with Lycaon in 21 and Hector in 22); Deucalion beheaded with the marrow spurting from his spine. The closing similes — forest fire, and oxen threshing barley — end the book mid-carnage, blood on the axle, “spattering his invincible hands with gore”: no cadence, because the *aristeia* has only begun.

Register notes: 20.196-198 reuse 17.30-32 (“When the thing is done, even the fool learns”); 20.449-454 = 11.362-367 verbatim; 20.431-433 repeat 20.200-202 (Aeneas’s opening returned by Hector, kept identical); 20.287 “such as mortals are now”; 20.78 keeps 5.289’s “Ares, the fighter under the ox-hide shield”; Ares borrows Hector’s “flashing helmet” at 20.38 — the register’s one loan of that epithet, as printed.



## Book 21

Book 21 is the wildest book of the Iliad — the one where the fighting bursts every frame that holds it: ransom, river-banks, even the difference between the elements. It opens at the ford of Xanthus (the lines repeat 14.433-434, where the stunned Hector was laid at this same crossing: the river of Trojan refuge becomes the trap), where Achilles cuts the rout in two, drives half into the water, and wades in after them with a sword — locusts before a grass-fire, fish before a dolphin. He takes twelve boys alive for Patroclus's pyre, collecting the vow of 18.336-337, and then meets Lycaon.

The Lycaon scene (34-135) is the moral center of the second half of the poem. The poem gives him the fullest biography of any minor figure — caught at night cutting fig-shoots for chariot-rails, sold to Lemnos, ransomed, home eleven days, and on the twelfth delivered by “the god” back into the same hands — precisely so that his death will be the death of the old economy: Achilles had sold him once, because “sparing was dearer to my heart”; now “Fool — offer me no ransom.” What follows the refusal is the most quoted consolation in Greek literature, spoken with the spear raised: “So, friend — you die too. Why lament it so? Patroclus died, and he was a far better man than you... over me too stand death and strong fate: there will be a dawn, or an evening, or a midday...”

(note [6]). The word is φίλος — friend — and it is not irony: it is the fellowship of the doomed, which is the only fellowship Achilles has left. Lycaon opens his arms and takes the sword; the body goes to the fish, with a taunt that cancels every funeral rite the poem holds dear — and the river begins to be angry.

Asteropaeus, who fights with a spear in each hand and draws the only blood Achilles loses in the Iliad, dies over the argument his corpse then illustrates: rivers against Zeus. Achilles' boast descends the ladder — Zeus beats rivers; not even Achelous, “not even the great strength of deep-flowing Ocean, from whom all rivers and all the sea and all springs and deep wells flow,” can face the thunderbolt. Zenodotus's text omitted the

Ocean line, crowning Achelous the first of waters — the oldest recorded Greek quarrel about cosmology, sitting in our apparatus (note [10]). Then the river itself has had enough: “my lovely streams are full of corpses... and you kill and kill.” The battle with Scamander (233-382) is the poem’s one war between a man and an element, and it strips Achilles to something no enemy has seen: running, outrun, wailing to Zeus that his mother lied, dreading the “wretched death” of a boy swept down a gully — death by water, without glory, without a grave. The river’s threat makes that explicit in the poem’s bitterest mock-burial: sand and shingle heaped so deep “the Achaeans will not know where to gather his bones... he will need no heaped tomb” (note [16]). Rescue



comes as plot: Poseidon and Athena, hand in hand, dictate the rest of the epic — pen the Trojans, kill Hector, take the glory — and Hera throws Hephaestus at the water. Fire drinks the plain; the riverside trees burn by name; eels tumble; the god of water surrenders while boiling “like a cauldron melting the lard of a fatted hog.” Then the Theomachy the poem has owed us since Book 20 — and it is played as comedy under one laughing spectator (“Zeus heard, sitting on Olympus, and his own heart laughed for joy”). Athena fells Ares with a boundary-stone and Aphrodite with a fist; Hera boxes Artemis’s ears with her own bow; Hermes politely forfeits to Leto; Artemis ends in Zeus’s lap in tears. Only one exchange is in earnest: Poseidon reminds Apollo of Laomedon’s cheat — the

wall built for a wage never paid, the threatened ear-lopping — and Apollo refuses combat with the most devastating thing any god says about us in the poem: mortals are not worth a fight, “who like the leaves now flourish in their blaze... and now wither heartless away” — Glaucus’s leaf-simile of 6.146 returned from above, as contempt (note [24]). The gods go home; Achilles remains — smoke of a burning city — and the book ends with Priam opening the gates, Agenor’s lonely stand (the soliloquy where a frightened man discovers that Achilles too “has one life”), and Apollo in Agenor’s shape running the fastest man alive across the plain, “always just a little ahead,” while everything that is left of Troy’s army pours inside the walls — everything except the man who will be

standing outside them when the next book begins.

Register notes: 21.1-2 = 14.433-434; 21.374-376 repeat Hera's oath verbatim (= 20.315-317) — the river swears her own clause back at her; 21.69-70 keep 20.279-280's planted-spear wording; the twelve youths pay the vow of 18.336-337; "worker-from-afar," "bane of mortals," "blood-stained," "who showers arrows," and the death-formulas hold their registered forms.

## Book 22

Everything in the poem has narrowed to this: one man outside the wall, “penned by deadly fate” at the Scaean Gates, and the whole apparatus of the epic — parents, gods, landscape, army, similes — arranged around the last hour of Hector. The book is built as three concentric scenes: the pleading (Priam and Hecuba from the tower); the running (three circuits of Troy); the killing and its consequences — and at each stage the poem does the thing only it would dare: it makes the terror specific. Priam does not simply fear death; he sees his own house-dogs — “the dogs I fed at my table, to keep my doors” — drinking his blood in the doorway, and

states the poem's cruelest law of decorum: a young man dead in battle is seemly, "all things are beautiful on a dead young man"; it is the mauled grey head of an old one that is "the most pitiful thing there is for wretched mortals" (note [3]). Hecuba answers with the bared breast that once quieted him — the body's own argument (note [4]). Neither works, because Hector's real audience is neither parent: it is Polydamas ("who will be the first to lay reproach on me"), and behind him the nameless "worse man" of the streets. Shame, not courage, holds him at the gate — his soliloquy admits it in so many words — until Achilles is close, and then shame does what shame does under enough pressure: it collapses, and the best man of Troy runs (notes [6], [8]).

The chase (136-213) is the greatest sustained passage of the poem, and its power is in what the runners pass: the lookout, the wind-blown fig, and the two springs of Scamander — one steaming, one ice-cold — “and there beside them are the wide washing-troughs, beautiful, of stone, where the Trojans’ wives and their beautiful daughters used to wash their glistening clothes — in the old days, in peace, before the sons of the Achaeans came.” Domestic memory set flush against the fact: “they ran for the life of Hector the horse-tamer” (note [9]). Zeus proposes rescue; Athena answers him with the same rebuke Hera used over Sarpedon (179-181 = 16.441-443, kept verbatim): the gods themselves have a form-line for this argument, and it always ends the same

way. The dream-simile — pursuer who cannot catch, quarry who cannot pull away — was athetized by Aristarchus and kept here (note [11]); the golden scales dip; Apollo leaves; and Athena, wearing the face and “unwearying voice” of the brother Hector loves, commits the coldest act any god performs in the poem (note [13]).

The duel is short because it was never a duel: it is the supplication theme played to its end. Hector offers a compact about corpses; Achilles answers with wolves and lambs — “there are no faithful oaths between lions and men” — and, when the throat is pierced and the dying man begs again, with the wish he could “hack your flesh away and eat it raw” (notes [15], [20]). Hector dies prophesying — Paris and

Phoebus Apollo at the Scaean Gates — exactly as Patroclus died prophesying Hector’s own death, and the soul-flight couplet repeats 16.856-857 verbatim, as the Greek does: the poem’s two great deaths are one death, twice (note [21]). What follows — the ankle-thongs, the dragging, the head “that was once so beautiful” in its own country’s dust — the narrator marks with the plainest sentence available: “Zeus gave him to his enemies to defile in his own fatherland.”

And then the poem does what only the Iliad does: it leaves the victor, and goes inside. Priam rolling in dung, already planning the journey of Book 24 (“He too has a father like me — Peleus”); Hecuba’s lament; and Andromache — who has heard nothing — at the loom, weaving flowers



into a purple cloak, ordering the cauldron heated “for Hector, for his return out of the fighting. Poor innocent.” She reaches the wall in time to see the dragging, and her fainting fling scatters the headdress Aphrodite gave her on her wedding day — the marriage undone garment by garment — before the great widow’s lament, with the athetized orphan-passage (the child at the feast, lips wetted, palate dry) defended in note [31], and the last quiet horror: the fire she will feed with his unused clothes, “no use to you: you will not lie in them.” The book ends on the women’s answering wail — the sound Book 24 will finally be allowed to finish.

Register notes: 22.179-181 = 16.441-443;  
22.361-363 = 16.855-857 (the soul-flight  
couplet, both kept verbatim); 22.365-366

reuse 18.115-116; “But why does my own heart argue these things with me?” (122, 385) = 21.562; “gluts with his blood Ares, the fighter under the ox-hide shield” (267) keeps 5.289 = 20.78; “portion of fire” (343) keeps 15.350’s wording; Hector’s Polydamas-shame (99-107) answers 18.249-313 as registered; the fixed formulas (glaring darkly, flashing helmet, swift-footed, the scales) hold.

## Book 23

Book 23 is the Iliad's demonstration that civilization is a thing people do on purpose, the day after the worst thing in their lives. Its first movement is all night and fire: the Myrmidons' three circuits of the body, the funeral feast where "blood ran in cupfuls," Achilles' refusal to wash until the pyre is built (the fast of Book 19 still governing his body), and the visit of the ghost — Patroclus "in everything like himself, in stature and the beautiful eyes and the voice," standing above the sleeper's head with the poem's most quietly devastating reproach: "You sleep — and you have forgotten me, Achilles" (note [4]). What the ghost asks for is

administration: burial, quickly, so the other souls will let him across the river; and one thing more — “give me your hand: I am weeping” — which the living man cannot deliver: the embrace closes on nothing, and the soul goes down “like smoke... squeaking,” leaving Achilles with the poem’s plainest statement of its afterlife: “a soul and an image — but the wits are not in it at all” (note [5]). Homer’s dead are real enough to make requests and too thin to hold.

The pyre-sequence keeps every terrible ledger the poem has opened: the hair vowed to the river Spercheius given to the dead instead (the vow of homecoming formally cancelled, note [7]); and the twelve Trojan youths of the vow of 18.336-337, killed with the narrator’s own verdict

attached — “and evil was the work his heart intended” — while, two lines later, the gods quietly begin Book 24: Aphrodite keeping the dogs from Hector with rose-oil, Apollo roofing the corpse with cloud (note [8]). The winds must be fetched by Iris from a dinner-party to make the pyre burn; and over the all-night fire the poem sets its most terrible simile of grief: Achilles mourning “as a father mourns, burning the bones of his son, a bridegroom” (note [9]).

Then the games — two-thirds of the book, and the poem’s whole social philosophy in action. Every crisis of the *Iliad* recurs here in miniature, and every one is resolved: a dispute over a prize (Antilochus’s foul and Menelaus’s oath-challenge) ends not in wrath but in yielding, a young man

handing over the mare and an elder,  
melted “as dew softens the ears of  
ripening corn,” handing it back (note [21]);  
a spectators’ quarrel (Idomeneus and  
Oilean Ajax) is stopped by — of all men —  
Achilles, the poem’s original quarreler,  
now its arbiter (note [17]); and the book  
ends with Agamemnon standing up for the  
javelin-throw and Achilles awarding him  
the prize uncontested — the two men  
whose fight over a prize began the epic  
closing it with a prize freely given (note  
[29]). Around these, the poem’s late  
tenderness is everywhere: Achilles’ only  
smile (at Antilochus, note [20]); Epeius’s  
disarming self-knowledge (“no man can be  
best in everything”); Nestor given a prize  
for nothing but memory; the biography of  
a silver bowl that once ransomed Lycaon

and is now raced for at the funeral of the man whose death doomed him (note [25]); Ajax face-down in cattle-dung while the army “laughed at him sweetly.” The dead man gets his games; the living get their order back; and the host of the funeral arranges prizes for a future — his own burial mound, his own bones in the same urn — that he has already scheduled (note [10]). It is the gentlest book of the poem, and it earns its gentleness line by line over an open grave.

Register notes: 23.22-23 report the vow of 18.336-337 in its registered wording; the twelve youths’ thread (18.336 → 21.27 → 23.175) closes; 23.179-180 repeat 23.19-20 verbatim (kept); the fast-and-wash continuity honors 19.208-210; “loud-roaring sea,” “rosy-fingered Dawn,”

“saffron robe,” “of many devices,”  
“resourceful,” “much-enduring,” “who  
strikes from afar,” and the “earth-  
upholder, earth-shaker” oath-title hold  
their registered forms; Patroclus is ἐννῆς  
— “the kindly” — at 252 and 648, both kept  
as “kindly,” the dead man’s adjective  
shared with Nestor’s self-description.



## Book 24

The Iliad does not end with a fall of a city or a death of a hero. It ends with an act of mercy so difficult that heaven has to engineer it and two broken men have to perform it — and with a funeral. Book 24 begins where Book 23's community ended: everyone else asleep, Achilles alone on the beach, cycling through his postures of grief, harnessing at each dawn to drag Hector three times round the tomb — and going nowhere, because Apollo keeps the corpse whole with the golden aegis. The mutilation has become a machine that grinds and does not feed. The gods' council states the poem's verdict through Apollo's indictment — Achilles “ravages dumb

earth in his fury,” having lost pity and that aidōs “that harms men greatly, and profits them”; even a man who loses a brother or a son “weeps, and laments, and lets go: for the Fates gave mankind an enduring heart” (note [3]). Zeus’s ruling refuses both theft and equal honor: Hector was dearest of Troy’s mortals to the gods; Achilles shall have the glory — of giving him back. Mercy is arranged as an honor, because that is the only currency the recipient still accepts (note [4]).

The double embassy — Thetis down to Achilles, Iris down to Priam — produces the book’s two impossible journeys: a mother telling her doomed son to eat, sleep, and lie with a woman, “for you will not be with me long” (note [6]); and an old man driving a treasure-wagon at night

into the camp of the man who has killed his sons, against his wife's plea (her wish to eat Achilles' liver raw is the third and most terrible of the poem's raw-eating wishes, because it is hers; note [8]).

Hermes — the god whose dearest thing is “to be man's companion” — walks Priam through the sleeping army disguised as a princely squire with his first beard, and delivers, along the way, the poem's kindest sentence: Hector lies twelve days unburied and “dewy-fresh... the blessed gods care for your son though he is nothing now but a dead man, because they loved him at heart” (note [13]).

Then the scene the whole epic exists for. Priam enters unnoticed, clasps Achilles' knees, and kisses “the terrible, man-slaughtering hands that had killed so

many of his sons” — while the poem compares him, the suppliant king, to a murderer arriving in exile at a rich man’s hall: the roles of killer and victim deliberately exchanged in the simile (note [15]). “Remember your father” opens the plea that ends: “I have endured what no other mortal on earth has yet endured: to lift to my lips the hand of the man who killed my son.” And the two of them weep together — Priam for Hector, Achilles “now for his father, now again for Patroclus” — two griefs, one sound, filling the house (note [17]). What follows is the consolation of the two jars — no unmixed good exists for mortals; Peleus’s splendor and Priam’s fifty sons end the same way; “Bear it... you will not raise him up” — and then supper, and the strangest, most humane moment

in Homer: the two enemies simply look at each other, each marveling at what the other is, “and when they had taken their fill of looking” (note [22]). The old rage flickers once — “Do not provoke me now, old man” — and its live presence under the mercy is exactly what makes the mercy real (note [19]).

The supplication-arc of the late books (Tros refused, Lycaon refused, Hector refused) closes with supplication accepted; and with it the poem’s largest ring: an aged father comes with ransom to redeem his child from a king’s wrath — Chryses, Book 1, line 12 — and this time the king says yes. Achilles washes and lifts the body himself, apologizes to Patroclus, promises a share of the ransom, and grants eleven days’ truce with his hand on the old man’s

wrist “so his heart should not be afraid.”  
Briseis, in one quiet clause, sleeps at his  
side again. Priam drives home past the  
ford of Xanthus (the register’s line, its  
third appearance); Cassandra cries the city  
awake; and the three laments —  
Andromache with the head in her hands,  
Hecuba, and last Helen, mourning the one  
man in Troy who was kind to her — carry  
the poem to the pyre, the golden box, the  
purple robes, the mound raised under  
guard, the funeral feast. “So they busied  
themselves with the burial of Hector, the  
tamer of horses”: the epic of wrath ends on  
rites performed — grief, at last, allowed to  
do its work properly (note [30]).

Register notes: 24.692-693 = 21.1-2 =  
14.433-434 (the ford, third occurrence);  
Iris’s message 175-187 repeats Zeus’s 146-

158 verbatim (kept); “your heart must be iron” 205 = 521 (Hecuba’s phrase returned by Achilles); the raw-eating triplet closes (4.35, 22.346, 24.212); “man-slaughtering” passes to Hector’s own head at 724; the Judgment of Paris (25-30, ath.), the jars, and Niobe’s petrification (614-617, ath.) are kept and noted; all fixed formulas hold to the last line.

# For Further Reading

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*The Iliad's ancient company: a guide*

The Iliad's ancient company: a guide

## FOREWORD

The Iliad was never alone. It stands at the head of a crowd of ancient works that continue it, contradict it, dramatize its aftermath, parody it, argue about it, and forge eyewitness rebuttals to it — a conversation that ran for well over a thousand years before the poem reached us, and whose voices are already present in



this edition's notes (Aristarchus athetizing, Zenodotus emending, Plutarch preserving four suppressed lines, Strabo reporting the variant Rome preferred). This list gathers that company. It is arranged not by date but by relationship to the Iliad — the companion, the sequels, the stage, the parody, the quarrel, the answer, the hoax, the scholars — because that is how the works themselves understood their positions. Each entry notes what survives and in what form; the losses are part of the story, and are reported as plainly as the survivals. Dates are approximate throughout; almost every early date in this field is argued about.

A note on access: nearly everything here exists in a Loeb Classical Library volume (Greek or Latin with facing English), and

most of it in public-domain translations available through Perseus or the Internet Archive. Specific standard editions are named where they matter.

## **I. THE COMPANION**

**THE ODYSSEY · attributed to Homer ·  
complete, 12,109 lines**

The other survivor. Composed in the same formulaic tradition, plausibly within a generation or two of the Iliad, and built to fit around it with astonishing tact: the Odyssey retells almost nothing the Iliad narrates, and instead slots its Trojan flashbacks — the horse, the sack, the quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles, the ghosts of Achilles and Ajax — into the gaps the older poem left. Where the Iliad asks

what a short glorious life is worth, the Odyssey asks what a long unglorious survival is worth; the shade of Achilles, telling Odysseus in the underworld that he would rather be a poor man's field-hand among the living than king of all the dead, is the one poem answering the other. A companion translation on the same principles as this one, sharing its formula register where the poems share formulas, sits beside this project.

## **II. THE REST OF THE STORY: THE EPIC CYCLE**

Antiquity possessed the whole war in verse: six more epics, collectively the "Epic Cycle," wrapped around the Iliad and Odyssey like the lost panels of an

altarpiece. All six perished. What survives is a set of terse plot summaries made by one Proclus (perhaps 2nd c. AD) for his Chrestomathy — themselves preserved only in Photius and in the margins of Iliad manuscripts — plus a few dozen quoted fragments. The standard collection is M. L. West's Loeb, Greek Epic Fragments (2003). Aristotle (Poetics 23) already saw the difference in kind: the cyclic poets narrated everything in order, one thing after another, while Homer took a single action and made everything else radiate from it. The Cycle is the everything; reading even its skeletons shows what the Iliad chose not to be.

**THE CYPRIA · attributed to Stasinus · 11 books, lost; summary and ~50 fragments**

The prequel: Zeus’s plan to thin mankind, the wedding of Peleus and Thetis, the Judgment of Paris, the abduction of Helen, the gathering at Aulis, Iphigenia, Philoctetes abandoned, the first nine years — everything the Iliad presupposes in its opening line. Herodotus (2.117) already argued it could not be Homer’s, because it contradicts the Iliad’s account of Paris’s voyage: the oldest surviving act of Homeric source-criticism.

**THE AETHIOPIS · attributed to Arctinus of Miletus · 5 books, lost; summary and fragments**

The direct sequel — it opened where our Book 24 closes, with a line ancient readers knew as an alternative ending to the Iliad itself (“So they busied themselves with the burial of Hector; and an Amazon came...”).

Penthesileia the Amazon queen, killed by Achilles as they fall in love across the spear; Memnon the Aethiopian, son of the Dawn, killed for killing Antilochus; and then Achilles' own death at the Scaean Gates by the arrow of Paris and Apollo — the event the Iliad prophesies five times and refuses to narrate.

**THE LITTLE ILIAD · attributed to Lesches · 4 books, lost; summary and fragments**

The Judgment of the Arms (Achilles' armor awarded to Odysseus; Ajax's madness and suicide), Philoctetes fetched, Neoptolemus brought from Scyros — the poem behind the son Achilles mourns for in our Book 19 — and the building of the horse.

**THE SACK OF ILION (Iliou Persis) · attributed to Arctinus · 2 books, lost; summary and fragments**

The horse debated, Laocoon, the night of the fall: Priam killed at the altar of Zeus, Astyanax thrown from the wall — the death Andromache foresees for him at our 24.734-738 — Polyxena sacrificed at Achilles' tomb. The atrocities that made the “sack of a city” the ancient shorthand for ultimate suffering all lived here.

**THE RETURNS (Nostoi) · attributed to Agias of Troezen · 5 books, lost; summary**

The costly homecomings: the wreck of Ajax son of Oileus, Menelaus blown to Egypt, and Agamemnon walking into his own murder — the story the *Odyssey* uses as its dark counter-example and the tragedians made their own.

**THE TELEGONY · attributed to Eugammon of Cyrene · 2 books, lost; summary**

The Cycle's strange coda: Odysseus's last wanderings and his death at the hands of Telegonus, his son by Circe — killed by a spear barbed with a sting-ray's spine, the sea reaching inland at last.

### III. THE SEQUEL THAT SURVIVES

**QUINTUS OF SMYRNA · Posthomerica ·  
probably 3rd c. AD · complete, 14 books**

Late antiquity, missing its Cycle, rewrote the gap: Quintus begins at Hector's funeral and marches in Homeric hexameters all the way to the sack and the storm over the returning fleet — Penthesileia, Memnon, the death of Achilles, the Judgment of the Arms, Philoctetes, the horse. Homer's manner without Homer's inwardness, but



the only continuous ancient narrative of the war's end, and often better than its reputation.

**TRIPHIODORUS · The Sack of Troy · 3rd-4th c. AD · complete, 691 lines**

A single night in a single sitting: a compact, theatrical telling of the horse and the fall.

**COLLUTHUS · The Rape of Helen · c. 500 AD · complete, ~390 lines**

The last ancient Troy poem: a small, ornamental epyllion on the Judgment of Paris and the abduction — the war's first evening, written at the tradition's last.

## **IV. THE TRAGIC STAGE**

Aeschylus is said to have called his plays “slices from the great banquets of Homer”

(Athenaeus 8.347e), and the phrase is exact: fifth-century Athens treated the Trojan matter — mostly the Cycle's panels rather than the Iliad's own plot — as its common story-hoard. This is the ancient fan fiction, written by masters, and it consistently does what fan fiction does: it goes looking for the people the epic wronged.

**AESCHYLUS · Oresteia (Agamemnon, Libation Bearers, Eumenides) · 458 BC · complete — the only surviving trilogy**

The homecoming as catastrophe:

Agamemnon walks the crimson cloth into the bath, and three plays work the blood out of the house. The Iliad's king of men becomes a study in what the war cost the victors; the herald's speech on the rains and frosts at Troy is the veteran's Iliad in

twenty lines. His lost Achilles trilogy (Myrmidons, Nereids, Phrygians) dramatized our Books 9-24 directly — the surviving fragments of Achilles' lament over Patroclus were famous in antiquity, and their loss is among the tradition's heaviest.

**SOPHOCLES · Ajax · c. 440s BC · complete**

What happens to the Iliad's second-best fighter when the poem's economy of honor fails him: cheated of Achilles' arms, mad among the cattle, and dead by the sword Hector gave him at the end of our Book 7 — the guest-gift completing its arc. The quiet debate over his burial replays the Iliad's final question (what is owed a dead enemy?) in a Greek camp without an Achilles to answer it.

**SOPHOCLES · Philoctetes · 409 BC · complete**

The man the expedition abandoned, the  
bow the war requires, and the young son of  
Achilles caught between honesty and  
Odysseus: the epic's margins turned into  
the sharpest ethics on the Athenian stage.

**EURIPIDES · Trojan Women · 415 BC ·  
complete**

The sack from beneath: Hecuba, Cassandra,  
Andromache, one day on the beach among  
the allotted captives, and the body of  
Astyanax brought in on his father's shield  
— the deliberate answering echo of every  
Hector-and-Andromache scene in the Iliad.  
Produced months after Athens massacred  
Melos; the oldest surviving anti-war play,  
made entirely of Homer's widows.

**EURIPIDES · Hecuba · c. 424 BC · complete**

Polyxena sacrificed to Achilles' ghost,  
Polydorus murdered by a guest-friend for

gold — a different death from the one Achilles gives him at our 20.407-418; the tradition never agreed on its youngest victim — and the old queen's revenge: grief curdling into atrocity.

**EURIPIDES · Andromache · c. 425 BC ·  
complete**

The afterlife of Hector's wife as the war-prize of Achilles' son: the sequel to our 6.450-465, where Hector foresaw exactly this.

**EURIPIDES · Iphigenia at Aulis · 405 BC ·  
complete**

The war's first death, bought before the fleet could sail: the Cypria's story done as domestic tragedy, with Agamemnon drafting and redrafting the letter — the ancestor of every study in the cowardice of command.

**EURIPIDES · Helen · 412 BC · complete**

Built on Stesichorus's recantation (below):  
the real Helen sat out the war in Egypt,  
and Troy burned for a phantom. The Iliad  
weighed against a hypothesis: what if it  
was for nothing — literally nothing?

**RHESUS · transmitted under Euripides'  
name; authorship disputed · complete**

The one surviving tragedy that dramatizes  
an actual episode of the Iliad: our Book 10,  
the night raid, seen this time from the  
Trojan watch-fires. Whoever wrote it, it is  
the only chance to watch the fifth century  
stage a scene we also have in Homer.

Lost, and worth mourning by name:  
Aeschylus's Myrmidons (above); Sophocles'  
Polyxena and his Lovers of Achilles;  
Euripides' Alexandros (Paris exposed and  
recognized — partially recovered from

papyrus), Palamedes, and Philoctetes (the versions that competed with the survivors). The tragic Troy we have is perhaps a tenth of the tragic Troy there was.

## V. LYRIC VOICES

**SAPPHO · fragment 44 (“The Wedding of Hector and Andromache”) · c. 600 BC**

The marriage the Iliad only mourns, sung whole: Hector and Andromache brought over the salt sea to Troy amid myrrh and cassia and the sound of pipes, “like to the gods.” Whether it ends in shadow is invisible — the fragment breaks off at the height of the joy, which is somehow the most Iliadic thing about it.

**STESICHORUS · Palinode · 6th c. BC ·**

**fragments**

The poet struck blind, tradition said, for blaming Helen — and cured on recanting: “The story is not true. You never went in the well-benched ships; you never came to the citadel of Troy.” The first recorded retraction in Western literature, and the seed of Euripides’ Helen.

**PINDAR · Nemean 7, Nemean 8, Isthmian 8, and passim · early 5th c. BC · complete odes**

The Iliad’s heroes as the currency of praise: Nemean 8 on Ajax destroyed by the secret ballot (“envy fastens always on the good”); Nemean 7 on Neoptolemus dead at Delphi, with Pindar’s startling charge that Odysseus’s reputation outruns his deeds because sweet-worded Homer inflated it; Isthmian 8 on Themis’s prophecy that



Thetis's son would outdo his father — the divine near-miss behind the whole poem. Pindar reads Homer the way the fifth century did: as scripture to be corrected.

## VI. THE PARODY

**BATRACHOMYOMACHIA** (“The Battle of Frogs and Mice”) · Hellenistic, though antiquity credited it to Homer · complete, ~300 lines

A mouse drowns; the mice arm for war; Zeus convenes the gods to watch; crabs settle it. Every convention of the Iliad — the arming scene, the aristeia, the divine council, the pathetic obituary — miniaturized onto a pond. The ancients thought Homer wrote it as a joke on

himself, which is false as scholarship and perfect as criticism.

**LUCIAN · True History; Dialogues of the Dead · 2nd c. AD · complete**

In the True History Lucian sails to the Isle of the Blest and interviews Homer, settling the scholarly questions directly: asked about the lines the critics bracket as spurious, Homer says he wrote every one — a joke aimed precisely at the atheteses recorded throughout this edition's notes. The Dialogues of the Dead send Achilles, Ajax, and Helen's skull down to Hades to be needled by Menippus: the underworld of Odyssey 11 replayed as satire.

**VII. THE PHILOSOPHERS'  
QUARREL**

Homer was ancient Greece's schoolbook, scripture, and moral authority — which is why the philosophers could not leave him alone.

**XENOPHANES and HERACLITUS · 6th-5th  
c. BC · fragments**

The opening shots: Xenophanes — “Homer and Hesiod attributed to the gods everything that is shame and reproach among men”; Heraclitus — Homer “deserves to be thrown out of the contests and beaten with a staff.” The scandal of the Iliad's gods, stated at maximum volume, within two centuries of the poem.

**PLATO · Ion; Republic, books 2-3 and 10 ·  
4th c. BC · complete**

The Ion teases a Homeric performer who knows everything about the poems and nothing about anything; the Republic, with

visible reluctance and repeated professions of love, banishes Homer from the ideal city for making gods lie and good men wail — citing the Iliad’s grieving Achilles by name. “There is an ancient quarrel between philosophy and poetry”: this is where it is declared, and the Iliad is the battlefield.

**ARISTOTLE · Poetics · 4th c. BC · complete  
(the surviving book)**

The defense. Homer is “divine beyond the rest” precisely for what this edition’s introduction calls the poem’s shape: he took one action — not the whole war — and made a unity of it, and he knew, alone among epic poets, when to shut up and let his people speak. Aristotle’s few pages set the terms of epic criticism permanently.

**LONGINUS · On the Sublime · 1st c. AD ·  
complete (with gaps)**

The most quotable of ancient critics on the Iliad's grandeur (the gods' battle, the horses' leap — our 5.770-772 — measured against the space of the world), and author of the famous verdict that in the Odyssey Homer is the setting sun: the greatness remains, without the intensity.

**PLUTARCH · How the Young Man Should  
Study Poetry · 1st-2nd c. AD · complete**

The ancient world's reading manual for Homer — how to profit from a poet who shows bad behavior — and, for this project, a benefactor: his quotation is the sole preserver of the four suppressed lines of Phoenix's confession (our 9.458-461 gap, translated in the note there from his text).

**DIO CHRYSOSTOM · Oration 11, “The Trojan Discourse” · c. 100 AD · complete**

A sophist’s tour de force arguing, with a straight face, that Homer lied and Troy won the war. Silly and serious at once: the earliest full display of how much play there is in a story everyone knows from one contested source.

## **VIII. ROME’S ANSWER**

**VIRGIL · Aeneid · 19 BC · complete, 12 books**

The losers’ sequel and the Iliad’s greatest reply. Virgil takes the one Trojan the Iliad conspicuously saves — Aeneas, rescued by Poseidon in our Book 20 “so that the race of Dardanus not perish seedless,” with the note there recording the variant Strabo knew, in which his line shall rule “over all”

— and builds Rome on the prophecy. Books 1-6 rewrite the *Odyssey*, books 7-12 the *Iliad*, and the poem ends on a deliberate, troubling inversion of our Book 24: where Achilles yields to a suppliant, Aeneas, remembering a dead friend, does not.

**OVID · *Metamorphoses*, books 12-13;**

***Heroides* 3 · c. 8 AD · complete**

*Metamorphoses* 12-13 run the war past at Ovid's speed — invulnerable Cygnus, the centaurs' brawl told by Nestor grown even older, and the Judgment of the Arms staged as a full courtroom debate between Ajax's deeds and Ulysses' words (words win; Ajax becomes a flower). *Heroides* 3 is the letter of Briseis to Achilles: the woman over whom the *Iliad*'s quarrel broke, given at last a voice and a viewpoint — the

ancient poem this project's Briseis passages most want beside them.

**CATULLUS · Poem 64 · c. 55 BC · complete**

The wedding of Peleus and Thetis in miniature epic, with the Fates singing the unborn Achilles as a prophecy of glorious slaughter — the Iliad's future tense made a lullaby, and meant to chill.

**SENECA · Trojan Women · 1st c. AD · complete**

Euripides' beach re-staged in the imperial manner: Astyanax and Polyxena, rhetoric at the cliff's edge. The Troy play as Rome's meditation on its own capacity for atrocity.

**ILIAS LATINA · attributed to Baebius**

**Italicus · 1st c. AD · complete, ~1,070 lines**

The Iliad compressed into a Latin school text — and, after the West lost its Greek,



the thread by which the poem itself (as opposed to the Troy story) stayed faintly alive in Europe for a thousand years.

## **IX. THE HOAX**

**DICTYS CRETENSIS · Journal of the Trojan War · Greek original c. 1st-2nd c. AD (papyrus-confirmed), Latin version 4th c. · complete in Latin DARES PHRYGIUS · The Fall of Troy: A History · Latin, 5th-6th c. · complete**

The fake eyewitnesses: “Dictys” claims to be a Cretan soldier’s war diary dug up from his tomb, “Dares” a Trojan priest’s account (he is borrowed from our 5.9, where a Dares serves as priest of Hephaestus) — both “predating” Homer, both correcting him, both stripping out the gods, and both

written centuries after him. The Middle Ages, preferring eyewitnesses to poets, took them as history: through Benoît de Sainte-Maure and Guido delle Colonne they begat the medieval Troy, and thence Boccaccio, Chaucer's Troilus and Criseyde, and Shakespeare's Troilus and Cressida — a whole tradition descended from two forgeries and a minor character. (Troilus himself gets one line in the Iliad, among the dead sons Priam counts at 24.257.)

**PHILOSTRATUS · Heroicus ("On Heroes") ·  
early 3rd c. AD · complete**

A Phoenician traveler and a vinedresser talk in a vineyard haunted by the ghost of Protesilaus — the first Achaean to die at Troy, dead before the Iliad opens — who corrects Homer on points of detail from personal experience. The gentlest of the

rebuttal-fictions, and the one closest to this project's next undertaking: it is, in its way, an interview with the fallen.

## **X. THE SCHOLARS**

**THE ALEXANDRIANS · Zenodotus,  
Aristophanes of Byzantium, Aristarchus ·  
3rd-2nd c. BC · surviving only through the  
scholia**

The founders of the text: the librarians of Alexandria who collated the manuscripts, invented the critical signs, bracketed what they doubted, and fixed the vulgate this translation renders. They appear throughout this edition's notes as living interlocutors — Zenodotus making Agamemnon stand, Aristarchus doubting the divine singer and the Judgment of

Paris — because the poem we have is, in part, their argument.

**THE SCHOLIA · especially the Venetus A manuscript (10th c. AD) · edited by Erbse (1969-88)**

The margins of the great Byzantine Iliad manuscripts preserve, in compressed centuries-deep layers, the wreckage of ancient Homeric scholarship — Aristarchus’s judgments, rejected variants, allegorists, grammarians, the lot. The Venetus A, whose margins carry the richest layer, is the single most important physical object in the poem’s transmission; its apparatus is the ancestor of the one extracted for this project. High-resolution images of the manuscript itself are freely available online through the Homer Multitext project.

**PORPHYRY · Homeric Questions · 3rd c. AD ·  
partially preserved**

The problem-and-solution tradition:  
apparent contradictions in Homer posed  
and resolved, some brilliantly, some by  
main force. The ancestor of every “but in  
Book 5 he was wounded” argument  
readers have with epics to this day.

**EUSTATHIUS OF THESSALONICA ·  
Commentaries on the Iliad · 12th c. AD ·  
complete, enormous**

A Byzantine archbishop’s line-by-line  
commentary that folds in everything he  
could still read of the older scholarship —  
much of it now surviving nowhere else.  
The last ancient reader, in effect, writing  
at the door of the modern ones.

**THE CONTEST OF HOMER AND HESIOD  
(Certamen) · compiled 2nd c. AD from older**

## **material · complete**

A fiction in which the two founding poets compete before a king: Hesiod asks the trick questions, Homer answers in effortless hexameters, and the prize goes to Hesiod — because the judge prefers the poet of peace and farming to the poet of slaughter. The tradition's own verdict on the Iliad's greatness, and its own joke about what greatness is for.

## **A CLOSING NOTE**

The shortest true history of ancient literature is that it is a long argument with the Iliad. The Odyssey answers it; the Cycle completes it; the tragedians prosecute it on behalf of its victims; the philosophers put it on trial; Alexandria edits it; Rome

appropriates it; the forgers depose it; the satirists interview it; and the scholiasts annotate every round of the fight in the margins. Any door in this list opens back into the poem. Begin anywhere.

# Index of Principal Names

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The poem's principal persons, gods, peoples, and places — every figure of consequence — with a pronunciation (Say:), epithets, aliases, kin, and line citations. Each citation is a link: tap a **book.line** number to jump to that verse. Pronunciations give the traditional anglicized reading; **stress falls on the capitalized syllable**. The several hundred men named once and killed in the same breath are catalogued for a later edition.

**Abantes** (Ἀβαντες) · PEOPLE — Say: uh-BAN-teez



The Euboean contingent of the  
Catalogue of Ships, holding Chalcis,  
Eretria,  
Histiaea, Cerinthus, Dios, Carystus and  
Styra, and led by Elephenor son of  
Chalcodon. The poem marks them twice  
over: they wear their hair long behind  
and  
shorn in front, and they are spearmen  
who close to break corslets rather than  
fight at range.

*Kin:* led by Elephenor, Chalcodon's son.

**Refs:** 2.536, 2.541, 2.542, 4.464. Books 2,  
4.

*See also:* Achaeans.

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**Abydos** (Ἄβυδος) · PLACE — Say: uh-BY-dos  
A town on the Asian shore of the  
Hellespont, held with Sestus and Arisbe

by

Asius' contingent of Trojan allies. It is  
named twice more for the men who  
come

from it: Democoon, Priam's bastard son,  
who kept the fast mares there, and the  
Phaenops whose shape Apollo borrows  
to shame Hector.

**Refs:** 2.836, 4.500, 17.584. Books 2, 4, 17.

*See also:* Asius, Arisbe, Hellespont.

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**Acamas** (Ἀκάμας) · MORTAL — *Say:* AK-uh-  
mas

Two men of the name fight on the  
Trojan side, and the poem keeps them  
apart. The

first is a son of Antenor, named with his  
brother Archelochus in the Catalogue  
and again among Hector's captains at

11.60; in Book 14 he stands over Archelochus' body and kills Promachus in vengeance, vaunting over him, and Meriones runs him down as he mounts his chariot at 16.342. The second is a Thracian leader, Eussorus' son, "the man who was best among the Thracians," whom Telamonian Ajax kills at 6.8; Ares had worn his likeness to rally the Trojans a book earlier (5.462).

*Kin:* the Trojan Acamas is Antenor's son and Archelochus' brother; the Thracian is Eussorus' son.

*Kills:* Promachus (14.476–477). *Killed by:* Meriones (16.342); the Thracian Acamas by Ajax (6.8).

**Refs:** 2.823, 2.844, 5.462, 6.8, 11.60, 12.100, 14.476, 14.478, 14.488, 16.342. Books 2, 5, 6, 11, 12, 14, 16.

*See also:* Antenor, Archelochus, Peiroos, Thracians, Meriones.

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**Achaea** (Ἀχαιΐς) · PLACE — *Say:* uh-KEE-uh  
The Achaeans' homeland, named in the formula "horse-pasturing Argos and Achaea of the beautiful women" that closes the terms of the duel in Book 3, and turned against the army as a taunt in Menelaus' reproach — "Women of Achaea, men of Achaea no longer" (7.96).

**Refs:** 3.75, 3.258, 7.96, 11.770. Books 3, 7, 11.

*See also:* Achaeans, Argos.

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**Achaeans** (Ἀχαιοί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* uh-KEE-unz

The poem's default name for the Greeks besieging Troy, used interchangeably with

Argives and Danaans for the same host. After Zeus and the Trojans it is the commonest name in the Iliad: the army is the standing audience before which honor

is won and lost, the assembly that must be persuaded, and the collective whose griefs the second line of the poem announces (1.2).

*Epithets:* “the long-haired Achaeans” (κάρη κομόωντες Ἀχαιοί, 2.11); “the strong-greaved Achaeans” (ἐϋκνήμιδες Ἀχαιοί, 1.17); “the bronze-shirted Achaeans”

(χαλκοχίτωνες Ἀχαιοί, 1.371).

*Also called:* Argives; Danaans — metrically convenient synonyms for the

same  
host, not distinct peoples. The  
Myrmidons and Hellenes are Achilles'  
own  
contingent and are not synonyms for  
the whole army.

**Refs:** 1.2, 1.17, 1.371, 2.11, 2.51 ...and  
throughout.

Books 1–24.

*See also:* Argives, Danaans, Myrmidons,  
Hellenes, Achaea, Agamemnon.

---

**Achilles** (Ἀχιλλεύς) · MORTAL — Say: uh-  
KIL-eez

The poem's subject, greatest of the  
Achaeans, whose wrath is its  
announced theme  
and its first word. Agamemnon's seizure  
of Briseis drives him from the fighting;

his refusal of the embassy in Book 9  
hardens the quarrel past mending; and  
Patroclus' death in his own armor  
brings him back not to win the war but  
to kill

Hector. The Iliad ends not with that  
vengeance but with him giving the  
body up to

Priam, having been argued out of his  
rage by an old man who kisses his  
hands.

*Epithets:* “swift-footed” (πόδας ὠκύς /  
ποδάρκης, 1.58); “brilliant” (δῖος, 1.7);  
“Zeus-sprung” (διογενής, 1.489).

*Also called:* Peleus' son; Aeacus'  
grandson; Thetis' son.

*Kin:* son of Peleus and the sea-nymph  
Thetis; grandson of Aeacus; father of  
Neoptolemus, reared on Scyros.

Companion of Patroclus; foster-son of

Phoenix.

**Refs:** 1.1, 1.58, 1.348, 9.199, 16.2, 18.22,  
22.330, 24.596 ...and throughout.

Books 1–2, 4–24.

*See also:* Patroclus, Hector, Agamemnon,  
Thetis, Peleus, Aeacus, Briseis, Priam,  
Phoenix.

---

**Actor** (ἄκτωρ) · MORTAL — Say: AK-tor

A name borne by more than one man of  
the older generation, all of them fathers  
rather than fighters. The poem's Actors  
include Azeus' son, in whose house  
Astyoche bore Ares' twin sons  
Ascalaphus and Ialmenus; the father of  
Menoetius,  
and so Patroclus' grandfather (11.785,  
16.14); the father of Echeclus (16.189);  
and the father of the twins Cteatus and



Eurytus, called both “Actor’s line” and “the two sons of Actor,” who crowd past Nestor’s horses in his reminiscence of the Epeian games.

*Kin:* variously father of Menoetius, of Echeclus, and of the Molione twins.

**Refs:** 2.513, 2.621, 11.750, 11.785, 13.186, 16.14, 16.189, 23.638.

Books 2, 11, 13, 16, 23.

*See also:* Menoetius, Patroclus, Amarynceus.

---

**Adamas** (Ἀδάμας) · MORTAL — *Say:* AD-uh-mas

Son of Asius, one of the Trojan captains who storm the wall in Book 12. In the fighting at the ships he stabs Antilochus’ shield and slips back into the ranks

“dodging doom,” but Meriones catches  
him with a spear-cast in the groin and  
he  
dies writhing like a roped bull.  
Deiphobus names him among the dead  
Trojan  
leaders at 13.771.

*Kin:* son of Asius, Hyrtacus’ son.

*Killed by:* Meriones (13.567–575).

**Refs:** 12.140, 13.561, 13.566, 13.760,  
13.771. Books 12, 13.

*See also:* Asius, Meriones, Antilochus.

---

**Admetus** (Ἀδμητος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ad-

MEE-tus

Father of Eumelus and husband of  
Alcestis, “brilliant among women,  
loveliest of  
the daughters of Pelias.” He does not

come to Troy: the name is a patronymic  
throughout, marking his son, who  
brings eleven ships from Pherae and  
drives the  
best horses in the Achaean host.  
*Kin*: husband of Alcestis; father of  
Eumelus.

**Refs:** 2.713, 2.714, 23.289, 23.391, 23.532.

Books 2, 23.

*See also*: Eumelus, Alcestis.

---

**Adrastus** (Ἄδρηστος) · MORTAL — Say: uh-  
DRAS-tus

King of Sicyon in the older generation  
— “Sicyon, where Adrastus first was  
king”

— and owner of Arion, the swift horse  
“whose line was from the gods,” against  
which Antilochus is told even a better

driver could not have won. His  
daughters  
marry into the poem's Argive houses:  
Aegialeia is named as Diomedes' wife at  
5.412, and Tydeus married a daughter of  
his after settling at Argos (14.121). The  
translation spells him *Adrastus* and the  
Trojan-side leader *Adrestus*, keeping  
two men distinct whom one spelling  
would merge; see `canon.md`.  
*Kin*: father of Aegialeia; father-in-law of  
Tydeus.  
**Refs**: 2.572, 5.412, 14.121, 23.347. Books  
2, 5, 14, 23.  
*See also*: Adrestus, Arion, Diomedes,  
Sicyon.

---

**Adrestus** (Ἀδρηστος) · MORTAL — Say: uh-  
DRES-tus

Three Trojan-side men bear this  
spelling. One leads the contingent from  
Adresteia  
and Apaesus with his brother Amphius,  
sons of Merops of Percote, who foresaw  
their  
deaths and could not keep them home.  
The second is the suppliant of Book 6,  
thrown  
from a bolting chariot, who clasps  
Menelaus' knees and offers ransom.  
Menelaus is  
on the point of granting it when  
Agamemnon runs up and shames him —  
“Soft-hearted  
Menelaus!” — so that Menelaus pushes  
the man back with his hand and  
Agamemnon  
does the killing (6.62–65). A third falls  
to Patroclus. The translation reserves

*Adrastus* for the Sicyon king.

*Kin:* the Percotian Adrestus is Merops' son and Amphius' brother.

*Killed by:* Agamemnon (6.63–65); the third by Patroclus (16.694).

**Refs:** 2.830, 6.37, 6.45, 6.63, 16.694. Books 2, 6, 16.

*See also:* Adrastus, Amphius, Merops, Agamemnon, Menelaus.

---

**Aeacus** (Αἰακός) · MORTAL — Say: EE-uh-kus

Peleus' father and Achilles' grandfather, himself sprung from Zeus (21.189). He never appears: in all its occurrences the name is a patronymic, and the translation keeps the generations apart by a fixed rule — “Aeacus' son” is **Peleus**, “Aeacus' grandson” is **Achilles**,

except inside the fixed epithet  
formulas, where “the swift-footed son  
of Aeacus” and “Aeacus’ blameless son”  
mean

Achilles. See

translation/CONVENTIONS.md.

*Kin:* son of Zeus; father of Peleus;  
grandfather of Achilles.

**Refs:** 2.860, 2.874, 9.184, 16.15, 16.140,  
16.854, 21.178, 21.189 ...and  
throughout. Books 2, 9–11, 16–18, 21, 23.  
*See also:* Achilles, Peleus.

---

**Aeneas** (Αἰνεΐας) · MORTAL — *Say:* ee-NEE-  
us or uh-NEE-us

Leader of the Dardanians and, after  
Hector, Troy’s best fighter. Son of  
Anchises  
and Aphrodite, he is twice snatched

from death by gods who have plans for him —  
by his mother and Apollo when Diomedes crushes his hip with a boulder (5.311ff),  
and by Poseidon when Achilles has him beaten, in the scene that gives the poem its  
one glance past its own ending: Aeneas is destined to escape, “so that the race of  
Dardanus not perish seedless,” and his line will rule the Trojans hereafter (20.302–308).

*Also called:* Anchises’ son.

*Kin:* son of Anchises and Aphrodite; of the line of Dardanus through Assaracus.

**Refs:** 2.820, 5.166, 5.311, 5.445, 13.459, 16.620, 17.323, 20.302 ...and  
throughout. Books 2, 5–6, 8, 11–17, 20,



23.

*See also:* Anchises, Aphrodite, Dardanus, Dardanians, Achilles, Diomedes.

---

**Aeseopus** (Αἴσηπος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ee-SEE-pus

A Trojan twin, killed with his brother Pedaesus by Euryalus in the general rout of

Book 6. The poem gives the pair a full genealogy at the moment of their death:

the water-nymph Abarbarea bore them to Bucolion, Laomedon's eldest son, got in

secret while he was shepherding. The name is also a river of the Troad, one of those the gods turn against the Achaean wall (12.21).

*Kin:* son of Bucolion and the nymph

Abarbarea; twin of Pedasus.

*Killed by:* Euryalus (6.20–28).

**Refs:** 2.825, 4.91, 6.21, 12.21. Books 2, 4, 6, 12.

*See also:* Pedasus, Bucolion, Euryalus, Laomedon.

---

**Aethe** (Αἴθη) · OTHER — *Say:* EE-thee

Agamemnon's mare, lent to Menelaus  
for the chariot race at Patroclus' funeral

—

a gift to Agamemnon from Echepolus  
son of Anchises, made so that he might  
stay

home from the war. Nestor's son  
Antilochus is warned that she will  
“pour shame”

on his horses, and her fury nearly

carries Menelaus past him at the finish.

*Kin:* yoked with Menelaus' own horse

Podargus.

**Refs:** 23.295, 23.408, 23.524. Book 23.

*See also:* Podargus, Menelaus,

Antilochus, Echeolus.

---

**Aetolians** (Αἰτωλοί) · PEOPLE — Say: ee-

TOH-lee-unz

The contingent from Pleuron, Olenus,

Pylene, Chalcis and Calydon, led to Troy

by

Thoas son of Andraemon with forty

ships. The Catalogue explains the odd

succession: Oeneus' sons were dead and

Meleager with them, so the whole rule

fell

to Thoas. Their older war against the

Curetes over Calydon is the setting of

Phoenix's Meleager story in Book 9.

*Kin:* led by Thoas, Andraemon's son.

**Refs:** 2.638, 2.643, 4.527, 9.529, 9.531,

13.218, 23.633. Books 2, 4–5, 9,

13, 15, 23.

*See also:* Thoas, Meleager, Oeneus,

Calydon, Curetes.

---

**Agamemnon** (Ἀγαμέμνων) · MORTAL —

*Say:* ag-uh-MEM-non

Commander of the whole Achaean expedition and Achilles' antagonist in the quarrel

that starts the poem. His refusal to give Chryseis back brings the plague, and his taking of Briseis in compensation drives Achilles from the fighting; the disaster that follows is his to answer for, and in Book 19 he answers for it by blaming

Blindness sent from Zeus. His authority rests on the sceptre whose descent Hephaestus to Zeus to Hermes to Pelops to Atreus to Thyestes to himself the poem

traces at 2.101–108: he rules “many islands and all of Argos,” and he is consistently a worse fighter than the men he commands.

*Epithets:* “lord of men” (ἄναξ ἀνδρῶν, 1.7); “wide-ruling” (εὐρὺ κρείων, 1.102); “shepherd of the people” (ποιμὴν λαῶν, of Agamemnon at 2.243) — the last is a general royal epithet, used of Atreus and others too.

*Also called:* Atreus’ son — in the singular this means Agamemnon unless the scene

is Menelaus’; see *canon.md*.

*Kin:* son of Atreus, grandson of Pelops;

brother of Menelaus; husband of Clytemnestra.

**Refs:** 1.24, 1.130, 2.100, 2.107, 4.148, 9.114, 11.91, 19.86 ...and throughout.

Books 1–11, 13–14, 16–19, 23–24.

*See also:* Achilles, Menelaus, Atreus, Briseis, Chryseis, Blindness.

---

**Agenor** (Ἀγήνωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* uh-JEE-nor

Antenor's son, "a man blameless and strong," and the last Trojan to stand in Achilles' path before Hector. Apollo puts courage in him at 21.545 and he turns to face the charge, breaking off his own debate with the formula the poem gives its cornered men — "But why does my own

heart argue these things with me?”

(21.562,

as at 11.407, 17.97, 22.122, 22.385). He casts, and Apollo snatches him away in mist, then wears his shape to decoy Achilles from the walls: the trick that lets

the routed Trojans get inside the gates.

*Kin:* son of Antenor; father of Echeclus (20.474).

**Refs:** 4.467, 11.59, 12.93, 13.490, 15.340, 20.474, 21.545, 21.595, 21.600.

Books 4, 11–16, 20–21.

*See also:* Antenor, Achilles, Apollo, Hector.

---

**Ajax** (Αἴαξ) · MORTAL — *Say:* AY-jaks

Telamon’s son, from Salamis with twelve ships: the biggest man in the

army and its  
best fighter after Achilles, whom Helen  
picks out from the wall as “gigantic  
Ajax,  
wall of the Achaeans.” He carries a  
tower-like shield of seven oxhides and  
an  
eighth layer of bronze, made by Tychius  
of Hyle. The lot chooses him to duel  
Hector in Book 7, and they part at  
nightfall exchanging gifts; he is one of  
the  
three sent to Achilles in Book 9, where  
his short blunt speech comes nearest to  
moving him; and in Book 15 he holds  
the last deck alone against the fire,  
giving  
ground plank by plank. Unqualified  
“Ajax” means him unless the line marks  
the



other.

*Epithets:* “wall of the Achaeans” (ἔρκος Ἀχαιῶν, 3.229).

*Also called:* Telamonian Ajax; Telamon’s son; the great Ajax.

*Kin:* son of Telamon; half-brother of Teucer.

**Refs:** 2.557, 3.229, 7.183, 7.219, 9.622, 15.727, 17.132 ...and throughout.

Books 1–18, 23.

*See also:* Ajax son of Oïleus, Ajaxes, Telamon, Teucer, Hector, Achilles.

---

**Ajax son of Oïleus** (Αἴας Ὀϊλῆος υἱός) ·

MORTAL — Say: AY-jaks, son of oh-EYE-lyoos

Leader of the Locrians with forty ships:  
“the lesser Ajax, in no way so big as  
Telamonian Ajax / but far smaller: a

little man, in a linen corslet, / but with  
the spear he surpassed all Hellenes and  
Achaeans” (2.528–530). He is the fastest  
Achaean in the chase — most of the kills  
in the Book 14 rout are his, “for there  
was no one like him for speed of foot”  
when men broke and ran — and the  
savage  
half of the pair: it is he who cuts off  
Imbrius’ head in wrath for  
Amphimachus  
and sends it “rolling like a ball through  
the crowd” to fall at Hector’s feet  
(13.202–205). In the footrace of the  
games Athena trips him at a dead run  
into  
the cattle-dung, and he stands spitting  
it out while the Argives laugh at him  
(23.774–784).  
*Also called:* swift Ajax; the lesser Ajax;

Oïleus' son. Unqualified "Ajax" is the Telamonian — see [canon.md](#).

*Kin:* son of Oïleus; half-brother of Medon, Oïleus' bastard son ([13.694–695](#)).

**Refs:** [2.527](#), [13.203](#), [13.701](#), [14.520](#), [23.473](#), [23.754](#), [23.774](#). Books 2, 13–14, 23.

*See also:* Ajax, Ajaxes, Oïleus, Locrians, Medon.

---

**Ajaxes** (Αἴαντε) · MORTAL — *Say:* AY-jak-seez

The dual — Telamonian Ajax and Ajax son of Oïleus fighting as a single unit, and

the poem's standing image of a defensive line that holds. They are always found

where the wall or the ships are about to break: marshaling the towers in Book 12,  
addressed first by Poseidon when he comes to rally the army in Book 13, carrying  
Imbrius' body off like two lions with a goat, and holding the line over Patroclus' corpse in Book 17. The Book 4 simile of a black storm-cloud coming on before the West Wind is given to them together.  
*Also called:* the two Ajaxes.  
**Refs:** 2.406, 4.273, 4.280, 12.265, 13.46, 13.197, 17.507, 17.732, 18.157.  
Books 2, 4–8, 10, 12–13, 16–18.  
*See also:* Ajax, Ajax son of Oileus, Poseidon, Patroclus.

---

**Alastor** (Ἀλάστωρ) · MORTAL — Say: uh-LAS-tor

At least three men. One is a Pylian, named among Nestor's captains at 4.295 and

twice paired with Mecisteus son of Echius as a stretcher-bearer, carrying the

wounded off to the ships (8.333, 13.422).

Another is a Trojan-side victim in Odysseus' rally at 5.677. The third is named only as a father: Tros, "Alastor's son," is the suppliant who reaches for Achilles' knees and is killed anyway at 20.463.

**Refs:** 4.295, 5.677, 8.333, 13.422, 20.463.

Books 4–5, 8, 13, 20.

*See also:* Nestor, Odysseus, Tros.

---

**Alcathous** (Ἀλκάθοος) · MORTAL — Say: al-

KATH-oh-us

A Trojan captain, Aesyetes' son, married  
to Anchises' eldest daughter

Hippodameia.

Idomeneus kills him in one of the  
poem's strangest deaths: Poseidon  
charms his eyes

and shackles his limbs so that he stands  
unmoving "like a grave-pillar or a tree  
in

high leaf" and cannot dodge, and his  
heart goes on beating hard enough to  
shake the

spear standing in it. Deiphobus calls  
Aeneas to avenge the man who reared  
him.

*Kin:* son of Aesyetes; husband of  
Hippodameia, Anchises' eldest  
daughter;

brother-in-law and foster-father to  
Aeneas.

*Killed by:* Idomeneus (13.427–444).

**Refs:** 12.93, 13.428, 13.465, 13.496. Books  
12, 13.

*See also:* Idomeneus, Aeneas, Anchises,  
Poseidon.

---

**Alcimedon** (Ἀλκιμέδων) · MORTAL — *Say:*

al-SIM-uh-don

Son of Laerces and grandson of  
Haemon, one of the five company-  
commanders Achilles

sets over the Myrmidons when  
Patroclus goes out (16.197). In Book 17  
he finds

Automedon fighting alone from  
Achilles' chariot with Patroclus dead  
and Hector

wearing the armor, tells him he has lost his wits, and takes the reins so that Automedon can fight on foot.

*Kin:* son of Laerces, grandson of Haemon.

**Refs:** 16.197, 17.467, 17.475, 17.481, 17.500, 17.501. Books 16, 17.

*See also:* Automedon, Achilles, Myrmidons, Patroclus.

---

**Alpheius** (Ἀλφειός) · PLACE — Say: al-FEE-us

The great river of the western Peloponnese, “which flows wide through the Pylians’ land.” It marks Nestor’s country in his reminiscences — the cattle-raid that reached its sacred stream by midday, the ford named in the



Catalogue — and  
as a river-god it heads a Pylian  
genealogy: Alpheius begot Ortilochus,  
who  
fathered Diocles, whose twin sons  
Aeneas kills at 5.541–560.  
**Refs:** 2.592, 5.545, 11.712, 11.726, 11.728.  
Books 2, 5, 11.  
*See also:* Nestor, Pylos, Elis.

---

**Altes** (Ἄλτης) · MORTAL — *Say:* AL-teez  
Lord of the Lelegians, “holding steep  
Pedasus on the Satnioeis,” and father of  
Laothoe, one of Priam’s wives. He is  
named only through his grandsons:  
Lycaon  
recites the descent while begging  
Achilles for his life at 21.85, and Priam  
names

him again mourning Lycaon and Polydorus at 22.51, recalling the dowry “the famous name” gave with his daughter.

*Kin:* father of Laothoe; grandfather of Lycaon and Polydorus.

**Refs:** 21.85, 21.86, 22.51. Books 21, 22.

*See also:* Laothoe, Lycaon, Polydorus, Priam, Pegasus.

---

**Amarynceus** (Ἀμαρυγκεύς) · MORTAL —

*Say:* am-uh-RIN-syoos

An Epeian lord of the older generation, father of Diores. Nestor’s last long reminiscence is of the funeral games his sons held for him at Buprasium, where Nestor beat every man there at boxing, wrestling, running and the spear, and lost

only the chariot race to the two sons of  
Actor — the memory he offers Achilles  
as

he accepts a prize he no longer has to  
compete for.

*Kin:* father of Diores.

**Refs:** 2.622, 4.517, 23.630. Books 2, 4, 23.

*See also:* Diores, Nestor, Actor, Epeians,  
Buprasium.

---

**Amazons** (Ἀμαζόνες) · PEOPLE — Say: AM-  
uh-zonz

A people of women who fight, named  
only in the back-story and only twice:

Priam

recalls campaigning against them in  
Phrygia in his youth, and Bellerophon is  
set

to fight them as the third of the

impossible tasks he survives.

*Epithets*: “the match of men”

(ἀντιάνειραι, 3.189).

**Refs**: 3.189, 6.186. Books 3, 6.

*See also*: Priam, Bellerophon.

---

**Amphidamas** (Ἀμφιδάμας) · MORTAL — *Say*:

am-FID-uh-mas

Two men. One is of Cythera, a link in the descent of the boar’s-tusk helmet Odysseus wears on the night raid:

Autolycus stole it, gave it to

Amphidamas at

Scandeia, who gave it to Molus, whose son Meriones lends it on. The other is of Opoeis, whose son Patroclus killed as a boy in a quarrel over dice — “a child’s act; I did not mean it” — the killing that brought him to Peleus’ house.

*Kin*: the Cytheran is a guest-friend of Molus; the Opoeisian is father of the boy Patroclus killed.

**Refs:** 10.268, 10.269, 23.87. Books 10, 23.  
*See also:* Meriones, Molus, Patroclus, Opoeis.

---

**Amphimachus** (Ἀμφίμαχος) · MORTAL —

*Say:* am-FIM-uh-kus

Two men, both leaders in the Catalogue. The Epeian is a son of Cteatus, of Actor's line, one of four captains from Elis; Hector spears him in the chest as he comes into the fighting at the ships and is reaching to strip his helmet when Ajax drives him back, and the lesser Ajax kills Imbrius in wrath for him. The

other is

a Carian, son of Nomion and brother of  
Nastes, one of the pair who “went to  
war

decked in gold, like a girl.”

*Kin:* the Epeian is Cteatus’ son, of Actor’s  
line; the Carian is Nomion’s son and  
Nastes’ brother.

*Killed by:* Hector (13.185–187).

**Refs:** 2.620, 2.870, 2.871, 13.185, 13.189,  
13.195, 13.203. Books 2, 13.

*See also:* Nastes, Actor, Cteatus, Hector,  
Ajax.

---

**Anchises** (Ἀγχίσις) · MORTAL — Say: an-  
KY-seez

Aeneas’ father by Aphrodite, who  
“conceived him to Anchises herding  
cattle” on the

spurs of Ida. He does not fight: he belongs to the genealogy Aeneas recites to

Achilles at 20.208–241, the Dardanian line running Dardanus — Erichthonius — Tros

— Assaracus — Capys — Anchises — Aeneas, the branch that survives when Priam's does

not. A different Anchises, of Sicyon, is the father of the Echepolus who bribed Agamemnon with a mare to be let off the war (23.296).

*Kin:* son of Capys; father of Aeneas by Aphrodite; father-in-law of Alcatous.

**Refs:** 2.819, 5.247, 5.313, 13.428, 17.491, 20.208, 20.240, 23.296.

Books 2, 5, 12–13, 17, 20, 23.

*See also:* Aeneas, Aphrodite, Dardanus, Capys, Alcatous, Echepolus.

---

**Andromache** (Ἀνδρομάχη) · MORTAL — *Say:*

an-DROM-uh-kee

Hector's wife, daughter of Eëtion of  
Thebe-under-Placus, whose father and  
seven

brothers Achilles killed in the sack of  
that city — so that, as she tells Hector,  
he is now father and mother and  
brother to her as well as husband. She  
meets him

at the Scaean Gates in Book 6 with their  
son in her arms and begs him to fight  
from the wall; he refuses, and the scene  
ends with the child frightened by his  
own

father's helmet. She is at her loom,  
ordering a bath for him, when the  
wailing

tells her he is dead (22.437–515), and



she leads the lament over his body in  
the  
poem's last scene.

*Epithets:* "white-armed" (λευκώλενος,  
6.371).

*Kin:* daughter of Eëtion; wife of Hector;  
mother of Astyanax.

**Refs:** 6.371, 6.377, 6.395, 6.405, 8.187,  
17.208, 24.723. Books 6, 8, 17, 24.

*See also:* Hector, Astyanax, Eëtion,  
Thebe, Achilles.

---

**Antenor** (Ἀντήνωρ) · MORTAL — Say: an-  
TEE-nor

The wisest of the Trojan elders and the  
one who says plainly what the war is  
about. He had hosted Menelaus and  
Odysseus on the embassy that first  
asked for

Helen back, and he identifies them for Priam from the wall; in Book 7 he tells the assembly to give Helen and her goods to the Atreidae, since “it is with sworn oaths made false that we fight,” and Paris refuses. Many of his sons die in the poem — Archelochus, Acamas, Iphidamas, Coon, Polybus — and Agenor is the last to face Achilles.

*Kin:* husband of Theano, Athena’s priestess in Troy; father of Archelochus, Acamas, Agenor, Iphidamas, Coon, Polybus, and others.

**Refs:** 2.822, 3.148, 3.203, 3.262, 6.299, 7.347, 11.221, 14.463, 21.546.

Books 2–7, 11–12, 14–15, 19–21.

*See also:* Theano, Agenor, Acamas,

Archelochus, Iphidamas, Coon, Helen,  
Paris.

---

**Antilochus** (Ἀντίλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

an-TIL-oh-kus

Nestor's son, the youngest of the

Achaean captains and among the

fastest. He kills

the first Trojan of the general fighting

(4.457) and fights hard through the

middle

books; but his two great scenes are late.

It falls to him to carry the news of

Patroclus' death to Achilles, and he does

it holding Achilles' hands, afraid he

will cut his own throat (18.32). In the

funeral games he takes second place in

the

chariot race by forcing Menelaus into a

narrow gully — his father having  
coached  
him at length in exactly such guile —  
and then gives the mare back when  
Menelaus  
challenges him on oath, in a scene of  
tact that ends the quarrel.

*Also called:* Nestor's son.

*Kin:* son of Nestor; brother of  
Thrasymedes.

**Refs:** 4.457, 5.565, 13.396, 15.585, 16.317,  
17.685, 18.2, 18.32, 23.514,  
23.541 ...and throughout. Books 4–6, 13–  
18, 23.

*See also:* Nestor, Menelaus, Achilles,  
Patroclus, Thrasymedes.

---

**Antimachus** (Ἀντίμαχος) · MORTAL — Say:  
an-TIM-uh-kus

The Trojan who took Paris' gold and argued in the assembly against giving Helen back — and who urged that Menelaus be killed on the spot when he came as an envoy.

Agamemnon kills two of his sons, Peisander and Hippolochus, in Book 11 and refuses their ransom on the strength of it: “now you will pay for your father’s foul outrage.” A third son falls to Leonteus at 12.188.

*Kin:* father of Peisander, Hippolochus, and Hippomachus.

**Refs:** 11.123, 11.132, 11.138, 12.188.

Books 11, 12.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Menelaus, Paris, Helen, Leonteus.

---

**Antiphus** (Ἄντιφος) · MORTAL — Say: AN-tih-fus

Three men. On the Achaean side, a son  
of Thessalus and grandson of Heracles,  
who

leads thirty ships with his brother  
Pheidippus from Cos and the Calydnian  
islands.

On the Trojan side, a son of Talaemenes  
who leads the Maeonians with  
Mesthles, and

a true-born son of Priam whom  
Agamemnon kills at 11.104 — he and his  
bastard

half-brother Isus riding one chariot,  
both of them men Achilles had once  
caught

on Ida watching sheep and released for  
ransom.

*Kin:* variously son of Thessalus; son of

Talaemenes; son of Priam.

*Killed by:* Agamemnon (11.109), the Priamid.

**Refs:** 2.678, 2.864, 11.101, 11.104, 11.109.

Books 2, 11.

*See also:* Pheidippus, Mesthles, Priam, Isus, Agamemnon.

---

**Aphareus** (Ἀφαρεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* AF-uh-ryoos

Son of Caletor, one of the younger Achaean captains who keep company with Meriones

and Deïpyrus on guard duty in Book 9 and in the line Idomeneus calls to in Book 13.

Aeneas kills him there with a spear-thrust to the turned throat, so that shield and

helmet crumple down on him.

*Kin:* son of Caletor.

*Killed by:* Aeneas (13.541–544).

**Refs:** 9.83, 13.478, 13.541. Books 9, 13.

*See also:* Meriones, Deïpyrus, Idomeneus, Aeneas.

---

**Aphrodite** (Ἀφροδίτη) · GOD — Say: af-roh-DY-tee

Paris' patron and the cause, through the judgment implied at 24.29–30, of the war

itself. She rescues Paris out of the duel in a mist and carries him to Helen's bedchamber, then bullies Helen into following — the poem's coldest scene between

goddess and woman. In Book 5 she comes to save Aeneas, her son, and



Diomedes

wounds her hand; she flees weeping to  
Olympus, where Dione comforts her  
and Zeus

tells her to keep to the works of  
marriage and leave war alone. She lends  
Hera the

embroidered strap of desire in Book 14,  
and in the theomachy Athena knocks  
her

flat with a blow to the breast.

*Epithets:* “laughter-loving” (φιλομειδῆς  
Ἀφροδίτη, 3.424).

*Also called:* Cypris — used in Book 5 only.

*Kin:* daughter of Zeus and Dione; mother  
of Aeneas by Anchises.

**Refs:** 3.374, 3.389, 3.424, 5.131, 5.312,  
5.330, 5.375, 14.188, 21.416, 24.699.

Books 2–5, 9, 14, 19–24.

*See also:* Paris, Helen, Aeneas, Anchises,  
Dione, Diomedes, Hera, Athena.

---

**Apisaon** (Ἀπισάων) · MORTAL — *Say:* ap-ih-  
SAY-on

Two Trojan-side men, killed in the same  
words. Phausius' son falls to Eurypylus  
at

11.578, struck “in the liver below the  
midriff,” and Paris shoots Eurypylus in  
the

thigh as he strips the body. Hippasus'  
son, a Paeonian and “their best in battle  
after Asteropaeus,” falls to Lycomedes  
at 17.348 in a line repeated verbatim  
from  
the first.

*Kin:* one is Phausius' son; the other  
Hippasus' son.

*Killed by:* Eurypylus (11.578–579);

Lycomedes (17.348–349).

**Refs:** 11.578, 11.582, 17.348. Books 11, 17.

*See also:* Eurypylus, Lycomedes,

Asteropaeus, Paris.

---

**Apollo** (Ἀπόλλων) · GOD — Say: uh-POL-oh

Troy's chief defender among the gods  
and the poem's first mover: Chryses'  
prayer

brings him down from Olympus "like  
nightfall," and his arrows loose the  
plague

that starts the quarrel (1.43–53). He  
fights on the Trojan side throughout —  
snatching Aeneas and Hector out of  
danger, standing off Diomedes at 5.437–  
444,

levelling the Achaean wall — and his

decisive act is to strike Patroclus from  
behind with the flat of his hand,  
knocking off helmet and corslet and  
leaving him  
dazed for Euphorbus and Hector  
(16.788–806). He puts strength in Hector  
one last  
time in Book 22 and then leaves him  
when Zeus’s scales sink. In Book 24 he  
keeps  
Hector’s body from disfigurement and  
shames the gods into ransoming it.  
*Epithets:* “who strikes from afar,”  
standalone “the far-striker” (ἐκηβόλος  
/  
ἑκατος, 1.15 / 1.385); “the worker-from-  
afar” (ἐκάεργος, 1.147); “god of the  
silver bow” (ἀργυρότοξος, 1.37); “the  
Lycian-born” (Λυκηγενής, 4.101);  
“famed for

the bow” (κλυτότοξος, 4.101); “of the golden sword” (χρυσάορος, 5.509).

*Also called:* Phoebus; Smintheus — the cult title of Chryses’ prayer (1.39).

*Kin:* son of Zeus and Leto; brother of Artemis.

**Refs:** 1.36, 1.43, 1.370, 1.479, 4.101, 5.437, 16.788, 21.545, 22.213, 24.18

...and throughout. Books 1–2, 4–5, 7–13, 15–18, 20–24.

*See also:* Chryses, Artemis, Leto, Patroclus, Hector, Aeneas.

---

**Archelochus** (Ἀρχέλοχος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

ar-KEL-oh-kus

One of Antenor’s sons, named in the Catalogue and again among the captains of the

Trojan storming-parties at the wall,

always paired with his brother Acamas  
as

“skilled in all fighting.” Telamonian  
Ajax kills him in Book 14 with a cast  
meant

for Polydamas: the spear takes him  
where head and neck join and shears  
both

tendons, so that his head strikes the  
ground before his knees do. Ajax then  
calls

across to Polydamas to say whether the  
man is a fair exchange for Prothoenor.

*Kin:* son of Antenor; brother of Acamas.

*Killed by:* Ajax (14.463–468).

**Refs:** 2.823, 12.100, 14.463. Books 2, 12,  
14.

*See also:* Antenor, Acamas, Ajax,  
Polydamas, Prothoenor.

---

**Areithous** (Ἀρηΐθoος) · MORTAL — Say: uh-  
REE-thoh-us

Three men. The first is the fighter of  
Nestor's Book 7 reminiscence, called by  
his  
surname the Club-man because he  
fought with neither bow nor long spear  
but smashed  
companies apart with a club of iron;  
Lycurgus killed him by craft in a narrow  
lane  
where the club was useless, and  
stripped the armor that passed to  
Ereuthalion.

The same man is named at 7.8–10 as the  
father of Menesthius of Arne, whom  
Paris  
kills, by ox-eyed Phylomedusa. A third  
Areithous is a Thracian charioteer,  
Rhigmus' aide, whom Achilles spears in

the back at 20.487.

*Kin:* the Club-man is husband of  
Phylomedusa and father of Menesthius.

*Killed by:* the Club-man by Lycurgus  
(7.142–145); the Thracian aide by  
Achilles  
(20.487–489).

**Refs:** 7.8, 7.10, 7.137, 7.138, 20.487. Books  
7, 20.

*See also:* Menesthius, Lycurgus,  
Ereuthalion, Nestor, Rhigmus, Achilles.

---

**Ares** (Ἄρης) · GOD — *Say:* AIR-eez

The war-god, who fights on the Trojan  
side and is the least dignified of the  
Olympians in the poem's handling of  
him. Athena leads him off the field by  
the  
hand in Book 5 and then, at Diomedes'



shoulder, rams the mortal's spear into  
his

belly, so that he bellows like ten  
thousand men and flees to Zeus, who  
tells him

he is the most hateful of the gods. In  
Book 21 Athena knocks him flat with a  
boundary-stone and he covers seven  
acres falling. His son Ascalaphus is  
killed at

Troy (13.518) and he is barred from  
avenging him by Zeus's designs.

*Epithets:* "bane of mortals"

(βροτολοιγός, 5.31); "blood-stained"

(μιαιφόνος,

5.31); "stormer of walls" (τειχεσιπλήτης,

5.31); "rushing" (θοῦρος, 5.30);

"insatiate of war" (ἄτος πολέμοιο,

5.388); "brazen Ares" (χάλκεος Ἄρης,

5.704);

“massive” (ὄβριμος, 5.845); “turncoat” (ἄλλοπρόσαλλος, 5.831).

*Also called:* Enyalios — chiefly in the formula “the equal of Enyalios, slayer of men” for Meriones (2.651).

*Kin:* son of Zeus and Hera; father of Ascalaphus and Ialmenus by Astyoche.

**Refs:** 5.30, 5.31, 5.385, 5.859, 13.521, 15.113, 21.391, 21.406 ...and throughout. Books 2–13, 15–24.

*See also:* Athena, Diomedes, Ascalaphus, Aphrodite, Zeus.

---

**Argives** (Ἀργεῖοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* AR-jyvz  
or AR-gyvz

One of the poem’s three interchangeable names for the whole Greek host, taken from Argos and used without distinction

from Achaeans and Danaans — the  
choice among  
them is metrical, not ethnic. Helen is  
“Argive Helen” (2.161); the plague and  
the  
grief are the Argives’ as often as the  
Achaeans’; and the assemblies, the  
funeral  
games, and the fighting at the ships are  
all narrated with the three names in  
rotation.

*Also called:* Achaeans; Danaans — the  
same host under three names. The  
Myrmidons  
and Hellenes are Achilles’ own  
contingent and are not synonyms for  
the army.

**Refs:** 1.79, 1.119, 2.109, 2.159, 5.3, 7.350,  
9.22 ...and throughout.

Books 1–19, 21–24.

*See also:* Achaeans, Danaans, Argos,  
Helen.

---

**Argos** (Ἄργος) · PLACE — *Say:* AR-gos  
Agamemnon's realm — the sceptre  
makes him "lord over many islands and  
all of  
Argos" (2.108) — and, loosely, the whole  
Greek mainland the army came from  
and  
hopes to go home to: "horse-pasturing  
Argos," "Achaean Argos, udder of the  
plowland." The Catalogue gives a  
narrower Argos, held with Tiryns by  
Diomedes  
(2.559); Hera names it first of the three  
cities dearest to her, with Sparta and  
Mycenae, and offers all three for Troy's  
destruction (4.52–53). Bellerophon's

Ephyra lies “in a fold of horse-pasturing Argos” (6.152).

**Refs:** 1.30, 2.108, 2.559, 4.52, 6.152, 9.22, 9.141, 19.115, 24.437.

Books 1–7, 9, 12–15, 19, 24.

*See also:* Argives, Agamemnon, Diomedes, Mycenae, Hera.

---

**Arion** (Ἀρίων) · OTHER — *Say:* uh-RY-on  
Adrastus’ horse, “whose line was from the gods,” named once: Nestor coaches Antilochus that if he takes the turn well no one will catch him — not even a man driving Arion, nor the horses of Laomedon.

*Kin:* Adrastus’ horse.

**Refs:** 23.346. Book 23.

*See also:* Adrastus, Nestor, Antilochus, Laomedon.

---

**Arisbe** (Ἀρίσβη) · PLACE — Say: uh-RIZ-bee

A town on the Trojan side, held with  
Sestus and Abydos by Asius son of  
Hyrtacus,

whose tall fire-colored horses came  
from there, from the river Selleïs — a  
detail

the poem repeats verbatim when he  
storms the wall (2.838 = 12.96). Axylus,  
killed

by Diomedes in Book 6, lived there and  
kept an open house by the road; and it  
is

to Arisbe that Eëtion of Imbros sends  
Lycaon after ransoming him.

**Refs:** 2.836, 2.838, 6.13, 12.96, 21.43.

Books 2, 6, 12, 21.

*See also:* Asius, Axylus, Lycaon, Abydos.

---

**Artemis** (Ἄρτεμις) · GOD — Say: AR-tuh-mis  
Apollo's sister, huntress and killer of  
women, who takes the Trojan side in  
the  
theomachy and is humiliated for it:  
Hera catches both her wrists in one  
hand,  
strips the bow from her shoulders,  
boxes her about the ears with it until  
the  
arrows spill, and she flees weeping to  
Zeus's knees like a dove from a hawk  
(21.479–513). Elsewhere she works  
chiefly in the back-stories, as the god  
whose  
anger kills — Andromache's mother,  
Bellerophon's daughter, Niobe's six  
daughters,  
and the boar sent against Calydon when  
Oeneus forgot her offering.

*Epithets:* “who showers arrows”  
(ἰοχέαιρα, 5.53); “of the golden reins”  
(χρυσήνιος, 6.205).

*Kin:* daughter of Zeus and Leto; sister of Apollo.

**Refs:** 5.51, 5.53, 6.205, 6.428, 9.533, 20.39, 21.471, 24.606. Books 5–6, 9, 16, 19–21, 24.

*See also:* Apollo, Leto, Hera, Niobe, Andromache, Bellerophon, Calydon.

---

**Ascalaphus** (Ἀσκάλαφος) · MORTAL — *Say:*  
as-KAL-uh-fus

A son of Ares, who with his brother Ialmenus leads thirty ships from Aspledon and Minyan Orchomenus; Astyoche bore the two of them in Actor’s house, having gone up



to her upper chamber where the god  
lay with her in secret. He stands the  
night

watch in Book 9 and dies in Book 13,  
when Deiphobus' cast — aimed  
elsewhere —

takes him through the shoulder. Ares  
knows nothing of it, penned on  
Olympus by

Zeus's designs, until Hera tells him at  
15.110; then he beats his thighs and  
calls

for his armor.

*Kin:* son of Ares and Astyoche; brother  
of Ialmenus.

*Killed by:* Deiphobus (13.518–520).

**Refs:** 2.512, 9.82, 13.478, 13.518, 13.526,  
15.112. Books 2, 9, 13, 15.

*See also:* Ares, Ialmenus, Astyoche,  
Deiphobus, Actor.

---

**Asclepius** (Ἀσκληπιός) · GOD — Say: as-

KLEE-pee-us

The healer, father of the army's two  
physicians, Podaleirius and Machaon,  
who lead

thirty ships from Tricca and Ithome. He  
does not appear: the name is a  
patronymic

throughout, and the poem calls him  
“the blameless healer” whenever  
Machaon is

fetches to a wound. His own healing  
knowledge came from Chiron, who  
“once gave his  
father” the soothing drugs Machaon  
uses on Menelaus (4.219).

*Kin:* father of Machaon and Podaleirius;  
taught by Chiron.

**Refs:** 2.731, 4.194, 4.204, 11.518, 11.614,

14.2. Books 2, 4, 11, 14.

*See also:* Machaon, Podaleirius, Chiron, Tricca.

---

**Asius** (Ἄσιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* AY-see-us  
Three men bear the name. The chief  
one is Hyrtacus' son, leader of the  
contingent  
from Percote, Sestus, Abydos and  
Arisbe, “whom horses carried from  
Arisbe, tall  
and fire-colored, from the river Selleïs”  
— a couplet repeated verbatim in Book  
12  
when he alone of the Trojan captains  
refuses Polydamas' advice to dismount  
and  
drives his chariot at the gate.  
Idomeneus spears him under the chin,

and he falls  
like an oak cut for ship-timber,  
bellowing and clawing at the bloody  
dust. A  
second Asius is Hecuba's brother, son of  
Dymas, whose likeness Apollo borrows  
to  
urge Hector on (16.717); a third is the  
father of Phaenops of Abydos (17.583).  
*Kin:* the leader is son of Hyrtacus and  
father of Adamas; the second is son of  
Dymas and brother of Hecuba.  
*Killed by:* Idomeneus (13.387–393).  
**Refs:** 2.837, 2.838, 12.96, 12.110, 12.140,  
13.384, 13.771, 16.717, 17.583.  
Books 2, 12–13, 16–17.  
*See also:* Adamas, Idomeneus,  
Polydamas, Arisbe, Hecuba, Phaenops.

---

**Asteropaeus** (Ἀστεροπαῖος) · MORTAL —

Say: as-ter-oh-PEE-us

Leader of the Paeonians of the long  
lances, at Troy eleven days when he  
dies, and

picked out by Sarpedon with Glaucus as  
the best of the allies after himself. In  
Book 21 he stands up out of the  
Scamander to face Achilles, throws both  
spears at

once — “for he was a two-handed  
fighter” — grazes Achilles’ elbow with  
one and

pins the other’s shield with the first  
cast to draw the blood of a god’s gift.  
Achilles kills him with the sword and  
strips him; the corslet and the Thracian  
sword become prizes at Patroclus’  
games.

*Kin:* son of Pelegon; grandson of the

river Axius by Periboea, daughter of  
Acessamenus.

*Killed by:* Achilles (21.179–182).

**Refs:** 12.102, 17.351, 21.140, 21.162,  
21.170, 23.560, 23.808. Books 12, 17,  
21, 23.

*See also:* Axius, Pelegon, Achilles,  
Paeonians, Sarpedon, Glaucus.

---

**Astyanax** (Ἀστυάναξ) · MORTAL — Say: as-

TY-uh-naks

Hector's infant son, carried to the  
Scaean Gates in his nurse's arms and  
frightened by his own father's helmet.

The poem glosses the name twice and  
both

times the gloss is the child's doom: his  
father called him Scamandrius, "but the  
others Astyanax — for Hector alone was

the saving of Ilion” (6.402–403); and Andromache, keening over the body, repeats it — “Astyanax, ‘the lord of the city,’ as the Trojans call him by name: for you alone guarded their gates and their long walls” (22.506–507). She foresees him pushed from other men’s tables and fatherless.

*Also called:* Scamandrius — Hector’s own name for him.

*Kin:* son of Hector and Andromache; grandson of Priam.

**Refs:** 6.403, 22.500, 22.506. Books 6, 22.

*See also:* Hector, Andromache, Scamandrius, Priam.

---

**Athena** (Ἀθήνη) · GOD — Say: uh-THEE-nuh  
The Achaeans’ fiercest divine partisan

and, with Hera, the implacable enemy  
of  
Troy. She checks Achilles' sword-hand  
in Book 1, seizing him by the hair and  
visible to him alone; she stops the  
army's flight to the ships in Book 2; and  
on  
Zeus's word — obtained by Hera — she  
goes down to make the Trojans break  
the truce  
first (4.64–73). In Book 5 she mounts  
Diomedes' chariot herself and guides  
his  
spear into Ares' belly. Her last work is  
the cruelest: she takes Deiphobus' shape  
to persuade Hector to stand, hands  
Achilles his spear back, and leaves  
Hector  
calling for a brother who is not there  
(22.214–247).



*Epithets:* “grey-eyed,” standalone “grey-eyes” (γλαυκῶπις, 1.206 / 8.373); “the driver of the spoil” (ἄγελείη, 4.128); “Unwearied one” (Ἀτρυτώνη, 2.157) — translated, not transliterated; “she of the mighty father” (ὀβριμοπάτρη, 5.747); “guardian of the city” (ἐρυσίπολις, 6.305).

*Also called:* Pallas; Tritogeneia (4.515).

*Kin:* daughter of Zeus.

**Refs:** 1.194, 1.200, 2.156, 4.73, 5.1, 5.856, 21.406, 22.214 ...and throughout.

Books 1–11, 13–24.

*See also:* Zeus, Hera, Diomedes, Achilles, Hector, Ares.

---

**Athenians** (Ἀθηναῖοι) · PEOPLE — Say: uh-THEE-nee-unz

The contingent from Athens, “the district of great-hearted Erechtheus,” under Menestheus son of Peteos with fifty ships. They are a minor presence in the fighting: “masters of the war-cry” when Agamemnon comes on them in his review of the army, and picked men holding the line against Hector’s charge at the ships in Book 13, where Stichius, Pheidas and Bias fight beside Menestheus. Iasus, son of Sphehus, is set a captain over them, and Aeneas kills him at 15.332. *Kin*: led by Menestheus, Peteos’ son. **Refs:** 2.550, 4.328, 13.196, 13.689, 15.337. Books 2, 4, 13, 15.

*See also:* Menestheus, Peteos,  
Erechtheus, Stichius, Bias, Iasus.

---

**Atreus** (Ἀτρεΰς) · MORTAL — *Say:* AY-tree-  
us or AY-troos

Father of Agamemnon and Menelaus,  
and the man from whose hand the  
sceptre passed

to Thyestes and so to Agamemnon in  
the descent traced at 2.101–108. He is  
dead

before the poem opens and never acts  
in it: in nearly all of the name's 181  
occurrences it is a patronymic, and  
“Atreus' son” in the singular means  
Agamemnon

unless the scene is Menelaus's — the  
duel of Book 3, the oath-breaking and  
the

wounding of Book 4, the fight over  
Patroclus' body. The dual "Atreus' sons"  
means  
the two brothers together. See `canon.md`  
for the rule.

*Kin*: son of Pelops; brother of Thyestes;  
father of Agamemnon and Menelaus.

**Refs:** 1.7, 2.105, 2.106, 2.249, 3.271, 9.340,  
11.131 ...and throughout.

Books 1–11, 13–14, 16–17, 19, 22–24.

*See also*: Agamemnon, Menelaus,  
Thyestes, Pelops.

---

**Augeias** (Αὐγείας) · MORTAL — Say: aw-JEE-  
us

An Epeian king of the older generation,  
"lord of men," named only in genealogy  
and  
in Nestor's long reminiscence of the

Pylian cattle-raid. He had kept four  
prize-winning horses that came to Elis  
for the games and sent their driver  
home

grieving — the debt that provoked  
Neleus' raid. Nestor's first kill in that  
fight

was Augeias' son-in-law Mulius,  
husband of his eldest daughter, tawny-  
haired

Agamede.

*Kin:* grandfather of Polyxeinus through  
Agasthenes; father of Agamede;  
father-in-law of Mulius.

**Refs:** 2.624, 11.701, 11.739. Books 2, 11.

*See also:* Nestor, Epeians, Elis, Mulius,  
Agamede, Polyxeinus.

---

**Automedon** (Αὐτομέδων) · MORTAL — Say:

aw-TOM-uh-don

Achilles' charioteer, "the man he honored most after Achilles breaker of men, and

trustiest at his post to await the shout of battle" (16.146–147). He yokes

Xanthus

and Balius for Patroclus and drives him out; when Patroclus is dead he fights on alone from the chariot, swooping like a vulture on geese and taking no man, because one man cannot both hold the immortal horses and use a spear — until Alcimedon asks who took his wits and takes the reins from him. He drives Achilles

back to the war in Book 19 and helps serve Priam his supper in Book 24.

*Kin:* son of Diores (17.429, 17.474).

**Refs:** 9.209, 16.145, 16.864, 17.429,  
17.459, 17.474, 19.396, 24.574.

Books 9, 16–17, 19, 23–24.

*See also:* Achilles, Patroclus, Alcimedon,  
Alcimus, Xanthus (horse).

---

**Axius** (Ἀξιός) · PLACE — Say: AK-see-us

The Paeonian river, twice praised in the  
same phrase — “the wide-flowing Axius,  
whose water spreads fairest over the  
earth” — as the country the Paeonians  
of the

curved bows come from, with Amydon,  
under Pyraechmes. As a river-god he lay  
with

Periboea, eldest daughter of  
Acessamenus, and begot Pelegon, so  
that Asteropaeus  
recites him as the head of his own line

when Achilles asks who he is (21.157–160).

**Refs:** 2.849, 2.850, 16.288, 21.141, 21.157, 21.158. Books 2, 16, 21.

*See also:* Asteropaeus, Pelegon, Paeonians, Pyraechmes, Amydon.

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### **Bear** (Ἄρκτος) · OTHER

The constellation set on the Shield of Achilles among the Pleiades, the Hyades and

Orion — “the Bear, which men also call by the name of the Wagon, who turns in her

own place, keeping watch on Orion, and alone has no share in the baths of Ocean”

(18.487–489). The one occurrence; the token’s other appearances in the poem



are

the imperative “Bear up.”

*Also called:* the Wagon.

**Refs:** 18.487. Book 18.

*See also:* Orion, Ocean, Achilles,  
Hephaestus.

---

**Bellerophon** (Βελλεροφόντης) · MORTAL —

Say: buh-LAIR-uh-fon

Glaucus’ grandfather, whose story is the long back-piece of the Book 6 meeting with Diomedes. Proetus, believing his wife Anteia’s lie, sent him to Lycia with “baneful signs” scratched in a folded tablet — the poem’s one mention of writing —

and the Lycian king set him three tasks meant to kill him: the Chimaera, the Solymi, the Amazons. He survived all

three and an ambush besides, and was  
given  
the king's daughter and half his kingly  
honor. He ended hated by the gods,  
wandering the Aleian plain alone and  
eating out his heart, his son killed by  
Ares  
and his daughter by Artemis. His guest-  
friendship with Oeneus is what stops  
Glaucus and Diomedes from fighting.  
*Kin:* son of Glaucus, grandson of  
Sisyphus; father of Isander, Hippolochus  
and  
Laodameia; grandfather of Glaucus and,  
through Laodameia and Zeus, of  
Sarpedon.

**Refs:** 6.155, 6.162, 6.190, 6.196, 6.200,  
6.217, 6.220. Book 6.

*See also:* Glaucus, Hippolochus,

Sarpedon, Proetus, Anteia, Chimaera,  
Oeneus, Diomedes.

---

**Bias** (Βίας) · MORTAL — Say: BY-us

Three men. One is a Pylian, “Bias,  
shepherd of the people,” named among  
the

captains Nestor is arraying at 4.296.

Another is an Athenian, “brave Bias,” in  
Menestheus’ company at the ships  
(13.691). The third is named only as a  
father:

Achilles kills “Laogonus and Dardanus,  
the two sons of Bias,” tumbling both  
from

their horses, one with a spear-throw  
and one with the sword (20.460–462).

*Kin:* the third is father of Laogonus and  
Dardanus.

**Refs:** 4.296, 13.691, 20.460. Books 4, 13, 20.

*See also:* Nestor, Menestheus, Laogonus, Achilles.

---

### **Blindness** (Ἔατη) · GOD

Ἔατη personified — the ruinous folly that comes over a man before he acts.

Phoenix

makes her the runner the limping

Prayers can never catch: “Blindness is strong and

sound of foot, and far outruns them all, and gets in first over all the earth tripping mankind” (9.505–507).

Agamemnon builds his whole apology on her in Book

19, calling her “the eldest daughter of Zeus, who blinds all men,” whose feet

are  
soft and walk over men's heads, and  
telling how she once blinded Zeus  
himself over  
the birth of Heracles, so that he seized  
her by her shining braids and flung her  
out of heaven forever. She also takes  
Patroclus' mind at 16.805, when Apollo  
has  
struck him.

*Kin:* eldest daughter of Zeus.

**Refs:** 9.504, 9.505, 9.512, 16.805, 19.91,  
19.126, 19.129, 19.136.

Books 9, 16, 19.

*See also:* Prayers, Agamemnon, Zeus,  
Phoenix, Patroclus.

---

**Boeotians** (Βοιωτοί) · PEOPLE — Say: bee-  
OH-shunz

The first contingent of the Catalogue of Ships, under five leaders — Peneleos, Leïtus, Arcesilaus, Prothoenor and Clonius — with fifty ships and a hundred and twenty young men to each. They hold the left of the line at the muster, and turn up again where the fighting is thickest: Hera watches two of them killing Argives in Book 5, and Hector cuts down Arcesilaus, “a leader of the bronze-shirted Boeotians,” at 15.330. *Kin*: led by Peneleos, Leïtus, Arcesilaus, Prothoenor and Clonius. **Refs:** 2.494, 2.510, 2.526, 5.710, 13.685, 13.700, 15.330. Books 2, 5, 13, 15.

*See also:* Peneleos, Leïtus, Arcesilaus,  
Prothoenor, Achaeans.

---

**Boreas** (Βορέης) · GOD — *Say:* BOR-ee-us  
The north wind, personified and  
genealogically active. He is the cold  
blast behind  
the snow-simile of Book 19; he desired  
Erichthonius' three thousand mares as  
they  
pastured, covered them in the likeness  
of a dark-maned stallion, and got twelve  
foals so light they ran over standing  
grain without breaking it (20.223–226);  
and  
in Book 23 Iris fetches him with  
Zephyrus from the feast in Zephyrus'  
house, at  
Achilles' prayer, to make Patroclus' pyre

burn.

**Refs:** 19.358, 20.223, 23.195, 23.208.

Books 19, 20, 23.

*See also:* Zephyrus, Iris, Erichthonius,  
Patroclus, Achilles.

---

**Briseis** (Βρισηΐς) · MORTAL — Say: bry-SEE-

is

Achilles' prize, taken from him by  
Agamemnon in compensation for  
Chryseis, and so

the occasion — not the cause — of the  
quarrel that is the poem's subject.

Achilles

had taken her out of Lyrnessus, where  
he killed her husband Mynes; she goes  
from

his hut unwilling, led out by Patroclus.  
Agamemnon offers her back in Book 9



with  
an oath he never touched her, and  
swears that oath publicly over a boar in  
Book  
19. Her one speech is the lament for  
Patroclus, who had promised to make  
her  
Achilles' wedded wife in Phthia and  
who "was gentle, always" — after which  
the  
women wail "for Patroclus in show; but  
each for her own sorrows." She is  
restored  
to Achilles' side in the poem's last book.  
*Epithets*: "fair-cheeked" (καλλιπάρηος,  
1.184).  
*Also called*: the daughter of Briseus.  
*Kin*: daughter of Briseus; widow of  
Mynes of Lyrnessus.  
**Refs**: 1.184, 1.323, 1.346, 2.689, 9.107,

19.246, 19.282, 24.676.

Books 1–2, 9, 19, 24.

*See also:* Briseus, Achilles, Agamemnon, Patroclus, Chryseis, Mynes, Lyrnessus.

---

**Briseus** (Βρισεύς) · MORTAL — Say: BRY-syoos

Briseis' father, who never appears and is never described. The name occurs only in

the periphrasis “the daughter of Briseus” — Achilles' complaint to Thetis (1.392)

and, twice over, in Agamemnon's list of amends and Odysseus' verbatim relaying of it (9.132 = 9.274).

*Kin:* father of Briseis.

**Refs:** 1.392, 9.132, 9.274. Books 1, 9.

*See also:* Briseis, Achilles, Agamemnon.

---

**Cadmeans** (Καδμείοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* kad-

MEE-unz

The Thebans of the earlier war, named only in the back-story of Tydeus' embassy.

Sent forward alone from the Asopus, he found them feasting in Eteocles' house, challenged them to contests and won every one with Athena's help; they set fifty

young men to ambush him on the road home, and he killed all but one.

Agamemnon

tells the story to shame Diomedes, and Athena tells it again herself to shame him

further; Diomedes recalls it to her on the night raid.

**Refs:** 4.385, 4.388, 4.391, 5.804, 10.288.

Books 4, 5, 10.

*See also:* Tydeus, Diomedes, Athena, Eteocles, Thebes, Maeon.

---

**Calchas** (Κάλχας) · MORTAL — *Say:* KAL-kus

The army's seer, "far the best of bird-readers, who knew what is, what will be,

and what was before," and who had guided the ships to Ilion by the craft Apollo

gave him. He names the plague's cause only after Achilles guarantees his safety, and Agamemnon answers him as "seer of evils" — the exchange that opens the quarrel.

Odysseus recalls his reading of the  
serpent and the nine sparrows at Aulis,  
which

fixed the war at nine years and a tenth.  
In Book 13 Poseidon takes his shape to  
rally the two Ajaxes, and Ajax son of  
Oïleus knows the god by his footprints  
going  
away — “and that is not Calchas.”

*Also called:* Thestor’s son.

*Kin:* son of Thestor.

**Refs:** 1.69, 1.86, 1.105, 2.300, 2.322, 13.45,  
13.70. Books 1, 2, 13.

*See also:* Apollo, Agamemnon, Achilles,  
Poseidon, Ajax son of Oïleus, Aulis.

---

**Calydon** (Καλυδών) · PLACE — Say: KAL-ih-  
don

Oeneus’ city in Aetolia, “rocky Calydon”

of the Catalogue and “lovely Calydon”  
of  
Phoenix’s tale. Artemis raised the war  
between the Curetes and the Aetolians  
over  
it in anger at Oeneus’ forgotten harvest-  
offering, and it is the city Meleager  
would not defend until his wife  
described what a sacked town looks like  
— the  
exemplum Phoenix presses on Achilles  
in Book 9. Poseidon takes the shape of  
Thoas,  
who rules “all Pleuron and steep  
Calydon,” to stir Idomeneus; and  
Diomedes names it  
in reciting Portheus’ three sons.

**Refs:** 2.640, 9.530, 9.531, 9.577, 13.217,  
14.116. Books 2, 9, 13, 14.

*See also:* Meleager, Oeneus, Aetolians,  
Curetes, Phoenix, Thoas, Artemis.

---

**Capaneus** (Καπανεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:*

KAP-uh-nyoos

One of the Seven against Thebes and  
father of Sthenelus, Diomedes’

charioteer. He

does not appear: the name is a  
patronymic throughout — “Sthenelus,  
Capaneus’ son”

— and it carries the argument his son  
makes at 4.404–410, that the sons who  
took

seven-gated Thebes with a smaller host  
were better men than the fathers who  
perished there by their own  
recklessness.

*Kin:* father of Sthenelus.

**Refs:** 2.564, 4.367, 4.403, 5.108, 5.109,  
5.241, 5.319. Books 2, 4, 5.

*See also:* Sthenelus, Diomedes, Thebes,  
Tydeus.

---

**Cassandra** (Κασσάνδρη) · MORTAL — *Say:*

kuh-SAN-druh

Priam's daughter, "the loveliest of  
Priam's daughters," whom Othryoneus  
asked for

without bride-gifts, promising to drive  
the Achaeans out of Troy; Priam bowed  
his

head to it, and Idomeneus killed him for  
it. She has one living appearance, in the  
last book: she has climbed Pergamus  
and is the first to see her father coming  
back

with the herald and the body on the



bier, and her cry through the city brings  
all

Troy out to the gates. The poem says  
nothing of her prophecy.

*Kin:* daughter of Priam and Hecuba.

**Refs:** 13.366, 24.699. Books 13, 24.

*See also:* Priam, Othryoneus, Hector,  
Idomeneus.

---

**Cebriones** (Κεβριόνης) · MORTAL — *Say:*

seb-RY-oh-neeZ

Hector's half-brother, "a bastard son of  
far-famed Priam," who takes the reins  
after Archeptolemus is killed and drives  
for Hector through the rest of the  
poem.

He is the man Hector left the chariot to  
when the Trojans went at the wall on  
foot,

and it is he who tells Hector the Trojans are being driven on the other wing. In Book 16 Patroclus kills him with a jagged stone that crushes both brows together

and drops his eyes into the dust at his feet, so that he goes over the rail “like a diver” — and Patroclus mocks him for it before the fight over his body, where he lies “mighty in his mightiness, his horsemanship all forgotten.”

*Kin:* bastard son of Priam; brother of Hector.

*Killed by:* Patroclus (16.737–743).

**Refs:** 8.318, 11.521, 12.91, 13.790, 16.727, 16.738, 16.756, 16.776.

Books 8, 11–13, 16.

*See also:* Hector, Patroclus, Priam, Archeptolemus.

---

**Chiron** (Χείρων) · MORTAL — Say: KY-ron  
“The most righteous of the Centaurs,”  
named four times and always as a  
source of  
gifts to the house of Peleus. He taught  
the healing drugs Achilles knows and  
passed  
on to Patroclus, and which reach  
Menelaus’ arrow-wound through  
Machaon’s hands,  
Asclepius having had them from him.  
And he gave Peleus the Pelian ash from  
the peak  
of Pelion, “to be death for heroes” —  
the spear no other Achaean could  
swing, which  
Patroclus alone of Achilles’ arms leaves  
behind when he borrows the rest.  
**Refs:** 4.219, 11.832, 16.143, 19.390. Books  
4, 11, 16, 19.

*See also:* Achilles, Peleus, Patroclus,  
Machaon, Asclepius, Pelion.

---

**Chromius** (Χρομῖος) · MORTAL — Say:

KROH-mee-us

At least four men, on both sides. One is a Pylian, in the group Nestor is arraying at 4.295. A son of Priam of the name is taken with his brother Echemmon, both from

one chariot, when Diomedes falls on them like a lion among cattle (5.160). A Lycian falls in Odysseus' rally at 5.677, and another Trojan-side man to Teucer's

bow at 8.275. A fifth is alive in Book 17, ranged among the Trojan allies Hector harangues and then, with Aeneas and Hector, drawing back from

Automedon's rescuers  
and leaving Aretus dead.

**Refs:** 4.295, 5.160, 5.677, 8.275, 17.218,  
17.494, 17.534. Books 4, 5, 8, 17.

*See also:* Nestor, Diomedes, Odysseus,  
Teucer, Aretus, Automedon.

---

**Chryse** (Χρύση) · PLACE — Say: KRY-see  
The town of Apollo's priest Chryses,  
over which the god "stands guard" with  
Cilla  
and Tenedos in the prayer that brings  
the plague. It is where the hecatomb  
has to  
go: Odysseus sails there with the girl  
and the beasts, and the ceremony on its  
shore — the prayer, the thigh-bones,  
the paean sung all afternoon — is the  
poem's

fullest account of a sacrifice made right.

**Refs:** 1.37, 1.100, 1.390, 1.431, 1.451.

Book 1.

*See also:* Chryses, Chryseis, Apollo, Cilla, Tenedos, Odysseus.

---

**Chryseis** (Χρυσήϊς) · MORTAL — Say: kry-

SEE-is

Daughter of the priest Chryses, given to  
Agamemnon out of the plunder of  
Eëtion's

Thebe. Agamemnon refuses her ransom  
and says he prefers her to

Clytemnestra, “since

she is not her inferior in build or  
bearing, in mind or in any work of her  
hands” —

so the god's arrows come, and when he  
is forced to give her up he takes Briseis

instead. Odysseus commands the ship  
that carries her home and puts her in  
her

father's arms at the altar. She never  
speaks.

*Epithets:* "fair-cheeked" (καλλιπάρης,  
1.143).

*Kin:* daughter of Chryses.

**Refs:** 1.112, 1.143, 1.182, 1.310, 1.369,  
1.439. Book 1.

*See also:* Chryses, Chryse, Agamemnon,  
Apollo, Briseis, Odysseus.

---

**Chryses** (Χρύσης) · MORTAL — *Say:* KRY-  
seez

Apollo's priest, whose daughter  
Agamemnon holds as a prize. He comes  
to the ships  
with a ransom past counting and the

god's wreaths on a golden staff; the  
army  
approves, Agamemnon sends him off  
harshly, and his prayer walking alone  
along the  
shore brings the plague that begins the  
poem. When Odysseus returns the girl  
to  
his arms at the altar of Chryse he prays  
a second time — "Once before you  
heard me  
when I prayed" — and the plague stops.  
He does not appear again.

*Kin:* father of Chryseis.

**Refs:** 1.11, 1.12, 1.370, 1.442, 1.450. Book  
1.

*See also:* Chryseis, Chryse, Apollo,  
Agamemnon, Odysseus.

---



**Clytius** (Κλυτίος) · MORTAL — Say: KLIT-ee-us

One of Priam's brothers, a son of Laomedon, who sits with Lampus and Hicetaon among the elders at the Scaean Gates, "finished with war now because of age, but speakers of quality." He is named in both Trojan genealogies — the elder-list of Book 3 and Aeneas' recital of the house of Dardanus at 20.238 — and his son Caletor, carrying fire toward a ship, is killed by Ajax under Hector's eyes; Hector calls on the Trojans to save "the son of Clytius" and cast at Ajax for him. A second Clytius is the father of an Achaean Dolops killed by Hector at

11.302.

*Kin:* son of Laomedon; brother of Priam, Tithonus, Lampus and Hicetaon; father of Caletor.

**Refs:** 3.147, 11.302, 15.419, 15.427, 20.238. Books 3, 11, 15, 20.

*See also:* Priam, Laomedon, Lampus, Hicetaon, Caletor, Dolops.

---

**Coeranus** (Κοίρανος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

SEER-uh-nus

Meriones' aide and charioteer, who had followed him from well-founded Lyctus in

Crete. Hector casts at Idomeneus, misses, and hits Coeranus instead — the spear under the jaw and ear, dashing his teeth

out at the roots and cutting the tongue  
through the middle, so that he crashes  
from the chariot and pours the reins to  
the  
ground. The poem stops to say that his  
driving up had saved Idomeneus, on  
foot and  
in danger: “to him he came as light, and  
beat off the pitiless day — and lost his  
own life.” A different Coeranus is a  
Lycian killed by Odysseus at 5.677.  
*Killed by:* Hector (17.610–619).  
**Refs:** 5.677, 17.611, 17.614. Books 5, 17.  
*See also:* Meriones, Idomeneus, Hector,  
Lyctus.

---

**Coon** (Κόων) · MORTAL — *Say:* KOH-on  
Antenor’s eldest son, who stabs  
Agamemnon mid-forearm from the

side, unseen, after  
watching him strip his fallen brother  
Iphidamas — “strong grief came down  
over his  
eyes.” Agamemnon shudders but fights  
on, spears him as he drags the body  
away by  
the foot, and cuts his head off over  
Iphidamas. The wound is what drives  
Agamemnon  
from the field, and he is still carrying it  
in Book 19 when he comes late to the  
assembly of reconciliation.

*Kin:* son of Antenor; brother of  
Iphidamas.

*Killed by:* Agamemnon (11.256–261).

**Refs:** 11.248, 11.256, 11.257, 19.53. Books  
11, 19.

*See also:* Antenor, Iphidamas,  
Agamemnon.

---

**Cos** (Κόως) · PLACE — Say: kos

“Cos, city of Eurypylus,” an island of the Catalogue’s southeast group, sending thirty ships under Pheidippus and Antiphus, sons of Thessalus and grandsons of

Heracles. It matters chiefly in the back-story Hera and Zeus each rehearse:  
after

the sack of Troy, Hera laid Zeus’s mind asleep and Sleep roused the winds that carried Heracles far off course to “well-peopled Cos,” for which Zeus hunted the

gods through his house and would have flung Sleep into the sea.

**Refs:** 2.677, 14.255, 15.28. Books 2, 14, 15.

*See also:* Heracles, Sleep, Hera, Zeus.

---

**Cretans** (Κρηῖτες) · PEOPLE — Say: KREE-tunz

Idomeneus' contingent, eighty ships  
from Knossos, Gortyn and hundred-  
cited Crete,  
led by him with Meriones. They are  
named almost always through their  
leader, in the  
formulas "Idomeneus, leader of the  
Cretans" and "counselor of the bronze-  
shirted  
Cretans" that carry his long exchange  
with Meriones in Book 13. Helen points  
them  
out from the wall — Idomeneus  
standing among them "like a god, and  
the Cretan  
captains gathered around him" — and  
Agamemnon finds them arming in his  
review of

the army.

*Kin*: led by Idomeneus and Meriones.

**Refs:** 2.645, 3.230, 4.251, 4.265, 13.219,  
13.255, 23.450, 23.482.

Books 2–4, 13, 23.

*See also*: Idomeneus, Meriones, Crete,  
Achaeans.

---

### **Crete** (Κρήτη) · PLACE

Idomeneus' island, "hundred-citied  
Crete" of the Catalogue, whose towns —  
Knossos,  
Gortyn, Lyctus, Miletus, chalk-white  
Lycastus, Phaestus, Rhytium — the  
poem lists  
in full. Helen recalls that Menelaus was  
often host to Idomeneus "whenever he  
came  
from Crete." Idomeneus gives its royal

line to Othryoneus as a boast just before  
he

kills him: Zeus begot Minos, Minos  
begot Deucalion, and Deucalion begot  
Idomeneus,

“lord over many men in wide Crete.”

**Refs:** 2.649, 3.233, 13.450, 13.453. Books  
2, 3, 13.

*See also:* Idomeneus, Cretans, Minos,  
Deucalion, Meriones.

---

**Cronos** (Κρόνος) · GOD — *Say:* KROH-nos  
Zeus’s father, deposed and shut away:  
Zeus “put Cronos down beneath the  
earth and  
the barren sea” (14.203–204), and he sits  
now at the nethermost limits of earth  
and sea with Iapetus, in Tartarus, taking  
no joy in Hyperion the Sun (8.479–481)



—

the gods gathered around him below  
are the Titans Hera swears by (14.274–  
279). He

never acts. Of the name's 109  
occurrences almost all are the  
patronymic "Cronos'

son," which means **Zeus**; Hera and  
Poseidon are also his children, and  
Poseidon's

claim to equal honor rests on it: "Three  
brothers are we, whom Rhea bore to  
Cronos"

(15.187).

*Epithets*: "crooked-counseled Cronos"

(ἀγκυλομήτεω Κρόνου, 2.205).

*Kin*: with Rhea, father of Zeus, Poseidon,  
Hades, Hera and Demeter.

**Refs**: 2.205, 4.59, 5.721, 8.479, 14.203,  
14.274, 15.187, 15.225 ...and

throughout, chiefly as the patronymic of Zeus. Books 1–9, 11–22, 24.

*See also:* Zeus, Rhea, Poseidon, Hera, Hades, Iapetus, Titans.

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**Curetes** (Κουρῆτες) · PEOPLE — Say: kyoo-REE-teez

The besiegers of Calydon in Phoenix's tale of Meleager, fighting the Aetolians over the head and hide of the boar Artemis sent against Oeneus' orchards. While Meleager fought they could not hold their ground outside the wall, though they were many; when he withdrew in anger at his mother they came on until the chamber itself was

under bombardment. The exemplum  
Phoenix presses on Achilles turns on  
their advance.

**Refs:** 9.529, 9.532, 9.549, 9.551, 9.588.

Book 9.

*See also:* Meleager, Aetolians, Calydon,  
Oeneus, Phoenix, Artemis.

---

**Danaans** (Δαναοί) · PEOPLE — Say: DAN-ay-  
unz or DAN-uh-unz

The third of the poem's interchangeable  
names for the whole Greek host,  
alongside

Achaean and Argives; the choice  
among the three is metrical, not ethnic.

It is the

name in Chryses' curse — "may the  
Danaans pay for my tears by your  
arrows" (1.42) —

and the one the Catalogue uses for the leaders it is about to list. Agamemnon's standing address to the army is "Friends, Danaan heroes, squires of Ares."

*Epithets:* "the Danaans of swift colts" (ταχύπωλοι Δαναοί, 4.232).

*Also called:* Achaeans; Argives — the same host under three names. The Myrmidons and Hellenes are Achilles' own contingent and are not synonyms for the army.

**Refs:** 1.42, 1.56, 2.110, 2.487, 4.232, 4.257, 7.382, 8.161 ...and throughout.

Books 1–17, 19–21, 23–24.

*See also:* Achaeans, Argives, Agamemnon.

---

**Dardania** (Δαρδανίη) · PLACE — Say: dar-

DAY-nee-uh

The city Dardanus founded on the lower slopes of many-springed Ida, “for holy Ilion

was not yet built on the plain, a city of mortal men” (20.216–218) — the elder settlement of the Trojan line, named in Aeneas’ genealogy. Elsewhere it is a region

paired with Troy as the home of the women who will mourn: Achilles means to make

“some deep-girdled woman of Troy or Dardania” wipe the tears from her cheeks, and

promises the same women will keep night and day around Patroclus’ body.

**Refs:** 18.123, 18.339, 20.216. Books 18, 20.

*See also:* Dardanus, Dardanians, Troy,  
Ida, Aeneas.

---

**Dardanians** (Δάρδανοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:*

dar-DAY-nee-unz

Aeneas' people, Trojan-side allies of the  
house of Dardanus, led by “the good son  
of

Anchises” with Antenor's sons

Archelochus and Acamas. The name  
lives chiefly in two

fixed address-formulas that recur  
across the battle books: “Hear from me,  
Trojans

and Dardanians and allies,” and the  
rallying line “Trojans and Lycians and  
Dardanians who fight at close quarters  
— be men, my friends; remember your  
rushing

courage” (8.173–174, repeated verbatim five times). The Dardanian gates of Troy are

named for them, and Euphorbus, who strikes Patroclus first, is introduced simply as

“a Dardanian.”

*Kin:* led by Aeneas, Anchises’ son.

**Refs:** 2.819, 3.456, 7.348, 8.173, 11.286, 15.425, 16.806, 17.184.

Books 2–3, 5, 7–8, 11, 13, 15–17, 22.

*See also:* Aeneas, Anchises, Dardanus, Trojans, Euphorbus.

---

**Dardanus** (Δάρδανος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

DAR-duh-nus

Founder of the Trojan line and its eponym: “Dardanus first was begotten by

cloud-gatherer Zeus, and he founded  
Dardania” (20.215–216), in the days  
before

Ilion stood on the plain. Aeneas recites  
the descent to Achilles, and Poseidon  
saves Aeneas so “the race of Dardanus  
not perish seedless” — Zeus having  
loved

Dardanus beyond all his mortal  
children, and having come to hate the  
line of Priam

(20.302–306). He never acts: outside the  
two genealogies the name is the  
patronymic

“Dardanus’ descendant,” used of Priam  
throughout and of the ancient Ilus at  
11.166–372. A second Dardanus, a son of  
Bias, is killed with his brother Laogonus  
by Achilles at 20.460.

*Kin:* son of Zeus; father of Erichthonius;



ancestor of Tros, Ilus, Laomedon,  
Priam, and through Assaracus of  
Aeneas.

**Refs:** 3.303, 5.159, 7.366, 11.166, 11.372,  
20.215, 20.303, 21.34, 24.171.

Books 3, 5, 7, 11, 13, 20–22, 24.

*See also:* Priam, Aeneas, Dardania,  
Erichthonius, Ilus, Zeus, Bias.

---

### **Dawn** (Ἠώς) · GOD

Personified daybreak, whose formulas  
divide the poem into days. She rises  
from her

bed beside illustrious Tithonus “to  
bring light to the immortals and to  
mortal men”

(11.1–2), spreads over all the earth in  
her saffron robe, and rises out of the  
streams of Ocean at 19.1 on the day

Achilles arms. Her fixed line — “and  
when  
early-born rosy-fingered Dawn  
appeared” — opens days from Book 1 to  
the poem’s  
close. She acts once in her own right,  
going up to high Olympus to announce  
the  
light to Zeus and the other gods (2.48);  
and in Book 8 she is what the Trojans  
wait  
for, sitting all night by their fires.  
*Epithets*: “rosy-fingered Dawn”  
(ρόδοδάκτυλος Ἡώς, 1.477); “early-  
born”  
(ἡριγένεια, 1.477); “Dawn in her saffron  
robe” (κροκόπεπλος Ἡώς, 8.1);  
“fair-throned Dawn” (εὐθρονος Ἡώς,  
8.565). Note χρυσόθρονος “of the golden  
throne” is **Hera’s**, not Dawn’s — all four

occurrences are hers or Zeus's;  
CONVENTIONS.md was corrected  
accordingly on 2026-07-27.

*Kin*: consort of Tithonus, Laomedon's  
son.

**Refs:** 1.477, 2.48, 8.1, 8.565, 9.240, 11.1,  
19.1, 23.109, 24.695, 24.788.

Books 1–2, 6, 8–9, 11, 19, 23–24.

*See also*: Tithonus, Ocean, Sun, Zeus.

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## **Death** (Θάνατος) · GOD

Personified, and twinned with Sleep:  
“Sleep, the brother of Death” (14.231),  
“the  
twin brothers Sleep and Death” (16.672  
= 16.682). Zeus, unable to keep Sarpedon  
alive, has Apollo wash the body in the  
running river, anoint it with ambrosia  
and

give it to the two of them as escorts,  
who set him down in wide Lycia for his  
brothers and kinsmen to bury — “for  
that is the honor-right of the dead.”

Agamemnon

uses the name unpersonified at 4.270 in  
the oath-breaking scene: “Death and  
sorrows

hereafter will be theirs.”

*Kin*: brother of Sleep.

**Refs:** 4.270, 14.231, 16.454, 16.672,  
16.682. Books 4, 14, 16.

*See also*: Sleep, Sarpedon, Apollo, Zeus,  
Lycia.

---

**Deiphobus** (Δηϊφωβος) · MORTAL — *Say*:  
dee-IF-oh-bus

A son of Priam and Hecuba, one of the  
more active Trojan fighters and the

shape

Athena wears to kill Hector. He leads  
the third storming-party at the wall  
with

Helenus, and in Book 13 he is  
everywhere: he grieves for Asius and  
kills Hypsenor

in vengeance, vaunts over him, then  
strikes Ascalaphus down with a cast  
meant for

Idomeneus and is wounded in the arm  
by Meriones over the body, so that  
Polites has

to lead him out of the fighting. In Book  
22 Athena takes his likeness “in body  
and

unwearying voice,” offers to stand with  
Hector, and vanishes; Hector calls for a  
spear and finds no one there — “he is  
inside the wall, and Athena has tricked

me.”

*Kin:* son of Priam and Hecuba; brother of Hector, Paris, Helenus and Polites.

*Kills:* Hypsenor (13.410–412); Ascalaphus (13.516–520).

**Refs:** 12.94, 13.156, 13.402, 13.413, 13.516, 13.534, 22.227, 22.294, 24.251.

Books 12–13, 22, 24.

*See also:* Priam, Hector, Athena, Helenus, Ascalaphus, Idomeneus, Meriones.

---

**Demeter** (Δημήτηρ) · GOD — Say: dih-MEE-tur

The grain-goddess, never present and never speaking. She stands behind the poem’s

fixed way of saying “mortal”: Ajax will not give way “to any man who is mortal and

eats the grain of Demeter” (13.322), and  
Lycaon’s plea to Achilles begins from  
the

same phrase — “it was at your table first  
that I ate the grain of Demeter.” She has  
a winnowing simile at 5.500, where  
“tawny-haired Demeter in the driving  
wind divides

the grain from the husks”; a precinct at  
Pyrasus in the Catalogue; and a place in  
Zeus’s list of loves, “the lady Demeter of  
the lovely braids.”

*Kin:* daughter of Cronos and Rhea; sister  
of Zeus.

**Refs:** 2.696, 5.500, 13.322, 14.326, 21.76.

Books 2, 5, 13, 14, 21.

*See also:* Zeus, Cronos, Lycaon, Ajax.

---

**Deucalion** (Δευκαλίων) · MORTAL — Say:

dyoo-KAY-lee-on

Two men. The first is Idomeneus' father,  
son of Minos and grandson of Zeus,  
named

only in the line Idomeneus recites over  
Othryoneus — “Minos got a son,  
blameless

Deucalion; and Deucalion fathered me,  
lord over many men in wide Crete” —  
and

otherwise carried as the patronymic  
“Deucalion's son,” which the poem uses  
of

Idomeneus at the moments of his  
greatest exposure (12.117, 17.608) and  
Meriones

uses to address him. The second is a  
Trojan Achilles kills in Book 20, pierced  
through the arm where the tendons of



the elbow join, so that he stands waiting  
with

his arm hanging heavy and sees death  
in front of him.

*Kin:* the Cretan is son of Minos and  
father of Idomeneus.

*Killed by:* the Trojan by Achilles (20.478–  
483).

**Refs:** 12.117, 13.307, 13.451, 13.452,  
17.608, 20.478. Books 12–13, 17, 20.

*See also:* Idomeneus, Minos, Crete,  
Meriones, Achilles.

---

**Deïpyrus** (Δηϊπυρος) · MORTAL — *Say:* dee-  
IP-ih-rus

An Achaean captain of the second rank,  
one of the seven leaders of the night  
sentries in Book 9 and one of the men  
Poseidon rallies and Idomeneus calls to

in

Book 13. Helenus kills him there at close quarters, shearing his helmet away with a

great Thracian sword — the helmet knocked spinning off between the fighters' feet

for some Achaean to pick up — and gloomy night comes down over his eyes.

His death

is what stirs Menelaus to the duel with Helenus that follows.

*Killed by:* Helenus (13.576–580).

**Refs:** 9.83, 13.92, 13.478, 13.576. Books 9, 13.

*See also:* Helenus, Menelaus, Idomeneus, Meriones, Aphareus.

---

**Diomedes** (Διομήδης) · MORTAL — Say: dy-

oh-MEE-deez

Tydeus' son, lord of Argos and Tiryns

with eighty ships, and the Achaean

whose

aristeia fills Book 5. Athena kindles

unwearying fire from his helmet and

shield,

takes the mist from his eyes so that he

may know god from man, and licenses

him to

wound Aphrodite — which he does,

drawing the ichor from her hand as she

carries

Aeneas off — and then mounts his

chariot herself and rams his spear into

Ares'

belly. He is the poem's model of the

young man who takes rebuke in silence:

Agamemnon rakes him at 4.365 and he

does not answer, and pays it back in the assembly of Book 9. He meets Glaucus between the lines, discovers their grandfathers' guest-friendship, and exchanges armor rather than blows; he goes with Odysseus on the night raid and kills Dolon and Rhesus; and he is wounded in the foot by Paris' arrow at 11.377.

*Epithets:* "good at the war-cry" (βοὴν ἀγαθός, 2.563).

*Also called:* Tydeus' son.

*Kin:* son of Tydeus of the Seven against Thebes; his charioteer is Sthenelus, Capaneus' son.

**Refs:** 2.563, 4.365, 5.1, 5.114, 5.330, 5.855, 6.122, 6.235, 9.31 ...and throughout. Books 2, 4–11, 14, 16, 21, 23. *See also:* Tydeus, Sthenelus, Athena,

Aphrodite, Ares, Glaucus, Odysseus,  
Dolon.

---

**Dione** (Διώνη) · GOD — *Say: dy-OH-nee*  
Aphrodite's mother in this poem,  
named only in the scene after Diomedes  
wounds her.  
Aphrodite falls on her knees; Dione  
gathers her daughter in her arms,  
strokes her,  
and comforts her with a catalogue of  
gods who have suffered at mortal hands  
— Ares  
bound in a jar by Otus and Ephialtes,  
Hera and Hades shot by Heracles —  
before  
warning that a man who fights the  
immortals does not come home to his  
children.

*Kin:* mother of Aphrodite by Zeus.

**Refs:** 5.370, 5.371, 5.381. Book 5.

*See also:* Aphrodite, Zeus, Diomedes,  
Ares, Heracles.

---

**Diores** (Διώρης) · MORTAL — *Say:* dy-OR-eez

Two men. The first is an Epeian leader,  
Amarynceus' son, captain of the third of  
the

four Elian companies, whose death  
closes the general fighting of Book 4: a  
jagged

stone thrown by Peiroos of the  
Thracians crushes both tendons and the  
bones beside

his right ankle, and he falls back in the  
dust stretching out his hands to his  
companions, and Peiroos runs up and  
spears him beside the navel. The second

is

Automedon's father, named only in the patronymic "Diores' son" during the fight

over Patroclus' body.

*Kin:* the Epeian is son of Amarynceus; the second is father of Automedon.

*Killed by:* Peiroos (4.517–526).

**Refs:** 2.622, 4.517, 17.429, 17.474. Books 2, 4, 17.

*See also:* Amarynceus, Peiroos, Epeians, Automedon.

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## **Dog** (Κύων) · OTHER

The star Sirius, "the star men call by name the Dog of Orion" — brightest of all,

rising at harvest-time among many stars in the milking-dark of night,

“made an evil  
sign, and brings great fever down on  
wretched mortals.” It is what Achilles’  
bronze  
looks like to Priam as he comes across  
the plain (22.26–32), the simile that  
opens  
the last hunt of Hector. The name’s  
other occurrences in the poem are the  
insult:  
Achilles’ “Dog’s eyes and a deer’s heart”  
to Agamemnon (1.225), the vaunt “Dog!  
Again you have run out from under  
death” that Diomedes and then Achilles  
throw at  
Hector (11.362 = 20.449), and Achilles’  
one-word refusal of Hector’s dying plea  
(22.345).

*Also called:* the Dog of Orion.

**Refs:** 1.225, 11.362, 20.449, 22.29, 22.345.



Books 1, 11, 20, 22.

*See also:* Orion, Achilles, Hector, Priam.

---

**Dolon** (Δόλων) · MORTAL — *Say:* DOH-lon  
The Trojan scout of Book 10, son of the  
herald Eumedes, “ugly to look at, but  
swift-footed,” and an only son among  
five sisters. He volunteers to spy on the  
ships  
and asks as his price the horses and  
chariot of Achilles; Odysseus and  
Diomedes let  
him run past them and take him, and he  
is caught green with fear, his teeth  
chattering. He tells them everything  
they ask — the watch, the disposition of  
the  
allies, the new-come Thracians of  
Rhesus and their horses — and is

begging with his  
hand out to Diomedes' chin when  
Diomedes shears through both tendons  
of his neck  
and "the head of the still-speaking man  
was mingled with the dust." His spoils  
go on  
Odysseus' stern as an offering for  
Athena.

*Kin:* son of Eumedes the herald.

*Killed by:* Diomedes (10.454–457).

**Refs:** 10.314, 10.374, 10.390, 10.412,  
10.426, 10.447, 10.478, 10.571. Book 10.

*See also:* Eumedes, Odysseus, Diomedes,  
Rhesus, Hector, Athena.

---

**Dolops** (Δόλοψ) · MORTAL — *Say:* DOH-lops  
Two men. The Achaean is Clytius' son,  
killed by Hector in the rally of Book 11

and  
named only in the list of that killing.  
The Trojan is Lampus' son and  
Laomedon's  
grandson, "a master of the spear" and  
"the strongest son that Lampus  
fathered": he  
springs on Meges as he strips Croesmus  
and stabs his shield, but Phyleus' old  
corslet from Ephyra turns it; Meges  
shears the plume off his helmet, and  
while the  
two fight Menelaus comes up unseen  
from behind and drives a spear through  
his chest.  
Hector rallies his kinsmen over the  
armor — "do you not see how they  
swarm over  
Dolops's armor?"  
*Kin:* the Achaean is son of Clytius; the

Trojan is son of Lampus, grandson of Laomedon, and Hector's kinsman.

*Killed by:* the Achaean by Hector (11.302); the Trojan by Menelaus (15.540–543).

**Refs:** 11.302, 15.525, 15.536, 15.555.

Books 11, 15.

*See also:* Clytius, Lampus, Meges, Menelaus, Hector, Melanippus.

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### **Dream** (ὄνειρος) · GOD

The messenger Zeus sends to deceive Agamemnon — “baneful Dream” — with the false

promise that he may take Troy now, because the immortals are no longer divided and

Hera has bent them by her begging. It stands above Agamemnon's head in the

likeness  
of Nestor, “whom Agamemnon honored  
most of the elders,” delivers the word  
exactly as  
charged, and flies away; Agamemnon  
reports it to the council as “a divine  
Dream” and  
acts on it, and the army’s near-flight to  
the ships follows.

**Refs:** 2.6, 2.8, 2.16, 2.22, 2.56, 2.70. Book  
2.

*See also:* Zeus, Agamemnon, Nestor,  
Blindness.

---

### **Earth** (Γαῖα) · GOD

Invoked, never acting: one of the  
standing witnesses of the poem’s oaths.  
Two lambs  
are brought “for Earth and Sun” at the

truce of Book 3, and Priam's oath-prayer calls on "Rivers, and Earth, and you two below who punish the dead." Hera swears by Earth, wide Heaven and the down-flowing water of Styx that she has not moved Poseidon; Agamemnon swears by Zeus, Earth, the Sun and the Erinyes that he never touched Briseis. The related "Earth-shaker" is a fixed epithet of Poseidon, not this entity.

**Refs:** 3.104, 3.278, 15.36, 19.259, 20.310, 21.462. Books 3, 15, 19–21.

*See also:* Sun, Zeus, Styx, Erinyes, Poseidon, Hera.

---

**Echius** (Ἐχίος) · MORTAL — Say: EK-ee-us

Three men. One is a father only:

“Mecisteus, Echius’ son,” one of the two  
loyal

companions who twice stoop under a  
wounded man and carry him groaning  
to the ships

(8.333 = 13.422). An Achaean of the  
name is killed by Polites in the rout of  
Book

15, in the same onset in which

Polydamas kills that Mecisteus. A third  
is a Trojan,

one of nine men Patroclus brings down  
in heaps at 16.415–418.

*Kin:* the first is father of Mecisteus.

*Killed by:* the Achaean by Polites

(15.339); the Trojan by Patroclus  
(16.416).

**Refs:** 8.333, 13.422, 15.339, 16.416. Books

8, 13, 15, 16.

*See also:* Mecisteus, Polites, Polydamas,  
Patroclus.

---

**Elis** (Ἠλῖς) · PLACE — *Say:* EE-lis

“Brilliant Elis” in the western  
Peloponnese, the Epeians’ country in  
the Catalogue,  
bounded by Hyrmine, Myrsinus at the  
land’s edge, the Olenian rock and  
Alesium, and  
sending forty ships under four leaders;  
the Echinae islands lie “across the sea  
facing Elis.” It is the setting of Nestor’s  
long reminiscence in Book 11: the  
cattle-raid in which he killed  
Itymoneus, the debt owed the Pylians  
“in brilliant  
Elis,” and Augeias’ seizure of the four



prize-winning horses that had come  
there for  
the games.

**Refs:** 2.615, 2.626, 11.673, 11.686, 11.698.

Books 2, 11.

*See also:* Epeians, Nestor, Augeias,  
Buprasium, Meges.

---

**Ennomus** (Ἐννομος) · MORTAL — Say: EN-  
oh-mus

“Ennomus the bird-reader,” who leads  
the Mysians with Chromis in the  
Catalogue,  
where the poem adds the notice that his  
birds did not save him from black doom:  
he

was broken under the hands of Achilles  
in the river, with the other Trojans  
(2.858–

861). He is still among the allied captains Hector harangues at 17.218, so the

Catalogue's notice runs ahead of the narrative. A second man of the name is killed

by Odysseus with Thoon in Book 11.

*Killed by:* Achilles, in the Scamander (2.860–861); the second by Odysseus (11.422).

**Refs:** 2.858, 11.422, 17.218. Books 2, 11, 17.

*See also:* Chromis, Mysians, Achilles, Scamander, Odysseus, Thoon.

---

**Enops** (Ἔνοψ) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-nops

A name borne by three fathers, none of whom appears. One is the Trojan who herded by

the banks of the Satnioeis, where a  
blameless naiad nymph bore him  
Satnius, killed  
by Ajax son of Oïleus (14.444–446).  
Another is father of the Trojan Thestor,  
whom  
Patroclus hooks out of his chariot by  
the jaw like a fish (16.401). The third is  
father of Clytomedes, the boxer Nestor  
beat at the funeral games of  
Amarynceus.  
*Kin:* father, severally, of Satnius, Thestor  
and Clytomedes.  
**Refs:** 14.444, 14.445, 16.401, 23.634.  
Books 14, 16, 23.  
*See also:* Satnius, Thestor, Clytomedes,  
Nestor, Patroclus, Satnioeis.

---

**Epeians** (Ἐπειοί) · PEOPLE — Say: eh-PEE-unz

The people of Elis and Buprasium, forty ships under four leaders —

Amphimachus and

Thalpius, Diores, and Polyxeinus — and “the shining Epeians” who hold part of the

line at the ships with the Locrians and Phthians under Meges and Amphion.

Their

larger role is retrospective: Nestor’s Book 11 reminiscence is entirely about them,

the debt they owed the Pylians, the Molione brothers, and the battle by the Alpheius; and the funeral games they held for lord Amarynceus at Buprasium are the

measure Nestor sets against Patroclus’.

*Kin:* led by Amphinachus, Thalpius,  
Diores and Polyxeinus.

**Refs:** 2.619, 4.538, 11.688, 11.694, 11.737,  
13.686, 15.519, 23.630.

Books 2, 4, 11, 13, 15, 23.

*See also:* Elis, Nestor, Diores, Meges,  
Amarynceus, Buprasium.

---

**Epeius** (Ἐπειός) · MORTAL — *Say:* eh-PEE-us  
Panopeus' son, "huge and strong,  
skilled in fist-fighting," who claims the  
boxing  
prize before the fight and gets it: "I  
claim to be the best. Is it not enough  
that I  
fall short in battle?" He drops Euryalus  
with one blow to the cheek — the man  
leaps  
at it like a fish under the North Wind

and goes down — then sets him upright  
again  
with his own hands. In the weight-  
throw he takes the lump of pig-iron  
first, whirls,  
lets it fly, and the Achaeans laugh at  
him.

*Kin:* son of Panopeus.

**Refs:** 23.665, 23.689, 23.694, 23.838,  
23.839. Book 23.

*See also:* Panopeus, Euryalus, Achilles,  
Polypoetes, Leonteus.

---

**Epistrophus** (Ἐπίστροφος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

ee-PIS-troh-fus

Three men, all named in Book 2 and  
none of them again. Two are Catalogue  
leaders:

the Phocian, who leads forty ships with

his brother Schedius, sons of Iphitus  
Naubolus' son; and the Halizonian, who  
leads with Odius "from far away, from  
Alybe,  
where silver has its birthplace." The  
third is one of the "spear-mad sons of  
lord  
Euenus" whom Achilles cut down with  
Mynes at the sack of Lyrnessus, where  
he took  
Briseis.

*Kin:* the Phocian is son of Iphitus,  
brother of Schedius; the third is son of  
Euenus, brother of Mynes.

*Killed by:* the third by Achilles (2.692).

**Refs:** 2.517, 2.692, 2.856. Book 2.

*See also:* Schedius, Odius, Phocians,  
Halizones, Mynes, Briseis, Lyrnessus.

---

**Ereuthalion** (Ἐρευθαλίων) · MORTAL — Say:

er-yoo-THAY-lee-on

The champion young Nestor killed, and  
the standing proof of what Nestor once  
was.

He wore the armor Ares gave Areithous  
the Club-man, which Lycurgus took by  
craft in

a narrow lane and gave in old age to  
Ereuthalion, his aide; wearing it he  
challenged

all the Pylia best by the walls of Pheia,  
and they trembled and no man dared  
until

Nestor, youngest-born of all, went out  
and killed him. “The tallest and the  
strongest man I ever killed: a great  
sprawl of him lay there, this way and  
that.”

Nestor tells it twice, both times to



shame men into fighting.

*Killed by:* Nestor (7.153–156).

**Refs:** 4.319, 7.136, 7.149, 7.150. Books 4, 7.

*See also:* Nestor, Areithous, Lycurgus, Arcadians, Hector.

---

**Erinyes** (Ἐρινύες) · GOD — *Say:* ee-RIN-ee-eez

The avenging powers a curse calls up,  
and the poem's guarantors of oaths and  
of due

order. Amyntor's curse on Phoenix  
summons "the hateful Erinyes";  
Althaea, beating  
the earth and calling on Hades and  
Persephone for her son's death, is heard  
"out of  
Erebus" by an Erinys "who walks in

mist.” Iris tells Poseidon that “the  
Erinyes  
always side with the elder-born,” and  
Agamemnon lays his blindness on Zeus,  
Fate,  
and the Erinyes who walk in mist. They  
are witnesses under the earth in his  
oath at

19.259, and they stop the mouth of  
Achilles’ speaking horse (19.418).

*Epithets:* “who walks in mist”  
(ἡεροφοῖτις, 9.571).

**Refs:** 9.454, 9.571, 15.204, 19.87, 19.259,  
19.418, 21.412.

Books 9, 15, 19, 21.

*See also:* Phoenix, Amyntor, Althaea,  
Meleager, Agamemnon, Blindness,  
Xanthus (horse).

---

**Euaemon** (Εὐαίμων) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-

EE-mon

Eurypylus' father, who never appears:  
in all seven occurrences the name is the  
patronymic, and almost always in the  
fixed phrase "Eurypylus, Euaemon's  
shining

son" — which carries him through the  
Catalogue, his killing of Hypsenor, the  
volunteering for the duel with Hector,  
and finally his own wounding,  
"Euaemon's

Zeus-sprung son, hit in the thigh by the  
arrow."

*Kin:* father of Eurypylus.

**Refs:** 2.736, 5.76, 5.79, 7.167, 8.265,  
11.575, 11.810. Books 2, 5, 7, 8, 11.

*See also:* Eurypylus, Hypsenor, Patroclus.

---

**Eumedes** (Εὐμήδης) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-

MEE-deez

Dolon's father, "the sacred herald —  
rich in gold and rich in bronze," named  
only to

place his son: the wealth is what makes  
Dolon's offer of ransom credible when  
Odysseus and Diomedes take him. The  
name appears three times in Book 10  
and nowhere

else, twice in the formula "Dolon,  
Eumedes' son" that introduces the  
scout's two  
truthful answers.

*Kin:* father of Dolon.

**Refs:** 10.314, 10.412, 10.426. Book 10.

*See also:* Dolon, Odysseus, Diomedes.

---

**Eumelus** (Εὐμηλος) · MORTAL — Say: yoo-  
MEE-lus

Leader of eleven ships from Pherae and  
Iolcus, and owner of the best horses in  
the

host: the Muse-question at 2.761–767  
answers that the finest were “the mares  
of

Pheres’ line, which Eumelus drove,”  
matched in coat and years, reared by  
Apollo in

Pereia. He is “supreme in  
horsemanship” and rises first for the  
chariot race in

Book 23, but Athena — retaliating for  
Apollo’s sabotage of Diomedes —  
shatters his

yoke, and he is thrown and comes in  
last, dragging his chariot. Achilles pities  
him and proposes second prize;

Antilochus objects, and Eumelus is given

Asteropaeus' corslet instead.

*Also called:* Admetus' son.

*Kin:* son of Admetus and Alcestis,

“brilliant among women, loveliest of the

daughters of Pelias” (2.715); grandson of Pheres.

**Refs:** 2.714, 2.764, 23.288, 23.354, 23.381, 23.481, 23.558, 23.565. Books 2, 23.

*See also:* Admetus, Alcestis, Athena, Diomedes, Antilochus, Asteropaeus.

---

**Euphorbus** (Εὐφορβος) · MORTAL — Say:  
yoo-FOR-bus

The Dardanian who strikes Patroclus first — from behind, between the

shoulders,  
after Apollo has already dazed him —  
then pulls his spear free and runs back  
into  
the crowd rather than face even an  
unarmed man. The poem gives him a  
resumé in the  
same breath: he outshone all men of his  
age at the spear, at horsemanship and  
in  
the footrace, and had brought down  
twenty men his first time out with a  
chariot.  
Dying, Patroclus names him second of  
his three killers, after Apollo. In Book 17  
he claims the body from Menelaus and  
is speared through the throat; his  
blood-soaked  
hair, “hair like the Graces’,” braided in  
gold and silver, gets the poem’s olive-

sapling

simile.

*Also called:* Panthous' son — the patronymic also serves Polydamas and Hyperenor.

*Kin:* son of Panthous.

*Kills:* wounds Patroclus (16.806–815).

*Killed by:* Menelaus (17.45–60).

**Refs:** 16.808, 16.850, 17.47, 17.59, 17.81.

Books 16–17.

*See also:* Patroclus, Menelaus, Panthous, Polydamas, Apollo, Hector, Graces.

---

**Euryalus** (Εὐρύαλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* yoo-  
RY-uh-lus

Third captain of the Argive contingent under Diomedes, behind Diomedes himself and Sthenelus, “a godlike man.” He kills four



Trojans in the Book 6 rout, among them  
the twins Aeseus and Pedasus, whom  
the water-nymph Abarbarea bore to  
Bucolion. In  
Book 23 he alone stands up to Epeius at  
boxing — Diomedes girds him and talks  
him  
up — and is knocked flat with a blow to  
the cheek, led away through the  
gathering  
with his feet trailing, spitting thick  
blood, his wits astray.

*Kin:* son of Mecisteus, son of Talaus. His  
father once came to Thebes for the  
burial of fallen Oedipus and beat all the  
sons of Cadmus (23.679–680).

*Kills:* Dresus, Opheltius, Aeseus and  
Pedasus (6.20–28).

**Refs:** 2.565, 6.20, 23.677. Books 2, 6, 23.

*See also:* Diomedes, Sthenelus,  
Mecisteus, Epeius, Bucolion.

---

**Eurypylus** (Εὐρύπυλος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

yoo-RIP-ih-lus

Thessalian leader of forty ships from  
Ormenion and Hypereia, and one of the  
nine

who stand up to answer Hector's  
challenge in Book 7. He kills Hypsenor  
the

Scamander-priest's son in Book 5 and  
Melanthius in Book 6, and in Book 11,  
coming

to the rescue of the hard-pressed Ajax,  
is shot through the right thigh by Paris.

His wound is the hinge of the plot:

Patroclus, sent by Achilles to ask after  
the

wounded, meets him limping from the field, and though on an errand he will not  
abandon him — he cuts the arrow out, washes the wound and lays on a root  
Chiron  
taught Achilles. Patroclus is still sitting in his hut at 15.390, delighting him with talk, when the Trojans storm the wall; the delay is the last thing between him  
and his own death. A different Eurypylus is the hero of Cos (2.677).  
*Also called:* Euaemon's son — the recurring line is "Euaemon's shining son."  
*Kin:* son of Euaemon.  
*Kills:* Hypsenor (5.76–83); Melanthius (6.36); Apisaon (11.578).  
**Refs:** 2.736, 5.76, 6.36, 7.167, 11.583,

11.809, 12.2, 15.392, 16.27. Books 2,  
5–8, 11–12, 15–16.

*See also:* Patroclus, Paris, Ajax, Machaon,  
Achilles.

---

**Eurystheus** (Εὐρυσθεύς) · MORTAL — Say:  
yoo-RIS-thyoos

The king Heracles served, present only  
in the back-story. Athena complains at  
8.362–369 that Zeus forgets how often  
she was sent to rescue his son “worn to  
breaking under Eurystheus’s labors” —  
among them the descent to Hades to  
fetch the

hound. His birth is the point of  
Agamemnon’s Blindness-parable in  
Book 19: Hera,  
trapping Zeus in an oath, hurried this  
child into the light before his month

and  
held back Alcmene's labor, so that the  
rule Zeus meant for Heracles fell to  
Eurystheus, and Zeus groaned ever after  
to see his son "doing shameful labor  
under  
Eurystheus's tasks." His herald Copreus  
carried the orders (15.639–640).

*Kin:* son of Sthenelus, son of Perseus.

**Refs:** 8.363, 8.367, 15.640, 19.123, 19.133.

Books 8, 15, 19.

*See also:* Heracles, Hera, Alcmene,  
Blindness, Sthenelus, Perseus, Copreus.

---

**Eëtion** (Ἠετίων) · MORTAL — *Say:* ay-EE-  
tee-on

King of Thebe-under-Placus, lord over  
the Cilician men, and Andromache's  
father.

Achilles sacked his city before the poem opens — the raid that also took Chryseis

—

and killed him there, but “did not strip him: his heart stood in awe of that,”  
burning him in his armor and heaping a mound over which the mountain

nymphs planted

elms. Achilles killed all seven of his sons in one day and ransomed his wife back.

The spoils of Thebe run through the poem: the lyre Achilles is singing to when the

embassy arrives, the horse Pedasus, and the lump of self-smelted iron he sets up as

a prize at Patroclus’ games, “that the huge strength of Eëtion used to throw.”

Two

other men bear the name: Eëtion of

Imbros, who ransomed Lycaon (21.43),  
and the  
father of Podes, Hector's feast-  
companion (17.575).

*Kin:* father of Andromache and of seven  
sons; father-in-law of Hector.

*Killed by:* Achilles (6.414–420).

**Refs:** 1.366, 6.396, 6.416, 8.187, 9.188,  
16.153, 21.43, 22.472, 23.827. Books  
1, 6, 8–9, 16–17, 21–23.

*See also:* Andromache, Achilles, Hector,  
Thebe, Placus, Chryseis, Podes.

---

### **Fate** (Μοῖρα) · GOD

Personified only where the translation  
capitalizes her; elsewhere μοῖρα is the  
common noun “fate,” and the death-  
line formula μοῖρα κραταίη is rendered  
“fate the

overpowering.” She walks the shield of  
Achilles beside Strife and Tumult,  
“deadly  
Fate, holding one man fresh-wounded  
and alive, another unwounded, another  
dead,  
dragging him by the feet through the  
fighting,” her cloak red with the blood  
of men  
(18.535–538). Elsewhere she is a  
spinner: what she “spun for him with  
her thread at  
his birth” is said of Achilles by Zeus  
(20.127–128) and of Hector by Hecuba  
(24.209–210), in the same wording.  
Agamemnon names her with Zeus and  
the Erinyes as  
the causes of his blindness, and the  
horse Xanthus names “a great god, and  
strong



Fate” as the killers of Patroclus.

**Refs:** 18.535, 19.87, 19.410, 20.127,  
24.209. Books 18, 19, 20, 24.

*See also:* Strife, Blindness, Erinyes,  
Xanthus (horse), Zeus, Hecuba.

---

**Gargaron** (Γάργαρον) · PLACE — Say: GAR-  
guh-ron

The peak of Ida where Zeus’s precinct  
and smoking altar are, and the seat  
from

which he watches the war: he halts his  
horses there at 8.48–52, pours mist  
around

them, and sits “looking out at the  
Trojans’ city and the ships of the  
Achaeans.”

It is where Hera comes to him arrayed  
in the keston, and where he sleeps after,

“broken by sleep and love, his wife in his arms,” while Sleep runs to Poseidon with the news; and where Iris and Apollo find him wreathed in a fragrant cloud when he wakes.

**Refs:** 8.48, 14.292, 14.352, 15.152. Books 8, 14–15.

*See also:* Ida, Zeus, Hera, Sleep, Iris.

---

**Glaucus** (Γλαῦκος) · MORTAL — *Say:* GLAW-kus

Co-leader of the Lycians with Sarpedon, and one of the two men — with Asteropaeus — whom Sarpedon picks out as best of the allies after himself. In Book 6 he meets Diomedes between the lines and answers the challenge with the poem’s

most famous  
image, “As the generation of leaves, so  
is the generation of men,” then recites  
the  
Bellerophon story; the two discover  
their grandfathers’ guest-friendship,  
refuse to  
fight, and exchange armor — at which  
“Zeus took Glaucus’s wits away,” gold  
for  
bronze, a hundred oxen’s worth for  
nine. Teucer’s arrow through his bared  
arm takes  
him out of the fight at the wall; Apollo  
heals it at his prayer in Book 16 so that  
he can rally the Lycians over Sarpedon’s  
body. In Book 17 he rounds on Hector  
for  
letting Sarpedon’s corpse go and  
threatens to take the Lycians home. His

great-grandfather Glaucus, son of  
Sisyphus, bears the same name (6.154).

*Kin:* son of Hippolochus; grandson of  
Bellerophon; cousin of Sarpedon  
through  
Laodameia.

*Kills:* Iphinous (7.13–16); Bathycles  
(16.593–598).

**Refs:** 2.876, 6.119, 6.234, 7.13, 12.309,  
12.387, 16.492, 16.530, 17.140.

Books 2, 6–7, 12, 14, 16–17.

*See also:* Sarpedon, Diomedes,  
Hippolochus, Bellerophon, Teucer,  
Apollo, Hector.

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### **Graces** (Χάριτες) · GOD

Divine craftswomen and, in Book 14,  
marriageable persons. They wove the  
ambrosial

robe Aphrodite is wearing when  
Diomedes cuts her hand (5.338). Hera  
buys Sleep's  
help against Zeus by offering him "one  
of the younger Graces" to marry, and he  
names  
his price: Pasithea, "whom I myself  
have longed for all my days." Their  
name is also  
the poem's measure of male beauty —  
Euphorbus dies with "hair like the  
Graces'."

*Also called:* the younger Graces (14.267,  
14.275); Pasithea is the one named.

**Refs:** 5.338, 14.267, 14.275, 17.51. Books  
5, 14, 17.

*See also:* Aphrodite, Hera, Sleep,  
Pasithea, Euphorbus.

---

**Hades** (“Αἰδης) · GOD — Say: HAY-deez

Lord of the dead, and by metonymy the underworld itself — most of the poem’s forty-six occurrences are the destination in phrases like “went down to the house of Hades,” which is where the wrath of the poem sends “many strong souls of heroes” in the fourth line. As a person he is the third of Cronos’ sons: Poseidon’s account of the lots at 15.187–193 gives Zeus the wide heaven, himself the grey sea, and “Hades the misty dark,” with earth and Olympus common to all three. Heracles shot him at Pylos “among the dead, and gave him over to pain” (5.395–397); Athena wears

his helmet to hide from Ares (5.845);  
and in the theomachy he leaps  
screaming from  
his throne, afraid Poseidon will crack  
the earth open and expose his “terrible,  
mouldering houses, which the very  
gods abhor” (20.61–65). Achilles learns  
from

Patroclus’ ghost that there is a soul and  
an image in his house “but the wits are  
not in it at all.”

*Epithets:* “the gate-closer” (πυλάρτης,  
8.367); “of the famed colts”  
(κλυτόπωλος, 5.654).

*Also called:* Aïdoneus (5.190, 20.61).

*Kin:* son of Cronos and Rhea; brother of  
Zeus, Poseidon and Hera.

**Refs:** 1.3, 5.395, 5.654, 5.845, 8.367, 9.158,  
15.188, 15.191, 16.856, 20.294,  
22.213, 23.103 ...and throughout. Books

1, 3, 5–9, 11, 13–16, 20–24.

*See also:* Zeus, Poseidon, Persephone,  
Erebus, Patroclus, Heracles.

---

**Haemon** (Αἴμων) · MORTAL — Say: HEE-  
mon

Three men. The first is a Pylian, “the  
lord Haemon,” one of the five captains  
Nestor is arraying his companions  
around when Agamemnon reaches him  
in Book 4. The  
second is a Cadmean, father of Maeon —  
one of the two leaders of the fifty-man  
ambush the Thebans set for Tydeus,  
and the only man Tydeus let go home  
alive. The  
third is named once as Alcimedon’s  
grandfather, father of Laerces, among  
the



Myrmidons.

**Refs:** 4.296, 4.394, 17.467. Books 4, 17.

*See also:* Nestor, Maeon, Tydeus,  
Alcimedon, Laerces.

---

**Hebe** (Ἥβη) · GOD — Say: HEE-bee

Daughter of Zeus and Hera, and the  
gods' cup-bearer: the poem's first sight  
of

Olympus at the opening of Book 4 has  
her pouring nectar among the seated  
gods while

they look out at the city of the Trojans.  
She also works as Hera's groom, setting  
the bronze eight-spoked wheels on the  
chariot when her mother goes to war  
(5.722),

and it is she who bathes Ares and  
dresses him in graceful clothing after

Paiëon has

healed his belly-wound.

*Epithets:* “the lady Hebe” (πότνια Ἥβη, 4.2).

*Kin:* daughter of Zeus and Hera; sister of Ares.

**Refs:** 4.2, 5.722, 5.905. Books 4–5.

*See also:* Hera, Zeus, Ares, Paiëon.

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### **Hector** (Ἑκτωρ) · MORTAL

Priam’s eldest son, Troy’s champion,  
and the man on whom the city rests —  
“for

Hector alone was the saving of Ilion”

(6.403). He is the poem’s second  
protagonist:

he duels Ajax to a standstill in Book 7,  
breaks the Achaean gate with a stone in  
Book 12, fires the ships in Book 15, and

strips Achilles' armor from Patroclus' body, the act that brings Achilles back and destroys him. His domestic scene with Andromache and the infant Astyanax at the Scaean Gates (6.390–496) is set against his own certainty that Ilion will fall; he twice rejects Polydamas' counsel to withdraw, the second time fatally. In Book 22 he waits alone outside the wall, runs three times around the city, is tricked by Athena in Deiphobus' shape, and takes Achilles' spear through the gullet. Achilles drags his body for twelve days until Priam ransoms it, and the poem closes on his burial.

*Epithets:* "of the flashing helmet" (κορυθαίολος, 2.816); "glorious"

(φαίδιμος,  
4.505); “man-slaughtering”  
(ἀνδροφόνος, 1.242 — given last to his  
own head at  
24.724); “breaker of horses” (ἵππόδαμος,  
7.38), rendered “tamer of horses” in the  
line that ends the poem (22.161, 24.804).  
*Also called:* Priam’s son — the default  
referent of the patronymic, though it  
also  
serves Paris, Helenus, Deiphobus,  
Polydorus, Lycaon and the Book 24 roll-  
call.  
*Kin:* son of Priam and Hecuba; husband  
of Andromache, daughter of Eëtion;  
father  
of Astyanax; brother of Paris, Helenus,  
Deiphobus, Polydorus, Lycaon,  
Cassandra and  
Laodice.

*Kills:* Patroclus (16.818–863), with Apollo and Euphorbus striking before him; Amphinomachos, Schedios, Asaeus, Antinous and many more.

*Killed by:* Achilles (22.326–330).

**Refs:** 1.242, 2.816, 3.38, 6.390, 6.440, 7.38, 12.445, 16.818, 18.284, 22.326, 24.724, 24.804 ...and throughout. Books 1–24.

*See also:* Achilles, Priam, Andromache, Astyanax, Polydamas, Patroclus, Ajax, Apollo, Deiphobus.

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**Hecuba** (Ἑκάβη) · MORTAL — Say: HEK-yoo-buh

Priam's wife and Hector's mother. She meets Hector at the palace in Book 6 and offers him wine, then leads the older

women to lay the loveliest robe of her  
Sidonian  
store on Athena's knees — a prayer  
Athena refuses. On the wall at 22.79–89  
she bares  
her breast and begs him to come inside;  
she leads the lament over his body  
twice,  
at the wall and at the bier, where she  
says his flesh is unmarked and “dear to  
the  
gods you were while you lived with me.”  
In Book 24 she opposes Priam's journey  
to  
the ships outright, calling Achilles  
savage and faithless and wishing she  
could eat  
his liver, then yields and makes her  
husband pour a libation before he goes.  
*Epithets*: “gentle-giving” (ἡπιόδωρος,

6.251).

*Kin:* daughter of Dymas, sister of Asius (16.718); wife of Priam; mother of Hector,

Paris, Deiphobus, Helenus, Laodice, Cassandra and the rest.

**Refs:** 6.293, 6.451, 16.718, 22.234, 22.430, 24.193, 24.283, 24.747. Books 6, 16, 22, 24.

*See also:* Priam, Hector, Andromache, Athena, Achilles, Dymas, Asius.

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**Helen** (Ἑλένη) · MORTAL — *Say:* HEL-un  
Menelaus' wife, taken to Troy by Paris,  
and the cause the whole war is fought  
over —  
“Argive Helen, for whose sake so many  
Achaeans have perished at Troy.” The  
poem

handles her almost entirely through her own speech, and every scene of it is self-reproach: she names herself “dog-face” to Priam on the wall while identifying the Achaean captains for him, calls herself “the dog, the evil-scheming horror” to Hector, and wishes a storm had carried her off the day she was born. Aphrodite compels her to Paris’ bed in Book 3 with a threat, and she goes in silence. She speaks last of the three women who lament Hector, mourning the only man in Troy who never gave her a hard word: “there is no one else now in wide Troy gentle to me, or kind: they all shudder at me.” *Epithets*: “of the trailing robe”



(τανύπεπλος, 3.228).

*Kin*: daughter of Zeus (3.418, “Helen sprung of Zeus”); wife of Menelaus; taken by

Paris; she names a daughter left behind at Sparta (3.175).

**Refs:** 2.161, 3.121, 3.171, 3.228, 3.418, 6.343, 7.350, 24.761. Books 2–4, 6–9, 11, 13, 19, 22, 24.

*See also*: Paris, Menelaus, Priam, Hector, Aphrodite, Antenor, Laodice.

---

**Helenus** (“Ἑλενος) · MORTAL — *Say*: HEL-uh-nus

Priam’s son, “far the best of bird-readers,” whose counsel twice sets the plot

moving: at 6.75–101 he sends Hector back into the city to have Hecuba

petition

Athena, which produces the  
Andromache scene; and at 7.44–53 he  
hears “the voice of  
the gods who are forever,” relays that it  
is not yet Hector’s fate to die, and  
prompts the challenge that brings on  
the duel with Ajax. He also fights — he  
leads

one of the storming-parties at the wall  
with Deiphobus, kills Deïpyrus with a  
Thracian sword, and is shot in the bow-  
hand by Menelaus and carried out.

Priam

curses him by name among the nine  
surviving sons in Book 24. A different  
Helenus,

son of Oenops, is one of the Achaeans  
Hector and Ares kill at 5.707.

*Kin:* son of Priam and Hecuba; brother

of Hector, Paris and Deiphobus.

*Kills:* Deïpyrus (13.576–580).

**Refs:** 5.707, 6.75, 7.44, 12.94, 13.576, 13.582, 24.249. Books 5–7, 12–13, 24.

*See also:* Priam, Hector, Deiphobus, Menelaus, Cassandra, Deïpyrus.

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**Hellas** (Ἑλλάς) · PLACE — *Say:* HEL-us

Not yet a name for Greece: in this poem it is a district of Phthia, listed in the Catalogue with Alos, Alope, Trachis and Phthia as the country of Achilles' contingent, and fixed as "Hellas of the beautiful women." Achilles offers it as his

marriage-market — "There are Achaean girls enough through Hellas and through Phthia"

— and Phoenix fled from it to Peleus

after the quarrel with his father  
Amyntor,  
crossing “Hellas of the wide spaces.”  
Bathycles, the richest of the  
Myrmidons, had  
his home there.

**Refs:** 2.683, 9.395, 9.447, 9.478, 16.595.

Books 2, 9, 16.

*See also:* Hellenes, Phthia, Achilles,  
Phoenix, Myrmidons, Bathycles.

---

**Hellenes** (Ἕλληνες) · PEOPLE — *Say:* HEL-  
eenz

Still a narrow regional term, twice only.  
At 2.684 it is one of the three names of  
Achilles’ own contingent — “and they  
were called Myrmidons, and Hellenes,  
and  
Achaeans” — and at 2.530 the lesser

Ajax “with the spear surpassed all  
Hellenes and  
Achaeans,” a pairing that keeps the two  
distinct. It is not a name for the whole  
host; that is Achaeans, Argives,  
Danaans.

**Refs:** 2.530, 2.684. Book 2.

*See also:* Hellas, Myrmidons, Achaeans,  
Achilles, Ajax son of Oïleus.

---

**Hellespont** (Ἑλλήσποντος) · PLACE — *Say:*

HEL-uh-spont

The strait beside the Achaean camp,  
always “strong-flowing” or “wide” or  
“boundless,” and the poem’s standing  
figure for the far edge of the beachhead.

Nestor

proposes the barrow of the unnamed  
dead be heaped “beside the wide

Hellespont” so  
that men sailing by in later ages will see  
it; Achilles threatens to load his ships  
and be seen sailing it at earliest light;  
Poseidon’s wall-destroying flood in  
Book  
12 smooths the beach “along the  
strong-flowing Hellespont.” It bounds  
the Thracian  
contingent in the Catalogue and, in  
Priam’s mind, the whole extent of his  
former  
wealth.

**Refs:** 2.845, 7.86, 9.360, 12.30, 15.233,  
17.432, 18.150, 23.2, 24.346, 24.545.

Books 2, 7, 9, 12, 15, 17–18, 23–24.

*See also:* Troy, Ida, Poseidon, Nestor,  
Achilles.

---

**Hephaestus** (Ἥφαιστος) · GOD — Say: hih-

FES-tus *or* hih-FEE-stus

The smith-god, lamed and comic in

Book 1 — where he bustles round the

hall pouring

nectar to break up his parents' quarrel,

and tells how Zeus once caught him by

the

foot and flung him from the threshold

of heaven to fall all day and land on

Lemnos —

and formidable everywhere after. He

made Agamemnon's sceptre and the

houses of the

gods; his name stands by metonymy for

fire ("the flame of Hephaestus," 2.426).

His

great work is the armor and the shield

of Achilles, forged at Thetis' asking,

with

the earth, heaven, sea, two cities, the  
plowing and harvest, the vineyard, the  
herd  
and the lions, the dancing-floor and the  
river of Ocean on it (18.478–608). In  
Book  
21 Hera sets him on the Scamander: he  
burns the plain, then the river itself,  
until  
the water boils in its channel and the  
god begs off.

*Epithets:* “crook-footed” (ἀμφιγυήεις,  
1.607); “famed for craft” (κλυτότεχνης,  
1.571); “famed” (περικλυτός, 1.607).

*Kin:* son of Hera (1.572, 21.330); husband  
of Charis (18.382).

**Refs:** 1.571, 1.600, 2.101, 2.426, 14.239,  
18.137, 18.369, 18.473, 20.36,  
21.342, 21.367, 21.381. Books 1–2, 5, 8–9,  
14–15, 17–23.



*See also:* Hera, Thetis, Achilles, Charis,  
Scamander, Zeus, Lemnos.

---

**Hera** (Ἥρα) · GOD — *Say:* HEER-uh or HAIR-uh

Zeus's wife and sister, and the  
Achaeans' most relentless partisan —  
she will trade

Argos, Sparta and Mycenae, the three  
cities dearest to her, for the sack of Troy  
(4.51–56), and Zeus says she would eat  
Priam and his sons raw if she could get  
at

them. She sets the poem going by  
putting the assembly into Achilles'  
mind (1.55),

and her Book 14 deception is its central  
act of divine mischief: she borrows the  
kestos from Aphrodite, buys Sleep with

the promise of Pasithea, and takes Zeus  
on  
Gargaron so that Poseidon can turn the  
battle while he sleeps. Zeus's fury when  
he  
wakes — and his reminder of the time  
he hung her from heaven with anvils on  
her  
feet — does not change her; she extorts  
his consent for Troy's fall in Book 4 and  
again in Book 21, and sends Hephaestus  
against the river to save Achilles.  
*Epithets:* “white-armed” (λευκώλενος,  
1.55); “ox-eyed lady Hera” (βοῶπις  
πότνια  
Ἥρη, 1.551); “eldest goddess” (πρέσβα  
θεά, 5.721); “of the golden throne”  
(χρυσόθρονος, 1.611).  
*Kin:* daughter of Cronos and Rhea; sister  
and wife of Zeus; sister of Poseidon and

Hades; mother of Ares, Hebe and  
Hephaestus.

**Refs:** 1.55, 1.400, 1.536, 4.5, 4.50, 5.721,  
8.198, 14.159, 14.292, 15.5, 19.407

...and throughout. Books 1–2, 4–5, 7–11,  
13–16, 18–21, 24.

*See also:* Zeus, Athena, Sleep, Aphrodite,  
Hephaestus, Poseidon, Hebe, Ares.

---

**Heracles** (Ἡρακλῆς) · MORTAL — Say: HER-  
uh-kleez

Always in the past tense, and always as  
the measure of a generation stronger  
than

this one. His Troy is the earlier sack: he  
came for the horses of Laomedon “with  
only six ships and fewer men, and  
sacked the city of Ilion, and widowed  
her

streets,” and Laomedon cheated him of  
the horses (5.638–651). Sleep and Hera  
between  
them wrecked his homecoming and  
blew him to Cos, for which Zeus hurled  
gods through  
the house; Poseidon shows Aeneas the  
wall the Trojans built him against the  
sea-monster. Achilles takes him as the  
precedent for his own death — “not  
even the  
might of Heracles escaped his doom” —  
and Agamemnon takes his birth as the  
great  
instance of Blindness, when Hera’s trick  
handed his rule to Eurystheus. He  
wounded  
Hades at Pylos, and he battered Nestor’s  
Pylos so hard that eleven of Neleus’  
twelve

sons were killed.

*Epithets:* “the might of Heracles” (βίη Ἡρακλεΐη, 2.658) — the periphrasis is kept, and is the usual form of the name.

*Kin:* son of Zeus and Alcmene; father of Tlepolemus by Astyocheia and of Thessalus.

**Refs:** 2.658, 2.666, 5.638, 11.690, 14.255, 15.25, 18.117, 19.98, 20.145. Books

2, 5, 11, 14–15, 18–20.

*See also:* Zeus, Hera, Alcmene, Eurystheus, Laomedon, Tlepolemus, Sarpedon, Nestor.

---

**Hermes** (Ἑρμείας) · GOD — *Say:* HUR-meez

The gods’ messenger and escort. He passes the sceptre from Zeus to Pelops in the

Book 2 genealogy, steals Ares out of the

bronze jar where the sons of Aloeus had  
him bound, fathers Eudorus on  
Polymele, and is paired against Leto in  
the theomachy —

where he declines to fight, saying it is a  
hard thing to trade blows with the  
wives

of Zeus. His great scene is Book 24: Zeus  
sends him to bring Priam through the  
Achaean camp unseen, and he comes as  
a young man, takes the reins, drugs the  
gate-keepers, opens the gate, identifies  
himself at Achilles' door, and comes  
back

before dawn to wake the old man and  
drive him out again. Every occurrence  
of “Argus”

in the poem is inside his fixed epithet.

*Epithets:* “the slayer of Argus”

(ἀργεῖφόντης, 2.103); “the guide”

(διάκτορος,

2.103) — rendered “the courier” in its later occurrences (20.34, 24.339).

*Kin*: son of Zeus; father of Eudorus by Polymele (16.181–186).

**Refs:** 2.103, 5.390, 14.490, 16.181, 20.35, 21.497, 24.334, 24.339, 24.461, 24.679, 24.694. Books 2, 5, 14–16, 20–21, 24.

*See also:* Zeus, Priam, Achilles, Eudorus, Leto, Ares, Pelops.

---

**Hicetaon** (Ἰκετάων) · MORTAL — Say: hy-suh-TAY-on

One of Priam’s brothers, a son of Laomedon, and one of the Trojan elders sitting at the Scaean Gates in Book 3 who watch Helen come and say she is worth the

suffering.

He does not fight. In the poem he functions mainly as a patronymic: his son

Melanippus, who had herded cattle at Percote until the war came close, is rebuked by

Hector into the front line and shot in the chest by Antilochus.

*Epithets*: “scion of Ares” (ὄζος Ἄρηος, 3.147), varied as “sprig of Ares” in the genealogy at 20.238.

*Kin*: son of Laomedon; brother of Priam, Tithonus, Lampus and Clytius; father of Melanippus.

**Refs**: 3.147, 15.546, 15.576, 20.238. Books 3, 15, 20.

*See also*: Priam, Laomedon, Melanippus, Antilochus, Hector.

---



**Hippasus** (“Ἱππασος) · MORTAL — Say: HIP-uh-sus

A name attached to men on both sides,  
never a character himself. On the  
Trojan side

he is father of Charops and of Socus,  
“such a pair of men,” both killed by  
Odysseus

in Book 11 — Odysseus taunts the dying  
Socus as “son of war-minded Hippasus,  
breaker

of horses.” A second Hippasus is the  
father of Hypsenor, killed by Deiphobus  
at

13.411; a third the father of Apisaon of  
Paeonia, killed by Lycomedes at 17.348.

The last two die in the same verbatim  
line, hit “in the liver below the midriff.”

*Kin:* father of Charops and Socus; also  
named as father of Hypsenor and of

Apisaon.

**Refs:** 11.426, 11.431, 11.450, 13.411,  
17.348. Books 11, 13, 17.

*See also:* Socus, Charops, Odysseus,  
Hypsenor, Apisaon.

---

**Hippolochus** (Ἰππόλοχος) · MORTAL — Say:

hip-OL-oh-kus

Glaucus' father, son of Bellerophon and  
brother of Isander and Laodameia — so  
the

link between the Lycian house and

Sarpedon, who is Laodameia's son by  
Zeus. He does

not appear: the name is Glaucus'  
patronymic throughout, and his one act  
reported is

sending his son to Troy with the charge  
“always to be the best, and to hold his

head

above all others” (6.207–208), the line

Peleus also gives Achilles. A second

Hippolochus is a son of Antimachus,

killed with his brother Peisander by

Agamemnon

in Book 11, who shears off his hands

and his head and sends him rolling like

a stone

through the crowd.

*Kin:* son of Bellerophon; father of

Glaucus; brother of Isander and

Laodameia.

**Refs:** 6.119, 6.144, 6.197, 6.206, 7.13,

11.122, 11.145, 12.309, 12.387, 17.140.

Books 6–7, 11–12, 17.

*See also:* Glaucus, Bellerophon,

Sarpedon, Laodameia, Antimachus,

Agamemnon.

**Hippothous** (Ἱππόθοος) · MORTAL — Say:

hip-OTH-oh-us

Two men. The chief one leads the  
Pelagian spearmen of Larisa in the  
Catalogue with  
his brother Pylaeus, and dies in Book 17  
in the fight over Patroclus' body: he has  
run a shield-strap round the dead man's  
ankle-tendons and is dragging him off  
by the  
foot "doing a favor to Hector and the  
Trojans" when Telamonian Ajax spears  
him  
through the helmet's cheek-piece and  
the brain runs out along the socket. He  
falls  
face-down on the corpse, "far from  
deep-soiled Larisa; nor did he repay his  
dear  
parents the price of his rearing."

Priam's son Hippothous is a different man,  
named once in the roll-call of the nine  
sons Priam curses (24.251).

*Kin:* the Pelasgian is son of Lethus, son  
of Teutamus; brother of Pylaeus.

*Killed by:* Ajax (17.293–303).

**Refs:** 2.840, 2.842, 17.217, 17.288, 17.313,  
17.318, 24.251. Books 2, 17, 24.

*See also:* Lethus, Larisa, Pelasgians, Ajax,  
Patroclus, Priam.

---

**Hyle** (Ἵλη) · PLACE — *Say:* HY-lee

A Boeotian town by the Cephisian lake,  
listed in the Catalogue. Two men are  
placed  
there: Oresbius “of the glancing waist-  
guard,” who lived there hoarding his  
wealth

with care and is killed by Hector in the Book 5 roll-call; and Tychius, “far the best of leather-cutters,” who made the seven-hide tower shield Ajax carries against Hector.

**Refs:** 2.500, 5.708, 7.221. Books 2, 5, 7.  
*See also:* Boeotians, Oresbius, Tychius, Ajax.

---

**Hyrtacus** (“Υρτακος) · MORTAL — *Say:* HUR-tuh-kus  
Asius’ father, and in the poem only that: every occurrence is the patronymic “Asius, Hyrtacus’ son,” including the couplet the poem repeats verbatim from the Catalogue when Asius storms the wall — “whom

horses carried from Arisbe, tall and fire-colored,

from the river Selleïs” (2.838 = 12.96).

Hector names him twice in the same formula when he searches the front for his missing captains in Book 13.

*Kin*: father of Asius, leader of the men of Percote, Sestus, Abydos and Arisbe.

**Refs:** 2.837, 2.838, 12.96, 12.110, 12.162, 13.760, 13.771. Books 2, 12–13.

*See also*: Asius, Arisbe, Percote, Adamas, Hector.

---

**Ida** (Ἰδῆ) · PLACE — *Say*: EYE-duh

The mountain above Troy, “of the many springs, mother of wild things,” from whose

peaks the eight rivers of the Troad run down to the sea. It is Zeus’s station for

most of the poem: he comes there from  
Olympus in Book 8, sits on Gargaron  
looking

out at the city and the ships, thunders  
from it, and sends Iris and Apollo out  
from

it with his orders. Hera climbs it to  
seduce him; the earth-quake of the  
theomachy

shakes “all the roots of many-springed  
Ida.” Aeneas was got on its spurs, “a  
goddess

bedded with a mortal”; Apollo herded  
Laomedon’s cattle “in the spurs of  
wooded,

many-folded Ida”; and Agamemnon’s  
oath calls on “Father Zeus, ruling from  
Ida.”

*Epithets:* “Ida of the many springs,  
mother of wild things” (πολυπίδαξ Ἰδη,



μήτηρ

θηρῶν, 8.47).

**Refs:** 2.821, 3.276, 8.47, 11.184, 12.19,  
14.283, 15.151, 20.59, 21.449.

Books 2–4, 7–8, 11–17, 20–24.

*See also:* Gargaron, Zeus, Hera, Troy,  
Scamander, Simois, Aeneas.

---

**Idaeus** (Ἰδαῖος) · MORTAL — Say: eye-DEE-  
us

Priam's herald, "wise" and "war-  
minded," and the poem's chief  
instrument of truce.

He carries the oath-offerings and the  
mixing-bowl for the Book 3 duel, and  
rouses

Priam to come out to the plain. In Book  
7 he and Talthymbius force their staffs  
between Ajax and Hector to stop the

duel at nightfall; then he goes alone to the

Achaean assembly with Paris' offer of the treasure but not of Helen, hears it refused, and takes Agamemnon's answer back — the truce for the burning of the dead.

In Book 24 he drives the mule-wagon of ransom to Achilles' hut and is left holding

the teams outside. A different Idaeus is a son of Dares the Hephaestus-priest, who

leaps from his chariot in Book 5 and is snatched away in darkness by

Hephaestus so that the old man should not lose both sons.

*Epithets:* “the far-calling herald” (ἡπύτα κῆρυξ, 7.384).

**Refs:** 3.247, 5.11, 5.20, 7.276, 7.372, 7.381,  
7.413, 24.325, 24.470. Books 3,  
5, 7, 24.

*See also:* Priam, Talthymbius, Hector, Ajax,  
Dares, Hephaestus, Achilles.

---

**Idomeneus** (Ἰδομενεύς) · MORTAL — Say:  
eye-DOM-uh-nyoos or eye-DOM-ih-nee-  
us  
Leader of the Cretans of hundred-citied  
Crete, with Meriones, and one of the  
Achaean elder statesmen —  
Agamemnon gives him a cup that is  
always full and honors  
him “beyond all the Danaans of swift  
colts.” He is one of the men Achilles  
names in  
Book 1 as fit to arbitrate, and one of the  
nine who volunteer against Hector. His

aristeia fills the middle of Book 13:  
Poseidon, in the likeness of Thoas,  
sends him  
back into the fight, and though “his hair  
was half-grey” he kills Othryoneus,  
Asius, Alcathous and Oenomaus before  
Aeneas comes at him and he gives  
ground,  
admitting his legs are no longer what  
they were. In Book 23 he is first to see  
Diomedes coming out of the dust and  
quarrels with the lesser Ajax over  
whose horses  
lead.

*Epithets:* “famed with the spear” (δοῦρὶ  
κλυτός, 2.645).

*Kin:* son of Deucalion (13.451); grandson  
of Minos.

*Kills:* Othryoneus (13.370–373); Asius  
(13.387–393); Alcathous, Oenomaus,

Erymas.

**Refs:** 1.145, 2.645, 4.252, 4.265, 13.210,  
13.361, 13.370, 13.467, 23.450.

Books 1–8, 10–13, 15–17, 19, 23.

*See also:* Meriones, Cretans, Poseidon,  
Asius, Othryoneus, Aeneas, Deucalion.

---

**Ilioneus** (Ἰλιονεύς) · MORTAL — Say: il-ee-  
OH-nyoos

A Trojan, the only son of Phorbas “rich  
in flocks, whom Hermes loved beyond  
all the  
Trojans, and gave him wealth.” Peneleos  
spears him under the brow at the root  
of the  
eye, pushes the eyeball out, and drives  
the point through the nape; then draws  
his  
sword, hews through the neck, and

holds up head, helmet and the spear  
still standing  
in the eye “like a poppy-head” to show  
the Trojans — telling them to carry  
word to  
Ilioneus’ father and mother to start  
wailing. It is the poem’s grimmest  
single  
image, and the Trojans’ limbs shake at  
the sight.

*Kin:* only son of Phorbas.

*Killed by:* Peneleos (14.489–500).

**Refs:** 14.489, 14.492, 14.502. Book 14.

*See also:* Peneleos, Phorbas, Hermes,  
Promachus.

---

**Ilus** (Ἴλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* EYE-lus

An ancestor of the Trojan kings, given  
in Aeneas’ recital of the line at

20.231–236: Tros' eldest son, brother of Assaracus and Ganymede, and father of Laomedon — so Priam's grandfather.

The poem does not gloss his name against Ilion.

He is dead long before the action, and what survives him is his tomb, “the man-made mound,” a fixed landmark in the middle of the plain: Hector holds his night council

beside it, Agamemnon's rout streams past it, Paris shoots Diomedes from behind its

pillar, and Priam and Idaeus drive past it on the road to the ships.

*Kin:* son of Tros; brother of Assaracus and Ganymede; father of Laomedon; great-grandfather of Hector.

**Refs:** 10.415, 11.166, 11.372, 20.232,

20.236, 24.349. Books 10–11, 20, 24.

*See also:* Tros, Laomedon, Priam,  
Assaracus, Dardanus, Troy.

---

**Imbros** (Ἰμβρος) · PLACE — *Say:* IM-bros

An island off Troy, always “rugged,” and  
in the poem a marker of the sea-road  
rather than a place with people.

Poseidon’s undersea cave lies “midway  
between

Tenedos and rugged Imbros”; Iris dives  
into the sea “midway between Samos  
and rugged

Imbros” on her way to Thetis; Hera and  
Sleep pass over it and Lemnos on the  
way to

Ida. Eëtion of Imbros is the guest-friend  
who ransomed Lycaon out of Lemnos,  
and



Hecuba names it in her lament as one of  
the places across the sea Achilles sold  
her  
sons into.

**Refs:** 13.33, 14.281, 21.43, 24.78, 24.753.

Books 13–14, 21, 24.

*See also:* Lemnos, Samos, Tenedos,  
Poseidon, Eëtion, Lycaon.

---

**Iphiclus** (Ἰφικλος) · MORTAL — Say: IF-ih-  
klus

Father of Protesilaus and Podarces, and  
“rich in flocks,” son of Phylacus; he does  
not appear, and both his sons are  
named by the patronymic when the  
Phylacean  
contingent is handed on from the first  
man killed at Troy to his younger  
brother

(2.703–708, 13.698). The Iphiclus Nestor claims to have outrun in the games at Buprasium — “good runner though he was” — belongs to the same back-story generation, but the text does not say he is the same man.

*Kin:* son of Phylacus; father of Protesilaus and Podarces.

**Refs:** 2.705, 13.698, 23.636. Books 2, 13, 23.

*See also:* Protesilaus, Podarces, Phylacus, Nestor, Phylace.

---

**Iphidamas** (Ἰφιδάμας) · MORTAL — *Say:* if-ID-uh-mas  
Antenor’s son, “a good man and a big one,” and the answer to the Muse-question of

who first came against Agamemnon in  
his aristeia. Reared in Thrace by his  
mother's  
father Cisses, who tried to keep him  
there by giving him his daughter, he left  
the  
bridal chamber "chasing the report of  
the Achaeans" with twelve ships,  
beached them  
at Percote, and walked the rest of the  
way to Ilion. His thrust bends on  
Agamemnon's  
war-belt "like lead"; Agamemnon  
wrenches the spear from his grip and  
cuts his neck,  
and he "slept a sleep of bronze," far  
from the wife he had bought with a  
hundred  
cattle and a promise of a thousand goats  
and sheep. His brother Coon wounds

Agamemnon in the forearm trying to  
drag the body clear and is beheaded  
over it.

*Kin:* son of Antenor and Theano;  
grandson of Cisses; brother of Coon.

*Killed by:* Agamemnon (11.238–241).

**Refs:** 11.221, 11.234, 11.257, 11.261. Book  
11.

*See also:* Antenor, Coon, Agamemnon,  
Theano, Cisses, Percote.

---

**Iris** (Ἴρις) · GOD — *Say:* EYE-ris

The gods' runner, and the poem's most  
reliable instrument: she carries Zeus's  
word

and no one else's business is ever her  
own. She rouses the Trojan assembly in  
Priam's likeness at 2.786, leads the  
wounded Aphrodite out of the fighting

and up  
to Olympus (5.353–369), turns Hera and  
Athena back from the field with Zeus’s  
threat (8.398–425), and brings Achilles  
unarmed to the ditch on Hera’s secret  
errand (18.166–202). She has one line of  
her own judgment — telling Poseidon  
that  
the hearts of the great can turn (15.203)  
— and Poseidon calls it the mark of a  
messenger who knows what is fitting. In  
Book 23 she carries Achilles’ prayer to  
the  
winds; in Book 24 she goes down  
through the sea to Thetis and then to  
Priam, and  
her speech to him repeats Zeus’s word  
almost exactly.

*Epithets:* “wind-footed swift Iris”  
(ποδὴνεμος ὠκέα Ἴρις, 2.786); “swift-

footed

Iris” (πόδας ὠκέα Ἴρις, 2.790); “of the golden wings” (χρυσόπτερος, 8.398); “storm-footed” (ἀελλόπος, 8.409).

**Refs:** 2.786, 3.121, 5.353, 8.398, 11.185, 15.157, 18.166, 24.143 ...and

throughout. Books 2–3, 5, 8, 11, 15, 18, 23–24.

*See also:* Zeus, Hera, Aphrodite, Poseidon, Thetis, Priam, Achilles.

---

**Jason** (Ἰήσων) · MORTAL — Say: JAY-sun

In the back-story only: “shepherd of the people,” to whom Hypsipyle bore Euneus, the king of Lemnos who sends wine-ships to the Achaean camp and gives a thousand measures separately to Agamemnon

and Menelaus (7.467–471). The poem's  
interest in  
him is entirely through his son, who  
buys Lycaon when Achilles sells him  
into  
Lemnos (21.41) and whose silver  
mixing-bowl — paid as Lycaon's price to  
Patroclus —  
becomes the foot-race prize in Book 23.  
*Kin:* by Hypsipyle, father of Euneus.  
**Refs:** 7.468, 7.469, 7.471, 21.41, 23.746.  
Books 7, 21, 23.  
*See also:* Euneus, Hypsipyle, Lemnos,  
Lycaon.

---

**Laertes** (Λαέρτης) · MORTAL — Say: lay-UR-  
teez  
Odysseus's father, who never appears:  
in every one of his occurrences the

name is

a patronymic for his son. It carries the fixed vocative “Zeus-sprung son of Laertes, Odysseus of many devices” (2.173), used by Athena, Agamemnon, Nestor, Diomedes and Achilles in turn; Helen names Odysseus to Priam from the wall as

“Laertes’ son, resourceful Odysseus” (3.200).

*Kin:* father of Odysseus.

**Refs:** 2.173, 3.200, 4.358, 8.93, 9.308, 10.144, 19.185, 23.723. Books 2–4, 8–10, 19, 23.

*See also:* Odysseus.

---

**Lampus** (Λάμπος) · MORTAL — *Say:* LAMPUS



One of the elders sitting with Priam at the Scaean Gates — “finished with war now because of age, but speakers of quality, like cicadas” — and one of Laomedon’s sons, so Priam’s brother; the genealogy Aeneas recites to Achilles puts him with Clytius and Hicetaon (20.238). His son Dolops, “the strongest son that Lampus fathered,” is killed by Menelaus while fighting Meges (15.525–543). The name also belongs to one of Hector’s four chariot-horses, called by name at 8.185.

*Kin:* son of Laomedon; brother of Priam, Tithonus, Clytius and Hicetaon; father of Dolops.

**Refs:** 3.147, 8.185, 15.526, 20.238. Books 3, 8, 15, 20.

*See also:* Laomedon, Priam, Clytius,  
Hicetaon, Dolops, Hector.

---

**Laodice** (Λαοδίκη) · MORTAL — *Say:* lay-OD-ih-see

Two women. Priam's daughter,  
“loveliest of the daughters of Priam”

(3.124), married

to Antenor's son Helicaon; Iris takes her likeness to fetch Helen to the wall, and Hecuba is leading her when she meets Hector in Book 6. A second Laodice is one of

Agamemnon's three daughters, offered to Achilles with Chrysothemis and Iphianassa

in the embassy's list of gifts (9.145 = 9.287).

*Kin:* Priam's daughter is the daughter of

Priam and Hecuba, and wife of  
Helicaon;  
the other is a daughter of Agamemnon.

**Refs:** 3.124, 6.252, 9.145, 9.287. Books 3,  
6, 9.

*See also:* Priam, Hecuba, Helicaon,  
Antenor, Agamemnon, Chrysothemis,  
Iphianassa.

---

**Laomedon** (Λαομέδων) · MORTAL — *Say:*

lay-OM-uh-don

Priam's father, dead before the poem,  
and its standing example of a man who  
cheats

gods. Poseidon tells the story twice: he  
and Apollo served him a whole year at a  
stated wage — Poseidon building the  
city wall, Apollo herding cattle on Ida —  
and

at the term he robbed them by force  
and threatened to bind them and sell  
them

overseas and cut off their ears (21.441–  
457, cf. 7.452–453). He also refused  
Heracles the horses promised for a  
service, and Heracles sacked Ilion for it  
(5.640–651). His horses remain the  
standard of excellence: Nestor tells  
Antilochus

no man will pass him, not driving Arion  
nor “the horses of Laomedon, best of  
the  
breed reared here” (23.348).

*Kin*: son of Ilus; father of Priam,  
Tithonus, Lampus, Clytius, Hicetaon and  
Bucolion.

**Refs:** 3.250, 5.269, 5.640, 5.649, 7.453,  
20.236, 21.444, 21.452, 23.348.

Books 3, 5–7, 15, 20–21, 23.

*See also:* Priam, Poseidon, Apollo,  
Heracles, Ilus, Lampus, Tros.

---

**Laothoe** (Λαοθόη) · MORTAL — Say: lay-  
OTH-oh-ee

One of Priam's wives, daughter of Altes  
lord of the Lelegians, and mother of  
Lycaon  
and Polydorus — the two sons Achilles  
kills within a book of each other. Lycaon  
names her as he supplicates: "to a short  
life my mother bore me — Laothoe,  
daughter  
of the old man Altes" (21.84–89). Priam,  
watching from the wall, counts the  
same  
two as missing and says that if they are  
dead it is grief to his heart and their  
mother's, "a queen among women"

(22.46–53).

*Kin:* daughter of Altes; wife of Priam;  
mother of Lycaon and Polydorus.

**Refs:** 21.85, 22.48. Books 21–22.

*See also:* Altes, Priam, Lycaon, Polydorus,  
Achilles.

---

**Lemnos** (Λῆμνος) · PLACE — *Say:* LEM-nos

The island Hephaestus fell on when  
Zeus flung him from the threshold of  
heaven,

where the Sintian men took him up

(1.593); Philoctetes lies there

abandoned with his

snake-bite while his ships fight at Troy

(2.722); and it is “the city of godlike

Thoas” that Hera passes through on her  
way to find Sleep (14.230). It is also the  
poem’s slave-market: Achilles ships

Lycaon there and sells him, and the son  
of Jason

pays the price (21.40–41) — a sale

Lycaon and Achilles both throw back at  
each other

in Book 21, and one Priam expects for  
his other sons in Book 24.

**Refs:** 1.593, 2.722, 8.230, 14.230, 14.281,  
21.40, 21.58, 21.79, 24.753.

Books 1–2, 7–8, 14, 21, 24.

*See also:* Hephaestus, Philoctetes, Thoas,  
Lycaon, Euneus, Imbros.

---

**Leonteus** (Λεοντεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* lee-  
ON-tyoos

One of the two Lapith captains, always  
paired with Polypoetes: they lead forty  
ships

in the Catalogue and stand before the

gate in Book 12 “like high-crowned oaks  
in the  
mountains that abide the wind and rain  
through all their days,” refusing to be  
driven  
inside the wall. There he spears  
Hippomachus at the war-belt and then  
goes at the  
rest with the sword. In Book 23 he  
throws the lump of pig-iron second and  
loses to  
Polypoetes.

*Epithets:* “scion of Ares” (ὄζος Ἄρηος,  
2.745).

*Kin:* son of Coronus, Caeneus’ son.

**Refs:** 2.745, 12.130, 12.188, 23.837,  
23.841. Books 2, 12, 23.

*See also:* Polypoetes, Coronus, Caeneus,  
Lapiths.

---



**Lesbos** (Λέσβος) · PLACE — Say: LEZ-bos

One of Achilles' conquests before the poem opens: the seven women skilled in blameless work whom Agamemnon offers in the embassy are the ones Achilles himself

chose "when he himself took well-built Lesbos" (9.129–130 = 9.271–272), and the woman sleeping beside him at the end of Book 9 is Diomedes, Phorbas's daughter,

brought from there. Achilles names it again in Book 24 as the seaward bound of

Priam's old prosperity, "the seat of Macar."

**Refs:** 9.129, 9.130, 9.271, 9.664, 24.544.

Books 9, 24.

*See also:* Achilles, Diomedes, Macar, Priam.

---

**Leto** (Λητώ) · GOD — *Say*: LEE-toh

Mother of Apollo and Artemis by Zeus,  
named in the poem's ninth line as the  
parent

of the god who sends the plague. She  
takes the Trojan side: she heals Aeneas  
with

Artemis in Apollo's shrine on Pergamos  
(5.447), and in the theomachy she is  
matched

against Hermes — who declines to fight  
her, telling her to boast among the gods  
that

she overcame him, and leaves her to  
gather up her daughter's scattered bow  
and

arrows (21.497–504). Zeus names her in  
his catalogue of loves at 14.327, and it is  
for matching herself against Leto that

Niobe's twelve children are killed  
(24.607).

Achilles' horse Xanthus calls Apollo  
“the best of the gods, whom lovely-  
haired Leto  
bore” (19.413).

*Epithets:* “lovely-haired” (ἡὔκομος, 1.36);  
“fair-cheeked” (καλλιπάρης, 24.607).

*Kin:* by Zeus, mother of Apollo and  
Artemis.

**Refs:** 1.9, 1.36, 5.447, 14.327, 16.849,  
19.413, 20.40, 21.497, 24.607.

Books 1, 5, 14, 16, 19–21, 24.

*See also:* Apollo, Artemis, Zeus, Hermes,  
Niobe.

---

**Leĩtus** (Λήϊτος) · MORTAL — Say: LEE-ih-tus  
One of the five Boeotian leaders in the  
Catalogue, and the one of them the

poem

keeps using. He kills Phylacus in Book 6,  
is among the captains Poseidon rouses  
in

Book 13, and in Book 17 Hector wounds  
him on the wrist at close quarters and  
stops

his fighting for good: “he shrank back,  
glancing round, for his heart no longer  
hoped to hold a spear steady in hand  
and fight the Trojans.”

*Kin:* son of Alectryon (17.602).

**Refs:** 2.494, 6.35, 13.91, 17.601, 17.605.

Books 2, 6, 13, 17.

*See also:* Peneleos, Boeotians, Alectryon,  
Hector.

---

**Locrians** (Λοκροί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* LOK-ree-  
unz

The lesser Ajax's forty ships, from  
Cynus, Opoeis and the towns around the  
Boagrius,

“who live across from holy Euboea.”

Book 13 makes them the poem's only  
distinct

light infantry: they carry no bronze  
helmets, no shields and no ash spears,  
only

bows and slings of twisted wool, so they  
will not stand in the close fight — they  
follow behind the armored line and  
shoot unseen, and it is their arrows that  
break

the Trojan formations and rout them  
(13.712–722).

**Refs:** 2.527, 2.535, 13.686, 13.712. Books  
2, 13.

*See also:* Ajax son of Oïleus, Opoeis,  
Euboea.

---

**Lycaon** (Λυκάων) · MORTAL — *Say:* ly-KAY-on

Two men. The chief one is Priam's son  
by Laothoe, whose supplication in Book  
21 is

the poem's most sustained refusal.

Achilles had taken him once by night in  
his

father's orchard cutting fig-shoots for  
chariot-rails, shipped him to Lemnos  
and sold

him; ransomed by Eëtion of Imbros, he  
had been home eleven days when

Achilles meets

him again in the river. He grasps the  
knees with one hand and the spear with  
the

other and pleads guest-right and the  
grain of Demeter; Achilles answers that

Patroclus died and was a better man,  
and that death and strong fate stand  
over  
himself too, then cuts through his  
collarbone and slings him into the river  
to the  
fish. His corslet is what Paris arms in for  
the duel (3.333). The second Lycaon is  
Pandarus's father, of Zeleia, whose  
eleven new-built chariots stand under  
cloths at  
home while Pandarus fights on foot  
(5.193–197); “Lycaon's shining son”  
throughout  
Books 4 and 5 means Pandarus, not  
Priam's son.  
*Kin:* Priam's son is son of Priam and  
Laothoe, brother of Polydorus; the  
other is  
father of Pandarus.

*Killed by:* Achilles (21.114–119).

**Refs:** 2.826, 3.333, 4.89, 5.95, 5.193, 20.81,  
21.35, 21.71, 21.127, 22.46,  
23.746. Books 2–5, 20–23.

*See also:* Pandarus, Priam, Laothoe,  
Polydorus, Achilles, Eëtion, Lemnos.

---

**Lycia** (Λυκία) · PLACE — Say: LISH-uh or  
LIS-ee-uh

The homeland of Sarpedon and Glaucus,  
the farthest of Troy’s allies — “from far  
Lycia, from the eddying Xanthus”  
(2.877). Sarpedon names it as what he  
has left:

his wife, his little son, and great wealth  
(5.480–481). It is also where  
Bellerophon was sent with the folded  
tablet, and where the king gave him his  
daughter and the best of the land



(6.168–195); and Glaucus’s account of the estate on the banks of Xanthus is the ground of Sarpedon’s argument about why kings must fight in front (12.310–321). Sleep and Death carry Sarpedon’s body back to “the rich country of wide Lycia” for burial (16.683).

**Refs:** 2.877, 5.105, 5.479, 6.168, 6.172, 6.225, 12.312, 12.319, 16.437, 16.673, 16.683. Books 2, 5–6, 12, 16–17.

*See also:* Lycians, Sarpedon, Glaucus, Bellerophon, Hippolochus.

---

**Lycians** (Λύκιοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* LISH-unz  
Troy’s strongest allies, led by Sarpedon and Glaucus, and the only contingent

the  
poem treats as a rival to the Trojans  
themselves. Hector's rallying-cry names  
them  
in their own clause — "Trojans and  
Lycians and Dardanians who fight at  
close  
quarters" (8.173) — and it is they who  
first break through the Achaean wall in  
Book  
12. Sarpedon shames them into the  
assault ("Lycians, why do you slacken  
your rushing  
courage so?", 12.409) and again as he  
dies over his own body; when he is  
killed they  
panic and abandon it, and Glaucus  
rounds on Hector for it in Book 17,  
threatening  
that no Lycian will fight for Troy again.

**Refs:** 2.876, 4.197, 5.633, 5.676, 8.173,  
12.317, 12.409, 16.421, 16.659, 17.146.

Books 2, 4–8, 10–17.

*See also:* Lycia, Sarpedon, Glaucus,  
Trojans, Hector.

---

**Lycomedes** (Λυκομήδης) · MORTAL — Say:

ly-koh-MEE-deez

An Achaean captain of the second rank:  
one of the seven leaders of the night  
watch

in Book 9, left with the lesser Ajax to  
hold the line while Telamonian Ajax  
goes

along the wall (12.366), and one of the  
seven men Achilles sends to fetch

Agamemnon's gifts in Book 19. His one  
killing comes in Book 17: when Aeneas  
spears

his companion Leiocritus, he casts in  
pity and hits Apisaon in the liver below  
the  
midriff.

*Kin:* son of Creon.

**Refs:** 9.84, 12.366, 17.345, 17.346, 19.240.

Books 9, 12, 17, 19.

*See also:* Creon, Ajax son of Oileus,  
Leiocritus, Apisaon.

---

**Lycurgus** (Λυκοῦργος) · MORTAL — Say: ly-  
KUR-gus

Two men, both from stories told inside  
the poem. Diomedes cites the first as  
the  
warning against fighting gods: Dryas'  
son, who chased the nurses of raving  
Dionysus  
down Nysa beating them with an ox-

goad, until Dionysus dived under the  
sea and Thetis  
took him in terror; the gods were  
angered, Zeus struck him blind, and he  
did not live  
long, “hated by all the immortal gods”  
(6.130–140). The second is the Arcadian  
of  
Nestor’s Book 7 reminiscence, who  
killed Areithous the Club-man by craft  
in a narrow  
lane where the iron club was useless,  
and in old age passed the stripped  
armor to his  
aide Ereuthalion.

*Kin:* the first is son of Dryas.

*Kills:* the Arcadian kills Areithous  
(7.142–145).

**Refs:** 6.130, 6.135, 6.139, 7.142, 7.144,  
7.148. Books 6–7.

*See also:* Dryas, Dionysus, Diomedes,  
Areithous, Ereuthalion, Nestor.

---

**Lyrnessus** (Λυρνησσός) · PLACE — Say: lur-  
NES-us

The town Achilles sacked, taking Briseis  
out of it “with great toil” and killing  
Mynes and Epistrophus, the sons of  
Euenus (2.690–693). Achilles wishes in  
Book 19

that Artemis had killed the girl with an  
arrow “on the day I chose her from the  
sack  
of Lyrnessus.” Aeneas names it too, in a  
different register: it was to Lyrnessus he  
fled when Achilles came down on the  
cattle off Ida and chased him, and  
Achilles  
wrecked the town behind him while

Zeus saved the man (20.90–92, 20.191).

**Refs:** 2.690, 2.691, 19.60, 20.92, 20.191.

Books 2, 19–20.

*See also:* Briseis, Achilles, Aeneas, Mynes, Thebe, Pedasus.

---

**Machaon** (Μαχάων) · MORTAL — Say: muh-KAY-on

One of the army's two physicians, son of Asclepius, who leads thirty ships from Tricca with his brother Podaleirius. He is fetched by Talthybius to draw the arrow

from Menelaus's war-belt and sprinkle the soothing drugs Chiron once gave his father

(4.193–219). His own wounding turns the poem: Paris hits him in the right shoulder,

Nestor drives him out of the fighting,  
Achilles sees the pair from his ship's  
stern  
and sends Patroclus to ask who the  
wounded man is — “and that was the  
beginning of  
his evil” (11.504–605). Patroclus finds  
him drinking Hecamede's posset in  
Nestor's  
hut and does not stay; Eurypylus later  
notes that of the two healers one lies  
wounded  
and the other is still on the plain  
(11.833).  
*Kin*: son of Asclepius; brother of  
Podaleirius.  
**Refs:** 2.732, 4.193, 4.200, 4.213, 11.506,  
11.598, 11.651, 11.833, 14.3.  
Books 2, 4, 11, 14.



*See also:* Asclepius, Podaleirius, Nestor,  
Patroclus, Menelaus, Eurypylus, Tricca.

---

**Maeonia** (Μηονία) · PLACE — Say: mee-OH-  
nee-uh

“Lovely Maeonia,” in Asia Minor beside  
Phrygia, named three times and always  
in a

pair with it. Helen taunts Aphrodite by  
asking whether she means to carry her  
off

next to some fine city of Phrygia or  
Maeonia (3.401); the simile for  
Menelaus’s

wound has “some woman of Maeonia or  
Caria” staining ivory with crimson for a  
horse’s

cheek-piece (4.141); and Hector says  
Troy’s heirlooms have been sold off into

Phrygia and Maeonia since Zeus turned his wrath on the city (18.292).

**Refs:** 3.401, 4.141, 18.292. Books 3, 4, 18.

*See also:* Maeonians, Phrygia, Caria.

---

**Maeonians** (Μήονες) · PEOPLE — Say: mee-

OH-nee-unz

A Trojan-side contingent from under Tmolus, led by Mesthles and Antiphus, the two

sons of Talaemenes, “whom the Gygaean lake bore” (2.864–866). Dolon places them in

the night dispositions among the allies quartered toward Thymbre, as “men who fight

from chariots” (10.431).

**Refs:** 2.864, 2.866, 10.431. Books 2, 10.

*See also:* Maeonia, Mesthles, Antiphus,  
Dolon.

---

**Mecisteus** (Μηκιστεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:*  
muh-SIS-tyoos  
Three men. The first belongs to the  
Theban generation: Talaus' son, father  
of  
Euryalus, and the man who went to  
Thebes for the burial of fallen Oedipus  
and beat  
all the sons of Cadmus at the games  
there (23.678–680) — a father's exploit  
of the  
kind Agamemnon uses to shame the  
sons. The second is Echius' son, a  
rescuer rather  
than a fighter: twice, in identical lines,  
he and Alastor stoop under a wounded

Ajax

or Hypsenor and carry him groaning to the ships (8.333 = 13.422). A third

Mecisteus

is killed by Polydamas in the rout at the ships (15.339).

*Kin*: the first is son of Talaus and father of Euryalus; the second is son of Echius.

*Killed by*: the third by Polydamas (15.339).

**Refs**: 2.566, 6.27, 8.333, 13.422, 15.339, 23.678. Books 2, 6, 8, 13, 15, 23.

*See also*: Euryalus, Talaus, Echius, Alastor, Polydamas, Oedipus.

---

**Medon** (Μέδων) · MORTAL — *Say*: MEE-don

The lesser Ajax's bastard half-brother, whom Rhene bore to Oïleus; he

commands

Philoctetes' abandoned contingent in  
the Catalogue and the Phthians in Book  
13.

His biography is given twice in the same  
four lines: he lived in Phylace, far from  
his own country, having killed a  
kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis  
(13.694–697 =

15.333–336). The second telling is his  
obituary — Aeneas strips the life from  
him

and Iasus together at 15.332. A Trojan-  
side Medon is named among the allied  
captains

Hector rouses at 17.216.

*Kin:* son of Oïleus and Rhene; half-  
brother of Ajax son of Oïleus.

*Killed by:* Aeneas (15.332).

**Refs:** 2.727, 13.693, 13.694, 15.332,

15.333, 17.216. Books 2, 13, 15, 17.

*See also:* Ajax son of Oïleus, Oïleus,  
Philoctetes, Aeneas, Phylace, Podarces.

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**Meges** (Μέγης) · MORTAL — Say: MEE-jeez  
Leader of the forty ships from  
Dulichium and the Echinae, son of the  
horseman  
Phyleus who had moved there in anger  
at his own father. He kills Antenor's  
bastard  
son Pedaeus in Book 5, and in Book 13 is  
named among the leaders of the  
Epeians.  
His long scene is Book 15: he kills  
Croesmus, and while he strips him  
Dolops son of  
Lampus drives a spear into his shield —  
the corslet Phyleus had brought home

from

Ephyra as a guest-gift saves him — and  
he shears the plume clean off Dolops's  
helmet

before Menelaus comes to his rescue.

He is one of the seven who fetch

Agamemnon's

gifts in Book 19.

*Epithets:* “the equal of Ares” (ἀτάλαντος  
Ἄρηϊ, 2.627).

*Also called:* Phyleus' son.

*Kin:* son of Phyleus.

**Refs:** 2.627, 5.69, 13.692, 15.302, 15.520,  
15.535, 19.239. Books 2, 5, 13, 15, 19.

*See also:* Phyleus, Dolops, Pedaeus,  
Croesmus, Menelaus, Dulichium.

---

**Melanippus** (Μελάνιππος) · MORTAL — *Say:*  
mel-uh-NIP-us

Four men bear the name. The one the poem develops is Hicetaon's son, a cousin of Hector's: he had been herding cattle in Percote until the Danaan ships came, and then lived in Priam's house and was honored like his own children. Hector rebukes him over Dolops's body and he follows; Menelaus sets Antilochus on him, and Antilochus hits him in the chest by the nipple and springs on him like a hound on a hit fawn, only to be driven off by Hector (15.546–585). The others are a Trojan Teucer kills at 8.276, one of Patroclus's victims in the roll-call at 16.695, and an Achaean among the men Achilles sends for Agamemnon's gifts (19.240).



*Kin:* the Trojan is son of Hicetaon.

*Killed by:* Hicetaon's son by Antilochus  
(15.576–578).

**Refs:** 8.276, 15.547, 15.553, 15.576,  
15.582, 16.695, 19.240. Books 8, 15, 16,  
19.

*See also:* Hicetaon, Antilochus, Hector,  
Dolops, Menelaus, Teucer.

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**Meleager** (Μελέαγρος) · MORTAL — *Say:*  
mel-ee-AY-jur

Phoenix's exemplum in the embassy,  
and the poem's model for Achilles' own  
case.

Oeneus' son, dead before the Catalogue  
is spoken (2.642), he killed the boar  
Artemis

sent against Calydon and then, in anger  
at his mother Althaea's curses,

withdrew  
from the fighting and lay beside his  
wife Cleopatra while the Curetes  
stormed the  
walls. Elders, priests, his father, his  
sisters and his mother all begged him  
and he  
refused the more; only when the towers  
were under bombardment and the city  
burning  
did his wife's plea move him, and he  
went out — and got none of the gifts he  
had  
been offered. Phoenix's point is the  
moral: come out while the gifts are still  
on  
the table.

*Kin:* son of Oeneus and Althaea; husband  
of Cleopatra.

**Refs:** 2.642, 9.543, 9.550, 9.553, 9.565,

9.590. Books 2, 9.

*See also:* Phoenix, Oeneus, Althaea,  
Cleopatra, Calydon, Curetes, Artemis.

---

**Menelaus** (Μενέλαος) · MORTAL — Say:

men-uh-LAY-us

Agamemnon's brother and Helen's  
husband, the man the war is nominally  
for, and the

one Achaean whose motive is personal.

He volunteers unbidden for the muster  
(2.408),

takes the duel with Paris in Book 3 and  
all but wins it — the spear through the  
shield, the sword shattering on the  
helmet-ridge, the chin-strap strangling  
Paris

until Aphrodite breaks it and carries the  
man off — and is then shot by Pandarus

in  
the broken truce, the arrow steered by  
Athena into the buckles of his war-belt  
(4.127–140). The poem's word for him is  
restraint verging on softness:  
Agamemnon  
overrules his mercy to the suppliant  
Adrestus and does the killing himself  
(6.51–65), the army fears for him when  
he offers to fight Hector (7.104–109). His  
full measure comes in Book 17, where  
he  
stands over Patroclus's body, kills  
Euphorbus for it, and, when at last he  
must  
leave it to the Ajaxes, goes off to find  
Antilochus so someone can carry the  
news to  
Achilles. In Book 23 he charges  
Antilochus with fouling him in the

chariot-race and  
then, satisfied by an apology, gives the  
mare back.

*Epithets:* “dear to Ares” (ἀρηϊφίλος,  
3.21); “tawny-haired” (ξανθός, 3.284);  
“good

at the war-cry” (βοὴν ἀγαθός, 2.408).

*Also called:* Atreus’ son — but “Atreus’  
son” in the singular means Agamemnon  
unless the scene is Menelaus’s; see  
canon.md.

*Kin:* son of Atreus; brother of  
Agamemnon; husband of Helen.

*Kills:* Peisander (13.601–642), Euphorbus  
(17.45–60), Podes (17.578–581).

**Refs:** 1.159, 2.408, 3.21, 3.339, 4.128, 6.37,  
7.94, 13.601, 17.1, 17.60,  
23.566 ...and throughout. Books 1–8, 10–  
11, 13, 15–17, 23.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Helen, Paris,

Atreus, Antilochus, Euphorbus,  
Patroclus, Ajax.

---

**Menestheus** (Μενεσθεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:*

muh-NES-thyoos

The Athenian leader, of Erechtheus' city,  
with fifty ships: “no man on the face of  
the earth was his equal at marshaling  
horses and shield-bearing men —

Nestor alone

rivaled him, for he was older” (2.553–  
555). The praise is not borne out in  
action.

His scene is Book 12, where Sarpedon's  
Lycians come at his stretch of wall and  
he

peers along it for help, unable to make  
himself heard over the din, until

Thootes

fetches Telamonian Ajax and Teucer to  
his tower. He and Stichius carry  
Amphimachus's  
body back in Book 13; his trusted  
companion Arcesilaus is killed by  
Hector at 15.331.

*Also called:* Peteos' son.

*Kin:* son of Peteos.

**Refs:** 2.552, 4.327, 12.331, 12.373, 13.195,  
13.690, 15.331. Books 2, 4, 12, 13, 15.

*See also:* Peteos, Athenians, Ajax, Teucer,  
Sarpedon, Stichius.

---

**Menoetius** (Μενόιτιος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

muh-NEE-tee-us

Patroclus' father, Actor's son, of Opoeis:  
he brought his son as a small boy to  
Peleus' house after a killing over a game  
of dice, and Peleus raised the two

children together (23.85–90). He is alive in Phthia through the poem — Achilles asks whether Patroclus has news that he or Peleus has died (16.14) — but he never appears, and in nearly all of the name’s 38 occurrences it is the patronymic “Menoetius’ son” or “Menoetius’s stout son,” meaning Patroclus. Nestor quotes the charge he gave at parting: you are the elder, so advise Achilles well, he will listen (11.785–789). Achilles’ reproach to himself in Book 18 is that he promised to bring the man’s far-famed son back to Opoeis with his share of the spoils.

*Kin:* son of Actor; father of Patroclus.

**Refs:** 1.307, 9.202, 11.605, 11.765, 11.785,



16.14, 18.12, 18.325, 21.28, 23.85,  
24.16 ...and throughout. Books 1, 9, 11–  
12, 16–19, 21, 23–24.  
*See also:* Patroclus, Achilles, Peleus,  
Actor, Opoeis, Nestor.

---

**Meriones** (Μηριόνης) · MORTAL — *Say:*  
muh-RY-oh-neeZ  
Idomeneus's aide and second in  
command of the Cretans, and one of the  
poem's most  
consistently competent fighters. Their  
exchange outside the huts in Book 13 —  
he has  
come back for a spear, having shattered  
his on Deiphobus's shield, and  
Idomeneus  
offers him twenty Trojan spears taken  
from the men he has killed — is the

poem's  
fullest picture of two veterans talking  
shop. He wounds Deiphobus in the arm,  
shoots  
Harpalion through the buttock into the  
bladder as he retreats, kills the priest  
Laogonus in Book 16 and trades taunts  
with Aeneas over a missed cast. He is  
Odysseus's  
armorer for the night raid, lending the  
boar's-tusk helmet whose four-  
generation  
provenance the poem tracks (10.260–  
271). In Book 23 he drives the slowest  
horses and  
finishes fourth, then wins the archery:  
Teucer, who did not vow to Apollo, cuts  
only  
the cord; Meriones snatches the bow,  
vows the hecatomb, and shoots the

dove through

under the wing high under the clouds.

*Epithets:* “the equal of Enyalios, slayer of men” (ἀτάλαντος Ἐνυαλίῳ, 2.651).

*Kin:* son of Molus.

**Refs:** 2.651, 10.260, 13.249, 13.528, 13.650, 16.603, 17.717, 23.528, 23.870.

Books 2, 4–5, 7–10, 13–17, 19, 23.

*See also:* Idomeneus, Molus, Cretans, Deiphobus, Teucer, Odysseus, Harpalion.

---

**Molus** (Μῶλος) · MORTAL — *Say:* MOH-lus

Meriones’ father, named only in the patronymic and in the pedigree of the boar’s-tusk

helmet: Amphidamas of Cythera gave it to Molus as a guest-gift, and Molus gave it to

his son Meriones to wear — the third of  
four hands it passes through before it is  
set

on Odysseus's head for the night raid.

*Kin:* father of Meriones.

**Refs:** 10.269, 10.270, 13.249. Books 10, 13.

*See also:* Meriones, Amphidamas,  
Odysseus, Idomeneus.

---

**Mulius** (Μούλιος) · MORTAL — *Say:* MYOO-  
lee-us

Three men, all killed. The first is the  
Epeian of Nestor's Book 11

reminiscence,

Augeias' son-in-law, husband of his  
eldest daughter Agamede "who knew as  
many drugs

as the wide earth grows" — the first  
man Nestor ever killed, and he took his

whole-hoofed horses. The second is one of Patroclus's victims in the roll-call at 16.696. The third is a Trojan Achilles spears through the ear in Book 20, the bronze point passing out through the other ear. *Kin*: the Epeian is son-in-law of Augeias and husband of Agamede. *Killed by*: the Epeian by Nestor (11.742); the second by Patroclus (16.696); the third by Achilles (20.472–473). **Refs:** 11.739, 16.696, 20.472. Books 11, 16, 20. *See also*: Nestor, Augeias, Agamede, Patroclus, Achilles.

---

### **Muses** (Μοῦσαι) · GOD

Daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus,  
singers in answer to Apollo's lyre at the

gods'  
feast in Book 1. Their function in the  
poem is to know: the poet invokes them  
before  
the Catalogue because “you are  
goddesses, you are present, you know  
all things, while  
we hear only the report and know  
nothing” (2.484–486), and the same line  
opens the  
three later roll-calls (11.218, 14.508,  
16.112). At 2.761 the singular Muse is  
asked  
who was best of the men and horses.  
Their one action is punitive: they met  
Thamyris  
the Thracian at Dorium, who had  
boasted he would win a singing contest  
against them,  
and maimed him — took away his

wondrous song and made him forget his harping.

*Kin:* daughters of Zeus.

**Refs:** 1.604, 2.484, 2.491, 2.594, 2.598, 2.761, 11.218, 14.508, 16.112.

Books 1, 2, 11, 14, 16.

*See also:* Zeus, Apollo, Thamyras, Olympus.

---

**Mycenae** (Μυκῆναι) · PLACE — Say: my-SEE-nee

Agamemnon's city and the seat of his fleet — “the great fleet that followed you from

Mycenae” (9.44) — and, in the formula, “Mycenae rich in gold” (7.180 = 11.46).

Hera

names it third of the cities dearest to her, with Argos and Sparta, and offers

all

three to be sacked whenever they grow  
hateful to Zeus, if Troy may fall (4.52–  
53).

Tydeus came there once as a guest with  
Polyneices, raising troops for Thebes  
(4.376–377). Periphetes, the best man in  
the city, is Hector’s one kill in the rout  
of Book 15.

**Refs:** 2.569, 4.52, 4.376, 7.180, 9.44, 11.46,  
15.638. Books 2, 4, 7, 9, 11, 15.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Argos, Hera,  
Tydeus, Periphetes.

---

**Myrmidons** (Μυρμιδόνες) · PEOPLE — Say:

MUR-mih-donz

Achilles’ own contingent, fifty ships  
from Phthia and Hellas; the Catalogue  
notes



that the same men “were called  
Myrmidons, and Hellenes, and  
Achaeans” (2.684), which  
makes the last a regional name here and  
not the whole host. They sit out the war  
with their leader — Agamemnon’s  
insult is “go home and be king over  
your Myrmidons”  
(1.180) — until Book 16, when Achilles  
arms them for Patroclus. Their two  
similes  
there are the poem’s harshest: wolves  
that have torn a stag, their muzzles red,  
going down to lap black water; and  
roadside wasps that boys have been  
provoking, who  
come out all at once. They mourn  
Patroclus, drive their chariots three  
times around  
the body, and build Achilles’ hut in the

description that opens the last scene of Book 24.

**Refs:** 1.180, 2.684, 9.185, 16.155, 16.200, 16.266, 18.355, 19.278, 23.6, 24.449.

Books 1–2, 7, 9, 11, 16, 18–19, 21, 23–24.

*See also:* Achilles, Patroclus, Phthia, Hellenes, Achaeans.

---

**Mysians** (Μυσοί) · PEOPLE — *Say:* MIZH-unz

Trojan-side allies, led in the Catalogue by Chromis and Ennomus the bird-reader,

“but his birds did not save him from black doom” (2.858–860). Dolon puts them in the

night dispositions with the Lycians and Phrygians, and Zeus turns his eyes from Troy

in Book 13 to look on “the close-fighting

Mysians” and the Mare-milkers. Ajax wounds  
their leader Hyrtius son of Gyrtius at  
14.512. Their last appearance is as  
gift-givers: the strong-hoofed mules  
Priam yokes for the journey to Achilles  
were  
once a Mysian present to him (24.278).  
**Refs:** 2.858, 10.430, 13.5, 14.512, 24.278.  
Books 2, 10, 13, 14, 24.  
*See also:* Ennomus, Chromis, Hyrtius,  
Priam, Dolon.

---

**Nastes** (Νάστης) · MORTAL — *Say:* NAS-teez  
Captain, with his brother  
Amphimachus, of “the Carians of  
barbarous speech” from  
Miletus and the Maeander — “Nastes  
and Amphimachus, the shining children

of Nomion.”

The Catalogue then says one of the two  
went to war decked in gold like a girl,  
“the  
fool: it did not ward off wretched  
destruction from him,” and was broken  
in the river  
under Achilles, who carried off the gold;  
the text does not say which brother it  
was.

*Kin:* son of Nomion; brother of  
Amphimachus.

**Refs:** 2.867, 2.870, 2.871. Book 2.

*See also:* Amphimachus, Nomion,  
Carians, Achilles.

---

**Neleus** (Νηλεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* NEE-lee-  
us

Nestor’s father and king of Pylos, dead

before the action: in nearly every one of  
its occurrences the name is a  
patronymic, and “Neleus’ son” means  
Nestor. He  
appears in his own right only inside  
Nestor’s Book 11 reminiscence, glad at  
heart  
when his young son drives Eleian  
plunder into Pylos, and afterward  
hiding the  
boy’s horses and forbidding him to arm,  
“for he said I did not yet know the  
works  
of war.” Twelve sons were born to him,  
Nestor says, and Nestor alone was left —  
the might of Heracles had killed the  
rest.  
*Kin:* father of Nestor and eleven other  
sons.  
**Refs:** 2.20, 10.87, 11.683, 11.692, 11.717,

15.378, 23.303, 23.514.

Books 2, 8, 10, 11, 14, 15, 23.

*See also:* Nestor, Pylos, Heracles,  
Antilochus.

---

**Nereids** (Νηρηΐδες) · GOD — Say: NEER-ee-  
idz

Thetis's sisters, the sea-nymphs who  
gather around her in the depths when  
she

wails for Achilles at the opening of Book  
18. The poem names thirty-three of  
them in a four-line catalogue (18.39–49)  
— Glauce, Thaleia, Cymodoce and the  
rest

— and closes it “and the other Nereids  
who were in the depths of the sea.”

They  
fill the silver-shining cave, beat their

breasts, and follow Thetis ashore;

Thetis addresses them as “sister

Nereids” and leads the lament.

*Kin:* daughters of the old man of the sea;

sisters of Thetis.

**Refs:** 18.38, 18.49, 18.52. Book 18.

*See also:* Thetis, Achilles.

---

**Nestor** (Νέστωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* NES-tor

The aged king of Pylos, third-

generation ruler who has outlived two

generations

of mortal men, and the counselor

whose plans set the poem’s machinery

moving. He

tries and fails to compose the quarrel in

Book 1; he proposes the wall and ditch

(7.325–343); he frames the embassy to

Achilles and picks its members (9.162–

172);

he devises the night raid; and it is his suggestion at 11.794–803 — send Patroclus out in Achilles’ armor — that Patroclus carries back and that kills him. His authority is verbal, not martial: he is rescued out of the fighting in Book 8, and at the funeral games Achilles gives him a prize outright because he will not compete, “the hard weight of age is on you now.”

*Epithets:* “the Gerenian horseman Nestor” (Γερήνιος ἱππότα Νέστωρ, 2.336); “the Gerenian, warden of the Achaeans” (Γερήνιος οὗρος Ἀχαιῶν, 8.80); “the clear-voiced speaker” (λιγὺς ἀγορητής, 1.248).  
*Also called:* Neleus’ son.



*Kin*: son of Neleus; father of Antilochus and Thrasymedes.

**Refs:** 1.247, 2.336, 4.293, 7.325, 8.80, 9.162, 10.18, 11.501 ...and throughout.

Books 1–2, 4–11, 13–19, 23.

*See also*: Neleus, Antilochus, Thrasymedes, Patroclus, Pylos, Agamemnon.

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### **Night** (Νύξ) · GOD

Personified, and named once in a story Sleep tells Hera to explain why he will not put Zeus to sleep a second time.

Hunted through the house by a furious Zeus

and about to be flung from the sky into the sea, Sleep ran to Night for refuge, and Zeus checked himself: “he stood in awe of doing what swift Night would

hate.”

The poem gives her no other action; the line is its shortest statement that some things are older than Zeus.

*Epithets:* “Night, subduer of gods and men” (Νύξ δμῆταιρα θεῶν καὶ ἀνδρῶν, 14.259).

**Refs:** 14.259, 14.261. Book 14.

*See also:* Sleep, Zeus, Hera.

---

**Niobe** (Νιόβη) · MORTAL — *Say:* NY-oh-bee  
Achilles’ exemplum in the last book: he  
tells Priam that even Niobe  
remembered  
food, though twelve children died in  
her halls — six daughters and six sons,  
killed by Artemis and Apollo because  
she had matched herself against Leto,  
who

bore only two. The dead lay nine days  
unburied, the people having been  
turned to  
stone by Zeus, and the gods buried  
them on the tenth; and Niobe, worn out  
with  
weeping, ate. She is now stone herself  
on Sipylus, brooding on the griefs the  
gods gave her. The story is the  
argument that persuades Priam to eat.  
*Kin:* mother of six sons and six  
daughters.

**Refs:** 24.602, 24.606, 24.607. Book 24.

*See also:* Achilles, Priam, Leto, Apollo,  
Artemis, Sipylus.

---

**Nireus** (Νιρεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* NY-ryoos  
Leader of three ships from Syme,  
named three times over in three

consecutive

lines of the Catalogue — the poem's  
most conspicuous piece of anaphora —  
as “the

most beautiful man who came under  
Ilion / of all the Danaans, after the  
blameless

son of Peleus.” The compliment is  
immediately withdrawn: “But he was a  
slight

man, and few people followed him.” He  
never appears again.

*Kin:* son of Aglaïa and lord Charopus.

**Refs:** 2.671, 2.672, 2.673. Book 2.

*See also:* Achaeans, Achilles.

---

**Ocean** (Ὠκεανός) · GOD

The stream that encircles the world and  
the god of it. As geography it is where

the sun and stars go down and Dawn rises out (8.485, 19.1), where Zeus goes feasting with the Ethiopians (1.423), and the outermost rim of the Shield of Achilles (18.607); the Bear alone “has no share in the baths of Ocean.” As a person he is the father from whom, Achilles says, all rivers and seas and springs flow, and who nonetheless fears Zeus’s thunderbolt (21.195–199); with Tethys he is “the begetting of the gods,” and Hera’s pretext for leaving Olympus is that she goes to reconcile their long estrangement.

*Also called:* Oceanus — the spelling the translation uses of the named god in Book 14; “Ocean” elsewhere for the

encircling stream.

*Kin:* consort of Tethys; father of  
Eurynome (18.399) and, as the poem has  
it,  
of all waters.

**Refs:** 1.423, 8.485, 14.201, 14.246, 14.302,  
18.607, 19.1, 21.195.

Books 1, 3, 5, 7, 8, 14, 16, 18–21, 23.

*See also:* Tethys, Hera, Achelous,  
Scamander, Eurynome.

---

**Odius** (Ὀδῖος) · MORTAL — *Say:* OH-dee-us  
Two men. The first leads the Halizones  
with Epistrophus “from far away, from  
Alybe, where silver has its birthplace,”  
and is the first man killed in the  
general fighting of Book 5: Agamemnon  
spears him in the back between the  
shoulders as he turns to run, and drives

the point through his chest. The second is an Achaean herald, sent with Eurybates to accompany the embassy to Achilles.

*Killed by:* Agamemnon (5.38–42).

**Refs:** 2.856, 5.39, 9.170. Books 2, 5, 9.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Epistrophus, Eurybates, Halizones.

---

**Odysseus** (Ὀδυσσεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* oh-

DIS-ee-us *or* oh-DISS-yoos

The Achaeans' tactician, and the man the poem sends whenever a thing must be

managed rather than won by force. He turns the army back from the ships in Book 2

and beats Thersites out of the assembly; he escorts Chryseis home; he speaks

first for the embassy in Book 9 and Nestor charges him “above all” to win Achilles over; he goes out with Diomedes on the night raid and brings back Rhesus’ horses; and in Book 19 he holds Achilles to the army’s need to eat before fighting. Antenor’s account of him at Troy long before the war (3.203–224) is the poem’s fullest portrait of a speaker: a man who stands with his eyes on the ground like a fool until the words come out of him like snowflakes in winter. *Epithets*: “resourceful” (πολύμητις, 1.311); “of many devices” (πολυμήχανος, 2.173); “the equal of Zeus in counsel” (Διὶ μῆτιν ἀτάλαντος, 2.169); “sacker of cities” (πτολίπορθος, 2.278); “much-



enduring brilliant Odysseus” (πολύτλας  
δῖος  
Ὀδυσσεύς, 8.97); “of the many tales”  
(πολύαινος, 9.673); “hardy” (τλήμων,  
10.231); “patient-hearted”  
(ταλασίφρων, 11.466); “of the subtle  
wiles”  
(ποικιλομήτης, 11.482).

*Also called:* Laertes’ son.

*Kin:* son of Laertes; father of Telemachus  
(2.260); of Ithaca.

**Refs:** 1.311, 2.169, 2.244, 3.200, 3.216,  
9.169, 10.243, 11.466 ...and

throughout. Books 1–11, 14, 16, 19, 23.

*See also:* Diomedes, Athena, Thersites,  
Laertes, Nestor, Achilles, Ithaca.

---

**Oeneus** (Οἰνεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* EE-nyoos  
King of Calydon in the generation

before the war, and the root of two of  
the  
poem's houses: Tydeus' father and so  
Diomedes' grandfather, and the father  
of  
Meleager. It was his failure to give  
Artemis a harvest-offering from his  
orchard  
slope — "he forgot, or he did not think  
of it: a great blindness of heart" — that  
loosed the Calydonian boar and set the  
whole Meleager story going; and it is  
Oeneus who begs his son at the  
threshold, one of the suppliants  
Meleager refuses.  
Glaucus and Diomedes discover their  
inherited guest-friendship through  
him:  
Oeneus once entertained Bellerophon  
twenty days and gave him a crimson

war-belt.

*Kin:* son of Portheus, brother of Agrius and Melas (14.115–118); father of Tydeus and Meleager; grandfather of Diomedes.

**Refs:** 2.641, 5.813, 6.216, 6.219, 9.534, 9.543, 9.581, 14.117.

Books 2, 5, 6, 9, 10, 14.

*See also:* Tydeus, Diomedes, Meleager, Bellerophon, Glaucus, Calydon, Portheus.

---

**Oenomaus** (Οἰνόμαος) · MORTAL — *Say:* ee-noh-MAY-us

Two men, one on each side. The first is an Achaean, named in the roll-call of those Hector and Ares strip of their arms in Book 5, between Trechus the Aetolian

and Helenus son of Oenops. The second  
is a Trojan, one of the captains who  
storm

the wall around Asius in Book 12;  
Idomeneus kills him in Book 13 with a  
spear

mid-belly that bursts the corslet-plate  
and spills his bowels, and cannot strip  
the armor for the missiles flying.

*Killed by:* the Achaean by Hector or Ares  
(5.706); the Trojan by Idomeneus  
(13.506–510).

**Refs:** 5.706, 12.140, 13.506. Books 5, 12,  
13.

*See also:* Idomeneus, Asius, Hector.

---

**Olympus** (Ὀλυμπος) · PLACE — Say: oh-  
LIM-pus

The mountain where the gods live, and

by extension the divine household itself

—

the place Thetis goes to petition, Hera  
and Athena start from, and Iris is sent  
down from. Its gates are kept by the  
Seasons, who roll the cloud aside  
(5.749);

Zeus sits apart from the others on its  
topmost peak; and when he bows his  
head he  
shakes the whole of it (1.530). The  
poem's assemblies of the gods are held  
there,  
and it is measured against the world  
below in Zeus's boast that he could  
hang  
earth and sea from a horn of Olympus  
with all the gods pulling (8.25).  
*Epithets*: "snow-capped" (ἄγάννιφος,  
1.420); "shining" (αἰγλήεις, 1.532).

*Also called:* Olympian, of the gods who dwell there.

**Refs:** 1.18, 1.420, 1.499, 1.530, 5.750, 8.3, 8.25, 20.5 ...and throughout.

Books 1–8, 10–16, 18–22, 24.

*See also:* Zeus, Hera, Thetis, Ida, Iris.

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**Opoeis** (Ὀποῦς) · PLACE — Say: oh-POH-is

A town in Locris, named in the Catalogue among the places the Locrians held, and otherwise the home of Menoetius and Patroclus. Patroclus was brought out of it as a small boy, exiled for killing Amfidamas' son in a quarrel over dice, and taken into Peleus' house; and Achilles admits at 18.324–327 that he promised

Menoetius

he would bring the son back to Opoeis  
with his share of the spoils.

**Refs:** 2.531, 18.326, 23.86. Books 2, 18, 23.

*See also:* Patroclus, Menoetius, Locrians,  
Amphidamas, Peleus.

---

**Orestes** (Ὀρέστης) · MORTAL — Say: oh-  
RES-teez

Three men. Agamemnon's son, "my  
late-born boy, reared in high plenty," is  
named

only as the measure of the honor  
promised Achilles in the embassy offer

— a

son-in-law would be honored his equal  
— and the phrase is repeated verbatim  
when

Odysseus relays it. Of the other two, one

is an Achaean stripped of his arms by Hector and Ares in Book 5, “Orestes, driver of horses”; the other a Trojan, in Asius’ storming-party at the wall and killed by Leonteus at 12.193.

*Kin:* Agamemnon’s Orestes is his only son, brother of Chrysothemis, Laodice and Iphianassa.

*Killed by:* the Trojan by Leonteus (12.193).

**Refs:** 5.705, 9.142, 9.284, 12.139, 12.193.

Books 5, 9, 12.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Achilles, Leonteus, Asius.

---

**Orion** (Ὠρίων) · OTHER — *Say:* oh-RY-un

The constellation. Hephaestus sets “the strength of Orion” on the Shield among



the Pleiades, the Hyades and the Bear —  
the Bear “who turns in her own place,  
keeping watch on Orion, / and alone  
has no share in the baths of Ocean.” His  
name

returns in Book 22 for the star Achilles  
is compared to as Priam watches him  
cross the plain: “the star men call by  
name the Dog of Orion,” brightest of all,  
and an evil sign that brings fever on  
wretched mortals.

**Refs:** 18.486, 18.488, 22.29. Books 18, 22.

*See also:* Achilles, Ocean, Hephaestus.

---

**Othryoneus** (Ὀθρυονεύς) · MORTAL — Say:  
oth-ry-OH-nyoos

A newcomer to Troy from Cabeus,  
“lately come, chasing the report of the  
war,”

who asked Priam for Cassandra without  
bride-gifts and promised in exchange to  
drive the Achaeans out of the land;  
Priam bowed his head to it, and  
Othryoneus  
fought trusting the promise. Idomeneus  
spears him in mid-stride through the  
belly  
and then jeers over the corpse, offering  
him instead the loveliest of  
Agamemnon's  
daughters — “you will find we are not  
hard men over bride-terms” — while  
dragging  
him off by the foot. Deiphobus names  
him among the lost Trojan leaders at  
13.772.

*Killed by:* Idomeneus (13.370–383).

**Refs:** 13.363, 13.369, 13.374, 13.772. Book  
13.

*See also:* Idomeneus, Cassandra, Priam,  
Asius, Deiphobus.

---

**Otrynteus** (Ὀτρυντεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:*

oh-TRIN-tyoos

Father of Iphition, the first man Achilles  
kills on his return to the fighting.

He is a “sacker of cities” whose estate  
lay by the Gygaean lake in the rich  
district of Hyde, under snowy Tmolus,  
and a naiad nymph bore him the son.

He does

not appear himself; Achilles names him  
twice standing over the split skull —

“Lie there, son of Otrynteus — most  
terrifying of all men!”

*Kin:* father of Iphition, by a naiad  
nymph.

**Refs:** 20.383, 20.384, 20.389. Book 20.

*See also:* Iphition, Achilles, Hyde.

---

**Oïleus** (Ὀϊλεύς) · MORTAL — Say: oh-EYE-lyoos

Two men. The first is the father of the lesser Ajax, whose name is the standing way of distinguishing him from

Telamon's son — “swift Ajax, Oïleus' son” — and

also the father, by Rhene, of the bastard Medon, who lives in exile at Phylace for killing a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis. He is called “sacker of cities”

at 2.728 and never appears in the action. The second is a Trojan

charioteer,

“Oïleus, lasher of horses,” who leaps down from his car to face Agamemnon

and is

killed at once (11.93).

*Kin:* father of Ajax son of Oïleus and, by Rhene, of Medon; husband of Eriopis.

*Killed by:* the charioteer by Agamemnon (11.93–95).

**Refs:** 2.527, 2.727, 2.728, 11.93, 13.694, 13.712, 14.442, 15.333, 23.754.

Books 2, 11–17, 23.

*See also:* Ajax son of Oïleus, Medon, Ajax, Locrians, Agamemnon.

---

**Paeonians** (Παίονες) · PEOPLE — Say: pee-OH-nee-unz

Trojan-side allies from Amydon on the Axios, “Axius, whose water spreads fairest over the earth,” led at first by Pyraechmes and later by Asteropaeus.

Patroclus

kills Pyraechmes and panics them; and  
in Book 21 Achilles, having killed  
Asteropaeus, hunts them down the  
river — Thersilochus, Mydon,  
Astypylus, Mnesus,  
Thrasius, Aenius, Ophelestes — and  
would have killed more had the river  
not

called out to him in anger.

*Epithets:* “the Paeonians of the curved  
bows” (2.848); “the chariot-fighting  
Paeonians” (ἵπποκορυσταί, 21.205).

*Kin:* led by Pyraechmes, then by  
Asteropaeus, son of Pelegon.

**Refs:** 2.848, 10.428, 16.287, 16.291,  
21.205, 21.211. Books 2, 10, 16, 21.

*See also:* Pyraechmes, Asteropaeus,  
Axius, Pelegon, Amydon.

**Paiëon** (Παιήων) · GOD — Say: pay-EE-on

The gods' physician, kept distinct from Apollo. He appears twice, in the same two

lines both times: he “sprinkled pain-killing drugs upon the wound / and healed

him: for he was not of mortal make” — first of Hades, shot at Pylos by Heracles, and then of Ares, when Zeus has finished telling him he is the most hateful of

the gods and orders him healed.

**Refs:** 5.401, 5.899, 5.900. Book 5.

*See also:* Ares, Hades, Zeus, Heracles, Apollo.

---

**Pandarus** (Πάνδαρος) · MORTAL — Say:

PAN-duh-rus

The Lycian archer from Zeleia “to  
whom Apollo himself gave the bow,”  
and the man  
whose shot breaks the truce. Athena, in  
the likeness of Laodocus, persuades him  
to shoot Menelaus during the sworn  
oath; the arrow is deflected by Athena  
herself  
and only grazes, but the oath is broken  
and the war resumes. In Book 5 Aeneas  
finds him and they charge Diomedes  
together: his spear-cast fails and  
Diomedes’  
answering throw, steered by Athena,  
goes in beside the nose and cuts his  
tongue  
off at the root.

*Also called:* Lycaon’s son — this Lycaon is  
his father, not Priam’s son of the  
same name; see `canon.md`.



*Kin:* son of Lycaon.

*Killed by:* Diomedes (5.290–296).

**Refs:** 2.827, 4.88, 5.168, 5.171, 5.246, 5.795. Books 2, 4, 5.

*See also:* Diomedes, Aeneas, Athena, Menelaus, Lycaon, Zeleia.

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### **Panic** (Φόβος) · GOD

Rout personified, and one of the attendants of Ares — “Panic, his dear son,  
strong and fearless, / who sends even the patient-hearted warrior running” (13.299). He is paired with Terror in the pair’s first appearance driving the armies on (4.440), is figured with Terror around the Gorgon’s head on Agamemnon’s shield (11.37), and is ordered with

Terror to yoke Ares' horses when Ares  
means to  
avenge Ascalaphus (15.119). The same  
English also renders Φύζα at 9.2, where  
the  
Achaeans are held by “unearthly Panic,  
the companion of icy Rout.”

*Kin:* son of Ares.

**Refs:** 4.440, 9.2, 11.37, 13.299, 15.119.

Books 4, 9, 11, 13, 15.

*See also:* Terror, Ares, Strife, Ascalaphus.

---

**Panthous** (Πάνθοος) · MORTAL — *Say:* PAN-  
thoh-us

A Trojan elder, one of the old men  
sitting with Priam on the wall in Book 3,  
and  
in the rest of the poem a patronymic:  
“Panthous’ son” is Polydamas in most

places, Euphorbus in Book 17, and Hyperenor at 17.24. Menelaus, having killed

Euphorbus, notes that he has now killed three of the line and that Panthous and his wife Phrontis got the arms of none of them; the family is called “the pride of

the sons of Panthous with their good ash spears.”

*Kin:* husband of Phrontis; father of Polydamas, Euphorbus and Hyperenor.

**Refs:** 3.146, 14.450, 16.808, 17.9, 17.23, 17.40, 17.59, 18.250.

Books 3, 13–18.

*See also:* Polydamas, Euphorbus, Hyperenor, Menelaus, Priam, Phrontis.

---

**Paphlagonians** (Παφλαγόνες) · PEOPLE —

Say: paf-luh-GOH-nee-unz

Trojan-side allies under Pylaemenes “of  
the shaggy heart,” from the Eneti

“where

the breed of wild mules is born,”

holding Cytorus, Sesamus, Cromna,

Aegialus and

the heights of Erythini around the river

Parthenius. In Book 13 they carry the

body of Harpalion off the field toward

Ilion, his father walking among them in

tears with no blood-price for his son;

Paris, who had been the dead man’s

guest-friend among them, shoots in

anger for him.

*Kin:* led by Pylaemenes.

**Refs:** 2.851, 13.656, 13.661. Books 2, 13.

*See also:* Pylaemenes, Harpalion, Paris.

---

**Paris** (Πάρις) · MORTAL

Priam's son, whose taking of Helen is the cause of the war and who is the least admired man in the poem. He challenges the Achaean champions in Book 3, loses his nerve when Menelaus comes forward, is shamed back by Hector, and is snatched out of the losing duel by Aphrodite and set down in his scented chamber. He refuses in assembly to give Helen back, offering only the goods (7.362–364). His weapon is the bow: he shoots Diomedes through the foot and laughs, cripples Machaon, kills Euchenor, and hits Nestor's horse — and it is Paris, with Apollo, whom the dying Hector names as Achilles' killer to

come. The translation keeps both of his names as the Greek gives them, per the Book 3 policy.

*Epithets:* “godlike” (θεοειδής, 3.16); “brilliant” (δῖος, 7.355); recurrently “the husband of lovely-haired Helen” (3.329, 11.369). Hector’s “Paris — evil Paris” renders Δύσπαρι (3.39).

*Also called:* Alexandros — one man, both names in use; Priam’s son.

*Kin:* son of Priam and Hecuba; brother of Hector, Helenus, Deiphobus and the rest; husband of Helen.

**Refs:** 3.16, 3.39, 3.380, 6.321, 6.503, 7.362, 11.369, 22.359 ...and throughout.

Books 3–8, 11–13, 15, 22, 24.

*See also:* Helen, Hector, Menelaus, Aphrodite, Priam, Achilles.

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**Patroclus** (Πάτροκλος) · MORTAL — Say:

puh-TROH-klus

Achilles' companion, and the hinge of the poem. He is silent through the first half — leading Briseis out of the hut at Achilles' order (1.345), receiving the embassy, sent to Nestor to ask after the wounded Machaon — and it is Nestor's plan

that he take Achilles' armor and go out himself that he brings back in tears.

Achilles grants it with a limit; Patroclus exceeds it, drives the Trojans from the ships, kills Sarpedon, and charges the wall four times. Apollo strikes him from behind, knocks off helmet and corslet, Euphorbus spears him between the

shoulders, and Hector finishes him — his dying words the prophecy of

Hector's own death. His body is fought over through Book 17, his ghost comes to Achilles for burial in Book 23, and his bones are to lie in one jar with Achilles'.

*Epithets:* "Zeus-sprung" (διογενής, 1.337).

*Also called:* Menoetius' son.

*Kin:* son of Menoetius of Opoëis, an exile in Peleus' house from boyhood.

*Kills:* Sarpedon (16.480–491), Pyraechmes, and many others.

*Killed by:* Hector, with Apollo and Euphorbus (16.783–822).

**Refs:** 1.337, 11.602, 16.2, 16.49, 16.480, 16.787, 16.822, 23.65 ...and throughout. Books 1, 8, 9, 11, 15–19, 21–24.

*See also:* Achilles, Menoetius, Hector,



Sarpedon, Euphorbus, Nestor, Opoeis,  
Automedon.

---

**Pedasmus** (Πήδασος) · PLACE — Say: PED-uh-  
sus

Two towns and, in Book 16, a horse. The  
Trojan-side Pedasus is “steep Pedasus  
on

the Satnioeis,” the town of Altes lord of  
the Lelegians, Laothoe’s father;

Agamemnon kills Elatus there in Book 6,  
and Aeneas recalls Achilles sacking it  
with Lyrnessus. A second Pedasus,  
“Pedasus of the vines,” is one of the  
seven

citadels near sandy Pylos that

Agamemnon offers Achilles. The horse  
Pedasus is

Achilles’ trace-horse, taken when he

sacked Eëtion's city, "a horse who,  
mortal  
as he was, kept pace with immortal  
horses"; Sarpedon's cast kills him. A  
man of  
the name, twin of Aesepus, is killed by  
Euryalus at 6.21.

**Refs:** 6.21, 6.35, 9.152, 9.294, 16.152,  
16.467, 20.92, 21.87.

Books 6, 9, 16, 20, 21.

*See also:* Altes, Laothoe, Satnioeis,  
Achilles, Xanthus (horse), Sarpedon.

---

**Peirithous** (Πειρίθοος) · MORTAL — Say: py-  
RITH-oh-us

The Lapith king of the back-story, first  
of the giant men of Nestor's Book 1  
reminiscence — "strongest they grew of  
all men reared on earth" — who fought

and  
destroyed the beast-men of the  
mountains. Zeus names him in Book 14  
among his own  
sons by mortal women, born of Ixion's  
wife. He does not come to Troy: in the  
Catalogue and at the wall the name  
marks his son Polypoetes, born to him  
by  
Hippodameia on the day he drove the  
shaggy beast-men out of Pelion.  
*Kin*: son of Zeus by Ixion's wife; father of  
Polypoetes by Hippodameia.  
**Refs:** 1.263, 2.741, 2.742, 12.129, 12.182,  
14.318. Books 1, 2, 12, 14.  
*See also*: Polypoetes, Nestor, Lapiths,  
Zeus, Leonteus.

---

**Peiroos** (Πείροος) · MORTAL — Say: PY-roh-  
os

Leader of the Thracians with Acamas in  
the Catalogue, son of Imbrasus, come  
from

Aenus. In the closing exchange of Book  
4 he kills Diores with a jagged stone that  
crushes both tendons and the bones of  
his shin, then runs up and spears him  
beside the navel; and as he springs back  
Thoas the Aetolian catches him in the  
chest above the nipple, wrenches the  
spear out, and finishes him with the  
sword.

The Thracians save the body; the two  
dead men are left stretched beside each  
other. His son Rhigmus is killed by  
Achilles at 20.485, where the printed  
text  
spells the father “Peiros.”

*Kin:* son of Imbrasus; father of Rhigmus.

*Kills:* Diores (4.517–526). *Killed by:* Thoas (4.527–531).

**Refs:** 2.844, 4.520, 4.525, 4.527. Books 2, 4.

*See also:* Diores, Thoas, Acamas, Thracians, Rhigmus.

---

**Peisander** (Πείσανδρος) · MORTAL — *Say:*  
py-SAN-der

Three men. The first is a son of Antimachus — the man who took Paris' gold and argued against giving Helen back — caught with his brother Hippolochus in a bolting chariot; the two beg Agamemnon for ransom, and he kills them both for

their father's counsel, spearing  
Peisander in the chest. The second is a  
Trojan  
who comes at Menelaus in Book 13,  
breaks his spear on the shield, pulls a  
bronze  
axe from under it, and is struck at the  
base of the nose so that his eyeballs  
drop in the dust at his feet. The third is  
a Myrmidon captain, Maemalus' son,  
best of them all with the spear after  
Patroclus.

*Kin:* the first is Antimachus' son and  
Hippolochus' brother; the Myrmidon is  
Maemalus' son.

*Killed by:* Agamemnon (11.143–144); the  
Trojan by Menelaus (13.615–618).

**Refs:** 11.122, 11.143, 13.601, 13.606,  
13.611, 13.614, 16.193.

Books 11, 13, 16.

*See also:* Antimachus, Hippolochus,  
Agamemnon, Menelaus, Patroclus.

---

**Pelasgians** (Πελασγοί) · PEOPLE — Say: puh-LAZ-jee-unz

Trojan-side allies, “the tribes of the  
Pelasgian spearmen” from deep-soiled  
Larisa, led in the Catalogue by  
Hippothous and Pylaeus, the two sons  
of Lethus

son of Teutamus; Dolon places them  
among the allies camped toward the  
sea. In

Book 17 Hippothous is killed dragging  
Patroclus’ body by the foot. The name is  
also used adjectivally of things not this  
people: “Pelasgian Argos” is Achilles’  
Thessalian country (2.681), and Achilles  
prays to “Zeus — lord — Dodonaean —

Pelasgian” (16.233).

*Kin:* led by Hippothous and Pylaeus,  
sons of Lethus.

**Refs:** 2.681, 2.840, 2.843, 10.429, 16.233,  
17.288. Books 2, 10, 16, 17.

*See also:* Hippothous, Lethus, Larisa,  
Dodona, Dolon.

---

**Pelegon** (Πηλεγών) · MORTAL — *Say:* PEL-  
uh-gon

Father of Asteropaeus, and the link  
between the Paeonian contingent and  
the river

Axius: the river begot him on Periboea,  
eldest daughter of Acessamenus. He  
does

not appear; Asteropaeus gives the  
descent himself when Achilles asks who  
he is,



in the exchange before the duel in the river — “he fathered Pelegon, famed with the spear; and of Pelegon / they say I was born.”

*Kin:* son of the river Axius and Periboea; father of Asteropaeus.

**Refs:** 21.141, 21.152, 21.159. Book 21.

*See also:* Asteropaeus, Axius, Paeonians, Achilles, Periboea.

---

**Peleus** (Πηλεύς) · MORTAL — Say: PEE-lee-us

Achilles’ father, king of the Myrmidons, and in the great majority of its 146 occurrences a patronymic: “Peleus’ son” is Achilles, and the name’s work in the poem is to keep saying whose son he is,

beginning with the first line. Peleus himself stays in Phthia. He is present as a voice in other men's memories — Odysseus and Phoenix and Nestor all quote his parting charge, “always to be the best, and to hold his head above all others” (11.784) — and as an argument: he took Patroclus in as an exiled boy and raised him; his marriage to Thetis is the gift the gods gave and the wound they left; and Achilles' surrender of Hector's body is won when Priam makes him think of his own father, old and alone with one son doomed out of season.

*Epithets:* “the old horseman Peleus” (7.125).

*Also called:* Aeacus' son — the fixed

rendering of the bare patronymic for Peleus, as “Aeacus’ grandson” is Achilles; see *canon.md*.

*Kin*: son of Aeacus; husband of Thetis; father of Achilles; foster-father of Patroclus.

**Refs:** 1.1, 9.252, 9.438, 11.769, 11.783, 16.33, 18.84, 24.534 ...and throughout. Books 1, 2, 7–11, 13, 15–24. *See also*: Achilles, Thetis, Aeacus, Patroclus, Phoenix, Phthia, Priam.

---

**Pelion** (Πήλιον) · PLACE — *Say*: PEE-lee-on  
The Thessalian mountain, home country of the Magnetes and the place from which Peirithous drove the beast-men to the Aethices. Its use in the poem is chiefly adjectival: “the Pelian ash that Chiron

gave his dear father / from the peak of  
Pelion, to be death for heroes” is  
Achilles’ spear, the one weapon  
Patroclus  
cannot take because no other Achaean  
can swing it. Achilles takes it out of its  
case in Book 19 and carries it against  
Aeneas, Asteropaeus and Hector.

**Refs:** 2.744, 2.757, 16.143, 16.144, 19.390,  
19.391, 20.277, 21.162, 22.133.

Books 2, 16, 19–22.

*See also:* Achilles, Chiron, Peleus,  
Peirithous, Peneius, Magnetes.

---

**Peneius** (Πηνειός) · PLACE — Say: puh-NEE-  
us

A Thessalian river of the Catalogue,  
named for the marvel at its confluence:  
the

Titaressus pours its water into Peneius  
but does not mingle with his silver  
eddies, and “flows along on top of him  
like oil,” being a branch broken off the  
water of Styx, the dread oath. The  
Magnetes under Prothoos dwell around  
Peneius  
and Pelion.

**Refs:** 2.752, 2.753, 2.757. Book 2.

*See also:* Titaressus, Styx, Pelion,  
Prothoos, Magnetes.

---

**Peneleos** (Πηνέλεως) · MORTAL — *Say:* puh-  
NEL-ee-os

One of the five Boeotian leaders of the  
Catalogue, and a steady presence in the  
fighting at the ships. His killing of  
Ilioneus in Book 14 is the poem’s most  
gruesome vaunt: he spears him through

the eye-socket and out the nape, hews  
the  
head off with the sword, and holds it up  
on the spear-point “like a poppy-head”  
to show the Trojans. He kills Lycon in  
Book 16 with a sword-stroke to the neck  
that leaves the head hanging by skin,  
and in Book 17 he is wounded in the  
shoulder by Polydamas’ spear and leads  
the rout.

*Kills:* Ilioneus (14.493–500); Lycon  
(16.339–341).

**Refs:** 2.494, 13.92, 14.487, 14.489, 14.496,  
16.335, 16.339, 17.597.

Books 2, 13, 14, 16, 17.

*See also:* Boeotians, Leïtus, Ilioneus,  
Lycon, Polydamas.

---

**Percote** (Περκώτη) · PLACE — Say: pur-

KOH-tee

A town on the Asian side of the  
Hellespont, on the Trojan side of the  
war. Merops

of Percote, “who beyond all men knew  
the seer’s art,” foresaw the deaths of his  
sons Adrestus and Amphius and could  
not keep them from the war; the poem  
repeats

his lines verbatim when Diomedes and  
Odysseus kill the pair at 11.329–332.

Asius

son of Hyrtacus left his ships there and  
came the rest of the way to Ilion on  
foot; Odysseus kills Pidytes of Percote in  
Book 6; and Melanippus herded cattle  
there until the Achaean ships came.

**Refs:** 2.831, 2.835, 6.30, 11.229, 11.329,  
15.548. Books 2, 6, 11, 15.

*See also:* Merops, Adrestus, Amphius,  
Asius, Melanippus, Hellespont.

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**Pergamos** (Πέργαμος) · PLACE — *Say:* PUR-  
guh-mos

Troy's citadel, the high ground inside  
the city, and Apollo's station. He looks  
down from it to shout the Trojans back  
into the fight at 4.508, sets the wounded  
Aeneas down "in holy Pergamos, where  
his own temple stood" to be healed by  
Leto

and Artemis while a phantom of him  
fights on below, and sits on its height to  
send Ares after Diomedes. Paris comes  
down "from the height of Pergamos,  
blazing  
in his armor like the beaming sun" to  
rejoin Hector at 6.513.



**Refs:** 4.508, 5.446, 5.460, 6.513, 7.21.

Books 4–7.

*See also:* Troy, Apollo, Aeneas, Paris.

---

**Periphas** (Περίφας) · MORTAL — Say: PER-ih-fas

Two men. The first is “gigantic Periphas, far the best of the Aetolians, Ochesius’ shining son,” killed by Ares in Book 5; Ares is stripping the body when he sees Diomedes coming and leaves it lying where it fell. The second is a Trojan herald, Epytus’ son, who had grown grey in his heraldry at his old father’s side, “his heart a well of kindly counsel”; Apollo takes his shape to stir Aeneas at 17.324.

*Kin:* the Aetolian is Ochesius' son; the herald is Epytus' son.

*Killed by:* the Aetolian by Ares (5.842–848).

**Refs:** 5.842, 5.847, 17.324. Books 5, 17.

*See also:* Ares, Diomedes, Aeneas, Apollo.

---

**Peteos** (Πετεώς) · MORTAL — Say: PEE-tee-os

Father of Menestheus, the Athenian leader, and himself Zeus-nurtured. He does not appear: in every occurrence the name is a patronymic marking his son — in the Catalogue, in Agamemnon's tour of the ranks where Menestheus is rebuked for hanging back, at the wall where "Menestheus, Peteos' son, shuddered to see them"

and sent Thootes for help, and in the muster of the Athenians in Book 13.

*Kin:* father of Menestheus.

**Refs:** 2.552, 4.327, 4.338, 12.331, 12.355, 13.690. Books 2, 4, 12, 13.

*See also:* Menestheus, Athenians.

---

**Phaenops** (Φαίνοψ) · MORTAL — *Say:* FEE-nops

The name of more than one Trojan father, and each time the poem uses it to weigh a death. Xanthus and Thoon, “both late-born and beloved,” are killed together by Diomedes, leaving their father “worn with hard age” no other son, so that kinsmen of the widowed house divide the estate;

Phorcys, Phaenops' son, is killed by  
Telamonian Ajax over Hippothous'  
body. A third Phaenops is Asius' son of  
Abydos,

Hector's dearest guest-friend, whose  
likeness Apollo borrows at 17.583 to  
shame

Hector for flinching from Menelaus.

*Kin:* father of Xanthus and Thoon  
(5.152); father of Phorcys (17.312); the  
guest-friend is Asius' son.

**Refs:** 5.152, 17.312, 17.583. Books 5, 17.

*See also:* Xanthus (horse), Phorcys, Asius,  
Abydos, Apollo, Hector.

---

**Phocians** (Φωκῆες) · PEOPLE — Say: FOH-  
shunz

A Catalogue contingent of forty ships  
from Cyparissus, Pytho, Crisa, Daulis,

Panopeus and the towns along the  
Cephisus, led by Schedius and  
Epistrophus, sons  
of Iphitus; they arm on the left, next to  
the Boeotians. Both their named  
casualties are called captains of the  
Phocians: Schedius son of Perimedes,  
killed  
by Hector at the ships, and Schedius son  
of Iphitus, “far the best of the  
Phocians,” killed by Hector’s cast in  
Book 17.

*Kin:* led by Schedius and Epistrophus,  
Iphitus’ sons.

**Refs:** 2.517, 15.516, 17.307. Books 2, 15,  
17.

*See also:* Schedius, Epistrophus,  
Panopeus, Boeotians, Achaeans.

---

**Phoenix** (Φοῖνιξ) · MORTAL — Say: FEE-niks  
Achilles' old tutor, sent from Phthia by  
Peleus with the boy to teach him “to be  
a speaker of words, and a doer of  
deeds”; he had fled his own father  
Amyntor's  
house and been received by Peleus, who  
made him lord of the Dolopes at the  
edge  
of Phthia. Agamemnon names him first  
of the embassy, and his is its longest  
and  
central speech — the story of his own  
exile, the allegory of the Prayers  
limping  
after Blindness, and the tale of  
Meleager. Achilles refuses the honor but  
keeps  
him to sleep in the hut and sail home  
with him. Later he leads the fourth

Myrmidon company, is among those who try to comfort Achilles in Book 19, and serves as umpire at the turn-post in the chariot race. Athena takes his likeness to rouse Menelaus over Patroclus' body (17.555).

*Kin*: son of Amyntor; foster-father of Achilles; called "his own father's follower," i.e. Peleus' (23.360). The "far-famed Phoenix" whose daughter Zeus loved (14.321) is a different figure, the Phoenician eponym.

**Refs:** 9.168, 9.432, 9.607, 9.621, 16.196, 17.555, 19.311, 23.360. Books 9, 14, 16, 17, 19, 23.

*See also:* Achilles, Peleus, Phthia, Meleager, Dolopes, Menelaus.

---

**Phrygia** (Φρυγία) · PLACE — Say: FRIJ-ee-uh

A land inland from Troy, allied to it and  
tied to Priam's house. Priam recalls  
going there as an ally in his youth —  
“Phrygia of the vines,” the hosts of  
Otreus  
and Mygdon camped along the  
Sangarius, on the day the Amazons  
came — and Hecuba's  
brother Asius, Dymas' son, lives there  
on the streams of Sangarius. Paris offers  
Helen no woman as lovely “in the cities  
of Phrygia or lovely Maeonia”; Hector  
says  
Troy's heirlooms have been sold off to  
Phrygia and Maeonia; and Achilles  
counts  
Phrygia inland among the bounds of  
Priam's old prosperity.

**Refs:** 3.184, 3.401, 16.719, 18.291, 24.545.



Books 3, 16, 18, 24.

*See also:* Phrygians, Sangarius, Priam,  
Hecuba, Maeonia, Amazons.

---

**Phthia** (Φθίη) · PLACE — *Say:* FTHY-uh or  
THY-uh

Achilles' homeland in Thessaly, Peleus' kingdom and the Myrmidons' country, called "deep-soiled Phthia, feeder of men" and "mother of flocks." It is the poem's standing image of the alternative to Troy: Achilles threatens in Book 1 to sail home to it, and in Book 9 sets out the choice plainly — three days' sail and a long life without fame, or death here with imperishable fame. Phoenix and Patroclus were both received there by Peleus, and both the embassy and the

funeral looking-back turn on the day  
the two of them were sent out of Phthia  
to

Agamemnon.

**Refs:** 1.155, 1.169, 2.683, 9.363, 9.439,  
9.479, 11.766, 19.330. Books 1, 2,  
9, 11, 16, 19.

*See also:* Achilles, Peleus, Myrmidons,  
Hellas, Phoenix, Patroclus, Phthians.

---

**Phthians** (Φθῖοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* FTHY-unz  
or THY-unz

Men of Phthia, named only in the Book  
13 muster of the contingents holding  
Hector  
off the ships, where they stand beside  
the Boeotians with the Ionians, Locrians  
and Epeians. Their leaders there are not  
Achilles' Myrmidons but Medon —

Oïleus’

bastard son, exiled to Phylace for killing  
a kinsman of his stepmother Eriopis —  
and Podarces son of Iphiclus.

*Kin:* led at 13.693 by Medon and  
Podarces.

**Refs:** 13.686, 13.693, 13.699. Book 13.

*See also:* Phthia, Medon, Podarces,  
Boeotians, Myrmidons.

---

**Phyleus** (Φυλεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* FY-  
lyoos

Father of Meges, “the horseman  
Phyleus dear to Zeus,” who had once  
quarreled with  
his own father and moved away to  
Dulichium. He does not come to Troy:  
the name is  
almost always a patronymic for Meges,

in the Catalogue, in the night muster, in  
the Epeian ranks at 13.692, and through  
the fighting at the ships in Book 15,  
where the corslet Phyleus brought  
home from Ephyra by the river Selleïs  
— a

guest-gift from Euphetes — turns  
Dolops' spear and keeps destruction  
from his

son's flesh. A Phyleus is also named  
among the men Nestor beat with the  
spear at

Amarynceus' funeral games (23.637).

*Kin:* father of Meges. The poem does not  
name Phyleus's own father, only that he  
quarreled with him and left for  
Dulichium.

**Refs:** 2.628, 5.72, 10.110, 13.692, 15.519,  
15.530, 16.313, 19.239, 23.637.

Books 2, 5, 10, 13, 15, 16, 19, 23.

*See also:* Meges, Dulichium, Epeians,  
Dolops, Ephyra, Nestor.

---

**Placus** (Πλάκος) · PLACE — Say: PLAY-kus

A wooded mountain in the Troad, under  
which stood Thebe, Eëtion's city. The  
name

comes only in the formula for

Andromache's origin — "Eëtion, who  
lived under

wooded Placus, / in Thebe-under-  
Placus, lord over the Cilician men" —  
used at

their meeting at the Scaean Gates, again  
when she names her mother "queen  
under

wooded Placus," and a third time in her  
lament over Hector, where the two of  
them

are born to one fate, “you in Troy, in the  
house of Priam, / and I in Thebe,  
under wooded Placus.”

**Refs:** 6.396, 6.397, 6.425, 22.479. Books 6,  
22.

*See also:* Thebe, Eëtion, Andromache,  
Cilicians.

---

### **Pleiades** (Πληϊάδες) · OTHER

A constellation, named once: among the  
stars Hephaestus works into the Shield  
of

Achilles, with the Hyades, the strength  
of Orion, and the Bear.

**Refs:** 18.486. Book 18.

*See also:* Orion, Hephaestus, Achilles.

---

### **Pleuron** (Πλευρών) · PLACE — *Say:* PLOOR- on

An Aetolian city, named with Olenus  
and Pylene in the Catalogue of Thoas’  
contingent and twice paired with “steep  
Calydon” — in Poseidon’s disguise as  
Thoas, who “in all Pleuron and steep  
Calydon ruled the Aetolians, honored  
like a  
god,” and in Diomedes’ genealogy,  
where Portheus’ three sons Agrius,  
Melas and  
Oeneus lived there. Nestor names  
Ancaeus of Pleuron as the wrestler he  
beat at  
Amarynceus’ funeral games.

**Refs:** 2.639, 13.217, 14.116, 23.635. Books  
2, 13, 14, 23.

*See also:* Aetolians, Calydon, Thoas,  
Oeneus, Ancaeus, Nestor.

---

**Podargus** (Πόδαργος) · OTHER — Say: poh-

DAR-gus

Two horses of the name, and the poem keeps them apart. The first is one of Hector's four, called by name with Xanthus, Aethon and Lampus when he tells them

to pay him back for the honey-hearted wheat Andromache set before them.

The

second is Menelaus' own trace-horse in the chariot race at Patroclus' funeral, yoked beside Aethe, Agamemnon's mare.

**Refs:** 8.185, 23.295. Books 8, 23.

*See also:* Hector, Menelaus, Aethe, Xanthus (horse), Andromache.

---



**Polites** (Πολίτης) · MORTAL — Say: poh-LY-teez

A son of Priam, and the Trojan lookout: he sat “on the very top of the tomb of old Aesyetes, watching for when the Achaeans should rush out from their ships,”

trusting the speed of his feet, and Iris takes his shape to bring Zeus’s message to the assembly at Priam’s doors. In battle he carries his wounded brother Deiphobus out of the fighting to the chariots and kills Echius at the ships. He is

one of the nine sons Priam curses and drives to yoke the wagon in Book 24, where

he is “Polites of the war-cry.”

*Kin:* son of Priam; brother of Deiphobus.

*Kills:* Echius (15.339).

**Refs:** 2.791, 13.533, 15.339, 24.250. Books  
2, 13, 15, 24.

*See also:* Priam, Deiphobus, Iris,  
Aesyetes.

---

**Polydamas** (Πουλυδάμας) · MORTAL — *Say:*  
pol-ih-DAY-mas or puh-LID-uh-mas  
Panthous' son, Hector's companion,  
born in the same night with him: "one  
was far  
the better in words, the other with the  
spear." He is the poem's counter-voice  
on  
the Trojan side, and Hector takes his  
advice three times and refuses it twice,  
the  
refusals being the ones that matter. He  
reads the eagle-and-snake omen at the  
ditch and urges the Trojans not to press

on to the ships, and Hector answers  
with

“One bird-sign is best: to fight for your  
fatherland” and a threat to kill him.

He urges retreat inside the walls the  
night Achilles reappears, and Hector’s  
refusal — praised by the Trojans, “the  
fools: for Pallas Athena had taken their  
wits from them” — is what Hector  
remembers alone before the gates:

“Polydamas  
will be the first to lay reproach on me.”  
He fights as well as he counsels,  
killing Prothoenor and Otus and  
vaunting over the body.

*Also called:* Panthous’ son.

*Kin:* son of Panthous; brother, in the  
family the poem names, of Euphorbus  
and

Hyperenor.

*Kills:* Prothoenor (14.450); Mecisteus (15.339); Otus of Cyllene (15.518).

**Refs:** 12.60, 12.210, 12.231, 13.756, 14.450, 15.518, 18.249, 18.313, 22.100  
...and throughout. Books 11–18, 22.

*See also:* Hector, Panthous, Euphorbus, Prothoenor, Ajax, Meges.

---

**Polydorus** (Πολύδωρος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

pol-ih-DOR-us

Priam's youngest and dearest son, by  
Laothoe daughter of Altes, forbidden by  
his

father to fight; "in his boy's folly,  
showing off the speed of his feet" he  
darts

through the front-fighters and Achilles'  
javelin takes him in the back, so that  
he sinks clutching his bowels. It is the

sight of his brother dying that brings Hector out of the crowd against Achilles. Lycaon names him as the brother already killed while pleading for his own life at 21.91, and Priam names the two of them together at 22.46 as the sons of Laothoe he cannot see among the Trojans. A different Polydorus is one of the men Nestor out-threw with the spear at Amarynceus' funeral games (23.637); the poem keeps them separate.

*Kin:* son of Priam and Laothoe; brother of Lycaon.

*Killed by:* Achilles (20.407–418).

**Refs:** 20.407, 20.419, 21.91, 22.46, 23.637.

Books 20–23.

*See also:* Priam, Laothoe, Lycaon, Altes, Achilles, Hector, Nestor.

---

**Polyidus** (Πολύιδος) · MORTAL — Say: pol-  
ih-EYE-dus

Two men. The first is a Trojan, son of  
Eurydamas “the old reader of dreams,”  
killed with his brother Abas by  
Diomedes in Book 5 — and the poem’s  
point is that  
“the old man read no dreams for them  
at their going.” The second is a seer of  
Corinth, father of Euchenor, who told  
his son often that he would either waste  
to  
death of a sickness at home or fall  
under Trojan hands at the ships;  
Euchenor  
sailed knowing his fate, and Paris’ arrow  
found him under the ear.  
*Kin:* the Trojan is Eurydamas’ son and  
Abas’ brother; the Corinthian is  
Euchenor’s father.

*Killed by: the Trojan Polyidus by*

*Diomedes (5.148–151).*

**Refs:** 5.148, 13.663, 13.666. Books 5, 13.

*See also:* Eurydamas, Abas, Euchenor,

Diomedes, Paris.

---

**Polypoetes** (Πολυποίτης) · MORTAL — Say:

pol-ih-PEE-teez

A Lapith leader, son of Peirithous and

Hippodameia, born on the day his

father

drove the shaggy beast-men out of

Pelion; he brings forty ships from

Argissa and

Gyrtone with Leonteus, and the two are

inseparable in the poem. They hold the

gate

against Asius “like high-crowned oaks

in the mountains that abide the wind

and  
rain through all their days,” and  
Polypoetes kills Damasus through the  
bronze-cheeked helmet, then Pylon and  
Ormenus. In Book 23 he throws the  
lump of  
iron past the whole field — Epeius,  
Leonteus and Telamonian Ajax — and  
his  
companions carry the prize away.  
*Epithets*: “steadfast in battle”  
(μενεπτόλεμος, 2.740).  
*Kin*: son of Peirithous and Hippodameia;  
grandson of Zeus by Peirithous.  
*Kills*: Astyalus (6.29); Damasus, Pylon,  
Ormenus (12.182–187).  
**Refs**: 2.740, 6.29, 12.129, 12.182, 23.836,  
23.844, 23.848. Books 2, 6, 12,  
23.



*See also:* Leonteus, Peirithous, Lapiths,  
Asius, Epeius, Ajax.

---

**Poseidon** (Ποσειδάων) · GOD — Say: poh-  
SY-dun

Zeus's brother, lord of the sea and the  
Achaeans' most active divine partisan.

He

and Apollo built Laomedon's wall and  
were cheated of their wage, which he  
still

holds against Troy in Book 21, when he  
offers Apollo the first blow and is  
refused.

His great sequence is Books 13–15: he  
watches from the peak of Thracian  
Samos,

comes down in three strides, and works  
behind Zeus's back — rallying the

Argives  
as Calchas, leading them with a sword  
“like a lightning-flash,” then stretching  
the strife taut against Hector — until  
Zeus sends Iris to order him off and he  
yields, protesting that the three  
brothers drew sky, sea and underworld  
by lot and  
he is Zeus’s equal in honor. He resents  
the Achaean wall for outshining his own  
work and unbuilds it after the war; he  
saves Aeneas from Achilles because the  
race  
of Dardanus must not perish; and he  
alone with Hera and Athena holds to his  
hatred  
of Ilion to the end.

*Epithets:* “the earth-shaker” (ἐνοσίχθων  
/ ἐννοσίγαιος, 7.445); “wide-ruling”  
(εὐρυσθενής, 7.455); “the holder of the

earth” (γαῖήοχος, 9.183); “blue-maned” (κυανοχαίτης, 13.563).

*Kin:* son of Cronos and Rhea; brother of Zeus and Hades.

**Refs:** 7.445, 12.17, 13.19, 13.43, 14.384, 15.158, 15.205, 20.291, 21.435, 24.26 ...and throughout. Books 1, 2, 7, 8, 11–15, 20, 21, 23, 24.

*See also:* Zeus, Hades, Apollo, Laomedon, Aeneas, Samos, Achaeans.

---

**Priam** (Πρίαμος) · MORTAL — *Say:* PRY-am  
King of Troy, old and past fighting,  
whose name the poem uses as much for the  
city and the doom as for the man —  
“Priam’s city,” “Priam and the people of  
Priam  
of the good ash spear.” He appears

rarely in battle books and decisively at  
the  
frame: on the tower in Book 3, calling  
Helen to him and refusing to blame her,  
and  
driving out through the Scaean Gates to  
swear the oaths for the duel, then  
leaving  
because he cannot watch his son fight;  
in Book 22 on the wall, tearing his hair  
and begging Hector to come inside,  
arguing that Achilles too has a father.  
That  
argument he carries into the Achaean  
camp in Book 24, going alone by night  
with  
Hermes for guide, kissing “the terrible,  
man-slaughtering hands that had killed  
so  
many of his sons,” and winning Hector’s

body back. He tells Achilles he had fifty sons when the Achaeans came, and not one is left him.

*Epithets:* “of the good ash spear”

(ἐϋμμελίω, 4.47); “the equal of the gods in

counsel” (θεόφιν μήστωρ ἀτάλαντος, 7.366).

*Also called:* Dardanus’ descendant (Δαρδανίδης, 3.303).

*Kin:* son of Laomedon; husband of Hecuba, daughter of Dymas, and of many wives

including Laothoe; father of Hector, Paris, Helenus, Deiphobus, Polydorus, Lycaon, Polites and the rest, and of Laodice and Cassandra.

**Refs:** 1.19, 2.37, 3.105, 3.303, 4.47, 6.242, 7.366, 22.25, 24.160, 24.477

...and throughout. Books 1–9, 11–24.

*See also:* Hector, Hecuba, Laomedon,  
Troy, Achilles, Hermes, Dardanus.

---

**Proetus** (Προΐτος) · MORTAL — Say: PREE-  
tus

A king of the Argives in Glaucus' back-  
story, who drove Bellerophon out of the  
land. His wife Anteia was mad to lie  
with Bellerophon and, refused, lied to  
her

husband that he had forced her; Proetus  
shrank from killing him — “his heart  
stood

in awe of that” — but sent him to Lycia  
with the folded tablet of “many  
life-destroying marks” for the king  
there to read, meaning his death. The  
poem's

one instance of writing.

*Kin:* husband of Anteia; son-in-law of the lord of Lycia.

**Refs:** 6.157, 6.160, 6.163, 6.164, 6.177.

Book 6.

*See also:* Bellerophon, Anteia, Glaucus, Lycia.

---

**Promachus** (Πρόμαχος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

PROM-uh-kus

A Boeotian, Alegenor's son, killed by Acamas in Book 14 as he was hauling Archelochus' body away by the feet.

Acamas vaunts over him — “Look how your

Promachus sleeps, beaten down by my spear” — as blood-price for his brother, and

the vaunt is what rouses Peneleos, whose killing of Ilioneus answers it in

kind.

*Kin:* son of Alegenor.

*Killed by:* Acamas (14.476–477).

**Refs:** 14.477, 14.482, 14.503. Book 14.

*See also:* Acamas, Archelochus, Peneleos, Ilioneus, Boeotians.

---

**Protesilaus** (Πρωτεσίλαος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

proh-tes-ih-LAY-us

Leader of the contingent from Phylace,  
and the first Achaean to die: “a

Dardanian

man had killed him as he leapt from his  
ship, far the first of the Achaeans.” He  
is already dead when the Catalogue  
reaches him — “by then the black earth  
held him

under” — leaving a wife with torn  
cheeks in Phylace and a half-built



house, and  
his brother Podarces, the younger and  
lesser man, leads his forty ships. His  
ship  
becomes the poem's landmark for the  
crisis at the camp: Hector breaks  
through  
where the ships of Ajax and Protesilaus  
are drawn up, lays his hand on its stern  
at 15.705, and Patroclus' first cast in  
Book 16 is thrown into the press around  
it.

*Kin:* son of Iphiclus, Phylacus' line;  
brother of Podarces.

**Refs:** 2.698, 2.706, 2.708, 13.681, 15.705,  
16.287. Books 2, 13, 15, 16.

*See also:* Podarces, Phylace, Hector,  
Patroclus, Phthians.

---

**Prothoenor** (Προθοήνωρ) · MORTAL — Say:

proh-thoh-EE-nor

One of the five Boeotian leaders of the Catalogue and, in Book 14, Polydamas' victim: the spear takes him in the right shoulder and he falls clutching the earth

in his palm. Polydamas' vaunt over him — that the man will lean on the spear for a

staff walking down into Hades — stirs Telamonian Ajax, who casts back, misses

Polydamas, and kills Archelochus instead, then asks across the field whether that

man is “a worthy exchange for Prothoenor dead.”

*Kin:* son of Areilycus.

*Killed by:* Polydamas (14.450–452).

**Refs:** 2.495, 14.450, 14.471. Books 2, 14.

*See also:* Polydamas, Ajax, Archelochus, Boeotians.

---

**Pylaemenes** (Πυλαιμένης) · MORTAL — *Say:*

py-LEM-uh-neeZ

Leader of the Paphlagonians from the  
Eneti, “of the shaggy heart,” called  
“captain

of the great-hearted Paphlagonian  
shieldmen.” Menelaus spears him  
through the

collarbone as he stands, while

Antilochus kills his driver Mydon in the  
same

exchange. His son Harpalion is killed by  
Meriones in Book 13, and the poem  
there

calls him “the son of king Pylaemenes”

— the father, killed in Book 5, is present again as a name.

*Kin:* father of Harpalion.

*Killed by:* Menelaus (5.576–579).

**Refs:** 2.851, 5.576, 13.643. Books 2, 5, 13.

*See also:* Paphlagonians, Menelaus, Antilochus, Harpalion, Mydon.

---

**Pylians** (Πύλιοι) · PEOPLE — *Say:* PY-lee-unz

Nestor's people, whose land the Alpheius "flows wide through." They are named

mostly inside Nestor's own reminiscences — the fight with the Arcadians by the Celadon, and the long Book 11 tale of the cattle-raid on Elis, the division of the

spoil at Pylos, and the battle with the  
Epeians in which Zeus “handed great  
power  
to the Pylians.” In the present action  
they are the contingent Antilochus  
leaves  
when he runs to Achilles with the news  
of Patroclus’ death, and “great longing  
was  
built for the Pylians” until Menelaus  
sends them Thrasymedes.

**Refs:** 5.545, 7.134, 11.687, 11.737, 11.753,  
17.704, 23.633. Books 5, 7, 11,  
17, 23.

*See also:* Nestor, Pylos, Antilochus,  
Thrasymedes, Epeians, Alpheius.

---

**Pylos** (Πύλος) · PLACE — Say: PY-los  
Nestor’s kingdom, “sandy Pylos,”

Neleus' before him; the Catalogue gives him  
ninety ships from Pylos, Arene and the  
towns along the Alpheiuss. Nestor was  
already king "among the third"  
generation there when he came to Troy,  
and the  
place belongs mostly to his memories:  
the cattle driven at night into Neleian  
Pylos, the debts divided among the  
leading men, the return from  
Buprasion. Agamem-  
non offers seven citadels "on the edge  
of sandy Pylos" among the gifts for  
Achilles. Dione names it as where  
Heracles shot Hades among the dead.  
**Refs:** 1.252, 2.77, 2.591, 5.397, 9.153,  
11.682, 11.712, 23.303. Books 1, 2,  
4, 5, 9, 11, 23.

*See also:* Nestor, Neleus, Pylians,  
Alpheius, Heracles.

---

**Rhesus** (Ῥῆσος) · MORTAL — *Say:* REE-sus  
Thracian king, son of Eioneus, whose  
men are “new-come, outermost of all”  
— they  
stand outside the Catalogue. Dolon,  
questioned under the knife, gives him  
up: his  
horses are the finest and biggest Dolon  
has ever seen, “whiter than snow, and  
like  
the winds in running,” and his armor is  
golden, fit for gods and not for mortal  
men. Diomedes kills him in his sleep,  
thirteenth of the Thracians, while  
Odysseus  
leads the horses out; Apollo wakes his

kinsman Hippocoon, who finds the place empty and the men gasping. A river of Ida also bears the name (12.20).

*Kin:* son of Eioneus; kinsman of Hippocoon.

*Killed by:* Diomedes (10.474–497).

**Refs:** 10.435, 10.474, 10.519, 12.20. Books 10, 12.

*See also:* Dolon, Diomedes, Odysseus, Thracians, Hippocoon.

---

### **Rhodes** (Ῥόδος) · PLACE

Tlepolemus' island, sending nine ships of "the lordly Rhodians," who "dwelt through Rhodes in three divisions: Lindus, Ialysus, and chalk-white Cameirus." He came there as an exile and a wanderer



after killing Licymnius, his father  
Heracles' aged uncle, and the settlers  
were loved by Zeus, who "poured  
wondrous  
wealth upon them."

**Refs:** 2.654, 2.655, 2.667. Book 2.

*See also:* Tlepolemus, Rhodians,  
Heracles, Licymnius.

---

**Samos** (Σάμος) · PLACE — *Say:* SAY-mos

Two islands of the name, and the poem  
distinguishes them. The Samos of  
Odysseus'

Catalogue entry (2.634) lies among  
Ithaca, Zacynthus and the facing  
mainland. The

other is "wooded Samos, Thracian  
Samos" — Samothrace — from whose  
topmost peak

Poseidon watches the fighting, because  
from there “all Ida showed clear, and  
Priam’s city showed clear, and the ships  
of the Achaeans”; Iris plunges into the  
sea between Samos and rugged Imbros,  
and Priam names Samos with Imbros  
and Lemnos  
as the islands Achilles sold his sons into.

**Refs:** 2.634, 13.12, 13.13, 24.78, 24.753.

Books 2, 13, 24.

*See also:* Poseidon, Imbros, Lemnos,  
Ithaca, Odysseus.

---

**Sarpedon** (Σαρπηδών) · MORTAL — *Say:* sar-  
PEE-don

King of the Lycians, son of Zeus by  
Laodameia, Bellerophon’s daughter —  
the only  
child of Zeus fighting at Troy whom the

poem lets die. He comes “from far Lycia,  
from the eddying Xanthus” with  
Glaucus, rebukes Hector for leaving the  
fighting to  
the allies, survives Tlepolemus’ spear  
through the thigh in Book 5, and is the  
first man over the Achaean wall, tearing  
the breastwork away with his hands  
“and  
he had made a road for many.” His  
speech to Glaucus before that assault —  
why kings  
are honored with the seat of honor and  
the fat land, and why, since death  
stands  
over them in thousands, they must go —  
is the poem’s clearest statement of the  
warrior’s bargain. Patroclus kills him  
with a spear through the midriff and he  
falls like a felled oak; Zeus, who has

weighed snatching him out alive and  
been  
argued down by Hera, rains blood on  
the earth for him, then has Apollo wash  
the  
body and give it to Sleep and Death to  
carry to Lycia. The fight over his  
stripped  
corpse fills the rest of Book 16, and his  
armor is the prize Achilles sets for the  
duel in the funeral games.

*Epithets:* “of the bronze helmet”  
(χαλκοκορυστής, 6.199).

*Kin:* son of Zeus and Laodameia;  
grandson of Bellerophon; cousin and  
companion  
of Glaucus.

*Kills:* Tlepolemus (5.655–659); Alcmaon,  
Thestor’s son (12.394). In the duel his  
own casts miss Patroclus twice; the

second kills the trace-horse Pedasus  
(16.466).

*Killed by:* Patroclus (16.480–505).

**Refs:** 2.876, 5.633, 5.657, 6.199, 12.292,  
12.397, 16.419, 16.480, 16.667,  
23.800 ...and throughout. Books 2, 5, 6,  
12, 14–17, 23.

*See also:* Glaucus, Lycians, Zeus,  
Patroclus, Tlepolemus, Bellerophon,  
Hector.

---

**Satnioeis** (Σατνιόεις) · PLACE — *Say:* sat-  
nee-OH-is

A river of the Troad, always named for  
the men who lived on it: Elatus, killed  
by  
Agamemnon, “who lived by the banks  
of fair-flowing Satnioeis in steep  
Pedasus”;

Satnius, son of Enops by a nymph who bore him “as he herded by the banks of Satnioeis,” killed by Ajax son of Oïleus; and Pedasus, the town Altes holds “on the Satnioeis,” home of Laothoe, mother of Lycaon and Polydorus.

**Refs:** 6.34, 14.445, 21.87. Books 6, 14, 21.  
*See also:* Pedasus, Elatus, Satnius, Altes, Laothoe.

---

**Scaean** (Σκαιαί) · PLACE — *Say:* SEE-un

The Scaean Gates, Troy’s main gate onto the plain, and with the oak beside them the fixed landmark of the poem’s approaches to the city. The elders sit there watching Helen come up onto the tower; Priam drives out through them to swear the

oaths; Hector meets Andromache there on his way out and it is where Theano's prayer asks Athena to bring Diomedes down; Achilles' chase brings Hector back to them, "in front of Ilion and the Scaean Gates," and the dying Hector names them as the place where Paris and Apollo will destroy Achilles.

*Also called:* the Scaean Gates.

**Refs:** 3.145, 3.149, 3.263, 6.237, 6.307, 6.393, 9.354, 11.170, 16.712, 18.453, 22.6, 22.360. Books 3, 6, 9, 11, 16, 18, 22.

*See also:* Troy, Hector, Andromache, Priam, Achilles.

---

**Scamander** (Σκάμανδρος) · PLACE — Say:

skuh-MAN-dur

Troy's chief river and the god who runs in it, "whom the gods call Xanthus, and men Scamander" — the poem states the double name outright at 20.74. It is the plain's standing feature: Ares set down on its high bank, the burial-ground of the

Achaean dead, the ford Priam and Hermes cross, the twin springs where the Trojan

women used to wash and past which Achilles chases Hector. In Book 21 the river

becomes a combatant: choked with corpses, he asks Achilles to do his killing on

the plain, then crests over him, calls his brother Simoïs to help drown him, and



is beaten only when Hera sends  
Hephaestus' fire against the water. He is  
one of  
the eight Idaean rivers Apollo and  
Poseidon turn against the Achaean wall  
(12.21).

*Also called:* Xanthus — the gods' name  
for it (20.74). NB: "Xanthus" also names  
one of Achilles' immortal horses, a  
Trojan killed by Diomedes (5.152), and a  
separate river of Lycia (2.877, 6.172,  
12.313).

*Kin:* "eddying Xanthus, whom immortal  
Zeus begot" (21.2).

**Refs:** 5.36, 5.78, 7.330, 11.499, 12.21,  
20.74, 21.15, 21.223, 21.305, 22.148

...and throughout. Books 5–8, 11–12, 14,  
20–22, 24.

*See also:* Simois, Achilles, Hephaestus,  
Hera, Xanthus (horse), Troy.

---

**Schedius** (Σχεδῖος) · MORTAL — Say: SKEE-dee-us

Two Phocian leaders of the name, both  
killed by Hector. The first is Iphitus’  
son,

Naubolus’ grandson, who with his  
brother Epistrophus leads forty Phocian  
ships in

the Catalogue; he is “far the best of the  
Phocians,” king over many men in  
famed

Panopeus, and Hector’s cast — dodged  
by Ajax — takes him under the  
collarbone and

comes out at the base of the shoulder.

The second is Schedius son of  
Perimedes,

“a captain of the Phocians,” cut down by  
Hector at the ships in Book 15.

*Kin:* the Catalogue leader is son of Iphitus; the other is son of Perimedes.  
*Killed by:* both by Hector (15.515; 17.306–311).

**Refs:** 2.517, 15.515, 17.306. Books 2, 15, 17.

*See also:* Phocians, Epistrophus, Panopeus, Hector, Ajax.

---

### **Seasons** (Ἔσραϊ) · GOD

The Ἔσραϊ, keepers of the gates of heaven, “to whom great heaven and Olympus are entrusted, to roll the thick cloud aside, or set it back.” They appear only in the formula for Hera’s chariot passing out and back: the gates groan open self-moved as she and Athena drive through (5.749

= 8.393), and when the ride is called off  
they unyoke the lovely-maned horses,  
tether them at the ambrosial mangers  
and lean  
the chariot against the shining wall.

**Refs:** 5.749, 8.393, 8.433. Books 5, 8.

*See also:* Hera, Athena, Olympus, Zeus.

---

**Selleïs** (Σελλήεις) · PLACE — *Say:* sel-EE-is

A river named only in contingent back-  
stories, always in the same phrase,

“from

the river Selleïs.” Heracles brought

Astyocheia, Tlepolemus’ mother, out of  
Ephyra

by it; Asius’ tall fire-colored horses

come from it, in a line the poem repeats  
verbatim when he storms the wall

(2.839 = 12.97); and Phyleus brought

home from it  
the corslet that saves Meges in Book 15.  
**Refs:** 2.659, 2.839, 12.97, 15.531. Books 2,  
12, 15.  
*See also:* Ephyra, Tlepolemus, Asius,  
Arisbe, Meges.

---

**Simoeisios** (Σιμοείσιος) · MORTAL — *Say:*  
sim-oh-EE-see-os  
A young Trojan killed by Telamonian  
Ajax in the first general engagement,  
born by  
the banks of the Simois while his  
mother was coming down from Ida with  
her parents  
to see the flocks, and named for the  
river. He never paid back to his parents  
the  
cost of his rearing; Ajax's spear takes

him in the chest by the right nipple and  
he falls like a black poplar felled by a  
chariot-maker to bend a wheel-rim, left  
lying to season along the river bank.

*Kin:* son of Anthemion.

*Killed by:* Ajax (4.473–489).

**Refs:** 4.474, 4.477, 4.488. Book 4.

*See also:* Ajax, Simois, Telamon.

---

**Simois** (Σιμόεις) · PLACE — Say: SIM-oh-is

The second of Troy's two rivers,  
running with the Scamander across the  
plain: the

armies fight “midway between the  
streams of Simois and Xanthus,” and  
Hera halts

her horses where the two join,  
whereupon Simois makes ambrosia  
spring up for them

to graze. It is one of the eight Idaean rivers Apollo turns against the Achaean wall — named there for the shields and helmets and “the race of half-god men” fallen in its dust — and in Book 21 Scamander calls to it as “dear brother” for help against Achilles. Spelled *Simois* at 20.53 and 21.307.

**Refs:** 4.475, 5.774, 5.777, 6.4, 12.22. Books 4–6, 12.

*See also:* Scamander, Simoeisios, Ida, Troy.

---

### **Sleep** (“Υπνος) · GOD

“Sleep, the brother of Death,” personified, and Hera’s accomplice in the Deception of Zeus. He refuses her at first — a

previous commission of hers, laying  
Zeus's  
mind asleep so she could drive Heracles  
to Cos, nearly got him flung out of  
heaven,  
and only Night saved him — and yields  
only when she swears by the water of  
Styx to  
give him Pasithea, one of the younger  
Graces, whom he has longed for all his  
days.

He perches in a fir on Ida in the likeness  
of the bird “the gods call chalkis, and  
men call kymindis,” then runs to tell  
Poseidon that Zeus is out. In Book 16 he  
and

Death are “the twin brothers” who  
carry Sarpedon's body home to Lycia.  
*Kin*: brother of Death; son of Night in  
effect, who shelters him (14.259).



**Refs:** 14.231, 14.233, 14.242, 14.264,  
14.270, 14.286, 14.354, 16.454, 16.672,  
16.682. Books 14, 16.

*See also:* Death, Hera, Zeus, Pasithea,  
Night, Sarpedon, Poseidon.

---

**Socus** (Σῶκος) · MORTAL — *Say:* SOH-kus

A wealthy Trojan, brother of Charops,  
who comes to his brother's rescue when  
Odysseus is cutting through Hippasus'  
sons and drives a spear through  
Odysseus'  
shield and corslet, tearing the flesh  
from his ribs — Athena keeps the point  
from  
his vitals. Odysseus, knowing the wound  
is not mortal, tells him destruction has  
caught him, and spears him between  
the shoulders as he turns to run. The

wound

Socus deals is what brings the Trojans  
down on Odysseus alone in the crowd.

*Kin:* son of Hippasus; brother of  
Charops.

*Killed by:* Odysseus (11.446–449).

**Refs:** 11.427, 11.428, 11.440, 11.446,  
11.450, 11.456. Book 11.

*See also:* Odysseus, Charops, Hippasus,  
Athena.

---

### **Sparta** (Σπάρτη) · PLACE

Menelaus' city in the Peloponnese,  
named in the Catalogue among the  
towns of his  
contingent and again by Hera, who  
names Argos, Sparta and wide-wayed  
Mycenae as  
the three cities dearest to her and offers

all three for Troy's destruction  
(4.52–53). The poem more often calls  
the country **Lacedaemon** — “hollow  
Lacedaemon full of ravines” heads the  
same catalogue entry — and it is from  
Lacedaemon that Paris carried Helen  
off, and there that she left the daughter  
and  
the household she keeps naming in  
Book 3.

*Also called:* Lacedaemon, the district in  
which the Catalogue places it (2.581).

**Refs:** 2.581, 2.582, 3.239, 3.244, 3.388,  
3.443, 4.52. Books 2–4.

*See also:* Menelaus, Helen, Argos,  
Mycenae, Hera.

---

**Spercheius** (Σπερχειός) · PLACE — Say: spur-  
KY-us

The river of Phthia, “the sky-fed river,”  
to whom Peleus vowed that Achilles  
would  
cut his hair and sacrifice fifty rams at  
its sources if he came home. He does  
not  
come home: standing apart from the  
pyre, Achilles cuts the tawny lock he  
had been  
growing for the river and puts it in  
Patroclus’ hands instead, telling  
Spercheius  
plainly that his father’s vow was made  
for nothing. The river also fathered  
Menesthius, a Myrmidon company-  
leader, on Peleus’ daughter Polydora.  
*Kin:* father of Menesthius by Polydora.  
**Refs:** 16.174, 16.176, 23.142, 23.144.  
Books 16, 23.

*See also:* Achilles, Peleus, Patroclus,  
Menesthius, Polydora, Phthia.

---

**Sthenelus** (Σθένελος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

STHEN-uh-lus

Diomedes' charioteer and companion,  
one of the Epigoni whose fathers fell at  
Thebes. He pulls Pandarus' arrow from  
Diomedes' shoulder in Book 5, spots  
Aeneas

and Pandarus coming and urges retreat,  
and drives off the horses of Tros;

Athena

shoves him bodily off the chariot to take  
the reins herself. He answers

Agamemnon's

shaming of the fathers by claiming the  
sons took seven-gated Thebes where  
the

fathers failed — the speech Diomedes silently declines to endorse. In Book 9 Diomedes vows that he and Sthenelus alone will fight on to the end of Ilion. **A second Sthenelus**, son of Perseus and father of Eurystheus, belongs to the Heracles back-story of Book 19 and is a different man.

*Also called:* Capaneus' son.

*Kin:* son of Capaneus.

**Refs:** 2.564, 4.367, 5.108, 5.111, 5.241, 5.835, 8.114, 9.48, 19.116, 19.123, 23.510. Books 2, 4–5, 8–9, 19, 23.

*See also:* Diomedes, Capaneus, Thebes, Athena, Eurystheus, Perseus.

---

**Stichius** (Στιχίος) · MORTAL — *Say:* STIK-ee-us

An Achaean captain, named three times

and killed by Hector in the rout of Book 15.

The poem describes him inconsistently: at 13.195 and 13.691 he is one of the Athenian captains under Menestheus, helping carry the dead back among the host,

but at 15.330, in the couplet on his death, he is “a leader of the bronze-shirted

Boeotians.” The text does not reconcile the two.

*Killed by:* Hector (15.329–330).

**Refs:** 13.195, 13.691, 15.329. Books 13, 15.

*See also:* Menestheus, Athenians, Boeotians, Hector, Arcesilaus.

---

**Strife** (Ἔρις) · GOD

Discord personified and capitalized, one

of the battle-abstractions who take the  
field with Ares. She stands with Terror  
and Panic in the muster of Book 4,  
works  
beside “Ares bane of mortals” over the  
corpses, and is blazoned on Athena’s  
aegis  
with Valor and blood-chilling Pursuit.  
Zeus sends her down to the ships at the  
opening of Book 11 to raise the war-cry;  
“Strife of the many groans” then  
rejoices  
alone among the gods to see the armies  
close. Hephaestus sets her on the shield  
with Tumult and deadly Fate, and at the  
theomachy “strong Strife, driver of  
armies” rises against Athena’s shout.  
*Epithets:* the fixed capitalization of the  
personified Δεῖμος / Φόβος / Ἔρις  
group



is set at 4.440; the poem also calls her “insatiably raging” (4.440) and “of the many groans” (11.73).

**Refs:** 4.440, 5.518, 5.740, 11.3, 11.73, 18.535, 20.48. Books 4–5, 11, 18, 20.

*See also:* Terror, Panic, Ares, Athena, Tumult, Fate.

---

### **Sun** (Ἥλιος) · GOD

Helios, invoked in the oath-scenes as the god “who see all things and hear all things”: one of the two lambs of the truce is for Earth and Sun, and he is called

to witness both Agamemnon’s oath over the sworn oaths in Book 3 and his oath about

Briseis in Book 19, with Earth and the Erinyes. He also marks the poem’s time

—

“when the Sun bestrode the middle of  
heaven” Zeus lifts his scales — and is  
once  
made to act: Hera sends “the unwearied  
Sun, much against his will, into the  
streams of Ocean” to end the day  
Achilles rearms, fulfilling the sunset  
clause of  
Zeus’s plan. Called “Hyperion the Sun”  
at 8.480 and 19.398, and named Helios  
once  
(14.344).

**Refs:** 3.104, 3.277, 8.68, 8.480, 18.239,  
18.241, 19.197, 19.259. Books 3, 8,  
18, 19.

*See also:* Zeus, Hera, Earth, Ocean,  
Hyperion, Erinyes.

---

**Talthybius** (Ταλθύβιος) · MORTAL — Say:

tal-THIB-ee-us

Agamemnon's herald, "the godlike  
herald," and the man sent to do what  
his king

does not do himself. With Eurybates he  
goes unwillingly to Achilles' hut to take  
Briseis in Book 1; he fetches the lamb  
for the truce-sacrifice in Book 3, and  
calls

Machaon to the wounded Menelaus in  
Book 4; with Idaeus of Troy he parts  
Ajax and

Hector when night falls on their duel. In  
Book 19 he holds the boar for  
Agamemnon's  
oath and throws the carcass into the  
sea. The poem closes his arc at 23.897,  
where

Agamemnon's prize is handed to

Talthybius to carry — the mirror of  
1.320.

**Refs:** 1.320, 3.118, 4.192, 4.193, 7.276,  
19.196, 19.250, 19.267, 23.897.

Books 1, 3–4, 7, 19, 23.

*See also:* Agamemnon, Eurybates, Idaeus,  
Briseis, Machaon.

---

**Tartarus** (Τάρταρος) · PLACE — Say: TAR-  
tuh-rus

The pit below Hades — “where the  
deepest pit yawns under the earth, /  
where the  
gates are iron and the threshold bronze,  
/ as far beneath Hades as heaven is  
above  
the earth.” It is Zeus’s standing threat at  
the opening of Book 8 against any god  
who helps either side, and the measure

of how far he is strongest. Iapetus and  
Cronos sit at the world's limit with  
“deep Tartarus all around them,” and  
Hera  
swears her oath to Sleep by the gods  
beneath it, “who are called the Titans.”  
**Refs:** 8.13, 8.481, 14.279. Books 8, 14.  
*See also:* Zeus, Hades, Cronos, Iapetus,  
Sleep, Hera.

---

**Telamon** (Τελαμών) · MORTAL — Say: TEL-  
uh-mon  
Father of Ajax the greater and, by  
another woman, of Teucer; a king of  
Salamis in  
the older generation who does not  
come to Troy. In nearly all of its  
occurrences  
the name is a patronymic —

“Telamonian Ajax,” “Ajax, Zeus-sprung  
son of Telamon,  
marshal of the people” — and the  
referent is Ajax, per *canon.md*. He  
appears in  
his own right only at 8.283, where  
Agamemnon urges Teucer to keep  
shooting and be  
a light “to your father Telamon, who  
reared you when you were little / and  
cared  
for you in his own house, bastard  
though you were.”

*Also called:* the source of the adjective  
Telamonian.

*Kin:* father of Ajax and of Teucer, who  
are brothers “by one father” (12.371).

**Refs:** 2.528, 2.768, 6.5, 7.234, 8.281, 8.283,  
9.644, 12.371, 13.170, 17.284

...and throughout. Books 2, 4–9, 11–18,

23.

*See also:* Ajax, Teucer, Salamis, Ajax son of Oileus.

---

**Terror** (Δεῖμος) · GOD

One of the battle-abstractions personified and capitalized with Panic and Strife

(4.440). He and Panic attend Athena as she arms, “glaring terribly, and around her

Terror and Panic,” and Ares orders the pair to yoke his horses when he means to

break Zeus’s ban and avenge

Ascalaphus. He never acts alone.

**Refs:** 4.440, 11.37, 15.119. Books 4, 11, 15.

*See also:* Panic, Strife, Ares, Athena.

---

**Tethys** (Τηθύς) · GOD — Say: TEE-this  
“Mother Tethys,” Ocean’s consort,  
named twice in the Deception of Zeus  
and only  
there, in the lie Hera tells first to  
Aphrodite and then verbatim to Zeus:  
that  
she is going to the ends of the earth to  
see “Oceanus, the begetting of the gods,  
and mother Tethys,” who reared her in  
their halls when Rhea gave her up as  
Zeus  
put Cronos down, and to settle their  
long quarrel. The pair are the poem’s  
nearest  
thing to a cosmogony.  
*Kin:* consort of Ocean; foster-mother of  
Hera.

**Refs:** 14.201, 14.302. Book 14.



*See also:* Ocean, Hera, Rhea, Cronos,  
Zeus.

---

**Teucer** (Τεῦκρος) · MORTAL — *Say:* TYOO-  
sur

Telamon's bastard son and Ajax's half-  
brother, "his brother by one father," and  
the best archer in the Achaean host —  
Idomeneus calls him "best of the  
Achaeans /

in bowmanship, and good too in the  
standing fight." His method is fixed in  
Book 8:

he shoots from under Ajax's shield and  
slips back behind it "like a child to his  
mother," and the poem gives him a roll-  
call of eight victims before Hector  
breaks

his collarbone with a stone and snaps

his bowstring. In Book 15 he has Hector lined up when Zeus himself breaks the fresh-twisted string, and Teucer, shuddering, gives the bow up for spear and shield. He hits Glaucus on the wall (12.387) and loses the archery contest at the funeral games by forgetting to vow to Apollo. *Kin*: son of Telamon; half-brother of Ajax.

**Refs:** 6.31, 8.266, 8.273, 8.322, 12.371, 12.387, 13.313, 15.458, 15.462, 23.862. Books 6, 8, 12–16, 23.

*See also:* Ajax, Telamon, Hector, Glaucus, Meriones, Apollo.

---

**Theano** (Θεανώ) · MORTAL — *Say*: thee-AN-oh  
Antenor's wife, made priestess of

Athena by the Trojans, and the woman  
who  
performs the poem's one Trojan  
supplication of a goddess: she opens the  
temple  
doors on the city's height, takes the  
robe Hecuba has brought and lays it on  
Athena's knees, and vows twelve  
unbroken yearling heifers if the goddess  
will  
break Diomedes' spear and drop him  
before the Scaean Gates — "So she  
spoke,  
vowing. But Pallas Athena turned her  
head away." She had also reared  
Antenor's  
bastard son Pedaeus with her own  
children, to please her husband.  
*Epithets:* "fair-cheeked" (καλλιπάρης,  
6.298).

*Kin:* daughter of Cisseus (6.299; called Cisses at 11.223); wife of Antenor; foster-mother of Pedaeus; aunt of Iphidamas.

**Refs:** 5.70, 6.298, 6.302, 11.224. Books 5–6, 11.

*See also:* Antenor, Athena, Hecuba, Pedaeus, Iphidamas, Diomedes.

---

**Thebe** (Θήβη) · PLACE — *Say:* THEE-bee  
Eëtion's city under wooded Placus,  
“Thebe of the high gates,” seat of the  
Cilician  
men, sacked by Achilles before the  
poem opens. It is where Chryseis was  
taken —  
the sack that begins the plague-chain —  
and where Achilles killed Eëtion  
without

stripping him, burning him in his armor  
and heaping a mound that the  
mountain  
nymphs planted round with elms.  
Andromache was born there and names  
it in both her  
laments. Not the Boeotian Thebes: see  
**Thebes.**

**Refs:** 1.366, 2.691, 6.397, 6.416, 22.479.

Books 1–2, 6, 22.

*See also:* Eëtion, Andromache, Achilles,  
Chryseis, Placus, Lyrnessus, Thebes.

---

**Thebes** (Θῆβαι) · PLACE — *Say:* theebz

“Seven-gated Thebes,” the Boeotian city  
of the war before this one. Tydeus went  
there as an envoy for Polyneices, beat  
the Cadmeans at their own games and  
killed

the fifty men they set to ambush him;  
the Seven perished before the walls,  
and the  
heaped earth covers Tydeus there still.  
Agamemnon uses the fathers' Theban  
exploits  
to shame the sons (4.370–400), and  
Sthenelus retorts that the sons took the  
city  
where the fathers failed. Euryalus once  
beat all comers at the games for fallen  
Oedipus there. A different Thebes —  
Egyptian Thebes, “where the houses  
hold the  
greatest treasures” — is Achilles’  
measure of a ransom he will not take  
(9.381–382).

**Refs:** 4.378, 4.406, 5.804, 6.223, 9.381,  
9.382, 10.286, 14.114, 19.99, 23.679.

Books 4–6, 9–10, 14, 19, 23.

*See also:* Tydeus, Diomedes, Sthenelus,  
Polyneices, Cadmeans, Euryalus, Thebe.

---

**Thersites** (Θερσίτης) · MORTAL — *Say:* thur-  
SY-teez

The one common soldier in the poem  
who speaks in assembly. He is described  
at

length and unkindly — bandy-legged,  
lame in one foot, hunched, his head  
coming to

a point with sparse stubble on it, “the  
ugliest man who came under Ilion” —  
and he

attacks Agamemnon for his greed in  
terms not far from Achilles’ own in  
Book 1.

Odysseus strikes him across the back  
and shoulders with the scepter until a

bloody  
welt rises and he sits down weeping,  
and the army, vexed as it is, laughs at  
him  
sweetly. He is never mentioned again.  
Odysseus' abuse still calls him a  
“clear-voiced speaker.”  
**Refs:** 2.212, 2.244, 2.246, 2.266. Book 2.  
*See also:* Odysseus, Agamemnon,  
Achaeans.

---

**Thestor** (Θέστωρ) · MORTAL — *Say:* THES-  
tor

Three men. The first is Calchas' father,  
named in the line that introduces the  
seer  
“far the best of bird-readers” (1.69), and  
never otherwise present. The second is  
the father of Alcmaon, whom Sarpedon



spears at the wall (12.394). The third is a son of Enops, caught by Patroclus' second rush in his aristeia: he sits hunched in his chariot with the reins fallen from his hands, struck out of his wits, and Patroclus spears him through the right jaw and hauls him over the chariot-rail like a fisherman landing a sacred fish. *Kin*: the first is father of Calchas; the second father of Alcmaon; the third son of Enops.

*Killed by*: the third by Patroclus (16.401–410).

**Refs:** 1.69, 12.394, 16.401, 16.402. Books 1, 12, 16.

*See also*: Calchas, Alcmaon, Sarpedon, Patroclus, Enops.

---

**Thetis** (Θέτις) · GOD — *Say: THEE-tis or*

THET-is

A sea-nymph, daughter of the old man  
of the sea, married against her will to a  
mortal, and the mother of Achilles —  
the figure through whom the plot of the  
poem

is made. She takes her son's grievance  
to Zeus, clasps his knees on the peak of  
Olympus, and holds on until he bows his  
head: the promise to give the Trojans  
power

until the Achaeans honor Achilles is the  
mechanism of everything that follows,  
and

she can extract it because she once  
saved Zeus from being bound by  
summoning

Briareus. She leads the Nereids' lament  
for a son not yet dead, tells him plainly

that his own doom stands ready  
straight after Hector's, and goes to  
Hephaestus —  
who owes her his nine years' refuge  
after his fall — for the new armor. In  
Book 24

Zeus sends her to her son with the  
order to give Hector back, and she  
delivers it  
sitting beside him, stroking him with  
her hand.

*Epithets:* “silver-footed” (ἄργυρόπεζα,  
1.538).

*Also called:* Achilles' “lady mother”  
(18.35, 24.126).

*Kin:* daughter of Nereus, “the old man of  
the sea,” never named; sister of the  
Nereids; wife of Peleus, “Aeacus' son”;  
mother of Achilles. She sheltered  
Dionysus

from Lycurgus (6.136) and, with Eurynome, saved the fallen Hephaestus (18.398).

**Refs:** 1.413, 1.495, 1.512, 1.537, 6.136, 18.51, 18.127, 18.369, 24.74, 24.120

...and throughout. Books 1, 4, 6, 8–9, 13, 15–16, 18–20, 23–24.

*See also:* Achilles, Peleus, Zeus, Hephaestus, Nereids, Briareus, Hera, Eurynome.

---

**Thoas** (Θόας) · MORTAL — *Say:* THOH-as  
Leader of the Aetolians, Andraemon's son, who inherited the whole rule of Aetolia  
because Oeneus' sons were dead and fair-haired Meleager with them. He kills Peiroos  
over the body of Diores in Book 4 and

cannot strip him for the Thracian  
topknots  
around him; he volunteers for the duel  
with Hector; and at 15.281–299 he gives  
the  
poem’s most level piece of tactical  
advice, telling the best men to stand  
and blunt  
Hector while the multitude falls back on  
the ships — “far the best of the  
Aetolians  
— skilled with the javelin, / brave in the  
standing fight,” and few could beat him  
in debate. **Two other men bear the  
name:** Thoas king of Lemnos, to whom  
the  
Phoenicians gave the silver mixing-  
bowl that becomes a prize at Patroclus’  
games  
(14.230, 23.745), and a Trojan whom

Menelaus kills at 16.311. See *canon.md*.

*Kin*: son of Andraemon.

**Refs**: 2.638, 2.643, 4.527, 4.529, 7.168,  
13.92, 13.222, 14.230, 15.281, 16.311,  
19.239, 23.745. Books 2, 4, 7, 13–16, 19,  
23.

*See also*: Aetolians, Peiroos, Diores,  
Meleager, Oeneus, Euneus, Hypsipyle.

---

**Thoon** (Θόων) · MORTAL — *Say*: THOH-on  
More than one Trojan of the name, all  
of them killed. The first is a son of  
Phaenops, cut down with his brother  
Xanthus by Diomedes — the two were  
late-born  
and beloved, and their father, worn  
with age, had no other son, so that  
kinsmen of  
the widowed house divided the estate

(5.152–158). The second falls to  
Odysseus in  
Book 11. A Thoon is also named among  
Asius' captains storming the wall  
(12.140);  
and in Book 13 Antilochus catches one  
as he turns and severs the vein that  
runs the  
length of the back to the neck.  
*Killed by:* Diomedes (5.152–155);  
Odysseus (11.422); Antilochus (13.545–  
548).  
**Refs:** 5.152, 11.422, 12.140, 13.545. Books  
5, 11–13.  
*See also:* Phaenops, Xanthus (horse),  
Diomedes, Odysseus, Antilochus, Asius.

---

**Thrace** (Θρᾷκη) · PLACE — *Say:* thrayss  
The land north of the Hellespont,

“Thrace of the deep soil, mother of  
flocks,”  
where Iphidamas was reared in Cisses’  
house. Boreas and Zephyrus blow out of  
it  
across the Aegean; wine is brought daily  
from it to the Achaean camp; Poseidon  
watches the war from Samothrace over  
the heads of the Thracians. Rhesus’  
late-come  
contingent and Rhigmus come from  
there, and the cup Priam takes to  
Achilles among  
his ransom was a Thracian gift.

**Refs:** 9.5, 9.72, 11.222, 13.301, 20.485,  
24.234. Books 9, 11, 13, 20, 24.

*See also:* Thracians, Rhesus, Iphidamas,  
Rhigmus, Hellespont, Samos.

---



**Thracians** (Θρᾴκες) · PEOPLE — Say:

THRAY-shunz

Trojan-side allies from beyond the  
Hellespont, led in the Catalogue by  
Acamas and

the hero Peiroos, and marked by their  
hair: “the Thracians with their hair in  
topknots, long spears in their hands,”  
who stand over Peiroos’ body and  
thrust

Thoas back. Ares wears Acamas’  
likeness to rally the Trojans, and  
Telamonian Ajax

kills “the man who was best among the  
Thracians.” Their second, larger  
appearance

is Rhesus’ company, new-come and  
camped outermost of all, whose watch  
Dolon betrays  
and whom Diomedes kills sleeping —

twelve men and their king — while  
Odysseus  
drags the bodies clear for the horses.

**Refs:** 2.844, 4.519, 4.533, 4.537, 5.462, 6.7,  
10.434, 10.470, 10.559, 13.4,  
14.228. Books 2, 4–6, 10, 13–14, 23.

*See also:* Rhesus, Dolon, Diomedes,  
Acamas, Peiroos, Thrace, Thoas.

---

**Thrasymedes** (Θρασυμήδης) · MORTAL —

Say: thras-ih-MEE-deez

Nestor's son and Antilochus' brother,  
“steadfast in battle” and “horse-  
taming.”

He commands the night sentries in  
Book 9, lends Diomedes a sword and  
shield for the  
night raid, and his shield is the one his  
father takes up in Book 14 — the son

having his father's. In Book 16 he kills  
Maris, who is standing over his  
brother's  
body in fury; in Book 17 he and  
Antilochus are the last two who have  
not heard that  
Patroclus is dead, and when Antilochus  
runs with the news it is Thrasymedes  
whom  
Nestor sends to replace him.  
*Epithets*: "steadfast in battle"  
(μενεπτόλεμος, 10.255).  
*Kin*: son of Nestor; brother of  
Antilochus.  
**Refs**: 9.81, 10.255, 14.10, 16.321, 17.378,  
17.705. Books 9–10, 14, 16–17.  
*See also*: Nestor, Antilochus, Maris,  
Patroclus, Diomedes.

---

**Tlepolemus** (Τληπόλεμος) · MORTAL — *Say:*

tluh-POL-uh-mus *or* tuh-LEP-oh-lee-mus

Heracles' son by Astyocheia, leader of the nine Rhodian ships. The Catalogue gives

him an exile's biography: grown to manhood he killed his father's aging uncle

Licymnius on the instant, and fled over the sea from Heracles' sons and grandsons

to settle Rhodes in three tribes, where Zeus poured wondrous wealth upon them. Fate

drives him against Sarpedon — the son and the grandson of Zeus — and he opens with

a taunt about Heracles' six ships and the sack of Ilion; Sarpedon's spear goes

through his neck, and murky night  
covers his eyes, while his own cast only  
grazes

Sarpedon's thigh-bone. **A second  
Tlepolemus**, Damastor's son, is one of  
the

Trojans Patroclus kills in heaps at  
**16.416**.

*Kin*: son of Heracles and Astyocheia.

*Killed by*: Sarpedon (**5.655–659**).

**Refs**: **2.653**, **2.657**, **2.661**, **5.628**, **5.632**,  
**5.648**, **5.655**, **5.660**, **5.669**, **16.416**.

Books 2, 5, 16.

*See also*: Heracles, Sarpedon, Rhodes,  
Lycymnius, Astyocheia, Selleïs.

---

## **Trojans** (Τρῶες) · PEOPLE

The defenders of Troy and, loosely,  
their allies with them — the poem's

second  
great collective, and after Zeus its  
commonest name. They are the army  
the  
Achaeans face and the people whose  
city is doomed: the poem sets against  
the  
Achaeans' anonymous mass a Trojan  
side that is a city with women and  
children in  
it, and its formulas of address gather in  
the allies — “Trojans and Lycians and  
Dardanians who fight at close quarters.”  
Their assemblies, their truce, their  
oath-breaking under Pandarus, their  
one night camped in the open on the  
plain, and  
their lamentations over Hector are as  
fully narrated as anything on the  
Achaean

side.

*Epithets*: “horse-taming” (ἵππόδαμοι, 2.230); the individual form of the same word

is “breaker of horses.”

**Refs**: 1.152, 2.123, 3.2, 4.509, 8.173, 12.440, 18.243, 22.1 ...and throughout.

Books 1–24.

*See also*: Troy, Hector, Priam, Dardanians, Lycians, Achaeans.

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**Tros** (Τρώς) · MORTAL — *Say*: tros

Two men. The first is the eponym of the Trojans, in the fourth generation of the house of Dardanus: “Erichthonius fathered Tros, lord of the Trojans; / and from

Tros in turn three blameless sons were born: / Ilus, and Assaracus, and godlike

Ganymede.” Zeus gave him the immortal horses in payment for Ganymede, and it is that stock — “the horses of Tros” — that Anchises stole a breed from, that Diomedes takes from Aeneas, and that he drives in the chariot race. The second Tros is Alastor’s son, killed at 20.463: he comes to clasp Achilles’ knees hoping to be spared as a man of his own age, and Achilles, “all raw fury,” stabs him in the liver — the first of the poem’s three refused supplications.

*Kin:* the ancestor is son of Erichthonius, father of Ilus, Assaracus and Ganymede, and great-grandfather of Priam; the victim is Alastor’s son.

*Killed by:* the victim, by Achilles (20.463–472).



**Refs:** 5.222, 5.265, 8.106, 20.230, 20.231,  
20.463, 20.468, 23.291, 23.377.

Books 5, 8, 20, 23.

*See also:* Dardanus, Erichthonius, Ilus,  
Assaracus, Ganymede, Aeneas, Achilles,  
Lycaon, Hector.

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### **Troy** (Τροίη / Ἰλῖος) · PLACE

The city, and the poem's fixed point:  
everything happens on the plain before  
it or  
inside its walls. The translation keeps  
both surface names the Greek uses —  
**Ilion**, “holy Ilion,” “the well-built citadel  
of Ilion,” and **Troy**,  
“well-walled,” “wide-wayed,” “deep-  
soiled” — and both are headwords. The  
city is  
never taken in the poem, but its fall is

stated as certain from Book 4 on (“the day will come when holy Ilion shall perish, / and Priam, and the people of Priam of the good ash spear,” 4.164–165 = 6.448–449), and Zeus names it the dearest of mortal cities to him even as he concedes it. It is Poseidon and Apollo’s own work, built for Laomedon, and its wall is what Hector must come outside of to die. *Also called:* Ilion — the same city, both spellings throughout; its citadel is Pergamos.

**Refs:** 1.71, 1.129, 2.113, 2.141, 4.46, 4.164, 6.315, 7.20, 21.544, 22.411

...and throughout. Books 1–24.

*See also:* Troy, Trojans, Priam, Hector, Pergamos, Scaean, Laomedon.

---

**Tydeus** (Τυδεύς) · MORTAL — *Say:* TY-dee-  
us

Diomedes' father, one of the Seven  
against Thebes, dead before the poem  
opens and  
covered by the heaped earth at Thebes.  
The name is overwhelmingly a  
patronymic:

“Tydeus' son” is Diomedes, and in most  
of its 109 occurrences the father is not  
the  
referent. Where he is, he is the standing  
measure the sons are held against —  
Agamemnon shames Diomedes with the  
story of the envoy who beat the  
Cadmeans at  
their games and killed the fifty men  
they ambushed him with, and  
concludes that

“the son he fathered is worse than he in battle — better in the assembly”;

Athena

tells Diomedes he is “no son of Tydeus” if fear holds him, recalling that his father

was a small man in build but a fighter.

Diomedes says he does not remember him.

*Kin:* son of Oeneus’ line, of Portheus through Oeneus; married a daughter of Adrastus and settled at Argos; father of Diomedes.

**Refs:** 2.406, 4.370, 4.372, 4.384, 4.399,

5.800, 5.813, 6.222, 14.114 ...and

throughout. Books 2, 4–11, 14, 16, 19, 21, 23.

*See also:* Diomedes, Thebes, Oeneus, Adrastus, Polyneices, Agamemnon, Athena.

---

**Xanthus (horse)** (Ξάνθος) · OTHER — Say:

ZAN-thus

One of Achilles' two immortal horses,  
yoked with Balius; the harpy Podarge  
conceived the pair by the West Wind as  
she grazed in a meadow beside the  
stream of

Ocean. In Book 19, when Achilles  
reproaches them for leaving Patroclus  
dead,

white-armed Hera gives Xanthus voice:  
he drops his head until his mane spills  
to

the ground and answers that they will  
bring Achilles back safe this time, but  
that

his day of destruction is near, and that  
the blame is a great god's and strong  
Fate's — "it is fated to be broken by

force — by a god, and by a man.” The Erinyes then stop his voice. The token *Xanthus* is otherwise counted under the river Scamander; see *canon.md*’s homonym register.

*Also called:* named always with Balius as a pair.

*Kin:* offspring of Podarge and the West Wind; yoked with Balius, and with the mortal Pedasus in the side-traces.

**Refs:** 16.149, 19.400. Books 16, 19.

*See also:* Podarge, Achilles, Automedon, Pedasus, Scamander, Erinyes, Zephyrus.

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**Zeleeia** (Ζέλεια) · PLACE — *Say:* zuh-LY-uh  
Pandarus’ town, “under the lowest foot of Ida,” whose men drink the dark water of

the Aesepus. The Catalogue calls them  
Trojans; the town itself appears twice  
more,  
in the vow Athena puts in Pandarus'  
mouth and then in his own  
performance of it —  
a hecatomb of firstborn lambs to Apollo  
the Lycian-born “when he came home  
to the  
town of holy Zeleia.” He does not come  
home.

**Refs:** 2.824, 4.103, 4.121. Books 2, 4.

*See also:* Pandarus, Ida, Aesepus, Apollo,  
Lycaon.

---

**Zephyrus** (Ζέφυρος) · GOD — *Say:* ZEF-ih-  
rus

The west wind, named in Book 23 only,  
where Iris finds all the winds feasting

indoors at “the house of gusting  
Zephyrus” and delivers Achilles’ prayer:  
he and

Boreas rise with an unearthly roar,  
drive the clouds before them, and fall  
on the

pyre so that Patroclus burns all night.  
Elsewhere in the poem the same wind is  
called “the West Wind” without the  
name — as the sire of Xanthus and  
Balius by the  
harpy Podarge (16.150), and in Xanthus’  
own boast that the two of them could  
run

with its breath (19.415).

*Kin:* father of Xanthus and Balius by  
Podarge (named there as “the West  
Wind”).

**Refs:** 23.195, 23.200, 23.208. Book 23.



*See also:* Boreas, Iris, Achilles, Patroclus,  
Xanthus (horse), Podarge.

---

**Zeus** (Ζεύς) · GOD — *Say:* ZOOS

The presiding god of the poem and the agent of its plot. Its fifth line announces that through all the deaths “the will of Zeus moved toward fulfillment,” and the mechanism is set in Book 1: Thetis clasps his knees, he bows his head — the pledge that cannot be taken back — and promises to give the Trojans power until the Achaeans honor Achilles. He enforces it by banning the gods from the field on pain of Tartarus, by his golden scales, and by a long plan-speech at 15.56–77 that lays

out Books 16 through 22 in advance. He is not omnipotent in it so much as bound by it: he cannot save Sarpedon, his own dearest son, without unmaking the order the other gods live by, and instead rains drops of blood on the earth; he weighs Hector's fate and lets it sink; Hera deceives him into sleep and he wakes furious but does not undo it. In Book 24 he ends the poem by sending Thetis to Achilles and Iris to Priam, ransom for a body.

*Epithets:* "aegis-bearing" (αἰγίοχος, 1.202); "Zeus the cloud-gatherer" (νεφεληγερέτα, 1.511); "Zeus the counselor / of the counsels" (μητίετα, 1.175); "who thunders on high" (ὑψιβρεμέτης,

1.354); “who delights in thunder”  
 (τερπικέραυνος, 1.419); “lord of  
 lightning” (ἀστεροπητής, 1.580); “wide-  
 seeing”  
 (εὐρύοπα, 1.498); “high-throned”  
 (ὕψιζυγος, 4.166); “father of men and  
 gods”  
 (πατήρ ἀνδρῶν τε θεῶν τε, 1.544); “the  
 dispenser of war” (ταμῆς πολέμοιο,  
 4.84);  
 “the loud-thunderer, Hera’s lord”  
 (ἐρίγδουπος πόσις Ἥρης, 7.411); “Zeus  
 of All  
 Voices” (Πανομφαῖος, 8.250); “Zeus of  
 Guest-right” (Ζεὺς ξείνιος, 13.625).  
*Also called:* “son of Cronos” (Κρονίδης /  
 Κρονίων, 1.398) — the patronymic that  
 resolves to Zeus throughout; “Cronos”  
 alone is the Titan father.  
*Kin:* son of Cronos and Rhea; brother of

Poseidon, Hades and Hera, who is also his wife; the three brothers divide sky, sea and underworld by lot (15.187–193). Father of Athena, of Apollo and Artemis by Leto, of Ares and Hebe by Hera, of Aphrodite by Dione, of Hermes, of Heracles by Alcmene, and of Sarpedon.

**Refs:** 1.5, 1.503, 1.528, 8.5, 15.187, 16.431, 22.209, 24.103 ...and throughout.

Books 1–24.

*See also:* Hera, Thetis, Achilles, Poseidon, Athena, Apollo, Sarpedon, Hector, Cronos, Tartarus, Fate.

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